
SATIPANYA BUDDHIST RETREAT

YouTube Talks

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Bhante Bodhidhamma

SHROPSHIRE, WALES · UNITED KINGDOM

Contents

YOUTUBE TALKS

Basics for Insight Meditation 01	42 min	8
70th Birthday: Bhante Bodhidhamma's Life Story	1h23	21
Talk Starting Inaugural Lockdown Evening Meditations 29/03/20	24 min	46
02 First Three Noble Truths	32 min	53
Sammādiṭṭhi Sutta (MN 9): Discourse on Right View — Wholesome and Unwholesome Kamma	23 min	62
Evening Lockdown Meditation	59 min	69
Coronavirus and the Contemplation of Death	18 min	74
Contemplation of Death: Living More Awake	21 min	79
Contemplation of Death Again!	32 min	86
06 Renunciation and the Buddha's First Occasion to Teach	21 min	95
Setting the Wheel of the Dhamma in Motion	24 min	102
08 Mindfulness at Work and Right View, Right Attitude	21 min	110
Right Speech, Action and Livelihood	22 min	117
Grief	18 min	124
The Nutriments: Food, Contact, Volition and Consciousness	24 min	129
The Investigation of Eating	23 min	137
Discourse on the Taints MN 2: Overcome by Seeing	21 min	144
Not-self Revisited: The Story of Sati (MN 38)	20 min	150
Investigating Not-self - The Practice	23 min	157
17 Questions — See Description	26 min	164
18 Overcoming the Āsavās by Restraint	22 min	172
Overcoming the Āsavās by Using Requisites Wisely	19 min	179
Overcoming the Taints by Endurance	21 min	185

Overcoming the Taints by Removing - Part 1	11 min	193
21b Overcoming the Taints by Removing 2	10 min	197
Overcoming the Taints by Developing the Seven Factors of Awakening	22 min	201
The Ten Fetters	26 min	208
Society	21 min	215
25 Reflections for an Harmonious Society	26 min	221
26 More Reflections	32 min	228
What Makes a Society Strong?	21 min	237
The Six Sense Bases — Saḷāyatana Vibhaṅga Sutta (MN 137)	21 min	243
The Sense Bases Continued: The Thirty-Six Positions of Beings	25 min	250
Mettā, Forgiveness and Determination Practice	51 min	257
Reiki with Bryan Lester	59 min	265
Some Pointers for Mettā	15 min	278
Bodycare Practice — Mettā towards the Body	44 min	283
02 Reiki with Bryan	1h12	289
Body as Meditation Object	22 min	302
The Basics of Insight Meditation 03	16 min	309
03 Reiki with Bryan	1h12	314
Kālāma Sutta (AN 3.65)	19 min	328
Caṅkī Sutta (MN 95) — Questioning Beliefs and Groundless Conclusions	18 min	333
Kālāma Discourse (continued)	21 min	340
Caṅkī Sutta (cont.)	19 min	347
Shorter Discourse on Gosinga	19 min	353
Gaia Standing and Sitting Guided Meditation	1h00	360
38 Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness — Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10)	22 min	367
31b The Body	22 min	374
Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness — Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10)	21 min	381
Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness: Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10) - Elements and Charnel Ground Contemplations	19 min	388
Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness — Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10)	21 min	394

Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness - Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10)	22 min	401
Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness — Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10)	27 min	408
The Relay of Chariots — Rathavinīta Sutta (MN 24)	23 min	417
The Relay of Chariots (MN 24)	30 min	425
The Dog Duty Ascetic Discourse — Kukkuravatika Sutta (MN 57)	1h21	434
Gratitude, Generosity, and Renunciation	18 min	443
Spanish Introduction — Refuges and Precepts, Standing and Sitting Meditation	1h20	449
Saddhā: Confidence and Trust	8 min	454
Dhp 188-192: The Role of Confidence	20 min	457
Dhp 153-154: The Buddha's Victory Verses	17 min	463
Dhp 4: Hatred is Not Overcome with Hatred!	18 min	468
Dhammapada 21-23: The Path of Diligence (Appamāda)	18 min	474
Dhammapada Chapter 3 - Verses 33 & 34: The Unruly Mind	17 min	479
Dhammapada 1-2: Mind is the Forerunner	14 min	484
Dhammapada No. 4: Hatred Is Not Pacified by Hatred	16 min	489
Dhammapada 256-257: Judgmental vs Judicious	17 min	494
Dhammapada 46: How to View the Body	18 min	500
The Four Noble Truths	18 min	506
The Nine Qualities of the Buddha	22 min	512
Dhammapada 360-362: Restraint	21 min	515
Dhammapada 90: The Arahant	19 min	522
Vita Quotidiana - Daily Practice and Spiritual Life	1h11	528
Dukkha: Unsatisfactoriness and Sila: Morality and Ethics	25 min	540
Paṭicca Samuppāda and the Role of Desire and the Only Choice	15 min	547
Kamma and Rebirth	17 min	552
Gratitude, Generosity and Renunciation	12 min	557
Facets of a Love	14 min	562
Appamāda: The Path to the Deathless — Dhammapada 22-24	17 min	567
Ageing	18 min	572

Dhp 152-153: The Inner Critic	24 min	578
Sympathy, Empathy and Compassion	17 min	585
DHP 314-317 From the Chapter on Hell	26 min	591
Non-Violence is not Pacifism	16 min	598
Neoliberalism and Mindfulness	19 min	603
The Buddha and War	23 min	609
Need, Sufficiency and Greed	18 min	613
Social Conditioning or Karma	13 min	619
Climate Emergency	14 min	624
Reset for Autumn	15 min	628
Identity and Not-Self	21 min	633
The Contemplation of Death	25 min	640
To Love or To Be Loved: That is the Question	17 min	647
The Bases of Success	10 min	653
Bāhiya of the Bark Cloth	11 min	657
The Discourse on Bāhiya of the Bark Cloth (Ud 1.10)	20 min	661
Joy	17 min	668
Is the Buddha an Atheist?	26 min	674
Fear and Courage	23 min	678
Patience	19 min	685
Equanimity — The Most Important of All Virtues	25 min	692
Compassion and Its Subtle Enemies	28 min	699
Good Friendship, Good Companionship, Good Comradeship is the Whole of the Spiritual Life	18 min	706
The Five Constant Contemplations	24 min	712
Retreat Start: Standing and Walking Meditation	55 min	719
The Discourse on Developing Loving-Kindness	28 min	726
The Importance of Tranquillity	16 min	735
The Crucial Importance of Desire and Intention	20 min	740
Satipaṭṭhāna Opening Ceremony 30th June 2007	56 min	746

Ceremony to Bless the Stupa — June 26th 2011 — Pt 1	15 min	752
Ceremony to Bless the Stupa - June 26th 2011 - Part 2	26 min	754
Ceremony to Bless the Stupa — June 26th 2011 — Pt 3	36 min	757
The Discourse on Not-self — Anattalakkhana Sutta (SN 22.59)	23 min	765
Upāli is Converted by the Buddha (MN 56)	21 min	772
Contemplating the Unpleasantness of the Body: Why and How	21 min	779
The Buddha's Alter Ego	24 min	784
The Unattractive Nature of the Body	29 min	788
The Four Great Elements	21 min	793
The Specific Law of Conditionality	22 min	799
The Dangers of Indulgence	20 min	806
Reflections and Contemplative Practice of Kamma	25 min	812
Forgiveness	15 min	818
The Basics of Insight Meditation 02	34 min	823
Dukkha — Basic Premise of the Buddhadhamma	15 min	833
Non-Violence is not Pacifism	15 min	838
The Eight Worldly Conditions	20 min	843
The Paradox of Fear	15 min	850
Renunciation: The Path to Liberation	15 min	855
The Buddha as a Teacher: The Discourse on Mālunkhyāputta	23 min	861
What was the Great Discovery by the Buddha	15 min	866
Where Do the Elements Cease Without Remainder?	16 min	871
Extinguishing the Housebuilder	16 min	876
Hope, Aspiration, and Expectation	19 min	881
Topics of Discussion	19 min	887
Practising the Five Remembrances	40 min	894
Revising the Basics	27 min	899
The Necessity of Joy	21 min	907
Polarisation	16 min	913

Dullness and Lethargy	15 min	919
Adhiṭṭhāna — Determination	20 min	924
The Four Clingings (Upādāna)	15 min	930
The Buddha's Use of Similes	20 min	935
Restraint (Saṃvara)	19 min	941
The Kālāma Discourse	15 min	947

Basics for Insight Meditation 01

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 42 min

In this foundational talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma presents the essential principles underlying insight meditation practice. Drawing from the Buddha's core teachings, he explores the three characteristics of existence (tilakkhana): impermanence (anicca), unsatisfactoriness (dukkha), and not-self (anattā). The talk emphasizes how meditation helps us develop an 'observation post' within ourselves, allowing us to witness the arising and passing away of bodily sensations, emotions, and thoughts without identification.

Bhante explains how our fundamental delusion lies in seeking happiness through sensual experience, creating the very suffering we wish to escape. He discusses the five hindrances (pañca nīvaraṇa) that obstruct clear seeing: sensual desire, ill-will, restlessness, sloth-torpor, and skeptical doubt. Rather than suppressing these mental states, practitioners learn to come off thinking, enter the body, and allow emotions to express themselves as felt sensations until they naturally dissipate.

The teaching emphasizes that liberation comes through direct seeing rather than intellectual understanding. Using the Mahasi noting technique, meditators cultivate the childlike quality of pure observation, discovering that true peace resides not in emotional states but in the awareness that observes them. This practice extends beyond formal sitting into daily life, requiring moment-to-moment awareness and the courage to bear the consequences of our past unwholesome actions.

So this is just an opportunity really to just revise the principles of our meditation, why do we do it and how do we do it. I'm aware that there are people in the hall that haven't heard anything about this or very little, and also that people have been at it longer than me, so I'll try and get a balance to what we say.

The Buddha himself, remember, began in a position that we are in, searching for happiness. That's basically what we're trying to do. We're trying to be happy, for heaven's sake. And at the time when he finally broke through what he called the delusion, the basic ignorance that we live under, he was able to point to three ways in which we can investigate our experience and to correct the way we are looking at things. You could say that our basic problem is one of relationship. He talked about them as the three characteristics of existence.

So in the meditation practice, the first thing is to really begin to get close to this idea of impermanence and what that actually means in terms of a direct experience. It's not as though that comes as a great shock to anybody that things arise and pass away. It's not as though, generally speaking, people are not aware that the seasons do change. But it's really turning that inward towards ourselves and to recognise that we are in a process of change, and that the change is not simply something that's changing shape like you might take a piece of clay, turn it into a saucer, screw it up and then turn it into a cup. It's actually radical. Things are dying and passing away, and the great exemplar of that, of course, is our own bodies.

Every cell is arising, dying and passing away. We don't experience that, at least I haven't. I haven't experienced the death of a cell. But I'm quite aware that in fact cells are arising and passing away. And it's that ability to really go into ourselves and see that all the experience that we're having is in this process of coming into being and then passing out, and that the mind with its conceptual ability draws us into an idea of continuity. So there is this feeling in me that I've always been me since the day I was born. My body changes but not me. I mean, my thoughts have changed. I don't think like a three-year-old anymore. But I haven't changed. I don't have the same emotions as a child, but I haven't changed. There's always this feeling that there's a me inside all this, which isn't changing. It's absolutely steady. And somehow I anchor myself to that.

When I actually investigate it, and I begin to describe what this me is, what do I end up experiencing? So I'm turning into myself, and I observe that everything I'm experiencing is passing away. But I still have this sense of me, the observer. Somehow I've retreated out of the body, out of the emotions, out of the mind, and I've found this other place within myself that I experience as the feeler or the experiencer or the knower, and sometimes it's very strong that oh, this is me, I'm the one who knows. Now from that position we're quite privileged because we can at least abstract ourselves from these other identities that we've had. So we've had the identity of the body.

Now these days it's very difficult to go back to that very early childhood state where you are the body, but we do occasionally get that. For instance, when was the last time you trapped your finger in a door? For that one moment you are the body. It's like a wonderful complete moment of pain. There is only pain. Then, of course, you shoot out of it and suddenly there's somebody feeling the pain. There's an objectivity comes to it. But at least there we can grasp what it is to be a self that is just the body, as a baby is supposed to be. I can't remember, you see.

Then there's the emotional self, which is much easier to get lost into. Suddenly I am angry. There's no separation. I just blow it, bang the doors and all that. Or I panic and I just become that fear. Or I'm depressed. I associate with, I identify with in a total way that this is me. Occasionally I'm happy, which is wonderful. And being happy, being joyful, you then of course get that sense of loss when it disappears.

But there's this self which attaches itself to an emotion, which defines itself as I am happy. I and happiness are the same. I and anger are the same. But here in meditation what we discover is that there is anger, there is depression, there is happiness. Somehow I've detached from it. Now this word detachment, that's what you'll get in the literature. It gives it a certain coldness. Another word that you might find used is non-attachment, which gives it a sense of not just wanting to push away or a coldness to it. It's just there's a sense of separateness from the emotion that you're feeling.

And then with thoughts, these are even more difficult as we discover in our meditation. Suddenly I'm thinking. There's no objectivity to it. I'm just lost in a dream sequence. I'm just lost in a whole flow of thoughts. And suddenly I come out of it by which time I can only note what has actually happened. I can't note it while it's happening because I'm lost in it. And in that moment I've become the intellectual self, the thinking self.

So we're constantly moving from these definitions of a self. And in meditation, we're finding this other place, which one writer happily called the observation post. I'm trying to think of the name of the book now. It's Nyanaponika. The Heart of Buddhist Meditation. It still remains a classic, that book. And we're finding this other place within ourselves from which we can observe these things and we're observing that they're arising and passing away. But in so doing we've also found a space, there's also a space between, a sense of distance from what we're actually experiencing within ourselves.

And that sense of space is the not-self, not me, not mine. So often you get this confusion in the teaching where we think the Buddha is making some metaphysical statement, there is no self, there is no body. But when you look at his actual teaching in the scriptures, it's just a way of beginning to realise what or who or whatever it is that we really are, and we're doing it by pushing away, by making an object of everything within us. Now as soon as something becomes an object, it obviously can't be the subject.

When I look at my hand, I'm still attached to it. But that objectivity means that it can't be me. It can't be that which knows. And I'm taking that objectivity into myself so that when I feel an emotion, I'm feeling it, I'm looking at it, I'm experiencing it. And there's that separation. Every time I separate from something, I'm disidentifying. I'm relocating. I'm relocating where I think I am.

So I've got to relocate out of the body, relocate out of the sensations, feelings, emotions, relocate out of thought. If I were going for this election next year, I'd be saying, relocate, relocate, relocate. So this constant relocation, I'm finding another place in which I can find, shall we say, a different identity. And this identity I experience as being the observer, the feeler. It's a very strange place to be because here I know what's happening. I feel an emotion. I can feel it. I can feel a sensation. I can know it. And yet somehow I'm not it.

Now that's all the Buddha's pointing to when he's saying, not me, not mine. This is not me, not mine. And the fact that it arises and passes away is also pointing out it can't be me or mine because one minute it's here and then it's gone. How could it be me? The idea of a me is something permanent, substantial, something that doesn't change. So the first position that we take in our meditation is that observer, that feeler. We lift ourselves out of the body-mind complex in order to discover this observation post.

All the noting we do, all the techniques that you come across in *Vipassanā*, and the technique I myself am teaching is known as the Mahāsi technique, but there are many others. And if you go into Zen, or you go to Dzogchen, the Tibetan tradition, all these techniques are always trying to get the meditator to find this position, that's all. And from this position, you can get this objectivity. And these three characteristics, we've mentioned the two at the moment, this idea of impermanence and the fact that it's not me, not mine, becomes more and more apparent the more you practice it.

Now, even though we get to this position of the observer, the knower, that's not your final position because there's still something there that knows itself. Now, if I have a sense of presence, this is me, it's also an object, so I can't be that either. Everything that I'm aware of can't be the awareness that's aware of it. So even at that point, which we can get to by an act of will, we can put ourselves into the observation post, is not the end point. The end point is even when that sense of self disappears.

And occasionally that may happen to you in little bits when you fall into an absorption, an absorption state where there's a sense of loss of a self and yet when you come out of that state you know that there has been a process of knowing, a process of seeing, a process of experience. These I like to call little Nibbānic moments. Even whether they're actually Nibbānic or not, let's not get into that discussion. But they're Nibbānic moments in the sense that just for that one moment, we've lost the sense of self.

Now, you might say to yourself, well, I do that when I watch a good film. When you sit and watch a good film, that's it, you're gone. You wake up two hours later and you say, that was a fantastic film. But you weren't aware of yourself watching the film while you were watching the film. There was a loss of self. But unfortunately, we enter into

those absorptions with an intention which corrupts the actual process. And the intention is, I, me, I'm going to enjoy myself. And as soon as you do that, you form a relationship with films. The film now becomes something that your happiness is dependent on. So after you've seen one film, there comes, in not too long a space afterwards, a thirst, a craving, an addiction to get another DVD. Or else life becomes meaningless. This is what I found.

So it's a case of recognising that we're talking about two different levels of consciousness. There's a level of knowing, a level of the way we relate to the world, which is seeking happiness in the world. Now, this is where we come to the other of the three characteristics, which the Buddha called *dukkha*. *Dukkha* translates as a hard place. So we're in a hard place and it's a hard place because we've made this wrong relationship. And this fundamental delusion that we suffer from expresses itself in a search for happiness in the sensual world. That's how it expresses itself.

Having identified ourselves with the body, having identified ourselves with our emotional life and our thought life, we're now trying to make this inner environment the happiness that we seek. That's all. So when I'm feeling well, when I'm feeling really fit and I'm walking up a hill or something, then that's happiness. I've made it, finally. Then I get to the top of the hill and I've got to come down, and it all dribbles away. The body feels weak and tired, and I've got to have my orange juice.

Emotionally speaking, I can create a situation. I try and find the right person who makes me happy, the right situation. And I find myself in this beautiful emotional euphoria. Nature, sex, drugs, rock and roll, it's wonderful. But unfortunately, as soon as I've got it, this emotion corrupts it, disappears it, falls away from me. But I still think that as long as I can just get the right thing, right job, right relationship, right house, right car, I will be definitely perfectly happy.

So this search for happiness in the world is producing that stress that we are suffering. Because we constantly want to be happy in a world which cannot deliver, if only because it passes away. Now, to let go of that is the process of renunciation. To begin to let go of that as a place to find happiness is the process of renunciation. Now, renunciation isn't self-mortification in the sense that we're not trying to beat ourselves up. For heaven's sake, we're suffering enough. What we're trying to do is to let go of our attachment to things. And we do that by, through this meditation, beginning to realise what desire is.

So the Buddha's Four Noble Truths, he begins with a very simple statement. Life is *dukkha*, it's a hard place. And the reason it's a hard place, he says, is because of a certain type of desire. It's a desire based on seeking happiness in the sensual world.

And then he says, if you can get rid of that, you will actually come to the end of this *dukkha*. You'll actually come to a position in yourself where there is no more unsatisfactoriness, no more suffering, and you live, in his words, contented and with it happy.

When somebody complains to him and says, look, this training is very difficult, he says, well, it is difficult, but then people achieve this wonderful state, *Nibbāna*. And the guy says, *Nibbāna*, so what? So he's very serious. When you get there, he says, you are contented and with it happy. He's describing himself.

So remember that the enlightenment or the liberation is not a destruction of what we have, but a refinement of what we have. When the Buddha is finally liberated, he doesn't turn into this amorphous blob, sitting under a tree with enlightenment, glowing but unable to speak, like he's lost in the Nibbānic bliss forever. He gets up, he walks, he talks, he relates. And the Buddha's heart is these immeasurables, which we'll practice this afternoon: love, compassion, joy and peace. That's his heart.

And his intellect, what had been such a barrier to actually seeing things the way they are, and that's why remember in our meditation we're constantly dragging ourselves down into the body to get back to basic experience away from conceptual thinking. Remember that concepts always hold our history. So whenever we experience something, we're always dumping our history on what we're experiencing. That's why whenever you eat an apple, it's always compared with the last apple or the apples you ate. And it's either rubbish or brilliant or whatever. But actually, the apple is just an apple. And to taste the apple, this apple, this apple that I'm tasting, in its individuality, I have to forget all history. And to do that, I place my attention just in the eating, just on the tongue.

So now, this liberation, when it came, did not take away his intellect. He used his intellect to express the Dharma, to express his teaching. So everything that we're doing is not an annihilation of anything. In fact, he says the only things that are annihilated are greed, hatred, and this fundamental delusion. Everything is returned to us in a purified form.

So this *dukkha*, this unhappiness, this unsatisfactoriness, meaninglessness that might come about our lives, is all resting on this delusion that somehow we can find the happiness in this human form. And we make the mistake of thinking we are human beings. But all we mean by human being is a conventional coming together of carrots and apples, isn't it? And then thoughts and images. When you get it all together and it's all working properly, we call that human being. But when you take it apart, what is there? But it's just a combination of objects, which the Buddha calls aggregates. He calls them

the five aggregates, the physical aggregates, the perceptual aggregates, the feeling aggregates, all the aggregates that we call our emotions and thoughts, and these acts of cognition, these acts of consciousness.

And our process is to begin to see that all that actually is, as it says in the scriptures, just bubbles in a stream, just like a flame which is constantly changing, just burning fuel, but in a constant process of change. But the flame looks one, it looks whole, it looks entire, but actually it's just made of a constant flow of energy.

So these three characteristics are what it is we're trying to experience directly. And to directly experience these three characteristics is to liberate us from this essential delusion.

Now, you might think, therefore, that having been liberated from that, you just end up in a sense of annihilation, like there's nothing left. But the Buddha points out, keeps stressing the fact, that he's not teaching annihilation. He's actually teaching that there is an experience which is beyond the phenomenal experience of ordinary daily life. And he points to that by calling himself the *Tathāgata*. And the *Tathāgata* translates best as the one who's transcended. The one who is transcended.

So every time we move into the position of the observer within ourselves, we're transcending the body. We're transcending emotion. We're transcending thought. We're finding a very different position within ourselves. And when occasionally in your meditation there is that loss of self, there is that absorption into what we're observing, and with the loss of self you'll lose a sense of time, we're catching just moments of *Nibbānic* bliss. And the problem with that for us, because we associate bliss and happiness with emotions, is that there are no emotions there.

So when Sāriputta is asked, you talk about the bliss, the happiness of emotions, but there are no emotions in *Nibbāna*. He says, yes, he says. It's the very absence of emotions which is the bliss in *Nibbāna*. So there's a real conundrum for us.

So, as in your meditation, when you can stabilise at some point this observer within you, when you can stabilise that position of just being within the phenomena of your own body, heart and mind, feelings, emotions, images, when you can stabilise that position long enough, for those of you who work at it, ask yourself, what is the mood, the emotion, of the one who's observing? What is the mood of it, right? Just reflect on that for a moment. And that will draw you more and more to want to be in that place because that's where the peacefulness resides. It doesn't reside in the emotional life, it doesn't reside in the intellect or the body.

Now, having done that, you might think to yourself, well, are you therefore denying the body, heart and mind? No, not at all. Because then, as it were, from that insight, you have to re-enter the whole psychophysical process. So the Buddha talks about right understanding, but then you have to draw yourself with right intention into the heart. And that right intention moves outwards into relationship, which is right speech, right action, right livelihood. And that mirrors back to you your wisdom or probably the lack of it and that's how you gain, that's how you begin to understand that oh yes in sitting yes I consider those lovely and impermanent you know I can feel pain in my knee and I'm perfectly equanimous with that, that's absolutely wonderful you see. And then you're waiting for the tube and somebody stands on your foot.

To hell with meditation.

So that's what we're trying to do in this, through the process of insight meditation, *vipassanā*, right? We're trying to see these three characteristics more and more clearly. And it's in the seeing that the liberation comes. When you see something, then it rebounds back upon your attitude. You know, why do I want to keep doing this if it's making me unhappy? Right? It's very simple. So the seeing is the first point. It then moves, as I say, into right attitude. And this we develop through the practice of *mettā*, loving-kindness.

Now, those three characteristics, the characteristic of impermanence, the characteristic of how we create suffering for ourselves, the process, the role of sensual desire, and this teaching about not me, not mine, that's what we're trying to see. Now, what stops us seeing that are what the Buddha called these hindrances. And these hindrances you can split basically into two types. There's those types that excite the mind and keep it busy and take you away from this observing. And there's those types that drop you into the black hole. Dullness and lethargy, given a moral twist by calling it sloth and laziness and all that.

So as these mental states grab you right, the meditator has to know well this is what it is and this is what I have to do to counteract it right. And one thing that I think has been quite confusing to some people from some of the emails I get is that when something comes up which drags you away, so for instance some planning, you're planning a new business or something, so you're planning to go on holiday and there's an excitement comes when you're planning, planning, you see right. You come into the body, this is why it's so important, you come into the body and you get in contact with the excitement and you're allowing the excitement to express itself right, express itself and to burn away.

When you have a depressive thought and you're feeling depressed and the mind goes off about, you know, the world's in a terrible state, we're all doomed, and I'm horrible, and all that stuff. You see, you come off the thought, you come into the body, and you contact the feeling of depression, and you go into it, you feel it. You're allowing the heart to express itself.

If you find yourself arguing and you're getting very angry about something, you see, and you're strangling them. Then you say, oh, stop the anger, anger. You come back into the body. You find where, if you can, you can find where the anger is expressing itself. And you bury your attention into the heat. So you're not pushing anything away. You're not trying to run away from anything.

Pushing away, running away are the usual way we suppress stuff. When something comes up we don't like, we either push it away with aversion, don't want to see it, or we run away from it, we turn away, we ignore it. All that produces psychological problems for us. Here we're not doing that. Here, when something comes up, we come off the mind and we bury ourselves in the emotional state and we give it the time to burn out. Some stuff takes a long time. You can expect to see true improvement over a period of something like twenty-five years. I don't want to give the impression that this happens overnight.

What you're beginning to realise is that the emotional states that we've created have not been caused by the obvious object. So when somebody has annoyed us, when somebody has annoyed us, they've not caused the anger. It's really important. What's happened is we ourselves have come from a position of this. This person has disturbed this position and we've reacted from inside towards them with anger. The anger is caused by us. So therefore, seeking happiness by destroying the other is not going to help. You can annihilate everybody else in the world and you'll still end up angry and lonely. It doesn't... because they haven't actually caused the problem. The problem lies within our own hearts, which remember is always trying to seek happiness in the sensual world.

Nobody has frightened us. Fear has arisen because of something in me has reacted to a situation. Nobody can cause us psychological pain. It's all been caused inwardly by ourselves. It's really difficult, if you're new to this, to really grasp that. And don't worry about it if you disagree. Nobody can cause us psychological pain. Now, the disappointment in that is that you can no longer blame somebody else. This is a real disappointment, because up until now it was great. Society, my parents, the dog, they were all to blame. But now, it's just you. But the liberation is that if I cause this, if I cause these

awful mental states that I have to bear, I must be able to undo them. And that's where the liberation comes, that we are actually, we can become in charge of our own psychic life, our own psychological life.

Now, given these hindrances when they come, so we've talked about the negative stuff, well, there's been a bit of excitement there. So there's excitement, there's depression, there's lust, there's romance, there's all the beautiful stuff too, I don't forget about that. And then there's all this other stuff, the anxiety, the depression, etc. All that, you see, has been caused by me.

Now, what can I do about something which is already conditioned? If I try to destroy it, all I do is push it down. If I push it away like this and not want to see it, we know from our own psychology, that it just makes more and more psychic problems for us. If I turn away from it, I know that it's just there within the psyche waiting for its little moment to appear. So what can I do? Hmm?

The answer, of course, is to bear it. We have to suffer the consequences of our past unwholesome actions. And that's exactly what we're doing when we sit in meditation. We're allowing this stuff to arise and burn away. That's all. That's all we have to do, is to have the courage, the fortitude, the resilience to stay with the mental states and to allow them to rise and pass away. But to stay with them as felt sensations.

As soon as they slip into the mind, as soon as we allow that moment of unmindfulness to come, and it slips into the mind as a dream, as a film, as a process, unwittingly we're developing the very same state. Because that's how the emotions develop themselves. Consider. You know in the morning somebody said something a little bit off and you've just dismissed it. That's the way they are. And then tea time comes, eleven o'clock something, and you get a cup of tea. Bloody say that to me. And then at lunch it's raving. By the time you get home you don't want to see them in case you kill them. And all that's been created by us, by me. They only insulted me once, but I've had them insult me thousands of times before I go to bed.

So, it's recognising the role of the mind in developing our mental states that needs to be really perceived. And this business of, in meditation, of noting what's happening and coming back into the body, that's not just meditation. We have to do that throughout our lives, from the moment we wake up to the moment we fall asleep. Every time you see your mind wandering during the day, there has to be that effort to stop, note it, come into the body, allow the emotion to dissipate a bit.

So all that I'm describing here is how to generally attack four of these hindrances, those to do with happiness and pleasures and all that, those to do with angers, depressions, all the negative stuff about life, those to do with just general restlessness, where the mind is just busy all the time or there's a feeling of restlessness in the body, just to relax into it and feel it and just allow it to expend its energy. And doubt.

Doubt here is sceptical doubt. The Buddha wants us to be in a state of wonder. He wants us to actually doubt his word in that very positive way of saying to ourselves, now, is this true or not? Because it's an investigation. It's the investigation that draws us to liberation. It's no good believing in the Buddha and what he said. That's not going to, I mean, it's not going to help at all. Faith is something different. It's confidence. And the confidence is there to make it easy for us to investigate the teachings. And sceptical doubt is something else. Sceptical doubt is always based on fear. It's fear of commitment, isn't it? An aversion to commitment. You don't want to go there.

And when sceptical doubt enters into our ordinary lives, it can be absolutely crippling. Because you can't, is this the job I should be doing? Is it not? Should I do it? Should I not? And the job goes. Is this the person I really love? Should I love? Should I be married? Should I not? Before they've gone off, they've gone off to somebody else. So sceptical doubt is a real undermining thing. And in your meditation, really, if that comes up, you know, everybody else can do it, I can't do it, I'm no good. Really come off the thought, come off the thought, go into the feeling of that doubt and let it express itself, the fear, whatever.

The final one is the business of dullness and lethargy. And it's a big hindrance. I mean, you know, falling asleep in our meditation all the time. And of course, when you look back into the way we've used sleep to escape problems. You know, every time we feel a bit depressed, well, you just, you know, it's like head for the bed, you know. Big neon lights, head for the bed. Or you just lie down on the couch, fed up, and off you go. Great, isn't it? I mean, oblivion, there's no suffering. And then you wake up, which is unfortunate. But if you would say completely oblivious, see, I mean, if death is complete annihilation, what's the problem? So unfortunately, we keep waking up out of this.

But what we're doing is we're creating that inner habit of falling asleep. And it comes up as these feelings of heaviness, sloth, torpor, etc. And there's also, of course, the fact that being in that gentle subliminal state on a Sunday morning is really nice, isn't it? You know when you wake up and you turn over and you're just wandering in that pleasant dreamy state or get back into bed and you just keep wandering in that lovely

subliminal state of not being quite asleep and not being quite awake. And developing that is developing sloth and torpor, dullness and lethargy. So we shouldn't be surprised when we come to sit that we're always bobbing up and down, falling asleep.

So all these things that we're experiencing here in our meditation in terms of these negative mental states, we have to bring that practice into our daily life. Every time you feel sleepy during the day, ask yourself, now is this real tiredness? Or is it just this dullness and lethargy? In which case, stay awake. Every time you see your mind wandering, you have to note it and bring it back. So the practice of *vipassanā* is something that we have to take into just every daily life. And remember that the thing that really helps the process, the spiritual process, is to relax. So if you find your life too busy, try and do something to make it less busy. Try to experience this standing meditation that we did in the morning as a constant throughout the day, every so often just to stop.

It's a really powerful word, you see. Just stop. Stop. I think I've stopped too.

So, what we've described is these three characteristics which we're investigating, the sense of impermanence, the sense of not me, not mine, and the role of sensual desire, all based on some fundamental delusion within us that we're seeking happiness in the wrong place. And while we're doing that, these hindrances draw us away. Old habits of thought, old addictions, little hatreds, depressions, they're all drawing us away into this dream world. And all we have to do is to come off the dream, re-establish that awareness within the body and let these things express themselves as feeling. That's all, as feeling.

And when occasionally there does descend upon you some blissful peacefulness, see, be careful you don't sink into that as you would ice cream. Try to still maintain the fact of observing it as something which is very pleasant, very beautiful, but also impermanent. Don't get drawn into beautiful states of mind. And use it. Those are really good moments to really draw the attention into the breath and begin to experience impermanence and to develop that sense of laser beam concentration. Laser beams, stillness and attention.

And finally, just to bring an image to your mind of the child. So when somebody before the age of seven sees something they don't know, you see in a child, what do they do, you see? They become locked onto the object, don't they? Their eyes don't move. They're just locked onto the object, a beetle that they've never seen before. Everything goes absolutely still.

The body relaxes. The jaw relaxes. They look gormless. And the good parent gives them a clip on the back of their head. They look gormless. The jaw's completely relaxed, which means there's no thought. That's why in your meditation, always make sure your jaw's relaxed, your tongue's relaxed. And they're just watching.

And then after a moment or so, they stop and they ask, what is it? Now all that learning has gone on in just that watching. And all we're trying to do is get back to that state. Just that state of the original child. And that's why in Zen they'll often talk to you about original mind.

So if you keep that image in your mind as a child, and that's what you're trying to get back to, a non-thinking state of pure observation, and having the trust—it really depends upon faith—having the trust that there is within us a superb intelligence which will see the way things are and liberate itself. That intelligence is constantly saying, get that meditator out of the way. Will that meditator please go home and just let me look?

So that's your big problem. That's our big problem, is to get this meditator out of the way. And we do it in a very simple way. We just relax, we place the attention on the breath, we raise the interest to observe these three characteristics, and we just watch. We just feel. We just experience whatever draws the attention within the field of awareness. Voilà.

So, thank you very much. What we can do now is some walking meditation.

70th Birthday: Bhante Bodhidhamma's Life Story

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 1h23

In this deeply personal and candid talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma shares his complete life story on his 70th birthday, tracing the remarkable journey from his difficult birth in post-war Italy to becoming a Buddhist monk and meditation teacher. He recounts his early devotional experiences in Catholic church, his traumatic expulsion from seminary, existential despair in young adulthood, and travels across Africa and Asia in search of meaning.

Bhante describes pivotal moments including his discovery of meditation through Zen Buddhism, profound out-of-body experiences, and the gradual purification of childhood traumas through intensive Vipassanā practice in Sri Lanka. He reflects on the interplay between suffering and awakening, sharing insights about forgiveness, the categorical imperative of liberation for all beings, and how personal catastrophes became doorways to spiritual growth.

This autobiographical account offers a rare window into the human journey toward awakening, demonstrating how life's difficulties can become the very conditions that turn one toward the Dharma. Bhante's story illustrates the transformative power of meditation practice and the importance of perseverance on the spiritual path.

Namo tassa

I just want to begin by thanking all those people who have organized this lovely little celebration for me. The organizing committee: Aya and Richard and Deya and Mark and Sarah. And all those people who've made lovely donations to buy this statue that will go at the back of the pond there, and to fund my little trip to Japan. I was relieved to see that I could get a return ticket.

Also, I thank Charles and Heather and Mark and Peter, who've done this very professional recording for us. And of course, everybody who's chipped in for today.

So we have other birthdays here. Sarah, her birthday. And also Andy, who's got the 5-0. We're all suffering. And I think we can bring to mind Stephen Hawking. We can feel a certain sorrow for David Bowie, didn't quite make his three score and ten. And I think we can all join in with a special regard and good wishes to Kim Jong-un in Korea.

I am delighted that you've taken such joy in my own little birthday. But of course I myself am depressed. This is the beginning of the steep, the downward trend to decrepitude and senility. Now there was a card which some thought was telling me that 70 was a new 30. It's not. 70's serious.

Something peculiar's happened to me this year, in the sense that, suddenly—I suppose it's reaching the end of all this building stuff here, and feeling very settled outside Sari Panya—memories of my past life came up. I mean, this one. Of my past living. And I just wondered how it is that I got to this place. So I thought it was an opportunity to answer the questions that I'm often asked, but I usually palm off with a sentence or two. How I became a Buddhist, how I became a monk, and why do I continue?

So to start at the beginning: my father was in the RAF. They were following the armies up the boot of Italy when he was billeted on my mother's house. And they fell in love. And it seems as though he took AWOL in order to marry her. And when he got back to Cyprus, they put him in jail for a while. It's all very romantic. Anyway, he brought her to Britain and that's when her real depression began. If you can imagine moving from a hillside village overlooking the Adriatic with the smell of pine in your nostrils and ending up in Manchester. Black Manchester. We forget how black the cities were. Saturated with soot everywhere and pea soup fog.

Anyway, she happily became pregnant with me, but decided to go home to have me. And when the time came, they brought in the local midwife. She was 25, so presumably there was a little difficulty, but either they rushed it or it was her particular way of doing things, but they cut her. Such was the agony she bit into my uncle's thumb, and he showed me the scar. Even then I wouldn't come out. They had to prize me out with forceps. I mean, what a start. What a start.

She went on to give birth to two more sons and a daughter. So I've got two brothers and a lovely sister.

The effect of birth upon us. Consider the Buddha. So as soon as he was born, his mother died. So there must be a feeling there of loss, whether the baby's fully aware of it or not. There must be a feeling of loss. And according to certain disciplines like rebirthing, that breathing thing, and Stan Grof, holographic breathing. The birth trauma has a real effect upon us. It's there within our psyche. So I know this from the difference between my siblings because my mother said that my sister, who was last 11 years on, fell out. And she's utterly phlegmatic. Nothing like me. So that was my birth.

Now, I want you to imagine this little five-year-old boy being taken to church by his father. And he's walking into church. The church is quite big. It's St. Patrick's. It belongs to a third generation of Irish. And as you walk in, your nostrils are suffused with incense, frankincense. The atmosphere is very warm. And the people are very quiet. And then you're sitting there. And you're taken up into the gallery, into the choir loft. And your father is conducting. And at the point where the priest in these wonderful garments comes in with all the altar boys, because it was high mass, you're there as a little boy, a little child, and you're let loose. You can wander around and you're hanging on to the barrier of the choir overlooking down into the congregation and suddenly Bach or Handel or sweet music is coming in. So this was my introduction into devotion. I was in ecstasy.

And it's something that I think a lot of children these days don't get. Not that they don't get it with other things like pop stars and things like that. But it was my introduction into religion as a real heart-based experience. And this was to carry on. So that was, I call, if my first catastrophe was birth, this was my first blessing.

And my mother, being a southern Catholic—they were Roman Catholics, so I should mention that—my mother being a southern European Catholic, it was all about the love of Jesus. And my father was all hellfire and brimstone. I had a nice balance. I obviously warmed towards my mother. Northern Catholicism is very Protestant.

When you convert to a religion, when you actually move into a religion, you move in for various reasons. Most people who come to Buddhism come because they're suffering, because things have gone wrong and they've heard about meditation and stuff like that. But to actually begin to develop a heart attachment, a heart, a good attachment—not all attachments are evil—a relationship of the heart with your religion is very difficult, because this is done when you're a child. When you go to Thailand, you'll see little children are brought into the monastery, into the temples, and they bow, and they also have this sandalwood and incense, and they have the chanting. So that sense of devotion, which is a beautiful emotional state, it's a mental state of praise, of being in a lovely spaced out place, it's absolutely glorious. And of course you can develop these things into absorptions.

That's very difficult for us because it's a different culture. We haven't got that background. So I always think the way into that, the way into a devotional, a heart connection with the Buddhist teaching is through gratitude. And the more that you consider what the teaching has done for you and for others, then you get this gratitude come up. And it's very simple to go from gratitude towards love, towards a relationship.

Now, of course, the Buddha is gone. It's not as though we're relating to the Buddha. What we're relating to is an image within us of the Buddha. And in growing that, in a sense, we're actually forming a devotional relationship to the Buddha within us that we want to become. So it's the Buddha as he appears in daily life. It's not the transcendent Buddha. It's the Buddha of compassion, of love, of joy. And that's why I've got all these statues. That's the idea of devotion. I'm trying to squeeze a bit of Dharma out of my autobiography.

So anyway, we moved then to North Manchester, which was all fields at that time, out of Dean G. Mostyn into the lovely fields. The fields didn't stay fields long. They were soon built on. And right at the back of us, they established a cemetery. We're at school. There were over 50 kids in the class. So 47 was the peak of the baby boom. It begins in 45 and ends in 65. And if you look at the graph, it goes up on 47 and then begins to slowly come down. So Theresa May is a boomer.

So then, while I was at primary school, a priest turned up. And he gave us this wonderful talk with pictures about the missions. He showed us pictures of Flores, which is a beautiful island in Indonesia. He showed us pictures about New Guinea. And he showed us pictures about South America. And he talked about the wonderful things that priests did out there, missionaries. And if anybody felt like they might be drawn to that thing, then they should get in contact. So anyway, I got the 11 plus and I went to Xaverian College, which was a grammar school. But two of my friends from that school went to St. Richard's College. And during that year, for some reason, it came to me that that's what I wanted to do.

My mother was fiercely against it, but my father was like that, but it was my Aunt Rose who really wanted a priest in the family. Come the age of 12, I'm off on the train down to St. Richard's College.

And for me, it was entering into two years of undiluted heaven, because it was all about doing exactly what you want to do. And that's when you're most happiest, isn't it? When you're doing exactly what you want to do in an unpressured situation, you're in perfect joy. For instance, a hobby, right?

So the routine there was up about half past six, seven o'clock. We went down for mass. After mass, we went out in most weathers, only in the most severe, to do the old army exercise. Back in, into breakfast, clean up. School starts nine o'clock, all the way through to five o'clock. And all that time, apart from a little break at lunch, I remember it was in silence. Can you imagine that for a 12-year-old these days? At 6 o'clock, we went in to study, and at 8 o'clock, we were finally let free and we could play games down in the big game room. Imagine a 12-year-old day like today.

So, and I really got into it. I mean it was, all I remember is just being blissed out and hating going home, and having to come back because it was just there that I found my joy.

Then, something began to happen which promised a different sort of joy. It promised gold, but it turned into glitter. And the joy it promised finally ended up with frustration. Puberty. Even Mick Jagger could get no satisfaction. And he tried.

Anyway, we were let out every so often to go for a walk on a Sunday. And there were about six of us, five of us on the trip. And as we got down, we suddenly had this idea that we'd smoke. Now, teenagers are by nature rebellious. The order didn't smoke. And it was a German order begun by a German priest. And it was mainly German and American. And the joke was, we don't smoke, so we drink. S-V-D. And so it was a little rebellion to go and get some cigarettes. And we decided to steal them. There was an old lady who ran a shop at this bridge on the Worcester Canal. And as we entered in, we'd had it all figured out, somebody distracted her and somebody took the cigarettes. And I can't remember what my job was. I'll leave that.

Well, we smoked, of course. And when we got back in the evening after lunch, we were all called to the prefect's office, the headmaster prefect. And he told us that, he asked us, had we taken cigarettes from this lady? And we all said yes. She was no fool. We were probably the only customers the whole day. There was nobody, that in the middle of nowhere. So we were dismissed, and we thought, well, that's it.

There was no corporal punishment in the seminary at all. If I was at Xaverian, you'd have been beaten. Anyway, about a day or so later, we were all called for a talk in the main, in this big classroom. And the rector, who was in charge of the whole place, announced that certain boys had stolen. And he called our names and he said, you are expelled. Can you imagine that? I was three months off my GCEs and they kicked me out.

Anyway, I got back and because of that, my GCEs went all over the place. I had about four GCEs. I had to take my English again. And unfortunately, because the education was mainly by Americans, who I don't think really understood the English GCE system at the time. So what happened was, I ended up with subjects that I had virtually no interest in. Latin, French, and history. I had a bit of interest in history.

So life went on. And I didn't do well at the GCEs. And I remember talking to my father about this. Now, when they expelled, when I was thrown out, that was a cut off of a vocation. This vocation to be a priest remained in me as a really strong, tremendous urge for three years till I was over 19. Why couldn't I go back? Why couldn't I go back? It's because they never forgave me.

I can't tell you how important it is to forgive your enemies. What happened was, come the GCE, I turned up and they gave me a room in an outer building. I had to go into the exam room at a different entrance from everybody else. I wasn't allowed to talk to anybody and they weren't allowed to talk to me. In other words, I was excommunicated. And there was no way you can come back on that. If a priest or somebody come up and said, look, give it a couple of years and then, you know, you can join another order. I'd have had an in, but I had this block. I couldn't move.

So if you have any pity on your enemies, on all of them, do forgive them because it allows them to forgive themselves. And of course, in our offering forgiveness, we empty our own hearts of the revenge and the hurt and all that sort of stuff. Now, it doesn't mean to say that you've got to have somebody's forgiveness in order to forgive yourself, but it just makes it much easier.

So I went on then to about 19, and my father pointed out to me that since I was lost, I had no clue what to do with my life at this point. I'm completely lost. He said, why don't you teach? He said, you can travel with teaching. They must have known I was unsettled.

So I decided, I didn't go into university, so I went down to St. Mary's College, which was then a Catholic training college. It's now a university. And it was the year they were introducing the B.Ed. And instead of doing the B.Ed., I did the other offering, which was a degree course and a teacher training course.

And it was during this time that I completely forgot about being a priest. I finally began to enjoy a bit of life. But there's this underlying meaninglessness. There's this underlying boredom that comes because nothing you're doing is of any direct meaning to your own heart. And so what you overlay it with is distraction. You get drunk, you chase women, you do all sorts of daft things. And that went on for a little while until...

And it was during that time I fell in love. Oh my goodness. Well, you know what the first time is. So I'm completely sozzled, right? And on one steamy, love-drenched night, she fell pregnant. This was my third catastrophe.

So now in a Catholic community, for that to happen is a horror story. The abortion law had just been introduced, so it was legal. Let's not confuse legal with moral, just because in a liberal society, many of our personal decisions are left to us. But I just couldn't go there. It just wasn't on my to-do list, getting married and having children. So we struggled with it. We both struggled with it. She would have been, I think, happy going that way.

And eventually I had to be true to my own heart. And I went up to visit the parents and I said, look, I can't marry you. I'll support them. It was a way of getting myself into that position where eventually I'd marry. It was an in-between place, which I felt happy with, that I wasn't entrapped, and then finally I'd probably give in. But to the family, it just wasn't a no-go, and they just saw disaster for her daughter. They had connections with surgeons and stuff, and so she had an abortion.

I never felt really bad personally about that because I was never brought into that decision making. And of course I'm part of that whole process.

But if you go on the website and just type in something like reactions to abortion, you'll see pages after pages of men and women who really regret, no matter what good reason they had, actually regret that whole process. So it's there, shall we say, within my psyche, that at some part of my life there was an abuse of my sexual powers, even though it was a very wonderful moment.

Buddhism is no different from other religions. As soon as there's conception, there's consciousness. So there's a living being. There's no way out of that. That's what's understood, anyway. And this further alienated me. It further alienated me from my own heart. It further put me into a position of what you might call an underlying despair, which I never really looked at. It was just there underneath — the boredom, the meaninglessness, and then this tragedy — and all that just lay down upon me as a despair, which every occasion would actually lend me in an angry depression. But it never lasted long because I'm very sanguine.

And then one day... I was 21, 1968, 1968, very important date, 1968. That was the student revolutions, if you remember, in Paris and all that. And I lay in bed on a Sunday and I said to myself, I wonder what will happen if I don't go to church. Now in those days, if you didn't go to church, it was a mortal sin. And if you didn't get to confess to a priest and you died, you went to hell forever. I mean, that was the teaching. So it was a big decision. They changed all that in the mid-60s with Pope John XXIII. And I said to myself, if I don't go to church today, let's see what happens.

Nothing happened. So I never went again. I know, it's the most ridiculous thing to do. And what it manifests really was that the religion had now lost that connection of devotion. It had just become an empty ritual. I was just turning up for the mass, receiving communion, et cetera, et cetera. And it had lost its potency. And I think also there might have been guilt about the abortion and all that. And so there was a cutoff there.

Now, what this did, of course, was it deepened my alienation. It deepened my alienation to the whole thing. In other words, I found myself where Nietzsche found himself. I only discovered Nietzsche fairly recently because God is dead. We've killed him. Nietzsche struggled with that. I mean, he came up with the answer of the courage to face the sufferings and the death of life and to somehow rise above it. And that's what he meant by the superman or supraman, the *übermensch*.

The Buddha himself, if you remember, had that existential crisis. I mean, he puts it in the myth. There's a myth surrounding seeing a sick person, an aging person, and a corpse, and this person sitting under a tree. And the whole thing is about him in his young 20s coming to realize that actually what he's heading towards is sickness, aging, and death. And that this image of the *samana*, of the recluse sitting under a tree, suggested some sort of an escape. So we have to, I think, imagine the Buddha that he himself is going through an existential crisis. And it's so strong within him to find the answer to this that he leaves his family. In his case, his just-born child. So I think from our point of view, this is where the Buddha's at. The meaningfulness of life is gone. It's an existential angst. And that's where I was, really, with this existential anxiety.

Now, I don't want to give you the impression that I was going around moping and all that. No, I was still getting drunk and having a good time. It's just that every so often in silent moments, just by yourself, you suddenly sink into this area of just sheer boredom, a despair about life. You're just living it.

And then came my third blessing. We went to see *Waiting for Godot* by Beckett. Now some of you probably don't know that play because it's years old now. But it's basically about two tramps who are having these gorgeous conversations waiting for Godot. Godot's going to come and sort it all out. And the same thing happens in the second act. And in the first act, two people come, walk across the stage. But in the second act, one's gone blind and the other one's gone dumb. And in the first act, there are leaves on the tree. In the second act, there's no leaves. So here are the two tramps waiting for Godot, and everything's just getting worse.

I came out of that play, even though it was just an amateur production by a college, absolutely enthused. I couldn't stop talking about it. They all thought I'd gone mad. But to me, it just caught this whole existential problem of what is the point if in the end you just die? And I thought at this point, just to get across this, I'd read out a poem by Beckett, which I came across much later. I spent a lot of time writing about nothingness, well, doggerel anyway, and what it meant to just come to the end, to just finish, to just, and that's it, you're gone, is it? So let me just read this little poem to you, see what you think.

Just think, if all this, one day,
all this one day, one fine day, just think,
if one day, one fine day, all this stopped.

Get it? So that was the underlying existential problem that I was battling with.

In terms of my emotional life, when I wasn't being extrovert and going out there, there was this, there's a lovely poem by Gerard Manley Hopkins, that gets it across. And I carried this now for a long time. But it gives you an idea of, I think it's just a wonderful piece of poetry.

I wake and feel the fell of dark, not day.
What hours, what black hours We have spent this night!
What sights, heart, you saw, Ways you went,
and more must In longer lights delay!

With witness I speak this,
But where I say hours, I mean years, I mean life.

My lament is cries countless, Cries like dead letters
Sent to dearest hymn,
that lives, alas, away.

I am gall, I am heartburn.
God's most deep decree.
Bitter would have me taste.
My taste was me.

Bones built in me, flesh filled, blood brimmed the curse.
Self-yeast of spirit, a dull dough sours.

I see the lost are like this, and they're scourged to be as I am mine.
They're sweating cells, but worse.

Ooh. Isn't that good, eh? They're sweating cells. I love it.

So then, actually, I've gone and forgotten my little centerpiece. I'm so sorry. I'll have to go back to my birth. Do you mind? I'm sorry, I don't know what's wrong with me. After that terrible birth, we seem to have both recovered.

I hadn't seen this picture for years. And when I saw it, I thought, well, blow me down. And two things came to mind when I saw it. I thought, first of all, we remember our mothers as old, in old age. We forget they were all lovely young women. And the

other thing was that little child, if it was just shown to me, there's no way I'd make a connection with that child at all. I mean, this is the 10th body. Well, no, he's got hair. There's no way I'd make a connection. This is my 10th body, if we're to believe biology. Every 10 years, you completely change all the atoms in your body. Anyway, sorry about that. I'm going to leave you here.

So I leave, the relationship breaks up. I can't handle it anymore. So anyway, I'm in Spain and I'm looking for my friends and I've lost them. I've arrived there sometime later. And I pick up a telegram from the local post office. Do you remember telegrams? Yeah, fantastic. And it said, congratulations, son, BA and teaching certificate. And I went up onto a high rock and overlooked the sea. And I said to myself, there's no way in this world I want to teach.

So I went down and camped in this camp. And that night, there was a torrential rain. I woke up with the tent around me, completely sodden with sand and everything, staggered to the drink area, the, what do you call it? It's where people drink. And looking pretty miserable for myself. And I met this bloke called Dave. And we began talking. And by the end of the evening, we decided to travel together across the world. Simple as that.

So I came back, and I got a job through somebody I knew as a rep for selling audiovisuals to schools. And there was lots of money in education, so I made lots of money. And I was traveling all over Cornwall and all over Wales selling this stuff to schools. And I gathered something like a thousand pounds, which must be a lot of money these days, isn't it? A thousand pounds. And come the year, off we went.

And during that time, remember, all this time I've got this thing going on, this nothingness and this stuff in the heart. But because of the joy of travel, just the constant new information coming in and the liberation of it, it was all underneath. It would only come up in the gloomier moments.

So anyway, we went off and we started off towards North Africa. We went down to, saw all the stuff in Egypt, the usual stuff, ride a camel and all that. Went over to Khartoum, lay on the luggage rack to sleep and woke up with sand everywhere because of a sandstorm. Got onto a boat down to Juba, which is now the capital of South Sudan. And for 10 days, we were looking at the amazing sight of reeds. The reeds were so tall, they went up above the boat. And the boat just plowed through this canal, which was the Nile. And all you saw for 10 days was reeds. And because we didn't have much money, we were just eating bread. So this was a really gloomy time. And that's when I wrote most of my doggerel about nothingness.

Got down to Juba. We flew across to Entebbe. We made this amazing bus ride across Africa. I slept on the back seat. And every so often, I was in midair as he ran over an elephant. It was just unbelievable. Got to Mombasa, stayed with his brother, but we didn't get on so well. So we went up the beach and camped up there. And there we got stolen. All our traveling checks were stolen, which was fantastic because when you got to India, you got on the black market and made a lot of money. Terrible, isn't it? And they stole my father's watch. He'd given me this gold watch that he had been given after he'd finished his time as a headmaster at St. Patrick's. And it had inscribed on it at the back, and it was a precious thing.

So I wrote him a letter expressing my sense of sorrow and my love of him and all that. Well, when his reply came back, about three or four months later.. He said, thank you, son. Bit sentimental.

So we get to India. So we get this cattle boat across the Indian Ocean from Mombasa to Bombay, playing chess all the time. Lots of travelers, by the way. There wasn't many going down Egypt. But by the time we got to Africa, the boat was full of Westerners. It was all hippies. I was dressed in purple. So we take this boat all the way across to Bombay, and we do the usual trip. And we finally end up in Nepal. And that's when we got really stoned. Up in Nepal, lots of these stones full of dope. And there were these lovely hippie gatherings where we'd all sit in a circle with a chillum. That's ridiculous, isn't it? And that lasted for a while.

And then we made our way down to Calcutta. And Calcutta was at war. That was the Indo-Pakistan war where Bangladesh split off. And so there was no planes going out. So we were stuck there for two weeks. And what I did every day, so this was one of my big awakenings. When you went to India, this time it wasn't so bad. But in those days, sickness, destitution was in your face. It was in your face. And in Calcutta, they have a huge park with this massive statue of Queen Victoria, which I presume they got rid of now. And there was a massive road, a circuit road going around. That road was packed tight with the sick. Elephantitis, everything, apart from lepers, all the way around. And they were lying on the pavement. And when you saw that, you understood Mother Teresa's compassion. Because many of them would have died just there.

So anyway, I saw that. That I'm not used to, I'm not ready to receive. I'm aware of the suffering, but I'm not ready to receive it. Every day I went to this Sikh restaurant to get curry, and I would always ask for a glass of water. And when they brought the glass of water, which was a pint glass, you'd always leave a nice oily thumbprint on the side. I don't know how it was that I was in India for so long and never caught anything. It's just weird.

Every day I passed this woman who had a huge goiter, and she sat there absolutely silent, holding a little thing for coins, and her eyes were always glazed with tears. She just sat there, never looked at me, just sat there. And as I passed on the other side of the road, I always saw her. Day after day I passed that poor woman, and I never gave her a penny.

So then I'm coming round the corner, I'm just wandering around Calcutta, and I come round the corner, and right before me, there's this little girl. She must be over seven, but she looks round about five. And she's sucking a dried black banana peel. And she sees me, and as she sees me, she has the dignity and that destitution to cover her sex. And that hit me so hard that I just bombed past her. I never went back to buy her a banana. It just hit me so hard. That was my little boy drowned on the beach moment, where you suddenly, the awareness of compassion is not enough. There has to be that contact. Anyway, that passed. And that stays with me. Every time I bring that image to mind, if I feel callous about anything, about refugees and all these people, I just bring that little child to mind. And that's my connection with all the suffering that's going on these days.

So we're in Calcutta, and we did a couple of naughty things. And we had opium. Opium's wonderful. And I was laid out there all night, and I remember waking up and just watching all these cockroaches going over Dave's body. I went into the toilet, and there was cockroaches everywhere. It sounded like cockroaches. I thought, fantastic. Anyway, I look, and all my troubles are gone. Like, what is all this business? Nothing. It's stupid. Get rid of it. I'm just absolutely blissed out. Then, of course, it wears off, and I'm depressed and anxious again.

So before long, we're off on a flight. We're going to Bangkok. And we do the usual tourist trip and wandering into all these beautiful Buddhist buildings. That's it. I have no connection at all with Buddhism. For me, they're just museums. And again, a bit of naughty stuff and cocaine and all that in Bangkok. And none of it really held. It was only years later when I read that book, Emotional Intelligence by Goldman, which brought this whole thing about emotional intelligence into consciousness, that he says in it, if you're a depressive, you tend to be drawn to those drugs that lift you out of your depression. These are not hallucinatory drugs. And if you are an anxious person, you're drawn to alcohol. Well, that's me, isn't it?

So we left Bangkok, we went down through Malaysia, and then we had to walk across the bridge to Singapore. As we got to the checkpoint, they sent us back to get a haircut. We had to cut my hair off, all of it, and then come back, and then we took this boat, which was a real proper lovely little boat, all the way to Port Moresby. It was on its

way to Cairns and down to Australia. That was New Guinea. We flew then from New Guinea to Medang, and I took up my post as a teacher in the Society of the Divine Word Missionary School.

I contacted them again and got this job, myself and Dave. He taught art and I was teaching English. That was a great year teaching those kids—they actually wanted to learn, you know what I mean? Great things like climbing Mount Harbour and going up this boat, which was run by a priest who was really a dislocated cowboy. He went up and down barking orders in that strident American way, giving sermons, selling things and shooting crocodiles. He had his huge rifle. He'd just go "Shoot!"

It was during that time that, because I was settled—and as soon as I was settled, you're kidding, blown me down after the rush—because I'm unsettled, I've got years to go yet. I'm only at the age of twenty-five, I'm not even twenty-five yet. But I get there. So anyway, I've got this dreadful thing going on, this nothingness. I go back from teaching, I don't know what it was, I lie on the bed and I'm suddenly suffused with this enormous fear. For some reason, I don't know, I must have got it from somewhere, I turn towards the fear, and I go into it, and next minute, I'm out of my body. I'm up there looking down, I turn round, I see that tunnel, swirling tunnel, and I'm back into the body. All fear of death disappeared. Not the fear of dying, all fear of death disappeared. And suddenly, out of the blue, I start writing plays. I start writing plays.

I go down to Australia because I'm interested in theatre and I go to a training school really to learn the art of theatre because I know virtually nothing about it. That's where I fall in love again. Hijacked. We have a lovely relationship. It's going fine. We're involved in theater. I get one or two plays going. Suddenly this idea of marriage comes up. My brother just got married. I was twenty-seven. That's what you do. But in my heart of hearts, I wasn't with it at all. But because of the relationship and because of the love, you get married. We went through a civil service. There was something in me that just couldn't handle this. I was getting overly happy. I remember my dear best man, as we got into the taxi, said to me, "You know, Pete"—that's what I was called—"Pete, you've got to take something seriously."

Well, it was a disaster because somebody who had been a friend, a companion, a lover, somebody whom I shared theatre with, suddenly became a burden. I'd fallen into the patriarchal trap. She became a burden. We went on a honeymoon and I drained it of joy. She said to me at one point, "You know, if you carry on like this, I'll leave you." That's not the sort of conversation you have on a honeymoon. It's absolutely awful.

We got to London, and my brother offered us lodgings. Hitting London in November from—it was the beginning of summer in Australia—the rain and the cold, and then we hit the theatre, and it was just overwhelming. Sydney was a small city with a major theatre and a couple of little outlets. You hit London, and it's just impossible. I sent my plays off, and I would follow them up, and I got one play back, and it had "600" written on it. It was just overwhelming. I was so depressed, and I was dragging her down too.

We were at SOAS, School of Oriental and Asian Studies. While we were there, this Nigerian approached us and said he was taking a troop out to Nigeria and would we be interested. Well, we were completely lost. We just said yes. He gave us lodgings. He said, "I'm going to get the group together in a house." I left my brother, went to this house, and it was just an empty room with a mattress in it. We had to put a line up for the clothes. I'm standing there for about two, three weeks, and nothing's happening. We're saying, "Larry, what's, can you show us the play? Can you show us the play?" Finally he shows us this play, and it could have been written by a ten-year-old. It was an inverted racist play. It was all about this great black chief who was going to teach these stupid white people something. Myself and Chris—by the way, her mother was Aboriginal and her father was English—we just looked at each other: got to get out of this, got to get out of this.

Very fortunately, I'd lost contact with Dave, my travelling companion. As we got onto a tube, he was right there. I said, "Dave!" Just a wonderful thing. He was moving out of a flat in Highgate. We were down in Kentish Town. It just worked for us.

The night before, we'd planned the escape because there must have been something in us that told us something like this would happen. We told him that we weren't going to come. That evening he came round and went ballistic. I mean, it was racist. It was awful. My wife stepped forward and slapped his face. He made for her. I grabbed hold of him. I'm on the floor with him. I'm holding him down. I'm shouting, "Relax, Harry, let go." Finally when he gives up the struggle, we both get up and he's standing there and he goes off again. I'm very penitent and I'm saying, "Get back." Finally he left. That night, we slept with chairs up against the doors and a carving knife. I slept with a carving knife. Seven o'clock in the morning, we were in that taxi and off we went.

Anyway, it just got worse and worse and worse. Eventually, my wife got a job in a theatre company up in Birmingham. Really, that was the first leaving. We both knew something was wrong. We knew it wasn't working. Her leaving really was the beginning of her leaving me.

I went back home really depressed. I was back in teaching FE. It was awful. I was getting nowhere with my plays. There was a fantastic opportunity when the director of Earl's Court Theatre actually asked me to come along. I had an interview with him. We were discussing this play I'd read—I mean, you don't do that with a top director. I didn't have the energy to go back with another play. I didn't keep the contact. That's what you do. Once you've got your foot in, you keep pushing. So I'm getting slowly, slowly depressed. That's when Chris tells me that she's fallen in love with somebody else.

Apart from the ego thump, the affection had almost disappeared, really. So there wasn't that sense of loss that you might get from somebody whom you truly love. But it put a cap on my situation. I mean, I was getting nowhere, plays were no good, I was teaching, which I hated doing, I was going nowhere. So I was in a state of absolute despair and shock.

I thought, well, everything I've built up these last years has just collapsed. Then it came to me that it was the most rational thing to do, the most obvious thing to do. In fact, it was common sense. I had to go to Japan to meditate. I don't know how that came. I'd read a book on Zen Buddhism in Sydney, and I'd walked from where I lived to the shops, looking at myself, observing myself. By the time I got to the shops, I thought, no, this is going to drive me crazy. So that was it. That was all I knew.

So I wrote to the Buddhist Society. How did we find places before Google? It's a mystery. Anyway, I wrote to them, and they wrote back and gave me twenty-one reasons as to why I shouldn't go to Japan. But they put me in touch with Throssel Hole Abbey that had only recently opened up in Hexham in Northumberland. From them, they put me in touch with Vajra Bailey, who was teaching in Birmingham, just a bus ride away from where I was living.

I remember going there on a cold February day, and she was very Zen, you know. The house was cold. We got up to the room, and there was a couple of Greek people there. Then she took us into the shrine room. We all bowed, and I thought, this is ridiculous. Then she sat me on a stool, and she pushed my back in and sat me upright. She said, "Just watch. Keep your eyes open like that." The instruction was: watch what comes up.

So I sat there for forty minutes in absolute agony, both emotionally and physically. But by the end of it, I was just convinced this was going to get me out of this hole. She had a room in the house which wasn't occupied, so I went to lodge with her. So that was February. By June, by July, I had a job, which was a really easy one, teaching English to

foreigners, foreign students. I bought a house. Everything began to move in that way. That was my last catastrophe, my last big catastrophe. I've had catastrophes since, but they're only small Cs.

I carry on doing that. Being part of a Zen monastery was like being back in St. Richard's. It just came to me with such ease. I loved going up there, even during the summer holidays. I'd spend six weeks up at Throssel Abbey.

Then one day I came back, and I lay on the bed, and this tremendous fear just filled the whole of my body, every cell—I felt it everywhere. There came this picture of this little boy, two years old, going into the front room, shaking my grandfather and saying, "He's dead, they've killed him, now they're going to kill me." Two years old.

I said to my father, "I found grandfather dead in the front room." He said, "No, he died in bed, I was with him." This tells a lot about trauma, children's trauma. Obviously my parents weren't getting on. I'm thinking I'm the problem, they go in and they presume they've killed my dear old grandfather, and I presume they're going to kill me now. What happened when that trauma came up—you have to be very careful with childhood memories, right? Because you don't know what you're laying on them actually. In the memory I speak to myself in English, but I don't think I had English—in fact, I could speak at the age of two. But that was the thought.

What happened then was I got a series of images coming through my life to tell me how this trauma had cancered every one of my relationships. There's your karmic line. It was just so plain to face, it was unbelievable. That was such a wonderful relief.

Then shortly after that, a little bit longer after that, I'm walking along the road, and on the other side there's a copse of wood. As I turn into the copse of wood, I get this thump on the head. This energy comes down into the heart, it shoots out towards this tree, and what I'm looking at is a kaleidoscopic vortex of energy reaching up into the sky. Can you imagine that? If you can imagine it, I've just turned towards a copse of wood, there's this gentle thump on my head, energy comes down in the centre of my body, it bursts out of my heart centre, and what I'm looking at is one tree amongst them all, which is this multicoloured, kaleidoscopic vortex of energy reaching up into the sky.

For a while I was blissed out and I remember particularly looking at this crimson geometry of a rose. That lasted for an hour or two and then I got depressed and anxious again. Now if you were to ask me if I had a choice between those two—this vision or this purification of the heart—no choice. You go for the purification of the heart. Because that's something you can do. You can't make these other things happen. They

seem to come to cap a certain level. They don't come to begin something. They seem to end a process. I don't think that would have been possible, that insight or vision or whatever it was, without the clearing of the heart.

If you look at the Dhammapada, the Buddha puts the practice as: "Stop doing evil, do good, purify the heart. This is the teaching of all the Buddhas." It's as simple as that. This purifying of the heart, what we go through when we're sitting there with all these things coming up, that is something that we can actually do something directly about.

Now when it comes to this other thing, this bump on the head, what do you think? God? Big being? Or just neurons firing through your head, just atomic, subatomic activity firing through the head. The thing is, I don't know. It didn't feel like a personal God. It just felt as though I was given this gift and I've remained at that level. If something happens like that to you, you don't have to expand it into some huge cosmology. It's just something that you receive. It's just an interesting thing. What I understood by that was that the whole of this phenomenal world is nothing but light. It's nothing but energy. Matter is just the coagulation of it. That's all it is. That's what it's made of. There's nothing real. There's nothing substantial in it.

Anyway, all that passed, and I carried on teaching. The story then is basically how I became a Buddhist. I went up to Throssel, I joined the Zen monastery. Through that, through Vajra Bailey, I met the *Theravāda* monk and I did a retreat with him. In that retreat I was drawn. Then the next year the Mahāsi teachers came and that gave me a real technique in which to really delve into myself in a way that Zen hadn't really done. It was from that that I decided to take a sabbatical from work and I went to Burma with my teacher for six months.

When I came back, during that time, this whole business of impermanence became even clearer because there I actually clearly saw that although this might be, what I'd seen about this tree might be true out there, what's actually true in here is the arising and passing away, minutely, of consciousnesses.

That's actually what we're experiencing all the time, just this screen which is flashing, flashing inside us. And what is it that's aware of it? What is it that is looking at it? And that, of course, is our *satipaṇṇā*, that's our intuitive awareness. And it's that separation which is the process of liberating ourselves from the delusion of thinking that we are this psychophysical organism.

So when I got back, I was really fired up. I was going to make a go of it. I got back to college, to the college I was teaching at, and they gave me a promotion. Can you believe that? So I thought, this is what I've got to do. I'll take it as a bad girl every so often. I'll come back and get a promotion. They gave me a promotion.

During that time, I was ready really to move into the whole thing of marriage. I bought a new house. It was a semi-detached house. And during that time, I began to fall in love again. Oh, my goodness. And so there was then this real potential. But something else started to creep in, which was, why don't I spend three years as a monk?

Now, the monastic order was established by the Buddha exactly for that reason. When you look at the rules of the monastic order, you end up simply learning the Dharma or meditating. There's nothing beyond that if you're keeping the rule as he would want it. And the whole infrastructure that comes with it in a society is that it holds you there, it holds you in that place.

So I struggled with that for about a year, making lists for and against, and for and against. And finally, when it really got on top of me, I went to see Revata Thera, my teacher, and I said, Bhante, I want to become a monk. And he said, you're too old. What a relief. Let's get back and live properly. So that was it. But it wouldn't leave me.

So come another six months, I'm back to him and I'm saying, listen, I've got to, I really have to ordain. Even if it's only for three years. That was my intention, a three-year ordination. So again, he said, well, no, he said, you're needed here. I'd become now so much part of that Vihara. And there were only a few of us. He wasn't the type of person who collected people. So there's only about three of us who held the whole Vihara up.

So again, I went away, but this time I wasn't so convinced. I spent two weeks in meditation with a good friend who read Lord of the Rings while I was suffering in the other room. If you're listening, Peter, you'll remember. And I came back absolutely determined. And when I went to see him again, he said, OK.

So I ordained for three years. And I remember telling my mother. And she burst into this enormous veil of tears. And I put my arm around her. I said, Mum, it's only for three years. And she stopped. In Catholicism, if you're a monk, you disappear. These days they're not so strict, but you disappear into the monastery, you don't see him again.

So there was a lovely feast for that ordination. And I went off to work with Goenkaji in his monastery, in his center in Igatpuri, India. And there, something came out of my neck, some snake or other, it was absolutely awful. And I came back feeling I'd got rid of

some big thing. And who should be there at the Vihara but Upandita, Sayadaw Upandita, some of you might know. He's one of the prime teachers of the Mahāsi tradition, who invited me to come and join him in Burma.

So before I did that, I thought, well, why don't I go and live at Amarawati, the big monastery there, and really get to know what it is to live in this community. So I turned up there, and it was during that year that there were those demonstrations in Burma and all the killing and everything that they did. It was the one before the one that finally made the military pull back. So I decided not to go.

And then at the turning of the year, I said to the sangha, I said to the monk, listen, I ought to go and tell Sayadaw Upandita why I've not turned up. So I went to his retreat in IMS. That's Barre, Massachusetts place. And as soon as I walked into the meditation hall, I just knew this was it. I didn't want to live in that forest community type of monasticism. I wanted this hard grind, full on, full metal jacket meditation.

So I decided to go to Burma. But I couldn't get in. I got to Bangkok. I couldn't get a visa. I ended up in a monastery in the north. I finally caught up with Upandita down in Penang. And I did a retreat with him in Penang there. And by this time, I'm despairing again. Because it's four years. I'm not getting anywhere. I'd determined three years. I thought, well, I'll give it another year. So I'm kneeling in front of the Buddha statue. And I'm saying, look, I've done what I can. I said, if nothing happens in another year, I'm going to go back and do something useful.

So there was a German monk there whom I was talking to and giving him all my sorrows and telling him where I was and all that. And he said to me, why don't you go to Sri Lanka? I said, Sri Lanka? I never even thought. The Mahāsis were out there. So I wrote to Venerable Pemasiri, who was the abbot. And he wrote back and said, come.

When I got there, I told him what I wanted to. I said, I just want to sit. I just want to find somewhere I can sit. So he gave me this bunch of keys and he directs me to this *kuti*, this hut at the back of the meditation room, of the monastery. And when I got there, there's this beautiful little ten foot by six foot hut with a little *cankamana*, a walking area with walls to keep the snakes out and all that. And a garden all to myself. And I walked in there and I thought, this is absolutely marvellous.

So I had a toilet built, that was important. And then there came that day, which was, it's very rare, even in a sense, even in the monastic life, where you didn't have to go into a retreat with the idea that you're going to finish in a month, three months, four

months. I went in with no ending date. And so I sat there going through all this purification of the heart, doing the meditation, two o'clock till ten o'clock at night, really going for it. I was absolutely empowered for doing it.

And it was during that time my second trauma appeared out of the blue. I had this dream of looking across a pond and there was a ghost waving at me. Now this ghost was exactly what you expect a ghost, a big sheet with two eyes. And it was on the other side of the pond. And I was absolutely terrified. And I asked a Jungian psychologist about this. He said it was a birth trauma. I don't know.

And then one night, the dream came once, it came twice, this nightmare. And then one night I woke up and there it was in the corner of the room. And I remember bouncing on the bed in absolute terror and my little voice saying, what do you want? What do you want? And the thing just disappeared. It just fizzled out. And that was it. Something just came out of the heart, this trauma. I still don't know what it means. And then after that, the clarity of impermanence became even more obvious to me.

And it was so fortunate. Death doesn't particularly regard you. Death happens when it wants to do it. It's usually most inconvenient. So at that point, just when everything was finished, my father died. So I remember receiving the news and I was walking back towards the kuti. I'm crying. But I didn't cry long because when I reflected on his life, you know, he had a good life. He was a happy man. He was very sanguine. And I loved him much.

And I went back for his funeral. And then I thought, well, somebody has to stay with my mother, comfort my mother. So I stayed with my mother for a year and I was a real Job's comforter. You know what I mean? I think I caused her more misery. Death stirs things up. I mean, if there's one woman I love to bits, it's my mother. And I could strangle her. So I stayed with her for one year and then I came back and I said to the family, I don't think she's going to live long because she doesn't have the moral support.

Anyway, what happened was I went back with the fierce intention again to start and off I went. And come about, it wasn't very long, something like that, she went seriously ill. And so I came back, and I felt really bad about that year of comforting. And so I really made an effort this time.

And you couldn't live with my mother. It was impossible. So we got her into a lovely nursing home. And at first, she hated it. She talked about le carrozze, these wheelchairs. She couldn't stand the wheelchairs. But when I went to see her after about a month, she

was perfectly at home. She was back in boarding school. She was with all these friends, all these women. She was chatting away. She was the life of the party. It was absolutely wonderful to see her.

Anyway, again, most inconveniently, she decided to have a stroke just before I was off to Sri Lanka. And she died within three days. So having buried her, I then went back to Sri Lanka and started the process again. So the death of my mother was really weird. I felt like an orphan. I mean, I was, what, forty-five years old? And I felt as though, yeah, I felt like an orphan. I wrote this big, long letter to one of my cousins in Italy explaining how awful I felt. I don't know what he's done with it.

And that passed. And then I went back and really went for it again. And there came this point where, oh, it was just impossible. The restlessness, the pain that was coming out of me, it was just constant. It was day in. I woke up into it. I carried it through the day. I slept into it. I woke up and it just went on day after day. And it got to a point when I thought, no, I just can't go on. I can't go on, I'm going to stop.

Well, I can't tell you what happened then. When I gave up at that moment, there came into me this enormous terror, which picked me up and threw me back onto the meditation cushion. Because that's the last thing you do. You can stop for a while, you can leave it, you can get drunk, you can do anything, but you never give up. Once you're on the path, you move on the path. If you give up, there's only one way to go. You're going to go down. And I was horrified. I can't tell you the horror that struck me when I realised that I'd actually given up on my spiritual journey. So I got over that pretty quickly. I just sat on the cushion and plowed my way through it.

So then I'm getting, my body is beginning to suffer, I think. I don't know, I'm beginning to feel weak. I'm not strong. I write to a monk I know in London, who's Dr. Vajiragana. And I write with the intention of staying there just to get my body right.

So I turn up at the London Buddhist Vihara, and I've got this back room, and I'm basically meditating. And the monk who was teaching there decided to leave the order and get married. So who did they ask to sit on the podium? It's me. So I'm sitting there, and I'm slowly beginning to understand that whatever took me to Sri Lanka, that energy, that inspiration was dying away. I didn't want to go back there. How would I live in Britain? So the only way you can live in Britain, if you want to find somewhere spiritually supportive, was to begin to teach. I needed support. So that's where the teaching began.

But, of course, I had this horror of teaching. I really didn't want to do it. So I'm teaching weekend retreats, and come the year 2000, I decide, look, I've got to sort this out, and I go on a retreat with Upandita, outside Upandita's place, Panditarama, in the middle of Rangoon.

And when you go on retreat with a problem, you don't think about the problem. You just go on retreat. And whatever is causing the problem will, in fact, just sort itself out. In other words, what's causing the problem is confusion. That's what's normally the problem. And if you just sit with it, if you just stay with it, as confusion, as fear of making a decision, eventually it just sorts itself out.

So that was another rotten retreat. Six weeks of misery. And then when it passed, it was lovely and peaceful for a week. So I'm down at the end of the retreat and I'm in the hall there and I'm looking at the bookcase and my eye falls on this book. And it's all the stuff on teaching that's taken out of A Course of Miracles. Some of you might know that book, A Course of Miracles. It's a big book and it's got a teacher's book with it. And I pick it out and I'm reading it and by the end of that book I'm absolutely certain that what I've got to do is teach. How weird. It happens, doesn't it? You've got this problem and you call for help and the answer comes. It comes in its own time.

So I get back to Britain. And I go back to the Vihara. And I set up a little trust. And before we know it, we've collected twenty-five thousand pounds to open a center. And that's where the big mistake comes. I open up in the north of London. All my support is in the south. I completely forget that London is not a city. It's a collection of villages. And you don't go from the south to the north for an evening meeting. That's a two-hour journey.

So on the opening day, thirty-odd people came. And what happened was they never came again. And I had this, they never came again, that's it. And come September, Matthias, a Dutch student, he was a student at one of the London universities doing a PhD. And he's very good. He supported me all the way. He's a lovely man. And I said to him, if we don't have somebody by the end of September, we're not going to have a group.

So we advertised all over the place, made these little stickers. And I had two young fellas, and they cycled everywhere. And they put these stickers everywhere, laundrettes, libraries, everywhere. And they had the wrong telephone number. Yeah, you learn, you learn. So the first night the neighbour came and he never came again. The second night nobody came. So by October I'm thinking this is a disaster.

By the end of that season the Sri Lankans had come to help us, especially Sita. She was always there helping me, Dr. Sita Siriwardhana. And then we had this six-week retreat over winter. We closed the place down. There were five of us. And I decided that it was not going to work. I've got to get out.

Luckily, there was a man who was on retreat with me, Peter, who knew the Batchelors. And he got in touch with the Batchelors. That's Stephen and Martine. Some of you might have read their books and might know them.

And he told them that the next cosmic Buddha was in the north of London. So there you go. So they came up to see me, and it was just one of these lovely moments.

Oh, my goodness. I'm really going over the top now. It's 3:15. I'm rushing now. I'm rushing through, right? Where do I need to get to? So anyway, this is it. This is the last bit. So it was just one of those times when Gaia House was stuck. The Bachelors had moved to France. They needed somebody there to look after the personals, about 12 personals. So I went to see Christina Feldman, and I thought it was a great place.

And when I was there, I became really my Dharma teacher's college. Because not only was I retreating with people who had come on personal retreat, some of them were ill with ME and things like that. Some were, you know, psychological problems, not mental illnesses, but, you know, passing depressions and lots of stuff. I had to deal with some of the managers who were running the place and I was given the chance to run these eight-week retreats in the Mahāsi system twice a year. And it was during that time that I realised that there was a little space to start something like this.

So after about a year or two, I decided to leave. I was never really fully into the teachers' organisation there because it's a very lay organisation. And so, again, I came to a choice as to whether to disrobe and become a lay teacher or to remain a monk. It was a bit like, for those of you who know the imagery, a bit like being a Catholic priest amongst Quakers.

So I gave up. I decided to leave. And then we just went through the whole business of a trust. I have a special thanks to Anne Ashton, who was the treasurer, who was the accounts person at Gaia House and she took us through this whole process of getting a lawyer. We've got a lawyer from down in London, you know, a simple letter to the charitable trust and we had it, and it only cost us two and a half thousand pounds. And then we set it up and, well, then it's just history, isn't it? You know, I found this place and from then on I think you know, it's all about that.

So let me see now. Let me see. I've got to finish now. This is the coda. This is finally the coda. Nobody's really rushed me. I could have been here three hours. So first, here we go. All right. Okay.

So you might ask now, after all this, where am I? Everybody wants to know where you are. So the Buddha gives this image of an ocean in which beings are swimming underneath, completely lost. Others bob their head up and down, and some are stable, and they can see there's an island. An island which is both in, but not of, this world.

Now for me, it wasn't an ocean, it's been a swamp, okay? So I'm stuck in this swamp with crocodiles, and every so often there's a bit of a clearing, and that's it. And all I can say is that I know where the island is. That's the important thing. I know where the island is. Does that mean I'm making a beeline for it? Not at all. I slip over here, slip over there, I sometimes turn my back on it. But generally speaking, I'm on the way, right? So that's where you've got to get to.

So you can see how I just stumbled and bumbled and just blundered my way through life, but not without lots of summery somersaults and sticky toffee pudding with custard. And I've landed here in an area of outstanding natural beauty. It's not bad, is it?

Anyway, so now, there are two things. I wanted to talk about some of my spiritual experience, because I want to really release people from keeping it to themselves. Often, you know, I get meditators come to me and tell me similar things that I've told you, and I've said, have you told anybody? They say, no, it's only just for me. Because there isn't that framework within which they feel free to express themselves. And often, of course, if they can't, they get into what's known as a spiritual emergency where it just sends them offline and they end up with a doctor. And if the doctor's not sympathetic, of course, you're back on drugs. It's a psychotic interlude or something.

So be much more open about out-of-body experiences. I go to Gaia and occasionally I'll ask a group of 25 how many people have had out-of-body experiences. Five hands go up. Now, I wouldn't say that's the same percentage for the general population, but it's not an unknown experience, you know?

And so finally, what is it that I would really like to pass on to you? What is it I've come to know? I've come to realise that the difference between me and the Buddha is one of degree and not of kind. And that the difference between me and you is the same. And that the difference between us and all sentient beings, all these animals, if you look into their eyes, the mirrors, the windows to the soul, you'll see they have this intelligence. And that, because of that, the force that lies in us all is to seek happiness. And

because we're deluded, we create all this suffering, but at some point there has to be a turning. You turn round upon it, and at some point in your life, you're pushed by your own suffering to move towards the end of it.

Now Kant has this little phrase called a categorical imperative. And he's talking about the moral law, whereby, if I can just quote him here, if I can just find it just a minute. I can find it somewhere. I thought I'd written it down. Oh, what a shame. It's the definition of it, you see. A categorical imperative by which he means that if you make a moral law, like for instance not to steal, that is unconditionally and completely applicable to all human beings. In the category of stealing, it is an imperative, a command that all human beings obey that. You can't say one human being can steal and others can't.

So I would like to say that it is a categorical imperative that all beings, all sentient beings, will become fully liberated from all suffering forever. Absolutely.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused confusion and befuddlement, and that you will, by your devotion to the practice, unrelenting, unremitting devotion to the practice, come to the end of suffering forever, sooner rather than later.

Sādhu, sādhu, sādhu.

I could have gone on. Sorry about that.

Talk Starting Inaugural Lockdown Evening Meditations 29/03/20

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 24 min

In this inaugural evening meditation talk from March 29, 2020, Bhante Bodhidhamma introduces a new series of lockdown meditation sessions designed to support practitioners during isolation. Drawing from his own experience as a lay practitioner, he addresses the particular challenges of maintaining evening meditation practice and offers practical guidance for using periods of seclusion skillfully.

Bhante discusses various contemplative practices to counter unwholesome mental states that often arise in the evening: contemplation of the Buddha, Dhamma, and Saṅgha; reflection on the brahmavihāras (loving-kindness, compassion, sympathetic joy, and equanimity); consideration of the eight worldly conditions; and the direct investigation of mental states through vipassanā. He emphasizes the importance of establishing beneficial routines, taking on meaningful projects, and maintaining physical exercise during isolation.

The talk culminates in guided evening contemplations including reflections on aging, sickness, and death, followed by brahmavihāra meditation. This session established the format for ongoing evening meditation sessions that would support the community throughout the pandemic lockdown period.

Very good greetings. This is our inaugural evening lockdown meditation and I want to thank you all for coming, both of you. So I want to first of all just start by thanking Charles Denscombe who runs a firm called Video Micro Video and Paul Ebray who works with him. They really set me up for this very quickly, so I'm really grateful. I'm also feeding back on one of their channels, so I'm even more grateful.

Unfortunately, the screen isn't very good because I've got a cheapo laptop here working on that. I have bought a proper camera and things like that, but it's just not arrived. The post is all over the place at the moment, as I'm sure you're aware of. Audience just come in to tell me to speak up a bit louder. So you can tell me if I'm not speaking loud enough. I think there's a sort of live chat where you can say something on the stream here. I'm here too. You're all here. Thank you so much. Oh, I feel much better now. Oh, wonderful. So I hope you've got my opening gambit there to thank Charles Denscombe and Paul Ebray. Very good. Sounds coming across very clearly. I've just had a little message. Thank you very much.

So what I want to do this evening is just set the process off. The first question is, why have I chosen an evening meditation? So I'm just going back to my own experience as a lay practitioner. And it was fairly easy to establish the morning meditation. In fact, that was almost, I rarely missed it. There'd be a good reason for missing it. You just get into that routine, you get up, you wash your face, and then you sit, and then you go and have breakfast. And that I think most people find fairly simple to establish. No matter for how long, it doesn't matter how long. It's the quality, isn't it? 20 minutes, 40 minutes, one hour, two hours if you can make it.

But the evening sit was always very difficult. By the way, I can see myself talking to myself. It was a very strange situation. So the evening sit was always difficult. But of course, when I did do it, I saw the benefits of it. If you're working, I found that the best time was when you get home and you have a cup of tea or something, and then just to sit in a chair, you don't have to sit formally and just let the day pass through the mind. If it's been a good day and you feel full of joy, then really appreciate that and see where you've been skillful and encourage yourself to be more skillful like that. And when you've had a bad day, some arguments, some anxiety, it's been boring or whatever, to come back and just let that manifest and let it work its way out of the heart and that way you feel so much better for the evening. And then of course later on just before you go to bed to just sit quietly with something, some reading, *mettā* of course. That's the time you tend to fall asleep and you don't want to fall asleep before you get into bed because that messes you up. So if you're working it's a slightly different rhythm I think that works.

As opposed to this. This is really aimed at people who are isolating, like myself. I am actually in splendid solitude. So I'm not concerned about lockdown at all. In fact, I'd be happy if it was a permanent state. I have with me now, actually, Sarah Blackman from the South. People in Brighton will know Sarah. And Noreen is with me. Mark had visited us on last Friday and then discovered later on that he'd been eight hours working with somebody who had contracted CV. So we're in isolation here till next Friday. And Mark's had no symptoms. We've had no symptoms, so we think we're fairly free. At least we're okay till tomorrow.

Now when you're in isolation of course in the spiritual life you call it seclusion. You seek seclusion, you seek solitude. Now of course you'll know that if you're a naughty prisoner you get put into solitary confinement. So you can see it can be used both as a way of spiritual practice and as a way of actually punishing somebody. So we've got to be careful that we don't see it as a punishment.

So evening, of course, we tend to feel a bit tired. We tend to feel a bit bored or what-not. We're looking to distract ourselves. And so this is the time, the evil one, Māra, the enticer, gets hold of us and we get into old habits. Habits that we don't want. We sleep, for instance, which really messes your sleep pattern up. We eat, butter toast and things like that with jam. Oh, my God. So you can find yourself slipping into old habits which really are not going to do you much good.

So to actually set a time in the evening where you sit obviously is the best policy. And that's why I chose this particular time because I'm hoping that afterwards most of you who are in isolation will actually go to bed and rise early. As they say, what is it? Early to bed and early to rise makes a man healthy, wealthy, and wise. And I presume that's also true for women. It's an old one, yeah.

So we've got to be careful in the evening. The old ghosts come out. So there's anxiety, depression, a bit of feeling down rather than depression, and we want to escape that so that's why we try to find some entertainment and whatnot. So the idea of this particular meditation at this time of the evening is to stop that happening and I'm hoping that you make it a regular practice with me. So that's the first thing.

There are practices that you can do which undermine certain mental states, sense of despair, for instance, even boredom. It doesn't matter really what mental state it is, unwholesome mental state, really just contemplating the Buddha Dharma Sangha is one way of lifting the heart. The Buddha, of course, is this historical personage but also recognizing that within us the Buddha is here within us and it's seeking liberation and according to the Buddhist tradition everybody will attain liberation at some point or other. And the Dharma, just think about the benefits that you've received from the Dharma, the benefits that others have received, it lifts the heart. And the Sangha, the fact that we have people in the world who've attained some of these paths and fruits, but also that we have a Sangha around us, friends, Dharma friends around us supporting us. And these days that can be a real benefit especially with all this communication business. We've just had an AGM this afternoon. We used teams and it was pretty successful. So there's no reason why we can't communicate with each other these days. Of course, relating is a different matter. But we won't go into that this evening.

The other thing, of course, is to contemplate the *Brahmavihāras*, love, compassion, joy and peace. And that's what I'll be doing at the end of the sitting this evening. But we'll come to that.

There's also contemplations of sickness, aging and death. It sounds a bit depressing to actually do that, but it's really coming to terms with the reality of our lives. And something that this CV, this coronavirus has brought up is the paranoia that everybody

feels around sickness, even though really it's the elderly. And even they have to have some sort of physical problems who are in real danger. Of course, it is killing others, but very minor. Even so, even if you could describe it as a very, very bad flu, people are very afraid of it. Of course, having said that, I know a lot of people need hospital help for breathing and stuff. So I'm not saying we shouldn't take it seriously, but the paranoia is way up there. And we undermine that unrealistic paranoia by reflecting that the body gets sick and eventually we die, and that's the end of it. It's just one of those things.

Also, there's the eight worldly conditions, contemplating sickness and health, contemplating success and failure, fame and disgrace, praise and blame, pleasure and pain and just knowing that these things flow. Sometimes you're successful and sometimes you fail. That's the way it is. Life just moves through that and it's finding that position above it all, a sort of equanimity with it.

And then finally there's *vipassanā*. So it's really just sitting with the mental state that comes up, knowing it is just another mental state and sitting in it. You've got to sit in the bonfire. You've got to sit in the dung heap, not next to it, not above it or around it, but in it. You've got to sit in and you've got to burn. And of course, we wait, if you can wait, until it completely exhausted, then you find that healing at the end of it.

Yeah, this happened to me in the year 2000 when I went on a two month retreat to Burma to Sayadaw U Paṇḍita's place in Yangon. And the six weeks were some of the worst meditations I've had ever. It was absolutely awful. Something came up. I couldn't put my finger on it. It wasn't despair or anything like that. It was just horrible. And I couldn't even do the slow walking meditation it was just so overpowering and after six weeks it finally just disappeared. And the gift of course was this beautiful state of peace that arises. So if you can wait until these negative states exhaust themselves you do see that they're being transformed.

So there's contemplating the Buddha, Dharma, Sangha, the virtues, I've forgotten that, the eight worldly conditions and so on. There's contemplating sickness, aging, and death, just to get us into the feel of these things. And there's the practice of *vipassanā* and *mettā*. So that's the first thing. That's what you can do to undermine mental states, unwholesome mental states in the evening.

The next one is the importance of routines. I can't stress that too much. As you know, when you come on retreat, you've got to get into that routine. It takes three or four days and then you're into it. And after five or six days, it's natural. Even if you don't want to get out of bed, your body gets out. So it's that routine that you want to establish.

And make it simple. Remember Ajahn Tate's words, take it easy. Make it simple, take it easy, and stay with the one who knows. There are things, you've got to do it religiously, remember. Once you've set your routine for the day, you've got to do it religiously until you know it's become a habit. And that takes maybe four or five days. And then if you slip, you've got to reestablish it. You've got to reestablish your commitment to that routine. It's not as though you can't change the routine, but you've got to recognize that you've got to make it some sort of habit.

One thing that you can do, of course, is go a bit slower around the place. Slow eating. You're supposed to chew the food 32 times. That's what I read on Google. 32 times until it loses its texture. It's sort of pre-vomit. Oh, I shouldn't have said that. I'm sorry. It's before it goes into the stomach. Remember, the stomach doesn't have any teeth. So if you put hard stuff in there, it's going to be difficult. Closing fridge doors, closing doors, just to bring a certain mindfulness, a slowness and mindfulness around whatever you're doing. So that's the routine. That's important.

The third thing is projects. You've got to have projects. They can be a day's project, a week's project, et cetera, et cetera. I mean, I've set myself one. I'm going to reread as much as I can of the Middle Length Sayings. And in the evening, if there aren't any questions, I mean to use that as a way of giving a small talk or something. My brother, for instance, has taken on practicing the piano so you can get the next grade so it really is anything, anything that you can feel you can commit to, something that you wanted to do but you've never got around to doing it, a new skill, learn a language and there's all this free stuff that you can access on the website so it really is quite simple to get yourself excited about something.

The final thing is exercise. Yeah, you've got to keep your exercise going. And if you're confined to a space, then that's really quite important. When I was practicing in Burma, I didn't do any exercise for about six months and I lost muscle. I felt really, really weak. I determined to find something that would give me just that little bit of muscle tone. And what I discovered were the Canadian Air Force exercises which were famous at the time. I mean basically you just within the space of your own body you do push-ups, press-ups, jump-ups and all sorts of ups and that keeps you going, running on the spot, things like that. The one thing that they showed you was straight legs if you do sit-ups or that is a killer, don't do that at all, bend your legs. That's one of the reasons I've got a bad back. I didn't get around to suing them.

But if you go on there, there's all sorts of things. You can do some shadow boxing. Yeah, just get it out of the system. Jog around the room. In one retreat I was in, the only real, because it was in North America, and it was at the Forest Refuge, and it was during

winter, and it was minus 20 or something. So in the morning when I used to run up, I used to walk up and down stairs. And that was pretty good. Anyway, again, if you go on to the websites, you've got all sorts of suggestions. There's one for cardio workout for small places.

And there's one that he suggested, which is called a burpee. So I looked that one up, a burpee, that sounds interesting. And this is what you do. You have to stand upright, stand upright with your arms to your side and your feet apart. And then you lower your body into a squat. And then you put your hands on the floor and you kick back so that your body is straight, straight and you do a push up. And then you jump back into a squat and then it says explosively jump into the air and when you land you die. No, no, when you land you go back into a squat and you do the whole thing again. So I'll try and build up to that over the two months, bit of luck.

So with those little pointers in mind, I'm probably teaching grandmother how to suck eggs but sometimes it's worth saying the obvious. That's my inaugural encouragement to use this time, especially if you are in real lockdown, people who've got physical problems. Roy, for instance, who's done all our work here on the ground, digging the trenches, putting in the septic tank and all that, he doesn't have any kidneys. And so he's basically locked into his home. So there are many people like that. And I know some of the people who come here are like that. So I'm aiming a great deal of this towards them, but it also works with people for those of you who are working and you have to go out, to come back and come and join us in the evening.

Okay. So we're moving up to 8:19. I just want to say what I mean to do this evening. I hope you were able to download the evening contemplations. Yeah. So I'm going to start with the refuge and precepts and then I'm going to do the evening meditations. So this is what we do here on retreat, of course, the old sickness, aging and death. Can't get away from it.

And then towards the end, I'll spend about 15 minutes or so just going through the *Brahma Vihāras*. First of all, compassion, then joy, and then *metta*. Equanimity, I'm presuming, is sustained underneath it. And I shall read out the discourse on loving kindness and then chant.

Now, during that chant, some of you know the chant, so you can chant along. Chant along a monk, you see. You sit along a monk and you can chant along a monk. So you can do that or just put some good intentions into your heart. May you be safe, well and happy. The ones that we use here, may you be safe, well and happy. May all beings be safe, well and happy. You can bring individuals to mind and just use it to express your loving kindness.

Well, I've done my inaugural speech and whatnot. And I'm just wondering if there's any questions that have come up about that. I see there's lots of people have joined us. Nice comments. Thank you very much. So we have somebody from Sweden and Italy.

Oh yes, you're on the continent, of course, then you're one hour ahead of us, so it's actually past nine really. What might be possible if you don't want to stay up that long is that eventually I will have the meditation itself as a separate video, and if you wanted to, you could use that to encourage yourself and then at eight o'clock, which would be your nine o'clock, you can join me live for whatever we're doing, for the talk or for the discussion.

If you do want to ask a question, it would be good if you emailed it to me in the morning or sometime during the day, definitely before six o'clock, or then five o'clock really, and then it gives me time to prepare some answer, because usually it comes off the top of my head. But it would be nice to prepare something.

So it's lovely to see everybody here. That's very lovely. Yes, so thank you all for coming. That's fantastic. So if you can, of course, stay with me every night. But if you can't, at least come and join me when you can.

So unless there are... I'm presuming everybody who's going to join has joined now. So if there's any... unless there's an actual question, I shall then proceed to the meditation. That's lovely. I'm just looking at all the people who come and join. Fantastic. Surprisingly, I've got here 127. That's not bad, is it? I can see that, 127. I might become famous at last.

So there's the offering every evening at eight o'clock, some small talk or answering some questions, and then we'll start the sitting. Join the sitting.

02 First Three Noble Truths

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 32 min

In this foundational teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the first three Noble Truths from the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta (SN 56.11), exploring why they form the cornerstone of all Buddhist teaching. He begins with dukkha - not merely suffering, but the fundamental unsatisfactoriness of conditioned existence, including birth, aging, sickness, death, and crucially, not obtaining what one wants. The teaching delves into the five aggregates affected by clinging (upādāna) and how our sense of identity creates existential suffering.

The second Noble Truth reveals taṇhā (craving or thirst) as suffering's cause - encompassing craving for sensual pleasures, becoming, and non-becoming. Bhante explains how our desires are actually attempts to create specific mental states, forming compulsive habits that keep us trapped. The third Noble Truth offers hope: the complete cessation of suffering through relinquishing all craving.

Drawing from the Sammādiṭṭhi Sutta (MN 9), this talk demonstrates how understanding any aspect of Dhamma fully leads to liberation, as all teachings interconnect. Perfect for newcomers seeking to understand Buddhism's foundational framework and experienced practitioners deepening their comprehension of these essential truths.

Greetings all. Very good. There are, at the moment, 66 people, all looking at me, for heaven's sake. That's very lovely.

So, I'll just start in my usual way.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa
Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa
Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

I'm presuming you can hear me. It's always good to have a little test there. If somebody could just give me a nod to say they can hear me, that would lessen my sense of overwhelming anxiety. Nobody's answering. Well, I'm just presuming you can hear me. Yes, I'll have to presume. Very good. Loud and clear. Thank you so much. Very good. Audio is great. Right. I'm with it. Yeah, that's enough. Thank you very much.

So, yes, hopefully you've had a fruitful day. Just to reiterate, if something comes up which is a bit heavy for you to handle, feel free to get in touch. Use my email, bbbodhibodhi at gmail.com. Sometimes it's good just to talk to somebody. I'm thinking, obviously, especially for those people who find themselves locked in by themselves, that can be a bit of a miserable state, although these days it's lessened with all the social media that's a blessing really.

So I just wanted to... oh, by the way, the little talk I give in the evenings, you'll find them as separate little items on the channel so that if you happen to miss some of my pearls of wisdom one night, you can always check it up in the daytime.

I wanted to answer these questions that were sent to me: "To what extent can it be argued that the Four Noble Truths was the Buddha's most important teaching?" It sounds a bit like one of these A-level questions. And "Are all the stages of the Eightfold Path equally important?"

Now, this discourse, which is the Sammādiṭṭhi, the Right View discourse, where Sāriputta is being asked basically what right view do we need to have in order to become liberated, and he gives various answers to that. And there's a suggestion that if you understand any of these fully, that would lead to liberation. Now, that only makes sense when we realize that the teaching, the Dharma, is all one piece, really. Once you investigate one part of it, it naturally leads you to other parts.

Anyway, he's being asked again, "But friend, might there be another way by which a noble disciple is of right view and has arrived at this true dharma?" And he says, "Yes there is." And then there is what you might call a regular expression of the Four Noble Truths. So I'll read those out: "What is the noble truth of suffering? What is the origin of suffering? What is the cessation of suffering? And what is the way leading to the cessation of suffering?" So there's your Four Noble Truths.

"Birth is suffering, aging is suffering, sickness is suffering, death is suffering, sorrow, lamentation, pain, grief and despair are suffering, not to obtain what one wants is suffering. In short, the five aggregates affected by clinging are suffering." We'll take it one by one.

Now, that's pretty straightforward, isn't it? The whole business of being born is not particularly pleasant either for the child and the mother. And then aging and all... so all of it is pretty straightforward. But then there's this little sentence: "not obtaining what one wants." Now there's your frustration, your anxiety that you might not get it, all that stuff.

This word *dukkha*, that's what it's translating as suffering. These days, people prefer "unsatisfactoriness." The word *dukkha* itself means just "hard to bear." Du is like... it just means bad, not good. And ka means to bear something. So it's something that's difficult to bear. And it's used figuratively, for instance, to describe an axle in a wheel which doesn't quite fit. So you get the grinding noise. It doesn't quite fit.

And what *dukkha*, what the Buddha is saying, the way he's using the word, is not just on these obvious things like ordinary sufferings and pains and all that sort of stuff. But there is this business of not getting what one wants. And that's to do with our desires, our expectations. So that obviously causes us a lot of suffering. But the next sentence goes a little deeper. It says the five aggregates affected by clinging are suffering.

Now those of you who know dependent origination will know the middle links, which connect or express how we create this suffering. So remember there is this point of contact. Then there's the discernment that what we're experiencing is pleasant or unpleasant, liking, disliking. And then, of course, we choose to grasp at or desire what's pleasant and push away what's unpleasant. And that's the reaction. But it's the next one where we *upādāna*, which means to cling to, get hold of.

Now this *upādāna* is manifest in four different ways. First of all, a clinging to the pleasures of the senses. That's the sort of clinging. And of course, if you are not being pleased, then your response is to get rid of it. So there's always this duality of aversion and desire. And the aversion, of course, splits into two. You either get rid of it or run from it.

And then there's this holding onto views, opinions. I'm right, everybody else is wrong. That's also a sort of clinging. Then there's this one about rules and regulations. This is really going back to an understanding of the time when ritual was a way of appeasing the gods or demanding the gods to do something. So if you think that, for instance, bowing to the Buddha, lighting candles and all that sort of stuff actually is going to liberate you, then you are definitely deluded. So that's the rules and regulations.

But the one that I particularly reinforce when I'm talking about this is identity. Because that's where the root cause is. The root cause is the sense of "I." And that's really where the suffering becomes existential. It becomes a position of "me." And that comes most obvious when death approaches us, but also serious illness or indeed the death of somebody we love or the serious illness of somebody we love. It impinges upon us. It begins to question our identity because this identity, this self, this feeling of "me" has a feeling about it of permanence. Even though we're quite happy to get rid of it when we fall asleep, there's the presumption that next morning I'm going to wake up and say, "Oh, here I am again."

So that's the suffering. It's pretty straightforward: unsatisfactoriness, not being able to get fully satisfied with life. It's always going to let us down a bit, even when we've got everything, the right house, the right car, the right partner, the right children, et cetera, et cetera. At some point, it just begins to disappear. And that's the way it is.

Then there's the suffering which is not getting what you want. And then there's the suffering which is to do with this existential, this sense of self. So this word *dukkha*, which is very difficult to define, very difficult to translate because it has such a wide meaning. And what the Buddha is really saying is that the whole of life, the whole of human life is unsatisfactory.

And I always liked the quote from Jesus on this when he said, "The birds have their nest holes, but the son of man has nowhere to rest his head." So I think that puts it very, very poetically, very beautifully.

So then, of course, there's the origin of suffering or the cause of suffering. And that is: "It is craving which brings renewal of becoming, is accompanied by delight and lust and delights in this and that. That is, craving for sensual pleasures, craving for becoming, and craving for non-becoming. This is called the origin of suffering." It's translated here as origin, but I would probably prefer the word "cause," the basic cause of suffering.

So the word here that's being translated is *taṇhā*, which some authors, I think, probably are closer to the mark when you translate it as a thirst, a lack, a sense of lack. That's another translation that some authors use. And those get close to it. Craving is a bit too strong, although we do have cravings. It's actually covering all desires, even from the simplest thing, like when you're watching TV and you feel a bit uncomfortable, there's a desire to move.

So if you watch all your intentions you'll see that they're all, normally speaking, desires to get rid of something you don't like or get something you do like. And so we're constantly manipulating the world to make ourselves feel comfortable. And it's accompanied, you see, with delight and it's got lust here, but it's more like indulgence, delight and indulgence.

So the question that we have to ask ourselves: when I want something, when I want something or someone from this position of trying to escape suffering, because that's what we're doing when we're often indulging things, and also enjoying it, what is it that we really want? Do we actually want the object we're desiring or the effect that the ob-

ject has on us? Have a guess, what do you think? What is it we really want? I mean, do we really want porridge or do we want what porridge does to us? Toast, that's another one. Yeah, I know I'm a bit obsessive about toast.

So it's trying to establish or trying to develop a certain mental state, isn't it? A certain emotional feeling state. And that's what this craving does or this thirst. And it produces habits.

And what we discover in meditation, and even now with this lockdown, is that when you interrupt a habit, when you stop a habit, it suddenly becomes a choice. Normally, we're running with habits. You get up, you do this, you do that. You want a piece of toast. See, I'm at it again. And off you go. But when you can't, when there's no bread, you see, or when the toaster is broken, the habit's broken, and it comes back at you. And now most times we would fight that and run out and get a toaster. But it also gives us a choice, you see, a choice to bring about an end to that compulsive behavior.

So if we look upon this lockdown, some of us are having to stay in rooms, can't actually leave. This is an opportunity really to see where these obsessive compulsive things are. And of course it can be difficult. It can be very difficult. But that's the whole reason for practicing this *vipassanā*, that you find a different relationship with it so that you allow the heart to express its turbulences, no matter how difficult that may be. And what we discover, of course, is that that's the way it heals itself.

So that's the origin or the cause of suffering. Sorry, I'm not finished yet. There's also the craving for becoming. So there's yourself, you see, always wanting to become. And you'll notice how you're always ahead of yourself. You're always thinking about what you're going to do in a minute or in an hour or this afternoon or when you go to work or when you don't go to work or when you retire. Yeah. What are you going to do, you see? So the self never feels safe just being in the present moment. It can't hold that position because it's unsafe. It doesn't know what's going to happen next, for heaven's sake. So this craving for constantly becoming.

And the other one is craving for non-becoming. So that, of course, takes us to the dark side: to put an end to this because of the suffering that we're having, leading towards suicide, right? That's the worst. Or if you're angry with somebody, murdering them because they're stopping you getting happy. But we've given that up, remember, because we take the five precepts. Yeah, so that craving for becoming and craving for non-becoming, that digs deep again to this existential problem about who am I. And that's the question: who am I or what am I?

Then finally, and then the third one is cessation of suffering. How does all this stuff come to an end? So this is the regular formula: "It is the remainderless fading away and ceasing, the giving up, relinquishing, letting go and rejecting of that same craving. Just this is the end of suffering, the cessation of suffering."

Now that sounds really simple, doesn't it? Just to give up the craving, give up all these obsessive desires, this compulsive behaviour, and voila, you've made it. But of course what we discovered is that that's no easy thing at all. And that becomes very obvious when we go on retreat, just the difficulty of changing our habits completely. The first three days, as you know, are all blood, sweat and tears. And then it eases off a bit, but never a lot. And it's always been a struggle. So the practice is hard. The Buddha doesn't pull punches on that.

I'm sure you've heard me quote from the scriptures there. Somebody says to the Buddha, "This training is very hard." And he says, "Well, it is hard, but in the end, you're liberated, you achieve *nibbāna*." And the questioner says, "Yeah, so what?" And the Buddha says, "Well, at the end of it, you are happy and contented." *Tuṭṭhi sukha wahati, tuṭṭhi*. That's the word for contentment, *tuṭṭhi*. Tutti frutti.

So that's this business of cessation. And the final one is, of course, the Eightfold Path.

Now the question is: "Can it be argued this is the Buddha's most important teaching?" Well, if you can imagine when the Buddha had his awakening and it was said he spent a week thinking about especially dependent origination, the psychology that he had discovered, and then he began teaching...

The first part of the scriptures which you'll see... some of you might know the *Sutta Nipāta*, which was translated by Venerable Ñāṇamoli. Ñāṇamoli was the chief monk at the London Buddhist Vihara in the 80s. And when I ordained he was my preceptor. So although all my meditation teachers were Burmese, my ordination was into one of the Sri Lankan orders. And he's translated it. It's a lovely translation, that, the *Sutta Nipāta*. And Bhikkhu Bodhi has done a great big, huge volume which translates the commentary as well.

Now, the interesting thing about the *Sutta Nipāta* is that it's pretty original. And that always surprises me, really, because you can see the original teaching wasn't so formalized. He's answering individual questions. And slowly, you know, the teaching becomes formalized. And that's when you get these, you know, four of these, ten of those, nine of them, and so on and so forth. And that formalization is the middle bit. And then it becomes, towards the end, it becomes very listy, like, to help you remember things and it begins to be a bit like the Abhidhamma, which was a later development which takes

away all that... what would you call it... not humanity. When you read the scriptures you do get the feeling of a person, the Buddha talking and people who are talking to him. And as the teacher becomes more and more intellectualized, that begins to disappear and it really does become lists.

So there's these three waves of development. And it's interesting, I think it's surprising, that the oral tradition maintained those very early teachings. They're there. And then of course you get this more formalized... the Four Noble Truths.

So when he has finally formalized it, these Four Noble Truths are the foundation of the whole teaching. And you could say that if you come across any teaching, so-called Buddhism, which doesn't fit into the understanding of the Four Noble Truths, then it's not right. It's not particularly right.

And each of these noble truths, of course, launches out into various other teachings, and we'll come to some of them very much in this particular discourse. Whenever you start talking about *kamma*, or start talking about the body, it doesn't matter where you start—whatever it is you start talking about, you always end up really investigating the whole of the dharma because it just leads from links one to another until you've virtually covered it. And you'll always come down to this root level about *dukkha*.

If you were going to encapsulate in one word the Buddha's understanding of the human condition, that's the word: *dukkha*. And if you wanted to choose one word which encapsulates the fundamental problem that we have, it would be *atta*—self—the teaching around not-self. And if you were to choose one word which expresses the way out of it, the actual practice to get out of it, it would be *sati*—awareness. But you'd have to put *samma* in front of it—it's right awareness. It's a specific definition.

In other words, if you're thieving, you're fully aware, but it's not going to get you liberated. It might make you rich for a little while.

So that's the phone number. I'm just looking at the time. Oh, it's going on. So I want to leave it there, and then tomorrow we'll have a look at the stages. And the question is: are all the stages of the Eightfold Path equally important? So we can have a look at that tomorrow.

Very good. So yesterday I forgot to take the refuges and precepts for those of you who would like to do it. And then once I've done that, we can sit and, as usual, towards the end, I'll do these contemplations.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I have not caused even greater confusion, and that by your devotion to practice you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Very good. So I shall now do the chanting. That's odd. My computer says twenty-five minutes past eight, but my clock says half past eight. I don't know. We can begin.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhassa
Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhassa
Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhassa

Buddham saranam gacchami
Dhammam saranam gacchami
Sangham saranam gacchami

Dutiyampi Buddham saranam gacchami
Dutiyampi Dhammam saranam gacchami
Dutiyampi Sangham saranam gacchami

Tatiyampi Buddham saranam gacchami
Tatiyampi Dhammam saranam gacchami
Tatiyampi Sangham saranam gacchami

Panatipata veramani sikkhapa dam samadiyami
Adinnadana veramani sikkhapa dam samadiyami
Kamesu micchacara veramani sikkhapa dam samadiyami
Musavada veramani sikkhapa dam samadiyami

We can begin our sitting. Make sure you're comfortable, feeling comfortable, and settling on the breath.

We can begin our sitting with these evening contemplations, which the Buddha says are there to make us more enthusiastic, to give us some real purpose as to why we're practising. So just repeating these phrases to ourselves:

This body is subject to disease. This body is of a nature to fall ill. This body has not gone beyond sickness.

This body is subject to ageing. This body has not gone beyond ageing. This body is now in a process of ageing.

This body is subject to death. This body has not gone beyond death. This body will die.

There is the unborn, undying, uncreated, uncompounded, the unconditioned—true refuge, harbour and home, perfect peace and contentment.

Those who are mindful are in the presence, in the vicinity of *Nibbāna*.

Sammādiṭṭhi Sutta (MN 9): Discourse on Right View — Wholesome and Unwholesome Kamma

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 23 min

In this foundational talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma guides us through the Sammādiṭṭhi Sutta (MN 9), where Sāriputta—the Buddha's chief disciple known as the 'General of the Dhamma'—explains Right View as the cornerstone of spiritual understanding. The discourse covers the first of five aspects of Right View: distinguishing wholesome from unwholesome actions and understanding their roots in greed (lobha), hatred/aversion (dosa), and delusion (moha).

Bhante examines the ten unwholesome actions across body, speech, and mind—from killing and stealing to idle chatter and covetousness—showing how they all stem from our fundamental misunderstanding of identity and where true happiness can be found. He emphasizes that Buddhist ethics goes beyond mere moral rules to encompass our entire relationship with the world, noting how every perception creates a relationship that can be either wholesome or unwholesome.

The talk addresses practical concerns often overlooked in traditional presentations—feelings of sadness, anxiety, anger, and the five hindrances—explaining how these too fall under unwholesomeness. Bhante highlights the supreme importance of understanding kamma (the law of consequence) as the foundation for all spiritual progress, noting that even accepting this principle qualifies one as a 'lesser stream-entrant' (chūḷa-sotāpanna). Through examining our ethical development over time, we can gauge our meditation progress and movement toward liberation.

Good evening, everybody. I messed up yesterday. Amateur. So that's the way it is sometimes. What can you do? So I shall begin.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhasa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhasa. Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

Even though I wasn't here, I know you all kept to your practice. There can be no doubt about that. I have three options when I go on: I can go private, which is just for me, or I can go for only those people whom I've personally invited, or I can go public.

So I made the mistake of going private. Well, it wasn't so much a mistake. I thought you'd all be able to beam in because of your extranormal powers. But I was mistaken. I had many emails asking me whether I'd died or not. I haven't died.

So what I'm going to do in the evening is try to choose a discourse from the Majjhima Nikāya. It's a great big book. There's 160 odd of these discourses. And just try to get our way through them. What I mean to do is reduce the discourse to a simple formula and then maybe address some of the things.

Now, you may have questions, questions which are not related to what I'm talking about. So it's best to email them and I'll answer them that evening if it's before lunch, because after lunch I'm preparing this. There were a couple of questions actually that came through. I haven't put their name, unfortunately. To what extent can it be argued that the Four Noble Truths was the Buddha's most important teaching? And then are all the stages of the Eightfold Path equally important? So I'll tackle that tomorrow, if I may.

What I'm going to do is chop off the first half hour, which will be these little discussions or talks, and separate them and list them on the YouTube so you can have a listen to them later if you can't be here for that.

So the discourse is called *Sammādiṭṭhi Sutta*. Discourse, it means the discourse on right view. And the person who's giving it isn't the Buddha himself, it's Sāriputta. Now Sāriputta was known as the general of the dharma. The Buddha gave nicknames to about 80 of his disciples. Sāriputta was known as *Mahāpañña*, the great wise one.

Moggallāna, whom I'm sure you know, was the second great disciple. He was called *Iddhimanto*, which means psychic power. Some of you will know the story of Bāhiya of the Bark-cloth, who asked for instructions while the Buddha was on his alms round. The Buddha said, can you wait till later? And he pleaded with him and said, no, I'm an old man. He's over 73. He gave him this teaching and he was immediately enlightened, but later on gored by a cow. He's known as *Khippābhiñña*, which is the most speediest enlightened person.

There's also Sīvali. That's a story that goes with that which I might say some other time. He was known for his ability just to get alms even when there was a famine. So he was called *Lābhī*, which just means receiver of gifts.

Two women, two nuns that you may know, are Kisāgotamī. She was known as wearing rough robes. She was the one who had lost a child and was crazed with grief. And he sent her to find a mustard seed from a house where there'd been no death. And that brought her back to her senses. And she ordained and then became fully liberated.

There was also Paṭācārā, which is another terrible story where she lost all her family, if you remember. Her husband, on the way back with her husband, her husband died from a snake bite. The two children were taken away by the great river. And by the time she got to her village to visit her parents, the house had burnt down with her parents in it. So she was in a pretty bad state. And she also joined the Order and became fully liberated. She was known as *Vinaya-dharā*. She was pretty heavy on the old Vinaya, the rule.

The two great lay supporters: Anāthapiṇḍika, so he was the one who bought the first monastery for the Buddha, and that's where this actually takes place. This discourse takes place in Jeta's Grove, Sāvattī. Sāvattī was the capital of the northern kingdom, whose name I forget. That's a senior moment. And he bought this field off Jeta, Prince Jeta, and he said he's covered it with gold, meaning he got done for that because he wanted the grove so much that Prince Jeta could ask for anything he wanted. So he's known as *Dāyaka*, which means supporter. It's a special title that the Buddha gave him. And that's a word we use for anybody now who supports the Saṅgha, the *Dāyaka*.

And of course, there was Visākhā, who was also a very famous supporter of his. The reason I remember it, because she once turned up at the monastery and all the monks were bathing in the rain, in the torrential monsoon rain, completely naked. Well, she was very upset. And so she went out and bought all this cloth so that they could cover themselves. It never became one of the requisites, one of the eight things that you get when you ordain.

So this is Sāriputta who's been asked this question, and the question is: is there a way, the one right view whose view is straight, who has perfect confidence in the dharma and has arrived at the true dharma? In other words, what do you have to have the right view about, the right understanding about, in order to achieve the true dharma, the true teachings? And he gives five ways.

The first one is unwholesome actions and wholesome actions and their roots as to why we behave like that. Then there's the nutriment. That's very rarely taught, the nutriment. And then, of course, there's the Four Noble Truths. And then he goes through dependent origination backwards. So he goes from ignorance all the way through to the end. And then finally the taints, which, again, as some of you might know, the word is *āsava*, which is like the sap coming out of a tree which can make frankincense. It oozes out of the tree, but it's also the oozings of pus from a boil. And I think that's the image we have to have when we think of the *āsava* that we have to get rid of.

So what I want to do this evening is just talk around about these unwholesome actions. The list of unwholesome actions, I mean, they're pretty straightforward. The physical ones: you have to stop killing people, and then you have to stop thieving from them, and then of course there's sexual misconduct. Now when it comes to those things, they're pretty heavy, they're pretty obvious.

Speech is just a bit more refined. You've got to be on your guard because we're always speaking. If we're not speaking to somebody then we're speaking to ourselves. False speech: you have to stop telling lies from now on. Malicious speech, that's to do with intent. Remember, you might say something which is not giving somebody a good name for a very good reason, but your intention is to put somebody straight about them if they're employing them. Something like that.

Then there's abusive speech. Sometimes it's translated as gossip, but gossip can be more like malicious speech, can't it? It's more like idle prattle. That's the best sort of translation. We're just talking for talking's sake. Now, those are to do with speech. And so the Buddha is asking us to be guarded with that.

And the mental ones, which are covetousness, wanting what other people have, envy. At worst, jealousy. You hate them for having what they have. And there's ill will, of course. You don't want any of that. And, of course, wrong view. Wrong views about things.

Now, these actions have their roots. And I'll give you just one second to guess what the roots are. You won't be surprised. Yes, you've got it. It's greed, hatred, or aversion, and delusion. So this *lobha dosa moha*. *Lobha* is really just indulging. It's just wanting stuff. It's not a case of I want these days. It's not a case of I want more TV or more money. Most people, what we want these days is more. It becomes a noun. How much do you want? You want more. So that's this business of indulgence.

The aversion, which is a word I prefer, is that you're averse to something and your reaction is either to get rid of it or to get away from it. So it's the old fight flight syndrome, but it's always about manipulating the situation in order to make yourself feel comfortable, most times at the expense of somebody else.

And the delusion. Now this digs deep, because it all begins from this false identity, the false identity of who I am. So remember, this business of "I am me" means that I'm seeking my own happiness. I'm seeking happiness in the world. And when the world doesn't fit, then of course I get this ill will. And when the world does fit, it's like me, me, me. It's all trying to get more and more of what I have.

So it all roots back always to this problem of identity, always roots back to this problem of identity. And in our practice in *vipassanā*, we're constantly rediscovering that place within ourselves which is separating out of these desires, these ill wills and all the rest of it. And that's the process of liberating ourselves from this wrong view as to where we can find happiness.

Now, that's not to deny the natural joys and pleasures of life. It's just the relationship we have to them. That relationship is variously called as attachment, indulgence and so on. And so that's why we end up always trying to manipulate the world. So it's important to understand that.

Now, one distinction to be made here, which is pretty important, whenever you read the discourses, it's always about these pretty heavy stuff: murder and thieving and malicious speech. And what seems to be missed out, of course, is all the stuff that we generally suffer from in a way. Feeling down. I don't like the word depression. It all medicalises it. You just feel down. I felt down today. So I felt down today.

And then there's anxiety. I mean, that's life, isn't it? Especially now with this coronavirus, the anxiety, the fear that's being generated is quite remarkable. And rightly so, if it stops people from being silly. Fear, and then there's anger, anger which comes up, frustration and all that. And then you've got all the different hindrances. So dullness and lethargy, restlessness, doubt, lots of doubts, things like that. So now all those come under the umbrella of unwholesomeness.

And so in a way, a better word than morality, which tends to sink us into this "thou shalt not" and "thou shalt," it's more to do with ethics. It's more to do with the way we relate to the world. We relate to people. That's what it's about. And everything you have, everything you touch, everything you see, we have a relationship with. As soon as you see a tree, you find you have a relationship with it. You like it. You're enjoying its shade and so on. Even a door, as soon as you see a door, you have a relationship with it. It's something you want to go through or shut behind you. It's one of those.

So you can see, to think about *kamma* at its wider sort of perception of *kamma*, we've got to think about ethics. That's what it's about. And of course, what we're trying to do is to get to the opposite of all this. And of course, that's often stated as non-stealing, et cetera, et cetera. But of course, what we're moving towards is a refinement.

So once we've stopped killing and we start respecting other people, then you get this idea of protecting them and protecting ourselves, protecting life. The Buddha is clear that this is a very treasured precious life form that we have. It has this dual misery and

happiness, joy and woe, but it also has, we have this intelligence, we have this ability to discern. And that's what's going to liberate us, this ability to discern. So we need to be very careful with our bodies.

When it comes to speech, of course, what we're trying to move towards is a kindly speech, a pure speech, a truthful speech, an ability to speak from the heart, to be open, to be honest. Those are the important things about right speech. And the other slightly important thing about that is often to be guarded when you say something. There's a right time to say something and a right time and a wrong time. And choosing the wrong time to say something can cause a bit of upset, especially if it's something you want to say that the person might not like. So you have to be very careful.

I remember when there was all this business of free speech came up. It was a while back with Islamists. And there was this idea that the right to abuse somebody, that was part of this free speech business, which I can understand, but it's a bit of a hard way to put it. You have a right to state what you understand and believe, even though you know other people might be insulted by it. But then one has to go very gently with that. You don't go around smashing people on the head with your views and opinions. So it's a case of being gentle, kind. So that's the right speech business.

When it comes to the covetous, ill will, then, of course, that's as soon as you see it come up in the mind to acknowledge it. I mean, that's the great thing about one of the things about noting, that you get in the habit of saying, oops, now that's a bit of cheek, that's cheeky. You see what I mean? You point to it, make sure you're aware of it.

Somebody's written here that they can't hear. Can somebody put in whether they can hear or not? They should be able to hear.

Sound is working okay, thank you, Muriel. So maybe I just push your sound button up a bit. So that's this business of morality now. It does go, I can hear fine, great. Okay, so maybe the person who can't hear, if you play around with your volume button, see if you can get it up there. I have actually bought a special microphone which is on the way and who knows when it'll arrive these days.

So this business of morality is understood to be of prime importance to understand this business of ethics and morality. Some of you may know that there are four stages to liberation, what we call the stream entrant. And that's somebody who's broken through this wrong view of self. It's only a lightning understanding of it. The sense of self is still very strong. And then the second level is when somebody has such an insight that their greed and hatred is much undermined. And in the third level, the greed and hatred,

aversion, is completely gone. And that simply means that the person is no longer attracted to this level of existence, but there are still five things to go. Restlessness, well the main one is conceit, and that includes the sense of "I am."

Such is the importance of understanding or accepting the law of *kamma*, the law of consequence, that if you do something harmful, something harmful will arise. If you do something wholesome, something wholesome will arise. Somebody who actually takes that on is known as a *cula sotāpanna*, so a lesser stream entrant. That's how important the commentaries put to it. I don't think it's in the scriptures themselves. It's the beginning. It's the beginning.

Why is that? Because our ethics, our morality is an expression of this original delusion. So the purer we get is a feedback to us of our progress. Often in our practice, we often wonder whether we're making any progress. It's a constant question for meditators. I don't feel any progress. But if you look back five, ten, maybe 50 years, you should be able to see some progress in your ethics, some progress in the way that you relate to people, that you relate to your work, things like that.

So I'm going to finish there this evening.

And I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I've not caused even greater confusion, and that you will, by your sincere practice, liberate yourselves from all suffering sooner rather than later.

So don't forget, if you have any questions, to email me. The email is on the website, but the simplest one is bb@gmail.com.

So I'd like to begin the meditation and we'll follow the practice that we did two days ago, which I did by myself here talking to nobody yesterday evening.

So settle yourselves into a good posture. For those of you who haven't been here, this is the meditation room. The Buddha that you see upon the lotus I've had with me since I set up a centre in North London. Venerable Vajirañāṇa, who was then the abbot of the London Buddhist Vihara, offered me this when I set up that centre.

Evening Lockdown Meditation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 59 min

This comprehensive evening meditation session from during lockdown begins with traditional Pali chants including the Triple Gem refuge and Five Precepts, followed by contemplative reflections on the nature of the body and mortality. Bhante Bodhidhamma guides practitioners through the Buddha's recommended evening contemplations on sickness, aging, and death, balanced with reflection on the unconditioned state of Nibbāna.

The session continues with systematic loving-kindness (mettā) meditation, beginning with self-compassion and extending to those who are suffering, then cultivating joy for ourselves and others. The practice culminates with the complete chanting of the Mettā Sutta (Sn 1.8), the Buddha's discourse on loving-kindness, in both English translation and original Pali.

This session demonstrates how traditional Buddhist evening practice integrates contemplation of impermanence with the cultivation of loving-kindness, creating a balanced foundation for peaceful sleep and continued mindfulness. The inclusion of both guided meditation and traditional chanting makes this suitable for practitioners seeking to deepen their engagement with classical Theravāda forms.

Okay, we can begin.

Sangam pūjemi. Namo tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsbuddhassa. Namo tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsbuddhassa. Namo tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsbuddhassa. Buddhāṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Dhammaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Dutiyampi Buddhāṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Dutiyampi Dhammaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Dutiyampi Saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Tatiyampi Buddhāṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Tatiyampi Dhammaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Tatiyampi Saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Pāṇātipātā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi. Adinnādānā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi. Kāmesumicchācārā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi. Musāvādā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi.

So we can begin our sitting. Make sure you are comfortable, feeling comfortable. Settling on the breath.

We can begin our sitting with these evening contemplations which the Buddha says are there to make us more enthusiastic, to give us some real purpose as to why we're practicing. So just repeating these phrases to ourselves:

This body is subject to disease. This body is of a nature to fall ill. This body has not gone beyond sickness. This body is subject to aging. This body has not gone beyond aging. This body is now in a process of aging. This body is subject to death. This body has not gone beyond death. This body will die.

There is the unborn, undying, uncreated, uncompounded. The unconditioned. True refuge, harbour and home. Perfect peace and contentment. Those who are mindful are in the presence, in the vicinity of *Nibbāna*.

So a moment's reflection, just looking back at the time, picking up on something, working with tiredness. Was it restlessness? Was some emotional stuff came up? Wandering mind? How did you deal with it? Don't forget, if you thought you were rather skillful, we should congratulate ourselves. If we thought we could have been more skillful, we should encourage ourselves. And we can make a resolution, either specific or general or both.

So we can just begin our contemplations, always beginning with compassion. Again it's a case of turning this goodwill compassion towards ourselves, and if we find that difficult, just to put our hands over our hearts and just consider some of the things that we've done to ourselves which has caused harm—physical, mental, emotional. Something comes up for you and just allow yourself to forgive yourself.

Then just turning that compassion towards our own hearts, speaking gently into the heart: May I be free of physical pain. May I be free of mental distress. May I be free of all my sufferings.

We can bring to mind now somebody whom we know is not having a good time one way or the other. And as you picture them in your mind's eye, just drive your goodwill towards them. May you be free of physical pain. May you be free of mental distress. May you be liberated of all your sufferings.

And we can bring to mind all those at this moment who are sick and or suffering from mental illness. People in the process of dying and those who have died and left grieving family, relatives and friends. People going hungry, homeless and destitute. Those having to deal with severe personal and interpersonal difficulties. All those caught up in wars and repressive regimes, those being tortured. And there are those suffering from natural disasters and climate crisis. All the sentient beings have been cruelly treated and unnecessarily slaughtered. And all who find life meaningless. May you be free of physical pain. May you be free of mental distress. May you be liberated of all your sufferings.

We can radiate this goodwill compassion to all beings in all directions. May all beings be free of physical pain. May all beings be free of mental distress. May all beings be liberated of all their sufferings.

Bring to mind now some moments during the day when you've experienced love or peace, joy, some level of happiness. Just bring it to mind. Be grateful for it. Then let's wish ourselves this joyfulness, again speaking joyfully into the heart: May I be joyful. May my joyfulness increase. May I experience the bliss of *Nibbāna*.

We can bring to mind now somebody whom we know has cause to be joyful. As you picture them in your mind's eye, drive your goodwill joy towards them. May you be joyful. May your joyfulness increase. May you experience the bliss of *nibbāna*.

And there are people at this moment who are happy and content with their lives, enjoying the warmth of friendship, the support of friendship, enjoying the delights of art and nature, enjoying the work they do, finding it meaningful, fruitful. And there's also the fruitfulness of those practicing spiritually, and there are those who are joyful because they rejoice in the joy of others. May they be joyful. May their joyfulness increase. May they experience the bliss of *Nibbāna*.

And radiating this joy to all beings in all directions: May all beings be joyful. May their joyfulness increase. May they experience, may all beings experience the bliss of *Nibbāna*.

I shall read again the discourse on goodwill, *Mettā*. If you are wise and want to reach the state of peace, you should behave like this. You should be upright, responsible, gentle and humble. You should be easily contented and need only a few things. You should not always be busy. You should have the right sort of work. Your senses should be guarded, and you should be modest. You should not be exclusively attached to only a few people, and you should not do the slightest thing that a wise person would blame you for.

You should always be thinking, may all beings be happy, whatever living beings they are, be they weak or small, big or small, large or slender, living nearby or far away, those who've already been born and those who have yet to be born. May all beings, without exception, be happy.

You should not tell lies to each other and do not think anyone anywhere is of no value. Do not wish harm to anyone, not even when you're angry. Just as a mother would protect her only child, so you should let that warmth of your heart go out to all beings. Let your thoughts of love go through the whole world, above and below,

without any fear, with no ill will and no hatred. Whether you are standing, walking, sitting or lying down, so long as you are awake, you should develop this mindfulness. This, they say, is the noblest way to live.

And if you do not fall into unskillful ways, but live well and develop insight and are no longer attached to all the desires of the senses, then truly you'll never need to be reborn into this world again.

So I'll chant the discourse. And if you wish, those of you who know it, of course, can chant with me, but you can also send out these blessings, the normal *mettā* blessings: may you be safe, well and happy. May you be safe, well and happy. May you live contented in harmony with the world.

Karaṇīyam-attha-kusalena yantaṃ santaṃ padaṃ abhisamecca. Sakko ujū ca suhujū ca suvaco cassa mudu anatimānī. Santuṭṭho ca subhara ca appakicco ca sallahukavutti. Santindriyo ca nipako ca appagabbho kulesu ananugiddho. Na ca khuddaṃ samācare kiñci yena viññū pare upavadeyyuṃ. Sukhino vā khemino hontu sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhittā. Ye keci paṇabhūtattā tasā vā thāvarā vā anāvasesā. Dīghā vā ye mahantā vā majjhimā rassakā anukathulā. Diṭṭhā vā ye ca adiṭṭhā ye ca dūre vasanti avidūre. Bhūtā vā sambhavesī vā sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhittā. Na paro paraṃ nikubbetha nātim-aññetha katthaci naṃ kiñci. Byārosanā paṭighasaññā nāññamaññassa dukkhaṃ iccheyya. Mātā yathā niyaṃ puttaṃ āyusā ekaputtam anurakkhe. Evaṃ pi sabbabhūtesu mānasambhāvaye aparimāṇaṃ. Mettañca sabbalokasmiṃ mānasambhāvaye aparimāṇaṃ. Uddhaṃ adho ca tiriyañca asambādhaṃ averaṃ asapattaṃ. Tiṭṭhañcaram nisinno vā sayāno vā yāvadassa vitamiddho. Etaṃ satiṃ adhiṭṭheyya brahmametaṃ vi-hāram idhamāhu. Diṭṭhiñca anupāgama sīlavā dassanena sampanno. Kāmesu vinayetvā gaddhaṃ na hi jātu gabbhaseyyaṃ punaretīti.

May all beings be happy. *Sabbe sattā sukhittā hontu.*

Very good. Thank you very much. You might be interested to know that 64 of us were there. Well, with me, that's 65, isn't it? Practicing meditation together. How wonderful is that?

So I don't forget—from now until you fall asleep is also part of your practice, our practice, don't forget myself. And it's good to put something beautiful in the mind so you sleep more peacefully. If it's the *mettā*, remember, make it very simple, just a blessing to yourself, to somebody you have little problems with, and to all beings.

And you can also just put the attention on the breath, but not to investigate—that might wake you up—but just to feel this gentle waving motion wafting you into deep sleep.

May you have a peaceful night.

Coronavirus and the Contemplation of Death

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 18 min

In this timely talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma addresses how the coronavirus pandemic can serve as a powerful doorway into maraṇānussati—the Buddhist contemplation of death. Drawing from the Buddha's teachings on death meditation, he explains how our society's 'denial of death' manifests as excessive risk-aversion and fear-based reactions. Bhante shares the Buddha's instructions for practicing death contemplation, where practitioners recognize that death could come with each breath, bringing this ultimate reality directly into awareness. This isn't morbid thinking, but a profound practice for confronting the fear that underlies our attachment to this psychophysical form. He distinguishes between the natural fear of death and the 'fear of fear' that creates panic and paranoia. Through sustained contemplation of mortality, practitioners can develop equanimity with life's fundamental uncertainty. Bhante emphasizes that this fear arises from our delusion of identifying completely with the body-mind, while the Buddha taught there is something within us that transcends this organism. This practice becomes especially relevant during times of collective uncertainty, offering a way to transform anxiety into wisdom and deepen our understanding of impermanence (anicca) and not-self (anattā).

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa (three times). Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

I was going to tackle this question of the precepts, which was "are all stages of the Eightfold Path equally important?" I might get around a little bit to that, but I came across a couple of interesting little articles here, which are letters actually, which you might be interested in.

So this one is written by a man called Darrell Davis from Denbighshire. And he says, "As well as being 66 and in poor health, I also have three sisters in the at-risk category for coronavirus. I therefore feel qualified to say this. We are demolishing our economy and small businesses and wasting many billions of pounds to protect an at-risk category comprising about 1% of the population. The science suggests that the rest of us may get a mild form of virus but will recover. The best estimate states that 250,000 people will lose their lives. This accounts for less than half of 1% of the population." You see where he's going? "This is extremely sad and awful for those affected. But while governments should be caring, they must also be pragmatic. Many of these people, including myself, will succumb to something else in the next few years. How can we justify the impact of

this path? We're spending effectively 1.2 million per expected death on people whose life will be taken soon anyway. Yet we cannot find the tens of thousands of pounds, only tens of thousands, for specialist cancer treatment for much younger people. It will take years to recover from this."

There's somebody who replied to an article that the journalist Matthew Parris had written. "He appears to feel that younger citizens should be allowed to continue their lives almost as normal and that older 70s should be sacrificed. Say no. I suggest he completely misses the point. If the over-70s contract the virus, they will obviously take up valuable capacity in the NHS. However, without some restrictions on the less vulnerable, the very nature of their lifestyles is likely to spread the disease, infecting a high percentage of the population, young and old. As a member of the over-70s group, I realise that we are more expendable. The facts, however, are that without restrictions on everyone, the consequences for the country could be catastrophic for us all." So you have an opposite view there.

Actually, when I looked at the death toll for coronavirus, most of them are over 75. See, so I'm all right. I'm only 73.

That reminds me of Boris Johnson. That was the herd immunity business - yes, let's everybody have it and then eventually everybody's okay. Yes, young people are dying, that's true, but very occasionally though, it's not at the same rate as the old.

You can see there are varying views and opinions as to how the government ought to have reacted. But of course, the more cynical reaction to this has been, you know, governments moving towards authoritarianism. And even in Europe there, this fellow in Hungary, Viktor Orbán. He's basically become a dictator. He can govern now without any restriction on his authority or, in fact, any criticism. You can get to jail for five years if you don't agree with what they're doing or write about it. And it's interesting because, you know, we thought the EU, Brussels, was all powerful. But actually, when it comes down to nation states, they eventually can do what they want. You can't do anything about it because it's a very small country, Hungary, and they're absolutely paranoid about being swamped by immigrants.

I did hear a funny story, though. There's a nun I know from the Czech Republic, and the Czechs also don't want any immigrants whatsoever. And this businessman, he actually set up a few jobs for the immigrants coming through Czechoslovakia. Nobody wants to stay; everybody would go to Germany. So that was a bit of a downer.

Anyway, I thought you'd be interested in that little article.

Now, it's, of course, what this brings up for us is this denial of death. And what do we mean by the denial of death? Everybody knows they're going to die one way or the other. It's not facing it. It's not turning around to find a relationship with death. And that brings about this fear, this running away from it. You can see that constantly in the way that the society has become so risk averse. It's just become absolutely ridiculous.

I came across this when we put the block up. I mean, all the windows, all the windows that look out from a height, you can't open more than six or seven inches, just in case somebody jumps out of them. Well, I mean, that's all very fair. But I mean, you know, it's like a meditation center. And I was arguing to them that these rules and regulations are not statutory. They're advice. And you're supposed to safeguard a building according to the purpose of it. So obviously, if you had children, then you put up all sorts of necessary safeguards. But I told him that we were completely sane meditators, 100%. Not a single person comes here who's suicidal or anything like that, I said. Anyway, he was a young fellow and he wasn't going to take any chances on that point.

This ability of fear of death - there was a, just to show you a difference in the way people have reacted way back in the 80s when I was at the Birmingham Buddhist Vihara, we laid a new path from the door to the gate and very stupidly lay a pavement on top of another so that was about a gap of a couple of inches, that's all. And one dark evening, you could never have seen it, one dark evening a woman came, tripped over it and broke a nose. So of course, when she told us that we said, "Look, we've got public liability, you know. Why don't you claim and we'll look after it," and she wouldn't. She wouldn't claim at all.

Many years later, in the year 2001, something like that, I was asked to go to a group of depressives. It was a depressive support group. And there were about 30 people in the room. It was a bit of a downer because it seemed as though all they were doing was making each other more depressed by telling each other how depressed they were. And there was one guy there who wasn't. And he was full of life and full of vim, you know. And you could see one or two people were snarling. I didn't think the atmosphere was very supportive.

Anyway, the man who was running it, he gave his life story for the day, how he'd been during the week. And he said he'd been walking on a pavement and he tripped up, and it hurt his knee or something, you know, nothing particularly serious. So he decided to claim from the local government, to sue them, and they said he didn't have grounds to sue them at all. And then he said, "I got very angry about that and then I got depressed." So you can see the very, there's various attitudes out there in society.

But this whole problem of denial of death - see, the Buddha gives us an exercise which you can try. It's extremely powerful, extremely powerful, because I've done it myself. I know what I'm talking about. And he's talking to certain monks who are practicing contemplation of death, and as he goes through, I'm just paraphrasing now, one monk will say, "I have set myself up as an imaginary point that when I finish this three-month retreat, three-month seclusion, I'm going to die and I'm getting the feel of death." And the Buddha says, "No, no, no, he says that's not how you practice the contemplation of death."

And then as he goes along to different monks, it all the time gets shorter and shorter until somebody says, "I'm sitting here contemplating that I might die during the night," something like that. And he says, "No, no, no, that's not the way to contemplate death. He says you have to contemplate death by recognizing as you breathe that every half breath you could die." Right? You've got to bring it right up in front of your face. You've got to really recognize that, you know, we're on a tightrope and that you can fall off any moment, any time.

And if you really work on that for a few minutes or a few seconds and really, really convince yourself how fragile life is, then you begin to get that contact with the fear of death. Now, this fear of death is a measure, of course, of our deluded self. I mean, that's what it is. The Buddha would not have had any fear of death.

In fact, there are various one or two tales of the arahats who died, and they died quite peacefully. Perhaps the most dramatic one was a man called Dabba, who was a Malian, a local ethnic group just north of the Ganges Plain. And he had certain abilities. And one of them you'll all know from E.T. He had a control, it seems, over the fire element, over heat. And when he became liberated, he said to the Buddha, would he mind if he just took care of lodgings in the monastery? That's fine.

So it says that as the monks came in he would ask them what they wanted to study or something like that and he would put them in various sections. So the people who wanted to study the Vinaya, the rule, he put them with those people. The ones who studied Dhamma with those people. And the ones who meditated with those. And he would put the athletic ones on another side, which is just a nice way of saying that they're just messing about.

He could, if they came late at night, he could show them the way to their lodgings by the light at the end of his finger. Now, these days we don't believe things like that, but you'd be surprised. And it seems as though when he died he just rose up in the air and exploded into light. That's how it's described. So that's just a little story just to keep you happy.

This fear of death, you see, is something that we can, because it's all around us at the moment, people are quite paranoid about it, is to recognize that it really drives us to paranoia, to unrealistic fears. I mean, here in Shropshire there's only about, I think it was about 200 cases in Powys. I think it's about the same. So although we have to be careful, it's really getting in touch with that sense of fear, the fear of death. It's a really good time to do it, especially if you're living in places where there's quite a lot of cases like London, Birmingham, Manchester, places like that.

And that's what you do. You just sit there and you breathe and you just keep saying, in one way or the other, "Death can come now." Breathing out, "Death can come now." It's just getting used to the fear of death. And now the problem isn't the fear of death itself. It's the fear of fear. That's what's causing the paranoia. It's what causes the panic. And it's a way of getting used to the feeling of fear.

Whenever that comes up, the feeling of anxiety or fear, is to sink into it. You know, this business of, remember the Buddha in the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse is always saying to get feelings in feelings. You have difficulty getting people to get into a feeling. So you've got to sit in the midst of the bonfire and feel the fear. See? Feel the fear. And what you're doing is you're accustoming yourself to the fear, and that means the reaction of fear of fear is disappearing, is going away.

And when that comes, you see, you can ask yourself, well, if I no longer fear fear, what's going to frighten me? And then eventually, of course, this is endgame, of course, that fear disappears entirely because the fear is based on the delusion of thinking that we actually are this psychophysical organism. We're just this organism. But the Buddha's quite clear that there's something in us which transcends it.

So have a go at that and see how you get on. You can drop me an email, all right, if you think it's been worthwhile. But I myself found it a very powerful meditation, contemplation.

The problem is we don't know what happens after death. No, you want to stay with that, you see. I mean, of course, there is this teaching of rebirth, but you don't have to come to a conclusion. You can actually stay with that, with the thought that you will be utterly annihilated. That's where the fear is. That's where you'll contact the fear.

Contemplation of Death: Living More Awake

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

In this profound teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma guides us through the Buddha's instruction on maraṇasati—contemplation of death—as preserved in the numerical discourses. Drawing from early Buddhist texts, he presents a sutta where the Buddha corrects monks who think contemplating death means hoping to live for days or weeks to practice the dhamma. Instead, true death contemplation happens in the space between breaths—recognizing the ending of each moment.

Bhante explains how this practice brings us fully into the present moment, helping us see through the illusion of a permanent self and recognizing that "all formations are entirely empty, they rise and cease." This contemplation of impermanence (anicca) naturally leads to insight into not-self (anattā) as we observe the breath as a process without a breather.

The teaching emphasizes how death contemplation paradoxically makes us more alive—awakening us to the preciousness of each moment rather than causing morbid preoccupation. Bhante recommends complementary readings and explains how this ancient practice offers a powerful antidote to the tendency to live mechanically, encouraging practitioners to regularly reflect on our existence "on a knife's edge" as a gateway to deeper mindfulness and Right Awareness.

Peace and joy. I hope you've had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, I say fruitful.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.
Homage to the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

Last night wasn't my fault. I think I've cured myself of mistakes of a beginner's nature. This was the broadband—it fell down to just one megabyte upload, one megabyte download, and in fact it's pretty slow at the moment. I don't know why, because we pay for a five megabyte upload and a ten megabyte download. I can only presume it's because we're at peak time, aren't we? This is when people are watching Netflix and Facebook and all that. There was no hope there, is there?

Anyway, the thing is not to expect me to appear. This is important. But to be delighted, or at least pleased, that I do so. And that way we shall get through this lockdown.

So I'm actually going back now to what we were discussing just a couple of days ago. Some people will have joined who weren't here for that, so I'll just paraphrase what was said because somebody sent me a question concerning this little letter that was written. It was just a letter from a man called Darrell Davis who was basically saying that we were spending billions of pounds and ruining the economy just to save a half of one percent of the population, a mere 250,000 people. And his last line is: it will take years to recover from this ridiculous path, which is ruining the economy.

Now, the question is that the reason for lockdown is to stop it spreading. But what the questioner, Julie, wants to know is: should we do this just for the sake of the economy? Is that why we're doing it? Whereas this man is saying the way we're doing it is actually going to ruin the economy. The question here—other illnesses that they could survive—and she obviously asks me what my opinion is. I'm not so sure about my opinion as such, but I think from the Buddha's point of view, as far as I can tell, remember the importance of right livelihood.

So the economy does—if you say to somebody about the economy, I think most people think, well, I can get rich or something. But the economy, a Buddhist economy as far as I'm concerned, is concerned with giving people right livelihood, because it's in this way that they create good habits, good *kamma*. And, of course, they can share in the wealth of society. And that's one of the problems, isn't it, with this neo-capitalism business. So that would be the importance of the economy, I think, in a Buddhist setting: the ability to have right livelihood. But, of course, we have a right to protect ourselves against illness and enemies, I would say.

So there is another question here, which is rather delightful. I keep getting a question coming in my head, so I thought I'd ask it: Is it useful or constructive to nurture *mettā* towards the virus? Should we try to love the little beast? What do you think?

Well, I don't think I can personally raise to the level of any sense of love for the beast. I'm not so sure it would be considered a being. It's a very strange area. It seems to have agency. I mean, as soon as it enters your body, it knows where to go. I mean, it dives into your lungs and messes you about. And other similar rhinoviruses, the ones that cause cold and that. I had one a few weeks ago and it went up my nose into my head. So there seems to be some intelligence there, should we say. Whether it has consciousness or not is another matter. Whether it has any sense of awareness is another matter. I don't know.

But if we were to say that it did have consciousness and all that, then of course we have a right to protect ourselves. And that's what we're doing. That would be the attitude: that we are protecting ourselves from something which can harm our bodies. So

it's not a case of developing aversion to the virus, but in a sense, recognising that they're just part of nature. I read somewhere you can have 500 million viruses on a pin-head. I mean, that's very, very small. And they're just part of the environment. They're just part of the ecological system. You can't get rid of viruses, it seems. But our attitude, of course, I think should be that we want to protect ourselves.

Interestingly enough, monks are allowed to protect themselves. So be careful you don't attack me. In China, where emperors blew hot and cold—sometimes they were all for Buddhism and supported it fully, and other times of course they persecuted it—it was from there that the monks developed this kung fu to defend themselves against attack. In those days, of course, it worked very well against bows and arrows and clubs. These days, I don't think it's so reliable to overcome our modern weaponry.

So that answers that. Do send me questions. Better to do it by email. Partly it gives me a chance to look at them, but also if I start communicating here, it gets a bit difficult. That's all.

So we're very fortunate tonight. We have about seventy-odd people with us. That's rather nice. I was reminded that some people will be with their partners and spouses and elderly children, so there's probably more there than meets the eye.

So what I wanted to do actually was follow up something that we were doing two days ago, which was my favourite topic: death. And I want to read—because we were talking about contemplating death, how to contemplate death, how the Buddha teaches it—and what I'm going to do is read a scripture which has been translated, I think it's been translated by Bhikkhu Anālayo. Now, if you haven't come across Bhikkhu Anālayo, he's quite a scholar and his books are based directly upon the scriptures, and of course he makes commentary on them. And he's also a meditation teacher and, for the most part, I think, very, very practical.

So the book that I'm taking it from is *Mindfully Facing Disease and Death: Compassionate Advice from Early Buddhist Texts*. Now you might not know this, but there are two collections: one that the Theravāda line holds, which is the one that we would normally refer to, and they're normally called *suttas* or discourses. But there was a whole load that were preserved in the Chinese of a line of a school of Buddhism called the Sarvāstivādins, and they're known as the Āgamas. And they've now been translated and studied, and they are very—you might say they are compatible with, definitely, and a companion to.

So the Buddha, in the numerical discourses that we have, has two discourses on death, how to do contemplation on death. The one is very similar to what we're going to do. The other one really brings out some other factor, which hopefully I'll get to.

So the contemplation of death is very powerful, and I also like to mention a couple of books really. There's one called *Living in the Light of Death: On the Art of Being Truly Alive* by a man called Rosenberg. Now I've read that one and it really is an excellent book. There are others, but this is the one I've read. And there's also Stephen Levine, who died a little while back now—he used to write lovely books, and one of them is *A Year to Live*. So the question is: if you really had only one year to live, how would you spend that time? So it makes you very reflective of how you're actually spending your time, as any meditation on death does. It brings you back into this present moment, makes it very alive.

So that's two books there by Anālayo: *Mindfully Facing*—if you've got a pen or something—*Mindfully Facing Disease and Death*. Anālayo: A-N-Ā-L-A-Y-O, Anālayo. And Larry—that's his name, Larry Rosenberg—which is *Living in the Light of Death*. And Steven Levine, of course: *A Year to Live*. I don't think you can get that as an ebook. I'm not sure, but the other two, I think you can.

So, this is reflections on death. Let me just turn this down a bit. So I'll read this just as it comes. It's not very long, so hang on in there. Remember, the Buddhist scriptures were all handed down in the verbal tradition of remembering the discourses one after the other. So they can tend to be a bit repetitious, but when you read them with the purpose of absorbing, the repetition actually does come through.

"Thus have I heard: At one time the Buddha was staying at Sāvathī in Jeta's Grove, Anāthapiṇḍika's Park." So that was one of his main monasteries. "At that time, the Blessed One said to the monastics: 'You should cultivate the perception of death and give attention to the perception of death.'"

Although the word is "perception" here, I think we probably will get closer to the idea of contemplating death, or how you perceive death maybe, how you relate to death.

"Then one monastic among those seated there said to the Blessed One: 'I constantly cultivate giving attention to the perception of death.' And the Blessed One said: 'How do you give attention to the cultivating of the perception of death?' The monastic said to the Buddha: 'At the time of giving attention to the perception of death, I have the aspiration to remain alive for seven days and give attention to the seven awakening factors in the Tathāgata's teachings'" —that's the Buddha; Tathāgata, that's what he called himself,

the transcendent one, that's what it means—"in the Tathāgata's teaching, that would be of much benefit, and I will not regret passing away after that. Blessed One, it is like this that I give attention to the perception of death."

So his aspiration is to stay alive for seven days and to contemplate the seven factors of awakening.

"And the Blessed One says: 'Stop, stop, monastic. This is not truly an undertaking of the practice of the perception of death. This is called being of a negligent nature.' That's not very nice, is it?

"Now, again, one monastic said to the Blessed One: 'I am capable of cultivating the perception of death.' And the Blessed One said: 'How do you cultivate attending to the perception of death?' And the monastic said to the Buddha: 'Now I have this reflection. I have the aspiration to remain alive for six days, and having given attention to the right teachings of the Tathāgata, that might reach the end, then might reach the end of my life. This will thus be my good fortune, and in this way I attend to the perception of death.'"

So he's hoping to die after six days, during which he will attend or will contemplate the teachings of the Buddha.

"And the Blessed One said: 'Stop, stop, monastic. You are also of a negligent nature. This is not attending to the perception of death.' Now, again, the monastic said to the Buddha: 'I aspire to remain for five days.' I aspire to remain alive for five days. And someone said—and then somebody else says: 'I aspire to remain alive for three days. I aspire to remain alive for two days.' And one of them said, finally: 'I aspire to remain alive for one day.' Now, at that time, the Blessed One said to the monastics: 'Stop, stop, monastic. This is also being of a negligent nature. This is not truly attending to the perception of death.'"

"Now, at that time, there was again one monastic who said to the Blessed One: 'I am able to cultivate the perception of death effectively.' And the monastic said to the Buddha: 'When the time has come, I put on my robes, take the alms bowl and enter Sāvattthī to beg for alms. Having begged for alms, I turn back to leave Sāvattthī and return to my place. I enter my meditation hut and give attention to the seven factors of awakening. Then I might reach the end of life. It is thus that I attend to the perception of death.'"

So he's got no idea about one day, two days and so forth. He's just going to contemplate the seven factors of enlightenment and then he's happy to go.

"And the Buddha says to him: 'Stop, stop, monastic. This is also not giving attention to the cultivation of the perception of death. Monastics, you all spoke of negligent ways of practicing. This is not the nature of cultivating the perception of death.' Now, at that time, the Blessed One spoke to the monastics: 'Those who are able to be like the monastic Vikārin, that they are indeed reckoned to have the attention to the perception of death. That monastic is well able to give attention to the perception of death, being disenchanted with this foul and unclean body.'"

Now, the Buddha doesn't look upon the body as something that we should indulge. It's not something that we should delight in. We shouldn't be concerned about how beautiful it is, etc., etc. And to get to that level is to recognise that beneath the skin, there aren't very many pleasant things. So he's always directing us to really be very practical about the body.

"So if a monastic gives attention to the perception of death, collecting his mindfulness in front"—which means being mindful here and now—"with a mind that is unshaken, being mindful of the exhalation and the inhalation, for the time it takes for them to go out and return, and during that period he gives attention to the seven factors of awakening, that would indeed be of much benefit in the Tathāgata's teachings."

So it's like one breath. I don't quite know how you can attend to the seven factors. I suppose you're just being aware that you are aware of the breath. So in other words, you're being within the moment. I think that's what this is saying.

"This is because all formations are entirely empty. They all become appeased. They rise and cease. They are all a magical illusion that is without any true essence."

So again, it's this business of not-self. It's seeing that, in fact, there is the breath, but there's nobody actually breathing. It's just the organism. It's the organism that is breathing in and breathing out. And you can get that sense when you've discovered within yourself that observation post where you're distancing from it and you see it as an object. So remember, the perceiver can't be the perceived. The one who sees an object can't be the object. The object is an object, not the subject.

"Therefore, monastics, you should give attention to the perception of death in the interval between the out-breath and the in-breath, so that you will be liberated from birth, old age, disease, death, grief, worry, pain and vexation. And in this way, monastics, you should train yourself.' Now, as I understand this and as I've practiced it myself:

as you breathe in and then breathe out, there's a break, isn't there? So that's the end of that process, the end of that breath. And it's bringing that sense of ending more and more into our lives that actually brings you into the present moment."

"At that time, the monastics, hearing what the Buddha had said, were delighted and received it respectfully."

Very good. So that's the—I hope that gives you some indication on how to practice perception of death. The thing is to do it regularly for very small periods of time. After every sitting or the beginning of a sitting, just to bring to mind that we're living on a tightrope, we're living on a knife edge and you can fall off anytime.

I'm sure those of you who've been here know that I go on about after a meal: this is one less meal in my life. This is one less breakfast. This is one less porridge in my life. I mean, it's a horror story, really, a continual horror story. But it's bringing into our awareness that we are actually moment to moment ending. We're very aware of the beginning of things. That's not a problem. We're always there at the start of something. But it's actually catching the end.

So breathing in, breathing out, and then recognising: at this moment, death could come to me, or there could be death.

So time moves on. If there's any questions, do send me questions by email, please, by email. And I think that just about does it.

Contemplation of Death Again!

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 32 min

In this deeply practical talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma revisits maraṇānussati (contemplation of death) through teachings from the Aṅguttara Nikāya. He shares a powerful email from a practitioner who experienced both the challenging and calming aspects of death meditation, including cemetery contemplations referenced in the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10). The talk explores proper mindfulness of death practice - from reflecting on life's fragility with each breath to the traditional evening examination of conscience, asking ourselves what unwholesome qualities remain unabandoned.

Bhante then addresses living frugally during economic hardship, drawing from the Buddha's teaching on the four requisites (cattāri paccayā): food, shelter, clothing, and medicine. He offers practical wisdom for those facing unemployment or reduced income, emphasizing the difference between needs and wants. Through personal stories and historical context, he demonstrates how simplicity can be lived with dignity and even joy, while maintaining spiritual practice as the least costly but most valuable pursuit of all.

Greetings, I hope you've had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, I say fruitful.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

Some of you who get my email might have got the news that they had a big meeting at five o'clock on Zoom to offer good wishes and prayers for Rob Bia, whom I think most of you know. So I'm hoping to mention him tonight when we do the business of compassion. Just bear with me a second so that I remember to do that.

I did say that I would be approaching the question about the Eightfold Noble Path, but I've been dragged back to contemplation of death. I hope you don't mind—it's always an absorbing topic for me. So I just want to read an email that came concerning somebody who's been practicing this.

This is what he says: "This morning I managed to catch up with the talk on death and the virus, which I found intriguing. I followed it up with a 20 minute contemplation on the last breath. It's powerful stuff. A quick way of generating a lot of unpleasant

feelings. After 20 minutes, I decided to switch to *mettā*, compassion practice for myself and others to balance the practice. The feelings that came up in the death contemplation lingered through the morning and gave a certain edge to the day."

Get that? An edge to the day—living in the moment.

"Now, in the afternoon, I went on a cycle ride and ended up doing a second death contemplation in a quiet local graveyard, the one about decay of the dead body."

Now, that refers to the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse especially, where in the body section on how to develop mindfulness of the body, the last section is the cemetery contemplations. In those days, the bodies were just being laid out in the charnel grounds, eaten by animals, and they were shrouded in white shroud. The monks would take the cloth—I think this was a general habit for the *śramaṇas*, for those who would become recluses of various different teachers—to take that cloth and stitch it into robes. The Buddha in that discourse really is saying, go and sit there and just watch that decomposition. And you're supposed to be saying, "as this body is, so mine will be." That's pretty heavy, no?

So anyway, I think he's referring to that. He continues: "I found this one surprisingly easy. Maybe it was the ecologist's perspective. For me, there's something comforting about the realization that I'm going to end up as food for something else. Waste not, want not. I left the graveyard with a great sense of calm."

Now that, of course, is the purpose of death meditation, or one of the purposes—having come to an acceptance of it, a growing acceptance of it. Of course, we never know how much we've accepted the process of dying or the moment of death until we're actually doing it. But at least we can approach it and just take away its sting. Oh, death, where is thy sting?

"I will soon have more cause to observe and contemplate death and its effect on the living as a coffin bearer in a local gypsy funeral. Apparently, it's becoming difficult to find four physically fit people who don't have to isolate themselves. There may be a whole new unexpected line of work opening up for me over the next few months."

And may that be so.

So there we have an email from somebody who's been practicing it. I would love to know that you have been practicing it and what effect it's had on you. For me, as I said, it was an enormously powerful practice in my youth, actually—in my twenties, that's when it really hit me, this whole thing about death. Now, at that time, I was an annihila-

tionist. I thought that when you die, that was the end of it. So my big question was a really silly question, really: what was it like to go into nothingness? I mean, it would be like nothing, wouldn't it? But for some reason, it became an obsessive investigation.

So definitely something to practice. You'd have to do it. He did it for 20 minutes—that's quite a lengthy length of time. If you want to do it on a regular basis, it can be just those few breaths where you remind yourself that life is on a knife edge. And as I said, occasionally during the day to just acknowledge that the cup of tea is finished. That's it. It's gone. It is no more. There's another cup of tea, but that cup of tea is completely gone. And the effect of that is to bring you into the present moment. That's the purpose of it—to live in the now, whereas for the most part we're planning to live in the now. That's ridiculous, isn't it?

Now I do want to follow up with this from the *Aṅguttara Nikāya*. See how big it is? You do some damage throwing this at somebody. So I mentioned last night that the discourse I read was from the collection which was only extant in the Chinese and has been translated and is used by Bhikkhu Anālayo. He seems to like those, probably to make us aware of them, really, and read them. But there are parallel discourses in the Theravada tradition.

So one of them is very much like that, except there's this slightly different way of doing it, you might say. Again, he's been through all these *bhikkhus* who tell him that they just want enough time to eat half of their alms food so that "I may attend to the Blessed One's teaching. I could then accomplish much." So we could translate that these days, that you would only want to eat half of your alms meal or half of your meal so that you could practice spiritually.

And then another one says, "may I live just the time it takes to chew and swallow four or five mouthfuls of food so that I may attend to the blessed one's teaching. I could then accomplish much." So they're always doing this thing, contemplation of death, in order to listen to the Buddha's teachings. And as I say, we can translate that these days as in order to continue our spiritual practice.

But at the end of the discourse, the Buddha delineates what in fact constitutes a proper contemplation of death using the similar image. The *bhikkhu*—remember, refers to anybody who's listening or reading the scriptures. It's a figure of speech. I can't remember what it's called now. It's like when you say "all hands on deck"—we don't expect just the hands to turn up.

For the *bhikkhu* who develops mindfulness of death thus: "may I live just the length of time it takes to chew and swallow a single mouthful of food so that I may attend to the Buddha's teachings, the Blessed One's teachings. I could then accomplish much." He is one who develops mindfulness of death. And there is one who develops the mindfulness of death thus: "may I live just the length of time it takes to breathe out after breathing in and to breathe in after breathing out so that I may attend to the blessed one's teachings." And then he says, "these I call *bhikkhus* who dwell heedfully."

We could also say diligently. I think the word being translated here, because I haven't been able to look up the Pali, is *appamādo*, which is a very favourite word of the Buddha. It's one of his last—*appamādena sampādehāti*—strive diligently for your liberation.

So that one is similar to the one that we read last night. But there's another one, which is a slightly different take on mindfulness of death.

So he again tells the *bhikkhus*, "mindfulness of death, when developed and cultivated, is of great benefit, of great fruit, culminating in the deathless, having the deathless as its consummation." The deathless is just another word for *nirvāṇa*.

So he says here, "*Bhikkhus*, when the day has receded and night has approached, a *bhikkhu* reflects thus: 'I could die on account of many causes. A snake might bite me, or a scorpion, a centipede might sting me, and I might thereby die. That would be an obstacle to me'—in other words, that's not good. 'I might stumble and fall, or my food might disagree with me, or my bile might become agitated, my phlegm might become agitated.'"

So remember, this was in those days where they had the four humours, the four temperaments: the melancholic—sad people; the choleric—the angry ones; the phlegmatic—the easygoing ones; and the sanguine—the happy ones. There's only one of the lot who are happy. Human misery.

And then he says, "sharp winds in the night might become agitated." So I don't know what that is. I did look up winds—it is part of a Chinese thing, but also I couldn't help coming across a medical journal which said this: "While farting every day is normal, farting all the time is not. You have excessive flatulence if you fart more than 20 times per day. In most cases, excessive flatulence can be controlled with changes to your diet and lifestyle." I just thought I'd give you that little tidbit of good advice.

And then finally said, "people might attack me and wild spirits might attack me and then I might die." So this would be a disadvantage because remember the preciousness of human life. The whole point about remaining a human being as long as we can is that this is the best place to free ourselves from suffering.

Now, then he says, "Then when the *bhikkhu* has reflected on the possibility of death during the night, he then is supposed to reflect and ask himself, 'Do I have any bad unwholesome qualities that have not been abandoned, which might become an obstacle to me if I were to die tonight?' If upon review the *bhikkhu* knows 'I have bad unwholesome qualities that have not been abandoned, which might become an obstacle to me if I were to die tonight,' then he should put forth extraordinary desire, effort, zeal, enthusiasm, indefatigability, untiringness, mindfulness and clear comprehension to abandon those bad, unwholesome qualities."

Now, this actually reminds me of my own upbringing. I think in most Christian circles, you would go to bed with an examination of conscience—that's what it was called in my particular form, which was Catholicism. The idea was you'd look back over the day and see where you got angry, where you got nasty, where you got greedy and so on and so forth, and of course you would ask for forgiveness for that.

You can extend that, of course, to how you related to a sense of anxiety. Did you get caught up in it? Did you start getting panicky? Did you know what to do about that? So it's not just on a moral level, but the whole of our habits, the habitudes that we have, and to be aware of them when they come up. And then at the end of the day, we can reflect, "Well, I should have been quicker there. I could have been a bit more kinder there," and then made that determination—tomorrow I will be.

So that's what he says here. And then, of course, the opposite of that. He actually gives a nice little example, a nice little image here. The Buddha is always trying to match an intellectual understanding with some sort of imagery, some sort of imaginative way, because as he says, some people think that way—some people think in stories, in images rather than a straightforward intellectual manner. So he said that we should practice like that "just as one whose clothes or head had caught fire would put forth extraordinary desire, effort, zeal and so on to extinguish the fires"—so somebody should do that.

Now for somebody who has had—upon review, the *bhikkhu* knows "I do not have any bad unwholesome qualities that have not been abandoned, which might become an obstacle for me if I were to die tonight." Then, the Buddha says, he should dwell in the same rapture and joy, training night and day in wholesome qualities.

So remember the wholesome qualities—we can also reflect on that. We don't have to be completely free of unwholesome qualities. We can reflect on the wholesome qualities that we expressed during the day and determine that we will continue to develop them. All these mental states can be developed indefinitely. You can become as evil as evil and become as beautiful as beautiful—mentally beautiful, of course, heart beautiful.

And then, as always, these scriptures are not only repetitive, but they also, as it were, reinforce. By being repetitive, they reinforce the teaching. So just as we started off by saying, "when day has receded and night has approached," so the final paragraph is, "when night has receded and day has approached." So again, it's that recollection in the morning.

Very good. So I think we can put death to bed for a little while. But I would love to hear from you if you happen to practice that and just see if it did have a beneficial effect on your life, on your sense of awareness.

So I had a question about how to live frugally. Many people now have found themselves without work, either because the firm has dismissed its workers or you've been furloughed. This is a new word for me, furloughed—I don't quite know. It just means that you're still employed by the firm, but you're not being paid. And many of you know Carl, Carl Fuchs, who teaches here. So he works for the Department of Work and Pensions. And the amount of people applying now for the Dole, what we call the Dole, is enormous. So you may find yourself in that position, of course. And the question is how to live frugally.

I think it's good to remember that we weren't always—the society wasn't always as rich as it has been over these past 20, 25 years. Even after the 2008 crash, unemployment stayed pretty high. The bulk of people did get decent wages. I'm sorry about the West now, or should we say the rich countries in the West. But it's not that long ago. I mean, World War II—rationing was there for 14 years from the beginning of the war to July 4th, 1954. And that was when food rationing came to an end, when restrictions on the sale and purchase of meat and bacon was lifted. It was 14 years of people having to be careful, were limited in what they could eat.

And as a child—of course I would have been a child then, born in '47, I'd been about seven years old—you don't know, you're not aware of being poor or not poor. But in those days, you got a clip around the ear if you left the light on, if you broke a cup. Your dad would be onto you—that cost money. And I do remember my aunties when we used

to go visit—you get a piece of bread and the jam on it was, well, it wasn't—you wouldn't say there was any jam on it. There was a touch of jam expressing itself on the bread. They were, I remember, cucumber sandwiches—really thin little pieces of cucumber.

So you don't have to die because you're going to be frugal. Just in my own case, there was a period there in the eighties when I was unemployed and I was on the dole. And I just remember by that time I was practicing, I was into Buddhism, so I wasn't drinking at that time or anything like that.

And I remember, I handled it well, but I was rather lucky really. I went to live in lodgings where they allowed me just to make a donation, basically. I was very fortunate. And I remember eating a lot of awful liver and kidney and beginning to feel a bit ill about it. It was about that time I decided to go vegetarian. But there wasn't much on the market then for vegetarian food. And I just got used to living frugally. So you can't go out and just buy stuff, as you might have done at one time. You just live simply. And of course, we've forgotten that. There's a whole generation that have forgotten how to live frugally.

Even as a child, I remember waking up in the morning. There was no heat in the house. The old man had to go downstairs and build a fire. And on weekends, I'd be down there with him, screwing up paper and putting coal on top. You'd get up in the freeze, especially winter. There'd be ice on the window and you didn't bother. You just got up, you washed your face, you went down and the kitchen was the only place that was warm. They had three kids, three of us bundling in there and making a bit of a row. That was the only warm place, the kitchen. By evening of course, Mum had built the fire and all that so it was a bit more pleasant. But central heating for us didn't come until the mid-60s, and for many came much later. So you can get used to a situation. You get used to that. I mean it's the same as coming on retreat. You change all your habits. It's difficult the first two or three days and that's it.

I mean the horror story for me of course would be, well as you know, no toast. But worse, no soya milk or oat milk to put in my tea. I mean, that brings up almost a panicky feeling. And I remember too, kids coming to school with no socks and things like that, a bit scruffy, even though you had three changes. You had one for your ordinary messing about clothes. You had your school uniform, if your parents could afford it. And you had your Sunday best. That was it. I remember being a student, I only had I think two or three shirts. So it's like realizing that you don't need all this.

How can we approach a situation where we find we don't have the money that we used to have? And it really is just drawing up a list of what you actually need, as opposed to want. Which might not be particularly greedy. You might want another shirt or another piece of dress, but when you look around, you don't need it. And it's just really bring yourself down to need.

Now, for the monastic life, the Buddha had these, what we call the four requisites, and you had to be happy with what you were given. This is the idea. And in those days you often ended up with the very simplest of things. For instance, we're supposed to be happy with whatever is put into the bowl. I remember when I was in Thailand once we went out to the villages and when we came back it was only rice. They were very poor, extremely poor. Just a bit of rice and I think they put in a bit of the fish used to get out of the ponds. It wasn't fish or something else, which I won't forget, frankly. But luckily, when we got back to the monastery, the middle class from the towns had brought some delicious food. But if I had lived deep into the places in Thailand at that time, so going back to again the late 80s, you would have had to be happy with just rice. So that was the first thing.

For shelter, that's another thing. So you need shelter. The four basic requisites are food, shelter, clothing and medicine. I mean, that's what the body needs. We're not talking about what the heart or the mind needs, but what the body needs. That's all. And when it came to shelter it was just to be happy in a root of a tree or to build yourself a temporary shelter. Later on, monasteries were built for the Buddha, so they became a bit more flashy. But you're just to be happy with the place you're living in, basically. Now having said that, we know that there are people out there on the streets, and that's of course an abomination, frankly, for a rich country. Absolute abomination.

And then there's clothing. Now, the clothing is just to protect the body from heat in India, from flies and gadflies and mosquitoes and stuff like that. And of course, for modesty's sake. But that's your basic need is to clothe the body so it doesn't get cold in this country anyway. It doesn't matter what you're actually wearing, does it? As long as it keeps you warm. I mean, it doesn't have to be fashionable.

And finally, medicine. In those days, you had to be, what the scripture says, the Buddha says is that you have to be happy with fermented cow's urine. Now, frankly, I never tried it. I never got around to doing that. And I'm not so sure anybody else has since those times. But obviously that was considered to be a medicine. And just happy with the medicine that comes. Now it might be that you end up with the NHS with a minor or serious complaint, serious disease, and we know it's actually being so heavily used it's at breaking point constantly. The nurses, the doctors being completely over-

worked. And so you might find yourself not being treated well or not being treated for quite some time. And you have to accept that. There's no point in getting angry about it. That doesn't do anything, does it? Anxiety will be there, of course, if you feel you have something serious. But that's basically what you have to accept. Fermented cow's urine! I'm sure it's good for you.

So thinking about frugality, seeing what the need is. When it comes to the heart-mind, really to keep the mind active, to keep feeding it. Now, these days, there's so much free material on the websites that it really doesn't have to cost you anything. Free book downloads from, what is it, the Gutenberg Project on Google, things like that. And of course, there are still, I believe, one or two libraries around. And of course, conversation, good conversation with friends.

And the heart needs also to be nourished. There's not just the social virtues of compassion, love and all that, conversation with people, but art, art and nature. We need that feed. I mean, it's one of those things that monasteries, the meditation monasteries, are often way out in the forests to get out there away from the city jungle and into a beautiful place. So one has to accept that as part of frugality. Now, in the old days, you might have done all sorts of things that cost money, but there's plenty of stuff out there that wouldn't cost anything. So it's looking after the body, principally, of course, because you can't be here without one. And then taking care of the heart, mind, culture, all that.

So in this way, we can live with frugal times. And I put here, the least costly of all, of course, is spiritual practice. All you need is the space of your own body to sit down and carry on.

So I hope that these little hints... I always like to have some feedback. If you're doing the actual practices, feedback about what your thoughts are. Email please, because this... I don't actually read this stuff coming down. I can't speak and read it. There's a lot coming through. Julie here says there's a detailed...

06 Renunciation and the Buddha's First Occasion to Teach

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma emphasizes renunciation (nekkhamma) as the heart of spiritual practice, encouraging practitioners to transform challenging circumstances into opportunities for letting go. Rather than self-mortification, true renunciation involves recognizing our attachments and skillfully releasing them, allowing trapped energy to transform into peace and compassion.

The talk features an extended reading from the Ariyapariyesanā Sutta (MN 26), where the Buddha recounts his journey from Bodh Gaya to Vārāṇasī after his Awakening. Bhante shares the Buddha's encounter with the Ājīvika Upaka on the road, his arrival at the Deer Park at Isipatana, and his patient work with the group of five bhikkhus who became his first disciples. This narrative illustrates the Buddha's initial hesitation about teaching and his commitment to sharing the Dhamma with those ready to receive it.

The discussion includes practical reflections on simplicity and frugality, drawing from listener correspondence about cemetery meditation and wartime austerity. Bhante emphasizes how current global circumstances offer natural opportunities to practice renunciation, transforming necessity into spiritual growth through mindful letting go.

Greetings, I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, I say fruitful.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

It's not that I don't wish you had a happy day, it's just that happiness comes and goes, but we can make it fruitful through our spiritual practice.

I want to share a quote from one or two emails that came through concerning our subjects. Harold writes, "I was on retreat last summer near Glastonbury. It was organized by Gaia House and walking out in the evening, I discovered nearby was a cemetery. So a couple of evenings I went and sat there and studied the gravestones, reflecting on how many had died before my current age, nearly 69, and how their bodies would now have rotted down to skeletons. However, I feel that experience was probably too comfortable to be really effective. That probably had to wait until a meditation

first thing one morning shortly after the first recommendation to socially distance, when the potential impact of the events I had been attending up to then suddenly hit me with waves of panic, which no amount of rationalization on actual probabilities of anything happening to me could calm. So I just sat with it that morning and the next morning, and it slowly subsided, but not fun while it was happening."

So that's when death strikes, when we feel the horror that we feel of serious sickness and death. That horror, that sickness is the measure of this false idea of who I am, this self.

He also goes on to say that it was good to hear my reminiscences of frugality. "I can remember about 1960 being tasked with cleaning the grate in my grandfather's house and carefully laying the fire for the evening with paper twists when my parents were staying there. When my parents bought their own house in the mid-60s, this had partial central heating which heated the ground floor and their bedroom on the first floor, but not mine. Well, I wasn't there all the time. This meant in the winter, I would crawl out of bed and switch on the electric fan heater and then get back into bed until the room temperature was high enough for a morning wash to be considered." Softie.

So there we are, a bit of frugality. These days, people in midwinter walk around in their shirts and blouses with the house at 24 or 26 degrees as if they were living on the Mediterranean. Terrible.

There's a little email here from May. She spent time in Japan at Bukokuji, a training monastery there with her teacher, but there was a monk there from Chile called Chikusa. He had traveled by foot alone in India and became ill with fever. He was in a village, he doesn't know where exactly, and had begun to accept that he would die. However, a herdsman brought him to his hut and treated him with what he believed was cow's urine. And he recovered after a week or so.

There we are. It's meant to be fermented, so any germs in it would hopefully be destroyed. According to Ayurvedic medicine, it's called *kaumūtra*. It contains nitrogen, sulfur, phosphate, sodium, manganese, iron, silicon, chlorine, magnesium, malic, citric and tartaric acids and calcium salts, vitamins A, B, C, D and E, minerals, lactose, enzymes, creatinine, hormones and gold acids, whatever that is. It says that the urine is actually similar to the human body in some way according to old Ayurvedic medicine, and it seems to have cured this Zen monk from Chile. So there we are.

Those are just a little bit of replies, but I must say that yesterday evening I didn't really stress enough that this is an occasion to begin to test our powers of renunciation and what happens when you renounce something. For a dharma teacher not to be teaching that is terrible, and I gave myself very poor marks. But I'm going to make up for it now.

Remember that the whole of the spiritual life could be said to be renunciation. We're not talking about self-mortification. We're not talking about blaming and beating ourselves up. We're talking about seeing where desire, where we get caught up with desire, with reaction, wrong desire, of course. And this is just an opportunity. If we find ourselves, for instance, out of work, furloughed, or our wages reduced, it's an opportunity to let go of certain things. Some of us may still be in jobs but we can't fly anywhere, we can't go anywhere, we might be isolated—although I prefer the word secluded. Of course we have to let go of certain desires that come up through our past habits.

It allows us to sit with them, feel their energy, feel their power. The important thing is to stay if you can till the very end of that feeling, because right at the end of that feeling there's a switch, there's a change, there's a sense of being relieved, a sense of relief from that grip. The more the grip, the more the relief. Then you get that sense of peacefulness.

Remember that in that process of transformation, the energy is being transformed. Nothing is lost. Whatever energy was caught up in that turbulence of desire, wrong desire, will then turn into pure energy, which can be used elsewhere. Given a situation, it may manifest as love, compassion, joy, or just being peaceful, just being calm.

Don't miss this opportunity. Every time you feel you want something, check it and say, "Ah yes, this is a desire. Now let me have a look at it, let me feel it." By renouncing those things that we have to renounce anyway—and this is the whole point—in a situation like this, you find yourself having to renounce stuff. So you may as well make spiritual capital from it, if you'll excuse the expression.

And baths—giving up baths. Somebody has given up having hot baths. Remember in the old days, medieval days, you only had one bath a year. It was taken in May or thereabouts. You only had one big tub where first of all your dad got in, then your mum, then all the kids from the eldest to the youngest. That's where we get the phrase, "Don't throw the baby out with the bathwater." You know what the water must have looked like by the time the baby had its bath.

Right up until, I think it was the 1980s somewhere around there, people were happy just having a shower a week, a bath a week. Now we find that very difficult. Now you have to have a shower every day. But actually, you don't. You don't need a shower every day. By the way, that's why most marriages took place in June—that was before people began to stink a little.

So you can look at your lifestyle and see what's actually necessary, what is actually necessary. Then you can add a little bit on top of that maybe, but you're beginning to define what our indulgences are. It's funny how we need things just because we have them, but you don't need many things that we have.

I'm putting that aside now and continuing to resolve to talk about the Eightfold Path and to answer the question. But I do want to sidetrack a bit.

I want to take a reading about how the Buddha began his teachings. There's a whole discourse here, the *Ariyapariyesanā Sutta*, the Discourse on the Noble Search, where the Buddha tells his life story up until how he became fully liberated. It gives you some idea of the person, how he was.

So he said, "When I was staying at Uruvelā, as long as I chose"—so that's where he became fully liberated, close to what they think is present-day Bodh Gaya. Some of you will have been there. "I set out to wander by stages to Benares"—so that's present-day Varanasi on the Ganges there.

Between Gaya—that's the town near Bodh Gaya and the place of enlightenment—the *Ājīvika* Upaka saw me on the road. The *Ājīvikas* belonged to a sect that were fatalists really. They had Makkhali Gosāla who was a fatalist—everything was predestined. There were many of these people who'd gone out, mainly men but some women, who had left society to live as *samanas*. *Samana* means somebody who strives—for spiritual attainment in this particular case.

When Upaka sees him, he says, "Friend, your faculties are clear. The color of your skin is pure and bright. Under whom have you gone forth? Who is your teacher? Whose Dharma do you profess?"

The Buddha replies in verses: "I am the one who's transcended all and knower of all, unsullied among all things, renouncing all things by craving's ceasing freed. Having known this for myself, to whom should I point as my teacher? I have no teacher and one like me exists nowhere in the world with all its gods, because I have no person for my counterpart. I am the accomplished one in the world. I am the teacher supreme. I alone am a fully enlightened one whose fires are quenched and extinguished"—that's

the fires of greed, hatred and delusion. "I go now to the city of Kāśi"—that's Varanasi—"to set in motion the wheel of the Dhamma. In a world that has become blind, I go to beat the drum of the deathless."

That's very impressive, eh? But Upaka replies, "By your claims, friend, you ought to be the universal victor." "The victors are those like me who have run to destruction of the taints"—so remember, these are the basic problems that we have, basic misunderstandings. "I have vanquished all evil states, therefore Upaka, I am a victor."

Now when this was said, the *Ājīvika* Upaka said, "Hmm, maybe so friend." Shaking his head, he took a bypass and departed. So I think the Buddha realized this isn't quite the way he was going to spread the Dharma.

Now we also have to accept there's a bit of hagiography here. Hagiography is the story of the saints. You always build a saint up—legends and myths all surround them and they become much greater in a sense in some ways than they actually were because of this mythology that surrounds them. So I doubt if he came out with a set of prepared verses. He probably said that he felt he was, that he knew himself to be fully liberated, but he didn't convince this *Ājīvika*.

That reminds me that when I was living at the Birmingham Buddhist Vihara in Birmingham in the 1980s, early to middle 1980s, we used to get cards and letters from somebody announcing that the next world leader was living in London, somewhere in Pudding Street or something. I remember picking these up, about seven or eight of them, picking them up and thinking, "Oh yeah, just like *Ājīvika*. Oh yeah, right, okay." I never got round to finding out who this person was.

He then, of course, is on his way—the Buddha's on his way—to see his old friends whom he'd been training with. He wandered in stages and eventually came to Varanasi, Benares, to the Deer Park at Isipatana, and approached the group of five. The *bhikkhus* who saw me coming at a distance agreed amongst themselves: "Friend, here comes the recluse Gotama who lives luxuriously"—remember he'd given up the path of self-mortification—"who gave up his striving and reverted to luxury. We should not pay homage to him or rise up for him or receive his bowl and outer robe. But a seat may be prepared for him. If he likes, he may sit down."

However, as I approached those *bhikkhus*, they found themselves unable to keep their pact. One came to meet me, took my bowl and outer robe, another prepared a seat, and another set out water for my feet. However, they still addressed me as friend.

Whereupon I told them, "Do not address the Tathāgata by the name of friend. The Tathāgata"—that was how he referred to himself; it means the transcendent one—"the Tathāgata is the accomplished one, a fully enlightened one. Listen, because the deathless has been attained. I shall instruct you, I shall teach you the Dharma. Practicing as you are instructed, by realizing for yourself here and now through direct knowledge, you will soon enter into and abide in that supreme goal of the holy life for the sake of which clansmen rightly go forth from home to homelessness."

So that's a very pat phrase that you get throughout the scriptures. Then he tries to talk to them about this. There's this lovely passage here where the usual thing is everybody tries three times. So a second time and then he actually says the same thing a third time, and then he asks them—because remember, this is anybody's guess, but here it's his five friends—"Have you ever heard me speak like this before?"

They said, "No, venerable sir." "The Tathāgata is the accomplished one." And then he goes through this business.

Then he says, "I was able to convince the *bhikkhus* of the group of five. Then I sometimes instructed two *bhikkhus* while the other three went for alms, and the six of us lived on what the other three *bhikkhus* brought back from their alms round. Sometimes I instructed three *bhikkhus* while the other two went on alms, and the six of us lived on what those two *bhikkhus* brought back from their alms round."

"Then the *bhikkhus* of five, thus taught and instructed by me, being themselves subject to birth, having understood the danger in what is subject to birth, seeking the unborn supreme security from bondage, *Nibbāna*, attained the unborn supreme security from bondage, *Nibbāna*. Being themselves subject to aging, sickness, death, sorrow and defilement, having understood the danger in what is subject to aging, sickness, death, sorrow, and defilement, seeking the unaging, unailing, deathless, sorrowless, and undefiled supreme security from bondage, *Nibbāna*, they attained the unaging, unailing, deathless, sorrowless, undefiled supreme security from bondage, *Nibbāna*. The knowledge and vision arose in them: 'Our deliverance is unshakable, this is our last birth, there is no renewal of becoming.'"

So there you have a nice little passage which gives us some idea of his early movements. Of course they've been souped up a bit with verses and stuff like that, but at least we can get an image of him, of how he walked 250 miles from Bodh Gaya to Sarnath with the sole purpose of seeking out these old companions whom he felt were open enough or developed enough to receive his Dharma.

Time is passing on and I did want to read the actual discourse, which is what you might call the root discourse of Theravāda, the root discourse of Buddhism, frankly. It's not just Theravāda, it's the root discourse and it's all about the Four Noble Truths. I'm afraid because time moves on, I shall have to leave that little delight for tomorrow evening. And I will be getting round to the Eightfold Path sooner.

Setting the Wheel of the Dhamma in Motion

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 24 min

In this foundational talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma delves into the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta (SN 56.11), the Buddha's first formal teaching delivered to his five companions at the deer park of Isipatana near Varanasi. This discourse established the "wheel of Dhamma" that continues to turn today, offering liberation from suffering to all who follow the path.

Bhante carefully examines the Buddha's rejection of two extremes: the pursuit of sensual pleasure (which leads to addiction and dependency) and self-mortification (blaming the body for spiritual obstacles). The Middle Way transcends both approaches, neither indulging nor suppressing, but understanding the true nature of dukkha (suffering/unsatisfactoriness) and its cessation.

The talk provides clear explanations of the Four Noble Truths in their complete framework: dukkha must be fully understood, taṇhā (craving) must be abandoned, nirodha (cessation) must be realized, and the Noble Eightfold Path must be developed. Through exploring how Venerable Koṇḍañña became the first to gain the "dust-free, stainless vision of the Dhamma," practitioners gain insight into what genuine spiritual understanding looks like and how the Buddha's teaching continues to offer a path to awakening for all beings.

Greetings, peace and joy. I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I also wish you did have a happy day.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammasambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammasambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammasambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble, and fully self-awakened one.

Can I just say that if you've emailed me some questions and I haven't answered them, could you do me a favour and email them again? Probably I've archived them carelessly or whatever. And don't feel afraid to ask a question that you think is silly. There are no silly questions. And I don't have to mention your name anyway, so it can be quite anonymous. And if you have a personal problem which you want to talk to me about, I'm quite happy to Skype. I'll ask your permission if I can discuss it publicly. Of course, I don't have to mention your name at all, so it remains completely anonymous.

Okay, so we were still answering this question about the Four Noble Truths and slowly making our way to the Eightfold Path. And yesterday we talked about the Buddha's first efforts to teach there, meeting the Ajivaka, meeting that wanderer and

not really impressing him, and then finding his five companions not really wanting to speak to him, being rude, thinking he'd gone soft and very slowly opening up with his question of, "Have you ever heard me speak like this before?"

And now I want to follow that through with the discourse called the *Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta*, which is translated as "Setting in Motion the Wheel of the Dhamma." So here the teaching is more formalised. It was put together obviously later, but it's still understood traditionally to be his first talk given to the five companions.

But before I go on that, I just want to tell you a story which illustrates hagiography – how people build up in their imagination somebody whom they think is saintly through passing messages from one to another, what is called Chinese whispers. I'm not so sure that's PC anymore, but that's what we call it. I think in the States they call it telephone or something. And, of course, the same happens with anybody. If you talk about somebody, they pass it on to somebody else. Before you know it, they're either a criminal or a saint.

So it so happened I was up in Kandy and went to visit Bhikkhu Bodhi up there. Occasionally, very occasionally I would go up and visit him. And there was a Danish monk with him whom I hadn't known, whose name of course I'd forgotten. And what had happened was that he was living in the forests in Sri Lanka in a three-sided hut – I mean he was living there with a three-sided hut, that means that one side was completely open to tarantulas, snakes, et cetera. And he's very well known for that, and I do believe there are other monks now living in a similar way.

When he was coming back from alms round, which would have been in the morning, early morning I suppose, from the local villages, an elephant suddenly shot out and ran over him. Now, if an elephant, I'm told, if an elephant wants to kill you, they will definitely kill you. But in this case, it seems they just wanted to shock him or something. But unfortunately, one of its feet landed on this monk's hip and shattered it, of course. And when I saw him, his leg was still up in the air. He'd been to hospital. They tried to do their best. Hopefully he's had it better seen to. Who knows?

Anyway, I had visited Colombo just before this. It was on my way up, you see. So I used to stay at the International Buddhist Center there, which was established by the Bandaranaiques, who were both presidents of the – well, prime ministers at that time of Sri Lanka – especially built for the Mahasi Sayadaw when he visited in about 1956 or something, maybe a bit later, who knows.

And there was a Swedish monk whom I knew there, a friend. And again, I've forgotten his name. And he told me a story about this Danish monk, you see. He said, "Have you heard about it?" I said, "No." He said, "Well, he said he was sitting in lotus under a tree meditating, and a she-elephant passed with a baby elephant, a baby elephant. And the baby elephant was drawn to this figure under a tree and approached it and tried to sit in lotus, fell over and broke his hip."

So you can see what happens when stories are passed along the lines. As the story goes, he actually laid there all night. It was only in the next morning that the villagers recognised he hadn't turned up for alms round and went looking for him. So quite a telling story there about the way we build stories around things.

So putting that aside, let me start this particular discourse. And as I go through, I'll try and make some sort of comments.

"Thus have I heard." Remember, these were all remembered by his attendant, Ananda, who became an Arahant just before the meeting, the big meeting that happened after he died. And it says that "On one occasion, the Blessed One was dwelling at Varanasi in the deer park of Isipatana." So this is the place near present-day Varanasi on the Ganges there. And the deer park at Isipatana, I think it's now known as Sarnath.

"There, the Blessed One addressed the *bhikkhus* of the group of five thus." So he's now with his companions, his old companions. He says, "Bhikkhus, these two extremes should not be followed by one who has gone forth into homelessness. What two? The pursuit of sensual pleasure, of sensual happiness in sensual pleasures, which is low, vulgar, the way of worldlings, ignoble, unbeneficial. And the pursuit of self-mortification, which is painful, ignoble and unbeneficial. Without veering towards either of these extremes, the Tathagata has awakened to the middle way, which gives rise to vision, which gives rise to knowledge, which leads to peace, to direct understanding, to enlightenment and to *Nibbāna*."

Now, these two extremes – so by one who's gone forth into homelessness, so he's obviously talking to people who are wandering mendicants. But here we can translate this as anybody who's on a spiritual path, right? This isn't just for monks and nuns. This is for anybody who is on a spiritual path wanting to be released from all suffering.

So he says the pursuit of sensual pleasure, sensual happiness in sensual pleasure. So remember, it's not the object itself that we want. It's not the good food, the sex, drugs and rock and roll. It's how we personally feel happy, excited when we have those things. He says this is low, you see, vulgar, the way of worldlings, ignoble and unbenefi-

cial. So we have to stop it. That's the message there. In fact, it's more than unbeneficial. It produces addiction, doesn't it? That's the problem with depending on sensual pleasures in order to make ourselves happy. They become a dependency.

And the next one is the pursuit of self-mortification, which is painful, ignoble and unbeneficial. Now, this self-mortification is really about blaming the body. It refers, I think, specifically to the practice of those days. The Jain leader was one of the – what was well known for this practice, and he was an elder contemporary of the Buddha, and there's some suggestion that the Buddha might have spent some time or at least visited him or whatever. But he was definitely practising self-mortifications for four years it said, and the main thing of course was to draw the body down, not indulge in any of the senses. He said he got so thin he could hold his spine through his stomach. So if you try that, you can see he's very, very, very thin.

And the understanding was that it's the body that's at fault. You wouldn't have lusty thoughts if you didn't have eyes. You start blaming the body for your problems. You wouldn't be greedy if the body didn't have appetite. So you start working with the body to draw down its sensual pleasures. And that way you stop these reactions which lead you to more suffering. But he, of course, found this to be painful. Well, it's painful, of course, yes. Ignoble, so it wasn't leading on the spiritual path. Whenever the word *ariya* is used, it's always about the spiritual path. And it was unbeneficial. He didn't get anything from it. In fact, he said it was just more suffering.

There was, of course, a philosophy that underpinned this idea. And that was that the body itself was your *kamma*. And that if you could just let go of the body, just let it go, the soul would rise naturally to an eternal heavenly place. And this definitely is true. The philosophy that underpinned Jainism – and a saint in Jainism is one who stops eating, basically, and often very elderly people will do so with that understanding. So the Buddha didn't think that was beneficial, right?

Now when he says the middle path, you see, it's not in between sensual pleasure and self-mortification. It's not you can have a bit of sensual pleasure and a bit of self-mortification and you'll find the way out. No, it's above, it's transcendent of it, right? The middle path has nothing to do with either the path of self-indulgence or the path of self-aversion. So this word "middle" has to be understood as a path which is transcendent of these other two unbeneficial paths.

And then he says, "Well, what is the middle way awakened to by the Tathagata?" Remember that the word *Tathāgata* means, translates as "thus gone," which isn't particularly helpful. He's transcendent. He's gone, in his own words, he's gone beyond. Gone beyond. And he says, "What is that middle way awakened to by the Tathagata which

leads to Nibbāna? It is this Noble Eightfold Path: right view, right intention, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness and right concentration. This is the middle way awakened to by the Tathagata, which gives rise to vision" – so a direct seeing – "which gives rise to knowledge, a direct understanding, leads to peace, to direct understanding, to enlightenment or awakening and to Nibbāna."

And then now he gives us just these basic definitions of the Four Noble Truths, which are just worth reading through and also understanding how we should approach them.

So the first one is, "This is the noble truth of suffering." So remember that word *dukkha* has a whole meaning going from the smallest dissatisfaction, irritation, to the highest, the most terrible sufferings that we're capable of, and it's also an existential suffering which comes to us when death approaches. So "birth is suffering, aging is suffering, illness is suffering, death is suffering." So there we have it, you see. "The union with what is displeasing is suffering, and separation from what is pleasing is suffering." So getting, having to deal with something that we don't like, and having not to be able to get what we do like. I mean, these are sufferings for people, for us who are committed to trying to find some sort of permanent happiness in this life form. And then finally "not to get what one wants," of course. So we've done that. "And the five aggregates subject to clinging are suffering." Now we haven't got time to go into the five aggregates this evening, but some other time. So these five aggregates really refer to what we would call the psychophysical organism, and this is what we identify with, and that identity is of course the root cause of our suffering.

"Now this is the noble truth of the origin of suffering," or the cause of suffering. "It is this craving that leads to renewed existence, accompanied by delight and lust, seeking delight here and there. It is the craving for sensual pleasures, craving for becoming, craving for annihilation." So our general motivation is to keep living. Like, we want to wake up tomorrow morning for instance. And what we're chasing, this business of pleasure and trying to get rid of what is unpleasant, and that's what this whole desire is concerned with.

So the word *taṇhā* translates as desire or sometimes craving, which is a bit strong. It can be a craving, of course. But there's no English word which gets across the idea of a desire which is constantly unwholesome. And that's what *taṇhā* refers to. There is another word for desire, *chanda*, which can be either good or bad. But *taṇhā* is a specific word which refers to those desires that are unwholesome for us, whether we're wanting or not wanting.

And so the more fundamental desire, of course, is to keep living, to keep becoming, to keep being me. And the desire to exterminate or to commit suicide, basically, is the opposite of that. In a more gentle way, the desire to become is always to put myself first, to make sure that I'm okay, that's how it manifests. And the desire to annihilate can be as simple as not being able to handle something and just falling asleep. And that's some of the problems of dullness and lethargy we get in our meditation – it's based upon that attitude, not wanting to be with anything that's painful or upsetting. So you fall asleep. So sleep becomes a way of suppressing it, keeping it out of consciousness.

So that's the second noble truth. The third noble truth is the cessation of suffering. "It is the remainderless fading away and cessation of that same craving, the giving up and relinquishing of it, freedom from it, non-reliance on it." So that craving, that *taṇhā*, that unwholesome wanting, that unskillful wanting, not wanting – that's what has to go. And a word for it would be reactivity, just reacting to things, not responding from wisdom, not responding from a position where we understand, but always reacting from this deluded place.

Now, we don't do that always, obviously, but often we do. And what we're doing is reinforcing an old habit of ours. It's so easy to fall into old habits. Old habits die hard. But in a sense, that sounds so simple, just get rid of this wrong desire. But of course, what we discover is that that is quite a challenge. It's more than a lifetime's work if you believe in rebirth.

And finally, "the noble truth of the path leading to the cessation of this suffering is the Eightfold Path." And just quickly before we begin, because I want to do the Eightfold Path finally tomorrow. I'm absolutely determined.

The noble truth of suffering, having stated what it is, he says, "This is what has to be fully understood." You have to understand it. And it's not just basic intellectual understanding, of course, but a direct understanding through personal experience. And part of that is the process of meditation, *vipassanā*. And then he says, as far as I'm concerned, "This has been fully understood."

The noble truth of suffering, the origin of it, he says, has to be abandoned. This is what we have to abandon completely. And then he goes on to say that he has, in fact, abandoned it.

The noble truth of end of suffering has to be realised, a direct personal experience of a *nibbānic* moment. And he says that, of course, he has actually experienced that too.

And then, of course, the path itself is something that is to be developed. And, of course, he goes on to say that this has been developed. So that's the process of becoming fully liberated from suffering.

So what I would like to do, I've just got time, I'd like to skip over to the ending of this discourse, which then shows you how it's built up into these wonderful images of other worlds, other gods, et cetera.

"So long, *bhikkhus*, as my knowledge and vision of these four noble truths as they really are in their three phases and twelve aspects" – that's what we've just been through – "was not thoroughly purified in this way, I did not claim to have awakened to the unsurpassed perfection, to the unsurpassed perfect enlightenment in this world, with its *devas*, gods, Mara and Brahma" – those are the higher gods – "and in this generation of ascetics and brahmins, its *devas* and humans." *Devas* are the beings around us. "But when my knowledge and vision of the Four Noble Truths, as they really are in their three phases and twelve aspects, was thoroughly purified in this way, then I claimed to have awakened to the unsurpassed perfect enlightenment in this world. Unshakable is the liberation of my mind. This is my last birth. Now there is no more renewed existence." This is the knowledge and vision that arose in me.

"This is what the Blessed One said and elated, the *bhikkhus* of the group of five delighted in the Blessed One's statement."

And while this discourse was being spoken, there arose in the Venerable Kondañña the dust-free, stainless vision of the Dhamma. Whatever is subject to a beginning is subject to an end. Everything arises and passes away.

And when the wheel of the Dhamma had been set in motion by the Blessed One, the earth-dwelling devas raised a cry: "At Bārāṇasī in the deer park of Isipatana, the unsurpassed wheel of the Dhamma has been set in motion by the Blessed One, which cannot be stopped by any ascetic or Brahmin or deva or Māra or Brahmā or anyone in the world."

And having heard the cry of the earth-dwelling devas, the devas of the realms of the four kings raised the same cry. And from there to the Tāvatiṃsa devas and the Yāma devas, the Tusita devas, the Nimmānaratī devas, and the devas of the Brahmā's company raise the cry: "At Bārāṇasī in the deer park at Isipatana, this unsurpassed wheel of Dhamma has been set in motion by the Blessed One, which cannot be stopped by any ascetic or Brahmin or deva or Māra or Brahmā or anyone in that world."

Thus, at that moment, at that instant, at that second, the cry spread as far as the Brahmā world, and this ten-thousand-fold world system shook, quaked and trembled, and an immeasurable, glorious radiance appeared in the world, surpassing the divine majesty of the devas.

Then the Blessed One uttered this inspired utterance: "Kondañña has indeed understood. Kondañña has indeed understood." And in this way, the Venerable Kondañña acquired the name of Añña Kondañña—Kondañña, the one who knows.

So that's a lovely poetic remembrance of the effect of turning the wheel of the Dhamma for us poor human beings.

08 Mindfulness at Work and Right View, Right Attitude

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

Bhante Bodhidhamma addresses a practical question about maintaining awareness during demanding technical work, distinguishing between retreat-style noting practice and the natural absorption that comes from focused attention at work. He emphasizes that when engaged in activities requiring careful attention, one should prioritize the work itself over systematic noting, allowing natural absorption to develop.

The talk then explores the first two factors of the Noble Eightfold Path: Right View (sammā diṭṭhi) and Right Attitude (sammā saṅkappa). Right View encompasses understanding the Four Noble Truths and the three characteristics of existence - impermanence (anicca), unsatisfactoriness (dukkha), and not-self (anattā). Bhante explains how our experience is constantly filtered through preconceived concepts and emphasizes the importance of understanding karma as intentional action with consequences.

Right Attitude involves the transformation from greed toward generosity, from hatred toward love and acceptance, and from harmfulness toward compassion. These attitudes naturally give rise to appropriate intentions in given circumstances, flowing into the remaining factors of the path. The teaching demonstrates how understanding must first be received conceptually, then personally integrated through reflection, and finally verified through direct vipassanā experience.

Greetings, good evening. I hope you've had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, although I wish it had been happy for you.

Namo tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa, Namō tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa

This evening I just want to start with a practical question that's come through. It's from Danny:

"I have a technical job assembling electromechanical units. This involves reading a drawing, collating the parts and getting the parts to fit together. I try to maintain a degree of mindfulness, but with all the movements associated with these activities, it becomes exhausting. Instead, I note walking from A to B and standing, but I spend more time at the bench. I have tried to note looking and seeing during these times, and even

with this, I'm aware of other actions too, and then note that I'm ignoring these objects to force my attention on the seeing. This can be followed by frustration, again noted. My formal practice is one of slow noting, even though, for example, when I raise my heel, I'm aware of the other touch sensations, but do not note them as independent sensations. My question then is, how to maintain mindfulness at work when I'm involved in an activity that needs to be done with relative speed?"

Now, this is a regular question that comes from people who practice the Mahāsi technique. The Mahāsi technique is a very specific technique for a particular type of situation, the retreat technique. And the whole idea, of course, is to slow everything down. And the noting is a way of stopping the mind from wandering. It has this other purpose, which is to turn everything into an object. You're pointing at something all the time. But in terms of this question, the retreat or the Mahāsi technique is about slowing everything down and noting, especially intentions, and becoming more and more refined in order to see how the mind is creating the world that we're experiencing.

Now, when you go out into daily life, I didn't have this trouble because I had started with Zen and I practiced at Throssel Hole in Northumberland. There we did things at speed, I mean, really fast, and for long times, an hour, two hours even sometimes. And I remember one time, for instance, I was given the job of the dining room, and part of it was polishing the chairs. And I had to polish the chairs as if they'd never been polished. And you did it at great speed. And the understanding is, of course, that the faster you go, the more you've got to keep your mindfulness. Your attention is right there. If your attention wanders, then you'll drop something, you'll trip up, you'll make a mistake. It's not as though mindfulness stops you making mistakes as such because accidents happen.

So I never had this problem of transferring noting into daily life because frankly, I never did it. Because of my Zen training, I knew that what I had to do was just put my attention on what I was doing now, when you are doing something, especially something that demands attention. I mean, careful attention, such as the work that Danny does, then of course, noting can get in the way, because your whole attention is towards the object.

Now, those of you who've been here know that when I talk about meditation at work, doing the chores in the morning, then yes, the idea is to be with what you're doing. And sometimes there's confusion about self-awareness, that you have to be aware of yourself all the time doing something. But that's, of course, a split consciousness in

the sense that one minute you're aware of yourself, and one minute you're aware of what you're doing. So that's not where we want to end up. Self-awareness arises quite naturally, and you can't get rid of it by creating another self. It just creates confusion.

But as you keep paying attention to what you're doing, then there's moments of absorption. Now, this happens to us quite easily when we're watching something exciting like a film. You absorb into the film, you disappear for a couple of hours. And then when you come out, you say, "Oh, that's a good film." And it's the same with hobbies. When we're really interested in what we're doing, gardening or something, time can just fly by. And that's when we lose that sense of self, somebody doing something. And with it, of course, a sense of time. It always happened at the computer a lot, and other ways like Facebook and all that.

So, when we're at work, our effort, of course, is to be attentive to what we're doing. Now, it might be that some noting helps us just to pay attention to that. But in a sense, we don't want it to get in the way. We want to pay attention to such a point that I'm just being my doing. That's the trick of it, you see. So it's not a case of being self-aware of what you're doing. It's not a case of being aware of everything else around what you're doing. It's a case of one-pointed concentration on the work that you're supposed to be attending to.

So it's not a case of noting everything specifically. And at times you can just drop that when you know that your attention is steady, when you can trust it to remain with what you're doing, then you've arrived. That's it now.

When you go into an absorption where you lose that sense of self and you're just doing, of course, how you enter into it is the mental state that you'll be developing. So if you go into it with a calmness, a sense of just doing, a sense of equanimity or whatever, or even a sense of kindness—I mean, that's more easy if you're tending to people rather than a machine. Or with a machine, it would be more carefulness, to be caring. It makes everything easy if you can bring your heart into it, give it a good reason for doing what you're doing. And if you go into it with care and attention, affectionate awareness, then you come out with more of that because you're developing it. If you go in there with a sense of rush, then of course you're reinforcing that attitude and you come out with more rush and that can lead to an early exhaustion.

So I'm presuming that what Danny's saying here is that trying to note and do the work, he's found exhausting and rightly so. So the thing to do is to do the work. If the mind's very jittery, it's going all over the place, then yes, keep noting a little bit just to put your attention there. But as soon as you feel that you're holding your attention and that you're involved, then let go of it. Just be aware. It's enough.

So now if that didn't answer the question, especially, Danny, if it didn't answer the question, just send me another email. And yes, do feel free to send questions about your meditation practice and so on.

So I'm finally arriving at the question: Are all the stages of the eightfold path equally important? Now the short answer is yes, but some precede the others. So they have preference in sense of preceding the others, but eventually they're all important in our practice.

First thing is to be clear as to what the eightfold path is actually referring to here. So remember we've got right view, right understanding, which is followed by right attitude, right intention, and then you have right speech, you have right action, right livelihood. It's interesting. And then you have right effort, right awareness, and right concentration.

Now, interestingly enough, when you actually talk about this as a practice, you start off with *sīla*, you start off with morality, which is right speech, right action, right livelihood. And then you talk about the meditation. And then finally, you talk about the wisdom, the right view and right attitude. But when you're actually talking about it as a logical process as to how it actually knits all together, then you talk about it in this eightfold way. So I'm going to follow just the eightfold path, not the teaching way of *sīla*, *samādhi*, *paññā*, which is morality, concentration or attentiveness, and wisdom.

So when the Buddha talks about *sammādiṭṭhi*, right view, he's basically referring to the four noble truths as the base of our understanding. And from a practical point of view from our practice point of view in terms of *vipassanā*, it really is relating to those three characteristics of existence: that the cause of suffering is desire, that everything changes. Nothing actually changes into something else. Everything is quite separate, quite distinct. And there's this constant impermanence going on. And that everything is *anattā*. From a human point of view, everything is not-self. Everything isn't substantial. Nothing can exist on its own. It's always in relationship, in dependency on something. So obviously the body's dependent on the air that we breathe and so on, and the heart dependent on relationships and the mind dependent on information. So everything has something to feed. It's got to be fed. It's got to be related to.

But the interesting thing is that *sammādiṭṭhi*, right view, is really about conceptual thinking. If you think about it, everything that we experience during the day, everything we look at, we hear, etc., it's always fitting it into a particular concept. This process actually has a word in psychology: apperception. So you see something and you've not seen it before, and when you look at it closely and get close, "Oh, yeah, well, that must be a type of fly." Or you taste something which you haven't tasted before: "Oh

well, this must be a type of Chinese dish." So you're always fitting it in to your preconceived concepts, your preconceived ideas which have been built up ever since we were born. And a lot of them are subconscious. We're not fully aware of these concepts that we are always looking at the world through.

The obvious ones, things like freedom. Now, what do we mean by freedom to you? And this idea—there was, I remember a few years ago now there was this whole thing about the right to insult, which is a very aggressive way of saying that you can say things which might upset others, but the way it came across was that you had to go and punch somebody with your new ideas or with your view. So this whole idea of free speech, the whole idea of personal liberty, the whole idea of democracy, parliamentary democracy, all these are great big concepts which manifest our relationship to the world we find ourselves in. And there's the negative ones: there's all the prejudices, sexism, racism, ageism. Now, I'm very much aware of ageism these days.

So you can see the way we look at the world is always coming from some preconceived ideas. What the Buddha says is that unless we can really correct these ideas, correct these perceptions, these conceptions, then we're just not going to get out of the mess we're in. And that's why he's always keen to deconstruct what we experience and to begin to investigate what we experience.

So the main one is, of course, the one that we directly experience virtually all the time: this relationship we have to pleasure and pain, pleasant and unpleasant. And what he's saying is, if you remember from the beginning of the discourse last night, it's neither indulging nor is it being averse to something. So we're trying to lift ourselves out of this reactivity, which comes from a fundamental misunderstanding somewhere as to where we can find happiness. That's where the base of it is. We all want to be happy and we're all chasing happiness. We've all got our own definition of happiness and it's all coming from this wrong understanding as to where we can find true happiness, or true well-being or true ease with living, an accommodation with life which no longer is painful for us.

So *sammādiṭṭhi* is that. And included in that would be the very important teaching about *kamma*, the fact that when we act, there are consequences. That's a real experience, a real understanding. I mean, there were teachers at the time of the Buddha who said that there was no... There was one, especially, Pūraṇa Kassapa, I think his name was, who said it didn't matter if you went down one side of the Ganges, full of compassionate act and generosity, and at the other side, full of murder and thieving, it wouldn't make a difference at all. It had no consequence.

So there was all these peculiar ideas going around at the time, and the Buddha was clear about action and consequence of action, and that the action had to have some awareness of what you were doing. So killing something by accident or—the usual thing that sometimes happens here, I've not done it so much here, but at Gaia House, I remember when I was there, I'd be walking in the dark and I could hear this crunch and it'd be a snail I just stood on. And I didn't mean to do it. I've got a natural regard for snails. And that wouldn't be considered to have bad *kamma*, except that, of course, one feels guilty anyway, one feels bad anyway, but that's not necessary because there wasn't the intention there. So the whole teaching about *kamma*, it comes into this right understanding.

Now, when we've got this right understanding, as I say, that comes first, and it begins with understanding what we hear, what we're told, what we receive. And then, as it were, it becomes our own personal knowledge, our own personal understanding when we think about it. Often I'm sure you've found that you've understood something but when you've tried to explain it to somebody else you can't do it. And so that's the same with this growth of understanding. The first is through your reading, through your listening, etc. Information comes in and then somehow you've got to think about it, you've got to activate it within yourself, and then it becomes your own property. And then of course it has to be reinforced by direct experience, and that's *vipassanā*—knowing by way of direct experience. And that's when it becomes your own personal experience. And then you find it has this flowing through the rest of the path.

And the next thing, of course, is that it changes your attitude. It changes what you intend. Some people translate it as thought, which I can understand, but I don't think it's quite right. I don't think it quite gets across the meaning of *sammāsaṅkappa*. Because when that's described, it's described as moving away from greed and selfishness towards generosity. And it's a process of renunciation, renouncing that wrong desire. So moving from greed towards generosity. It's described as moving from hatred and aversion towards love and acceptance. And it's described as moving away from harmfulness, from cruelty, from one-upmanship and all that sort of stuff towards compassion. So these are attitudes. And it's out of these attitudes that these intentions begin to manifest in a given circumstance.

And from then, of course, you're into right thinking in your mind, which is a sort of speech. I mean, you're talking to yourself. Then it goes into right speech, right action, right livelihood. And all this is supported by your meditation.

And we'll say a bit more about the right speech, right action and all that, and especially right livelihood actually, tomorrow evening.

So that's the short answer: all these sections in the eightfold path are equally important, but some precede another. And of course, right understanding precedes them all. It then has the effect upon your attitudes and then the rest flows naturally depending on the circumstance. So sometimes you're talking, sometimes you're doing something, sometimes you're at work.

So if any questions arise about that, do send me an email. So I shall leave it there for this evening so that we can get back.

Right Speech, Action and Livelihood

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 22 min

In this teaching on the Noble Eightfold Path, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines three interconnected aspects of ethical conduct that arise from right understanding and intention. He explores sammā vācā (Right Speech), emphasizing truthfulness, kindness, and beneficial communication while avoiding lies, slander, harsh words, and idle chatter. The discussion includes practical guidance on listening with an open heart and choosing appropriate timing for difficult conversations.

The talk continues with sammā kammanā (Right Action), covering the five precepts as a foundation for moral refinement: moving from non-killing toward active protection, from not stealing toward generosity, and from sexual misconduct toward respectful relationships. Bhante addresses the challenge of alcohol abstinence in our society and the importance of sense restraint in daily practice.

Finally, sammā ājīva (Right Livelihood) is presented as an expression of our deepest values, showing how our work shapes our character. The Buddha's guidance to avoid trades in weapons, slavery, meat, alcohol, and poison reflects the principle of non-harm. Throughout, Bhante emphasizes the feedback loop between understanding, intention, and ethical action, demonstrating how virtuous conduct both arises from and reinforces wisdom and compassion.

Greetings and good evening. I trust you've had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and self-awakened one.

I want to read an email that came through. They say they thank me for the live stream: "I have been meditating with you daily and have set up my evenings around this time. You won't be surprised by this, but it's changed my life. I'm sleeping better, feel less burdened in the day. During meditation, I'm able to stay with painful surface and deeper emotions whilst holding them with *metta*. Seeing you meditate and knowing lots of others are doing the same at the same time offers a sense of connection and commitment to my practice. Thank you." There we are. Thank you so much. A little bit of feedback there. I am presuming that that's the same for everybody.

Now, I just want to go back and try to complete a little bit of this Eightfold Noble Path. Remember that my aim over this two months or more was to introduce you to the various discourses in the Middle Length Sayings. So I'll try to get through most of this this evening.

Remember, we started with *sammādiṭṭhi*, right understanding, the Eightfold Path, which is transcendental, not in between indulgence and aversion, but rising above it. In that sense, it's the middle, it's transcendent. And remember that this *sammādiṭṭhi* is to do with conceptual, the way we conceive, the way we look at things and experience things through our concepts.

The big mistake, according to the Buddha, is to seek any sort of lasting happiness in anything to do with this world, that things are impermanent, radically so. They're arising and passing away momentarily. And that this whole concept of me, the self, is causing a great deal of problems. And that manifests through our attachments. Attachments are psychological dependencies. We use things, we use people in order to make ourselves feel happy. That's not the same as *metta*, compassion and generosity. That's coming from a different place, coming from the place of wisdom, coming from the place of not me, me, me.

This conceptual, the right concept draws us into these social virtues. The main ones being generosity, love, goodwill, and compassion. The desire to help people. Now, once this is passed into our attitudes, into our intentions, then of course they begin to manifest in the way we think, which is an internal speech, an internal speaking. I speak to myself. Sometimes I'm speaking to myself, but also I find myself speaking to lots of other people too inside this little head of mine. And it includes, of course, speech in ordinary daily life.

The type of speech we don't want to get into is, of course, untruths. We don't want to do that. We don't want to slander people. Blake says, "A truth told with bad intent beats all the lies you can invent." So that's a beautiful little verse. It depends on your intention, which makes it either slander or having to say something which might undermine somebody's reputation, but it might be for good reason. Abusive speech, using speech in order to upset people. And finally just chit chat, just talking for talking's sake, just a waste of time really.

We hate silence when you're walking with a friend or walking with somebody who's close to you, your partner or a child. There's always this compulsion to have to communicate. You have to speak. And it's a sign of maturity of a relationship that you can be silent with each other. That's my understanding anyway.

When it comes to free speech, there was a period there a couple of years back where free speech came up around this whole business of Islam and not insulting the prophets, and there came this phrase "the right to insult." That's a very aggressive way of saying that everybody has a right to express their opinion, even though they know it'll upset somebody. But it became very hard, it became a sort of aggressive thing, the right to insult. I don't think you have a right to insult. You have a right to express yourself, your own truths, even though you might upset somebody.

When that happens, we normally introduce it, don't we? We say, "I know this is going to upset you, I hope you don't mind," and so on and so forth. So it's a case of being kind, being gentle. That's one of the qualities of right speech, being gentle and being truthful, of course, truthful to ourselves, truthful to the situation. And the sense of being beneficial, that is, you're speaking for either your own benefit, somebody else's benefit, or your own and somebody else's benefit. And with a heart of loving kindness, the Buddha says, coming from a heart of loving kindness.

Sometimes that's difficult, of course, when you're talking to somebody who's being aggressive and whatnot, in which case at least you can come from the heart of no harm. There's no point in upsetting ourselves and getting angry ourselves. That's just a waste of energy. And it's that distinction between being aggressive and being assertive. That's a very clear way of putting it. You can actually state your truth coming from a position of strength, a position of goodwill, a position of compassion. You don't have to come from anger.

In fact, if anything, anger manifests a certain weakness because sitting underneath anger, there's always fear. You don't get angry unless you're afraid. It's underneath it. It's underpinning the anger. Fear is underpinning anger.

One of the interesting things the Buddha says, of course, is to say at the right time, to choose your time to say things. There's a right time and a wrong time. I'm sure we've all experienced dropping a clanger. So it's a case of recognising a situation and being careful about what we say. And I think the key to that, when we're with people, is the ability to listen.

I think we find listening difficult, especially when somebody is expressing ideas or positions which are not the same as ours, even opposed to ours. Then there's a sort of fear, I think, that we're going to be converted, that if we allow ourselves to listen, open-hearted, open-minded, there's this terrible danger that they might change me. But if we come from that sense of inner stability, just that calmness, and with a willingness to un-

derstand the world that they are living in... I mean, we're all creating our own little worlds, and the intention is to understand, well, where are they coming from? Where are they coming from? It doesn't have to convert us.

But on the other hand, we may find ourselves that our views and opinions are nuanced by what other people say. And that's coming from the heart of humility. None of this business of "I'm right and everybody else is wrong." I'm special that way.

So there's a whole area of right speech which we can contact on a daily basis. And that would be the purpose of an evening reflection, an evening reflection where you look back and you've had a conversation with somebody where it didn't go right or you had a conversation with somebody where it really did go right, where you felt you were skillful, wise and stuff like that. And on both counts, you can reinforce, you can encourage us, you can congratulate yourself. There's nothing wrong with that. "Well done. Well done, Bodhidhamma." Absolutely.

And if you haven't done so well, you can always encourage yourself. Go do better now. Go do better than that. So there's no need to get angry with oneself, hate oneself. It's a waste, a complete waste of energy, useless. It doesn't go anywhere at all except to more misery, just creates more misery for us.

So that's the position of right speech. And again, it's coming from these attitudes that we've developed because of our different view about life. It all goes back to view. And this is what I meant about they're all important. And we'll see why when I come to the end. But some precede others. Some precede others.

When it comes to *sammākamanta*, which is right action, that's usually expressed as the moral law, just basic morality, not to kill, steal, offensive sexual behaviour, conduct. And including in this being untruth and, of course, the use of drugs and alcohol and stuff, which isn't very good for us.

The move there is towards refinement. It's towards refinement. Where obviously we've given up killing, at least for a while, and we're moving towards protecting, protecting each other, protecting animals, protecting the wildlife, protecting flowers. It's all... so it's a change of attitude and protection. Stealing moves us towards generosity. Offensive sexual conduct moves us towards right relationship, treating the other as a person, not as an object to satisfy our personal erotic desires. When it comes to right speech, well, we've done that, of course.

And this idea of non-alcohol, which is very difficult for our society because we are alcohol-based. It's a case of recognising that under the influence, especially if we've drunk a little bit too much, we can do things which aren't particularly good. And when

you consider that our purpose is to maintain a sort of bright awareness at all times, as soon as you wake up to the point you fall asleep, we're supposed to be bright, we're supposed to be mindful. Putting alcohol in the system really doesn't help.

I had a very good experience with that myself. I'd given up alcohol and I'd come out of a Zen session. So I was going right back to the beginning of my practice. And just on the way home, I sort of slipped into a pub and had half a beer, half a mild or something. And I did it in order to see what effect it would have. And to my surprise, after I'd drunk it for a little while, I just felt this sort of curtain, it's difficult to describe, a sort of net coming down, an actual physical feeling in my brain. And that convinced me that I had to give it up, which I did.

So when you consider that poison... I mean, this is the point, isn't it? That alcohol is the most vicious of poisons for the body. It kills brain cells. It messes your liver up, it does all sorts of bad things. And non-alcoholic beer is very good. So there's no reason for drinking alcohol at all.

So those are the sort of things we're moving towards, moving towards refinement. The other thing in that is to do with restraint of the senses. That's one of the big teachings of the Buddha, to restrain, to guard the senses, to be on the lookout for when the senses do get involved in stuff and to be aware of that reaction that we have to what we see, to what we hear. Restraining the senses.

I mean, that sounds like suppressing something. But it's not. It's sort of holding and saying, no, we don't want to keep developing that particular mental state. So, like, for instance, when you see something which draws a certain anger out of you or draws a certain neurotic feeling out of you, to actually catch at the beginning and just say, no, you don't want to go there. And that way you're undermining an old habit, undermining an old habit. Not saying by the way that there aren't times when erotic feelings are to the point, within a proper relationship, okay.

Right livelihood. Now the importance of livelihood is it's an expression of our desire, of the way we see ourselves. If you happen to have the job that you wanted, if you happen to have the area of work that you want, your own personal interest, your own personal bent, your own personal special qualities. So people want to move towards helping other people. So they end up being nurses or doctors or involved in some sort of hospital medical staff. But even wanting to be involved in a hospital as a cleaner, that might be that desire to be involved in that sort of place of helping people.

Other people want to develop their lives to art or to nature. They want to be involved in gardens and things like that. Other people want to be involved in artificial intelligence and information technology and all that sort of stuff. What you do is actually developing your particular characteristic, your particular character. So it's a case of recognising that the work you're doing is actually affecting your personality and your character. And that's why it's so important.

And of course, there are particular types of trades that we don't want to get involved with. Trading in arms, in living beings, slavery and prostitution, meat, alcohol and poison. So those are the five ones that you try not to get involved with. So that shows you that there's a flow down from right understanding, right attitude manifesting in the way we speak, in the way we behave, and in our work.

And the last three we'll come to at another time. They're basically to do, of course, with our meditation, both in our sitting practice, but also in daily life. This mindfulness, affectionate mindfulness. The Buddha, when we read or chant the loving-kindness discourse, when he talks about we should always live with this mindfulness, he's talking about a mindfulness which is imbued with a sense of kindness, a sense of goodwill. So the heart's always involved.

It's the same with your work. I should have mentioned this. There are these two qualities: being attentive, like you're attending to what you're doing, but you have to give the heart a good reason. So there's attention and care. Attention and care. You can always bring care into anything, sense of care.

And the important thing is that all of these feedback, they feed back into themselves. Although we began with the importance of conceptual, of getting our concepts right, of understanding how we create suffering, etcetera, etcetera, of getting our attitudes right, and from then there's a flow, there's a feedback. Because as we behave coming from that position of wisdom, it feeds back into the wisdom. It supports the wisdom and there's a desire to deepen that wisdom. There's a desire to grow in those attitudes: love, compassion, joy, peace, and all that.

They're known, remember, as illimitables. You can develop them without boundary. They can just keep going. They can just be developed ad infinitum. There's no limit to how much we can develop mental states. And that's unfortunately true of evil states too. But here, we're only concerned with what's good.

So there's a sort of feedback loop in this. And the interesting one is between attitude and understanding. Because if we are drawn to compassionate action, to compassion which is driven by goodwill, action which is driven by generosity, by giving, remember

that is constantly undermining the sense of this isolated me. It is constantly reinforcing the fact of we, that we're all in this together, that I am my relationships. And that undermines this very isolated sense of self.

And every time we give or do something which hurts a little, like what you give through generosity or what is demanded of you from your compassion, all that is undermining that sense of me. It's all about me, me, me. That doesn't, of course, undermine self-care. It just takes away this barrier of me. And we see ourselves more as inter-related. We know all these words: interrelated, interdependent, into being. I mean, that's *taṇhā* and that manifests through the way we actually speak, the way we act and so on.

So that reinforces again, that changes our concepts. Change our concept if, for instance, you've been a sort of person who's not been very generous and then suddenly you begin to be generous and you realise the joy that you're giving to people. When you give joy to people you find your own heart rejoicing. Then that's your feedback. Then you realise, "Well this is where I can find some real happiness which is based on community, based on communication."

Okay, so time has moved on and it's time to do our little meditation here. Definitely very good.

Grief

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 18 min

In this compassionate teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma addresses the difficult topic of grief, drawing from personal correspondence about recent losses and the challenges many face during times of isolation. He makes a crucial distinction between sorrow—the natural empathetic response to others' suffering—and grief, which arises from our psychological attachments and dependencies.

The talk explores how the Buddha himself dealt with grief when his two chief disciples, Sāriputta and Moggallāna, passed away, and the advice given to Ānanda about finding refuge in oneself and the Dhamma. Bhante discusses the famous teaching about how "those who have a hundred loved ones have a hundred sorrows," clarifying that this doesn't negate love and care, but points to the suffering that comes from attachment.

Drawing on poetry from John Donne and contemporary grief counseling wisdom, this teaching offers practical guidance for working with loss—allowing the natural healing process to unfold over time without adding unnecessary suffering through self-blame or guilt. The talk emphasizes that grief is simply a consequence to be experienced, not a punishment, and that the measure of our grief is not the measure of our love.

Good evening and greetings. I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I wish it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

So I've had two rather sad emails. We've discussed all this business about death. And then, of course, there's the complementary side, which, of course, is grief.

One writer says these last years has brought to my daughter a series of griefs: the deaths of close ones and beloveds, some unexpected due to suicide, some through the combination of illness, one the most beloved from a cardiac arrest. And she also lost her pet, and they themselves were diagnosed with cancer, but is in remission now. And she's found that during this lockdown, a lot of this grief and sorrow are arising, particularly in dreams during meditation. So when we're alone, these turbulences, whatever they are, they tend to come back to haunt us.

And very recently, a very sad case, a very sad situation of a man, a young man, well, youngish—34 from my point of view, youngish—Pete, who's had a seizure at night and died, leaving his wife and three small children. So that, of course, is a huge shock to somebody who has to suffer that, to all those close to him.

This problem of grief obviously is coming up for all those people who have lost somebody to this coronavirus. And it's good just to say something a little bit about all that.

First of all is to try to make a distinction, just using these words, between sorrow and grief. I mean, they're interchangeable. Sorrow is that trembling, as the Buddha would say, in the heart, what we would call empathy, where you feel the sorrow of somebody else. And you can say that when somebody dies in an unfortunate way, or they're too young to die, die before their time, as we say, that there's a certain sorrow on their behalf, as a thing that they could have offered more to society, they could have lived a longer life. But generally, there's a sense of sorrow about it. And that's really looking at it, as it were, from their point of view, not from our point of view.

When we see—I mean, the big case, of course, was that little boy on the beach, which caused Angela Merkel to allow refugees in. So there was a movement there, a resonance in the heart with the suffering of others. And that sorrow normally demands some sort of action into compassion or else it lies unrequited. It lies as a pain in the heart. And of course, if you can't do anything, then you can at least send your good wishes, you can do the meditation on contemplation, and you have to accept that you can't do anything. There's no point in beating ourselves up about that. So in a sense that sorrow is part and parcel of our communication, our being with people.

I'd like to read this really lovely poem by John Donne. I won't read it all, just the main section. John Donne was a poet in the restoration period, James I, all that sort of thing. And he says: "No man is an island, entire of itself. Each is a piece of the continent, a part of the main. If a clod is washed away by the sea, Europe is the less. Each man's death diminishes me, for I am involved in mankind. Therefore send not to know for whom the bell tolls; it tolls for thee."

So in other words, every man's death is also a little death within me. I had a friend down in Cornwall I would visit on occasion, and he died, and of course I've lost that relationship. So something in me has been lost, and there's a wholesomeness about that because we need people, we need friendships, we need to be able to relate, to communicate. It's just part of that feed. Hopefully tomorrow I'll be talking about the nutrients and you'll see that this was recognised by the Buddha—that we do need other people. And that's obviously obvious when it comes to meditation: it's so much easier to

suffer when you know everybody else in the room is going through something similar than just sitting on your own. And I'm especially aware of people who are actually in isolation because of medical problems. So it's difficult just to be on your own. These days, of course, it is attenuated, shall we say, by modern technology.

Interestingly enough, when the Buddha's two main disciples died—that's Moggallana and Sariputta—I'm going to read this little bit actually. This again is taken from the book *Mindfully Facing Disease and Death* by Venerable Analayo. Highly recommend it. There is another book, by the way, which I might have mentioned, *Living in the Light of Death, The Art of Being Truly Alive* by Larry Rosenberg.

Now, when Sariputta died, Ananda said, "I declare having myself known them on attaining full awakening before establishments of mindfulness," and so on and so forth, "these have all been taken away." In other words, Ananda is grieving the loss of his teacher. And there's a series of questions that the Buddha asks him: "Well, has he taken away your ability to observe your mind?" He goes through the discourse on how to establish right awareness. "Has he taken away your ability to investigate? Has he taken away your ability to become fully liberated yourself?" And of course, Ananda says no.

And then the Buddha gives him his advice, which you also get right at the end of the discourse which tells about the last few days of the Buddha. He reminds him that he himself, the Buddha himself, the Tathagata, would go. "Therefore, do not be so very sad, Ananda. You should know that soon the Tathagata will also be of the past. Therefore, Ananda, you should have yourself as an island by relying on yourself. You should have the Dharma as an island by relying on the Dharma. You should not have another island, no other reliance."

So now this seems contrary to what we've just read from John Donne, that every man isn't an island. Of course we're talking about two different things. We talk about our relationship, our necessary relationship with other people, and the fact that the relationship goes wrong. Now that's the problem. Where does the relationship go wrong? It goes wrong through attachment. We all know this. Attachment is just another way of saying a psychological dependency on somebody for my happiness, for my security, for my comfort, and so on and so forth. And what the Buddha is saying is, when you put that aside, you've got to find your own inner safety, your own inner place. And of course we're doing that every time we sit in meditation—we're discovering this, the observer, the feeler, the one who knows.

And when that's very clear to you, when you are really the one who knows within yourself and everything else is happening—the body with its feeling and the heart with its emotions, the mind with its thought—when you're quite separate from that and you are the observer, the feeler, ask yourself: What's it like? Is it okay? Is it worth being there most of the time? Not so much as the observer, but in that coolness.

The Buddha actually says that when Sariputta dies, and Moggallana too—Moggallana was murdered, it seems, by another sect who got jealous of him or something—when these two main disciples died, and they would have been a similar age, because he was 35 when he began teaching, and they became very quickly his disciples, his first disciples, they would have been late twenties, thirties, so very close to him in age—he said that the sangha, that's the order of monks and nuns, felt empty without them. So that's the other side. That's the business of no man is an island. But now we've got this more negative side which is really about the grief that we feel.

So this grief has to be felt. It has to be suffered. It's what's left. It's what is the consequence, the *kamma*, the *kamma* of unwholesome relationship. Now, you have to be careful here. This isn't immoral. It's not as though you go to hell forever because you had an attachment to somebody. Not at all. It's unwholesome in the sense that eventually it causes pain and it causes us to suffer.

And grief, especially with sudden death, as we had with Pete who died a couple of nights back—I meant to bring this up last night, actually, but it wasn't here—and with this woman who's come with all these series of griefs, that really it's extremely difficult to stay with that shock, with the constant death of people in our lives. And of course, as you grow older, as I am, people begin to disappear. And eventually, if you live long enough, it's just you. I mean, you've made other friends, younger friends, whatever. But all those old friends that you've known for years, that maybe even go back to childhood, they've all gone. And you're just left there with all these memories.

So grief is that sore, the wound, which is caused when something from the heart is taken out, it's ripped out when it's a shock like that. And there's no other way but to sit with it and to give the heart time to heal and to know that this is the cause of a psychological dependency. But that isn't to take away the fact that there was also love there, there was also a sense of care for the person. So sometimes you get confused about that. And of course the big confusion is to think that as your grief diminishes, it's telling you that you don't love the person as you used to, you're losing their love. Well, if you get into that, you're into a never-ending cycle of grief, which lessens and then you have to grieve a bit more. You have to keep pumping it up because you're trying to prove that the grief you have is the measure of your love.

But if the grief process is gone through in its normal passage, which they say is about nine months, and I'm sure you all know if you happen to have grief in your life, there is a charity, Cruse, which helps people—if you allow the heart to express its pain, then over a period of up to nine months it begins to dissipate. Not that it doesn't come back in little blips, but at least the terrible pain, especially the first three, six months, begins to dissipate. And slowly one begins to contact that love that one had. That love, that care that one had. And of course, that brings up beautiful memories and joy arises. I mean, that would be the normal passage of things.

There's a lay woman who was a great supporter of the Buddha. It goes right back to his early days. And she turns up one day at the monastery with her hair drenched, weeping, crying out in sorrow. And it says, she went to see the Buddha in the middle of the day in spite of the sun. Her favorite grandchild, Datta, who had always helped to distribute her alms, had suddenly passed away. And when she told the Blessed One of her sorrow, he asked whether she wanted to have as many children and grandchildren as there were people in the city of Sravasti. That's the capital of Kosala. And she joyfully agreed. "But how many people die in Sravasti every day?" said the Blessed One. And she considered and said, "Oh, Lord, in Sravasti, nine or ten people, five or three or two people, or at least one, die every day. Sravasti is never free of dying."

And being asked whether in this case she would ever be without sorrow, she had to admit that she would feel sorrow every single day. So the Blessed One said, "Those who have a hundred loved ones have a hundred sorrows. Those who have ninety," all the way down to one, "have only one sorrow. And those who have no loved ones have no sorrow. Those alone, I say, are without sorrow, without suffering, without desperation."

And, of course, he's not talking about love and care. He's talking about what happens when you're attached, when you are dependent on somebody for some well-being, for some happiness, for some comfort. And that, of course, is something that we simply have to work through. And as I say, not to make the mistake between grief and love. The way I'm using the word, grief is the measure about attachment, and we just have to suffer it. And that's something to remind ourselves too, that punishment is out of the question in Buddhism. You don't have to punish anybody or punish yourself or get angry with yourself. All we're doing there is adding more suffering to the suffering. All we have to do is suffer consequences. That's all we're asked to do. And allow the heart, give it time to heal.

The Nutriments: Food, Contact, Volition and Consciousness

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 24 min

In this profound exploration of the Sammādiṭṭhi Sutta (MN 9), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's teaching on the four nutriments (āhāra) that sustain both physical and mental existence. Drawing from the Saṃyutta Nikāya's vivid metaphors, he explains how edible food nourishes the body, sensory contact feeds our feelings, mental volition empowers our actions, and consciousness sustains our ongoing rebirth moment to moment.

The teaching reveals how our attachment to these four nutriments perpetuates suffering and binds us to saṃsāra. Bhante explores the psychological dimension of eating, showing how our relationship with food reflects deeper fears about death and our animal nature. He examines how sensory contact creates the pleasant-unpleasant duality that drives craving, and emphasizes the crucial role of volition in spiritual development - explaining why the Mahasi method focuses so intently on noting intentions.

The discussion illuminates how consciousness serves as the window through which we experience both inner and outer worlds, while warning that Right Awareness (sammā sati) must recognize itself as distinct from ordinary consciousness. This teaching offers essential understanding for anyone seeking to comprehend the mechanics of dependent origination (paṭicca samuppāda) and the path to liberation from the cycle of becoming (bhava).

Greetings. I hope you've had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I wish it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So, I want to go back to the original discourse which we started with 10 days ago. I'm still making my way through it. And it's called the *Sammādiṭṭhi Sutta*. It's the Discourse on Right View. And we've discussed some of these things. The core question that Sāriputta—remember this is Sāriputta, not the Buddha, answering. Sāriputta, remember, was considered by the Buddha to really have a grip on the Dharma. He trusted him. So

this is the basic question: In what way is a noble disciple, one of right view, whose view is straight, who has perfect confidence in the Dharma, and has arrived at the true Dharma?

So in this discourse on right view, the first thing he talks about is, if you remember, wholesome, unwholesome. Unwholesome—to know the distinction between those two is of vital importance, or else we end up in a nasty place. And the next one is nutriment. And I would think that most people haven't come across the nutriment. So this is the Buddha always deconstructing something, deconstructing our experience and then putting it together again, showing us how it all fits.

And the four nutriment—I'm going to read the actual text, but before that, I just want to give an introduction to them. So first of all, there's food for the body. That's pretty straightforward. The nutriment for the body itself is food. And then there's contact. That's the contact of the senses with the world from which we get our feelings. Those of you who know dependent origination know that that's the point where we contact the physical world. Five senses. That's what he's talking about in the present moment, not the mental sense. And then there is the contact of volition. Now, volition is the point where we bring something out of the potential—a desire—and through empowering it, it manifests. So that's pretty important. We'll come back to it. And then consciousness is driven by, feeds that desire for constant rebirth.

So if we go back to the business of food, when you think about food, why you're eating, then you recognize that underneath it, there's a great fear. So this is going back to our old friend death. And I wanted to quote from Ernest Becker here, who won the Pulitzer Prize in '73 for his book called "The Denial of Death." And he says, "The real world is simply too terrible to admit. We hide the real constant threat of death by fantasies where we survive: the idea of death, the illusion of human supremacy, male supremacy, class supremacy, race supremacy, age supremacy." See, it's always trying to make us special.

And what he's saying is, of course, is that underneath it all, we're just these little animals. We're human animals. At a physical level, there's no distinction to be made between us, between me and the sheep in the field here. We both of us need food. And we both of us need protection from the weather, although me more than them. So this protection makes us quite irrational sometimes.

It's interesting to note—this is from a website I picked up on, thearrowjournal.com. It's about terror management—and he points out, this has also happened here, why in the midst of this genuine panic—so this is coronavirus—did North American consumers turn first—this is perfectly true for us too—not to rice, nuts and oranges? It wasn't that that people snapped up first; it was toilet paper.

And I might have mentioned this the other day, but I met a neighbor who had been at the local co-op supermarket in Churchstow. And a woman wheeled out two trolleys, two trolleys full of toilet paper. Seemingly, he made some wry comment, which probably upset her. And the whole thing is that we're just trying to hide from ourselves this animal nature. So we've got to go back to food to recognize that it is a nutriment for this body, and that this body is part of our nature and it's part of the natural world.

The Buddha—we'll come to it at some future date—the Buddha is very anxious for us to actually get in touch with the foulness of the body, to become equanimous with it, to be happy in our skin, as I think it's said.

Now the next is contact. Just consider from the moment we wake up, the senses are constantly bombarded by information. As soon as you open your eyes, you can see around the room, your ears are hearing. You might be able to, when you walk out, like I do in the morning out into nature—very fortunate—there's that lovely smell of humus in the air, the earth coming up from the ground is really, really quite beautiful. And of course, I can hear the birds. The birds are all coming out. We've got a very lovely black-bird who sings to us every morning. And there's, of course, the taste—you know, breakfast, you have that fullness of taste. And there's just feeling, feeling things—you know, like just brushing your teeth, holding something—so that there's a constant input of information coming in at contact.

And these create sensations, which we then translate into either pleasant or unpleasant. And of course there's a whole area of neutral feelings. But if you really go down into a neutral feeling, you'll see it shades off—it shades off very quietly into either something we don't want or something we don't like, something we do like. So that's the dual world that we live in—the dualistic world of feeling. Some of it's pleasant, some of it's unpleasant. And this of course takes us on to the next position on the dependent origination where we react to it. But because of contact, the feeling arises. So contact is a nutriment. It's feeding us in order to experience feelings.

And what we want to get to is, of course, a disinterest—which doesn't mean, say, a boredom—it just means not to be attached to pleasant or unpleasant sensations.

The third one is volition. So this is the point where a desire is activated. It's our power. It's the power that we have to do things in the world. And it's driven by a curiosity of the world, but also a will to become, a will to live. And that's produced all this science, all the art, all the doing that we do, the huge financial system and all that. It's all driven by this lust for life, this *bhavatanā*, the desire to become. And what empowers that is this volition.

And remember that every time you act, there's a field of energy goes out which has an effect and which comes back to you in some way. As you know, if you're angry with somebody, you get a response, you get a reaction. And if you're kind to somebody, generous to somebody, that something happens, right? So remember that passage between an act of will produces an action, a set of similar actions produces a habit, a set of habits produces a personality—personhood, should we say. And that, of course, determines your destiny.

And it's only when we turn round upon it to question the validity of our attitudes—this goes back to the Eightfold Path—that we begin to change ourselves. And it always comes right back down again to volition. That's why here, you know, when people come on retreat here, the Mahāsi was so keen to actually note intentions, note intentions. It's crucial in terms of our development, spiritual development.

And then finally there's consciousness, which is this constant rebirthing now. Consciousness arises and passes away, and we're experiencing rebirthing now. The only difference with death is that the body drops off. That's the Buddhist understanding. Some of you I know are scientific materialists, so forget that bit. It's just recognizing that here and now we're actually rebirthing. And that's done through consciousness.

So consciousness is the mirror, or should we say the window, which manifests the world, both the inner world and the outer world. And it's through this screen of consciousness that we experience the world. And it's on the screen of consciousness that all this hidden stuff that we don't know is inside us—the old subconscious, call it what you want—begins to manifest. And that's often what we're experiencing when we sit in meditation. So consciousness feeds experience.

And just as an aside, the real spiritual insight is for this *satipaññā*, this intuitive awareness, to realize it is not this consciousness. And it's on the screen of consciousness that you get that sense of self—the observer, the feeler, and so on.

So time's running on. So I actually want to read this discourse, which I think you'll find somewhat amusing. So it's on the nutriments, and it's in the book, The Connected Discourse, the *Saṃyutta Nikāya*, and there's two of these, for heaven's sake. I have to

confess, I've never read the whole scriptures through. I've always centered on the longer discourses and the middle discourses and some of the others, but I've never had the will to get through all the other tomes, not being a particular academic of mind.

So here we are. This is called "The Son's Flesh." At Sāvattthī, the Buddha's talking at Sāvattthī, one of his main monasteries. "There are four kinds of nutriment for the maintenance of beings that have already come to be and for the assistance of those who are about to come to be. What four? Nutriment edible food, contact, volition and consciousness."

"Now, how should the nutriment edible food be seen? Suppose a couple, husband and wife, had taken limited provisions and were traveling through the desert. They have with them their dear son, beloved. Then in the middle of the desert their limited provisions would be used up and exhausted while the rest of the desert remains to be crossed. The husband and wife would think, 'Oh, our limited provisions have been used up and exhausted while the rest of the desert remains to be crossed. Let us kill our only son, dear and beloved as he is, and prepare dried and spiced meat. By eating our son's flesh we can cross the rest of the desert. Let not all three of us perish.'"

"Then the husband and wife carry on doing this. They kill the son and all that. And they lament, 'Where are you, our only son?' Well, they should know. It's in their bellies, aren't they? So now what do you think? Would they eat that food for amusement or for enjoyment or for the sake of physical beauty and attractiveness?"

"No, venerable sir."

"Wouldn't they eat the food only for the sake of crossing the desert?"

"Yes, Venerable Sir. In such a way, I say, nutrimental edible food should be seen. When nutrimental edible food is fully understood, then the lust of the five senses is fully understood. And when lust for the five chords of sensual pleasure is fully understood, there is no fetter bound by which a noble disciple might come back into this world."

In other words, eat for the purpose of becoming fully spiritually enlightened and not for any other. That takes you off the path. But what a wonderful metaphor.

So now he goes on to say the nutriment, the contact. So this is contact—yeah, the sensual contact, the eyes, the ears, et cetera—vision, hearing, that's more precise. "Supposing there is a flayed cow—right, all the skin's taken off. If she stands exposed to a wall, the creatures dwelling in the wall would nibble at her. If she stands exposed to a tree, the creatures dwelling in the tree would nibble at her. If she stands exposed to water,

the creatures dwelling in the water would nibble at her. And if she stands exposed to the open air, the creatures dwelling in the open air would nibble at her. Whatever that flayed cow stands exposed to, the creatures dwelling there would nibble at her, right? In such a way, I say the nutriment contact should be seen."

"When nutriment contact is fully understood, the three kinds of feeling are fully understood—pleasant, unpleasant, neutral. And when the three kinds of feelings are fully understood"—that is, they are just feelings, not to be indulged, not to be seeking some sort of permanent happiness there, not to be dependent on them for happiness—"I say there is nothing further for a disciple to do."

"How should the nutriment mental volition be seen? Suppose there's a charcoal pit deeper than a man's height filled with glowing coals without flame or smoke. And a man would come along wanting to live, not wanting to die, desiring happiness and averse to suffering. Then two strong men would grab him by both arms and drag him towards the charcoal pit. The man's volition would be to get far away. His longing would be to get far away. His wish would be to get far away from that charcoal pit. For what reason? Because he knows, 'I will fall into the charcoal pit and on that account I will meet death and deadly suffering.' It is in such a way that I say the nutriment mental volition should be seen."

Right? So in other words, not to get into the fire of wrong will, unwholesome will. "And the three kinds of craving are fully understood: craving for sensual pleasure, craving to become and craving not to become. When these three kinds of cravings are fully understood, I say there is nothing further for a noble disciple to do."

"How should the nutriment consciousness be seen? Supposing they were to arrest a bandit, a criminal, and bring him before the king saying, 'Sire, this man is a bandit, a criminal. Impose on him whatever punishment you wish.' And the king says, 'Go, men. And in the morning, strike the man with a hundred spears.' In the morning, they strike him with a hundred spears. And then at noon, the king asks, 'Men, how's that man?' 'Still alive, sire.' 'Then go and at noon, strike him with a hundred spears.' At noon they strike him with a hundred spears. And then in the evening the king asks, 'Men, how's that man?' 'Still alive, sire.' 'Then go and in the evening strike him with a hundred spears.' And in the evening they strike him with a hundred spears."

"What do you think, bhikkhus, would that man being struck by 300 spears experience pain and displeasure on that account?"

"Venerable sir, even if it was struck with one spear, he would experience pain and displeasure on that account, not to speak of three hundred spears."

"It is in such a way, bhikkhus, that I say the nutriment of consciousness should be seen. When the nutriment of consciousness is fully understood, body and mind are understood. When body and mind is fully understood, I say there is nothing further for a noble disciple needs to do."

So it is through consciousness that we become aware of this psychophysical organism. And the image of them is two sheaves of wheat leaning against each other. One is dependent on the other. Without consciousness, as in deep sleep, you're not aware of your body and mind. But as soon as consciousness arises, you're aware of it.

Now, of course, what he's pointing to is that this consciousness is the way into delusion, right? And it's recognizing that. It's recognizing that we have to be very careful where we put our attention. Every time you attend to something, it's an act of intention. It is conditioning us, okay?

So time moves on, as always. So let me finish with another little paragraph. This is a slightly different way of looking at it. "If there is lust for nutriment edible food, if there is delight, if there is craving, consciousness becomes established there and comes to grow."

Okay? So, I mean, that's what we experience, isn't it? The more we feed our greed, et cetera, et cetera, the more we want of it, no matter what the greed is of. These days, people just want more. It doesn't matter what it is, it's just more. I mean, that's what we've come to want, just more of anything.

"Wherever consciousness becomes established and comes to grow, there is a descent into name and form"—body and mind. Notice that—the descent.

I don't quite understand the image there as to why he says descent, but I presume it's a case of that it's something which is not to be desired. So remember, *nibbāna* is something beyond all this, right? That's difficult for us to accept.

Where there is a descent into name and form, body and mind, there is a growth of volitional formations. So as soon as we have this psychophysical organism, then we want to do, we want to act, and that's our volitions. Where there is a growth of volitional formations, there's the production of future renewed existence, moment after moment, and if you will, life after life.

And where there is a production of future renewed existence, there is future birth, aging, and death. Where there is future birth, aging, and death, I say, that is accompanied by sorrow, anguish, and despair.

So he's actually asking us to contemplate our lives from these four nutriment points of view: to become aware of what we're actually eating for the body's sake, that we're not getting attached to food; that we're aware of the feelings that arise when we make contact with anything; that we're aware of the process of attention and intention which creates *kamma* for us; and that we're aware of how consciousness is the window or the mirror in which we enter into the world.

So it's very important to recognize where we put our attention. Very good.

So I hope my words have been of some assistance there. They've not caused even greater confusion. And it's time to do a bit of meditation, I think.

The Investigation of Eating

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 23 min

In this insightful talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's striking metaphor from the Puttamāṃsa Sutta about parents eating their son's flesh to survive crossing a desert - a powerful teaching on the nature of nutriment (āhāra) and right intention in consumption. He guides practitioners through the practice of eating meditation, one of his signature teachings, showing how mindful consumption becomes a vehicle for understanding attachment and developing Right Awareness.

The talk addresses three crucial distinctions for liberation from indulgence: distinguishing enjoyment from indulgence, separating body from mind in the eating process, and recognizing the difference between desire and action. Bhante explains how the suffering of obsessive craving, frustration, grief at loss, anxiety, and boredom all arise from attachment to sensory pleasures. Through careful investigation of the eating process - from initial excitement to the fading of taste pleasure - practitioners learn to see how the mind overlays excitement onto bodily sensations.

This practical teaching extends beyond food to all areas of life, offering a daily laboratory for understanding the mechanics of craving (taṇhā) and developing the will power to choose wholesome actions over habitual reactivity. Perfect for anyone seeking to transform everyday activities into opportunities for insight and liberation.

Good evening. I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, but I wish that it has been happy.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

Happy Easter to those of you who are still connected to Christianity. I thought this evening to make a bit of a meal out of that discourse that we read last night. It's a pun on words, of course. Just to centre in on the first metaphor that the Buddha uses there about food, the son's flesh, as it's called.

He always teaches, first of all, from a rational, intellectual point of view. Then he makes a great effort to give us a metaphor — there are literally hundreds of metaphors in the scriptures — and he says that some people think that way, they understand things, they make a better connection. Most of us, of course, would use both. So we

were talking about the nutrients, and I just want to read that bit again. And then we'll talk about eating meditation, which those of you who've been here will know is one of my obsessive teachings.

So suppose a couple — we're back in the desert. Suppose a couple, husband and wife, had taken limited provisions and were travelling through a desert. They have with them their only son, dear and beloved. Then in the middle of the desert their limited provisions would be used up and exhausted while the rest of the desert remains to be crossed. The husband and wife would think, "Our limited provisions have been used up and are exhausted while the rest of the desert remains to be crossed. Let us kill our only son, dear and beloved, and prepare dried and spiced meat. By eating our son's flesh, we can cross the rest of the desert. Let not all three of us perish." And they do that, of course. They kill and they prepare dried and roasted meat.

So cannibalism doesn't particularly appeal to us, but this is a very, very strong image for telling us that hunger is one of our basic fears. And that when we eat, we ought to eat with right intention, not for indulgence sake, but we'll come to that.

None of us really — I mean, maybe you have, but none of us really — have experienced hunger. We've experienced being peckish and then just going for that evening piece of toast. And we might have ended up a day in some peculiar situation where we haven't eaten. And when we get home, we're famished. But actually, we've never really experienced hunger, that annoying feeling. I certainly haven't. Where you really do believe that if you don't get some food, you're dying. And you can see some of the gaunt faces in the refugees. And for me, going back to the 60s and 70s where there were famines in India especially.

I've mentioned already the Greek myth of Erysichthon who upset the goddess Demeter — the Roman name was Ceres, from which we get cereal. She was in charge of all that grows, all the stuff that people eat. And he went and built a banqueting hall over her shrine. So she cursed him with this insatiable hunger, and he ends up eating all the food, everybody, his own family, and finally himself. So this is a myth about what happens when you're actually really hungry. She cursed him with this insatiable hunger.

Now, I did meet a man in Sri Lanka many years ago who told me that he had actually got lost out in the wilderness in the US. And he'd got to this stage of real hunger. And he said, you know, there came a point where he caught a bird — a large bird, let's say a pigeon or something — and he actually ripped it apart and ate the raw flesh. So that gives you an idea of how hunger, when it gets right to the point of life or death, becomes utterly overwhelming, really. The same with thirst, of course.

So I just wanted to take this opportunity, really, to reintroduce some of you — because you might not have worked with me — but remind the rest of you about eating meditation and how we can use it, especially if we're off these two or three days and there's a tendency to, well, have a good meal.

And there are three things when we're eating that we have to try and distinguish in order to liberate ourselves from indulgence. Now, we won't liberate ourselves from indulgence unless we see the consequences. And the problem is that while we're indulging ourselves, it's great. I mean, it's nibbana, what's the problem? But it's only afterwards that we begin to realise that there is quite a lot of suffering involved.

And the first one, of course, is just that obsessive nature of indulgence. You know, having to have — we're not — I mean, just the morning cup of tea, try and give that up for a while, or coffee, and you'll see how obsessive it is. And if you look at any of your habits and you try and stop them, you'll see that there's a real strong desire coming up from that habit which demands to be satisfied, to be gratified really — gratification is the right word.

And the second problem would be frustration. Frustration always comes when you can't get what you want. So just look at the past week you've been in and see how many times you've been frustrated. Somebody's not behaved the way you wanted them to — a family member, somebody at work, whatever. Some piece of equipment hasn't worked for you. You're frustrated. The shopping didn't arrive at the right time. The bus was late. It goes on and on and on. And what you feel is anger. It's a frustration at not getting what you want. And, of course, once we drop all that, we just begin to establish an equanimity with the way things are. This is the way it is. That's the constant phrase we have to repeat to ourselves. This is the way it is. What's the point of getting upset?

Grief — grief at loss. You've only got to think if somebody actually went off with your mobile phone — that's a heavy grief, that is. Definitely our lives are now wrapped up in that little machine. But of course grief takes on a much deeper meaning, as we mentioned the other day, when we lose somebody who we're attached to. So grief is always waiting for us when we are possessing something, or worse, identifying with us and identifying with ourselves.

And then underneath all that there is this anxiety. There's an anxiety of loss. That's why we have insurance. Some of it's realistic, of course — you want to insure your house. I had a cousin who thought that insuring your house was just a trick just to get money out of you, so he never paid insurance for his house. And then there was one very, very bad storm where his roof caved in. Now, I don't know whether he made up

his money — how much that roof cost him and whether actually over a long period of time, 30-odd years or so, he never paid any insurance — he would have actually saved some money if he had paid the insurance.

But when we buy anything from something like a laptop or something, they always want to give you insurance to make it last three years so you don't worry. See, there's your anxiety — worry at loss, worry at breakage, breaking down. So you can see that the more we have, the more we're in for some level of dissatisfaction, some level of suffering. It's all to do with this attachment, this indulgence.

And the final one is boredom, of course. Boredom is when we are not getting the same excitement that we used to get from what we're indulging in. And that boredom is not a nice place to be. I mean, it's an aversive place. And there's a search for something new. Variety is the spice of life. And that's what we do — one pleasure after another just to keep ourselves occupied, keep ourselves happy. But this happiness isn't true happiness. As we see it, it's an excitement based on overwanting something more than we actually get from any object. And that's when we have to remind ourselves that we don't actually want the object so much as the mental state that it produces.

So the three things that we then have to do in order to undermine all this is to distinguish between enjoying something and indulging it. It's not as though the Buddha is saying we shouldn't enjoy life, we shouldn't enjoy art, nature, friendship and all that sort of stuff. That's perfectly viable. He himself enjoyed, for instance, going to shrines, just the normal things of life. But that distinction is very difficult because indulgence is so close to enjoyment. I mean, aversion pushes you apart from the object, but indulgence sticks you to it.

The second thing is to begin to distinguish the body from the mind. And that's all to do with beginning to deconstruct our sense of self, our sense of an identity, our sense of being whole, entire, like an integer, one number.

And the final one, which is just as important, is to distinguish between a desire and an action.

So just to go back on those — to distinguish between desire and indulgence, as I say, is difficult. So the way you overcome the indulgence is by putting a clear intention in your mind. So this food, as the Buddha says with this example of this mother and father who ate their son — there has to be a real purpose for it. That food is something to nourish the body for the purpose of becoming liberated. It has that spiritual purpose to it. If it has any other purpose, then you have to question it as to whether it's wholesome, whether it's actually leading you on the path.

So every time we're with a cup of tea, with that mythical biscuit, with a meal, we have to sit there for a moment and just remind ourselves, "Okay, this is to nourish the body, full stop, that's all." The fact that I enjoy it has to be received as a gift. You don't have to enjoy food that's nourishing. It can be quite tasteless — porridge without sugar and all that sort of stuff. So that's the first thing.

And then as you go through the meal, to begin to realise that the excitement that you had at the beginning of the meal is beginning to fade away and there's just this tasting of the food. So there you're beginning to distinguish the overlay of excitement that we have when we have a good meal in front of us, and then very slowly over, say, even as little as 10 bites or something, it becomes ordinary. And then that's the chance to really investigate just enjoying, just enjoying.

And to make that clear to ourselves, we separate the body from the mind, the heart-mind, from feeling, from thinking. And you do that by driving your attention, first of all, into the body, into the process of tasting and smelling. And by isolating that physical taste process, you're beginning to realise that this is just the body. It's the mind that is translating it into something beautiful. And when you, as it were, swallow, intending to swallow, and it's dropped, and you stop for a moment and you get the afterglow. So that afterglow is the mind. The mind, the heart, the feeling of wellbeing, the feeling of joy is our habituated reaction to the food we're eating. That's a habit we have. The habit is to become happy and to indulge the food we're eating. So it's recognising that these are two different processes.

And then, as I say, as the meal goes on and the excitement dies out, then one can get close to this business of just enjoyment. And you might find that when you're just enjoying something, there's a sense of loss because before you really enjoyed it. See, that's the overlay of excitement. And then you have to remind yourself, "Well fine, I can indulge, but then I've got consequences." So it's this constant reminder. And eventually, of course, we find that indulgence is just too much. It's too much sugar. And you just want to taste things as they are without overlaying excitement onto it.

Years ago when I was teaching at the Birmingham Buddhist Vihara, a young man came, and when he came again the next week, he said that he'd been meditating and he could no longer listen to heavy rock. So there you can see how refined this young fellow was becoming.

And then the final thing, of course, is action — the distinction between a desire and an action. And so when you have your cup of tea — and I would suggest you try and do it at least once a day with a cup of tea and a biscuit or a sandwich, it doesn't matter what — just sit with it, get the feel, get the hunger, feel the hunger, know that some of it

is natural appetite, and some of it is this excitement that we get from indulging, and just stay there with it for a while, and then feel, just feel the force of that desire of wanting to eat. The more hungry you are, of course, the greater that desire will be.

And then at some point, a decision is made. A decision is made — something, yes, like you're giving permission for the desire to manifest. And that manifests through an act of will. That's your power. The power is to bring something from potential into actual. Now, the will itself is completely neutral. It's just a power. It's the intention which matters. It's the intention which is conditioning us. And it's good to make that distinction and to realise that actually you really can sit with a desire which you don't want until it fades away.

Now, when we sit with a desire which we don't want, no matter how strong it is, and wait for it to fade away completely, you get your little gift. The gift is one of feeling released from it, as if you've been imprisoned or shackled. And with that, there comes a sense of joy. But more than that, we're undermining that very habit that we don't want. And if we keep that going, eventually there comes a point where the habit just doesn't have the force over us. It doesn't have that force and we can just see it come and let it pass. And that just comes by constant practice.

If we fail, if we find ourselves chucking 10 biscuits down our throats, then it's no point in getting guilty or feeling horrible about that. You just notice that, well, just for that moment there, you gave in, but then you have to make a firm resolution, a resolute resolution that you'll be very quick to see when that desire arises and just to stay with it, suffer it. So you've got to suffer. You've got to stay with the feeling of it until it completely passes away.

And the opposite, of course — if a desire comes up which you see is wholesome, then of course you empower it. Now, just in that very simple way, we can actually change ourselves. We are nothing but a compendium of habits. We're just a collection of habits. And it's a decision to keep some of them, develop some of them, and get rid of the ones we don't want. And that's just that process.

I'm not saying it's easy. The stronger the habit, the more established the habit, the more difficult it is to get the better of it. And eventually, of course, once we're fully awakened, once we're fully liberated from suffering, the traces of that habit might still appear in the heart, the heart-mind, but they just don't have any power over us at all.

So I've tried to put this in a little essay, which I'll post. I'll post it up onto the website there. On the front page, again, you'll see next to videos because I've — excuse me — I've gone and posted all the videos up on the website. Again, you'll see that on the front

page. But somebody told me that you can't download them from there. It just goes back into YouTube and you have to pay a fee for it. So I'm thinking about how to overcome that. I've just put one on Dropbox because somebody in New Zealand wanted it and just see if she comes back and says that she was able to download it.

Very good.

The final thing to say is that when we practice this on something so obvious as eating, which we have to do every day—it's not as though you can give up eating—it becomes a constant little practice for us, a constant reminder.

When we do that, we begin to realize that actually this cuts across everything in our lives in terms of our enjoyment of art, television, film, our enjoyment of nature, the hobbies we have. Anything you enjoy will have that overlay of wanting something more from it.

And of course, relationship—relationship with its obsessive quality, the obsessive part. That often manifests in the way that we try to manipulate the other, demand of the other, try to control the other, become disappointed in the other, frustrated by the other, and so on and so forth.

So this practice on just eating, just having a cup of tea with a biscuit, will eventually bring that sort of insight into our lives and begin to change it. Going back to what we said about the Eightfold Path, this is the feedback. This is the feedback from our right understanding through right action. And that reinforces the insight—it makes the insight more and more real for us.

So I think that's enough about food for the moment. I suggest that we now turn to our meditation. I can only trust my words have been of some assistance and they have not caused greater confusion.

Discourse on the Taints MN 2: Overcome by Seeing

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

In this exploration of the Sabbāsava Sutta (MN 2), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines how the taints (āsava) - sensual desire, becoming, and ignorance - are overcome through right seeing (vipassanā). The discourse reveals how unwise attention to existential questions about past, future, and present selfhood leads to six deluded views of self: eternalist views that posit an eternal self, annihilationist views denying any continuity, and various combinations of perceiving self and not-self through observer and observed.

Bhante explains how these speculative views form 'a thicket of views' that bind us to suffering through the three fetters: identity view (sakkāya-diṭṭhi), doubt (vicikicchā), and adherence to rules and observances (sīlabbata-parāmāsa). The teaching shows how wise attention and proper understanding lead to abandoning these fetters, marking the attainment of stream entry - the first glimpse of nibbāna.

This teaching offers profound insight into how our fundamental delusions about selfhood perpetuate suffering, while pointing toward the liberating wisdom that sees through these false constructions to reality as it truly is.

Good evening, happy YouTubers. I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So we have been looking at the Sammādiṭṭhi Sutta, the discourse on right view, and now we want to do the end bit. If you remember, the question that Sāriputta, who is the person teaching here, was asked goes like this: "Might there be another way in which a noble disciple is one of right view, whose view is straight, who has perfect confidence in the Dhamma and has arrived at this true Dhamma?"

"There might be, friends," says Sāriputta. "When a noble disciple understands the taints, the origin of the taints, the cessation of the taints and the way leading to the cessation of the taints, in that way he is one of right view, whose view is straight, who has perfect confidence in the Dhamma and has arrived at the true Dhamma."

Now fortunately, we have a whole discourse devoted to the taints. This word "taint" translates *āsava*. I think we're closer to the understanding if you think of the word as meaning an oozing, as in sap from a tree, or in this case, pus from a boil. Because these *āsava*, these taints, are the fundamental expression of our delusion.

The first one is, you won't be surprised, sensual pleasure. The second one is the desire to become, to exist, to continue existing. And the third one is ignorance. But later on, wrong view was attached to it. If we can think of ignorance as delusion, as the way ignorance expresses itself.

So we have this triad, this trio of roots. That's something else, the *mūla*. So you've got plenty of categories—three of these, four of those, ten of them, illimitable. The three roots are those roots that cause all our unwholesome behaviour: *lobha*, *dosa*, *moha*—that's greed, aversion, and delusion. So ignorance has to be translated into some sort of delusive understanding. And as I say, in some recensions, the taints include wrong view.

Okay, so now this is the Buddha: "Thus have I heard. On one occasion the Blessed One was living at Sāvattthī in Jeta's Grove, Anāthapiṇḍika's Park." So remember, Anāthapiṇḍika was his main lay supporter, bought him this field, covered it with gold, bought it from Prince Jeta.

"There he addressed the bhikkhus. 'Bhikkhus!' 'Venerable sir,' they replied. The Blessed One said, 'Bhikkhus, I shall teach you a discourse on the restraint of the taints. Listen and attend closely to what I have to say.' 'Yes, venerable sir,' the bhikkhus replied."

Remember, bhikkhus, here is anybody who's listening. "Bhikkhus, I say that the destruction of the taints is for one who knows and sees, not for one who does not know and see. Who knows and sees what? Wise attention and unwise attention. When one attends unwisely, unarisen taints arise and arisen taints increase. When one attends wisely, unarisen taints do not rise and arisen taints are abandoned."

So it's where we put our attention. Don't forget, every time you attend, there's an intention. So it's empowering. You're conditioning yourself. Every time you pay attention to something, you're conditioning yourself. What the Buddha is saying is that you've got to have the right attention.

And then he tells us how to get rid of these taints. "There are taints that should be abandoned by seeing. There are taints that should be abandoned by restraining. There are taints that should be abandoned by using. There are taints that should be aban-

doned by enduring. There are taints that should be abandoned by avoiding. And there are taints that should be abandoned by removing. And there are taints that should be abandoned by developing."

So that's seven ways in which we can get rid of these taints, this oozing, this pus oozing from our hearts. And they depend on what taint we're actually dealing with.

So the first one, hopefully we'll finish tonight, but we might have to go tomorrow, is the taint abandoned by seeing. Now this seeing is *vipassanā*. And with this particular method, what he's dealing with here specifically is what leads a person to the first path and fruit, what we call stream entry, a glimpse of *Nibbāna*.

"So the taints should be abandoned by seeing. An untaught ordinary person who has no regard for the noble ones and is unskilled and undisciplined in the Dhamma, who has no regard for true men and is unskilled and undisciplined in their Dhamma, does not understand what things are fit for attention and what things are unfit for attention. Since that is so, he attends to those things unfit for attention and he does not attend to those things fit for attention."

"Now, what are the things unfit for attention that he attends to? They are things such that when he attends to them, the unarisen taint of sensual desire arises in him and the arisen taint of sensual desire increases. The unarisen taint of becoming arises in him and the arisen taint of becoming increases. The unarisen taint of ignorance arises in him and the arisen taint of ignorance increases."

So these are things that are unfit to attend to. And then he says the opposite for things that are fit to attend to.

So now he goes on to the specific bit that has to do with this seeing, seeing things as they really are, which leads to insight.

"This is how he attends unwisely. In this particular case: 'Was I in the past? Was I not in the past? What was I in the past? How was I in the past? Having been what, what did I become in the past? Shall I be in the future? Shall I not be in the future? What shall I be in the future? How shall I be in the future? Having been what, what shall I become in the future?' Or else he is inwardly perplexed about the present thus: 'Am I? Am I not? What am I? How am I? Where has this being come from? Where will it go?'"

So these are all existential questions. Like, why am I here? What's the meaning of life? It's just put in this way of the self, the me, me.

"And then he says when he attends unwisely in this way, six views arise in him." So we have six different ways of defining this self.

The first one is: "The view 'self exists for me' arises in him as true and established." So now this self is the feeling that there's something in me that is eternal. It's an eternalist feeling that there's something in me—this me, this I that I feel myself to be—is eternal.

The next one is: "The view 'no self exists for me' arises in him as true and established." So this of course is annihilationism. This is a materialist view of life. Now this self has no reality. I might feel myself very strongly, but actually when I die the whole thing disappears and that's the materialist annihilationist view of the self.

The next one: "I perceive self with self." Now this is the peculiar ability that we have of becoming aware of the body, aware of myself. So there's two—there's myself and I'm aware of myself. So this is the self-awareness and the body and mind. That ability of being self-aware, to make the mistake of being—well, what I'm aware of is me. It's another form of eternalism in a way.

"I perceive not-self with self," and this arises in him as true and established. So in this case, the observer, the feeler, what we experience in meditation is the only real, and the body and mind is just experience which arise and pass away, but it's not me. But the observer is me, and the observer will have that sense of eternality about it.

"The view 'I perceive self with not-self' arises in him as true and established." Now, in this case, the person does not believe that the observer is the real, but what is observed—the body, heart and mind. And this equates really to the scientific materialism, because what's understood is that the body is basic—your cells, chemicals and electrical impulses—and they create the mind and all your subjective experience, and they also create this sense of self. So all this mind and self are emergent properties coming from the physical base. So the sense of self is not real, but the physicality is real. And of course that's an annihilationist view because we all know that we die.

To take another instance: if you walk into a room and it's full of mechanical pieces which you can figure out are the pieces of a car, they're useless. But when you put it all together, the emergent property of a car is that of course it can propel itself. That would be an emergent property. It's not within the individual pieces. So the scientific materialist view is that the body with its cells, with its chemicals, electrical impulses, and all that stuff, create the mind and consciousness. And ultimately, in the human sense, this heightened state of self-awareness.

The final one: "It is this self of mine that speaks and feels and experiences here and there the results of good and bad actions. But this self of mine—see, this self that's experiencing all this—is permanent, everlasting, eternal, not subject to change, and it will endure as long as eternity."

And that would be somebody who believes that the body, that the mind or the heart-mind exists after death forever, that they go into this eternal state and that it's not part of the body. That would be very close to what I understand of Jainism, where the whole idea is to get rid of the body because the body is the expression of bad *kamma*. When you get rid of the body, the soul—I can translate self as soul here—of mind that speaks and feels and experiences here and there the results of good and bad actions. But this soul of mine is permanent, everlasting, eternal, not subject to change, and it will endure as long as eternity.

So these are the six selves. I don't know whether you want to remember them. But there's something for us to reflect upon about, well, what do we believe ourselves to be? Do we believe that the self, the sense of self, not the body and mind and all that, actually is eternal? Do we believe that nothing of what we are has any more existence after death—annihilationism? So where do you position yourself? Do you think that awareness, self-awareness is the real and the body and mind are not? Or the other way around, that the observer is not real and it's just an epiphenomena, an emergent property from the body and mind? Do you perceive that the observer is the only real, not the body and mind experience? And the last of those three: the perceived is not the self and the observer is not real, except what is experienced. And then the final one, this full-blown idea of a soul, an eternal soul.

Now, the Buddha says: "These speculative views, bhikkhus, are called a thicket of views, a wilderness of views, the contortion of views, the vacillation of views, the fetter of views. Fettered by the fetter of views, the untaught ordinary person is not freed from birth, ageing and death, from sorrow, lamentation, pain, grief and despair. He is not freed from suffering, I say."

So I think it'd be good if we worked on this, make sure that you've understood it properly. Now, as individuals, we don't have to know all this stuff. We have to really just contemplate: how do we experience ourselves? What do we experience as something real within ourselves? That's the question that we have to ask.

Now then, if at some time you just ponder, what am I? What am I? Not what I have been—that's gone. What I will be is yet to come. But how do I experience myself now? What do I really believe myself to be? Now, where do I stand on that continuum, on that spectrum? Am I an eternalist or a full-blown annihilationist? Or do I pass along that spectrum?

Now, the Buddha says that we're none of it at all. All that stuff, all those beliefs are completely outrageous. They're completely deluded, and they're just leading to more suffering. So it's a case of really being able to define where we think we are, where we believe ourselves to be, and in our meditation, just to hang on in there. Just leave the question mark open. Leave the question mark on, because the Buddha is clear that there is something in us which simply doesn't belong to this psychophysical organism. There's lots of quotes—I won't go into it this evening—where he states that.

And of course, that's the whole teaching of not-self. He's not saying that there isn't a self. He's just saying whatever we think is a self or a soul or a person doesn't have any real basis. It is just as impermanent as anything we know, as anything we can experience. And because of that mistake, we cause ourselves suffering.

In his words—I love this—"When he attends unwisely in this way"—that's right—"fettered by the fetter of views, the untaught person..." Well, let's go back a little bit. "This speculative view, bhikkhus, is called the thicket of views, the wilderness of views, the contortion of views, the vacillation of views, the fetter of views. And fettered by the fetter of views, the untaught ordinary person is not freed from birth, ageing, and death, from sorrow, lamentation, pain, and grief, and despair. He is not free from suffering, I say."

And then right at the end, he points to this ability of this contemplation and realisation in our meditation to actually enter the first path and fruit: "When he attends wisely in this way, the three fetters are abandoned in him." This is another way of talking about what is actually keeping us in this round of rebirths: personality view—which means, actually it's much better to translate that as identity view—identity view, doubt in the Buddha's teaching, and adherence to rules and observances whereby we think rules and observances are actually going to liberate us. "These are called the taints and they should be abandoned by seeing."

Very good. I hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused even greater confusion. And I think now we can begin our sitting.

Not-self Revisited: The Story of Sati (MN 38)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 20 min

Bhante Bodhidhamma continues his exploration of anattā (not-self) through the compelling story from the Mahātaṇhāsāṅkhaya Sutta (MN 38). This discourse tells of Bhikkhu Sati, son of a fisherman, who held the mistaken view that consciousness runs unchanged through rebirths—a fundamental misunderstanding of the Buddha's teaching.

The talk clarifies what the Buddha means by 'self' versus identity, examining how we identify existentially rather than socially. Bhante explains the five khandhas (aggregates) and how consciousness operates as a 'screen' that arises and passes away with each moment of contact, rather than being a permanent entity. He addresses common confusion between awareness and the consciousness aggregate, showing how this subtle delusion keeps us bound to saṃsāra.

Through Sati's story, we see how even sincere practitioners can misinterpret core teachings. The Buddha's firm correction—that consciousness is dependently arisen (paṭiccasamuppāda)—reinforces that nothing in our experience constitutes a permanent, unchanging self. This teaching is essential for understanding the path to liberation through the destruction of craving (taṇhākkhaya).

Greetings. I trust you've had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhasa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhasa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhasa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed noble and fully self-awakened one.

I wanted to just carry on with this not-self business, just to make it even clearer for those people who feel baffled by it. I have had some questions sent me. I hope the questioners will be patient enough to wait a couple of days, because tomorrow I want to actually go through the core discourse on not-self, which is the second one traditionally that he gave to his five companions.

So it's a case of recognizing what the Buddha means when he talks about self. It's translating the word *atta* in Pali, or the language of that time. And it's still there, of course, *atta* in Hinduism—the *atta* is your eternal soul, whatever. So now it's to do, if we forget the word self for a minute and just talk about identity. Identity. What do you identify with?

Now we have all sorts of identities. I'm a father, a son, husband, wife, brother, daughter, workmate, et cetera, et cetera. I also have social relationships, which I identify with my job. I'm a worker, I'm an office worker, et cetera, et cetera. But what we're talking about is your existential identity. What are you in the face of death? That's where the answer, that's what we're trying to discover or find out.

And there are two major opposite opinions. One is that I exist, meaning me, this that I think I am, exists after death in some way. And me, what I think I am, completely annihilates at death. So there's your two opposites.

Now, in between that, you might find people who say, I am the body, and also have some idea of afterlife. I was with a friend down in Cornwall. He's died, unfortunately. I used to go down there and spend some time with him. And he was living with his mother and father. So we're talking about 10 years ago. And we were having a discussion, we were sat on the couch, and his mother and father sat on these separate chairs, and of course the TV was on, and we were having a discussion about something. And his father was seemingly listening to what was on the television.

Anyway, at some point in our supposedly private, quiet discussion, I said to him, well, we're not the body. And his father suddenly burst into this declaration, "Yes, we are!" And it was such a loud snap that silence and embarrassment descended upon the four of us for a little while before we continued our discussion. So ironically, of course, he died that very year. I don't know what his last thoughts were.

So there are some people who believe in some way that they are the body. They are definitely the body. And the more subtle one of course is that no, I'm not the body that disappears in death, I am my heart mind. Now the old word for that is soul, that's our word for it. Anima would be the Latin, psyche would be the—psychology and all that, psyche would be the Greek for it. So you have body, heart-mind, and then usually have spirit, and that's what most people think: well I'm not the body, I'm not the heart-mind with its emotions and thought, I am the one who knows, I am consciousness. So that's your more subtle position of those who think about afterlife.

Now the Buddha says we're not any of that. That's the point. And to put it in his categories, he would talk about the five *khandhas*. So there's the body, that's the *rupa*. And the *nama*, the mind, includes all your feelings, both physical, mental, pleasant, unpleasant, et cetera. All your perceptions, your thoughts, your images in the mind, which produces your imagination and thinking. And then you have this section of *sankhara*, which is translated as volitional formations, because this is where we create things,

create with the will, volition. But I much prefer just a very simple word: our habits. It's just the way we perform. And that's what we are, just a compendium of habits, just a group of habits.

And consciousness. *Viññāna* is variously used so it's quite difficult to find out what this consciousness is when it comes to the *khandha* itself, the actual five heaps or aggregates that we're made of. But the one thing that points to what it is is the point of contact. Now, the point of contact, you must have an object which is coming into the mind. So you're looking at something like a tree and there must be a sense base that is bringing the information in, which is the eye. And there's consciousness, which, of course, makes it bright and you become aware of it. I've got to be careful here.

So consciousness at the point of contact, it's just a screen upon which the object and the sense base work to create something on a screen. That's what that's all it is—a screen, something that allows something to appear. Now the problem is that this consciousness is arising and passing away with every bit of information that comes in. And you could say bits, just like we say in computers, bits and megabytes and all that, these are bytes. These are just tiny little bytes that come in and the mind works on it and produces an image which then comes on the screen.

Now, the Buddha says we're not any of that. The Buddha says, well, not any of that. He says there is something within all that which is confused with it. And that's where the delusion lies. And at the most subtle point of delusion, it is the confusion of this awareness, this Buddha within, this intuitive awareness with that screen. So that would be the same as for instance when we absorb into a film. You get at a cinema or watching it on a screen, you absorb into the film and for a while you live in that imaginative world. And during that time there's not you or the world or anything, you're completely absorbed. So generally speaking we're absorbed in the world that is appearing on this screen.

So now having said all that, if you think about these words that are used here which sound very confusing, things like "the self exists for me," "there's no self exists for me"—so that means he doesn't identify with anything. Or put it this way: nothing is. Remember self here means identity, permanent identity. So there's no permanent identity existing.

"I perceive self with self." So I perceive that I am self-awareness and the body and mind. The two things that they perceive self, so they think both sides are self.

And "I perceive not self with the self"—that the observer perceives is the only real and the body and mind are what it experiences. So here, so the not-self here is the body and mind, the experience that we're having, and the true self, the true identity is with the observer.

And then you have, "I perceive self with not-self." So here, it's the perceived that is—the perceiver is not the self, but what is actually perceived. So that's this business of the consciousness being an emergent property.

And then finally, there's a full-blown sense of self: "It is the self of mind that speaks and feels and experiences here and there, the result of good and bad actions. And this self of mine, this identity I have is permanent, everlasting, eternal, not subject to change, and it endures as long as eternity." So that's obviously the self as agent, the feeler, everything you experience now, that's what you are, and that will last forever.

All that the Buddha said, and I love to repeat these things to myself, that is, this speculative view is called a thicket of views, a wilderness of views, a contortion of views, a vacillation of views, the fetter of views. So fettered by the fetter of views, the untaught ordinary person is not freed from birth, aging and death, from sorrow, lamentation, pain, grief and despair. He is not free from suffering, I say.

So I don't know whether that helps to clarify or makes things even more complicated. But I would love now to—let's see what time it is. Oh yes, got plenty of time. I want to read the story of Sati. So this is the opening paragraphs of the greater discourse on the destruction of craving. That's what it's about. The *Mahatanha Sankhaya Sutta*, and it's number 38 in the *Majjhima Nikaya*. That's my main textbook. If you want to follow me, so this is number 38, The Great Discourse on the Destruction of Craving.

So this is the story of Sati. "Thus have I heard. On one occasion the Blessed One was living at Savatthi in Jeta's Grove"—so remember, that's probably his most favorite monastery built by Anathapindika, the businessman.

"Now on that occasion a pernicious view had arisen in a *bhikkhu* called Sati the son of a fisherman: 'Thus as I understand the *Dhamma* taught by the Blessed One, it is this same consciousness that runs and wanders through the round of rebirths, not another.'" So he's saying that this consciousness—remember not the body-mind—it's the consciousness that is the same from birth to birth. It just runs through all rebirths.

"Now several *bhikkhus*, having heard about this, went to the *bhikkhu* Sati and asked him, 'Friend, is it true that such a pernicious view has arisen in you?' 'Exactly so, friend.'" That's funny. He seems to agree that it is a pernicious view. "As I understand the *Dhamma* taught by the Blessed One, it is the same consciousness that runs and wanders through the rounds of rebirth and not another.'

"Then those *bhikkhus*, desiring to detach him from this pernicious view, pressed and questioned and cross-questioned him. 'Friends, Sati, do not say so. Do not misrepresent the Blessed One. It is not good to misrepresent the Blessed One. The Blessed One would not speak thus. For in many discourses, the Blessed One states consciousness to be dependently arisen, since without condition there is no origination of consciousness.'

"Yet although pressed and questioned and cross-examined by those *bhikkhus* in this way, the *bhikkhu* Sati, son of a fisherman, still obstinately adhered to that pernicious view and continued to insist upon it. Since the *bhikkhus* were unable to detach him from this pernicious view, they went to the Blessed One and after paying homage to him, they sat to one side and told him what had occurred, adding, 'Venerable Sir, since we could not detach the *bhikkhu* Sati, the son of a fisherman, from this pernicious view, we have reported this matter to the Blessed One.'"

"Then the Blessed One addressed a certain *bhikkhu* thus: 'Come *bhikkhu*, tell the *bhikkhu* Sati, son of a fisherman, in my name, that the teacher calls him.' 'Yes, Venerable Sir,' he replied. And he went to *bhikkhu* Sati and told him, 'Friend Sati, the teacher calls you.' 'Yes, friend,' he replied, and he went to the Blessed One, and after paying homage to him, sat down at one side.

"The Blessed One then asked him, 'Sati, is it true that the following pernicious view has arisen in you: "As I understand the *Dhamma* taught by the Blessed One, it is the same consciousness that runs and wanders through the rounds of rebirth and not another"?' 'Exactly so, Venerable Sir, as I understand the *Dhamma* taught by the Blessed One, it is the same consciousness that runs and wanders through the rounds of rebirth and not another.' 'What is that consciousness, Sati?' 'Venerable Sir, it is that which speaks and feels and experiences here and now the result of good and bad actions.'

"Misguided man! To whom have you ever known me to teach the *Dhamma* in that way? Misguided man, in many discourses have I stated consciousness to be dependently arisen, since without condition there is no origination of consciousness. But you, misguided man, have misrepresented us by your wrong grasp and injured yourself and stored up much demerit, for this will lead to your harm and suffering for a long time.'

"Then the Blessed One addressed the *bhikkhus* thus: '*Bhikkhus*, what do you think? Has this *bhikkhu* Sati, son of a fisherman, kindled even a spark of wisdom in this *Dhamma*, in this discipline?' 'How could he, Venerable Sir? No, Venerable Sir.'

"When this was said, *bhikkhu* Sati, son of a fisherman, sat silent, dismayed, with shoulders drooping and head down, glum and without response. Then knowing this, the Blessed One said, 'Misguided man, you will be recognized by your own pernicious view. I shall question the *bhikkhus* on this matter.'

"Then the Blessed One addressed the *bhikkhus* thus: '*Bhikkhus*, do you understand the *Dhamma* taught by me as this *bhikkhu* Sati, the son of a fisherman, does when he misrepresents us by his wrong grasp and injures himself and stores up such demerit?' 'No, Venerable Sir, for in many discourses the Blessed One has stated consciousness to be dependently arisen since without condition there is no origination of consciousness.'

"Good *bhikkhus*, it is good that you understand the *Dhamma* taught by me thus, for in many discourses I have stated consciousness to be dependently arisen, since without condition there is no origination of consciousness. But this *bhikkhu* Sati, son of a fisherman, misrepresents us by his wrong grasp and injures himself and stores up much demerit, for this will lead to his harm and suffering for a long time."

Now, you have to have a certain sympathy for poor old Sati. I mean, he sat there, silent, dismayed, with shoulders drooping, head down, glum and without response. Well you'd want to hug him wouldn't you? I mean, poor old Sati. And it keeps going on about him being a son of a fisherman, so they all have that name behind them. I put a little twist on it to suggest a bit of caste prejudice, a bit of class prejudice—son of a fisherman. And that's of course how these stories grow.

So the next one, it would be, if I were retelling this tale elsewhere, I'd say, "but the son of a fisherman," something like that. So you have to be careful with these stories that obviously played upon over generations, really. 500 years they were handed down from person to person. So they obviously changed. But I think we can take the root thing that there was a monk called Sati, who was the son of a fisherman, who got it wrong and made this mistake of thinking that the Buddha was talking about consciousness when he said that there was something eternal in us, something that doesn't die, et cetera.

And when you read the discourses like that, I have the patience to just read them through, then of course the core of the teaching keeps coming back at you. And the core of the teaching is obviously, consciousness is dependently arisen, since without condition there is no arising of consciousness. So that's telling us.

Now unfortunately, then the Buddha goes on about consciousness and dependent origination and shows us how we can come to an end of craving. But he hasn't let go of Sati because right at the end of the discourse, the conclusion: "*Bhikkhus*, remember this deliverance through the destruction of craving as taught by me. But this *bhikkhu* Sati, son of a fisherman, is caught up in a vast net of craving and a trammel of craving." Poor Sati, he must have sat through all this, poor man. "That is what the Blessed One said and the *bhikkhus* were satisfied and delighted in the Blessed One's words."

So I think that gets the message home. So tomorrow what I mean to do is actually look at the core discourse or the main discourse on not-self, which is traditionally the second one that he gave to the five companions when he left, remember, and returned when he was fully awakened. So I'll be doing that.

Investigating Not-self - The Practice

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 23 min

Moving beyond intellectual understanding, Bhante Bodhidhamma offers concrete vipassanā techniques for directly investigating anattā (not-self) in meditation practice. Drawing from the Buddha's second discourse on not-self, he presents three practical approaches: deconstructing experiences into their constituent sensations, recognizing our lack of control over arising phenomena, and objectifying all mental and physical processes.

The talk demonstrates how to deconstruct common experiences like knee pain or loneliness, breaking them down from conceptual labels into raw sensations of heat, pressure, or tightness. This reveals how the mind constructs our experienced reality and how the sense of 'I' emerges as the final step in perception. Using developmental psychology and the myth of Narcissus, Bhante illustrates how we can establish the position of inner observer, watching all phenomena arise and pass away beyond our control.

This practical guidance shows how vipassanā meditation naturally leads to the direct realization that any sense of self is a mental construction. The teaching emphasizes that the Buddha doesn't deny the existence of self, but reveals how all selves are manufactured and can be deconstructed through mindful investigation.

Good evening. I hope you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, but I hope it has been a happy day.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So these past few days we've been looking at *anattā* as an intellectual exercise, really, just trying to understand it, trying to understand the way the Buddha expresses it in the scriptures. And hopefully that's become more clear, become more clear to me, trying to teach it, frankly. But now we have to get down to the practice. How do we actually investigate this in terms of our *vipassanā*, in terms of our practice?

So many of you who've worked with me will have heard me speak about it and explain it. So for you, it's a bit of a revision, you might say. But for those who haven't, it might offer you a technique, a way of investigating not-self.

There are three things. First of all, deconstruction, right? To deconstruct what we experience. The second one is control seeing, seeing what control we have, what control we don't have. Remember that was one of the aspects in that second discourse on not-self, where he starts off by saying, if this body were me, I'd be able to say, don't fall ill, et cetera, et cetera. And the third one is objectification. To turn everything into an object. If it's an object, it can't be me.

So when we talk about deconstruction, we can take a very simple object. Everybody suffers from pain in the knee, usually, unless you're a yoga person. It took me years to be able to sit without any pain in my knees. So, okay, the pain comes. It draws your attention. And the first thing is your reaction, which is not to want the pain, the desire to move. So you have to wait for that to die away. Just recognize it. Desiring, desiring. Feel it. Feel the desire to move. It's all about feeling.

And then when that's passed and you find yourself equanimous, that's the time to start using the word pain. Okay, so we're using the word pain or discomfort, whatever. And we're not trying to get rid of pain or defeat pain, right? That's a no-no. And if the pain gets too much, well, you move, right? Make the intention to move and off you go.

But let's say that the pain is bearable. So you've got this pain, pain. And then what you have to do is deconstruct it, by which we mean you go into the pain. You try and see what it's actually made of. And when you get in there, you might find heat. You might find tightness. You might find pressure. You might find little bits of sparkly sensations. All sorts of little things might happen. And your noting word might change. So you might be saying tight, heat, et cetera. And make that very clear to yourself by staying there and feeling it.

It's not an intellectual process. You don't want to think about it. It's a direct experience of these sensations, which are the information coming to us, and then the mind does something with it. Now, at the second level of perception, that's when the word pain comes up. And that's when you realize that pain is a mental construct. It doesn't actually exist. What exists are these sensations. Now it's not as though you have to forget what pain is. You need to know when to go to the doctor, but there's that clarity now that pain is basically a concept that we have about certain groups of sensations that arise from the body itself, right? So that's your sense base. Remember the retina is for the eye, sensations in the body, your felt, your sensation base.

So by deconstructing something, you're taking away its substance, right? And by doing that, you're realizing there's actually not much there. And as you go into it, that detail, the quality of impermanence becomes much more obvious. So whatever is impermanent can't be substantial. It can't be a self. It can't be anything because as soon as it arises, it's virtually disappeared.

So by moving between those two perceptions, the perception of sensations, basic sensations coming in, heat, pressure, etc., and the concept of pain, we're also beginning to see how the mind builds up the world that we are living in. So remember, we're encased in this little bubble of consciousness. This is our world. And whenever in the scriptures the Buddha says, the end of the world, he doesn't mean the end of the cosmos. He means the end of the world that we constantly are creating.

So that's one way in which we can take away substance from things. And you can do the same with an emotion. So if you're isolating now and you're stuck in a room, et cetera, then sometime in the evening, especially, you might feel lonely, might feel sad, et cetera. So if that negative state comes up, you don't think about it. You don't start indulging this business. If I'm unlovable, you know, nobody loves me. Everybody hates me. I've got no friends, but you go into the field, the field of loneliness. And as you take it apart, as you begin to look at it just as sensation, it begins to lose that reality that we give it when we turn it into an emotion. And it's at that point that we flip into this, I am lonely. So there's the identity, right? When it comes to the pain is I have a bad knee. There's your possession.

So we're sort of breaking up that mental process and recognizing that the I is, in a sense, the last step in the process, the sense of identity is the last thing that happens in that process of perception.

The one example I use, which I know some of you know, is about ice cream, you see. So as soon as you see ice cream, there's the memory of it. And there's that sense of like, so that's the *vedanā* like it. So seeing it, it has to go through that process of recognizing it as ice cream. And then there's the liking of it. Then there's the want of it. And then there's the, I want, and as soon as the I comes in, it's very difficult to stop the empowerment and that's the getting right. So even though I say I like, want, get ice cream, actually psychologically, in Buddhist understanding, it's like, want, I, get, ice cream. That's the process. And it's breaking that up that you realize that this identity is unnecessary, right? It's just something we put into that process.

Okay, so you can always do this. You can start your meditation with this. If you find the mind's wandering, you can raise the interest and go through that little exercise.

And now the second thing is this business of powerlessness or absence, you know, that we haven't got entire control of the body. So obviously pain in the knees is a case in point. You recognize that the pain has arisen, whether you want it to or not, it's not under your control is the control center is elsewhere. It's in the body somewhere. It's in the brain, whatever you wish. And it's that disconnection with something that's happening that is disconnecting the I, right? So it's not all mine. It's not my pain. It's just the pain. And when you have something like loneliness or happiness, then it's not me and I who are happy. There is an emotion of happiness.

Now, in your noting, you can make that plain to yourself. There is pain. There is happiness. There is sadness. And just by objectifying it like that, you're undermining that sense of possession and an identity. And when you step back into that position of the observer, the feeler, you can ask yourself, can the perceiver be the perceived?

Now that takes us on to the third point which is about the objectivization of our experience. So the two examples I use is first of all, when we were babies, we were all babies. And the second one is the myth of Narcissus.

So seemingly, when we're born and presumably in the later stages in the womb, for the first four months of our birth, everything we experience is just a shower. It's just a continual bombardment of sensations out of which we can make no sense. There's light coming in, there's sounds coming in, there's sensations in the body, there's smells, there's tastes, and it's all one. It's not differentiated at all. That's what seems to happen. But of one thing we're very sure, whether something is pleasant or unpleasant. And when we're hungry, we definitely tell our mothers we're hungry.

So that undifferentiated catastrophe, you can say, of sensation for this poor little baby. No wonder it sleeps for, what, 16, 18 hours a day or something. Out of that, there looms, you might say, the first object. This is what psychologists tell you. And that object is usually your carer, your mother, usually. And very slowly over time, this differentiation occurs, helps to push the outer world outwards. And so the baby becomes to recognize that there's an outer world, although it might not be so much aware of the inner world, but it's definitely objectifying the outer world. And then there's also the attachment to the carer, to your mother.

And so it seems that this business of detaching, pulling out in this too close a relationship with our parent begins to sort of break apart. And there's all this terrible twos and all that. But by the age of three, we seem to be very clear. I'm me and everything else is not me. And that's taken three years. That's taken three years to push the outer world out into an object, into something that exists outside me, as different from me.

Now, if you think about it, that's all that's happening in our *vipassanā*. We are taking a position within ourselves and pushing the inner world outwardly to observe it. And in so doing, we're reestablishing our identity. So sometimes we identify with the body, especially if it's a sharp pain like biting your tongue or when you're hungry or whatever. It's easier for us to identify with our emotions. I am sad. And then you pull yourself out of that identity. It's even easier to get lost in thought. You don't say I am thinking. You are thinking. You are the thinker.

And you pull yourself out of that, out of the imaginative thinking, and you find yourself in this very strange position of being the inner observer, the inner feeler, the one who knows, the experiencer. And when we've really got that position, everything is manifesting in front of us, right? And that's a point where we can also recognize that all this stuff is arising whether we want it to or not. And that again points to this business of control.

And something you can do when you're in that position of the observer is reflect what's it like being just the observer. Because in the observer, there's no emotions, there's no thoughts, and there's no sensations. Keep working on that right because that identity is a fraction of the experience of *Nibbāna*, right? We'll come to that another time.

So we're into this objectivization and I want to give you another image that you can work with and that's this myth of Narcissus.

Now remember Narcissus looks into the pool, this very beautiful young man, and he falls in love with himself with the image and he goes to embrace himself and falls in and drowns. Now in mythology water is creation normally, it's often used for an image for creation, and Narcissus is sitting on the bank. And he looks onto the surface of the water, into the water, and he catches his own image. Okay?

Now, that's exactly what's happening with this *satipaṭṭhāna*, with this intuitive awareness, with the Buddha within. It looks into the mind, the heart-mind complex, the body-heart-mind complex, the psycho-physical organism. And what it sees is that surface consciousness upon which everything is rising, and it captures its own image. And that's the sense of the observer, the feeler, the experiencer, the sense of presence. In other words, that mirror, that scheme, that surface is mirroring back to the awareness, its own presence.

Now, what happens is you get lost, you dive into, you go into the world that the mind is creating on that very same surface. And that's what we're experiencing. That's the bubble of consciousness that is our world and it's specific, it's just our world. I can't

know your world. I've got some idea of it but I can't experience your world as your world. And so everything that I experience is very personal to me, it's very subjective, but I'm actually creating it when I say I. I mean the body, the heart mind. The psychophysical organism is creating the information.

And what's happening is that this intuitive awareness is drowning in it. That's the delusion. It thinks that this is where true happiness is to be found. And it fails. Our practice is to objectify all that, to see it right there in front of our inner eye, you could say, manifesting. And in so doing, we're pulling out this quality of intuitive awareness.

Now, that's as far as we can go by our own practice and act of will. We can determine that, right? We can just push things away from us inwardly and make them an object. But you can't push that sense of the observer away. That just creates another self trying to get rid of the observer.

So in a sense, you can do two things. You can either, as it were, from that position, just glance back. And what I mean by glancing back is the question, what's inside this observer? What's inside it, right? We know what's inside the body, the feelings, the sensations. We know what's inside the heart, the emotions, the moods. And we know what's inside the mind, thoughts, images. What's inside the observer? And that's one way of indicating that it's something which is of a completely different order. It doesn't belong to this psychophysical organism.

And the next thing is that you can turn your attention towards the sense of self of that observer, right, the sense of somebody observing and just keep your eye there just wondering where is that being manufactured, okay? And after that really, you just have to wait until the insight arises.

And this is one way of investigating this whole teaching around not-self. So remember, the Buddha is not saying there's no self. He's saying that any self is manufactured. It's being constructed. And our whole purpose is to deconstruct that.

So remember, this is just one avenue of investigation. So the other two avenues which will hopefully come to later, because now we've got another three weeks of lockdown, would be understanding desire and looking more deeply at impermanence.

Okay. So just to recap there, when you've got your sitting posture correct and you're calm, you can do it with the breath or with a very loud sensation, the knee. It's often actually better with something louder and to actually go into it and deconstruct it. In the discourse on how to establish this awareness, the Buddha actually encourages us to do that. He says to feel feelings in feelings, to experience mental states in mental states. He's asking us to go into it and to deconstruct it.

And my own teacher, one of my own teachers, Sayādaw U Paṇḍita, used to talk about plunging it. You have to plunge into your experience and deconstruct it, by which we mean find out what its constituents are.

Okay. And the second thing is to recognize that when we've discovered that position of the observer, this observation post, to see that everything's happening of its own accord. It's happening beyond our commanding. It's not within our personal power when we've taken that position. So sensations arise, feelings arise, et cetera, et cetera.

And the third thing is to recognize that everything we're looking at is an object, not me, not mine, and not a self. So I hope that's helpful, and you might have a go at it this evening's meditation. So it's just a way of practicing.

And then when we get into that steady position of just observing, just feeling, just experiencing, just that, then you let go of all that.

And have this confidence, this real inner confidence, trust that this intuitive awareness can work it out for itself. It doesn't need us at all. It doesn't need this person talking and guiding it. And just watch. That's enough. Whatever draws the attention within that field of awareness, that's it.

Very good. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance that it's not caused even greater confusion.

So I think it's time that we can begin our meditation again. Very good. You see, I've kind of forgotten this little gadget again. Oh dear me.

17 Questions — See Description

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 26 min

In this Q&A session, Bhante Bodhidhamma tackles seventeen practical questions from students, offering clear guidance on common meditation and dharma challenges. He explores the crucial distinction between anger and assertiveness, explaining how equanimity-based action differs from reactive aggression. Drawing from the Buddha's own example of engaging with conflict situations, he shows how wisdom and compassion can guide effective responses to injustice without falling into the mental distortions of anger.

The discussion covers the difference between compassion and grief—true compassion arising as empathetic response to others' suffering versus grief as our personal pain from loss. Bhante addresses questions about death contemplation practice, warning against spiritual bypassing while highlighting how mortality awareness brings proper perspective to daily concerns. He also clarifies various Buddhist psychological categories including the three unwholesome roots (lobha, dosa, moha), the taints (āsava), fetters (saṃyojana), and defilements (kilesa), explaining their overlapping but distinct functions in describing mental obstacles.

The session concludes with practical guidance on establishing the observer-observed distinction in meditation, particularly useful for working with pain and developing the insight into anattā (not-self). This accessible yet thorough discussion provides both newcomers and experienced practitioners with clear frameworks for understanding Buddhist psychology and applying these insights in daily practice.

Good evening. I trust you've had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samasambuddhasa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samasambuddhasa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samasambuddhasa.

Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble, and fully self-awakened one.

This evening, we were going to leave not-self for a while and tackle some of the questions that have come in.

The first one is about anger. Is all anger to be avoided and purified? So I'm thinking of abuses of power and injustice. I was feeling angry at the government for suggesting the public fundraise for the NHS when they already pay it through taxation, yet find money for other things when pressed.

Really, all you have to ask yourself is, when you're angry, what's your state of mind? Are you open to the other person's viewpoints? Are you really concerned with winning the argument and not really seeking the truth? What's actually guiding the anger?

Often the case of anger sits on fear. Your identity, your views, your opinions have been upset, they've been attacked, and the response is to get rid of the enemy. The Buddha is quite clear that any form of anger is going to distort our thinking and will eventually end up creating even more anger one way or the other. Even if we overwhelm the person and they run away with their tail between their legs, they will be thinking about ways in which to get back to us. So anger is, in Buddhist understanding, basically a no-no.

One example that is given here is how is Jesus viewed in Buddhism turning the moneylenders out of the temple? Well, of course, in Christian thinking, they do often translate that as righteous anger. But in Buddhism, they don't say righteous anger. But what there is is assertiveness. So that distinction between aggression and assertiveness.

Now, if one is coming from a state of inner equanimity and yet knows what ought to be said, then that anger becomes translated into a force, into a form which supports you. And of course, because you're based on equanimity and wisdom, you have the power for that. And the other people feel that. As soon as you're angry, they also feel your fear because if they come back at you and they see that there's a slight bit of fear in you, then they know they're winning the argument. But when you're being assertive, when you're being correct, when you're standing your ground, you are open to the other person's argument and you may be nuanced. You may be affected by it. It's not a problem. But you are assertive about your particular position.

This goes back to this business of free speech where there was a time a couple of years back, two or three years back maybe, where they had the right to insult. Well, nobody has a right to insult anybody. It was a very harsh way of expressing the fact that you can be assertive about your opinion, about your perspective, and I know that the other person's not going to be happy with it, but that's their problem, not yours. So I think that distinction is very valid and it stops you getting into fights, awful situations that can come back at you.

Again, does the Buddhist path separate from all these things? Is it all seen as *samsāra*, not to be engaged with? That's the other thing that you might do because you don't want to get angry, you don't get engaged. Well, that's the other negative side of not being engaged. But if you are coming from a point of wisdom, a point of compassion, then, of course, your behaviour will engage you. And the Buddha had no problem engaging in serious situations.

His people and the Kāliya who owned the other side of the river were going to fight about water rights. And he went up and he said to them, "What's more precious, the blood in your veins or the water in the river?" And that cooled them down a bit. Kings would come to him for advice. His advice was always to seek the way to peace, not seek the way to war.

And then they go on to say, "Also, I've been feeling sad about all the deaths and the families that have been left bereaved. Am I right in thinking that Sharon Salzberg in Loving Kindness is saying that that is no longer compassion, but sadness. And is it compassion that we need to develop?"

Yes. I think we've also touched upon this, the distinction between grief and sorrow. Well, sorrow is the ability to feel another person's pain and empathy. And it requires us, it impedes us to find a way of helping. Even if we can't help, at least we can send our good wishes or influence somebody else to help them. But that's not to be confused with the grief, which is the pain we feel when we lose somebody whom we're dependent on for our personal happiness. It's a different thing. The sensations, the feelings can be very similar, but they have different roots.

The Buddha himself is also known as the Mahākaruṇiko, he's the great compassionate one. Because after all, he spent his life trying to save us from suffering, trying to save all people from suffering, which was a big task, let's face it.

So yes, anger, generally speaking, is a no-no. You want to try and redirect the energy towards assertiveness. We do need compassion. We need to be in touch with people, feel what they feel as a resonance. Now, obviously, you can't feel what another person feels, but you can resonate with it and do what we can to help. Trembling in the heart, that's what the Buddha says, a trembling in the heart when you see somebody suffering.

By the way, if questions come up out of this, just email me.

Are my thoughts and feelings dependent on my physical body? If I had a different body, would I have different thoughts, et cetera?

Well, of course, many of them are dependent on the body. That's why we keep, in the evening, we go on about sickness, ageing, and death with it. We're very concerned with the body. It definitely brings up a lot of anxiety and all the other stuff. It's through the body, of course, we're in contact with the material world outside through our senses. And it's that which creates this inner phenomenal experience.

So, obviously, if you're deaf, then that dimension of experiencing things as something that you can hear is not there for you. So the body has a direct effect on the mind.

But then, of course, there are many things that affect the mind-heart which are not directly coming from the body. We've just talked of one, really, is that when we see somebody who's in a bad state, we want to help them. It might not be a physical bad state, it might be a mental one that you want to help. So not everything comes from the body.

If you had a different body, would you have different thoughts? It very much depends, really. When I shaved my head to become a monk, my sister was there. My family were there. And she said to me afterwards, "I didn't realise you had such big ears." Well, I was shocked. I thought, fancy somebody saying that on your ordination day. So ever since then, I've been slightly aware of these jugs on the side of my face, these jug handles. And you can imagine, if you had ears the size of an elephant, then you'd be aware of it. It would affect your self-esteem, probably. I'd forgotten that particular remark until just today, actually.

So yes, different bodies. Obviously, if your body's disabled, that's a different situation too. So having the body we have brings its own mental situations. If you've got a healthy athletic body that never falls ill, that's very different from a person who's continuously weak, falls ill, et cetera, breaks their bones and so on. So yes. Don't wish for another body. That's what I say. Just be happy with the one we've got. You never know what you're going to get.

The next one is: I've tried the death contemplation, breathing in as the body's last breath, only for around five minutes tagged onto the normal meditation. First I was shocked just how attached I was to everything, absolutely everything. Then I realised it was to this body and sense experiences resulting from it. Then when I applied it to wandering thoughts and worries, it put these worries and thoughts into perspective and the realisation how unimportant they are. Should I use this when I'm really upset or worried?

I think that's what the contemplation of death does. It puts things in a wider perspective. You get different priorities. Even now, through this COVID thing, where we're having to isolate, it's making a lot of people experience life in a different way. And they might be thinking, why am I rushing around all the time? What's the point of earning all that money if I'm going to be stressed out all the time? I'm hoping that's what's happening anyway.

So the contemplation of death puts life into a different perspective. And one of the things is to see what a treasure it is. And one wants to live fully within the present moment. So when one turns to one's worries, you think, well, what's that in terms of death? So little worries or these superficial things might just fade away.

You have to be careful about using these techniques not to feel what the heart wants to express, especially if the feeling is a strong one. If you've got sadness or anxiety, doing that sort of thing, you can fall into the error of what's been called spiritual bypassing, which is just another way of saying suppressing.

Often, for instance, in the tradition, a great emphasis is put on impermanence, *anicca*, *anicca*, everything's changing, everything's changing. And what happens is you're looking or you're feeling, say, some anxiety, and you're stepping back, but stepping back in the wrong way and looking at it and saying, "Oh yeah, it's all arising and passing away, it's all arising and passing away." But you're not feeling the intensity of that anxiety, and therefore the heart can't cure itself. It just goes back into the system. You just get just as neurotic as you were before.

So don't forget that it's *anicca*, *anattā*, but it's also *dukkha*. And that's in the discourse on establishing right awareness, the *Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta*. The Buddha's constantly putting us in to feel feelings in feelings, to feel mental states in mental states. It's the same as a room. It's the difference between being outside looking in through the window, or at the doorway, or on top of the room, or under the room. It's completely different when you actually go into the room. And that's when you actually experience the room as an internal experience.

And that's what you're doing with these emotions, with these mental states. You want to get into them and feel them as they are. Then when you're inside feeling them as they really are, that's when you can also begin to recognise that it's actually changing. And that's when you're getting down to that level of the different things that make up a feeling, the heaviness, the burning, and all that sort of stuff.

So be careful about that. That's when you get teachers saying that you need psychotherapy before you go to *Vipassanā*. Or you need psychotherapy after you've done *Vipassanā*. And it's usually because of this problem. I can't remember, unfortunately, the name of the psychiatrist who actually wrote this. He was a good meditation teacher too, died recently. But if it suddenly springs to mind, I shall mention him.

So yes, death meditation is very powerful. And as this person experienced, you don't have to do it for hours, just a little bit at the end of each sitting, just a little reminder occasionally during the day. It brings you back to this lovely present moment we've got. Even though it's horrible.

I have a bit of confusion here. I get the three unwholesome roots. So that's greed, aversion, and delusion. And that they're fundamentally the base of all unwholesome states. But the taints, which we're coming to later, of course, tomorrow, the cankers, also called, the hindrances and the fetters all seem to have similarities, with some being blockages to insight and some being yokes to the worldly states. The same factors may be in the different groups. Are the taints generally the same thing as the fetters, or is the different way of looking at these items or considering their arising and passing? The taints may be cleared to allow stream entry. That's the first level of insight. But somehow I'm sure that I've seen clearing the fetters described as being overcome by the same results. Are fetters and taints interchangeable?

This is where we get into these lists. The three or four taints are also called *ogha*, they're called floods, they saturate everything. It's an unwholesome saturation. It's like you're painting in watercolours and you have your first wash and that wash gives the whole painting a feel. So these taints, these oozings, are like these floods, these colour washes that are behind everything that we speak, think, say, and do.

They're also called *yoga*, yokes, because they tie us to the worldly thing. And as taints, they are referred to their malignancy, their horrible oozings.

Now the fetters, there's only four of those, by the way. The fetters are a specific group of ten which tell you which ones go as you go up the four stages of awakening. And the first three to go are doubt in the Buddhist teaching, belief that any form of ritual or practices will actually bring about liberation, although they have their place. Like, you know, I do the taking refuges and precepts. They have their place. But you could do that for an eternity and it wouldn't actually liberate you from suffering. And the final one is the one we've been addressing: that insight which undermines or you just get that insight into not-self, into the fact that there's something there which is not changing. And that's what the Buddha calls it, like a flash of lightning. You've seen it, but it's not been long enough to really be sustained. It has its effect.

So those are the fetters. Then you've got defilements, latent tendencies. I used to know some of these lists, but happily I've forgotten most of them. It just weighs on the mind, I think.

Let me just go to the defilements. None of these will come as a surprise: greed, aversion, delusion. So there's your three basics. Then you've got conceit, which is to do with me. Speculative views, wrong views. And then you've got sceptical doubt. So that's the doubt that stops you doing something. If you're on the high board wanting to dive into the pond, if you doubt that you can do it or you're too afraid to do it, then you just don't jump, you come down.

Mental torpor, so that's a bit of a hindrance or a defilement. Restlessness, shamelessness, and lack of moral dread. When we lose shame and fear of consequences, then really there's nothing much to stop us doing unwholesome things.

So those are known as your defilements. I don't think they are exhaustive, but at least they give you some idea of what a defilement is. I think that's more the case.

When it comes to *anusaya* or latent tendencies, as far as I know these are not defined as such in the discourses. It's just a way of talking about things that are there which we might not be aware of. So sometimes they're called, they're translated as proclivities or inclinations, tendencies.

And again, you won't be too surprised by what they are. So it's greed, of course. And then grudge, which is rather interesting. Resentment, the inability to forgive. Speculative view again, sceptical doubt, conceit. Craving for continued existence. So that's the other one of the taints. If you remember, sensual desire, desire for existence, and ignorance.

So all these lists, I think you just take them as indications, that's all, indications.

So the best thing to get is the Buddhist Dictionary. Here we are, Buddhist Dictionary. The Buddhist Dictionary, a manual of Buddhist terms and doctrines by Jnana Tiloka. And he's got it all there for you. You get it from BPS, which is the Buddhist Publication Society in Kandy. I think you can download it as a PDF too. So that'll give you all your lists.

How are we doing for time? It's getting on, isn't it? Just the last one here.

I also have some thoughts on assuming the position of the observer. I'm not good at staying with sensations for a long time. Rather, I'm at that stage of my development where it tends to last for a split second or so, maybe minutes in some circumstances. I

gather from the Mahāsi treatises that this state tends to extend itself with practice until liberation when it becomes permanent. The only exception seems to be, for me, meditating on pain. I work a lot with pain, provides a powerful focus. Eventually, and in the right circumstance, this focus leads to the objectivization of pain itself, once the position of the observer is established. This is also one of the most effective ways of managing pain, I find. Pity, it tends to be more impermanent than the pain itself.

Yes, that's what we discover, isn't it? That with things that are unpleasant, when we have dealt with the reaction—see, that's the important thing—not wanting to go there, feel the reaction. When the reaction goes and we then turn towards the difficulty, the pain, physical or mental, then we can stay with it. And of course, we realize that the reaction is causing the suffering. Pain is just pain, as it were, and we can be quite equanimous with it.

Now, one thing I did that's brought to mind, which I didn't stress actually in the discussion yesterday evening about not-self, when I talked about the object, the distinction between the subject, the observer, the feeler, the knower, and what is felt, seen, observed, etc. You can make that clear to yourself by making the distance between the two obvious to yourself.

So for instance if there's pain in the knee, you're up here somewhere looking down and you can say there's pain. So that's—and then to be aware of the distance that there is between the two, the observer and the observed. So it's like here—now you're looking at the screen and at me no doubt, and I'm filling most of your awareness, most of your attention.

Now, if you become aware of the distance between your eyes and the screen. Now, that's what I mean by recognizing the distinction between the subject and object. And you find you can do that with emotions because they're in the body and you're still up here. Images, sometimes you can see them ahead of you and you can at least intuit the space. There must be a space there between them, as it were. It's a mental space. Thoughts, of course, very difficult. And that again accentuates the whole business of what I'm experiencing doesn't constitute me, right? Because this me now is felt to be the observer.

So I think that's enough of that for one evening, don't you think? And we can begin our meditation. I just hope, as usual, that I've not caused even more confusion.

Very good.

18 Overcoming the Āsavas by Restraint

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 22 min

In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the second method for overcoming the āsavas (mental taints) as taught by the Buddha: abandoning through restraint. Drawing from the Sabbāsava Sutta, he explores how every act of seeing, hearing, or sensory engagement involves intention and conditioning that can lead us toward or away from awakening.

Bhante emphasizes that we live in an increasingly visual society where constant sensory stimulation conditions our minds toward wanting and aversion. He explains how the practice of sense restraint—particularly on retreat but also in daily life—allows us to observe the mind's habitual patterns more clearly. Through the example of catching the 'sign and features' of attractive objects before they develop into full fantasies, he shows how Right Awareness can interrupt the cycle of craving.

The talk highlights a crucial insight: when we successfully restrain our impulses and allow desires to fade naturally without indulgence, we experience 'a bliss that is unsullied'—the contentment that comes from letting go. This positive reinforcement helps develop the confidence to continue the practice. Bhante connects this ancient teaching to our current circumstances of isolation, showing how periods of seclusion offer valuable opportunities for developing moment-to-moment awareness and finding stillness wherever we are.

Good evening. I hope you've had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa
Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa
Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

Just to say something about this observer position within ourselves, a couple of questions come up. Remember that so long as there's a sense of the observer, there are two consciousnesses, one following the other very rapidly, so rapidly that we get the impression that the observer is constant, even though what it's looking at is steady. But that sense of the self, the observer, is a consciousness. It's the feel of awareness on that screen of consciousness.

Now, as your concentration goes, driven by interest to see things as they really are, that stops and there's that absorption where the sense of self disappears as just the awareness and the object that you're observing. You can call that pure *vipassanā*. It's the same absorption you might say when you watch a DVD, but because it's a completely different purpose it doesn't lead to awakening. So this practice is about leading to awakening. So you have to enter into absorption with that interest. Unfortunately you can't make it happen. It just arises when the conditions are there, the seven factors of enlightenment, and it's just practice. Sometimes it comes, sometimes it doesn't. Sometimes it stays a little bit, sometimes stays a little bit longer. On retreat of course it's a bit easier. In daily life, depending how busy you are... now that everybody's in isolation, you're of course very contented and peaceful and at ease and therefore it should arise fairly easily, maybe.

So we want to carry on now to the *āsavas*. What we've done is we've seen the first way of overcoming *āsavas*, which is through insight, and that actually leads to awakening. But the next one is abandoning by restraint. Just let me remind you of the various ways. So the first one we're seeing, that's we've done that: abandoned by restraining, abandoned by using, abandoned by enduring, abandoned by avoiding, abandoned by removing, and abandoned by developing. So each of these, the Buddha's offering those different ways to overcome unwholesome states.

So the second section is, taints to be abandoned by restraining. So we'll read it through and see what happens. What taints, bhikkhu, should be abandoned by restraining? Here a bhikkhu, reflecting wisely, abides with the eye faculty restrained. While taints, vexation and fever might arise in one who abides with the eye faculty unrestrained, there are no taints, vexation or fever in one who abides with the eye faculty restrained.

Now just this little phrase, "reflecting wisely" — *yoniso manasikāra*, that's a bit of Pali. That's a very regular phrase by the Buddha. He constantly wants us to reflect upon what we're doing. I'm reminded of a talk I remember given by a monk where he was talking about reflection and reflecting on reflection. And the word reflect came up every second word. And by the end of the talk, I hated the word reflection. So we have to reflect wisely, not unwisely.

And then he goes on to say there are no taints, vexation or fever in one who abides with the eye faculty restrained — no discontent and no fever over wanting something in somebody who abides like that. And then, of course, he goes through the other ones: the ear faculty restraint, the nose faculty restraint, et cetera, et cetera.

Now, if we just go back to the eye restraint, we're a very visual society. If we think of our grandparents, they would have had the radio. There wouldn't have been much to excite the eye, no screens. And their sense of hearing, I think, would have been better than ours, because just from the sound of a voice on a radio, you'd be able to tell what sort of person that was. The voice is telling you a lot about the person. And I got a feeling that we've lost all that because we've become so visual. And the sounds, when we go out in nature, we're often into views and scenes and panoramas, but not so much the sounds of nature.

And that's something that the Buddha's talking about restraint of course. It's basically looking at what we're looking at. So remember, every time you look at something, that's an act of intention. An act of attention is an act of intention, whether we're aware of that or not. There's a moment when we intend. Normally we don't notice these things because they're habitual. It's only when you're forced to look at something that you don't want to look at that you might recognize that a decision has to be made. So within any act of seeing, smelling, touching, anything like that, there's always a moment of impulsion. There's always a moment of a decision and an actualization, the will. And that's conditioning. That's conditioning.

One example I have mentioned, which is my favorite example, was that sometime in the 80s, there was a loss of confidence in the billboards. And the people who owned them wanted to prove in fact that they did have a big effect on people. So they put up a big poster advertising this new perfume. I can't remember what it was called, but it had a sort of an Australian hat on it, with the corks hanging down to stop the flies in the outback attacking you, and it was given a funny name. And what happened was of course there was a huge demand for this new perfume, and they proved that they had an effect.

So just consider: you're on a bus and you're just looking around, you're not really being fully aware, and your eye wanders outside the window, or you're constantly looking out of the window, and your eye hits this perfume, and you think, well, I've got to have that. And it's just part of that conditioning. So once we accept that wherever we put our attention, that's conditioning us, and that's what the Buddha means by restraint.

So when people go on retreat, especially a Mahāsi retreat, the idea is to restrain your senses. So we stop talking to each other so that we can hear the inner dialogue more clearly. We stop looking around so much so that we can see how impelled we are to see, to look. Here at Satipaṇṇā, of course, we've got things like sheep and cows and a pheasant. We've had a pheasant recently. We've actually got a duck on the pond, believe it or

not. And she's hidden in the top there, just underneath the Parinirvana Buddha, the Buddha in his death posture. And they say there's three ducks — she's attracted three ducks. I haven't seen them personally, but there she is.

And so there's, as soon as you hear a quack or a bleat or something — like now we've got these little lambs jumping around the place — and you want to look. You want to look. Now on a retreat that would be distracting. I mean, living here as I am, I do actually watch the lambs gambling and all that sort of stuff. But on retreat, you want to restrain the sight because you want to look inward. We're trying to see on retreat how the mind works. That's the same when you're sitting. That's why we close our eyes. Some people like to have them just ever so slightly open like in Zen. It doesn't matter. The point is you're not looking around so you can see inwardly. You've not got music going on. You're trying to be silent so you can hear the inner voice, the inner sounds that are in the body and so on.

So this restraint also, of course, is to do with greed and all that sort of stuff. You're walking through town and you're looking around and suddenly you see this... you see the signs.

So there's another discourse called the simile of the elephant's footprint. This is basically the opening metaphor where the elephant has the largest footprint of all animals and so the Buddha is the greatest of all animals. He's often shown as, he's often represented as an elephant or a cock or something which is the head of that particular type of animal.

Anyway, this is what he says. This is a bit more detailed about seeing. On seeing form with the eye, he does not grasp at its sign and features. So a sign would be the distinctive qualities and the features would be the other bits that come up when you look a bit more closely. So an obvious case is walking through town seeing a coffee shop. Now, you see it, and of course, that's the sign. Whatever it is, there's a sign of the thing, whether it's Nero's or whatever. And that's your sign.

And then you've got to, if you're aware and you know you shouldn't be nipping in there to get a coffee, then you avert your gaze. But more often than not, we hang around there and visions of Danish pastries and other delights begin to invade the mind. And even though you've made a very fierce decision that you won't be nipping into the coffee shop, you find yourself sitting there wondering how you got to that place. And this is what happens when something grabs you.

So what he's saying is that if we maintain a sharp awareness, an awakesness, we'd catch the sign, we'd catch the desire that comes up with it, and we'd be able to let it go. Since he left the eye faculty unguarded, evil, unwholesome states of covetousness and grief might invade him. So covetousness and grief are just another way of saying desiring or wanting and not wanting, aversion. And he practices the way of restraint. He guards the eye faculty. He understands the restraint of the eye faculty.

Then he goes through all the other senses of course, and finally: cognizing a mind object with the mind, he does not grasp its signs and features. So something might come up in the mind where — I mean this happens in meditation obviously — where you remember something. And before you know it, you're planning your holiday. You're off to, well, not at the moment anyway, but normally speaking, you'd be off to Timbuktu or somewhere in your mind. And then you wake up and what's happened is the first sign has come up, some idea that you've seen in a magazine or something or on the screen. And you've gone into it. Before you know it, you're planning your holiday.

So if we're aware and we catch that first image, we should be able to stop it there, or at least make a decision that we won't indulge it. I mean, there's nothing wrong, obviously, with going on holiday. And there's nothing wrong with planning a holiday. It's just the fantasies that arise with it often create future disappointment, where you expected sun and beaches is drenching with rain.

And then of course he carries on: since he left the mind faculty unguarded, evil unwholesome states of covetousness and grief might invade him. So he practices this way of restraint and he guards the mind faculty. He undertakes the restraint of the mind faculty.

Possessing this noble restraint of the faculties, he experiences within himself a bliss that is unsullied. Now, when a desire arises, if we can stay with it to the very end — in fact, it's more obvious the greater the desire — if you can stay with it to the very end of that feeling, without, of course, indulging it, you're there with the wanting, and you wait for it to completely end. Then you get that sense of release. You get that sense of being released from this obsessive desire. And with it there arises this contentment, and that's blissful. And it's for us to really recognize when contentment is there and to recognize that that is the consequence of restraint, that's the consequence of letting go.

So when we're sure that that happens, that when we do let go and allow these desires and lusts and all the griefs and the aversion and all that — when we let all that fade away and drop away, the product is this blissful contentment. And if we do it often enough and convince ourselves that is what happens, then of course that makes us want to do it more and not want to get caught up in these desires. So that's a really im-

portant line: possessing this noble restraint of the faculties, he experiences within himself a bliss that is unsullied. Because every time, of course, you let a desire go, you undermine that conditioning.

And then he goes into examples of how we maintain that sense of awareness. And now all the examples are usually about monks because it's the monks and nuns, the monastics rather, who have remembered all this stuff. They've tended to remember it for themselves. So you have to translate this into the lay life.

So for instance, he becomes one who acts in full awareness when going forward and returning. So any journey you're on, you're actually being aware — going to work, going to the shops, whatever it is. It's not as though that isn't part of our practice. Who acts in full awareness when looking ahead and looking away. In other words, we're aware of what we're looking at. We will do it when we're crossing the road. That's not a problem. But otherwise, we tend to let the mind just wander.

He acts in full awareness when flexing and extending his limbs. Basically, when we're doing anything, we're aware of it, whether it's as simple as opening a door or doing some difficult work. It doesn't matter what it is. We're aware of it. It's within our range of awareness. That's when we're doing jobs, of course. I mean, if you're on the computer and you're typing, well, obviously, often the typing is automatic. And what your attention is, is on what's actually appearing, what you're actually writing about.

Who acts in full awareness when wearing his robes and carrying his outer robe and bowl. So it's a case of being aware of how we look, going down the street, whatever, even privately — just being aware of what we're wearing. I don't think it's something that you're doing all the time. It's just occasionally you're aware of your presence, of how you look. What it's supposed to do is make you look dignified. We're supposed to have this sense of dignity.

Who acts in full awareness when eating and drinking, consuming food and tasting. Who acts in full awareness when defecating and urinating. That's a time we'd rather think of something else. Who acts in full awareness when walking, standing, sitting, falling asleep, waking up. As soon as you wake up, bring that awareness to bear. Talking and keeping silent.

So in other words, whenever — basically at all times during the day — we try to maintain this awareness, this awakedness.

Possessing this aggregate of noble virtue, so this collection of noble virtue, this noble restraint of faculties, and possessing this noble mindfulness and full awareness, he resorts to a secluded resting place: the forest, the root of a tree, a mountain, a ravine, a hillside cave, a charnel ground, a jungle thicket, an open space, a heap of straw.

And this, of course, leads us to the benefits of what we're actually experiencing now, which is isolation. But in the spiritual life, we call it seclusion. So for us, this is a real opportunity to find times when we just sit in silence. You don't particularly have to practice *vipassanā*. You could be doing *mettā*. You could just be sitting aware of being aware, in a chair and just resting, just resting in the present moment. That's enough. That also has an effect on us. Instead of always trying to do something, more being than doing.

So this is what the Buddha is asking us to do: to restrain the senses so that we're not always chasing our desires. To stay with a desire if we can until it completely evaporates and to experience the bliss of contentment. And to do it all the time, to try and be awake all the time. I mean, that's a bit of a task, but that's where we're heading. We're heading for a complete moment-to-moment awareness. And then, wherever we are — sitting on a bus, waiting for somebody in a waiting room, at home — there are these lovely moments of stillness.

Where we've gone to the forest, to the jungle thicket, an open space, a heap of straw. So that gives us some idea of using restraint to guard our senses and to maintain mindfulness.

So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance and that I've not created too much confusion. And I think it's time now for us to practice.

Overcoming the Āsavas by Using Requisites Wisely

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 19 min

In this practical Dhamma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the third of seven methods for overcoming the āsavas (mental taints or cankers) as taught by the Buddha - abandoning them through wise use of life's necessities. Drawing from monastic training while adapting the teachings for lay practitioners, he explores how we can approach the four basic requisites with mindful awareness rather than greed or attachment.

The talk covers the Buddha's practical guidance on using clothing for protection and modesty rather than vanity, consuming food purely for bodily nourishment rather than entertainment or emotional comfort, maintaining simple dwellings that support rather than complicate spiritual practice, and taking medicine only when genuinely needed for health. Bhante emphasizes the importance of yoniso manasikāra (wise reflection) in examining our motivations behind consumption and acquisition.

Extending beyond the traditional four requisites, he applies these principles to modern technology and entertainment, encouraging practitioners to regularly examine their intentions when using phones, computers, and media. The teaching emphasizes sitting with uncomfortable feelings rather than immediately seeking distraction through consumption, developing the inner strength that comes from not automatically giving in to every craving or impulse.

Good evening. I trust you've had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, but I do hope it has been happy. The sun's come out too.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsbuddhassa, Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsbuddhassa.

So we're still struggling through the āsavas. There are seven ways of overcoming the taints. We've done the first one, of course, which is all about *vipassanā* really, and seeing this whole business of the self of identity. Then we did restraining. So remember, the taints should be abandoned by seeing, restraining, by using, by enduring, by avoiding, and by removing, and finally by developing. We've moved from seeing to restraining, so we're now on to abandoning by using.

This is the passage: what taint should be abandoned by using? Now remember that these discourses are remembered by the monastics and basically for monastics, so we have to translate it into daily life.

"Using the robe only for protection from the cold, from protection from heat, from contact with gadflies, mosquitoes, wind, the sun, the creeping things, and only for the purpose of concealing the private parts." Very forward, isn't he?

So here he's given us the reason for wearing clothes, which is obviously for protection, warmth of the body, and so on and so forth. But not really for anything else. Now, that doesn't particularly work for lay people. You've got to dress according to where you are, at work, at play, with the family and so on and so forth. But there's an interesting thing that happened when the order was first established. When people joined him, both monks and nuns, they would go to the charnel grounds, and dead bodies then were wrapped up in white cloth and just left to be eaten by wild animals. It was the general custom of the *samaṇas*, these people who had left the lay life to live an ascetic life with various teachers, to go and take this cloth and turn it into robes and sew little bits together to make a lower robe and an upper robe.

Now, the first thing was that he himself decided that it didn't look so good. So he asked the monks to cut the pieces so that when the robe was laid out, it looked like paddy fields. So if you ever see a monk's robe laid out, you'll see that there are large patches for the paddy and little passages all around it. And they're all measured out. They're all meant to be of a certain measure. And that way the robes didn't look so untidy.

On top of that, he asked them to dye it in the arakka nut, which gives it a light brown colour. And that's why monks' robes and nuns' robes are all some form of shade of brown: warm brown, red brown, all that sort of stuff. And it all comes back to the Buddha wanting his order to look neat. So it's not as though he's saying you should just wear scruffy clothes.

You should wear things that you feel comfortable with, both from the point of view of the climate and the situation you're in, but also in terms of how it fits your understanding of, shall we say, natural beauty. Not something forced constantly by fashion, constantly changing by fashion, although that has obviously something to do with it. But it's again this wonderful practicality that the Buddha has, constantly asking, what are clothes for?

And then, of course, there's the amount of clothes that we have. And that's to do with what is need rather than greed, or what is, shall we say, allowable by just common sense. So one needs various pairs of shoes in the West. In the East, a monk or nun might just get away with slippers. Some actually go barefoot. But here you need, if you want to go walking, you need boots and then you need slippers and then you need all sorts of things. So it's all to do with where we are, but being practical, being practical.

And modesty, of course, runs high in the Buddhist teachings because we're trying to reduce the desire for our sexual appetite. So that's why nuns and monks especially robe themselves in very loose robes so that the body is not so obvious. So that's this business of wearing robes. These paragraphs that I'll be reading are chanted by monks as a reminder.

Then we come to almsfood: "He uses almsfood neither for amusement or for intoxication nor for the sake of physical beauty or attractiveness, but only for the endurance and continuance of this body, for ending discomfort, and for assisting in the holy life. Considering thus: I shall terminate old feelings without arousing new feelings, and I shall be healthy, blameless, and shall live in comfort."

So here again, it's just the practicality of eating for the nourishment of the body. Now, you have to be careful. He didn't tell lay people what to offer him. If he went to kings, if he was invited by kings or rich people, they would obviously give him very special dishes. And he never complained about that. That was an offering that they could give. So he was quite happy to receive it. On the other hand, if he was wandering just in ordinary villages, he might have some very basic food.

And of course, at that time, they had famines. When I went out to Thailand, for instance, I was up at Wat Pah Nanachat just for a visit. I was there for about two weeks and we would go off on almsround. And I also did it with Ajahn Mahā Bua's place up in the northeast. And we went on our rounds to the villages in the morning. And basically all we were offered was what they could, which was rice, with little bits of meat sometimes, a bit of fish or something. Basically it was just rice. And it was only when we got back to the monastery that the local richer middle class had supplied us with abundant food.

So there's a huge disparity, as it is everywhere in the world these days, between the rich and the poor. But there would have been times during the Buddha's time when there were actual famines. And the mendicants would have been right at the end of the line, of course, except for devotees. The devotee would obviously try to make sure that the people whom they honoured would have enough food.

But again, it's not eating for any other purpose. That's the real thing: for the nourishment of the body. Now, it doesn't mean to say that the food has to be plain or horrible. It's just that that's where your intention is. Your intention is to nourish the body for the purpose of spiritual practice. That doesn't mean to say that you can't cook yourself a pleasant meal.

So these days, where many of us are in isolation, that's one way of raising your heart, raising your spirit: to make an effort to cook for yourself, to care for yourself, and to give something which is appetising. How much you eat, of course, will be determined by feeding your appetite or feeding your greed. So that's the distinction we have to make. What we eat is not so important. And the whole thing is, of course, to reduce this greed.

Now remember that often we eat not just because we enjoy it and indulge because of that, but also we're hiding from ourselves feelings that we don't want. So many of you who are living completely alone in isolation might find the evenings difficult. Loneliness might come, bit of depression, etc. And one way that we seek is, of course, to get up and have a toast, buttered toast. I mean, well, that is the cure, but unfortunately it hides from us these painful mental states.

So what is better to do is to sit with that for a while, to sit with it and wait for it to exhaust itself, or at least to diminish. And then to, as it were, congratulate ourselves that we haven't just given into it to try and get rid of it. We can then congratulate ourselves with a piece of toast. See, you can rejoice that you overcame a negative reason for having toast. You're now celebrating.

Feast days are there for celebration. It's a way of expressing joy or praise or wonder. It's a way of thanking everybody. So in Buddhist countries there are two main times, which is Buddha Day, where we're celebrating the life of the Buddha, and that's coming up. I mean, we would have run a course now at the beginning of May, but for this virus. And that's a place where we would celebrate. So people bring lovely food, not only for the monastics, but for themselves.

And the other time is the Sangha Day, the Kāṭhina, where the Sangha is celebrated. And that's normally a time when people bring things that the Sangha might need. So these two occasions are, shall we say, a community effort to celebrate, and food is very much part of it. So there's nothing wrong with feasting. That's what I say anyway.

So then we go on to reflecting wisely. It's always reflecting. Remember this: *yoniso manasikāra*. It's a very constant phrase of the Buddha, just to sit and think about things, to reflect upon things.

"He uses a resting place only for protection from cold, for protection from heat, protection from gadflies, mosquitoes, wind, the sun, creeping things, and only for the purpose of warding off the perils of climate and for enjoying retreat."

So here he's talking about a place where you stay. So in the East, the monks can be happy with just a little hut somewhere. I was very fortunate when I stayed at Kanduboda. I had an eight foot by five foot—that's about what? Two and a half metres by one and three-quarter metres. Little space there. It was very comfortable. All I needed was a bed and a chair and that was about it. And that was enough for that particular time. Now, of course, I need mobiles and all sorts of silly things. But in those days, it was extremely simple.

And that simplicity brings with it a great sense of peace. You don't have to worry about anything. You don't have to worry about whether you have Wi-Fi or not. And again, to be very practical: What's the purpose of your house, of your flat? What's the purpose of your room? What's the purpose of it? And to keep it very simple.

As soon as we add things, as soon as we make things more complicated, then the worries come, the worry of loss and all that sort of stuff. So try and keep things simple by reflecting: what's the purpose of a dwelling? What is the purpose of this room? I mean, what's the purpose of my bedroom?

"And enjoying retreat"—well that, of course, is a monastic thing about seclusion, not isolation. But it's always good, remember, to have a regular place in your house, in your flat, wherever you're living, which you have partitioned off in some way, where you go in order to practice, in order to meditate. That also helps with creating this habit because it's there as a place. It's the same as when we have temples or here where we have the stupa. They remind you it's there, you see. If you have a statue, if you like statues, but definitely some place in the house where you have established a certain atmosphere. So that's important.

And then finally, of course, "to use wisely medicinal requisites only for the protection of arisen afflicting feelings and for the benefit of good health."

So again, medicine, you know, to use it for the benefit of the body. This one I think is easy enough to understand. But often we are—these days we've become very neurotic about things. I never used to take vitamin pills. Now I'm taking vitamin pills and quercetin. I'm just piling this stuff into my body and I'm coming to a point where I must, you know, I've determined to stop all that stuff because the body knows how to care for itself. And if it's not in a good way, then it'll tell you.

The food we get, people complain about it, there's this and that in it. But the fact is that generally speaking, we're living longer. We're living more healthy, so we must have got something right. And usually a lot of diseases that we have are caused by not eating the right things, by eating sugary things. That's why we've got all this diabetes stuff. So it's not that—I don't think it's so much to do with the food. I'm sure I can hear many of you complaining about that now, but in my understanding, I've no complaint with the food that we get from the shops.

So seeing food as medicine, that's the other thing too. Food as nourishment for the body, that's also part of this. Of course, that will remind us of this special medicine, Ayurvedic medicine, of which, if you remember, there was the story of the Zen monk who was cured with cow's urine. Fermented cow's urine. So make sure it's fermented when you get some, okay?

"So the taints which create vexation and fever might arise in one who does not use these requisites wisely." So it's a case of being careful how we use things. Now, you can extend this to everything you use: the television, the mobile, your computer. Why are you using it at this time? What are you looking at? What's the purpose of it? And make sure that it is actually for Dharma purposes.

Now, if it's not for Dharma purposes, if it's for something that you see as unwholesome, be truthful to yourself, be truthful to ourselves. When I'm doing something which I know is not quite right, you know, it's like, yeah, I know there will be consequences, there will be consequences. And it's being truthful to ourselves about what we're doing. And if we see that we're doing something which is not good for us, just keep making the resolution, make the resolution, make the resolution, and eventually it comes through.

But remember, with all these things that are tempting, it's always good to try and just sit with the feeling of it, sit with the feeling of it and wait for it to exhaust itself. And then it gives you a feeling of power that you can actually control these habits. That's also important.

So we've completed today the abandoning of these taints by using things wisely. So this obviously only refers to certain things that we have and use. So we'll carry on tomorrow to the next one because each one has something to teach us.

So I hope that's been useful in some way and that you've not found it completely useless. And I think it's time for us to do some meditation. Very good.

Overcoming the Taints by Endurance

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the fourth method for overcoming the mental taints (āśava) as taught by the Buddha: abandoning unwholesome mental states through patient endurance. Drawing from the classical teaching on the seven ways to overcome taints, he explores how patience—described by the Buddha as the highest form of ascetic practice—allows us to transcend our reactive patterns to unpleasant experiences.

Bhante discusses the Buddha's comprehensive list of situations requiring endurance: physical discomforts like heat and cold, social irritations including noisy neighbors and differing opinions, the four worldly conditions of gain and loss, fame and obscurity, happiness and unhappiness, praise and blame. He illustrates these teachings with practical examples from daily life and monastic experience, including a humorous story about the housewife Vedahikā and her maid Kālī that reveals the difference between genuine patience and suppressed anger.

The talk culminates with the Buddha's famous Simile of the Saw, where even extreme violence should be met with loving-kindness rather than hatred. Bhante emphasizes that true patience isn't passive resignation but active acceptance—opening to difficulties with awareness and compassion rather than fighting against what cannot be changed. This approach, he explains, prevents the arising of mental taints and supports both meditation practice and daily life wisdom.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāśambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāśambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāśambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

We're still on the taints. Just to remind you, we have seven taints here. Let me just read them through – it's good to revise them. There is the taint by seeing, which is overcome through insight, remember. The insight through overcoming the taint, especially on not-self, the false sense of I through *vipassanā*. And then we had one by restraint, by restraining ourselves. Then we abandoned them by using things better. And now we have to abandon things by enduring.

So the quality here, of course, is patience. The Buddha is big on patience. The highest form of ascetic practice – by which he means ascetic practice is renunciation – it's the highest form of renunciation because you are renouncing reaction to what is unpleasant.

So let's read what he says here. "What taints, bhikkhus, should be abandoned by enduring? Here, reflecting wisely, he bears cold and heat, hunger and thirst, contact with gadflies, mosquitoes, wind, the sun, creeping things and COVID-19. He endures ill-spoken, unwelcome words and arisen bodily feelings that are painful, wracking, sharp, piercing, disagreeable, distressing and menacing to life. While taints, vexation and fever – so vexation is the aversion, fever is the desire – might arise in one who does not endure such things, there are no taints, vexation or fever in one who endures them. And these are called overcoming the taints by enduring."

If we just look at one or two areas where we find ourselves getting very irritated, there are those little niggly irritations, aren't they? Leaving the freezer door open and finding that it's all iced up on the door and then you kick it. The toaster – when you set it wrongly, it's burnt the toast. All these little irritations, impatience with things too. It's surprising how everything has to be now. Everything has to be now.

I read somewhere that Amazon spent millions on getting this immediate delivery – what do they call it? Prime Amazon or something – so that as soon as you've clicked on your box of chocolate, you can hear it drop in your letterbox. That's how we're demanding that everything has to be now.

In fact, I have to express a certain impatience myself here, confess to it. This little gadget I'm looking at, I did actually order through Amazon and after about two weeks gave up on them and went on to eBay. Now, that doesn't mean to say that I prefer eBay to Amazon. It's just that I finally got it on eBay. But I just remember my concern bordering on a certain annoyance that it hadn't been delivered.

Then there are neighbours. Neighbours, oh, my goodness. If you have a noisy neighbour, it can drive you potty. I know it. I used to live in these two up, two downs, and my next door neighbour had a real love of Elvis Presley. Now, I myself like Elvis Presley, but not all the time and not at the volume that she would play it. And I had to go down once and asked her to turn it low. I said, "Do you mind just turning it low?" And her reply was, "I pay my rates." I thought, "Well, OK." Anyway, she did. She was very kind. But yes, neighbours, those little noises from the TV or from music coming through the walls.

This reminds me when I used to go to Sri Lanka or the East, but mainly in Sri Lanka. When I first got there and I had this beautiful little hut, this *kuti*, and the squirrels were around and what they used to do was they used to climb along the beams of my walking – there was a channel for walking, a *chaṅkamā* – and they were at the wood to get the grubs out. And this of course was I found tremendously disturbing. And then there was this what you might call cartoon moment when I jumped off the cushion that I was sitting on and ran down the corridor waving this flag and beating these beams. These days if that had been caught on camera it would definitely have gone viral. And of course I went back, they disappeared and I thought, "That's that." And of course as soon as I sat down again they were at it, scratching away.

So of course one has to accept these things. Noises in the East – I only remember real quietness descending around about one o'clock at night. I used to wake up in a real quietness at two o'clock and then it would all start at about three o'clock. But even the absolute quietness would be no crickets or anything like that, cicadas, so there was always noise.

I remember I came back once. I had to return to England – my mother and father died during that time. And I came back and noise was just overwhelming. The birds, the squirrels. There were these set of birds that squeaked to each other all the time. They're called the Seven Sisters. And they don't stop talking. And then I noticed that of course as soon as I stopped getting irritated, within a day or two I didn't hear them. This is the point, isn't it? As soon as you're angry, as soon as you're irritated, your ear sticks on it. And as soon as you stop being averse, trying to reject, trying to get rid of it, the attention moves away from it and it just becomes background noise – within reason, of course.

We get angry at people's opinions if they're not the same as ours. This whole Brexit thing – boy, do we see some awful stuff there. And of course, this is a fear that you're going to be somehow converted to their point of view. And that's, of course, where the pride sits. So when you hear something and you feel yourself getting irritated with the person for expressing that view, we have to remind ourselves everybody has their perspective. And if I open up to this person's point of view, I might not agree, but at least I'll understand where they're coming from.

Then you've got things like illness, illness that comes. Obviously now we're suffering this COVID thing. But any illness, we don't want to be ill. That's the end of it. So you can be quite angry with yourself for catching a cold or angry with somebody else for giving

you the flu or worse, COVID. And of course, there's loss of work. A lot of people, loss of work. And that's another thing that brings about a sense of depression, a sense of not wanting to bear with it.

So patience, remember, is not resignation. We're not resigned to it. We're not rolled over by it. Patience is accepting things as they are and recognising that any aversion, any rejection, any trying to manipulate it for my own personal good is just causing more trouble. And it makes us even more angry.

Then the Buddha talks about the four worldly conditions. So there's gain and loss. So every time we gain something, we're happy. When we lose it, then we're unhappy. And we don't like it. And we get angry and we get depressed and all that. And it's recognising that that's just not necessary. It's not necessary. Loss comes and that's the end of it. You receive it, one accepts it fully, and if one accepts it with a good heart, one always sees potential. When that situation ends you're open and you're ready to see where the potential lies.

Fame and being ignored. You walk into a crowd and they all know you and they all greet you and you get some high idea about yourself. And you walk into another crowd and they completely ignore you, or worse they think they want to ignore you – and that's even worse, of course. So this whole idea of having lots of friends – in the Sangha, often you find that together because they feel comfortable in each other's company. But often when they mix in terms of their different nationalities, you find them not so open to each other. It's not so very nice sometimes, but it occasionally happens.

And then, of course, there's happiness and unhappiness. So one minute we're happy, one minute we're unhappy. And you have to bear with that. There's no point in trying to fight it. And whatever is causing the unhappiness, it could be a relationship, it could be the weather, it could be the situation financially, your own personal situation. And again, to get angry with it, to get irritated with it, to try and get rid of it, it's all wasted energy, all wasted energy.

And then finally, he talks about praise and blame. We all like to be praised. That's wonderful. But blame – we're always trying to defend ourselves. Even when we've obviously done something wrong, we'll find some way of defending ourselves. But of course, it's worse if you're blamed and you know you shouldn't be. I mean, that is hard to bear, hard to bear. But he's asking us to bear with it.

Now, I just want to break off here to this delightful story of Kālī. And this is to do with somebody who is pretending to be patient.

Formerly, in the same Sāvatti – remember that's where his main monastery was, well, definitely one of his main monasteries, Anāthapiṇḍika, the rich merchant had bought for him – there was a housewife named Vedehikā. And a good report about Mistress Vedehikā had spread thus: Mistress Vedehikā is kind, is gentle, is peaceful.

Now, Mistress Vedehikā had a maid called Kālī, who was clever, nimble and neat in her work. The maid Kālī thought, "A good report about my lady has spread thus: Mistress Vedehikā is kind, is gentle, is peaceful. How is it now? While she does not show anger, is it nevertheless actually present in her? Or else is it just because my work is neat that my lady shows no anger, though it is actually present in her? Supposing I test my lady."

So the maid Kālī got up late. Then Mistress Vedehikā said, "Hey, Kālī, what is it, madam? What's the matter with you getting up so late?" "Nothing is the matter, madam." "Nothing is the matter, you wicked girl! Yet you get up so late!" And she was angry and displeased and she scowled.

Then the maid Kālī thought, "The fact is that while my lady does not show anger, it is actually present in her. It's not absent. And it is just because my work is neat that my lady shows no anger, though it is actually present in her, not absent. Supposing I test my lady a little more." It's a bit cheeky, really, isn't she?

So the maid Kālī got up later in the day and Mistress Vedehikā said, "Hey, Kālī, what is it, madam? What is the matter with you? You get up later today." "Nothing is the matter, madam." "Nothing is the matter, you wicked girl! Yet you get up later in the day!" And she was angry and displeased and she spoke words of displeasure.

Then the maid Kālī thought, "The fact is that while my lady does not show anger, it is actually present in her, not absent. Suppose I test my lady a little more." Wicked!

So the maid Kālī got up still later in the day. Then Mistress Vedehikā said, "Hey, Kālī, what is it, madam? What is the matter with you? You got up later still today." "Nothing is the matter, madam." "Nothing the matter, you wicked girl! And you get up still later in the day!" And she was angry and displeased. And she took a rolling pin and gave her a blow on the head and cut her head.

Then the maid Kālī, with blood running from her cut head, denounced her mistress to her neighbours. "See, ladies, the kind lady's work! See, ladies, the gentle lady's work! See, ladies, the peaceful lady's work! How can she become angry and displeased with her only maid for getting up late? How can she take a rolling pin, give her a blow on the head and cut her head?"

And later on, a bad report about Mistress Vedehikā spread about. Mistress Vedehikā is rough. Mistress Vedehikā is violent. Mistress Vedehikā is merciless.

So often you might get somebody who doesn't show anger, but actually it's all hidden in them. I remember one person whom I knew who actually declared that he never felt anger, but of course it was all over him. I mean, you could tell it a mile off that he was very angry.

So it's a case of bearing up, bearing up what we have to suffer. It's that sense of endurance. And of course, in our practice, there's a lot of that because when we sit, all this turbulence comes up – the fears and the worries and the angers and the depressions and all the stuff that we suffer from. And remember that we open up to it and we open up to it with loving kindness. We embrace it. And if we can take that attitude to anything in the world that disturbs us, then obviously it just undermines this wrong relationship we have of getting angry, of not wanting to endure things.

Of course, it gets worse because there are severe situations – victims of violence and, of course, torture. That's the worst. That really is quite awful, torture. And we know that even our own soldiers were playing at torture. And that's very hard to forgive, especially when you've been really brutalised like that.

There was a lovely book, actually, although he wasn't particularly brutalised in a way, by I think it was Brian Keenan called *An Evil Cradling*. It goes back to the 80s, I think, something like that, where he was hostage – some of you might remember – and that is definitely worth reading. And his ability to forgive them, this is remarkable. And you'll find people who've been terribly damaged and are able just to forgive. And so forgiveness is the way out of this resentment towards them and resentment towards yourself. You have to be able to forgive yourself.

It's often a case of pride. It's an inverted pride: "I'm horrible. I'm useless. I'm terrible. I ought to live in hell."

So, again, the Buddha gives us a wonderful simile, which many of you will know. It's called the simile of the saw: "Because if bandits were to sever you savagely, limb from limb, with a two-handed saw, he who gave rise to a mind of hate towards them would not be carrying out my teaching."

When I said this at one point, at one place, somebody said, "The Buddha had a great sense of humour." But I think he actually means it.

"Hearing bhikkhus, you should train yourself thus: Our minds will remain unaffected. We shall utter no evil words. We shall abide compassionate for their welfare with a mind of loving kindness, without inner hatred. We shall abide pervading them with a mind imbued with loving kindness. And starting with them, we shall abide pervading the all-encompassing world with a mind imbued with loving kindness, abundant, exalted, immeasurable, without hostility and without ill will. That is how you should train yourselves, bhikkhus."

"If you keep this advice on the simile of the saw constantly in mind, do you see any coarse speech, trivial or gross, that you could not endure?" "No, venerable sir." "Therefore, bhikkhus, you should keep this advice on the simile of the saw constantly in mind. That will lead to your welfare and happiness for a long time."

That was what the Blessed One said, and the bhikkhus were satisfied and delighted in the Blessed One's words.

So this is our overcoming certain taints. Remember, taints are oozings, floods, these washes of negativity, of unwholesomeness that are within us, and they manifest in specific situations, specific incidences. And therefore we have to have that real awakenedness to catch the first movement of irritation, of anger, of rejection, of trying to change something just to make us feel more comfortable.

But more that sense of opening up to the unpleasant, and then you see there's no suffering in it. There's no suffering in it.

So I think that brings us to the end of that little particular exploration of overcoming the *taints* by endurance. The Buddha's teaching here is really quite profound and practical. When we encounter difficult situations, difficult people, or unpleasant experiences, our habitual response is often to resist, to push away, to try to change things so we feel more comfortable. But this very resistance is what creates our suffering.

The simile of the saw shows us a different way. Even in the most extreme circumstances—and the Buddha uses the most extreme example possible, being sawn limb from limb by bandits—we can maintain our inner peace and loving-kindness. If we can do that in such circumstances, then surely we can handle the everyday irritations and challenges we face.

The key is that awareness, that *sati*, that catches the very first movement of irritation, of anger, of rejection. Before it builds up into a full-blown emotional reaction, we can meet it with this quality of endurance, of patient acceptance. We open to the unpleasant rather than pushing it away.

And this is where the insight comes: when we stop fighting against what's happening, when we stop trying to make reality different from what it is, we discover that the suffering was never in the situation itself. The suffering was in our resistance to it. The unpleasant experience remains unpleasant, but the suffering—that extra layer of mental anguish we add on top—that disappears.

This is the wisdom of endurance, the wisdom of *khanti*. It's not passive resignation or becoming a doormat. It's an active, aware, skillful response that maintains our inner freedom regardless of outer circumstances. This is how we overcome the taints—not by avoiding difficult situations, but by meeting them with wisdom, with patience, with an open heart that remains unshaken.

Overcoming the Taints by Removing - Part 1

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 11 min

In this teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma continues his series on overcoming the mental taints (āsava) by examining the sixth method: abandoning by removing. Drawing primarily from the Dvedhā Vitakka Sutta (MN 19), he explores how the Buddha-to-be systematically dealt with unwholesome thoughts before his Awakening.

The talk focuses on the Buddha's approach of dividing thoughts into two categories: unwholesome thoughts of sensual desire, ill-will, and cruelty versus wholesome thoughts of renunciation, goodwill, and compassion. Bhante emphasizes the importance of wise reflection (yoniso manasikāra) in recognizing how unwholesome thoughts lead to affliction for oneself and others, obstruct wisdom, and lead away from nibbāna.

A key insight explored is the psychological principle that "whatever a person frequently thinks and ponders upon, that will become the inclination of his mind." This teaching offers practical guidance for meditators on how to work skillfully with obsessive thinking patterns while distinguishing between abandoning thoughts versus suppressing feelings. The approach emphasizes understanding rather than force, showing how wise reflection naturally causes unwholesome desires to subside.

I just realized I had the sound off. Anyway, you saw me chanting and wishing you a greeting and hoping you had a fruitful day. So we'll start again.

Back on the old taints. Just as a reminder, we've got the taints. These are the āsava. Remember the underlying washes of our mental states, and they manifest through defilements. Some should be abandoned by seeing — that was when we were discussing this whole business of not-self. Should be abandoned by restraining. Abandoned by using — that was things like food and stuff like that. Abandoned by enduring — yes, there are certain things that all we can do is bear with them until they pass. And then we avoid them. We avoid certain places that are too tempting for us. And now we have abandoned by removing.

So let me just read the passage. What taints should be abandoned by removing? Here a *bhikkhu* — remember the *bhikkhu* refers to anybody listening — reflecting wisely. So don't forget he's very big on wise reflection. Does not tolerate an arisen thought of sen-

sual desire. He abandons it, he removes it, he does away with it, he annihilates it. He does not tolerate an arisen thought of ill will, an arisen thought of cruelty. He does not tolerate it. He abandons it, he removes it, does away with them and annihilates them.

While taints, vexation and fever — so vexation, remember, is the vexation fever referred to the two sides of desire, wanting, not wanting — might arise in one who does not remove these thoughts. There are no taints, vexation or fever in one who removes them. These are called the taints that should be abandoned by removing.

So now we have to move again to a different discourse where this is explained in greater detail. This is number 19 of the *Majjhima Nikāya*, the middle length sayings, and it's *Dvedhāvitakka*. Now *vitakka* just means thinking. So that's important. *Vitakka* just means thinking, as opposed to emoting, thinking.

This is the Blessed One. He was speaking again at Jetavana, Jeta's Grove. Remember the place that Anāthapiṇḍika, this rich businessman, bought for him. And he says, "Venerable Sir," they replied. The Blessed One said, "Before my enlightenment, while I was still only an unenlightened Bodhisattva, it occurred to me, 'Supposing I divide my thoughts into two classes.' Then I set on one side thoughts of sensual desire, thoughts of ill will and thoughts of cruelty. And I set on the other side thoughts of renunciation, thoughts of non-ill will and thoughts of non-cruelty."

So here we have the Bodhisattva. Remember, that's what we call somebody who has made a determination to become a fully self-awakened Buddha. That's different from the Mahāyāna, where everybody takes the Bodhisattva vow. In Theravāda, they're very specific. Sometimes people do it in this very lifetime. Others remember during their meditation that they've made this vow in the past life. Perhaps we can give you examples of that some other time, but we'll stick to this discourse.

So when he says, "and set on the other side thoughts of renunciation, non-ill will and non-cruelty," the Buddha often likes the negative form, telling you what's not there. So obviously here he's referring to *mettā*, goodwill and compassion, not cruelty.

"As I abided thus, diligent, ardent and resolute" — so we've come across this little trilogy before: diligent, ardent and resolute — "a thought of sensual desire arose in me and I understood thus: this thought of sensual desire has arisen in me. This leads to my own affliction, to others' affliction and to the affliction of both. It obstructs wisdom, causes difficulties and leads away from *Nibbāna*."

"This leads to my own affliction" — when he thought this leads to my own affliction, it subsided in me. In other words, as soon as I recognized the thought was doing me harm, the desire to indulge it began to fall away, subsided. When I considered that it

leads to other people's affliction, and then also that desire subsided in me — well, that's the compassion bit, isn't it? And when I considered this leads to the affliction of both, in the same way it subsided in me.

So there's your wise reflection. These are examples of wise reflection. You have a thought in your mind of some sensual desire or sexual desire, doesn't matter what it is. And you can see that it's obsessive. And if you hang on in there, it's just going to do you harm. And it's reflecting on the harm that it could possibly do to you that makes you want to let go of it. So then it'll subside. You're bringing up the opposite.

In the same way, if you have a sensual thought which is going to hurt somebody else, like feeding their addictions, then you have to see what a horrible thing that is, and the desire will subside. And when we do something that harms both myself and somebody else, then obviously that also helps us to let go of these thoughts.

"It obstructs wisdom." So remember, wisdom here is not an intellectual thing. It's a way of being. So it obstructs the wisdom, which is to live in harmony, to live with goodwill, to live with non-greed. "Causes difficulties and obviously leads away from *Nibbāna*."

So here, whenever the thought of sensual desire arose in me, I abandoned it, removed it and did away with it. The same thing he said of course of all those thoughts around ill will and the thoughts around cruelty: I abandoned it, removed it, did away with it.

Then he says — there's a little passage here — "Whatever a person frequently thinks and ponders upon, that will become the inclination of his mind. If he frequently thinks or ponders upon thoughts of sensual desire, he has abandoned the thought of renunciation to cultivate the thought of sensual desire. And then his mind inclines to thoughts of sensual desire."

This may seem a little obvious to us now, but in those days, I would have thought this is quite a revolutionary way of thinking about our psychology. We know that when we keep thinking about the same thing, it becomes obsessive. It becomes a place where the mind seeks pleasure, seeks happiness. And then, of course, it is then expressed in the way we speak and what we do. And in so doing, of course, you're renouncing the path of renunciation.

Always remember, when we talk about the path of renunciation, it's not the same as self-mortification. We're not blaming the body for its appetite. What we're trying to let go of is our obsessiveness around food, obsessiveness around sex, and so on and so forth. And that obsessiveness is what we're renouncing. We're not indulging it.

How do we indulge these things? Through our thinking, through imagination. And it excites the heart. Remember, all these desires begin in the heart, the heart base. And that's what we have to recognize here. What the Buddha is pushing away, abandoning, annihilating, is thoughts. He's not suggesting here that you should also try to annihilate a feeling, your emotional, your heart state. Far from it. We know from the discourse on how to establish right mindfulness that he wants us to actually go in there to feel those feelings, feel feelings in feelings.

21b Overcoming the Taints by Removing 2

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 10 min

In this continuation of his exploration of mental purification, Bhante Bodhidhamma delves deeper into the Buddha's teaching on overcoming the taints (āsava) through skillful removal. Drawing from the Buddha's own account of his path to Awakening, he explains how thinking develops mental states and the importance of allowing underlying emotions to exhaust themselves naturally rather than suppressing them.

The talk emphasizes the Buddha's counsel from the Satipaṭṭhāna method: to go into difficult emotions, feel them fully, and allow them to heal through complete experiencing. Bhante uses the Buddha's metaphor of the cowherd guarding cattle to illustrate how we must vigilantly watch our mental states, being careful not to let unwholesome thoughts stray into the 'crops' of our practice.

A key teaching emerges about the danger of excessive thinking—even wholesome thoughts of renunciation, mettā, and compassion can strain the mind if pondered too much. The Buddha's approach was to establish good mental habits and then simply remain mindful that these states are present, like a cowherd relaxing under a tree once the cattle are safely contained.

The episode concludes with the Buddha's powerful metaphor of the deer and the two paths, representing Māra's false way versus the Noble Eightfold Path, followed by his compassionate instruction to find time for meditation practice without delay.

Okay now, the important thing is that thinking is developing a mental state, and when the Buddha talks about annihilating the thinking he's not talking about annihilating the emotion or the desire that's actually motivating it. In the discourse on how to establish right mindfulness, he asks us to go in there, to feel it and to allow it to exhaust itself. And that's the process of healing, of course.

Then he says, so this is the more positive, then he gives us a lovely, his usual metaphor. "Just as in the last month of the rainy season, in the autumn, when the crops thicken, a cowherd would guard his cows by constantly tapping and poking them on this side and that with a stick to check and curb them. Why is that? Because he sees that he could be flogged, imprisoned, fined or blamed if he let them stray into the crops. So too I saw in unwholesome states danger, degradation and defilement, and in wholesome states the blessings of renunciation and the aspect of cleansing."

"Now, as I abided thus diligent, ardent and resolute, a thought of renunciation arose in me, and I understood this thought of renunciation has arisen in me. This does not lead to my affliction, to others' affliction or to the affliction of both. It aids wisdom, does not cause difficulties and leads to *Nibbāna*."

Now here, this is obviously that person who thinks a great deal. "If I think and ponder this thought even for a night, even for a day, even for a night and day, I see nothing to fear from it. But with excessive thinking and pondering, I might tire my body. And when the body is tired, the mind becomes strained. And when the mind becomes strained, it is far from concentration. So I steadied my mind internally, quieted it, brought it to a singleness and concentrated it. Why is that? So that my mind should not be strained." In other words, don't think too much.

So then he goes on, he repeats that with non-ill will, *mettā*, and non-cruelty, compassion. And then, of course, he repeats this understanding that a bhikkhu who frequently thinks and ponders upon, that will be the inclination of his mind. That will be the inclination of our minds, wherever we continue to think and ponder upon. But remember, when we're pondering upon things, not to ponder too much, because it strains the mind.

And then, when we're developing the better side of ourselves, "just as in the last month of the hot season when all the crops have been brought inside the villages a cowherd would guard his cows while staying at the root of a tree or out in the open, since he needs only to be mindful that the cows are there, so too there was need for me only to be mindful that these states were there." So in other words, once we've established these better ways of thinking, it's just a matter of keeping an eye on them, that's all, and they'll just keep coming. The work is letting go of the stuff which we don't want, because often that's quite delicious.

And then he says, "tireless energy was aroused in me and unremitting mindfulness was established, my body was tranquil untroubled, my mind concentrated and unified." And in this way, he works through the purification and he finally comes upon the moment of awakening.

And this is one of these lovely phrases that you get throughout the scriptures. He realizes that birth is destroyed, becoming is destroyed, the holy life has been lived, what had to be done has been done, there is no more coming back to any state of becoming. That lovely phrase: what had to be done has been done. You can imagine the sense of relief, the sense of joy at having finally reached the end of all this stuff.

This was the third knowledge. The first, excuse me, this was the third true knowledge attained by me in the third watch of the night. "Ignorance was banished and true knowledge arose. Darkness was banished and light arose, as happens in one who abides diligent, ardent and resolute." This was the third knowledge. Remember the first two was recollection of all his lives and how he came to this point. And the motivation through all those lives was his moral conduct. And then he saw beings moving from one place to another, one rebirth to another, driven also by their moral decisions. So what had been a personal law when he realized that his life was, the movement from life to life, and even in this life, is driven by our ethical decisions, became a universal law when he saw that all beings behave in the same way. And the third one was the realization that his heart was completely purified of these taints, these defilements.

I've got a bit of time. I'll go over time a little bit. "Suppose because there was a wooded range there. In a wooded range, there was a great low-lying marsh near which a large herd of deer lived. Then a man appeared desiring their ruin, harm and bondage. And he closed off the safe and good path that led to their happiness. And he opened up a false path and he put out a decoy and he set up a dummy so that the large herd of deer might later come upon calamity, disaster and loss.

But another man came desiring their good, welfare and protection and he reopened the safe and good path that led to their happiness and he closed off the false path and he removed the decoy and destroyed the dummy so that the large herd of deer might later come to growth, increase and fulfillment. I have given this simile in order to convey a meaning. This is the meaning: the great low-lying marsh is a term for sensual pleasure. The large herd of deer is a term for beings. A man desiring their ruin, harm and bondage is the term for Mara, the evil one. The false path is a term for the wrong eightfold path: wrong view, wrong intention and so on. The decoy is a term for delight and lust. Well, better say indulgence and lust. The dummy is a term for ignorance. The man desiring their good and welfare and protection is a term for the Tathāgata, accomplished and fully enlightened. The safe and good path that led to their happiness is a term for the noble eightfold path: right view, right intention, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness and right concentration.

The safe and good path that leads to happiness has been reopened by me. The wrong path has been closed off, the dummy removed and the decoy destroyed. What should be done for his disciples out of compassion by a teacher who seeks their welfare and has compassion for them, I have done for you. There are these roots of trees, these empty huts, these meditation centres and corners of bedrooms where you can sit. Meditate bhikkhus. Do not delay or else you will regret it later. This is my instruction to you."

I don't know about you, but I find this an extraordinarily moving little piece here where he says, "What should be done for his disciples out of compassion by a teacher who seeks their welfare and has compassion for them? I have done for you." Remember, he spent 45 years, the rest of his life trying to get us out of a mess. And then he tells us that we must find a place to meditate and do not delay or else you regret it later. This is our instruction to you.

"And what the Blessed One said and the bhikkhus were satisfied and delighted in the Blessed One's words."

Very good. I hope that you've also been inspired by this discourse. And I think it's time now to do a little sitting.

Overcoming the Taints by Developing the Seven Factors of Awakening

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 22 min

In this concluding talk on overcoming the taints (āsava), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the seventh method: abandoning taints through developing the seven factors of awakening (satta bojjhaṅgā). Drawing from the Ānāpānasati Sutta (MN 118), he explores how mindfulness (sati), investigation of states (dhammavicaya), energy (vīriya), rapture (pīti), tranquility (passaddhi), concentration (samādhi), and equanimity (upekkhā) work together to overcome mental defilements.

Bhante emphasizes how these factors naturally balance each other - effort with tranquility, investigation with equanimity, curiosity with calmness. He discusses the importance of approaching meditation with 'original mind,' investigating our inner phenomenal world with the wonder of a child seeing something for the first time. The talk includes practical guidance on how the four foundations of mindfulness (satipaṭṭhāna) fulfill these awakening factors, and how noting technique supports this natural process of investigation leading to absorption and insight.

Good evening. I trust you've had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa
Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa
Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa
 Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So we must continue with the taints. We're now coming to the last one. Breathe a sigh of relief. I shall read the passage and then we'll go into it.

Just as a little reminder, it's always good to just go through them again. There are taints that should be abandoned by seeing. That was the one with *vipassanā*, seeing not-self. Taints should be abandoned by restraining. Taints should be abandoned by using. Taint should be abandoned by enduring, by avoiding, by removing those other thoughts, and finally developing.

So what taint should be abandoned by developing? Here, the meditator, the *bhikkhu*, reflecting wisely. Don't forget there's always a bit of reflecting wisely. Develops mindfulness enlightenment factor, which is supported by seclusion, dispassion and cessation and ripens in relinquishment. He develops the investigation of states enlightenment factor, the energy enlightenment factor, the rapture enlightenment factor, the tranquillity enlightenment factor, and the concentration enlightenment factor. And finally, the equanimity enlightenment factor, which is supported by seclusion, dispassion, cessation and ripens in relinquishment. While taints, vexation and fever might arise in one who does not develop these enlightenment factors, there are no taints, vexation or fever in one who develops them. These are called the taints that should be abandoned by developing.

Just three words there: seclusion, dispassion and cessation. So this seclusion *viveka* means, well there's two meanings - either you seek seclusion from people, I mean we're in a sort of state of seclusion, but it's also meaning a seclusion within ourselves. That's when we close off and investigate ourselves within ourselves. Dispassion *virāga* is that state of not being overcome by any of the defilements.

Cessation *nirodha* is the point where everything, as it were, phenomenal disappears. And this lovely word relinquishment, the word is *patinissagga*. *Nissagga* means to give, it means to let go of, to relinquish everything. *Pati* is everything. It means to just let go of everything and jump. It has this quality of beginning something, of getting into something.

When I read that, I was reminded of the story around Jesus. I hope you've all read your New Testament recently, or the Bible. If you remember the story of the rich man who came to him and said, look, I keep all the laws, I keep all the rules. What must I do to enter the kingdom of heaven? And he said, drop everything, leave everything and follow me. And the rich man went away shaking his head sadly. So there's a point where you have to let go of everything. It's a sort of death. So that's the meaning of these words: seclusion, dispassion, cessation ripens in relinquishment. Now the cessation and relinquishment are both, I think, the same moment.

Now you'll notice that these qualities, everybody has them, and they all come up at various times. Everybody has awareness, everybody has that sense of investigation, curiosity, sense of wonder. Everybody has that, well that's what the rapture is referring to. *Pīti* means any sort of physical shaking because of happiness, a little thrill up the spine, to great absorption joy. But here of course it's the joy of interest, the heart's interest. Tranquillity, people feel tranquil at times. Concentration. Equanimity, sometimes people are equanimous about things.

So none of these factors are something strange to us. We all experience them. What turns them into enlightenment factors is we turn those qualities to investigate the Dharma, and specifically those three characteristics of existence: suffering, the cause of suffering, and reactivity and all that, impermanence and not-self.

Anyway, there are a couple of discourses which go into this a bit more deeply. And the one I'm looking at is actually the discourse on the breath, how to develop a meditation on the breath. It's 118. And it's right towards the end.

So the question is, how are the four foundations of mindfulness developed and cultivated? How do they fulfill the seven factors of awakening, the seven factors of enlightenment? So he says *bhikkhus*, remember that means all meditators, whatever occasion a *bhikkhu* abides contemplating the body as body, ardent, fully aware and mindful, having put away covetousness and grief for the world.

So remember that ardent is that real energy that we need to maintain that mindfulness, fully awake, mindful and putting away covetousness and grief. That's just another way of saying greed and aversion. Unremitting mindfulness is established in him. And whatever occasion unremitting mindfulness is established in him. On that occasion, mindfulness enlightenment factor is aroused in him. And he develops it. And by developing it, it comes to fulfillment in him.

So that quality of awareness is something that we, just by constantly establishing it and maintaining it, it becomes a continuous factor within us. I don't say continual, which means there's never a break, but at least it's there for longer and longer periods.

Abiding thus mindful, he investigates and examines that state with wisdom and embarks upon a full inquiry on it. So just read that again. He investigates and examines that state with wisdom and embarks upon it and fully inquires upon it. So this is *dharmavicaya*. This is that process of looking into something, just as any scientist might, really investigating. But this investigation, of course, is our own inner phenomenal world, the world of the heart-mind, the body-heart-mind that we experience internally.

And abiding thus mindful, a *bhikkhu* investigates and examines that state with wisdom and embarks upon a full inquiry of it. Now on that occasion, the investigation of states enlightenment factor is aroused in him. He develops it. And by development, it comes to fulfillment in him. So again, the same process, just keep practicing, keep practicing, and it comes to fulfillment.

Then he says, so he's going through it in a particular manner, going through it in a particular specific manner. And he wants to investigate and examines the state with wisdom and embarks upon a full inquiry into it. Tireless energy is aroused, tireless

energy. And then again, whatever occasion, tireless energy is aroused in the *bhikkhu* who investigates and examines etc. On that occasion the energy enlightenment factor is aroused in him, he develops it and by development it comes to fulfillment in him.

So this is that energy effort that we need. Of course you must remember we always fall usually on one side or the other. Not enough, we fall asleep. Or too much, often over-efforting to try and achieve something, instead of just remaining in that lovely space of just being aware, just investigating.

The first two he begins with, by the way. The first one is Awareness *Sati* and the next one is *Paññā*. They always come up together in the discourse on the *Satipaṭṭhāna*, how to establish the four foundations of mindfulness. These two words always run together, *sampajāno-sātimā*. *Sampajāno* is with intuitive intelligence, *sātimā*, mindfully. And that's why this place is called Satipaṭṭhāna.

And in one aroused with energy, unworldly rapture arises in him. Unworldly simply means not sensual. So this is something to do with the spiritual life. Now this rapture that I was mentioning before is the sense of wonder, the sense of curiosity which is very natural. You see it in animals. It's in all sort of intelligent beings. In all little sentient beings, all sentient beings have some sense of curiosity. I saw a video that somebody sent me of whales, and a playground was empty and a load of sheep got in there. And blow me down, before you knew it they were on the roundabout going round and round. It was quite funny to see it.

So again, just by arousing it in him, he develops it and it comes to fulfillment. And then when this rapturous state is established, they're occasioning him of tranquillity. Tranquillity enlightenment factor is aroused in him, he develops it and it comes to fulfillment. So this tranquillity, you know, we all feel that at times: calmness, feeling at peace, feeling at ease. And that supports this curiosity which can get a little bit excited, it can go over the top. So that calmness balances that state of over wonder, over curiosity. We'll come to that again in a minute.

And in one whose body is tranquil, he feels pleasure and the mind becomes concentrated. And on whatever occasion, etc., on that occasion, concentration enlightenment factor is aroused in him, he develops it, and by development, fulfillment.

Now you'll notice concentration comes after calmness, you see, and I'll talk a bit about that a bit later. So remember that. First of all, that sense of calmness, sense of peacefulness, and then the curiosity and the concentration is drawn. It develops around those qualities.

He closely looks on with equanimity. So here now the sentence changes. He closely looks on with equanimity at the mind thus concentrated. And on whatever occasion a *bhikkhu* closely looks on with equanimity at the mind thus concentrated. Now this equanimity is really about an attitude of that objectiveness, that objectivity - not getting involved, no reactivity. And of course that also is aroused in him, he develops it and development comes to fulfillment.

So now, and then, so the first one was on the body, so now of course he says exactly the same thing with the other three establishments of mindfulness. First of all, feelings - feelings in the body but mental, emotional feelings. The next one is, of course, mental states. And then finally, mental objects, by which we mean seeing things through the seven facts of enlightenment, the five hindrances, the three characteristics of existence, the four noble truths. It's a way of investigating things. And this is how the four foundations of mindfulness are developed and cultivated and fulfilled.

So then he just repeats himself, or he repeats it. Remember this is learned by rote and so repetition is just part of that helpful process of keeping things in mind, being able to remember them. Because this is how the seven factors are developed and cultivated, fulfill true knowledge and deliverance - deliverance from suffering, of course. And as usual, this is what the Blessed One said. The *bhikkhus* were satisfied and delighted in the Blessed One's words. They didn't always delight in his words, but on this occasion they did.

So what you find in the traditions is often an accent on effort and concentration. This is very much the way my own teachers worked, very much pushing this whole idea of really pushing the concentration, making the effort. And well, it worked for me, it works for a few people, but I did find in my own teaching that to put the accent more on curiosity and calmness seemed to help people a bit more to see these characteristics.

So it's not as though this is the final way that the seven factors can be generated one after the other. I mean, if you want me to remind you the way the Buddha does it, or the way it's put in the scriptures here, so he starts off by establishing awareness, and then there comes that sense of investigation of everything. And with that there comes this energy, this tireless energy. And then there comes this interest. Now for me that's the other way around really. I put interest first and then the investigation of the Dharma. And then there comes this tranquillity and then finally, sorry, then there's the concentration and finally the equanimity.

The thing is that they balance each other so that the effort is balanced with the concentration. So if you don't put enough effort and there's good concentration, then you tend to fall asleep or go into a state of unconsciousness. And if there's too much effort, then of course the restlessness begins and you just find it difficult to concentrate.

With that interest, the curiosity, the sense of wonder, there has to be a carefulness not to get excited. And that's what tranquillity does. It just keeps it nice and soft. If there's too much tranquillity, you fall asleep. If there's not enough tranquillity, you become restless. And the same with investigation of Dharma, which is supported by equanimity.

So again, if there's not the equanimity there, then you're looking for something, you're trying to get something. And if you do get it, you're probably fully, I think if you think you're awakened, you're probably fully deluded. So it's a case of being careful that you're always taking this stance of just watching, just feeling, just knowing.

And many of you will remember the three, four, five year old, when they see something, how the jaw drops and say, what is it? So this business of, that's the, you know, this is what Zen calls original mind, right? To approach something as if we had never seen it before, to approach the breath as if we'd never breathed before. Which of course is very difficult, but we can find a way of accessing that observation post within ourselves, you see, and just watching, just feeling.

And that's one of the blessings of the noting technique because the noting does, shall we say, stop the mind thinking about things. And even though the word is there, your attention is towards the object and you begin to notice other things. The note itself is only centred on one particular little thing that you're feeling. Like for instance, if you're watching the breath rising, you're just aware of that process of rising. But of course we're feeling it, we're actually feeling that process. And we're also aware of the image of the abdomen or the nose, wherever you're observing it. And within all that, there's just a sensation.

And as we drive the attention towards just sensation, we'll get to the point where the arising disappears. We're using a different word. Actually, at that point, normally there's no time to note. One is absorbed into the object. And even the sense of where it is has gone. So that's how the process works.

And all of these things, all of these seven factors, remember, are all guided by awareness. Where the awareness is, the other six factors come up to support it. And that's often why when we're being taught how to meditate, all these seven factors are not really talked about, apart from saying, you know, concentration or interest. I don't re-

member any of my teachers making any big effort to teach the seven factors as such. It was always when your attention, when your awareness is there with right intention, the seven factors support it.

So I think that brings to an end our investigation of the taints. I might come back to the last paragraph and we might spend just one or two evenings or whatever it takes on the fetters, what it is we're supposed to be unfettering, unchaining ourselves from. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance and that you are not left completely confused.

And I think it's time now to do a bit of meditation.

The Ten Fetters

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 26 min

In this illuminating talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the ten fetters (saṃyojana) that keep us bound to saṃsāra, drawing from the Mahāmalunkya Sutta (MN 64). He begins by concluding the discussion on āsavas (mental taints) before exploring how these fetters operate at three levels: underlying tendencies (anusaya), mental obsession, and manifest actions.

The first five lower fetters are: sakkāyadiṭṭhi (identity view), vicikicchā (skeptical doubt), sīlabbataparāmāsa (clinging to rules and rituals), kāmacchanda (sensual craving), and vyāpāda (ill-will). These are abandoned through the first three stages of awakening. The five higher fetters include craving for fine material and immaterial existence (the jhānas), māna (conceit of 'I am'), uddhacca (restlessness), and avijjā (ignorance).

Bhante emphasizes the practical importance of recognizing these fetters in daily life and meditation practice, explaining how different practitioners achieve liberation through either samatha-vipassanā or pure vipassanā approaches. This teaching provides essential understanding for anyone serious about the path to complete liberation from suffering.

Good evening. I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

We shall just finish off the taints. As a last reminder, just in case you've forgotten, there are taints. Now, what are the taints again? They are all the sensual desires, all the senses, the longing to keep living, to become, and ignorance, which often manifests as wrong view. Remember that wrong views is often listed with ignorance.

So there are taints that should be abandoned by seeing—that's your insight through *vipassanā* and specifically around not-self. That first one will take you directly to full liberation. The next one by restraining and then by using and then by enduring and avoiding and removing—all those will certainly help but they will not lead to full and entire liberation. But the last one will, which remember, is the development of the seven factors of enlightenment.

So the first and the last, number one and number seven, are the ones to remember more. But remember that as soon as you see something coming into your heart, into your mind, which is unwholesome, jump on it and then reflect and say, "Now which one of these wonderful techniques the Buddha has given us is to be used here?" And that way we'll find ourselves becoming more pure of heart.

So we went through all that. It's taken us a while, but that's good. So I just want to read the last paragraph, the conclusion. It's a very long sentence. "And when the taint had been abandoned by all the seven that we've mentioned, then he is called a *bhikkhu* who lives restrained with the restraint of all the taints. He has severed craving, flung off the fetters, and with complete penetration of conceit, he's made an end of suffering." So that's somebody who's finally completed the path. And of course, as usual, the bhikkhus are very satisfied and delighted in the Buddha's words, the Blessed One's words.

So he's severed craving—that's the end of those wrong desires based on seeking happiness in the sensual world. He's flung off the fetters, and that's what we're going to look at this evening, and his complete penetration of conceit. In other words, that whole sense of self has disappeared. So remember, self in this sense is identity with what we're experiencing, an identity.

We shall now move to number 64, which is the Mahāmālunkeyaputta Sutta. So it's the great discourse to Mālunkeyaputta. Often it would seem people were named the son of their mother. So this is the son of Mālunkeyā—Mālunkeyaputta, of Mālunkeyā, the Sāriputta, the son of Sārī. So I suppose in those days, instead of saying Johnson, you would say Jameson and then you'd know who you were.

So the Buddha's back in Sāvatthi—that, remember, is his favourite place, and Anāthapiṇḍika's park there. The local king, Pasenadi of Kosala, I think I'm right, yes, Kosala, he was a great supporter.

Now he asks the venerable Mālunkeyaputta, "Do you remember the five lower fetters taught by me?" I suppose before I go into that, I ought to just go through them very quickly.

So the first one is an identity, a belief in identity—that's a self. Skeptical doubt. Remember that skeptical doubt isn't the wonder, the honest doubt, the desiring to know for oneself, which is based on "I wonder if it's true." It's the doubt that stops you doing something. We'll come to that another time maybe. Clinging to mere rules and ritual. And then there's sensuous craving, ill will. And then there's craving for fine material existence and fine immaterial existence. That's number six and seven. So those are the *jhānas*, the absorptions. Then there's conceit. That's a big fetter. "I am." It's how you

finish that sentence is your conceit. "I am," see? And then finally, then there's restlessness. So this refers to any leftover agitation from the defilements and, of course, ignorance. So we'll come to them in the fullness of time.

So here he's asking Mālunkyaputta, "What do you remember of the lower fetters as taught by me?" And he replies, "I remember it's translated as personality view, but it's basically identity as a lower fetter, doubt as a lower fetter, adherence to rules and observances as a lower fetter, sensual desire as a lower fetter. And I remember ill will as a lower fetter taught by the Blessed One. It is in this way, Venerable Sir, that I remember the five lower fetters taught by the Blessed One."

Now, without the commentaries, we wouldn't actually understand the Buddha's reply. What the commentary says is that the Buddha, from this, has understood Mālunkyaputta to say that these fetters only arise here and now, only arise on occasion.

So this is what he says: "To whom do you remember my having taught the five lower fetters that way? Would not the wanderers of other sects confute you with the simile of an infant? For a young tender infant lying prone does not even have the notion of self-personality. So how could personality view arise in him? Yet the underlying tendency to personality view lies within him. A young tender infant lying prone does not even have the notion of teachings. So how could doubt about the teachings arise in him? Yet the underlying tendency to doubt lies within him. A young tender infant lying prone does not even have the notion of rules. So how could adherence to rules and observations arise in him? Yet the underlying tendency to adhere to rules and observation lies in him." And then, of course, he says the very same thing about desire, sensual desire and ill will.

So then Ānanda steps in and says, "Blessed one, it is time, sublime one, for the blessed one to teach the five lower fetters." So although he's talked about it before, he obviously needs to talk about it again.

"Then listen, Ānanda, and attend closely to what I say." "Yes, venerable sir."

So now here he says, "An untaught ordinary person who has no regard for the noble ones and is unskilled and undisciplined in their Dharma, who has no regard for true men and is unskilled in their Dharma, abides with a mind obsessed and enslaved by identity view. And he does not understand as it is, as it actually is, the escape from a risen identity view. And when that identity view has become habitual and is uneradicated in him, it is a lower fetter. He abides with the mind obsessed and enslaved with doubt, rules and observations, sensual desire, and ill will. And when that ill will has become habitual and uneradicated in him, it is a lower fetter."

And then he says, of course, there is an escape. That's his usual way of doing it. "For the underlying tendency is abandoned in him."

So what we have here is the Buddha telling us that at an obvious level, these fetters, unwholesomenesses, arise through our speech, through our actions, etc. But even when they don't, the tendency is there within us. So that's an underlying thing. There are, in fact, three levels of that. The first one is called *anusaya*, which is a latent tendency. Now, in the discourses, they're not actually enumerated, but they were later, especially in the Abhidhamma, the higher teaching. And then the next part is that they obsess the mind. And then, of course, they express themselves in what we say and do. So those are the three things. And of course, it's occasion that brings them out. We find ourselves falling into some sensual desire when the object of sensual desire arises. Otherwise, it won't manifest, but it's there as a potential.

Again, he gives us some similes. "Just as when a great tree standing possessed of heartwood"—that's the inner part—"it is not possible that anyone shall cut out its heartwood without cutting through its bark and sapwood." So too there is a path that we can't get on until we process of training. And then of course he says that that's possible.

He then talks about, "Suppose the river Ganges were full of water right up to the brim so that crows could drink from it. And then a feeble man came thinking by swimming across the stream with my arms, I shall get safely across to the further shore." Remember, the further shore is always a metaphor for Nibbāna. "Yet he would not be able to get safely across. So when the Dharma is being taught to someone for the ending of the cessation of identity, if his mind does not enter into it and acquire steadiness, confidence and decision, then he can be regarded as a feeble man."

In other words, this has to be truly investigated by us through the process of *vipassanā*, but also just any time of the day, the notion of investigating who I am might arise. And of course, he says the opposite of someone who is strong. "Abandoning unwholesome states quietly secluded from sensual pleasure," etc., and in this particular case he takes us through the absorptions.

Now, just before we go on to the last bit, it's good just to go through these fetters. So a fetter, a shackle, a chain, is what's keeping us to this form of existence. So one of the definitions of *nibbāna* is to be unshackled. It's an awareness, the *sati*, which is unshackled, liberated from its delusion with the world, its illusion with the world.

So we have this personality belief, that deep identity with the human being, with our psychophysical organism, with all our thoughts, with all our relationships, etc. Skeptical doubt is this particular doubt which stops us doing things. I'm sure you probably have a

memory of being at the public baths and climbing on the diving board and getting right up to the top one and not having the confidence to jump until somebody pushed you and then after that it was dead easy. So skeptical doubt, doubting ourselves, unable to meditate properly and all that, doubting the Buddha's teaching and doubting the teacher. It becomes a barrier even in ordinary daily life if you apply for a job but you doubt if you can do it—then you never go for the interview.

Mere rules and regulations or mere rules and ritual ceremonies—the mistake is that they are actually important to the path. But no, they're just aids to the path. When we take refuges and precepts, for instance, or when we light candles, they're aids which help us to establish the right sort of atmosphere, the right sort of attention within us. They're just aids, really, but in themselves are, of course, useless in attaining liberation as such. In those days, there would have been lots of rituals to get what you want. The belief in ritual would have been very strong. And of course, it still is in some religions.

Now, those three go when we enter the stream, the *Sotāpanna*. So remember, there are four levels of attainment. The first one being that insight into one of the three characteristics—either not-self, that everything we're aware of is not me, not mine, and itself is not a self. Impermanence—that also will help us to enter the stream, to see that everything actually does perish, does come to an end. There is no continuity. And the third one is *dukkha*, suffering, and that's really seeing how we create suffering. It's a direct understanding of the role of desire. And those insights have to be deep enough to have a change, to bring about a change in our lives. So those are the first three fetters, as they're known.

By the way, that first insight that person might have into not-self—it's a change of view. The sense of self is still very strong. And often people doubt whether they've had that insight because the sense of self still remains very strong. But the actual view has been changed or the insight has broken the illusion. The example I normally use is about smoking because when my father smoked, pre-Second World War, 1940s, 50s, it wasn't considered to be particularly harmful. But as the science finally got through, when the tobacco companies finally admitted that they'd been fooling everybody, deluding everybody, everybody began to understand that smoking is really, really bad for your health. But it didn't stop them smoking. The obsession was still there. The view was changed, but the desire to smoke had not been undermined. It's surprising how when some people actually had the consequence of that—I'm thinking particularly of a father of one of my friends who had a heart attack, smoked all his life, had a heart attack and after that completely stopped.

Now the next two—the sensuous craving, craving that arises on all the senses including the inner sense of the mind, whatever the mind is offering our dreams, our fantasies, etc. And all the ill will, all the negativity that's in us—they are only attenuated. They're only undermined with the second path. And they lose their power with the third path. And what that really is saying is that the attraction of the sensual world is no longer there for somebody who's a non-returner. So the second path is called a once-returner, suggesting that you have to come back for a bit more suffering to another rebirth. But the one who has broken through the delusion of seeking happiness in the sensual world, they don't have to come back to this form of existence. They can be reborn in a particular heaven, it is said, where they attain full liberation.

And then the final ones—the craving for material and immaterial existence, that's really to do with these absorptions, which are in themselves very delightful, beautiful places to be, and often, especially the fine immaterial ones, can be mistaken for Nibbāna. The conceit of "I am," remember, disappears—that comes right at the end, the breaking of that conceit. And then restlessness is always there. That's the little bits of agitation that's left from old habits that the person has had. And then finally, undermining ignorance as such. And that suggests, of course, that they know what or who they really are. The Buddha within. That's the moment of complete liberation.

So that takes us through the ten fetters. "Whatever exists therein of feeling, perception, habits and consciousness, he sees these states as impermanent and suffering, as a disease, as a tumour, as a barb, as a calamity, as an affliction, as alien, as disintegrating, as void"—in other words, empty, insubstantial—"as not-self. He turns his mind away from those states and directs them to the deathless element."

That's really confusing, isn't it? I mean, what does that mean, direct them to the deathless element? It's a way, remember, of the Buddha pointing out that there is something which is not phenomenal, something that doesn't belong to the mind, etc. Now, how do we do that? You can't obviously see Nibbāna. If we were to be able to see or experience Nibbāna as an object, then of course it would be conditioned. So it can't be that. It's not looking at that. What he's saying is to turn away from that desire to involve ourselves in the world and to pull ourselves away.

So that's why when we're in that position within ourselves of the objective observer, when we've accessed that observation post to recognise that there is that distance, there is that separation, that everything we're observing is an object, and then of course to realise that the very sense of self, the observer, is an object so we can't be that—it's just a case of remaining in that position which is beginning to see the deathless.

And when we're in that state, we can always ask ourselves, "What's it like? What's it like being the observer where there is no body, no physicality, where there is no emotion, where there is no thought?" This comes to us usually at some time on a retreat, but even in ordinary daily life, depending on what's happened during the day, as long as you're calm, as long as you can get concentrated, as long as you can lift yourself up to that position, you can always ask yourself, "What's it like being this observer?" Because that's what we mean when we say those who are mindful are in the presence, in the vicinity of, in the presence of Nibbāna. And just that little insight tells us that this is peaceful, it's sublime, the stilling of all formations, all habits, the relinquishing of attachments, the destruction of craving, dispassion, cessation.

That's the ending of the world as a place where we're going to find happiness and *nibbāna*. And this is, of course, right at the end of the whole process. This is when we become fully liberated. And standing upon that, he attains the destruction of the taints.

But he does not attain the destruction of the taints. So if he doesn't attain the destruction of the taints then, then he says, because of that desire for the Dhamma, the delight in the Dhamma, with the destruction of the five lower fetters, then he becomes one due to reappear spontaneously, and there in the pure abodes and there attain final nibbāna without ever returning to this world. This is the path, the way to abandoning the five lower fetters.

And then here's a real clincher at the end. So Ānanda says, "Venerable Sir, if this is the path, the way to abandoning the five lower fetters, then how is it that some bhikkhus here gain deliverance of mind and some gain deliverance by wisdom?" Now, deliverance by mind is through these *jhānas* and the purity of the mind. But then, of course, there has to be insight. And there are some who are delivered just through insight. So that's the vipassanā only way. And the answer is the difference, Ānanda, is in their faculties, in how they are.

And, of course, the Venerable Ānanda was satisfied and delighted in the Blessed One's words, as I'm hoping we are too.

So I hope this describes the fetters well enough for you to understand them and it gives us pointers and that of course you're not confused by it all and that I trust that you will devote your meditations to investigating the fetters.

May you be fully liberated.

Society

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

In this thought-provoking talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines what Buddhist scriptures teach about creating harmonious society, drawing primarily from the Dīgha Nikāya's accounts of the wheel-turning monarch (cakkavatti). He explores how these mythical rulers governed through Dhamma (righteousness), establishing the five precepts as the foundation of just governance.

The talk addresses contemporary social issues including mental health challenges, inequality, and environmental destruction through the lens of Buddhist social ethics. Bhante references the chaplain's advice to the king about addressing crime through economic justice rather than punishment - providing livelihood support to farmers, traders, and government workers rather than relying on harsh measures.

Drawing connections between the Buddha's Axial Age teachings and modern movements like Joanna Macy's "Great Turning," he emphasizes that societal transformation requires not just stopping destructive actions and creating alternatives, but fundamentally changing our values and worldview. The Buddha's teaching focuses on two pillars: ethics (sīla) and transcendence, offering guidance for both personal development and social harmony. The talk concludes with a challenge for listeners to reflect on the most important value needed for societal change.

I just realised I didn't have my microphone on. That has now been corrected. I'm sure you know what I said.

In fact, today I was on Hangouts with somebody and a question came up concerning my evening salutation. Why do I say I hope you've had a fruitful day, though I don't say happy? So there was an occasion where my teacher arrived at a meditation centre, Sayadaw U Pandita. And somebody went up and said, "Sayadaw, I'm so happy to see you." And he replied in Burmese and the translator did not translate. Later on, the translator was asked by this person, "What did he say?" And the translator said, "Well, he said, I haven't come to make you happy. I've come to make you aware."

When I say, "I hope you've had a fruitful day," even if it's been an absolutely horrible day — perhaps you're frontline staff, perhaps you've been harassed at work, you're travelling with people breathing coronavirus all over you, you've been frightened, per-

haps you've just had a rotten day emotionally — but if you've worked with it with awareness and with investigation, or just, as we know, bearing... Remember, the taints are overcome by enduring, by just bearing with it. And that's been a fruitful day.

If, on the other hand, you had a happy day and you found yourself indulging, excitedly planning stuff, overeating and so forth, that is not a fruitful day. But if you have been aware of these tendencies, and you have renounced them — remember overcoming the taints by renouncing them — that is also a fruitful day. Hence my evening salutation.

Now then, I thought we would leave these taints for a little while and look at what the scriptures say about our society. So I've noticed in the BBC — I forget where I read it now, it might have been in The Guardian or something — it said that there's been an increase in mental illness and drug abuse over this period. So it seems as though lots of people are having real problems with this isolation. And I just wanted to look at some of the scriptures here. I've left the *Majjhima Nikāya*, the middle-length sayings, for a while, and I'm using Bhikkhu Bodhi's book called *The Buddha's Teaching on Social and Communal Harmony*. So this has all the little quotes that I need, saves me reading the whole scripture.

When the Buddha was born — and remember his mother died within a week — his father, Suddhodana, who was, I mean, he wasn't a king so much as a headman, a head of the Sakya group or tribe or clan, call it what you want. And the clan was under the vassalage of the local king of Kosala, who then was Pasenadi, who became a great supporter of the Buddha. And the king, or the headman — call him what you wish — gathered eight sages and asked them to predict what would happen to his son. So seven of them said, well, he could either become a world-conquering monarch or a self-enlightened being. But one of them, Kondañña, said he would surely become a self-enlightened being.

So in the scriptures, what we have is this sort of alter ego of the world-conquering monarch. And I'll just read a few passages and then we'll go back to something else.

"Even a world-turning monarch, a just and righteous king, does not govern his realm without a co-regent." And a certain monk asked, "Who, Bhante, is the co-regent of a wheel-turning monarch, the just and righteous king?" "It is the *Dhamma*, the law of righteousness," replied the Blessed One. "The wheel turning monarch, the just and righteous king, relying on the *Dhamma*, honouring the *Dhamma*, esteeming and respecting it, with the *Dhamma* as his standard banner and sovereign, provides lawful protection, shelter and safety for his dependents."

And then he goes on. So then we have this moment when at some point in the history of this king, of the kings, as he bathed his head on the Uposatha day — which is a religious day, every full moon, where you might go and pay respects to the temple — he ascended the upper palace chamber and there appeared to him the divine wheel treasure with its thousand spokes, its tyre and its nave complete in every aspect. And on seeing it, the head-anointed noble king thinks thus: "Now it has been heard by me that when a head-anointed noble king has bathed his head on the observation day and has ascended to the upper palace chamber, and there appears to him the divine wheel treasure with its thousand spokes, its tyre and its nave complete in every aspect, that that king becomes a wheel-turning monarch. I am then that wheel-turning monarch."

And what happens is that he sprinkles it with some holy water and then it starts moving. And as it moves to the east, he takes his four constituent army — so that's his elephants and his chariots, his cavalry and his infantry — and off he goes. And eventually, by going to the left and the right, east, west, north, he becomes a world-conquering monarch. And whenever he enters a territory, the local king says, "Welcome, great king. Great king, advise us, great king." And the wheel-turning monarch speaks to them. And you won't be surprised: "You should not destroy life. You should not take what is not given. You should not engage in sexual misconduct. You should not speak falsehood. You should not drink intoxicants. And you should enjoy your accustomed enjoyments." And so then he becomes the wheel-turning monarch.

So now there comes a point where somebody comes to the king and says the wheel-turning monarch — so there's a succession of them — "has slipped from its position, and I have heard when this happens to a wheel-turning monarch he has not much longer to live. I have had my fill of human pleasures. Now is the time to seek heavenly pleasures. You, my son, take over control of this land. I will shave off my hair and beard, put on the ochre robes and go forth from the household into homelessness." And having installed his eldest son in due form as king, this particular king, Dalhanemi, shaved off his head and off he went.

Now then, this new king went up and a certain man came to him and said, "Sire, you should know the sacred treasure wheel has disappeared." And the king was grieved and sad and he went to his father and said, "Why is it?" "My son, you should not feel grieved or sad at the disappearance of the wheel treasure. The wheel treasure is not an heirloom from your fathers. But now, my son, you should turn yourself into a noble wheel turner, and then it may come about that you perform the duties of such a monarch."

And of course he does the same. He does the little rituals and he determines to rule by the *Dhamma* and he becomes a wheel-turning monarch. And this went on for about six kings. But the seventh king to arise in this dynasty did not go to the royal sage — that would have been his father — and ask him about the duties. Instead, he ruled the people according to his own ideas. And being ruled thus, the people did not prosper as well as they had done under previous kings.

The king then ordered his ministers and advisors to come together and he consulted them. And they explained to him the duties of a wheel-turning monarch. And having listened to them, the king established guard and protection for his subjects. But he did not give wealth to the needy. And as a result, poverty became rife. "Thus, from not giving of wealth to the needy, poverty became rife. And from the growth of poverty, theft increased. From the increase of theft, the use of weapons increased. From the increased use of weapons, the taking of life increased, lying increased, divisive speech increased, and sexual misconduct increased. And on account of this, the people's lifespan decreased and their beauty decreased."

Does that ring a little true these days?

So then we have a repeat of this in a different discourse. These are all, by the way, from the long collection, the collection of long discourses. So here we have a similar thing. And this time the chaplain, a brahmin, approaches His Majesty and he says, "Your country is beset by thieves. It is ravaged. Villages and towns are being destroyed. The countryside is infested with brigands. If Your Majesty were to tax this region, that would be the wrong thing to do. Supposing Your Majesty were to think, 'I will get rid of this plague of robbers by executions and imprisonment and by fines, threats and banishment,' the plague would not be properly ended. Those who survive would later harm your Majesty's realm. However, with this plan, you can completely eliminate the plague. To those in the kingdom who are engaged in cultivating crops and raising cattle, distribute grain and fodder. To those in trade, give capital. To those in government service, assign proper living wages. Then those people, being intent on their own occupations, will not harm the kingdom. Your Majesty's revenues will be great, the land will be tranquil and not beset by thieves, and the people with joy in their hearts, playing with their children, will dwell in open houses."

What do you think of that?

And of course he does it. He accepts the chaplain's advice. He gave grain and fodder to those engaged in cultivating crops and raising cattle, capital to those in trade, proper living wages to those in government service. And then those people, being intent on

their occupations, did not harm the kingdom. The king's revenues became great. The land was tranquil and not beset by thieves. And the people with joy in their hearts, playing with their children, dwelt in open houses.

So there's a little bit of guidance from the scriptures coming from this mythical king who completely rules the world using the *Dhamma* as a basis. So the moral law — if you look at the scriptures, you'll see that the Buddha is only teaching ethics. He teaches ethics and transcendence. Those are the only two things you'll find. I'd be surprised if you find anything else. If you do find something else, send me an email.

Now, you may have heard of Joanna Macy. So she's a well-known deep ecologist. She's an activist, a teacher, written plenty of books. And there's a nice little video that I saw. And she talks about the great turning. She has this understanding, and other people do, that we are at a point where we could have a really great turnaround in the world to a completely different way of living, or at least a much more wholesome way of living.

If we go back to the Buddha's time, that was a time which is called the Axial Age, where we had suddenly a raising of human consciousness. The Buddha, of course, there were the Brahminical sages who were writing the Upanishads. There was Lao Tzu in China, Moses in the desert, and of course, our own Socrates. And the message from all of these people was, do unto others as you would have them do unto you. That's one of the basic messages that came from that axial age. There were others too, but that was one of the basic ones.

And she talks about this moment of turning and what's necessary for it to happen. And she talks about three different things. First of all, holding actions to stop the destructiveness of what's happening. So we have, for instance, in this country, 2,000 food banks. I mean, that's the situation where people have to go to food banks to get food. We have the Big Issue, which is a newspaper that homeless people can sell on the streets in order to make a bit of money to pay for rent and stuff. Recently we've had the ecologist Chris Packham stopping the extension to Heathrow Airport by going to the courts and saying it would undermine the aim we have of reducing our carbon footprint. And he's now in the process of trying to stop that HS2, the fast speed railway that's going to rip up half of England in order to get to the north quicker.

And so all these are really trying to undermine the destructiveness of this particular form of economics we have, neoliberal economics. So that's the first thing, that there are people who are trying to limit the damage.

Then she goes on to say that the next thing is that we need alternative structures and patterns of organising. And one of the things she talks about is organic farming, turning away from prosperity towards human happiness, what makes us happy. And the use of plastic, looking at that very closely. So there's all that business of actually doing something differently. And I think in many ways that's beginning to happen perhaps.

But the third one — and really the foundation of any turning point that has to come — is, of course, a change of values, depending on our belief systems. There has to be a *metanoia*, which is a change of perception, a change in the whole way that we view life and the purpose of our lives. And of course, this is the role of religion.

Science is very good at telling us how things come to be, but it can't answer the question why. All religions always posit something beyond this world that we're actually experiencing. If you turn just to the world and say, "Well, this is it and there's nothing else," then this becomes your aim, to make this world work for you. And it's very difficult not to make it a selfish enterprise. Of course, one begins to understand that if you turn outward, if you start doing things for other people as well as for yourself, then the payback is a deeper personal happiness. But that's not the way at the moment this neo-liberalism is asking us to work. It's all about me getting as much as I can, dog eat dog and so forth.

So what we need is, as this wheel-turning monarch shows us, a change of values.

So now I woke up today and I thought, "I'm doing all the work here." I thought, "Bodhidharma, you're doing all the work, you're doing all the research and giving all these talks." So it's about time the listeners did something. So I thought to myself, why not ask them to email me and make a statement, a small statement as to what value they think is the most important? I'm challenging you to send me an email and to state very shortly — because I don't want to read huge pages — what you feel is the most important value. Some change in the way that we look at society. And the one word you can't use is love. OK, that's a four-letter word and you can't use it. You have to find some other word or some other way of expressing yourself.

So I thought I'd leave you with that. And hopefully tomorrow, you have to send me these emails, shall we say, before five o'clock or something, because I have to read them and digest them, try to put them all together. So I shall leave you with that little challenge for this evening. I can only hope that my words have been inspirational in some way and have not depressed you. And we shall turn now to do a little meditation.

Very good.

25 Reflections for an Harmonious Society

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 26 min

In this thoughtful exploration, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines several key reflections for building a harmonious society, drawing from Buddhist wisdom and practical ethics. He discusses humanity's relationship with the natural world, questioning our assumed superiority over other beings while acknowledging the precious opportunity of human existence for spiritual development. The talk addresses the reality of intensive farming and our treatment of animals, connecting this to how we treat each other.

Key themes include moderation and restraint - fundamental Buddhist principles about not taking more than needed or given. Bhante explores the concept of care as preferable to 'love,' linking it to the Buddha's teaching on heedfulness (appamāda) and affectionate awareness. The discussion emphasizes personal responsibility through the lens of kamma, explaining how our actions create ripple effects both externally and within our own psychology.

Drawing from the Aṅguttara Nikāya's teachings on the three Arahats led by Anuruddha, Bhante illustrates how harmony emerges when we consider others' needs alongside our own. The talk weaves together practical wisdom for daily life with deeper insights into Buddhist ethics, offering guidance for practitioners seeking to live more consciously and compassionately in relation to all beings.

I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, but I hope it has been happy.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa.
Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

I'm afraid I did a silly thing. Every evening or in the morning I cut the little bit out that's a talk, or as it was last night questions and answers, and I save it. Without going into details, I went and wiped out the whole thing, so there's a lesson there somewhere. However, I will tag the actual statements onto whatever we say tonight, whatever questions we come across tonight, so they won't be lost.

So let's see if we can carry on here. Unfortunately, I don't know which statement I ended up on, but I think I ended off with a society driven by economics of sharing and healing. I think that was the one.

Before I start, let me remind you that when we hear somebody's statement, we either fully agree with it, reinforcing our conceit, or we disagree with it, which is reinforcing our conceit. Remember, views and opinions come with, first of all, the view itself, which is never—it might be right, but it's never total. It's never the full perspective, you might say. And secondly, there's an identity with it. This is what I believe. This is my understanding. And with that, there comes a cleaving to it, a clinging to it, and that's your attachment. And that's why people find it so difficult to change their opinions, because they are changing this sense of I. So we have to be open to other people's opinions, and it may affect us, it may not. But just because we hear somebody's opinion doesn't mean that we have to be converted.

So with that in mind, I'll read first, catch your reaction, and then I'll read it again. I think the world would be improved if humans did not believe they were superior to the rest of nature, but realized they were just part of it, that no one is more or less important than another.

I think the world would be improved if humans did not believe they were superior to the rest of nature, but realized they were just part of it, that no one being is more or less important than another.

This is a tricky one, actually. From beings' point of view, I think it would be difficult to disagree with that. In other words, the way a cow or a pig that people eat feel about their lives, how they treasure their lives, how they want to live, no matter how nebulous that is, is much the same as ours. They don't particularly want to be slaughtered.

But in terms of more or less important, I suppose that's true in the general, but I think Buddhism or the Buddha would eventually put human life above that of animal life. So if it came to a choice between me and a cow, it would be me. I would have—it would be difficult to say this—I would have the right to preserve my life. And the cow wouldn't have the same right on the grounds of it being a higher life form.

Now, I'm on dodgy ground here, I know, and a lot of people would disagree. But there is something very precious about the human existence. And in terms of full liberation, this is the place you want to be.

Now, I'll give you a little story. I was in Thailand, and I was with a group of monks. And a group of them were introduced to me as Korean monks. And after a little bit of conversation, I said, are you from Japan? And they said, no, Korea, Korea. Anyway, I was traveling to the south of Thailand to go to Suan Mokkh, which is a famous monas-

tery down there of the teacher Buddhādāsa, who was very famous in his time. One of these monks was on the train, and while we're on a train a mosquito landed on his hand and he swatted it.

So I said to him, mosquitoes? And they said, better life, dengue fever, and all the other illnesses that mosquitoes can carry. So I suppose it's a call really for the dignity of all life, which people would be able to relate to.

Yes, I think we had a similar one come up before, not to harm living beings. And we talked about what it would be like if all people stopped. And the need to protect animals, especially these days with all this climate crisis going on.

There is an extreme nature with which we keep animals that really is not supported. In Powys, this is a county which runs alongside the border with Wales—it's a big agricultural county, there's not many people live here—they have, because farmers are now asking to diversify partly because of Brexit, Powys has 116 intensive poultry units. Each one of these has 40,000 birds approximately, and you can check it—I did it on a calculator—four and a half million chickens per year are slaughtered in those houses. And in 2018, I picked up this bit of information: in the UK, just short of one billion farm animals are slaughtered. One billion. That's a thousand million. It's an enormous figure, of which 40,000 die on the way to the slaughterhouse, in which case they're just dumped. The bodies just dumped.

So there's a huge callousness about it, of which people don't know, not interested anyway, and they want their chicken and that's the end of it. But again, how we treat animals is often a mirror to how we treat ourselves and how we treat other human beings. And this huge poverty that we have in the West, and of course it gets even worse when you move out of the West.

So it's this whole business of really reestablishing a proper relationship with animals. In the West, they didn't do very well because Aristotle started off by saying they have no rights. An animal has no rights because it has no responsibilities. But he also said that of women. So it is a view. And then in the Christian era, St. Thomas said they didn't have any souls, which means that they just died, and that was it. They didn't go on like human beings. And then when Descartes came along, he said they were just machines. They acted as if they felt something, but they didn't. They were just machines.

And that reminds me of a little quip in Sri Lanka. When I got to the monastery, one of the monks said to me, we're vegetarians. And I said, that's wonderful. Anyway, that very same day or the next day, they serve fish. And when I mentioned this to the other

Western monk who was there, he said, well, in Sri Lanka, they think fish are self-propelling animated vegetables. So that's a beautiful thing. And I think that's what most people think animals are—self-propelling animated vegetables.

So there's something that I think we need—we need a sea change when it comes to the use of animals. And now, of course, they're producing meat from cells. That was an interesting thing, isn't it? That they can take a cell, a muscle cell from an animal and they just put it in chemical vats and it grows. So eventually, hopefully, there will be other ways of eating meat which don't actually include a living being. Who knows?

I believe one needed value for the world to function correctly is a sense of harmony. We wish every evening all sentient beings to be in harmony with the world. If every thinking being centered their decisions while integrating just this notion—how is this action impacting the world around me?—I believe huge change could happen. The current societal movements around climate crisis and the growing number of vegetarians are a movement in this direction, I believe.

When the Buddha talks about actions, he always says to reflect wisely that this is something wholesome for me, that it's wholesome for the other, and that sometimes it's wholesome and skillful for both me and the other. So yes, it's a case of being sensitive, isn't it, to the other.

There was another case in the scriptures where the Buddha comes across three monks—the three of them are Arahats—and they're referred to as Anuruddha because he was the chief monk amongst them. And he asked them, how is it that they live so peacefully together? And Anuruddha said, well, when I get up in the morning, I say to myself, what if I put aside what I want to do and do what the others want to do?

Now, if the three of them said that, you can see there's going to be a lot of harmony because there'll be a bit of give and take. But if you try it with people whom you're living with, you might find that you're saying that and the others aren't. And then it doesn't really work because they take advantage of you. But if the attitude within a group or within two people—partners or married people—if they have that attitude, what if I put aside what I want to do and do what the other wants to do? Then obviously there's that lovely way of living with each other.

And harmony always presumes that you are empathic with the other person or with, as we just talked about, with animals around us.

How about moderation, undertaking the rule of training not to take too much, not to take more than is given, more than is needed? Any ideas I have will be based, I hope, on responsibility and the belief that most folk are responsible and reasonable. I've always believed that if you take too much, you probably owe too much in return.

Yeah, well, that resonates, doesn't it, with the Buddha's teaching about restraint. If you remember, overcoming the taints, the oozings with restraint. It's one of his big teachings, really, just not giving in to desires, just to please oneself.

I think there's also a sense of gratitude, I think. Even with food, when you actually just recollect how the food came to you on the plate and the enormous amount of work that goes into it and the energy needed for it, then I think that sense of gratitude comes and a certain respect, a certain desire not to abuse it, not to take too much. And that's probably true for everything, especially when you think about how the garments that we wear are all made for peanuts in the East. The garment factories of Bangladesh come to mind.

And I think if you take too much, you probably will owe too much later. I think if you know you're taking too much, that you're taking advantage, that you're being greedy with anything, there's always that sense of guilt, which we might hide from ourselves for a very long time, but at some point in the spiritual practice, the heart's got to be purified, and you've got to, as it were, pay back. You've got to find some way of paying back for the greed.

And that's—that would be my understanding of probably owe too much in return. So you have to, if you've taken too much, then at some point you're going to feel bad about it. You're going to feel that you shouldn't have done it. There's going to be a sense of shame. And to get rid of that, you have to pay something back.

That's why, of course, the Buddha says that these qualities of shame and dread of consequences, guilt, are guardians of society. In the Abhidhamma, they put them as wholesome attitudes. But they're only wholesome once they are rested in us as little wake-up calls. Don't do that. You'll feel shame. You'll feel that. But actually, the feelings of shame and guilt we experience when we do something which we see is unskillful or unwholesome, that's obviously not wholesome. We want to get rid of that. Often you have to sit through that sort of stuff in our sitting.

So yeah. Moderation in all things.

Care, which implies empathy and doing something. When my concern or care stems from a feeling of kindness and manifests in actions, I'm both being insightful and a good human being.

Yes, I much prefer the word care to love. Love has so many meanings and so many undertones and overtones. But the sense of care is a lovely word—to care for somebody and to care for things, to care for your mobile. It's an attitude, isn't it? It's a wonderful attitude. Taking care of, to be careful.

It's one of the meanings of one of the Buddha's favorite words, *appamādo*—heedlessness, not to be heedless, to be diligent—but it also has that sense of care, caring. I think this is what the Buddha means when, or part of what the Buddha means when we read during the discourse on loving-kindness, that we should develop this awareness, this mindfulness. It's a mindfulness which is imbued with care, with kindness. It's an affectionate mindfulness, to go around with an affectionate mindfulness.

Responsibility. I am responsible for my actions. My decisions and actions will affect myself and others. If I cause harm to others, I will be harmed sooner or later. I'm responsible for my own happiness. I should not depend on others. I can make a change, a positive change in myself.

So that's of course the teaching of *kamma*. When we do something—whatever an action of speech or the body and of course the mind itself, because the mind eventually expresses itself through the way we speak and what we do—remember there are two waves of energy that go out: out into the world which has an effect, but also into our own inner psychology, into our own inner world.

And just as we don't know the effect of what we say and do will have outwardly, although we can say generally speaking, if I do something good, good will come of it. If I do something with a bad intention, something not so good will come from it. But that also works inside myself as well.

And it's beginning to realize that if I can just empower myself—those thoughts—it always begins with thoughts. If I can empower those thoughts that express beautiful attitudes, then very slowly my heart will grow. And that runs in tandem with—it runs at the same time as purifying the heart. Remember, behaving in a beautiful way, in a very wholesome way, doesn't actually purify the heart. What it does is it extends those virtues, but then you still got to deal with the gunge, with the taints, the oozings.

Responsibility. It's interesting, responsibility. The word duty went out of fashion, I think, after the First World War, where people didn't even question their sense of—they had to do it because they were told to do it. The word responsibility probably fits easier with the modern person, to be responsible. And it's something that is not so—

Um, should we say, so popular as the word rights. You know, "my right" – everybody's about, everybody wants their rights to be respected. And often that sense of responsibility doesn't come up so high on the list. But it really is the Buddha's – the Buddha's really all about taking responsibility for ourselves. And the understanding is that when you change yourself, you change people around you. You affect people around you. And so it has a flowing outwards of effect upon the world.

You know, you can't take upon ourselves to change somebody else. That's an absolutely no-no, that is. You know, you don't get anywhere with that. But when you change, you find the other person changes. Perhaps you've experienced that, yeah?

I once used to talk about something I read. She was a journalist, and she went to see how dolphins were trained. And what the trainers did was they say they were training the dolphin to jump through a hoop. Whenever it jumped through a hoop and it did it well, it was always full of praise, right? Clapping or something, so the dolphin knew how wonderful it was. When it failed, nothing was said at all – nothing. There was no sense of even acknowledging it in a way.

And she went home and she did this with her husband. Every time her husband did something wonderful or something that she was pleased with, she would praise him. And when he did something that she didn't like, she didn't say anything. And of course he changed, you see.

And then she very foolishly told him the trick. I think probably all hell let loose, because often you don't want to feel you've been manipulated. But that's an interesting thing, that is. Criticism of somebody else who's not taking responsibility often backfires.

Oh dear, time moves on. And I've still got a few to go, which is good, actually, because it just gives me time to think about these things for myself. Very good.

So we shall leave it there for this evening. I hope you found that, I don't know, of value. Peace and joy.

26 More Reflections

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 32 min

In this concluding talk of his reflections series, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines profound community insights on truth, interdependence, and sympathetic joy. He begins by addressing the critical importance of truthfulness in our 'post-truth' world, discussing how dishonesty affects personal relationships, corporate ethics, and political life. Drawing from monastic discipline, he explains how lying about spiritual attainments constitutes a pārājika offense—grounds for expulsion from the Saṅgha.

The discussion moves to our fundamental interdependence with all beings, from humans to insects, emphasizing how harming others ultimately harms ourselves. Bhante explores the challenging practice of sympathetic joy (muditā)—one of the four brahmavihāras—noting how rejoicing in others' success can be more difficult than feeling compassion for those who suffer. He addresses the three forms of conceit (māna) and how gratitude supports the development of joy.

The talk concludes with a beautiful reflection on how all the pāramīs interconnect, allowing each perfection to become an entry point for developing others. Using the classic simile of blind men describing an elephant, Bhante illustrates how our limited perspectives can come together to reveal fuller understanding. He emphasizes that developing the perfections and reducing the āsavas (taints) can happen simultaneously, with unwholesome energies being sublimated into wholesome states.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sambha sambuddhasa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed noble and fully self-awakened one.

So this evening we'll come to the end of these wonderful expressions of aspiration. The next one is, so I'm going to do the same so that we overcome our biases, just to listen, catch that reaction, let it go, and then open up to the statement. Luckily, none of these are controversial, which would cause us to shake our fists and other such demonstrations.

So I find it difficult to choose one above others. So ideally, I would go for one which involves keeping the precepts. If this is too wide, I will allow myself to be influenced by our post-truth world and identify the value of truth. Truth in personal relationships and interpersonal transactions, truth in the corporate world and the world of work, truth in politics, don't laugh, and the spiritual truths we seek, the truths of the Dharma.

If this is too wide, I will allow myself to be influenced by our post-truth world and identify the value of truth in capitals. Truth in personal relationships and interpersonal transactions, truth in the corporate worlds and the world of work, truth in politics, don't laugh, and the spiritual truths we seek, the truths of the Dharma.

Yes, not to lie. It's in right speech, of course. Not to tell the truth also includes things like calumny, talking badly about people. It also includes abusive language and of course just talking for talking's sake, but the main thing of course is truthfulness.

Yes, we live in a post-truth world. It's been shocking, really, when you think about it, how politicians like Trump and our own blessed Boris get away with the most astounding lies. Nobody pulls them up. You can't take them to court. Politicians seem to be above the law. You can actually go on a website which is called Boris Johnson Lies. And the journalist has listed all the lies, and they're all supported by research, et cetera, et cetera. And it is extraordinary. It's not that we ever thought politicians told the truth. Well, we never thought they told the whole truth. As Winston Churchill said, a lie is to be economical with the truth, so you only tell half truth. But some of the stuff that we hear from Boris and from Trump and others is just completely untrue, and nobody pulls them up about it. It's just extraordinary.

But on a personal level, yes, being truthful in our relationships and interpersonal reactions. You could say, couldn't you, that our relationships are based on that honesty, on being honest, open, not hiding things from each other, not exaggerating things. That's another way you can be dishonest, by exaggerating, exaggeration. Corporate worlds, of course, we know we have astounding examples of the cigarette companies, the tobacco companies, and all that false research, and the same with these oil companies and the research on climate change. And all that, it's awful really, absolutely awful. And we talk about transparency, you know, and governments are anything but transparent. So that's just the way it is.

And somehow, you know, we have to keep working to ask for the truth. And we're very fortunate in this country that we have a free press. As you know, what happened in China when somebody was being truthful about coronavirus, they were, I think they were definitely pulled up by the police for being subversive. So it's an awful state we're in.

Lying in the monastic rule is a very serious offence, and if it's like about your attainments, if you say that you know you're an Arahant or something or you've been through all the jhānas and it's a lie and you know it's a lie and perhaps you've done it in order to get supporters, that's a *pārājika*. *Pārājika* means end of life, that's how a defeat is often termed, as a defeat by which you have to leave the order. Interestingly enough,

much in the same way as our politicians. You can't make a monk leave the order. I mean, if you're in certain organisations in certain countries, of course, the force of the country, of the order can make you leave, but they can't disrobe you. All they can do is not accept you in their monastery. So if somebody declares themselves to be an Arahant, for instance, and has enough lay people who believes them, then he can continue. There's not much can be done about it. It's an interesting little point about the order.

I mean, there were people who made that mistake in the Buddha's time. There's one occasion where there's a monk, and I'm not actually absolutely clear whether it was a pārājika in other words one of these defeats, but the Buddha wouldn't start the recitation of the *Patimokkha*, the rule, and Moggallāna asks him. You have to forgive me these little lapses, I've got the main story right. And finally, and they sit all night and finally the Buddha's asked, you know, why aren't you starting? He said, there's somebody impure, you see. And Moggallāna, that's right, Moggallāna with his special abilities could see who it was and actually got hold of him and threw him out of the meeting. It's about the only bit of violence that seems to occur in the scriptures.

So truth is of course an absolute necessity, absolute necessity. Yes, I've got here that wonderful moment when Trump's people came out with this wonderful phrase alternative facts. I thought that was absolutely brilliant, alternative facts. And of course, perhaps some of the hardest thing is to be truthful to ourselves. Sometimes we're not truthful to ourselves, not really open to our own defilements. I always remember being slightly shocked when I realised that I was jealous. I was jealous of somebody. And it took me by surprise because I would have gone around saying, well, I'm not jealous of anybody. But in fact, on this particular occasion, I was. And that pulled me up, you see. So I keep a lookout for that sort of unwholesome mental state.

Jealousy is one of those things that we don't obviously like to accept about ourselves because it diminishes us. I mean, as soon as you're jealous of somebody, you're saying that they're better than you. So yes, that truth is something that we could all ponder more on and demand it, demand it of our politicians, especially of our politicians. Very good.

So the next one is, my thoughts on society is that we need a greater awareness of our interdependence with all human beings, but also all organisms, animals, birds, insects, etc. Then it wouldn't occur to us that to cause any harm to anything would be peaceful and considerate. My thoughts on society is that we need a greater awareness of our interdependence with all human beings, but also with other organisms, such as animals, birds, insects. And it wouldn't occur to us to cause any harm to anything. It would be peaceful and considerate.

So we've had similar expressions of that, of course, interdependence. Thich Nhat Hanh's poem about I am this, I am that, some of you might know it, I am the flower on the something, you know, it's a bit romantic, but really it's trying to, a poetic way of saying that I am my relationships, I am that's what I am phenomenally. I'm my relationship. I'm a relationship to me. And as soon as I meet somebody, I become somebody else. As soon as I'm in nature, I become somebody else. We're always recreating ourselves within a given situation, within a given environment. If there's no environment there, then it becomes a real unpleasant place.

I remember in the earlier talks that I was giving, we talked about this confinement, solitary confinement of prisoners and how it can really mess them up psychologically because you need that feed. You need the feed from other people or else your mind just goes a bit bonkers. That is, unless you've not got so many defilements. In the monk's life, you're not supposed to go out on your own until you've reached the first path and fruit. Meaning, you know, going into the jungles and all that and the forest in those days because of the danger of losing your mind.

And of course, I'm especially aware of the lack of insects. I remember just driving from London to Manchester, my home, home of the brave, in the 60s and 70s, and your windscreen, you'd have to get out and wash your windscreen. The insects would be splattered all over it. These days you drive anywhere and there's hardly anything that hits the windscreen. I must say that this year I've noticed more bees and stuff. But last year I hardly saw any. So what to do?

And of course it is that interdependence where we begin to realise that when we harm anything out there, we're actually harming ourselves. That's the thing, isn't it? That's the interconnectedness, the interdependency. And it's really beginning to understand that and getting to a position where you try and do as little harm as possible. Definitely as little harm intentionally as possible.

Next one is my value statement would be, we need to recognise the real relationship of fundamental interdependence that exists between us individuals and social groups, between us as species and the planet, and to start behave accordingly. So my value statement would be, we need to recognise the real relationship of fundamental interdependence that exists between us as individuals and social groups and between us as species and the planet and to start to behave accordingly.

So as I said, I just laid them out as they came in rather than put them in sections, but these two came one after the other. So obviously, much the same sentiment here. Again this accent that I think we've become more aware of these days of our dependence upon species, upon other beings, especially as I say these insects upon which we so depend for our food.

The next one is regarding your request for our thoughts. What I found most rewarding and liberating is rejoicing in other people's happiness and success. I find it trickier than feeling compassion for those struggling. It is somehow much easier to be a bigger person, to find love for someone in need, but the joy that comes from truly feeling happy for someone that is already in a good place and finding generosity to wish them even more happiness. This has been a lovely, uplifting revelation for me from our evening sittings. Not an easy one, though.

Regards your request for our thoughts, what I found most rewarding and liberating is rejoicing in other people's happiness and success. I find it trickier than feeling compassion for those struggling. It's so much easier to be a bigger person, to find love for someone in need. For the joy that comes from truly feeling happy for someone that is already in a good place and finding the generosity to wish them even more happiness, this has been a lovely, uplifting revelation for me from our evening sittings. Not an easy one, though.

It's not an easy one, though. It's something that we don't particularly practice, do we? Rejoicing in other people's success. I mean, we do it on birthdays, of course, and special days like marriages and births and all that. But we don't go around rejoicing in people so much. And it's another level of connection, isn't it? So you have love and care, you have compassion when people are not in a good place. And then this sense of rejoicing in people's success, in people's abilities.

Recognising people's abilities and rejoicing in it and of course that lifts the heart tremendously, and you have to do it to yourself too. You have to rejoice in our own qualities, in our own success, and this lifts us. If we don't do that, the tendency is always to think negatively. It's to think how I could have been. The glass is always half empty. It's not half full. And that's what joy does. It balances out the more negative feelings we have towards us because most of us never feel good enough. We're always lacking something. It could have been better. It's to do with comparison, and comparison is a form of conceit.

So there are three conceits, you know, I'm better than you, so that makes me feel much, that makes me feel good. I'm worse than you, that doesn't make me feel very good, but it's somehow, there's an inverted pride and I can take comfort in it, you know,

I can excuse my failures because I'm not as good as you. And then there's a more subtle one of we are equal. Now, at first you might think, oh, well, that's egalitarian. That's perfectly all right. But of course, when you look into it, when you say that we're equal, what we're saying is that you and me are part of this group who are equal, but actually we're superior or inferior to others. So it's a communal conceit.

So rejoicing, and of course, it undermines that near enemy of envy and jealousy. So yes, it's a lovely thing to practice. And we also had, I think we had somewhere, if I remember rightly, we had generosity and a sense of, I mean, what actually goes to support that is gratitude, thankfulness. When we develop a certain level of gratitude, then we're much more open to the qualities that people have and to the things they've achieved. So, yes. Sympathetic joy. It is one of the four *Brahmaviharas*. It's one of the four dwelling places of Brahma.

So what the Buddha is saying there is that this is one of the greatest mental states we can develop. And I have to say, it's not often taught. I don't remember doing any in all my training. I mean, it was there, of course. One is happy. But there's no specific training any time in any of my spiritual practice, you know, in Buddhism, to do with joy. I have put you on to that book, by the way, I mentioned it before, *Awakening Joy* by James Baraz, very good.

So now, today, I had an email which nicely sums up everything for me. So I've not had to think about how to draw these questions to a conclusion. I've been enjoying the exploration of values over the last few days. It is fascinating to see how the different perfections all link up so that each one of them can become an entry point to developing all of them. That works nicely with the diversity of humanity.

My initial response to your question, which value would be most fundamental, was humility. It's not one of the *pāramis*, that's one of the ten perfections. On reflection, I see it as related to generosity. Both imply that my own needs and opinions are not of more value than those of others around me or far away, and allow for the possibility that my own views may be limited, that another person may be as blind and that their view is as limited as mine, holding a different part of the same elephant and describing the whole beast from their own perspective.

If enough of us could come together to share our limited perspectives openly and without clinging, then between us a fuller picture of reality might emerge and hopefully lead to better collective and individual actions in the world. I can now see that it also all links up with renunciation, in particular of ego-driven views. The *pāramis* are an area that I have so far not greatly looked at, partly believing that it was necessary to get rid of the taints before they can develop. If I understood you rightly last night, both

processes can actually happen in parallel. That's great and encouraging to hear. Of course, thinking about it, the two are like positive and negative images. By developing the perfections, I can start reducing the taints and vice versa.

So these are lovely ending paragraphs for us. And as I say, I've relieved me of any duty of drawing things up. So I shall read it again. I've been enjoying the exploration of values over the last few days and it's fascinating to see how the different perfections all link up so that each one of them can become an entry point to developing all of them. That works nicely with the diversity of humanity. My initial response to your question, which value would be most fundamental, was humility.

It's not one of the *parami*, the perfections. On reflection, I see it as related to generosity. Both imply my own needs and opinions are not of more value than those of others around me or far away, and allow for the possibility that my own views may be limited, that another person may be as blind and their view as limited as mine, holding a different part of the same elephant and describing the whole beast from their own perspective.

If enough of us can come together to share our limited perspectives openly and without clinging, then between us a fuller picture of reality will emerge and hopefully lead to better collective and individual actions in the world. I can see now that it all links up with renunciation, in particular the ego-driven views. The *parami* is an area I've so far not greatly looked at, partly believing that it's necessary to get rid of the taints before they can develop. I understood you right last night. Both processes can actually happen in parallel. That's great and encouraging to hear. Of course, thinking about it, the two are like positive and negative images. By developing the perfections, I can start reducing the taints and vice versa.

That's a lovely conclusion for us. I think that's a really good point that manifests our diversity, all these different views, but also our fundamental unity, which he later points out. This image of the elephant—that's an old Indian simile about blind men feeling an elephant and then saying that it's a brush, the tail, or it's a stump of a tree, the leg, completely misunderstanding the elephant as a whole. And that's what happens when we cling to a view or an opinion and we think that we've got it all. It's a case of seeing our views and opinions, as he said, as a perspective.

This business of working with the taints when they come up, but also developing the power of me—yes, indeed, that's what we're instructed to do. And remember that the energy or the malevolent energy or the turbulences that come with the defilements,

that energy is not lost. It is transformed. In fact, the word I prefer is sublimate. It moves directly from the unwholesome state directly into the wholesome, and sometimes you might actually experience that.

I remember I was having a hard time with my teacher once and I was doing a personal retreat. I was working with this real deep disappointment I had in him, and it came up with a lot of aversion. Being a very good meditator at that time, I just stayed with the feeling, stayed with the feeling. And to my honest surprise, it just turned in front of me into this really warm, compassionate feeling for him. And that manifested for me that these energies, they just turn—they evaporate and become something else. So you can work on both.

On that last line, the bit about hopefully lead to better collective and individual actions in the world—I was told a story by Nori. She was in Bulgaria, and somebody told her that he was in Sofia, the capital, and just noticed that lots of people were walking towards the centre. And so he joined in. A whole crowd began to develop in the central square.

And then one man got up and began to talk about all the people, all his relatives or friends who'd gone missing in the communist era. And more and more people got up to talk about their grievances. And the building, the government building behind them was full of lights, it seems. And eventually, when everything had been spoken, seemingly everybody turned and looked into the building, and all the lights started to go out. And there's a presumption that they were all escaping. And from that moment onwards, it seems the communist government began to give in.

Of course, that was all around '89 when the wall collapsed. And looking back at that time, generally speaking, what a peaceful revolution that was, you know, compared to the earlier times when there were uprisings in Hungary, '56, I think, which were brutally suppressed.

So the whole purpose of us really considering these different qualities is to begin to see how they can manifest through our economics and our social life, even personally individually. It might make us much more aware of what we're buying, what we're eating, and how we talk to others, how we actually begin to persuade others—especially those whom we meet who have opposite views and opinions—perhaps to get them to open up to our views and for us to understand theirs.

I mean, we've been through this whole Brexit thing where it was very difficult for some people who were for staying to understand that anybody could want to leave. And there's all this thing about them being a bit thick—they didn't understand. And of

course, one of the fundamental reasons that people wanted to leave was that they just weren't benefiting. They saw nothing but their own poverty, and the immigration had made them feel a loss—this is the white English people and the Welsh—had made them feel their sense of community was being undermined.

Anyway, that's what we have to do. We have to keep these values, these virtues in our minds, and whenever the opportunity comes to say what's necessary, to be open about it, not to be afraid. And hopefully we shall move towards a very wonderful and enlightened society in no length of time. We can hope.

So with those wonderful words, let us now begin our practice.

What Makes a Society Strong?

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

Drawing from the Mahāparinibbāna Sutta (DN 16), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's seven principles of non-decline delivered to the Vajji confederacy during his final days. These timeless guidelines for societal strength include frequent assemblies, harmonious governance, respect for established principles, honoring elders and experts, protecting the vulnerable, venerating traditional institutions, and welcoming worthy individuals.

The talk contextualizes these teachings within the political upheaval of the Buddha's time, when democratic confederacies were giving way to autocratic kingdoms under rulers like Ajātasattu of Magadha. Bhante explores how the Buddha's democratic values influenced monastic governance and considers how these ancient principles might apply to contemporary challenges in Western democracies.

With references to the historical manipulation that led to the Vajjis' downfall, this discussion offers both a window into early Buddhist political thought and practical wisdom for building resilient communities. The talk bridges ancient wisdom with modern concerns about harmony, governance, and the foundations of a stable society.

We spent the last three days looking at all these various viewpoints as to the virtues and wholesome attitudes that we need to build a different sort of society, or at least one that moves towards people rather than things. That's one way I would like to see it anyway.

Now, of course, these things have to be turned into policies. And that's the difficult thing, and how it manifests in our institutions. So there's a lovely passage here, which you find at the beginning of the *Parinibbāna* discourse, the Sutta number 16, which is the last days of the Buddha.

During those last times, I think the Buddha was a little preoccupied by what was happening, probably very concerned, worried about his order. He'd always had two kings who supported him. In fact, seemingly everybody supported him, all the different groups of people, ethnic groups, confederacies. But the two main ones were Bimbisāra, who was a king of Magadha, around Varanasi, in those days called Benares, which is right on the Ganges there. And further north was Pasenadi in Kosala.

Both of them died before him. Bimbisāra and then their sons weren't particularly supportive at all. In fact, Ajātasattu, who was the son of Bimbisāra, ganged up with the dastardly Devadatta to overcome the Buddha and Bimbisāra. Devadatta was unsuccessful.

ful. He sent a wild elephant on the border. He rode a boulder down the hill, which caught him on the toe, it seems, trying to kill him so that he could take over the order. He's got a very bad name in Theravāda Buddhism. But actually, I think what he was trying to do was take the order back to its original, hard, committed ways to the ascetic life. He felt it had gone soft, and he wanted to introduce new rules. One of them was vegetarianism, another was only one meal a day, only three robes, etc. The Buddha said that you can practice these as special practices, but he didn't institute them as rules. Well, this upset Devadatta very much, it seems, so he tried to kill him.

And he was in cahoots with this Ajātasattu, and Ajātasattu did actually seemingly murder his father. He locked him up in a hut in Rājagaha, which is present-day Rajgir. And if you go there, one side of the ring of hills is where the Buddha gave his talks at Vulture's Peak. And a lot of the Mahāyāna scriptures are given on that Vulture's Peak. And down below, within the circle of that, you can visit this hut where Bimbisāra was starved to death. It's very pleasant, is it?

Anyway, the big political movement of the time was away from these confederacies, which had a sort of democracy about them. It wasn't full suffrage or anything, it was more like the ruling class and the brahmins would vote to have a leader. His own father was the leader of the Sakyans up in the north along the present-day border of Nepal. One of there were still these confederacies but the movement was towards kingship.

And this eventually culminated, of course, in the great emperor Ashoka, third century, I think, second, you know, 200 and odd, who became emperor virtually of all India. But it had begun before the Buddha's time and there were established kingdoms, one of Kosala, Pasenadi, and one where he is now at Vulture's Peak by Bimbisāra.

Anyway, Ajātasattu, he's got plans, you see. So he said to his chief minister, the Brahmin Vasakāra, "Brahmin, go to the Blessed One, worship him with your head at his feet in my name, ask if he is free from sickness and disease, if he's living at ease, vigorously, comfortably, and then say, Lord, King Ajātasattu of Magadha wishes to attack the Vajjians. I will strike the Vajjians who are so powerful and strong, I will cut them off, destroy them, and I will bring them to ruin and destruction."

So this is what Vasakāra actually says to the Buddha. It's an odd thing to approach him with that clear statement of what the king wanted to do.

Now, Venerable Ānanda was standing behind the Lord fanning him. And he asked certain questions. So here I found the, this is in the long length discourses, which was translated by Maurice Walsh. But you get a slightly, I think, easier translation in that book that I'm looking at, Social and Communal Harmony by Bhikkhu Bodhi. So he's collected all this stuff around politics and stuff.

So this is what the Buddha says. He says there are seven principles of non-decline. As long as the Vajjis assemble often and hold frequent assemblies, only growth is to be expected of them and not decline. As long as the Vajjis assemble in harmony, adjourn in harmony and conduct their affairs and conduct the affairs of the Vajjis in harmony, only growth can be expected of them and not decline. As long as the Vajjis do not decree anything that has not been decreed or abolish anything that has already been decreed, but undertake to follow the ancient Vajji principles as they have been decreed, only growth is to be expected for them and not decline.

As long as the Vajjis honour, respect, esteem and venerate the Vajji elders and think they should be heeded, only growth can be expected for them and not decline. As long as the Vajjis do not abduct women and girls from their families and force them to live with them, only growth can be expected for them and not decline. So long as the Vajjis honour, respect, esteem and venerate their traditional shrines, both those within the city and those outside, and do not neglect the righteous oblations as given and done to them in the past, only growth can be expected for them and not decline. And as long as the Vajjis provide righteous protection, shelter and guard for Arahats, so that those Arahats who have not yet come may arrive, and those Arahats who have already come may dwell at ease there, only growth can be expected for them and not decline.

So these are the seven principles of non-decline. This is from a different part of the scriptures in the one about the Buddha's final days, he asks Ānanda, you see, and Ānanda says, that is so, that is so, the Vajjis do behave like this, they do behave like that.

So at this point, we'll come back to these in a minute, the Vasakāra, the Brahmin who's come to ask these questions of the Buddha, goes away saying, let's see if I can pick it up here. "Venerable Gautama," this is what Vasakāra says, having heard these seven principles. "If the Vajjians keep even one of these principles, they may be expected to prosper and not to decline, far less all seven. Certainly the Vajjians will never be conquered by King Ajātasattu by force, but only by means of propaganda and setting them against one another. And now, Venerable Gautama, may I depart. I am busy and have much to do."

The Buddha replies "Brahmin do as you think is fit" and according to the history, don't quite know where this comes from but it must be in the commentaries presumably, in the commentaries later on Vasakāra posed as a conspirator against his king and so he was denounced as a traitor and fled to Vesāli which was the capital of the Vajjis for asylum. Now the next three years were spent by him in artful dissemination of distrust and mutual suspicion among the members of the confederacy and when he judged the moment right he secretly informed king Ajātasattu and the rulers of Vesāli were now too disunited to defend their country, and Ajātasattu was soon able to round off a successful invasion with an extensive massacre of the population.

So that's what was happening at the time of the Buddha. If you look around the world today, I don't think there's been much improvement.

But let's go through these principles again and see if we can match them to anything of our present society. So the Vajjis assemble often and hold frequent assemblies. So we can look upon our parliaments and assemblies, local governments, I suppose, and we can probably expect to grow and not to decline. As long as the Vajjis assemble in harmony, adjourn in harmony and conduct affairs of the Vajjis in harmony, only growth can be expected of them and not decline. So there's not that much harmony around Europe and the West at the moment, not as harmonious as it used to be, but they're still assembling and nobody's picked up any arms yet. Although I have to say, I'm always reminded of the murder of Jo Cox there during the Brexit stuff, which of course is absolutely awful.

As long as the Vajjis do not decree anything that has not been decreed and abolish anything that has already been decreed, but undertake and follow the ancient Vajji principles as they have been decreed, only growth can be expected. That sounds a little conservative, doesn't it? I don't mean conservative party, I mean, you know, holding on to the past, not willing to change.

It's pretty clear I think that the Buddha really supported democracy as he would have known it. And there is definitely within the Sangha within the ordained Sangha a lot of democracy in the sense that monks will vote, it's not done in any formal way but through discussion and as a community they will vote for somebody to be their abbot and they'll vote for people to do certain jobs most of it's done through quiet conversations. But generally speaking, you always have a general agreement as to who the abbot is, for instance.

So when I was at Kanduboda, Venerable Pema Siri left to run a centre in Colombo. And it was a particular monk who decided that since he was the elder, he was therefore the abbot. But actually, most everybody else wanted this other monk to be the abbot

who was the teacher of *Vipassanā*. Because Kanduboda itself was a *Vipassanā* center. That's what it was meant to do. It had a throughput of something like a thousand lay people throughout the year.

Anyway, he became quite paranoid. I rather liked him. He was very good on the Vinaya, kept us all in order. He had a certain authoritarian feel about him, which is sometimes good. And he became quite paranoid because obviously he could feel that people didn't want him, that the monks didn't want him. And as a story, I mean, I was there at the time, actually. He came out of his hut, his *kuṭi*, one day, and there were these scratches on the floor. And he accused people of putting a hex on him, that somebody had come along and put a hex on him. And he determined, I know it's very strange to hear this, he determined to murder the monks.

And every morning, five of them used to go and chant together. And he went up and picked up a chair, it seems, and hit the first monk on the head, broke his nose, it seems. And by that time, of course, the other monks had woken up and were able to stop him. He eventually went and stayed with Venerable Pema Siri for some time. It's interesting that the police weren't called in or any attempt to disrobe him or anything like that. He went to live with somebody whom he did respect, Venerable Pema Siri, and eventually went off to monastery and nobody ever heard of him, or I never heard of him again since.

So that's what happens in the extreme where you don't want it. But as I say, generally speaking, everything is done on an understanding of everybody has an influence on who is going to be the abbot. And the abbot in Theravāda Buddhism is the central figure of the institution they are independent monasteries and once a monastery begins to fail there's not much effort to try and save it, it's presumed that there's you know it's time for it fail and that's the end of it or disappear.

In harmony the assembly in harmony, self-respect of elders so the next one is as long as the Vajjis honour respect and esteem and venerate the Vajji elders so I suppose we could translate this into our experts like the economists. Have we do we honour respect and esteem and venerate economists and all these other people who are supposed to be experts so that's something we can contemplate.

As long as the Vajjis do not abduct women and girls from their families and force them to live with them. That's an interesting piece there. I don't know what was going on at the time, but obviously there was an abuse of women and girls, which of course won't come as a surprise in a patriarchal society.

As long as the Vajjis honour respect and esteem and venerate their traditional shrines so these are honouring the gods really and that's interesting the Buddha didn't denounce other people's beliefs or anything. I remember well there's one occasion when somebody comes to the Buddha and says you know your followers they're still offering making offerings at different shrines and he says, he says, there's no harm in it. So, you know, just let them do it. It's not a problem.

So what would be our traditional shrines, I wonder, in a society which is very multi-cultural, multi-religious? I mean, we still have churches and gurdwaras, mosques, temples, mosques. But I suppose if we were talking about the UK as a whole, it would have to be the established church and the Archbishop of Canterbury. Other countries, of course, have completely eliminated the church from any doings within the politics or running of the country. But here there's a tenuous hold. In others, of course, it's much stronger. Those of you from other parts of Europe will know, will be able to relate to that. But as soon as you start losing respect for these people, then in a sense, you're into secularism, really. I mean, you know, because this relates to religion, you see.

And the last one, too, he's talking about Arahats. He's talking about people who you honour for one reason or another as being good human beings. We could extend it to that and that they are honoured.

So those are the seven principles that the Buddha thought would stop the Licchavis from decline and being attacked. And of course, they were unfortunate in letting this Vasakāra in. And before they knew it, they became vassals of the king of Magadha, the dreadful Ajātasattu.

So I was just thinking maybe some of you also had some reflections. I'd be happy to receive them and bring them up tomorrow.

The scriptures have the Buddhist time have you know obviously certain pointers for us but it's a very different society in many ways but even so the basic principles remain the same you know harmony and he's big on harmony and that's what that's what we have to work towards.

So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance that they have not caused even greater confusion and that you will consider or continue to practice for even greater wisdom.

So it's time to do a little bit of sitting.

The Six Sense Bases — Saḷāyatana Vibhaṅga Sutta (MN 137)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

In this illuminating talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma guides us through the Saḷāyatana Vibhaṅga Sutta (MN 137), the Buddha's exposition of the sixfold sense bases. Drawing on the Buddha's post-awakening insights into paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination), he explains how our six senses operate as separate dimensions that don't intermix—we cannot see through our ears or hear through our eyes.

The talk deconstructs our experience into its component parts: the six internal bases (eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, mind), the six external bases (forms, sounds, odors, flavors, tangibles, mind-objects), and the six classes of consciousness. Bhante explains how contact (phassa) occurs when these three elements come together, and how this leads to the eighteen kinds of mental exploration based on vedanā—our affective responses of joy, grief, or equanimity.

Using accessible analogies like a mechanic deconstructing an engine, Bhante shows how the Buddha's approach reveals the rapid succession of consciousnesses that create our illusion of continuous selfhood. He clarifies that consciousness is merely a 'screen' upon which experiences manifest, while true awareness—the Buddha nature within—remains the unattached observer. This foundational understanding is essential for comprehending how we construct suffering and how liberation becomes possible.

Good evening, everybody. I hope you've had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed noble and fully self-awakened one.

So we've trudged our way through the taints, the disgusting oozings, and then we looked at society, and each of us came to conclusion whether we're heading towards doom or whether we're at the great turning point. So I thought we'd move on to the psychology of the Buddha around dependent origination.

Remember, after he was fully liberated on that night, he then spent seven days according to the tradition—he spent seven days in bliss, really just enjoying the ecstasy of being liberated from all suffering. Those of you who know Ajahn Mahā Boowa, very famous monk in Thailand who declared himself to be fully liberated—you can see him on YouTube talking about that moment. And he begins to cry, just the joy of that liberation. Of course, everybody then said, how could it be an *arahant* if he's crying? And he gave a rather strong riposte to that.

So after that blissful seven days, he then spent the first part of the night, I think it was a night, going through what became known as dependent origination. In other words, the whole process whereby we create suffering for ourselves. And then on the second quarter or whatever, he went the other way, understanding how we can bring it to an end. And then finally, he made sure he got it right by going both ways up and down.

And remember that the Buddha's technique is always to deconstruct everything. But having deconstructed our experience, then he shows how it comes together, how it actually works to give us the impression of an entity, of a one being, of a me, of a self, of a soul, call it what you wish. Just like a good mechanic can pull a car apart and then an engine apart and then put it together again.

Actually, when I was thinking about this, it reminded me of an occasion in my childhood. I had a cousin who was extremely good at engineering and especially doing things like that. And seemingly as a child, 10, 11 or something, he pulled this watch apart and put it all together again. Well, I wasn't going to be outdone with that. I found myself in the kitchen and I took the clock off the cooker and very cleverly took it apart. But for the life of me, I couldn't get it quite back together again. However, I didn't really understand why my mother was so angry, because it had lost its alarm. Anyway, that's the way it was.

So what I'm going to start with is the *Salāyatana Vibhaṅga*, or the exposition of the sixfold base. Now, Bhikkhu Bodhi has translated this as the sixfold base. *Āyatana* is a sphere. It's a dimension. And so one of the qualities of our six senses is that they don't mix into each other. You can't for the life of you smell through your ears and you can't see through your nose. And they are separate experiences of life. So we have vision, we have hearing—these are two very different qualities, very different capabilities, and they don't mix.

Now remember that in Buddhist psychology, consciousnesses are arising at a rapid rate depending on where the attention moves or what's calling the attention. So even now as I'm looking at this little gadget and hopefully you can see me looking at you

rather than away from you, I'm also hearing what I'm saying and thinking what I'm saying. All this comes together as one person looking, seeing, thinking. But in Buddhist psychology, the millions—thousands—of little consciousnesses that run so rapidly together give us the impression of continuity. And that, of course, gives us also an impression of solidity. So what is continuous has the feel of always being here in a total congealed way. And that's basically our delusion.

So just before we go into it, remember that when you read the discourses, there's only two things that the Buddha really is interested in, and that's ethics and transcendence. The transcendence he points to—I think he has 250 ways of pointing to *Nibbāna*. None of them actually hit the nail on the head, because the definition is beyond the psychophysical world, and therefore is indescribable. And somehow we make a mistake.

So once we understand that this nirvanic element is actually this very awareness, this Buddha, the one who knows within us, then we understand that something's gone wrong with its relationship to this psychophysical organism. Now, at what point does it actually associate with or identify with this organism? It's at the point of consciousness. And at that point of consciousness, what we discover as meditators, when we come back out of the involvement with the senses, with the emotions, with the thought, is that we discover ourselves, and it is a discovery of being the observer—the unattached observer, the equanimous observer, the equanimous feeler, the one who knows, the one who's experiencing. And yet that sense of self that comes with it is a mirror image on that very same consciousness. And so there's your first relationship. And it's through that relationship that you enter into the world of the mind.

So he's very keen on getting us to, first of all, understand from a backwards point of view, starting at the base, how we build up the world. And this is what this sixfold base discourse is trying to do.

So I shall read the passage. "Thus have I heard. On one occasion, the Blessed One was living at Sāvattthī in Jeta's Grove, Anāthapiṇḍika's Park." So we've come across this monastery before. It was definitely, I think, his favorite.

"And there he addressed the bhikkhus thus: 'Bhikkhus!' 'Venerable Sir,' they replied. And the Blessed One said, 'Bhikkhus, I shall teach you an exposition of the sixfold base. Listen and attend closely to what I shall say.' 'Yes, Venerable Sir,' the bhikkhus replied, and the Blessed One said this:

'The six internal bases should be understood. The six external bases should be understood. The six classes of consciousness should be understood. The six classes of contact should be understood. The eighteen kinds of mental exploration should be under-

stood. The thirty-six positions of beings should be understood. Therein, by depending on this, abandon that. There are three foundations of mindfulness that the noble one cultivates, cultivating which the noble one is a teacher fit to instruct a group. Among teachers of persons for training, he is called the incomparable leader of persons to be tamed. This is the summary of the exposition of the sixfold base."

Now, I think anybody reading that paragraph for the first time would probably suffer from a severe headache. There's so much presumption of knowledge in it that it really is a bit of a pain. So anyway, he now actually gives us an explanation.

"'The six internal bases should be understood.' So it was said, and with reference to what was this said? There are the eye base, the ear base, the nose base, the tongue base, the body base, and the mind base. So it was with reference to this that it is said the six internal bases should be understood."

In other words, the six senses. Now, we're quite aware of the senses—of the retina, for the eye, etc. Now, it's not as though the retina is—of course, the retina is the energy you can call it whatever it is, and it is that which leaves the body upon death. Now you don't have to believe that to understand this, but you have to understand that the mind is of a more subtle form than the material body.

At that point, the retina is, shall we say, the sensitive part. That's the internal sense base. But that's not what we actually know. What we actually experience is vision. It's the capability of seeing. So that's what he's talking about there. He's talking about the point where the mind touches the body and perceives form, light—well, we'll come to that in a minute. So it's the same with the ear—the sensitive part, whatever it's called, the drum or something. All that is actually sensitive to are the incoming waves of pressure from the air around. That's all. We're going to go into that a bit more deeply in a bit.

So here he is saying there are six of these internal bases. Now when it comes to the mind, there's nothing in the scriptures which tells you what the actual physical base of the mind is. And I was happy to read that even in the Abhidhamma, the later teaching, there was no base for the mind actually explained. But the commentaries felt that there was something missing here, so they came to the conclusion that there was a globule of blood in the heart—the *hadaya-vatthu*, the base of the heart—where the mind actually had its contact with the whole body.

Yes, it's been difficult to find this little globule of blood. And there was once an occasion when Sayadaw Pandita, who is in America—this is a story I heard—where they asked him, "Well, what happens in a transplant?" So the heart's taken out and the blood is put through a machine. So where is this *hadaya-vatthu*? Where is this base of the mind? So he had to say, "Well, it's in the machine."

So going back to the scriptures, the Buddha doesn't say that it has a base as such. And I personally just presume that it's the whole body. But it doesn't have to be, because the information coming from the five senses is enough for the mind to work out what's actually happening around it, what's actually coming into the mind from the outside.

So the next one is: "'The six external bases should be understood.' So it was said. With reference to what was this said? There are form base, sound base, odour base, flavour base, tangible base, mind-object base. So it was with reference to this that it was said the six external bases should be understood."

So for the eye to see something, there has to be something to be seen. And what is said to be seen on the actual eye base is just colour, which creates a certain sense of form. But everything else is actually done by the mind.

So at the ear, for instance, what is actually felt at the ear drum is only pressure. There is no sound. And it's taken into the mind, through the mind door, and it's there that it's understood as a sound. And from a sound, a meaning is given to it. And from a meaning, there's a reaction.

So when you hear the bell of an alarm, the only thing that actually strikes the ear is the pressure waves. And then everything else comes in. So first of all, there's a sound, and then you know it's a bell, and you know it's an alarm bell, and then you know you've got to get up. So you come out always at the end of that process. That's experiential, by the way.

And then on the third one, he says: "'The six classes of consciousness should be understood.' And with reference to what was this said? There are eye consciousness, ear consciousness, nose consciousness, tongue consciousness, body consciousness and mind consciousness. So it was with reference to this that it was said the six classes of consciousness should be understood."

So you have three components here for us to have an experience. The first, you have to have that sense base. You have to have some sort of object, and you have to have consciousness. So you can see if the sound waves come in—so there's your object, the bell.

The ear is what actually brings it into the mind, and it must manifest somewhere. The mind is doing all the work in terms of giving you the reason etc., and it manifests somewhere.

So this consciousness is just a screen upon which things happen, upon which things are known. And the delusion is to give that screen of consciousness the intelligence which actually belongs to the awareness, the intuitive awareness, the Buddha. Got it?

And this is, for those of you who know dependent origination, this is the moment of contact. So you've got the body and mind. There's your first split. There's your first separation. And then dependent on the body and mind, you've got these six sense bases. And depending on the six sense bases, you have contact. And at contact, you have to have the sense base, the object, and that screen of consciousness for it to manifest on.

So that hopefully clears up the first bit of that awful paragraph: the six external bases should be understood, the six internal bases should be understood, the six external bases should be understood, and the six classes of consciousness should be understood, and the six classes of contact should be understood.

"'The six classes of contact should be understood.' So it is said. With reference to what is this said? There is eye contact, ear contact, nose contact, tongue contact, body contact and mind contact. So it is with reference to this that it was said the six classes of contact should be understood."

So that's got us through the first section. Let's see what the time is. Yes, I might just do the next bit before we go on.

So then we talk about the eighteen kinds of mental exploration. "'The eighteen kinds of mental exploration should be understood.' So it was said, and with reference to what was this said? On seeing a form with the eye, one explores a form productive of joy, one explores a form productive of grief, one explores a form productive of equanimity. On hearing a sound, on smelling an odour with the nose, on tasting a flavour with the tongue, on touching a tangible with the body, on cognizing a mind object with the mind —" Remember, your mind objects are not only this stuff coming in, but your emotions and your thought life, your imaginative life. All that must appear upon the mind base, the mind consciousness.

"One explores the mind object productive of joy, one explores the mind object productive of grief, and one explores the mind object productive of equanimity. Thus there are six kinds of exploration with joy, six kinds of exploration with grief, and six kinds of exploration with equanimity. So it was with reference to this that it was said the eighteen kinds of mental exploration should be understood."

So we've slightly moved off the sense base here to an internal reaction. And that reaction is learnt by us. So even as little babies, we know what is painful and what is not painful. What makes us happy and what doesn't? We're very quick to cry when we get upset, when we're not getting enough milk, and we're very quick to smile, at least after a couple of weeks or something, when we feel happy. And other times, we're very peaceful. That's if you're a good baby.

So here there's a point where we have this reaction. And although we use the words joy and grief, of course, it refers back to pleasant and unpleasant. And this takes us to the next step in the dependent origination, which is *vedanā*.

So *vedanā* is an understanding of what we're experiencing as either pleasant or unpleasant. I said reaction—that's not quite the right word. It's an interpretation of what we're experiencing from an affective point of view. In other words, how we feel about it.

So this is about recognizing that whenever we hear something, see something, eat something etc., it's always going to produce a mental state—a mental state which is either in some level of joy even if it's only a little, some level of grief even if it's only a little, and sometimes just an equanimous level which is normally experienced when we have something neutral, when there's just a neutral feeling.

So for instance, even now your tongue—because there's no specific taste on it, it's not producing any particular emotional reaction. We don't have a feel about it. It doesn't feel either unpleasant or pleasant. So that's what the meaning is here.

So I think that's enough for one night, what do you think? So I think we shall come back to this exposition, and hopefully by the end of it we'll know something about the six sense bases in the way that the Buddha wanted us to understand them.

So we can now cool ourselves with a bit of meditation.

The Sense Bases Continued: The Thirty-Six Positions of Beings

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 25 min

In this continuation of his exploration of the Saḷāyatana Vibhaṅga Sutta (the Exposition of the Sixfold Sense Base), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the thirty-six positions of beings - how our six sense experiences are categorized as pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral, and further divided between worldly attachment and spiritual renunciation.

The teaching delves into how contact (phassa) through the six sense bases leads to different emotional responses: joy, grief, and equanimity. Bhante distinguishes between responses rooted in sensual attachment - where we seek happiness through worldly experiences - and those arising from renunciation, where we find joy in letting go of dependency. He explains how even spiritual longing, while wholesome, remains a form of unsatisfactoriness until complete liberation is achieved.

This analysis of the mechanics of experience offers practical insight into how attachment forms and how vipassanā practice reveals the impermanence underlying all sensory contact, leading to true equanimity that transcends rather than ignores the changing nature of phenomena.

Good evening. I trust you've had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed noble and fully self-awakened one.

So apologies for yesterday evening. The upload was down. That's what happened. But I'm sure now that your habit is well established and that you carried on and continued and did your own *mettā* and compassion, all those reflections at the end of the sitting. I'm sure of it.

Before I go back to that discourse, tomorrow I begin this course for people. It has a combination of *vipassanā* and *mettā* goodwill exercises on body care and Brian Lester will do the reiki. Now if you want to jot the times, I'll try and put them on the front page actually but the times for the YouTube: at eight o'clock in the morning, and I'll be doing my usual opening process of taking refuges and precepts, standing meditation, sitting

meditation. At two o'clock in the afternoon I might give, depending on how I moved, I might give a small introductory talk and then we'll sit again. And then at six o'clock in the evening Brian will be on this same channel going through the reiki, and we're back here at eight o'clock as usual in the evening.

The talks will be based around what the retreat is. So the first one is about goodwill. The second, only short talks. The second one is around the body and the third one, bringing your practice into daily life because that's what we have to do. So that starts tomorrow morning at eight o'clock, same channel, and same face, me, and that'll be it. I think that's the announcement I have to make, yes.

Okay, so we're back on the old Saḷāyatana-vibhaṅga Sutta, which translates as the exposition of the sixfold sense base. Now, what the Buddha is trying to show us all the time is how we build up the world that we are experiencing. He starts off by pointing out that everything that we experience comes up upon a particular base, a particular consciousness, a moment of consciousness, which remember is a mirror. And it's always coming from the sense bases.

So you've got your five basic bases, the five sense bases that we normally associate with consciousness and the mind base which records what's coming in from the other five senses and from the mind-heart itself—emotions, moods, imaginings, thoughts. They all must appear on that screen of consciousness so that moment is called contact. And that's what we went through yesterday: the six internal bases.

So the eye base—that's the word for it—ear base, et cetera. And then there's something that has to appear. So that's your sound base and odor base, flavor base, tangible base, and mind object base, the emotions, thoughts, and all that. And then there are these six classes of consciousness. When these three come together—a sense base, an object and consciousness—then you have what the Buddha calls contact, *phassa*. So that's on your dependent origination. Remember dependent origination starts off with the body and mind as a separation between our physicality and our mentality, psycho-physical organism. And then in that organism there are these six sense bases.

And because of consciousness, we get this contact. Now, when it came to the contact, there's the next point where we define what we're actually experiencing as either pleasant, unpleasant or simply neutral. And here the words used have been translated as joy, grief and equanimity. This equanimity here just means neutral—it's not the virtue of equanimity. It's basically the same word *upekkhā*. And so he says that seeing a form with the eye, one explores the form productive of joy. One explores the form productive of grief. One explores the form productive of equanimity.

So now this exploration, remember, is *vipassanā*. In other words, seeing the process is the process of exploration. You're not trying to change anything at this stage because this is all given. As soon as you place your eye on something—such now I'm placing my eye on the table that this camera is set on—I can't stop my eye seeing that table in the way it sees it. So if I'm colorblind, I'll see perhaps a different table, a different color from other people. And I can't stop that. And as soon as I see a table, I've already had, through all the tables in my life, a relationship with the table. So normally speaking, it's fairly neutral. But if I see, for instance, a flower, a rose or something like that, then because of my past experience, I'll see it as pleasant. And the same with unpleasant objects. So that's a given.

So those are six. Now, having said that, so there are six kinds of, there are six sense bases, six consciousnesses. And when you multiply the six by whether they're pleasant, unpleasant or neutral, then you get the eighteen. Remember, we've got numbers to explain here. And the next one is the thirty-six positions of beings should be understood. Now with reference to what was this said: there are six kinds of joy based on the household life and six kinds of joy based on renunciation.

Now a household life—really a better translation would be the sensual life, a life based on seeking happiness in the sensual world. He tends to have a downer on the householder, which he says the household life is dusty. But basically what he's trying to make a distinction between are people who are devoted to trying to find happiness in the sensual world and those people who are beginning to renounce that. That doesn't mean, remember, that you don't keep on enjoying things. It just undermines the indulgence, the dependency on other things, on other people for our happiness. Now of course a householder could also be a renunciate, which I'm sure refers to all of you as spiritual athletes.

So there are six kinds of grief for the householder life, six kinds of joy and six kinds of equanimity. You've got in the householder life those people who have joy when they experience things, who have unhappiness when they experience things and who experience a neutral mental state, which here is translated by equanimity. It's a bit confusing that. So you could say in other words that those who are devoted to the sensual life are just going to keep being reborn. And this is what we mean by *samsāra*—it is driven by the desire to seek happiness in whatever form in the human realm. And those who are renunciates are really trying to escape that to a different level of being.

So there are six kinds of joy based on the household life. The six kinds are, of course, based on the six senses. When one regards as an acquisition, the acquisition of forms cognizable by the eye that are wished for, desired, agreeable, gratifying, and associated

with worldliness—now, that's the word I was looking for actually, worldly—and when one recalls what was formerly acquired, that has passed, ceased and changed, joy arises. Such joy is called the joy based on the sensual or as he would have it, the household life.

Now, one regards as an acquisition the acquisition of forms cognizable by the eye. That's a double take. In other words, one becomes attached to what one acquires or what one experiences through the eye, the nose, etc. And then, of course, we have happy memories too. So we not only enjoy, for instance, a good meal now for the purpose of just indulging it or just enjoying it. And when we think of all these wonderful meals we've had, holidays we've had, romantic affairs we've had, all that, when we think about them, they bring up a happy state of mind. Or as he would have it here, joy. And this is true for things that we've heard, things that we've smelled, things that we've tasted and so on and so forth. This is called the joy based on the sensual or the household life.

Now, what are the six kinds of joy based on renunciation? So this is the spiritual life. When by knowing the impermanence, change, fading away and cessation of forms one sees that is actually is with proper wisdom that forms both formerly and now are all impermanent, suffering and subject to change, joy arises. Such joy is called the joy of renunciation.

Now that at first seems a little bit much. Renouncing something is supposed to bring us joy? But remember, we're not renouncing the normal joys, the normal enjoyments of life, we're renouncing this attachment. Now, for me, the great example is eating. When we eat, we not only eat to nourish the body, we eat in order to make ourselves happy often. Now that's something that we are, should we say, becoming dependent on food for. So that's often why we find ourselves taking biscuits and having a bit of cake and doing this and doing that. And it's simply there only to make us feel comforted or happy. But that creates a dependency.

So when the coffee's not there and the tea's not there and so forth, there's a feeling of panic. So that's caused through dependency. That's what we mean by attachment. Now, letting go of that can be a relief. And one thing I try to stress when I'm teaching is if you've got a real desire for something, which you know you shouldn't have—so too much food or something in this case—just stay with that feeling of desire and explore it, by which we mean experience it as a feeling. Desire arises from out of a state of dissatisfaction and is itself a state of dissatisfaction. That's why we want it gratified.

So it's a case of staying with that feeling of the desire of wanting, wanting, wanting, and really staying with it till it actually completely ends. And when it completely ends, you'll get the present. I think I've said it before with the taints, the *āsavas*. You'll get the present for it. And what it'll be is that sense of release because these wrong desires are like chains around us. And once the chain drops off you just feel that sense of liberation. That's what we mean by liberation in terms of nirvana is liberating ourselves from wrong desires and then joy arises and that's the joy of renunciation. Try it.

So then he goes through the six bases again, the six senses, each of them by knowing impermanence, change, fading away, the cessation of forms, one sees that it actually is the proper wisdom that forms both formerly and now are all impermanent, suffering and subject to change.

So then he goes on to the six kinds of grief of the sensual or household life. And one regards as a non-acquisition the non-acquisition of forms cognizable by the eye that are wished for, desired, agreeable, gratifying and associated with worldliness. But when one recalls what was formerly not acquired, that has passed, ceased and changed, grief arises. Such grief as this is called the grief based on the household life.

Now, again, that double negative is very confusing. When one regards as a non-acquisition, the non-acquisition of forms. So in other words, when you don't get what you want. So the non-acquisition of forms, in other words, you wanted to see something like the latest movie or something, and you couldn't get to it. So it was denied you. So all the cinema didn't show it or it wasn't on the video, it wasn't on some platform or other. So this brings about a sense of grief, disappointment, a sense of loss—whatever you want, which you can't get, is going to make you frustrated and so on. And then he goes on, of course, then he takes that through the six senses.

Now, what are the six kinds of grief based on the renunciation? When by knowing the impermanence, change, fading away and cessation of forms one sees that is actually is with proper wisdom that forms both formerly and now are all impermanent, suffering subject to change and one generates a longing for the supreme liberations thus. When shall I enter upon and abide in the base—the base, you might say the sphere—that the noble ones now enter upon and abiding in? One who generates thus a longing for the supreme liberation, grief arises with that longing as condition. Such grief is called grief based on renunciation.

So now having given something up one longs for something better and that longing is not quite the same as desire. It's very wholesome. It motivates you to move towards what you feel you really want. It gives us a sense of urgency, a sense of real commitment to what we want. And of course, because we're not satisfied yet, until we become

fully liberated, that longing is never entirely fulfilled. So even though it's a great motivation in us to move towards what we really want, which is going to be wholesome and in this case completely liberating from suffering, it is itself a state of unsatisfactoriness. And that's one of the griefs—it's a big word, that is a bit too strong—for what happens when you start giving up all the indulgences and bring yourself onto the path.

And we'll do that when we see that there is a real possibility of an end to all suffering. And when you're sitting and you sit with a desire, for instance, and it really does come to an end. And you sit with something which is horrible and terrible, and it does come to an end. You're actually experiencing the fact that things come to an end. And by doing that and doing it often and realizing that it has an effect on your habits, that your habits actually do have less and less power to overcome you, then you see the possibility that in fact there can be an end to suffering. That's not to be confused with the ordinary pains of the body—I mean that's once you've got a body you've got pain, that's just the way it is. So that's what happens when you give up. You get this sense of longing for something better, in this case longing for liberation. And then of course it goes through all the six senses here.

In what are the six kinds of equanimity—so again I think the word better thing is neutral or indifference—based on the household life. On seeing a form with the eye, equanimity arises or neutralness in a foolish, infatuated, ordinary person. He doesn't like ordinary people. Ordinary people infatuated. In an untaught, ordinary person who has not conquered his limitations or conquered the results of karma and who is blind to danger. Such equanimity as this does not transcend the form. That is why it is called equanimity based on the household life.

So seeing something with the eye, something which somebody who had a bit of wisdom would be disturbed by, and they're not fazed. So here we have an untaught ordinary person not conquered by his limitations. So according to the commentary, that means defilements. So he's just not fazed by somebody, for instance, who might be at ease with cruelty, soft cruelty like sarcasm and whatnot. He's not fazed when he sees somebody being humiliated. And therefore he's blind to the danger of the anger that such behavior can cause. Such equanimity as this does not transcend the form. So it keeps you locked into. And so it's true with other things that we hear or feel, etc.

And then of course there's the six senses, the six kinds of equanimity based on renunciation. When by knowing the impermanence, change, fading away and cessation of forms—that's your basic approach—knowing the impermanence, change, fading away and cessation of forms, one sees that it actually is with proper wisdom that forms

both formerly and now are all impermanent, suffering and subject to change. Equanimity arises. Such equanimity as this transcends the form. That is why it's called equanimity of renunciation.

So that equanimity is one of acceptance, like this is the way it is. So you're not ruffled when things go wrong and we're not incredibly excited when things go right. And that's the equanimity that comes when we understand that things are in the process, that things always change. You can't rely on anything and nothing is reliable. And that brings about a certain attitude to life. Here, equanimity is, I think, the right word.

One that arises from just seeing things as they really are, that sort of acceptance — this is the way it is.

So it was with reference to this that it was said the thirty-six positions of beings should be understood. So those are your six senses, which have three affective values — joy, grief, or pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral — and that is again split into two: those that are associated with the life of the senses, seeking happiness in the sensual world, something that you've got to hold on to, creating attachment and dependency; and those that arise because we're letting go of the world as somewhere where we can find permanent happiness or even comfort and seeking it elsewhere.

So I think that brings us to the end for this evening. We'll stop there.

Now, tomorrow, because of this course, the short talk will be on goodwill. And then on the Saturday evening, it'll be about the body. And then on — hold on, Saturday evening, it'll be about goodwill. That's tomorrow. Sunday evening, about the body. And on Monday, practising in daily life.

So I hope you take advantage of a little bit of extra meditation over the weekend. If you're on your own, then turn it into a little mini retreat for yourself.

So it's time for us to do a little bit of meditation.

Mettā, Forgiveness and Determination Practice

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 51 min

Bhante Bodhidhamma leads a comprehensive guided practice session that weaves together three essential aspects of spiritual development: mettā (loving-kindness), forgiveness, and determination. The talk begins by explaining mettā as an attitude of goodwill rather than mere emotion, emphasizing its role in re-engaging with the world after vipassanā practice to prevent equanimity from corrupting into indifference.

The guided mettā practice follows the traditional progression from benefactors to loved ones, friends, neutral people, oneself, and difficult people, expanding outward to include all beings in the six directions. Bhante explains the traditional blessings: "May you be safe, well and happy. May you live contented in harmony with the world."

The forgiveness section addresses three areas: asking for forgiveness from those we've harmed, forgiving others who have hurt us, and forgiving ourselves. This is grounded in the Buddha's teachings on paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination) and karma, showing how our harmful actions arise from ignorance rather than inherent badness, and how meditation leads us from delusion to wisdom, from harm to purity.

The determination practice uses a four-step formula: "I can, I ought to, I want to, I will" to strengthen resolve in abandoning unwholesome traits and cultivating virtue. The session concludes with extended mettā phrases addressing the three unwholesome roots and cultivating their opposites, ending with the traditional Pali blessing "Sabhe sattā sukhitā hontu" (May all beings be happy).

So good afternoon everybody. I hope you're ready to do a little bit of that *mettā* practice. If you get yourself into a good meditational posture, I'll go through an explanation and then we'll do the exercise. The exercise includes after *mettā* the forgiveness exercise and then how to develop our sense of determination.

By the way, this morning, those of you who opened your eyes and looked at the screen may have noticed that I was leaning to the left. I didn't used to. I think this is to do with some injury I have in the spine. I've got a prolapsed disc on one side, and I think that's what makes me do it. I'm not aware of it at all. See, just like the leaning tower of Pisa. I'm not aware I'm leaning.

So let's get ourselves into a comfortable posture. The usual thing – make sure the energy is running up the spine, lifting up from the lower back and the abdomen. Just a moment to relax the brow, jaw, the shoulders.

So let me explain a few things about *mettā* before we actually do the practice. Remember that when we are practicing *vipassanā*, the quality that we want to develop is equanimity. So there's no specific effort to develop goodwill or compassion or joy. In a sense, that's all presumed. We wouldn't be doing it were it not that we care for ourselves. But when we finish the *vipassanā* and come out into the world, that equanimity can stay with us and can begin to corrupt into what's known as its more subtle enemy of indifference. We might feel we're not engaging. People might feel that we are indifferent. And so the way we overcome that is by practicing *mettā*. That re-engages us.

Now *mettā* is the basic relationship that the Buddha put to us that we should have towards all beings. So sometimes it's translated as an affective feeling of loving kindness, but I much prefer an attitudinal way of looking at it. In other words, goodwill. It's just goodwill.

Now when you've established a good relationship of goodwill with everybody – I mean it's easy to do with friends, obviously – you can see that if a friend or a family member or whatever falls into misfortune, there's just a natural desire to help. And if they have good fortune, then of course you're happy for them. So compassion and empathetic joy arise quite naturally from that base of goodwill.

Now when we talk about it being non-attached – in the old books you might read detached, which sounded a very cold sort of love or goodwill. Now they use this non-dual term, neither attached nor detached, but non-attached. But I think we can say, simply, universal. It rises above whether we like somebody or not, or whether they like us or not. So it's rising above personality to the humanity within us. And of course, this can be extended to any living being, all animals.

Now, it's not an emotion per se, but an attitude, as I say. So don't worry if you don't feel loving – it's still working because these intentions are creating a habit. From an intention you get an action, an action of thought in this case, which comes out of goodwill, and from that you get a habit. So don't worry about whether you feel like practicing *mettā* or not. The heart may respond. You might have lovely warm feelings and there's no problem with that at all. And in fact, you might encourage the heart by sending warm feelings from the heart to the various subjects that we bring to mind. So just practice anyway.

So the practice – we go through the various categories, as you'll see. First particular and then more universal. And when we get to all beings, we'll do it in the six directions. All beings before us, behind us, left, right, above and below.

Now, the traditional blessings, if you wish to use them – and of course, you can always make up your own – but the traditional blessings are: may you be safe, well and happy. Everybody wants to be safe. Everybody wants good health. And of course, everybody wants to be free of mental distress. So may you be safe, well and happy. And to have a certain ease about living. So to live contented and in harmony with the world, even when the world is not such a pleasant place for us. So may you be safe, well and happy, live contented in harmony with the world.

So let's begin by bringing to mind someone who's been a benefactor for us, someone who's helped us in our lives. And as you picture that person in your mind's eye, just direct your goodwill towards them. May you be safe, well and happy. May you live contented in harmony with the world.

We can bring to mind someone who is near and dear to us, or more than one person – it doesn't matter. And again, as you picture them in your mind's eye, just direct your goodwill towards them.

You can bring to mind a friend. Even an acquaintance.

Now there's a category of a neutral person. So if you think about it, many days in our lives, we see many tens of people whom we don't know. These are all neutral people. Can you think of somebody whom you see quite often when you travel, maybe at work, down the street, a neighbour, but you don't know them? Offer them the same quality of goodwill.

Turning now that stream of goodwill towards ourselves. Now, if you find that's difficult, if you're suffering a little bit from self-aversion, just put that to the side. So we're not suppressing it. We know it's there. When we suppress something, we do it with anger or with aversion or fear. But here we just acknowledge it, just putting it to the side, parking it. Sometimes it helps to put your hand over your heart and then just speak gently into your own heart. May I be safe, well and happy. May I live contented in harmony with the world.

Now it's at this point that we can bring somebody into the heart who we're having a hard time with. So obviously you don't have to go for the big one. Just make it somebody who you don't feel too bad about. And just as they slip into your mind, just hold them there for a second and at least offer them your goodwill.

Now we can open up more outwardly. If there are other people living with you in the house, then we bring them in now. For those who are living with close neighbours in flats or something, you can bring those people in. Whoever is around you, just bring them into your *mettā*, into your goodwill, and offer them your blessings.

And from there, just begin to widen out to include your neighbourhood, your village, your small town, just the wider area in which you live. And from there, radiating out to all the people in our country. And from there to all the peoples of Europe – if you happen to be in another continent, of course, to all the peoples of your continent. And from there to all people on earth.

So now we come to all beings in all directions. So here you can just think of it as infinite space and just send out your goodwill in all directions. I mean if you have a vivid imagination you might populate them, but I think it's enough just to send your goodwill into a sort of infinite space.

All beings before us. All beings behind us. All beings to our left. All beings to our right. All beings below us. All beings above us. And finally, to all beings in all directions.

Having developed our goodwill, we can move into the area of forgivingness, overcoming our grudges and our resentments. So there are three areas. There is asking for forgiveness, forgiving others and forgiving ourselves.

So beginning with asking for forgiveness. Can we bring to mind someone whom we've hurt? And again, we don't have to go for the big one. This is an exercise which we can extend in the fullness of time. If you can bring to mind somebody whom you've hurt in some way, a sharp word or whatever. Now, as they come to mind, you'll find you have a memory of an event or the person themselves, and the attitude will come of hurting them and you may find there's still justifying yourself, or you might find some guilt or some shame or a desire to be reconciled, remorse. So it's a case of using this image, this event, to contact those feelings and to really allow them to express themselves.

Now you have to be very careful not to let this image or this memory suddenly draw you into a fantasy, in which case, of course, it will be developing one of these attitudes. So be careful of that. You have to hold the event, hold the person in your mind, and as it were, look into your heart and just see if you can feel what your reaction is. Is there still some justification there? Is there still guilt or shame, sense of remorse? And just stay with it. Just let the heart express itself.

Someone whom we hurt. Can we see how we've hurt ourselves? How these mental states are unwholesome, unskillful, knowing that they will just create more suffering? We undermine them by seeking reconciliation. So again, we bring that person to mind and talk to them and bring yourself round to apologising, to make amends. Perhaps you can see in them a desire to be reconciled, holding out a hand of friendship. Can you take it? Allowing the love back in. And let's offer them our good wishes. Allowing them to fade away.

Well, you can see here the two purposes for such an exercise. First of all, it's a process of healing the heart. It's also just like we go for an interview for a job. You're preparing yourself for that interview. And even though the interview is nothing like the way you would imagine it, what you have done is prepared yourself and entered the room with a certain confidence. So it is with these exercises. It makes it more easy for us to ask for forgiveness.

Turning now to somebody who's hurt us. So again don't feel you have to go for the big one. And as that person comes to mind there'll be an event or there might be a history, and of course we'll have hurt, and we tend not to want to feel the hurt. It's humiliating, after all. We prefer to be angry and to seek revenge. So these are the two qualities, these are the two reactions which we are getting in touch with when we bring somebody to mind who's hurt us. So again, be careful not to let the mind wander off into a fantasy. Just hold the image fairly still and just feel. Allow the heart to express its turbulences. Open up to the hurt with affectionate awareness.

Someone who's hurt us. Can we accept that these feelings, these mental states have been produced by us, not the other person? We're the ones who reacted with hurt. We're the ones who are seeking revenge. And we accept that these are unwholesome states, unskillful, just making us suffer. So the antidote, of course, is to forgive. So we bring this person to mind and have a conversation with them. Just tell them how much you were hurt, etc. How you do not intend to seek revenge and all that. And finally tell them that you forgive them.

Perhaps you can see in them a desire to be reconciled. And they also want to make friends, make amends. Can you hold out a hand of friendship to them? Can you wish them well? And again, allowing that image to fade away.

Turning to ourselves and the harm that we might have done ourselves physically, mentally. So there are two contemplations which help us here. The first is dependent origination, the psychology the Buddha teaches, and a teaching on *kamma*.

Understanding dependent origination means that we understand that we have started from a position of not knowing and we make a mistake, and this mistake leads us to have wrong attitude, wrong understandings, and through the practice of meditation these are corrected and we end up with wisdom. From the heart's point of view, we're never meant to do any harm. We begin from a place of innocence, but because of these wrong understandings we do harm, and that's the suffering that we have within us and the pain that we cause others. And through the process of meditation we allow the heart to heal itself and so we end up with purity.

So there's your two trajectories: from ignorance, from not knowing – it's not a culpable ignorance, we just didn't know – from a mistake, a delusion, through these misunderstandings we create attitudes, and then through the meditation, through insight, we begin to undo these knots and we become wise. From the heart's point of view we begin with innocence, but because of these wrong understandings we create harm to ourselves, to others, and through the process of meditation we allow the heart to heal itself and we end with purity. So we're on the back end of this. We're moving now very rapidly towards wisdom and purity.

Kamma is very simple. It's at an obvious base. When you do harm, harm comes of it. And when you do something that's wholesome, good, good comes to it. You can say that as a general rule. From our point of view, with this forgiveness, we have to understand that punishment, self-hatred, self-aversion, picking on ourselves are completely unnecessary. Whenever we do harm, all we have to do is bear the consequence. That's enough. That's the karmic consequence of what we've done. So we don't have to get into all this other stuff about hating ourselves and punishing ourselves or even, and of course, punishing others. So it really is all about receiving the consequences of unwholesome action.

So can we choose something that we've done to ourselves which has harmed us? It might be physical harm – we might take drugs or whatever. It might be emotional harm – we might have put things in our minds which have become obsessive. Just choose one of them.

Now can you open up to that? Can you receive it? Can you hold it with a sense of care, of loving kindness? And just allow it to manifest. Now you can also talk to your body. You can talk to your heart. You can speak gently into your heart. Sometimes if you have the time, you wait for the heart to completely express its emotional turbulence. It might be feeling sorry about any harm you've done to your body. You might be angry about the way you've behaved in the past and things like that.

So for the purpose of this exercise, it's a case of making a resolution that you won't behave like that again. To seal the past with the resolution. Now if it's a habit that we don't want and we keep falling into it, we have to recognize that sometimes one resolution won't do and we have to go through this many times until we disempower a habit we don't want. And offer ourselves some blessings.

So this brings to an end our practice of loving kindness. And we can move to just an exercise which helps us to develop determination. So there are four steps to this. First of all, I can. So I can resist temptation and I can develop virtue. Then we have to take on personal responsibility for this. I ought to, for my own benefit and the benefit of others. Sometimes you have to cajole, you have to encourage the heart. I want to, I want to. And finally, when the occasion arises, I will, I will resist that temptation. I will develop that virtue.

Can we bring to mind a trait within our characters, personalities, which we would be very happy to be rid of? And then just gently speaking – again, always speaking into the heart, you see. I can resist. I ought to for my own benefit and the benefit of others. I want to. And I will. Can, ought, want and will. Three times.

We can bring a virtue to mind that we'd like to develop more. So I can, I ought to, want to, and I will when the occasion arises. Three times.

Well, this brings to an end our little practices of developing determination. So we can end this now with a slightly different way of developing *mettā*, just repeating these phrases.

May I be free of greed and selfishness. May I be free of anger and ill will. May I be free of fear and anxiety. May I be free of ignorance and delusion. May I be kind and gentle, sympathetic and benevolent. May I be forgiving and compassionate. May I be joyful and rejoice in the success of others. May I be peace loving and calm. May I be liberated of all my sufferings. May I experience the bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Radiating this goodwill to all beings in all directions.

May all beings be free of greed and selfishness. May all beings be free of anger and ill will. May all beings be free of fear and anxiety. May all beings be free of ignorance and delusion. May all beings be kind and gentle, sympathetic and benevolent. May all beings be forgiving and compassionate. May all beings be joyful, and rejoice in the success of others. May all beings be peace loving and calm. May all beings be liberated of all their sufferings. May all beings experience the bliss of *Nibbāna*.

We can end our meditation with a little chant, which means may all beings be happy. *Sabhe sattā sukhitā hantu*, three times. *Sādhū*, which means well done, three times.

Sabhe sattā sukhitā hantu
Sabhe sattā sukhitā hantu
Sabhe sattā sukhitā hantu

Sādhū sādhū sādhū

Very good.

So it's up to you now to continue your practice. You could continue practicing this method all afternoon if you wish. Those of you who are officially on the course, we have a Zoom meeting at 4 o'clock. And at 6 o'clock, Brian will begin his Reiki class. And then we shall be back this evening at 8 o'clock for a little short talk and some meditation.

Until then, please keep practicing. Thank you.

Reiki with Bryan Lester

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 59 min

This unique session blends Reiki healing practices with Buddhist meditation, exploring the intersection of energy work and spiritual development. Bryan Lester, accompanied by Bhante Bodhidhamma, introduces practical techniques combining breath work (prāṇāyāma), visualization, and movement to cultivate healing energy.

The session opens with the traditional recitation of the Bojjhaṅga Sutta, the seven factors of awakening (sati, dhammavicaya, vīriya, pīti, passaddhi, samādhī, upekkhā), which historically served as a Buddhist healing practice. The Buddha himself used these teachings therapeutically, understanding words and sensory experiences as integral to our physiology rather than separate from it.

Key practices include breath sculpting posture, the Reiki shower visualization, and Joshin Kokyūhō (inner cleansing meditation). These techniques emphasize the cultivation of compassion and healing energy, integrating traditional Reiki hand positions with mindfulness of the body. The session demonstrates how ancient Buddhist wisdom complements modern energy healing approaches, offering practical tools for both physical wellbeing and spiritual development that can be integrated into daily life and formal meditation practice.

Good, it's lovely to be here anyway. I've been really looking forward to this because I'd like to share with you some techniques that I have. Techniques that I've been using and that I've found really quite life transforming for me. Mostly taken from Reiki, but also Qigong has been a big influence. So I did Qigong and Tai Chi for about 15 years before doing any Reiki. And also Pranayama is a feature as well of the work we're going to be doing today.

Good, I can hear you Sarah, so I'm assuming that sounds lovely. That's very encouraging. I've never thought I had a fantastic voice, but in the rush there I've lost the notes, but I do know what I'm going to say fortunately.

Reiki means universal or spiritual energy, and the particular frequency of energy that we draw on is the energy of compassion and healing. It's an energy that is very subtle. It requires practice. We all do it, actually. All parents do Reiki. Every time you comfort a child, you're doing Reiki. And it's like wellness. It's unspectacular. It isn't spectacular. It seems that only the bad things are spectacular. So it's very quiet, is very gentle thing, Reiki.

Somebody asked me last year how do I know when I have, when I can feel this energy, how do I know that it's working when trying to help somebody or themselves? And the answer I gave, I think that they found rather disappointing, I found it disappointing actually, because I said well, as soon as you feel a sense of caring for yourself or for that person.

Anyway, I've called this session "The Space Between." This is my own working title because of the situation we're in. So it's the space between the polarities defining that space and the space that defines the polarities. All right. So we'll be doing a lot of that sort of thing.

But before we start, as I said, the energy is one to do with healing. In Buddhism there is a tradition of healing, and the Buddha himself used healing. He healed people and he recited this to heal. So there was a very strong perception of words being part of one's physiology. It wasn't like a charm really, it was based upon the knowledge that words and all sensory things of which words are made, really sensory fragments that are constructed into metaphors of meaning, but they're not aside from the physiology, they're part of it. So they're coming from a place of knowledge.

The *bhōjjaṅgas* are the seven factors of enlightenment. I'm going to read these actually because I know I probably forget them, but the first of course is mindfulness, and the second one is investigation into truth, and the third one is energy. And then you have, after the energy, you have rapture and tranquility. And then the last two are concentration and equanimity. There you go. I've done it without having to refer to my list. I'm very chuffed with myself.

Now, in Reiki, there's a thing called *Reiju*, which is a blessing. I can talk about that more tomorrow when I talk about the history of Reiki. I don't want to talk about the history of Reiki much today, I want to get on with doing things. But it's basically a blessing, but in a way the first blessing that was ever used, certainly within the Buddhist tradition, was the Bojjhaṅga Sutta. And Bhante has recorded this for us, so he's going to bless us all.

The long, the short, and the tall. And if I can get, I've got an MP3 here. And what I want you to do is just to breathe and listen. You don't need to put your hands in *gasshō* or anything unless you feel you want to. But I'd like you to assimilate the words, just the sounds. There's stories in the sutta that tell of healing, and these seven factors also are mentioned, but if we can just drink in the sounds.

Samsāri samsarātanaṃ sabbadukkhavināsane sattadhamme ca bojjhaṅge marāsenā pamādane... [full chanting continues]

Thank you, Bhante.

With Reiki, we have three strands to the exercises. One is the breath, the other is the imagination, and the third is movement. Now, the movement, you can do virtual movement. It doesn't happen in too many exercises, but you do have movement in some. You can visualize the movement if it isn't possible for you to move. What I'm saying is that really you can do these exercises anywhere, even on a train. And I do this. I fully integrate these exercises into my life.

I'm a musician, so I practice the piano a lot. And when I'm not practicing the piano, I'm doing these sorts of things, the pranayama, Reiki, a few asanas. When I'm playing the piano, I do these sorts of things. In other words, I use an actual technique which applies these skills. They're not separate. And that's the exciting thing about them, because you're investigating all the time with these spiritual practices. And it's like being a child and wondering what you're going to discover next, because you do discover things. There may be very, very small insights, but a child only needs small insights to be delighted.

Now the first strand then is the breathing. So we're going to go straight into the breathing, and I suspect that most of you probably know how to do yogic breathing and it may vary from the technique I use. But what I use is the three-stage breath, so expanding the stomach and then expanding outward horizontally the chest. If you imagine it, if you think it rather than try to do anything, it will work better. And then a very slight, very, very slight lift at the end with the breath, not in a muscular way, you see.

And this brings me to what I want to offer. Whether it's any use to you, I don't know, but give it a try. And what I want to offer is the idea of breath sculpting the posture. When we think, oh, I'll pull myself up, and of course, the movements are all muscular. But if you think what pneumatic power can have on the body, it's considerably greater. And we pull ourselves up and we're breathing. We're probably breathing in the wrong way. So breath needs to be coordinated with action, you see. So the breath is sculpting the posture.

Now, there are things that happen anyway. With the in-breath, there are two things that have been discovered in research. And anatomists, some would argue about this, but the sutures of the skull, when you breathe in, they actually expand. This is what they've found with technology, that this happens in recent research. And I've researched this, and not all medics do describe the sutures as immovable joints. In fact, they actually say it would be unhealthy to have completely immovable joints, which makes sense to me. So they move on the in-breath.

And at the same time, the sacrum, the triangular bit at the bottom of the spine, slightly tilts back. And this is a wonderful thing. And on the out-breath, you have a more internal sort of activity going with the vagus nerve. So the tone of the vagus nerve increases. So the out-breath triggers the chill-out system, the parasympathetic. So at the end of the day, when you flop down in a chair, you're absolutely washed out. That's what you're doing.

You may know this anyway, but I'm just saying that the breath works with the body all the time in ways we're not really aware. We just think of this exchange of oxygen, carbon dioxide, but there's all kinds of things going on. It's amazing. I mean, the eyes, the cornea of the eye has no circulation. It only has the air. The epidermis of the skin, as I'm sure you know, there's no circulation there. It has the air around it. You see all these molecules of air, the sea of air. I like to think of it as, but I mean, that's my language. That's the language I like. But it's all right to think in purely physical terms, of course it is with all of this actually.

So it's tremendously important. Breathing is a living document of our reaction to the outside world. I do an exercise with fingers like this. I get distracted because there's a visual display. Like this, you see. You hold your hand up like this if you can be patient with me and try it. And you go one, two, three. I have to look away because I get distracted by the delay.

Right, so we've got a metric cycle of four there. We're going back to school. We're learning something. Now in this hand you do the same thing but you miss off the little finger, you go one, two, three. So this is your first exercise, we have to put them together at the same time and keep them going. Are you ready? After two I want you to get it wrong actually, and maybe I will get it wrong too, and that's okay, and you'll see why. Now watch yourself while you're doing it as well, I'm afraid you've got to do that too. Watch your breath.

One, two. So after 12 synchronized movements, we realized that the body understands arithmetic, but does your breath? Did you notice you were holding your breath? Did I? I mean, I can't see, but when I did it with a class, this was including Bhante, oh I loved it because everybody including, it was terrific, it was like a chorus line of breath holders, it was wonderful.

Why? It's counterproductive. If you have a problem, isolate the smallest part of that problem that you can and breathe out. Why, if it's to do with the body and coordination and doing a sequence of movements? The reason is that if you're stiff, if you lock your knees for instance and try to jump in there, you won't get anywhere at all, you see. You need to be supple, and the out breath is the way to do it.

So with sculpting, we've already got a head start with all the things that the breath does anyway. So we expand with the stomach, then we expand with the stomach. But as you expand, right, the stomach's expanding out just slightly, very slightly, even if you only think it without doing anything, tilt as though you've got a tail, still got a tail. You've devolved, with a tail like that. And then you will feel in the lumbar region a lovely sense of, it's a very wonderful sensual feeling, actually, of the curve of the spine.

And as the rib cage expands out, you'll feel it. But it isn't a stretching of the spine like that, you see. It would stretch how it needs to, how it wants to. And then the last bit, like a sniff. Yeah, not like that, like a sniff.

So the breath is breathing you. We don't breathe, the breath breathes us. This is the idea. So let's try a cycle, and when we get to the top, in, down, you let go, you see, down, coat hanger style, and then if it's comfortable, not if you've got any hernias or anything, but if it's comfortable, an abdominal, lower abdominal contraction. Gentle.

Not all teachers teach that, but quite a lot of yoga teachers do teach that. And I am talking about it now because it's crucial to the way up, this breath ends, you see. So just let's try getting that far. After two, so go one, two, expand, out, lift, in, let go, drop, coat hanger style and contract.

Now the words are good, you can use your own words if you like, but say you have expand, out, lift, in, drop, contract. Let's try it one more time. I have to do, one, two, expand, out, lift, in, drop, contract.

Now if you can, I wonder if you could stand up. I haven't got enough room here to organise the perspective that would be required for me to do this with you. I usually, I never teach like this. I'm one of these guys that walks around all the time. I don't know whether that irritates people or not, but it's just, I suppose, a way of directing nervous energy. I don't know. So I'm having to sit here. I've been super glued to a spot against my will.

So could you stand up? If you can stand up, if not, don't worry. You can do this lying down, but really standing up for this last bit, even if it's just for one breath to get the thing that I'm getting at, you see, is when you contract the lower abdominals or don't contract them. But at that point also do a buttocks clench.

It's a bit like a *mūlabandha* only it isn't, because with a *mūlabandha* you'll be raising your chest, but anyway do a buttocks clench. So if you're standing, you stand shoulder width apart, toes pointing forward, and don't fuss and worry about oh why should my toes be turning out or turning, don't worry about that.

What is important? You look, you watch animals, how they get their posture right. They go around in a circle until they've got exactly the right spot. I'm not suggesting you do that. But what I am suggesting is that you rock it. If you rock from one foot to another, do you get that feeling of rocking from one foot to another? You will find your comfort, your comfort zone within that little area. You get a sense of being anchored.

Now we're going to do that breath again and at the end clench your buttocks. So after two, one, two, expand, out, lift, in, drop, clench. Now hold it. You can carry on breathing if you like, but hold that clench.

Now what you'll notice is that all the muscles right down to the floor flex just slightly. And don't you feel rooted? I'm confident you do. I'm confident you all feel rooted. If you have a problem, I'm sorry, obviously you can't help that. Then you can sit down and think this.

So it's that sense of rootedness, and already you've got a wonderful social tool there because if you're in a group, you say you're in a group, you know that situation where you're in a group and you don't feel very confident, you don't feel like a very strong member of the group, a bit of an outsider maybe, always stand on two feet.

I mean this is just simple body language that most people know anyway, but I'm going to say it. Don't put your weight on one leg because what you're doing, the message that goes out is that you have a weakness. Now if you stand on two legs, on two feet, you will look confident. If you stand on two feet like this, you will look super confident, you see. You feel that no one can knock you over. They can, of course, but the point is you're giving out the right message. So it's good. It's good to feel confident. So if you've never done this before, then it would really please me if you find that a good thing to do, that you find it a useful thing and you're enjoying doing it.

Right? So relax now. Now we're going to change the focus of our attention a bit now. We're going to think, stay standing, and we're going to think about space between. I am going to read this because I don't quite know it from memory confidently. Relax into that posture. You don't need to keep your buttocks clenched, by the way.

Standing alone in stillness, one can observe every mystery present at every moment and ceaselessly continuing. This is the gateway to indescribable marvels." Lao Tzu. And it's used sometimes in describing a series of exercises in qigong called Zhan Zhuang, and you probably all know them because it's the holding the imaginary balls and that kind of thing. They're tremendous exercises. I've done a lot in the past and I've started revising them again actually recently.

But the one I love is the first. And that's what you do now. You're just standing. I love it. And you stand on a railway station and you miss your train. Great. That gives me a chance to practice the first one, which is called Wuji.

Now, we're not exactly going to practice Wuji, but what I want you to do is it's just inspired by Wuji because Wuji instructors of Zhan Zhuang would not, I don't think, ask you to do this. But I want you to do it because it's to do with polarities and it's to do with the space between. Now, just calmness.

Now, if you place your eyes just a few feet ahead on the floor, or just half close your eyes, you're making, by doing that, a physiological change. You're moving towards, by doing that, you're telling the brain that you're thinking of sleeping, basically towards an alpha state and then a theta state. So basically it's another way of relaxing and being receptive.

So lift your eyes and I want you to look at the wall in front of you. Put your attention on the wall in front of you. Nothing strenuous, just look at it. Now put your attention on your own body. In fact, I think you can do this with your eyes closed, probably. Just think of the wall in front of you. Now your own body. One more time. The wall. Your body.

Now the wall behind you. And your body. The wall behind. Now your body. Now the wall to the left. And your body. To the left and your body. To the right and your body. To the right and your body. The ceiling. If you're outside, just as high as you can think. And your body. The ceiling. And your body.

Now the earth, deep in the earth. And your body. Deep in the earth and your body. And now the whole room in your body, the space in the room. Sense the qi, the sea of qi. Well, we all know it's air molecules colliding. But some of us know that it's chi, the dance of chi. It's a dance. And I want you to imagine that you picked up a seashell. Imagine putting it to your ear. That is the amplification, of course, as you know, of the air molecules colliding. That is the amplification of the song of chi.

And now take a breath, a good breath, and sigh. Now with the sigh, if you open your mouth, it's approaching the Reiki breath. With the Reiki breath they don't talk about any of this stuff in Reiki, by the way. I haven't heard of it spoken of anyway, the pranayama, the classical yogic breath. But what they do do is specify breathing through the nose on the inhale and out through the mouth on the exhalation, but the tongue resting on the roof of the mouth on the inhale and dropping down just behind the bottom teeth on the exhalation.

So you can try that. Just try that for a bit. Just on your own. It's rather nice actually. Still trying to let the air scope to the body. Maybe I'm throwing a lot at you. I don't know. I mean, I know you will know a lot that I've spoken about, so it helps. And I suspect you've all done spiritual work before, and that counts for a lot in this because you don't need sort of visual aid, so to speak.

Now, if you want to, you can sit down just in front of your computer and I'm still here as you can see. I hope you could hear me okay. My voice was sufficiently clear for you whilst we were doing all that.

And what I want you to do now is just hold your hands like this. You hold your hands like this. In fact it might be a good idea before we start this to just give them a bit of rub, get a bit of heat going, a bit of heat. This is all very physical, you see. It's magic without magic. That's what it is. It's all in the physics. The friction creates the heat.

Now open your hands. Now you may know this one as well. You imagine you've got a ball in your hand. You've got a ball in your hand and play with it. Roll it around. Now let it get bigger. It's getting bigger. It's a bigger ball now. It's moving towards football status. Yeah. It's a great feeling. And now it's moving towards beach ball status. Yeah. There it goes.

Now just blow it away. Keep your hands here. Now I want you to think of these polarities. Left palm, right palm. Left palm, right palm. Carry on doing that. Don't do anything strenuously. You can make it move a bit, gradually faster, and you can feel energy moving between the two hands, and it's very palpable. If you don't, it doesn't matter. We're not into sensation. We're actually into investigation. Yeah, you might find something different.

Now raise the hands like this, just above the head, and carry on doing that. So left hand, right hand, or whichever way you want to think. All right. Now this is called the Reiki shower. Now I want you to take a good breath in, turn their hands so they're facing like that, and bring them down the body and imagine energy like rain. Imagine it dripping off every part of you, every nook and cranny, your elbows, your shoulders, the tip of your nose, right down. And then shake your hands. Yeah. And then come up again, turn your hands. And exhale as you go down. I forgot to say that. And imagine going down. And then up again. And down. Then up.

And always finish an exercise with gassho. It honours the skill. I knew a woman, she's a very high-flying pianist and academic in music, and her daughter, who's ridiculously talented, you know the kind. And when her daughter played the piano, she used to get her to sing a song to the piano to thank the piano afterwards. And it's wonderful.

I think it's a great idea, actually. It's showing respect and it's showing, here's a key, here's a buzzword, it's being used more and more in modern spiritual teaching, it's showing gratitude, which by some teachers is described as the emotional signature of receivership.

And there's one researcher, a guy called I think he's called Greg Braden. You probably know what I'm talking about, I'm quite remembered his name. There's research back to the apocryphal writing Saint Thomas, and apparently they practiced this thanking before receiving, you see. It's very powerful and it's to do with frequencies, it's to do with energy of course, but it's good anyway. It's a good feeling. It has rewards.

So there we have the Reiki shower. Now the use of this is terrific because, you know, when you've got a long day, I'm fortunate I can do more or less what I like now. I'm sort of retired, or not retired. I write a bit of music for the media and that kind of thing occasionally, but basically I don't have to turn for work in the morning because I'm a dinosaur, a retired dinosaur. Well, that would be the day. I don't want to retire at all. But I used to remember having several hours still today and I was absolutely worn out, and I used to do that. I'd do, when no one was looking at, just this is the other version of it where you don't bother with starting there but you scoop energy up, you see, up to the crown and then down. And even if you imagine yourself doing that, if you're low in energy, it works. It does work.

I don't like to think of you having to do it. I didn't like being like that. I still do get like that sometimes. I get tired, of course I do. But I've considerably more energy then, well, 20 years ago I had less energy than now. Why? Because I practice pranayama and these energy exercises.

Now I'm looking at the time, so that's one exercise. I'm just going to show you one other one quickly, and this is called Joshin Kokyū-hō, which is inner cleansing, and this is a terrific exercise. Well, I do some of these exercises walking around. You feel good. And there's two versions of this exercise. I'm going to give you the version that's in the pack. I'll be sending you a pack tonight. And I didn't want you to get it too early because I wanted you to digest what Bhante had sent you. But I'm going to send you this tonight. And there are two versions. I'll do the version that is in there. And then I'll talk about the other version.

You breathe in, draw energy in from the crown. Imagine doing that. Or if you find that difficult, you see, it's really to do with polarities. It's focusing on one point and then another point, and it can be more than one point, and then the energy will find its way. So basically you draw energy through the crown down to the hara or the dantian if you

know tai chi, using tai chi terminology. Just about an inch and a half below the navel. But don't think in a precise way like that. Think of your gut. You draw it down to your belly. You draw it down to your belly.

So draw the energy down or just think of your belly when you inhale, and before you exhale, just imagine it sort of spreading a little. And then as you exhale, out through every part of the skin system, every part of the surface of your body so that it's making a kind of oval balloon and you're inside that balloon.

Now this is used as a meditation actually. I don't use it as a meditation. I will use either, you know what I do with what Bhante does. I don't do a lot of meditation, but in a way all of these things are. And I think that if you're into *vipassanā*, which is wonderful, it's the king really of exercises really, this will help you help you with your posture and who knows maybe with your concentration. I don't know. But just try it. And so this is a continuous thing, so you can do it for a period of time rather than so many times. So we imagine drawing energy in and then the balloon begins to creep out of you. It's great, isn't it? Quite extraordinary because I can feel your energy. You're a very good class. I can feel it's strong. It's strong. It's good.

I walk down the street sometimes doing this and you feel protected, but I sometimes combine it with *mettā*. It's a wonderful technique, *mettā*. And when we do these things, we have to think that it is for our highest and greatest good and for the highest and greatest good of those whose lives we touch. You can't separate it. There is no, not anymore. I mean, we've come to a precipice now anyway, and I think big things are happening spiritually. I mean, horrible things are happening of course, yeah, but spiritually there's a lot happening. And I don't think it's the kind of thing that is anticipated by the great powers, those builders of empires. I don't think they understand that, but there is a lot happening, and it's wonderful to be part of it.

Now with self-treatment, because of the time as it is, what I'm going to do now is just to show you the positions of the hands. Before you start you do the precepts, the Gokai, which is five precepts: to be thankful, that's your gratitude, and to be free from anger, to be free from fear, be honest, which doesn't mean telling the truth, it simply means treating people fairly, not trying to cheat them, and to be kind, compassionate. So I've reduced that down to three statements, which is: just for today I'll be thankful, just for today I'll be free from anger and fear, just for today I'll be honest and kind. And that's a powerful tool as well. It's real. It's in our physiology. The words are inside us. They're part of us. And you say that two or three times, it prepares you. And then you sit quietly, find the calm centre of yourself, and raise your hands and go gassho and ask for the Reiki to flow.

Who do we ask? Who are we asking? The first thing I thought when I was shown this, we have to give everything a persona, don't we? We can't accept that intelligence doesn't need a persona all the time. A persona is like a suit of clothes, that's all. So what I'm saying is that Reiki is the intelligence of compassion. It's the intelligence of compassion. That is the energy. And it's not unthinking. How could it be? It wouldn't make sense. It wouldn't make sense at all. So you asked for it to flow. And this is the trusting, isn't it?

And how can you feel safe? This is why we had a blessing from Bhante to make us feel, to create a safe place for us to practice. But we can create it ourselves, and you create it with this. Reiki's heart driven, and when we can breathe from the heart, breathe from the heart, you think of something in your past that makes you happy and breathe it. I think Bhante's hinted at this before, his teachings in the evenings. Breathe from the heart. Imagine the breath entering there and going out of there, and you think of a good thing that you've experienced.

Yeah, like an old man who was absolutely crippled, with his spine had more or less gone, leaning over so near to the floor, old guy. And somebody said, "How are you? How are you feeling today?" And he said, and this was his present to that guy and his present to me and his present to you, he said, "The tears of my laughter flow like a stream into a dry desert." That's a gift. That's a gem. That's a gem he's given us all. And other people will quote that. So he's left a legacy just in his response to "how are you today?" You know, so breathing from the heart is important in Reiki.

And when we do the positions, I'll just go through the positions because you warm your hands. We're not actually doing self-treatment at the moment, but we can go through the different positions. We start here over the eyes. So that covers the frontal lobes where all those crazy loops go on incessantly in a tangled sort of horrific, unceasing movement when you can't get to sleep. It covers those, soothes them. When if you've got a headache, I'll tell you, that's the one thing Reiki, for me anyway, takes it away. Strangely, it didn't at first. It did other things, really great things. But yeah, don't give up. If it doesn't work at first, don't give up.

And the eyes, the eyes, which is supposed to bring in about, I think, about 90% of sensory data. So they're very important with sighted people, of course, but there are other things that happen. So that's the first. And then the temporal, the auditory areas, yeah, to do with the ears, you can put your hands over the ears.

and keep your fingers together. Make sure your hands are warm and as you come, I will instruct you in this when we do it. If you imagine your hands rising from the surface of the skin and you relax, if you relax and imagine that, what will happen is that

the hands—I'm doing it now, I'm not making any conscious movement, I'm just thinking—I'm just thinking of hands, right, and then you can feel, you can feel the heat and something else.

And then the next position is you could put it either over here. So over here you've got, of course, you're in the area of movement, the motor cortex and fine movement with the fingers, very fine movement. I usually go for the back rather than that, but you can—there's no reason why we shouldn't do both. So you put your hands like that, and then at the back as if you're resting on them but not over each other, although we do that at one point. So at the back like that.

So at the back we've again got movement of a different kind, the kind of movement where we have to adjust—it's a bigger kind of movements like when you kick a ball or you're navigating your way across the street and adjusting where you are to avoid things, which would be the cerebellum I suppose. But also, of course, back there you've got the "tiger, tiger burning bright," haven't you? You've got the raw emotion.

You know, in body language—they're probably on to it now—but the guy trying to work a scam, typical in body language, they say, "Well I don't know, the trouble is the deal runs out and oh my god, yeah, it runs out tonight but I may be able to, I just might be..." The hand goes right back there because back there does not understand lies.

It doesn't understand lies. It doesn't have morality. It's not to do with morality. It just does not understand this peculiar human trait of lying to each other and getting into all kinds of problems. It doesn't understand it. So it hurts. It hurts because it's being presented with nonsense. So the hand goes.

So that's one position. And then down around the throat here, so stimulating the lymph nodes around there. And this, of course, is the chakra—I say chakra, some people say chakra. I don't know what you say, but one of those tomato things. It's the one to do with expression, isn't it, in communication around here.

So on the face then we've got one, two, three, and then four. And then we go to the body and if you have the fingers touching, we go to the heart, the heart.

And what they found—it was a guy researching called Amor, strangely enough. He had the French word for love, yes, and he's called, this researcher, and he discovered that in the heart you have 40,000 neurons, I think, which isn't great as neurons go, is it? But it's what it does. The heart sends far more messages to the brain than the brain does the heart. This is what he discovered. It dictates to the brain. We didn't think that, did we? We didn't think that, that the heart dictates to the brain.

And there's actually—for people with broken hearts, it is an actual medical condition. I think I can remember—it's something like takotsubo cardiomyopathy. Takotsubo is an octopus trap. You know, I'm laughing, but it's not funny because we've all been, most of us have been dumped at some time and your world ends, the sun goes out. Nothing is beautiful in your world anymore. You've got takotsubo cardiomyopathy. I don't know whether it's when it's very, very extreme or something that people get. That's what happens. The actual shape of the heart is affected.

Love your heart, give it lots of love, give it lots of love. I mean, often no one else will anyway, so you might as well. You might as well have an affair with yourself, be your own lover, your own partner. And then it doesn't matter as much what happens in the outside world.

So that's there, so the heart, and then here at the lower part you're over the thymus. Now the thymus, of course, no longer exists because it goes, doesn't it, when we reach out, but it's left a lifelong legacy of immune functions, you see, so that's very important.

And there's a guy in Daoist medicine—see if I can remember his name—Master Manta Cheer, I think Manta Cheer it is. Wonderful to watch because he does this thing—he presses on the thymus, see there, and he laughs. He laughs and laughs. I've got neighbours so I can't. So you laugh and laugh and laugh and laugh, and this is what you—and he does the same down with the gut as well, down with the gut in the belly, you see, and you sort of massage first. He's a great guy to watch. I can recommend. I don't know enough about Daoist health systems or medicine to know—he seems to be high ranking, but perhaps you can tell me. I'm sure some of you will know more of this than I do.

Okay, so we've got the heart, then the lower, and then the stomach, right? The stomach, just below the navel basically, and then the hands just slot them into the inguinal fold. So that's the position. So we go one, two, and then three, four like that. And then we go the heart, the thymus, then down in the tummy and then the inguinal fold. And tomorrow night we'll do a longer, an actual self-treatment thing.

All right, now it's about time I released you. And you've been—I can feel that you've been a very good, engaging class that's been with me. Maybe it's in my imagination. Well, leave me with that delusion, please.

So breathe well. Many, many blessings. Many blessings. *Mettā*. Thank you.

Some Pointers for Mettā

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 15 min

In this accessible dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma offers practical guidance on developing mettā (loving-kindness), reframing it as an attitude of goodwill rather than simply an emotional feeling. He emphasizes that mettā practice works even when we don't feel particularly loving, as each mental determination of 'may you be well' cultivates the underlying attitude.

Drawing from the Buddha's teachings on speech, Bhante explains how mettā manifests as 'awareness imbued with goodwill' - an affectionate awareness that naturally influences our words, facial expressions, and interactions. He addresses common pitfalls like the 'do-gooder syndrome' where we help without truly listening to what others need, and the tendency for love to become controlling when we get angry at others' behavior.

The talk explores how mettā transforms three negative states: aversion becomes love, selfishness becomes generosity, and cruelty becomes compassion. Bhante particularly emphasizes generosity as both an expression of mettā and a practice of renunciation, showing how giving creates a virtuous cycle that reduces clinging. He connects generosity to gratitude, noting how recognizing what we've received naturally cultivates the desire to give back.

Practical and down-to-earth, this talk offers valuable insights for both meditation practice and daily relationships, showing how mettā functions as a fundamental attitude that can transform how we relate to others and ourselves.

I trust you've had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

I wanted to say something about *mettā*. Today we practiced *mettā*. The people who were joining the weekend retreat—actually it's a three-day retreat, it goes on till Monday—we practiced the whole process of developing *mettā* and then we went into forgiveness and finally into determination, how to practice determination.

I just want to say something about *mettā*. So often it's translated as loving kindness or tender loving care, those sorts of things. And they are the emotional relational feelings that we have, but they're not necessary in order to develop *mettā*.

So love has a huge spectrum from erotic to romantic to siblings to your spouse, your partner, to your boss. Everybody has a relationship, and hopefully it's one in which there's general goodwill. And that's really the operative word: goodwill. So it's to do with attitude. Attitude is something that sits behind the emotional life.

And as we practice this goodwill, of course, the heart rises to it. That's what's supposed to happen. But that doesn't mean to say that when we're practicing the mettā practice, if we don't feel loving, we feel depressed, anxious, et cetera, it's not working. It is working. Because every time you make an act in the mind of a determination—may you be well, may you be happy, et cetera—you're developing that attitude. It's as simple as that.

And the same of course in the opposite. So if you keep saying to yourself, "I am depressed, I'm so depressed," you know, "May all beings be depressed," then that also will bring about more depression. So we have to be very careful what we say to ourselves. So if we translate mettā just as the attitude of goodwill, it manifests in three different ways. From feelings of aversion we move towards love. From feelings of selfishness, we move towards generosity. And from feelings of cruelty, not being nice to people, sarcasm, we move towards compassion.

So having said that, how does it manifest in our speech? So here's the Buddha speaking to his monks. Remember, although I say monks, it's anybody who's listening.

"There are these five aspects of speech by which others may address you: timely or untimely, true or false, gentle or harsh, beneficial or unbeneficial, with a mind of goodwill or of inner ill will. Others may address you in a timely way or an untimely way. They may address you in a true or what is false," and then he goes through it. "In any event, you should train yourselves. Our minds will remain unaffected and we will speak no evil words. We will remain sympathetic to the person's welfare with a mind of goodwill and with no hate. We will keep pervading him with awareness imbued with goodwill. And beginning with him, we will keep pervading the all-encompassing world with an awareness imbued with goodwill, abundant, exalted, immeasurable, free from hostility, and free from ill will. That's how you should train yourself."

Now, the operative phrase for me in this is "awareness imbued with goodwill." So it's an affectionate awareness. If you just try it, if it comes very rarely to you, but if you look kindly upon all people whom you meet or see, even in the street, you'll see that it's a sort of background, sort of backdrop to the way you behave. It has a direct effect on the way you speak and your facial expressions.

So he's very big on speech. Get the speech right. And of course, the speech comes right when the thought comes right. So he's always saying that the mind comes first. What you do with your mind, what you do with your thoughts and your imaginings, they precede everything.

So the next thing is in action. One acts from a position of goodwill, you are connecting with somebody, and it might be that you fall into the error of a do-gooder. Everybody does it at some time or other. And that's when we are willing to do good, we want to do good, but we're not actually listening to what the other person needs. And so you end up doing something, and you can't understand why they want you to leave. Why are they not big on thank yous? Because you've done your best. So you have to be careful when you want to help somebody out of goodwill that we open up. We ask them, "What do you need? What do you want?" And if, of course, you can't fulfil that need, well, you have to say, "I can't do it."

On that level, sometimes I think, definitely true for me, too quick to say yes. So somebody says to you, a friend or a family member or somebody says, "I've got to do, my garden's overgrown, et cetera. I want to do a lot of gardening this weekend. If you've got a spare moment, I'd really appreciate your help." And you immediately say, "Oh, yeah, yeah, yeah, I'll come over Saturday. Yeah, I'll give you a hand." And then when you leave, you think, "Why did I do that? I don't want to go over there doing the garden." And, of course, come Saturday morning, you've got a headache, you don't feel good, you've lost your spade and things like that.

So it's always good, I think, when somebody asks you to do something, to just spend a moment and just say, "Well, give me a moment there. I'll think about it. I've got to see what I've got to do." Just delay a bit of time.

Now, I trained myself, I mean, this is going back ages, to if I said yes too quickly, no matter how I felt, I would actually go and do it and go through the pain of doing something that I really didn't want to do. And that way, it had some effect on me stopping saying yes too quickly, but actually to recollect or to consider whether I had the time or the will. You don't always have to want to help somebody, you might have other things to do. So you have to be careful that we don't fall into the do-gooder syndrome.

When we love somebody in this mettā way, it doesn't mean to say that you won't be hurt. You have to accept that because you have an attitude of goodwill to somebody that they're not going to be huggy huggy wuggy you all the time. Sometimes people are cruel, sometimes people say nasty things, sometimes we do nasty things, and yet you still have to have that goodwill.

Often I think in a relationship there's a sort of underlying resentment that grows because somebody is not being as generous as you are. The other person not being as generous as you are, or they're doing things you don't want to do and you keep swallowing it, and the resentment grows and then there's a big blowout, a big argument, and all that's really unnecessary. It is just a case of being open to the other person.

And this is where the problem can lie when love moves towards control. How do you know that you are moving that way? Well, it's when you're getting angry with somebody. If you're getting angry with somebody, they're doing something you don't want them to do. That means you want to control them. Now, that doesn't mean to say that what they're doing is skillful or is wholesome, but the anger is not necessary because the anger is manifesting your desire to control them. And as soon as you realize that, you sort of just wait or go out of the room for a little while, go for a walk, count ten, and then come back. And when you're coming from a place of non-aggression, then of course there's the ability to discuss something.

It doesn't mean to say that at times we can't be assertive, direct. But the anger really builds up a bad energy between people. And if it's not resolved, it remains there as resentment. And before you know it, there's a lot of bad feeling. And you can end up in a very nasty sort of divorce or separation. So you have to be careful of that.

And generosity. So generosity is the ability to give. I mean that's what it is. Whenever the Buddha's talking to lay people he always starts with generosity. He even points out that thieves can be generous. Having saved a thousand pounds, he might give it to needy people in his family and so on. So generosity is just that basic willingness to share of your wealth or of your time for the benefit of another.

Now, this is really a great virtuous circle because when you give something, you're renouncing. Remember that renunciation is the path, renouncing me, me, me, mine, mine, mine all the time. And so this effort to give, to let go of something for the benefit of another is a process of renunciation. Giving up of your time which you could have done something which you personally like for the benefit of another, that is also an expression of renunciation. Letting go, putting the other first. Now of course you don't always have to do that, it depends on the circumstance, but just that ability to give.

Now we will give more when we develop the attitude of gratitude. So if you look back through your life and just see what we've received from our parents, the education from society, the health service, and when you match it all up, you see that it's impossible to repay it. We've been given an enormous amount. It might not feel like that when you're paying taxes and all that, but when you go back to your life and think of all

the things that were given to you until eighteen and then you realize that it's not repayable, you can't repay what has been given to you. And that really is part of that ability to bring up a gratitude.

Now when you have a lot of gratitude, very easy to give because it's part of that barter. I don't want to, perhaps that's the wrong word. It's not a mechanism. It's not a business contract. But there's a desire to want to give something back.

You'll notice now that even these very rich people, Gates, Bill Gates and all those people, they've got a massive amount of money. Well, it's in the American tradition. Philanthropy going right back to Rockefeller and all these people where they've amassed an enormous amount of money and they're putting it to good use. So there's a lovely circular process there where you begin to think of how thankful you are for all the things you've received and how you want to give something back depending on a situation. Every time you give with the heart of letting go, you're renouncing something. And that means that there's less and less clinging in the system, less and less clinging.

Now this sort of pure generosity doesn't undermine the fact that sometimes you have social contracts in your family. Somebody, a sibling or somebody might buy you a bottle of wine for Christmas, non-alcoholic, of course, and you send them a box of chocolates. And it's normally an equal exchange. If you send a box of chocolates that cost thirty pounds and they sell you a seven pound bottle of non-alcoholic wine, well, you can feel very upset about that. But even so, because of the heart of generosity, you still continue to send great big parcels of chocolate.

So generosity is a core value which manifests this mettā. That's how mettā manifests.

So I think I've actually done my little bit there. That's all I wanted to say about love, just a sort of résumé of love itself. So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, and that hopefully you can send mettā.

Bodycare Practice — Mettā towards the Body

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 44 min

Bhante Bodhidhamma leads a comprehensive bodycare practice that transforms our relationship with the physical form through Buddhist contemplation and mettā (loving-kindness) meditation. The session begins with traditional body contemplations designed to undermine possessive attachment — examining bodily functions with equanimity, accepting physical appearance without vanity, and confronting the realities of sickness, aging, and death that the Buddha himself encountered as a young prince.

After establishing right relationship with the body through these reflections, Bhante guides practitioners to offer sincere apology for any harm done through neglect or harsh treatment. The practice then shifts into an extended mettā meditation directed toward every part of the body — from skin and skeleton to muscles, organs, and sensory faculties. Each system receives focused loving-kindness as practitioners learn to appreciate the body as a collection of billions of cells working harmoniously.

The session culminates with energy healing techniques adapted from Tibetan Medicine Buddha practices, visualizing healing light flowing through the body before extending these blessings to household members, neighbors, those who are suffering, and ultimately all beings everywhere. This integration of Theravāda contemplative practices with healing meditation offers a profound method for developing gratitude, acceptance, and care for the precious human birth that supports our spiritual journey.

Greetings.

This afternoon we're going to practice body care. I'll explain what we're going to do and then we'll do it.

The first thing is to get the right relationship to the body. The Buddha has offered us lots of exercises to do that, two main ones. But as we go through, you'll see it's all about the usual thing about me and mine, attachment and identity. Once we've corrected that relationship to the body, we can turn the *mettā* that we did yesterday afternoon towards the body itself. Then we can open up very much like Reiki. In fact, I would say it's the same. The practice is taken from the Tibetan tradition of the Medicine Buddha. Then we can share it. If you've got people in the house, you can share it with them, whether they know that or not, or your neighbours, and then we can share it to all beings in all directions.

Let's get into a nice contemplative posture to make sure that your body is the expression of the enlightened mind of the awakened one. Just that energy coming up the spine. Spending a moment just relaxing. For both this exercise and mettā, it's good to feel comfortable, so feel free to move your position.

Our first contemplations are to undermine the sense of "my body," possessive. I will say something like, "I have a headache," but "I am ill." So sometimes we have a body and sometimes we are the body. One of the reflections that the Buddha gives us is on the foulness of the body. What I'm going to do is mention some of the obvious ones, and as I go down through the body, just catch your reaction. The reaction, of course, is one of disgust. Now disgust is natural when it comes to taste—if you put something in your mouth which is off, then we should be able to tell it's bad for us and we want to spit it out. But disgust as a relationship to the foul parts of the body, that's something we learn. If you were in the medical professions, of course, you'd have to get over all that.

I'm just starting at the top there: tears, wax in the ears—as soon as I mention it, you see, you've got to catch your reaction. Nasal fluid, saliva, catarrh, blood, contents of the stomach which if they came out we'd call vomit. Diarrhoea in the lower intestine, the intestines. Stools. Urine. Sweat. Not a pretty list.

Go back to the one which, you know, you just felt that bit of disgust for. Just stay with that for a moment and just keep asking yourself, is this necessary? And I just see it as a natural product of the body.

We have another relationship to the body and that's to do with beauty. Often, unless you happen to be supremely beautiful, a Hollywood star or something, most people would not be satisfied with their bodies one way or the other. Just catch your face in the mirror. What do you say about it? What's your opinion? Can you change your view and just see it as holding virtually all your senses? That it's doing a job of work. This is what we are born with. Just accepting it. The importance is, of course, that our self-esteem is often affected by how we feel we look in other people's eyes. What about the whole body? Your whole body in the mirror? Can you just accept it? This is the way it is. Be happy in your skin, as they say.

Beauty is a social construct. It's we who decide what's beautiful and what's not. Can we lift ourselves above all that and just see the body as an organism and that it's doing the job? The legs are to carry us about. This contemplation helps us just to accept the body as it is and, of course, as it grows older.

The final contemplation is how much pleasure the body gives us from what we see, feel and so on. What do you fear the most? Going blind? Going deaf? Paralysis? Something else? Now that's the fear of loss of something we're dependent on for happiness. But we know from people who are disabled that this doesn't have to upset their quality of life. But for an able-bodied person to become disabled is a huge challenge, depending on how bad the disablement is. And there's the suffering.

Using these contemplations to undermine this false idea of the body being mine, somehow I possess it, control it completely. But more the sense of working with it.

The next contemplations are to do with coming to terms with sickness, ageing and death. These, of course, were the so-called messengers from the gods that awoke the Buddha to his search. As the tradition goes, he was out on various days seeing a person who was extremely ill, one who was extremely old and a corpse, and an ascetic sitting under a tree suggesting that there may be an escape from this. So these contemplations are really getting down to the nitty-gritty, the sense of identity, this body as me, I am ill, I am well.

Just repeating these phrases to ourselves and accepting their truth value, that's all. Feel the resistance. Just let it be there. Just receive the truth value of these statements, repeating them gently to ourselves.

This body is subject to disease. This body is of a nature to fall ill. This body has not gone beyond sickness. This body is subject to ageing. This body has not gone beyond ageing. This body is now in a process of ageing. This body is subject to death. This body has not gone beyond death. This body will die.

Now having undermined this wrong relationship of possessing and identifying with the body, we have to have the right relationship. The Buddha reminds us that this is a very precious rebirth. Here we have this combination of joy and woe and the intelligence to make our way out of it. Of course, you can't be here without a body—it's as simple as that. It's through the senses that we experience the world, that we learn, everything comes towards us. It's through the body we relate, we communicate, we express ourselves. It's through the body we work for the benefit of ourselves and others. In this way we create *kamma*, consequences. Finally, in vipassanā techniques, but virtually all meditation techniques, the body comes in at some point or other.

What we have to do is turn to the body and apologise for any harm we've done it. Whatever harm I have done to you in thought, word or deed, by way of greed, hatred and delusion, intentionally, unintentionally, habitually, I'm sorry for it and I determine from this day on to treat you with due care and respect.

Now having corrected in some way our relationship to the body, we can now turn that mettā, that goodwill that we were practising yesterday, towards the body itself. Remember, what is this body but a collection of billions of cells, each one quite individual, all doing their little tasks? All we're going to do is saturate and drench them with our goodwill. This is done so infrequently, and I'm sure that when they do feel our love towards them, they want to just jump up and down with joy.

Let's begin now. First of all, you have to find a phrase which expresses for you healing or invigorating. May you be free of sickness and disease. May you be well and strong. It could be that or just choose one of your own. Then just put it at the heart centre there in the chest and just radiate it out first of all to the whole body. Now you might find using colour helpful or sending out a sense of warmth, or it's just good enough just to say the phrases. Let's take our time.

Let's start at the top of the head there and let's come down the protective skin of our bodies and just shower it with our loving kindness, all the way down to the toes. Coming back to the top of the head. Now when you do this exercise by yourself, of course, you can take as much time as you wish.

Just come down into the skull—don't frighten yourself, it's just a piece of bone—and saturate it with your loving kindness and then down the spine, the arms, all the way down to the toes. Just following the skeleton all the way down. All the way down to the toes.

Coming back to the top of the head and, of course, remembering that it's in our bones that all the blood corpuscles are being manufactured. Drop down now into the brain and pour your loving kindness into that area. Brighten it up, light it up. Then just follow the nervous system, higgledy-piggledy, all the way down to the toes. Just like a big jellyfish, all the way down to the toes.

Coming back now to the head and moving into the muscles, the jaw, the cheeks. Massage them with your loving kindness. Then just make your way down the musculature of the body, all the way down to the toes.

Coming back now to the head and blessing the senses. Offer your blessings to your eyes. Into your ears. To your nose. Your tongue and teeth. Coming into the throat to the voice.

Coming down into the chest area. Spend some time there. Turning towards the heart, pour your loving kindness into that organ. This is the one muscle that never tires. Then follow the blood any which way round the body, bringing its warmth and love to all parts.

Coming down now into the midriff, the liver, stomach area. If you know the individual organs, you can bless them individually or you can just see it as a felt space and just pour your blessings, your loving kindness into that area. Moving down into the abdomen with its various systems. Again, you can spend time with each system or just see it all as a felt space. Pour your loving kindness into that area.

Bless your hands. Bless your feet.

Now we've touched every part of our bodies with our loving kindness. Perhaps there's a part that needs special attention. Spend a little time there now.

Now we can open up to other energy. This is much the same as Reiki. Here we have to invite the energy into us—that's much the same as the way Brian was doing it. What we imagine doesn't have to be an amazing visualisation, just an image in the mind, just a shaft of light coming down from above.

Down onto your head. Now you have to give it a colour, one that you feel is healing or invigorating. You have now this shaft of light, having chosen a colour, coming down and forming a ball just above your head. As it pours in, the ball takes on a quality of liquid, or if you prefer, oil. It's either cool or warm. It slowly begins to rotate.

Here we have the image pouring down from above, this shaft of light, which has a colour, pouring into this ball, which has a feel—liquid, oil, warm, cool—and it's just gently rotating. Can we now lower it slowly just on the scalp and see if we can feel those sensations? Just let the ball now just come down into the head, deep into the head. Into the throat. The whole head is this ball gently rotating. Still pouring down from above, the shaft of light.

Let the ball lengthen out over the shoulders and slowly make its way down the chest. Don't forget the spine and the arms. Deep inside the chest. Still pouring down from above, down through the head into this ball, gently rotating around the chest.

Let it sink a bit deeper into the liver, stomach area. Don't forget the spine and the arms. Still pouring down from above, down through the head, down the chest into this ball, gently rotating around the midriff.

Let it keep going down into the abdomen. Don't forget the spine and the arms. Still pouring down from above, coming right the way down through the body to this ball now gently rotating around the abdomen.

Let it complete its journey all the way down to the feet. All now is gently rotating around our feet or legs if you're sitting cross-legged.

Now with the in-breath, just draw the energy up from the ball, up the body to the top of the head with our own energy. Then with the out-breath, with new energy from above, just let it all cascade down the body. Just breathing in and up. Breathing out and down. The feel of a wave motion. If there's a part of the body needs special attention, let it go through that like water through a sponge.

Now we can offer this energy to others. If you're living with somebody in your house, you can include them. If you're by yourself, you could include your immediate neighbours. Here we're just breathing in that energy into the heart centre. It's the energy from above and our own energy. We're offering it out to whoever is close to us. Again, just breathing in and breathing out. With it, you can offer blessings. May you be free of sickness. May you be well. May you be strong.

We can also bring to mind anyone we know who's having a hard time, but especially physically. I'd like to mention Rob Berbier, who seems to be approaching his final days. With people who are dying, of course, the offering is a painless, peaceful death, a letting go.

Since this is uppermost in our minds at the moment, we can also include all the victims of COVID-19.

Finally, we can offer our blessings to all beings in all directions. May all beings be free of physical pain. May all beings be free of mental distress. May all beings be liberated of all their sufferings. May all beings live in contentment and joy. May all beings live together in peace and harmony. May all beings experience the bliss of Nibbāna. May all beings be happy.

Sabbe sattā sukhitā hontu. Sabbe sattā sukhitā hontu. Sabbe sattā sukhitā hontu.

Sādhu, sādhu, sādhu.

Very good. Do continue your practice. Those of you who want to join me on Zoom, I'll be here at four o'clock. Otherwise, keep putting in those hours and hours of meditation. When Milarepa, the great Tibetan saint, was asked by his student what it took to become fully liberated, he took his pants down and showed him the calluses on his bottom. So we have a lot of work ahead of us.

I shall leave you to your meditations and hopefully see most of you, or some of you anyway, at four o'clock. Thank you.

02 Reiki with Bryan

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 1h12

In this unique talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the fascinating Buddhist origins of Reiki healing. He traces the spiritual journey of Dr. Usui Mikao (1865-1926), founder of Reiki, who was deeply connected to Tendai Buddhism and its esoteric traditions, as well as the Yamabushi mountain ascetics who practiced meditation and fasting in the mountains.

The talk covers the five traditional strands of Reiki practice: the Gokai precepts ("Just for today, I will be thankful..."), blessing practices, Hatsurei-ho energy exercises, palm healing (Tenohira), and the use of mantras and symbols. Bhante guides participants through various breathing techniques including alternate nostril breathing and specific pranayama patterns for calming and balancing the nervous system.

The session includes practical instruction in the "Three Diamonds" energy exercise, connecting earth, sky, and heart energies, as well as guided Reiki self-healing positions. Throughout, Bhante emphasizes the interconnected nature of all things and the natural healing capacity of human touch and presence, drawing parallels between Reiki's Triple Gem-like structure and Buddhist wisdom traditions.

Well, I think we'll begin now. Good evening, everyone. Good to be back with you.

Before I begin, Bunty asked if you'd be interested in a Zoom meeting tomorrow at 11. You may not be free, it's late notice, but if you could let me know. You could, I suppose, put a message here just to say yes or no, or if you need to think about it, just send an email. And then I can contact Bunty this evening. Well, it doesn't look as if we're going to have many more.

I've been thinking about the situation with getting back to the idea of the space between, the way space has been created in between people within society. And there's a little thing you could do with the hands. You may know this. And I was thinking that it was rather a good representation of what's happened, taking an individual as a micro representation of society and taking a couple of polarities, doing a mock-up in an individual's body of what's happened by separating two polarities in the body and then watching what happens.

There's a little game with the hands. What you do is you clasp your hands as if in prayer. And you extend your two index fingers like that. And you press them close together. Keep them pressed quite firmly. Don't hurt yourself, but keep them pressed

firmly. Now, what I want you to do is to count to five and then suddenly open them, open those fingers. Don't stop clasping your hands. Just open those fingers so they're apart. And then just watch the fingers. Don't do anything. Just watch the fingers.

So I'm going to count one, two, three, four, five. Open. Just watched your fingers. See, if you suddenly separate polarities that have been used to being close, what happens is exactly that, but the renewed contact is different, isn't it? It's more sensitive.

And I thought it was a good representation in one person of society and the state we're in. So I'm presenting it really as an optimistic view of things, hoping that this will be an experience very much across society, that people will form different relationships, a different quality relationship that will be fruitful, more sharing, more sensitive, more appreciative of each other, because there are big changes taking place.

If we go back to the 19th century, 1865 in Japan, there were big changes taking place there with the restoration of the monarchy. And also it was the year that Dr. Usui Mikawa was born. He came from an old samurai family. And they were very privileged because they served the shogun, powerful people. So they lived privileged lives. And of course, that gradually disappeared. Usui as a child was still sent to martial arts school, and he was a martial artist. And it was the same school that Yoshiba went to, the founder of Aikido. And of course, Usui founded the new style that was Aikido. Aikido's got a very strong spiritual protocol and philosophy to it. You don't go in for the kill. So it has that spiritual quality. And of course, Usui founded Reiki.

But before he did that, he was very much involved with Tendai Buddhism. He was involved also with the esoteric sect of Tendai Buddhism. He was very devout. And he was also connected to the Yamabushi. They were a mountain group. They used to meditate and fast in the mountains. And that's what he would do sometimes.

And in 1922, he was doing exactly that. And he had, as the story goes, this vision, this road to Damascus type of experience. And as a result he founded a teaching that brought a lot of the esoteric traditions to the ordinary people, which would involve certain exercises and certain ways of enhancing one's spiritual life, and he became an able doctor. He didn't go in for healing, he didn't think of himself as a healer, but of course the Yamabushi actually did have healing practices, and he would have been connected to that. So these influences were in place.

But the thing that strikes me about this person who was obviously so very spiritual isn't so much the legend of visions on the mountain, but it's the fact that he was known to be good to be with. People felt good after they'd been with him. They came away feeling better and feeling physically better. And gradually, a healing practice developed

from this and he developed a system that was designed for self-healing. It really started with self-healing, or so the commentaries go. Obviously there's a lot of different versions, but this was for the military.

So it meant that they had to hand first aid, because sometimes of course in warfare you can't get help. And there are stories of people who've... I heard one recently of someone whose legs were more or less blown off. I mean, they certainly finished without... the particular person that this story was about, I think, was during Afghanistan. And he was passing out, just with the sheer trauma of the experience. And he remembered some breathing had been shown. It was just a simple count. He was able to stop himself because of doing this breath and help his men and call for help, and he was saved and the men were saved. He lost his legs, but he could have lost his life, but he remembered the breathing. And that wasn't anything to do with Reiki, but it's just to do with the fact that if you have to hand very simple tools that just as knowledge without anything else, breathing or some of these techniques, the Reiki techniques for instance...

My first experience was probably when I was at the Festival Hall and I had some musicians in the room at the back where the musicians gather. And they're heavy doors because they have to be soundproof. And I went to see them at the end just to speak to them. And I said, "Oh, hello." I remember making an exclamation because there was somebody who came out who I didn't know. And my hand was in the hinge door. It's a big, heavy door. And bang. Blood everywhere. And I immediately applied Reiki. No pain. No bruise. No swelling. We're talking about a severely trapped hand. I lost the nail, the nail did fall out, but there was no bruise, no swelling, no pain. So in a trauma first state of that nature, it can be very useful. And it was certainly to me.

So anyway, he formulated this system of self-healing and eventually healing other people. And it had and still does have five strands to it. One is *gokai*, which is the precepts: just for today I will be thankful, etc. And the other of course is a blessing which we've heard. He didn't do that blessing, that's nothing to do with Usui. It's just that in the context of doing this over the internet, of course it's really good that we have a monk that can just do a blessing. I mean, I can tell you more about what became an attunement later. It was developed more in the West, I think, and supposed to be based around a rite in the esoteric Tendai school called *goshimbo*, which means dharma protection for the body, and it was just a vigorous choreographed movement around the initiate. But really it's very little connected with that and it involves more symbols and mantras, symbols that you draw with the hands. I mean, I know all these and I do use them because I've been shown them. But anyway, that is one of the ways that blessings are done. But we're very lucky to have had the *Bojjhanga Sutta*.

And then, of course, is the Hatsu Rei Reho, which are the energy exercises. Then there's Tenohira, which is the palm healing. Palm healing is not... it isn't just Reiki that uses that. I think there was a time when they had the nurses doing it in America as a kind of experiment, because the hands are great comforters. What do you do when you comfort? Your hands go to the shoulder or around their shoulders. Or you hold somebody. What do we do when somebody's... you hold their hand. So it is the nature of hands to give off this healing, comforting effect. And then of course there are the mantras and symbols that are mentioned that are used in the blessing, but mantras and symbols also are used in healing. But the symbols are constructs. They mean what we want them to mean. I mean, the actual value of them is what we give to them.

I have a friend who taught the piano, and he was teaching a student some Beethoven, and this student said to him, he was a challenging student, "How do you know Beethoven wanted it to be played like this?" And he said, he's the kind of friend that always makes one smile, he said, "Because my teacher told me. And my teacher's teacher told him, and her teacher's teacher told her, and his teacher's teacher was told by Beethoven." It's that sort of thing. Very impressive.

Well, we all know we can do this. We can all always connect. I mean, I too connect to Beethoven in that way. We can all connect to people, can't we? If you take the trouble to find out the chains, the links in the chain, it becomes meaningful then. And if it's important to you, it becomes meaningful. And then if you tell people that, it becomes even more meaningful, even though people know... I mean, we can all connect to each other. We are all so very connected in spite of the space between. You could make double the space between, we would remain connected. You won't stop it. So we're connected in many different ways.

Anyway, that gives you a bit of info about Reiki. I wasn't really looking forward to doing that. I find history a bit tedious. But I mean, it's how you tell it, isn't it? It's like jokes. It's like humour.

What we're going to do now is we're going to do just a bit of breathing. You don't have to stand up. The breathing exercises, they are exercises. They're not really meditations, but you can use them. I'm talking about the pranayama things we did. And I do feel very strongly about this idea of allowing the breath to shape the body and to shape the posture.

I have some lovely suggestions from... I'm terribly sorry, it's Dan, somebody, I think. I can't remember, but it was a suggestion about breathing. And one was just to breathe, just take an ordinary breath and look for the calm between the breaths. It's lovely. I

mean, I'd certainly do that. I'll probably do that. It's a nice technique. It's a good technique. And if you have any ideas, techniques that you want to share, because now is the time to share. It's the time for ideas to be shared.

We tend to take ownership of things, don't we? That's my idea. In a way, we do that more with ideas than we do objects. And I'm thinking of the idea of a cooperative sharing, but just a non-ownership sharing where there's an awareness that we don't own anything. I mean, there's nothing I've shown you... I mean, there are things, some of those things are things that I've evolved, but they don't belong to me really. I could write a symphony, it wouldn't belong to me. You'd find so much there belonging to other people. And the same with those other people. So it's a way of looking at the interconnectedness of things. It's a way of looking at polarities, at spaces, and feeling the energy of them.

There is another point, though, I want to make about the breathing and the pranayama breaths. And it is that they are meant also as a tool. You can do them as exercises every day. You can count or whatever, or just use that breath and do it for longer periods of time, gradually build up. So the idea isn't that you breathe all day like that at all. It is an exercise, but days are stressful. So I mean, before I come on here, I do some breathing exercises because there's always a bit of a buzz, isn't there? You need energy to do things like this and you don't want to fall on your face. So there are breathing exercises.

Well, one for instance, the simplest is four, four, four, four. So rhythm is very good. It's very good as long as it doesn't become stressful where you're holding your breath until you're passing out. So four, four, four, four would be breathing in for four, hold for four, out for four, and the last bit for four. If you like, the cleansing, and then again, in for four, hold, out for four. It's calming. And you're taking control. So if your heart's beating fast, breathing, it's good, but you have to do a fair amount to keep at it, keeping control, and the breath will control it.

One that's good for increasing the vagus tone... And of course, the vagus runs right from the top here, right down into the gut. Very powerful nerve. And one that's used, there's various ones you'll find that are given if you research it, is the five, two, eight. So we'll try this. And don't worry too much about all the details of what I showed you yesterday. Remember the stomach. Remember to allow the breath. Just feel a slight shaping of the lumbar region and let it go a bit further. I mean, that's fine. We want to avoid this. I even do it when I'm trying to explain it, I will find myself doing that because

we're taking it apart, aren't we? And it becomes more complicated when you take things apart, but it isn't really, it's just, if you remember the expansion of the stomach and let the breath take over, that will be good.

So we're going to do five, two, eight. So after... two, one, two, one, four, five. Hold two. Out two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight. In two, three, four, five. Hold two. Out two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight. In two, three, four, five. Hold two. Out two, three, four.

And if you do that, it will calm you and keep you more in the chill-out system, keep you chilled, keep you cool.

But there's another I would like to mention. I resisted this. There's another way of using breath, another technique, and I'm sure you've all seen it and heard about it and you might do it. I hope you do. But of course it's the alternate nostril breathing. Now you're supposed to put two things here and you block the right nostril, and then you breathe five times in and out. Three, four, five. Now and then you put your ring finger there, the other nostril. Now one, two, three, four, five.

Now, it's tremendous. You get a great feeling of balance. I don't know what it is about it, but you start the day with that. If you do about nine in one, that's fine. I do three different ones where you breathe in one nostril and out through the other. Now, if you find one side is blocked, what you do...

is give just a bit of pressure. Say if it's that side, if my left side is blocked, then a bit of pressure under the right armpit, you know, the lymph nodes. So you've got a bit of pressure there. If you just—I mean, not too much or for too long—but what it does for some reason is loosen up on the other side. So if that's blocked, you put your arm under there, and if you can lie with a bit of pressure on it, yeah, not for prolonged periods. You don't want to cut off your blood supply, but it balances the body in a very good way.

I have a funny story about this because I do this breathing on a train, and it's discreet, you know. But when it comes to alternate nostril breathing, what I'd do is sort of lean on one and then lean on the other. But it became evident that some people would look at me and say, "You all right, mate?" Obviously they thought that I was making a comment about their body odour or something. I don't know, but I decided to stop it. But I thought, well, it's a pity I can't do that.

And I found myself imagining that I was breathing through one nostril. I want you to try this, actually. I want to see if you find the same thing. That's very interesting, right? I've blocked my nostrils now. I don't know about you. But anyway, if you breathe, let's say through the left nostril, if you imagine that you're breathing just through here. All right, let's just try it. Now imagine you're breathing through the other nostril.

I don't know what you're experiencing. And I mean, it's not like the holding the breath thing when we were doing the finger game, where I was pretty sure most people will be holding their breath. This is different. I mean, I was trying not to offend people and get myself into trouble. And so I then found myself trying that. Now it's like, to me, it feels like I'm breathing through only one nostril. All the attention is there. So all the sensations that you're focused on are here.

But what I found quite fascinating—this has happened a number of times where you stumble on something and then you find that it's actually done—and it's done certainly in the version I heard of *Yoga Nidra*. Now, Nidra yoga is sleep yoga or dream yoga. And there's a very, very excellent guided Yoga Nidra record done by Sacred Acoustics. It's really good. It's very well crafted, particularly that you get a long version and a short version. The short version I really like. It's quite beautiful.

And it takes you as a guide. You lie down. It's great. No effort. And you go down to the throat, then out to the joint there, then the joint there, then the wrist joint. And then you go back again. Then you do the other side. And then gradually you go down to the lower part of the body and do the same with the legs and then come back. You finish up in the end, and it's actually—I think it's in the long version where they do this alternate nostril breathing with the imagination, except you breathe in and out quite a lot through one nostril or you keep alternating. I can't remember now because I tend to listen to the short version.

So it already exists. Well worth the thing to try because you can really space out and you've got this binaural rhythms. I'm not quite sure about binaural rhythms, but it's the sort of thing I'd love to discuss with you because I know you'd have opinions about it.

So that's the breath. And don't forget with the breathing for Reiki, you breathe in through the nose. That's all you need to remember. You don't have to do great full breaths, you know, as in the exercises we've been doing. In through the nose with the tongue on the roof and then out.

Now we're going to do exercises, and I want to show you something now that, if anything else, take this with you as far as the Reiki exercises go. It's very good. It's a beautiful exercise.

What we've done so far, just to remind you, is we've done the Reiki shower, which you can do the short version where you just scoop up the energy. Imagine you're scooping up energy on the in-breath, and then down on the out-breath. And just a few times like that, you know, when you need to, or even if you just imagine you're doing it, you'll find you can get through. It doesn't affect—I don't think it affects you immediately—but

after a few minutes, you suddenly, yeah, I seem to be carrying on now. I mean, it won't suddenly make you into Superwoman or Superman, but it will get you through. Well worth doing.

And the other one is the inner cleansing. The inner cleansing I really like. So you pull it down. I like some of the imagery Buntei uses and the way you talk, but it's wonderful stuff. And I like the way he spoke of a shaft of light coming down. It's great. So that might help actually. In this way you pull the energy down into the stomach, and it goes out. Before you start breathing out, you think of it just beginning to go, and then you breathe out, and you begin to feel it going out through the skin and forming a balloon.

Now, teachers, well-known teachers, commentators who have written lots of books about this will use that straightaway. Others say, well, yeah, that's fine, but before you do that, for six months, you should do this one. And I'll tell you what it is. You breathe. It's the same. You pull the energy down into the *hara*, the gut. Again, it starts to spread. But then just the fingertips, fingers and toes, fingers and toes, you can feel it coming out. Now, it does make them tingle quite a lot, that exercise, actually. You breathe in freely going out and breathe out. And now the extremities. So think of the toes and the fingers. It always works. It's wonderful.

So those are the two exercises. In the pack, there's an exercise called dry bathing. And you imitate bathing. So you breathe in, breathe out. Sorry, you go across the body first, right? That side, then that side. Read it. It's supposed to be used before other exercises. I prefer the Reiki shower. It's simple. I do the dry bathing, but it's partly because I was shown it. The Reiki shower is over the whole body and it's simple to remember.

Read the dry bathing exercise and see if you take to it. But the three diamonds is the one that I would really like you to take away with you. The three diamonds I always associate with the Triple Gem in Buddhism. The Triple Gem of course being the Buddha, the Dharma and the Sangha. But it's likened to a diamond in that it's something that is very, very clear, beautiful, polished. We think of the diamond as being something polished, but it also cuts through anything. You know, it'll cut through anything.

And that of course refers to the idea of cutting through dualistic thinking or concepts, getting to the heart of a problem, to the essence of things. And you do it—you can do this sitting down. There's no reason why you shouldn't do this sitting down or standing with the feet shoulder width apart. But first of all, you know what you're going to do. So you take up the position. All right, this is our position. We're sitting and then don't forget the eyes forwards, half closed. So it makes us just a bit sleepy and receptive. And then bring your attention to the *hara*.

And then raise hands in *gassho* and then we lower the hands and we start the first part. This is in three parts. Imagine as you breathe in that you're pulling up energy from deep in the earth right up into the gut. Okay, right? So you breathe in through the nose, tongue on the roof of the mouth, into the gut. Now hold that idea, the image between that polarity—deep in the earth and you and your stomach—as you breathe out. Then again, you simply keep that as a fixed image. And out. Three times. And out. Four times. Five, six, seven, eight.

Now the second part. You breathe in again nine times and what you do is you imagine a sphere floating down. If you can't—actually that sometimes helps you to get a sensory foothold. If you can't just think of that polarity and then this polarity. So you breathe from here. Really the first fixed attention is really on the *hara* because that's where it's going. But if you can develop that image, then you would use it. Make it easy. Never try to visualize in a ferociously concentrated way. Just pull that sphere of energy down as you breathe in or just think of your heart, just think of your belly, and now think of your crown. It's floating back to your crown. This is sky energy. We're pulling it up from the sky. In fact, you can think of the sky and then back again. It floats back. Pull it down from the sky or the crown to the *hara*. And out again. I think that's three. Right. Now four. Five. Six, seven, eight, nine.

And then what we do, the last one is the heart energy. The heart energy. And you make as if holding a tree. Now just take a breath before we start the cycle of breath. Just breathe in and breathe out and just bring your hands down towards the ground.

Now breathe in from the earth. Imagine it coming up from the earth, down from the sky, and then bring your hands round. I don't know whether you can see. This is not—this is one that is a bit—so they're out and the palms are facing out and you give from the heart. And bring back to where you started and the last bit of air out, then second time. Up from the earth, from the sky, bring them around and give out from the heart and then down again. I'm going to call that three. Now we say four. Down and then breathe in. Right, I've decided that that is six. Now seven and down. Now eight. Down and nine.

Now you could substitute the heart one—you could substitute the heart one for an exercise that's given to us by the Heart Math Institute. They studied the heart. They had been since 1991. That's when a lot of research was done into the heart. The heart forms before the brain, and it calls the shots. This is the thing. It doesn't seem to, does it? But the heart has a lot of intelligence. It just doesn't use words to express the intelligence and we don't listen to it when we should either.

So the heart, the first thing is you breathe—you breathe, just imagine breathing into your chest and out. That is the actual portal for the breath to enter. In and out. And then if you can produce an elevated emotion. What is that? It's something that makes you feel good. You know, I'm not thinking of the kind of elevated emotion that comes from a mystical experience really, but I don't know. I think of my parents. I had beautiful parents and they've long gone. When I think of them—I was so blessed. They're beautiful people. If I think of them. Our family dog—I go around, she doesn't see me now, but when she does, she doesn't look pleased. She explodes with joy.

Now that gives me—you may not like dogs, I'm sorry if you don't—but it gives me, I don't—it's indescribable. I feel wonderful. And sometimes she'll just sit under my legs. I sit on the wall outside. She doesn't know about distancing. And she sits there and I look into her eyes and the message is: this is where I want to be. It's very beautiful.

And you can collect gems like that. You remember the one last night: the tears of my laughter flow like a stream into a dry desert. And here's another one: sitting in a train and listening to—there's parents behind me with a baby. The baby wasn't making a sound. But the thing is that we're both singing to the baby. And what made it beautiful for me was the fact that the guy didn't know the words. I don't know why that made it beautiful, but he didn't know the words. He was constantly missing words and trying to catch up in the song. And the second thing was that the baby did not need pacifying. Not at all. She was perfectly happy without being entertained. You could see that. They sang to that baby out of sheer love.

And that's a gem. And you can collect these. And they don't all have to be sort of—I don't know, some people might find those things sort of soppy. Well, okay, that's all right as well. But the point is that you can build up a treasure trove of these things. This is where memory, instead of becoming the machine of anger and regrets and shame and remorse, it becomes—you use it to build your Aladdin's cave with these memories. I'd love it if you could share some, you know, anything you find that elevates. So you place this memory here and as you breathe out you give it to the world. You see, so it's the quality, the frequencies, the resonance of your heart breathing.

I'd like you all to put your hands now in *gassho* and with me, if you just—you can just think it if you like. I can't hear you so just for today. And we do it three times. You'll find it on your sheets. Just listen to me anyway, if you can't quite remember. It's very simple.

Just for today, I will be thankful. Just for today, I'll be free from anger and fear. Just for today, I'll be honest and kind.

Just for today, I will be thankful. Just for today, I'll be free from anger and fear. Just for today, I'll be honest and kind.

Just for today, I will be thankful. Just for today, I'll be free from anger and fear. Just for today, I'll be honest and kind.

Now we wait. Let's just rub our hands. Think of the left hand. Think of the right hand. Left hand, right hand. Left palm, right palm. Left palm, right palm. Now if you haven't got your shoes off—I haven't, I've got my slippers on, I'm kicking them off here. It doesn't matter if you can't. Energy likes—it likes these little hollows in the body. Likes to nestle in them.

Left arch. Yes, it's the left arch. All right, think of the left arch of your foot. Now the right. Now the left arch. Now the right. The left arch. Now the right. Now go to your right palm. Right palm. Left palm. Left arch. Right arch. Right palm. Left palm. Left arch. Right arch of the foot.

Now we're going to go around in a circle. Here, enter here, then left foot, right foot. Get the circle going. It's a circle of energy. Feel it going around. Just feel it going around. Now we've got a circle going. Can you feel that going? I think some of you can actually. Now just slow it down. Now the left arch. Now the right palm. The left palm. The right arch. With a figure of eight. Left foot, right palm, left palm.

right arch left arch and up. Now get the figure of eight going. Okay, now it can move as fast as thought, and there's no other thing that has moved as fast as thought. I think it's the fastest thing on the planet, isn't it? I don't know. And like a train stopping.

Okay. Lie down. If you can find a place to lie down, please. And if you lie down and just think, try to invite the energy. Try to feel, get that sense of allowing.

May all beings be happy and safe. May all beings be happy and safe. May all beings be happy and safe. And then if you lift your hands just to your brow between the eyes and just silently ask the energy to flow freely for your highest and greatest good and for the highest and greatest good of all those whose lives you touch. May the energy of Reiki flow free for my highest and greatest good and for the highest and greatest good of all those whose lives I touch. And then a third time: May the energy of Reiki flow freely for my highest and greatest good, and the highest and greatest good of all those whose lives I touch.

Now we breathe in. Place the hands over the eyes gently, just touching gently. I want you to just do a couple of breaths of inner cleansing just to clear away any distractions. Breathe in. Send the energy out. In fact, you can send it to your fingers and your toes.

Okay. Know that you're a very special, important person, creative, an amazing machine with infinite possibilities. Feel a sense of tenderness. You are the child. You are the child, no less.

Now relax your hands and imagine them floating away. Don't move consciously. Just think of your hands. Imagine them floating off your skin. As soon as you relax, they will do it. Now move them to the side of your head. You can put them over your ears if you prefer. Take a good breath. Send the energy out. Allow it. Let me see you breathe. Allow it to go to your fingers and your feet. Feel it in your hands tingling. Imagine your hands floating. Just relax them. Only think of them floating off your skin and feel the space between. Sense the space between. It's alive.

Now gently move your hands to the back of your head. One higher than the other, as if you're resting your head in bed on the pillow with your hands behind you, but not on top of each other. Fingers close. Now imagine your fingers floating away. Well, of course if you're lying down you can't do that obviously. I'm sitting up, you see. So just gently let them slide down towards the front of the neck until the heels of your hands meet so it's like a cup rest, a little golfer's seat with a spike, so this covers around the throat.

Imagine your hands gently relaxing from there and leaving that area. Now you put them on your chest with fingers close together and fingers pointing in towards each other and the middle fingers would be touching. Okay, now just to get rid of any distractions that might have got in the way, let's do an inner cleansing. Breathe in and as you breathe out to let the polarity be your fingertips and your toes. Breathing fingertips and the toes. Fingertips on the toes. Love your heart.

We're talking about an electromagnetic field that is not just a bit more than the brain's. We're talking a few thousand. It has a very big electromagnetic field. Now down to the lower part where the bottom of the sternum, that little navel there where the thymus would be. You know when a child is distressed, when a child is distressed and the parent, they put their hand on the child and just cuddle them and say, "It's going to be all right, it's going to be all right." That is the relationship now between you and your body. You and yourself, if you like. How it's, you don't have to overthink it, just treat yourself as you would treat a child. It's going to be okay.

Now gently slide the hands down towards the inguinal fold, covering the lower part of the abdomen and pointing down towards the base energy centre, towards the genitals. I want you to put one hand over your stomach, over the navel. Any hand, another hand on your forehead. There's no past. There is no future. There is now. There is no anger. There is no fear. There is gratitude.

Now bring your hand down from your forehead and put it over the other one. Now cross your hands like a St. Andrew's cross, with one hand pointing to the opposite shoulder diagonally. Feel gratitude and the love for the healing energy of compassion. Wiggle your toes and roll your shoulders a bit and take your hands away. Hands can rest out.

I give thanks for the healing energy of Reiki. I give thanks for the healing energy of Reiki. I give thanks for the healing energy of Reiki.

All right. Sorry, we overran a bit, but we had a bit of a slow start. It doesn't bother me, by the way. I'm not worried. But before you go, I should give you time to blink a bit, shouldn't I? I've been sitting, you see, but I suppose most of you have been. You can do this sitting, of course. We would have spent a bit of time on any parts of the body that you were concerned about. It's just that we're a bit late.

Could you make it known if you'd like to manage an 11 o'clock Zoom tomorrow, if you can? I don't know whether... if you could type in yes or no or something here, then I'll know now rather than say, send me an email. Okay. Are they coming? Yeah. Okay. Jackie, Krish, okay now. Oh, Krish, you've put sound had gone. Oh, so you haven't managed to get onto the Zoom, Krish? You might, yeah. That's 11 o'clock in the morning, okay.

Well, look, I tell you what, why don't we just have one anyway? For those who can't come, do send me an email, any questions you have, okay? If you can't make the 11 o'clock one. I don't know why I can feel your energy, but it's quite extraordinary. I could feel it during the day today. It's a new one. This is a new thing. It looks if I've got about a hundred in the class, but I think it's people just sending messages.

I'm going to go now and you've been a lovely, lovely class and sleep, sleep well. *Metta*, breathe well and love yourself. Okay.

Body as Meditation Object

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 22 min

Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's comprehensive teachings on the body as a meditation object, drawing from the Kāyagatāsati Sutta (MN 119) and the body section of the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10). He explains how our wrong relationship with the body—through identity ('I am the body') and possession ('my body')—creates suffering, while the body itself can only provide pain or pleasure.

The talk covers the Buddha's own journey from self-mortification to discovering the Middle Way, and explores the traditional contemplations: mindfulness of breathing, the four postures, full awareness in daily activities, contemplation of the body's constituent parts, the four elements (earth, water, fire, wind), and charnel ground reflections. Bhante emphasizes how developing right awareness of the body serves as a foundation for understanding the three characteristics of existence—impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and not-self.

This teaching offers practical guidance for undermining attachment to the body while maintaining its proper care, showing how mindfulness of body becomes a gateway to true knowledge and liberation from Māra's influence. The discussion includes how physical pain differs from psychological suffering, and how proper body awareness leads to conquering discontent, fear, and the challenges of aging, sickness, and death.

Greetings, I trust you've had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhasa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

Today we practiced this body care and it's been substantiated by Brian, who's been doing the Reiki. So I thought we'd have a look at the body from the Buddha's point of view.

In the Buddha's teachings, the body and mind are two different, for want of a better word, forms of energy, whatever. But it's not the awareness, the *satipaṇṇā*, the Buddha within. This was made more plain in Mahāyāna, where they talked about the three bodies, Yogācāra.

So the first was the body of the Dharma, which is the unconditioned Buddha. Remember, he said that he had achieved the unconditioned *citta*, *citta* here meaning the awareness, he's pointing to the awareness, not the mind. And there's the Sambhogakāya, which is the body of bliss, which is the mental body, which for the Buddha, of course, becomes one which is heart-based happiness. Somebody who's fully liberated doesn't suffer as such. And then there's the Nirmāṇakāya, which is the body of appearance, which is this physical body.

And this physical body can only give us pain, right? It can't make us suffer. The suffering has come because of a wrong relationship to the body, which is identity. It's me. I am sick. I am well. And possession, right? I have a bad knee, which I do have at the moment. And I have a headache, things like that. So the suffering comes from a relationship to the body. The body can only offer us pain and pleasure, of course.

The Buddha, of course, made this mistake in his training. After he had achieved all these *jhāna* states, his absorption states, in the first part of his training for about two years or so, he then went into the process of self-mortification. So there the understanding was the body was the product of your unwholesome actions, your *kamma*. And you had to let go of the body. So there was this process of eating less and less and less. This seemingly was the doctrine of the Jain leader, where the saint is one who finally just stops eating, just lets go. So he found that to be just more pain and he left it highly disappointed and very thin. And that's when he went off to sit under the tree where he became fully liberated.

So somewhere along that line, moving away from self mortifications and reflecting upon his practice, he came upon the insight into what was really causing the problem, really causing the suffering and the escape from suffering. And that was his big insight. And it's, as we've mentioned before, to do with our relationship, to do with ethics.

Now, so we have that dualistic relationship with the body. It's me and it's mine. And it's interesting to note, I've got this book called *The Human Body*. And occasionally I open it and very quickly close it. And there are astounding little facts, you see. For instance, if I were to ask you now, have you any idea what your liver's doing? It's a mystery. And there are many little things that this book mentions which are astounding, really.

For instance, the brain contains 12 billion neurons. 12 billion neurons. And there are 50 billion supporting glial cells, wherever they are. 50 billion neurons. I mean, I've never seen a single neuron. And if it's to do with my thinking, I've probably lost a few.

And then there's the blood. Now, this is amazing. This is coming out of the marrow of our bones. Every second, every second, I can't believe this, frankly, but every second, two million oxygen-bearing red blood cells die. But they are replaced at the same rate by new ones generated in the process within the marrow of the bone. Can't be right, can it? Two million. Two million oxygen. I should be dead. So it just shows, when you get all these facts, they are quite astounding. And how the body works and what the little parts of it do, the pancreas, the liver. You wonder that you live so long and that you can remain so healthy because anything can go wrong. The minor thing and you're sunk.

So it's actually good to reflect on the fact that actually, we don't really know the body. We don't experience the body. What we experience of the body really comes through the sense of touch, the sense of movement. And just that sensual divide between what's pleasurable and what's unpleasurable.

Then we have to accept that there's a changing nature. The body's never the same. They tell you that every seven years you've got a new body. I just wish the renewal would be a little bit more enhancing. It just seems to get worse. I don't know why. So this changing nature of the body, every seven years a new body. I mean, every seven years. It's ridiculous, isn't it, when you think about it? To think that when you're standing and you're looking at your hand, you didn't have this hand. I did not have this hand seven years ago. It was a completely different hand.

The sheer dependency of the body on food, on air, any of that becomes denied us before we know it. We're dead. The body just dies. You can live without water, I think, for about nine days.

And the control we have is minimal. It's more like somebody driving a car. You get in a car, you drive it, you feel you're in control of the car and then the car comes to a stop or the wheel blows or somebody hits it and that's it. And that's the end of the car as far as you're concerned, at least its mobility.

So this idea that we're feeling of being in control of the body, actually the control is quite surface, quite minimal. Of course, when you see these athletes, the woman gymnast in the last Olympics was just unbelievable what she can do with the body, but it's still only a surface control of the body, just through actions and movements.

So what we were doing was a practice whereby we undermine this wrong idea of possessing the body and being the body. Just like any objects, what you can do is use it, right? There's no point in possessing an object. It's just going to cause a lot of suffering.

Emotionally, I mean. Obviously, legally, the mobile might be yours. But when the thief takes it, it's his. It's no good. Going around saying somebody's taken my mobile, it's no longer yours.

So it's getting rid of the idea of somehow possessing the body. Somehow we're in it, we're in it, but not of it. What is that we referring to? It's awareness. The awareness is in it, but not of it.

And then we went through this relationship that we have with the body, part of it we like, part of it we're disgusted by. So these relationships are not particularly needed at all. I mean, you need it for food. If you put something rotten in your mouth, then you need to know this is rotten, it's going to poison me. So then that is a sort of sensual disgust. But the actual emotion of disgust is not necessary, is it? And, of course, it displaces itself to being disgusted with people.

And the wrong relationship, of course, forms an attachment to the body as a place where we're using to create happiness. So that's where the suffering really lies because, for instance, if you go blind, if you go deaf. If you suffer from an accident and become paralysed, I mean, the suffering involved in that will be as much as your dependency on those faculties for your happiness. Now, we know from disabled people that the quality of your life need not be undermined, but the change, going through the grief and the sense of loss and all that is obviously due to this psychological dependency we have on the body for happiness and that's what we mean by attachment.

And then the contemplation of sickness, aging and death which we do every evening. See that's to try and undermine the fact that we are the body, this peculiar identity.

So we went through all that of course. Death. In the, well, the body turns up in two major discourses, the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse, the discourse on how to establish awareness. And then there's a whole discourse which is devoted to the body. I think it's mindfulness of the body, he translates it as.

And what the Buddha says is that mindfulness of the body, by which he means a right relationship with the body, is one way of stopping Mara getting in, by which he means unwholesome and unskillful thoughts. And he gives a couple of examples. He likes metaphor. He loves metaphor.

"Anyone who has developed and cultivated mindfulness of body has included within himself what wholesome states there are that partake of true knowledge, just as one who has extended his mind over the great ocean has included within it whatever

streams there are that flow into the ocean. So too, anyone who has developed and cultivated mindfulness of the body has included within himself whatever wholesome states there are that partake of true knowledge."

So the true knowledge, which is to do with the three characteristics, seeing things as they really are, begins with the body. The body is obvious, right? The mind isn't so obvious. Emotions can be obvious. Thoughts are not so obvious. They're sort of, in a sense, intangibles when compared to the body. The body has that sort of sense of reality, inverted commas, and it's not real, but it has that groundedness in the earth, dust to dust, ashes to ashes.

And then he says, anybody who's not developed a cultivated mindfulness of the body, Mara finds an opportunity and a support in him. "Suppose a man were to throw a heavy stone ball upon a mound of wet clay. What do you think? Would that heavy ball find entry into that mound of wet clay?" "Oh, yes, venerable sir."

That's so he gives these lovely examples. "Supposing suppose there were a dry sapless piece of wood and the man came with an upper fire stick" — so remember they're rubbing sticks together — "I shall light a fire and I shall produce a fire. What do you think? Could a man light a fire and produce heat by rubbing the dry sapless wood with an upper fire stick?" "Yes, Venerable Sir."

And he gives lots of these little examples to show, to sort of get across to people that if you're not aware of the body, if you're not within the body, have a proper relationship to the body, then it can cause you suffering. And the suffering is through attachment, through indulgence, and through aversion to the body.

And then finally he has the benefits of the body. Some of them are about extrasensory perceptions and all that, and remembering past lives and all that. But the first ones we can relate to, I think, easy enough.

So one becomes a conqueror of discontent and delight and discontent does not conquer one. One abides overcoming discontent when it arises. This, of course, is the discontent from the body, feelings of hunger, etc.

One becomes a conqueror of fear and dread and fear and dread do not conquer oneself. One abides overcoming fear and dread whenever they arise. So, of course, fear and dread to the body arise whenever it's in peril, whenever it's in danger.

One bears cold and heat, hunger and thirst, the contact with gadflies, mosquitoes, wind, the sun, the creeping things, and of course coronavirus. So those are the physical things that we can endure. But one also endures ill-spoken, unwelcome words, especially when people make comments about your body. And arisen bodily feelings that are painful, wracking, sharp, fierce, disagreeable, distressing and menacing to life.

So if we can get the right relationship to the body, then yes, pain is part of the process. Pain comes with life. What can you do? But at least we won't have this second arrow, as the Buddha talks about it, the second dart, which is the suffering, which is our reaction, which is how we relate to the body as me, mine, etc. And all the fears of sickness, of aging and death arise because of that.

So yes, there's a whole discourse here on how to establish that mindfulness. And the sections are the same as in the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse.

So first of all, there's the breath itself. The breath and emotions are intimately connected, as you know. And therefore, when we sit with the breath and quieten the breath, it has an effect on the heart. It quietens the heart. And it stills the mind and the body feels good when we allow the body just to breathe. In fact, he says, "I shall breathe in, tranquilizing the body formations. I shall breathe out, tranquilizing the bodily formations." So there's an effort there in the practice to use the breath to just feel relaxed, to feel at ease.

And when you're doing that you can feel the tension sort of slough off as they leave you, these tensions that might be in the body, overactivity or something. It can even be invigorating, if you especially if you use the breath, just put a bit of energy into it, you can lift the energy right up.

Now these exercises are not *vipassanā*. So you have to be careful that. You have to know you're using the breath to bring about calmness, to calm yourself or to lift energy. And that's fine. What we don't want to do is confuse *samatha* or breath techniques with *vipassanā*. *Vipassanā* is letting things be and seeing the three characteristics.

He talks about the four postures, which are the four postures of meditation: walking, sitting, lying down. They're your major postures. Full awareness. And here he talks about doing things mindfully. So he acts with full awareness, going forward and returning. Full awareness, looking ahead, looking away. Full awareness, flexing and extending his limbs. Full awareness, wearing his robes, wearing your clothes. Full awareness while eating, drinking, consuming, tasting. Full awareness while defecating and urinat-

ing. Fancy. And who acts in full awareness when walking, standing, sitting, falling asleep, waking up, talking and keeping silent. So in other words, the whole moment to moment mindfulness, as the Mahāsi would say, is the secret of success.

Then he goes on to the foulness of the body. So here he's got a great list that just goes on and on: bone marrow, kidneys, heart, large intestine, small intestine, faeces, bile, phlegm, pus, blood, sweat, fat, tears, grease, spittle, snot, oil in the joints. That's quite a list really, isn't it?

So and he says, "Just as though there was a bag with an opening at both ends full of many sorts of grains such as hill rice, red rice, beans, peas, millets and white rice, and a man with good eyes were to open it and review it thus: "This is this, this is this."

So it's really getting that sense of equanimity, that getting that sense of non-reactivity to the body and its foulness because we tend to put our attention on its beauty, surface beauty.

Then, of course, there's the elements. Now, the elements, remember, fire, earth, water and air, or wind, fire, earth, water and air. Well, wind is movement, you see. These refer, of course, to pressures, solidity, to water, elasticity, cohesiveness, fire, heat, any form of heat or cold, and, of course, wind, which is movement. And this is pointing to how the basic sensations that come in from the body into the mind, that's what they are, right? They're not objective physics, right? They're about how they are the subjective experience we have within ourselves of matter. So, I mean, this is what you can explore a bit in your practice.

And then finally, there's the charnel grounds. I think there are nine. There are nine where you go and sit at the charnel ground, because in those days, they would just leave the body out, dressed in white robes. And it was these white robes that the ascetics would take, the *samaṇas* would take, and make robes out of them. And the Buddha himself would have done that. So they're on the charnel ground devoured by crows, hawks, vultures, dogs, jackals, worms, etc.

The Basics of Insight Meditation 03

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 16 min

In this final talk of a three-part series, Bhante Bodhidhamma focuses on vipassanā (insight meditation) and the cultivation of Right Awareness (sammā sati). Drawing inspiration from the Buddha's childhood memory of natural absorption, he explores how we can return to the pure, conceptual-free awareness of a child observing the world with complete attention and an open jaw—symbolizing the absence of mental commentary.

Bhante explains how the noting technique in the Mahasi tradition works to occupy the thinking mind while allowing us to see through concepts to direct visceral experience in the body. He uses the myth of Narcissus as a metaphor for how awareness recognizes itself in the mirror of consciousness before falling into the world of mental formations. The talk emphasizes moving beyond the five aggregates (khandhas) to discover our Buddha nature—the intuitive awareness that can observe without being caught in the content of experience.

This teaching offers practical guidance for developing the subtle skill of 'just watching, just feeling, just experiencing' while understanding the process of how awareness separates itself from the objects of meditation, ultimately leading to insights into anattā (not-self). Suitable for practitioners familiar with basic meditation concepts who want to deepen their understanding of vipassanā practice.

Good evening. I trust you've had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.
Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

That was a cruel ending last night. I was leading up to a crushing statement that would have changed the world. However, it will now have to be a footnote. So this evening is the end of this three-day retreat. And let's hope this machine will keep working. We have messed about with it, and the hard drive doesn't seem to be working as hard as usual. I think that's what was wrong with it. If not, I have another, I have Noreen's laptop at the ready.

So on the first night, we talked a little bit about goodwill, *mettā*. And the second night was the body care, thinking about the body, about our relationship to the body. So this evening, really, it's the turn of *vipassanā*. And I'm only reinforcing what I'm sure most of you know, but it's always good to go over basics.

The first thing is to really grasp what the Buddha means by this right awareness. I think we have to go back, you know. I do mention his moment in childhood where he's watching his father doing a plowing ceremony, and after his ascetic practices that becomes a memory which gives him some inspiration. And what he recognises was that as a child he was equally absorbed. He could very quickly go into an absorption because the heart's very pure as a child usually. But there was something extra which he had not been practicing. He had been practicing the *jhāna*, which is really about establishing very beautiful intense mental states, but there's no wisdom there. That's what he eventually discovered.

And this memory from childhood, I think, inspired him and gave him a different angle. So instead of trying to achieve happiness, I think he then sat down and wondered how he was creating suffering. There were points before that when he was investigating that, such as the time he felt fear, such as the time he realized that there were two types of thoughts. One was wholesome and one was unwholesome. That was the beginning, really, of recognising that at the root of our problems is ethics, our relationships.

And that, of course, was very novel for the time, remember, because people presume that misfortune and all the rest of it partly happened because of the gods or fate or something like that. The Buddha really wasn't into fate as such. Of course, things happen not simply because of my own personal actions, but eventually what happens within me, my own mental state, the inner world, my subjective world, is something that I'm creating. And he discovered how not only the heart could be healed, but how there was something that actually lay beyond the body and mind.

So I always think it's good when we're a bit confused about what we mean by right awareness, just to go back to that little child. All of us will have had that moment of seeing a bug or something or a beetle and asking our parents where it is. But there will have been a moment there where, like children, their eyes fix on it and you can see they're completely absorbed, they lose—even if you talk to them, they don't hear you. They're completely absorbed in what they're looking at. And of course, the jaw drops. Remember that? Yes, they look gormless. And that tends to be a reason why your parents, you know, give you a little tap on the shoulder or in the old days, a smack across the head. I remember one woman telling me that her father used to tell her to keep her mouth shut or a fly would get in there.

The whole point of course is that with the relaxed jaw there's no thinking, there's no coming from a position from some idea, from some concept. And that's what opens up this intelligence we have, this intuitive awareness, to receiving stuff. And of course the intelligence is within the awareness, so it makes insights. Because remember what happens is the child then, having absorbed the little bug, will turn to the parent and say, you know, what is it? And mummy will say, well, that's a beetle, you see. So already the child has a photocopy, a perception of this, a percept of this little bug. And every time it sees one from now on, it's not interested in actually seeing that as an individual little creature. It's interested in naming it. And so it says, oh, there's a beetle. And mummy says, oh, very good.

So how to get back to the original mind, what Zen often calls original mind or beginner's mind. That's our problem. And of course, the noting technique in the Mahāsi tradition is meant to occupy the thinking mind. We're meant to see through the word towards the object, to the feeling of something. So we're moving off concepts, off percepts, off perception, and moving down into the visceral part of our experience, which is the body, the feelings in the body. And now the heart is expressed and felt in the body. It's not anger for instance—we often just splurt it out with bang doors and silly stuff like that. But when you sit with it, there's a completely different experience. And you're allowing the heart to, of course, clear itself.

So whenever we're lost about, well, what is this meditation about? Just go back to that child. Just watch, just feel, just experience. Of course, now this intuitive awareness has been instructed. It knows within itself what it's looking at: the cause of suffering, desire, impermanence. But you don't have to keep telling it. You don't have to keep doing it purposefully because when you do it purposefully, you're putting some idea in the way. So it is quite difficult for us just to get into that very relaxed, at ease, focused position of just watching, just feeling, just experiencing.

Now, when you get there, you see after, when you come out or when the mind shoots off or something, you come back, remind yourself: how did I get there? And reflect on the quality of that pure watching, because that's how you'll get back to it more and more easily. That's of course, so long as life doesn't become horrendous as it has been for me in the past hour, trying to get this streaming correct.

So the second thing is to begin to understand how we work with these hindrances. I won't go into that detail. There's many talks on it. And finally, seeing these three characteristics. Again, these things—there are talks, hundreds of talks about it. But what I want to talk about is this awareness, and to give some other images that help us to perceive what this awareness is.

The first thing is, and the process of meditation. So the first thing is to go back to being to the baby again. So we're told that within the first three, four months of our lives, it's just a shower of information: light, sounds, touches, feelings, tastes, and can't make head or tail of it really. But slowly out of that mass of information, your first object arises: your carer, your mother, obviously more often than not. But of course, the one thing the baby does know is what is pleasant and unpleasant. I mean, I think we're born with that.

So over the next year or more, the baby pushes out this outer world, separates from it. And so the outer world begins to manifest with its three dimensions. And it's moving away from it. It's finding itself in another position to it. And psychologically, of course, it doesn't really liberate itself from that intense connection with the mother till about three years old, something like that anyway.

So at the age of three, the little child has a very great sense of me, and with it there comes not me. So they push that outer world out and it's become not me, and this is who I am. Now, in our practice, that's all we are doing internally. We're now pushing the internal world out, as it were, into an object to observe. When we see sensations, the observer, the feeler, is observing it as an object. When we feel emotions, the observer, the feeler, the experiencer, is feeling it as an object. And so by doing so, this awareness, which has been confused in what the Buddha would call the five aggregates, the psychophysical organism, is slowly pulling itself out and making these five aggregates—the body, feelings, all perceptions, thoughts, and all our habits, and even consciousness—as an object.

So now that's, of course, very confusing because most people would say, these days anyway, that you are your consciousness. You are what you are aware of, without making that distinction between awareness and consciousness as a screen upon which everything happens.

So how do we know that the Buddha talks about it as a screen? Because even in the scriptures, the Buddha is not so—the use of words in the scriptures varies according to who he's talking to and what he's trying to say. But at the point of contact, what we have is a physical base, an object, and consciousness. So consciousness becomes the screen upon which we can see things, the screen upon which we hear things. It's a moment of cognition, you might say. I don't really know what the proper word in English is because they also have various meanings. But if you think of a screen, you see.

Now, with that in mind, I like to use the myth of Narcissus. Now, Narcissus is a beautiful young man. He looks into the pool. He falls in love with his image. He goes to embrace it and drowns. And this is normally understood to be, you know, self-love, pride,

or whatever. But it works perfectly spiritually because the awareness, as it were, looks into that screen and it mirrors back its own presence. That's your first object. I am aware. I am me. That sense of me being the awareness.

And then, as it were, through that very same screen, it falls into the world of make-believe of the mind. And in mythology, usually water is creation. So if you can imagine the awareness waking up in the morning, catching its presence in the mirror and knowing itself, and then immediately falling into the make-believe world: alarm clock, get up, go to work, et cetera, et cetera. That's happening really many times during the day.

But that distinction is extremely subtle and very difficult to actually directly experience. But it can be experienced. And there's a point in your practice when you're very, very still, very, very quiet. The body's very still, the heart's very calm, the mind is quiet. And the sense of the observer, the feel of the observer is very strong—the feel of the feeler, the experiencer. You're right there with that self-awareness. And as it were, you've almost separated out the awareness from all the stuff on the screen. And if you can just, as it were, glance back—or yes, glance back or, yeah, that's about the best I can say. Other teachers use the same. It's mainly a little Mahāyāna technique. And then ask yourself, well, what's in there? What constitutes the awareness? Do I find any sensations, any feelings? Are there any emotions or moods or any thoughts or images, you see?

And in that way, we're starting to realize this unique quality of our Buddha nature, our intuitive awareness. So that's one process. There are many ways people can have insights. They can have insights directly through seeing the process of desire. That can also be a moment of liberation. And the same with impermanence. So this is more like a moment of understanding, of clear understanding, through the process of *anattā*, not me, not mine.

So with that image, let me see the time. Oh, I'm not doing so bad. I think it's, oh yes, that's right. With that image and the image of the child and the whole idea of getting into a position of just watching, just feeling, just experiencing, then now we're clearer about the practice that we're doing.

Well, I'm afraid that's it. So I can only hope my words have been of some service, that you aren't even more confused, and that by your devotion to practice, you will be liberated sooner rather than later. So I think we can do a little bit of practice.

Very good.

03 Reiki with Bryan

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 1h12

In this engaging talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the spiritual healing practice of Reiki, tracing its origins to Dr. Usui Mikawa (1865) and his deep connections with Tendai Buddhism and the Yamabushi mountain meditation tradition. The teaching reveals how Usui's spiritual awakening in 1922 led to a system originally designed for self-healing, incorporating five key elements: the Gokai precepts, energy exercises (Hatsurei Reo), palm healing (Tenohira), mantras, and symbols.

The talk offers practical instruction in Reiki breathing techniques, including the foundational 4-4-4-4 rhythm and the 5-2-8 pattern for vagus nerve stimulation. Bhante demonstrates the 'Three Diamonds' exercise - a powerful practice connecting earth energy, sky energy, and heart energy that he associates with Buddhism's Triple Gem (Buddha, Dharma, Sangha). Drawing from Heart Math Institute research, he explains how the heart's electromagnetic field surpasses the brain's and teaches methods for cultivating elevated emotions through treasured memories.

The session concludes with a guided Reiki self-healing practice, emphasizing the Buddhist principles of compassion and loving-kindness. Throughout, Bhante connects Reiki's healing potential to Buddhist concepts of interconnectedness and non-ownership, making this both a practical healing workshop and a reflection on spiritual interconnection during times of social distancing.

Well, I think we'll begin now. Good evening, everyone. Good to be back with you.

Before I begin, Bunty asked if you'd be interested in a Zoom meeting tomorrow at 11. You may not be free, it's late notice, but if you could let me know. You could put a message here just to say yes or no, or if you need to think about it, just send an email. And then I can contact Bunty this evening.

Well, it doesn't look as if we're going to have many more. I've been thinking about the situation with getting back to the idea of the space between, the way space has been created between people within society. And there's a little thing you could do with the hands, you may know this, and I was thinking that it was rather a good representation of what's happened.

Taking an individual as a micro-representation of society and taking a couple of polarities, doing a mock-up in an individual's body of what's happened by separating two polarities in the body and then watching what happens. And there's a little game with the hands. What you do is you clasp your hands as if in prayer. You clasp your hands as if in prayer, and you extend your two index fingers like that. And you press them close together. Keep them pressed quite firmly. Don't hurt yourself, but keep them pressed firmly.

Now, what I want you to do is to count to five and then suddenly open them and then open those fingers. Don't stop clasping your hands. Just open those fingers so they're apart and then just watch the fingers. Don't do anything. Just watch the fingers. So I'm going to count one, two, three, four, five, open. Just watch your fingers.

So if you suddenly separate polarities that have been used to being close, exactly that happens. But the renewed contact is different, isn't it? It's more sensitive. And I thought it was a good representation in one person of society and what the state we're in.

So I'm presenting it really as an optimistic view of things, hoping that this will be an experience very much across society that people will form different relationships, a different quality relationship that will be fruitful, more sharing, more sensitive, more appreciative of each other. Because there are big changes taking place.

And if we go back to the 19th century, 1865 in Japan, there were big changes taking place there with the restoration of the monarchy. And also it was the year that Dr. Usui Mikawa was born. He came from an old samurai family. And they were very privileged because they served the shogun, powerful, powerful people. So they lived privileged lives.

And of course that gradually disappeared. Usui as a child was still though sent to martial arts school and he was a martial artist, and he was the same school that Morihei Ueshiba went to, the founder of aikido. And of course one founded the new style that was aikido. Aikido's got a very strong spiritual protocol and philosophy to it. You don't go in for the kill in other words. So it has that spiritual quality.

And of course, Usui founded Reiki. But before he did that, of course, he was very much involved with Tendai Buddhism. He was involved also with the esoteric sect of Tendai Buddhism. He was very, very devout. And he was also connected to the Yamabushi. They were a mountain group. They used to meditate and fast in the mountains. And that's what he would do sometimes.

And in 1922, he was doing exactly that. And he had, as the story goes, he had this vision, this road to Damascus type of experience. And as a result he founded a teaching that brought a lot of the esoteric traditions to the ordinary people which would involve certain exercises and certain ways of enhancing one's spiritual life and he became an able doctor. He didn't go in for healing, he didn't think of himself as a healer, but of course the Yamabushi actually did have healing practices and he would have been connected to that. So these influences were in place.

But the thing that strikes me about this person who was obviously so very spiritual isn't so much the legend of visions on the mountain, but it's the fact that he was known to be good to be with. People felt good after they'd been with him. They came away feeling better and feeling physically better.

And gradually, a healing practice developed from this and he developed a system that was designed for self-healing. It really started with self-healing or so the commentaries go. Obviously there are a lot of different versions, but this was for the military. And it meant that they had to hand first aid, because sometimes of course in warfare you can't get help.

And there are stories of people who've heard one recently of someone whose legs were more or less blown off. I mean, they certainly finished without the particular person that this story was about. I think it was during Afghanistan. And he was passing out with the sheer trauma of the experience. And he remembered some breathing he had been shown. It was just a simple count. And he was able to stop himself because of doing this breath and help his men and call for help. And he was saved and the men were saved. He lost his legs, but he could have lost his life. But he remembered the breathing.

Nothing to do with reiki, but it's just to do with the fact that if you have to hand very simple tools that are just knowledge without anything else, breathing or some of these techniques, the reiki techniques for instance.

My first experience was probably when I was at the Festival Hall and I had some musicians in the room at the back where the musicians gather. And they're heavy doors because they have to be soundproof. And I went to see them at the end just to speak to them. And I said, "Oh, hello." I remember making an exclamation because there was somebody who came out who I didn't know. And my hand was in the hinge door. It's a big, heavy door. And bang. Blood everywhere.

And I immediately applied Reiki. No pain. No bruise. No swelling. We're talking about a severely trapped hand. I lost the nail. The nail did fall out, but there was no bruise, no swelling, no pain. So you see, in a trauma, first aid of that nature can be very, very useful. And it was certainly to me.

So anyway, he formulated this system of self-healing and eventually healing other people. And it had and still does have five strands to it. One is *gokai*, which is the precepts: just for today I will be thankful, etc. And the other of course is a blessing which we've heard. He didn't do that blessing, that's nothing to do with Usui. It's just that in the context of doing this over the internet of course it's really good that we have a monk that can just do a blessing.

I mean, I can tell you more about what became an attunement later. It was developed more in the West, I think, and supposed to be based around a rite in the esoteric Tendai school called *goshimbo*, which means dharma protection for the body. And it was just a vigorous choreographed movement around the initiate. But really it's very little connected with that and it involves more symbols and mantras, symbols that you draw with the hands.

I mean I know all these and I do use them because I've been shown them. But anyway, that is one of the ways that blessings are done. But we're very lucky to have had the *Bajanga Sutta*. And then of course is the *Hatsurei Reo*, which are the energy exercises. And then there's *Tenohira*, which is the palm healing.

Palm healing isn't just Reiki that uses that. I think there was a time when they had the nurses doing it in America as an experiment because the hands are great comforters. What do you do when you comfort? Your hands go to the shoulder or around their shoulders. Or you hold somebody. What do we do when somebody's dying? You hold their hand. So it is the nature of hands to give off this healing, comforting effect.

And then of course there are the mantras and symbols that are mentioned that are used in the blessing, but mantras and symbols also are used in healing. But you know, the symbols are constructs. They mean what we want them to mean. What I mean is that the actual value of them is what we give to them.

I have a friend who taught the piano and he was teaching a student some Beethoven, and the student said to him, "How do you know Beethoven wanted it to be played like this?" And he said, it's the sort of friend that always makes one smile, he said, "Because my teacher told me, and my teacher's teacher told him, and her teacher's teacher told her, and his teacher's teacher told her, and his teacher's teacher was told by Beethoven." It's that sort of thing and very impressive.

Well, we all know we can do this. We can all connect. And I too connect to Beethoven in that way. We can all connect to people. But it's taking, if you take the trouble to find out the chains, the links in the chain, it becomes meaningful then. And if it's important to you, it becomes meaningful. And then if you tell people that, it becomes even more meaningful, even though people know we can all connect to each other. We are all so very, very connected in spite of the space between. You could make double the space between, we would remain connected. You won't stop it. So we're connected in many different ways.

Anyway, that gives you a bit of info about Reiki. I wasn't really looking forward to doing that. I find history a bit tedious. But I mean, it's how you tell it, isn't it? It's like jokes. It's like humour.

What we're going to do now is we're going to do just a bit of breathing. You don't have to stand up. The breathing exercises, they are exercises. They're not really meditations, but you can use them. I'm talking about the *pranayama* things we did. And I do feel very strongly about this idea of allowing the breath to shape the body and to shape the posture.

I have some lovely suggestions from, I'm terribly sorry, it's Dan somebody, I think. I can't remember, but it was a suggestion about breathing. And one was just to breathe, just take an ordinary breath and look for the calm between the breaths. It's lovely. I mean, I'd certainly do that. I'll probably do that. It's a nice technique. It's a good technique.

And if you have any ideas, techniques that you want to share, because now is the time to share. It's the time for ideas to be shared. We tend to take ownership of things, don't we? "That's my idea." In a way, we do that more with ideas than we do objects. And I'm thinking of the idea of a cooperative sharing, but just a non-ownership sharing where there's an awareness that we don't own anything.

I mean, there's nothing I've shown you, I mean, there are things, some of those things are things that I've evolved, but they don't belong to me really. I could write a symphony, it wouldn't belong to me. You'd find so much there belonging to other people. And the same with those other people. So it's a way of looking at the interconnectedness of things. It's a way of looking at polarities, at spaces, and feeling the energy of them.

There is another point that I want to make about the breathing and the *pranayama* breaths, and it is that they are meant also as a tool. You can do them as exercises every day or you can count or whatever, or just use that breath and do it for longer periods of time, gradually build up. So the idea isn't that you breathe all day like that at all. It is an exercise.

But days are stressful. So I mean, before I come on here, I do some breathing exercises because there's always a bit of a buzz, isn't there? The energy, you need energy to do things like this and you don't want to fall on your face. So there are breathing exercises.

Well, one for instance, the simplest is four, four, four, four. So rhythm is very good. It's very good. As long as it doesn't become stressful where you're holding your breath until you're passing out. So four, four, four, four would be breathing in for four, hold for four, out for four, and the last bit for four if you like, and then again. It's calming and you're taking control. So if your heart's beating fast, breathing is good. But you have to do a fair amount to keep at it, keep in control, and the breath will control it.

One that's good for increasing the vagus tone, and of course, the vagus runs right from the top here, right down into the gut. Very powerful nerve. And one that's used, there's various ones you'll find that are given if you research it, is the 528.

So we'll try this and don't worry too much about all the details of what I showed you yesterday. Remember the stomach, remember to allow the breath, feel just a slight shaping of the lumbar region and let it go a bit further. I mean, that's fine. We want to avoid this kind of thing. I even do it when I'm trying to explain it, I will find myself doing that because we're taking it apart, aren't we? And it becomes more complicated when you take things apart, but it isn't really. It's just, if you remember the expansion of the stomach and let the breath take over, that will be good.

So we're going to do five, two, eight. So in for five, hold for two, out for eight.

In, two, three, four, five. Hold, two. Out, two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight. In, two, three, hold, two. Out, two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight. In, two, three, hold, two. Out, two, three, four.

And if you do that, it will calm you and keep you more in the chill-out system, keep you chilled, keep you cool.

But there's another I would like to mention, this I resisted, there's another way of using breath, another technique. And I'm sure you've all seen it and heard about it and you might do it. I hope you do. But of course it's the alternate nostril breathing. Now

you're supposed to put two fingers here and you block the right nostril and then you breathe five times in and out: one, two, three, four, five. Now and then you put your ring finger there, the other nostril. Now one, two, three, four, five.

Now, it's tremendous. You get a great feeling of balance. I don't know what it is about it, but you start the day with that. If you do about nine in one, each nostril, that's fine. I do three different ones where you breathe in one nostril and out through the other.

Now, if you find one side is blocked, what you do is give just a bit of pressure. Say if it's that side, my left side, then a bit of pressure under the right. So the lymph nodes. So you've got a bit of pressure there. I mean, not too much for too long, but what it does for some reason is loosen up on the other side. So if that's blocked, you put your arm under there.

And if you can lie with a bit of pressure on it, not for prolonged periods, you don't want to cut off your blood supply, but it's good and it balances the body in a very good way.

I have a funny story about this because I do this breathing on a train and it's discreet, you know. But when it comes to alternate nostril breathing, so what I'd do, I'd lean on one and then lean maybe on the other. But it became evident that some people, they'd look at me and say, "You're right, mate." Obviously they thought that I was making a comment about their body odour or something, I don't know, but I decided to stop it. But I thought, well, it's a pity I can't do that.

And I found myself imagining that I was breathing through one nostril. I want you to try this, actually. I want to see if you find the same thing. That's very interesting, right? I've blocked my nostrils now. I don't know about you. But anyway, if you breathe, let's say through the left nostril, if you imagine that you're breathing just through here. All right, let's just try it. Now imagine you're breathing through the other nostril. Right. No, I don't know what you're experiencing. And I mean, it's not like the holding the breath thing when we were doing the finger game where I was pretty sure most people will be holding their breath. This is different.

I mean, I was trying not to offend people and get myself into trouble. And so I found myself trying that. Now it's like, to me it feels like I'm breathing through only one nostril. All the attention is there, so all the sensations that you're focused on, I feel there. Whether you feel that, but what I found quite fascinating, this has happened a number of times where you stumble on something and then you find that it's actually done, and it's done in certainly in the version I heard of yoga nidra.

Now nidra yoga is the sleep yoga or dream yoga, and there's a very excellent guided yoga nidra record done by Sacred Acoustics. It's really good, it's very well crafted, particularly that you get a long version and a short version. The short version I really like, it's quite beautiful. And it takes you, you lie down, it's great, no effort. You just go down to the throat, then out to the joint there, then the joint there, then the wrist joint, then there, and then you go back again, then the other side, and then gradually you go back, you know, down to the lower part of the body and do the same with the legs and then come back. You finish up there in the end. And it's actually, I think it's in the long version where they do this alternate nostril breathing with the imagination, except you breathe in and out quite a lot through one nostril, or you keep alternating. I can't remember now because I tend to listen to the short version. So it already exists. Well worth the thing to try because you can really space out and you've got this binaural rhythms. You know, I'm not quite sure about binaural rhythms, but it's the thing I'd love to discuss with you because I know you'd have opinions about it.

So that's the breath. And don't forget with the breathing for Reiki, you breathe in through the nose. That's all you need to remember. You don't have to do great full breaths, you know, as in the exercises we've been doing, in through the nose with the tongue on the roof and then out.

Okay. Now we're going to do exercises now. I want to show you something now that, if anything else, take this with you as far as the Reiki exercises go. It's very good, it's a beautiful exercise. What we've done so far, just to remind you, is we've done the Reiki shower, which you can do the short version where you just scoop up the energy. Imagine you're scooping up energy on the in breath and then down on the out breath. And the more, you just a few times like that, you know, when you need to, or even if you just imagine you're doing it, you'll find you can get through it. It doesn't affect, I don't think it affects you immediately, but after a few minutes you suddenly, yeah, I seem to be carrying on now with a, I mean, it won't suddenly make you into superwoman or superman, but it will get you through. Well worth doing.

And then the other one is the inner cleansing. The inner cleansing I really like. So you pull it down. I like some of the imagery that Bunty uses and the way you talked about it. Wonderful stuff. And I like the way he spoke of a shaft of light coming down. It's great. So that might help, actually, in this way. You pull the energy down into the stomach, and it goes out. Before you start breathing out, you think of it just beginning to go, and then you breathe out, and you begin to feel it going out through the skin and forming a balloon.

Now, teachers, well-known teachers, you know, commentators who have written lots of books about this, will use that straightaway. Others say, there are some who say, "Well, yeah, that's fine, but before you do that, for six months, you should do this one." And I'll tell you what it is. You breathe. It's the same. You pull the energy down into the heart, the gut. Again, it starts to spread. But then just the fingertips, fingers and toes, fingers and toes, you can feel it coming out. It does make them tingle quite a lot, that exercise, actually. You breathe in freely going out and breathe out. And now the polarity, now are the extremities. So think of the toes and the fingers. It always works. It always works. It's wonderful.

So those are the two exercises. In the pack, there's an exercise called dry bathing. And you imitate bathing, you know. You breathe in, breathe out. Sorry, you go across the body first, right? That side, then that side. Read it. It's supposed to be used before other exercises. I prefer the Reiki shower. It's simple. I do the dry bathing. But it's partly because I was shown it, you know. The Reiki shower is over the whole body and it's simple to remember. Read the dry bathing exercise and see if you might take to it.

But the three diamonds is the one that I would really like you to take away with you. The three diamonds. I always associate it with the triple gem. Buddhism, the triple gem, of course, being the Buddha, the Dhamma, and the Sangha. But it's likened to a diamond in that it's something that is very clear, beautiful, polished. We think of the diamond as being something polished. But it also cuts through anything, you know. It'll cut through anything. And that, of course, refers to the idea of cutting through, I don't know, dualistic thinking or, you know, concepts, getting to the heart of a problem, to the essence of things.

And you do it, you can do this sitting down. There's no reason why you shouldn't do this sitting down or standing with the feet shoulder width apart. But first of all, right, you know what you're going to do. So you take up the position. All right, this is our position. We're sitting. And then don't forget the eyes forwards, half closed. Yeah, so it makes us just a bit sleepy and receptive. And then bring your attention to the *hara* and then raise hands in *gassho*. And then we lower the hands and we start the first part. This is in three parts. This, imagine as you breathe in that you're pulling up energy from deep in the earth, right up into the gut. Okay? Right. So you breathe in through the nose, tongue on the roof of the mouth, into the gut.

Now hold that idea, the image between that polarity, deep in the earth and you and your stomach. As you breathe out, then again, you simply keep that as a fixed image. And out. Three times. And out. Four times. Five. Six. Seven. Eight.

Now the second part. You breathe in again. Nine times. And what you do is you imagine a sphere floating down. If you can't, actually that sometimes helps you to get a sensory foothold. If you can't, just think of that polarity and then this polarity. Okay? So you breathe from here. Really, the first, the first fixed attention is really on the *hara* because that's where it's going. Okay? But if you can develop that image, then you would use it. Make it easy. Don't never try to visualise in a ferociously concentrated way. Just pull that sphere of energy down as you breathe in, or just think of your heart, just think of your belly. And now think of your crown. It's floating back to your crown. This is sky energy. We're pulling it up from the sky. In fact, you can think of the sky and then back again. It floats back. Pull it down from the sky or the crown to the *hara* and out again.

I think that's three, right? Now four. Five. Six. Eight. Nine.

And then what we do, the last one is the heart energy, the heart energy. And you make as if holding a tree. Okay? Now just take a breath before we start the cycle of breath. Just breathe in and breathe out. And just bring your hands down towards the ground. Okay? Now breathe in from the earth. Imagine it coming up from the earth, down from the sky, and then bring your hands around. I don't know whether you can see, this is not, this is one that is a bit, so they're out and the palms are facing out. And you give from the heart. Okay? And bring back to where you started and the last bit of air out. Then second time, up from the earth, from the sky. Bring them around and give out from the heart. And then down again.

I'm going to call that three. Now we say four, down, and then breathe in. Right. I've decided that that is six. Okay? Now seven, and down. Now eight, down. And nine. Okay?

Now, you could substitute the heart one, you could substitute the heart one for an exercise that's given to us by the Heart Math Institute. They studied the heart. They have been since 1991. Yeah, 1991. That's when a lot of research was done into the heart. The heart, the heart forms before the brain, and it calls the shots. This is the thing. It doesn't seem to, does it? But the heart has a lot of intelligence. It just doesn't use words to express the intelligence. And we don't listen to it when we should either.

So the heart, the first thing is you breathe. You breathe, just imagine breathing into your chest and out. That is the actual portal, you know, for the breath to enter, in and out. And then if you can produce an elevated emotion. What is that? It's something that makes you feel good. You know, I'm not thinking of the elevated emotion that comes from a mystical experience really. But I think of my parents. I had beautiful parents and they've long gone. And when I think of, they were, I was so blessed. They're beautiful people. If I think of them, our family dog, I go around, she didn't see me now, but when she does, she doesn't look pleased. She explodes with joy.

Now that gives me, you may not like dogs, I'm sorry if you don't, but it gives me, it's indescribable. I feel wonderful. And sometimes she'll just sit under my legs. I sit on the wall outside. She doesn't know about distancing. And she sits there and I look into her eyes and the message is, "This is where I want to be." It's very beautiful. And you can collect gems like that.

You remember the one last night, "The tears of my laughter flow like a stream into a dry desert." And here's another one. Sitting in a train and listening to, there's a parent behind me with a baby. The baby wasn't making a sound. But the thing is that we're both singing to the baby. And what made it beautiful for me was the fact that the guy didn't know the words. I don't know why that made it beautiful, but he didn't know the words. He was constantly missing words and trying to catch up in the song. And the second thing was that the baby did not need pacifying. Not at all. She was perfectly happy without being sung to. You could see that. They sang to that baby because out of sheer love. And that's a gem. And you can collect these. And they don't all have to be, I don't know, some people might find those things soppy. Well, okay, that's all right as well. But the point is that you can build up a treasure trove of these things. This is where memory, instead of becoming the machine of anger and regrets and shame and remorse, it becomes, you use it to build your Aladdin's cave with these memories.

I'd love it if you could share some, you know, anything you find that elevates. So you place this memory here, and as you breathe out, you give it to the world. You see? So it's the quality, the frequencies, the resonance of your heart breathing. Right.

I'd like you all to put your hands now in *gassho*. And with me, you can just think it if you like. Okay, I can't hear you, so just for today, okay? And we do it three times. You'll find it on your sheets. Just listen to me anyway, if you can't quite remember. It's very simple. Right.

Just for today, I will be thankful. Just for today, I'll be free from anger and fear. Just for today I will be honest and kind. Just for today, I will be thankful. Just for today I will be free from anger and fear. Just for today I will be honest and kind. Just for today I will be thankful. Just for today I will be free from anger and fear. Just for today I will be honest and kind.

Now we wait. Let's just rub our hands. Think of the left hand, think of the right hand. Left hand, right hand. Left palm, right palm. Left palm, right palm. Now if you haven't got your shoes off, I haven't, I've got my slippers on, I'm kicking them off here. It doesn't matter if you can't. Energy likes these little hollows in the body, likes to nestle in them.

Left arch, yes, it's the left arch. Right, think of the left arch of your foot. Now the right. Now the left arch. Now the right. The left arch. Now the right. Now go to your right palm. Right palm. Left palm. Left arch. Right arch. Right palm. Left palm. Left arch. Right arch of the foot.

Now we're going to go around in a circle. Right. Here, enter here, then left foot, right foot. Get the circle going. It's a circle of energy. Feel it going around. Just feel it going around now. We've got a circle going. Can you feel that going? I think some of you can actually.

Okay, now just slow it down. Now the left arch, now the right palm, the left palm, the right arch, with a figure of eight. Left foot, right palm, left palm, right arch, left arch, and up. Now get the figure of eight going. Okay? Now it can move as fast as thought, and there's no other thing that has moved as fast as thought. It's, I think it's the fastest thing on the planet, isn't it? I don't know. And like a train stopping.

Okay. Lie down. If you can find a place to lie down, please. And if you lie down and just think, try to invite the energy.

Try to feel, get that sense of allowing. May all beings be happy and safe. May all beings be happy and safe. May all beings be happy and safe.

If you lift your hands just to your brow between the eyes and just silently ask the energy to flow freely for your highest and greatest good and for the highest and greatest good of all those whose lives you touch. May the energy of Reiki flow freely for my highest and greatest good and for the highest and greatest good of all those whose lives I touch. And then a third touch. May the energy of Reiki flow freely for my highest and greatest good and the highest and greatest good of all those whose lives I touch.

Now we breathe in. Place the hands over the eyes gently, just touching gently. I want you to just do a couple of breaths of inner cleansing just to clear away any distractions. Breathe in. Send the energy out. In fact, you can send it to your fingers and your toes. Know that you're a very special important person, creative, an amazing machine with infinite possibilities. Feel a sense of tenderness. You are the child, you are the child no less.

Now relax your hands and imagine them floating away. Don't move consciously. Just think of your hands. Imagine them floating off your skin. As soon as you relax, they will do it. Now move them to the side of your head. You can put them over your ears if you prefer. Take a good breath. Send the energy out. Allow it. Let me see you breathe. Allow

it to go to your fingers and your feet. And feel it in your hands tingling. Imagine your hands floating. Just relax them. Only think of them floating off your skin and feel the space between. Sense the space between. It's alive.

Now gently move your hands to the back of your head. One higher than the other, as if you're resting your head in bed on the pillow with your hands behind you, but not on top of each other. Fingers close. Now imagine your fingers floating away. Well of course if you're lying down you can't do that obviously. I'm sitting up you see. So just gently let them slide down towards the front of the neck until the heels of your hands meet so it's like a cup rest, a little golfer's seat with a spike. So this covers around the throat.

Imagine your hands gently relaxing from there and leaving that area. Now you put them on your chest with fingers close together and fingers pointing in towards each other and it would be the middle fingers would be touching.

Just to get rid of any distractions that might have got in the way, let's do an inner cleansing. Breathe in and as you breathe out let the polarity be your fingertips and your toes. Breathing fingertips and the toes. Bring your tips and toes. Love your heart. We're talking about an electromagnetic field that is not just a bit more than the brain's. We're talking a few thousand, you know. It has a very big electromagnetic field.

Now down to the lower part where the bottom of the sternum. That little novel there where the thymus would be. You know when a child is distressed, when a child is distressed and the parent, they put their hand on the child and just cuddle them and say, "It's going to be all right, it's going to be all right." That is the relationship now between you and your body. You and yourself, if you like. You don't have to overthink it, just treat yourself as you would treat a child. It's going to be okay.

Now gently slide the hands down towards the inguinal fold, covering the lower part of the abdomen and pointing down towards the base energy centre, towards the genitals. I want you to put one hand over your stomach, over the solar plexus, and another hand on your forehead. There's no past. There is no future. There is now. There is no anger. There is no fear. There is gratitude.

Now bring your hand down from your forehead and put it over the other one. Now cross your hands like a Saint Andrew's cross, with one hand pointing to the opposite shoulder diagonally. Feel gratitude and the love for the healing energy of compassion.

Wiggle your toes and roll your shoulders a bit and take your hands away. Hands can rest out. I give thanks for the healing energy of Reiki. I give thanks for the healing energy of Reiki. I give thanks for the healing energy of Reiki.

All right. Sorry, we overran a bit, but we had a slow start. It doesn't bother me, by the way. I'm not worried. But before you go, I should give you time to adjust a bit, shouldn't I? I've been sitting, you see, but I suppose most of you have been. You can do this sitting, of course. We would have spent a bit of time on any parts of the body that you were concerned about. It's just that we're a bit late.

Could you make it known if you'd like to manage an 11 o'clock Zoom tomorrow, if you can? I don't know whether... If you could type in yes or no or something here, then I'll know now rather than sending me an email. Jackie, Krish. Oh, Krish, you've put "sound had gone." Oh, so you haven't managed to get onto the Zoom, Krish? That's 11 o'clock in the morning, okay.

Well, look, I tell you what, why don't we just have one anyway? For those who can't come, do send me an email with any questions you have, okay? If you can't make the 11 o'clock one. I don't know why I can feel your energy, but it's quite extraordinary. I could feel it during the day today. It's a new one. This is a new thing. It looks as if I've got about 100 in the class, but I think it's people just sending messages.

I'm going to go now. And you've been a lovely, lovely class. And sleep well. *Mettā*. Breathe well. And love yourself.

Kālāma Sutta (AN 3.65)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 19 min

In this engaging talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma begins an exploration of the renowned Kālāma Sutta (AN 3.65), one of the Buddha's most famous discourses on critical thinking and spiritual discernment. The episode opens with a contemporary essay by Italian philosopher Gloria Origgi about our transition from the "information age" to the "reputation age," where we increasingly rely on others' evaluations rather than direct knowledge.

Bhante then introduces the Kālāma Sutta, where the Buddha encounters the Kālāmas of Kesaputta, who express confusion about conflicting teachings from various spiritual teachers. The Buddha's response offers timeless guidance: "don't go by reports, by legends, by traditions, by scripture, by logical conjecture, by inference, by analogy, by agreement through pondering views, by probability, or by thought." Instead, he emphasizes direct personal experience and practical wisdom.

This teaching addresses the fundamental question of how to evaluate spiritual teachings and information in our complex world. The Buddha's approach emphasizes discernment based on whether teachings lead to skillful or unskillful outcomes, harm or benefit. While focusing on spiritual development, these principles offer valuable guidance for navigating information in our modern digital age.

And I've also moved the repeater right here, so we've got one hundred percent all the way. I'm absolutely sure this evening I shall be with you all the time. I trust you've had a fruitful day. I don't say happy, but I hope it has been happy.

Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

Now this evening I'm going a little off-piste. I've been, as you know, working from the scriptures. I do mean to reference the scripture, but I came across this essay. Those of you who know the *Kālāma Sutta*, where the Buddha really tries to explain what we should believe in—at some point I won't give the game away for those who've not read it. We'll wait until I've actually read the discourse, which I hope to read tonight. But I want to just read this essay by an Italian philosopher, Gloria Origgi. She wrote a book in 2017 called "Why Trust Matters."

There is an underappreciated paradox of knowledge that plays a pivotal role in our advanced, hyper-connected liberal democracies. The greater amount of information that circulates, the more we rely on so-called reputational devices to evaluate it. What

makes this paradoxical is that the vastly increased access to information and knowledge we have today does not empower us or make us more cognitively autonomous. Rather, it renders us more dependent on other people's judgements and evaluations of the information with which we are faced.

We are experiencing a fundamental paradigm shift in our relationship to knowledge. From the information age, we are moving towards the reputation age, in which information will have value only if it is already filtered, evaluated and commented upon by others. Seen in this light, reputation has become a central pillar of our collective intelligence today. It is the gatekeeper to knowledge, and the keys to the gate are held by others. The way in which the authority of knowledge is now constructed makes us reliant on what are the inevitable biased judgements of other people, most of whom we do not know.

Let me give some examples of this paradox. If you are asked why you believe that big changes in the climate are occurring and can dramatically harm future life on earth, the most reasonable answer you're likely to provide is that you trust the reputation of the sources of information to which you usually turn for acquiring information about the state of the planet. In the best case scenario, you trust the reputation of scientific research and believe that peer review—the review of other scientists—is a reasonable way of sifting out truths from false hypotheses about nature. In the average case scenario, you trust newspapers, magazines, or TV channels that endorse a political view which supports scientific research to summarise its findings for you. In the latter case, you are twice removed from the sources. You trust other people's trust in reputable science.

Or take an even more controversial example. One of the most notorious conspiracy theories is that no man stepped on the moon in 1969 and that the entire Apollo program, including six landings on the moon between 69 and 72, was a staged fake. The initiator of this conspiracy theory was Bill Kaysing, who worked in publications at the Rocketdyne Company, where Apollo's Saturn V rocket engines were built. At his own expense, Kaysing published the book "We Never Went to the Moon: America's Thirty Billion Dollar Swindle." After publication, a movement of sceptics grew and started to collect evidence about the alleged hoax.

According to the Flat Earth Society, one of the groups that still denies the facts, the moon landings were staged by Hollywood with the support of Walt Disney and under the artistic direction of Stanley Kubrick. Most of the proofs they advanced are based on seemingly accurate analysis of the pictures of the various landings: the shadow angles are inconsistent with the light; the United States flag blows even if there's no wind on

the moon; the tracks of the steps are too precise and well-preserved for a soil in which there is no moisture. Also, is it not suspicious that the program that involved more than 400,000 people for six years was shut down abruptly, and so on?

The great majority of people we would consider reasonable and accountable—myself included—will dismiss these claims by laughing at the very absurdity of the hypothesis. Although there have been serious and documented responses by NASA against these allegations, if I asked myself on what evidentiary basis I believe that there has been a moon landing, I must admit that my evidence is quite poor, and that I've never invested a second trying to debunk the counter-evidence accumulated by those conspiracy theorists.

What I personally know about the facts mixes confused childhood memories, black and white television news, the deference to my parents who told me about the landing in subsequent years. Still, the wholly second-hand and personally uncorroborated quality of this evidence does not make me hesitate about the truth of my beliefs in the matter. My reasons for believing that the moon landing took place go far beyond the evidence I can gather and double-check about the event itself. In those years, we trusted a democracy such as the US to have a justified reputation for sincerity.

Without an evaluative judgement about the reliability of a certain source of information, that information is, for all practical purposes, useless. The paradigm shift from the age of information to the age of reputation must be taken into account when we defend ourselves from fake news and other misinformation and disinformation techniques that are proliferating through contemporary societies.

What a mature citizen of the digital age should be competent at is not spotting and confirming the veracity of the news. Rather, she should be competent at reconstructing the reputational path of a piece of information in question, evaluating the intentions of those who circulated it, and figuring out the agendas of those authorities that lent it credibility. Whenever we are at the point of accepting or rejecting new information, we should ask ourselves: where does it come from? Does the source have a good reputation? Who are the authorities who believe it? And what are my reasons for deferring to these authorities? Such questions will help us to get a better grip on reality than trying to check directly the reliability of the information at issue.

In the hyper-specialised system of the production of knowledge, it makes no sense to try to investigate on our own, for example, the possible correlation between vaccines and autism. It would be a waste of time and probably our conclusions would not be accurate. In the reputation age, our critical appraisals should be directed not at the con-

tent of information, but rather at the social network of relations that has shaped that content and given it a certain deserved or undeserved rank in our system of knowledge.

These new competencies constitute a sort of second-order knowledge. They prepare us to question and assess the reputation of an information source, something that philosophers and teachers should be crafting for future generations. According to Frederick Hayek's book "Law, Legislation and Liberty," civilisation rests on the fact that we all benefit from knowledge we do not possess. A civilised cyber world will be one where people know how to assess critically the reputation of information sources and can empower their knowledge by learning how to gauge appropriately the social rank of each bit of information that enters their cognitive field.

I just think it's a great article when you bring to mind everything that happened around Brexit—the fabrications, the exaggerations and so on and so forth. It basically fed into people's prejudices, and we weren't sure many times where the information was coming from.

Now to complement that is of course the famous *Kālāma Sutta*. I'll just read the first part so that you can get the flavour of it, and then tomorrow we can go into it a little bit more deeply.

I have heard that on one occasion, the Blessed One, on a wandering tour among the Kosalans with a large community of monks, arrived at Kesaputta, the town of the Kalamas. The Kalamas of Kesaputta heard it said: "Gotama the contemplative, son of the Sakyans, having gone forth from the Sakyan clan, has arrived at Kesaputta. And of that Master Gotama, this fine reputation has spread: 'He is indeed the Blessed One, worthy, rightly self-awakened, consummate in knowledge and conduct, well-gone—I don't know why they keep translating *Tathāgata* as well-gone—the transcendent one, a knower of the cosmos—that's not the physical cosmos, that's all the different worlds—an unexcelled trainer of those persons ready to be trained, teacher of human and divine beings, awakened, blessed. He has made known, having realised it through direct knowledge, this world with its *devas*, its gods, its *māras*, *brahmās*, its generations with its contemplatives and brahmins, their rulers and common people. He has explained the *Dhamma*, admirable in the beginning, admirable in the middle and admirable in the end. He has expounded the holy life, both in its particulars and in its essence, entirely perfect, surpassingly pure. It is good to see such a worthy one.'"

All that is often repeated through the scriptures as a description of the Buddha. Actually in the morning we chant part of that series.

Now this next little bit gives us some idea of their social habits. So the Kalamas of Kesaputta went to the Blessed One. On arrival, some of them bowed down to him and sat to one side. Some of them exchanged courteous greetings with him and, after an exchange of friendly greetings and courtesies, sat to one side. Some of them sat to one side having saluted him with hands palm to palm over their hearts. Some of them sat to one side having announced their name and clan. And some of them sat to one side in silence.

As they sat there, the Kalamas of Kesaputta said to the Blessed One: "Lord, there are some brahmins and contemplatives who come to Kesaputta. They expound and glorify their own doctrines, but as for the doctrines of others, they deprecate them, revile them, show contempt for them and disparage them. And then other brahmins and contemplatives come to Kesaputta. They expound and glorify their own doctrines, but as for the doctrines of others, they deprecate them, revile them, show contempt for them and disparage them. They leave us absolutely uncertain and in doubt. Which of these venerable brahmins and contemplatives are speaking the truth and which ones are lying?"

The Buddha replies: "Of course you're uncertain, Kalamas. Of course you're in doubt when there are reasons for doubt. Uncertainty is born. So in this case, Kalamas"—now here's the statement for personal freedom of thought or direction, in the same sense as the essay that I've read—"don't go by reports, by legends, by traditions, by scripture, by logical conjecture, by inference, by analogy, by agreement through pondering views, by probability, or by the thought, 'This contemplative is our teacher.' When you know for yourselves that these qualities are unskillful, these qualities are blameworthy, these qualities are criticised by the wise, these qualities when adopted and carried out lead to harm and to suffering, then you should abandon them."

I want to leave it there. It's a good time to leave it, and what we'll do tomorrow is just go into the Buddha's categories of why we shouldn't believe something, or at least not give it credence. He's always going towards the practical: what have you actually experienced? Now this of course relates specifically to the spiritual life within ourselves, because it's about our personal experience—not so much to what the essay is about, which is the information coming from the outside world. But there's obviously a correlation.

I shall leave you in suspense until tomorrow. I can only hope the little reading and readings have been helpful, and that you will continue your meditations.

Caṅkī Sutta (MN 95) — Questioning Beliefs and Groundless Conclusions

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 18 min

In this engaging exploration of the Caṅkī Sutta (MN 95), Bhante Bodhidhamma presents the Buddha's encounter with Brahmin Caṅkī and his learned student Kāpaṭhika. The discourse reveals the social dynamics of ancient Indian caste society, where Brahmins claimed superiority based on birth, learning, and scriptural authority.

The Buddha masterfully challenges the Brahmins' assertion that "only this is true, anything else is wrong" by questioning whether any of them has direct, personal experience of these truths. Using the vivid metaphor of a file of blind men, he demonstrates how religious claims can be passed down through generations without any foundation in actual knowledge.

Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the five unreliable ways of knowing: faith (saddhā), oral tradition, personal preference, reasoned cogitation, and reflective acceptance of views. Each can lead to either truth or falsehood, making definitive conclusions dangerous. This teaching directly connects to the Kālāma Sutta's guidance on not accepting teachings based solely on tradition or authority.

The talk emphasizes how beliefs can become barriers to genuine Dhamma practice, particularly in vipassanā meditation where we must remain open rather than trying to manifest preconceived notions. A perfect foundation for questioning our own conclusions and approaching the path with beginner's mind.

Good evening all. I trust you had a fruitful day. I don't say happy, but I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

I hope some of you were able to join the Buddha celebrations this evening, which I thought were really fantastic.

So I want to move on to another discourse over the next two or three days. And then on Monday, I'm starting a course, a *Vipassanā* course with the Gaia group. So it's Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday. You're welcome to join it. I'm just thinking, I'll email the

connections later on, I think, or I'll send it out with a news bite. And I'll be doing the usual thing of meditating at eight o'clock in the morning. Something like that. Anyway, I shall send details or better still, if you think you might want to practice, even if it's only one of the sessions during the day, send me an email and I'll send you the details. Perhaps that's the best way to do it. And on those days, I'll probably be going through very quickly the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse.

So it's just the next three days that we're looking at. And I've chosen to do a sutta called Caṅkī, the Caṅkī Sutta. And I want to read the first part, not because it's so much Dhamma, but because it gives you some idea of the society that was in.

So it would seem that in the old days, of course, the Kṣatriyas, the warrior caste, the aristocracy, were the rulers, were at the top of the ladder. This would have been a time when they were conquering, when they were settling into North India. And going really back, they would have been chieftains and the Brahmins would have been their shamans. They'd be the shamans. As time progressed, of course, the shamans gathered or began to develop these verses. A lot of them were just spells or ways of doing certain rituals to get the better of the gods. And as they began to settle on the Gangetic plain, by the time the Buddha was there, there was no need for this warrior caste so much. They were fighting with each other.

And the Brahmins began to establish themselves as the superior caste. And I think we joined that time that the idea was that they came from the mouth of Brahmā, the warriors came from the shoulders of Brahmā, the workers and the trades people and all that came from the body of Brahmā. And of course the Śūdras, the ones right at the bottom came from the feet. And it would seem that in the East of India, present day Bengal, the Brahmins had established themselves as the top caste. But it hadn't really established itself where the Buddha was. And so there was a bit of argy-bargy going on. And I think we catch this in this particular discourse.

So on one occasion, the Blessed One was wandering in the Kosalan country with a large *saṅgha* of *bhikkhus*, and eventually he arrived at the Kosalan Brahmin village. I think you still get that in India. I'm almost, well, I'm not absolutely sure, but villages will be Brahmin or Kṣatriya or whatever. They'll be quite separate. And he arrives at a village called, the Brahmin village called Upasada. And there the Blessed One's staying at the God's grove, that's the Deva grove, the Salah tree grove to the north of Upasada.

Now on that occasion, the Brahmin Caṅkī, who was ruling over Upasada, a crown property abounding in living beings, rich in grasslands, woodlands, waterways and grain, a royal endowment, a sacred grant given to him by King Pasenadi of Kosala. And then on that occasion, so the householders now decided to go and see the Buddha. And

he had retired, Caṅkī had retired to the upper story of his palace for the midday rest. And then he saw the Brahmin householders of Upasada setting forth towards the God's Grove.

When he saw them, he asked his minister, "Good minister, why are these Brahmin householders of Upasada setting forth from Upasada in groups and bands heading northwards to the God's Grove?" "Sir," and then he tells him that the recluse, the Samaṇa Gautama, that's how he would be referred to, the son of the Sakians who's gone forth from the Sakian clan, has been wandering in the Kosalan country.

So then he sends his minister, he says, tell them to wait. The Brahmin Caṅkī will also go to see the recluse Gautama. And off he goes.

Now, on that occasion, 500 Brahmins from various states were staying in Upasada for some business or other. And they heard this Brahmin Caṅkī was going to see the recluse, so they went to see him. "Sir, do not go to see the recluse Gautama. It's not proper for Master Caṅkī to go and see the recluse Gautama. Rather, it is proper for the recluse Gautama to come and see you. For you, sir, are well born on both sides of pure maternal and paternal descent seven generations back, unassailable, impeccable in respect of birth. Since that is so, Master Caṅkī, it's not proper for you to go to see Master Gautama, Recluse Gautama, rather Recluse Gautama has come to see you."

"You are rich, great wealth, great possessions. Master of the three Vedas and the vocabularies. That's the Vedas of the liturgical texts. Liturgy, phonology, etymology, and the histories as a fifth. Skilled in philology and grammar." I did have to look up philology. It means interpretation of the texts. "And you are fully versed in natural philosophy and the marks of the great man. You are handsome, comely, graceful, possessing supreme beauty of completion, with sublime beauty and sublime presence remarkable to behold. You are virtuous, mature in virtue, possessing mature virtue. You're a good speaker with good delivery. You speak words that are courteous, distinct, flawless, and communicate the meaning. You teach teachers of many and you teach the recitation of the hymns to the 300 Brahmin students. You, sir, are honoured, respected, revered, venerated and esteemed by the King Pasenadi of Kosala. You, sir, are honoured, respected, revered and esteemed by the Brahmin Pokharasāti. You, sir, rule over Upasada a crown property abounding in living beings a sacred grant given to you by the king. Since this is so, Master Caṅkī, it is not proper for you to go to the recluse Gautama, rather it is proper for the recluse Gautama to come to you."

Now the Brahmin says, "No, now hear me," he says right, and he says virtually the same about the Buddha. Saying that, you know, he came from a homeless nurse to live the life of a recluse, noble in virtue, wholesome, etc., etc. But then he says, "Sirs, the

recluse Gautama is free from sensual lust and without personal vanity. Sirs, the recluse Gautama holds the doctrine of moral efficacy of action, *kamma*, the doctrine of moral efficacy of deeds. He does not seek any harm for the line of Brahmins. The recluse Gautama has gone forth from an aristocratic family, one of the original noble families."

So here we see the caste system in bright colours. Of course, our class can also be much the same and how they measure themselves as opposed to the other castes. But in this particular case, he seems to honour the Buddha with the same accomplishments. And at the end, there's a repetition of what has become the morning chanting. "Now the Blessed One is accomplished, fully enlightened, perfect in true knowledge and conduct, what he says he does. Sublime, knower of the worlds," that's the cosmology of Buddhism. "Incomparable leader of persons to be tamed, teacher of gods and humans, enlightened and blessed." So he goes off.

Now they're all there with them. So they all go down there. And then the Brahmin Caṅkī, together with a large company of Brahmins, went to the Blessed One, exchanged greetings, etc. And after courteous and amiable talk was finished, he sat down to one side.

Now on that occasion, the Blessed One was seated, finishing some amiable talk with some senior Brahmins. At the time, sitting in the assembly was a Brahmin student named Kāpaṭhika. Young, head-shaven, 16 years old, he was the master of the three Vedas with their vocabulary, liturgy, phonology and etymology and the histories as a fifth. Skilled in philology and grammar, he was fully versed in natural philosophy and in the marks of the great man.

While the senior Brahmins were conversing with the Blessed One, he often broke in and interrupted their talk. Then the Blessed One rebuked the Brahmin students thus, "Let not the Venerable Bhāradvāja break in and interrupt the talk of the very senior Brahmins while they are conversing. Let the Venerable One wait until the talk is finished."

And when this was said, the Brahmin Caṅkī said to the Blessed One, "Let not Master Gautama rebuke the Brahmin student. The Brahmin student Kāpaṭhika is a clansman. He is very learned. He is very good delivery. He is wise. He is capable of taking part in the discussion with Master Gautama."

Then the Blessed One thought to himself, "Surely since the Brahmins honour him, thus the Brahmin student must be accomplished in the scriptures of the three Vedas." Then the Brahmin student thought, "When the recluse Gautama catches my eye, I shall

ask him a question." Then knowing with his mind the thought of the Brahmin student, the Blessed One turned his eye towards him. And the Brahmin student thought, "The recluse Gautama turned towards me, suppose I ask him a question."

Then he said to the Blessed One, "Master Gautama, in regard to the ancient Brahminic hymns that have come down through oral transmission and in the scriptural collections, the Brahmins come to a definite conclusion. Only this is true. Anything else is wrong. What does Master Gautama say about this?"

"Now then, Bhāradvāja, among the Brahmins, is there even a single Brahmin now who says, I know this, I see this by my own personal experience? Only this is true and anything else is wrong?" "No, Master Gautama."

"Well, then Brahmins, the ancient Brahmin seers, the creators of the hymns, the composers of the hymns, whose ancient hymns have been formally chanted, uttered and compiled by Brahmins nowadays, that the Brahmins nowadays still chant and repeat, repeating what was spoken and recited," and then there's a whole load of names of the ancient rishis, the ancient teachers. "Did even these ancient, did even these Brahmin seers say thus, we know this, we see this for ourselves, only this is true, anything else is wrong, everything else is wrong?" "No, Master Gautama."

"So, Bhāradvāja, it seems that among the Brahmins, there is not even a single Brahmin who can say, I know this, I see this for myself. And among the Brahmins, there's not even a single teacher or a single teacher's teacher. Going back to the seventh generation of teachers who say, I know this, I see this by my own personal experience. The ancient Brahmin seers, the creators of the hymns and so on. Even these cannot say, we know this, we see this by our own personal experience and that only this is true and everything else is wrong."

"Supposing there's a file of blind men, each in touch with the next. The first one does not see, the middle one does not see, and the last one does not see. So, Bhāradvāja, in regard to their statement, the Brahmins seem to be like a file of blind men. The first one does not see, the middle one does not see, and the last one does not see. What do you think, Bhāradvāja? That being so, does not the faith of Brahmins turn out to be groundless?"

"The Brahmins honour this not only out of faith, Master Gautama, but also out of oral tradition."

"Ah, Bhāradvāja, first you took your stand on faith, now you speak of the oral tradition. There are five ways, Bhāradvāja, that may turn out in two different ways here and now. What are these five?"

Now, this goes back to the Kālāma discourse, right? How we can use various ways of knowing things in order to prove what we think is true. Faith, approval. So that's more to do with the heart. You have a heart connection with the teacher, with the tradition. This is often true of people who are brought up in religious traditions. They don't question anything. It's just part and parcel of the way they see the world.

Oral tradition, right? Just because it's come from the past. So this is the traditionalists or the fundamentalists. Reasoned cogitation and reflective acceptance of view. Now the problem with reason and reflecting, you're always, all this reasoning and reflecting is based on a premise. If the premise is false, the whole thing comes crashing down. So these five things may turn out in two different ways.

Now something may be fully accepted by faith and yet may be empty, hollow and false. But something else may be fully accepted by faith and yet may be factual, true and unmistakable. And so he goes through the other types of misunderstood ways of thinking about things or coming to believe in things. "It is not proper that a wise man who preserves truth to come to a definite conclusion: only this is true, anything else is false."

So I love this thing about definite conclusion. And I want to end here with, because it goes on then as to how do we know the truth? That's what the discourse is about.

Some of you might have heard me tell you this little tale. I was on the way last year down to Brighton and when I got to the edge of London somewhere, some rugby fans came on and they sat opposite me and I don't think they were tipsy, they were just high and one of them said to me, "Are you a Buddhist monk?" and I said, "Yes I am." And he said, "Well I don't believe in reincarnation." And I said to him, "Do you know, I mean by your personal experience, you know, have you died and remembered, I mean do you know by your personal experience whether there's reincarnation or not?" And he said, "No." So I said to him, "Well then why come to a conclusion?" And his mate said, "Yeah, why do you come to a conclusion?" So that was just a lovely moment there.

So even we ourselves, you know, it's good to question what conclusions have I come to and on what grounds have I come to those conclusions? And I know we shouldn't be surprised when we find that actually a lot of our conclusions are groundless. Or some of them are, or maybe just one is. But it's worth questioning ourselves about what are our conclusions? What do we actually believe?

Remember, in the Buddhist teaching, beliefs can be a real barrier because often when you believe something, you want to manifest that belief. And as he says, it might be completely wrong. So it's a case of dropping all beliefs and just opening up to the Dhamma when we're practicing, especially when we're practicing the *Vipassanā*. Very good.

So I hope my words have been of some assistance, not caused any confusion. May you be fully liberated in this very lifetime. We can begin our meditation.

Kālāma Discourse (continued)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

In this continuation of his exploration of the Kālāma Sutta (Aṅguttara Nikāya 3.65), Bhante Bodhidhamma delves deeper into the Buddha's revolutionary approach to spiritual authority and personal investigation. The discourse addresses the Kālāmas' confusion when faced with conflicting religious teachers, each claiming exclusive truth while denouncing others.

Bhante examines the Buddha's systematic rejection of ten unreliable sources of knowledge: tradition, hearsay, scripture, logical conjecture, axioms, personal bias, teacher authority, and others. Through contemporary examples—from medical history to conspiracy theories—he illustrates how these fallacies persist today. The Buddha's approach transcends mere skepticism, staying grounded in direct personal experience rather than metaphysical speculation.

The talk then explores the ethical foundation the Buddha established after clearing away false authorities: the abandonment of greed, hatred, and delusion, naturally leading to the four brahmavihāras (loving-kindness, compassion, appreciative joy, and equanimity). Bhante concludes with the Buddha's 'four assurances'—practical benefits of ethical living that hold true regardless of one's beliefs about rebirth or karma, making this teaching accessible to people of all backgrounds while maintaining its profound spiritual depth.

Greetings. I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa — Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

Before I launch into the Kālāma discourse, just to remind you, tomorrow evening, if you want to join the Buddha Day celebrations, it's going to start at 9.45. I'll be sending out a news bite with the details again. And you're going to have to download the Zoom app because they haven't sent me a link which would get you on to Zoom through Google or another way. That's at 19.40. That's quarter to eight tomorrow. And it's about an hour and a half long. I'll repeat it again, of course, this evening, just in case you missed it.

So we were taught, we read yesterday Professor... I can't remember her name now. Anyway, we read it. And it's not as though we don't know that, because we know we're always going through secondhand knowledge, secondhand opinion, views and opinion.

It's just that it really made me realize that that's what I'm doing and that I really ought to check out when I read something: who's actually funded it? Where's it coming from? What's the organization? It just made it very much more real to me.

So here we have the Kālāmas, Kesaputta, in the city of Kesaputta. And remember what they said: they've got all these people coming, all these teachers, they're all confused. One says, "This is right, nobody else is wrong." Disparage, denigrate, deride and denounce the doctrines of the others.

So then he goes through all these various ways in which they mustn't believe just because. So there's one which is an appeal to traditions. That's the first one. The first one is not to go by tradition, not just by reports or by because something's been said over and over. Jumping on the bandwagon.

For instance, this habit that some people have — it used to be worse — where they got to be sipping water all the time. It seems that there were two reasons, two origins of this. One was concentration camps where people would approach a doctor in the concentration camp and tell them about their illness, and of course all he could say was drink water. In drinking water, they tended at least to ameliorate the disease they had. But the other one was in 1945, the Food and Nutrition Board of the USA advised people to drink 2.5 litres a day, but seemingly without any research at all. It was just pulled out of the air. So it's just what you hear when you say it's this whole business of what everybody else is doing must be right.

Same with tradition. It's the tradition, "this is the way we've always done it," so this is the way it's going to be. It tends to be very conservative — that's small "c" — just keeping the way things are. And of course, it prevents creativity.

Then you get rumours, mainly anecdotal evidence, just personal evidence. Somebody said this and therefore it must be true. When I ran my first course up in Yorkshire, near Thirsk, it was a beautiful big house. And there was a man who was looking after it, Johnny, a real Yorkshire man. And one day we're in conversation and he was telling me that he'd smoked all his life and it had not done him any harm. And I'd been watching him smoke and it must've just caught me the way he was doing it or something. So I said to him, "Well, do you inhale the smoke, Johnny?" And he said, "No." I said, "Well, you're obviously not going to get lung cancer." But of course, he would have gone around telling everybody that he smoked for 30, 40 a day and nothing's ever happened.

There was also another story, this is way back a few years now, when there was all this stuff about paedophilia, people were afraid. And it seems as though somebody turned up at a house, a gang of people turned up at a house to approach this man. And when he came out and they accused him of paedophilia, he pointed out that he wasn't. He was a paediatrician. So anyway, that's these little stories I've come across.

Of course, religious texts — these, of course, can be quite wicked. We know what fundamentalists do with texts. But just because it's in the scriptures, it doesn't mean it's right. Now, that's really quite radical. So he's basically saying that about his own teaching.

Also, not by inference or by logical conjecture or by inference. It's very interesting that the Buddha doesn't really go beyond what you can personally experience. He says that there's something in us which is not of this order. It's beyond or above or transcendent of the psychophysical organism. And this is the Nibbāna Dhātu as it's put in Theravāda, the element of *Nibbāna*. As Mahāyāna would say, it's our Buddha nature. It's this very *satipañña*, this intuitive awareness.

But he never talks about what the relationship of that is to somebody else's *satipañña* and what happens after death. Of course, there is a tradition that Buddhas are reborn in other realms. But the other one is that that's it, and something happens to that Buddha nature or that *satipañña*. And he doesn't talk about that at all. In other words, there's no ultimate God, there's no Brahman, this impersonal God whom you absorb into, come out of, as it would be in Hinduism. So there's nothing — it doesn't go beyond what can be personally experienced.

The phrase that captures this is "the map is not the territory." It's getting confused with ideas and logical ideas and all that with actually what's real. So the Buddha doesn't go into metaphysical propositions so much.

The other one is upon axiom because it contradicts established norms or beliefs and whatnot. And I found that there's a special title for this. It's called the Semmelweis Reflex. And this is the story. It derives from the name of a Hungarian physician, Ignaz Semmelweis, who discovered in 1847 that childbed fever mortality rates fell tenfold when doctors disinfected their hands with chlorine solution before moving from one patient to another, and most particularly after an autopsy.

At one of the two maternity wards at the University Hospital where Semmelweis worked, physicians performed autopsy on every deceased patient. Semmelweis's procedure saved many lives by stopping the ongoing contamination of patients, mostly pregnant women, with what he termed "cadaverous particles." This is 20 years before

germ theory was discovered. Despite overwhelming empirical evidence, his fellow doctors rejected — I think maybe not all, but many of his fellow doctors rejected his hand washing suggestions, often for non-medical reasons. For instance, some doctors refused to believe that a gentleman's hand could transmit disease. So this is the fact and this is the way it is, and that's impossible.

There's also specious silly reasoning, illogical reasoning. This is again a formal thing — they call it divine fallacy. If you can't understand something, if like, for instance, if you're in a God believing community, if you can't understand something, then God knows, everything's put down to God.

I remember I was up in Kandy once, and I was up there visiting and I happened to share a bench with a Muslim and we got talking and I asked him about God. And I said to him, "What's the proof that God exists?" And he just pointed to nature and said, "All this — God made this." And that was it. That was it. There's no argument against that. By the way, this also includes conspiracy theories.

And the final one — yes, the final one. The final one is upon another's seeming ability or that this particular monk or this particular person is my teacher. So this is often a big mistake, isn't it? Where people devote themselves blindly to a teacher or to a particular tradition and they can't get out of it. An example of this is "How dare you criticise the prime minister? What do you know about running an entire country?" So we won't go into that one.

Now, usually when people mention this Kālāma discourse and they point out the free thinking that the Buddha is saying, that it's up to you. Let me just get the quote there. "But when, Kālāmas, you know for yourselves these things are unwholesome, these things are blameworthy, these things are censured by the wise, these things, if accepted and undertaken, lead to harm and suffering, then you should abandon them." And of course, he says the opposite for what's good.

So he's always really pushing people to investigate for themselves and to be sure for themselves by their own experience. So that's why it's called a charter of free thought, the Kālāma Discourse.

But he doesn't stop there. He does go into quite a discourse then about really the two things that he teaches throughout the scriptures: ethics and transcendence. This one is not so concerned with transcendence. It comes right at the end, as you'll see, but always about ethics.

So that's his first question here: "What do you think? When greed arises in a person, is that for his welfare or for his harm?" "It is for his harm, Bhante." "Kālāmas, is a greedy person overcome by greed, with mind obsessed by it, destroys life, takes what he's not given, transgresses with another's wife, speaks falsehood, and he encourages others to do likewise. Will that lead to his harm and suffering for a long time?" "Yes, Bhante."

And of course then he goes on to hatred and on to delusion. And then he says the opposite, of course. It's a question and answer thing. Remember these are remembered, so there has to be a certain repetition to make it easy to remember these discourses. "What do you think, Kālāmas? Are these things wholesome or unwholesome? Blameworthy or..." and then he goes on.

And then, of course, says the opposite. "When non-greed arises in a person, is it for his welfare or his harm?" Says "for his welfare." "Kālāmas, a person without greed, not overcome by greed, his mind not obsessed by it, does not destroy life, take what is not given, transgress with another's wife or speak falsehood. Nor does he encourage others to do likewise. Will that lead to his welfare and happiness for a long time?" "Yes, Bhante." And of course, the same with non-hatred and the same with non-delusion.

The Buddha does more often than not prefer the negative. So if there's not greed, then there must be all those qualities that are not greed. So instead of saying generosity and all that, trying to find words for all that, he just simply says where there's no greed, then there's not that possibility of making mistakes that greed would lead you to.

So then when he's cleared the path, when he said, "Look, it's up to you to decide what is to your welfare, to the welfare of others," then he goes: "Kālāmas, that noble disciple who is thus devoid of longing, devoid of ill will, unconfused, clearly comprehending, ever mindful, dwells pervading one quarter with his mind imbued with loving kindness, with a mind imbued with compassion, with a mind imbued with altruistic love, with a mind imbued with equanimity. And the second quarter, the third and the fourth quarter, thus above and below, across and everywhere, and to all as to himself, he dwells pervading the entire world with a mind imbued with equanimity, vast, exalted, measureless, without enmity, without ill will."

So that's a beautiful way of saying to people that once you stop all this negative stuff, the mind naturally moves towards these very beautiful mental states.

Now, and then he talks about the solaces or the assurances that come for somebody who behaves like that. "The noble disciple, Kālāmas, whose mind is in this way without enmity, without ill will, undefiled and pure, has won four assurances or solaces in this very life."

"The first assurance he has won is this: if there is another world and if there is fruit and results of good and bad deeds, it is possible that with the breakup of the body after death I will be reborn in a good destination in a heavenly world."

"The second assurance he has won is this: if there is no other world and there is no fruit and result of good and bad deeds, still right here in this very life I maintain myself in happiness without enmity and ill will, free of trouble." Right now — you've got to be careful here — doesn't mean to say that the person wouldn't have trouble, but in himself, in himself there remains this equanimity.

"The third assurance he has won is this: suppose evil comes to one who does evil. Then when I have no evil intentions towards anyone, how can suffering afflict me since I do no evil deed?"

"The fourth assurance he has won is this: supposing evil does not come to one who does evil" — right, evil does not come to one who does evil. So that's often a big question, isn't it? People get away with murder, as they say. "Suppose evil does not come to one who does evil, then right here I see myself purified in both respects."

"The noble disciple, Kālāmas, whose mind is in this way, without enmity, without ill will, undefiled and pure, has won these four assurances in this very life."

"So be it, O blessed one, so it is, fortunate one. This noble disciple whose mind is in this way, without enmity, without ill will, undefiled and pure, has won four assurances in this very life. Excellent, Bhante. We go to refuge to the Blessed One, to the Dharma and to the Sangha of Bhikkhus. Let the Blessed One consider us lay followers who from this day on has taken refuge for life."

That wasn't bad, was it? That was a very quick conversion there by the Buddha. They don't seem to have had time to take his words for real, to go away and actually see if what the Buddha was saying was actually true. So they've broken all the rules. Never mind.

So that's it, really. That's the Kālāma discourse. And as I say, normally only the first bit is discussed, how he talks about freedom of thought and that one has to have one's own personal experience as to what is beneficial or unbeneficial. But then he has no problem with getting people to understand the way that he himself saw was beneficial.

So I hope that's clarified the Kālāma Sutta a bit. If you hadn't come across it, it's a good one to remember. So I hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused depression, anxiety, confusion, and that it will encourage you to continue your investigations.

Sādhū, sādhū, sādhū.

So we can do a bit of meditation.

Caṅkī Sutta (cont.)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 19 min

In this continuation of his exploration of the Caṅkī Sutta (MN 95), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's teachings on how spiritual truth must be personally discovered through investigation rather than accepted on faith alone. The discourse reveals three crucial stages: preservation of truth (maintaining openness without premature conclusions), discovery of truth (the initial awakening through vipassanā practice), and final arrival at truth (complete realization through continued cultivation).

The talk emphasizes that Buddhism is fundamentally based on investigation, not blind faith. Even cherished beliefs about rebirth should remain open questions until personally verified. Bhante guides us through the systematic process outlined in the sutta: from initial confidence in the teachings, through finding a qualified teacher, to developing the zeal and determination necessary for penetrating insight. The path requires examining teachers for freedom from greed, hatred, and delusion, then applying sustained vipassanā investigation to realize the three characteristics directly.

This discourse underscores that awakening cannot be given by another—it must be personally realized through one's own investigative awareness. The ultimate truth (nibbāna) and insights into impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and not-self can only be discovered through sustained practice, making this a profoundly personal spiritual journey.

Good evening. I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, but I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa, Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa, Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa — Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

So, first of all, an apology. I mispronounced the word. It's not Canki, it's Chanki. The C in Pali is a ch and the K is a hard k. So from now on, I shall call him Chanki, the *Chanki Sutta*.

What this discourse is about is how do we know the truth and how do we get to realize truth for us, for ourselves, or in this case, for this particular Brahmin. Realizing the truth is the operative thing. How do you know for yourself what is your personal truth rather than believing others?

Now, I have to say there's a bit of Buddhist propaganda involved in here. When he asks him about whether the ancient rishis knew, the answer is that they didn't know. But actually, he would know that, and it's presumed that the Rig Vedas were in fact developed by these early rishis. So they must have known something.

There's another discourse where somebody who's a very close supporter of the leader of the Jains comes to see the Buddha and he's been sent by the Jain leader to convert the Buddha. And when he gets there the Buddha converts him and he becomes a follower of the Buddha. When the leader of the Jains hears this, then he vomits blood out of anger and dies. So you have to take these stories with a bit of pinch of salt, really. He didn't, obviously.

So now, in what way does one preserve the truth? If a person has faith, he preserves the truth when he says my faith is thus, but he does not yet come to a definite conclusion: only this is true, anything else is wrong. In this way there is a preservation of truth. In this way he preserves the truth. In this way we describe the preservation of the truth, but as yet there is no discovery of the truth.

He doesn't say he doesn't come to this definite conclusion: only this is true, nothing else is true, just because he has faith in something. So that's a big mistake, isn't it, a lot of people might make. And then the discovery of the truth here is, of course, referring to the awakening. So remember, whenever they talk about truth or aims or anything of that nature, it's always about the spiritual aim of the awakening.

And then he says if a person approves of something and he receives the oral tradition — so in our case books — and if he reaches a conclusion based on reason, cogitation or thinking about it, and he gains a reflective acceptance. Now faith has these two modes: it is both a heart connection with something, but it's also a reflective thing. As soon as you read something which strikes you as true, it lifts your confidence in what the book is saying.

I remember in my own case, it was a Zen book that I read way back when I was in Australia in the 70s. And I remember reading the book and it inspired me and I tried this business of awareness, which I presumed was watching yourself all the time. So I determined from where we were living in this flat to go up the road to the shops and I was going to watch myself all the way. By the time I got up I thought this is going to drive me crazy, so I stopped it. But that initial connection with Zen Buddhism actually, I think, finally gave me some inkling of confidence somewhere because when I went into a really bad period, first thing I thought of was I've got to get to Japan to meditate. So these things come to us, get little inklings, little openings. And I'm sure you've all got stories of how you first came across the Buddha's teachings.

So that's to do with that initial bit of faith. But then it has to be supported by not only the practice, but also by reason, your understanding. But because you've come to a reflective acceptance of the view, my reflective acceptance of the view is this, but he does not yet come to a definite conclusion: only this is true, nothing else, everything else is wrong. In this way, too, there is a preservation of the truth. In this way, the truth is preserved. And in this way, we describe the preservation of the truth.

Now, having stated this business of don't come to any conclusion about anything — I mean, one of the great doubts for us is this whole thing about rebirth, reincarnation and whatnot. And unless we ourselves have had an experience personally of remembering our past lives or of leaving the body and going to a particular heaven, then there's no point in coming to a conclusion. One leaves it open. I mean, let's face it, when we die we'll either find ourselves awake or we'll have disappeared completely, so you may as well leave it to that point. The important thing about of course leaving it open is just in case there is a future rebirth that might prevent us from doing terrible things in this life. It's a bit of a safeguard. In fact, the Buddha says that somewhere.

So here, now, the next thing that he then goes into is there is a preservation of the truth. In that way, one preserves the truth and that way we recognize the preservation of the truth. This is the Brahmin talking to him. But in what way, Master Gotama, is there the discovery of the truth? In what way does one discover the truth?

Now here, there's a whole section here which I'll read. It's only a paragraph. Here, the spiritual seeker may be living in dependence on some village or town. The householder or householder's son goes to him and investigates him in regard to the three states: in regard to the states based on greed, in regard to the states based on hatred or aversion, in regard to the states of delusion. Are there in this venerable one any states based on greed such that with his mind obsessed by these states, while not knowing, he might say, "I know," and while not seeing, he might say, "I see"? In other words, he might be not telling the full truth about spiritual truths. And he might urge others to act in that way, which would lead to their harm and suffering for a long time.

As he investigates, he comes to know there is no such states of greed based on this venerable one. So here there's an examination of the teacher. The bodily behaviour and verbal behaviour of this Venerable One are not those of one affected by greed. And the *Dhamma* that this Venerable One teaches is profound, hard to see, hard to understand, peaceful and sublime, unattainable by mere reasoning, subtle to be experienced by the wise. This *Dhamma* cannot easily be taught by one affected by greed.

Now that little sentence there — profound, hard to see, hard to understand, peaceful and sublime, unattained — is a regular thing that you get through the scriptures. And of course, he says the same of anybody who has aversion and also, of course, delusion. So obviously, he's pointing to himself as the fully awakened one. I don't think I passed that investigation.

So now, having seen that the teacher is pure, he places faith in him. And filled with faith, he visits him and pays respect to him. And having paid respects, he gives ear. And when he gives ear, he hears the *Dhamma*. Having heard the *Dhamma*, he memorizes it and examines the meaning of the teachings he's memorized. When he examines their meaning, he gains a reflective acceptance of these teachings. And when he's gained a reflective acceptance of these teachings, zeal springs up. When zeal has sprung, he applies his will, he commits himself. And having applied the will, he begins to scrutinize.

So this is the word for *vipassanā*. He actually begins to look inward. And having scrutinized or getting into the scrutinization state, he strives, resolutely striving, and he realizes with the mental body the ultimate truth and sees it by penetrating it with wisdom. So this wisdom is really with intuitive intelligence. And in this way, Bharadwaja, there is the discovery of the truth. In this way, one discovers truth. In this way, we describe the discovery of the truth. But as yet, there is no final arrival at the truth.

So the first one is what we call stream entrance, but there's yet a whole load of training to be done. And then the question is, well very good, he asked him, is there the final arriving at the truth? In what way does one finally arrive at the truth? Now, this has to be taken to heart because this is absolutely crucial: the final arrival at the truth lies in the repetition, development and cultivation of those same things.

And it's a question I sometimes get: okay, we've got this *vipassanā* business and we understand the three characteristics, now what's the next stage? There's no next stage. From the very first time you come to meditation and you're taught how to look, how to investigate, and what it is you're investigating — the cause of suffering, desire, that whole process, impermanence and not self — that's it. There's nothing actually, there's nothing else to be learned as such. You could get all the way up to awakening with just knowing that. So in a sense that makes it a bit easy for us. In this way there is a final arrival at truth. In this way one finally arrives at truth. In this way we describe the final arrival at truth.

Now in the next session, so he's accepted that this particular Brahmin, and so he now goes backwards. Just to get the point across. And this is obviously a trick that people would use. This is a trick that people use to memorize things. So you do it one way and then you ask a question and then you come back the other way.

So if we go through that process, you'll see it quite clearly. So first of all, something must arouse a certain confidence, a certain connection with the teaching. And then once that done that, you visit the teacher. So that might be more books. It might be an actual person. But at some point you do need a personal teacher and you go there to pay respects, by which is meant opening the heart. And because you've opened the heart to the teacher, you're ready to lend your ear and you're listening to the *Dhamma*, memorizing it — meaning not so much these days because we can just have it on our phones, can't we? But definitely thinking about it, examining it.

And when we think about the *Dhamma*, there's a point where we see its logicity, its reason, there's an acceptance of it. This allows — this actually, with that initial confidence, that initial heart connection — gives us that impetus. If you remember how eager you were when you first started, how everything was new and there was that sense of adventure about it.

And then, of course, one begins to apply oneself and the real investigation begins with a real striving. Here, I think really means a continual determination until you finally reach the goal. And when one makes the first path and fruit, it's just repetition, repetition, repetition. So that's the process here.

And so then we have this lovely final paragraph. We asked Master Gotama about the preservation of the truth. And Master Gotama answered about the preservation of the truth. We approve of and accept that answer. And so we are satisfied. We asked Master Gotama about the discovery of truth and Master Gotama answered about the discovery of truth. We approve of and accept that answer and so we are satisfied. We asked Master Gotama about the final arrival at truth. The Master Gotama answered about the final arrival at truth. We approve and accept that answer and we are satisfied. We asked Master Gotama about the thing most helpful for the final arrival at truth and the master got them answered about the thing most helpful for the arrival at truth. We approve of and accept that answer, and we are satisfied.

Whatever we asked Master Gotama about, that he has answered us. We approve of and accept that answer, and so we are satisfied. Formerly Master Gotama, we used to think: Who are these bald-pated recluses, these swarthy menial offspring of the kinsman's feet? How can they understand the *Dhamma*? So there's a bit of prejudice there. But Master Gotama has indeed inspired in me love for these recluses, confidence in recluses, and reverence for recluses.

And then the usual process where he's expressing his confidence, his faith, and that ending line, and from today, Master Gotama, remember me as a lay follower who has gone to him for refuge, for life. So he's obviously inspired this young Brahmin.

So that, the *Chanki Sutta*, is really about, first of all, the truth. Ultimately the truth is — spiritually speaking — the truth actually has to be realized by us. *Nibbāna*, all these insights have to be realized by us. And until we've actually realized them, then we ought not to come to a conclusion. Now that's really important as far as I'm concerned because this isn't a religion based on faith. It is based on investigation.

And the whole process of liberation is the process of investigation. And that's what it's about. In other words, it's about this awareness, this intuitive awareness, slowly investigating its situation, how it finds the world it's in, how mistakes are made, how mistakes are unmade, and slowly but surely begins to realize its own true nature. That is a process of insight. And that has to be done by ourselves to ourselves. Nobody else can do that for us. If the Buddha could have done it to his disciples he would have done so, but that's our job. And once we realize that then we've got to get on with it.

So I hope my words have been of some assistance and they have not confused you and that you will devote yourself to the practice and be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later. So we can do a bit of sitting.

Shorter Discourse on Gosinga

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 19 min

In this evening talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Cūḷagosinga Sutta, where the Buddha visits three monks living in exemplary harmony at Gosinga. The discourse reveals profound teachings on community living through the monks' practice of 'living in concord with mutual appreciation, without disputing, blending like milk and water; viewing each other with kindly eyes.'

Bhante explores the practical wisdom of setting aside personal preferences for collective harmony, maintaining loving-kindness in body, speech and mind, and taking responsibility for shared tasks without complaint. The monks demonstrate diligent practice while supporting each other through simple gestures and purposeful speech, gathering every five days specifically to discuss Dhamma.

This teaching offers invaluable guidance for anyone living with others - whether in spiritual community, family, or shared housing. Bhante draws from his own experience facilitating retreats to illustrate how releasing attachment to 'doing things my way' creates peace and harmony. The discourse concludes with the Buddha's emphasis on being exemplars whose conduct inspires confidence and benefits the wider community.

Good evening. I trust you've had a fruitful day. I do not say happy. I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa – homage to the Buddha, the blessed noble and fully self-awakened one.

Just to tell you that if the screen freezes, if I lose the transmission, just keep renewing the page. If we're in meditation, if you put your alarm clock on for about seven minutes past nine o'clock and it's frozen, then just renew the page and I may be back on. It doesn't take me long to get back on. I think the upload just collapsed every so often. We're not getting the full upload that we're actually paying for. I have, of course, complained.

Now tomorrow begins this retreat I'm doing for Gaia House, so if you want to join it you're very welcome. It's best to go through Gaia House – just register with them – and hopefully you've received the news bite about that. If you don't receive the news bite you can get it on the website, it's on the front page there just on your right. You can

click on the – ah, no, excuse me, wrong. This is not on the News Byte. So if you didn't get the News Byte, drop me an email and I'll send it to you. We start tomorrow morning at eight o'clock, if you can make it.

So we're going to move on to a different discourse. This one is called the Shorter Discourse on Gosinga. And Gosinga is a place, though "At Gosinga" would just as well have been a good translation.

So I shall read it and you'll see very quickly what it's about. Thus have I heard: on one occasion the Blessed One was living at Nadika in the brick house. Now that's interesting. Most houses, of course, were wooden. So when the scriptures mention a brick house, it's obviously something that wasn't usual in those days, or sometimes perhaps the first floor was brick and the rest was wood. But most houses would have been wood, I think. The jungles were all around them. There was only a small population.

In fact, it brought to mind when I went up to North Thailand to visit Ajahn Tate, who was a very well-known monk, in fact, was understood to be fully liberated. And he had this beautiful monastery. It was a royal monastery. So it was excruciatingly beautiful. Now, when I went to the border, I had to go to the border to renew my visa. When I looked across to Thailand, it was all agriculture. When I looked across the Mekong into Laos, it was just this thick jungle. It was quite apparent that the distinction between the two was obvious. So that would have been all jungle really around and about them.

Anyway, now on that occasion the Venerable Anuruddha, the Venerable Nandiya and the Venerable Kimbila were living in the park at Gosinga Sala Tree Wood. Then when it was evening, the Blessed One rose from meditation and went to the park. The park keeper saw the Blessed One coming in the distance and said to him, "Do not enter the park, recluse. There are three clansmen here seeking their own good. Do not disturb them."

Now the Venerable Anuruddha heard the park keeper speaking to the Blessed One and told him, "Friend park keeper, do not keep the Blessed One out. It is our teacher, the Blessed One, who has come." Then the Venerable Anuruddha went to the Venerable Nandiya and the Venerable Kimbila and said, "Come out, venerable sirs, come out. Our teacher, the Blessed One, has come."

Then all three went to meet the Blessed One. One took his bowl and outer robe. One prepared his seat and one set water to wash their feet. So in the East, often when the monks line up for food and they're going into the dining hall for it, the refectory, often lay people there will pour water over your feet and dry your feet. It's an ancient tradition. But the Blessed One sat down on the seat made ready and washed his own feet.

Then these three Venerable Ones paid homage to the Blessed One and sat down to one side. When they were seated the Blessed One said to them, "I hope you're all keeping well, Anuruddha. I hope you're all comfortable. I hope you're not having any trouble getting alms food." So there's the preoccupation of all monks – the alms food. What are we going to eat today? They've got to go on alms round. So remember in these times there would have been famines and so often they would have to go with a little bit of rice or perhaps nothing.

"We are keeping well, Blessed One. We are comfortable and we're not having any trouble getting alms food."

"I hope, Anuruddha, that you're all living in concord with mutual appreciation, without disputing, blending like milk and water, viewing each other with kindly eyes."

Now, look at that for a statement of congenial living together. Living in concord – harmony, concord with mutual appreciation. Now that's one step up from respect. You can respect somebody but not really appreciate them. You can respect their view but not appreciate it. But appreciation – there is a sense of joy. It's one step above respect. You appreciate them, there's a joy in there. Without disputing or arguing, blending like milk and water, viewing each other with kindly eyes.

So there we have it. So if you are living with somebody, you can ask yourself, are we living in concord? Do we have mutual appreciation? Are we living without disputing, at least too much? And do we blend like milk and water? And are we viewing each other with kindly eyes?

"Surely, Venerable Sir, we are living in concord with mutual appreciation, without disputing, blending like milk and water, viewing each other with kindly eyes."

"But Anuruddha, how do you live like this?"

"Venerable Sir, as to that, I think thus: it is a gain for me, it is a great gain for me that I'm living with such companions in the holy life." So there's your appreciation. "I maintain bodily acts of loving kindness towards these venerable ones both openly and privately. I maintain verbal acts of loving kindness towards them both openly and privately. I maintain mental acts of loving kindness towards them both openly and privately. And I consider: why should I not set aside what I wish to do and do what these venerable ones wish to do? Then I set aside what I wish to do and do what these venerable ones wish to do. We are different in body, Venerable Sir, but one in mind."

Now, have a look at this one then. Why should I not set aside – well, first of all, it's this whole business of appreciation and thinking well of people, acting well towards people. It doesn't mean to say that sometimes they don't do things which they ought not to do or you don't do things which you ought not to do. But in general, there is this attitude of loving kindness, attitude of goodwill.

But then: why should I not set aside what I wish to do and do what the Venerables wish to do? Now, remember, the three of them are all saying this to themselves. So therefore, you have three people who might sit together and say, "What would you like to do? What would you like to do?" And then after some discussion, come to an agreement of what ought to be done. But obviously, you've all got to say it. In a household of three where only one says it, then there's no doubt that you might feel abused because everybody else will just want to do what they want to do.

But that as an attitude in your household, if you are living with somebody, sharing or living with somebody, that is something that obviously brings about this feeling of milk and water. So you might try that if you find that you're always at loggerheads with people – there's a bit of irritation: "I want to do this, you want to do that, why don't we do it this way, this should be over here" – and then just to give up a little.

For me this was a bit of a training when I opened the center because obviously I thought well we should do things this way. Often I had an assistant, a facilitator. We had a set of facilitators, about one, two, three, about four different men who came to facilitate. And they were all brilliant. But of course, they would do it their way. And sometimes I would say, "Why don't we do it this way?" And no notice would be taken. Well. And then I would say it again, just to see in case they've forgotten. And they didn't do it the way I would suggest it. So I would feel a little irritation.

I would wait for that to pass and I would give them one more go. So I would then, next time I would meet them and say, "Perhaps we ought to do it this way," in a gentle way. And then they wouldn't. And then I thought to myself, well, to hell with it, let them do it their way. Because what's the point of getting into an argument about it? And it seemed to me that I lived very peacefully generally with everybody. As far as I know, they might not have lived peacefully with me but I generally lived peacefully with them by recognizing that so long as something wasn't immoral, it was fine. It was just the way they wanted to do it. So that was a bit of a nice little learning for me there.

So then Venerable Nandiya and Venerable Kimbila each spoke likewise, adding, "This is how, Venerable Sir, we are living in concord with mutual appreciation, without disputing, blending like milk and water, viewing each other with kindly eyes."

"Good, good, Anuruddha. I hope that you all abide diligent, ardent, and resolute." Diligent, ardent and resolute. So diligence – really committing yourself to a particular meditation in the morning or whatever, being diligent with it, being ardent, putting your energy with it, and resolute – and those times when you don't want to do it.

"Surely, Venerable Sir, we do. We abide diligent, ardent and resolute."

"But how do you abide in this way?"

"Venerable Sir, as to that, whichever of us returns first from the village with alms food, prepares the seats, sets out the water for drinking and washing, and puts the refuse bucket in its place. Whichever of us returns last, eats any food left over if he wishes, otherwise he throws it away where there's no greenery or drops it into water where there's no life. He puts away the seats and the water for drinking and for washing. He puts away the refuse bucket after washing it and he sweeps out the refectory. Whoever notices the pots of water for drinking, washing and the latrine are low or empty, takes care of them. If they are too heavy for him, he calls someone else by a signal of the hand and they move it by joining hands. But because of this, they do not break out into speech. But every five days we sit together all night discussing the Dharma. This is how we abide diligent, ardent and resolute."

So now then, whichever of us returns first from the village with alms food, prepares the seat, sets out the water for drinking and washing and puts the refuse bucket in its place. So how many – I'm thinking of times when I've shared with people and you come back and there's a load of dishes that haven't been washed. What's the reaction? Irritation, perhaps you just eat and leave your dishes as well, out of spite really. But if we're going to live like milk and water, then of course, when something has to be done and you've got some free time in your hand, you do it. That doesn't mean to say that you then end up doing all the cleaning and the washing and everything like that. I'm sure with some gentle discussion, the others might also wash their plates, et cetera, et cetera. But it's just that attitude of, well, this has to be done. I've got time. I'll just do it.

And whichever returns last eats any food left if he wishes, otherwise he throws it away where there's no greenery and drops it into water where there's no life. So this just goes back to the idea of not – even plants were thought to have some level of consciousness and so monks are not allowed to cut the grass or anything like that or do gardening really. And also throwing away where there's life – it might harm the life that's in the pond or the water. So the idea was to put food or throw food away where it wouldn't harm anybody or harm any living being.

He puts away the seats and the water for drinking and for washing. He puts away the refuse bucket after washing it and he sweeps out the refectory. Now, whoever – this is it – whoever notices the pots of water for drinking, washing and latrine are low and empty takes care of them. That's it. If you see it, then in a sense you take on that responsibility. If they're too heavy for him, he calls someone else by a signal of the hand and they move it joining hands. But because of this, they do not break out into speech.

So this is not wasting one's energy on silly talk, wasting energy, wasting one's energy on just needing to talk about anything, about silly stuff. But every five days they sit together, discuss the Dharma. So every so often they would sit together and purposefully discuss the Dharma. In other words, when we speak, it should be for a purpose. So this gives us some idea of how we can live peacefully with each other, gives us some hints.

The rest of the discourse is really about their attainments – all the *jhānas* that they've done, all the *jhānas* they're capable of getting, right up to what's known as *nirodhasamāpatti*, which is the point where feeling and perception disappear and it's often thought to be the same as *Nibbāna*, but there's a bit of dispute about that.

And then at that time – and this is more to do with the age – there's a spirit or a god or a disembodied being, Digha Parajana. And what the Buddha says is that it's a great benefit that they're living close to a village so they can have an effect on the town and the people will praise them, et cetera, et cetera. And because the spirit is aware of that, it also becomes – he makes other gods aware of it too and it goes all the way up to the highest heaven of the Brahmās.

And finally, there's just a point and we should remember that. So and then it says that all the people on Earth – the nobles should remember these three clansmen with confident heart that would lead to the welfare and happiness of the nobles for a long time. So in other words, it's this business of being exemplars. And it's the same with the Brahmins and merchants and the workers should remember these three clansmen for the welfare, et cetera. And then it goes through the world of the gods.

"See, Digha, how these three clansmen are practicing for the welfare and happiness of the many, out of compassion for the world, for the good, welfare and happiness of gods and humans." This is what the Blessed One said and the spirit Digha Parajana was satisfied and delighted in the Blessed One's words.

So he's very much concerned with being an example. And often when we have a rule in the order he'll often say it's there to build up the confidence of lay people. Because when you see a monk behaving badly obviously it undermines not just your confidence in that monk but in the whole order – people's confidence and faith can just drop away if they see this corruption.

Very good. So I hope you found that discourse of some interest. Tomorrow it will be more aimed towards the *Vipassanā*, the Mahāsi *Vipassanā*. So I hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused any disturbance and that you will by your diligent, ardent and vigorous practice achieve full liberation sooner rather than later.

So don't forget if I go off screen or something just every so often refresh and I might reappear. Okay, so let's do a little bit of meditation.

[The text ends here as the speaker transitions to a meditation session]

Gaia Standing and Sitting Guided Meditation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 1h00

This guided meditation session begins with traditional Pali chanting of the Three Refuges and Five Precepts before moving into a comprehensive practice combining standing and sitting postures. Bhante Bodhidhamma guides practitioners through developing awareness of bodily sensations, breath, and the 'bubble of consciousness' that forms our experiential world.

The practice emphasizes the Mahasi method of slow, deliberate movement with mental noting, cultivating the five factors leading to liberation: awareness (sati), investigation, effort, tranquility, and equanimity. Key vipassanā insights are explored including the three characteristics of existence - impermanence (anicca), unsatisfactoriness (dukkha), and not-self (anattā). The session concludes with reflective questions to assess one's practice and commitment to mindful awareness.

This meditation is particularly valuable for understanding how to integrate formal sitting practice with mindful movement and daily life activities. The guidance on recognizing the 'observer' or awareness itself, distinct from all experienced objects, points toward the deeper insights of insight meditation practice.

I can't have the windows open, the curtains open, because there's too much light and you wouldn't be able to see me, unfortunately.

Puran pujani Dhamman pujani Sangham Pujyami. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sama Sambuddhasa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sama Sambuddhasa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhasa buddhang saranam gacchami dhammang saranam gacchami sanggang saranam gacchami Tuthi Ampī Bodhan Saranam Gacchami Tuthi Ampī Dhamman Saranam Gacchami Tuthi Ampī Sangam Saranam Gacchami Tatthi Ampī Bodhan Saranam Gacchami Tattyaṃ vīdāmaṃ śāraṇaṃ gacchāmi Tattyaṃ vīsaṅgaṃ śāraṇaṃ gacchāmi anati-katha-veramani-sikapadan samadhi-ami adhinadana-veramani-sikapadan Samadhi Ami. Kame sumi cacera. Vairamani sikapadan. Samadhi Ami. Musavada. Vairamani sikapadan. Samadhi Ami. Suramraya. Majjhapamadhatana.

Now the one thing I forgot to mention was that sometimes the line drops, unfortunately. It's happened very rarely, so I think it doesn't happen now.

Standing posture. Make sure you feel balanced, steady, grounded, and then just lifting up through the top of the head, standing tall. I'll just spend a moment relaxing the brow, the jaw. If there's tension there, you can clench the jaw and relax it. Shoulders, you might need a good squeeze. Hands joined in front or by the side, whatever's comfortable. Just acknowledging that posture, the energy rising up through the spine, top of the head, lifting you up. Everything else just hanging off. Relax. Just acknowledging that posture.

And now draw your attention to the soles of your feet. What can you feel down there? Can you isolate the sensations of pressure? What about sensations of temperature, coolness or warmth? More subtle sensations that tell you what you're standing on, sponginess of the carpet, see if you can find a word. Just acknowledge how these sensations are continuously changing as the body rebalances itself.

And acknowledge how these sensations arise, whether you want them to or not. Not under our direct control.

Taking your time now, just come up the body, see what you can feel on the surface of the body, inside the body, areas that seem to be void of feeling. When you get to the abdomen, can you feel the sensations caused by the breath there, the rise and fall of the abdomen? Any other sensations there, maybe a bit of tension? What about the stomach area? Can you feel the breath there? Any other sensations, tensions? Can you feel the breath in the chest? Or is that fairly relaxed? Or maybe tense. What do you find there? Feel the heartbeat. Shoulders still relax. The jaw. The brow. When you get to the scalp, scan it like you did the soles of your feet. What can you feel there?

Now without moving the eyes, just become aware of what's outside you. So the shapes and colors in front of you. Any sounds? The atmosphere of the room you're in. And if there's somebody in the house or flat, sense their presence, even immediate neighbors or pets. So attention is entirely out there.

Now at the same time, bringing the in here, the breath, the feet and so on, both the inside and the outside. So this is the bubble of our consciousness. This is our world. This is what we're creating moment after moment. Nobody else can know it. It's our universe. We're always at the center of it. So we may as well relax. Just relax into this present moment, wide awake. And as it were, hang in the middle.

Just allow the attention to be drawn now to something you see, something you hear, something you feel. Don't choose. Relaxing, abiding in the present moment wide awake in this mode just being we can let go of ideas of achieving something so in that mode we're always doing something now for some future result but in this mode there is no result this is the result there's no reason for being it just is

Relaxing. Dwelling in the present moment, wide awake. In this mode, just being, there's no future. So there's no need to plan. You can drop all that. We're never going anywhere. We're always arriving.

Relaxing, inhabiting the present moment, wide awake. In this mode, we're being very passive. We're not reacting. We're not responding. We're just observing, feeling, experiencing whatever manifests. In which case, we don't have to present somebody, a person, a personality. We can, as it were, sit back in an anonymous position.

Relaxing, abiding in the present moment, wide awake, achieving nothing, going nowhere, being nobody. In this mode, we're developing five of the seven factors that lead to liberation. The awareness, of course, and then there's that steadiness of attention and the effort needed to maintain just that. A background sense of calmness, because we're not trying to achieve anything. And a quality of equanimity. A balanced mind, a balanced heart. So a mind that's not coming from a particular view or an opinion. Open-minded. A heart which is not coming from prejudice, fear, aversion, even preference. Open-hearted. Open-minded, open-hearted.

That's the platform upon which we bring that sense of curiosity to investigate the Buddha's teachings. A direct experience of the Buddha's teachings by observing ourselves, feeling ourselves, experiencing ourselves intimately.

Now, this mode is also very important in ordinary daily life, just to be able to stop like this after a phone call or a WhatsApp, after you've eaten, after you've done a piece of work, whatever, you stop and just see if there's any accumulation. There might be some irritation. There might be some overexcitement. On the other hand, you might be peaceful and joyful. So it's a case of recognizing that.

And when it's something unwholesome, you just wait there. Just let it exhaust itself a little bit. If it's wholesome, of course, then you receive that with gratitude. Then there's enough space, enough stillness to see the next intention. If we can see these intentions, we'll have enough time to decide whether it's wholesome enough, skillful enough. But if it's unskillful, you just wait for that desire to exhaust itself. And then you're liberated from it. If it's wholesome, skillful, you empower it, of course.

Just in this very simple way, we can change ourselves. But it takes this level of mindfulness, attentiveness, awareness. So our next intention is to sit. So try to take your time. So part of the Mahāsi technique is to go slow. The more you slow down the body, the more you can see the mind. The mind slows down. You can see the process by which we create this world.

And there's also a noting and noting small little notes, lifting, moving, placing, partly to stop the mind wandering and partly to really push the attention towards what we're feeling, sensing, observing. So see if you can find these little words. At first, for those for whom it might be the first time, it seems a little false. Well, it is, of course, but it's there as a technique. And very slowly, you'll find yourself quite used to doing these little notes and even around the house with something physical. Washing pots and stuff. It just stops the mind from wandering, keeps your attention to the task.

Intending to sit. So now make sure that your posture, whether you're sitting on the floor, cross-legged or on a chair, on a kneeling stool, doesn't really matter. What really matters is the back, the spine. Just make sure that it has its natural curvature and that you're pushing up from the lower muscles, the muscles around the base of the spine and around the abdomen. When you do that, the breath of the abdomen becomes pretty clear.

So you're pushing up from there, gently of course, up through the top of the head. There you are, sitting tall. And then as usual, just pass your attention down the body, just relaxing the brow. Eyes gently closed. Jaw. Lips together, teeth apart. Shoulders, give them a squeeze if there's tension in there. And hands on your lap, whatever is comfortable. So just acknowledging that posture, the energy running up the spine, everything else, relax.

Draw your attention now to where you feel the breath most in the body, the chest, the stomach, the abdomen. Now if you are already established at the nostrils, feel free to stay there. So just adapt my instructions to the nostrils. So as the breath rises, as the body rises, the abdomen rises, just a little noting word, rising, as it falls, falling.

And just relax on the breath. Just get in touch with it. What does it feel like? If the mind is wandering, as soon as you come out of the dream, really recognize and acknowledge the mood, the emotion, the attitude which is driving it. Let go of the story completely. It's not important. Thinking, thinking, worrying, worrying. And then just draw the attention back to the breath.

Just relaxing the attention on the gentle sensations caused by the breath. Just allowing them to bring silence to the mind, calmness to the heart, stillness to the body. Rising, falling.

If the mind is wandering as soon as we wake up really recognize and acknowledge the emotion the mood the attitude which is driving the mind driving the imagination let go of the story worrying worrying planning planning irritation irritation judging judging whatever and then as soon as you've acknowledged it just come back to the breath determined to stay there feeling sleepy or tired lift the spine you can open the eyes first just a little just to let the light in but you can open them wide keep the attention inward though and you can even stand up just relaxing the attention on the breath as we begin to feel

More focused see if you can get a little closer just to catch the very beginning of the inbreath just stay with it to the very end the very beginning of the out breath stay with it to the very end now if when you do that you feel you get tense have more of the impression of sitting back within yourself and receiving the breath rising

If the mind is very busy, you can note more quickly. As we become more focused, more relaxed, just choose your own time when you can open up to whatever draws the attention within that field of awareness. If it's a sensation coming from the body, some discomfort, some pain in the knee, for instance, if it draws your attention, we don't go looking for anything. If it draws your attention, go there, feel it, experience it intimately. It might be an emotion, a feeling, a mood within the body. If it draws the attention, go there, feel it, experience it intimately.

But when the mind moves, always come off the mind, come off those stories, recognize and acknowledge what's driving it, the emotion, the mood, the attitude, and then come back into the body and see if you can feel it. If you can't feel anything fine just go back to the breath the breath is our anchor it's our reference point when we're confused we just begin again with the breath rising falling

And see if you can find little noting words for everything that you're experiencing. If something doesn't come naturally, just say feeling.

Becoming more aware of how we are relating to what we're experiencing, reacting to it. How when something is pleasant, we're drawn to it, want to maintain it, want to develop it. How when something is unpleasant, we want to push it away, get rid of it, turn our attention away from it, ignore it. Can we become aware of those reactions? This is the desire that the Buddha is pointing to when he says it's the direct psychological cause for our suffering. Is that true for you?

Becoming more aware about everything we're experiencing is in process. Everything is arising and passing away. Nothing ever repeats itself. Each breath is similar but not the same. Everything is transient, impermanent. Is there anything reliable?

When we're practicing *Vipassanā*, we've discovered, keep discovering within ourselves a sort of observation post. We've become an inner observer, inner feeler, inner experiencer, just watching the process of this psycho-physical organism. Can we make it more plain to ourselves that everything we are experiencing is an object of our awareness? The pain in the knee is down there. Emotions are in the body down there. Images appear before me up here. They're always other.

You can make that distance more clear to yourself by being aware of the distance. So you're aware of the distance between the knower upstairs here in the head and the knee down there. Even between the knower and the image that's in your mind. Everything is an object. Can the perceiver be the perceived?

As the knower the feeler the experiencer on this observation post establish their looking feeling experiencing what is arising and passing away everything that is being experienced is happening of its own accord the body offers sensations and feelings whether we want it to or not

The heart begins to emote all sorts of emotions, moods, whether we want it to or not. And the mind, oh mind, forever thinking, imagining, whether we want it to or not, nothing is under our direct control. How can it be me?

Letting go now of all instruction. Have absolute confidence in this intuitive awareness that we are, allowing it to make its own insights. No need to think, no need to guide it. It now knows everything it needs to know to liberate itself from suffering. All we have to do is allow it to watch, to feel, to experience intimately, whatever draws its attention within that field of awareness. Don't do anything. Don't change anything.

When we come to the end of a sitting, it's good to reflect a little bit. One question we can ask is, how diligent was I in bringing myself back to the present moment? How committed was I? If I felt that my effort was good, I should congratulate myself. If I thought I could have been more diligent, then I should encourage myself.

How did I deal with the various physical and mental states that arose? Just choose one of them restlessness sleepiness. Continual thinking. Big emotion. Just choose something that happened there, how did you deal with it, did you know what to do. If you thought you were skillful, then again, congratulate yourself. If you thought you could have been more skillful, well, encourage yourself. Next time I'm feeling sleepy or whatnot, I'll immediately open my eyes.

Which of those three characteristics of existence was most prominent for you in this sitting? The process of desiring, wanting, not wanting? Was it more the impermanence of things, the transient nature? Or was it that everything was an object not under our control, not me?

We can also make a resolution. It can be quite specific, such as the one, if I feel sleepy next time, I'll really open my eyes immediately. I won't hang about. Or it can be just a general commitment to mindfulness, affectionate mindfulness, mindfulness with a good heart.

When we come out of a sitting don't just jump out of it. Open the eyes slowly gently very good so I hope you found that a

38 Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness — Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 22 min

In this opening session of a detailed series on the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), Bhante Bodhidhamma introduces the Buddha's foundational discourse on establishing Right Awareness. He explains the sutta's structure, covering the four foundations: contemplation of body, feelings, mind states, and dhamma objects. The talk emphasizes this as the 'ekāyāna' or one-way path of pure vipassanā meditation, as practiced in the Mahasi tradition.

Bhante focuses particularly on the first section dealing with mindfulness of breathing (ānāpānasati), explaining the three stages: initially contacting the breath, settling into awareness of the whole breath body (beginning, middle, end), and allowing natural calming to arise. He clarifies that 'pajānāti' (knowing) involves intuitive wisdom rather than mere intellectual recognition, and that true awareness sees the breath through the three characteristics of impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and not-self.

Drawing from traditional commentaries and modern teachers like Nyanaponika Thera and Sayadaw U Pandita, this talk provides both scholarly context and practical guidance for establishing the foundation of vipassanā practice in daily life and formal meditation.

Sorry about that. I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, although I hope it has been happy.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa.

So we have a few people joining us this evening who are doing the Gaia House Course. Those of you who are doing the Gaia Course, I'm presuming that you've listened to those three talks that I mentioned which you find on the website under Gaia House and it has a title underneath it "Personal Retreat". So I'm hoping that you've looked at the first one, which is the technique, and what we've been doing in the evening is looking at the various discourses that the Buddha gave and trying to find some meaning in them.

So in tune with this particular course, I'm going to look at the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse, the discourse on how to establish right awareness. Now, there are very good books now on this, which again, I've put on the website. Bhikkhu Anālayo has written an academic

study of it. But one of the classics is *The Heart of Buddhist Meditation* by Nyanaponika Thera, who was a very famous German monk in his time. He was the one that began the Buddhist Publication Society up in Kandy, which publishes all the books. And he was one of Bhikkhu Bodhi's teachers.

There's also *Mindfulness* by Joseph Goldstein, which was modeled on Anālayo's book, by the way. Well, at least he took that as the base. And there's always Sayadaw U Pandita's *In This Very Life*. So there's lots of literature out there. And all I'm going to do is just go through it making occasional comments just so that you are familiar with the actual discourse, and then hopefully you'll read those books. Not necessary to become fully liberated, by the way. Don't need any of this. But if you're going to have a pastime, this is a very skillful way to use your time.

So the structure of the sutta is, first of all, he lays out what he's going to talk about. And then we have the body. So he talks about the body, the breath, the postures, awareness in ordinary daily life, the repulsiveness of the body. He's very much into the body. The elements, of course, the four elements. And finally, the charnel grounds, mindfulness of death. Then he talks about feelings, both physical feelings and mental feelings caused in the body by emotions. The contemplating of the mind, of mental states, he goes into that. And then finally, contemplation of things. Actually, it's contemplation of the Dhamma, looking at it from various angles, the hindrances, the seven factors of enlightenment, the sense spheres.

Now, I'm using here a translation by Bhikkhu Ānandajoti, who's an English monk marooned in Thailand. He doesn't want to come back to England, to Britain, because it's too cold, he says. And he's quite a good scholar, quite a good translator. If you go into his websites, he's got one with lots of translations and comments, and he's got another one with all sorts of documentaries and films, and another one which is an endless row of photographs. He's a keen photographer.

So let's begin. "Thus have I heard" — remember all these discourses were remembered by, so the tradition tells us, by Ānanda, who was his companion for about twenty years at the end of his life. "At one time, the Blessed One was dwelling amongst the Kurus near the market town of the Kurus named Kammāsadhamma." So they think this was near Delhi, by the way. So he really moved around that North Gangetic plain.

Now, the important thing, one of the things that the commentary says was that he was very taken by the Kurus because he'd been there before. And when he returned, he found them being very mindful. There was no well talk, you know, the gossip around

the well. And so he was very struck by that. And it was at that time that he gave this discourse. So we can say that when he gave this discourse — this is just my own understanding — that he really was thinking about lay people.

But not entirely so, because there's a group of monks whom he meets coming out of meditation in the jungles of the forest back to the monastery, and he points out that some of them were using *samatha* and *vipassanā* and some of them were using only *vipassanā* as their main vehicle. And this discourse is really about *vipassanā* as the path without the other concentration exercises. And of course, the Mahāsi system is basically a *vipassanā*-only path. But we'll come to that.

So he's now asked them to listen to him. Now, the opening line is, "This is, monks, a one-way path" — this word, *ekāyano*. Sometimes it's translated in a fundamentalist way: "This is the only path." And then it's "the single path," "the direct path." And he's translated as "a one-way path," meaning that you can only go along it. You can't come back on it. But the commentaries also point out that it's in opposition to the *dvāyano*, the two-way path, which is of concentration and *vipassanā*. One of the great teachers of that was Ajahn Mahā Bua, whom some of you might know from Thailand. He didn't die so long ago and was an Arahant — declared himself to be an Arahant in so many words.

So he starts off by telling us that this is the one-way path, pure *vipassanā*, pure *vipassanā*. And he tells us that this is "for the purification of beings" — that comes first, the purification of beings — "for the overcoming of grief and lamentation," the sorrow of life, "for the extinction of pain and sorrow." Now, this pain is both the physical pain and eventually sorrow, but pain, of course, in the body is natural to the body. So really, this is the pain in the body caused by the mind. "And this is for attaining the right way, the direct realization of *Nibbāna*."

Now, *Nibbāna* is another word which has various meanings. It can mean that there is no more desire, but it also has a meaning of being unshackled, released. And referring to this awareness which is shackled by its misunderstandings with the psychophysical organism — put in the Buddhist teaching, these are the five *khandhas*, the five aggregates — and it's by pulling itself out of that through this practice that it unshackles itself.

So there are four ways in which we do it. He dwells contemplating the body in the body. Now, this is another thing. Sometimes it's translated as "the body as the body," but actually, the grammar of it is — for those of you who know the locative — it's like being in a room. So it's actually contemplating the body in the body. And to me, that's the Buddha stressing the fact that you've got to get into things. You've got to actually absorb or absorb into your experience within yourself. One of my teachers, Sayadaw U Pandita, used to talk about plunging, plunging into the object.

And he does it "with ardour." Ardour — this word *ātāpī* is a very strong word. It reminds, it's the sort of word you'd use with self-mortification exercises. And the commentary says that you've got to be as ardent until you've burnt out all the defilements. So it's a real commitment. "Fully aware and mindful" — now again, this *sampajāno satimaṃ*, they're both adjectives: mindfully and fully aware. This *pajāno*, it really is the same word as *pajānāti*, as *paññā*, which means wisdom when you've got it and the process of insight. And so this is, I think, better translated as with intuitive awareness, intuitive intelligence and awareness.

So when you combine them, it's intuitive awareness. The awareness is what's receiving the information. The intuition is what understands it, grasps it. So we have it in our language when we say, "Go and have a look and see what it is." So first of all, you look and then you see and you understand.

"After removing *abhijjhā*" — sometimes this is translated as "desire for worldly things," "for worldly pleasures and sorrow regarding the world." I mean, you'll all have experienced those if you've been on retreat. That there's a, towards the end of a retreat, there's a longing to get back to your family, to your friends, to your hobbies and things like that. So it's that pull that the outer world always has upon us. And sorrow, we might feel unhappy about the world. And these things we have to, as it were, put aside when we're meditating. You don't forget them. You're just parking them. Remember, there's a distinction between suppressing something which we do out of aversion or fear and just taking our attention away from it for a while, just putting them to the side, picking them up when the retreat is over or whatever.

And he contemplates feelings in feelings, fully aware, mindful, and removing this desire for the world and sorrow. And he contemplates the mind — so these are mental states in mental states — and fully aware, etc. And then finally contemplating things. Now, *Ānandajoti* is translated as "things," but actually it's the actual Dhamma. So I think we've been through that, those things like the hindrances, seven factors of enlightenment, the Four Noble Truths.

So he's made a very broad statement there that it's about contemplating in this *vipassanā* way, in this insightful way, the body, the feelings in the body, the mental states that we suffer from, and looking at what is actually arising from a Dhamma point of view. So that's the summary. That's the summary of it.

And then he goes into contemplating of the body. And there are different sections of this. So I'll just — looks as though time is passing. By the way, those of you who are on retreat, this may take me a few days to get through the discourse. You are, of course, welcome to join in the evening. And I usually, well, I do post up the talk, the evening talk, the next day. Just takes a little while for me to do it.

So he says that, well, he's talking now specifically about monks going into the wilderness, to the root of a tree, to an empty space and all that. But basically, folding his legs crosswise and setting his body straight. So we needn't take that too literally. You can sit, you can do with your legs what you want. You can take them off if you want. It's basically keeping the body straight, keeping the body energized, lifting it, and establishing mindfulness in front of him. In other words, bringing mindfulness to bear.

So he breathes in mindful and he breathes out mindful. And then it says that "while breathing in long, he knows 'I am breathing in long.' And when breathing out, he knows 'I am breathing out long'" and then breathing short and then breathing out short. So this is your beginning. This is contacting the breath as you feel it, whenever you sit down, whenever you start your practice, unless there's something immediate that draws your attention. I mean, if you sit down, if you just had a big upset, for instance, and you sit down and you have to deal with this upsetting feeling — somebody's let you down or made you angry or whatever — then of course you would go immediately to that. You wouldn't go to the breath. But normally speaking, you would begin with the breath. And of course, what he's saying is just get in contact with it. Know that it's long, know that it's short.

And then, "experiencing the whole body, I will breathe in, experiencing the whole body, I'll breathe out." So, having contacted the breath and got the feeling of it, one then begins to stay with the full length of the body. The body of the breath is the body here. It isn't the body. It's the body of the breath, the beginning, the middle section and the end. Now, when you do that, you're not looking for a middle point of your breath. You're beginning at the — the beginning is the moment it begins. The whole business of coming to the end of the in-breath is the middle, and the end is the end. So it's beginning, middle and end, and it's the beginning, middle, and end of the out-breath.

And he says, "calming the body process, I will breathe in and breathe out." Now, it's not as though you do that purposefully. As soon as you put your attention on the breath, you will feel this calmness come and you keep doing it until the calmness becomes established. It's not something that you force upon yourself.

So the example, he says, is of a clever turner or turner's apprentice. This is on a machine that carves wood, a bowl or something. "I am making a long turn." And while making a short turn, he knows "I'm making a short turn." "And so monks, a monk while breathing knows 'I'm breathing long.' And while breathing out, he knows 'I'm breathing out long.' He knows 'I'm breathing in short and breathing out short.' Experiencing the whole body, he trains himself this way. Experiencing the whole body, I breathe out." That's the whole body of the breath. "Calming the bodily process, I breathe in. Calming the bodily process, I breathe out."

So there you've got three points there where you first of all contact the breath, then you settle into the breath, and very slowly the breath begins to create — just the fact of making a neutral, quiet sensation the object of your meditation has the effect of silencing the mind, calming the heart and stilling the body.

Now, you have to be careful not to take this too literally. In no tradition that I've worked with does it say that you're supposed to be saying "I am breathing out." One of the problems of Pali is it doesn't have a passive voice. So you can't say "the breath is being breathed." In English, we can say "they drove the car." And then we can turn it around and say "the car was driven by them." Well, you can't say that in Pali. So you've only got an active sense. And the commentaries point out that a dog or a jackal knows where they're going and they know where they're sitting down. But obviously they don't say it. So it's just really a recognition.

Now, the word that is used is *pajānāti*. So it's not a case of just knowing that the breath is rising or falling. It's knowing in a particular way. So remember this word *pajānāti*, the noun is *paññā*, wisdom, insight. So it's looking at it from the three characteristics of existence. The relationship we have with things, wanting, not wanting, impermanence — mainly it's impermanence with the breath. And of course, the body is breathing. It's not me. When you're watching the body, the body is just breathing. So there's your *anattā*, it's not me.

So that brings us to the breath, which — time is moving on. What I'll do is just the next bit. And just the last little frame where he says he dwells contemplating the body in the body with regard to himself, so he does it with himself. But it also, with regard to others, and the commentaries are quite clear, that you're sometimes aware of other people breathing. And in meditation halls, I'm sure you've experienced people with heavy breaths, noisy breaths coming through the nose. And instead of getting really up-tight about that and wanting to strangle them, you can use it as a meditational object. The beginning, the rising and the falling — it's all impermanent. And of course, both ways in regards to oneself and in regards to the other.

So that brings us to the end of the section on breathing. And I think we might leave it there. It might take me some time just to make my way through this discourse, but I think it's worth doing it.

So I can, as usual, I do hope my words have been of some assistance and they have not caused any confusion. If they have, of course, you can always email me. And that by your devotion to practice, you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

So we can begin our sitting meditation.

31b The Body

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 22 min

Drawing from the Kāyagatāsati Sutta (MN 119) and Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's profound teachings on establishing Right Awareness of the body. He explores how our suffering arises not from bodily pain itself, but from our wrong relationship to the body through identity ('I am sick') and possession ('I have pain').

The talk illuminates the Buddha's own journey from extreme asceticism to the Middle Way, showing how he discovered that self-mortification was merely another form of attachment. Bhante discusses the body's impermanent nature, its dependency on conditions, and our limited control over its functions. He explains the traditional contemplations of bodily foulness, the four elements (earth, water, fire, wind), and charnel ground reflections as methods to develop equanimity.

Through mindful breathing and the four postures, practitioners learn to use the body skillfully while avoiding both indulgence and aversion. The teaching emphasizes that proper kāyagatāsati practice becomes a foundation for wisdom, preventing unwholesome mental states and establishing the groundwork for insight into the three characteristics of existence.

Greetings, I trust you've had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhasa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

Today we practiced this body care and it's been substantiated by Brian, who's been doing the Reiki. So I thought we'd have a look at the body from the Buddha's point of view.

In the Buddha's teachings, the body and mind are two different, for want of a better word, forms of energy. But it's not the awareness, the *satipanya*, the Buddha within. This was made more plain in Mahayana, where they talked about the three bodies, Yogacara. So the first was the body of the Dharma, which is the unconditioned Buddha. Remember, he said that he had achieved the unconditioned *citta*. *Citta* here meaning the awareness — he's pointing to the awareness, not the mind.

There's the Sambhogakaya, which is the body of bliss, which is the mental body, which for the Buddha, of course, becomes one which is heart-based happiness. Somebody who's fully liberated doesn't suffer as such. And then there's the Nirmalakaya, which is the body of appearance, which is this physical body.

This physical body can only give us pain. It can't make us suffer. The suffering comes because of a wrong relationship to the body, which is identity: "It's me. I am sick. I am happy. I am well." And possession: "I have a bad knee," which I do have at the moment, "I have a headache," things like that. So the suffering comes from a relationship to the body. The body can only offer us pain and pleasure, of course.

The Buddha, of course, made this mistake in his training. After he had achieved all these *jhana* states, absorption states, in the first part of his training for about two years or so, he then went into the process of self-mortification. There the understanding was the body was the product of your unwholesome actions, your *kamma*, and you had to let go of the body. So there was this process of eating less and less and less. This seemingly was the doctrine of the Jain leader, where the saint is one who finally just stops eating, just lets go. So he found that to be just more pain and he left it highly disappointed and very thin.

That's when he went off to sit under the tree where he became fully liberated. Somewhere along that line, moving away from self-mortifications and reflecting upon his practice, he came upon the insight into what was really causing the problem, really causing the suffering and the escape from suffering. That was his big insight. And it's, as we've mentioned before, to do with our relationship, to do with ethics.

So we have that dualistic relationship with the body: it's me and it's mine. It's interesting to note, I've got this book called *The Human Body*. Occasionally I open it and very quickly close it. There are astounding little facts. For instance, if I were to ask you now, have you any idea what your liver is doing? It's a mystery.

There are many little things that this book mentions which are astounding, really. For instance, the brain contains twelve billion neurons, twelve billion neurons, and there are fifty billion supporting glial cells, wherever they are. I mean, I've never seen a single neuron. And if it's to do with my thinking, I've probably lost a few.

Then there's the blood. This is amazing. This is coming out of the marrow of our bones. Every second — I can't believe this, frankly — but every second, two million oxygen-bearing red blood cells die, but they are replaced at the same rate by new ones generated in the process within the marrow of the bone. Can't be right, can it? Two million. I should be dead.

It just shows you that when you get all these facts, they are quite astounding — how the body works and what the little parts of it do, the pancreas, the liver. You wonder that you live so long and that you can remain so healthy because anything can go wrong, the minor thing, and you're sunk.

It's actually good to reflect on the fact that we don't really know the body. We don't experience the body. What we experience of the body really comes through the sense of touch, the sense of movement, and just that sensual divide between what's pleasurable and what's unpleasurable.

Then we have to accept that there's a changing nature. The body's never the same. They tell you that every seven years you've got a new body. I just wish the renewal would be a little bit more enhancing. It just seems to get worse. I don't know why. So this changing nature of the body. Every seven years, a new body. It's ridiculous, isn't it, when you think about it? To think that when you're standing there and you're looking at your hand, you didn't have this hand. I did not have this hand seven years ago. It was a completely different hand.

The sheer dependency of the body on food, on air — any of that becomes denied us, before we know it, we're dead. The body just dies. You can live without water, I think, for about nine days.

The control we have is minimal. It's more like somebody driving a car. You get in a car, you drive it, you feel you're in control of the car, and then the car comes to a stop, or the wheel blows, or somebody hits it, and that's the end of the car, as far as you're concerned, at least its mobility. So this feeling of being in control of the body — actually the control is quite surface, quite minimal. Because when you see these athletes... the woman gymnast in the last Olympics was just unbelievable what she can do with the body. But it's still only a surface control of the body just through actions and movements.

What we were doing was a practice whereby we undermine this wrong idea of possessing the body and being the body. Just like any object, what you can do is use it. There's no point in possessing an object — you're just going to cause a lot of suffering emotionally. I mean, obviously legally the mobile might be yours, but when the thief takes it, it's his. It's no good going around saying somebody's taken my mobile — it's no longer yours.

It's getting rid of the idea of somehow possessing the body. We're in it but not of it. What is that "we" referring to? This awareness. The awareness is in it but not of it.

Then we went through this relationship that we had with the body. Part of it we like, part of it we're disgusted by. These relationships are not particularly needed at all. I mean, you need it for food. If you put something rotten in your mouth, then you need to know this is going to poison me. So then that is a sort of sensual disgust. But the actual emotion of disgust is not necessary, is it? And of course, it displaces itself to being disgusted with people.

The wrong relationship, of course, forms an attachment to the body as a place where we're using to create happiness. That's where the suffering really lies because, for instance, if you go blind, if you go deaf, if you suffer from an accident and become paralysed, I mean, the suffering involved in that will be as much as your dependency on those faculties for your happiness. We know from disabled people that the quality of your life need not be undermined. But the change — going through the grief and the sense of loss and all that — is obviously due to this psychological dependency we have on the body for happiness. And that's what we mean by attachment.

Then the contemplation of sickness, aging, and death, which we do every evening — that's to try and undermine the fact that we are the body, this peculiar identity.

The body turns up in two major discourses: the *Satipatthana* discourse, the discourse on how to establish awareness, and then there's a whole discourse which is devoted to the body. I think it's mindfulness of the body he translates it as. What the Buddha says is that mindfulness of the body, by which he means a right relationship with the body, is one way of stopping Mara getting in, by which he means unwholesome and unskillful thoughts.

He gives a couple of examples. He likes metaphor. He loves metaphor. "Anyone who has developed and cultivated mindfulness of body has included within himself what wholesome states that are, that partake of true knowledge. Just as one who has extended his mind over the great ocean has included within it whatever streams that are that flow into the ocean, so too anyone who has developed and cultivated mindfulness of the body has included within himself whatever wholesome states there are that partake of true knowledge."

So the true knowledge, which is to do with the three characteristics, seeing things as they really are, begins with the body. The body is obvious. The mind isn't so obvious. Emotions can be obvious. Thoughts are not so obvious. They're sort of, in a sense, intangibles when compared to the body. The body has that sort of sense of reality, inverted commas — and it's not real, but it has that groundedness in the earth. Dust to dust, ashes to ashes.

Then he says, "Anybody who's not developed and cultivated mindfulness of the body, Mara finds an opportunity and a support in him. Suppose a man were to throw a heavy stone ball upon a mound of wet clay. What do you think? Would that heavy ball find entry into that mound of wet clay?" "Oh, yes, venerable sir."

He gives these lovely examples. "Suppose there were a dry sapless piece of wood and the man came with an upper fire stick" — so remember they're rubbing sticks together — "I shall light a fire and I shall produce heat. What do you think? Could a man light a fire and produce heat by rubbing the dry sapless wood with an upper fire stick?" "Yes, Venerable Sir."

He gives lots of these little examples to show, to get across to people that if you're not aware of the body, if you're not within the body, have a proper relationship to the body, then it can cause you suffering. The suffering is through attachment, through indulgence, and through aversion to the body.

Finally he has the benefits of the body. Some of them are about extrasensory perceptions and remembering past lives and all that. But the first ones we can relate to, I think, easily enough. "One becomes a conqueror of discontent and delight, and discontent does not conquer one. One abides overcoming discontent when it arises." This, of course, is the discontent from the body, feelings of hunger, etc.

"One becomes a conqueror of fear and dread, and fear and dread do not conquer oneself. One abides overcoming fear and dread whenever they arise." So, of course, fear and dread to the body arise whenever it's in peril, whenever it's in danger.

"One bears cold and heat, hunger and thirst, the contact with gadflies, mosquitoes, wind, the sun, the creeping things," and of course coronavirus. So those are the physical things that we can endure. But one also endures ill-spoken, unwelcome words, especially when people make comments about your body, and "the risen bodily feelings that are painful, wracking, sharp, fierce, disagreeable, distressing and menacing to life."

If we can get the right relationship to the body, then yes, pain is part of the process. Pain comes with life. What can you do? But at least we won't have this second arrow, as the Buddha talked about it, the second dart, which is the suffering, which is our reaction, which is how we relate to the body as me, mine, etc. And all the fears of sickness, of aging and death arise because of that.

There's a whole discourse here on how to establish that mindfulness. The sections are the same as in the *Satipatthana* discourse. First of all, there's the breath itself. The breath and emotions are intimately connected, as you know. Therefore, when we sit with the breath and quieten the breath, it has an effect on the heart. It quiets the heart. It stills the mind and the body feels good when we allow the body just to breathe.

In fact, he says, "I shall breathe in, tranquilizing the body formations. I shall breathe out, tranquilizing the bodily formations." So there's an effort there in the practice to use the breath to just feel relaxed, to feel at ease. When you're doing that, you can feel the tension slough off as they leave you, these tensions that might be in the body. It can even be invigorating if you use the breath, just put a bit of energy into it — you can lift the energy.

These exercises are not *vipassana*. You have to be careful. You have to know you're using the breath to bring about calmness, to calm yourself or to lift energy. And that's fine. What we don't want to do is confuse *samatha* or breath techniques with *vipassana*. *Vipassana* is letting things be and seeing the three characteristics.

He talks about the four postures, which are the four postures of meditation: walking, sitting, lying down. They're your major postures. Full awareness. Here he talks about doing things mindfully: "He acts with full awareness going forward and returning, full awareness looking ahead, looking away, full awareness flexing and extending his limbs, full awareness wearing his robes, wearing your clothes, full awareness while eating, drinking, consuming, tasting, full awareness while defecating and urinating, and who acts in full awareness when walking, standing, sitting, falling asleep, waking up, talking and keeping silent."

In other words, the whole moment to moment mindfulness, as the Mahasi would say, is the secret of success.

Then he goes on to the foulness of the body. Here he's got a great list: "bone marrow, kidneys, heart, large intestine, small intestine, feces, bile, phlegm, pus, blood, sweat, fat, tears, grease, spittle, snot, oil in the joints." That's quite a list really, isn't it?

He says, "just as though there was a bag with an opening at both ends full of many sorts of grains such as hill rice, red rice, beans, peas, millets and white rice, and a man with good eyes were to open it and review it thus: this is this, this is this." It's really getting a sense of equanimity, getting that sense of non-reactivity to the body and its foulness, because we tend to put our attention on its beauty, surface beauty.

Then, of course, there's the elements. The elements, remember — fire, earth, water and air, or wind. Wind is movement. These refer, of course, to pressures, solidity, to water — elasticity, cohesiveness, fire — heat, any form of heat or cold, and of course, the wind, which is movement. This is pointing to how the basic sensations that come in from the body into the mind. That's what they are. They're not objective physics. They're about how they are the subjective experience we have within ourselves of matter. This is what you can explore a bit in your practice.

Finally, there's the charnel grounds. I think there are nine where you go and sit at the charnel ground, because in those days, they would just leave the body out, dressed in white robes. It was these white robes that the ascetics would take, the *samanas* would take, and make robes out of them. The Buddha himself would have done that. They're on the charnel ground devoured by crows, hawks, vultures, dogs, jackals, worms, etc. And as you're looking at...

Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness — Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

In this teaching on the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), Bhante Bodhidhamma continues his exploration of Right Awareness (sammā sati) with focus on body contemplation (kāyānupassanā). He examines the traditional refrain that follows each section, emphasizing how practitioners develop awareness internally and externally while recognizing impermanence and establishing independence from clinging.

The talk covers the four postures meditation, daily life awareness practices, and the contemplation of body parts. Bhante addresses common misconceptions about the "foulness of the body" teaching, clarifying that the Pali term nibbidā means disenchantment rather than disgust. He shares the historical account of monks who misunderstood this teaching with tragic consequences, leading to the Buddha's third Pārājika rule.

Drawing on his experience with both Zen and Mahasi Vipassana traditions, Bhante offers practical guidance for maintaining awareness throughout daily activities without mystification. He emphasizes finding a balanced relationship with the body — neither indulging in sensuality nor developing aversion, but seeing the body as a precious vehicle for liberation while remaining unattached to its changing conditions.

Greetings. I trust you've had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa, Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa

So we're making our way through the discourse on right mindfulness. We'll see how far we get this evening. Don't want to rush it, but remember this is only a quick introduction and there are many studies now that you can follow if you wish.

We talked about the body and the breath yesterday, and there's a refrain that comes after every section. It says: "In this way he abides contemplating the body as body" — and it really should be "body in the body" — "internally, and abides contemplating the body in the body externally." That's a bit more difficult. It's really recognising the breath in other people. So we've talked about that, I think. "Or else he abides both the rising and falling factors." So this is beginning to understand the impermanence of the

breath. And then finally, he establishes just this mindfulness, just this direct, clear comprehension of what's happening. So that just enough intuitive intelligence and mindfulness is there for insight to arise. And that just comes with practice. You just keep practising.

"And he abides independent, not clinging to anything in the world." So by taking the position of the observer within ourselves, we've left the world as it were. We transcended it. We found a different relationship with it. We don't want to be concerned with it as somewhere where we're going to find any permanent happiness or try to escape the natural pains of living. And so he abides contemplating the body in the body or as the body, whatever you prefer.

Now, the next section is the four postures. It's very simply stated. When you're walking, you understand "I am walking." So in other words, you're aware of walking. And the same with standing and sitting and lying down. So those postures relate mainly to meditation practice. That lying down one, it came up this afternoon in a discussion. It's difficult to do that because as soon as you lie the body down, there's no physical energy supporting your mindfulness. And therefore, of course, there's a tendency just to fall asleep and there's not so much to be gained in oblivion.

There is one way — for those of you who weren't there this morning — a little trick that people use to keep awake if they're doing the lying meditation is to keep your hand up like this. And every time you fall asleep, the hand drops. And that wakes you up. And if you put something just under your elbow so that you don't hit the funny bone, after a while, it just stays there. The body learns how to just keep your hand there, just as it learned. If you're ill, although actually when you're ill, it's more common to practise *mettā*, loving kindness towards the body.

And there's always this "externally, internally and externally" — in other words recognising this in ourselves but also recognising it in other people. And that gives you this connection. If you remember when the Buddha was fully liberated, he had these two insights: how he had come there by his moral ethical actions — and it was that line of ethical actions rebirth after rebirth that led to his liberation — and he saw the beings also moving from realm to realm dependent on their moral and ethical actions. So what was personal becomes a universal law. What is personal for us becomes universal when you see other people behaving or acting in the same way, having the same experiences, similar experiences.

And then, of course, there's a whole section here about daily life practice. So, again, one acts in full awareness going forward, coming backwards, returning. One acts in full awareness when looking ahead or looking away, when flexing and extending one's

limbs. When wearing — well here, of course, it's directed to the monks — but wearing one's clothes, one acts in full awareness when eating, drinking, consuming food and tasting. That's one that's devoted entirely to the whole process of eating. One acts in full awareness defecating and urinating — so you don't forget, that's very important. And then acts in full awareness walking, standing, sitting, falling asleep and waking up, talking and keeping silent.

So in other words, this mindfulness we should carry with us throughout the day as best we can. How do we know we're being mindful? We're being mindful when we're being deliberate, when you are doing what you meant to do. If you're doing something and the mind's wandering — take a simple example: if you're washing the pots and you're thinking about where you're going to go for your holidays — then there's a split. You're not being mindful about what you're doing so the pots don't get washed so well or you drop one or whatever. But as soon as you wake up from that little fantasy, then you can decide: are you going to stop and think about your holiday or you're going to keep washing the pots? So you keep washing the pots. So this mindfulness is just being with what you're doing.

I remember because the Mahāsi technique — everything's very slow. People were much confused about daily life. Did you have to go very slow in order to be mindful? Now, luckily I'd begun with Zen at Throssel Hole Abbey in Northumberland. And there you did — we used to do everything at speed. It wasn't slow, you did everything very, very fast. And the idea was that you built up energy while you were doing this, working, cleaning or out in the gardens. And because you were working fast you had to keep your mind on it or else you'd stump your foot, you'd cut yourself, you'd do something silly. And when you sat of course that energy and focus stayed with you. That's one reason why the Zen I was doing didn't have a particular focus because you could maintain just that attention, just feeling, observing things that came into your mind. We didn't sit that long — forty minutes.

So I didn't have that problem, really. But people who were just doing the *Vipassanā*, just doing the Mahāsi, there was this constant question: "Well, how do you keep mindfulness? You have to go very, very slow." And I remember my teacher, *Sayādaw* Janaka, he'd pick up a pencil that was lying there, he'd pick it up and then he'd put it down. That was it, really. That was a demonstration of mindfulness in action.

So don't mystify it. It's just being with what you're doing. Being your doing is a way to put it. And then, of course, the usual refrain: to be aware of what you're doing, to begin to recognise that things are finished, especially finished. We're very much aware of beginning something, starting something. Because that tends to be new, it tends to be

renewal, a rebirthing moment after moment. But we're not so much aware of things ending. Before something ends, we're on to something else. The ending — all ends, remember, are mini deaths. And so we tend to shy off and we tend to leap beyond that to the next thing to be done.

And then, of course, one can have insights, peeling a banana, having a cup of tea. Insights don't come just when you're sitting. In fact, in the Mahāsi tradition, it's well known that it's when you're not sitting that you're more likely to have an insight because often when you're sitting, you're trying, you're trying to get an insight, you're trying to do something. And then when you get up from the seat, because you've got that mindfulness and concentration and you've given up trying to see something or understand something, suddenly there is a seeing of impermanence or not-self. Or just that process of creating suffering for ourselves through wrong desire. So mindfulness in action can bring about the same insights as in meditation.

Now, the next one — let's just keep an eye on the time here, that's good — the next one is rather interesting. It's translated as "the foulness of the body parts." I'll just read it through so that the Buddha is not shy of the body. "And he reviews the same body up and down from the soles of the feet, down from the top of the hair, bounded by skin and full of many kinds of impurities. In the body: head hairs, body hairs, nails, teeth, skin, flesh, sinews, bones, bone marrow, kidneys, heart, liver, diaphragm, spleen, lungs, large intestines, small intestines, contents of the stomach, faeces, bile, phlegm, pus, blood, sweat, fat, tears, grease, spittle, snot, oil of the joints and urine."

That's a good list, isn't it? What intrigues me actually about this list is that the brain isn't included. That was a later addition. I don't know whether the ancients knew what the brain was or what it was for. Because, of course, when it drops out of somebody's head, it's just this lump of fat, isn't it?

And then he gives an example. Now, this example really tells us what the attitude really is. It's unfortunate that people use the word "disgust" or "foulness." "But just as there were a bag with an opening at both ends full of many sorts of grains such as hill rice, red rice, beans, peas, millet and white rice, and a man with good eyes were to open it and review it thus: 'This is hill rice, this is red rice, this is beans, this is peas, this is millet and this is white rice,' so a *bhikkhu* reviews the same body full of impurities."

Now there was a moment where the Buddha obviously gave a very inspiring speech about this, about the body, looking at the body like this, and he must have got across to these monks, to really look upon the body as something that is not to be indulged — their senses weren't to be indulged. But somehow they got the wrong message. And so what happened was: "And he talked to the *bhikkhus* in many ways on the subject of im-

purity. He spoke in praise of what is impure. He spoke in praise of the contemplation of what is impure. He spoke again and again in praise of the stage of meditation of what is impure."

"And then the *bhikkhus* went away to meditate. Now they dwelt intent upon the practice of contemplating what is impure in different ways. They were troubled in their own bodies, ashamed of them, loathing them. And as if — and then he goes on — it is as if a woman or man, when young or delicate and fond of dressing, having washed their hair, would be troubled, ashamed and full of loathing because they had a corpse of a snake or of a dog or of a man hung around their neck. Now, so these *bhikkhus*, being troubled by their own bodies, ashamed of them and loathing them, by themselves, deprived themselves of life and deprived each other of life."

So they actually killed each other and killed themselves. Now, when this came back to the Buddha, of course, he must have been — well, it says here that he's extremely angry with them. He must have been, shall we say, very forthright. "*Bhikkhus*, it is not suitable for *bhikkhus*. It is not fit. It is not proper. It is not worthy of a disciple. It is not good. It should not be done." — killing each other, that is.

And then he says, "Whatever *bhikkhu*..." and then he makes a rule, which is the third rule, I think. Yes, the third rule, the *Pārājika*, the defeat rule, whereby if you break the rule, you've lost your robes — you're no longer in communion, that's how it's put. "Whatever *bhikkhu* intentionally deprives a human being of life or seeks to be the knife bearer, he is defeated, he is not one in the community." And there's also encouraging somebody to commit suicide — that's also included in being a knife bearer. So it becomes a third major rule for monks after that.

And then, of course, Ānanda says to the Buddha, "It would be a good thing, Lord, if you would explain in another way, so the community of *bhikkhus* might establish their knowledge." And of course, he does do that.

Now, interestingly enough, the word that's often translated as "disgust" is *nibbidā*. But *nibbidā* really ought to be translated as "disenchantment," a disinterest. So the whole idea is that you balance the pleasures of the body with the displeasures, with the things that are unpleasant. And that way you get a balanced view of your body. When it comes to lust, erotic feelings that have become obsessive, to become lustful, when one actually makes that body go to the toilet, and that definitely undermines the lust. But you're not supposed to then feel disgusted of the object of your lust — you're just supposed to be able to counteract that lustfulness that's grown in you. So it's a balancing act.

But of course the body is also a precious vehicle. The Buddha is clear about that. This is a precious life form and we ought to care for the body. He's often talking about the need for health for the body in order to meditate. So one has to be careful with this.

Now there was one incident — I've been trying to find it but I've been unable to do so — where the monks have been practising this contemplation on the parts of the body that we dislike or we sometimes find disgusting. And he sees that they've created some form of non-attachment to the body. But there's something missing. And what he does is he teaches them loving kindness. And according to the tale, they all become fully liberated. So there's the balance really: to respect the body, care for the body, the need for the body. But we're always trying not to get caught up in its sensuality and not be attached to our sense pleasures, but to recognise that they arise and pass away. And that allows us to enjoy things without that stickiness, without wanting more, more, more. So that's the purpose of the meditation on the body.

And as usual, he abides contemplating internally — one's own body — another person's body. And in that way, they abide independent. That's the nice word. Independent, not clinging to anything in the world.

I think we can stop there because the next bit now takes a little bit more. I ought to spend a bit more time on that because that's the elements. So I hope that's a little bit just to go on with. It's something you can practise by yourself. It's not a big deal. Just recognising the parts of the body that we don't normally like. So there's a sense of disgust for parts of the body — and then is that necessary? Can you live, can you just see what the disgusting parts of the body is — just a necessary function, chemicals? Change your view of it.

Then there's the body beautiful — expecting the body to be beautiful and that often has an effect upon our self-esteem. Just remind ourselves it's an organism and it has a job to do and it's making me see things and hear things. It carries me here and there, it lifts things for me. So it's a case of bringing ourselves off this idea that you have to be beautiful to be happy.

And the third one is to recognise or to contemplate: what is it that we most fear loss of? Going blind or going deaf or paralysis. The loss of functions in the body creates a lot of fear for us. And by bringing those to mind and to accept that, to accept our attachment to these things... And of course, we know from people who do have disabilities that it doesn't have to undermine the quality of your life. But moving from an able person to a disabled person is traumatic. It's a sort of death. But once you get there and arrive, then you accept things as they are.

So these contemplations are there to find a different relationship to the body and that relationship is to be disenchanted with it, not to be caught up in it, but to see it as a precious vehicle through which we are trying to become fully liberated from suffering.

So I can only hope my words will in fact lead you to the liberation from suffering sooner rather than later, so we can begin our contemplation, our meditation.

Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness: Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10) - Elements and Charnel Ground Contemplations

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 19 min

In this profound exploration of the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines two crucial contemplations within the body section: the four elements (mahābhūta) and the nine charnel ground reflections. He explains how the classical elements of earth, water, fire, and air correspond to pressure, cohesiveness, temperature, and motion, demonstrating their practical application in vipassanā meditation. Through vivid examples, Bhante shows how to deconstruct painful sensations by investigating their elemental components, moving beyond conceptual suffering to direct perception at the sense base level.

The teaching then turns to the traditional charnel ground contemplations, where practitioners reflect on corpses in various stages of decay. Bhante shares personal experiences with death and explains how death contemplation paradoxically brings us into the present moment, fostering appreciation for life's preciousness. He emphasizes the Buddha's direct experiential knowledge of these practices and their role in developing Right Awareness and insight into impermanence (anicca). This teaching offers both theoretical understanding and practical guidance for incorporating these profound contemplations into daily meditation practice and spiritual development.

Good evening. I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, although I do wish it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So we are continuing with our passage through the discourse on the foundations or the establishment of mindfulness. And we're looking at the body. The first section is the body, and we've been through the breath, using the breath for mindfulness and seeing mainly impermanence. The four postures and then full awareness, which basically is daily life practice. Then we have the body parts to overcome any sense of disgust with the body. Remember, it's about being disenchanted.

And so there are two more sections, one is called the elements and one is called the nine charnel grounds, so these elements. I think this runs across the ancient world actually. They say they determine four different characteristics, from which the mind built up some image some feeling et cetera. And they were earth, which is to do with pressure and lightness; fire, which is to do with heat, cold, and warmth; water, which is elasticity, cohesiveness, so it also is stiffness; and air or wind. Sometimes it's wind, which is motion or again, stillness.

These were meant to be investigated when we actually meditate. Now, it's pretty clear to see that when we're doing touch, on the feeling of touch. We'll come to it in a minute. With eyesight, I mean, it's the subatomic particles, which is quite amazing, really, when you think about it, to be sensitive to subatomic particles. Photons, light, maybe heat, but it's not really discussed. The ears definitely pressure, definitely the pressure of sound waves. And that's actually all you get at the ear drum. That's the sense base. Everything else is done by what's known as the mind door or the whole process within the mind itself, turning it into a sound, giving it a meaning, et cetera. When it comes to taste and smell, that's even more subtle in a way. I don't think they pertain so clearly to that, although things like pressure, heat, I mean that's obvious when you're eating, but the more subtle sensations I think really aren't explained by these four, but that's just a personal understanding.

If you want to have the traditional understanding, it's in the *Visuddhimagga*, The Path of Purification by Buddhaghosa. There's a whole section there if you want it. So that's a big tome. It's probably one of the greatest, one of the great spiritual works of the world, of any spiritual tradition. It holds not only the understanding of the Buddha, but also all the practices. So it's quite a compendium. You wouldn't want to read it from the first page to the end. There's about a thousand pages. But as an encyclopedia of spiritual practice and understanding, it really is quite extraordinary. Buddhaghosa. It was compiled, I think, in our Middle Ages, about 500s or so.

Okay, so what it says is that the meditator reviews the same body, however it is placed, however disposed as consisting of elements. In this body, there's the earth element, the water element, fire element and the air element, just as though a skilled butcher and his apprentice had killed a cow and was seated at a crossroads with it cut up in pieces. So a *bhikkhu*, a meditator reviews this same body as consisting of the elements. So just as a butcher, you know, whatever, the leg or the head or whatever, yeah, so you understand that.

So this comes into play when we're practicing *vipassanā*. For instance if you have a pain in the knee for instance when you're meditating or discomfort in the knee or whatever so as it draws your attention you go to it and your first word will be say pain right so you're saying pain this is pain this is what pain feels like and then when you're established there and you make sure that the aversion to the pain has disappeared completely so you're entirely equanimous with the pain. You then, as it were, absorb into the pain. You go into the pain to deconstruct it, right? To find out what are the sensations that constitute this concept of pain. And of course, when you go in there, you'll find things like pressure or heat or a combination of little sensations. And at that level, of course, there's no concept of pain, so there's no suffering, right? You've deconstructed it.

So that's the level of direct perception at the sense base. So this is where the Buddha talks about the point of contact. For those of you who know dependent origination, the psychology of the Buddha. So at the point of contact, there has to be an object, there has to be a sense base, so the five senses, including the mind, the sixth sense, because that's the one that the emotions and thoughts appear upon. And also this basic information from all the other senses appear upon the mind door, as it's called.

The object, the sense base and consciousness. So consciousness is obviously there like a screen upon which this arises. If it doesn't arise on consciousness, the screen of consciousness, then you don't know it. I'm sure you've all had the experience of wondering where you got that bruise from or how you cut yourself because your mind was so involved in something you didn't actually notice how you got caught in a door or something or, you know, slight bruise, not a big one. And that means that that sensation didn't impact on the mind door.

So these four elements are really apparent to us when we really go into a sensation or feeling. Now it's the same with an emotion you see, deconstructing an emotion. What is an emotion before you give it a name? So you might find for instance anxiety or fear for instance and it is in you, you can feel it in your heart and you draw your attention to it and then of course you've got to make sure the fear, the fear's gone, all the reaction's gone, the aversion's gone. And so you're left with the fear. Then you go into the fear. Now what is it you're actually feeling at that sense sensation base? You see it's not very much, some watery business, some fluidy stuff, some pressure. And of course by doing that you begin to undermine this fear of the fear when you realize actually it's just a compendium of these sensations. Okay so it does have a real purpose for insight.

And the second thing is, of course, that when you're at that level of perception, impermanence becomes more obvious. They're just arising and passing away all the time. So this is an important teaching about elements in the foundations there.

Now, the next one is the charnel ground. So it's always interesting this, by the way, in those days, they would just lay the bodies out in an open ground, and as you'll see from it that the local animals would eat it, they were shrouded in white. And it was these cloths that the mendicants, not just the Buddhists, not just the followers of the Buddha, but all mendicants used to take and sew into robes. And the Buddha simply followed that practice. Later on, when he had a group of monks and nuns around him, he wanted them to look a bit more tidy. So he asked them to cut this cloth in such ways that it recreated a paddy field. And you can probably see the lines on my robe here at the back here. So in between the sections there, the paddy fields and the narrow bits of the paths, the raised paths that sort of follow the paddy field round and you can walk around the paddy field. So you've got a very good robe there, that shows you. And to then boil them with an arachnid, which gave them a sort of brownie colour.

And then he went on to ask the orders to shave their hair off their head, you see. So all the others had matted hair, you know, dreadlocks. If you see the aesthetics of today that still exist today in India, you'll see that they've got matted locks. So it was cooler to have your hair off anyway in that sort of climate. So I think it was an effort to make his monks and nuns look a bit smart, you might say.

So again, because as though he were seeing a corpse thrown aside in the charnel ground one, two, three days dead, bloated, livid and oozing matter. A *bhikkhu* compares this same body with it thus. This body too is of the same nature. It will be like that. It is not exempt from that fate. So it's that connection, you see, to sit with this rotting corpse and to remind oneself that, well, you know, one day this is going to be like that.

By the way, the commentaries tell people not to sit windward. That's obviously a bit of good advice. Now in this way, he abides contemplating the body both internally and externally, et cetera.

And as though, again, as though he were to see a corpse thrown aside in the charnel ground devoured by crows, hawks, vultures, dogs, jackals, various kinds of worms. And again, this body, this body too is of the same nature. It will be like that. It is not exempt from that fate.

And as though he were to see a corpse thrown aside in the charnel ground, a skeleton with flesh and blood held together with sinews. A fleshless skeleton smeared with blood held together with sinews. A skeleton without flesh and blood held together with

sinews. Disconnected bones scattered in all directions. Here a hand bone, there a foot bone, here a shin bone, there a thigh bone, here a hip bone, there a back bone, here a rib bone, there a breast bone, here an arm bone, there a shoulder bone, here a neck bone, there a jaw bone, here a tooth, there a skull. And the *bhikkhu* compares this same body with it thus. This body too is the same nature. It will be like that. It is not exempt from that fate.

And then the final bit is a corpse thrown aside in the charnel grounds, bones bleached white, the color of shells, bones heaped up more than a year old, bones rotted and crumbled to dust. The *bhikkhu* compares the same body. This body too is of the same nature. It will be like that. It is not exempt from that fate.

So he's very big on death, the Buddha. I did, for those of you who are new to the evening, I did a whole section on death and the Buddha's teachings about death and how to do death contemplations in earlier videos. But here it's really grinding our nose in the dirt you might say and you can see from his explanation that he's done it, he's been there, he's sat with this lot and he's made those observations right. So this comes from his own personal experience without any doubt.

I don't know if you've actually seen a dead body, but it is definitely lifeless. And when you go to the East as a *bhikkhu*, as a monk or nun, you can go to the mortuary, you can go to the pathology department and see them cutting the body open and trying to find out why the person died, et cetera. And that's quite an experience.

My first experience with a dead body actually goes back to when I was about the age of 10. My father, my great aunt Florence, which is a lovely First World War name, isn't it, Florence? She died and my father asked me if I wanted to come and see the body. I was a 10 year old, of course, that did sound like an adventure. And when we got there, she was laid out, you see, and I just remember touching her forehead here. And it was very cold or cool, you know, and it moved, you know, like I thought it'd be stiff, but it moved. And I don't remember being particularly upset by it or anything like that. It was just a dead body.

But the next time I had an occasion with a dead body was I was at the Buddhist Vihara. I was already ordained actually, it was my first year. And I was at the Vihara in Birmingham, that's where I was staying. And we had a visit from some Christian monks from the St. Bernard's Abbey, which is near Birmingham. And they were picking up Tibetan monks who were staying with us. And it was part of this communication, you might say, between monks of different, well, between the Buddhist and the Christian monks. And he was an elderly man and he got hold of this huge case and carried it out to his car. As I came out from the gate, he was falling to the ground, calling for assist-

ance, you see. So I put the bags down and ran over to him. And so I held him as he was lying down on the ground, you see. And he lost consciousness. And then he made this huge effort to come back, his eyes open and he's trying to come back. And then he just let go. And the weight of the body was quite obvious to me. I was thinking it's rather ironic that this wonderful Christian monk died with a Buddhist head as his last vision. And then the ambulance came 10 minutes later, but he was gone.

So when we have an occasion to be with somebody who's dying, this is a real teaching for us. I mean, that sounds a bit callous almost. I mean, you're there for the person who's dying, of course, but it does bring it to you. And to observe anything that's died, your pet that's died, that can be also quite a teaching too. Or anything that you see on the road that's been run over by a car. That also is a teaching of this finality, of this disappearance of the person. And what you're left with is, well, just a bag of bones, really.

So something that it's good to contemplate. Now, I do it every day this evening. I do the reflections on sickness, aging and death. It only takes a moment, but it just puts that sort of reality back in life, you know, that everything is coming to an end. And quite paradoxically, you think you'd get depressed if you brought that to mind. But of course, it brings you into the present moment and the sheer miracle of being here, the sheer miracle of being awake, of being aware. And the effort then is to make the most of it. So the contemplation of death, however you do it, has great benefits. And also, of course, in the final hour, we remind ourselves, my mother died, my father died. Everybody's been there. The Buddha died, for heaven's sake. And that gives you the courage to go through the gate.

So, yes, do contemplation of sickness aging and death at least for a little moment every day. So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not created too much confusion and that by your practice you will be liberated from suffering sooner rather than later. Just in case I forget by the way, all those of you who've joined because of the lockdown, you are, of course, welcome to join me every evening because this will go on until the end of lockdown, whenever that is. I'm hoping it won't be next year, that's all.

Very good. So I'll start with the Refuges and Precepts.

Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness — Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

In this continuation of his series on the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the second and third foundations of Right Awareness: contemplation of feelings (vedanā) and mind (citta). After completing the body section in previous talks, he examines how to observe pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral feelings, distinguishing between worldly feelings arising from sensual experience and unworldly feelings connected to spiritual practice.

The talk covers the contemplation of mental states, including minds affected by desire, hatred, and delusion versus those free from these hindrances. Bhante discusses concentrated and unconcentrated states, exalted jhānic absorption, and the liberated mind. Throughout, he emphasizes the importance of maintaining the observer position — watching feelings and mental states arise and pass without identification or personalization.

Key practical guidance includes recognizing when desires or aversions end naturally, experiencing the peace of an untroubled heart-mind, and using investigation to deconstruct the apparent solidity of mental phenomena. This approach cultivates dispassion and insight into the three characteristics of existence while establishing the independence necessary for vipassanā practice.

There's a lovely German word for when you try to make it something better only to make it worse. I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, although I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sambhasambuddhassa.
Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sambhasambuddhassa.
Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sambhasambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed noble and fully self-awakened one.

I just want to mention, some of you might not know, the online meditation hall, which is on the Zoom. And the times are 6 a.m., nice and early, fresh, 9 a.m., 11 a.m., so that's 6, 9, 11 in the morning, and 2 p.m., 4 p.m., and 6 p.m. in the afternoon. And in the morning at 6 a.m., Noreen is normally here, and I'm hoping to be here at 2 p.m. Noreen will also be here. If you want to get on the Zoom to stop Zoom bombing and all that, you

have to get in touch with Mark. There he is, there's Mark. Hi Mark, I'm just wondering if you'd like to put your email up so that people can contact you if they want to be on the online meditation hall.

So that's an online meditation or you can join. You can go on anytime actually, but those are the times set where you might meet people there—6, 9, 11 in the morning and 2, 4, 6 in the afternoon. Mark's put it up there. That's Mark Arthur. So if you want to take that email, he'll let you in. He's the gatekeeper. We don't pay him anything.

So now just to carry on with the foundations of mindfulness, as Bhikkhu Bodhi calls it, discourse number 10. It's the jewel of the collection, remember. And we finished the body part. So that contained the breathing, of course, the whole instructions on breath meditation, the four postures—standing, walking, sitting and lying down—full awareness, continual awareness during the day, the foulness of the body, which remember is really to do with becoming disenchanted with the body, disinterested with it. And of course, the good old charnel grounds. Oh, elements, the elements, the four basic elements that point to where our physicality and mentality meet at the sense door. That's the retina, the eardrum and so forth. And the nine charnel grounds, yes, the nine bodies that are slowly corrupting into pure dust, to dust thou shalt return.

So the next one is feeling. Now, I've actually done quite a bit on that already on talk number 28, if you want to look it up. But we'll read it through and it's pretty straightforward.

And how does one abide contemplating feelings as feelings? Now, remember, he's translating it as feelings. But to me, the grammar is to feel feelings in feelings. In a sense, they both mean the same thing—feeling as feeling, feelings in feelings. But the idea of being right in there, like in a room, in the bath, like you're sunk in. So whatever feeling that is, the idea is to get into it and really feel it. Open up to it completely, absorb into it, you might say.

Here, when feeling a pleasant feeling, the meditator understands, "I feel a pleasant feeling." Now remember, you're not supposed to be saying to yourself, "I am feeling a pleasant feeling." It's just a recognition that you're feeling a pleasant feeling. It's a consciousness. You're aware of it. And when feeling a painful feeling, he understands, "I feel a painful feeling." When feeling a neither painful nor pleasant feeling, he understands, "I feel a neither painful nor pleasant feeling."

So there's the neutral bit. Actually, if you look close enough, feelings will always shade ever so slightly towards pleasant, ever so slightly towards unpleasant, and that's the dual world that we live in. I mean that's apparent to us, I think even in the womb,

that there are pleasant feelings and unpleasant feelings. And this whole area that we would call neutral. And of course, it's upon neutral feelings that we can establish that calmness, that peace. That's why the breath, walking meditation—so they do have their purpose in our practice.

And then he knows when there's a worldly feeling—a worldly pleasant feeling and a worldly unpleasant feeling, and a neither pleasant nor unpleasant worldly feeling. And he knows when an unworldly feeling is there. So worldly and unworldly. So we did this, of course, way back there.

So worldly feelings are just to do with being in the world. The sensual world is to do with the work we're doing, whatever we're experiencing, eating, etc. The unworldly feelings are all to do with the spiritual side. So it's to do with renunciation, letting go of things with compassion, love, worldly feelings that come through our practice, peacefulness, the factors of enlightenment, equanimity and things like that. So anything to do with the spiritual life is unworldly. That's the word for it. Anything to do with the world is worldly. That doesn't necessarily mean it's unwholesome. If you're doing worldly, like the work you're doing, for instance, will have a worldly purpose. You've got to earn money and so forth. But it doesn't make it unwholesome. But that doesn't lead to liberation. What leads to liberation are the investigation of these three characteristics—remember how we cause suffering, the process of wrong desire, impermanence and not self.

And there's the usual refrain—he abides contemplating feelings as feelings internally, but he also notices such feelings in other people. You can tell it on their face and so forth. And if you're sensitive enough, sometimes you can actually feel how they feel. If they're joyous, you can feel the joy being mirrored on the surface of your own heart, equally so anger and all that. And he abides feeling feelings both internally and externally. He also abides contemplating feelings in their arising factors and abides contemplating feelings in their vanishing factors, and abides contemplating feelings in both their arising and falling. So that's basically being aware that everything is always in process, always consistently changing. That's the one thing that never changes.

Or else mindfulness that "there is feeling" is simply established in him to the extent necessary for bare knowledge and mindfulness. And he abides independent. So this last phrase is really the position of *vipassanā*, where finally you're just resting on the object, observing it very carefully. And there is this background view of it, which is looking at it from the point of view of any reaction that we have to it—it's impermanence and not self. It's just a way of looking.

And just enough. He says just enough knowledge. Actually, the word is just enough intuitive awareness, actually. Just bare knowledge and mindfulness, bare knowledge and mindfulness. So it's just that ability to observe with that open curiosity, with the intelligence awakened—that intuitive intelligence awake. And that's just part of that whole of awareness. Remember, there's the active and the passive. So the passive is when we're receiving stuff and the active is when we actually grasp what's happening. First you look and then you see. And he abides independent, not clinging to anything in the world. So let go of the world as such. So that's the whole section on feeling.

Now, it is an important section because if you ask yourself—if you look into your body, especially feelings that are caused by the mind. So there are two—this doesn't actually say that, but there are two different types of feelings. Remember, feelings coming from the body—pain, discomfort, sense of pleasure, itching, all those sorts of things. And pleasure and pleasant feelings coming from the heart, from mental states.

And when you say you're happy, just ask yourself, what do you mean by that? Do you mean you have happy thoughts? Or is it a sensation? Or is it more a feeling of being a happy feeling in us? Do we rate our happiness by how we feel rather than what we're thinking, or actually or the physical state? If I put something in my mouth which is sweet, do I say that this is happiness? No, that's just sweetness. But if the sweetness makes me happy and I say, "Oh, I'm happy. I'm happy because of the sweetness." And we often judge our lives according to whether we're happy or not. So if I'm not being happy, I find that I'm wasting my life or I'm finding that my life isn't worth living anymore.

See, so it's important to find that distance from feeling and not to be governed by them, not to personalise them. There it is. There is now a happy feeling. There is now a sad feeling. Now get on with what you have to do. As soon as you identify with it, you say, "I am happy, I am depressed," etc. And in a sense, you've locked yourself in. It's like an imprisonment. So that's the section on feeling.

The next section is also pretty straightforward, the section on mind or mental states. So these include both your thinking, your imagining, etc., and just general mental states as such of which feeling is part of it, of which the body, of course, comes in somewhere.

So how does one abide contemplating the mind as the mind? He understands a mind affected by lust. He's got lust here, but that's pretty heavy lust and it tends to be around erotic desires, but it could be any sort of desire—the mind affected by wrong desire. He understands the mind affected by wrong desire as a mind affected by wrong desire and the mind unaffected by wrong desire as a mind unaffected by wrong desire.

It's also recognising actually when there's no desire in us and how does that feel? How does that feel when there's no desire? So it's not only the negative bit or that, you know, I'm overcome by this desire and whatnot, but how does it feel when it finishes? When it ends? And the same with hatred—a mind affected by hatred, a mind unaffected by aversion or hatred. So again, if we are in an adverse state, when it comes to an end and the aversion passes and the mind is just empty of those sorts of feelings, how does that feel?

So when we begin to experience the heart-mind—I should say heart really—the heart-mind as a pleasant place to be, when we begin to experience directly a heart-mind which is not caught up in wrong desires or some form of aversion or whatever, then of course we tend to go there. We tend to go there. So remember that we're always caught up with being excited, always trying to exercise a certain emotional mental state. What's it like when there isn't any there? When it's just a sense of peacefulness, calmness? And delusion as well, so that's the mind which is perhaps in a sense of doubt, confused.

The next one is a contracted mind. So this is much the same—it's contracted by wrong desires, aversions, things like that, sloth and torpor, wrong sort of tiredness, dullness in the head, lethargy in the body. That's caused by acts of laziness. So that is a contracted mind, whereas a distracted mind is one that is governed by restlessness. Mind going all over the place. Obsessive thinking, that sort of thing. So it's a case of just knowing what the mind is actually doing, what the heart-mind is actually doing.

He understands an exalted mind and an unexalted mind. So that's to do with the *jhānas*, really, these absorption states. So mostly we're not in an absorption state. He understands a surpassed mind as a surpassed mind and an unsurpassed mind. So this is, again, just in these absorption states—exalted, unsurpassed. These are all very high, very refined states of mind. And the unexalted ones and the surpassed ones are really to do with just the worldly states of mind.

And then there's the concentrated mind, of course, and the unconcentrated mind. So you can see they all shade into each other. It's just slightly different ways of looking at it. And then finally, the liberated mind and the unliberated. That's not to do with final liberation. That's just to do with the fact that when we're in an insightful mode, then the heart-mind is liberated. And when we're in a *jhāna*, in more of an absorbed, concentrated state, then the mind is liberated from hindrances.

And he abides contemplating the mind as mind internally and externally. So you can see these moods and emotions, mental states in other people, can't you? Even in their body language. And he abides contemplating the mind again with the arising factors

and the vanishing factors. So it's again always this impermanence, always this impermanence. And then finally, just this—this is the mental state—and he abides independent, not clinging to anything in the world. So that covers the next two sections of feeling and the mind itself. And the next one is the mind objects. And we'll tackle that tomorrow because that's a whole new section.

Really, it's just ways of looking at what we're experiencing. And remember that when we open up to something, say an emotional state, say we're full of joy, there's always that tendency to want to try and develop it. So we're always looking at that reaction. See, we're not getting caught up either in the joy or the reaction to it. And we're just watching that process. That's all, just watching the process and watching that desire to indulge just begin to fade away. Then we come back to the joy and there's that mental joy, that mental state.

And then you can go into it to find out, well, what's it made of at that basic level? And how is it affecting the body? How does the body feel when we're in a state of joy? Then you can move from those two different levels of perception. The perception of those four elements—some form of lightness, of warmth, etc. And then when you come to the next level of perception, you find this warm joy, and you recognise it as joy. So there are different ways that you can play around within yourself, just slowly deconstructing things. And this takes away that sense of solidity.

And in so doing, unwittingly, of course, we are establishing this position of the observer and it's there that we want to stay as best we can. That's in the meditation. Of course, as you begin to absorb, as you begin to become very concentrated in what you're seeing, then remember that that reflexive moment of the awareness being aware of itself as the observer, as the feeler, can disappear and with it time. And when you come out of that you can always say to yourself, oh well that was a moment of pure *vipassanā*, you might say. That doesn't make the other type of *vipassanā* with the observer impure—not at all. Insights are just insights. They come at any time.

So just work with what you have that comes up and you just see it as something to investigate, constantly awakening that sense of curiosity.

So I think we've done for this evening. And if you want to, there are those times—remember I'll just remind you again just in case. So this is the Zoom at 6 a.m.—yes, wonderful time—and they also start, there's a chanting starts at 10 to 7 and finishes 10 past thereabouts. Then there's a 9 a.m., 11 a.m., so it's 6, 9, 11, and then in the afternoon 2, 4 and 6. And of course when you join you stay as long as you want. If it's 10 minutes, it's 10 minutes. If it's an hour, it's an hour.

So hopefully you'll take advantage of this if you're still in firm lockdown, if it's just you in a room or in a house. So you might want to take advantage of that. Very good. I can only hope my words have been some assistance. May you by your fierce determination be liberated sooner rather than later. So we can begin our practice.

Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness - Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 22 min

In this continuation of his series on the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the fourth foundation of Right Awareness: contemplation of mind objects (dhammānupassanā). He examines specific Buddhist teachings as objects of contemplation, including the five hindrances (pañca nīvaraṇa), the five aggregates (pañca khandha), the six sense bases (saḷāyatana), and begins discussion of the seven factors of awakening (satta bojjhaṅga).

Bhante emphasizes the practical application of these teachings in vipassanā meditation, warning against over-analysis during practice itself. He explains how recognition of hindrances like sensual desire and aversion leads to understanding their arising and passing away, demonstrating the characteristic of impermanence (anicca). The talk illuminates how the aggregates represent a cross-section of human experience, while the sense bases function as different dimensions of awareness.

This teaching provides essential background knowledge for insight meditation while maintaining that during actual practice, one must simply watch, feel, and experience without analytical thinking. The discourse reveals how systematic awareness of these mind objects leads toward the liberation that is the ultimate goal of the path.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So we are making our way through the discourse on how to establish right awareness. We did the body, then we did feelings, and then we did mental states. So the last section is called the contemplation of mind objects. In the old translation, sometimes they used to talk about thoughts and things like that. But actually, when you read the discourse, it's quite obvious that the mind objects are specific teachings from the Buddha. So they're the five hindrances, the five aggregates, the six sense bases, the seven factors of enlightenment and the four noble truths.

I am going through this at great speed and the purpose and the reason for that is of course there are many good books on this sort of study if you want to take it more deeply. But also I'm always fearful that the meditation turns into a sort of analysis,

which is exactly what you don't want. So if you're in the meditation there and you're speaking to yourself and you're saying, "Now, is this a worldly, neither pleasant nor unpleasant feeling? Or is this an unworldly, neither pleasant nor unpleasant?", then in a sense, you've lost the plot.

The idea of studying like this is for it to be in the background and then when we come to *vipassanā* we forget all that. We just watch, we just feel. After *vipassanā* then of course you can reflect – that's not the problem. But it'll be quite clear that all thinking processes have to be put aside when we're just watching, just feeling, just experiencing.

I'll just read it so you get the phraseology of how the Buddha would have talked about it. So how does a bhikkhu – remember this word bhikkhu means anybody who's practicing – abide contemplating mind objects as mind objects? Here, a bhikkhu abides contemplating mind objects as mind objects in terms of the five hindrances. So when something comes into the mind, heart mind really, and it's one of the hindrances, that is an object to be observed, felt, understood.

And how does a bhikkhu abide contemplating mind objects as mind objects in terms of the five hindrances? Here, there being sensual desire in him, a bhikkhu understands there is sensual desire in him. So it's a direct acknowledgement of desire. So this is the benefit of the noting. So it's just "desire, desire." And then of course when it passes and there being no sensual desire in him, he understands there's no sensual desire in him.

So this is something that we have to really experience for ourselves. If the mind is full of some sort of desire, or if we go through the other hindrances – all the aversive stuff, all the dullness and lethargy, all the restlessness and the guilt, and all that, and finally all these doubts – when these come to mind to actually recognize what it is. And in recognizing what it is, we're also experiencing how it affects us – the agitation of desire, the burning of anger and that sort of stuff. And then when it passes, then you experience the mind, the heart mind without that. And knowing that, you want to move always towards the heart mind which is not disturbed by any of the hindrances.

And so it ends by saying how there comes to be the arising of an unarisen sensual desire. In other words, what triggers the sensual desires and how there comes to be the abandonment of the sensual desire, which is of course not getting involved. So that's the indulgence bit. Remember there's always the original desire comes up and then there's the desire to indulge it. Are you planning your holiday for instance and off you go dreaming about how wonderful it will be? That's when the fetter's out.

And how there comes to be a future non-arising of abandoned sensual desire, which means that eventually the whole process of wrong desire, wrong aversion is completely gone. And that's a high state of realization, what we call the non-returner. So that means that somebody has arrived at a place where the sensual world no longer appeals. It's like when we're children and we grow out of snakes and ladders – snakes and ladders as a game no longer appeals. So we come to a place in our practice where fine, the sensual world is fine but it doesn't draw you into it anymore.

And so he goes on with the other four hindrances – remember the aversion, dullness and lethargy, restlessness and included in there is things like guilt, remorse, shame, things like that, and skeptical doubt. Remember skeptical doubt isn't the honest doubt of the philosopher in us, the sense of wonder. None of this is meant to be taken as gospel – remember we're supposed to be investigating it so it becomes true for ourselves.

Remembering that there's a type of doubt which stops you from doing something, and that's the skeptical doubt. When you say "I can't do something" and you convince yourself you can't do it, and that stops you from doing it. Something that perhaps we've all experienced is on the high diving board, and you might have got up there and you're just too afraid to go into it, "can't do it, can't do it," until somebody pushes you, then of course you get in.

So skeptical doubt is different from what you might call an honest doubt, which is what we're supposed to have. We're supposed to have an attitude of curiosity, of finding out whether the Buddhist teaching is actually true for us. And that's the process of the enlightenment, you might say. The understanding, the insight – the insight won't come unless we are investigating for ourselves.

And of course, he does this – you're aware of it within you, but you can also be aware of these things in others – greed in others, anger in others and so forth. And then of course there's always this vanishing factors and arising factors, both the arising factors and vanishing factors. So always this realization or this constant understanding that things are continuously arising and continuously disappearing. That's the *anicca*, that's the impermanence of what it is that we're experiencing.

And then finally, when we get to that point of *vipassanā* where we're just watching, just feeling, just experiencing, simply established in him to the extent necessary for – now the word is *ñāṇa*, and it's translated here as bare knowledge. But *ñāṇa* is a similar word to *paññā*, which means to realize, to actually see something directly. And so enough of that intuitive intelligence and awareness to arise. And that word "mattāya", that word "just enough" – just enough for the insight to arise. So that's the investigation of the five hindrances.

Then there are the five aggregates. So if you forget them, let me remind you – there's the body with all its sensations, and it includes the sense bases. Then there's feelings. This is now, those of you know dependent origination, that's the process – the human being in process of creating the world. Mainly the process of how we create suffering, and as we undo that, the process is how we slowly become fully liberated from wrong views and the purification of the heart. So the dependent origination is the description of the process. Now the five aggregates is more a cross-section – if you were to take a human being at any one time and just look at that human being, then you'd come across these five aggregates.

So an aggregate is telling us that it's made up of all sorts of little bits and pieces, like the body – billions of cells. So there's the body, which from the mind's point of view, from our personal experience point of view, of course are the senses. And we'll come to that in a minute. And then there's the feeling.

And then perception. So this is all the meditation stuff that goes on. The perception, which is like a photograph or a photocopy of something, and how that photocopy is changed as we get to experience similar things over and over again, until we reach the higher concepts, things like freedom and happiness, for heaven's sake.

So when those two are combined, feeling and perception, with the will to create something, that's when you have a habit. Sometimes you'll see it translated literally as volitional formations. In other words, the act of will has to be there for something to be done, and when you make an action and you repeat it, then you get the habit. And as they say, a compendium of habits, a whole collection of habits, is your personality. That's all that's all character and personality is – it's a collection of habits. Once you've got that, your destiny. It'll drive you somewhere.

So what our practice is doing is making us look at these habits and decide, "Well look, this habit is going to take me into the hell realm and these habits are going to take me into the heavenly realm. So where do you want to be tomorrow?"

So again, he says, and how does a bhikkhu abide contemplating mind objects as mind objects in terms of the five aggregates? Here, a bhikkhu understands such is material form, such is its origin – in other words, aware of the body when it arises like an itch, so you're aware of it, aware of its disappearance and of its arising and passing. And the same with feeling, such as its origins, such as disappearance. Perception, such its origins, such as disappearance. The habits, such as origin and their disappearance, and finally consciousness.

So I'll put that right at the end as it's mentioned – that consciousness. Remember, that's just a screen upon which everything is arising to be known. It's the first act, you might say, of cognition.

So in this way, he abides contemplating objects, mind objects internally. You can often see it in other people too – their feelings, their emotional states, their habits. And that's how we contemplate these mind objects as the five aggregates.

The next one is the six sense bases, the *āyatana* – dimensions, six dimensions, six spheres of experience, because the sense bases are mono, aren't they? So you can only see through your eyes. You can't see through your ears – even if you try very hard through your ears, you can only hear. So they are different ways of experiencing the world, and of course our inner experience too. And so they are to be seen more as dimensions.

And this word *āyatana* is also used to explain *Nibbāna*, because he'll talk about *Nibbāna* as an *āyatana* where all this is not included, where all this does not manifest. It's a very famous verse in the inspiring discourse, inspiring verses, the inspiring verse of *Udāna*, which perhaps we'll come upon another time.

So he, again, it's the same thing. You're observing the eye, he understands forms – the perception in the eye. He understands the fetter that arises with both. So the fetter of course is desire or aversion.

Just as a side point, you can sometimes just, as it were, if you're standing in a park – I think we're allowed now some parks anyway – or in the garden, and if you pan your garden from one side to the other or you pan what you can see out of your window, what you're looking at or what you're being aware of is how the eye picks things up for you. You don't have to try at all. As soon as the eye hits something, then it'll be recognized by the mind. So you can actually step back, as it were, from that process and recognize that it's just happening as a psychological habit, you might say. So that, of course, gives you the sense of, again, *anattā* – not me, not mine.

So he does that with all the other ones. He understands the ear, he understands sounds. He understands the nose, he understands odours. He understands the tongue, he understands flavours. He understands the body, he understands tangibles – what you can feel. He understands the mind, he understands mind objects – what you think, what you emot. And he understands the fetter that's dependent on them both, and he understands how there comes to be the arising of that fetter. So it's always this desire,

this aversion, or a certain deluded understanding about what we're experiencing. And so there becomes also the abandoning of that fetter and how there comes to be no more fetters arising.

So these fetters – that's a special word. We've actually touched upon it earlier. There are ten of them and two of them are to do with sensual pleasure and aversion. So they're fetters. They're holding us to this level of existence or to this level of being that we're in, which is causing us suffering at some level or another.

How are we doing with time? Oh, right. Well, I've got enough time to do the seven enlightenment factors.

So much the same. So this one is slightly different because these are beautiful. So again, the bhikkhu abides contemplating mind objects as mind objects in terms of the seven enlightenment factors. How does he do that? Here, the mindfulness enlightenment factor is in him. When you become aware of being aware, "there is this mindfulness enlightenment factor in me." And there being no mindfulness enlightenment factor in me, he understands that. So when the mind has wandered, you wake up and you think, "Ah, that's being mindless."

And then the paragraph is, and he also understands how there comes to be the arising of unarisen mindfulness factor. In other words, what makes mindfulness come, what establishes mindfulness for us, and how arisen mindfulness enlightenment factor comes to fulfillment by development. So in other words, how we can develop this mindfulness to a point where the fulfillment is eventually – not at this point, but eventually – is the liberation, the awakening.

And so he then talks about the investigation states. That's the factor of investigation. Here it's put in a particular form, but the way that I've come to understand it is just by seeing the opposites. So this applies the same to interest, your curiosity, but that has to be balanced with a certain calmness. And then there's concentration which has to be balanced with effort. If there's not enough effort you fall asleep, if there's too much effort you get restless and so on. And equanimity – coming from a place of a balanced heart mind where you can do the investigation clearly.

The investigation is this direct understanding of what it is we're experiencing, which is always from the point of view of relationship, desire, wrong desire, aversion, impermanence, and not self.

And so with all of them, you get this last standard and it says he also understands how there comes to be the arising of what was not there before – how it comes to be all these different seven factors of enlightenment, and how to maintain it and develop it to its fullness. And at which point, hopefully some liberation arises.

So I think we can leave it there and we'll just finish it off tomorrow evening.

So again, apologies for rushing through this, but as I say, there are many texts and this is a very fulsome discourse on it. There are other scriptures, the main one being the Sarvāstivādin. So this was another school which existed at the same time as Theravada, but seems to have died out. But their scriptures were kept in Chinese and they've now virtually been all translated. And so we now have a translation of their *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse, their discourse on how to establish awareness. And it's not as full as this. So this has been obviously augmented. It's been made fuller. It's grown over time with memory from what the Buddha was teaching, trying to get it all together in one discourse.

So remember, even though we know all this, when we're sitting, we're not trying to be analytic, all right? That's bringing the head in, and you don't want the head. You want just pure awareness, pure intuitive. We're just watching, just feeling, just experiencing.

So I hope my words have been of some assistance. May you, by your devotion to practice, be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness — Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 27 min

In this concluding talk on the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the final section on contemplating dhamma as mind objects, focusing specifically on the Four Noble Truths and the Noble Eightfold Path. Drawing from the Dīgha Nikāya version which includes the complete exposition, he provides detailed explanations of dukkha (unsatisfactoriness), its origin in taṇhā (craving), its cessation, and the path leading to that cessation.

The talk offers profound insights into the Buddha's analysis of suffering, including birth, aging, death, and the fundamental problem of not getting what we want. Bhante explains how the five khandhas (aggregates) become sources of suffering through upādāna (grasping and identification), and how the path of renunciation transforms negative mental energies into their positive opposites: generosity, loving-kindness, and compassion.

Particularly inspiring is the Buddha's promise that even seven days of complete Right Awareness practice can lead to either arahantship or the state of anāgāmī (non-returner). This presentation of the 'one way path' (ekāyana) of pure vipassanā offers both theoretical understanding and practical encouragement for dedicated practitioners seeking liberation through mindfulness meditation.

Good evening. I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I do hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sambha Sambhudassa Namō tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sambha Sambhudassa — homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So we're making our way through the discourse on how to establish right mindfulness. Now the one in the middle-length sayings, the Majjhima Nikāya, that doesn't have the fullness of the Four Noble Truths. For that, I've had to go to another book called The Long Discourses of the Buddha, and they are long. And this one does include the Four Noble Truths. So this is something that you very rarely get — they are presumed in all the literature that you read, that the Four Noble Truths are there at the basis. But here we've actually got what the Buddha meant by those Four Noble Truths.

Now as I say what the Buddha meant and what's actually written here — they've obviously been formalised. So in the earlier part of the scriptures it's much more informal, the way he's teaching. By this time everything's been formalised into lists and so forth. So I'll read through these Four Noble Truths. This is, remember, in the section on *dhamma*, which is translated as mind objects, but I think to be closer to the mark when we talk about the teachings.

So again, a meditator abides contemplating mind objects. And how does he do this? He does in respect to the Four Noble Truths. "This is suffering," he knows it as it really is. "This is the origin of suffering," he knows it as it really is. "This is the cessation of suffering," he knows as it really is. "And this is the way of practice leading to the cessation of suffering."

And what is this Noble Truth of Suffering? Birth is suffering. Ageing is suffering. Death is suffering. Sorrow, lamentation, pain, sadness and distress are suffering. Being attached to the unloved is suffering. Being separated from the loved is suffering. Not getting what one wants is suffering. In short, the five aggregates of grasping are suffering.

So then there are definitions of these. For instance, what is birth? Whatever beings of whatever group of beings — there is birth, coming to be, coming forth, the appearance of the aggregates. So that's a psychophysical organism — the acquisition of the sense spaces, the six sense bases including the mind. This is called birth.

Ageing: whatever beings of whatever group of beings — that is ageing, decrepitude, broken teeth, grey hair, wrinkled skin, shrinking with age, decay of sense faculties. This is called ageing. He's not bad, is he? He's got it nailed there, I think.

And what is death? Whatever beings of whatever group of beings — passing away, a removal, a cutting off, a disappearance, a death, a dying, an ending, a cutting off of the aggregates, a psychophysical organism, discarding of the body. This is death.

So then he describes these words that he's used. What is sorrow? So any kind of misfortune anyone is affected by something of a painful nature — sorrow, mourning, distress, inward grief, inward woe. That is called sorrow.

Lamentation: whatever, any kind of misfortune, anyone is affected by something of a painful nature and there is crying out, lamenting, making much noise of grief, making great lamentation. This is called lamentation.

What is pain? Whatever bodily painful feeling, bodily unpleasant feeling, painful or unpleasant feelings result from bodily contact. This is called pain. Always says body — of course it's the whole body, the whole senses, everything.

What is sadness? Whatever mental painful feeling, mental unpleasant feeling, painful or unpleasant sensation results in mental contact. This is called sadness.

And distress: whatever kind of misfortune anyone is affected by something of a painful nature — distress, great distress, affliction with distress, with great distress. This is called distress.

And what is being attached to the unloved? Here, whoever has unwanted, disliked, unpleasant sight objects, sounds, smells, tastes, tangibles or mental objects, or whoever encounters ill-wishers, wishes of harm, of discomfort, insecurity, with whom they have concourse, connection, union. This is called attached to the unloved. In other words, when you're stuck with some situation which is highly unpleasant or some person whom you find unpleasant.

And what is the separation from the loved? Here, whoever has what is wanted, liked, pleasant sight objects, sounds, smells, tastes, tangibles and mind objects, and whoever encounters well-wishers, wishes of good, of comfort, of security — mother or father, brother or sister, or younger kinsmen, or friends, or colleagues, or blood relations — and then is deprived of concourse, connection, and union. That is called separation from the loved.

So he's now described those little adjectives that come at the end of the noble truths. And then he says, what is not getting what one wants? So this is the crux of it, isn't it? In being subject to birth, this wish arises: "Oh, that we were not subject to birth, that we might not come to birth." But this cannot be gained by wishing. This is not getting what one wants. In being subject to ageing, to disease, to death, to sorrow, lamentation, pain, sadness and distress, this wish arises: "Oh, that we were not subject to ageing," and so forth. But this cannot be gained by wishing. This is not getting what one wants.

And how, monks, in short, are the five aggregates of grasping suffering? The aggregates of grasping: form, feeling, perception, mental formations and consciousness. These, in short, are the five aggregates of grasping.

So now, remember the Buddha has this cross section of human beings where there's the body, which includes the senses, all the senses, including the mind — the mental base. And then there are all the feelings, both physical and mental feelings that we have in the body. There's all the perception, which then grows into concepts and all that. And

when these two things are joined, feeling and perception, that's when we start creating these habits — mental habits, physical habits. And all that has to appear upon a screen of consciousness.

Now, all that the Buddha did after his awakening — nothing changed at that level. He had a body, he was feeling things, he had perceptions and concepts. I mean all his teaching is a psychological philosophy or an ethical philosophy. And he, of course, he's conscious. So nothing has changed. What has changed is the grasping. That's the one thing that's changed.

What is this grasping? His identity. So we did all that at the beginning of this series, if you remember, about the self. It's identifying with this form that creates the initial problem. Because with this being me, I'm trying to chase happiness with it. And either I'm getting it and it disappears just when I've got it, or it never stays long enough, or I'm stuck in a situation which is unpleasant. So chasing happiness from the point of view of a self is a fool's game. So that's this whole business of letting go. But we've come to that — we're coming to that.

So now the next Noble Truth, of course, is the origin of suffering. It is that very craving which gives rise to rebirth, bound up with pleasure and lust, finding fresh delight now here, now there — that is to say, sensual craving, craving for existence, and craving for non-existence.

So if you think about what it is that we crave for — this craving is again a desire. The way they translate these two words, *tanha* and *upadāna* — so *tanha* is your initial desire, which can be a craving, unfortunately. And the *upadāna* is the craving which comes about by identification. So I would always prefer to translate them as desire, wrong desire, craving and identifying, possessing, possessing and identifying.

So basically the cause, the cause of everything, is this relationship of wanting happiness from or through this psychophysical organism. And where does this craving arise and establish itself? Wherever in the world there is anything agreeable or pleasant, there this craving arises and establishes itself.

And what is there in the world that is agreeable and pleasurable? Now remember, when he's talking about the world at this level, it's not the objective world out there. It's the world we're creating. And the world we're creating, of course, is often dependent on information from the outside world, but it's still our world. It's still our little universe.

So, and what is there in the world that is agreeable and pleasant? Well, anything to do with the eye, the ear, the nose, the tongue and so forth — that's where craving arises and establishes itself. Sights, sounds, smells, tastes, tangibles and mind objects in the world are agreeable and pleasurable, and there this craving arises and establishes itself.

It's obvious that when he says "the world" he really means — sometimes he talks about "in this fathom-length body." And of course it establishes itself also in consciousness. And then there's a whole section here which touches upon dependent origination. We won't go into that because it's a bit too long, but it's about the initial contact, the feeling that he's got from contact. So your contact may be with a friend, the feeling comes of happiness. Perception — so we have perceptions which then tend to develop into concepts. Then there's the will, the wanting, the desire, the volition. And then there's this craving, which is — volition is the energy needed for something to happen. Then there's the craving, and then there's thinking — they've translated it as thinking and pondering. This is Maurice Walsh, who's died — well, he died a while back actually — thinking and pondering. So basically it's your initial ideas and how you're developing them. And of course, all this happens in the objects in the world that are agreeable and pleasurable.

Now, having established the fact that the real fundamental problem that creates all this dissatisfaction, suffering and so forth for us, is this desire, this wrong type of desire, he then, of course, can make the statement that is the Noble Truth of the cessation of suffering. It is the complete fading away and extinction of this craving. This very craving is forsaking and abandonment, liberation from it and detachment from it. And how does this craving come to be abandoned? How does this cessation come to be?

In other words, our practice is renunciation. So it's not — remember it's not self-mortification, not trying to punish ourselves, definitely not trying to punish the body. The body's just doing its thing. It's this constant effort to see where there's a wrong desire and just hold it there, not activate upon it, let it arise and pass away. And every time we experience that and the release, the relief, the unshackling from that desire and the little bit of joy that arises — even if it's just that lovely equanimity that arises, the peacefulness of a mind which is not agitated, turbulent with desire — that's a little sneaky preview of *Nibbāna*.

Whatever is agreeable — let's take a look now. Then he goes through, you know, the consciousness, the eye consciousness and all that, through all the sights and sounds and so forth. Letting go of all that, of contact. And then finally, that is the cessation of suffering.

And what, monks, is the Noble Truth — so this I'm sure you all know, but even so — right view. What is right view? Well, it is the knowledge of this suffering, the knowledge of the reason or the cause of suffering, the knowledge of the cessation of suffering, and this very practice leading to that cessation.

The next one, of course, is right attitude. *Samma sankappa* — some people translate it as right motive, but I just prefer the word attitude. So it's thoughts of ill will — it's actually an attitude of letting go of things, letting go of that desire. Thoughts of non-ill will, which is, of course, everything that you don't want to do in order to establish love. And thoughts of harmlessness, which, of course, is just another way of saying compassion. So when he says thoughts of renunciation, it's also a way of saying generosity. So these things always move towards their opposite.

See, the more you let go of things, the more you're happy to give. And the more you let go of ill will and hatred and all that silly stuff, the more you are able to love. And the more you let go of harmfulness, harmful thoughts, wishing somebody ill, and the more obviously there's compassion — because all this negative stuff is always being transformed. You don't lose anything. It's just energy. It's just energy. It's just thinking and all that. And it's just slowly transforming towards their opposites.

What is right speech? So he always tells us what we shouldn't be doing first. So it's refraining from lying, from slander, from harsh speech — there's a better word than harsh speech. Abusive. Abusive speech is a much better translation — refraining from frivolous speech as well. But then, of course, as you let go of that, you move towards gentle, truthful, at the right time, and with the heart of loving-kindness. So your speech is coming from a different sense — it's coming from the good heart.

What, monks, is right action? Refraining from taking life, from taking what is not given, from refraining from sexual misconduct. So obviously, if we stop taking life, then we move towards preserving it. If you stop taking what is not freely given, you move towards generosity. And now this *kama* is always translated as sexual misconduct, but it has a wider meaning of indulging the senses. But here, refraining from sexual misconduct — obviously the proper place for erotic rather than sexual conduct is within a fulsome relationship.

And then, what is right livelihood? Well, it basically says to give up wrong livelihood — so any livelihood that does harm — and to have right livelihood. Now, this is an important thing, because I remember my teacher saying that wasn't necessary because it's included really in right action. But even so, he makes it a special category. And when you think that you spend a lot of your energy — we spend a lot of our energy on the work we do — you can see that it has an effect upon us.

So if you're in the caring professions, then obviously you're developing that sense of care, the sense of compassion. If you're in, say, policing, then again, you're there with a sense of protecting, of trying to stop harm. So that also is compassion. Although it makes you very suspicious, I think. So whatever livelihood you're undertaking, it will have an effect on your character, on the way you experience life.

Then the last three — by the way, often, remember, the Eightfold Path is put as *sīla*, *samādhi*, *paññā*, which is morality, meditation and wisdom. It mixes it the other way around. But as it's laid out by the Buddha, it's wisdom and then right conduct and then finally the meditation.

So right effort: arouses his will, makes an effort, stirs up energy, exerts his mind and strives to prevent the arising of unarisen, evil, unwholesome mental states. In other words, to stop naughty things arising in the mind. He arouses his will and so forth and strives to overcome evil unwholesome mental states. So as soon as something that you see is unwholesome comes up, then there's the effort to not enjoy it, not develop it, not express it. And then he arouses his will, makes an effort, stirs up energy, exerts his mind and strives to maintain wholesome mental states that have arisen and not let them fade away. And he does the same — hold on — he arouses to produce unarisen wholesome states. In other words, always having right intentions which bring up wholesome mental states. And when they arise, to do our best to maintain them.

And what, monks, is right mindfulness? And now I did say this was about meditation, but obviously the effort is there in the whole of the path. What we do, our livelihoods and so forth. Right mindfulness is also throughout the day — it's not just when we're sitting. But here it's basically meant as only the meditation, when we're sitting.

So that puts us right mindfulness and right concentration. Here it's really only expressed as the *jhāna*, these absorption states, but obviously in all of our daily life, it's keeping your attention on what you're doing.

So then the usual refrain: that he contemplates mind objects as mind objects internally and externally — both. So you can see them in other people, these things that you can see, these attitudes and what they're doing and so forth. He abides contemplating the arising of mind objects. He abides contemplating the vanishing. So it's the arising and vanishing, both the arising and vanishing.

So it's always about seeing process, about seeing that nothing remains, nothing's reliable. Or just this bare attentiveness, as they put it, of something which arises within our consciousness, and just enough so that insight and awareness can arise.

And he abides detached—that should be, see, that's the old way of saying it. You see, this was published in, I don't know, I think it's the 1890s or something. And that was the old way of expressing this detachment. Now they say non-attachment. It's non-dual, right? It's neither attachment nor detachment. It's non-attachment.

And monks, this is how you abide. Or meditators, this is how you abide, contemplating mind objects. So that completes all these mind objects, the last section, the fourth section of the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse.

But then there's this lovely ending, this conclusion, which hopefully raises possibilities for us. Whoever should practice these four foundations of mindfulness for just seven years may expect one of two results: either *arahatship*—complete liberation from all suffering and the awakening—or if there is some substrate left, they haven't quite made it, then the state of *non-returner*. Now the non-returner is that person who is no longer attracted to the sensual life, right? They've gone beyond, but they've not gone so beyond that they're fully liberated.

Let alone seven years. Whoever should practice it for just six years, five years, four years, three years, two years, one year may expect one of two results. Never mind one year. Whoever practices for seven months, six months, five months, four months, three months, two months, one month, half a month, may expect one of two results.

And whoever practices this even for one week can expect one of two results, either full liberation or with the substrate left as a non-returner. And now it was said, this is... And so then having said that, he repeats the original statement that he makes right at the beginning of the discourse.

How could you possibly be fully liberated in one week? You see, we do have occasions in the scripture where people wake up just like that. I might bring—there's the very famous, or well-known case rather, of Bāhiya the bark-cloak, where he basically gives him a few hints and he becomes fully liberated right there and then. There's not time to go into that at the moment.

So this one week—one presumes that that means that from the moment you get up on Monday morning until you fall asleep the next Sunday evening, that you haven't lost your mindfulness even for one second, right? Then we can expect some results. So that's what we're working towards.

And so finally, this monks, this is the one way. Remember, this is... they've translated *ekayāno* in various ways, but the one that I prefer is that this is the path of pure *vipassanā* as opposed to the path where you practice these absorptions and *vipassanā*. So this is the one way, path of pure *vipassanā*: purification of beings, for the overcoming of

sorrow and distress, for the disappearance of pain and sadness, for the gaining of the right path, for the realization of *Nibbāna*—that is to say, the four foundations of mindfulness. And it is for this reason that it has been spoken.

Thus spoke the Lord, and the listeners, the monks and everybody else rejoiced and were delighted at his words, as I'm sure we are too.

So that brings to an end our run through the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse on how to establish right mindfulness. As I say, there are now excellent books on it which you can read, and you'll find them on the website there, on resources.

So, oh, time moves on. I trust my words have been of some assistance, not caused too much confusion. May you, by your continuous efforts and practice, achieve full liberation sooner rather than later.

The Relay of Chariots — Rathavināta Sutta (MN 24)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 23 min

In this exploration of the Rathavināta Sutta (MN 24), Bhante Bodhidhamma presents one of Buddhism's most systematic teachings on the path to awakening. The discourse unfolds through a profound dialogue between two great disciples: Sāriputta and Puṇṇa Mantāniputta, who meet for the first time in the Blind Man's Grove near Sāvattṥi.

Through their exchange, we learn the seven stages of purification that lead to final nibbāna without clinging: purification of virtue (sīla), mind (citta), view (diṭṭhi), overcoming doubt, knowledge and vision of path and non-path, knowledge and vision of the way, and finally knowledge and vision itself. The Buddha's famous relay chariot simile illustrates how each stage serves as a vehicle to reach the next, just as King Pasenadi would use successive chariots to complete his journey.

Bhante contextualizes this teaching within the broader Theravāda tradition, noting how this sutta provided the structural framework later adopted by works like Upatissa's Path of Liberation and Buddhaghosa's Visuddhimagga. The episode beautifully captures the mutual respect and joy these two accomplished practitioners experience upon meeting, offering both systematic guidance for the spiritual path and inspiration for noble friendship in the Dhamma.

Good evening everyone. I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa, Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa — homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

So I thought this evening we'd move on to the *Majjhima Nikāya*, the middle length discourses, to a discourse number 24 called the Relay of Chariots. Now the interesting thing about this is that it laid down a schema which was later copied in two works: the Path of Liberation by Upatissa, which if I remember rightly was only in the Chinese and then translated. And the way it's written, people think that Upatissa was in fact fully liberated. But a later book, which is more well known, of course, is the Path of Purification, the *Visuddhimagga*, which I hold in my hand here.

This is more of an encyclopedia, if you haven't come across it. It's a great book to dip into, and it's got to be one of the great spiritual manuals of the world because it contains virtually all the teachings and all the practices that are in Theravāda Buddhism. And it's more of a scholastic work. I for one couldn't read it from page one to the end, but it's great to dip into. You can download it as a PDF if you're interested. It's got all the exercises.

So in this discourse, it's seemingly some monks have come down from the Buddha's own territory, you might say his own country, the Sakyan country which remember is just on the southern border of present-day Nepal. At that time, on one occasion the Blessed One was living at Rājagaha in the bamboo grove, the squirrel's sanctuary.

Rājagaha is now Rajgir, you can visit. It was the capital of the southern Magadha and King Bimbisāra would have lived there. It's surrounded by a circle of hills and on one of the hills is Vulture's Peak, which is where most of the Mahāyāna discourses were given and some of the Buddhist discourses in the Theravāda tradition. And on one hill, there's a really magnificent peace pagoda, all white and shiny. And you can go down and you can visit the hut where, what's his name? Oh dear, it's gone out of my head. Bimbisāra's son murdered his father, starved him to death by putting him in that little hut. And you can visit that if you want. And in the middle of Rajgir, it's only a small town now, there's a fountain where people bathe. And there's a yoga center there, a Gandhi yoga center. So if you're ever in that place, you can always pay a little visit.

So that's where the Buddha is. He's in this bamboo grove, the squirrel sanctuary. And a number of *bhikkhus* from his native land, that's how he's put, who had spent the rains there. They've gone there for the rainy season, which is the monsoon season, July, August, September. And they went to the Blessed One and paying homage sat down at one side and the Blessed One asked them because, "Is there anyone in my own country, my own native land, who is esteemed by the monks and the order, his companions in the holy life? One who has few wishes and he talks to the *bhikkhus* of the fewness of wishes. Content in himself, he talks to them about contentment. Secluded himself, he talks about seclusion. Aloof from society, he talks about the benefits of being aloof from society. Energetic in himself, he talks about arousing energy to the order. Attained to virtue himself, he talks about the attainment of virtue and attaining concentration, he talks about the attainment of concentration, attained to wisdom, he talks about wisdom, attained to deliverance, he talks about deliverance, attained to knowledge and vision of deliverance, he talks about that too and he is one who advises, informs, instructs, urges, rouses and encourages his companions in the holy life?"

And they answer, "Yes indeed there is. There is a venerable and he is highly esteemed in his native land." Now it would seem that this particular monk was ordained by Añña Koṇḍañña who was one of his five companions when he was, you know, before he became liberated, it was the five companions he gave his first talk to. And the first one who got it, you know, the first insight, stream entry, was in fact this Koṇḍañña. And he gave him this name, Añña Koṇḍañña, Koṇḍañña, the one who knows. So he must have been up in the Sakyan territory, probably a Sakyan himself, although I can't find that out at the moment. And he ordained this monk. And he became known, he was given a special name by the Buddha, so Koṇḍañña being the first was given this nickname, Añña, the one who knows, and to Mantāniputta Buddha he gave the nickname of the most eminent amongst preachers, so he was obviously very good at giving talks.

Now, at that time, Sāriputta is with the Buddha and he hasn't met him. So this gives you an idea that by now the order is quite large. Senior monks are ordaining monks, not just the Buddha. And, you know, I mean, in those days, you know, ox carts, no mobiles. How do they communicate? You know, how did you find out where the Buddha was? It was all by hearsay. And the Venerable One, so they, like you hear somebody has come out, oh, the Buddha's making his way to the squirrel's grove. So everybody said, oh, right, well, we'll go and try and meet him there.

So Sāriputta was with the Buddha at the time. And he thought to himself, "It's great gain for Venerable Puṇṇamantāniputta. It is great gain for him to have wise companions and perhaps sometime or other we might meet." So there is that desire in Sāriputta to meet this famous monk from the Sakyan country. It doesn't say that Mantāniputta himself was a Sakyan, he just happened to be in that country when he ordained.

So the Blessed One has stayed long enough and he set out on stages to Sāvatti, so remember that's just north of present-day Varanasi, Benares, and that's where he gave his first talk to the five companions and wandering by stages he finally arrived there staying at Jeta's Grove, Anāthapiṇḍika's park.

Now the Venerable Puṇṇamantāniputta heard, "Oh, the Blessed One has arrived at Sāvatti and is living there." So somehow the rumour had got and off he goes, determined to see the Buddha. Wandering by stages, he eventually arrived at Sāvatti. And on paying homage to the Buddha, the Blessed One, he sat to one side. The Blessed One instructed, urged, roused and encouraged him with a talk on the *Dhamma*. Then the Venerable Puṇṇamantāniputta, instructed, urged, roused and encouraged by the

Blessed One's, delighted and rejoiced in the Blessed One's words, rising from his seat, paid homage, keeping to his right, and went to the blind man's grove for a day's abiding to meditate.

Now then a certain *bhikkhu* went to the venerable Sāriputta and said to him, "Look, this Puṇṇamantāniputta that you speak so highly of, he's just been, he just had a talk, he's just been talking with the Buddha, with the Blessed One and he's delighted and all that and he's gone off and he sat for a day's abiding at the blind man's grove." So of course venerable Sāriputta quickly picked up a mat and followed him and followed close behind the Venerable Puṇṇamantāniputta, keeping his head in sight. So he obviously didn't know he was being followed.

And so they were both sat abiding for the day in the blind man's grove. And then when it was evening, the Venerable Sāriputta rose from meditation, went to the Venerable Puṇṇamantāniputta and exchanged greetings with him. And when the courteous and amiable talk was finished. So don't, you know, mustn't confuse that with useless talk. And when you meet somebody, there's always that little exchange of how are you, how are you doing, and et cetera, et cetera. Especially these days, we don't meet, we've probably forgotten how to do that after this lockdown.

So then he begins to talk to this monk, as if he himself was a beginner or not so new or fairly immature in the order. So he asks him, he says, "Is it for the sake of purification of virtue that we live under the *Dhamma* of the Buddha? Is that the purpose of the Buddha's *Dhamma*? Purification of virtue?" And he says, "No, no, no, that's not."

"Then is it for the sake of the purification of the mind?" He says, "No friend, no it's not that at all." "Is it for the sake of purification of view?" He says, "No friend, I'll explain these things you know when we've gone through them." "Is it for the purification of overcoming doubt that the holy life is lived?" He says, "No friend, no." "Then is it for the sake of purification of knowledge and vision of what is the path and what is not the path that the holy life is lived?" "No." "Then is it for the sake of purification of knowledge and vision of the way?" He says, "No, no, it's not that either." He said, "Then is it for the sake of purification of knowledge and vision that the life is lived under the Blessed One's?" He said, "No, friend, no."

It's interesting that he approached him as "no friend." There's two ways in which, in the scriptures, the monks talk to each other. One is *bhante*, when you are addressing somebody who's older than you in the order, and the other one is *āvuso* which is friend when somebody is your same age in the order, and that means anybody who was ordained five years before you and five years after you. So the monks you meet who are within that ten-year period, you would have approached as friend, and anybody above

you, you would have said *bhante*, and anybody much younger than you, you would have said *āvuso*, friend, but they would have approached you with the word *bhante*. That's just a little aside.

So then Sāriputta repeats all this by simply saying it all and repeating his reply, "No friend." So he goes through it all again. So this is one way that you would make something memorable. You would get the whole thing repeated again from a different angle. So he's asking these questions. He said no. And so Sāriputta says, "I've asked you this question and you said no." So then he finally comes.

"For the sake of what, then, friend, is the holy life lived under the Blessed One?" And here's the answer. "It is for the sake of final *Nibbāna* without clinging that the holy life is lived under the Blessed One."

But now, having stated that, you see, all the questions are asked again with a slightly different angle. "Is purification of virtue final *Nibbāna* without clinging?" So are any of these other six stages final *Nibbāna* without clinging? And of course there's "No. The purification of mind final *Nibbāna*?" "No." He says, "Purification of views?" Says "No." He says, "Purification of overcoming doubt?" "No. Purification by knowledge and vision of what is the path and what is not the path?" "No. Purification of knowledge and vision of the way?" "No, it's not that either," you see. "Then is purification of knowledge and vision final *Nibbāna* without clinging?" Says "No, friend," you see.

So then we get, "Well, none of these six stages that we've talked about are equivalent to *Nibbāna* without clinging," okay? And so he repeats all that. Just he repeats that all that saying that. Right, saying "No, this level is not *Nibbāna* without clinging."

And then there's a nice little sentence here. He says, "But friend, is final *Nibbāna* without clinging to be attained without these states?" Okay, so could you get there without going through these stages? "There's no friend." "But how, friend, should the meaning of these statements be regarded?" So then he repeats all that, you see. In other words, you've got to go through these stages.

And then he says, "If final *Nibbāna* without clinging were to be attained without these states, then an ordinary person would have attained final *Nibbāna*. For an ordinary person is without these states." Now an ordinary person is someone who's not instructed in the *Dhamma*. So what he's saying is, if somebody reaches *Nibbāna* without any of this, then these teachings wouldn't pertain. But they do pertain. You've got to go through these stages.

And then he gives a simile of it, you see. He says, "For some wise men understand the meaning of a statement by means of a simile." So there's always this way of doing it as, shall we say, an academic thing. And there's always a more artistic way of expressing the *Dhamma* through some image, through some simile or metaphor.

So this is where we get the chariots. "Supposing King Pasenadi of Kosala, while living in Sāvātthi, so that's where they are at the moment, so the local king was Pasenadi, had urgent business to settle in Sāketa. And that between Sāvātthi and Sāketa, seven relay chariots were kept ready for him. Then King Pasenadi of Kosala, leaving Sāvātthi through the inner palace door, would mount the first chariot, and by means of the first chariot, he would arrive at the second chariot." And then he goes through all the business of arriving with the second chariot, gets the third et cetera, et cetera, and then he would arrive at the inner palace door of Sāketa.

"Then when he had come to the inner door, his friends and acquaintances, his kinsmen and relatives would ask him, 'Sire, how did you come from Sāvātthi to the inner palace door of Sāketa by means of this relay chariot?'" How then should King Pasenadi of Kosala answer in order to answer correctly? And of course, this gives the reciter an opportunity to say all that again. It's just one of those tricks of the ancient way of remembering things. A mnemonic.

So then he says, "So friend, the purification of virtue is for the sake of reaching purification of heart, mind." So remember the word mind in the scriptures is referring to the combination of the heart and the mind. "Purification of mind is for reaching the purification of view. Purification of view is for reaching the purification of overcoming doubts. Purification of overcoming doubt is for the sake of reaching purification by knowledge and vision of what is the path and what is not the path. Purification by knowledge and vision of what is the path and what is not the path is for the sake of reaching purification of knowledge and vision of the way. Purification by knowledge and vision of the way is for the sake of reaching purification by knowledge and vision. And purification by knowledge and vision is for the sake of reaching final *Nibbāna* without clinging. It is for the sake of final *Nibbāna* without clinging that the holy life is lived under the Blessed One."

And then Venerable Sāriputta, so this is the nice little bit where they finally meet, Venerable Sāriputta asks him, "What is the Venerable One's name and how do his companions in the holy life know the Venerable One?"

"So my name is Puṇṇa and my companions in the holy life know me as Mantāniputta."

Now what I understand from this is that Puṇṇa would have been his ordination name and that people would recognize him as Mantāniputta, the son of Mantāni. I think that probably was the remnants of a matriarchal society where you're known by your mother, Sāriputta, you see, son of Sāri. And that, I think, is kept in Thailand. It's not kept in Burma or in Sri Lanka, where a monk is known by his ordination name. But in Sri Lanka, they often call you by your lay name as a nickname, so when I was there I was Prapita, holy Peter, well you know what I mean.

"So it is wonderful, friend, it is marvellous, each profound question has been answered point by point by the venerable as a learned disciple who understands the teacher's dispensation correctly." So it is gain for his companions in the holy life, et cetera. "Even if it were by carrying the Venerable Puṇṇa Mantāniputta upon a cushion on their heads, that his companions of the holy life would get the opportunity to see and honour him, it would be a great gain for them. And it is a great gain for us, a great gain for us, that we have the opportunity to see and honour the Venerable Puṇṇa Mantāniputta."

Now, when this was said, the venerable Mantāniputta said to the venerable Sāriputta, "What is the venerable one's own name and how do his companions in the holy life know him?"

"My name is Upatissa." So that's his ordination name.

My companions know me as Sariputta." Now he's suddenly come across Sariputta. So it's a big shock, you see.

"Indeed, friend, we did not know we were talking to the venerable Sariputta, the disciple who is like the teacher himself." Calling somebody *Satukappa* is the highest of praise. It means you are like the Buddha. "If we had known that this was Venerable Sariputta, we should not have said so much. It is wonderful, friend. It is marvelous. Each profound question has been posed point by point by the Venerable Sariputta as a learned disciple who understands the teacher's dispensation correctly. It is gain for his companions in the holy life. It is great gain for them that they have the opportunity to see and honor the Venerable Sariputta, even if it were by carrying the Venerable Sariputta on a cushion on their heads, that his companions in the holy life would get the opportunity to see and honor him, it would be a great gain for them. And it is a great gain for us, a great gain for us that we have the opportunity to see and honor the venerable Sariputta."

This was how the two great beings rejoiced in each other's good words.

So I'm going to leave that there. And tomorrow I shall explain to you all these different levels of purification of the path.

So a nice little discourse there of two monks meeting and enjoying each other's company. I can only hope you found this little discourse encouraging and I trust that by your practice you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later. So we can begin our practice.

The Relay of Chariots (MN 24)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 30 min

In this teaching on the Rathavinīta Sutta (MN 24), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's teaching on the seven purifications (satta visuddhi) - the progressive stages that lead to complete Awakening. Drawing extensively from the Mahasi Sayadaw tradition and the Progress of Insight, he maps these purifications from basic moral conduct through the challenging 'suffering ñāṇas' to final liberation.

The talk covers the purification of virtue (sīla visuddhi), purification of mind (citta visuddhi), and the deeper insights including purification of view and overcoming doubt through understanding conditionality and paṭicca samuppāda. Bhante warns against the ten corruptions of insight (vipassanupakkilesa) that can trap meditators in beautiful but impermanent states.

With characteristic wisdom and humor, he shares cautionary tales about spiritual obsession while encouraging practitioners to maintain 'beginner's mind.' The teaching emphasizes that these insights arise naturally in practice - both in formal meditation and daily life - and cannot be forced or grasped. This comprehensive overview provides essential guidance for understanding the progressive nature of vipassanā practice.

Good evening. I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

Yesterday we went through the discourse on the seven chariots and we met Mantani Putta, Puna Mantani Putta, and we saw how these two well-advanced meditators, both of them arahats, fully self-awakened, greeted each other and recognised each other's greatness. Mantani put to calling him the closest to the Buddha himself, a great honour to be called that.

I found out that Kondañña, who was one of the companions of the Buddha — remember right at the end — was actually also a Sakyan, so they must have known each other as kids, although he was older than the Buddha. When he went back home to the Sakya country, that was where his sister Mantani lived, and his sister had a son who was later called Puna. This is a long way around of saying that Puna Mantani was in

fact Añña Kondañña's nephew. There's a book on all their names and the research has been done, most of it's commentary. Whether it's true or not, who knows, but they're lovely stories.

Anyway, so the nitty gritty of these seven purifications, the *visuddhi*, the seven purifications. If you want to know them in terms of your practice, the book is Progress of Insight by the Mahasi. I don't know whether you see that. No, I thought it would be the wrong way around. It's called the Progress of Insight. And in it, of course, there are what we call the *ñanas*, the path *ñanas*. So we'll come to that with a warning.

So the first one is the purification of virtue. This is really getting your moral act right. In terms of all of your daily life, you know, we want to stop killing people, thieving and stuff like that. But in terms of meditation practice, when you come on retreat, if there's something that's happened which you need to clear your heart of, it's always best to do it. You've had angry words with somebody, and if you come on retreat with that, it tends to be a bit obsessive. So it's always good to come with a clear conscience to a retreat. And that's one of your first purifications.

The next one is the purification of the mind, which is dealing with the hindrances. So, of course, we do that in the meditation — all the desires, the hatreds, the dullness and lethargies, all the restlessness and the shames and guilts. And then finally, of course, doubt. So those, of course, we're dealing with during our practice, but also in daily life. Remember, when desires come up, if you're right there with it, you can always hold on and say, "Is this skillful or not?" Just wait for that energy to disappear. So these *visuddhis*, these purifications, are not only applicable to the actual practice of *vipassanā* on a retreat — they're also applicable just in ordinary daily life.

Now sometimes people get into a dilemma because you can't attain full liberation until you're perfectly purified. On the other hand, you can't be perfectly purified until you've attained — until you've attained *Nibbāna*. Now *Nibbāna* here is the final point when you become an arahat.

Unfortunately, especially in the order, you can get very tight about this. I have a rather sad story of somebody I knew whom I got to know rather well. We were meditating together for some time and he wasn't getting anywhere in his practice. So he presumed that it was because his *sila*, his morality and the rule keeping wasn't being kept well enough, perfectly. So he left and began to read the Vinaya, all the little rules and everything. And he came across the original size of this upper robe that you see hanging behind the Buddha here. Now, actually, the original size was basically just a cloth that you put over the top part of your body when you entered into a village. It was just a modest thing to do. And in time, of course, it grew to be this long robe, you see.

And also the bowl — the monk's bowl is rather big. When you go on alms round and it's full, there's no way you can eat what they put in that bowl. But the reason it got so big was because it became the vessel that you carried your little bits and bobs in when you went wandering from village to village or from monastery to monastery.

So when he read these rules, he went off to see Ananda Maitreya, Venerable Ananda Maitreya, who was a very famous monk in Sri Lanka. He'll come up again when I talk about the insight knowledges, who was understood to be quite a scholar. And he agreed that these weren't strictly Vinaya.

We went to a Katina ceremony. That's the ceremony at the end of the rainy season, October, November, October, when there's a big party and lay people bring to the monastery those things that monks and nuns might need — the monastics might need — umbrellas, soap, toothpaste, stuff like that. And he came with this little thing on his shoulder, and he also had convinced a younger monk to follow him. And instead of a bowl, because the bowl originally was to be the depth of your hand, of your palm here, you see, that was supposed to be the depth of the bowl. And so he turned up with this natty little cover over his shoulders and a biscuit tin, you see.

And when the monk saw this, they just said he's gone mad. When you slightly go off like that, they just say you've gone mad. And that means that they look upon you with a certain pity, right? They not jump on you and say, "Hey, what about this rule and how dare you do that?" They just say he's gone a bit mad.

Anyway, seemingly he drove himself into this dead end corner where he's absolutely obsessive about keeping every little rule so that he can move spiritually. And what I heard later was that he left and he went to Thailand and they basically stopped him, asked him to leave the monastery. And he left eventually and went back home.

So a bit of a sad story there. So don't get obsessive about purity. We just work with it as it comes, just as it comes.

So that's the purity of the mind. We've been through the purity of our basic morality, purity of the mind. And then we come to the purity of view. And that really do with over time. All this business about self, which we've been through before, it's beginning to understand what the difference between the body and the mind, looking at it more closely.

It's basically looking at the five aggregates. So we've been through that, if you remember, just to recognise that this is a compendium. It feels like one being, it feels like me. But actually, the body has its own little life form, all these billions of cells or whatever. And then we've got this whole feeling thing that's going on inside the body,

which is both from the heart — the emotional stuff — and from the body, feelings, sensations. We've got all the stuff about how we build up memory with images and conceptual images and abstract thinking. And then we have all our habits and the way we think, which we've taken a lot from our culture, and some of it, of course, has been our own ingenuity, creating our own little special habits. And all of that appears on consciousness. The consciousness is like a screen upon which things appear.

So it's beginning to separate all that and beginning to get the feel of this not being a person, an entity, whole, entire unto itself. It's made up of pieces. So that's this beginning to understand the purification of view.

When it comes to the purification of overcoming doubt, that's to do with conditionality. And this brings us to things like dependent origination and seeing that everything is conditioned. We do have a choice. We know that when especially around desires. If we see a desire which is unwholesome, we can hold it there and let it pass. But even that is conditioned by our wisdom. So everything is conditioned. Everything has a cause. And that's beginning to understand that.

Now, this whole idea of cause and effect is quite profound. It's understood that when a person really grasps conditionality, that they're actually on the path. And in the commentaries they're called a *chula sotapanna*, which means a lesser sotapanna, a lesser stream entrant. That's how important understanding conditionality is. Everything is dependent on something else. Nothing arises of its own accord.

And so we're always looking at the immediacy of those components that bring something about and what's happened in the past to bring something about. Perhaps we'll come to that at a later stage. Conditionality. And its main expression is through dependent origination.

So that's why we're always looking at this distinction, especially this little trilogy of contact — sorry, of *vedanā*, which is the feeling, the feeling tone of what we're experiencing, pleasant, unpleasant — how we're reacting to it and then that sudden grasping and to stay steadily between the original feeling, the original pleasant, unpleasant state and that reaction and waiting for the reaction to go. And that gives us that clarity, that wisdom to then act in a way that's going to be a benefit to us.

And then the next one is knowing what is the path and what is not the path. This on a worldly, on a very obvious level, we begin to realise that all the sensual pleasures really have to be let go of as places where we're going to seek our liberation. They're all

right when they come as — what's his name — Blake said in that lovely poem, "To kiss a joy as it flies is to live in eternity's sunrise." But as soon as you grasp it, as soon as you try and hold on to it, misery awaits you.

So it's this business of recognising that now in our practice when we actually come to practice. Often in our sittings we'll get these beautiful states, you see, and then we'll think, "Oh, well, that's it. That must be it." And, of course, it isn't.

And this comes about — there are various ways in which these beautiful states arise. There are ten of them, actually, nine of which are fine. It's the last one, the holding on to something, which makes them into kilesa, defilements.

So the first one is that people have insight. It's quite remarkable. Some people in their practice suddenly see something and they almost go out and write a book about it. They've just had that clarity of understanding. And they think that therefore they must have had a really deep insight. I remember one monk I met who was really very clear about the Dharma. He was absolutely certain that he was born as a stream entrant, that he had it in his past life. But else, how could he explain the Dharma so clearly? How could he speak about it so clearly? And that's a confusion, that is. The intellect is very clever at confusing you. Remember the story of Lucifer, who thought he was equal to God in intellect? He found himself in hell, so be careful.

Then sometimes people get beautiful light, like they're suddenly surrounded, like an inner light which is overwhelming sometimes. And that, again, is just a product of good concentration. And some people might think, "Oh, well, that's it."

I know somebody who actually felt that. There's also a knowledge, much the same as insight, that they suddenly understand things at a more intellectual level, and that also can be a bit of a trap.

Then you can feel extraordinarily happy, extraordinarily joyous, and you think to yourself, "This is so pure a joy, this is what *Nirvāna* is." And then you have to remind yourself that there's no mental states in *Nirvāna*. There are no emotions in *Nirvāna*. And when Sariputta is asked, "How is it you talk about the bliss of *Nirvāna* when there's no emotions there?" He said, "Well, it's the very absence of emotions, which is the bliss of *Nirvāna*." Well, that's very confusing for us, isn't it?

And then you can have this wonderful sense of peace, this real deep peace where, "Oh, you know, this must be *Nirvāna*." And then there's happiness, which is more of a — the rapture, the rapture is felt more as a physical thing, a physical ecstasy, whereas the happiness is more of a mental ecstasy.

And then suddenly you get this huge determination, which is over-determination actually, and it can cause you to try and get *nibbāna*, and that can also be a bit fatal.

A load of energy can come up, it's quite remarkable, you can sit for — you can go through a whole night without any sleep. I know somebody went through two nights. Just a pure energy comes up where you can just maintain that mindfulness just continuously, over and over. And, of course, such a person might think, "Well, this is it, I've made it."

Also awareness, the awareness can be very bright and very sharp, especially for somebody who hasn't done very much practice. Suddenly to have this really sharp awareness, they think, "Well, that's it."

And the delight at the end really is hanging on to these things as meaning, as being some sort of real spiritual practice. But actually, they're all expressions of the pure heart and concentration. So then you have to let go of that. So you know, well, that's not the path. You see, that's not the path. And so one returns to the meditation. One returns to just observing, just feeling, just experiencing.

And during that time, again, these three characteristics become more and more obvious to a person. So they might be more obvious of desire at certain times. They might be more obvious of impermanence. They might recognise that things are happening of their own accord, that they're not always under our control.

And this is not only in the meditation room, it's also in ordinary daily life. You might ask yourself, for instance, if you drive a car and you've driven between point A and point B or you've actually arrived and you can't remember yourself driving because you might have been somewhere else. Well, who's been driving, for heaven's sake? So if that isn't an experience of not-self, I don't know what is. And then you might come in and you've opened the door and you put the keys down and you can't remember where you put the key. But something happened. You did put the key. There was a putting of the keys down. And that was done by whom? So it's little things like that that awaken you to the fact that this self isn't entirely in control.

And then finally, there's the first what you might call true insight, which is the knowledge of rise and fall. A person sees that now much more clearly on the breath. And this, again, this doesn't need to happen while you're sitting. It can happen while you're riding on a bus, while you're walking down the street. This awareness, this intuitive awareness can grasp these things at any time.

And then the next one after that, after there's a clearer viewing of that, is dissolution. Now, this point of dissolution is just when there's a real grasping, a real direct insight, you actually experience, there's an experience of things actually vanishing.

Now, that has a big effect on us because, normally speaking, we're much more aware of when things begin. So you'll notice that as soon as you finish one piece of chocolate, before you've actually swallowed it, you're on to the next one. So we're always one step ahead of ourselves. We're always into something new, something exciting, something drawing us always into the future. But this is actually a sudden realisation that everything actually does disappear. Everything does collapse. Everything does vanish. And that has an effect on us. It's like coming to terms with death in a way. It's an opening that recognises that things end kaput and all that.

And so what happens then is some fear comes up. And during the next period which are known as the suffering *ñānas* or the *dukkha* *ñānas*, also it can be mixed up with your own psychology. So there's this underlying awakening of your spirit of spiritual insight into the way things really are, but it also can bring up stuff from your more surface level psychology.

So there's fear comes up, which is a shock. It's a shock.

And then after that, there's a sort of downer where you might feel depressed, and all these things can last any length of time. It's not a case of zipping through it in a few days or something. I know people who've taken years to go through these stages.

And then after that, there's a sort of disinterest in life, a real profound disinterest. It's like nothing's worth doing. You lose interest in everything. And often in that sort of case, a person might just stop. And that's a bit dangerous. You've got to keep going. In the Christian literature, it's known as the desert. So you've got to keep walking on.

And then after that, there's a rising out of that, a desire to escape, to sort of run away, and a tremendous restlessness comes. And again, the meditator can fly out of the meditation hall or can just be very restless in ordinary daily life. And of course, it's very difficult to separate that from a person's ordinary restlessness, ordinary disinterest in life, ordinary sense of boredom.

Going back to that disinterest, that can be confused with boredom. But boredom always is a sort of rest period where you're a bit fed up with doing the same thing for a while, but then the urge to go back and do the same thing again comes back. And that's a sign of boredom. Whereas disinterest is you don't want to go back there again. You've had enough.

And after this restlessness, where often a meditator just wants to escape, there comes an insight. And this insight is always a deeper insight into one of these three characteristics. It's always about the three characteristics of existence, how we create suffering, the role of desire, impermanence and not-self.

And then after that, the *dukkha* ñāṇas seem to come to an end and one enters into a very beautiful place of peacefulness, equanimity, and awareness is very easy to maintain. And again, this can happen in ordinary daily life. It doesn't have to happen in a meditation centre or while you're on a retreat. And there's an immature part and a mature part.

What separates them is often something comes out — some deep trauma maybe, doesn't have to be. It could be just a memory of something. Now the monk I mentioned before, Ananda Metteyya, who is a very famous monk and highly respected, he did a Mahāsi retreat when the Mahāsi came to Sri Lanka in the 1950s, '56 or something. And on retreat he came to this point and at this point he remembered right back in the Buddha's time when he took the vow to become a fully self-awakened Buddha. He said he could remember the face of Sāriputta, Moggallāna, but unfortunately not the face of the Buddha.

And at that point he could have made a decision to actually renege on that desire or to reinforce it. Now he must have decided to carry on with that determination, that avowal, because he couldn't move after that. He could not enter into stream-entry because the understanding is that somebody who is training themselves to become a fully self-awakened Buddha — in other words, without any help from anybody — has to develop all the virtues necessary in order to make it in one lifetime.

So in the story of the Buddha, we find him up in the Tushita heaven, ready to take rebirth, having developed all his perfections, as they're called, his *pāramī*. *Pāramī* means those virtues that you need to get to the other shore. So he didn't make it to stream-entry. And that's Ananda Metteyya.

And then, of course, right at the end of that there is a quick process where you finally break through. You really do see deeply into one of these three characteristics. And seemingly, according to the scriptures, it could be the same one four times. You could see impermanence more and more and more deeply and become fully liberated. But I think it's more regular that with every step you go on, you see things from that other angle. So if at first it was impermanence, maybe the next time you see not-self more deeply and the next time you see the process of *dukkha* more clearly by seeing the process of dependent origination.

And that's it. And then you start all over again. This is the thing, you see. You have to go through this four times minimum to become fully liberated.

And that brings us to the end of these seven purifications. This book — as I say, if you want to read through it, it's a snazzy little book, about 36 pages and you can download it as a PDF — "The Progress of Insight." It is really about the meditation retreats. It's not about daily life. It's how you experience these seven purifications while on retreat.

Now the only real warning is that when you read the insight knowledges — as a lot of people do and a lot of writers write about them — you are of course building up concepts about them and then those concepts become a real hindrance. So we're not trying to get any of those insights. They come when the time is ripe.

Why do you read them? Really just to give you faith, to give you confidence that there is an actually highly delineated path, but we're not in charge of it. It comes of its own time, of its own accord. So always remember, you go back to that childlike mind, what Zen called beginner's mind.

And personally, I feel myself extraordinarily fortunate that I began with Zen. Because they don't talk about any of this in Zen. Any of this sort of talk is just verboten. They don't allow it. The student might talk about it with the teacher on occasion when something happens. And therefore, when I was practising, you see, I really did have beginner's mind. And because of that, I was able to progress.

So remember, that childlike mind, that childlike way of looking at things. When we finally settle into our practice — and you can do it in ordinary daily life — you can look at things, just to stare, you know, just to put your eye on something and stare, or just to keep your attention on your ear and just hear, without any interference, no judging, nothing.

Well, I can only hope that all this has been inspirational and not confusing, and that you will devote yourself to your practice and become liberated sooner rather than later. So we can begin our practice now, I think.

The Dog Duty Ascetic Discourse — Kukkuravatika Sutta (MN 57)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 1h21

In this thought-provoking discourse, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Kukkuravatika Sutta (MN 57), where the Buddha encounters two unusual ascetics: one who imitates ox behavior and another who lives like a dog. Through their earnest questions about rebirth destinations, the Buddha reveals profound teachings about kamma and its results.

The talk explores the Buddha's classification of four types of actions: dark actions with dark results, bright actions with bright results, mixed actions with mixed results, and the transcendent actions of the fully liberated that lead to the destruction of kamma itself. Bhante explains how wrong views about spiritual practice can lead to unfortunate rebirths, while right understanding opens the path to Awakening.

Despite the discourse's seemingly grim beginning, it concludes with hope as both ascetics abandon their misguided practices. One even ordains as a bhikkhu and attains arahantship, demonstrating that even those following wrong paths can find liberation through the Buddha's teaching. The session includes guided meditation on the body's impermanence and loving-kindness practice, emphasizing the human realm's unique opportunity for spiritual development.

Good evening. I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So I've chosen from our modern point of view, our present day point of view, a rather strange discourse. It's entitled the Dog Duty Ascetic. Ascetics are well known in most religions. As you know, the Buddha himself underwent certain ascetic practices, especially the process of drawing the body down through eating less and less and less, which was more of a Jain practice. And in the early Christian ages were ascetics who lived on top of pillars. And they would come down every so often, but they would stay there for quite some time, lowering their chamber pots, I think. And in the medieval ages, the anchorites, they were men and women who locked themselves into a room in a cathedral. Most famous, of course, was Julian of Norwich, who's worth reading.

So there was this very strong element in all religious traditions of a fierce asceticism. But there's nothing quite like this in the West because this is on the basis of rebirth, of reincarnation.

So here we have the Blessed One. He's living in Koliya country. And two people have come to see him. Punna, who was one of the Koliyas, was an ox duty ascetic. And also Seniya, a naked dog duty ascetic. And Punna, the ox duty ascetic, paid homage to the Blessed One, sat by one side, and they both exchanged greetings. And after the courteous and amiable talk was finished, Punna addressed the Blessed One.

"Venerable sir, this Seniya is a naked dog duty ascetic who does what is hard to do. He eats his food when it's thrown on the ground. He has long taken up and practiced dog duty." So you can imagine him there sitting like a dog. "What will be his destination? What will be his future course?"

"Enough Punna, let that be. Do not ask me that."

A second time and a third time, the ox duty ascetic asked the Blessed One, "Venerable Sir, this Seniya is a naked dog duty ascetic. What will be his destination? What will be his future course?"

"Well, Punna, since I certainly cannot persuade you when I say, 'Enough, Punna, let that be. Do not ask me,' I shall therefore answer you. Here, Punna, someone develops the dog duty fully and uninterruptedly. He develops the dog duty habit fully and uninterruptedly. He develops the dog duty mind fully and uninterruptedly. And he develops dog behaviour fully and uninterruptedly. Having done so on the dissolution of the body after death, he will reappear in the company of dogs. But if he has such a view as this, 'by this virtue or observance or asceticism or holy life, I shall become a great god or lesser god,' that is wrong view in this case. Now, there are two destinations for one with wrong view, I say. Hell or the animal realm. So, Punna, if his dog duty succeeds, it will lead him to the company of dogs. And if it fails, it will lead him to hell."

Now when this was said, Seniya, the naked dog ascetic, cried out and burst into tears. Well, you would.

Then the Blessed One said to Punna, "Punna, I could not persuade you when I said enough, Punna, do not ask me this."

Then Seniya, the naked dog ascetic, said, "Venerable sir, I am not crying because the Blessed One has said this about me, but because I have long taken up and practiced this dog duty asceticism." In other words, he's very quickly recognised that it's been a waste of time. Worse than that, it's been worse than a waste of time. He's now developed the dog duty mind. He's developed mind like a dog.

So then, of course, he says, "Look, my friend Punna, son of the Koliyas, is an ox duty ascetic. He's long taken up and practiced the ox duty. What's his destination? What will his future course be?"

"Do not ask me that."

First and second time, "Venerable Sir, this Punna, son of the Koliyas, is an ox duty ascetic. He's taken up this practice a long time. What will be his destination?"

"Seniya, since I certainly cannot persuade you when I say enough, Seniya, let that be. Do not ask me that. I shall therefore answer you. Seniya, someone who develops the ox duty fully and uninterruptedly, the ox duty habit fully and uninterruptedly, ox duty mind, and the ox behaviour fully and uninterruptedly, having done so on the dissolution of the body after death, he reappears in the company of oxen. But if he has such a view that this by this observance or asceticism or holy life I shall become a great god or some lesser god, this is wrong view. Now there are two destinations for one with wrong view, I say. Hell and the animal realm. So Seniya, if this ox duty succeeds it will lead him to the company of oxen and if it fails it will lead him to hell."

When this was said, Punna, son of the Koliyas, the ox duty ascetic cried out and burst into tears. Well, he would, wouldn't he?

And then the Blessed One said to Seniya, "Seniya, I could not persuade you when I said enough, Seniya, let that be, do not ask me."

"Venerable sir," says Punna, "I'm not crying because the Blessed One has said this about me, but because I have long taken up and practiced the ox duty." So again, this ox duty ascetic realises his big mistake.

And he says, "I have confidence in the Blessed One thus. The Blessed One is capable of teaching me the Dhamma in such a way I can abandon this ox duty and that this Seniya, the naked dog ascetic, can abandon his dog duty."

Then he says, "Well, listen to what I have to say. There are four kinds of actions proclaimed by me after realising them for myself with direct knowledge, direct experience. There is dark action with dark result. There is bright action with bright result. There is

dark and bright action with dark and bright result. And there is action that is neither dark nor bright, with neither dark nor bright result, action that leads to the destruction of action."

Well, you've got to get into the language. Basically, this dark action is of course immoral behaviour, unethical behaviour. So unethical behaviour leads to unethical results and ethical moral behaviour leads to lovely results. And of course most people have a mixture of both, a little bit on the dark side and a little bit on the bright side. But there's also a level where there's none of that, and that belongs to the one who is fully liberated.

So that sort of action in the Abhidhamma, this later work, was called *kriya*, functional. So most people's actions are either *kusala* or *akusala*, skilful or unskilful, wholesome or unwholesome. But when you become liberated, because there's no self-generation, no selfing going on, no attachment going on, the actions are simply pure. And of course, the defilements are gone too. So it's always a wholesome action, but there's no consequence for that person in terms of rebirthing, because there's no identity with it. It's just pure action.

So then, of course, he says those with dark action will have afflictive bodily formations, afflictive verbal formations and afflictive mental formations. So those people who are acting immorally or unethically will have afflictive, painful mental, verbal and bodily actions. And they will reappear in such a world that is afflicted, that's painful. And that's because of this constant rebirthing. So that's what he says. "This, I say, beings are heirs to their actions." You're an heir to your actions. So whatever a previous self did yesterday, this self now has to deal with it.

And so he says the same, of course, with those things that are bright and those things that are dark and bright. There's a mixture there of afflictive and unafflictive contacts. And so unafflictive and afflictive feelings, mixed with pain and pleasure, as in the case of human beings and some gods and some beings in the lower worlds.

So the ones who are bright action would end up in the heavenly realm where basically you're happy all the time. And if, of course, you've done some really bad stuff, you end up in the animal or worse, the hell realm. But the human beings, it's a bit of mixture of both. And, of course, that's the blessing of this particular existence because with our bright intelligence, this intuitive awareness, we can find our way out of the problem. This is not open to people in hell. They're suffering too much. Animals, of course, don't have the intelligence and people in the heavens are enjoying life too much. And of course remember that these realms are mirrored in the human life, aren't they? There

are people who are basically so caught up in their desires that they're enjoying themselves because they've got billions of pounds or whatever and then they don't think about the spiritual life.

And there are people who are caught up in an animal existence of drugs, et cetera, where the intelligence is dulled. And there are people, of course, who are in great suffering, either mental suffering or physical suffering, where it's difficult to practice spiritually. They're lost in it. So all these realms are just mirrors, really, of what we see in the human realm.

And then finally of course this neither dark nor bright actions, that's the one where there's no consequence. The volition in abandoning the kind of action that is bright brings bright results and the volition of abandoning the kind which is dark and also with dark and bright results. So the Arahant, the one who's liberated, is lifted above that duality. "These four kinds of actions I've realised for myself," the Buddha says.

So now Punna, of course, he's the ox, isn't he? I think he's the ox. Yes, he's the ox ascetic. So he's really taken to this. He's said, "Magnificent, Venerable Sir, magnificent." And he becomes a lay follower from that time onwards.

And the dog duty ascetic also says the same thing, the usual, this lovely phrasing that comes up, "turning upright what has been overthrown, revealing what was hidden, showing the way to one who was lost, holding up a lamp in the dark for those with eyesight to see form." And he also goes to the Blessed One. And he actually wants to receive, he wants to become a bhikkhu. And when somebody becomes a bhikkhu who's been involved in some other tradition, they have to be on probation for four months. That's now a rule in the order, you see. So he put him on probation for four months and then ordained him. The Buddha, in fact, ordained him.

And so then just the last little paragraph tells us what happens to Seniya, the naked dog duty ascetic. So he received the ordination from the Blessed One, full admission, and then not long after his full admission, dwelling alone, withdrawn, diligent, ardent and resolute, the Venerable Seniya, by realising for himself with direct knowledge, here and now entered upon and abided in that supreme goal of the holy life for the sake of which clansmen rightly go forth from home life into homelessness.

And then this lovely phrase, these are phrases that you'll find often repeated throughout the discourses. He directly knew "birth is destroyed. The holy life has been lived. What had to be done has been done. There is no more coming to any state of being." And the Venerable Seniya became one of the Arahants.

So although we started off in a gloomy place with somebody behaving like an ox and another one behaving like a dog, it seems as though they finally ended up in a very good place. And Seniya became an Arahant, fully liberated. So we don't have to choose that particular path. We don't have to do the dog duty part to become fully liberated. We've got a slightly easier part, you might say, of just being ordinary people.

So there we are. I hope that this discourse on the dog duty ascetic has been of interest and I can only hope that like Seniya you will be ardent with your practice and I trust you'll be fully liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

So we can do a little practice. *Puraṃ pūjemi Buddhaṃ pūjemi Dhammaṃ pūjemi Saṅghaṃ pūjemi.*

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and perfectly enlightened one.

Buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Dhammaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Dutiyampi Buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Dutiyampi Dhammaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Dutiyampi Saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Tatiyampi Buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Tatiyampi Dhammaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Tatiyampi Saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi.

Pāṇātipātā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi. Adinnādānā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi. Kāmesumicchācārā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi. Musāvādā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi. Surāmerayamajjapamādaṭṭhānā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi.

Very good.

So make sure your posture is the expression of the awakened one. So again, as usual, lifting up from the lower spine and the lower back and the abdomen. Sitting tall. Spending a moment relaxing the brow. The jaw lifts together, teeth apart. The shoulders. And hands on the lap, whatever's comfortable.

Just acknowledging that posture. Energised spine, everything else relaxed.

This body is subject to disease. This body is of a nature to fall ill. This body has not gone beyond sickness. This body is subject to ageing. This body has not gone beyond ageing. This body is now in a process of ageing. This body is subject to death. This body has not gone beyond death. This body will die.

There is the unborn, undying, uncreated, uncompounded. The unconditioned. True refuge, harbour and home. Perfect peace and contentment. Those who are mindful are in the presence of *Nibbāna*.

Waiting for that settlement upon the breath, then opening up to whatever draws our attention within the field of awareness, just observing, just feeling, just experiencing intimately. It's enough.

A moment's reflection. Resolution.

So we can begin our evening contemplations. Make sure that you're sitting comfortably. Speaking gently into our own hearts.

May I be free of physical pain. May I be free of mental distress. May I be liberated of all my sufferings.

Bringing to mind someone we know is having a hard time. May you be free of physical pain. May you be free of mental distress. May you be liberated of all your sufferings.

And there are all those at this moment who are sick and suffering from mental illness. People in the process of dying and those who have died and left grieving family, relatives and friends. People going hungry, homeless and destitute. Those having to deal with severe personal and interpersonal difficulties. All those caught up in wars and repressive regimes and those being tortured. And there are those suffering from natural disasters and climate crisis. All the sentient beings being cruelly treated and unnecessarily slaughtered. And all who find life meaningless.

May you be free of physical pain. May you be free of mental distress. May you be liberated of all your sufferings.

Radiating our compassion to all beings in all directions. May all beings be free of physical pain. May all beings be free of mental distress. May all beings be liberated of all their sufferings.

Bringing to mind now some moments of joyfulness we've experienced today. Happiness, peacefulness.

May I be joyful. May my joyfulness increase. May I experience the bliss of liberation.

Bringing to mind someone we know who's joyful. May you be joyful. May your joyfulness increase. May you experience the bliss of awakening.

And to all those at this moment who are happy and content with their lives, who are enjoying the warmth of friendships, enjoying the delights of art and nature, hobbies and so on, who find their work meaningful, who enjoy the fruitfulness of their spiritual lives and who rejoice in the success of others.

May you be joyful. May your joyfulness increase. May you experience the bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Radiating our goodwill joy to all beings in all directions. May all beings be joyful. May all beings' joyfulness increase. May all beings experience the bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Allowing these words to flow through us.

If you're wise and want to reach the state of peace, you should behave like this. You should be upright, responsible, gentle and humble. Easily contented and need only a few things. Not always be busy and have the right sort of work. Your senses should be guarded and you should be modest. You should not be exclusively attached to only a few people. And you should not do the slightest thing that a wise person could blame you for. You should always be thinking, may all beings be happy, whatever living beings there are, be they weak or strong, big or small, large or slender, living nearby or far away, those who have already been born and those who have yet to be born. May all beings be happy.

Without exception, be happy. You should not tell lies to each other and do not think anyone, anywhere, is of no value. Do not wish harm to anyone, even when you're angry, just as a mother would protect her only child at the risk of her own life. So you should let the warmth of your heart go out to all beings.

Let your thoughts of love go through the whole world, above and below, without any barrier, with no ill will or hatred, whether you're standing, walking, sitting, or lying down. As long as you're awake, you should develop this affectionate mindfulness. This they say is the noblest way to live.

And if you do not fall into unskillful ways and live well and develop insight and are no longer attached to all the desires of the senses, then truly you never need to be reborn into this world again.

Please join me in the chanting, or if you wish, offer these blessings. May you be safe, well and happy. May you live contented, in harmony with the world.

*Kāraṇīyam atthakusalena yaṃ taṃ santaṃ padaṃ abhisamecca
Sakko ujū ca suhujū ca sūvaco cassa mudu anatiṃānī
Santuṭṭho ca subharo ca appakicco ca sallahukavutti
Santindriyo ca nipako ca appagabbho kulesu ananugiddho
Na ca khuddaṃ samācare kiñci yena viññū pare upavadeyyuṃ
Sukhino vā khemino hontu sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā
Ye keci pāṇabhūtatthi tasā vā thāvarā vā anāvasesā*

*Dīghā vā ye mahantā vā majjhimā rassakāṇukathulā
Diṭṭhā vā ye ca adiṭṭhā ye ca dūre vasanti avidūre
Bhūtā vā sambhavesī vā sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhittā
Na paro paraṃ nikubbetha nātimaññetha katthaci naṃ kañci
Byārosanā paṭighāṇasaññā nāññamaññassa dukkham iccheyya
Mātā yathā niyaṃ puttāṃ āyusā ekaputtam anurakkhe
Evampi sabbabhūtesu mānasambhāvaye aparimāṇaṃ
Mettañca sabbalokasmi mānasambhāvaye aparimāṇaṃ
Uddhaṃ adho ca tiriyañca asambādhaṃ averaṃ asapattaṃ
Tiṭṭhañcamaṃ nisinno vā sayāno vā yāvat'assa vigata middho
Etaṃ satiṃ adhiṭṭheyya brahman etaṃ vihāram idham āhu
Diṭṭhiñca anupagamma sīlavā dassanena sampanno
Kāmēsu vineyya gedhaṃ na hi jātu gabbhaseyyaṃ punar etīti*

May all beings be happy.

Very good. So I hope you were somewhat amused by the dog ascetic practice and also the presumed sense of humour of the Buddha. He comes across sometimes with wry humour. He likes to have a little dig at people sometimes too.

So don't forget from now till we fall asleep, it's also about practice - putting something beautiful into the heart, drifting away into sweet oblivion, rising in the morning to make the best of the day. May you sleep peacefully.

Gratitude, Generosity, and Renunciation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 18 min

In this inaugural Full Moon Day teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma introduces a powerful trilogy of interconnected practices: gratitude, generosity, and renunciation. He clarifies that true renunciation is not self-mortification or rejecting life's pleasures, but rather letting go of our attachment and dependency on external conditions for happiness. The Buddha himself enjoyed taste without greed.

Bhante explores how genuine gratitude—for our parents who gave us life, teachers, society's gifts like education and healthcare, and nature itself—naturally leads to wanting to give back. Since we cannot truly repay what has been freely given, this gratitude flows into generosity. He offers practical guidance on pure giving: acting without expectation of repayment, acknowledgment, or praise, and giving that 'little bit more' that creates a healthy pinch.

This virtuous circle culminates in renunciation—each act of pure generosity loosens our grip on possessions and desires, providing a taste of liberation. Bhante emphasizes this is daily life practice, not a formal meditation technique, but one that naturally changes our habits from those causing suffering toward those bringing genuine happiness and moving us closer to awakening.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed and noble self-awakened one.

This is our inaugural Full Moon Day meeting. I've always wanted to do this, but I've never found a way to do it. So I was really happy when Magda suggested that I try it on this medium. I think we can keep this going. Luckily it's fallen on a Sunday and I'm inclined to in the future choose the closest Sunday to the full moon because that's most convenient for people. In Sri Lanka they are public holidays, all the moons are public holidays so there's no problem in keeping the full moon itself there.

My idea is that with every full moon we look at some of the teachings of the Buddha and eventually throughout the year we cover it all. I'm going to start with this lovely little trilogy, a virtuous circle of gratitude, generosity and renunciation.

Starting with renunciation, the big problem here that can arise is confusing what it is that we're actually renouncing. Remember the body is not our fault. When the body has appetite then it has appetite and when you put something lovely and sweet on the tongue it will taste lovely and sweet. That's never the problem. The problem is our relationship to it, which is wanting more, depending on it in order to establish a beautiful mental state.

That's what we've really got to grasp. We use the sense bases not because they are lovely in themselves but because they are a way of creating a lovely mental state. Hence you might have a piece of toast in the evening just to raise your spirits. The unfortunate thing is that of course you have dependency and that dependency is what we call attachment. And so there's suffering there. If there's no bread and there's no toast well it's misery, isn't it?

When we click onto that we become much more sensitive to this draw towards what is pleasurable. This renunciation is therefore not to be confused with what they call self-mortification, in other words blaming the body for our mental states. So that's an important distinction to make. We're not trying to get rid of the pleasures and joys of life at all. The Buddha himself did enjoy life. He enjoyed taste, but he didn't greed for it. That's what it says in the scriptures.

This whole idea of renunciation will arise on two different types of grasping which is one about our wealth and the other about our time. We can be greedy with our time but not greedy with our wealth. We can be generous with our wealth but if somebody asks us to do something for them we shy off it. And the other way around we can be very happy giving time but if somebody asks us for a bit of money we're not inclined to give. Again, we have to look at that.

This trilogy, this little virtuous circle of gratitude, generosity and renunciation, is not actually taught in the scriptures themselves as a way to liberation. This is more a commentary pointed out. This directly connects with our daily life. This is our daily life, in our daily work, in the way we are with people. If we can generate that virtuous circle, it's actually drawing us towards liberation.

Letting go of attachment, letting go of dependency is the path to liberation. You might say that the whole of the path is one of renunciation. Because eventually you've got to renounce the sense of self. That's the last thing to go, this little idea that somewhere within us, we actually do believe ourselves to be this psychophysical organism, for want of a better word. So that's this renunciation business.

Now, just to go to the front of the trilogy, this sense of gratitude. When you feel gratitude, it really is a heartwarming feeling. And when we feel this gratitude, we always want to repay it. If we spend some time just considering what we've received from our parents, our parents gave us our life, our mothers. When you think about that, you might have problems with your mother and your father. In fact, somebody once asked, "How do you know when you're fully liberated?" And they said, well, go and spend a week with your mother. And then you'll know.

It may be that our general relationship is a bit fractious and so on, but you still have your life through your parents. The Buddha said that even if you were to carry them on your shoulders the whole of your life you'd never repay them. In fact it's unrepayable and that's what you begin to realize when you contemplate everything that's been given to you from your family, from your friends, the good deeds and the companionship of family and friends. All this is given to you.

Then there are things like what society gives us, all our education. Our parents could not have afforded, most of our parents could not have afforded to educate us. It's the same with the social services. We might not have needed them up until now, but if we get old enough, you definitely begin to need them. And of course, there's our health system. It's funny how you take something as a right and you presume that it's something that isn't given because either you've paid for it through the national insurance or because it's taken for granted. But how many times have you thanked your doctors? Thank the dentist?

The dentist I had here in Bishop's Castle was really good. The front tooth here finally gave in and he put this false tooth in. It was pretty awful. You've got to get used to it. You couldn't eat nuts, all the nuts got behind the tube behind the palate so you had to take it out and wash your mouth out and stick it back in. When I told him that it was a little inconvenient he finally decided to give me a bridge and there it is, it's absolutely fantastic. It's a case of recognizing all these gifts that people have given us.

If you bring to mind for instance the teachers one or two favourite teachers that you've had, it does fill the heart with a sense of gratitude. And finally of course there's nature, just the earth that we live on which we become more and more aware of these days.

What gratitude does is it makes you want to repay. Because you can't repay what has been given, you can't repay something that has been given to you freely. You have to find a substitute. And that draws you towards just being generous ourselves. And that moves us into this whole area of generosity.

When the Buddha talked to lay people, he always began with generosity. He pointed out that even a thief can be generous. He's just taken something off you and he's very kindly given it to somebody in his family or friends. When we think about generosity, the ability to give without some idea of being repaid, that's quite difficult for us. We have to clarify the mind about that.

There are certain times you give gifts such as Christmas, which is more like a little ritual re-establishing friendship. You get your pair of socks and they get their pair of socks and that's fine, unless of course the pair that they've given you is obviously much cheaper than what you spent on the socks that you gave them. That's when the trouble starts. There's always a bit of bargaining going on. It's always like business.

If we want to have an act of pure generosity then you have to listen to what's going on in the background of our minds about being repaid, about being adored because of our generosity. If you're going to give for instance a donation to a charity and there are so many of them these days, you have to get yourself into that mental state where that's the only thing in your mind and heart and you are giving this in order to help somebody. There's no hope of repayment. The charity is not going to give you any money back so you're doing it for just that purpose and when you do it for that purpose that's when you make the donation whether it's by card or by cash.

Once you've done it you'll hear these little voices like "you are truly a very wonderful person" or you might get the one "that's too much, what do you give so much for? You could have..." You haven't been caught up in that. The *mara* did not catch you there so you can let those thoughts disappear. If guilt comes you have to point to it and say well that is false guilt because when I actually made the action, my heart was full of generosity.

The same arises when you do something for somebody. I think most people, I certainly do, is say yes too quickly. If somebody says, "I've moved into this new house, it's actually happened to me. I've moved into this new flat and we're painting it, would you like to come and give us a hand?" And I said, "yeah, yeah, I'll come on Saturday." And then as I'm walking away, I'm thinking, "What? What have I given this Saturday away?"

In that case, at that time, I was shall we say advanced enough to actually make myself do it, to teach myself, not to say yes just because somebody asked something. You don't have to say yes. There's a point where you can actually reflect for a moment and then say yes. So it's coming from a point of reflection. You're not just doing it by habit. Again, that point of generosity, there has to be a certain reflection about it and that you are doing it from the heart of goodwill and that you're not even expecting a thank you. And that's very difficult.

When I became a monastic, we're not supposed to say thank you. I mean, I say it in the West because people get very upset. But in the East, you don't say thank you. It undermines the person's gift. That's the understanding. Because if somebody gives something to you, they don't expect you to say thank you. But if they expect you to say thank you, and then you don't say thank you, then of course, they feel very upset. That tells you that the gift is slightly corrupted they wanted praise they wanted appreciation.

To be able to give something without that desire to be acknowledged is leading us towards a real pure heart generosity. The other little telltale is just to give that little bit more that pinches. That little pinch is where you're truly being generous, where you're giving just that bit of extra time, just that little bit of extra money. That's the point where it just begins to hurt a little bit. That's the point where you are truly extending our generosity.

Just to recap, we have this lovely virtuous circle. This feeling of gratitude and one exercise you can give yourself is just to say that tomorrow everything I will say thank you to everything. In Zen of course you always *gassho* when you enter a room. You're taught to thank everything. You have to *gassho* when you approach the table you *gassho* to the chair. This whole attitude of actually not presuming on anything, not thinking that we have a right to everything but that everything is a gift. If you go through the whole day like that you'd be surprised how it lifts you. It really does lift you.

Once you've established more and more this sense of gratitude and the knowledge that you can't repay directly what people have given to you, you have to find a way of expressing that gratitude through generosity. When we are being generous, just to stop for a moment and to make sure that you're doing it for pure reasons. That's all.

Then to realize that when I've actually made an act of generosity with a pure heart, I've renounced something. I've let go of something I'm holding on to. And I'm actually practising renunciation. Letting go of that grip on things. That loosening of a grip, that letting go of these tight desires, wrong desires, is a little every time we do that and we feel that that loss of grippiness that in a sense is a touch of *Nibbāna* because one of the descriptions of *Nibbāna* is that it is desireless of these sorts of wrong desires. There's a lovely little practice there which is just ongoing day in and day out and it's only a matter of reminding ourselves to do it and just very slowly it becomes a habit. That's all.

Really that's what we're doing in our practice we are just changing our habits moving away from habits which cause ourselves suffering and aren't very pleasant for others and moving towards habits which bring us happiness. The gift of the practice is a

natural happiness in life. It's not *Nirvana*, it's just a natural happiness. This happiness that we talk about is the internal environment within ourselves. This is a really powerful practice. I try and remember to do it myself occasionally.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused even greater confusion and that you will, by your practice, become liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Spanish Introduction — Refuges and Precepts, Standing and Sitting Meditation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 1h20

In this bilingual introduction to Buddhist meditation practice, Bhante Bodhidhamma begins with the traditional recitation of the Three Refuges (Tisarāṇa) and Five Precepts (Pañca Sīla) before guiding practitioners through both standing and sitting meditation. The session emphasizes present-moment awareness, teaching the fundamental vipassanā technique of noting whatever arises in consciousness without manipulation or judgment.

The standing meditation focuses on grounding awareness through body sensations, while the sitting practice develops concentration through mindfulness of breathing (ānāpānasati) before opening to whatever draws attention. Bhante explains the development of the Seven Factors of Awakening (Bojjhaṅga) and introduces the three characteristics of existence: impermanence (anicca), unsatisfactoriness (dukkha), and not-self (anattā). The session concludes with guidance on wise reflection after meditation, emphasizing self-encouragement rather than criticism. This introductory session provides Spanish-speaking practitioners with foundational instruction in the Mahasi method of vipassanā meditation.

Buddham pujemi, Dhammam pujemi, Saṅgham pujemi. Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Buddham saraṇam gacchāmi, Dhammam saraṇam gacchāmi, Saṅgham saraṇam gacchāmi. Dutiyampi Buddham saraṇam gacchāmi, Dutiyampi Dhammam saraṇam gacchāmi, Dutiyampi Saṅgham saraṇam gacchāmi. Tatiyampi Buddham saraṇam gacchāmi, Tatiyampi Dhammam saraṇam gacchāmi, Tatiyampi Saṅgham saraṇam gacchāmi. Pāṇātipātā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi. Adinnādānā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi. Kāmesumicchācārā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi. Musāvādā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi. Surāmeraya-majjapamādaṭṭhānā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi.

Very good. So we can begin with a standing meditation.

Make sure you feel balanced, grounded, and lifting yourself up through the top of the head, standing tall. Spending a moment relaxing, relaxing the brow. Eyes lowered, unfocused. The jaw. If there's tension there, just clench the jaw and then relax. The shoulders, give them a squeeze. Hands joined in front or by the side, doesn't matter. Just whatever is comfortable.

So acknowledging the posture, the energised spine, lifting us up, everything else relaxed. Bring your attention to the soles of your feet. What can you feel there? Can you isolate the sensations of pressure? Can you do that with sensations of warmth or coolness?

And there are those subtle sensations that tell you what you're standing on—the hardness of wood, the softness, the sponginess of a carpet. Acknowledging how the sensations are constantly changing as the body rebalances itself, and acknowledge how these sensations arise, whether we want them to or not. They are not under our direct control.

So taking our time, let's come up the body, see what we can feel. Both inside and outside. And there are areas that seem to be void of any feeling. When you get to the abdomen, can you feel the breath there? Is there any tension in the area? Can you feel the breath in the stomach area? Just the natural breath. Any tension? Do you feel the breath in the chest? Do you have a shallow breath? Any tension? Shoulders still relaxed. The jaw. The brow. And when you get to the scalp scan it like you did the soles of your feet.

Now without moving your eyes, just become aware of what's outside you. Colours and shapes in front of you. Any sounds. The atmosphere of the room, presence of other people either in your home or your neighbours. So your attention is entirely out there. Now at the same time, bring in the in here. Both the inside and the outside.

So this is the bubble of our consciousness. This is the world we are actually experiencing moment after moment. This is our universe. And we can't get out of it. You can't get underneath it, over the top of it. You're always in the middle of it.

So we may as well relax, just relax into this present moment, wide awake. In this mode we can let go of ideas of achieving something. That's the mode of doing, doing something now for some future result. But in this mode, just being, this is the result.

Relaxing, abiding in the present moment, wide awake. In this mode, just being, there's no future. There's only this ever-presenting moment. We're never going anywhere. We've always arrived.

Relaxing, abiding in the present moment, wide awake. In this mode just being, we're not reacting, we're not responding. It's as though we are nobody. Anonymous. Relaxing, abiding in the present moment wide awake. Achieving nothing, going nowhere, being nobody.

In this mode we're developing five of the seven factors that lead to liberation. There's the awareness of course. And there's the steadiness of attention, and the effort needed just to maintain that steadiness. A sense of calmness. The quality of equanimity. Not coming from a fixed position, an opinion, very open-minded. Not coming from aversion, fear, greed or preference. Open-hearted. Open-minded, open-hearted.

When this is established, we bring in two further factors, a sense of inquiry and an investigation of the Buddha's teachings. But remember this mode is important in ordinary daily life. To stop like this after a phone call, after a meal, after a job. When we stop, we can feel what mood or mental state we are in. We might be happy, we might be feeling stressed. So just to feel that, just for a moment. And then we can see the next intention. And we have enough calmness to decide whether it's something we should do or something we shouldn't do. If it's something we shouldn't do, we should just stay with the feeling of desire until it comes to an end. If it's something we should do, then of course we should empower that desire.

So our next intention is to sit. Let's really take our time, be aware of every little movement it takes to get the body into a sitting posture. And you can use a little noting word just to keep the attention steady: pushing, pulling, lifting, placing.

So make sure you're comfortable, the spine in its natural position, just lifting up through the top of the head. And spending a few moments relaxing the brow. Eyes gently closed. Relaxing the jaw, lips together, teeth apart. Shoulders, if there's some tension, give them a good squeeze. And hands on your lap, whatever is comfortable. Just acknowledging the posture. If during the sitting it becomes tense, spend a moment relaxing. If you find that the body is slumping, then take a moment to lift up that energy.

Draw the attention now to the sensations caused by the breath. Preferable in the body, but if you're established at the nostrils, that's fine. Just placing the attention on the gentle sensations caused by the breath. Rising, falling. If the mind is wandering, as soon as you wake up note what it's doing. Planning, planning. Worrying, worrying. And then just draw the attention back to the breath. If you're feeling sleepy or tired, lift the spine, and you can open the eyes to let the lighting in, but keep the attention inward, resting the attention on the gentle sensations caused by the breath, allowing them to bring silence to the mind, calmness to the heart, stillness to the body.

Rising, falling. If the mind is wandering, recognise and acknowledge what it's doing. Thinking, thinking. Irritation, irritation. And bring the attention gently back to the breath. Feeling sleepy or tired, lift the spine, open the eyes.

As we become calmer, perhaps we can get closer to the breath, to catch the very beginning of the in-breath and feel it all the way to the very end. The very beginning of the out-breath, feel it all the way to the very end. If when you do that you feel you get tense, as it were, sit back within yourself and receive the information. Rising, falling.

If the mind is wandering just bring it gently back to the breath, acknowledge what's causing it to wander and then bring it back to the breath. Feeling sleepy or tired keep making that effort.

Once we feel somewhat concentrated, somewhat calm, we can open up to what is causing the mind to wander. If the mind is planning a holiday, I let those thoughts go. I'm not interested in the story. I come back into the body and feel the excitement, and wait till the excitement begins to fade away. If some worry comes up, let go of the story, come into the body and feel the anxiety, and wait for it to pass away. If there's nothing calling the attention, then come back to the breath.

It might be something physical. Some discomfort in the posture, some pain in the knee. So again, just feel those sensations and if it gets too much, change your posture, do it slowly.

So, beginning with the breath and then whatever draws the attention within the field of awareness. Whatever draws that attention is to be observed, to be felt, to be experienced. Beginning with the breath, rising, falling.

Becoming more aware of how we are reacting to what we are experiencing, how when something is pleasant we're drawn towards it, we want to maintain it, we want to develop it. When something is unpleasant, we don't want to feel it, we want to think of something else, we want to push it away, we want to reject it, we want to eliminate it. So this sort of desire, which is always manipulating the world in order to make us feel happy and comfortable—this is the cause of our attachments. The Buddha says this is the direct cause for our sufferings and unsatisfactoriness. Is that true for you?

Becoming more aware of how everything we're experiencing is arising and passing away. Everything appears only to vanish. Nothing ever repeats itself. Every breath is similar but not the same. Can you see anything that you can rely upon?

Becoming more aware of how everything I'm experiencing is an object. The observer is seeing something. The observer sees a thought or an image. The feeler can feel sensations and emotions. The experiencer experiences feelings, emotions and thoughts. You can make this distance more obvious to yourself, for instance if there is discomfort in the knees, you can say, there, there is discomfort, down there. So the observer, the feeler is up in the head and the feeling is down in the knee.

Same with an emotion. You can feel it in the body. It's an object. Even images you can see in front of you. And thoughts you can be aware of. So there's a distinction between the observer and the observed. The feeler and the felt, and the experiencer and what is being experienced. Can the perceiver be the perceived?

Becoming more aware of how everything we're experiencing is arising of its own accord. The body offers us sensations, whether we want it to or not. Pleasant and unpleasant. The heart offers us emotions, pleasant and unpleasant, whether we want it to or not. The mind is forever thinking and imagining whether we want it to or not. In this *Vipassanā* position everything is happening of its own accord. How can they be me?

Putting aside all instruction, have confidence that this intuitive awareness can understand things directly. Remember that childlike way of looking at things. Just observing, feeling, experiencing whatever draws the attention in the field of consciousness. Don't change anything, don't do anything.

When we come to the end of a sitting, it's good to reflect for a moment. How diligent were we at bringing ourselves back to the present moment? If I thought I was diligent, I will congratulate myself. If I thought I could have been more skilful, I will encourage myself. No need for self-criticism.

How did we deal with the various physical and mental states that arose? Were we experiencing a lot of dullness and lethargy? Or perhaps agitation? Or perhaps an obsessive thinking? How did we deal with it? If I thought I was skilful, I will congratulate myself. If I thought I could have been more skilful, I will encourage myself. No need for self-criticism.

Which of those three characteristics of existence was most obvious to us? The process of desiring which causes suffering and unsatisfactoriness. How everything is impermanent. And how everything is an object, not always under our direct control. Not me, not mine.

And it's good to make a resolution. Next time I feel sleepy and tired, I will open my eyes immediately.

And don't jump out of the sitting, open the eyes gently, let the light in. Very good.

Muy bien. Muy bien.

Saddhā: Confidence and Trust

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 8 min

In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores saddhā, one of the five spiritual faculties (pañca indriya), translating it as both confidence and trust rather than faith. He explains how saddhā works in partnership with paññā (wisdom) through three progressive levels: hearing the Dhamma, contemplating its meaning, and realizing it through vipassanā practice.

Bhante discusses the enemies of saddhā - particularly skeptical doubt that arises from fear of failure or attachment to cherished views like scientific materialism. He addresses common doubts practitioners face: doubt in the Buddha and teacher, doubt in the practice when progress doesn't match expectations, and doubt in oneself through comparison with others.

The talk emphasizes that liberation is a categorical imperative - everyone must eventually become awakened, as that which seeks to understand and end suffering is what becomes liberated. Bhante offers practical guidance for developing confidence in the Triple Gem: cultivating devotion to the Buddha through study and imagination, maintaining steady practice with the Dhamma without expecting dramatic progress, and recognizing that fully liberated beings exist today in the Saṅgha.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

So because it's spring and because the next moon day is celebrating the Buddha himself, I thought it would be a nice thing to do the seven factors of enlightenment and the five spiritual faculties. They double over on certain ones, so what we have is *saddhā*, which translates as confidence, and that matches with insight, with wisdom. Then we have effort, which supports concentration or focus. Then we have calmness, which twins with interest. And then finally equanimity, which twins with investigation of the Dhamma or the insight. And holding all that together is, of course, awareness.

So I've mixed these five spiritual faculties with the seven factors of enlightenment there.

Now, what I want to centre on is this whole quality of *saddhā*, which translates—the two words I prefer rather than faith—as confidence and trust. When I use the word confidence, I have confidence in... it seems to centre upon my relationship to what it is

I'm confident in. But when I use the word "I trust," I trust the Dhamma, I trust the teaching, it seems to centre more upon what it is that I'm putting my confidence in. So it's just me with words. So it's confidence and trust, I think, gets close to the idea of this *saddhā*, translating the Pali word.

Now this is twinned with the word *paññā*, and there are three levels of this wisdom. The first one is when we come to hear something—so our initial interest in what we hear. Now that will actually give us some confidence. If it doesn't, then of course we don't take it any further. And the more confidence we have, the more we'll want to read about the Dhamma. And the more you do that, the more of course you find the opportunity to think about it, and it becomes your own bit of intellectual knowledge. And then finally, that leads us into the actual practice, the *vipassanā*, which is the final stage of this process of insight. And it's through *vipassanā* that these things are realised by us—they become our own personal experience.

So that is all supported with this confidence, this trust. And if that begins to fade, then of course you find yourself losing interest.

Now what is the enemy of that? Of course, it's doubt. And this is a skeptical doubt—it's not the doubt that the Buddha wants us to have, which raises up that interest, a sense of wonder. Is the Buddha right about this? This skeptical doubt is what stops you doing things. And it's often because of fear of failure, or it could be because you're fearful of it undermining your treasured opinions.

So for instance, if you are committed to scientific materialism, and it turns out that there is a transcendence, then of course that does undermine your position a bit. And that's always fearful for us because we identify ourselves with our opinions and our views. So sometimes this skeptical doubt will just stop us mid-tracks. It'll just stop us from doing something.

Now, the other doubt that we can have is in the Buddha himself, and of course in the teacher—heaven forbid. But that doesn't mean that we should lose our critical faculties of the teacher. We're not supposed to be enslaved to our teachers.

And often we lose certain confidence in the practice. And I think that comes because we have some idea of progress. And if it doesn't fit our idea of progress, then you think, "Oh well, the teaching doesn't work." And often it turns back into us: "It works for some, but not for me. I'm no good. I'm useless at this."

So there's also a doubt in oneself, and that comes often about by comparison. You see somebody who started with you and they're fully liberated, and you're still hanging around being depressed and anxious. So you tend to think, "Well, I can't do it. Everybody else can, but I can't."

So these types of doubts have to be undermined by recognising the wrong view, the wrong reason as to why doubt has arisen. And of course that doubt will be completely undermined really through the practice. And no matter how little the insight is, that insight is supporting our confidence.

So that final point about the self: the whole teaching of the Buddha leads to the conclusion that everybody must become liberated. It's not possible for anybody not to become liberated, no matter how long it takes, because that which is trying to understand why it is suffering and seeking the end of suffering is what is actually liberated by that process. So we can say that it's a categorical imperative. It's an absolute must that whether you want to or not, like it or not, we will be driven towards full liberation and awakening. So there's a bit of hope there for us all.

So just finally, this confidence—we can develop it. We can develop a confidence in the Buddha, for instance. Now that's if you've got a devotional heart. So you read about the Buddha. You can imagine yourself listening to the Buddha when you're reading the scriptures. Actually now, a lot of the scriptures are on YouTube, just delivered by somebody. There's a couple of websites that do it too. So there are certain ways in which you can develop a relationship with the historical Buddha.

With the developing in the Dhamma, of course, is really just not expecting great progress—just keep at it little by little. And the Sangha—that's our other commitment, should we say—is recognising that there are people who are progressing, there are people who are fully liberated even now. There's somebody in Thailand called Ajahn... dear, come on memory... there is an Ajahn in Thailand—Ganha, that's his name—Ajahn Ganha, who is recognised as fully liberated, and he is a nephew of Ajahn Chah, for those of you who know Ajahn Chah.

So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance and they have not caused even greater confusion, and that by your commitment to the practice, you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Dhp 188-192: The Role of Confidence

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 20 min

In this exploration of Dhammapada verses 188-192, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's teaching on taking refuge and the fundamental role of confidence (saddhā) in spiritual practice. The talk begins with the traditional story of Ajidatta, a former head priest who became an ascetic teaching people to take refuge in mountains, forests, and trees, until his encounter with Mahāmoggallāna and the Buddha transformed his understanding.

Bhante discusses how confidence operates as one of the spiritual faculties (indriya), working in tandem with wisdom (paññā) through experience and practice. He draws parallels between confidence in spiritual practice and confidence in everyday activities, explaining how this quality eventually becomes an unshakable power (bala) for stream-enterers who have directly experienced the possibility of liberation.

The teaching covers the Three Jewels (Buddha, Dhamma, Saṅgha) as true refuges, contrasting them with worldly refuges that cannot provide ultimate security. Bhante explains the historical development of refuge-taking from the Buddha's original invitation "ehi passiko" (come and see) to the formal lay ordination we know today. He emphasizes the importance of daily practices like morning precepts as reminders that cultivate and strengthen confidence in our spiritual path.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa.
Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

So we can continue our little exploration of the Dhammapada. I've chosen a set of verses, 188 to 192, and they're all to do with taking refuge and confidence.

So I shall do my usual thing of intoning them:

*Bahuṃ ve saraṇaṃ yanti, pabbatāni vanāni ca
Ārāma rukkhā cetyāni, manussā bhaya tājjitā
N'etaṃ kho saraṇaṃ khemaṃ, n'etaṃ saraṇaṃ uttamaṃ
N'etaṃ saraṇaṃ āgamaṃ, sabba dukkhā pamuccati
Yo ca Buddhaṃ ca Dhammaṃ ca, Saṅghaṃ ca saraṇaṃ gato
Cattāri ariya saccāni, sammappaññāya passati*

This one's easy because it's very straightforward really. So this is a translation:

"People threatened by fear go to many refuges: to mountains, forests, parks, trees and shrines. None of these are a secure refuge. None is a supreme refuge. Not by going to such refuge is one released from all suffering. Having gone for refuge to the Buddha, Dhamma, Saṅgha, they see with right view the Four Noble Truths: suffering, the arising of suffering, the overcoming of suffering and the Eightfold Noble Path leading to the end of suffering. This is the secure refuge. This is the supreme refuge. By going to such refuge, one is released from all suffering."

So these verses were chanted by the Buddha when he came across a certain character called Ajitadatta. So this is the story that it hangs on.

Ajitadatta was the head priest during the time of King Mahākosala, father of King Pasenadi. King Pasenadi was a great supporter of the Buddha and was the king of Kosala. After the death of King Mahākosala, Ajitadatta gave away all his property in charity and after that he left home and became a non-Buddhist ascetic. He lived with his 10,000 followers in a place near the border of three kingdoms: Anga, Magadha and Kuru, not far from the mound of sand where a powerful *nāga* was staying.

Now a *nāga* is a combination of a divine being or even a human being and a snake or a serpent. It was the *nāgas* that kept the Mahāyāna scriptures hidden until it was time for them to be discovered, or revealed rather. These *nāgas* are worshipped all over Southeast Asia. I'm not so sure now, but in those times it's not just a Buddhist thing. But the famous one for a Buddhist is of course Mucalinda. So Mucalinda was the cobra who came and protected the Buddha from the heavy rains. A deluge came down just after his enlightenment, so I presume it was the start of the rainy season, and Mucalinda rose up and his cobra cover helped the Buddha from getting soaked.

I actually have a very regular copy of that. That is a picture of the *nāga*. He's got a few heads there. I don't quite know why. And the Buddha looks tremendously serene. So he's doing all right. It's a great old statue. I don't know where it came from or who gave it to us. So that's the *nāga* and he lived on this sandpit.

Now, one day the Buddha saw Ajitadatta and his followers in his vision and realized that the time was right for them to attain Arahantship. So the Buddha sent Mahāthera Moggallāna - that's remember his second great disciple, who was Sāriputta and Moggallāna, and Moggallāna is the one known for these special powers. So Moggallāna went to Ajitadatta and then the Buddha said he'd follow afterwards.

So when Moggallāna went to the place of Ajitadatta and his followers, he asked them to give him shelter for one night. They first turned down his request, but finally they agreed to let him stop at the mound of sand, the home of the *nāga*. The *nāga* was very

antagonistic, and there followed a duel between the *nāga* and the *thera*. On both sides, there was a display of power by emitting smoke and flames. However, in the end, the *nāga* was subdued. He coiled himself round the mound of sand, raised his head, spreading it out like an umbrella over the Mahāthera, thus showing respect for him.

Early in the morning, Ajitadatta and the other ascetics came to the mound of sand to find out whether Mahāthera was still alive. They had expected him to be dead. When they found the *nāga* tame and meekly holding his head like an umbrella over Moggallāna, they were very much astounded.

Just then, the Buddha arrived, and Mahāmoggallāna got up from his seat on the mound and paid obeisance to the Buddha. Mahāmoggallāna then proclaimed to the audience of ascetics, "This is my teacher, the Supreme Buddha, and I am but a humble pupil of this great teacher." Hearing him, the ascetics, who had been very much impressed even by the power of the *bhikkhu*, were awed by the greater power of the Buddha.

The Buddha then asked Ajitadatta what he taught his followers and the residents of the neighbourhood. Ajitadatta replied that he had taught them to pay homage to the mountains, forests, parks, gardens and trees, and that by doing so they would be liberated from all ills of life. So I presume he was what we would call a pagan, I suppose. It's funny, in those days they would have presumed that the *devas* were around these particular places.

The Buddha replied to Ajitadatta, "Ajitadatta, people go to the mountains, forests, gardens and parks and trees for refuge when they are threatened with danger, but these things cannot offer them any protection. Only those who've taken refuge in the Buddha, Dhamma, Saṅgha are liberated from the rounds of rebirth."

At the end of the discourse, Ajitadatta and all his followers attained Arahātship. All of them entered the order of the *bhikkhus*. On that day, when the disciples of Ajitadatta from Anga, Magadha and Kuru came to pay respects to him, they saw their teacher and his followers garbed as *bhikkhus* and they were puzzled and wondered, "Who is the more powerful? Our teacher or the Samaṇa Gotama? Our teacher must be more powerful because Samaṇa Gotama came to our teacher."

The Buddha knew what they were thinking. Ajitadatta also felt that he must set their minds at rest. So he paid obeisance to the Buddha in the presence of his disciples and said, "Venerable sir, you are my teacher, I am but a disciple of yours." Thus the audience came to realize the supremacy of the Buddha.

So there we have a nice little story to support our verses. I always find it rather amusing that the *nāga* and Moggallāna were spitting fire and fumes of smoke on this mound which can't have been that far away from Ajitadatta. How they slept through the commotion is itself a magical effort.

So anyway, what I really want to dwell on a little bit is the crucial role of confidence. Just if you sometimes reflect back on your life and remember the first time that you started your job, your first work, of course you were confident, but you weren't entirely confident. It was only after being there for a while, knowing what the work actually involved, that the confidence grew. So here, through the experience, and of course, the knowledge that came as you're doing it. So here you have this combination of confidence and experience.

If you think about a relationship, how long did it take? I mean, the confidence was there at the beginning, an intimate relationship, but then how long did it take for there to be enough confidence to establish an intimate relationship, to establish either a partnership or a marriage? So that again is to do with experience, is to do with going through what you had intended to do. But without that confidence, you would never have started.

If you take a very simple example, like jumping off the high board, I do remember starting off on the springboard and then moving up to the first level of the high board. And then finally I got to the top and it was a jump. I never quite got around to diving head first into the water. So I lacked confidence there. So you can see confidence is at the basis, at the root of anything we do. In fact, you wouldn't lift your cup of tea to your mouth if you didn't have confidence that it would actually arrive there.

And it's one of what we call the faculties, spiritual faculties, which runs normally in tandem with *paññā*, with insight and wisdom. So this combination of confidence, practice, and experience, the one supports the other. And at some point, if a person has a deep enough insight to enter the first path and fruit, this quality becomes a *bala*, a power. You could say it's unshakable because now they realize by their own direct experience that in fact, there is an end to suffering. Even if it's only dimly seen, they have that absolute confidence.

Now here's a little something that came to mind when I was thinking about this. In Islam, if you are asked to deny your religion and your life is in danger, you can do so. So when the Inquisition in Spain demanded that they all become baptised, they were able to do so. Outwardly, they were Christians, but inwardly, of course, they remained Muslims. If you contrast that with Christianity, which begins, of course, with the story

of Peter, who denies Christ and really feels - and of course, Judas, who then hangs himself. But Jesus - Peter must have felt terribly embarrassed having denied his teacher. And so what we get in Christianity is much more an acceptance of martyrdom.

And even when the Inquisition moved to southern France and started chasing the Cathars, the Illuminati and in fact I think just ordinary Cathars, they actually threw themselves onto the bonfires. I went to one place - I couldn't find the name of it - but what happened was there were about 150 of Cathars who may have all been Illuminati, I don't know, but they actually threw themselves onto the bonfire. So a very different attitude, and of course you wouldn't do that if you didn't have absolute confidence that you were righteous and that you would be reborn in heaven and that you wouldn't be just jumping out of one fire into the fires of hell. Just a nice little aside there.

So of course what do we mean when we say we take the refuges? Well in terms of the Buddha, of course, it's just a confidence in him as our teacher. But it's also his practice. We know what he went through to become liberated. And that, of course, gives us a confidence. It's not as though he just appeared and said, "Do this and do that." He actually went through it himself. So his teaching comes directly out of his own experience.

If you find yourself to be a devotional type, then the whole idea of reading about his life and his story and contemplating that - and of course, the idea is that you say to yourself, "May I be like the Buddha." So there's a connection there of wanting to imitate the Buddha. But I think we also have to take the refuge within ourselves. There's a Buddha within us. We just haven't realized it yet. And it's actually putting confidence that is in us, that which is seeking its own liberation from suffering. So I think that's an important aside, which is normally not included in the refuges and precepts. But I just think acknowledging that is important.

The Dharma, of course, is the teaching and the practice itself. And it's normally put as three types of knowledges. The first one is that when you hear the teaching, you may be inspired by it. And then you have to make it your own teaching. And that's when you mull over it, where you ponder the teachings. And that leads you to a certain practice. And what you learn actually becomes your own real experience. And that's *vipassanā*. So there are these three levels that are pointed at when it comes to our understanding of Buddhism. It starts with just that reading, hearing, and then finally moves to our own direct experience. None of that could happen were it not that the confidence is slowly building up over time.

Now these refuges that we take, they weren't actually part of the original refuges that the monastics took. When he first started, the first people who approached him and said, "Look, I'd like to follow your teachings. Could you be my teacher?" His response was just, "*Ehi passiko*," which just means come and try, have a go, see what happens.

Later on when he had established some of his disciples as Arahats, that's when this taking refuge in him and in the teachings and in the Saṅgha came in for anybody who wanted to become a monastic. However, in time - well they say about after 20 years - people who joined the order weren't of a high calibre and they started doing naughty things and so rules had to be made, all sorts of rules that go from obviously moral law such as thieving and murder and all that sort of stuff, but go down to very minute behaviour. So that for instance when I'm eating I'm not supposed to make chapa chapa sounds or suru suru sounds. I'm not supposed to be making sounds as I chew or slurping my drink. So even that sort of very basic etiquette is part of the rule.

So now what happened was as lay people came to want to be his disciples, that second tier of commitment - Buddha, Dhamma, Saṅgha - became the lay ordination. That's how it moved. That's how it's become the lay ordination. And there's all sorts of levels of commitment. When I became a monk and came back to the West, I began daily shaving my head. In the East I would do it every two weeks - that's a normal time just before you go in for the *uposatha*, the *pāṭimokkha* where the vinaya is read out. But here when I returned to the West I determined to shave my head every day just to remind myself that I am actually a monk. It was my morning ritual. Nothing catastrophic happens if I miss shaving my head, but it's just there as a little practice in the morning.

And that's why taking refuge and precepts is something that we try to make fairly habitual every morning. It doesn't take long, but it's just a moment where you remind yourself of your practice, of what your life is ultimately about. And it's just those little reminders every day that just keep pumping the energy into your practice.

So that's it really. The question is, as a sort of contemplation: what is the role of confidence in my life and how can I make it grow? How do I increase this confidence? Various ways in which I can do it.

So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused even greater confusion, and that by your devotion to the practice you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Dhp 153-154: The Buddha's Victory Verses

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 17 min

In this profound exploration, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines verses 153-154 of the Dhammapada—the Buddha's celebrated Victory Verses spoken after his Awakening. These verses describe the end of saṃsāra through discovering the 'house builder' of rebirth and breaking free from conditioned existence.

The talk then delves into the remarkable Kaimaka Sutta from the Saṃyutta Nikāya, which illustrates the crucial distinction between intellectual understanding of anattā (not-self) and the deep-rooted sense of self that persists even after stream-entry (sotāpanna). Through the dialogue between the ailing Venerable Kaimaka and senior bhikkhus, we learn how the conceit 'I am' lingers as an underlying tendency even when one no longer views the five khandhas as self.

Using vivid similes of flower scent and cloth washing, the sutta reveals how continued vipassanā meditation on the arising and passing of the aggregates gradually eradicates this final delusion. Bhante emphasizes the practical importance of observing impermanence in both formal meditation and daily life, showing how this leads to complete liberation from dukkha.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa.
Homage to the Buddha, the blessed noble and fully self-awakened one.

I've chosen the victory verses of the Buddha to end my little five efforts at the Dhammapada. So I shall chant it. This is the one I know, by the way, because we do it every morning.

Anekajātiṃ saṃsāraṃ sandhāviṃ anibbisaṃ gahakāraṃ gavesanto dukkhā jāti punappunaṃ. Gahakāraka diṭṭho'si puna gehaṃ na kāhasi sabba te phāsukā bhaggā gahakuṭaṃ visaṅkhitaṃ visaṅkhāragataṃ cittaṃ taṇhānaṃ khayamajjhagā.

So the translation: Through many rounds of rebirth have I wandered, looking for the house builder, but not finding him. Painful is repeated rebirth. O house builder, you are seen. You will not build this house again. All your rafters are broken. The ridge pole is destroyed. My *citta* is not conditioned and I have attained the end of all cravings.

Just to go through the Pali there. The word for wander also means to run, so a word like coursing through rebirth after rebirth. I think it gives the idea of that onward going *saṃsāra*. There's a lovely little word, *aneka*, which translates as not one, therefore it means many. It's just a nice way of saying it: not one.

Now, of course, these are called the victory verses of the Buddha, which there's some idea that he spoke them after his awakening. But I dare say he manufactured them. He created them sometime afterwards to express what his kernel insight was. And we shall come to that.

So now the house builder, you have seen, you have been discovered, you have been uncovered. You'll not build a house for me again. Your rafters are broken. Now the word for rafter is also the word for rib, so that makes sense. The ridge pole, the top of the roof is destroyed, and that's basically what the Pali says: the top of the roof.

Now, the *citta* is translated usually as mind, but obviously it can't be part of the *khandhas*, part of the aggregates, because it's not conditioned. The aggregates, which are of course your physicality, your feelings, all your perceptions, concepts, all your habits and momentary consciousnesses that manifest these things, are all conditioned. Now the word here is *visaṅkhāra*, so *vi* is another way of saying not, and the word there is *saṅkhāra*, so it's not conditioned.

And then the last verse is *taṇhā*, is again this destruction of this wrong desire based on the delusion of the house builder, which of course manifests as greed, aversion, and fear as a basic relationship to the world we live in.

So that's the verses. Now, normally speaking, this would evoke then the life of the Buddha, how he became fully liberated, etc. But I think most of you know that. And there's this quite amazing little discourse from the *Samyuttanikāya*, the grouped sayings. They're the small discourses, and it's called "With Khemaka."

So it's about this senior monk. So I'm going to read it, take some time over it, because it's quite delightful.

At one time several senior mendicants or monks were staying near Kosambī at Gosita's monastery. Now at that time the Venerable Khemaka was staying at the Jujube Tree monastery and he was sick, suffering, gravely ill. In the late afternoon these senior mendicants came out of retreat and addressed the Venerable Dāsaka: "Please, Venerable Dāsaka, go to the mendicant Khemaka and say to him: 'Reverend Khemaka, the seniors hope you are keeping well. They hope you are all right. They hope your pain is fading, not growing. That it's fading is evident, not it's growing.'"

So Dāsaka wanders off, and I presume it's quite a way because he's living in another monastery. It would have been close by, but at least he's got to go over and find him. And when, of course, he gets to Khemaka and relates this to him, Khemaka says, "No," he said, "I'm not all right. My pain is terrible and growing, not fading. And its growing is evident and it's not fading."

So Dāsaka then goes all the way back to the seniors, and the seniors say, "Ask him, say: 'Reverend Khemaka, the seniors say that these five grasping aggregates'" — so actually five *khandha* — "'have been taught by the Buddha. That is, the grasping aggregate of form, feeling, perception'" — it's got, and here's a translation from Sutta Central, which is Sujato's website where he's translated all the discourses — he's translated *saṅkhāra* here as choices. Not habits, not volitional condition, but choices. I thought was rather nice — "and consciousness. Do you regard any of these five aggregates as self or as belonging to self?"

Anyway, off Dāsaka goes, and he asks Khemaka this, and he says, "No, concerned, I do not regard anything among the five grasping aggregates as self or as belonging to self." So Venerable Dāsaka goes back and he tells the seniors, and then the seniors say, "That is," you know, because he does not see them as self or belonging to self. "If, as it seems, Venerable Khemaka does not regard anything among these five grasping aggregates as belonging to self or self, then he is a perfected one with defilements ended." In other words, he's an *arahant*.

So off he goes, Dāsaka, to see his poor Khemaka who's suffering — I mean, he's in pain — and he says, "No, I do not regard anything among these five aggregates belonging to self, yet I am not a perfected one with defilements ended. For when it comes to the five grasping aggregates, I'm not rid of the conceit of 'I am,' but I don't regard anything as 'I am this.'"

So off he goes, Dāsaka goes back to the seniors on the other side of the fence, and the seniors send him off again. So the seniors say, the message this time to Khemaka is, "When you say 'I am,' what is it that you're talking about? Is it the form or apart from form? Is it feeling, perception? What is it you're talking about?"

So Venerable Khemaka now gets fed up with this and he says, "What's the point of running back and forth? Bring me my staff and I'll go and see these senior mendicants myself."

So off he goes. And when he arrives, of course, the usual exchanging of greetings. And then he sat down to one side. So they say to him, "When you say 'I am,' what is it you're talking about?"

"Venerables, I don't say 'I am' with reference to form or apart from form, and that's the same for feeling, perception, choices, *saṅkhāra*, consciousness. But when it comes to the five aggregates, I'm not rid of the conceit 'I am,' but I don't regard anything as 'I am this.'"

Then he gives this simile. "It's like the scent of a blue water lily or a pink one or a white lotus. Would it be right to say the scent belongs to the petals or the stalk or the pistil?" "No, Reverend." "Then reverends, how should it be said?" "It would be right to say the scent belongs to the flower."

"In the same way, reverends, I don't say with reference to form or apart from form, I don't say 'I am.' The same with feeling, perception, conditional volitionings or choices, and consciousness. For when it comes to the five grasping aggregates, I am not rid of the conceit 'I am,' but I don't regard anything as 'I am this.'"

"Although a noble disciple has given up the five lower fetters, they still have a lingering residue of the conceit 'I am,' the desire 'I am,' and the underlying tendency 'I am,' which has not been eradicated."

Now, the five lower fetters go with *sotāpanna*, the stream entrant. Something's broken, but not this sense of self.

"After some time they meditate, observing the rise and fall of the five grasping aggregates: such is form, such is the origin of form, such is the end of form, and the same with feeling, perception, choices, and consciousness. And as they do so, the lingering residue is eradicated."

And then he gives another simile. "Suppose there was a cloth that was dirty and soiled, so the owners gave it to a launderer. The launderer kneads it thoroughly with salt, lye, and cow dung, and rinses it in clear water. Although that cloth is clean and bright, it still has a lingering scent of salt, lye, and cow dung that has not been eradicated. The launderer returns it to the owners, who store it in a chest permeated with scent, and the lingering scent would be eradicated."

"In the same way, although a noble disciple has given up the five lower fetters, they still have a lingering residue of the conceit 'I am,' the desire 'I am,' and the underlying tendency 'I am,' which has not been eradicated. And after some time," etc. "The lingering residue is eradicated."

Now, when he said this, the senior mendicants said to Venerable Khemaka, "We didn't want to trouble you with our questions, but you're capable of explaining, teaching, advocating, establishing, disclosing, analyzing, and clarifying the Buddha's instructions in detail. And that's just what you've done."

That's what Venerable Khemaka said. Satisfied, the senior *bhikkhus* were happy with what Venerable Khemaka said. And while this discourse was being spoken, the minds of sixty senior *bhikkhus* and of the Venerable Khemaka were freed from defilements by non-grasping. So they all became fully liberated.

The distinction here is between a view of self and a sense of self. One incident that comes to mind is concerning smoking. You know, there was a time when smoking was not thought to be particularly harmful. And then during the fifties, especially as I remember, fifties and sixties, it slowly became apparent that in fact it caused things like cancer, lung cancer. And of course, there was the usual effort by the tobacco companies and any company to protect itself with false science and fake news. But when it finally came through, the science did come through, then people became convinced that smoking actually caused cancer and death.

Now, even though the view of the smoker was changed from being non-harmful to being harmful, did they stop smoking? No.

So here, even though the view of a self — seeing this psychophysical organism as me — is broken with the stream entrance, still there lingers on this idea of me, and it's an underlying tendency. So it's very deeply ingrained. And that me, remember, is the way that this awareness, this *satipaṇṇā*, this intuitive awareness, the Buddha within, experiences itself within the five *khandhas*. That's the sense of self you get when you become the observer, the feeler, the knower.

And of course, you can't get rid of that by an act of will. But what Khemaka is saying, and what he's saying that the Buddha said was, you just keep investigating the impermanence of the five *khandhas* of this organism, and at some point, you'll break through that final delusion and become fully liberated.

So the task in hand is very clear. We have to keep meditating, and not only in meditation, but in ordinary daily life, to keep on realizing that everything is arising and passing away. It has no substance and therefore it's not worth clinging to.

So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused greater confusion, and that you will, by your practice, liberate yourself, as Khemaka did, from all suffering.

Dhp 4: Hatred is Not Overcome with Hatred!

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 18 min

In this inaugural Full Moon teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma introduces a profound trilogy from Buddhist commentary: the virtuous circle of gratitude, generosity, and renunciation. He clarifies that renunciation is not self-mortification or rejecting life's pleasures, but rather letting go of our dependency and attachment to them—our craving for experiences to create particular mental states.

The teaching explores how genuine gratitude for what we've received from parents, teachers, society, and nature naturally leads to wanting to repay these gifts. Since such gifts are unrepayable, this gratitude transforms into generosity toward others. Bhante emphasizes pure generosity—giving without expectation of thanks, acknowledgment, or repayment, and giving just enough to create a small 'pinch' that challenges our attachment.

This practice of generous giving becomes renunciation itself—a letting go of our grip on things that gradually loosens the tight desires causing suffering. Each act of pure generosity touches liberation (nibbāna) by cultivating the desireless state characteristic of awakening. This is presented as an accessible daily practice for transforming habits that cause suffering into those that bring natural happiness and draw us toward ultimate liberation.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed and noble self-awakened one.

So I just say this is our inaugural Full Moon Day meeting. I've always wanted to do this, but I've never found a way to do it. So I was really happy when Magda suggested that I try it on this medium. So I think we can keep this going. Luckily it's fallen on a Sunday and I'm inclined to in the future choose the closest Sunday to the full moon because that's most convenient for people. In Sri Lanka they are public holidays, all the moons are public holidays so there's no problem in keeping the full moon itself there.

So my idea is that with every full moon we look at some of the teachings of the Buddha and eventually throughout the year we cover it all. So I'm going to start with this lovely little trilogy, a virtuous circle of gratitude, generosity and renunciation.

So starting with renunciation. The big problem here that can arise is confusing what it is that we're actually renouncing. So remember the body is not our fault. When the body has appetite then it has appetite, and when you put something lovely sweet on the tongue it will taste lovely and sweet. That's never the problem. The problem is our relationship to it, which is wanting more, depending on it in order to establish a beautiful mental state.

Now that's what we've really got to grasp. We use the sense bases not because they are just lovely in themselves but because they are a way of creating a lovely mental state. Hence you might have a piece of toast in the evening just to raise your spirits. Now the unfortunate thing of that of course is that you have dependency, and that dependency is what we call attachment. And so there's a suffering there. See, if there's no bread and there's no toast, well it's misery isn't it? So when we click onto that, we become much more sensitive to this draw towards what is pleasurable. And this renunciation therefore is not to be confused with what they use is self-mortification, in other words blaming the body for our mental states.

So that's an important distinction to make. We're not trying to get rid of the pleasures and joys of life at all. And the Buddha himself did enjoy life. He enjoyed taste, but he didn't greed for it. That's what it says in the scriptures.

This whole idea of renunciation will arise on two different types of grasping, which is one about our wealth and the other about our time. So we can be greedy with our time but not greedy with our wealth. So we can be generous with our wealth but if somebody asks us to do something for them we shy off it. And the other way around, we can be very happy giving time but if somebody asks us for a bit of money we're not inclined to give. So again, we have to look at that.

And this trilogy, this little virtuous circle of gratitude, generosity and renunciation, is not actually taught in the scriptures themselves as a way to liberation. This is more a commentary pointed out. And this, of course, directly with our daily life. This is our daily life, in our daily work, in the way we are with people. So if we can generate that virtuous circle, it's actually drawing us towards liberation.

So letting go of attachment, letting go of dependency is the path to liberation. So you might say that the whole of the path is one of renunciation. Because eventually you've got to renounce the sense of self. That's the last thing to go, this little idea that somewhere within us, we actually do believe ourselves to be this psychophysical organism.

Now, just to go to the front of the trilogy, this sense of gratitude. Now as you know, when you feel gratitude, it really is a heartwarming feeling. And when we feel this gratitude, we always want to repay it. Now, if we spend some time just considering what we've received from our parents, our parents gave us our life, our mothers. When you think about that, you might have problems with your mother and your father. In fact, somebody once asked, "How do you know when you're fully liberated?" And they said, "Well, go and spend a week with your mother. And then you'll know."

So it may be that our general relationship is a bit fractious and so on and so forth, but you still have your life through your parents. And the Buddha said that even if you were to carry them on your shoulders the whole of your life you'd never repay them. In fact, it's unrepayable. And that's what you begin to realize I think when you contemplate everything that's been given to you, from your family, from your friends, the good deeds and the companionship of family and friends. All this is given to you.

And then there are things like what society gives us, all our education. Our parents could not have afforded, most of our parents could not have afforded to educate us. And it's the same with the social services. We might not have needed them up until now, but if we get old enough, you definitely begin to need them. And of course, there's our health system. It's funny how you take something as a right and you presume it's something that isn't given because either you've paid for it through the national insurance or because it's taken for granted. But how many times have you thanked your doctors? Thank the dentist?

Now the dentist I had here in Bishop's Castle was really good. The front tooth here finally gave in and he put this false tooth in. And it was pretty awful. You've got to get used to it. You couldn't eat nuts. All the nuts got behind the tooth, behind the palate, so you had to take it out and wash your mouth out and stick it back in. And when I told him that it was a little inconvenient he finally decided to give me a bridge. And there it is, it's absolutely fantastic. And it's a case of recognizing all these gifts that people have given us.

If you bring to mind for instance the teachers, one or two favourite teachers that you've had, it does fill the heart with a sense of gratitude. And finally of course there's nature, just the earth that we live on, which we become more and more aware of these days. Now what gratitude does is it makes you want to repay.

And because you can't repay what has been given, you can't repay something that has been given to you freely, you have to find a substitute. And that draws you towards just being generous ourselves. And that moves us into this whole area of generosity.

Now, when the Buddha talked to lay people, he always began with generosity. He pointed out that even a thief can be generous. He's just taken something off you and he's very kindly given it to somebody in his family or friends. So when we think about generosity, the ability to give without some idea of being repaid, and that's quite difficult for us. So we have to clarify the mind about that.

Now, there are certain times you give gifts such as Christmas, which is more like a little ritual re-establishing friendship. So you get your pair of socks and they get their pair of socks, and that's fine unless of course the pair that they've given you is obviously much cheaper than what you spent on the socks that you gave them. So that's when the trouble starts. So there's always a bit of bargaining going on, it's always like a business.

So if we want to have an act of pure generosity then you have to listen to what's going on in the background of our minds about being repaid, about being adored because of our generosity. So if you're going to give for instance a donation to a charity, and there are so many of them these days, you have to get yourself into that mental state where that's the only thing in your mind and heart and you are giving this in order to help somebody. And there's no hope of repayment. The charity is not going to give you any money back. So you're doing it for just that purpose. And when you do it for that purpose, that's when you make the donation, whether it's by card or by cash.

And then of course once you've done it you'll hear these little voices. Like "You are truly a very wonderful person" or you might get the one of "That's too much! What do you give so much for? You could have..." So you have to be now you haven't been caught up in that. You see, so you've not been caught up in *Māra*. *Māra* did not catch you there. So you can let those thoughts disappear. And if guilt comes you have to point to it and say, "Well that is false guilt because when I actually made the action, my heart was full of generosity."

And the same arises when you do something for somebody. So I think most people, I certainly do, is say yes too quickly. So if somebody says, "I've moved into this new house," it's actually happened to me, "I've moved into this new flat and we're painting it. Would you like to come and give us a hand?" And I said, "Yeah, yeah, I'll come on Saturday." And then as I'm walking away, I'm thinking, "What? What have I given this Saturday away?"

And in that case, at that time, I was, shall we say, advanced enough to actually make myself do it, to teach myself not to say yes just because somebody asked something. You don't have to say yes. And there's a point where you can actually reflect for a moment and then say yes. So it's coming from a point of reflection. You're not just doing it by habit.

So again, that point of generosity, there has to be a certain reflection about it and that you are doing it from the heart of goodwill and that you're not even expecting a thank you. And that's very difficult. When I became a monastic, we're not supposed to say thank you. I mean, I say it in the West because people get very upset. But in the East, you're not supposed to, you don't say thank you. You see, it undermines the person's gift. That's the understanding. Because if somebody gives something to you, they don't expect you to say thank you. But if they expect you to say thank you, and then you don't say thank you, then of course, they feel very upset. And that tells you that the gift is slightly corrupted. They wanted praise, they wanted appreciation.

So to be able to give something without that desire to be acknowledged is leading us towards a real pure heart generosity. And the other little telltale is just to give that little bit more that pinches, that little pinch is where you're truly being generous, where you're giving just that bit of extra time, just that little bit of extra money. And that's the point where it just begins to hurt a little bit. That's the point where you are truly extending our generosity.

So just to recap, we have this lovely virtuous circle. And one exercise you can give yourself is just to say that tomorrow everything I will say thank you to, everything. I'll say thank you to the door that opens. In Zen of course you always gassho when you enter a room. You're taught to thank everything. You have to gassho when you approach the table, you gassho to the chair. So this whole attitude of actually not presuming on anything, not thinking that we have a right to everything, but that everything is a gift. And if you go through the whole day like that you'd be surprised how it lifts you. It really does lift you.

And then once you've established more and more this sense of gratitude and the knowledge that you can't repay directly what people have given to you, you have to find a way of expressing that gratitude through generosity. And when we are being generous, just to stop for a moment and to make sure that you're doing it for pure reasons. That's all.

And then to realize that when I've actually made an act of generosity with a pure heart, I've renounced something. I've let go of something I'm holding on to. And I'm actually practising renunciation. Letting go of that grip on things. And that loosening of a

grip, that letting go of these tight desires, wrong desires, is a little every time we do that and we feel that loss of grippiness. That in a sense is a touch of *Nibbāna* because one of the descriptions of *Nibbāna* is that it is desireless of these sorts of wrong desires.

So there's a lovely little practice there which is just ongoing day in and day out. And it's only a matter of reminding ourselves to do it and just very slowly it becomes a habitude. That's all. And really that's what we're doing in our practice, we are just changing our habits, moving away from habits which cause ourselves suffering and aren't very pleasant for others and moving towards habits which bring us happiness.

So there is the gift of the practice is a natural happiness in life. It's not *Nibbāna*, it's just a natural happiness. And this happiness that we talk about is the internal environment within ourselves.

So this is a really powerful practice. And I try and remember to do it myself occasionally. So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused even greater confusion, and that you will, by your practice, become liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Dhammapada 21-23: The Path of Diligence (Appamāda)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 18 min

In this teaching on Dhammapada verses 21-23, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the crucial quality of appamāda—diligence, heedfulness, or vigilance—which the Buddha identified as the path to the deathless (amata), a term often used for Nibbāna. Drawing from the traditional commentary story of Queen Samāvatī and the vengeful Magandiyā, Bhante examines how these verses emphasize the fundamental importance of sustained spiritual effort.

The talk breaks down appamāda into three essential components: mindfulness and attentiveness, careful and conscientious action, and sustained effort with perseverance. Bhante explains how the vigilant 'do not die' spiritually, while the negligent remain bound by the yoga (fetters) of existence. He offers practical daily reflections for cultivating diligence: examining our mindfulness throughout the day, assessing whether we've acted with care and put our heart into our activities, and evaluating our effort in completing tasks.

Significantly, Bhante reminds us that appamāda were among the Buddha's final words: 'All compounded things are impermanent. Strive diligently (appamādena) for your liberation.' This teaching provides both philosophical understanding and practical guidance for developing the sustained spiritual effort essential for progress on the path to Awakening.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa (three times)

I'm looking at the chapter now on diligence, and it's the first three verses. I shall do my usual little bit of chanting.

*Appamādo amatapadaṃ, pamādo maccuno padaṃ
Appamattā na mīyanti, ye pamattā yathā matā*

*Etaṃ visesato ñatvā, appamāde panditā
Appamāde pamodanti, ariyānaṃ gocare ratā*

*Te jhāyino sātaccakārī, niccaṃ dalhaparakkamā
Phusanti dhīrā nibbānaṃ, yogakkhemaṃ anuttaraṃ*

Translation: "Vigilance is the path to the deathless, negligence the path to death. The vigilant do not die, the negligent are as if already dead. Knowing this distinction, vigilant sages rejoice in vigilance, delighting in the company of the noble ones. Absorbed in

meditation, persevering always, steadfast, the wise touch Nibbāna." A better translation would be "attain Nibbāna, the ultimate rest from bondage, the ultimate escape from bondage."

Now, the story is a bit strange and it was very long, so I've narrowed it down to specifics. The King Udena of Kosambī had a few consorts, I dare say, but one of them was Sāmāvatī. Now, Sāmāvatī had maids, and a Khujjuttarā used to fetch flowers from the forest for her every day. And one day when she got there, the Buddha was giving a sermon. On hearing it, she became a stream-entrant because of her past very good *kamma*.

When she went back, she told Sāmāvatī about this and related the whole talk to her and the other maids. They all took on a devotion to the Buddha, so much so that they put holes in the walls of their apartment, of their palace, so that when the Buddha came on alms round, they could bow to him. The reason they put holes in the wall was because they didn't want to tell the king, because they thought he might be a bit upset.

Now his other consort was a very beautiful woman called Māgandiyā. Her father, the brahmin, had actually offered her as a wife to the Buddha, and the Buddha of course said that he was way beyond all sensual, romantic pleasure—none of that. But then he went on to say, why would he be attracted to a body full of filth? And then he gave a discourse on impermanence. The brahmin and his wife became *anāgāmis*, which means non-returners, but her daughter was offended and she vowed revenge.

So the first thing she did, when she heard that the other wife, Sāmāvatī, had been bowing to the Buddha and looking at him through these holes in the wall, she told the king, Udena, thinking that he would be extremely angry. But when they explained to him what they were doing, he was quite all right with it. So now she began to gaslight, putting little ideas that, in fact, Sāmāvatī was out to kill him or do him great harm.

One time when the king determined to see his wife, taking a lute along—a vina—this Māgandiyā hid a snake in it and put flowers in the hole. When the king got to the queen and her maids, the flowers were taken out, the snake jumped out at him, and he realised then that in fact they had meant to kill him. So he lined them up in a row and took out his bow and arrow and began to shoot them. But the arrow kept missing the target, even though he was an excellent archer, which meant that they were innocent. So he gave up, he let them off.

That wasn't the end of it. Māgandiyā now was really in a very bad mood and she asked her uncle with some relatives to come and burn the palace down. That's what they did—they burned the palace down. When the king heard this he rushed over, and I shall read the last paragraph:

"As soon as he heard the news that all had been burnt, the king rushed to the scene, but it was too late. He suspected that it was done at the instigation of Māgandiyā, but did not show that he was suspicious. Instead, he said, 'While Sāmāvatī was alive, I had been fearful and alert, thinking I might be harmed by her. Only now is my mind at peace. Who would have done this? It must only have been someone who loves me very dearly.'

Hearing this, the foolish Māgandiyā promptly admitted that it was she who had instructed her uncle to do this terrible deed. Thereupon the king pretended to be very pleased with her and said that he would grant her a great favour and honour all her relatives. So the relatives were sent for and they came gladly. On arrival at the palace, however, all of them, including Māgandiyā, were seized and put to death in the palace courtyard. Thus, the evil Māgandiyā was punished for plotting the death of the holy queen and her attendants."

When the Buddha heard of these incidents—he says incidents here, these little things—he then spoke these verses concerning diligence. But frankly, I don't quite know how that fits into the story of diligence, but we shall let that be.

Just a little bit of vocabulary here from the Pali. The word *amata*, the deathless, is often a way that the Buddha talks about Nibbāna. It's a state of deathlessness. *Pada* means footsteps, so the path to the deathless. The quality of diligence is really important. The commentary doesn't say much more. It just says negligence, on the other hand, is the way to repeated cycle of birth and death. Remember that rebirth is presumed in all the Buddhist scriptures—*saṃsāra*, the onward going. That's what happens to people who aren't diligent.

In the second verse, knowing this distinction, vigilant sages rejoice in vigilance, delighting in the field, sphere, dimension of the noble ones. Just an interesting word there: *gocara* is where the cows go. *Go* is cow and *cara* means to go, so it's basically a pasture. You might say it's their club. The wise ones have distinctly understood the importance of vigilance, and we'll come to that a little later. They rejoice in it—they're happy when they're in that state of vigilance. It's the same for us, I hope.

The third one is absorbed in meditation, persevering always, steadfast, the wise obtain Nibbāna, the ultimate rest from bondage. Here the translation has been put as toil, but *yoga* is a bond. A bond or a yoke—it might in the Dhammapada be referring to the ten fetters. I won't go into them so much, but the ten fetters are what you have to get rid of to become fully liberated. But *yoga* became a technical term later on for the three qualities: acquisitiveness, always trying to hold on and get hold of things and people; wrong view that this would bring happiness; and delusion, which is always basically to

do with the sense of self. So long as we believe in some smallest way that we are this psychophysical organism, we'll be seeking happiness through this form, and it will always be disappointing in the end because we die.

In the commentary, the one little line is one has to persevere constantly and with right effort. I had on my tips—if you go into resources and then tips, you'll find one on *appamāda*. There's a verse there that I quoted which says the Buddha says, "I do not see even a single thing that so causes latent unwholesome qualities to arise and arisen wholesome qualities to decline than negligence. For one who is heedless or negligent, latent unwholesome qualities arise and arisen wholesome qualities decline." Of course, there's the opposite when one is actually diligent.

I looked up in the thesaurus the synonyms for this diligence, and I came up with a whole load of words which then happily could be divided into three qualities. First of all, there was mindfulness: attentiveness, vigilance, being heedful. Then there was a sense of care: careful, conscientious, meticulous, thorough, painstaking. Then there was the quality of effort: hard-working, industrious, assiduous, zealous, dogged, perseverance.

So these three qualities are included in the word diligence: mindfulness, right attention; care, so where you put your mind you always put your heart into what you're doing—there has to be a sense of care, even just doing something carefully; and of course that effort, the right effort to complete what one is doing as best one can.

I've suggested that there were some reflections that one can make. At the end of the day one can ask, "How mindful have I been all day?" You don't want to ask it if you're going to be very disappointed. Well no, if you ask it and you're very disappointed, then of course we should encourage ourselves. That's where you make the determination in the evening: "Tomorrow I shall try to be more attentive."

The next one would be, "Have I been careful with everything I've done? Have I been gentle? Have I put my heart into what I'm doing? Have I done it for good reasons?" And then finally, "Did I put the right effort in? Did I actually complete the task, whatever I was doing?"

Of course, this *appamāda* is expressed not only in our doing but in the way we speak and the way we think. Remember, everything starts with something in the head and then manifests through our speech and action.

Just as a little aside, it is one of the seven heavenly virtues as opposed to the seven deadly sins. The first one is chastity: purity, abstinence, and the opposite, of course, is lust and all that. The next one is temperance, and it's put as humanity, equanimity, and

the opposite is gluttony. The next one is charity: goodwill, benevolence, generosity, sacrifice, and the opposite is greed. The next one is diligence. Now the Latin word for diligence is *industria*, hence industry, persistence, effortfulness, and ethics, and the opposite is sloth.

Ah, you see, so we'll come to that in a minute. Patience, which is forgiveness and mercy, and the opposite is anger. Kindness, which is satisfaction and compassion—actually the Latin word is *humanitas*, so I don't quite know how that fits—the opposite is envy. And finally, humility: bravery, modesty, reverence, and the opposite is pride.

When I looked up the synonyms for diligence, they also give you the antonyms. That's also something we can remind ourselves: lazy, sluggish, slothful, can't be bothered, do it tomorrow, slapdash. So we've got lots of ways there to consider our actions during the day, even after every action.

This quality of heedfulness—that's Bhikkhu Bodhi's preferred word, heedfulness, but others translate it as diligence—remember that it's his last words. All things, all compounded things are impermanent. *Appamādena sampādehātī*—strive diligently for your liberation. So that was his second to last word before he completed his journey. So that's something to consider.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused even greater confusion, and that by your diligence you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Dhammapada Chapter 3 - Verses 33 & 34: The Unruly Mind

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 17 min

In this exploration of Dhammapada Chapter 3, verses 33-34, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's teaching on the naturally unsteady and difficult-to-control mind. Using the story of Thera Meghiya, who struggled with wandering thoughts during meditation, these verses illustrate how the wise train the mind like a fletcher straightens an arrow, and how the mind quivers like a fish out of water when withdrawn from sensual pleasures.

The talk provides detailed commentary on the Buddha's practical instructions from the Vitakkasaṇṭhāna Sutta (MN 20) for dealing with unwholesome thoughts: focusing on opposite wholesome objects, examining the drawbacks of negative thinking, ignoring and forgetting distracting thoughts, investigating the causes of mental formations (saṅkhāra), and using strong concentration practices like loving-kindness meditation to overwhelm unwholesome states.

Bhante Bodhidhamma explains how these ancient techniques remain relevant for modern meditators struggling with mental restlessness, offering both immediate practical solutions and deeper insight into the workings of consciousness. The teaching emphasizes the importance of persistent effort in mental training while maintaining balance and avoiding self-hatred in the process of spiritual development.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahatto sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahatto sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahatto sammā-sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

In this particular video, I want to move to chapter three on the mind, and I've chosen the first two verses. So I shall chant them in my own inimitable way.

The wavering, unsteady mind, hard to control, difficult to restrain — the wise one straightens like an arrow maker straightens an arrow. That was the first verse. And the second one: As a fish quivers when taken out of its watery hole and thrown onto dry ground, so does the mind quiver when it is taken out of the sensual world to escape the realm of Mara.

So how did this come about? We can go to the story of Thera Meghiya. While residing at the Calika Mountain, the Buddha uttered these verses in reference to this Thera Meghiya. Now *thera* is an elder. You have to be a monk or a nun for ten years to become a *thera* or a *theri*. After twenty years, you're called a *mahāthera* or a *mahātheri*, which is a big *thera*, a big elder. These days, you don't normally use the word *mahāthera* except for people who become quite elderly.

An interesting thing about a *thera* is that they can ordain, but you don't do it that way usually. You belong to an order, a sect within the Buddhist monastic community, and somebody is ahead of that, and that's the person who would ordain. That way, it is said, you can trace your lineage all the way back to the Buddha.

At that time, Thera Meghiya was attending upon the Buddha, and on one occasion, on his return from alms round, the *thera* noticed a pleasant and beautiful mango grove, which he thought was an ideal spot for meditation. So he asked the Buddha's permission to let him go there. But as the Buddha was alone at the time, he was told to wait for a while until the arrival of some of the *bhikkhus*. The *thera* was in a hurry to go, and so he repeated his request again and again until finally the Buddha told him to do as he wished.

Thus Thera Meghiya set out for the mango grove, sat at the foot of a tree and practised meditation. He stayed there the whole day, but his mind kept wandering and he made no progress. He returned in the evening and reported to the Buddha how all the time he was assailed with thoughts associated with the senses, with ill will and with cruelty. So the Buddha told him that as the mind is easily excitable and fickle, one should control one's mind.

Now in the first verse, there's nothing particularly important about the Pali as such. It's a case of the mind is excitable, unsteady, wavering; it's difficult to control, keep hold of; it's difficult to restrain, but yet one has to work at it as a fletcher straightens an arrow. I did go onto YouTube and I found out how to straighten an arrow. Where the arrow is bent, you put it onto a surface so the bow is sticking upwards, and then you rub it up and down with a piece of wood, and the friction creates heat. It's easily bendable, and then when it cools it'll stay straight. There were other ways, but this is the way that I think the Buddha was referring to, because of course training the mind, you've got to keep bringing it back, bringing it back.

The second one about the fish has a slightly interesting word there for fish: *vārija*. *Vāri* is water and *ja* means born, so born in the water — hence a fish. As a fish quivers when taken out of a watery home, so the mind quivers when taken away from the realm of Mara.

We are of course entranced by our senses: what we see, what we hear, what we taste and so on. And suddenly to find ourselves in this inner quiet place, not feeding the senses, then obviously those old habits go berserk. They want to be back out into the world, engaging with Mara, the enticer. And so just like a fish taken out of water, almost gasping for oxygen and quivering, so the mind is gasping for these sensual delights. That's a very good image. The Buddha is very good at these little metaphors just to get across his meaning. Some people think like that. People have imaginative, poetic minds, and others have very intellectual minds. Most of us, of course, are in between.

Now, having said all that, does he somewhere give ideas on how to train the mind? Well, for this, we have to go to the scriptures themselves. Just before I go, I'll read the commentary. There's a commentary on all these *Dhammapada* verses and on the scriptures. The story of this verse is the same as the previous one, so they're both much the same. Our mind is indeed wavering, writhing and difficult to restrain, and now they want to give us an image like a snake or a young branch. So an arrow maker making an arrow has to straighten it, otherwise it would be worthless. In the same way, we have to straighten the mind, otherwise it won't hit the goal. The goal, of course, is *nibbāna*.

So now, how to stop thinking. This is in the middle discourses, the *Majjhima Nikāya*, number 20. You can look it up yourself there. I shall only mention the various ways in which it can be done.

The first thing is that the mendicant should focus on some other foundation of meditation connected with what is skilful. For instance, if erotic images appear in the mind, one thinks of the foulness of the body, and that definitely undoes the eroticism. That's one example. With food, when you're eating food, you're feeling greedy, you're overeating, then just imagine what happens to the food until its final elimination, and that would definitely put you off eating much more.

It says here that when desire arises, always try to create the opposite. Now you're not trying to develop disgust and self-hatred, or hatred towards the body. You're just trying to balance it. So when something pleasant comes up, which is an obsessive thing, one brings up the opposite and it cancels each other out. It's just a way of undermining these unwholesome habits.

If it's directed towards an inanimate object, then of course it's impermanence. You might be wandering around the shops, escaping from lockdown and seeing all these wonderful clothes, and then you recognise that well, the body's impermanent, clothes are impermanent, everything's impermanent. So you undermine that greed. That's what we're concerned with — not with not buying clothes; we need to dress ourselves.

When thoughts of hate arise towards another, the opposite is loving-kindness. If it's towards an inanimate object and there was a greedy desire to have something, see it in its characteristics, the four great elements: that it is actually just something that comes together with pressure, with heat, with something that is elastic and moving — movement. In other words, just deconstruct it. Just see it for what it actually is. Thoughts with delusion are slightly different — that would be something like doubt. Then of course it says just put yourself under the guidance of a teacher, study the Dharma, inquire into its meaning, listen to the Dharma and inquire into its causes.

Here we have number one: the mendicant should focus on some other foundation of meditation, on some other object, usually the opposite or something that undermines whatever is causing the mind to wander.

The second one is to examine the drawbacks of these thoughts. Just remembering the unworthiness of evil thoughts causes us to be shameful. Now, shame doesn't have very good support in modern psychotherapy, but that would be neurotic shame. That is shame to do with self-worth, with self-esteem — statements that we have about ourselves. Sometimes we feel a wholesome shame thinking about these things or getting ourselves into those sorts of mental places. This is only about thoughts, remember. And of course, to understand that there are dangers, because when you develop unwholesome states, they do grow within ourselves, and every so often they'll escape through what we say and even through what we do. So there has to be a little bit of dread of consequences there.

The next one is a little bit difficult for us: to try to ignore them and forget about them. When the mind is just restless, just moving all over the place, sometimes the best thing to do is just push it aside and bring the attention back into the body. Sometimes that works; sometimes you do forget them. Of course, here we're talking about training the attention to be still. This is obviously a little bit of suppression here, but we can deal with these things much better when we've attained some level of steadiness of the mind.

Then it says you should stop the formation of thoughts. That's interesting because the Pali uses the word *saṅkhāra*. *Saṅkhāra* are our habits, our volitional formations — what we have created in ourselves through acts of will. All our negative speaking, all our anger, all our anxiety — all that is self-created, just as much as our love, our happiness and joy. Here it actually translates as stopping the causing of thought. Here we can ask the question: what is the cause? Why is this happening in me? That's getting us close to a more *vipassanā* position where we would then go into the body to examine

the actual mental state that's causing the thoughts to arise. And of course, that's where we would stay. We would stay there investigating, feeling, allowing this mental state to express itself.

Finally, if all that doesn't work, the Buddha says: with teeth clenched and tongue pressed against the roof of the mouth, they should squeeze, squash and torture the mind with mind. That sounds pretty heavy, but here, what the Buddha is saying is that we should really replace an unwholesome thought with a wholesome thought.

This is especially useful if you're trying to develop a particular mental state, such as loving-kindness. If you find that you're very involved in some sort of hateful thing, angry place, anxious place — doesn't matter what it is — one really just keeps going with beads: "May all beings be happy, may all beings be safe, may all beings be healthy, may all beings..." and you just pound, pound, pound. What you're doing is creating a mental state which will eventually sit on top, keep these unfortunate states underneath. You are developing that mental state. When we practise this, we are developing loving-kindness, but we're not looking at what's underneath. But again, the purpose is to still the mind, to stop this energy going up into the head and creating this vortex of energy.

Just to go through them again: focus on some other object, opposite to what we're actually experiencing. If it's something to do with anger or hatred, you do the loving-kindness. Examine the drawbacks, feel the shame, the dread of consequences. Just ignore them and put them away. Then you can go into the causes of those thoughts — why are they happening? And finally, to dampen it down by strong loving-kindness practice or compassion practice, joy practice or peacefulness practice. "May all beings be peaceful. May I be peaceful. May all beings be peaceful." Something like that.

So what we've done is we've read these two little verses. The mind is excitable and unsteady. It is difficult to control and to restrain. The wise one trains his mind to be upright as a fletcher straightens an arrow. As a fish quivers when taken out of its watery home and thrown onto dry ground, so does the mind quiver when it is taken out of the sensual world to escape from the realm of Mara.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused even greater confusion, and that you will, by your devotion to practice, liberate yourselves from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Dhammapada 1-2: Mind is the Forerunner

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 14 min

In this foundational teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the very first verses of the Dhammapada, which establish one of the Buddha's core insights: "Mind precedes all mental phenomena, mind is their chief, they are mind-wrought." These twin verses present both the positive and negative aspects of how our mental states determine our experience.

Bhante explores the Pali terms mano (the conceptual mind), dhammā (mental phenomena), and the crucial role of cetanā (volition) in creating karma. He explains how unwholesome thoughts, when empowered by will, lead to unwholesome speech and actions, bringing suffering "like the wheel that follows the foot of an ox." Conversely, wholesome mental states bring happiness "like a never-departing shadow."

The talk includes the traditional story of Venerable Cakkhupāla, an arahant who accidentally killed insects while blind, illustrating the importance of intention in karmic consequences. Bhante clarifies Buddhist psychology's distinction between different aspects of mind and consciousness, while emphasizing the practical importance of mindful attention to our thoughts as the foundation of ethical conduct and spiritual development.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sambha Sambhodassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sambha Sambhodassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sambha Sambhodassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So last week I did what is arguably the most famous of the verses in the Dhammapada. This week I want to go back to the very beginning of it, and it opens up with twin verses. So one verse says positive and the other verse says the negative. And the first two really are core teachings of the Buddha.

So I'd like to chant it first in Pali, and then a simple translation, and then we'll read the story.

Mano Pubhanga Madhamma Mano Seta Mano Maya Manasa Chapa Dutena Vasati Wa Karoti Wa tatonandukkhāmanvāyati chakāmvavahato padam.

And the opposite:

Manopubāṅgamaḍḍama mānosaīta mānasa chapaḍḍana vasaṭi vākaraṭi vā tatonandasukkhāmanvāyati cāyavānāpayaṇi.

A very literal translation, the most literal that I've come across was by Buddharakkhita: "Mind proceeds all mental states. Mind is their chief. They are all mind-wrought. If with an impure mind a person speaks or acts, suffering follows him like the wheel that follows the foot of an ox.

"Mind proceeds all mental states. Mind is their chief. They are all mind-wrought. If with a pure mind a person speaks or acts, happiness follows him like his never departing shadow."

If we read the little story that's always with these verses, it's about an Arahant who lost his eyesight. One day, Venerable Chakupala, who was blind, came to pay homage to the Buddha at the Jetavana monastery. While he was pacing up and down in meditation, he accidentally stepped on some insects. In the morning, some bhikkhus visiting him found the dead insects. They thought ill of him and reported the matter to the Buddha.

When questioned by the Buddha whether they had actually seen Chakupala killing the insects, they answered in the negative, and the Buddha then admonished them: "Just as you had not seen him killing, so also you had not seen those living insects. Besides, being an Arahant, he had no intention of killing and was not guilty of committing an unwholesome act."

On being asked why Chakupala was blind, the Buddha revealed the following story to explain the nature of karmic effects. Chakupala had been a physician in one of his past existences. Once he had deliberately made a woman patient blind. That woman had promised to become his servant together with her children if her eyes were completely cured. Fearing that she and her children would have to become servants, she lied to the physician. She told him that her eyes were getting worse when in fact they were perfectly cured. The physician knew she was deceiving him, so in revenge he gave her another ointment which made her totally blind. As a result of this evil deed, the physician lost his eyesight many times in later existences. The Buddha then commented that an evil deed committed will follow the evildoer, just like the wheel follows the hoof of an ox that bears the yoke.

So I dare say there's a core truth to the story somewhere about an Arahant killing insects and being thought guilty of doing it on purpose. But of course, his name, Chakupala, ironically means "guardian of eyesight." So I doubt a monk is called guardian of eyesight. Anyway, there's two points here. First of all, is that he's not guilty because he hadn't meant to kill. That's the important thing. And that because he in a past life had

committed this terrible deed of making somebody blind, he himself suffered blindness. So that's a very mechanical understanding of karma—it's a bit more subtle than that, and I think at a later time we might go into it.

But let's look at the actual Pali here so that we can understand what the Buddha's saying. *Mano* refers to the part of the mind that when you see something—and it's the same for all the senses—you create a percept, like a photocopy. And as a human being, you put a label on it. So all animals have memory. I mean, they remember their owner. The dog remembers its owner. But they don't have that facility of putting a label on it. And so if we think of *mano* referring to the imagination and intellectual capacity of the mind.

Now, the word for the heart coming from our emotional involvement in life, feeling, that's *citta*. And the *viññana* refers to consciousness, which is the screen upon which things come to be known. Now, these words are sometimes used to mean each other. So you have to look at the context, but generally speaking, that's the split.

Now that isn't so surprising for us because even in our own history, through our wonderful enlightenment—I think the 18th century—we got very rational and we have the great philosopher Kant. And as opposed to that, as a rejection of pure logic, we have the Romantic movement, which is much more to do with feeling. So that dichotomy also exists in the Buddhist psychology.

And what he says is that this faculty, this mind, it comes before. It instigates, it starts things. Without that, without that faculty, we wouldn't have this imagination and so on.

And then this word *dhamma*. Now we know it normally as meaning the teachings, but in its plural form *dhamma* it means what the mind actually creates. So it's mental phenomena. The actual philosophical word for it is qualia—I just like that word. So if you come across the word qualia, it's referring to your subjective conscious experience. So this is what *dhamma* is here referring to.

And then, of course, he says it's *mano seta*. *Seta* is the one who governs, who rules. So it's the mind that's ruling this process. And finally, *manomaya*, which refers to the mind's ability to fabricate, to make, to produce. So that's the basic statement.

Now, if we were to take that statement entirely on its own, then you might be thinking that the Buddha is teaching a sort of idealism, that there is only the mind—which of course does happen in later Buddhism at the Vijñānavāda school. Theravāda tends to keep a hold on realism in the sense that it doesn't deny the reality—that's inverted com-

mas of course—of the world outside the mind. So when you look at a tree, the tree actually does exist, have its own existence out there. But what we actually see of it, of course, is being fabricated.

But then when we read the rest of the verse, he's actually talking about something quite specific. The next one is, of course, if with an impure mind—*duṭṭhena*—so with an impure mind, somebody speaks or acts, then suffering will follow them. So there's your process.

Now, there's an incident in the scriptures where the Buddha meets a disciple of the Jain leader. And when he asked the Jain leader, what does the Jain leader teach about karma? He says, the worst thing is an action, is a bad action. Now, from one point of view, of course, it is because that's the outer consequence of bad thinking and it causes a lot of suffering. But the Buddha's insistence is that actually what's most important is your mind because that's where it all begins.

And so here we have the mind offering us an unwholesome thought and we empower that. So there's a bit of empowerment. And this moment of empowerment, which is *chaitanya*, that's the faculty of will, is the moment that we're actually creating something.

Now once something's in the mind buzzing around in the mind, it doesn't take too long for it to begin to express itself in the way we speak and in what we do. So the Buddha is saying, you know, be careful about what you think. And that *chaitanya*, that will, is the point where you actually make a decision to express something either in speech or in action. And it all begins in the mind.

So then of course he warns us that if we do that, then of course suffering will follow. There'll be some comeback, there'll be some consequence. And he uses this image—he's got lots of images, he's very good on metaphors. So it'll follow you, it'll chase you down, just like the wheel follows the footstep of an ox. So here we have an image of burdensome, you know, a beast of burden, just the life that is burdened. And so every time we do something which is unwholesome, this burden will arise.

And of course, in the opposite one, he gives a different image. So here of course we're thinking wholesome thoughts and we're speaking wholesomely and we're acting wholesomely. So then he says of course happiness follows like a never-ending shadow. So it's very light, something that you don't even notice but it's following you all the time.

The teaching here basically is, you know, just be careful of what we think about. That's the basic teaching. And it starts the whole of the Dhammapada. And then the Dhammapada, of course, goes into all sorts of different subjects. But later on, there's lots of little verses teaching about karma itself. And that's a bit too much for this evening.

So that's the two opening verses of the Dhammapada. And I shall offer you to hear my own little translation: "All thinking and imagining are started by the mind. The mind is in charge of them. The mind fabricates them. And as we speak or behave with an impure mind, suffering will follow as a consequence, as the cartwheels follow the hooves of an ox."

So that's my little gift for this evening. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance and that by your devoted practice you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Dhammapada No. 4: Hatred Is Not Pacified by Hatred

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 16 min

In this inaugural Dhammapada talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines one of Buddhism's most famous verses: "Nāhi verena vairāṇi sammantīdha kudācana, averena ca sammanti esa dhammo sanantano"—hatred never ceases through hatred, but only through non-hatred, which is an eternal law.

Using the traditional story of two rival wives whose feud continued through multiple lifetimes until the Buddha's intervention, Bhante explores the psychological truth behind this teaching. He explains how hatred and anger arise from hurt, and how our natural fight-or-flight response only perpetuates cycles of conflict. The talk emphasizes developing Right Awareness to recognize these reactive patterns and respond instead with compassion and understanding.

Drawing on the Buddha's encounter with Devadatta's elephant, Bhante illustrates how non-reactive love (mettā) and compassion can transform hostile situations. He offers practical guidance for daily life: when faced with another's anger, we can absorb their negative feelings without letting them penetrate our hearts, listen deeply to understand their hurt, and respond with empathy rather than reactivity. This approach often leads to healing and reconciliation, demonstrating the absolute psychological truth of this ancient teaching.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhasa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhasa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhasa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

This is my inaugural talk around the *Dhammapada*, taking the verse and just seeing what we can make of it. The first one is a very famous one. I shall chant the Pali first.

Nāhi verena verāṇi sammantīdha kudācana, averena ca sammanti esa dhammo sanantano.

The usual translation is something like this: "Hatreds never cease through hatred at any time. They only cease through love. This is an eternal law." It doesn't really matter the exact translation.

That's the verse. Of course, it's one of the most famous of the *Dhammapada* verses, of which there are well over 400. Most of these are taken from the Scriptures, and there comes a story with it. The stories can be charming and sometimes are related, but sometimes I find it difficult to relate to the actual verse.

Very fortunately, I have this book, *The Dhammapada*, which I think is limited in edition by Sri Dhammananda, who was a monk, a Sri Lankan monk living in Malaysia. He's kindly reduced the stories to something quite manageable. So I shall read the story and see what you make of it.

Once there lived a householder whose wife was barren. Being unable to bear a child and afraid that she would be mistreated by her husband and her mother-in-law, she herself selected and arranged for her husband to marry another woman. But on two occasions, as soon as she knew the second wife was pregnant, the barren wife gave her food mixed with drugs, causing her to have miscarriages. On her third pregnancy, the fruitful wife kept it to herself without informing the barren wife. But when the latter came to know of it, she again caused a miscarriage. Eventually, the second wife died in childbirth. The unfortunate woman was filled with hatred and vowed vengeance before she died on this barren wife and her future offspring. Thus, the feud was started.

Among their later existences, the two were reborn as a hen and a cat, a doe and a leopardess, and finally as the daughter of a nobleman in Savatthi and an ogress. One day, the demon was in hot pursuit of the nobleman's daughter and her baby. When the lady heard that the Buddha was giving a religious discourse at the Jetavana Monastery, she fled to him and placed her son at his feet for protection. The demon was thus prevented from entering the monastery, but she was later called in and both the lady and the ogress were admonished by the Buddha.

The Buddha told them about their past feud as rival wives and how they had been harbouring hatred towards each other and killing each other's offspring through their various lives. They were made to see that hatred could only cause more hatred and that it could only cease through friendship, understanding and goodwill. Both realised their mistakes and on the admonition of the Buddha, made their peace with each other.

Then the Buddha requested the woman to hand over her son to the ogress. Fearing for the safety of her son, she hesitated, but because of her devotion and confidence in the enlightened one, she handed over her son as directed. The child was warmly received by the ogress. After kissing and caressing the child tenderly like her own son, the ogress handed over the child back to his mother. As a result of this episode, there was much goodwill on both sides.

Here we have a very ancient story with ogresses—I think a nasty Shrek. I presume that there's a kernel of truth in the story somewhere. It could be that a distraught husband came to the Buddha and said his two wives were at daggers with each other, and could he help? And when they came to see him, he counselled them and they stopped their fighting. But these three words are worth noting: hatred is overcome by friendship, understanding and goodwill.

If we go back to the verse itself and just look at the Pali: *nāhi verena verāṇi*. *Nāhi* just means no or not. *Vera* is the root word. It means hatred, revenge, hostile action. And this is not pacified, this is not brought to an end by this wrong reaction of more hatred. *Kudācana*—at any time, on any occasion, could be another translation.

But it is pacified by *averena*. The Buddha doesn't use the word for love, *metta*, or some other word, *karuṇā*, whatever. He simply puts a negative, *averena*, which means that the response we have to another person's anger or hatred can be varied. It doesn't have to be just love, as we'll see in a minute. And this is an eternal truth. This is an absolute law, and we'll see that it's an absolute law when we understand the psychology of it.

If we just consider ourselves for a moment and think back when we hated somebody—when we severely disliked somebody, could have been a personality thing, could be something they did—when we felt angry, behind that hatred and anger obviously there's hurt. Something has hurt us. Whether that's right or wrong doesn't matter in this case. It's the fact that we feel hurt and we want to get our own back. So we do that through hating, finding a way of getting our own back through revenge, through spite, or we let it all out in a fiery emotion of anger. That's how we release this hurt—we turn it towards hurting the other.

You can see that if the other person reacts with anger, then of course that fuels our anger. We find ourselves growing even hotter and more cold in our hatred. But if the other person asks us what's wrong, and then we have that occasion to tell them why we feel hurt, and they are prepared to adjust or to do something which undermines my hurt, then of course that hatred and anger begin to die away.

When we understand our own psychology, obviously it's easier to understand somebody else. Here we have somebody who hates us. We can feel the hate. Or we have somebody who is bursting with anger. Our natural reaction would be to fight back. Or if we feel we're not going to win, would be to run. Somehow we have to stop that from firing up within us. The best thing is awareness—to be aware of that immediate arising of that negative emotion towards the person and to be able to put something in between.

Here we can look at a story from the Buddha. The dastardly Devadatta had set this elephant on him, and the elephant was running towards him with his trunk lifted, presumably to attack. The Buddha stood fearless, not reacting, not running away. If an elephant went for me, I would definitely be running away. He held out his hand and offered *metta* to the elephant. The elephant was so affected by this love that it slowed down, finally came to a halt, and in fact lowered itself before the Buddha in some sort of obeisance.

That might be difficult for us to grasp these days, the power of love, but of course people use it to train dogs, to pacify dogs sometimes. When a dog is barking at you and looks angry, as soon as you open up to it and say, "Oh, quiet down, come on, boy," it'll begin to quiet down and finally come and sniff you out and be a friend. Love is a powerful message to give to somebody that you're not going to come back at them, that you're not going to react, you're not going to take revenge.

Here we are in a situation where somebody is hating us, perhaps, or somebody is angry with us. First of all, is to get in touch with that. In an actual situation where somebody is being hateful or is being angry, imagine that hand in front of you, if you can, and then absorb their negative feelings, as it were. So it stays on the outside of your heart. You can feel it, but you're not letting it in. The heart itself may be in this dual state of wanting to be angry, wanting to react. But we have to go over the top of that. The best way that I found is to point our attention directly to what they're saying.

As soon as you do that, as soon as the person who is angry with you realises that you're not going to react, it's not going to be a big fiery situation, you're not going to pour petrol on it, and that you're actually open to understanding why they're angry, of course their anger has got nowhere to go. It needs something to fire it up. It needs that reaction. Therefore, the anger begins to settle down. The more they begin to see that you want to understand them, then of course it slowly fades away and they begin to explain why they're angry and why they're in a position of hatred towards you. At that point, of course, there's some negotiation, there's some ability to settle the problem most times.

Obviously this doesn't always work. If the person has set their heart against you, well, that's a situation you have to accept and maybe you have to leave, but maybe you have to accept that the friendship is over or whatever that relationship had been. That's an extreme case. Most times, we can come to some understanding and more often than not, the friendship is healed.

We have a wonderful example there of the Buddha overcoming this terrible elephant from Devadatta. That attitude of seeing when somebody is angry or hateful, of actually understanding that they're coming from a position of hurt—there's your compassion. It's not love, it's compassion, it's an empathy, because we've been hurt, we know what it's like. Then the response is one of love, one of opening up to the person and allowing them to express themselves.

That's the teaching of this particular verse. These verses, if you take them on and you learn them off by heart, they're just like a mantra within us. Every so often, it's actually changing our attitude or deepening our attitude of how we relate to situations which are difficult for us.

That's the verse: hatred or anger or anything violent can never be pacified by that reaction of hatred and anger at any time. It's through compassion, through love that we can bring that to an end. This is an eternal law, an absolute law, because we can see the truth of it within our own psychology.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance and I have not caused even greater confusion, and that by your devotion to the practice, you may be fully liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Dhammapada 256-257: Judgmental vs Judicious

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 17 min

Drawing from Dhammapada verses 256-257, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the crucial difference between being judgmental and being judicious. The teaching begins with the story of bhikkhus who witnessed corrupt judges in King Pasenadi's court, prompting the Buddha's discourse on righteous judgment.

Bhante explores the Pali terms dhammato (standing in the Dharma) and sahasa (hasty, violent action), explaining how true righteousness requires thorough investigation from all perspectives before making judgments. He discusses the qualities of a good judge—patience, open-mindedness, compassion, and freedom from bias—and how these apply to our daily interactions.

The talk addresses the reality of cultural conditioning and inevitable prejudices we all carry, offering practical guidance on acknowledging these mental formations without suppressing or indulging them. Through Right Awareness, we can recognize prejudicial thoughts as conditioning while choosing not to act upon them, eventually transforming judgment into wisdom and compassion. A valuable teaching for developing discernment while cultivating love and understanding in our relationships.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

I shall continue by chanting the verses that we're going to do tonight.

Na tena hoti dhammiko, yen' atthaṃ sahasā naye. Yo ca atthaṃ anattañ ca, ubho niccheyya paṇḍito. Asāhasena dhammena, samena nayatī pare. Dhammassa gutto medhāvī, dhammiko ti pavuccati.

That translates as: One is not called righteous because one hastily judges what is good. A wise person has thoroughly investigated both the right and the wrong. Judging others without haste, justly and impartially, such a wise person, guardian of law, is called righteous.

So it's about judging. And Gil Fronsdal's translation: One is not a judge who judges a case hastily. A wise person considers both what is and isn't right. Guiding others without force, impartially and in accord with the dharma, one is called a guardian of the dharma, intelligent and just.

Before we go into the actual verses, here's the little story that surrounds it. It seems that some bhikkhus were returning from alms round, caught in a storm. They sheltered in the hall of justice at Sāvattihī, which is the capital of Kosala. King Pasenadi was a great supporter of the Buddha. They saw judges making arbitrary decisions and taking bribes and reported this to the Buddha. The Buddha said, "If one is influenced by monetary considerations in deciding cases, he cannot be called a just judge who abides by the law. If one weighs the evidence intelligently and decides a case impartially, then he is called a just judge who abides by the law."

Now, the commentary says something that perhaps is more attuned to us: it is very easy to judge others, to point out others' mistakes and bad qualities. Therefore, we have to be very thorough when we have to judge others. We have to listen to every possible point of view. We have to look at the problem from all sides. Only then can we be able to judge according to truth and call ourselves righteous.

Just one or two words that we've come across there: *dhammato*, translated as righteous. It actually means to stand in the Dharma. The Dharma here means, of course, the law, the truth—not only the spiritual laws, but just the general laws, truthfulness. Well, *dhammato* is given in the dictionary as fitness, propriety, a general rule, higher law, cosmic law, general practice, regular phenomenon, usual habit. So it's got a wide range of meaning.

In terms of justice or in terms of our sense of judging, it means to be as truthful as we can. And that means you need to collect as many facts and views and opinions as you can before you can come to a decision about somebody.

The other one is a rather interesting word: *sāhasa*. It has an odd meaning. It has violence, violent, hasty, arbitrary action, acts of violence, a sense of force. So one translator translates it as hasty—get on with it without really listening to both sides. And the other one is with a bit of force, a bit of push. Get on with it. So that's what these two words are.

And of course, one is called a guardian, a *gutto*, a guardian of the Dharma, if one is judging properly.

Of course, I looked up what makes a good judge—I mean a judge in court. My research came to some qualities that perhaps we should all have: patience, open-mindedness, courtesy, tact, firmness, understanding, compassion and humility. But of course, these are general characteristics of somebody who is a judge.

But when you're in court, there are four qualities that we would expect of a judge. The first one is that he's not averse to the accused, no matter how terrible the actions of the accused have been. Not to be glowering there saying, "I hate this guy, I hate this woman. I'm going to make sure that they go down." He's going to be aware of that aversion and not indulge it.

And of course, he's not going to be partial to the prosecutor. Could be the other way around, of course, that he has a liking or he feels that there's been some injustice done to the defendant and he's biased against the prosecutor. Either way, it obviously isn't going to come to a good judgment, or the way that he talks to the jury is going to be tainted.

He also doesn't want to be swayed by the baying of the crowd, the newspapers saying "hang him." You've got to be careful not to get caught up in that general feel of things. And the way things are really riled up by newspapers and politicians, as we've seen all over this business of the government and Brexit and all that.

And finally, of course, he's got to be free of fear—fear of reprisals, especially when he or she, the judge, sends somebody to prison, or in the old days, to hanging. In some parts of the world that still is possible. To be killed as a judge—in fact, in 1992, Giovanni Falcone, who was the judge in Sicily who brought many of the mafiosi to trial, was shot dead. So it happens.

I've also put here what the actual judge said. I've got a recording of it, which I thought you might be interested in. So you can imagine yourself standing in the dock.

This is the judge sentencing somebody to death. This would be before 1965, so it's not that long ago:

"You will be taken from this place to a lawful prison and then to a place of execution where you will suffer death by hanging, and your body buried in the precinct of the prison in which you shall be last confined before execution. And may the Lord have mercy upon your soul."

You can imagine listening to that. Just to rub that in, I thought I'd give you what they used to say in the 18th century: "The Lord is that thou shalt return to the place whence thou camest, and from thence to the place of execution where thou shalt hang by the neck till the body be dead, dead, dead, and the Lord have mercy on your soul."

It's pretty gruesome. These days, of course, at least in many of the Western countries, we've abandoned hanging. But just to finish this little bit off about judges, there was, of course, a standing joke when they brought hanging to an end in Britain. The judge sentenced somebody: "You will be taken from this place to the place of execution and be hanged until dead." And the clerk of the court jumped up and said, "Your Honour, hanging has been abolished." So the judge cleared his throat and said, "You will be taken to the place of execution and hanged by the neck until it really, really hurts."

That's always a good standing joke.

What this takes us to, of course, is the whole thing about judging. And this takes us to the fact that when we're judging people, when we see people, when we hear people, we've always got this background judging going on. We're always fitting them into a box in some way. And of course, what we're doing is being prejudicial—prejudging, prejudicial.

Now, the Dalai Lama actually says that love is the absence of prejudice. Well, it's definitely one of the big cornerstones of it—not being judgmental. But that doesn't stop us from being judicious, which means, of course, to come to a right understanding about somebody or some action. So it's not as though we have to stop judging. We just have to make sure that it's fair and that it is based on facts and truth.

Just thinking about judging or prejudice, speaking for myself, but I'm sure it's true for everybody in any society: you are given the prejudices of your society from the moment you're born. They're inculcated. You can't—it's part of the whole cultural education that you get. So you're bound to have, in my opinion, you're bound to have racist, sexist, prejudice against religions, et cetera, et cetera. It's got to be there.

And what's important really is to understand that when, because we are more aware, more mindful of what we're doing and what we're thinking—when you see a prejudicial thought come up, to know that that's all conditioning. And even though some shame and guilt might come up around it, those are to be seen as guardians. So this is where the Buddha says that shame and guilt about doing something harmful are guardians. Otherwise, you know, we would just indulge it. So there's a proper sense of shame and a bit of guilt that comes up which stops you from indulging that particular prejudice.

But if it goes on and on—being guilty and dreading consequences because of this old conditioning—then of course it's gone on too long. It's not proper to the situation. There's no need for that. It's only when we indulge those thoughts—either allowing the mind to escape on a fantasy or to actually speak something or to do something which is prejudicial—that then of course we should have a greater sense of shame and guilt.

And that leads us to apology. Shame and guilt are the beginnings of compassion, of understanding, opening up to the pain that we've caused somebody else.

And of course, we're full of it. I've even forgotten classism, which is a big one in our society. Xenophobia brought up through immigration. So all these prejudices that come up, they have to be acknowledged. If they're not, of course, then we suppress them. We suppress them out of fear, out of an aversion towards them. But remember, Freud was perfectly right. These things slip out in little Freudian slips and they can be very embarrassing.

So it's best to be aware of any prejudicial thought that comes up and to accept that that's part of our conditioning. But we're not indulging it. We're not giving it headway. And in so doing, we've not done anything wrong whatsoever. There is no consequence. There's no *kamma* to have to suffer. And eventually, of course, these things become very light in the mind—little traces that really don't bother us anymore.

Now, one little trick you can try, which opens us up to these background voices, these little devils that we have within us, is just to walk down the street, turn your head, look at somebody, and just listen to the judgments that you're coming up with, to the opinions, to the biases that you're coming up with in the mind. As I say, that's not to be excessively guilty about or anything. It's just to know that there is within us these conditionings, and that by not indulging them, in time they atrophy, they die away. Of course, they are replaced by love, compassion, sympathetic joy, and so on.

That's a little exercise that we can occasionally try on ourselves just to wake us up to the fact that these things are with us really. And even when we are fully liberated, they remain as *vāsanā*—they remain as little traces in the mind, but of course they have no effect whatsoever.

So these two verses are really asking us to look at this whole process of judging and to be able to make that distinction between being judgmental—being prejudicial, coming to opinions and understandings and decisions and actions based on not enough knowledge or on our own prejudicial views and opinions—and being judicious, which is of course coming from the point of view of—here he uses the word intelligence—to do something with intelligence, to be rational about something. But there's a sense of

wisdom about it too. And then of course we can make proper judgment. We can be righteous. We can be standing in the Dharma. Standing in the Dharma—that's where we want to be.

So this is *dhammassa gutto*. That's what we want to be. We want to be standing in the Dharma.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I have not caused any confusion, and that you will, by your own devoted practice, liberate yourself from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Dhammapada 46: How to View the Body

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 18 min

In this teaching on Dhammapada verse 46, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the Buddha's instruction to see the body as foam and mirage - impermanent and insubstantial. Through the traditional story of a bhikkhu who attained Arahatsip by contemplating these similes, Bhante examines three key characteristics: the body's impermanence (like froth breaking up on water), its insubstantial nature (like a mirage created by water vapor), and how attachment to bodily beauty becomes a source of suffering through Māra's 'flower-tipped arrows' of sensual pleasure.

Drawing from the Girimananda Sutta's contemplation of bodily parts and afflictions, Bhante discusses the traditional 31-part meditation and the Buddha's comprehensive list of bodily ailments - practices designed to undermine attachment rather than create disgust. He emphasizes that the goal isn't rejecting sensual pleasures entirely, but understanding our dependency on them for happiness. The teaching connects body contemplation to the broader path of liberation, showing how awareness of impermanence and not-self leads beyond the 'king of death' to awakening.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

So this evening, to carry on our little Dhamma exploration, *Dhammapada* exploration, I thought I'd choose verse number 46. I shall chant it in the Pali first:

*Phenūpamang kāyam imang viditvā
Marīcidhamang abhisambudhāno
Chetvāna Mārassa papupphakāni
Addassan gacche maccurājassa*

And the translation. This is Gil Fronsdal:

"Knowing this body is like foam, fully awake to its mirage-like image, cutting off Mara's flowers, one goes unseen by the king of death."

And I prefer Thanissaro's translation actually on this one:

"Knowing this body is like foam, realizing its nature a mirage, cutting out the blossoms of Mara, you go where the king of death can't see."

That's a bit more dramatic, I think.

So let me read a little story that comes with it:

On one occasion, the Buddha was residing at Jetavana Monastery in Savatthi, and a certain *bhikkhu*, after obtaining a subject of meditation from the Buddha, went to the forest for the purpose of practicing meditation. Although he strove diligently, he made little progress and was not happy with himself, and so he thought, "I'll return to Jetavana Monastery and request the Enlightened One to give me another subject of meditation better suited to my temperament." And with this thought he set out to return to Savatthi.

Now on the way he saw a mirage. Reflecting mindfully within himself, he realized that a mirage after all is only an illusion caused by a sheet of water vapour. So also was his body an illusion and insubstantial by reason of birth and decay. And fixing his mind on the mirage, he continued with this meditation practice.

Later, he went for a bath near the bank of the river Aciravati. While resting under a tree close to the river and seeing the froth breaking up, he realized further the impermanent nature of the body. Now from Jetavana Monastery, the Buddha saw the *bhikkhu* and sent forth his radiance and exhorted him: "*Bhikkhu*, you are on the right track. Keep it up. It is good that you've realized the body is impermanent like froth and insubstantial like a mirage."

At the conclusion of the exhortation, the *bhikkhu* attained *Arahatship*.

Well, that's not bad, is it? See what we're missing out on, not being born at the time of the Buddha!

So: "Knowing this body is like foam, realizing its nature a mirage, cutting out the blossoms of Mara, you go to where the king of death can't see."

So a couple of vocabulary items there. *Marīci* just means to shimmer or glitter, and so it becomes a word for mirage. And that is a metaphor for illusion. If you see it as a mirage, that it is a mirage, it's an illusion. But if you think it's real, then it's a delusion.

Now here it says "having cut off Mara's flower-tipped arrows" — that's a more direct translation: "having cut off Mara's flower-tipped arrows."

Now it's interesting because the only time that I'm certain that the arrows of Mara approached the Buddha was just before he was fully liberated. And it attacked him with "What about the sensual life? It's great out there! What are you doing just sitting under this tree?" And then there was fear — fear of failure — and who was he anyway to try and become fully liberated, and so on.

And as these arrows came to the Buddha, because of his determination, commitment to his path and that sense of hope, they turned into flowers. So here, I think this "Mara's flower-tipped arrows" is extending the metaphor a bit, because flowers stands for sensual pleasure. So he cut off sensual pleasure.

So there are three things in this discourse: insubstantiality, impermanence, and of course the cause of suffering — attachment. And the last thing is the king of death. So if he's gone beyond the king of death, then of course he must be liberated. That's just another way of saying that the person's liberated.

So when we're contemplating the body as body, there are these three characteristics to look at. So this impermanence of the body — I mean that's pretty easy for us to see the older we get. Things change downwardly. But so that's not so difficult for us to see, but we don't really see the power of seeing impermanence unless somebody dies.

So even today I was talking to somebody, a student who is having problems with seeing impermanence everywhere. It's coming up as a lot of fear, and they've had two close deaths in the family, one after the other, very sudden. So when that happens, of course, the impermanence of the body becomes quite real — its insubstantiality, its fragility. We're all living on a knife edge.

And the image there is of froth on water. It just breaks up. You've seen it gathering on streams, and then it just breaks away, breaks up. So it's the whole deconstruction of the body. If you were to imagine it laid out before you, all the bits and pieces, then we would see that it's just something that's constructed, something that's put together.

But of course, it's real in the sense that we feel it. You bite your tongue and you can't deny that you have a body. It definitely feels real. But of course, that is the perception that we are trying to cut through. Pain is pain — that's fine. But when it's my pain, when I'm suffering from it, then it gives it a sense of reality which it doesn't have.

And it's interesting that the discourse uses the idea of vapour that's creating the mirage, the froth on the water, because the body, it seems, is 60% water. So if you were to separate all the elements of the body rather than the parts, you'd end up with a lot of bottles of water.

And then when it comes to the body itself in terms of the attachment to the body, the main thing is, of course, our attachment to the body as something which is — we can't say beautiful for most of us because we have this awful image of Hollywood, Bollywood, and CGI. Nobody lives up to that standard! But there is always that — we can say — slight concern that people see us as pleasant, as something to look at which is pleasant.

And so there is this concern about how we look. And if a person is using their looks in order to gain advantage, of course, then you very quickly catch somebody who is attracted to you, and with that there comes power. But there's also a real bite back — it's not a feedback, it's a bite back — because now your sense of power is dependent on their admiration.

And of course when their admiration fades away, you discover it's not love. And of course if their admiration turns to somebody else, then we're fired up with rage and jealousy. So there's a whole mixture of suffering that comes with being too concerned about how we look.

There's a distinction between cleanliness, tidiness, and beauty. So how do we overcome this connection to the body, the body as something that has to be beautiful in other people's eyes?

So in the discourse on Girimananda, who is a monk and he's very ill, and the Buddha knows about this and he tells Ananda to go and see him and gives him ten perceptions: perception of impermanence, of not-self. Now here it's translated as ugliness, sometimes it's translated as repulsiveness. The drawbacks, giving up, fading away, cessation, dissatisfaction with the whole world, impermanence of all conditions, and mindfulness of breathing.

And we'll just concentrate on the business of the body and its foulness or ugliness or unpleasantness, maybe we should say.

So interestingly enough, there are 31 parts enumerated by the Buddha. In this body: there's head hair, body hair, nails, teeth, skin, flesh, sinews, bones, bone marrow, kidneys, heart, liver, diaphragm, spleen, lungs, intestines, bowels, undigested food, feces, bile, phlegm, pus, blood, sweat, fat, tears, grease, saliva, snot, synovial fluid, and urine.

That's quite a wonderful list! Interestingly, and I've always wondered why, but the brain isn't included. But it is when you do the Mahayana list — they've added it and the list changes a little bit. So you've got feces and then brain, presumably saying that you might be a fathead or something! But it seems as though the ancients didn't know what

this lump of fat or whatever in the head was. They thought it was part of the skull, part of cartilage or something. It seems they had no idea that's where your thinking and imagining is manufactured.

Now although I say that, although we might be surprised by that because we take this for granted, when you're thinking and imagining, it's out there somewhere, isn't it? It's not — although it's inside you, it's — you wouldn't imagine it to come out of this lump of fat that's inside your head. And I think in those days, prior to our severe split between the body and mind, people thought more from the heart often, more about what I feel, what I understand, rather than what I think and understand.

Anyway, what we're supposed to do, of course, is to bring the image of these in mind and just relate and just feel what our relationship is. Normally speaking, it's some form or some level of disgust. And to recognize that that's not necessary. That's, again, something to do with not really accepting our body as animal. We're here as animals as well, and not accepting that part of it is unpleasant. It doesn't smell nice for a start. And it's just recognizing it's a smell, and the disgust is not actually necessary at all, which is a measure of our delusion about how the body should be or how we imagine the body to be.

So now, of course, the Buddha says what we do is to contemplate the drawbacks. "This body has much suffering and many drawbacks, for this body is beset with many kinds of affliction, such as the following: diseases of the eye, inner ear, nose, tongue, body, head, outer ear, mouth, teeth and lips; cough, asthma, catarrh, inflammation, fever, stomachache, fainting, dysentery, gastric pain, cholera, leprosy, boils, eczema, tuberculosis, epilepsy, herpes, itch, scabs, smallpox, scabies, hemorrhage, diabetes, piles, pimples and ulcers. Afflictions stemming from disorders of bile, phlegm, wind or their conjunction. Afflictions caused by change in the weather, by not taking care of ourselves, by over-exertion, or as a result of past deeds. Cold, heat, hunger, thirst, defecation and urination."

And so they meditate, observing the drawbacks of the body. Great old list, isn't it? He's not shy of listing these things at all, is he? Hits it on the nose, you might say.

So these exercises are given us in order to undermine this relationship of attachment to the body. Now, we have to ask ourselves, why do we form this relationship of attachment to the body? And for that, you have to go back a couple of steps to this idea of identity, which we're trying to constantly undermine.

So this identity, this "me," is seeking happiness, remember. It's just seeking it in the wrong place. And what it does by seeking happiness, it forms a relationship with what makes it happy. How do we define our happiness? I would say for the most part it's how we feel. I feel happy, I feel comforted, I feel warm, I feel beautiful, I'm in love, and so on. So this happiness has an anchor in the way we feel, and that's what we're always chasing. We're always chasing something that's going to make me feel good.

And that's where the problem lies, because then everything that makes us feel good becomes something we depend upon. And when it's not there, that's when you get your grief. And behind it sits your fear of loss and so on and so forth. All the miseries come out of trying to seek some sort of permanent happiness through the body.

And the mistake that we can make of course is then to try and get away from all sensual pleasures. Well that just takes you into a very miserable place, like a dry prune. I mean that's no good at all! So it's not a case of getting rid of sensual pleasures as such, but getting rid of that relationship and being aware of it, being aware of it.

And of course, that was the old reason for fasting, and why Muslims also fast for one month every year, is to try and cut through this dependency we have on the sensual world for pleasure. That's what we used to do it for as Christians, or I as a Catholic. During Lent you had to give something up — your sweets. Well, there's a pain really, but the idea was to realize that you don't need sweets in order to be happy.

So this verse, I've built up a lot around it, but the basic message, of course, is the impermanence, the insubstantiality, and how not to be attracted by Mara's flowers.

So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused confusion, and that by your devotion to practice you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

The Four Noble Truths

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 18 min

In this foundational talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma presents the Four Noble Truths as the cornerstone of the Buddha's entire teaching. He begins with an in-depth exploration of dukkha—often translated as suffering but encompassing dissatisfaction, discomfort, and unsatisfactoriness—explaining how it manifests in three distinct ways: the suffering of pain and loss, the suffering inherent in impermanence, and the suffering that arises from our misconception of self.

Bhante explains how our reactions to life's inevitable pains create additional suffering, and how meditation practice teaches us to observe these reactions with Right Awareness. He discusses how attachment to pleasures leads to anxiety, frustration, and boredom, while our inability to accept impermanence keeps us from living fully in the present moment. The talk addresses the fundamental delusion of self-concept and how this creates the very foundation of our unhappiness.

The second Noble Truth reveals how desire (taṇhā) manifests these delusions, while the third proclaims that liberation (nibbāna) is possible. Bhante concludes with an inspiring quote from contemporary Thai nun Meiji Kyo, describing how an Arahant experiences complete awareness while remaining fully engaged with life. This accessible yet profound teaching provides essential understanding for anyone beginning or deepening their Buddhist practice.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhasa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhasa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhasa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed noble and fully self-awakened one.

What I'm hoping to do for the rest of the year is go through the whole teaching in little short talks, and the place to start of course is with his declaration of the Four Noble Truths. If you were to choose one word upon which all his teaching is based, it would have to be the word *dukkha*. This *dukkha* means hard to bear, and it's translated variously as suffering, dissatisfaction, discomfort, and so forth, but it really covers the whole of life.

It begins with dukkha-dukkha, which means the suffering of suffering or the dissatisfaction of dissatisfaction. In other words, ordinary physical pain, mental anguish, and so forth, are natural to the human condition. But what makes it suffering is the way we react. It's knowing that that allows us to find the escape out of suffering.

That's what we're doing when we're meditating, of course. When we're in posture, we note something coming up, a pain in the knee or something, and we note the reaction to it. When we can stand apart from the reaction, we find ourselves in a place which is not suffering, even though the environment—the pain in the knee and the not wanting of the pain in the knee—is not pleasant. It's making that distinction when it comes to the pains and woes of life.

Even taking something very heavy like a death, the death of somebody close to us. There's a tremendous amount of grief and heart suffering. But then there's the reaction to that, which is sometimes a desire not to face it, so it remains in the system as a turbulence. And sometimes the desire to indulge it. You get into this wrong relationship with grief where if you stop grieving, you think you've stopped loving. But when we feel it as a feeling in ourselves, we're standing apart from it, and that separation from the reaction that we've had is the nibbanic gap. That's what we have to keep rediscovering for ourselves. In these situations, the heart heals itself.

On the other side of that, of course, is everything to do with pleasure—the pleasures and joys of life. Here we have a different problem to do with indulgence. What indulgence simply means is that we're using something, we're becoming dependent on something in order to be happy. Everybody has their own definition of what makes them happy and everybody has their own particular feeling as to what happiness is. We tend to believe that that's the purpose of our lives, to feel happy.

When Sayadaw U Pandita turned up at IMS once, a woman said to him, "I'm so happy to see you." He replied in Burmese, but the translator didn't translate it. Afterwards, she went to the translator and asked, "What did he say?" He said, "I haven't come here to make you happy. I've come here to make you aware." That's the crucial point about the Buddha's teachings.

When we do indulge, there are always consequences—the grief of loss, the anxiety of loss, paying out loads for insurance. There's the anger of not getting what you want, the frustration of not getting what you want. And then, of course, the boredom—what used to make you happy and joyful, now you find boring. There's a whole load of mental diseases that comes through the process of attachment, through the process of indulgence. This is all contained in that little phrase, dukkha-dukkha. It's one type of suffering.

The second type is to do with impermanence. This is basically not coming to terms with the fact that everything arises and passes away. Not only does everything arise and pass away, nothing ever repeats. There's actually nothing in this universe, in our universe, in our lives, that we can rely upon. Anything can disappear at any moment. Coming to terms with that is really understanding this process of change.

We're especially fortunate in Britain because of our weather. The weather is constantly changing and therefore we can never make absolute plans as to when you want to go for a walk. I'm a fair weather walker and you make a plan to walk on such a day, and of course it rains or it rains and snows or it does everything else apart from sunshine. This whole idea of impermanence comes across when we actually look at what we arrange sometimes and sometimes we can't make it.

At a deeper level, this whole impermanence is taking us to the whole process of aging and final death. That's the difficult one to come to terms with, of course. But it's the quiet, gentle remembrance at all times that everything comes to an end, life comes to an end. You might think by reminding myself of that, I'm going to make myself depressed, but what happens is you find yourself living more in the moment. You come to appreciate the moment more and therefore, paradoxically, your life becomes much more joyful.

In medieval times, of course, it was very regular to have your memento mori, your reminder of death—a little skull on your desk or somewhere—so that you never actually forgot that life is short. That whole attitude of coming to terms with impermanence is part and parcel of our practice.

The final one is to do with the concept of self. The concept of self creates a substantiality, something that is real, whole, entire unto itself. But actually, when we look even a little bit deeper, we can see that everything is compounded. Everything is made up of little bits and pieces and these little bits and pieces are dependent on other little bits and pieces. This whole planet as we know is a living organism with little bits and pieces dependent on some other little bits and pieces. It's beginning to dissolve, beginning to deconstruct our experience of ourselves, which is part and parcel of that process.

We wouldn't do that or we'd be afraid to do that if when we actually deconstruct everything we find there's nothing there. That would be terrible. But what the Buddha is saying is that hidden within this organism, there is something which doesn't die. It wasn't born, doesn't die. It's not even conditioned. Now, where is it? What could it possibly be? That's the process again of our meditation.

This sense of self is the fundamental delusion that lies at the basis of all our unhappinesses. It's the point where the awareness within us begins to experience this organism as itself. That's the big point of contact and it's right there that the whole trouble of delusion begins. The dependent origination begins with that phrase *avijjā*—delusion, not knowing. It's not a culpable thing. It's just the way it is.

How do we know when any of these delusions are arising? How do we know when we are under the spell of these misunderstandings? This is where the genius, you might say, or the real insight of the Buddha lies. It lies right there in our desires. If we're aware of a desire, we'll be able to pinpoint what is causing that desire. If it's wholesome, of course we empower it, but if it's not wholesome, then we have to sit with that energy until it dies away.

To be aware of a desire as it rises takes that bit of *appamāda*—his favourite word, one of his favourite words, which of course was his second to last word in life: *Appamādena!* Strive diligently for your liberation. It's that sense of constantly bringing ourselves back to the present moment and being awake to any little desire that comes up.

Most desires are neither here nor there. There's a desire in me to wave my hand about like I'm doing now. It's not something I'm going to be too bothered about. But if a desire is for something which I immediately perceive as unwholesome, unskillful, unvirtuous, then if I'm right there with the initial movement of that desire, the choice arises. Once I've activated it, that's it. I've lost that moment of choice. Once it's activated, then of course there are going to be results.

That second noble truth—the noble truth that desire is the cause of suffering—that's how the delusions manifest. Then of course he says that there is an end to this suffering. Finally, there's the path that he delineates, which is a bit too much for us to go into this evening. But most of you know it—it begins with right understanding, which is what we're doing now. That of course changes our attitudes. When our attitudes change, it affects the way we speak and what we do and our livelihood. It all reverts back to this: really understanding the way things are. Through that process of not activating those desires that are unwholesome and activating those desires that are wholesome, the attitude changes and very slowly we pull ourselves out of the morass of human suffering.

But let's go back to the third one, which is, of course, there is an end to suffering. The word he gives for that is *Nibbāna*. It's translated in various ways. Some of it is creative etymology, but the two main ones are no desire and unshackled, unfettered. Some of you will know the ten fetters that keep us at this level of existence. It's unfettering those that releases this awareness, which is the Buddha within.

I'd like to end my little homily with a quote from Mae Chee Kaew. Mae Chee Kaew was a Thai nun who died in 1991, so she's absolutely contemporary. She was a student of Ajahn Mahā Bua. Some of you might know his writings. She worked with him and then once she became liberated, she went back to look after her nuns. That's what she did for the rest of her life. She died when she was about ninety-one, if I remember, of lung cancer.

This is what she says, which tells us how somebody who's fully liberated actually experiences life. Remember, she's fully engaged. She's there with the nuns and lay people who come, but mainly her concern seems to have been to guide her nuns. She's fully engaged in life. This is what she says, which tells us how that engagement manifests:

"Body, mind and essence are all distinct and separate realities." There's three parts to us: the body, our physicality, our mentality and this, what she here calls essence, that which is. "Absolutely everything is known," which means that whatever comes into the awareness, whatever arises on the screen of consciousness, she knows it. Her mind isn't somewhere else.

"Earth, water, fire and wind"—these, remember, are your four great elements—"the body, feeling, perceptions, conceptual thinking, and then there are the habits that we have, and finally consciousness. She knows when sounds, sights, smells, tastes, touches and emotions arise. She knows when"—now this is interesting—"when greed, anger and delusion arise. All are known. I know them as they exist in their natural states."

Now it might surprise you to think that somebody who's fully liberated still has negative unwholesome thoughts arise, but remember the mind is now habituated in a way of thinking. But the distinction between somebody who's an arahant and us is that they are traces in the mind that have no pull. They have no attraction and therefore they just arise and pass away. Whereas our habit of course is to jump and grab hold of them and off we go. What she's saying is that these are just traces that pass through the mind.

"Now no matter how much I'm exposed to them, I'm unable to detect even an instant when they have any power over my heart"—that's her next word for this Buddha within, her heart. Remember, it's not the emotional heart. This isn't emotion. This is her real being—"and they have no power over it. The awareness is there."

We experience that in our meditation on occasion. When we're observing things rising, passing away, we're in this state—we're having a little touch of *Nibbāna*. "All these things arise and cease. They're forever changing. But the presence"—that's the third word she uses to describe this awareness, this Buddha nature—"but the presence that knows them never changes for an instant. It is forever unborn and undying. This is the end of suffering."

I've never come across a more clear statement as to how an arahant experiences life. Not even the Buddha, which may be surprising. The Buddha has many statements about *Nibbāna* and about that state of mind, but I've never seen it expressed in a way that the ordinary meditator can grasp. There she is, looking after her nuns, always in the moment, aware of what's actually happening. Whenever something slightly negative arises in the mind, it simply arises and passes away. It doesn't enter into her heart, into her awareness.

I'm hoping that you find that inspiring. I personally find it very inspiring. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I have not caused confusion, and that by your total devotion to the practice, you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

The Nine Qualities of the Buddha

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 22 min

In this illuminating talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the nine classical qualities of the Buddha that are recited during pūjā (devotional practice). He explores each quality in depth: araham (accomplished one who has destroyed all defilements), sammāsambuddho (self-awakened), vijjācaraṇasampanno (endowed with clear vision and virtuous conduct), sugato (one who has completed the journey), lokavidū (knower of worlds), anuttaro purisadammasārathi (incomparable trainer), satthā devamanussānaṃ (teacher of gods and humans), buddho (the awakened one), and bhagavā (the exalted one).

Bhante explains how these qualities reflect the Buddha's complete understanding of dukkha and its cessation, his role as the founder who first discovered the path to liberation, and his skillful guidance through the spiritual realms we create within ourselves. He connects these traditional epithets to vipassanā practice, showing how understanding the Buddha's accomplishments can inspire our own journey toward awakening. The talk emphasizes how the Buddha's clear vision of our fundamental misunderstanding - taking ourselves to be merely human beings seeking happiness in the sensual world - led to his discovery of the path of purification through the development of virtue, the four brahmavihāras, and insight meditation.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

First of all, many thanks to Donatella who is translating for me, honeying my words with her angelic voice. This evening I will talk about the nine qualities of the Buddha, which we refer to when we listen to the puja. So we chant that in the morning.

The first quality is *arahant*. It means accomplished, somebody who is worthy of respect. Now, what the commentators do is they begin to separate the word to give it more meaning. And the one that makes sense to me is the division between ari and hatta. It means he destroyed his enemies. Now the enemies, of course, are the defilements. The defilements are listed as ten, but actually in the scriptures it just means anything that is unwholesome within our personality. And such a person has no secret evil. He can say with the Buddha, with all the enlightened people, that birth is destroyed and the holy life has been lived. What had to be done has been done. There is no more rebirth for me. So whenever we say arahant, that's what we mean.

Now the second one is *sammāsambuddho*, which means self-enlightened. So this is the crucial role that the first person plays for us. Somebody must have planted the first wheat. Somebody must have created the wheel. And we know that Edmund Hillary and Sherpa Tenzing climbed Everest. So once they did it, everybody else can do it, even the dogs. So in other words, the one who initiates, who begins something, has a special place within our praise. And so this means that the first person, the one who started all this, has a special place in what we attribute to him, in the blessings we wish him. So he is the founder of our tradition. Without him there simply wouldn't be any Buddhism.

Now the next quality is endowed with clear vision, or we can say direct understanding, and virtuous conduct. So this means that he has understood the cause of our problems, and of his own problems. And because of that, his actions are always virtuous. So remember that everything begins from this misunderstanding. It's a misunderstanding as to who we are. Presuming ourselves to be human beings, that's all, we seek happiness in the sensual world. And this creates what we call an attachment, which means we are dependent on the sensual world to make us happy. And this leads us to certain unfortunate qualities: greed, aversion and fear, and all the rest. All the rest of human misery. So, in other words, he is somebody who has understood the path and understands it to be a path of purification.

The next quality is translated as someone who has completed a journey. So this includes all the training that he went to with his two teachers, and his own discovery of the path. And don't forget that he also did some very severe mortification exercises. So in other words, by practicing in the wrong paths, he eventually found the right path. So this often happens to us. First you make mistakes and then you find the right way to do something.

Now, the next one is a seer of the worlds. Now, this does not refer specifically to seeing other realms of being. This is to do with the worlds that we create. These are the ones that we manufacture, our little universes. So sometimes we're in the hell realm, when we're depressed and upset. Sometimes we're in the animal realm, when we used to get drunk, but we don't do that anymore. And then there's the hungry ghost realm when we are very greedy. And sometimes we're in the human realm where we have some sort of intelligence, some sort of wisdom. Occasionally we get lost in anger and we become angry gods. And of course occasionally we are bathing in absolute wonderful joy and pleasure. So these are the worlds that we create within ourselves. So somehow we have to go beyond these worlds. And that's what we do whenever we practice *vipassanā*. Because when we practice *vipassanā* we can see these worlds appearing in front of us. So that was the knower of the worlds.

The next translates literally as a coachman driving an ox or a horse. It translates better as an incomparable trainer of trainees. And of course he has left us certain rules and regulations that we can follow. So on the negative side there are the five precepts, the eight precepts. And then, of course, for the monastic life, all the rules of the Vinaya. And on the positive side, he's given us the ten perfections. And the four brahmaviharas, the four great illimitables: love, compassion, joy and equanimity.

The next one is, he is a teacher of gods and men. Gods and human beings. So this of course refers to the dhamma, all the teachings of the dhamma. And of course the practice of vipassanā, of all the absorption techniques, and of course how to live the spiritual life in ordinary daily life.

And number eight is *buddho*, which is the one who knows. So this is simply saying that he knows how we create the world of *saṃsāra*, the world of ongoing, and the escape. So remember he said he only taught two things: *dukkha* and the end of *dukkha*. And *dukkha* is all the miseries that you can think of.

And then the final quality is *bhagavā*, which means exalted, sublime. Yes, it's an honorific, like we say of the Dalai Lama, his holiness.

So those nine qualities: he has accomplished and has destroyed all his defilements. He was self-awakened. He has a clear understanding of our situation and because of that virtuous conduct. He has completed the journey and he did it skillfully. He knows all the worlds that we can create and how to get out of them. He's a wonderful trainer, a coach. Life coach. And he's also a great teacher. He has penetrated the human condition, he is the Buddha. And therefore we consider him to be exalted, sublime and blessed.

I hope my words have been of some assistance. That's this silly Google Assistant. A very great annoyance. So, I hope my words have been of some assistance. That I have not caused confusion. And that by your devotion to the path, you will be liberated. Sooner rather than later.

Dhammapada 360-362: Restraint

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

In this teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the profound practice of saṃvara (restraint) through Dhammapada verses 360-362, which emphasize restraint of the six senses as essential for liberation from suffering. The talk examines how restraint differs from suppression, being not about killing our senses but about distinguishing between healthy enjoyment and harmful indulgence.

Drawing from traditional Jātaka stories and commentaries, Bhante discusses the five essential qualities needed to develop restraint: ñāṇa (understanding), moral practices, Right Awareness (sammā sati), viriya (effort), and khanti (forbearance). He illustrates these teachings with practical examples from daily life, including eating habits and the detailed training rules (sekhiyadhamma) for monastics that cultivate mindful deportment.

The teaching emphasizes that restraint leads to four beautiful qualities: inner delight, composure, contentment in solitude, and true contentment (santuṭṭhi) - the hallmark of liberation. This practice is presented as fundamental preparation for meditation, as unrestrained senses create constant distraction from mindful awareness. Perfect for practitioners seeking to understand how ethical conduct supports deeper meditation practice.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhasa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhasa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhasa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So the subject this week is restraint. I shall do my usual chanting and we'll take it from there.

Cakkhuna samvaro sadhu, sadhu sotena samvaro, ghanena samvaro sadhu, sadhu jivhaya samvaro. Kayena samvaro sadhu, sadhu vachaya samvaro, manasa samvaro sadhu, sadhu sabbattha samvaro. Sabbattha samvuto bhikkhu, sabbadukkha pamuccati. Hatthasamyato padasamyato, vachasamyato samyatuttamo, ajjhatarato samahito, eko santusito tam ahu bhikkhu.

And that translates as: Restraint of the eye is good. Good is the restraint of the ear. Restraint of the nose is good. Good is the restraint of the tongue. Restraint of the body is good and good is the restraint of speech. Restraint of the mind is good. Good is restraint in all circumstances. Restrained in all circumstances, the Bhikkhu is released from all

suffering. The one with hands restrained, feet restrained, speech restrained, who is foremost among the restrained, inwardly delighted, composed, solitary and contented. He is called a Bhikkhu.

Now Bhikkhu, remember, stands for everybody. It's one of those figures of speech, all hands on deck. So when you see monk in the scriptures or anywhere, it's everybody.

So just a couple of little words there. What the Buddha is saying is that if we do practice restraint, we will achieve this inner joy, and we will be resolved and collected, settled, composed. We'll also be solitary - it's just being happy by oneself. It's not the same as loneliness where you are dependent on somebody else for your well-being or well-feeling. To be solitary means that you're happy just being by yourself. And finally, *santusito*, which means contented. And that's one of the signs of somebody who is fully liberated, a sense of contentment, which means there's no wrong desires. It's as simple as that.

Now, this word *samvara* that we're looking at, it just means restraint, full stop. In the dictionary, that's the only word he's got, restraint.

So we'll go straight to the stories. I shall use this little book here which has all the stories in it. So the first two - the story is this: Once there were five bhikkhus in Savatthi, five monks, and each of them practiced restraint of just one of the five senses, and each of them claimed that what he was practicing was the most difficult, and they could not come to an agreement. Finally, they reported their disagreements to the Buddha who told them, each of the senses is just as difficult to control as the others, but the bhikkhu's control of all five senses will escape suffering.

The story that goes with the second one - that's the last one which ends with delighted within, composed, solitary and contented - once there was a bhikkhu who was very skilled at throwing stones. He could even hit a fast moving object. And one day while sitting with another bhikkhu after having taken a bath in the river, he saw two geese flying over and he said to his friend he could hit the eye of one of the geese. So he took a pebble, aimed and threw it at one of the geese. The pebble struck the bird's eye. The bird cried out in pain and dropped dead at the feet of the young Bhikkhu. Other Bhikkhus seeing this incident reported it to the Buddha. Monks are always snitches! And he admonished the young Bhikkhu. He said, my son, why have you killed the bird? Especially as a Bhikkhu, you should be practicing loving kindness to all beings and should also be striving ardently for liberation. A Bhikkhu must control his thoughts, words, and deeds.

Now, it might seem you have to be 21 before you can actually become a monk, so somehow I think this refers to the *samaneras*. You can become a *samanera* at the age of eight, and I was at one monastery which was a teaching monastery that was teaching Pali mainly to - well, they looked to me about 10 onwards. And I saw two 10 year olds with catapults going after birds. So as they say, boys will be boys, I suppose.

So that's the little stories that surround it. It doesn't make sense to me, of course, if geese are flying overhead and you throw a stone and hit one in the eye and it falls to your feet, there's something wrong with the dynamics. But anyway, you never know with these stories.

However, the commentary - so remember there's always commentaries on the actual stories, commentaries on the verses, and there are commentaries on commentaries. And these days, of course, there's a whole industry of studying the scriptures again. So it says restraint over the senses - and remember the sixth sense in Buddhism is the mind, mind, heart - is one of the basic requirements for really beneficial meditation practice. Without this control, the meditation cannot progress because we will always be distracted from it by input from one of the five, six senses. Therefore, we must practice concentration and mindfulness in our daily lives and then apply this tool in our meditation practice. So here we have the importance of restraint.

Now, if we just go into the whole idea of restraint - so it's not a word that we use these days, is it? I have a memory of my father telling me to restrain myself, but I've never heard it being used these days. You walk into a department store, you don't see a sign saying please restrain yourself, or into a restaurant it would be good for you to restrain yourself. It just doesn't happen. We've become so much involved in consumerism. And in the dictionary it says a measure or condition that keeps what someone or something under control - so that's of course our own inner desires.

And when you look for synonyms, it really pinpoints it. Self-control, self-discipline, self-possession, moderation, prudence, reserve. So that's what we're actually practicing.

There's a lovely case in the scriptures of Pasenadi who was the king of Kosala which is north of the Ganges and who was a friend and supporter of the Buddha. I presume that these people, the warrior caste would know each other, especially the leaders of tribes like the Sakyas, which the Buddha belonged to. He would have met people like Pasenadi because he was subject to the kingdom of Kosala. They were subjects. So he was a good friend. Anyway, as he entered into middle age, he put on a lot of weight. So he went to the Buddha and asked what he could do. And so the Buddha said to him, tell your servant to put a little less food on the plate every day so that you don't actually

notice that you're eating less. So every day you take a little bit off and then a little bit more and a little bit more. Now, it doesn't say whether it worked or not. Well, at least it's something we could try for ourselves if we find ourselves overeating.

So, restraints. It's all part of the whole process of renunciation, and this renunciation remember is not trying to kill our senses. We're not trying not to enjoy things. We're just trying to see that distinction between enjoying something and indulging it - it's a difficult one to get because they're very close.

Unlike aversion, the aversion or fear pushes what you don't want away. But indulgence sucks into what you want. So trying to separate them is quite difficult. And it's good to take one of the senses. So I suppose the one that we're always feeding at least two or three times a day, if not more, is eating. And just to go into the body and sense how much hunger is in there and to know that part of it is natural appetite and part of it's this override. And then just to be careful we don't slip into that override.

It's the same with - I was thinking, the generation, I had a great aunt. She was the last child of my grandfather, great grandfather, who was an Italian, by the way, came from Milan. And he married two Irish women because in the north of England there were - the Catholics were either Italian or Irish so they would have met in church or whatever. And she was the last child of the second marriage. I think he had something like 12, 15 kids in those days. She - I remember being with her in the kitchen, I was only a kid, being with her in the kitchen and she was preparing cucumber sandwiches and sandwiches with jam. And when she took the butter, she put it onto the piece of bread and then scraped it off. And then when she put the jam on she did the same - she put the jam on and then scraped it off so that what you were left with were these pieces of bread with a hint of butter and just a little splat of jam and the cucumbers were so finely chopped. And it just takes you back to those days when things were scarce, for heaven's sake, especially during the war and afterwards. I always remember that.

So what are the qualities that we need to develop in order to develop this *samvara*, this restraint? Well the first one is *nana*, which means to understand. So obviously we've got to understand why we have to restrain ourselves. I can't imagine many people really understanding why you should do that. I mean they can understand not getting completely drunk, but why not get tipsy? It's a little bit beyond comprehension these days.

So remember, it's all part and parcel of letting go of our attachment to this form. And we experience the form through the senses. Everything that we know, everything that we experience is coming through the five senses, six senses, the sixth being of course the heart-mind. So emotions that arise, thoughts, images that arise are always coming

up onto a sense door within the mind itself. And in fact everything that comes in through the five physical senses enters again through the mind door. So for instance at the ear what you actually experience is pressure - you don't, it's not a sound, it's just pressure, and it's the next moment when it enters the mind that gives it a sound. So everything is happening within the mind.

And it's the understanding that what we're experiencing, we also have this relationship with it. I mean, we're trying to find happiness through it, full stop, which is understandable. And there's a certain amount of happiness and joy to be had. But then it's this override. So understanding that is really the path of renunciation. And part of it is to be able to restrain ourselves when we see we're overdoing it.

So I remember there were these two young fellows I met in Sri Lanka when I was there. And they were traveling around and they were taking all sorts of drugs in order to maintain a sense of contentment and happiness. So even when they were traveling on a bus, just to make it easy for them, they took tranquilizers. It was just amazing when I talked to them. And there was no arguing about it. That's what they thought, well, that's what life was about.

The next one is understanding the restraints by way of the moral practices. And by the way, that comes to what in Christian monasticism you call imperfections. So we're not talking about killing people and all that. We're talking about just those overrides where we're being unwholesome or unskillful.

And I thought I might read to you some of the rules of monks that the Buddha established. And there's right at the end, there are 75, what are called training rules, *Sekhiyyadhamma*. I'll just read one or two of them. So for instance, I shall wear the robe round, all the way round, perfectly round. Now, one time Sariputta was dragging his robe on the floor and a little *samanera* came up and told him what he was doing. And he praised the *samanera* for helping him get his robe right.

I shall walk, sit etc with downcast eyes. See now that's what we do when we're on retreat - when you're on retreat you don't want this constant barrage of images into your mind so you keep your eyes lowered or you keep them closed. But according to this as a monastic I should be doing this all the time.

I shall not go laughing loudly in inhabited places. I shall not sit laughing loudly in inhabited places. I should go quietly in inhabited places. So it's all to do with deportment and how people see you. But it's also part of the training.

I shall not go fidgeting in the body, fidgeting in the arms, fidgeting the head. I shall eat alms food with attention to the bowl. See and there's a lovely one here just to finish off: I shall not look enviously at another's bowl. And I shall not make up extra large mouthfuls. I shall not speak with a mouthful. I shall not eat stuffing out the cheeks.

The final ones or one of the final ones is: I shall not make the sound *chapu chapu* - that's when I'm eating - and I shall not make the sound *suru suru* when I'm drinking - slurping.

So these 75 little indications of training come towards the end of the *Patimokkha*, which is all about really that sense of containment, of self-restraint, deportment, etc. So that's to do with the second quality, which is ethical standards.

The next one is awareness, of course. Now this awareness, remember, is an intuitive awareness. So it's a sensitivity. As soon as you see that there's an override, you're sensitive to it. So it's really beginning to develop that sense of knowing when the line's being crossed. And that's through practice. That's just through practice.

Remember that awareness is always two qualities. It's an intuitive awareness. And if the intuition is badly informed, then it becomes a delusive awareness. So the Buddha doesn't talk about awareness. He talks about right awareness, *samma-sati*.

I mean, if you rob a bank, you're going to be really aware, really awake and aware. But unfortunately, it's not the path to freedom. When I reminded myself of this, I remember this little interview where a well-known bank robber in America was asked, why do you rob banks? And he said, well, that's where the money is. I thought, that's a very good answer.

The fourth one is *viriya*, which means effort, commitment. And that's what we're often lacking, that we'll do it for a little while and then we stop. And then we do it for a little while and then we stop or we back off. But it's this real commitment to know this distinction and to keep working at it, which will have the results.

And then finally there's *khanti*, which is a sense of forbearance. Now that's the difficult thing, you see, because when you restrain yourself, there is the pain of letting go. And that's what you've got to bear. So just wanting that another cup of tea, another coffee, another biscuit, another mouthful, and just waiting until that desire exhausts itself is not a pleasant thing to do. But if we do that, then you get this little bit at the end where you get that sense of relief, the sense of release from that over desire. And it's really taking it to that point that makes us realize that there's a good ending to this process.

And if we go back to the good ending, the Buddha is quite clear. With it we are inwardly delighted, composed, solitudinous, and contented. So these are the prizes that we get if we practice restraint.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I have not caused even greater confusion, and that you will by your devotion to restraint be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Dhammapada 90: The Arahant

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 19 min

In this profound exploration of Dhammapada verse 90, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the qualities that define an arahant - one who has reached the journey's end. The verse describes someone "freed of sorrow, liberated in all ways, released from all bonds, with no fever." Through a traditional story of Devadatta's attempt to harm the Buddha, Bhante illustrates the arahant's mastery over physical pain and mental distress.

The teaching focuses on the four kāyagathas (bodily bonds) that must be released: abhijjhā (covetousness), byāpāda (ill will), sīlabbataparāmāsa (attachment to rules and rituals), and diṭṭhiparāmāsa (dogmatic fanaticism). Bhante explains how these bonds, rooted in the three unwholesome roots of greed, hatred, and delusion, keep beings tied to saṃsāric existence. He emphasizes that while rituals and rules have their place in practice, attachment to them as ends in themselves becomes a hindrance.

The discussion reveals the paradox of ethical purification and liberation - complete ethical purity requires the dissolution of self-view, yet self-view only disappears at full awakening. This accessible yet profound teaching offers practical wisdom for understanding both the goal of the path and the balanced approach needed in our practice of sīla, samādhi, and paññā.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sambha Sambhodassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sambha Sambhodassa Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sambha sambodasa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

I'm looking at the *Dhammapada* number 90, and it's about what makes an *arahat*. It gives us some indication, shall we say. So I shall do the little chanting:

Gatadino visokasa vimuttasa hi sabbadhi sabbaganthehi mutvasa parila na vijjati

The translation from Gil Fronsdal is: "For someone at the journey's end, freed of sorrow, liberated in all ways, released from all bonds, no fever exists." And Thanissaro says: "In one who has gone the full distance, is free from sorrow, fully released in all respects, has abandoned all the bonds, no fever is found."

We'll go into exactly what all that means, but let's look at the little story which sometimes throws light. On one occasion, Devadatta tried to kill the Buddha by pushing a big rock on him from Vulture's Peak. The rock struck a ledge on the side of the mountain and a splinter struck the big toe of the Buddha. He was taken to the mangrove grove monastery of Jivaka. There, Jivaka, the renowned physician, attended to him and applied some medicine on the toe and bandaged it. Jivaka then left to see another patient in town but promised to return and remove the bandage in the evening.

When Jivaka tried to return, the city gates were already closed and he could not attend to the Buddha. He was very upset because if the bandage was not removed in time, the whole body would be affected and the Buddha would be very ill. The Buddha knew that Jivaka would not be able to attend him, so he asked Venerable Ananda to remove the bandage and found the wound was healed.

Jivaka came to the monastery early next morning to inquire whether he had felt great pain and distress the previous night. The Buddha replied, "Jivaka, ever since I attained enlightenment, I had the ability to stop pain and distress at any time whenever I needed to do so." Then the Buddha explained the nature of the mind of the enlightened one, and that's what this verse is.

It's interesting that he says pain doesn't feel pain, or he can stop the feeling of pain. I had a student who got kidney stones, and they're said to be extremely painful. He was in A&E and he decided to sit in meditation and the pain disappeared. When the nurse came to take him to the doctor, it reappeared again. So there's something about where your attention is, but I also think that the body does have an ability to anaesthetise itself. I believe I'm right in saying that in war, if you're shot or if you have a serious injury, you don't actually feel it - you feel it afterwards.

But the Buddha says he has the power to stop that anyway. And distress, of course, would be a mental state. He would be free of that anyway. On that point, of course, there is the *arahat* who is suffering severely, very painful feelings from an illness. He's quite old and he goes to the Buddha and tells him, "I'm going to take the knife" - which was a way of saying he's going to commit suicide. And the Buddha simply said, "Well, do as you think is fit." And he did. He committed suicide, took his own life. So that's something to ponder about.

If we look at some of the words here, the *gata dino* - *gata* just means having done the path. So it is a fairly straightforward translation. *Visokasa* means without sorrow. This *soka* actually seemingly comes from the Vedic *shoka*, which actually means the flame of a fire, but then later had the sense of burning grief. So very strong words here.

Then he's free from these bonds, which we'll come to in a minute - they're a special classification. And the word used for the ending of sorrow is *parilaho* - free from fever. It's a very strong word, free from fever. It would seem to me that we're talking about fairly extreme emotional states here, but really somebody who's fully liberated wouldn't feel any negative feelings.

That doesn't mean to say that sorrow would not be felt. Sorrow is that heart connection with the suffering of somebody else, so I can't imagine that disappearing. But the big thing is, of course, that the *arahat* is liberated from these *gantha*. A *gantha* is a knot or a bond. The full word is *kaya gantha*. *Kaya* means body, and it refers both to the physical and the mental body. So it's basically saying those things that keep you tied to this form of becoming, this form of existence.

The four ties - you won't be surprised by them, I don't think - are covetousness (*abhija*), ill will (*vipada*), an attachment to rules and rituals, and dogmatic fanaticism. If we look at these, you'll see that they are all these lists of what is unwholesome in us - like the five hindrances, the ten fetters - they're always rooted in the three unwholesome roots, which is acquisitiveness, aversion (which remember includes both aversion and its sort of twin, which is fear), and delusion.

The first one, *abhija*, is obviously to do with *loba* - that's the word for it - which is greed or acquisitiveness. But here, it gives a certain slant to it. It's called covetousness. You always want what somebody else has. Sometimes when you're in line with monks for food and people put things into your bowl, you're often tempted to see what the other person got which you didn't get. So it's that wanting, not only just wanting something, coveting something, but this added thing of wanting what somebody else has.

You can see how greed creates that dissatisfaction, that conflict. As soon as you say, "I want what you have," you're putting yourself in a sense in competition with the other person or against the other person. So already it's not a great mental state to develop.

The next one, of course, is ill will, *byāpāda*, malevolence, ill will. So this gives it a more active, rather than a passive hatred - an active form where when your heart feels hatred, it'll manifest in some angry way, in some way which is antagonistic, conflictual. So those two things have gone in the *arahat*.

The final two - the first one is an attachment to ritual, to rules and rituals. Does that mean that we shouldn't be doing any? No, it's really what we believe the ritual to be doing. So for instance, when we take refuges and precepts, it's really just creating an atmosphere within us of devotion, of commitment, of reminding ourselves what our path is. But if we were to believe that taking the refuge and precepts was quite enough

and we don't have to do anything else - just light a few candles, burn a joss stick, say the refuges and precepts and that's it, I'll get on with my life, I'll keep on being as I am - then I think we'd be sorely disappointed.

It's a case of recognising that there are bound to be rituals in our lives. In fact, we have rituals that we keep, just as the morning ablutions, for instance. There'll be a little ritual that we've performed for ourselves when we prepare our meals. So it's not as though rituals don't have a place in our lives - it's an habitual thing. But I think what a ritual does is it gives it meaning. So rather than just slapping the food on the plate and chucking it down into the stomach, if one takes one's time with a little reflection and then eats mindfully, it gives it meaning. It gives it meaning in the fullness of our practice. And that's what a ritual is meant to do.

When it comes to rules, there are overt and covert rules. Obviously when you go into somebody's house, it's presumed that you're not going to steal from them. That's an obvious rule, you might say. But there are also covert rules, like you don't move the furniture around when you're staying at somebody's house. I always remember, I invited my mother to come and stay with me. She came and I had a flower pot with a flower flowering in the front room. When I came down, she'd moved it. It was just one of those things that your mother does that just presses the button. I remember shouting at her, "This is my house, leave me alone! It goes here." Sort of like a little kid. Dear me. Wouldn't have been so bad if I weren't over thirty.

So there are these rules and regulations. Rules, of course, are what establish an institution. Every institution has a set of rules. The big ones, like democracy, you've got your constitution. The monks have their own rules and regulations. So they have a place.

But if I as a monastic were to say to myself, "My job is to keep the rule absolutely perfectly and in so doing I will become enlightened," I again would be very disappointed because that is not an end in itself. Often you do meet monks who have that mentality because you get caught in this double bind, a catch-22. You can't become fully liberated until you are ethically completely purified. But you can't be ethically completely purified until you become liberated because you don't lose the core reason for our unwholesomeness until the point of liberation. And that is the sense of self or the notion of self. That doesn't go to the last bit.

So it's an impossible situation to try and negotiate. One works on one side, purifying the heart, doing the right thing, and you keep on investigating the process. At some point, hopefully, we'll find ourselves liberated from all suffering.

The next one is this dogmatic fanaticism. That of course again is based on misunderstanding, upon delusion. The Buddha points to three qualities when we have that "I'm right and everybody else is wrong and this is the way, this is the only way" and all that. He says, first of all, there is the wrong view. Even if the wrong view is "this is the only way" or "I'm right," and even if I'm right, I'll be wrong in saying that this is the only way.

Although he does say it at the beginning of the discourse on how to establish right mindfulness: "This is the one-way path." But he doesn't say this is the only way. By the way, it has been translated as that. But in fact, this *ekayano* - just as a little aside - this one-way path is meant to be as opposed to the two-way path, which is concentration plus insight practice. So what the Buddha is saying is that you don't need the concentration, you can just go straight with the insight practice. That's what it's referring to. But you'll find, for instance, Nyanaponika translating it as "this is the only way." So there is that misunderstanding, that wrong understanding.

Then there's that emotional attachment to it. There's always a clinging around it, and that's what causes us to be angry when people disagree with us. And of course, underneath all that, there is the sense of me. So I'm defining myself as "this is me. This is my understanding. I am a socialist. I am a capitalist. I am a Christian," and so on. That connection of an identity brings about this emotional clinging to a particular view, and that's what causes us to get into arguments. War, for instance.

So how do we get out of that? Well, it's recognising that we all have opinions. That's the way it is. Everybody has a view, an opinion. But when we actually begin to perceive that as a perspective, it does allow us to listen to other people. It doesn't mean to say that we're going to be converted by them. It may be that it nuances what we actually believe. It may be that it changes what we actually believe. But in order to do that, you've got to let go of this business of "I'm right and everybody else is wrong."

So here is another thing that disappears with the Buddha. It's interesting when people come to him and say, "I believe this - what do you believe?" He always asks them first of all to explain what they actually believe, what is their position. Then having heard it, he will begin to question it and slowly undermine that position if it's wrong. Once the person begins to feel that their argument isn't so strong, it's not right, that's when the Buddha puts in the Four Noble Truths and away they go.

So just to go over those things, go back to the original verse. We're talking about our practice coming to a fulfilment, the journey's end. We can be free of all sorrow. Sorrow is such a big word. It's not only grief about something, it's perhaps grief about some-

thing that we ought to have done, something that we did do, and so on. Of course it's liberated in all ways, and that's defined in this particular verse as released from all the bonds.

These bonds we find are this acquisitiveness, this aversion and finally these two wrong understandings which are around rules and rituals and opinions. The final result, of course, is to be liberated from all the emotional distress that comes from having these wrong views and these wrong attitudes. All that disappears. And that's the wonder of the practice.

So that's the verse on number 90 on what it is to become an *arahat*. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance and that by your devotion to practice you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Vita Quotidiana - Daily Practice and Spiritual Life

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 1h11

In this comprehensive talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the essential elements of bringing Buddhist practice into everyday life. He begins by clarifying the nature of karma, emphasizing that our real spiritual work involves addressing the suffering within our own minds rather than external circumstances.

The talk provides practical guidance for daily practice, including morning meditation routines, managing workplace stress through Dhamma principles, and evening reflection practices. Bhante discusses the Noble Eightfold Path in practical terms, showing how insights into impermanence (anicca) and unsatisfactoriness (dukkha) can transform our relationships and daily interactions.

A significant portion addresses the dynamics of love versus attachment in relationships, explaining how attachment manifests as control and offering guidance from the Arahant example of mutual consideration. The discourse also covers the four roads to success (iddhipāda) - desire, effort, commitment, and discrimination - as qualities essential for any meaningful achievement.

The talk concludes with an explanation of taking refuge in the Triple Gem (Buddha, Dhamma, Saṅgha) and the five training precepts (pañca-sīla), presented not as commandments but as a path of spiritual training that supports liberation from suffering.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

I just wanted to say something extra about *kamma* because I realised that I hadn't really made clear what the real kamma is. So if we remember that when we do an action, it has an effect into society, into the world. But we don't know what's going to come back to us because of surrounding conditions, and we don't really know the effect inwardly on our psyche.

Now, then we have to remember what the Buddha's teaching is concerned with. So he's concerned with suffering and bringing suffering to an end. So where is this suffering? It's not out in the world, it's within our own minds.

So in terms of the process of liberation, the kamma that we have to deal with is the one that's inside us. And remember that within us there is a given pain, you might say, mental and physical pain. So some of it is natural to the body, illness and so on. And the other is, of course, coming from our habits, from our unwholesome habits.

Now, how we relate to that is also something we've taught ourselves. And this reaction is the direct cause of our suffering. And underneath that, there are these wrong views. So this is our kamma. And this is the kamma that we have to work with.

This evening I just want to talk about daily practice and some other things too, because usually, especially for beginners, there are lots of questions about that.

So remember that you've got to bring this practice into your daily life. And the morning sitting, the morning meditation is I think absolutely important, because you're setting yourself on the right path right there at the beginning of the day. At the end of the sitting, when we do a reflection on the sitting, after that, bring to mind what is going to happen, we hope, during the day. And where you see there's a possibility of anxiety, irritation, etc., really bring it to mind and make the decision that you're going to work with that as it comes up.

So, you know, especially at work, sometimes relationships can be pretty awful. Sometimes we can feel overloaded by the amount of work we have. So recognising that, knowing how you react to it, and saying to yourself, right, well, when I get there I'll work with it in a *Dharma* way. In other words, skillfully. So that's important.

The next point of important practice, if you can make it into a habit, is after the day, after a day's work or when you've been out for the day, just to sit and allow whatever accumulations have happened during the day to rise. So there may be anxiety, irritations, excitements. So just let everything cool down. And then you have an evening ahead of you, see?

And this is something you can do in little bits all the way through the day. So this is something I brought into my own working life at the time and it reserved so much energy - which was to keep stopping throughout the day and just let whatever accumulation, let it exhaust itself a bit.

Even in the mid-day break, often I wouldn't go into the staff room. So I would go out and sit in the local church. I had to knock on the door for the... it was a Church of England church. I'd knock on the door and ask, can I have the keys? They give me the keys. I'd just sit there, you know. Of course, churches are always quiet, they're always lovely places to sit.

So, I think if you get into the habit of doing that, you'll see it really does save a lot of energy. Yes, because remember that if in the morning you become irritated with something, you know, somebody has said something to you that's irritating. So, you know, everybody has that experience that you're sitting there during the coffee break by yourself, and before you know it, the mind's off. It's going, it's going, it's going. By evening, you've got a headache.

So it's a case of just being with, after every action whatever, just to stop, feel something, just let it go. So that's important.

Now in the evening it's also really important to prepare to go to sleep. There was a survey done in England a while back and people just aren't sleeping well, and one of the reasons is that they're going to bed straight off Facebook or a horror movie. So you have to allow this organism to just begin to relax. You have to allow your body to start relaxing.

So half an hour before you intend to go to bed, just cool down. You can listen to some music, you can meditate, you can listen to some quiet music. Just whatever you feel is relaxing, just drawing the energy down.

So that would be a daily routine. And if you can, maybe join a group once a week, once every two weeks or something, because this does raise your commitment.

The Buddha says, there's a passage where Ananda, who was the Buddha's companion for the last twenty years, looking after him... So the Buddha tells about Ananda who was his companion for twenty years of his life. He told him that for him a good companion was half of the spiritual life. Half the spiritual life. And the Buddha said, oh no, Ananda, it's all the spiritual life. Yes, and he points out, if you have good companions, you tend to do what is good for you.

And remember we live in a society which is not driven by spiritual values. So it's very difficult to maintain that sort of spiritual view of our lives. I mean, if you consider one of these Islamic countries like Saudi Arabia. Now, we might not like many things about Saudi Arabia, but it is a society which is geared towards the spiritual. So if somebody at the prayer time - noon, I can't remember the times - but if somebody at the prayer time just stops the car, gets out of the car, puts the carpet down and starts praying, everybody thinks, oh, that's wonderful. Here they put you in jail. Or they lock you away.

So, having to live in a society which doesn't have spiritual values makes things more difficult for us, that's all. And of course finally to try and get on to a retreat every year.

Now just on that, people are always slightly concerned about progress. Unfortunately, spiritual progress isn't like studying a subject. So you get a diploma and then you get a B.A. and an M.A. and a doctorate. Yes, you get a diploma, then a master's, a doctorate, no.

I mean, there are, of course, these attainments, what we call the spiritual attainments, which arise really when the time is ripe. There are spiritual achievements that come when the time is right. Yeah, you can't push them.

But through our practice what we can begin to experience is a change in the way we relate to the life we're leading. So you might find that you just become less angry, more generous.

So this practice has a systemic effect because in a sense you've got to take whatever understanding you have and it's got to be translated into an attitude. So this is the *Eightfold Path*, you see? It's the Eightfold Path.

For instance, beginning to really perceive impermanence and know that you don't have complete control over your life. So in the morning you remind yourself something might happen today, good and bad, and I have to be open to it. And to work with it. Not try to ignore it or to try to go against what the circumstance is actually coming at you with.

So, for instance, somebody might call you during the day and ask for some help, but because you've set yourself on this path, you're not listening to the call, you see. Recognising impermanence makes you much more malleable, able to move and change as the circumstance demands.

And then we have to bring it into this right speech, the way we speak. I mean, most of us have given up telling great big lies, whoppers, great big lies. But it's surprising how we exaggerate things. So this borders on a mild level of dishonesty. Yes, and just to be aware when we're talking for talking's sake, wasting time.

That doesn't mean that you don't go through the normal pleasantries of life, such as when you meet somebody. And yeah, that's it really.

And then there's right action. So this is to do with just remaining as close as we can to those five training rules. But it also has a positive side of really seeing our lives as an exercise in being virtuous.

Our delusion manifests in the way we relate. So the Buddha's teaching, remember, is all about ethics. You can always ask yourself, what is my relationship to this, to this object? What is my relationship to this person and so on? And if you perceive it to be wholesome for yourself, for somebody else, or for both of you, then that's what we should do.

And then there's right livelihood. It's interesting that he should include this. It's interesting he should include right livelihood. Because it would normally be included in right action. But if you consider the effect on your personality and character that the job you do has upon you.

So, for instance, the virtues that you would develop as a soldier, as opposed to, say, being a nurse. Or a policeman. So, one of the virtues of the policeman is that he's always suspicious. So it affects you, doesn't it? It affects the way you look at the world.

Oh, and then the last three are to do with our practice and meditation, right effort, right mindfulness, right concentration. And he often says, especially when you're doing something, an awareness imbued, saturated with loving kindness. Even as you close the fridge door. With great loving kindness.

So, if we can develop that sort of attitude in our lives, you see, your heart lifts. You feel more happy?

The next thing I want to point out is this virtuous circle: gratitude, generosity and renunciation.

So now if you consider just for a minute how much you've received from your parents, from friends, from society, education, medicine, from your practice. When you actually consider how much you received, you know, it's impossible to pay it back. When you realise how much you have received, you realise that it is impossible to give it back. The Buddha said that if you carried your parents on your shoulders the whole of your life, you would not have repaid them for the gift of life. This is presuming that you want to continue living.

So, when you think about that, then of course the heart wants to try and give something back, you see. And this is your generosity.

Now, you can be generous with your wealth and you can be generous with your time. Now, every time you give something away for the benefit of another, you could have used that for yourself. Every time you give away some of your wealth, well you

could have used it for a day by the seaside. Ice cream. When you give your time to something, to somebody, or to any occasion, it was time that you could have used just for yourself.

So every time you're generous, you're also practising renunciation. Now, if it's to be a true act of generosity with a feeling of really giving something that you didn't really want to give, then there has to be that little bit of pain. And that's stretching your renunciation a bit, you see, your hold on things.

So now in the commentaries, it doesn't say this in the actual scriptures, but the commentaries say that this is a path to liberation. And you can understand that if you see that the process of liberation is the process of becoming more and more non-attached.

Just one little thing that I suffered from and I think a lot of people do - a little thing that I have suffered, and I think many people do, is that you say yes too quickly. For example, a friend has a lot of gardening. And they call you to ask you for a little help. And you say, oh yes, yes, yes. Saturday morning. And then afterwards you think, oh. And then come Saturday morning you ring them and say I have a cerebral headache.

So you know it's always good just to pause a moment before you say yes. It's very difficult if you're in the habit of saying yes too quickly, it's very difficult to say let me get back to you, let me think about it.

The other thing is about love and attachment. So long as there's a self there will be attachment. And remember attachment is a dependency on something or somebody for our personal well-being, happiness, joy, etc. So this process of generosity is helping us to let go of things. And this process of generosity helps us to let things go.

But when we bring that attachment into relationships then it always manifests in various ways. But the underlying attitude from attachment is one of control.

So if your partner or your spouse doesn't do what you expect them to do then that's when you get angry. Or if they do something that you don't expect them to do or something strange, then that's when, or they change, they change, then you get this feeling of anxiety that you're losing the person.

And I think I mentioned it before, when you stop laughing at your partner's jokes and you get bored with them, then you see you're expecting them to entertain you. So, if you catch your relationship, you'll see when this attitude of control is coming in and that's how this attachment manifests.

Now the opposite of that is to think that you should suffer everything because you love the person. Ah, and then you become the one who becomes controlled. So even there you've got to be clear as to what your relationship is and what you're prepared to work with. I mean, love doesn't mean that you allow yourself to be abused, full stop. It's a tricky area, you see.

And, you know, just the attachment of a parent to a child. You could say it's almost natural. It's impossible for a parent not to have some special feeling towards their child. But again, notice how sometimes it manifests - how your child is absolutely perfect, but next door he's an absolute... you want to strangle him. Your child is perfect, while the one next door you'd like to strangle.

And how, for instance, if you see your child hurt itself... for example, if you see that your child hurts himself... but you know, it's nothing, it's just a scratch or something, even though they're crying their eyes out. So then you very calmly, you know, you hug the child. But if you see the child may have done some real damage, they've broken their arm or banged their head badly, then there's panic.

Then you have to ask yourself, is this panic necessary? And what's it doing for the child? Now, unfortunately, you can't stop the panic because panic panics. So... but as soon as somebody who meditates is aware of that, they don't allow it to completely control their actions.

So if you keep your sensitivity open to how you're relating to people, you'll see pretty clearly where love is and where control is.

There's one example in the scriptures where the Buddha asks these three *Arahats* how they live so peacefully together. There is a story in the scriptures that says that Buddha asked these three Arahants how they could live so peacefully. And he asks Anuruddha, how do you maintain this peacefulness between the three of you? When I wake up in the morning, I say to myself, I shall put aside what I want to do and do what the others want to do.

So if you can see, if you're in a family or in a group of friends, if everybody were to say that, you can see that there's some diplomacy to go on, but eventually there wouldn't be any argument. There would be a discussion, but there wouldn't be any argument.

Now, this only works if everybody says that to themselves. This putting aside what I want to do and do what the others want to do, this only really works if everybody says the same thing. Otherwise you'll find yourself doing what everybody else wants to do. But at least it gives us an idea of how we might suggest to our partners and friends how they might approach a situation.

The other thing is to talk about these roads of success or roads of power. Some of you will know them, the *Iddhipāda*. When you practice in this way, with these absorptions, then you can get these powers. You can walk through a wall. Now, that at first might seem ridiculous. But it's the ability to separate the subtle body, the mental body, from the physical. And the mental body is not bound by the physicality of the world. So perhaps you can try that this evening, eh?

Then there's telepathy, which, believe it or not, has actually been proven as a power, as an ability. They've done experiments where certain people who do have this gift of telepathy and they've sent the other people in a submarine down in the ocean, so that it can never be explained as some sort of electromagnetic manifestation. And yes, they were able to communicate. Oh, I forgot his name. It'll come to me.

Clear audience, where you can hear things which a person would not normally hear. Hear people's thoughts, read their minds. You can bring up all your past lives. And you can also sometimes see the destination of people, where they're actually going to go. And the last one, interestingly enough, is of course the extinction of the mental intoxicants. The *āsavā*, that's what they're called. These three *āsavā*, sometimes four, are the basic delusions, the manifestations of that basic ignorance: sense desire, the desire to seek happiness through the senses; the desire to become; and wrong views, wrong understandings. Ignorance is also one of them. But the others arise out of that ignorance.

But these qualities, the roads to success, can be used for anything in your life. And if you think about anything that you've really wanted to do, you'll see that these qualities were there. First of all there has to be that very strong desire, zeal. You've got to really want it. Secondly there has to be the effort to begin to manifest that desire. The Buddha, in the discourse on how to establish mindfulness, uses the word *ātāpī*. *Satipaṭṭhāna*, mindfulness. *Ātāpī*. And this *ātāpī* is the energy of self-mortification. If you, well, as an example, if you think of these Olympic sports people, how much they practice every day with the goal in mind of getting that medal.

So it also means that you've got to put your whole heart and mind into the project. That you can't be taken off on this little thing and that little thing. You're absolutely centered on what you want to achieve. And you've got to maintain a certain level of dis-

crimination, of investigation. So if you think about that right: a real determined desire; a real effort to make that manifest; a complete commitment of your heart and mind to the project; and then just keeping alive that sort of, you might say, helpful doubt, just looking for the way things are, keeping in contact with the way things are moving. Making sure that that aim is not like blinkers on a horse, that you're aware of other things, you see.

So I'm sure you've all done that once in your life. I'm sure you've all done it at least once in your life. So these are called the roads to success or the roads to power. So when you want to do something, you can ask yourself, how much do I really want to do this? And if you feel that there's not enough desire, but you want to do it, then you have to sort of build up your desire. You have to cajole yourself.

For instance, just watching the breath. You want to do it, but you can't really do it. Then you ask yourself, do I want to do it? And like these athletes, you have to say, yes! And it's like lifting weights. Just one more. Just one more. So you get that sort of energy. So this is what we're looking at when we say zeal.

So that gives you, I hope, some ideas about daily life. In Zen they say if there's a separation between the meditation and daily life, by a hair's breadth you've lost the path.

So finally, I just want to talk about taking refuges and precepts. I know some of you have done it. But there comes a point, I think, in a spiritual life when, in a sense, you want to make a decision about your commitment. For instance, when I began practicing in Zen, after about a year, every year they do this particular ceremony. There was an occasion to take the refuges and precepts and I felt at the time that I had found my path. And so I went through that ceremony.

And just like any ceremony which punctuates our lives, it gives you a sort of starting point for a particular commitment. Like for instance a marriage. There's a social event in which that is proclaimed. And then that changes your life. So there comes a point in the spiritual practice where you may feel you just want to commit yourself to this path.

So what is it that you would commit yourself to? Well the first thing is the Buddha. Now the Buddha is an exemplar and a teacher. Because he actually lived through this training process. And that's why he was able to teach it so intimately. So, it's a sort of understanding that the originator of this particular dispensation really was expressing what he had personally experienced.

But spiritually, it's the Buddha within that you're taking refuge in. That's your real refuge. So there is an act of confidence that there is something in us that is seeking liberation and will attain it. So that's taking refuge in the Buddha.

Taking refuge in the Dhamma. The Dhamma is both the understanding, the teachings, but also the practice. And I think you'll find across all Buddhisms the same basic teachings. There may be different interpretations, but the basic teaching remains the same. So the basic teachings are the Four Noble Truths, the Eightfold Path, the Dependent Origination. That's the psychology. And the three characteristics of existence. So that's your basis. I've never come across a Buddhism that doesn't teach that in some way or other.

When it comes to the practice, you don't have to stay with just one practice. I myself moved from Zen to this *vipassanā* and in the field of *vipassanā* I also practiced other forms. So I did some work with Goenkaji and also I went to certain different practices especially in Thailand. But eventually I centered on this practice because this is the one that had the greatest impact on me. And I practiced it enough to feel that I had really grasped the technique. So in the end I was able to just practice by myself. And that's of course why I teach it. I don't teach Zen.

So you're taking refuge in the teaching, which means that you ought to try and lift your understanding of the Dhamma. When I started in the late 70s, there was virtually, there weren't many books on Buddhism. And there were hardly any talks or anything. Now there's a whole website. It's ridiculous. There's a book every second. Everybody wants to write a book. Even me. So that's the Dhamma. And again, when I was starting, there were very few meditation centers. But now there's many. So the opportunity to practice is available.

And then finally there's the taking refuge in the Saṅgha. Saṅgha is a technical word that's used normally speaking to refer to monks and nuns. But these days you find it being used by the Buddhist community to refer to themselves. But this isn't what you're taking refuge in. No, neither the monks and nuns, nor... Yeah, no, don't put your refuge there. The refuge, your confidence is in those people who have attained some insight into *Nibbāna*.

So, we have these four levels of attainment: stream entry, once returner, non-returner, arahant. So there isn't time to go into much detail about that, but these such people stand as witnesses to the Buddha's own particular experience. So their confidence is unshakable.

It is understood that if the dispensation no longer produced these people even at that level of stream entrant, if these teachings didn't generate people at least at the first level of entering the stream, the teaching would first of all corrupt into an intellectual scholastic exercise and eventually corrupt into just empty ritual, lighting candles, bowing, which, if the practice is full, has its role for those people who have more of a devotional feel towards their heart. More of a heart connection to the religion.

And then, of course, there are the five precepts. Remember, the real translation is training. Path of training. *Sikkhāpada*. *Pada* means footstep and *sikkhā* means training. So it's the path of training. So they're not commandments. It's not as though you should feel guilty too much if you don't follow them. You should feel perhaps a little disappointed that you cannot follow. You could feel a moment of disappointment that you didn't follow them. And this could lead you to encourage yourself.

So the first one is usually very easy for us. We're not going to kill any living beings. Even this can be attenuated, in my understanding. I mean you have a right to protect your own life. And then, but what that leads us to is, of course, protecting life. It always moves us towards the opposite.

And then there's not to take what is not freely given. So, when we begin to practice that, it leads towards generosity.

Now, this one is usually translated as sexual desire. Not to abuse sexual desire. But the word *kāma*, really in its fullness, is all sensual pleasure. And therefore also not to eat with avidity. So it's about indulgence. It's about, letting go of this indulgence.

And then there's right speech. This is of course the most difficult. Because we're always talking. If we're not talking to somebody, we're talking to ourselves. It just never stops. Even in dreams we're talking. So even though that's the most difficult, we have to make an effort. It should be as best as we can. It should be truthful. It should be kind, gentle. And we should speak at the right time. So if we keep that sort of ideas in our minds, then usually we're okay with right speech.

The last one is probably the most difficult for Western society anyway. Not to take, alcohol, drugs, whatever, that mess your level of consciousness. It also says in the scriptures that of course when we're under the influence of alcohol we tend to do things that we then regret.

And so it depends on you how much wine you want to drink. You can be very strict with it, no alcohol. Or you can be a little bit easy with it. It's just remembering that you want to maintain throughout our lives this bright awareness, that's all.

I remember once I hadn't eaten all afternoon and I went to the Zen practice and on the way home I went into the pub and had a half a beer, just a half. And it was quite remarkable, I just felt this weight coming down on my brain. Even so, it took a while before I was able to abandon alcohol.

And these are the refuges and precepts. A good practice is to start the morning by chanting or reading them. And then to remind yourself how you want to behave throughout the day. So over time you can see some progress. And you can rate progress by how your virtues are manifesting. Are you calmer? Are you more generous? Are you more open to people? Are you, generally speaking, more happy with your life?

It doesn't mean to say that trouble won't come. It doesn't mean that sometimes you will become very anxious or angry and so on. But over a long length of time, five years, twenty, it depends on how much you put into the practice. You can see some change for the better. If the change is for the worse, stop.

So if over this evening and tomorrow morning you think you might want to take these Refuge and Precepts, then you have to fill out this little certificate for me. I need to know what name you want to put on my very lovely certificate. And you have to choose a virtue that you want to develop. But only one. And how long you want to take the refuges for. I would suggest a minimum of one year. One person said to me, until my birthday, I said, when's your birthday? In three weeks. I said, what's the point?

So, I'll leave it at that. The other thing is that on Saturday evening, we have an opportunity to answer any questions that come up. And so, there's a leaf here. You can just write your questions up.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I have not caused even greater confusion, that by your devotion to your practice, you will be liberated from all suffering, sooner rather than later.

Dukkha: Unsatisfactoriness and Sīla: Morality and Ethics

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 25 min

In this comprehensive teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the deep connection between dukkha (unsatisfactoriness/suffering) and sīla (morality and ethics). He explains how dukkha manifests from three unwholesome roots - delusion, acquisitiveness, and aversion - and how ethical conduct provides the foundation for liberation from self-created suffering.

The talk covers the five fundamental precepts and their positive counterparts, the five hindrances (nīvaraṇa) that obstruct meditation, and the ten defilements (kilesa) including sensual desire, hatred, delusion, conceit, and wrong views. Bhante explores the crucial concept of anusaya - latent tendencies or underlying biases that lie dormant in consciousness, ready to manifest when triggered.

Particularly relevant for contemporary practitioners, he discusses how universal prejudices and conditioned responses operate as saṅkhāra (volitional formations), emphasizing the importance of yoniso manasikāra (wise attention) in recognizing unwholesome thoughts as they arise. The teaching offers practical guidance for understanding how our own conditioning creates suffering and how mindful awareness can gradually exhaust these harmful patterns, leading toward greater freedom and peace.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So on this full moon, by the way, I hope you saw the blood moon. It wasn't actually the full moon, but it was very red against the clear sky. I don't know whether you all caught that. It was very lovely.

So the topic I've chosen for this one is *dukkha* and *sīla*. These are words that I'm sure you're familiar with, but it's good to have a little reminder. *Dukkha* translated as unsatisfactoriness, as suffering, simply means hard to bear. But why does it manifest? It manifests because of three basic roots, these unwholesome roots: the delusion which

forks off into some form of acquisitiveness and some form of aversion, and the aversion spikes off into hatred and fear. So these are our basic attitudes that arise out of this deep delusion.

In order to go backwards to the original delusion, we have to work through the moral laws and ethical guidance. The moral laws, I'm just using these words to mean two different things. The moral laws are basically things like not to kill. But the ethical guidance is really about relationships, about changing our relationship not only to people, animals, plants, but even to material things. For instance, at Eihei-ji Monastery, the founding monastery of Zen, I'm told that when they take water from a well, they will use the water but always leave a little bit to put back into the well. It's an offering, an acknowledgement of the preciousness of water.

Now the thing about this suffering is that we cause it to ourselves. And what's difficult for us to really accept is that we actually are doing it since we were born. In fact, we're probably doing it in the womb. You have to make this distinction between the pressures coming upon us, even as babies, which are usually not meant to be harmful—such as the process of birth, feeling hungry and mummy's not there—and acts against us which can be harmful. Whatever happens to us is the original pain. How we react to it through aversion is our suffering.

We have to recognize that if that were not so, it would be impossible to become fully liberated unless we got rid of the actual cause of our suffering. If we believe other people are the cause of our suffering, then basically we've got to get rid of other people and then we can be liberated. But it's the very fact that we cause our own suffering that we can become fully liberated from it.

I want to remind you of things, but I really want to centre upon what they're known as the defilements and the latent tendencies, but we'll come to that in a minute.

The five basic laws are places that I'm sure none of us go there, but it's good to know that there are things that we don't do anymore, like kill people. We don't kill anybody if we can, and we don't steal. We don't tell lies. We don't abuse our sexual powers. The last one's a bit difficult: not to take drugs and drink and all that which make the mind fuzzy. We do live in an alcohol culture, but it's up to the individual. If one brings to mind that alcohol, no matter how little it is, is actual pure poison to the body, probably worse than any of the drugs, then that might go for non-alcoholic wines and beers, which I can tell you now are very good.

When we take those precepts, obviously we move towards the opposite. So we don't kill anybody, but we move naturally towards protecting them. It's just a natural movement towards that. Sometimes that first precept is translated as no harm, but it's not. It's actually killing. So it's actually a refinement if you're not harming any living being.

Not to steal—when we give that up we know that leads to a harmonious society and eventually generosity. Sexual powers—the use of those is out of respect and within a loving relationship.

When it comes to lying, right speech splits into four different types. There are great big whoppers that we don't want to tell anymore, but slandering is a bit more difficult. We will let words slip, find ourselves saying things about people. Then there's abusive language, and just wasted talk—talking for talking's sake. What we're moving towards is kindly speech, truthful, beneficial, and most important, to say things at a suitable time, because often we're saying what we want to say, but it's not quite the right time to say it.

We have this other category of hindrances where all these things come up as hindrances to our meditation when we're sitting. It's just another list which allows us to see where these defilements within us are and how to deal with them. Each category has a way of dealing with them. I'm sure you remember.

The first one being all to do with sensual desires, avarice, greed, and all that. The next one is all the hatreds, the grudges, the vendettas. And then there's this sloth and torpor, which comes about through our habit of using sleep to escape, to get rid of ourselves for a little while. I think somebody called it the duvet dive. When you do that, you're developing an energy which is pulling you down. It's like a whirlpool. These things have to be overcome, have to be allowed to drain themselves.

Then there's that whole area of restlessness caused by just inner turbulence. But that also contains guilt, remorse and shame, which are secondary effects of doing something harmful.

Finally, skeptical doubt, which is quite a problem if you have it badly because you can't make a decision. You keep making lists for and against. If you have a relationship where you might, yes, you are attracted—could it work? Could it not work? Before you know it, the person's left you. It's the same with a job. Shall I go for it? Shall I not go for it? And it's gone. So it often comes from fear of failure or a lack of self-esteem.

Just moving on to the *kilesa*. This is often translated as the ten defilements. In the early scriptures, the word *kilesa* is used as a general way of pointing to that within us which is unwholesome. But later on, the early scriptures and the Abhidhamma couldn't

resist making lists, so they've given us a list of ten of these defilements. None of them will come as a shock—you know they're there. But the reason for looking at this is for self-reflection. When we see thoughts coming up, when we see our actions coming up, then it categorizes it and gives us some idea of how to deal with it.

The first one obviously is to do with sensual desire, basic sensual desire—the greed, the lust, the avarice and so on. The next one is to do with hatred, with hate—unforgiveness and things like that, holding grudges. The next one is delusion. This is always around this fundamental problem of identity. It's always about this feeling of being a self, a person, something that doesn't change within us. This gives us, moving from this self which is actually only seeking happiness—it's only seeking happiness—then it gives us some purpose for life to seek this happiness. But unfortunately, as we know, human life doesn't eventually satisfy us. It's not somewhere where we're ever going to feel completely satisfied.

This also manifests as conceit. Conceit has three manifestations. The obvious one is "I am better than you," and then you get the opposite: "I'm not as good as." And then you get a more subtle one where you feel "This is okay. I'm equal to this person." So there doesn't seem to be any conceit of I'm better or worse. That seems to be a good place to be, wholesome, but unfortunately, you are creating a group of people who all think that they are equal. Once you've done that, there are other groups which are not equal and they are actually worse or better. So it's a subtle one that.

The next one is wrong views. This really goes back again to the self. It's about believing that something of our personhood is eternal. We all know the body will die, but the heart-mind, the mental body continues to live, never changes. The soul—often people will talk about their souls as being this unchanging person, basically, but without a physical body. That is not the Buddha's teaching. The subtle body, the body that seeks rebirth, is just as impermanent as this one. It is just a more finer energy.

When I say that, sometimes you can experience that. When you're there with an emotion, something loud, like you might be feeling irritated—or anxious is a bit difficult. Irritation or anger, that's a good one. And you're in the body and you can feel it. By centring in on it very clearly, by holding your attention right there, it might just separate for you and then you'll see that the mind's anger isn't that bad, but that when it touches the physical base of the body it's like a sounding box—it comes back as very loud, as very burning.

Little experiences like that prove to the meditator that these two things, the body and mind, are actually two different forms of energy. But neither of them are permanent. They're arising and passing away.

The opposite of eternalism is annihilationism—the idea that when you die, well, you're dead and that's it. In the Buddha's time there were materialists, people who believed that there wasn't a soul, there wasn't anything—you were just this body and when you died you died. These days we would have scientific materialists who would take that position.

Definitely the Buddha was against both. He tended to be accused of being an annihilationist, not an eternalist, because of his teaching of not-self. It became very confusing, this not-self business. The Jains said, "We believe, ourselves and the Brahmins, we believe that there is an eternal soul. And the materialists believe that there isn't. But the Buddhists haven't made their mind up." That was how confused people were with this doctrine of not-self. There are occasions in the scriptures which are quite funny, actually. We'll do that some other time.

Then we've got this skeptical doubt, which we've talked about, and torpor, again, which we've talked about, and restlessness. So those are your ten *kilesa*: sensual desire, hatred, delusion, conceit, wrong view, skeptical doubt, torpor and restlessness. What I'm going to do is just put these lists onto a PDF if you want to have a look. There's lots of stuff on the websites if you want to go into it a bit more deeply.

But the next bit is particularly interesting, I think, for us as Westerners: this idea of *anusaya*, which are latent tendencies. This tells you that within us there are these habits, *saṅkhāra*. *Saṅkhāra* is often translated as volitional conditioning, which is really confusing. But if we think about habits, it's just what we habitually do. All that—the way we think, the way we speak, our thought patterns—these are all habits. And the compendium of habits is what we would call our personality, character.

It's understood that these are lying underneath everything we're doing. Given an opportunity, given some sort of catalyst, some sort of stimulus, there will arise out of this *saṅkhāra* a response. For instance, all of us have some amount of anger within us, and if somebody stands on your foot, then that's a little stimulus, and this anger will want to reply to it. And it's lying there dormant. It's lying there dormant.

What the Buddha is saying is that these are actually underneath our obvious consciousness, but that they're always ready and they're always, in many ways, affecting the present moment. So it's translated as bent, bias, proclivity. They're exactly the same. The list is much the same as the defilements, with one extra one, or one different one, which is the tendency of the desire to become. In other words, that will to live. And its opposite, the will not to live.

This will to live will lead us to beliefs of eternalism and the desire not to live will lead us to beliefs about annihilationism. Obviously, if you have that desire to live, then you'll do everything to keep alive and you will substantiate your life. You'll try to make it safer and safer with more money, more friends, and so on. It causes us to be acquisitive. If you are on the other side, where there's a feeling of okay with annihilation, with the fact that death is the end of it and all that, then you'll find such people often taking refuge in sleep, the duvet dive. As soon as something's too much, well, you just lie down and go to sleep. But on its worst level, it's suicide, just wanting to get rid of yourself. Unfortunately, in Buddhist understanding, that doesn't work. It will re-arise. So it's not a good solution.

That tendency there is put in as an underlying tendency which is making us grasp everything which proves to us that we're alive. That means trying to make ourselves happy, defending what makes ourselves happy from any enemies. So there's your aversion. And if the enemy is too big, well, you run for it. So we're constantly trying to manipulate our lives in order to establish this constant state of living happily.

Now the last thing that I just want to mention is that it's translated as tendencies. Obviously these days we're very much aware of our prejudices and there are two words that people are using. The commentators use the word prejudice which is a hard word. There's almost an activity there. If you're racially prejudiced or sexually prejudiced and somebody calls you that, there's a feeling of you being actively so. The other word that's being used is bias, which is slightly softer on a person.

But I think that if we use these two words in the sense of the defilements and the latent tendencies, then it allows us to accept that all these prejudices are within us. It's part of the baggage that we get when we are born into a culture. I've got a list here of well-known prejudices: racism obviously and tribalism which is a lesser form, sexism, ageism—I'm very much against that—classism, homophobia, nationalism, religious prejudice and xenophobia. And that's only a short list. There's lots and lots of other prejudices.

It's being kind to ourselves. It's recognizing that we will have these prejudices within us. They can manifest and sometimes it can be embarrassing for us. But how do we overcome these prejudices? Well, obviously, on the obvious side, you don't indulge them. But the other thing that the Buddha often talks about is this *yoniso manasikāra*, this wise attention, this being really awake, that in any situation you are aware of unwholesome thoughts as they arise, not after they've arisen and done something, but as they arise. When we are awake enough to actually catch these little unwholesome

thoughts coming up, they very quickly dissipate. In that way, these prejudices, these biases begin to be exhausted of their energy and they lose that power to take us by surprise.

I think one of the difficulties is that it's very difficult for us to say to ourselves, "Well, I am racially prejudiced." To say that and to mean it as an active thing wouldn't be correct. But to say that there is in me that *saṅkhāra*, that conditioning—

and to be aware should it ever arise and not to indulge it — I think that's a more truthful way of being with these conditionings within us. And it's also, I think, how should we say, comforting to know that every person in the world will have these prejudices. It doesn't matter what ethnic group you come from, what race you belong to, whatever. These are just basic prejudices that are completely universal, doesn't matter where you live.

So that allows us, I think, to be more open about ourselves, at least to ourselves anyway. And that means that we will be aware of these things when they arise, and they don't sneak out as Freudian slips, which can be very embarrassing.

So what we've done this evening is just revise these moral precepts and begun to look at much more this idea of relationship. And we've looked at the more negative side. At another time, we'll be looking at the more positive side, the virtues. But it's just ways in which we can reflect upon these things whenever the occasion arises and allows us to find a way to heal the heart of these things. So that's the purpose of bringing these things to mind.

And as I say, you can, if you want to go deeper into it, there's lots of stuff on the websites, lots of talks on Dharma Seed and things like that.

Very good. I think I've done my bit there. So I hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused confusion, and that you will, by your constant effort, release yourselves from all suffering and achieve the peace of *Nibbāna*.

Paṭicca Samuppāda and the Role of Desire and the Only Choice

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 15 min

In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma presents a detailed exploration of paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination), examining how the twelve interconnected links create our experience of suffering and the path to liberation. Beginning with avijjā (not-knowing) rather than mere ignorance, he traces how our fundamental delusion about self leads to saṅkhāra (habitual conditioning), consciousness, and the psychophysical organism with its six sense bases.

The teaching focuses particularly on the crucial transition from vedanā (feeling) to taṇhā (desire/thirst), explaining how our reactive patterns of grasping and pushing away arise from wrong understanding. Bhante emphasizes that suffering truly begins when we identify with our experiences ('I am this pain'), making it nearly impossible to stop the momentum of desire-driven actions.

Using practical examples from meditation practice, including the Mahasi noting technique, he demonstrates how we can recognize and work with desire as it arises. The talk reveals the profound insight that the moment when desire appears is actually our only point of genuine choice - the narrow window where free will operates and where liberation becomes possible. This moment-to-moment understanding of dependent origination offers a psychological framework more accessible to Western practitioners than traditional three-lifetime explanations.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

Yesterday I gave the moon talk and then it failed to, well, I failed to do the right thing and so I lost it. So I'm doing it again. I'll be covering exactly the same ground, but of course it won't be quite the same as you yourself had heard it, or as those on the moon broadcast had heard it.

So we're talking about the dependent origination and centering towards the end on this process of desiring. Now, the dependent origination begins with this word *avidyā*, and it's been translated as ignorance, giving it some sort of culpability, like we shouldn't have been ignorant. But no, this is just a plain flat not knowing, didn't know. And it's because of that that we fall into a delusion.

Now, that delusion, of course, is to believe ourselves to be this heart, body and mind, this psychophysical organism. That leads us into a funny relationship with the world. Wanting to be happy, so we acquire things – money, friends, power and so on. And then anything that upsets us or threatens us we push away, we get angry and so on. And if it's bigger than me then of course I'll run for it. So these are your basic attitudes that come from that delusion: acquisitiveness, aversion and fear.

And they have created these *saṅkhāra*. The *saṅkhāra* is translated rather awkwardly as volitional conditioning. But I think it's much easier to think of them just as our habits – habits of thought, habits of feeling, habits of reaction and so on.

And these two, this not knowing, this delusion, and the *saṅkhāra*, the habits, underlie every moment of our life. They're just passing with us underneath every moment. Now, when something moves on the *saṅkhāra*, it will manifest on that screen of consciousness.

And consciousness is described by its six bases: the five sensual bases – the eye, ear, nose, and so on – and the mind-heart, the inner life of images, thoughts, emotions. And these five consciousnesses, whenever there's a stimulus, it'll manifest on that screen.

Now then we have, because of that screen, we of course become aware of our body and mind, of our materiality and of our mentality. And it can also be understood as what is subjective, mentality, and what is objective, our physicality. And this psychophysical organism has of course these six sense bases.

And whenever we have a contact, which includes a sense base, some sort of object, and the awareness, the consciousness of it, we have that moment when we become aware of something, conscious of something. Now, that moment is just an experience, but we then put a judgment on it, or we look at it from the point of view of happiness. So obviously there are some things that make us happy and some things that don't.

And that's the point where it becomes *vedanā*, or feeling – physical feelings, mental feelings. So as soon as these first little sensations come up in our sitting posture, for instance, of pain in the knee or pain in the back or pain in the neck, as soon as they

come up, immediately we say, "Oh, that's pain." Pain meaning don't like. And of course, if it's something pleasant, we suddenly have a lovely, joyous memory, then of course we label that as something to be enjoyed.

It's the point next which is the problem – how we relate to it. And this is our reactivity. So because we've determined to try to make this life really absolutely happy, whenever something does create happiness, we grasp it, we try to maintain it, we try to make it grow. And when something is unpleasant, we want to push it away. That's the point of this *taṇhā*, this translated as craving, but that's too strong. Thirst is not bad, but it's just that reactivity coming from the wrong understanding.

Now, at the next point, there's an identity. And this is the point where actually suffering begins, because that's when you say, "This is me. I am this pain in the knee. I am depressed." And once that is determined, it's virtually impossible to stop the empowerment of that desire.

So if the desire said, "Take an aspirin, get rid of this headache," and you say, "Yes, I will take an aspirin to get rid of it," it's virtually impossible to stop reaching out for the aspirin. You may, of course, change your mind in the process, but the reaching out or the movement towards, even the slightest movement, will be very difficult to stop. And then once you've started an action, there'll be a process of the action and the completion of the action.

Now that's looking at dependent origination from a present moment-to-moment experience. But of course it is also explained as a sort of three lives. In the past life we develop these habits, we come into this life with consciousness, with awareness, we go through this process, we build up hopefully better habits which get us reborn in a better place and life begins again – birth, death, birth, death. But to us, I think, as Westerners, really much more involved in our psychology and all that, then the moment-to-moment, the present moment experience of dependent origination makes much more sense to us.

Now this is what's really important here is the Buddha's tremendous insight about the point of identity. So if we take a very simple sentence which some of you will have heard me often use: one sees ice cream, one makes a contact with ice cream. It's a lovely sunny day, it's very warm, you're out walking and there it is – the vision, the seeing of the ice cream – and immediately that brings up a sense of liking.

Once you like something, there's a wanting. So there's a contact: ice cream. There's like: ice cream. There's want: ice cream. And then there's "I want ice cream." So the "I" comes in late in the process. "I" is a sense of identity. This is me. If that weren't so, there

wouldn't be an escape. There wouldn't be an escape. It's the fact that it comes at the end of that process, that we can now, instead of moving into that identity, actually stop at the point of desire.

And when we stop at the point of desire, we can see that process quite clearly. It's a sort of energy that wants to manifest, and it needs our permission, a decision to manifest. And that's what comes after this identity. It's known as *bhava*, becoming. When we are becoming, we are creating a self all the time, but it's also an action, and therefore there are consequences. And it all reverts back to this desire.

Now, we're talking here specifically about unwholesome desire, but it also works for wholesome desires. Now, unlike the Buddha, we have this underlying delusion. And so, no matter how we try, there'll always be that sense of self. Now, that doesn't mean to say it somehow destroys the benefit of a good action. Far from it. But there'll always be that sense of me doing something. And with it, this underlying little conversation about how wonderful we are or how we're not so wonderful or how we've given too much, spent too much, and so on and so forth.

So now, if we go back to this desire, we have to feel that. So in our meditation, when we're sitting there, as soon as something comes into our attention, on that screen of consciousness, we become aware of it. As soon as that happens, the Mahasi technique of labeling is extremely good at making us acknowledge what is happening.

So if my mind is wandering, I note "wandering," but then I can see that I'm planning something. So I note "planning." And when I come back into the body, I can feel the agitation, the excitement of this amazing thing that I'm going to do – saving the world. And if I can stay with that, I'll see that there's a sort of little energy that wants to take me out, take me back into the dream world. And I've got to be aware of that. If there's an iota, a moment of inattention, I'll shoot off again up into la-la land.

So this whole process is explained by the Buddha in this dependent origination. And this desire has to be felt, it has to be known, it has to be understood, so that when a desire comes and we see it is unwholesome, we've got to hold it there, we've got to stand. We mustn't let it take us, we mustn't let it tempt us into an action of thought, word or deed. And if we fail that's not a problem – you just know that, ah yes, it's still a very strong habit. So okay, I've got to work with it, which means the next time it arises being slightly on the ball, just waiting for that energy to dissipate, dissipate, dissipate.

Now that energy, remember, doesn't disappear. It's always transforming to its opposite. So where there was selfishness, they'll find generosity. Where there's hatred, you'll find love. And where there's cruelty, you'll find compassion, and so on.

So that was our little contemplation yesterday. It was probably slightly better, slightly longer yesterday, but at least we have gone over it again. So it'll be slightly different from what you heard yesterday, but at least we've covered the same area.

Now, I think I also said, just to finish off, this moment of desire is actually the only moment of, for want of a better word, free will. That's the point where we can actually say no or yes. Otherwise, we would just be automatons, we'd just be living automatically. We wouldn't have an ability to guide ourselves.

Now, when I say that's the moment of choice, the moment of free will, actually speaking, it's very narrow, because what we want to do is get to a point of liberation from suffering. And the path is ahead of us. Now we come along the path as if you were just walking in the country, going somewhere, to a tea shop perhaps, or to a place where you can get a nice cup of coffee and a tea cake. And you know the way – it's on the map – and as you're going along there's a little road to the left and as you look you think, "Oh that's interesting."

So now you've got a choice. You can either wander up there, wasting time, getting more and more anxious as to whether the tea shop will be closed by the time you get there and getting all flustered and you may get lost. Even though you've got a map. And so you have to decide at that crossroad, "Have I got time? Do I want to go there? Do I need to go there?" And then you move on.

So that moment of choice, when the desire comes up, is the point where we can liberate ourselves, that we can actually make the decisions that will liberate ourselves from this whole process of desire.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused even further confusion, and that you will, by your devotion to practice, liberate yourself from all suffering sooner rather than later. I hope you like the photo, by the way. That's the centre on a very hot, lovely day.

Kamma and Rebirth

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 17 min

In this foundational talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma clarifies the Buddha's understanding of personal kamma - the ethical actions that lead to liberation or continued suffering - distinguishing it from natural physical laws, hereditary factors, and psychological conditioning. Drawing on the framework of the Five Laws (physical, hereditary, psychological, karmic, and Dhamma), he emphasizes that our personal kamma lies not in external circumstances that befall us, but in how we choose to respond to them.

The talk explores the intimate connection between ethics and wisdom in the Buddha's teaching, showing how purification through right speech, right action, and right livelihood must accompany insight practice. Bhante discusses how our reactions - rooted in taṇhā (craving) and wrong identification with the psychophysical process - perpetuate saṃsāra through paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination). He offers practical guidance for vipassanā practitioners on recognizing the observer-awareness that remains untouchable by external circumstances.

Regarding rebirth, Bhante takes a practical approach for those who find this teaching difficult, suggesting it be held as a possibility while focusing on the immediate work of ethical development and insight. He concludes with the Buddha's profound teaching on the 'un-born, undying, unconditioned' - the ultimate refuge that makes liberation possible for all beings.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhasa, namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhasa, namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhasa — homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

So we're celebrating the moon night. Actually I think it's on Wednesday, but we have to bend the rules a bit for our culture, so we're doing it tonight. And the topic is on *kamma* and rebirth.

So just going through the basics really, just being sure as to what we mean by personal *kamma* — in other words, the *kamma* that leads to liberation.

We understand in Buddhism that there are five laws. The first one being the law of heat — that's how it translates, but it's really to do with what we would call physics and chemistry, just matter. So those are laws which are separate from personal responsibility. Now what I think is really pointing to here is things like the tsunami. So in the East,

if you were a victim of the tsunami, they would tend to think that was because in some past life you must have drowned somebody or something worse. So it gets a bit far-fetched. So we have to be clear that the Earth matter has its own properties, and we happen to be born at this time. Now, there is this connection, of course, with climate change, but that comes later.

The next one is hereditary. If you're born with a disease coming from your parents and their parents and back all the way, that's not your personal *kamma*. That's to do with being born with that certain genetic makeup. Now what is your personal *kamma* is how you relate to it. And again we'll come to that in a minute. So to think of somebody who's born say with Down Syndrome and to think that they therefore must have been some sort of animal in the past life and that they're born at the same level of intelligence — that wouldn't be correct. Even they have their own *kamma* to work out.

The next one would be *citta*, so this is our psychology. So we're born with a certain set of psychological rules and that's as simple as that. A simple one would be just the way we learn language, and that's all to do with the mind, the wake up of the mind and the brain. Remember, in the Buddha's teaching, the mind and the body are two separate energy systems. And when we're reborn, it's the mind that leaves the body. And we'll come to that again when we have just a quick reminder of what rebirth is.

So again, you have to be very careful when we're talking about personal *kamma*, the *kamma* that leads to liberation or not. It's the opposite way too. And this leads us to the problem of social *kamma*. So a lot of people might talk about social *kamma*, meaning the *kamma* of, say, being born in British culture or in another culture. And again, that wouldn't be quite the way that the Buddha would see it. He would see it more as a collection of individuals. And the collection of individuals have agreed to certain rules and regulations, certain cultural norms. Most of this is passed on to us, whether we like it or not, when we're children. It's not as though it's something that is out there as a social or as something separate from individuals. The whatever is passed on to us through our societies is passed on individually through our parents, through the media and so on and so forth. So again it's about individuals.

And it's the same when you think about, say, thousands of deaths from famine or thousands of deaths from all these conflicts that are going on. All that really is individuals who are dying. And some will die very peacefully, some will not have suffered greatly, and others, of course, will have died in agony. But again, it's all very individual. It's our universe. So if you think about it, everything that we're experiencing is coming in through the senses and through our own particular conditioning, and what we're experiencing now is our own little universe, and we're always at the center of it.

So when somebody steps into that universe and does us harm, that isn't our personal *kamma* — that's coming from their decision-making. Our personal *kamma* is how we react.

So that takes us into the next section about *kamma* itself, the law of *kamma*. And this is all about ethics. And you could say that the Buddha really — you could reduce all his teachings to ethics and transcendence. And the reason for that, remember, is that because of this delusion that we are suffering from, we enter into a wrong relationship. So when we look at our ethical, moral behavior, that will be a measure of our wisdom or lack of it. So there's a connection there between the process of liberation and ethics.

So there's always this purification has to go on at the same time as insight. You can't have insight and still go around murdering people and robbing from them and getting wild on drugs. It's not possible, because of the connection between the delusion and how it manifests and the process of beginning to undermine that delusion through the process of ethical behavior. And that's all put out of course in the eightfold path — right speech, right action, right livelihood. And the more we work on that, the more it feeds back into the way that we understand the world.

So that *kamma*, when we talk about the law of *kamma*, we're talking really about ethics. And that's now beginning to be where our... well, the core work is, you might say.

The final one is to do with Dhamma. And these are, of course, the basic teachings of the Buddha — the Four Noble Truths, the law of *kamma* itself, and the wheel of dependent origination, dependent origination itself too. So all that teaching of the Buddha comes under the law of the Dhamma. The Dhamma itself is the truth that will, when we take it on, will lead us to the end of our own personal inner suffering.

So remember, the suffering we're talking about is to do with wrong understanding. So it doesn't include physical suffering. So long as we have a body, it's going to give us pain. It's just the way it is. But the heart, once cleansed of all its negativity, of all its unwholesome habits and understandings, begins to be in a state of one of the four great illimitables, one of the four *brahmavihāras*. It's in some state of love or some state of compassion, some state of joy or just peaceful equanimity. That's the Buddha heart. But don't confuse that with the Buddha itself, the Buddha within, which is this pure awareness. Remember, the awareness is within this psychophysical organism. And it's through this organism that it's manifesting its delusion or its wisdom.

That's the Dhamma. So the point here is to be very clear as to what is our personal *kamma* — the *kamma* that leads to either continued rebirth or to liberation. And it all comes back to the dependent origination and to the point of reaction to what we're experiencing.

So dependent origination — what it's saying is that this *taṇhā*, this wrong relationship to things that we call attachment, indulgence, aversion, fear, all these sorts of reactions to what we are experiencing, is the cause of our unsatisfactoriness, our suffering and our continued suffering. And it's when we undermine that, that we begin to roll that wheel backwards upon itself, and we come down to the root problem, which is about our sense of identity. That's where the root is.

Remember, his victory verse is that he had discovered the house builder. And he's broken down — he's found the house builder, he's broken the house, he's broken this and he's broken that, it all sounds very violent, and he's liberated himself, he's found the *citta*, that knowing which is the Buddha within. So that's the root problem as to what we identify with.

And remember that when you are practicing *vipassanā*, you've pulled yourself out of this organism into this observer. And that observer really recognizes it as a place of un-touchability. Once you're established there, nothing can harm you. Really sort of grasp that because that's very close to our liberation.

So when it comes to something like rebirth, it's not within our culture. It's a bit difficult for us to get our head around that — the fact that we might be reborn into another place, another time, take on a different personality. And yet through that personality, whatever unwholesomeness and wholesomeness we have in terms of the way we look at things will again begin to manifest.

So really, for those that find it just difficult to accept, it's a case of just putting it on the back burner. I mean, there'll come a point when we'll know for sure. And that's when we leave the planet. So there's no point in rushing the decision. The decision will be made for us when we die. And if after all it's just annihilation, we just disappear, well, there's no problem in that at all, is there? I mean, there's no suffering involved in that whatsoever. So it's best not to come to a decision about that. There's no need, for instance, to come to a conclusion.

If we don't have that information — and we're talking about information which is experiential, this is not science, we're never going to prove it with a thermometer or something, it's just something which is beyond our ability to know in that way — but

there are people who have come out of the body and have gone to such places and they stand as witness to that possibility. So really it's just the case of keeping it as a possibility.

I mean in the fullness of the teaching it gives you some idea of the grand moral laws that go right through the cosmos, through all the different levels of being. There is this law of *kamma* which is basically saying if you're coming from a wrong place you're going to end up unhappy. If you're coming from a deluded place you're going to keep finding yourself in an unhappy situation. And slowly it's going to come through to you that maybe you're the problem. It isn't the other person who's making you angry. The world doesn't make you depressed. There's something within us which is causing it. And there's some resolution, you might say, to the whole problem of moral behavior.

But again, it always comes down to the individual. So whether *saṃsāra* will ever come to an end is anybody's guess. As individuals keep reappearing, they themselves are their own little universe working out their own plan. And eventually, in Buddhist understanding again, liberation is a... it has to happen. It's within the process. I can't think of the word. It's something which is set into the process because that part of us which is deluded is not naturally deluded. Itself is clear of delusion. What it is, is a simple not knowing.

So in itself it is absolutely pure and whole, but because of this misunderstanding it finds itself creating this bad *kamma*, these bad consequences, unwholesome consequences, the suffering. And it can pull itself out and return to its original purity, otherwise there'd be no escape. So that's what the Buddha says in one of these little verses about the process: there is an unborn, there is an undying, there's something that doesn't die. There is an unconditioned. And then he says, if it were not so, there would not be an escape from what is born and dies and is conditioned.

So there's hope for us all. This is the big message. So no matter how miserable we become, there is an end. So we have to accept that. I mean, he's up there on his pedestal and he's definitely teaching us that.

So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused any confusion, and that you will, by your careful ethical behavior, release yourself from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Gratitude, Generosity and Renunciation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 12 min

In this timely talk given during the season of giving, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines one of the ten perfections (pāramī) — generosity (dāna) — and its profound role in Buddhist spiritual development. Drawing from the Buddha's own story, he explains how perfect generosity gave the Awakened One the final push toward liberation, allowing him to 'open the gates of the Dhamma' for all beings.

Bhante distinguishes between ordinary generosity with expectations of return and true spiritual generosity — giving without any expectation of payback. The key practice involves suffusing one's mind with pure intention before making donations or offering help, while remaining vigilant against Māra's whispers of pride or stinginess that may arise afterward.

The foundation for developing genuine generosity lies in cultivating gratitude. Through reflecting on all we have received freely — from parents, teachers, society, healthcare, education, and countless daily kindnesses — we recognize the impossibility of repaying what has been given. This overwhelming sense of gratitude naturally inspires us toward greater generosity.

The talk reveals how generosity connects to renunciation (nekkhamma), as each act of giving involves letting go of our acquisitiveness and greed. This creates a 'virtuous circle' where gratitude leads to generosity, which cultivates renunciation, gradually undermining delusion and spiraling us toward nibbāna. A practical and inspiring teaching for integrating the pāramī into daily life.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed noble and fully self-awakened one.

So the topic for this evening were the ten perfections. I'll just read through them. Generosity, morality and renunciation. Wisdom, effort and patience. Honesty, determination, goodwill, and equanimity. This is one list I never bothered to learn. So you can see that's a bit too much for one evening.

So what I've chosen is generosity since we're at that time of the year when we give presents. So generosity rates highly in the Buddhist teachings. If you remember in his own personal story, he went through that great doubt just before he became liberated.

So the great doubt really centred on who was he of all people to try and find the end of suffering. And as the myth goes, the earth goddess rose and said, he has every right to do this because he has fully perfected the virtue of generosity.

So basically what gave him that little bit of extra energy as far as I'm concerned is that he knew he was doing it for other people. So if you think about Mount Everest when Sherpa Tenzing and Edmund Hillary got up there, they opened up the gates of Everest and now everybody and his dog can get up there. So that's the same with the Buddha. Once he discovered this path as he said the gates of the *dhamma* were opened and that business of generosity was what gave him the last little push to go for it.

And whenever he's talking to lay people he always starts off with generosity and he points out that even thieves can be generous. So after they've stolen a thousand pound from you they can always be generous with it and give it to their mates. So what we have to distinguish is between what you might call just ordinary generosity and spiritual generosity.

I mean, at this time of the year, you're giving presents. So if you buy a family member, you spend a lot of money on an amazing pair of socks and they send you a scrappy pair of gloves. Well, you know what they're going to get next Christmas. So I mean, it's a sort of generosity, but obviously there's a bit of payback. And it's the same with when you help people. Like if somebody says come and help with the garden or do some decoration, well you're very happy to but you presume that when your garden is doing or you need a bit of decoration somebody else now they'll come back and do it for you. You're very upset if they don't. So that's what you might call just friendly generosity.

But I think that we get to spiritual generosity when we're making donations to charities that obviously have nothing to do with us personally. So making a donation to things like Oxfam, Médecins Sans Frontières, all those sorts of charities, we're obviously giving something and there's not going to be any personal return for us at all.

Now that's a different sort of generosity and we can call it a spiritual generosity. So it's giving something without any expectation. So how do you do it? This is the point you see because normally speaking even whether we are aware of it or not there's always a bit of greed in there. We're always doing it for some payback. So whenever you're making a donation whether it's putting money in a box or you're going to just press a button on the screen, you have to suffuse the heart and mind with that intention. That this is for such and such and I don't expect and I don't want any return. That has to suffuse your mind and then when you press the button when you actually drop the coin or the money into the box.

That's what's conditioning you. And then of course the evil Mara will turn up and whisper in your ear, you truly are a very generous person. So as soon as you hear that, you say, ah, I saw you Mara, just like the Buddha did, I see you Mara, you didn't fool me this time. Or he might say something like, that's too much, get some back. You don't think it's that much. See so that's the old stingy Mara. So as soon as that comes into your mind you note it. You see it's there but that wasn't the intention. That was not conditioning. This is really important. Remember that the actual conscious intention with which you do something is the main conditioning factor.

So just keeping that in mind whenever you're going to give something, even to a friend, even if you're going to help them with decoration, you can still do it as a pure gift. And that has that effect of developing in us just a natural generosity.

So the question is how do you develop this generosity? Well, I mean, obviously there's things like compassion. If you feel bad about something or bad about some situation, then obviously you're prepared to give. Also for joy, you know, birthdays, Christmas marriages, you just give naturally because you want the other persons to have even a greater enjoyment, greater joy.

But these are dependent you might say on those sorts of relationships of compassion or joy. But if we want to develop a sort of general attitude of generosity the real thing to develop is gratitude.

And I don't know whether you've ever done this, but if you make a list of everything you've received in life for which you've not paid, for which was just given to you, it can be a bit overwhelming because you realise it's impossible to pay back what you've been given.

You're just starting with your parents, even if they were the most awful, terrible people in the world who messed up your life completely. The fact is, they fed you enough to keep you alive and in this particular lifetime you happen to meet the *dhamma* which is going to liberate you from suffering so even for that you can be grateful. And then there's, I just made a quick list here like society, you know, the health care you get, the social care, the education. I mean your parents could not have afforded all that. All that was given because of the general commitment of the community towards individuals.

Then you've got teachers, your ordinary teachers through school, your spiritual teachers, all these people have given. And I mean, especially during school, I bet you never gave anything to your teachers. I don't remember. As a teacher, the only thing I

ever received was a bottle of wine from one of my students. Eight years for one bottle of wine. That was their expression of, I can't have been a very good teacher, that's all. That's what I put it down to.

Then your employers. You see you have to thank your employers whether you like them or not. The point is that they give you work and it's through your work you earn money. What about the government? See they never do what you want them to do but you know somebody's got to do the dirty work so you have to thank them for that.

And then there's all the little things, little things like just the gifts of the day. For instance I was trying to get on the computer at the centre this morning and Kristin and then Dita went out of the way to try to get me on it. Failed completely of course but the fact is that they were there just giving that bit of help. So even during the day these little things like opening doors saying you know keep well I hope you're happy and all that. All those are just little offerings to us that we don't recognise as generosity.

So once you begin to reflect on the amount of stuff we receive for which we don't have to pay anything, we don't even have to say thank you. I mean, if you think about the dentist, did you walk out of the dentist saying thank you? You sometimes forget that they've actually given you a service.

So if you just make a list of all the things that you've received in this life then of course there is this unrequited desire to repay and of course you can't repay and I doubt most of these people that I've mentioned would want you to repay but it invites you to really develop your own generosity.

Now, finally, the reason for it, of course, is because it's part of the spiritual path. And so one of the perfections is this generosity, supported by gratitude, which isn't listed, shall we say it's presumed. But the other factor that comes in now is renunciation, just the natural renunciation. And what we mean by renunciation is what is not feeding our desire to indulge our desires.

So every time we give something away some of our wealth or some of our time we're actually renouncing something. And that process of renunciation is letting go of all that greed and all the greed and everything that comes from acquisitiveness which is the manifestation of delusion. So the more generous we are the more we're undermining that sense of delusion.

And that will eventually, according to the commentaries, unfortunately it doesn't actually say this the scriptures but you can see the logic of it, just by exercising generosity that in itself is a path to liberation.

So you can see that there's a lovely little virtuous circle here of gratitude, generosity and renunciation which as it were just spirals us, it twirls us up towards *nibbāna*.

So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I have not caused confusion and that by your devotions of generosity, you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Facets of a Love

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 14 min

In this heartfelt exploration of love and relationship, Bhante Bodhidhamma moves beyond romantic notions to examine the fundamental qualities that create genuine human connection. Drawing on the Buddha's teachings about spiritual friendship, he identifies care as the foundation of love—recognizing our deep interconnectedness rather than viewing others as competitors in our individualistic society.

The talk weaves together practical wisdom about expressing affection through kindness, while warning against using or controlling others. Bhante emphasizes two crucial underpinnings of all relationships: gratitude and forgiveness. He shares the story of three Arahats living in harmony by each putting aside their personal preferences for others' benefit, and offers the amusing tale of a journalist applying dolphin training techniques to improve her marriage.

Concluding with the Buddha's teaching to Ānanda that spiritual friendship constitutes the entire spiritual life, Bhante shows how good companionship supports our development of the Noble Eightfold Path. This accessible talk offers invaluable guidance for anyone seeking to cultivate more caring, harmonious relationships—whether intimate partnerships, friendships, or community connections—grounded in Buddhist wisdom about our shared humanity.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So I've chosen this topic of love and relationship. Well, as you know, huge amounts of literature are written on love from philosophers, psychotherapists, self-helpers, all religions, so I don't think I'll be covering everything, but I just want to mention a few of the essentials really. So this is just love in general. It's not specific. I'm not going to talk about parental love or falling in love, all that sort of stuff.

So I think the first thing that I always find important is just this sense of care. You know, love is a little bit abused, the word love itself. But it's just understanding that interconnectedness we have. And it's funny that with COVID and all that, a lot of people rediscovered neighbourliness. And I think this is really part of this neoliberal thing. You know, most people think of neoliberalism as an operating system, an economic operating system based on the market, but actually it's an ideology. It's an understanding that

everything moves if everybody can just be an entrepreneurial individual, and what it does is it excites my greed to get things and have experiences, to get lots of money. And by doing that, of course, I see you as a competitor. So this is the system we're in. We're in a system that supports greed and competitiveness. It's not about coordination. It's not about interconnectedness.

And I think this manifests clearly now with this COVID, because the rich countries, just like individuals, are just looking after themselves and to hell with everybody else. But unfortunately the interconnectedness is biting back, and I'm hoping that it has some effect on the actual system that we're under at the moment. But just that sense of caring for somebody, you know, not talking about people who are sick or need help, but just a general attitude of looking after people, being aware of their needs no matter what it is, caring for them. I think that's a really important part of that whole syndrome that we call love.

And if we don't do that, if we don't have that attitude, then I think we can shade off into controlling people, using them. I mean, abuse is at the far end, but you can also just use people for your own benefit, a presumption that they will help you but you don't have to help them. So I think that really undermines a relationship when a person finds that they've been used.

I think the other thing is a kindness expressed through a certain affection. You know, we manifest that with hugging and holding hands and hand on heart, tone of voice, all that sort of stuff. I mean, the danger is it becomes a bit mawkish, bit sentimental, huggy-wuggy, touchy-feely stuff. But I think it's important that there's an expression of affection. And I don't know about you, but when I remember acts of unkindness that I've committed, there's always a bitter sorrow that goes with it. How could I have behaved like that? And all that really just depends on this sense of being kind. It's a lovely word, kind.

And when we put these two together and we wonder about how to live with other people, sharing spaces, whether it's intimate or just in an office, doesn't really matter. And there's this occasion in the scriptures where the Buddha comes across three Arhats living together. I think their name — I was trying to find it, I just couldn't find the passage — but I think they're called the Anuruddhas after the chief monk who was with them. And he asked them, how did they live so peacefully together? And he says, "Well, when I get up in the morning, I say to myself, what if I put aside what I want to do and do what the others want to do?" And of course, if everybody says that, then you have this wonderful harmony. But if you're the only one who's saying it, then you'll probably get used.

So it's a case of, if you're with somebody, it doesn't matter where it is — as I say, the office or an intimate relationship — just to get that feeling in the group that you're prepared to put aside what you want to do for what somebody else wants to do if it's more beneficial. I mean, it could even happen on holiday, you know, where you've decided to go here and somebody else has decided to go there, and there's a big rumpus over which one to do. But that doesn't necessarily have to happen if people have the attitude of putting aside what they want. In other words, not being attached to what one wants to do. It's a lovely attitude.

But I think underpinning all relationship actually are these two qualities of gratitude and forgiveness. I mean, if we develop this constant sense of gratitude, of being in debt, of wanting to manifest how much we appreciate what's been given to us, I mean, there's always that desire to help, to communicate, to be with somebody in that grateful way.

And you can't have a relationship which at some point isn't going to hurt. They're going to say something or do something which is going to upset you. And if you can't let go of that, if that grudge stays within us, a sense of resentment, that really undermines the relationship. It comes out just in the way we speak and in how we ask them to do things. It's there within our communication. And I think that's really important. And I would have thought that most relationships begin to collapse when one or the other side just holds on to these grudges, these resentments.

I remember somebody telling me who was a lawyer for family cases, and there was a divorce. It was quite bitter. And he kept saying to the husband, "There's no point in going to court for this because you will lose. It'll be a complete waste of time for you to go to court and get all this out in court because you will lose the case." So he tried to get it across to him, but he wanted to go to court. He wanted somewhere where he could explain all over the place. And that's the anger and the bitterness that can come with holding onto resentments.

There's something quite lovely about this. I read something quite lovely about this journalist. She'd gone down in America. She'd gone down to see how dolphins are trained. And what she saw was that whenever a dolphin didn't jump through the hoop or play the trick or failed to do the trick, nothing was said, absolutely nothing. And then they did the usual routine and the dolphin would complete the trick. When the dolphin completed the trick, the trainers jumped up and down with great joy, shouting and whooping and making all sorts of great noises. So she thought, "Well, I wonder if this would work on my husband." So when she went back home, she never criticised him. She never said anything. But every time he did something that pleased her, or he did

something the way she wanted him to do, she would jump up and down with great joy and blow trumpets. And he changed completely. Without knowing it, it was very harmonious. And then, of course, she went and told him. And so he found that also worked, even if it's conscious, even if it's a conscious thing that the other person knows what you're doing, it actually works. So holding back on criticisms and all that sort of stuff and really rejoicing when the person does something which is to your benefit seems to be the trick really, getting people to do what you want them to do.

And the final thing is, of course, our spiritual well-being. I mean, obviously, if you're living with somebody who's on your path, then that's a tremendous boost, isn't it? I mean, I've known people who've taken to the Buddhist path, but their partner really just doesn't like it. The spouse doesn't like it. And it's been a point of contention. But if you happen to be living with somebody who's actually practising with you, it's obviously a massive support. And it's the same with any friendship that does it.

And just to end with this lovely quote from the Buddha. So Ananda, who was with him for the last 20 years of his life as a personal assistant, always thinks he knows a bit more than he actually does. And on this occasion, he said to the Buddha, "Bhagavan, this is half the spiritual life: good friendship, good companionship, and good comradeship." The Buddha says, "Oh, not so, Ananda, not so. This is the entire spiritual life, that is, good friendship, good companionship, and good comradeship. For when someone has a good friend, a good companion, and a good comrade, it is to be expected they will develop and cultivate the noble eightfold path."

So that was his understanding of what friendship was, good friendship. And of course, if we remember, he was with his five friends when he left them. They all thought he'd gone soft, remember. He was practising this asceticism, which was basically not eating, letting go of the body. And he was with five friends. Five close friends were all practising together. And we all know that practising with people in a group is so much more encouraging than doing it by yourself.

So all these points — I mean, there's a lot more of course that you could think of — but just bringing to mind that sense of care, affection and kindness, especially kindness. I don't know, it's a big thing with me, these underlying attitudes of gratitude and forgiveness. And then finally, just that ability to be with somebody, to be open to their ideas, to their understandings, even in conversation. Even in conversation, what if I put aside my ideas, my views, my opinions, and open up to what the other one has to say? So often we don't like to do that because they might change our minds.

So it's a case of looking at our relationships from this point of view of being with another human being who's like us. So I'm a human being and you're a human being, and just remembering that. And that I think produces for us that relationship of kindness and care.

Very good. So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance and I have not caused any confusion, and that you will, by your practice of loving-kindness, be fully liberated sooner rather than later.

Appamāda: The Path to the Deathless — Dhammapada 22-24

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 17 min

In this illuminating talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines three crucial verses from the Dhammapada (22-24) centered on the concept of appamāda — variously translated as vigilance, conscientiousness, or heedfulness. He explores how appamāda represents the path to the deathless (amatapadam) while negligence (pamāda) leads to spiritual death.

The discussion delves into the Buddha's final exhortation "appamādena sampādetthāti" (strive diligently for your liberation) and references teachings from the Aṅguttara Nikāya on how heedlessness causes unwholesome states to arise while wholesome qualities decline. Bhante offers practical guidance on cultivating appamāda in daily life through mindful attention to our reactions and intentions.

Key themes include: maintaining right intention throughout activities, the practice of 'parking' unwholesome states rather than suppressing them, and understanding appamāda as encompassing mindfulness, care, and diligent effort. The talk emphasizes how genuine spiritual diligence involves constantly restarting our practice whenever we notice we've gone 'offline' from awareness, making this teaching highly relevant for both formal meditation and everyday mindfulness practice.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

I'm looking at the Dhammapada, verses 22, 23, 24. They're very similar. I shall do the little chanting.

Appamādo amatapadaṃ, pamādo maccuno padaṃ. Appamattā na miyyanti, pamattā yathā matā.

Etaṃ visesato ñatvā, appamāde paṇḍitā. Appamāde pamodanti, ariyānaṃ gocare ratā.

So it translates as this. This word *pamādo*, that's what we're looking at, *appamādo*, translated variously. Here it's translated as conscientiousness, but as I say, I slightly prefer Gil Fronsdal. He uses the word vigilance.

So the translation is: vigilance is the path to the deathless, negligence the path to death. The vigilant do not die, the negligent are as if already dead.

Then there's a commentary to that. So wise people know very clearly that conscientiousness is the state of the deathless. Therefore they rejoice in conscientiousness, they praise it and pay high attention to it. They are delighting in the sphere of the noble ones. This is, of course, nothing else than *Nibbāna*. So again, the only way to reach this state is to make conscientious effort in this direction, applying all one's energy and striving. So that, of course, reminds you of the Buddha's last words: strive diligently.

The next verse says: knowing this distinction between vigilance and non-vigilance, vigilant sages rejoice in vigilance, delighting in the field of the noble ones. So that's much the same. The commentary just says you cannot proceed on the path towards awakening without it. And if we are negligent, how can we find the energy to purify our hearts. So conscientiousness is the path to the deathless. Only with it we can find the way to our goal, *Nibbāna*. And negligence is the way to repeated cycle of birth and death. Conscientious people are able to achieve or reach *Nibbāna*, thus escaping the re-births. Whereas the negligent cannot escape, they may as well be dead already.

And the final verse: absorbed in meditation, persevering, always steadfast, the wise experience *Nibbāna*, the ultimate rest from toil.

So again, the commentary adds: continuing the line of reasoning of the previous verses, if one knows that conscientious heedfulness, vigilance or diligence—these are all words for the same *appamāda*—is the key to reaching *Nibbāna*. Applying this to the practice of meditation, one has to persevere constantly and with strong effort. By this we are able to reach *Nibbāna*, to really touch it, here and now. Thus we obtain the highest peace from bondage, the only true peace and freedom available.

Now, I usually read the story, but frankly I can't see any connection whatsoever, which tells you that whoever compiled the Dhammapada thought, now where did this come from? I don't have the ability to find out whether these verses are directly from the Buddha, but most of them are. But anyway, this is the story they attach to it. It's a long story, so I've just reduced it.

So Sāmāvatī was the consort of the King Udena of Kosambī. Now Khujjuttarā was fetching flowers for her and the Buddha was present and she heard a talk and became a first stream entrant, *sotāpanna*. Now she went back and she told Sāmāvatī, the queen, and all the maids, and they began to take on the teaching, and they began to pay

homage to the Buddha as he came on alms round. But because they were afraid the king might not like what they were doing, they would do it through little holes in their dwelling.

Now there was another consort, the very beautiful Māgandiyā. This is a parallel story. Her father was a Brahmin and he had offered her to the Buddha as a bride, and the Buddha had rejected it, having no sensual pleasure and reminding him that the body was full of filth. The Brahmin and his wife realised that of course everything is impermanent and, believe it or not, became *anāgāmis*, non-returners. But the daughter vowed revenge. She was very upset with the Buddha.

Anyway, she went and told Udena about these holes. This is the king. But he didn't seem to be concerned. But then she began putting ideas in his head that he was in grave danger. And she hid a snake when the king was going to go over with his lute, his *vīṇā*, and play a few songs for the queen. She hid a snake inside the *vīṇā* and put flowers over the hole. And when they arrived, of course, and the flowers taken out, the snake jumped out and the king was furious.

So he lined up Queen Sāmāvatī with all her maids and fired an arrow to kill them all, just like that. But the loving kindness of the women was such that the arrows failed to connect. Would you believe that? And so this way the king discovered or realised that the women were innocent.

However, Māgandiyā was not satisfied. She asked her husband to go and burn the palace down, which he did, and they all died. Fantastic story, isn't it? You can see this on Hollywood.

And we've got the last paragraph says: as soon as he heard that the palace was burning, he rushed to the scene. But it was too late, and he suspected it had been done by the instigation of Māgandiyā. But he did not show that he was suspicious. Instead, he said, while Sāmāvatī was alive, I was very fearful and alert, thinking I might be harmed by her. Only now I have peace of mind. Who could have done this? It must only have done by somebody who loves me dearly. Now on hearing this, the foolish Māgandiyā promptly admitted that it was she who'd instructed her husband to do this terrible deed. Thereupon the king pretended to be very pleased with her and said that he would grant a great favour and honour to all her relatives. So the relatives were sent for and they came gladly. On arrival at the palace all of them including Māgandiyā was seized and put to death in the palace courtyard. Thus the evil Māgandiyā was punished for plotting the death of the holy queen and her attendants.

And then he said, when the Buddha was told about these incidents, that's what he said. He just talked about *appamāda*. If you can make the connection, you must email me. Anyway, that's by the way.

So we've got this word *appamāda*. *Maccuno* just means death. So it's a very favourite word of the Buddha. Remember that it's his final exhortation. This thing here, strive diligently for your liberation. *Appamādena sampādetthāti*. *Sampādeti* means to strive, it means actually to work hard at trying to get what you want, to fulfil a longing. I rather like that, fulfil a longing.

Then although he mentions lots of virtues which stop unwholesome states arising and develop wholesome states, here's a couple of quotes from the Aṅguttara Nikāya, which is the Collection of Numbers. So the teaching is set out in numbers, one of these, two of those, very Theravāda. And it says: I do not see even a single thing as causes un-arisen unwholesome qualities to arise, and arisen wholesome qualities to decline, as heedlessness. That's another word for *pamāda*. One who is heedless—un-arisen unwholesome qualities arise and arisen wholesome qualities decline. It's a funny way of saying things but there we are. And then he says in the next verse of course the opposite.

Now what I did was I looked up words for diligence because that's why it's normally translated, and I came up with lots of little words which are approximate. And then when I separated them out, I was quite pleased to see that you could divide these words into mindfulness: attentive, vigilant, heedful. You also had a sense of care with the word diligence: careful, conscientious, meticulous, thorough, painstaking. And diligence also is a sort of effort, to be diligent at your work and all that: hardworking, industrious, assiduous, persistent, zealous. And of course all these words do bring a nuance to the meaning.

So I just made up a little exercise here. You can take each word mindful and just ask yourself, when you reflect on the day or something that you've done, you can always ask yourself these questions: have I been mindful? Have I been careful? Have I been diligent? Did I put the right effort in?

Now, when it comes to spiritual practice, of course, bringing that quality of mindfulness into daily life is very much about being aware of how we are reacting to what we're doing. So even things like eating or gardening, simple tasks, is always to stop for a moment and to make sure that we've got the right intention. It's often the case that you might start off with the right intention, but then it slips into its opposite. So you might be washing the pots and the mind starts wandering off somewhere and you find yourself washing the pots very angrily. And so you have to stop and consider and then re-

start. So the whole process is one of restarting. You stop, as soon as you see you've gone offline, you've gone off piste, you stop for a minute and just bring yourself back. And that's diligence in the practice.

In ordinary daily life, you can see from the antonyms, from the opposites: lazy, sluggish, slothful, can't be bothered, do it tomorrow. So these are the underlying tendencies. So there is this understanding that when some unwholesomeness arises consciously, it's always there, present underneath, as a potential. So those are your *anusaya*. Here, of course, the Buddha is only concerned with what makes us suffer, what causes problems. But it's obviously also true for all the virtues. So when we find ourselves being gentle, kind, generous, those qualities are also as potential within our hearts.

When you recognise something's come up which you don't like, like you're getting angry with something, or you're getting anxious about something, or you feel a bit down because of something, you have to just be very careful that we don't push it away with a sense of not wanting. So the action of just suppressing something is only going to add more bad energy into the system. So I've got this thing about parking it. So you just put it to the side. You don't use anger or fear to get rid of something. You just put it to the side and turn your attention towards what you want to do. In fact, that's one and the same action. If you just acknowledge, for instance, that there's irritation, and then you acknowledge it and you, as it were, just leave it to the side and you draw your attention to what you want to do. That way you're not suppressing, you're not adding further unwholesome energy into the system. Refuse to be hijacked.

So that's my little presentation for the evening. And I can only hope it is of some help in your practice and that you will be fully liberated sooner rather than later.

Ageing

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 18 min

In this contemplative talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines three verses from the Dhammapada that address the reality of ageing and the body's impermanence. He shares the traditional stories accompanying each verse, including the courtesan Sirimā whose death taught a lovesick monk about non-attachment to physical beauty, and the 120-year-old nun Uttarā who attained the first path and fruit despite her frail condition.

The talk contrasts how even royal chariots decay while the Dhamma remains eternal, illustrated through the curious story of Queen Mallikā. Bhante reflects on the psychological and spiritual dimensions of ageing, noting how reaching 75 can mark an awakening to mortality that abandons youthful ambitions for present-moment acceptance.

Drawing on both Buddhist wisdom and Shakespeare's "Seven Ages of Man," he traces life's progression through seven-year cycles, from childhood's loss of innocence to old age's preparation for death. The discussion emphasizes how ageing offers opportunities for reflection, healing old wounds, expressing gratitude, and developing comfort with impermanence—ultimately supporting the path toward liberation from suffering.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

What I've chosen is a chapter called "On Ageing," but actually there are very few verses in the chapter. The title of a chapter in the Dhammapada really doesn't tell you what's in it. It usually has one or two verses to do with the title. So I found about three or four of them. We're going to do three of them. I shall change my normal way. I'm going to chant and then translate, and then give the story three times that way, even though they're very similar.

The first one: *Etha passathimam kāyam cittam roga-nilam pabhaṅguramuhuccitam yassa natthi dhuvam ṭhānam.*

Gil Fronsdorf translates that as, "Look at this beautiful mind-made body." I don't see where he gets the "beautiful" from. Maybe he's translating this *bimba*, which I don't know whether it's connected, but the Italian word for baby is *bimbo*. It just means shape, the shape of the body. So it's like this elusive or delusive idea that we have of the

body. We don't see it as it really is, but actually it's a mass of sores, propped up, full of illness, and of course we use it for our many plans. But there's nothing stable or lasting about it. It's impermanent and unstable.

The story that goes with that is about a courtesan named Sirimā. She was a devotee of the Buddha, offering alms food to the monks and all that. She was known as very generous, but she was also very beautiful. One young monk heard about this, and he fell in love with her, even without seeing her. Very strange. The next day he joined the monks who went to her house, but Sirimā was sick. But she still paid respects to the monks, and after seeing her, this young monk desired her even more.

That night poor Sirimā died. Sad story. The Buddha wanted to teach this young monk a lesson. So he asked the king to keep the corpse for a few days. Then on the fourth day, he took the dead body out to the charnel grounds. Of course, it was no longer beautiful. It was bloated, stinky and full of worms. The Buddha told the young monk if he wanted to see Sirimā, then he would be able to go and see her. When he got to see her, of course, it was a terrible shock when he saw in fact it was a corpse. He must have had some inkling of that because the Buddha would have told him where to find her, which was at the charnel grounds.

The Buddha asked the king to announce that anybody who paid a thousand coins—she was a courtesan, so a very royal prostitute we can say, or a high-up prostitute—to pay a thousand coins for a night with her, but of course nobody wanted to. Even when it was free, nobody wanted to spend a night with a corpse. The Buddha told the monks about this, and he then talked about non-attachment to the body. This young monk, as always in these stories, seeing the true nature of the body, his love for Sirimā completely disappeared. I never know how to really connect these stories, but anyway, they tell us something about the time.

The second one: *Parijñāṇam idaṃ rūpaṃ roga-nilāṃ pabhaṅguraṃ bhijjati pūti-kāyo maraṇantañ hi jīvitaṃ.*

That translates as: "This body is worn out, so fragile and a nesting ground for disease. When life ends in death, this putrid body dissolves." It's not centering on old age, but at least it tells us about the unreliability of the body.

The story that goes with that is about Uttarā, who was a very old nun. She was 120 years old. She was very generous and respectful. Many times she shared her alms food with the monks just out of her kindness. Once while going on alms rounds, she met the Buddha. Reverentially, she stepped out of his way and paid her homage. While she was doing that, she accidentally stepped on her robe and fell over. The Buddha consoled her

and told her to understand the condition of her body. She was very old and her body was frail. She should practice diligently to perfect her mind. Uttarā reflected on the Buddha's words and attained the first path and fruit. That was the second verse.

The third one: *Jīranti ve rāja-rathā sucittā atho sarīram pi jaraṃ upeti dhammo ca puññānaṃ na jaraṃ upeti santo have sabbhi pavedayanti.*

This translates as: "Even the splendid chariots of royalty wear out, so does the body grow old. But the Dhamma of the virtuous doesn't decay, or it is upheld when the virtuous teach it to good people." The other translation is "the good ones teach it to each other." Here the Buddha is contrasting how even things begin to wear out, never mind the body, but the Dhamma doesn't.

There's a very strange story that goes with this. Queen Mallikā was the wife of King Pasenadi, who was the king of Kosala, north of the Ganges. Once she went to the bathroom to wash herself, and her dog entered with her. While she bent over to wash her feet, the dog started to misbehave with her, and the queen did not stop it. Leave that to your imagination.

When she came out, the king told her he saw everything through the window. What was he doing looking through the window? Anyway, he scolded her for her behavior, but Mallikā denied doing anything and suggested that the bathroom was enchanted— whoever went inside would be seen doing strange things through the window. She sent the king inside. When he came out she told him she saw him misbehaving with a goat. The king, not being very smart, accepted this as an explanation, but the queen felt very bad about lying to the king for many years.

When she was dying, this moment kept coming back to her consciousness over and over again. Because our dying thoughts determine our next birth, she was born in a state of suffering, in a hell state. The king wanted to ask the Buddha where she'd been reborn, but the Buddha was not willing to tell him—he didn't want to hurt his feelings. Only after seven days in a state of suffering, the queen was born in the Tusita heaven as a result of her great meritorious deeds. Only then did the Buddha reply to the king's question, and the king was happy to hear this, but at the same time felt sad for her death. The Buddha replied with this verse saying that everything is subject to old age and death and therefore he should practice the Dhamma diligently.

I had written down some thoughts about death, which might lead to your own contemplation. Presuming now a healthy old age—healthy or not—mobility lessens, strength weakens, everything diminishes. Parts don't work so well, and some parts die before others. Life is strewn with "ooh" and "ahh." Acceptance, that's the way. This is what it is. That's an old meme now, isn't it? "This is what it is."

But the big thing is to abandon all lingering youthful plans. Old age offers time to reflect, to write one's life story, if only for oneself. Slowing down leads to restfulness in the present moment, watching the world go by. These days that might not be so pleasant. But it's a time to heal old wounds, apologies withheld, now offered, to remember all that was given, heartfelt gratitude expressed. And I think most of all, learning to wait—waiting to leave, to move on, to disappear, to go, comfortable with death.

I only had these thoughts once I reached 75. Until I reached 74, I had ideas of becoming a prime minister, ruler of the world, great footballer, great lover. It all disappeared, all in one birthday.

I was just thinking about life, and various people have separated our lives into certain allotments, you might say. I think I read somewhere Aristotle thought in terms of 25 years—25, 50, 75. That sort of works. Twelve years also can work in terms of splitting your life up, but the one that Shakespeare uses—I shall read his poem at the end—is of course seven years, which I think came into fashion during the medieval ages.

The first seven years: the first three are incredibly important, it seems, but at seven, you shed that lovely, delightful childlike mind and get real, a bit more real anyway, a bit more rational. Father Christmas can't come down the chimney. But worst of all, we become aware of guilt. We start feeling guilty about doing naughty things. Of course, this is the story of Adam and Eve. They ate the fruit of the tree of good and evil. I mean, it's so obvious. I don't know how people can come to believe it was actually real, that there was a place called Eden. It just boggles me anyway. So that's the first seven. That's a real change within us, actually. You might say that is actually part of the process of awakening. If you're always at the age of three, there'd be no hope, would there? I think chimpanzees get to about the age of three. I read that somewhere.

Then, of course, 14. Well, that's a real change, isn't it? Sex, drugs and rock and roll. A whole different type of relationship. When we get to 21, we normally feel quite mature. We're normally either in some sort of skilled job or we're still gathering skills. We feel we're ready to move out into the world as fully grown adults.

By 28, it's all getting serious, I think. Some people start thinking about pensions and marriage and all that sort of stuff. You're getting a bit more real. But by 35, of course, you're normally well-established, if you've been lucky enough. Don't know about these days. But that officially is middle age, but you never think of that because you're still on top of the world. That hits you around about 40, 42. That's when the upward swing of life, the growing up, begins to level out, and we know we're growing down. We say growing old, but what goes up must come down.

By 49, 50, you know, you're not going to get that many more promotions or things aren't going to happen too much. These days you probably get fired. By 56, you're becoming aware that retirement is just over the hill there, looming ahead of you, retirement and all the thoughts that come around that. Some people, of course, take early retirement, but it's usually in the 60s. Then you're entering into a different way of life really. You try and make sense of it, got to keep busy, join all sorts of civic activities and reading clubs and anything to make life worthwhile.

By the time you're 70, you're well established if it's gone well. You normally feel okay, life's going your way, you might say, as long as you're healthy and all that. But when you reach 75, that's a bit of a doomsday birthday because you're looking at 80 and basically you're on countdown. You know most people disappear before 85, and that's a bit of an awakening call, isn't it? If you reach grand old age, well, it just carries on, but basically somewhere in your 80s, I think the mind has to become accustomed to the idea of dying.

It's one way of reflecting on our lives. I can end here now with this lovely poem by Shakespeare. Everybody knows it.

"All the world's a stage, and all the men and women are merely players. They have their exits and their entrances, and one man in his time plays many parts, his acts being seven ages. At first the infant, mewling and puking in the nurse's arms. And then the whining school-boy, with his satchel and shining morning face, creeping like snail unwillingly to school. And then the lover, sighing like furnace, with a woeful ballad made to his mistress' eyebrow. Then a soldier, full of strange oaths and bearded like the pard, jealous in honour, sudden and quick in quarrel, seeking the bubble reputation even in the cannon's mouth. And then the justice, in fair round belly with good capon lined, with eyes severe and beard of formal cut, full of wise saws and modern instances; and so he plays his part. The sixth age shifts into the lean and slippered pantaloone, with spectacles on nose and pouch on side, his youthful hose, well saved, a world too wide for his shrunk shank; and his big manly voice, turning again toward childish treble,

pipes and whistles in his sound. Last scene of all, that ends this strange eventful history, is second childishness and mere oblivion, sans teeth, sans eyes, sans taste, sans everything."

Dear me. With that lovely little poem I shall bring my little homily to an end. I trust it has been of some use, and I can only hope that by our contemplation of life and death we shall be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Dhp 152-153: The Inner Critic

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 24 min

Bhante Bodhidhamma examines Dhammapada verses 152-153, which address our tendency to easily spot others' faults while remaining blind to our own shortcomings. The first verse illustrates how we sift others' faults "like chaff" while concealing our own "as a cheat conceals a bad throw of the dice." The second warns that focusing on others' faults while taking constant offense allows our own āsavas (toxins/taints) to flourish, moving us further from their destruction.

Drawing parallels with Jesus's teaching about removing the beam from one's own eye, Bhante explores the psychology of criticism and projection. He presents a framework of seven types of inner critics from contemporary psychology: the Perfectionist, Controller, Taskmaster, Underminer, Destroyer, Guilt-Tripper, and Conformist. Each represents different ways we can become trapped in destructive self-criticism versus beneficial self-reflection.

The talk emphasizes the importance of distinguishing between constructive self-awareness—essential for spiritual development—and the harsh, obsessive inner criticism that breeds inadequacy, shame, and depression. Through mindful recognition, feeling the emotional impact, and responding with kindness rather than harshness, we can transform our relationship with self-criticism while maintaining the wisdom to see our faults clearly.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambhodassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambhodassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambhodassa

Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

So I've chosen these two *Dhammapada* verses, 152 and 153. I shall do my little chanting.

*Sudassan̐ vajjan̐ aññesan̐ attano pana duddasan̐
Paresan̐ hi so vajjan̐ opunāti yathā bhusan̐
Attano pana chādeti kalin̐ va kitavā saṭho*

And the translation, I'll do the one and then we'll do the little story that comes with it. So the first one is, it's easy to see the fault of others, but hard to see one's own. One sifts out the faults of others like chaff, but conceals one's own as a cheat conceals a bad throw of the dice.

The commentary, a little story. In the town of Bhaddiya there lived a rich man called Mendaka. When the Buddha arrived at Bhaddiya, he realised that Mendaka and his whole family were able to understand the Dharma. He explained the teaching to them, and after hearing the Dharma from him, Mendaka, his wife, son, daughter-in-law and servant all attained first level of attainment. It was quick, wasn't it?

Mendaka related how many ascetic teachers spoke ill of the Buddha and tried to dissuade Mendaka from seeing him. The Buddha explained by this verse that it is only very natural to see others' faults and not to see one's own. The Buddha then revealed the past existences of Mendaka. He was always a rich man who donated many things to those seeking awakening. So that's a big hint. You have to take these things with a pinch of salt.

So that's really about finding fault with others, not seeing one's own faults. That's the problem. I think we all do that to some extent.

Now the next verse, much the same. If one focuses on others' faults and constantly takes offense, one's own toxins flourish and one is far from their destruction.

Now here, Gil Fronsdal has translated the word *asava* as toxins, but it's a particular word, it's a group of three, sometimes four, often translated as the taints or the cankers, and it includes sense desire as leading to attachment, the desire to become eternally, to be yourself eternally, to be a person eternally, and ignorance or delusion. But sometimes you get wrong view added to it, which seems to me just an extension of ignorance. This ignorance *avijja* is often also talked about as *moha* which is delusion, and of course that will manifest in the way we think and how we understand things. So that was probably a later addition or a clarification.

So the commentary on that one is, there was a monk named Ujjhanasaññi. He was always finding faults with others. It's fairly easy to get angry and speak ill of people. When the Buddha found out, he spoke this verse. He also added that sometimes finding faults with others is good. When we see someone misbehave and we try to teach that person good ways, then it's worthy of praise. But if we do it out of spite or malice, then we won't be able to achieve concentration, and therefore we get further and further away from awakening.

Why would spite and malice stop us from achieving concentration? Well, the understanding is, of course, that it becomes a hindrance. It's always there in the back of our minds. It'll either replay itself, doing the same old thing in our fantasies, or we'll end up feeling guilty and horrible.

So this one is really about hypocrites, I suppose. And of course, what came to mind was the sayings of Jesus. So in Matthew 7, verse 5, he's very abrupt. He was said to have spoken directly, "Thou hypocrite, first cast out the beam out of thine own eye, and then shalt thou see clearly to cast out the mote out of thy brother's eye." So that's telling you. In Luke chapter 6:42, it's a bit more gentle. "And how art thou able to say to thy brother, Brother, permit, I may take out the speck in thine eye, thyself not beholding the log in thine own."

The Buddha too, he asked people not to criticise young monks so much because it would take away their confidence. It discourages you.

So just one or two questions to reflect upon. What is the effect on us when somebody criticises us? I think we feel a certain anger, a certain resentment. It's a bit infra dig and all that. So when we criticise somebody, it's always best to remind ourselves that their reaction is not going to be very pleasant unless somehow we can put it in a way that doesn't sound as though we are criticising them.

I remember once somebody, I was a friend and he said to me just out of the blue, he said, "You're jealous of me." Now actually it's not as though I don't suffer from jealousy, this is going back now before I was a monk, but I wasn't jealous of him. Anyway, we were standing there and another friend came up and started praising my new jacket, and when I turned this man was brimming with jealousy.

So often we criticise in others what we ourselves are not aware of. That's an old understanding, isn't it? But also I think sometimes we criticise others because we are caught up in our own understanding of how to behave. I'm just thinking of people coming late to meditation. So most people would get slightly angry with that, a bit miffed. Somebody's coming in constantly two, five minutes late. And of course that would be justified. They shouldn't do that. But then I think reflecting on the many times we've been late and upset people, it just undermines that attitude.

I think also there are times when we criticise somebody because we have a particular standard. So for instance, talking about punctuality, if we tend to be very punctual, we tend to be critical of somebody who isn't. And somehow there's an overlay. I mean, you might be a little miffed that somebody's come late, but if you're over-angry, then that suggests a certain pride, a certain holding on to one's opinions. You've got to be a bit easy with people.

The Buddha talks about when you're going to say something to somebody that isn't going to be pleasant, you have to choose the right time. You don't want to choose it just when they're at the peak of happiness. And it has to be truthful and spoken gently, and

of course known to be beneficial. So that's important. So if somebody comes late you might, I mean sometimes I do this to people who come late here, I might say to them, "Do you think you coming late upsets the other meditators?" Perhaps sometimes I appeal to them. "I'd be really pleased if you came early." So there are ways in which you can suggest, maybe without saying, the bell goes, you should be here on time. Anyway, I'm too small to act like that. I'll get beaten up.

Now, I did get slightly sidetracked here because I got into this inner critic, looking at the beam in our own eye, the log in our own eye. And it reminded me of Freud's super-ego and all that, where you've got this ethical component damning you and telling you how terrible you are. But I think we have to, presuming that we can distinguish between constructive self-criticism and what is destructive. Obviously, it's important for us to be able to have a clear view of our shortcomings. That's not a problem. But I think often our inner critic, as they say, is really a bit over the top sometimes. And as I say, it produces a sense of inadequacy, shame, defeat, low self-esteem, depression. We sometimes absorb our abuser's language.

I was thinking of a point where my father, I'd forgotten something, and my father said, "Forget means don't care." Now I, in those days you didn't answer back or you'd get a smack on the head, so I had to swallow that. "Forget means don't care."

Now, later on, of course, I began to realise, yeah, if you care for something, you tend not to forget it. I mean, you don't forget the plane time that you're going to take when you go on holiday. And you don't forget meeting a friend for a cup of tea or something. So it's really when we don't want to forget something, if we make it important to ourselves, then we don't. Now the only exception to that is when you get old like me and then you get what you call senior moments. It doesn't matter how much you remind yourself, you just forget.

Anyway, I came across this compilation by Jay Earley and Bonnie Weiss. One is a psychologist and Bonnie is a psychotherapist. And they've come up with these seven types of inner critics. I thought, well, that's interesting. I thought we'd just read through these and then afterwards we can all have a little discussion as to which one we're guilty of.

So the first one is the perfectionist. The critic tries to get you to do things perfectly. It sets high standards for things you produce and has difficulty saying something is complete and letting it go out to represent your best work. Tries to make sure that you fit in and that you will not be judged or rejected. And its expectations probably reflect those of people who've been important to you in the past.

And that critic, when it comes, I think you have to recognise it. It's like you're doing *vipassana* and you record, you call it by its name. "Now that's perfectionism." And then you have to feel, you have to feel the negativity of it. And then you have to remind yourself, a person cannot be perfect. It's just a fact. You can't be perfect. But you can be excellent. You can do things as best as you can. And that's good enough.

So in a sense, these inner critics, you have to actually acknowledge them. You have to feel what they're doing to you in your heart. I mean, they're all aversive. And then when that passes you've got to find the opposite.

So here we have the inner controller. So this critic tries to control your impulses, eating, drinking, sexual activity and so on. It's polarised with an indulger, an addict who it fears can get out of control at any moment. It tends to be harsh and shaming in an effort to protect you from yourself. It is motivated to try and make you a good person, which is accepted and functions well in society.

Now, in a sense, of course, part of that's good. I mean, we don't want to be overcome by habits such as overeating and things like that. But on the other hand, there's an overlay of that, which can make life miserable for you. So this harsh and shaming, see? So again, I think it's a case of feeling it, naming it for what it is. "That's the controller." And then just to sit with it till that aversion disappears. And then to talk to yourself kindly. Yes, the Buddha's word is restraint, to exercise restraint.

Then we have the taskmaster. So the critic wants you to work hard and be successful. And it fears that you may be mediocre or lazy and will be judged as a failure if it does not push you to keep going. Its pushing often activates a procrastinator, a rebel that fights against its harsh dictate. So here we have a real contradictory mental state. And I think again it's the same thing, to actually feel that and hear what it's saying and to name it. And then one other thing we can do is to have a conversation with it. That you're not lazy, insist that you're not lazy by any means.

The next one is the underminer. So the critic tries to undermine your self-confidence and self-esteem so that you won't take risks. It makes direct attacks on your self-worth so that you will be able to stay small and not take chances where you could be hurt or rejected. It's afraid of your being too big, too visible, and not being able to tolerate judgment or failure.

So this seems to centre on self-confidence, self-esteem. Fear of failure, that really can be such a destroyer of life. You don't do anything just in case you fail. That can be quite destructive. One has to take the measured risk. And in so doing, even failure becomes a

success because then you know it's a learning process. But if you're always going to be afraid of failing, then you just don't risk anything. You just stay dead safe and you undermine your potential.

So it's the same with the destroyer. So it makes pervasive attacks on your fundamental self-worth. It shames you and makes you feel inherently flawed and not entitled to basic understanding or respect. This most debilitating critic comes from early life deprivation or trauma and it is motivated by belief that it is safer not to exist. My goodness. So that's a, if there is that within us then that really has to be tackled. That's not a very good thing to have within us. But again, it is very much a case of naming it, not being afraid of it, turning towards it and really getting into the motivating moods, the motivating emotional states and to hold steady, to be with that and to know that it passes. And when it passes and we haven't indulged it, it's actually being weakened all the time. It's only a habit, that's what it is, just a habit. And then of course to turn around upon ourselves and say things that make us feel we are worthy.

The guilt tripper. Well that's a regular one, I think. This critic is stuck in the past. It's unable to forgive you for wrongs you've done or people you've hurt. It is concerned about relationship and holds you to standards of behaviour prescribed by your community, culture and family. Tries to protect you from repeating past mistakes by making sure you never forget or feel free. Oh yeah, guilt can be awful really, always feeling that we've done something terrible. It can almost be an amorphous feeling which hangs around. "You are guilty, you ought to be hanged." And that of course just messes your relationships up.

So again, much the same way, to feel the guilt, know it's delusive. Now here, of course, we have to be careful because there is proper guilt. I mean, if we do something wrong, which is plainly wrong, or if we know it's plainly wrong, then obviously we should feel guilty and shameful. When it works at that level, the Buddha calls them the two guardians of society. That's tough for us to accept. We have such a downer on guilt and shame. But when they actually activate to correct our behaviour, then they're doing their job. And once the behaviour is corrected, there shouldn't be any more guilt and shame. That's the way it ought to work. And then it stays in the background as a lesson. And so it stops you doing the same thing again, the same wrong things again, because you remember, "Oh, when I do that, this is how I feel." But if it continues and continues, then it's become an obsessive mental state.

And then finally the conformist. So the critic tries to get you to fit into a certain mode based on standards held by society, your culture or your family. It wants you to be liked and admired and to protect you from being abandoned, shamed or rejected. The conformist fears that the rebel or the free spirit in you would act in ways that are unacceptable. So it keeps you from being in touch with and expressing your true nature.

So again, yes, I'm reminded actually of a monk who joined the order, of a man who joined the order. And he was in the order for quite some time. And then he realised that he was just playing at being a monk. He was just, it was like a performance. And there was no real connection with the...

way of life. He was just dressing nicely, holding his bowl beautifully, saying the right things, always looking monkish and spiritual. When he woke up to that, he left. He'd been play-acting, although I dare say his original impulse, his original desire to become a monk had been real. But that really undermined him.

So eventually, I think it's this whole thing about distinguishing between what is beneficial self-criticism. To be able to look at one's actions and recognize that they're not wholesome, they're not good, and then to make that determination not to behave like that. We can be a bit too sensitive, we can be a bit too lax with our behaviour. But we learn that just through doing what we think is correct and then learning from those mistakes.

They've written a book, by the way. It's called *Freedom from Your Inner Critic*, if you want to read more about what they say about things. I thought that was a nice breakdown of what we all suffer from. I think we all have a little bit of all of those, probably.

So as usual, I can only hope my little homily has been of some benefit, and that by your undermining this awful self-critic and yet knowing how to criticise oneself wisely, you may attain full liberation from suffering sooner rather than later.

Sympathy, Empathy and Compassion

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 17 min

In this thoughtful exploration, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines three distinct ways of relating to suffering: sympathy, empathy, and compassion. Drawing from the Buddha's own terminology, he notes how the Awakened One used the word 'anukampa' (literally 'trembling with') when describing his compassionate teaching, suggesting a form of empathy that resonates deeply with others' suffering.

The talk addresses the practical challenges of engaging with suffering in our daily lives, from the risk of emotional burnout through excessive empathy to the potential coldness of distant sympathy. Bhante explores various psychological definitions of empathy and warns against unhelpful responses like pity (rooted in conceit) and moral outrage (often masking personal insecurity).

Using vivid examples including a chance encounter on a bus with an injured elderly man, the talk illustrates different ways we might respond to others' pain - from simple acknowledgment to potentially intrusive 'do-gooding.' The teaching emphasizes finding a middle way that allows genuine heart connection while maintaining the clarity needed for truly helpful action. This practical dharma talk offers valuable guidance for anyone seeking to develop wise compassion without losing themselves in others' suffering.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsbuddhassa

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsbuddhassa

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsbuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

I thought we'd just have a little contemplation around these three words: sympathy, empathy, and compassion.

I want to quote the Buddha here, talking about himself and his relationship to the monks: "Thus, monks, I have taught you the unconditioned, the destination and the path leading to the destination. Whatever should be done, monks, by a compassionate teacher, out of compassion for his disciples, desiring their welfare, that I have done for you. These are the roots of trees, monks. These are empty huts. Meditate! Do not be negligent, lest you regret it later. This is my instruction to you."

Interestingly, whenever he talks about compassion, about himself as a compassionate person, he always uses the word *anukampā*. This word means to tremble. The *anu* is just a reinforcement — shaking, trembling. It's what we would, I presume, recognise as empathy. It's a sort of resonating with somebody else's heart, with somebody else's suffering. The usual word that you'll find, of course, is *karuṇā*, which just means compassion. He's often titled the Mahākaruṇiko, the great compassionate one.

If we look at these three words, sympathy, I think, gets bad press these days in the caring professions. Well, you can understand that if you're looking after somebody, sympathy doesn't quite make it. But even in psychotherapy, I think they have a bit of a downer on it. But frankly, if you were going to feel empathetic about all the suffering in the world, I think you'd burn out. At least I think I'd burn out.

The danger, of course, is that you're standing too far apart. You're not actually feeling anything. This makes any expression of sympathy sound a bit false. Also, in that state, you could fall into the error of being judgmental about the person who's suffering. If somebody fell off a ladder, you might say, "Oh well, you shouldn't have put the ladder there at all. I mean, you were just asking for an accident." It doesn't particularly help somebody who's just broken their legs.

I think there's a place for sympathy. I mean, when somebody dies, you send a card with sympathies — you don't send a card with empathies. So I think it still has some role to play in our relationship to suffering, to people who are suffering.

If you hang about, know certain facts about the world and you allow yourself to become empathetic, then it's a big weight upon you because that empathy moves you towards action. Sympathy, I think, just has a place as a mild connection, a mild heart connection, just knowing that there's not much you can do about it. At the moment, for instance, every day it seems around about 40,000 children die of starvation or hunger-related causes. If you were to hang on to that, it's a dreadful, awful figure.

The Buddha in the Dhammapada actually says hunger is the worst of all diseases. I mean, we don't really feel hunger. We feel hungry, feel a bit peckish, but we're very quick to fulfil it. But hunger — knowing hunger as something that really begins to make you worry about your life — that we've never, or at least I've never had that sort of hunger.

There was somebody who came to Kanduboda who said that he'd been out in the country and he'd lost his food. Something happened. This is in America. He got so hungry that when he caught a bird, he just ate it. He ate it raw. I couldn't tell you how hungry you can get.

Sympathy comes from the Greek, which just means to have a feeling with — a community feeling actually, a sympathy. Empathy, of course, comes from the Greek as well, meaning "in feeling." So you're actually much closer to the person in your heart.

I've got something from this social psychologist, Daniel Batson, who's researched empathy, it seems, for decades. He says there are eight different concepts. I'll read them through and you can decide which one you prefer.

The first one is knowing another's thoughts and feelings. That's how some people use empathy — knowing another's thoughts and feelings. Imagining another's thoughts and feelings. Adopting the posture of another. Actually feeling as another does. Imagining how one would feel or think in another's place. Feeling distress at another's suffering. Feeling for another's suffering — sometimes called pity or compassion. And finally, projecting oneself into another's situation. So people use this word with various meanings.

That one about actually feeling as another does — I think it's a dodgy one, isn't it? I mean, if you have some great sorrow and the person you're telling that to says to you, "Oh, I know exactly what you feel" — well, I mean, it's a bit of a jump, isn't it?

The other one about feeling distress at another's suffering sounds a bit like reactivity. You know, it's like you're reacting to it.

So there's all sorts of definitions for this empathy, but basically I think it differs from sympathy in that there's a heart connection, a greater heart connection. One definition was the ability to appreciate the other person's feelings without becoming so emotionally involved that your judgment is affected. I think that's the danger with empathy — that the emotional part overrides your rational part. There's got to be a balance there.

If you just think about this recent case of this poor five-year-old boy who fell down a well in Morocco: hundreds of people watching online, hundreds of people turned up, thousands watching online. It became worldwide news. And yet, as I've mentioned, every day 40,000 children are dying of hunger or hunger-related causes. So there's a point where something touches you very greatly and it becomes a sort of obsession really.

You might not feel empathy for various reasons. One of them is fear and aversion towards another's suffering that keeps you away from it. If that comes to us then really we have to do a bit of *vipassanā* on it and wait for it to pass and make that effort to connect.

I was once walking on the main road — this is going back many years — and a dog had been knocked over. It was dark at night and it was obviously in agony. Whoever had knocked it over had put it under a tree. I was with my ex-wife at that time. I went to try and make the dog comfortable. As I lifted it a little bit to try and get it into a better position, it just grimaced with this dreadful pain. I didn't know what to do, really. So we just left it. I mean, these days, of course, with mobiles, you'd have got in touch with the RSPCA. But it was imprinted on my mind, the dreadful agony that this poor dog was in.

The other thing is pity. Pity is feeling sorry for someone. It's really coming from a place of conceit, and it stops you really feeling what you're really — what you're really doing is hiding your feeling for that person by covering it over with a sense of being sorry for someone. Well, I mean, we've all I'm sure had that experience of somebody feeling sorry for us. It's not very helpful.

But it's one way that we can, as it were, bypass that feeling of being connected to somebody's suffering if it's something that we find very difficult to be with.

The final thing is moral outrage — people being outraged by the dreadful things that are going on in society and things like that. I was just reading that there are recent studies where for celebrities it's very good for publicity to be morally outraged, and then social media content loves it — sharing, retweeting it, expressing this tremendous moral outrage. But it often disguises a sense of insecurity about one's own moral standing, it seems.

So if you find yourself being morally outraged, just hang on in there for a minute and just ask yourself: well, where's this outrage coming from and how is it helpful? In Buddhist understanding, rage doesn't really help. It only clouds our minds, clouds our hearts.

Finally, if the empathy has force behind it, then there'll be a demand really within ourselves to do something, and that's when we enter into some sort of compassionate action. I just think you have to be very careful there, isn't it? Because often people get burnt out with this stuff, not recognising that difference between what you can do and what you want to do, who you can influence and who you can't influence.

If you try to do something which is not within your power or your area of influence, then obviously you're just going to end up burning out. You're going to end up feeling disappointed, disheartened and all that. I've used the word "depressed" there, which I don't like. It medicalises it. "Disheartened" would be a better word, I think. Down in the dumps.

Here's a little thing that might be of interest. When you're a bit down in the dumps and you feel a bit low, you might give yourself a little present, and that makes you feel happy. It lifts you a little bit. I suppose it comes to what they call retail therapy or something. But how interesting it is that when you see somebody who's a bit down in the mouth and you want to give them a bit of a lift, doing a little kindness to them — your happiness stays much longer.

It tells us about how we relate to each other and how important it is for us to have that kind relationship.

I just want to end with this little occasion that happened to me and what responses I might have given. I won't tell you which one I did. That wouldn't be fair.

I got on a bus once and I sat next to this elderly man — again, this is going back years — and his face was very badly injured and scarred and bruised. I asked him, I said, "What happened?" He said he'd been worrying about his rent and he walked out in the road and got knocked over, got knocked down.

I mean, I could have said things like, "Well, that's bad news. Well, that's what happens when you get worried, you see." "Well, at least you weren't killed." I could say something like, "Well, I'm very sorry to hear that, but you know, the Citizens Advice Bureau — they can really help you with money problems." That would be particularly helpful.

I might say, "Well, that's really terrible. I'm so sorry to hear it. I do hope you heal quickly."

I might say, "I'm very saddened. I'm saddened to hear what you say. It's a pretty terrible experience. How are you feeling now? Are you getting treatment? Are your rent troubles getting sorted? And I hope you heal up quickly." I've had that little bit of conversation. I might leave him cheered up a bit.

But then you might step over that line and you might be saying similar things, but then you say to him, "Have you asked — do you know where to go for help?" And then you suggest the Citizens Advice Bureau. And then you might go a step further, which

takes you a little bit into do-gooding, where you say, "Listen, what I'll do is I'll get in touch with the Citizens Advice Bureau for you and I'll get you to meet them and I'll take you there and do this and do that" — whether the person wants it or not.

So this is do-gooding. A do-gooder is a person who does you the good they want to do you, whether you want it or not, whether you need it or not.

So there's all these various ways that we can relate to somebody's suffering.

Anyway, I hope that gives some food for thought and just allows us not to feel that we have to always do something about somebody's suffering. We're limited by our circumstances. And not to feel that we always have to be deeply empathetic every time we hear somebody's suffering. I just think that burns out. And that there's a place for just ordinary sympathy. I don't know whether you agree with me or not.

Anyway, I hope my words have been of some assistance and that by your wise choice between sympathy, empathy and compassion, you will release yourself from all suffering sooner rather than later.

DHP 314-317 From the Chapter on Hell

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 26 min

In this engaging exploration of Dhammapada verses 314-317 from the chapter on hell, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the consequences of wrong views (micchā diṭṭhi) and misplaced shame. The verses address being ashamed of what is not shameful while remaining unashamed of what truly is, and finding fault where none exists while ignoring real faults—all leading to unfortunate rebirths (durgati).

The teaching includes commentary stories about Jain ascetics and their practices, illustrating how wrong understanding leads to suffering. Bhante provides a detailed explanation of the six realms of existence: the deva realm (driven by vanity), asura realm (jealousy), human realm (desire), animal realm (ignorance), hungry ghost realm (greed), and hell realm (hatred and cruelty). He emphasizes these can be understood both as literal realms and as psychological states we experience in daily life.

The talk concludes with Nāgārjuna's profound insight that saṃsāra and nibbāna are distinguished not by different worlds, but by our relationship to experience—when we cease clinging and cultivate equanimity, loving-kindness, and compassion, we transform suffering into peace. Richly illustrated with traditional hell imagery from Thai, Tibetan, and Western art traditions.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

I shall do my usual little bit of chanting here. These are from the Chapter on Hell.

Lajitāya na lajjanti, micchādiṭṭhi samannāgā, sattā gacchanti duggatim. Abhaye bhaya-asamino, bhaye cābhayasamino, micchādiṭṭhi samannāgā, sattā gacchanti duggatim. Avajje vajjamatino, vajje cāvajjasamino.

Now the translation. This is taken from Gil Fronsdal's book.

Ashamed of what's not shameful and not ashamed of what is, those who take up wrong views go to a bad rebirth.

Seeing danger in what's not danger and not seeing danger in what is, those with wrong views go to a bad, unfortunate rebirth.

I'll read the commentary that goes with that. A group of monks once saw some naked ascetics on their alms round. These would have been the Digambara Jain ascetics who don't wear clothes. You've probably seen them at the Kumbh Mela, the twelve-year celebration, and they cover their bodies with ash, which is antiseptic.

A group of monks once saw some naked ascetics on their alms round. They were naked, but they had their bowls covered with a piece of cloth. The monks remarked that perhaps they should put the cloth in the front part of their body. The naked ascetics retorted that they cover their bowls because they do not want insects or miniature life-forms to enter the bowl and be killed by them later.

When the monks returned to the monastery and told the story to the Buddha, the Buddha responded with this verse, saying that one who is ashamed of what is not shameful, but not shameful of a shameful thing, surely will go to a bad rebirth.

And on the next verse, just a little addition: we should be ashamed and afraid of things that are truly bad. Causing suffering to others is bad, and we should always be ashamed and afraid of doing so. On the other hand, being afraid and ashamed of something that is not bad at all will not help us in any way towards awakening. Thus we only accumulate demerit and suffer an unfortunate rebirth in the next life.

The next two verses I'll do together. I'll put the four together because they're all about going to hell, except the last verse where you get to heaven.

Finding fault in what's not a fault and seeing no fault in what is, those who take up wrong views go to an unfortunate rebirth, bad rebirth.

This little refrain: those who take up wrong views. But knowing fault as fault, and the faultless as the faultless, those who take up right views go to a good rebirth. The word is actually *duggati* and *suggati*. *Gati* means to go, destination. *Du* means not good and *su* means good. So you've got *dukkha*, hard to bear suffering, and *sukha*, easy to bear happiness.

The story goes that all members of a certain family at Sāvatti were followers of an ascetic. They did not want their children to mix with the Buddha's followers' children. They specifically forbade their children to go to Jetavana monastery. But once all the children were playing in the vicinity of the monastery and got thirsty. They asked one of their friends whose parents were followers of the Buddha to go to the monastery and bring them some water. The boy went inside, paid respects to the Buddha, and told him about his friends who were not allowed to enter. The Buddha invited the children in to have a drink and gave them a discourse, and in the end all the children became his followers.

Now when they came home, they told their parents what had happened. The parents were very angry and accused the children of disloyalty. But the neighbours, who were followers of the Buddha, were able to change their view gradually, and before long the whole family converted to the Buddha's teachings. When the Buddha heard this, he spoke that verse.

And the little addition for the next verse, the one that goes to heaven: In order to ascertain a good future existence, both in this life and in the next one, we should always understand and distinguish right from wrong, good from bad. We also must use our understanding and insight to be able to decide which is which. Without this understanding, we might choose wrongly and believe the good to be bad and vice versa. And in this way, our future existence will not be good.

Actually there are a lot of things to discuss there, just the meaning of various things like what we should be ashamed of or not. When we feel shame, that's a loss of self-esteem, isn't it? And if we do something that makes other people see us in a bad light, then obviously we suffer from this embarrassment or shame.

There are things like when you go to a hospital or a doctor's or the dentist. When you go to the doctor or the dentist or the hospital, everybody has their name on the lapel: Mary, Barbara, Fred. They always speak to you in your first name. Now my first name is John. Nobody ever called me John. I was always called Pete. But legally speaking my name's John, so they say "John do this," "Oh yes John, good to see you, John, John, John." At the end you say something like "Thank you very much Mary," and oh my goodness, do they give you a dirty look.

I was at the hospital for a procedure and I was introduced to Sister Margaret something. And again it's all this "John, John, John" and I said "Thank you very much Sister." Oh my God, it was like an insult. I find that very confusing really. There are little overt rules and covert rules, things that you don't know about, and then suddenly you break them and it's all embarrassing.

When it comes to danger, I always think that's really to do with indulgence. Because even we think that everything in moderation, so a little bit of indulgence is not a problem. But unfortunately, it still ties us into the world of the senses.

Finding fault in what's not fault, I think that's being judgmental rather than judicious. And in the final verse, I think when it says, because these four verses all have these two last lines: those who take up wrong views go to hell, those who take up right views go to a good rebirth. This not knowing fault as fault and the faultless as the faultless, that would be referring back to all of them, I think.

The important thing here is this wrong view, because everything begins with wrong view. It starts the Eightfold Noble Path. If you've got wrong view, then you're going to have not very good attitudes. If you don't have good attitude, which is the second on the path, obviously we're going to make mistakes.

And there is a distinction to be made between right and wrong and good and bad, I think, although here the commentary doesn't make that distinction. I think if we say something is good and bad, we are referring to something moral, something ethical. Right and wrong, I would have thought, might be referring to institutional laws which are made up. Well, institutions are described by their laws.

As a monastic I have a rule not to eat after twelve, not to take any substance after twelve. I'm allowed certain things but not a meal. And that's not a moral rule. I mean for twenty years there wasn't that rule amongst monks. It was just lay people complained that monks and nuns were turning up at all sorts of times, sometimes twice or more a day. So they got fed up with it and complained to the Buddha. So then he made this rule: you have to go out in the morning and eat before twelve.

Well many monks didn't like it. They grumbled and he said, "Well look, if you belong to this dispensation, if you want to be my disciples, then this is what you do." So I presume a lot of them wandered off actually.

I thought those things about good and bad and all that, there are many of the *Dhammapada* verses concerned with that, but since this is in the chapter on hell, I thought we'd have a look at the realms.

Now these six realms: there's the *deva* realm, the happy realm, the happiest of realms, and there's the *asura* realm. They're the realm of the angry gods. And then there's the human realm. And then there are these lower realms of the animal realm, the hungry ghost realm, and the hell realm. And they each have a particular mental state that goes with it.

The heavenly realms are obviously there because we've acted in a good way, but it produces a certain vanity, a certain smugness, and the person loses touch with ordinary suffering. Eventually that *kamma* dies out and they end up in another realm dependent on their past *kamma*. But you can see that this is also something which relates entirely to human beings. These people are incredibly rich and live on yachts. They're hardly going to worry about people who are at the moment destitute. That's for somebody else to worry about.

The angry God realm is driven by jealousy. That's interesting. And these two are always warring. The angry gods are always having a go at these *devas*. The *devas* are always winning. And in a sense, that tells us something about ourselves, how we relate to people who have been more fortunate than us or who have better abilities than we have. And that jealousy often puts us into a very antagonistic relationship with people.

Often we'll say something like, "Oh, I envy you." But that's often, I think, in its more positive sense, is really praising the person. And it's something that you would like to be. But when that envy begins to want what the other person has, and then you begin to dislike and hate the other person for what they've got, then I think we're moving into the realms of jealousy.

The human realm is driven, of course, by desire, unquenchable thirst, as we now know from neoliberalism and consumerism. So that's pretty straightforward. And of course, that does draw us into, again, this negativity of getting rid of anything which doesn't satisfy us.

Now, the lower realms: the animal realm is driven by ignorance. And it's often a case that somebody might die in a state of dullness, alcoholic stupor, so they might end up in an animal realm. But in terms of a human being, that's where your intelligence is now. You've dropped down, you've lost your human intelligence.

And the hungry ghost realm is driven by greed, by a total commitment to greed. And it's a worse world than human beings. It's insatiable greed. And they're often depicted with big bellies and tiny mouths. If you look in the mirror and you've got a big belly and a small mouth, then you're probably in the hungry ghost realm.

But then finally hell, which is driven by anger, but I think the worst thing is cruelty, of course. Any form of hatred or cruelty would put you into a hell realm.

Now, whether these realms exist or not, of course, is just a matter of personal belief or understanding. Some people in meditation say they've experienced these things. But they obviously relate directly to the human realm as well. And we move in and out of these realms. So whether these realms actually exist as separate realms can be taken as something that actually, that's the way it is, or it could be that there is a realm where spirits, for want of a better word... these words have been debased by science. Ghosts, spirits, disincarnated beings... one gets lost for words really. But if we just use spirits, that there may just be a world of spirits where beings are just like here, either full of greed or full of hatred and so on.

But hell is something that all these religions like to pump as a fear factor.

The one I actually like, this is from Thailand: you've got people being put in boiling pots of water. There's somebody here who's being tied to something and somebody's poking them. Oh look, a crucifixion. This is a modern picture of... there's another one here, this is a modern picture of somebody being sawed in half. So lots of good imagery.

Oh, this is from Tibet. So you're in a great big pot of boiling water and everybody looks as though they've been stabbed. It's all good stuff, isn't it?

But this one from the West, of course, this is Hieronymus Bosch. He's got you being eaten here. Look, you've got people being eaten and people strung out on guitars. And liars, I suppose that music was seen as something not particularly leading to heaven. Look at this rabbit chewing on somebody's foot.

But I think the best one I came across was this one, and this is from Thailand. Look at that. That gets it across, doesn't it? It's left to your imagination what the heck's going on underneath there. We're all trying to get out. We're all reaching up somewhere or other to get out of hell.

And I'm reminded of that sign on Dante's hell: abandon all hope, ye who enter here. The thing is, of course, that in Buddhist understanding, it's not eternal. So that's a relief, isn't it?

In the *Abhidhamma*, by the way, they do create even more realms, up to thirty-one, which has to do with the *jhānas*. So once you're into absorptions, and if you were very good at getting into these absorptions, you would end up in different realms.

I suppose the last thing I'd like to say is... oh yeah, I've got a story. At the monastery I was at, Kanduboda, one Christmas, it was Christmas because I usually went to a friend for egg on toast. When I came back, I was told that a father had come with his daughter. And the daughter, who was around about ten or eleven, had kept saying to him in the evening, "I'm writing a biography of the Buddha." And he would humour her: "Oh that's very good," all that. And she knew he didn't believe her.

And one evening she said this to him, "I'm going up to this particular realm to write the story of the Buddha." And she rose up in front of him and disappeared. And so he thought, "Well I better take her to a monastery." So he brought her to Kanduboda.

And the monks questioned her and she said she was an *Arahant* and that she had been born specifically to help her grandfather, and that she would go to this realm where the Buddha was and all the other saints, all the other *Arahants*, and she was writing his story. And when they questioned her about meditation, she seemed to understand it. And she wouldn't pay respects to the monks because she was an *Arahant*.

Now, unfortunately, I went back, I came back to Britain at one point and then came back to Kanduboda. And unfortunately, they'd lost contact with her. So I don't know what happened to her.

But obviously, I'd love to have heard what she had to say when she was a little bit more grown up. So that makes you think, doesn't it?

Just a final thing. Nagarjuna, the great metaphysical philosopher of the Mahayana, points out that when we talk about *samsāra*—so that's a word I haven't mentioned up until now—*samsāra* is a word which just means "onward going," and it refers to this constant rebirthing, rebirthing, which at the time of the Buddha, for most people, would have been something quite horrible, because you never knew where you were going to be reborn, and it would happen. Some thought it was just fate, and that would be your fate, lifetime after lifetime after lifetime. There were materialists, of course, who thought that life ended with death. But the general understanding was that you would be constantly reborn.

What Nagarjuna points out, of course, is that what makes it *samsāra*, the world of suffering, is our relationship to it. Because, remember, everything we're experiencing is being created by this psychophysical organism right here and now, and we're living in the world that we're actually creating. And once we have changed our relationship to that world, of no longer clinging to it, no longer seeing it as a place to find any sort of permanent happiness, letting go of all our irritations and fears, then of course it becomes *Nibbāna*.

So *Nibbāna* is really—one way of looking at it—is just changing our relationship to the world that we're actually experiencing right here and now. And every time we're in a state of calm, equanimous, loving, compassionate states, then we have to ask ourselves, am I actually suffering? So it gives us a little hint as to the path that we're actually moving on when we practice meditation and in daily life.

So he made no distinction whatsoever between *samsāra* and *Nibbāna*. It was all to do with relationship.

So I can only hope a revision of the six realms will be an occasion for you to really work on your practice, and be liberated in no time at all. Peace and joy.

Non-Violence is not Pacifism

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 16 min

In this timely reflection prompted by current world events, Bhante Bodhidhamma distinguishes between Buddhist non-violence and philosophical pacifism. He explains that the Buddha, teaching in a pre-literate society, offered practical wisdom rather than systematic philosophical positions or "isms."

Drawing from the Dhammapada and various suttas, Bhante explores how the Buddha's approach was grounded in personal experience of what causes suffering. He discusses the Pārājika rule for bhikkhus regarding killing, the concept of the cakravatti (world-conquering monarch) who establishes the five precepts, and how later Buddhist cultures like the samurai tradition understood killing without hatred.

The talk examines the crucial distinction between force and violence - force being necessary action without mental negativity, while violence involves anger, hatred, or revenge. Bhante addresses the complex ethical questions surrounding armed intervention and self-defense, noting that while the Abhidhamma suggests one cannot kill without some negativity, there are degrees of moral consequence based on one's mental state and intention.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

Well, a few things have happened since we last met. My goodness, I think it was Harold Wilson said a week is a long time in politics. So although it was on the horizon, something was going to happen in Ukraine, I don't think anybody imagined what actually has eventuated.

Anyway, I just thought I'd clarify, or at least give you my opinion on this business of non-violence as opposed to pacifism.

Pacifism really is an ideal. It's coming from some great concept about violence, making it a global total position. At its most radical, an absolute pacifist would never take part in any war. It's normally centred on war, but of course it does spread out to killing as well. The basic position is that the value of human life is such that killing a person deliberately is simply not on. Unfortunately, with isms, they do tend not to be in touch with reality as it is, so you do get types of pacifisms which are a bit more close to reality, you might say.

So you get militant pacifists who will oppose all violence and war, but then you get conditional pacifism – circumstances where war might actually lead to less suffering. I think perhaps the Second World War would be one example of that, to overcome Nazism. Then there are selective pacifisms that really only have to do with weapons of mass destruction. But normally speaking, when people talk about pacifism, it tends to be in that absolute category.

Now, non-violence is of a different nature. One of the things that I think we find hard to understand is that the Buddha was pre-literate – the society was pre-literate. So there was no writing. If you don't have any writing, you really can't think about things in that systematic philosophical way. So there are no isms during the Buddha's time. The Buddha is always grounding himself on actual experience, his personal experience as to what actually causes suffering and how to get rid of it.

So there's nothing in the literature like philosophy as we would recognise it, sociology, systems thinking – there just isn't that sort of thing. Not that there weren't views and opinions, but there weren't these solid isms that we have these days.

What he's actually teaching is how to be in a world which is largely driven, at the moment anyway, by greed, aversion, fear and delusion. So it's a very practical approach to the world. And this practical approach is coming from a wisdom base, a practical wisdom base. It's coming from his own personal experience and, of course, the good heart. So what we're getting to is an ethical stand, a way of relating to people and, in fact, all sentient beings. And these days you can also add nature.

So when there's no violence in the mind – the mind is never empty in the sense that there's nothing there, apart from maybe sleep – when there's no violence in the mind, when it's in a state of non-violence, then of course empathy and compassion arise quite naturally. Those two can't exist together. That's the point.

Now, interestingly enough, in the discourses, when the kings are talking to him and one or two of them go to war, he never advises the kings to get rid of their armies. He never tells them to stop executing people. And also, certain punishments were delicious. There was one I remember which was rubbing the convict's head with a conch shell until the bone glistened. I mean, it's amazing how we can think up of these things. But there's a point that he never actually advises kings to get rid of their armies. So there's some basic understanding that this is the way it is, but he does of course invite them to develop this sense of non-violence.

So basically it's about principle rather than going into the details of how you ought to do something. He always leaves that to us, right? It's up to us to decide what we feel to be ethically good or bad.

Now, this translated in later Buddhism, in later Buddhist cultures, for instance, the samurai. The samurai was taught, or developed himself, to kill without any hatred. And there was one story where a samurai has beaten his opponent, and the sword is high, about to crash down on his head, and he walks away. And when they asked him why did he walk away, he said he was angry. And you'll also know the martial art of Aikido, which is really based upon the idea that you use the other person's energy to deflect their violence towards you.

Now, there's another interesting thing about the scriptures. Remember that when the Buddha was born, the Brahmins, one in particular, a sage, came to see him and decided or saw that he was either going to be a world-conquering monarch or a fully self-awakened being. And this alter ego of the world-conquering monarch is in the scriptures – it's the *cakravartin*. And he has this wheel which appears and begins to roll, and he follows it with his fourfold army: his foot soldiers, his cavalry, his chariots and his elephants. And wherever it goes, of course, he defeats the enemy, and at times he's actually invited.

Now, as soon as he takes over, what does he do? He establishes the five precepts. And in so doing, everywhere he goes is just a very peaceful and loving place. And that's a motif that occasionally comes up in the discourses.

And then it gets to a point where one of these *cakravartins* doesn't follow the five precepts. And immediately the society begins to corrupt and all sorts of things happen. There was one rather interesting occasion where stealing began. So the minister told him, "Well, the person's stealing because they're poor," so he decided to give this person some wealth, some land, so that he had no reason to steal. And then others thought, "If I want more wealth and land, what I've got to do is steal." So stealing became common, and that's when he had to start chopping heads off. So that's the way it goes.

Now there's also an occasion which brings about a rule for the *bhikkhus*, for the monastic lives – *bhikkhus* and *bhikkhunis*. The Buddha had obviously given a very enthusiastic talk about the repulsiveness of the body. And of course the purpose of seeing the repulsiveness of the body is to become non-attached to it. However, the *bhikkhus*, the monks, seem to have misunderstood this, and they went off in the forests and they began to do this contemplation on the disgusting nature of the body. And they became so disgusted that they started killing themselves and asked other monks to kill them.

And so there's this wonderful story of a monk who's actually just stabbed a monk to death to release him from this disgusting body, and he's wiping the blood off the knife. But when the Buddha hears about this, of course he must have been in a bit of a shock really, because his words had been completely misunderstood.

So anyway, he makes up this rule: "Should any *bhikkhu* intentionally deprive a human being of life, or search an assassin for him, or praise the advantages of death, or incite to die in this way: 'Dear friend, what use is this wretched, miserable life to you? Death would be better for you than life,' and with such an idea in mind, such a purpose in mind, should in various ways praise the advantages of death and incite them to die, he is also defeated and no longer in communion."

So this is what we know as the *Pārājika*. In other words, he's defeated in the sense that he can no longer be a monk in this lifetime and he leaves the order.

The people who actually – this rule of course doesn't apply to the people who've just been murdering the other because it's not backdated, right? It starts from that point onwards. Now the other interesting thing about this rule is that the person has to actually be killed or died for it to be a proper *pārājika*, a proper defeat. So if the person whom he's trying to attempt to die, or intentionally trying to kill him, but fails to do so, then it's a serious offence, of course, but he's not actually asked to leave the order.

So, we've said it's not a philosophy as such. It's really just practical moral reasoning. And these two verses come from the Dhammapada: "All tremble at violence, all fear death. Seeing others as being like yourself, do not kill or cause others to kill. All tremble at violence, life is dear to all. Seeing others as being like yourself, do not kill or cause others to kill."

A distinction here has to be made really between force and violence, and I think this is the crucial bit. So for instance, if you drop your mobile, you might just go and pick it up and see if you've broken the screen and then just put it in your pocket. But on the other hand, you might be quite angry with yourself and fed up with yourself. And so you go down and there's that extra pressure in the hand of grabbing this mobile phone and stuffing it in your pocket.

So one is non-violence and the other one is – one is the use of just simple force to put what was wrong or what has happened that is wrong, to put it right. Whereas violence is the same with some form of anger, hatred, revenge, etc.

So there are arguments to justify armed intervention which would prevent, say, further worse bloodshed. And in this terrible thing that's happening in Ukraine, if the soldiers are following their duty – this is the Buddha saying – well, you've been given a

command, this is what you've determined to do with your life. If they try to kill, or in fact if they kill soldiers and people of the other side, but there isn't any violent hatred in their hearts doing it, then obviously that would come under non-violence. But it still isn't something that they should be doing.

Now the Abhidhamma, this later teaching, says that you cannot kill anything. You can't kill any sentient being without some negativity in the heart. But as you can see, to actually try to – if somebody would try to kill somebody with that sense of hatred, revenge, anger, that's a far worse place to come from than somebody who is killing in order to defend themselves.

So anyway, these are just some thoughts that I might put to you. On the News Byte that comes out in a couple of weeks, I shall put a couple of links. Some of you might already have started seeing it, but it's a very good set of programs on the BBC about this Ukraine disaster, and it gives you a bit of back history. And you can begin to see that it's a product really of all sorts of reasons that have come to manifest in this terrible war.

Very good. So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, and that by your devotion to non-violence, you will eventually liberate yourself from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Neoliberalism and Mindfulness

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 19 min

In this thought-provoking talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the troubling appropriation of mindfulness by neoliberal capitalism. He examines how the fundamental Buddhist practice of sati (awareness) has been stripped of its ethical foundation and repackaged as a corporate stress-reduction tool, serving to help workers cope with exploitative systems rather than addressing systemic causes of suffering.

Bhante contrasts the Buddha's teachings on generosity (dāna) and compassion (karuṇā) with neoliberalism's core principle of acquisitive greed. Drawing on the traditional account of Māra's temptation before the Buddha's Awakening, he shows how the Buddha's commitment to liberation for all beings directly opposes individualistic market ideology. The talk explores how genuine Buddhist practice cultivates a shift from 'me' to 'we' consciousness, fostering community care over competitive antagonism.

This accessible yet penetrating analysis offers both critique and hope, examining how the Buddha's emphasis on generosity and interdependence provides an alternative vision to market-driven society. Bhante concludes with the Buddha's own words on the joy of giving and sharing, pointing toward economic systems grounded in compassion rather than greed.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So I thought this evening I'd tackle this neoliberalism, save us all, and the role of Buddhism, of *Buddhadhamma*, in that particular ideology.

Just to remind ourselves, an ideology is a set of beliefs and principles that go on to a policy. But as an ideology, as an idealism as well, there's always some future goal, some sort of Shangri-La that it's always heading towards. It always has, even in Marxist terms, the seed of destruction within capitalism. But that's true, as we've discovered from the last century, of any ideology — communism, national socialism, even democracy. Democracy at least has this self-correction every so often, and as we've discovered, it only really works when the society tends to be fairly peaceful with itself. As we see these days, there's a leaning towards the right again, towards authoritarianism.

The Buddha himself didn't fashion Buddhism. He simply taught a practical path to liberate us and the understanding that underlines it. So it's really about ethics. He belonged to a period before writing, so there isn't this philosophy and systems theory. It just didn't exist at that time. The thought was really very practical.

Now, the fundamental attitude that actually drives neoliberalism is greed, acquisitiveness. I'm quoting here from Oliver Stone's movie from 1987 called *Wall Street*. Some of you might have seen it. Gordon Gekko is the anti-hero, played by Michael Douglas, and he gives this speech: "The point is, ladies and gentlemen, that greed, for lack of a better word, is good. Greed is right. Greed works. Greed clarifies, cuts through and captures the essence of the evolutionary spirit. Greed in all its forms — greed for life, greed for money, for love, knowledge — has marked the upward surge of mankind." My, doesn't sound so bad, does it? What it does is it makes you a very special human being. You're out for yourself, this very selfish attitude that I should have what I want when I want it. If you remember Frank Sinatra's old song, "I did it my way."

Of course, it's a corruption of what Darwin said. Darwin — I quote him here — "It is not the strongest of the species that survive, not the most intelligent, but the ones most responsive to change." So this word "fittest" actually means adaptable.

But ever since the beginning of the Industrial Revolution, we've had this idea that there'll come a time when we can produce enough stuff so that everybody has everything. There's a book I might mention — I might come back to that — by Jill Westcott called "The Psychological Roots of the Climate Crisis." One thing that she points out is that the wealthy nurtured the concept of neoliberalism through right-wing think tanks, and they captured the Republicans and eventually the Tories. So that's dear old Margaret Thatcher for us.

So now this acquisitiveness, this greed, it operates in a market. We're all now entrepreneurs in this market and we all want everything all at once. What it does, of course, is it creates this competition. But it's a competition that is antagonistic because either you're, at best, my rival, at worst, you're my direct enemy. So I'm always working against somebody.

Now, you can't say that competition is all bad, because it does actually create efficiency and inventiveness. In fact, in the worst cases where you have this aggressive competition — war — in the Second World War, jet planes, jet engines, radar and the computer were developed. So there's a tremendous irony there. But the thing is that what neoliberalism presumes is that society is at best when it services the market. We're all individuals, we're all working against each other in order to get the biggest piece of the pie we can, and the whole process is very antagonistic.

But when you look at something like academia, where scientists from all over the world might be working on a particular project, they're very happy to share with each other their discoveries. They're not motivated by power or money. I mean, they're given a salary. They might covet the Nobel Prize, but it's usually just sheer interest in the scientific investigation. So here we have a collaborative competitiveness, which is a very different atmosphere altogether. I think it's something the Buddha would have liked.

Now, the downside of this, of course, is that if you're not a player in the market, then in a sense, you've only yourselves to blame. And in blaming the victims — if you remember going back to that period, those from the rest of Europe won't remember this — but we had this fellow called Tebbit who told people to get onto their bikes. It's up to you, you've got to get the work. And if you don't get the work, well, that's your problem, you're to blame.

So workers begin to lose their rights because basically you have to negotiate with your employer, and the competition between workers determines the cost, which will go down and down. So this is the gig economy, isn't it? This is what we mean by the race to the bottom. I give a definition here of a race to the bottom: a competitive situation where a company, a state, or a nation attempts to undercut the competition's prices by sacrificing quality standards or worker safety or reducing labor costs.

You can see, for instance, when Uber started in London — I'm hoping that the situation is the same in the rest of the world, or I'm not sure — basically, those who wanted to join Uber were in competition with each other. So you can imagine a parent who has children, holidays and all that; a young woman who has a mortgage; and a young fellow who's got no problems whatsoever, he's only about 21 or something. They are bidding for your ride. Well, if the parent with all the problems is charging you 30 and the woman charges you 25 and he charges you 20, then if the parent wants that ride, they've got to come all the way down to 20. And that's what happens — everything starts moving downwards.

The worst example, of course, is this recent sacking of 800 workers by the P&O ferry line. Interestingly enough, they were losing 100 million, but at the same time, they paid out 270 million to their dividend, to their shareholders. So you can see it's not very fair, is it?

And we all know about this tremendous lie, doesn't it? This thing about trickle down — eventually the wealth trickles down and everybody's happy. But it doesn't trickle down to the unemployed, to the disabled, or the old, the aged. These players, of course, are not in the market, so they would be a real drag, draining money from the market.

So the only way to get around that is to privatize all the social services so that these companies get their 10 percent. I don't know what's happening in the rest of Europe, but now there are many GP surgeries that are being taken over by a company called Centene. Even the Daily Mail said it was the most avaricious of insurance companies. So it's all bad news, isn't it?

But the big thing is that this competition just undermines a sense of common wealth. You no longer have a caring society. You're not actually caring for each other; you're just trying to make money.

So that means that any government or charitable effort that tries to do something about your basic physical or material well-being, people in need, would undermine the entrepreneurial spirit of competition. See, people have got to get out there and get into it. And of course, neoliberalism hates governments interfering with the markets. So there was this whole business about very few regulations. Well, we knew what happened. The banks went berserk. And then who had to step in to save them? Us, the poor ordinary punter.

So you can see that this is diametrically opposed to anything that the Buddha would teach.

The wonderful thing is that, of course, people are highly stressed in that system, all the way down from CEOs all the way down to the ordinary worker. Now it seems that the World Economic Forum at Davos — where the mighty, the rich and the powerful, the high and mighty meet to decide how to rule the world — they were overjoyed to hear about mindfulness. So mindfulness would help people with their stress.

So you began to tell all the workers that were stressed out, you've got to take a course in mindfulness and stress reduction. And if you happen to be even more stressed by it, well, all you had to do was find a place in the office or somewhere and just sit there for a while and watch your breath and it would all disappear — as though stress were entirely a person's internal response to a situation. But as we know, the stress that's put upon you from the outside has a great deal to do with our own mental states.

So this wonderful gift that the Buddha gave us of investigating our lives and our being in order to achieve complete liberation from suffering is now being used to support a system which is doing exactly the opposite. What an irony!

And of course, what the neoliberal system is doing is the work of *Māra*. Now *Māra* is the evil one. If you remember, just before the Buddha's liberation, *Māra* came and gave him this great doubt: "Come on, what are you doing? Why are you going through all this

pain, this suffering? Why don't you get back to your family and get back to sensual pleasures and how it was in the old days before you took up this silly idea?" And of course, the Buddha touches the earth. Now this is the important thing — he touches the earth and the goddess of the earth arises and says, "No, the Buddha has every right to do this because he has perfected the virtue of generosity."

So in other words, the Buddha's commitment came from his desire also to free everybody from suffering. And this is really something that undermines the neoliberal agenda — the idea that we can actually be like citizens who are helping each other. If you remember during the lockdown here, suddenly neighbors realized they could help themselves. It was unknown. You could actually knock on a neighbor's door and say, "How are you doing?" and be there to help them out. This was a new discovery, it seems.

So now, just before I carry on with generosity, the question is, what can we personally do? Well, the obvious thing, of course, is to be aware of what we're buying, not to support these satanic factories in Bangladesh and Cambodia and even in China.

But coming back now to generosity, I'm sure you've noticed that when you do something out of a sense of care for yourself, like you might buy a warm jumper or something like that, there's always a good feeling about that. You feel good about yourself. You're caring for yourself. Have you noticed that when you care for somebody else, when you look after somebody else, when you buy something for somebody, when you give something for somebody or spend time for somebody else, the joy that comes from it is much more long lasting? And it's that shift from going away from this "me" towards "we" where we can begin to find a different sort of economic system.

Of course, that sounds a bit glib, "me" to "we" and all that. But basically, it's that sense of bringing back that sense of community.

And I would just like to end with this lovely quote that I've got from the Buddha: "If beings knew, as I know, the results of giving and sharing, they would not eat without having given, nor would the stain of miserliness overcome their minds. Even if it were their last bite, their last mouthful, they would not eat without having shared, if there were someone to receive the gift. But because beings do not know this, as I know, the results of giving and sharing, they eat without having given, and the stain of miserliness overcomes their mind."

So it's possible that we can have a life of joyfulness, which is a shared joy with people around us, and to get away from this very tight sense of this little self like a little castle which has to defend itself against everybody. And you see it in these new woke

movements, especially Extinction Rebellion, which is trying to wake people up to recognizing that things are getting worse — we have to do something about it. And you'll find great resistance from those people who, of course, are committed to neoliberalism.

So all we can hope for is a change of attitude. You'll get politicians saying, "Oh well, what we need is better jobs and better housing." But that's all within the system of neoliberalism. So in a sense, if we're going to move towards something which is much more just, much more equitable, much more caring, it's that fundamental attitude that has to change. Let's hope that when it does happen — because the seeds of destruction are within capitalism itself — when it does happen, hopefully in the near future, let's just hope it's not another ideology because that again will create problems. And what the Buddha is saying is if you ground yourself in the right attitude and you recognize that the situation of times are in constant flux, then you can always come at a particular situation not from some preset view and opinion but from this attitude of compassion, of sympathetic joy, of caring, of love.

Anyway, I hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused even greater confusion, and that by your commitment to the good life of compassion and joy, you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

The Buddha and War

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 23 min

In this thoughtful exploration, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's relationship with warfare through three significant historical encounters. He begins by distinguishing between pacifism as an ideology and non-violence as an attitude—a crucial difference that frames the Buddha's pragmatic approach to conflict.

The talk recounts three key episodes: the Buddha's intervention in a water rights dispute between the Sakyas and Koliyans, his attempts to dissuade Viḍūḍabha from attacking Kapilavatthu (the Buddha's birthplace), and his indirect counsel regarding Ajātasattu's planned conquest of the Vajji Confederacy. Through these accounts, Bhante reveals how the Buddha never directly told people what to do regarding war, but rather pointed to fundamental principles about karma and the consequences of acting from aversion.

The discussion extends to examining defensive warfare and the development of martial arts in Buddhist contexts, including the Shaolin monks' approach to fighting without hatred. Bhante emphasizes that the Buddha's primary concern was always the cessation of suffering, noting the difficulty of killing without aversion in one's heart and the karmic consequences that follow. This nuanced presentation offers practitioners a framework for understanding Buddhist ethics in relation to conflict, self-defense, and the complex realities of protecting family and community.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhasa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhasa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhasa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

I'm going to start off with a little talk about the Buddha and war. The first thing is to make a distinction between pacifism and non-violence. Pacifism is an ideology, and ideologies like communism and neoliberalism always work on some sort of idea of how things ought to be. Therefore, they lose connection with what's actually happening. And as Marx said about capitalism, it has the seeds of its own destruction—so you can say that of any ideology. Non-violence is an attitude, a way of relating to all beings.

There are various stories that have been told about the Buddha who came into contact with war. The first one is an argument between the Sakyans, his own people, and the people on the other side of the river, the Koliyans. This argument over water rights was moving towards a war between the two tribes. So the Buddha heard about it and

went up there to try and help with the dispute over the water. He asked them what was more precious, the water in the river or the blood in their veins? This made them decide to sit around a table to discuss.

Now there was a more serious situation with Viḍūḍabha. He was the son of Pasenadi, and Pasenadi was a very committed supporter of the Buddha. Viḍūḍabha wanted to marry into the Sakya clan. The Sakyans were already vassals to the king of Kosala—they were subjects. And so he married one of the Sakyan princesses. However, he came to know that in fact she wasn't a princess at all, but belonged to the lowest of all the castes.

Well, he was very angry, so he got his army together to go and destroy the Sakyans. He had his elephants and his cavalry, his chariots and his infantry. When the Buddha heard this, he went to see him. Now, we don't know what the Buddha said to him, but I would think it was along the lines of "this is not going to create good *kamma* for you." So Viḍūḍabha took his advice and went home.

No sooner had he got home than he got angry again and got back on his elephant. So the Buddha appeared again and seemed to have convinced him to turn back. As soon as he got back he got angry and he got back on his elephant. Again the Buddha came and again convinced him that this was not a good idea, so he went back home. But unfortunately, as soon as he got home he got angry and he got back on his elephant. This time, when they asked the Buddha to go again, he said, "It's not going to work, he's committed."

So it would seem that he destroyed the capital of the Sakyans, Kapilavatthu. Probably the Sakyans ran off into the jungle for a while and they set up another capital city. Seemingly, you can actually visit them—one is in India and one is in Nepal.

The final example is to do with Ajātasattu. Ajātasattu was the son of Bimbisāra, the king of Magadha. In the same way, Bimbisāra had been a very good supporter of the Buddha, but his son just didn't have the same commitment. In fact, Ajātasattu starved his poor old father to death. He locked him in a little room, which they say you can still see in Rājgir. It was a small building away from the palace.

Now, he wanted to conquer the Vajji Confederacy. And the peculiar thing is that he sent his chief minister to ask the Buddha whether it was the best time to do so. Now the Buddha, of course, won't tell anybody what to do. All he does is point to principles and you are left to make the decision. What he did was to describe the qualities of a strong

community—the qualities that keep a community strong. And he was really talking about the monastics, the monks and nuns. So Vassākāra and the king presumed that he was hinting that the Vajjis were a strong people.

So he didn't attack them. He sent in the equivalent of the CIA in order to bribe and set one people against another. And when the time was right, he went in with his army to keep the peace—the war that he had himself created.

So some writers say that the Buddha would support a defensive war. But there's no indication in the scriptures that he either encouraged or discouraged anybody from war as such. He was in a tricky position because the monks and nuns had spread throughout the whole of northern India. If he had supported one king against the other, then you can imagine all the monks and nuns in the territory of the king he did not support would be kicked out.

Now, this does make the Buddha sound a little cynical. But he was grounded in reality, realpolitik. So there must have been some concern about the monks and nuns. But I think the main thing is that he never told people what to do. He was only concerned with getting across those principles that are necessary to bring suffering to an end. What really interested him was to communicate those principles that could allow suffering to cease.

So I can only presume that when the question of war came up, it was always pointing to that person and saying, "If you go to war, you will create bad *kamma* for yourself," because it's very difficult to kill another human being unless you have aversion in the heart.

Now we have the example of the Shaolin Kung Fu monks in China. What happened in China was that if an emperor did not favour the monks, the Buddhists would be persecuted, while perhaps a subsequent sovereign would support them. So the Shaolin monks began to develop a form of fighting which was defensive, so that they could not be overwhelmed by aversion towards the enemy. This type of ethics was then passed on to Japan from China and became part of the samurai code.

So the samurai were warriors. And there is a story where a samurai had beaten his opponent, had lifted the sword to cut him in two, and then walked away. And when they asked him why he'd walked away, he said, "I was angry."

So when it comes to considering what our personal relationship is to war, remember that it is our personal relationship to war—it's not the Buddha's. And all the Buddha would say to you if you were to ask him is, "Can you kill somebody without aversion in your heart?" And if you do kill someone with aversion in your heart, then that will bring unwholesome results for yourself.

So of course, this is not a very straightforward decision between black and white. If you're defending your family, defending the country, then of course that particular motivation may be greater than getting rid of the aversion in your heart. Certainly, if you find yourself having to defend your family or your country, it's left to the individual to decide how they feel or understand they ought to behave.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I have not caused greater confusion, and that by careful decision-making you will find your way to complete liberation from suffering.

Need, Sufficiency and Greed

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 18 min

In this practical talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma addresses contemporary economic anxieties by examining what we actually need versus what we want. Drawing from the Buddha's regulations for monastics, he explores the four basic requisites: shelter (dwelling content with simple accommodation), food (eating once daily before noon), clothing (the three-robe system), and medicine (including the traditional fermented cow's urine as Ayurvedic remedy).

Bhante shares personal experiences of simple living and wartime rationing, illustrating how reducing our needs to basics can eliminate fear around financial insecurity. He distinguishes between actual need, sufficiency for our cultural context, and greed—encouraging practitioners to experiment with one day of truly minimal living.

The talk offers practical exercises: creating a 'refugee list' of essentials, trying minimal heating, eating simple meals, and decluttering unused clothing. This approach to voluntary simplicity serves both as spiritual practice and practical preparation for uncertain economic times, helping practitioners find contentment through reducing attachment to material excess.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa —
Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble, and fully self-awakened.

This evening, I thought to tackle this business of need, sufficiency and greed. As you know, in the UK here, well, I think it's all over the world, but in Europe and the UK, we've got these huge national debts and in the UK it's made worse by the wonderful Brexit deal that was made. Everybody's predicting high inflation and a downturn. This is frightening, because you lose your savings, you might lose your work. It can all be very upsetting.

So I just thought, well, what we need to do is undermine the fear and anxiety by asking ourselves, what do we actually need? What I want to do is just explain to you, and most of you won't know, what the rules for the monks are when it comes to their physical well-being.

The first one is shelter. In the discourse on how to establish right mindfulness, the Buddha said that we should be happy with the wilderness, a root of a tree or an empty hut. Those reflect the three seasons. You want a hut when it rains, in the rainy season. You want a tree in the hot season. And in the cool season, well, you can sleep anywhere and do your meditation anywhere.

In fact, if I remember rightly, when the Buddha settled down to his meditation, which brought about the liberation, the enlightenment, near a place called Uruvila, which is now, of course, Bodh Gaya, it sounds as though it was a cool season, which makes a lot of sense. If you're going to make a big effort, you want it to be cool.

So when we look around our houses, our flats, or wherever we're living, you can ask yourself, well, what do you actually need? Not what you want, or even what is sufficient, but what do you actually need? I'm thinking of things like heating. There was a little article where a man had explained that when he called up the electrical company they told him well to reduce heating just heat one room and he seemed to be quite upset by that. He sounded as though he lived on his own in a house and he was quite upset that he had to now reduce his heating to one room.

Well, if you think about what you actually need it probably is just the room you're generally living in. I met somebody at Gaia House when I was teaching there, I've known him for a long time, and he says during winter he lives at 12 degrees centigrade. You'd have to, if you really want to know how he does it, I can always put you in touch with him. But that's what he actually gets down to, 12 degrees. And then he says, if it's under 12, then he starts to lose it. He can feel the body heat really reducing too much. So that's all he needs. He needs just 12 degrees. But of course, we tend to walk around our houses at 25 degrees. In the middle of winter, you find people wearing just a t-shirt walking around the house.

So again, if the price of gas and all this is going to go up, well, it throws it back on ourselves. How much do you actually need? There was an article for people who are really poor, who are really going to have real problems, that they can buy these rather cheap jackets and pullovers that are heated. You just stick the plug in and the batteries fill up and then the body armour gives you heat.

Again it's just a reflection. One exercise I was going to suggest at the end was what would you take with you, what would you need if you were a refugee? Of course there are people who are homeless, even in the depths of winter. So it's not a case of getting to a point where we're like that, but it's a good question to ask. When it comes to dwelling, what do I actually need?

I lived for quite some time just in a bedsit. It was in the house of my teacher in Birmingham. She had prepared this room specifically for a monk. It was just a bed, a place to sit next to the fire, gas fire. And on one side was just a small stove, a fridge and a little cabinet for pots and pans. I was very happy.

That's to do with dwelling. What do you actually need? Now when it comes to food, the monastic has to go out with his bowl and just accept what's given. There were famines in those days and often they would have to just make do with whatever was put in the bowl in terms of rice.

The Buddha, well, lay people complained to the Buddha that these monks and nuns were turning up at all times of the day and asking for food and being quite a nuisance. So he made a rule. He said, right, well, from now on, you have to go out in the early hours or during the morning on alms round, and you have to finish eating and everything else by noon. Well, there were a lot of monks who rejected that. They got very upset. They would normally have had an evening meal. They would normally have had three meals a day. And so there was a bit of a rebellion. And the Buddha said, look, if you want to belong to this dispensation, then that's what you're going to have to do. And for the most part, monks try to keep that rule.

So again, it's a case of, well, how much food do you actually need? And of course, there's a distinction between good food and food which is not so good for the body. And that's the problem, I think, with people on these food banks. When you get a shot of a food bank, some of it tends to be all tins, for heaven's sake. But again, it's just settling down and just thinking to yourself, making up a little menu for yourself, which is really basic.

Now, when I was in India, the regular food for the ordinary worker, the ordinary person, you might say, in North India, was dal, vegetable curry, and a chapati. And that's what you got every day. You didn't say, well, I'm going to have a Chinese today. It was just dal, vegetable curry, and a chapati. And that's what you made do with.

Interestingly enough, when they started to recruit men during conscription for the Second World War, they were really taken aback to find that many of the men weren't having three meals a day at all. They were actually eating really badly and were happy to join the army just to get some decent food, I think.

So another little exercise you might set yourself for a little while anyway, is to have a day as if you were poor, as if you couldn't just buy the food you need. What would you eat? What would sustain you for that day? So again, it's just taking away this fear that if we become very poor for one reason or another, that's not the end of the world. You just make do.

I'm old enough to have memories of just after the war. I remember going to my aunt's for food. On the toast you would put the butter on the toast and then you scraped it off and what you were left with was just a little suggestion and then they did the same with the jam. I couldn't believe it, I was only a kid, I must have been about six or seven, just looking at this. You put the jam on the bread and then scraped it all off and then stuck it on another piece. All these were considered luxury. The food was the bread itself.

When it comes to clothing, again, the Buddha noticed that people were coming away with huge amounts of cloth from the lay people. And so he actually set out one night on a cold night, this would have been the cold season, to actually decide how many robes you actually need.

So in the beginning of the night, he had his lower robe and the top robe, this one here. And then as the night got colder he needed another robe so he took another robe and then towards the end of the night, the coldest hour is just before dawn, he felt he needed one more so he put the last two together and those are your three robes: the lower robe, the upper robe, and the *saṅghāti*, the one that you see monks putting over their shoulder. That was it and that was the rule then, that's all you could have.

But of course, rules are rules and you get ways around it by having extra cloth, which is a bit cheeky, I know. But it was just coming down to what do you actually need? And of course, we're talking about the tropics, but what do you actually need? How many coats do you need? How many pairs of shoes do you need? And it's just drawing ourselves down to that basic need that I think gets rid of a lot of the fear that comes from a loss of wealth, whatever that wealth is, a loss of your job and so on.

Just as an aside, of course, it does make us more aware of where we're getting our clothes from. I met somebody and they showed me this, I was in Shropshire, and they showed me this jumper they just bought and they said they bought it for three or four pounds or something. And they'd gone to this other shop, probably Marks and Spencer's, and it was a similar jumper, it was 12 pounds. And when I said to them, yeah, but this is probably made in one of those satanic sweatshops in Bangladesh, they were taken by surprise. It hadn't even occurred to them to think that way.

Now the final one, so we've done shelter, food, clothing, the final one is medicine. Now the Buddha said that we should be contented with fermented cow's urine. Now that might come as a big surprise but in fact it's a very well-known Ayurvedic medicine. It's an antibiotic, anti-fungal and if you take it regularly it maintains the homeostasis of the body to lower cholesterol, relieve tension, enhance liver function and slow down aging. So tomorrow morning you need to get out there and get your bottle of fermented cow's urine. That's what we're supposed to be happy with. Now, frankly, I've never tried it. So I don't want to say whether it's any good or not, but it's definitely Ayurvedic medicine and people do drink it.

So here we have this whole business of really asking ourselves what we need, what we actually need to sustain life. This is only the physical needs. There's also the other side, our cultural needs, our heart needs and things like that. In the Buddha's instructions to the monks, basically, the day was to be spent meditating and remembering and studying and understanding the Dharma. In those days, of course, you had to memorize the teaching. They didn't have clever little gadgets like we've got to remember things.

One exercise you can just set yourself is to live one day, one day with just what you need and just find out for yourself. The second one is more to do with just lifting the level of it to sufficiency. And that depends, I think, a lot on our culture. For instance, when it comes to clothes, people need a set of clothes for work, they need a set of clothes for leisure, set of clothes for climbing mountains and things like that. So it's not a case of making ourselves miserable. But just being clear in ourselves as to what we actually need.

I think that if you spend just one day with need, then I think that undermines a lot of the fear and anxiety that comes about with the loss of wealth, no matter how much or how little wealth you had, to suddenly find yourself unemployed and on the dole, which is pretty miserable. You just find you can live with it, at least at a physical level.

And then, of course, there's a final one of greed. Well, that takes us to another step that does. I think most of us know when we're being greedy. I don't think I need to go into that too much.

So a couple of exercises there. When it comes to food, just to have one day with what you feel is the cheapest and most sustainable food that you could have that was good for the body, just one day a week just to remind ourselves. And when it comes to clothes, just go through the wardrobe and just see how much clothes you're not wearing. I remember somebody was in the habit of, in their wardrobe, if they used a piece

from it, a shirt or some sort of dress, they would put it at one end. And then over the year, they would see all the clothes they hadn't actually used and they would take them down to the charity shop.

There's all sorts of little tricks that we can play on ourselves in order to actually just come down to sufficiency. And eventually it saves a lot of money. When it comes to heating, that's really quite crucial for us these days. Our heating bill is going to go up something awful. But just by being careful with it and wearing jumpers, it won't be that heavy on us, I don't think.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance and they have not caused any confusion and that by your devotion to practice and the practice of poverty, simplicity, that's the word simplicity, you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Social Conditioning or Karma

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 13 min

In this thought-provoking talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma distinguishes between personal karma—our intentional actions of body, speech, and mind driven by will (cetanā)—and social conditioning, the cultural patterns we absorb from our environment. Drawing on the Sigālāda Sutta's guidance on social relationships and the Buddha's teaching that 'good friendship is the whole of the spiritual life,' he examines how we unconsciously inherit prejudices, cultural biases, and societal attitudes.

The talk explores practical examples of conditioning—from childhood gender roles to racial prejudice, from attitudes toward monarchy to the effects of neoliberal ideology on health-care. Bhante emphasizes that while we may have had little choice in acquiring our conditioning, we become responsible for it once we recognize it. He discusses how our embedded cultural position influences our saṅkhāra (mental formations) and shapes our responses to the world.

This teaching offers valuable insights for practitioners seeking to understand how social forces affect spiritual development. By recognizing and working skillfully with our conditioning, we can transform negative patterns and positively influence those around us, contributing to the collective journey toward liberation.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sambha sambhudassa Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sambha sambhudassa Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed noble and fully self-awakened one.

So I thought this evening I'd tackle this thorny problem of social karma. Now, according to the Buddha, the karma that we own is the actions that we've performed. So these can be a thought, speech or, of course, actions. And they're all products of the will. It's the will that manifests them.

Now, some of these are automatic. We're just habitually thinking, doing things. Speech, of course, tends to be spontaneous or unfortunately impulsive. But then there are times when our responses are measured, when we have to think about what we're going to do, and those have often the greatest force within our personality. And the importance in the process of liberation is the ethical value, or lack of it, of course. So these mental states, these saṅkhāra, are created by our decisions, moment-to-moment decisions, moment-after-moment, whether they are habitual or considered.

Now, from that, it might be a little bit confusing to talk about social karma. I think it's better to talk about social conditioning. That makes a bit more sense, I think.

The fact is that we're embedded in our culture. I was visiting my brother down in the Isle of Wight and I was just watching this grandfather and grandmother taking their grandchild for a walk, and the child stopped and turned around and, lifting her arms to the air, was obviously asking her grandfather to lift her up. And I could hear him saying... she'd probably been saying lift me up and he'd say... and this went on for a little while. Unfortunately my attention was taken away, and of course I presume the grandmother cut in, just unable to bear her husband's unwillingness to respond to the child's pleas, and prompted her by saying that magic word "please."

So right there he took it upon himself to teach the child that you have to say please. And usually, of course, as children we totally accept the conditioning. It's only when we get to be naughty teenagers and later in life when we can reflect that we can see the conditioning that we have.

We also, of course, pick up our prejudices. So I remember my niece and nephew were playing hospital. And my nephew was two years older than my niece, but they were both under seven, six and four. And of course, he said, "I'll be the doctor and you'll be the nurse." And afterwards, I thought to myself, if she'd been the elder, would she have chosen to be the doctor?

The same is true, of course, of racial prejudice. I was traveling to get back home. I had to go from Liverpool Street to Waterloo, and it really is a pain. And unfortunately, I ended up in Canary Wharf thinking it'd be easier. And I hadn't a clue where I was and everybody said I should take the Jubilee line. So I was really stuck and everybody disappeared apart from this black guy. So I asked him how to get there.

Now, as I asked him, I could feel this anxiety that he might reject my request in some way on my understanding of how he feels about white people. I mean, I was lucky he happened to be working near the Jubilee line, which was something like a 15-minute walk away through I don't know how many streets, and he was very glad to take me. But I was interested in that idea that came up as I was asking him. I actually got out of my way to ask people of colour.

The other one, of course, is we just celebrated the Queen's Platinum Jubilee, and it's no doubt that she's fulfilled that role of the monarch admirably. But have we ever actually considered the institution of monarchy? Now, I have to confess, I am a lifelong Republican. You have to forgive me for that. And the monarchy, the institution, is the pre-

serve of nobility, of privilege, the House of Lords and all that. And it has an influence on us. It has an influence on how we see ourselves in society. How would you feel if you met her?

Then, of course, something I've been banging on about these past couple of weeks is neoliberal ideology, and what it's done to us, made us much more selfish. So, for instance, in the NHS, instead of being patients, we were told that we were clients. And this meant that we moved away from an attitude of gratitude to entitlement. And the amount of suing of the NHS went up enormously. And it stands today at, yes, last year at £2.4 billion.

Now, it's not that we shouldn't be compensated for poor treatment. That's not the problem. It's just where we're coming from, the indignant entitled as opposed to the injured patient. So how do you feel when you go for a service, when the bus doesn't arrive? My parents would have just felt grateful.

There's even now, I don't know whether you know about this, a defensive dentistry. Dentists won't do anything on your teeth unless they have proof there's something wrong. They're absolutely scared of being sued for anything they do. There have been some really bad cases because of that.

At a deeper level, of course, it's our race. How do we feel? If we're black, how do we feel being in a white-dominated culture? Jews' unrelenting history of persecution. And then there's, of course, whites who are, at the moment, being suggested by extreme Brexiteers with their shining luminary Boris that we're British, special, etc., etc.

So all this will be there within us. I mean, I came across real prejudice when I became a monk. One time I walked into a shop and the assistant or the shopkeeper simply turned around and walked out. I was left just standing there until I realized she wasn't going to come out to serve me. And then there was a quite nasty occasion when I was at Dubai, so I was flying back from Sri Lanka, when this drunken Englishman just went on and on about how stupid and ridiculous I looked.

So it's catching how our personal conditioning, not the societal conditioning, how we are personally conditioned. And although we've had little choice in that conditioning, the fact of the matter is, it's us. We are an expression of our culture, and it's our duty, it's our responsibility to accept that, and to do something about it when it's unwholesome.

I mean, I have stressed the unwholesomeness within society, but obviously there's beauty too. And just mentioning the NHS, it's a product of a society of care. So everything around us is influencing us, and we are influencing everybody around us. So there's a certain responsibility there to make sure we know where we stand with all these issues.

I mean, the Buddha has lots of advice for laypeople in the Sigālovāda Sutta, where he talks in detail about your relationship within a family. It's of course very patriarchal, but then he was a man of his time. And the monks were allowed to wander any way they wished, but during the rainy season they had to come together and re-establish the fact that they were a community.

And of course he goes on to say how good companionship is the whole of the spiritual life. I mean, Ānanda has come to the opinion that it's only half the holy life. And the Buddha replies, "Don't say that, Ānanda, don't say that. Admirable friendship, admirable companionship, admirable camaraderie is actually the whole of the spiritual life. When a monk has admirable friends, people as friends, companions and comrades, he can be expected to develop and pursue the Noble Eightfold Path."

And of course, he has also advice that he gave really to the Duddaba who wanted to attack the Vajji Confederacy, pointing out that the nation's welfare was dependent on frequent meetings, that assemblies assemble and disperse peacefully and attend to their affairs in concord, that they do not enact new decrees or abolish old ones, and proceed in accordance with ancient constitutions. They respect, honour and esteem their elders, refrain from abducting women and maidens of good families, show respect, honour and esteem and veneration to shrines, and look after their arahats. So, of course, you can retranslate that for our own times.

But here the Buddha is actually saying that the society we are in, we are dependent on it for our conditioning. We are responsible. Once we know we're conditioned, once we know our conditioning, we are responsible for it. And where we can, we develop a right conditioning. And in so doing, we affect the people around us.

So that's about as far as I think social conditioning goes. So we can't really talk about social karma. We can only talk about our social conditioning within ourselves and then how we work with it, how we deal with it, and hopefully clear our hearts of anything that's negative.

So I don't know whether that's created more confusion or in some way brightened up this little dark area, which I don't think many people talk about. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance and that you will, by your endeavour to overcome all negative social conditioning, arise into the glory of Arahatsip sooner rather than later.

Climate Emergency

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 14 min

In this profound talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma confronts the reality of our climate emergency and growing social instability with unflinching honesty, while offering a deeply spiritual approach to these overwhelming challenges. Drawing from the Kakacūpama Sutta (MN 21), the "Simile of the Saw," he explores how the Buddha's teaching on maintaining goodwill even under extreme duress applies to our current global crisis.

Bhante discusses the psychological responses many experience—denial, despair, anger, and fear—when facing the magnitude of climate change and social breakdown. Rather than succumbing to these states, he presents the situation as an unprecedented opportunity for spiritual growth and the cultivation of the brahmavihāras (divine abodes): loving-kindness, compassion, empathetic joy, and equanimity.

The talk emphasizes accepting the limits of our individual power while focusing on what we can control—our own responses and spiritual development. Bhante suggests that just as we care for someone with a terminal illness when no cure exists, we must learn to "care" for our planet and society with deep compassion, recognizing that all beings die individually regardless of collective circumstances. This perspective, grounded in the understanding of dukkha (unsatisfactoriness) and the possibility of liberation, offers hope through spiritual practice even in seemingly hopeless times.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and fully self-awakened one.

A couple of moons ago, I was tackling the whole idea of social conditioning and how it becomes our *kamma*—how it becomes our *kamma* in the sense that we have to take full responsibility for the conditioning that we've been given and try and sort it out. Then I tackled the problem of neoliberalism and how mindfulness was being used to further their agenda. So the third thing to tackle, which everybody's probably very concerned about, is the environment and social collapse. I thought I'd give a résumé of where we are, and then say how we can approach it.

In 2015, the first nine months, global mean warming reached one degree Celsius above pre-industrial times. That was an important moment, and of course it's continuing to climb. In the UK here, on the 19th of July, we passed 40 degrees—first time ever.

As you know, there's a huge drought at the moment all over Europe and massive floods in Australia. I was talking to a friend out there—it peaked at 14.4 metres high. That's unbelievable. That's about three or four double-decker buses, isn't it? The amount of water that must have been dropped.

Anyway, these are all little signs preparing us for what's to come, and we're not seeing very much action about it. It reminds you a little bit about Britain before the Second World War, where Chamberlain did his best to bring about "peace for our time." He'd lived through the First World War; he just didn't want to see the horror of war again. But of course, he was duped really by Hitler, and he died shortly after he declared war.

At the moment, we've got all these terrible things going on—apart from Ukraine, China, and then there's the terrible incident in America, Salman Rushdie being stabbed. He was quoted as saying that he was concerned about democracy in the US, and I think that's there as well. And I think perhaps most disturbing is the general mood of the age, the zeitgeist, slowly moving away from liberal democracy to illiberal democracy—in other words, fascism, some form of authoritarianism.

I think many people were shocked by Orbán saying things like, "We are not a mixed race and we do not want to become a mixed race." They are a mixed race—they're a combination of Huns, which were Mongoloid, and Turkic, the same people as Turkey. I don't know what he's going on about. Then, of course, he went on to say that countries where European and non-Europeans mingle are no longer nations, and then he went off to America to give a talk to his buddies. The fact that a head of state in the EU can actually say that, and obviously there have been many people who will support him, really shows us where we're moving towards.

As these pressures grow, I'm reminded again of that poem by W.B. Yeats, "The Second Coming," which I think I read one evening. It's got this wonderful line: "The best lack all conviction, while the worst are full of passionate intensity."

My reaction has been very gloomy. I had two or three conversations where on both occasions I had to get in touch with them again and apologise for being so gloomy about the situation. So it's a case, I think, of beginning to realise that we have to see the situation from a spiritual point of view.

To deny the situation, to devote ourselves to escapism—sex, drugs and rock and roll—or to become despondent and uncaring, disengaged, is just going to lead to some sort of despair eventually. There's of course the fear that grows in us and a sense of panic, and that can lead to even suicidal feelings. There was a case in 1938 where Orson Welles adapted H.G. Wells' "War of the Worlds," and it began without telling anybody

that it was a play. It was done as if it was a real broadcast that the Martians had landed. Of course, people fled their homes—lots of people fled their homes. Luckily, nobody committed suicide. But that just shows what happens when something grips a population. In a sense, we've got to tackle these things within us.

The other major feeling might be anger. I thought I would read out the discourse, the *Kakacūpama Sutta*, which translates as the Simile of the Saw. So the Buddha says: "Even if bandits were to carve you up savagely, limb from limb, with a two-handed saw, he among you who let his heart get angered, even that would not be doing my bidding. Even then you should train yourselves: 'Our minds will be unaffected and we will say no evil words. We will remain sympathetic with a mind of goodwill and with no inner hate. We will keep pervading these people with an awareness imbued with goodwill.' And beginning with them, we will keep pervading the all-encompassing world with an awareness imbued with goodwill—abundant, expansive, immeasurable, free from hostility, free from ill-will. That's how you should train yourselves.

"If you attend constantly to this admonition on the simile of the saw, do you see any aspect of speech, slight or gross, that you could not endure?"

"No, Lord."

"Then attend constantly to this admonition of the simile of the saw. That will be for your long-term welfare and happiness."

That is what the Blessed One said. Gratified, the monks delighted in the Blessed One's words.

I once read that out in a talk to people, and somebody said, "The Buddha had a great sense of humour." So it's very difficult for us to follow that command.

But in fact, all these emotional states that we might suffer from—the sense of fear, of not wanting to face reality, the realities as they come, and the anger—we really have to ask ourselves: in what way is it helping? How does it help me? How does it help anybody else? That immediately, hopefully, cuts through the catastrophising and allows us to stay with the present moment, with what's actually happening.

Even if millions of people start to die from lack of food, from thirst with this drought, from overheating—even though that looks from a total point of view really quite apocalyptic—we have to remind ourselves that we all die singly. We all die just ourselves. We're all alone when we die. Some will die in a very painful situation, others will die in

beatitude. It's just recognising that these are all still individual deaths. We're stuck with what can we do. We have to accept the limits of our ability, of our power, and even of our influence.

Beginning to see this whole situation as an opportunity for spiritual growth, then at least we know we can benefit from it. We might have to come to that awful realisation that there's not going to be a cure for this situation, and that all we can do is care. It's a bit like when somebody has a progressive illness or a chronic or even a terminal illness. There's no cure for it, but you can develop care. That means friendship and at times even rejoicing. And of course, definitely compassion.

That's really where our spiritual practice is taking us. We have to look upon this growing situation as an opportunity for that. Otherwise, I can't see anything else but despair.

This talk is an introduction to the six forums that Noreen will be leading based on those maxims, the six maxims that were sent as a tip in the last month by Shantigarbha. We're also going to email you an essay that was written by Gwen Sanderson. She's actually one of our trustees and she's very much involved in this whole business of climate change and social breakdown. There's a whole study now, a university study on col-lapsology. She went to a meeting and was able to put that down for us in an essay.

Once that's circulated, we'll have a meeting on Zoom on the 12th of September. It will be an opportunity really for people to share their feelings, to explore their thoughts and feelings about this.

The situation will get worse, won't it? There's no way we're going to stop it. So it's a case of really looking into ourselves and making that special effort to see it from a spir-itual angle, to see it from a place which is going to make us have that basic hope that there is an end to suffering and that we can actually achieve it.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not doomed you too much, and that you see the light at the end of the tunnel, and that by your prac-tice you will liberate yourself from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Reset for Autumn

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 15 min

As autumn begins and routines reset, Bhante Bodhidhamma provides essential guidance for establishing a sustainable daily practice. Drawing from the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta framework, he emphasizes the importance of proper preparation: winding down before sleep with calming activities, and beginning each day with quality meditation rather than lengthy but unfocused sitting.

The talk explores the complete vipassanā process when difficult experiences arise during meditation—recognizing aversion, developing patience with the unpleasant, cultivating the perspective of anattā (not-self), and investigating the three characteristics of existence (impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and not-self). Bhante stresses feeling rather than merely observing experiences, allowing natural understanding to unfold without forcing insights.

Central to the teaching is developing 'affectionate awareness'—combining bright mindfulness with kindness of heart, as the Buddha encouraged when he spoke of looking at each other 'with kindly eyes.' The talk concludes with practical advice for maintaining practice throughout the day: pausing regularly, cultivating ease, practicing mettā (loving-kindness) after vipassanā sits, and reflecting on the day each evening. This accessible guidance helps both new and experienced practitioners establish a gentle yet committed approach to awakening.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhasa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhasa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhasa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

I just thought that September's a beginning for people. Academia wakes up, schools go back, the summer holidays are over, and usually people about this time think about what they're going to do during the autumn and winter. So they start joining courses and hopefully going to meditation groups. So I thought to go over some general instructions which we all know, but it's sometimes important to have them reminded to us. As I'm speaking it to you, I'm actually reminding myself of the importance of what I'm saying.

The first thing of course is good sleep. You really have to wind down at the end of the day. I mean, you've got to give yourself half an hour. It's no good coming off a Netflix horror film and throwing yourself into bed, or coming off social media and then expect-

ing yourself to have a deep sleep. Really, if you can just find that half hour before you intend to sleep, you can do anything. You can do *mettā* practice, meditation, read something which is calming, something which is inspiring, listen to music—not heavy rock, more like some spiritual music, something that's calming.

What that does is it creates this strata underneath the sleep, a calmness underneath the sleep. Then when you're in bed, continue that to find some practice—either relaxing on the breath, not to awaken the inquiry, just to feel the loveliness of it, the body breathing, or *mettā*. There are all these little practices, and of course it just helps us to have a deeper sleep.

Then in the morning, that morning sitting. It doesn't matter how long you do it; it's the quality of it. Often, when we've been practicing for so long, we just get very lazy, just sit there for an hour with the head going all over the place and we can tick a box. There's not much point in it. Rather than sitting ten minutes with good intention.

So I always think it's good practice, when you finally decide to sit, just to stay there for a minute and just think about the worries, concerns, the planning, the excitements that you expect during the day. Because the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse actually begins by putting aside those things. So it's recognizing what's there at the back of the mind and just putting them to the side. It's not as though you're going to forget them.

Then, of course, you have to make this clear determination that you are going to put effort into the practice. It's good to start with just a little bit of calming meditation. Place the attention on the breath. The mind is very busy. Don't forget there are these five touch points. So you feel your knee, then you feel the other knee, feel your hand, feel the other hand, and then come back to the breath. As you feel yourself settling, at one point when you get back to the breath, you could probably stay there.

When you feel that settlement, just begin by recognizing the beginning and end of the breath, and of course be open to whatever draws your attention. Now during that sit, something might come up which is pretty obvious, which keeps your attention—some difficult emotion, some pain, some discomfort.

So we can remind ourselves of the process of *vipassanā*. When something unpleasant comes up—that's the easiest really—one immediately recognizes your relationship, the aversion, not wanting that at all. Remember, this is the direct psychological cause for our suffering. It's a case of staying with that and hanging on in there until it completely passes. Then you find this equanimity with whatever is being presented. Of course, you're actually growing in patience too, being able to bear what is unpleasant.

Then you distance it. So there you've got this *anattā*—whatever you're looking at is not me, not mine. You can use a little word like "there." So there's a discomfort, there's some emotional turbulence. You create that distinction between whatever is feeling it and what is being felt.

Although in the literature you always get this word "observing," the accent should be on feeling, actually directly experiencing what's happening. Once that's established, it's as though you can go into it and deconstruct it, find out what it's made of. So a pain might end up just being tightness or fiery feelings. An emotion could just be wobbliness or a feeling of sickness or something. But as you go in there at that level, the quality of impermanence is a bit more obvious to you.

So just in that movement—recognizing the reaction, waiting for it to pass, distancing what it is you're looking at, and then investigating more closely—you're actually exercising this curiosity around the three characteristics of existence. That's what's going to liberate us.

The fact that emotional turbulences are actually dying away, they're blowing out, you might say, they're being transformed into their opposite just by allowing that energy to arise and express itself—that's by the by. So you have to be careful you don't slip into psychotherapy because it's happening quite naturally. You don't have to work at it.

As you progress in the sitting and your mind's wandering and all that, don't keep forcing yourself back. Just stop for a minute and ask yourself, what is it that's making the mind wander? Come back in the body. It could be that you're also coming through a time when you're feeling a bit dozy, a bit tired. So then make that your observation. So that you're awakening this understanding of actually feeling things and allowing this intuitive awareness to make its own understandings.

When you come to the end—this is what I try and get people to do—reflect upon the hour. Don't forget, if you've really made the effort, it doesn't matter whether the mind's been wandering all over the place. It's the effort to come back and restart, restart. We ought to congratulate ourselves, an extra biscuit. If you thought, well, you could have done better, you have to encourage yourself. It's no good punching yourself on the nose. What's the point of that?

Then after that, make some resolution. So it could be, if you didn't feel you were so committed to being in the present, just make that resolution: "Next time I'll really make that commitment." If there was a part that you felt you really were highly investigative and the mind was bright, encourage yourself: "Right, I've got to get there next time."

Then of course after that there's *mettā*. This *mettā* is really helping that equanimity that you need for the *vipassanā*. So that you're not coming from an "I know" place or any sense of preference or anything like that. It's undermining the possibility of corruption into what we call the subtle enemy, which is indifference, aloofness. It stops you engaging. So it's really important that the *mettā* is practiced after any *vipassanā* sitting. That's the time you can bring to mind people you're going to meet during the day. In so doing, you're preparing yourself for that meeting, especially people whom you might be having some difficulties with.

So those two things are important. Then make that decision to try and feel at ease during the day. Keep coming back to just relaxing into the present moment.

What helps that is to keep stopping. You'll see writers use the word "pausing." I prefer the word "just stop." Just stop and just catch what it is that you're developing, sometimes unknowingly—like a little irritation, a little anxiety, whatever's there, a little excitement—and just allow it to drop. Keep coming back to that level of contentment, because that's where we'll find that ease with living. You could always sort of head yourself either because you're anxious about something or because you want to do something, and it's just a waste of energy really. So if we make that effort just to stop and just come back to a place of ease, you'll see that it tends to support mindfulness, but it also saves so much energy, because these emotions and stuff, they really draw upon our energy.

Then develop this affectionate awareness. That's why we go through the discourse on loving-kindness at the end of this session. Because what the Buddha is encouraging us to do is to develop an affectionate awareness. So the awareness is of course being bright, being awake to what's actually happening. The affectionate is referring to a general attitude in the heart of kindliness.

Even now, as you're listening to me and as you're seeing me, you can actually develop a nice attitude of kindliness towards me, and it would make me feel so much better to know that so many people are beaming this lovely kindness towards me. If you have that as a general attitude which you've developed, you can see it calms situations. It just undermines anybody who might be a little miffed with you or something like that. But it's also good for us. I mean, it creates this lovely feeling of an inner gentle happiness. So put those two words together—it's not just mindfulness, it's affectionate mindfulness, mindfulness with kindliness.

I mean, that's one of the things the Buddha says that we should do. We should look at each other with kindly eyes.

Then see if you can find some time in the day to spend just five minutes, ten minutes, just being with yourself.

Finally, when you get to the evening, coming back from work, or a day out or whatever, just sit down somewhere and recollect the day. If you find the mind wanders a lot when you're doing that, you can always write it on a bit of paper. As you go through the day, you can see where you've been skillful, where you could have been more skillful.

That reflection is very helpful because it slowly wakens us up to certain habits that we'd like to be rid of and certain habits that we'd like to develop. Having been brought up a Catholic, we were always told in the evening to have an examination of conscience, that's how they put it. So we always thought, "Oh my, I better go try to get confession pretty quick." But I mean, it's a good thing. You just go through the day recollecting what's happened and it just makes you more aware of yourself. That's all.

Then of course, try and do some sitting. It doesn't matter how long—five minutes, ten minutes. Before you eat—I mean, doing it after you eat is miserable, you just fall asleep. Then you've got the evening with more energy.

These are just basic reminders on how to go through the day gently, at ease. I mean, that's what we do in the *mettā*, when we do the *mettā* practice—it's to live more contented, be more contented with what we have and in harmony, that harmony with the world, whatever's happening around us. So these are just a little pointers to remind ourselves.

On top of that, it's always good to have a little bit of feed intellectually, just an occasional read from a book, a spiritual book, a Buddhist book or something, or listen to a talk. It's just that little bit of encouraging ourselves to just keep the practice turning over.

I hope this little talk has been of some use, that you're all eager now to sit in meditation, and that I've not actually undermined your hopes to do so. So I can only hope, thank you very much, and that you will be liberated by your practice sooner rather than later.

Identity and Not-Self

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

In this profound exploration of one of Buddhism's most challenging teachings, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines anattā (not-self) through the lens of our everyday identifications and emotional reactions. Drawing from the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), he explains how practicing mindfulness both internally (subjective experience) and externally (objective observation) can help us recognize the suffering that comes from over-identifying with our roles, abilities, and achievements.

Using vivid personal examples—from failed attempts at fixing a gas connector and printer to the emotional storms that follow—Bhante demonstrates how these moments of frustration become 'rocket fuel for Awakening' when met with sustained awareness. He reveals how the process of 'selfing' (upādāna) creates temporary identities that arise and fade based on external circumstances, leading us to recognize the conditional nature of all our various 'selves.'

The talk offers practical guidance for working with the dukkha of identification, showing how unpleasant sensations can serve as messengers reminding us 'this is not who you really are.' Through patient observation of our emotional reactivity, we can discover new pathways of gentleness, patience, and compassion—ultimately leading toward the peace of nibbāna beyond all limited identities.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa.

Homage to the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

The Buddha's teaching on *anattā*, not-self, is a hard aspect of the Dhamma to understand. We will all be grappling with it till the moment of enlightenment. To motivate ourselves for the challenge, it's worth reflecting on the suffering we experience because of identifying with our body, our mind, our life stories.

Take the example of role identification. Whatever role we're playing in life – father, daughter, gardener – we want to do it well, which is a good motive, no problem there. It's when we over-identify, can't see beyond our role, that *dukkha*, suffering, emerges.

On a good day, we get a buzz out of doing things well: cooking a meal, mending a puncture, teaching a class. But we all have days when these go wrong. The sponge cake turns out as a stodgy lump. The tyre deflates the minute we put the wheel back on. We go blank when trying to teach. This is when the dukkha of identification is felt.

The more we identify as a good cook, a good DIYer, a good teacher, the harder it is to bear the letdown. We can't stop thinking about it. What went wrong? How could I have made such a mess of things? What did they think of me? We look for someone to blame. If he hadn't interrupted, it would have been perfect.

While none of us enjoy those times when we've made a hash of something, it is worth dwelling on them long enough to acknowledge that the source of the misery is not actually the gooey mess or the deflating tyre. It's the sense of me and how badly I've let myself down. That's the real rope: a loss of confidence, perhaps an almost desperate need to reassert ourselves, prove our ability.

The more clearly we can acknowledge the suffering that comes from identification, the more we will be willing to explore the difficult Buddhist teaching of anattā, not-self. And there is no doubt anattā is a difficult nut to crack. We all have a strong sense that we are the ones baking the cake, mending the tyre, teaching the class, living our life. It's hard to even toy with the idea that this might not be so.

The Buddha's advice is to keep breaking down experience into smaller and smaller chunks. It's easier to get glimpses of the truth in these. Then gradually over time, the notion of not-self becomes easier to contemplate. We start to see its benefits, how much easier life is when we're not identified by our roles or opinions or abilities or achievements. It's wonderful to have nothing to defend.

One instruction from the *Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta*, the Four Foundations of Mindfulness, that I found very helpful for exploring anattā is the advice to practice internally and externally. Internal can be interpreted to mean our subjective felt experience, while external means our mental understanding of it. We feel the sensations of breathing for internal practice. For external practice, we reflect that we are breathing.

The Mahāsi noting technique provides a way of practicing both internally and externally. We feel the breath and at the same time make a mental note of it. Same for walking, eating, talking. All of life can be known both internally as moment-to-moment sensations and feelings, and externally as our objective mental perception of what's happening.

Say we are practising mindfulness of breathing. Feeling the sensations of breathing is to practise mindfulness internally. Although we don't usually make the thought conscious, we assume we are the one who's sitting here breathing. If we're also practising externally, then we're noting "rising, falling" as we track the breath.

As concentration deepens, it can seem like our identity shifts. Instead of being the one who is sitting here breathing, we sense ourselves as the observer, some sort of spaced-out entity hovering around our head, the one who is watching the body breathing. On a good day, we'll also be able to watch our thoughts coming and going, watch emotions rise and fade, realise we don't have to get caught up in them.

All of this is helping us disentangle our confusion about identity. Internally, we feel ourselves breathing, thinking, growing happy one moment, sad the next. But because of our external perspective, we realise we don't need to identify with our thoughts, emotions, breathing. We see these as happening of their own accord, driven by various stimuli, but not driven by what I now think of as me.

This can be a lovely experience, a sense of coming home, having found our true self: a sort of disembodied entity that hovers in and around the body, equanimous, interested, watching the show without getting caught up in it. But after a while, we might grow uncomfortable. Things start to feel sticky, as if there's a sheet of Velcro passing over each sensation, pulling us along with it. We start getting caught up with experience again, identified with thoughts and feelings and emotions. We are again the one who is sitting here breathing and now anxiously trying to find our way back to the lofty crow's nest from which we've been able to observe the show.

Although there's a temptation to see this as bad meditation, we should really see it as a precious opportunity to learn the Dhamma more deeply. Pema Chödrön likens these episodes as rocket fuel for enlightenment.

To take a practical example: we got a new connector for our gas canister the other day, and so I overcame all my fears about gas and explosions. I went to hook it up. After about a dozen failed attempts, all the bits eventually came together. It looked perfect. But gas started leaking the moment I opened the cylinder. I took it apart, reread the instructions, reconnected it. Still no go. Disappointing.

I was then asked to look at the printer because it wasn't working. It needed a new toner cartridge. And again, I overcame my deep suspicion of all things electrical and mechanical and managed to replace the cartridge, but no go. Every page came out white as snow with nothing at all being printed. Again, I took it all apart, reread the in-

structions, watched a few videos on replacing the cartridge, tried again. Still no go. Another disappointment. And this time I felt the edge of bad humour. My mind was starting to close up, feel oppressed by others and by the world in general.

A bit later, Bhante came over, took the cartridge out and, in his own words, "gave it a few thumps" and put it back in place. Lo and behold, it worked perfectly. Of course, I was impressed and amused and grateful, but alongside these happy responses, my incipient bad humour gave a painful kick within. Why couldn't it have worked for me?

I decided to go to my room to explore this more deeply. Rationally, it was just silliness, the mind building a mountain out of a molehill. And yet there was – not quite a mountain, but certainly more than a molehill of frustration at my failure to connect up a gas cylinder and change a toner cartridge. But what was more distressing was the admission of being so emotionally impacted by such trivial matters. What was the point of decades of Dhamma practice only to be getting distraught over nothing?

This is the dukkha, the suffering of identification. Identifying with self as manager, the one who is supposed to sort out problems. Identification with self as meditator, who should by now have developed outstanding equanimity. Not to speak of self as meditation teacher, who should know the Dhamma upside down and be able to instantly see through this latest delusion.

As always, mindfulness allowed the storm to blow itself out. Looking back now, I sense the truth of Pema Chödrön's advice to see these times when our buttons are pressed and we feel like a two-year-old again as rocket fuel for enlightenment. Emotional storms have so much energy that negative thoughts and feelings we normally suppress come skyrocketing into consciousness. In the light of awareness, their pain becomes so acute that our system is forced to learn a new way of coping with the dukkha.

This new coping mechanism, learned from within, from moment-to-moment awareness, opens up new pathways for energy flow in the body and new doorways in the mind. We discover new thoughts and perspectives which are gentler, kinder, more patient and forgiving.

In my own example, a new doorway opened because of feeling so acutely the pain of identification, how it traps the mind in a prison of delusion. The pain of this prison sharpened when the storyline of me who should be better at everything had fallen away, and I could more clearly feel the emotional patterns underlying the thoughts.

Practising mindfulness internally, I could feel how eagerly the body and mind pounced on a pleasant feeling, sending tentacles of energy around it to clutch and hold as mine, while a bright light switched on in my head, which I perceived as me: confid-

ent, on top of things, in control. A whirlpool of energy raised around my chest and head to sustain this delight. The feeling of confidence was gorgeous, but watching it, the external perspective showed up the craziness and pain underneath.

Seeing this, I desperately wanted to escape the prison of identification. The external perspective let me recognise the crazy whirlpool of energy and the bright light as what the Buddha terms *upādāna*, usually translated as grasping or clinging. It's also sometimes referred to as "selfing". What is happening is that unskillful desire, *taṇhā*, has driven us to create a new identity so as to fulfil this desire.

The better we get to know this experience of selfing, the more we are persuaded of the Buddhist teaching on *anattā*, not-self. Knowing from our direct experience that a "me" has suddenly arisen makes it hard to take "me" too seriously. We start to see how various "me"s arise and fade depending on external stimuli. When things go well, a happy, pleased, self-confident me emerges. But that fades quickly when things go wrong and the deflated, miserable me takes its place instead.

Back to my own example of watching the fallout from my emotional storm. Internally, I was experiencing the selfing process, which was generating a confident, delighted sense of me, one who could fix all the printers and gas cylinders in the world. However, the external perspective knew this as delusion. Undermined by that news, the confident self suddenly collapsed into a timid, scared, stiff entity which felt it had no rights to exist. A moment later, the confident self reappeared, wildly insisting it was totally in control of the situation.

This yo-yo between elated confidence and abject fear continued for some time. Both identities felt excruciatingly painful and vulnerable. There was a strong desire to abandon the meditation, but I persisted, allowing my emotional roller coaster to take its course, trusting that a lesson would eventually be learned.

In *vipassanā*, we can't interfere. We can't tell ourselves to stop being deluded. We have to bear patiently with our greeds, hatreds and delusions, trust them to burn out in the light of awareness, teach us the Dhamma as we suffer their flames.

And sure enough, the energy of the roller coaster gradually diminished. As it did, so my attention extended gingerly beyond the whirlpool of elated and fearful energies in my chest and head to sense my arms, legs, my body sitting. I couldn't really feel these in any detail. I only knew them as faint suggestions. They seemed like strangers from another world – alien, scary.

Luckily, curiosity was stronger than fear, and each out-breath let awareness rest more attentively in the seemingly alien body. At last, some feelings rippled through. These were unpleasant and carried the message that the heady whirlpool of confidence was not me, not mine. The emotionally energetic, deluded part of myself felt this as a threat. But some wisdom emerged from the depths to welcome the unpleasantness. Here was something I would not want to cling to, therefore very welcome.

Letting attention rest on the unpleasantness became a non-interfering way of containing and restraining the deluded self. Gradually, the energetic bright-light me felt glad of being contained and limited, embodied rather than a totally deluded mental entity.

It became like looking in a mirror. Perhaps we've all had similar experiences where we sense ourselves as both watching and being watched. Sometimes I was the watcher, the observer, the disembodied entity that hovers near my head. This was the external mindful perspective. Sometimes I was the mirror image. This was the internal mindfulness perspective, bringing the embodied experience of me – the experience of sitting and breathing and knowing that I was being watched.

The desire to know who I really am has always been very strong for me. And that part of me that was observing, watching, felt this now as an almost overwhelming attraction towards the mirror image. I wanted to grasp hold of the image, devour it even. But whenever I gave in to that desire, it was as if I'd gobbled up my own reflection. All that was left were little shivers of fear and grief as I realised how I'd destroyed what I desired.

I had to suffer the fear and grief, wait patiently till peace prevailed, before I could again glimpse the mirror image. I became grateful for any unpleasant sensations in the mirror image. These acted like repulsive forces, countering the attempt to grasp and own the image. They carried the message: this isn't who you really are. That understanding also helped me not to grasp and thereby destroy the image of me that I desired so deeply.

I became grateful for the fact that the body can repel the mind as well as attract it. By this stage, I'd forgotten altogether about my sense of having let myself down. It just wasn't an issue. And I was very glad I'd persisted with the meditation, hadn't given up at the height of the emotional storm.

The great gift of sitting with the misery was that the message "this is not who you really are" became for the first time totally welcome. As the meditation went on, the message brought joy, relief, gratitude. I understood it as necessary to counter the strong desire to identify with my body and mind – the only reflection I can find for whatever it is I sense myself to be.

In subsequent meditations and in daily life, I was better able to recognise all "me"s as temporary and conditional. I could smile at them, appreciate them, but not be surprised when they dissolved. This is such a gift. The deluded me expects too much of me, expects me always to be on top of everything. Being able to see myself as limited brings forth compassion as well as appreciation for whatever efforts I make to follow the path, fulfil my various roles.

And if I'm getting a bit heated in conversation, clinging to my opinion, then I can focus on some unpleasant sensation and welcome them as messengers that this strongly opinionated one is not your true self either. Again, this brings a smile and allows me to be more flexible, ready to change my mind and see the other's point of view.

I hope this illustration of working with the dukkha of identification encourages you to explore the teaching around anattā, not-self, and perhaps also see how those external and internal mindfulness perspectives can help with this challenging teaching.

In this way, may we all see through our identification as daughter, manager, cook or whatever – see these as temporary, conditional, not ever designed to be satisfactory. As the Buddha said, whatever is inconstant, conditioned, unsatisfactory is not worthy of being thought of as me. We sell ourselves short by investing in these limited identities. Our continued practice leads us to a truth, a resting place beyond all such limitations. May we all experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

The Contemplation of Death

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 25 min

In this profound teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines maranasati (mindfulness of death), which the Buddha declared the most powerful of all contemplations. Drawing from the traditional teaching that "mindfulness of death when developed and pursued gains a footing in Nibbāna, the deathless," Bhante explores how this practice addresses our deepest fear and delusion around self-identity.

The talk covers the Buddha's teaching on the three divine messengers—sickness, aging, and death—that awakened the Bodhisatta to begin his spiritual path. Bhante guides practitioners through contemplative phrases: "This body is subject to disease," "This body is subject to aging," and "This body is subject to death," explaining how regular repetition dissolves fear and resistance in the heart.

Rather than morbid reflection, this practice brings relief, gratitude, and present-moment awareness. By accepting the inevitable, we stop wasting energy on denial and discover greater appreciation for life. The contemplation naturally leads to understanding impermanence (anicca) and not-self (anattā), potentially offering glimpses of the unconditioned—Nibbāna itself. Bhante emphasizes that every meditation session prepares us for death, making this practice essential for liberation from suffering.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So the title of this is Death. A happy subject. I've started off here with a quote from St. Paul's letter to the Corinthians: "O death, where is thy sting? O grave, where is thy victory?"

Now, it also reminds me, of course, of my Roman Catholic upbringing. In that doctrine, there are three realms. There's hell, from which you never escape. That's bad news, isn't it? And there's heaven, from which you never want to escape. But there's this little in-between place called purgatory. It's because most of us don't die with terrible sins on our hearts. We just need a little place where we get smacked about a bit and then we're ready to move up into the heavenly realms.

Now whether these realms actually exist or not, as you can say for any of these religions with their realms—the Buddhists have hundreds of them—the fact is they do mirror our mental states. So hell, of course, are those times in our lives when things fall apart, everything's going wrong, we lose our work, everything looks really bad, especially, for instance, people who are suffering from this COVID business. And heaven are those wonderful little moments when really this is the life. We're out there and we're really enjoying it. But most of our time, or at least it's true for me, is that in-between place of purgatory, where I'm not so happy and I'm not so sad.

So the reason I mention this is because in the Roman Catholic religion, November is a special time. It's a funny month. It doesn't have the colour of October and it doesn't have the promise of December. It's a dowdy month, dank, getting darker and this was a month that was dedicated to the holy souls. These were the people who'd ended up in purgatory and who would eventually rise to heavenly joy, and we could help them by praying for them. These were little shots of grace that would help them to generate the energy they needed.

So it occurred to me that this would be a wonderful full moon dedicated to the contemplation of death. Now, I know you're very excited by this, I'm sure of it.

If we now consider that actually death is right with us at every moment, at the beginning of time. Now, when we say the beginning of time, we're not talking about historical time, we're talking about this moment arising and passing away. What is arising and passing away? Moments of consciousness. Each moment of consciousness has a moment of initial delusion. And then it finishes and that delusion finishes. That essential delusion, of course, is to do with identity. And here is the corner, here is the basic reason for our fear, our terror of death. And therein lies the destruction of that fear.

Now here's what the Buddha says. He tells us about contemplation which he says is the most powerful of all contemplations because it reaches down to that very foundation stone of delusion—the self-identity. There's one thing the self doesn't want to do, and that is die.

This is what he says: "Monks, mindfulness of death when developed and pursued is of great fruit and great benefit. It gains a footing in *Nibbāna*, the deathless, and has *Nibbāna*, the deathless, as its final end." Now, what's he saying there? He's saying that if we contemplate death, we'll have a glimpse of *Nibbāna*. That's the footing, a glimpse of it. And if we continue to contemplate our deaths, it'll actually lead us to the end of death, to the experience of that which doesn't die—the deathless, the *amatādhama*, the deathless truth.

Now, I like to quote Ernest Becker, who wrote this wonderful book called "The Denial of Death." It's still a smashing read. He wrote it in 1973. He got the Pulitzer Prize for this. But there's a line in that which captures it all: "The basic motivation for human behavior is our biological need to control our basic anxiety, to deny the terror of death."

We've seen this with COVID. The enormous terror, the fear, people locking themselves away, wearing masks, doing all sorts. And of course, there was a certain reason for that. People were actually dying. But for most people who got COVID, it was just a very nasty type of flu. But even so, this basic motivation for human behavior sits right there underneath everything—this fear that we're going to die at any moment. Dying on the in-breath, dying on the out-breath. And that's why the Buddha points to it as the most powerful. This is the only contemplation where he says you can actually experience *Nibbāna*. So you can throw away all this *vipassanā* stuff and all that, *mettā* and all that—just sit there from now on contemplating death and you'll make it. That's how powerful it is.

Now, how often should we contemplate death? So here's the Buddha asking the question. This is a paraphrase. The Buddha asked several monks, "How often do you contemplate death?" And one of them replied, "Lord, I contemplate death every day." Not good enough, the Lord wasn't happy with that. Then he asked another one and he said, "Well, I contemplate death with every mouthful I take at a meal." Not good enough, said the Buddha. And then he turns to another and he says, "What about you?" And he says, "Well, I contemplate death with each in-breath and out-breath." Ah, now the Buddha was pleased.

In other words, you do it all the time. Now, you can't actually do it all the time. You can't be thinking about death while you're adding up your bills. It would be awful. It's more in the sense of it's always there as a background. It's always there sitting on your shoulder. And as you know, in medieval times, it was quite regular to have a *memento mori*, a reminder of death on your desk, on your shelf, by your bedside, just somewhere where the eye would catch it every so often. And it would just remind you, OK, in the end, there is death.

Of course, if we constantly ignore that, if we constantly ignore death and distract ourselves from it, then it'll just take us by surprise. I mean, I have this terrible fear that I will be holding a piece of toast just dripping with margarine and layered with great big topping of marmalade, and holding it up like this so I can see it and I can begin to enjoy this lovely aroma, and suddenly I get a heart attack. Now what am I going to do? Am I going to actually make the effort to take that one last bite, or will I be able to just drop the whole damn toast? Who knows?

There is a lovely example from the Zen tradition where a monk flips over or falls over a cliff and he's hanging there by his fingernails, but he has time to admire, peeping from a cranny, this wonderful golden flower.

The Buddha also talks about these four types of people. He says there are people who wake up, that's how he puts it, as soon as they hear even the word of death. Then there are those who don't wake up until somebody close—your mother, your father, somebody dies who is close to you. There are those who don't wake up until lots of people have died. I think all these deaths caused by COVID have had some effect, especially on young people. We seem to be getting a lot of 20 to 30 year olds coming to meditate. There's an awakening. And then of course the most unfortunate is to wake up to death when the doctor tells you you've got six weeks. You definitely don't want that. That is definitely a terminal shock.

So our work is really to get ready. And you could say that every time you meditate, you are actually preparing yourself for your death.

Without any further ado, we can do these contemplations. Contemplation is not thinking about it. So we're not sitting there saying, "Death, I wonder what it means. Where will I go? I wonder where I'll be reborn." No, it's nothing to do with that. It's to do with getting down to our relationship with death, which is always in the heart. The fear, the terror, the aversion, it's always down here in the heart somewhere.

So what we do is we repeat these phrases slowly, and we're centering in on the heart and we're noticing any aversion, any pushing away, any fear, anything at all. And we're just waiting for that to begin to dissolve. And if you keep saying it, you keep saying it, "This body is subject to death." This body. Is subject to death. This body is subject to death. This body is subject to death. So you play around with it and very slowly you just get that feeling of surrender, surrendering to the truth. And that resistance vanishes, and with it there comes that lovely sense of relief and then even a smile. You can even laugh because you've suddenly realised that there is no monster under the bed. It's not something to be afraid of. It's just something that's going to happen anyway.

That's the important thing about mantra, about contemplation practice. Those of you who've done mantra, those who've done contemplative prayer will understand that. But others won't have done this really. We're going to do very regular ones, but eventually you can find a phrase, you can find a passage in a book, and you just keep reading it. You don't think about it, you just keep reading it to get the feel of it, how you're relating to it.

Here we go, and we're going to do three of the messengers from the gods that awoke the Buddha to his path. Of course, this is a mythical way of what actually happened to him as a young man. He's out, he's been brought up in this luxurious palace, he goes out, he sees for the first time somebody who's terribly ill, a very old person, and a corpse. But he also sees somebody sitting under a tree—an ascetic under a tree—which gives him the hope that in fact there's an escape from sickness, aging and death. So that's what we're going to do. We're just going to repeat these to ourselves.

Make sure you feel settled.

Sickness is a mini-death, it's a preparation for death. The body manifests its vulnerability. There's discomfort or pain, and there's some disability. This contemplation undermines our intoxication with youth. This is the Buddha. It undermines our intoxication with staying young, to always being 60 when you're 40, always being 30.

So sickness is unpreventable. Just repeating gently into our hearts: This body is subject to disease. This body is of a nature to fall ill. This body has not gone beyond sickness.

Aging is a progressive dying. Contemplating aging undermines the obsession with health and beauty, with intolerances, with fasting, food ingredients and all that other stuff. Aging is inevitable. Just repeating into our hearts: This body is subject to aging. This body has not gone beyond aging. This body is now in a process of aging.

Some quotes from the Buddha, taken from parts of the scriptures and the *Dhammapada*:

Life is uncertain. Death is certain. It undermines the overwhelming clinging to life at all costs, to shoring it up, barricading it with fame, riches and power. Death is inescapable. Everyone must die. The remainder of our lifespan is decreasing continually. Death will come regardless of whether or not we have made time to practice Dharma.

We don't know when we are going to die. Human life expectancy is uncertain. There are many causes of death. The body is very fragile. Only the practice of Dharma can help us at the time of death. Our wealth cannot help us. Our loved ones cannot help us. Our body cannot help us. Death is inescapable.

Repeating gently into the heart: This body is subject to death. This body has not gone beyond death. This body will die.

Now usually tagged onto that are the contemplations about *kamma*: I own my actions. I inherit the results of my actions. I am born of my actions. I'm related through my actions. I live dependent on my actions. And whatever I do, for good or for ill, I shall inherit the results. So that's something we can always add on.

Now, if we get into that practice just for every morning, it's just a little reminder. It can be just half a minute, it can be five minutes, it doesn't really matter. And it has that effect on our lives.

The first one is that sense of relief that comes with the acceptance of the inevitable. We simply stop fighting. There's so much energy pushing away those thoughts about death, about falling ill, about COVID, and that energy is all released. The underlying fear of sickness, aging and death puts a pall over our lives. Now you can see life is much more colorful. We appreciate it more. We regain some of that childlike wonder, the miracle of life, being conscious.

Now with that there comes a sense of gratitude, and of course with gratitude always the desire to share our joys and to comfort others in their sorrow. Accepting death as part of life cycle, it's much easier to be with people who are sick. There's a much easier compassion for them and it's so much easier to see somebody who is dying. They don't represent for us something that we are afraid of anymore.

The big thing about it too is that it does bring us into the present. If you've had a shock like you've fallen off a ladder or you've nearly missed being run over, then that really brings you into the present moment, the arising and passing away of every present moment. And it's within that moment that there may come just a glimpse or a realization of what is not changing, not conditioned. That is the beatitude of *Nibbāna*.

And of course, that's why we practice *Vipassanā*—to keep us in touch with this impermanence. And when we're in touch with impermanence, we can see that holding on to anything is going to be illusory. It's bound to cause dissatisfaction because it disappears. And it also leads us to understand that anything we feel is substantial, that it has some sort of base of permanency—the sense of self—it can't be real. It's an illusion, a delusion.

So that's the benefits that we can get from it. And by practicing it as a constant, it eventually has an effect on us, just like practicing *mettā* has an effect on us. But it's this constant practice, just a little moment every day, just after the *vipassanā*, before the *vipassanā*, it doesn't really matter. But just that constant little reminder, and it just brings a spice into our life, which is, of course, very strange. You'd think the opposite, you'd think you'd become depressed.

Anyway, I'd like to finish this little talk with a clip, which I think says everything, and which is expressed beautifully by Samuel Beckett. "We are born astride a grave."

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I have not caused confusion, and that by your regular contemplation of death you will liberate yourself from all suffering sooner rather than later.

To Love or To Be Loved: That is the Question

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 17 min

In this profound exploration of love and spiritual practice, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines a fundamental question: when we act out of love, are we doing so to develop our capacity for love, or to be loved in return? Drawing from Eric Fromm's 'The Art of Loving' alongside Buddhist psychology, he reveals how our deep sense of unsafety drives acquisitiveness in four key areas: wealth, power, pleasure, and the desire for appreciation.

Bhante explains how the Buddha's teaching on anusaya (latent tendencies) helps us recognize the subtle background motivations that can corrupt our loving actions. He emphasizes that true purification of love requires making these unconscious drives conscious, allowing us to act from genuine goodwill rather than neediness. The talk explores how vipassanā meditation can transform difficult emotions like loneliness, showing how staying present with these states can lead to their natural transformation into universal love (mettā).

This teaching offers practical guidance for developing authentic loving-kindness while addressing the psychological roots of attachment and dependency that often masquerade as love. Bhante distinguishes between feeling and attitude in love, showing how genuine care can be cultivated even without emotional feelings.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa.

So greetings to all you revellers in full moon delights.

Some of these months lend themselves to certain subjects, so obviously this one is about love. I re-read Eric Fromm's classic *The Art of Loving* — I've read it about five times over the years, and some of you might know it. Definitely worth the read anyway. He starts off, but I'm going to turn it into a sort of question: when we do something or say something or think something out of love, do we do it in order to love, in order to develop our love, or do we do it to be loved? That's a cheeky one, that.

He talks about why we need this love. Of course it's a psychoanalysis thing. When we're born, for those first few months or so there's no separation between us and our mothers. So that's really a halcyon period, a heavenly state to be in. And then, of course, the separation starts, which is needed for the child to become a little independent be-

ing. But that separation is a sense of loss. And according to psychoanalysis, that's what produces our loneliness in life, because we want to get back to that wonderful place we were when we were babies.

From the Buddha's point of view — from the Dharma's point of view rather — of course it's more to do with the essential relationship that we make with this psycho-physical organism that we call the self. And the self knows that it is unstable; it comes to know that it's not secure. So the fundamental position from a dharma point of view is this feeling of unsafety. And because of that, we start collecting things.

That's the first thing that the Buddha talks about. It's translated as greed, but it's much better to see it as acquisitiveness. So we acquire things, and there are four major areas where we do that, of course.

First, you want to be rich — loads of money, like Scrooge. And the more I have, the safer I feel. If I've got a million pounds in the bank, I feel really safe.

And then there's power. Control — control over our lives, control over people — makes us feel safe. We're in charge. That can also be a real pain.

And then there's pleasure, of course. People who just want one experience after the other. Been there, got the T-shirt, all that sort of stuff. Foodies who live for the next exciting menu rather.

And then finally, there's those who seek to be appreciated, seek to be praised. And that's usually we're seeking some sort of fame. Here we're dealing with fame or the desire to be loved.

Now, that would be, of course, also a cause of loneliness. The fact that when we feel lonely, then we have these little words going on in our heads about how useless we are and horrible. And what we do, we tend to reinforce that by forming friendships, by padding out our friendships by making sure that they are stable friendships. We don't want to lose them because then we'd feel really lonely.

But that unfortunately is a bad strategy because what it does is it makes us dependent on them. And what it means is that our self-worth or our self-esteem is dependent on what other people think about us or what they say about us, how they treat us. And therefore sometimes you feel pretty rotten if you do that. And of course, people whom you love disappear — they either leave you or they get fed up with you, and some of them die.

So nothing is to be taken for granted. So there's always that little sense of anxiety of loss. Anything you become attached to is going to create some anxiety of loss. And the other thing we do, of course, is to seek distraction. And I'll come to that in a minute.

So the best strategy is actually to love, to come from the position of love. So when you come from a position of love, you immediately fill yourself with good feelings, good feelings about yourself. And that sense of self-worth, self-esteem comes naturally when we behave from a position of love and all the other social virtues of compassion, joy, and so forth.

So how do we purify our love? First of all is to recognise that this thing about the self and its feeling lonely and its neediness — that has to be recognised. So that when we are doing something we've got to see these little background voices. In the Buddhist teachings, they're known as latent tendencies, the *anusaya*, the latent tendencies. So they're always there, ready to be fired. And in psychology, they'd call it subconscious motivations. So that's where we get the idea of Freudian slips. Something's happening in the back of the mind, we're not recognising it, and it comes out in a slip that makes us feel embarrassed.

So when we're about to do something or say something or even think something, you've always got to be aware of this little other dialogue that's going on. So it might be, for instance, "Well, I'm going to do your garden" — and the background little voice is saying, "and you'll come and do mine when I need it," or "I know you'll really love me after this. You'll really appreciate my friendship." So there's always these little things going on in the background. And it's a case really of making those conscious.

Now, as soon as they become conscious, they lose power over you. So if you remember, after the Buddha was fully liberated, there were seven years it said that Māra chased him with his three daughters: sensual desire, sexual desire — and if you don't know the third one, I'll leave you to guess it. And after seven years, he sort of began to go away. And he said, "What's happening?" He said, "Well, the Buddha sees me. He sees me." He said, "Well, give us a bit more time." He said, "No," he said, "after seven years, I'm not going to get through. I'm not going to get through to the Buddha."

So as soon as we see these little conversations coming from the self, the neediness of the self, the wanting to be loved, they don't have power over us. And we then re-establish our commitment to doing something from the heart of love. And that's how we begin to purify our hearts.

Now the purification of the heart demands a lessening of the self. So therefore, the path of love is the path of liberation. Rather — excuse me — the path of purification is itself a path of liberation.

Normally, of course, we put the accent on insight, on seeing things, which is absolutely necessary as well. But with the path of love, this is the process. You're constantly purifying your intentions, coming from the heart.

And it's funny, there's always an effort in philosophy to give you reasons. There's not time to go into the way that philosophers think about ethical behaviour, love, compassion and joy and all that. They try to give us rational reasons. But the great Scottish philosopher Hume — and I've heard him called the philosopher's philosopher — says that whenever he looked into an act of goodwill, he didn't find a reason at the bottom of it. What he found was a sentiment, and that's his word for something that arises out of the heart.

And Confucius said that the ground of a harmonious society was benevolence and concern — love and compassion. So everything around love always begins in the heart.

Now the only problem is that it's not always a feeling. You don't have to feel loving in order to act from a position of goodwill. So for instance, a surgeon who's operating — I doubt if they feel some great big gushing love towards their patient. I mean, their attention is on what they're doing. They should be equanimous, calm, cool, right? So again, when we say the heart, we're really talking about attitude. We're not talking about feeling. The feeling is sometimes there and it sometimes isn't. That's important.

So that gives us some idea as to how to make our acts of love, the way we speak and the way we think, coming from the heart of love, more and more pure.

But let's just say a word about loneliness. Now, when we feel lonely, it's a bit of a downer for the self because the language is something like "Nobody loves me. Who could love me? I mean, I'm horrible," and all that sort of really upsetting talk. So we try to escape that as soon as you feel lonely, as soon as it actually just drips into consciousness. Off we go — we turn on the TV, get onto social media, open a new packet of biscuits, anything but feel the loneliness. And that's of course why we don't like to tell people we feel lonely, because what we're saying to them is that we're not loved, we're not appreciated. So it's a difficult one for us.

Now if, by trying to escape it, of course it still remains there as one of these *anusaya*, as one of these latent tendencies. And what it's going to do is going to make you overact your love to other people so that you can prove that you are appreciated. You're going to be overly joyous at people's success just so they know that you are joyous and that you are to be praised because of that and appreciated and loved.

So you've got to tackle the loneliness in its rawness. And this is what *vipassanā* teaches us. So we go into the mental state, the feel of it. And you have to have the patience, you have to be open to it. And it helps to have a sense of care towards it, a sense of wanting to heal the heart of it. And that gives you a right attitude towards the feeling of loneliness. But you still have to go in there. You have to sink into it and feel the raw feelings. And of course what you're doing is you're opening up to your heart. The heart wants to speak to you. It speaks in feelings, in mental states.

And in so doing, what you're doing is we're letting off that steam. We're allowing that turbulence to manifest as turbulence, as energy. And therefore, it's exhausting itself, just like anything else. If you go for a run, at the end of it, you feel exhausted. So if you give the heart a run, it'll feel exhausted.

And now the really important thing is, if you can — this is a really important thing — if you can stay to the very last sensation caused by that loneliness, right? Because if you stay there, you might see the transformation. And that energy is never lost. It always transforms towards its opposite. And what you may experience is a sense of wonderful relief and peacefulness. But also, to your great surprise, it might burst out into this universal love for all beings. It's quite remarkable what will happen if you stay to the end.

You don't have to stay to the end for this technique to allow the heart to purify itself. But if you do, it gives you real confidence because now you know that all these negative mental states are always moving towards their opposites. No energy is lost.

And of course, that doesn't mean to say that when they are their opposites, when you do feel love, these mental states can't be developed indefinitely. So in other words, after this year of real commitment, you should be constantly sailing in a sea of joyous love. No doubt about it.

Unfortunately, this universal love that we're trying to get to, this sort of love which is above any love to do with attachments, is something we have to develop. All these other loves, if you think about it, come naturally. I mean, there's a natural loving of parents towards their children. You don't organise yourself. You don't sort of set yourself up to

fall in love. You just fall in love. You meet somebody and you like them and before you know it you fall in love, or you've developed a friendship because of that sort of connection between two hearts.

All these types of love are just part of our natural human nature. But to lift it into this universal love, this *mettā*, takes effort. You've got to lift yourself out of that stuff and really make an effort to open up your heart to all beings in all directions. So that's really the final thing.

So the question then is: to love or to be loved? I'm not Shakespeare and Hamlet — that's the question: to love or to be loved, in terms of our daily activity, in terms of our spiritual practice. And if we keep an eye on these *anusaya*, these latent tendencies, we'll get a hang of it.

It means that you've got to have a slightly more spacious awareness, an awareness which is not only about what's out there, but a constant sort of inner awareness, like you know all the time how you're feeling. It's just there in the sort of background. And when something moves — an irritation or something like that — you become aware of it. And because you're aware of it, it no longer has control over you. And you can just either park it, so you're not pushing it away with fear or with aversion. So those are suppressive measures. You're just putting it to the side and re-establishing your attitude, your act of will.

I think that's it. I think I've done it. So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that by your serious practice of goodwill and concern, you will be liberated from all sufferings sooner rather than later.

The Bases of Success

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 10 min

In this New Year teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the four iddhipādā (bases of success or power), one of the seven sets within the 37 bodhipakkhiya dhammā (requisites for awakening). These four essential qualities — chanda (aspiration/desire), vīriya (energy/effort), citta (devotion of heart-mind), and vīmaṃsā (discrimination/reflection) — form the foundation for both spiritual attainment and success in worldly endeavors.

The talk distinguishes between unwholesome desire (taṇhā from paṭicca samuppāda) and skillful aspiration (chanda), emphasizing how genuine yearning for liberation from suffering must be supported by sustained energy, complete devotion, and constant reflection on one's practice. Bhante illustrates these principles through personal examples, showing how missing any one quality undermines our efforts.

Drawing from the Buddha's final teaching on appamāda (diligence), he connects these bases to developing affectionate mindfulness in daily life — the care and attention that transforms ordinary awareness into the path toward awakening. This practical teaching offers essential guidance for maintaining spiritual resolutions and cultivating the inner conditions necessary for purifying the heart and achieving liberation from all forms of suffering.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So I thought today, being the new year and everybody's made these amazing new year resolutions, that we would do the four bases of power, or better still, better translation, the four bases that lead to success.

Now these are part of the thirty-seven requisites for awakening, the *bodhipakkhiya dhammā*. And this is the practice that the Buddha teaches us. So it begins with the four foundations of mindfulness, and then you have the four right efforts. I won't go into details—it takes too long. Then you get these four roads to success or bases for success. Then you have the spiritual faculties, and when you achieve stream entry they become the five spiritual powers. Then you have the seven factors of awakening, the Noble Eightfold Path, and all that adds up to thirty-seven.

And according to Bhikkhu Thanissaro, Ajahn Thanissaro—some of you will know his very good work—he reckons that this relates to the thirty-seven chords of those times. If you wanted to play the *vīṇā*, which was like a guitar, then you had to be able to find these thirty-seven chords. I don't know—I've never seen proof of that, but there we are. So the nice connection there between music and the Buddha Dhamma.

Anyway, when you practice these four bases you get what's known as the *iddhis* or the powers. You might have heard them called the *siddhis*. So you can bi-locate—you can appear in two different places or more. You can fly through the air and through walls. You can have the divine eye where you see beyond what's possible through the physical body, and the same with the divine ear—you can hear things which you can't hear if the mind is constrained by the physical body. You can read other people's minds. You can see how people are born and die depending on their *kamma*. So these are just some of them.

Now, all these are very wonderful and magical. But the really important one for us is that it leads to the destruction of the mental defilements. So that's where they become important for us. So these four bases or four qualities are what we need in order to purify the heart. And that's an absolute necessity in order to become fully liberated.

Okay, so what are these four bases? The first one is *chanda*, and it translates as desire. Now, in the dependent origination, of course, we have this word *taṇhā*. That's always an unwholesome desire. It's always a desire which is driven by greed, hatred or delusion. *Chanda* can be unskillful, but here, of course, it's skillful wish. Now it's not just a wish—it's an aspiration, it's a longing, it's a yearning for something. So in order to get this liberation from suffering you've got to really want it.

Now, once you've got that desire, once you've got that aspiration, the next thing that arises to support that, of course, is your energy, your commitment, true grit, doggedness, perseverance and all that drive. And then with that, there comes a devotion to it. So that word is *citta*. Now *citta* refers to both the heart and the mind. In other words, it's the whole mental process. And it demands a complete devotion from the heart to the task in hand. It's to do with attitude, dedication, devotion, care. And this is where the Buddha's word *appamāda*—one of his favorite words, which means diligence—it's one of his last two words: *appamāda sampādetā*—really strive, really work for your liberation. So there's the *citta*.

And then finally, there's this word *vīmaṃsā*, which translates as discrimination, reflection, knowing what you're doing, constantly reflecting on how you feel, what you're doing, what the process is, where you're going, etc.

So these four qualities—I'm sure all of you have exercised these. They are necessary for spiritual attainment, but they're necessary for anything that you set about in ordinary daily life. If you set yourself a goal, whatever it is, even if it's a simple thing like having to replant the garden or a job of work, you've got to have these qualities. And if one of them is missing or if one of them is not up to standard, then it undermines the project. It'll undermine your process.

Let's see now. I'm just thinking of my own personal—there's about four or five times in my life where I've had to put some special effort in. One of them was when I was a student. So I just lived the good old student life. And I was doing at the time this combination of a BA with a teacher's certificate. And in that very same year, they'd actually instituted the Bachelor of Education, which would have been far easier. Anyway, by the time I got to the fourth year, I knew I actually knew nothing. I had to pull my socks up, as they say. And I really, really, really wanted that BA because it's a passport to jobs and all sorts of stuff, especially in teaching.

So I really had to put my heart and soul into it. And I remember working twelve, fourteen hours a day trying to get this stuff into my head. But what was missing there? So I had the desire—I had the aspiration. I really, really wanted that BA. I had the energy because I was young anyway. I had the energy, the empowerment to do it. My heart was completely devoted to it. But I'm also sure about the discrimination and reflection. So in those days, I don't remember anybody teaching you study skills or anything like that. You just hung on in there and drove it in. If I'd have had some sort of guidance on study skills, it probably would have been that much easier for me. So I wasn't really reflecting on the way that I was studying or the way that I had chosen to do this work. And it probably led to inefficiencies and all sorts of stuff.

So I think if you look back into your life, I think you'll find there were times when you really had to put your body and soul into something. I use soul, of course, in a Buddhist sense.

So here we have these four qualities. You have to have an aspiration, a yearning, a real zeal for something. And there has to come that energy, which includes diligence. Your heart has to be right behind it. And there's this constant reflection.

So in our spiritual life every day, there's that—if every time you wake up in the morning to set yourself to make this a day of mindfulness, affectionate mindfulness. I mean that's what the Buddha wants us to do—that's his teaching in the Metta Sutta, the discourse on goodwill, to develop not just a mindfulness, but something that's coming up, something that engages also the heart. And that's your sense of care. So it's care and attention. Care and attention leads to this affectionate mindfulness.

And sometimes you have to give yourself a really good aspiration. So the aspiration, whatever it is—the end of suffering, make life a bit easier, movement towards contentment, it's better for other people. You can always bring others in. And then to raise that energy, the commitment to your practice, and then this constant reflection.

So throughout the day when the mind's wandering, you find yourself all over the place—just to stop for a minute. Whoa, where am I going? What am I doing? And in that way, we're slowly developing these qualities. And well, that's the path. I mean, it's pretty straightforward, really, once you're into it.

So that's what I've got for this evening. And it supports whatever resolutions you've made. So a resolution normally lasts for as long as you say it. So it's no good saying, "Oh, I won't eat, I won't have any tea from now on." It'll last about ten minutes. So you've got to keep reinforcing that commitment, whatever your resolution has been.

Very good. Short and sweet. I hope these words have been of some assistance, that I have not caused confusion, and that by your devotion to the practice and the four bases of success, you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Bāhiya of the Bark Cloth

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 11 min

In this deeply contemplative talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines one of the Buddha's most profound and concise teachings from the Udāna. He explores the story of Bāhiya of the bark cloth, a seeker who approached the Awakened One for urgent instruction, receiving what many consider the most direct pointing to liberation in the entire Pāli Canon.

Bhante contextualizes this teaching within the broader spiritual landscape of ancient India, particularly the Upaniṣadic tradition's concept of the 'unseen seer,' showing how the Buddha's approach differs fundamentally from Brahmanical ontology. The core instruction—'in the seen there is merely the seen, in the heard merely the heard'—points to experiencing phenomena without the fabrication of a separate experiencer.

Through careful analysis of Buddhist psychology and the mechanics of consciousness arising through sense contact, Bhante illuminates how this teaching addresses the very foundation of suffering. He explains the Buddha's statement that when one is 'not with that,' 'not in that,' then one is 'neither here nor beyond nor in between'—pointing to a liberation beyond the ordinary psycho-physical process. This talk offers both theoretical understanding and practical guidance for insight meditation practitioners seeking to understand the nature of direct experience and the cessation of suffering.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

I thought today we'd tackle a slightly more, for want of a better word, mystical discourse. It's called, or it's called after, somebody called Bāhiya of the Bark Cloth.

Whenever you get people writing about saints and holy people—hagiography—they always pump it up to make sure that either the person is amazing or the teacher is amazing. Now, it's not that the Buddha wasn't an amazing teacher, but in order to make him more amazing, we got this story about Bāhiya.

So he was a merchant and he used to ply up and down the Indian coast. One day he was shipwrecked and on a raft he made land. Suddenly he starts wearing a bark cloth. Now, for those of you who want to know what a bark cloth is, you have to peel the inner bark off trees and beat it until it's soft. Then it can be used as a loincloth, skirt,

draperies and wall hangings and in thick layers make an excellent bed. So that's what you can do tomorrow. But it also says it's an ancient art which is deeply involved in religious and ceremonial life. So remember that bit.

Anyway, he starts wearing this bark cloth and he becomes a mendicant. Of course, people feed him. After a while, he got the impression that, in fact, he was fully liberated. Well, as these stories go, a god appeared to him, an old relation, and said to him, "No, you're not liberated, you're not enlightened. In fact, spiritually speaking, you're as thick as a plank. The person you want to go and meet is the Buddha." So, of course, off he goes to meet the Buddha. He must have been a bit disappointed at that revelation, mind, you know.

Now, when he gets to the Buddha, of course, we'll come to that. So I think a better story, shall we say, which seems more true, is that the Brahmins were developing their own scriptures, which were called the Upanishads—translates as connection, but also known as the Vedanta, the end of the Vedas. They were specifically interested in who we were, what was the ground of our being—ontology.

This is a passage from the *Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad*, and this is what it says: "That imperishable is the unseen seer, the unheard hearer, the unthought thinker, the un-understood understander. Other than it there is naught that sees, other than it there is naught that hears, other than it there is naught that thinks, and other than it there is naught that understands."

In other words, it's pointing to this self, which is transcendent of everything. But it's interesting to see how it is expressed. The imperishable, that which does not change, is the unseen seer. The unseen seer. It's very Zen, you know, like the effortless effort, the unseen seer.

Now, these people who followed this particular Upanishad used to wear the bark cloth. That was their signature dress, just like the Buddhist monks went around with a bald head. Everybody else had long matted hair, dreadlocks, but the Buddha made us shave our heads. So all these sects had their own little way of manifesting who or what they were following.

So he's obviously heard about the Buddha, and he comes to find him. He finds him on alms round, and the Buddha says, you know, this isn't the time. And he says, "Look, I'm a very old man, and you're not so young, and we could die any moment. So really, please give me the teaching." So the Buddha, out of his compassion, does so.

Now as the story goes, not long after he was fully liberated, he got gored by a cow who was looking after her calf. So again, I think we can take that with a little pinch of salt.

Anyway, this is what the Buddha says to him: "Here in Bāhiya you should train yourself thus. In the seen there is merely the seen. In the heard there is merely what is heard. And in the sensed there is merely what is sensed. In the cognized there is merely what is cognized. And in this way you should train yourself, Bāhiya."

Now, if you're listening to this, you may very well become fully liberated. Here's the crucial bit: "When Bāhiya, for you, in the seen there is merely what is seen, in the heard merely what is heard, in the sensed merely what is sensed, and in the cognized is merely what is cognized, then, Bāhiya, you will not be with that. When you are not with that then you will not be in that and when you are not in that then you will neither be here nor beyond nor in between the two. Just this is the end of suffering."

Anybody awaken? No? Don't worry, it didn't work for me either.

So now, what's the Buddha saying here? In Buddhist psychology, we have a sense base, we have something that the sense base is aware of, or senses, rather, and there is the awareness, the consciousness. This consciousness is dependent on the sense base. That's why the Buddha enumerates consciousnesses according to the sense bases. So you have eye consciousness, nose consciousness, ear consciousness, and so on.

Here what the Buddha is saying is that in any given experience there's an object. It could be a video you're watching, it could be a biscuit you're eating, whatever. That's the object. He's saying when you are not with that. So that's a connection of being with something. When you're not with that, then the sense base—if you're not aware of something through a sense base, then you're not in the sense base. If you're not in the sense base, then consciousness cannot arise.

So you're neither there with the object, here with the sense base, and in between with that consciousness, which is a screen upon which these two things arise. When you experience something beyond that, then you've experienced something which is not part of the psycho-physical organism. And just this is the awakening.

Now, this is recorded, so I'm not going to repeat it. I couldn't repeat it anyway, but you've got the idea. So you can always listen to it again if you want.

The thing is that when Bāhiya hears this, he is actually immediately enlightened. The Buddha actually gives him a title. He gave titles to certain disciples who had special gifts. For instance, Sāriputta was called the *Dhammasenāpati*, the general of the Dhamma, because of his understanding of the Dhamma, which was said to be second only to the Buddha.

So he called him *lahupaññānaṃ*, the quickest person to become liberated amongst all those who were quick to become liberated. That's the title he gave him. And as I say, later on, as it's said, he dies from an attack from a cow.

So this is the story of Bāhiya of the Bark Cloth, and it fits into the *Udāna* Sutta. These are a collection of the inspired verses of the Buddha. Next week, I'll actually read that discourse and the Buddha's own response in verse, which will add to this meaning, if I explain it correctly.

So I hope that has been of some use, that it has not confused you, and that by your insight meditation, by seeing this process of how we create the world, you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

The Discourse on Bāhiya of the Bark Cloth (Ud 1.10)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 20 min

In this profound exploration of one of Buddhism's most cryptic yet transformative teachings, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Bāhiya Sutta from the Udāna collection. This discourse tells of Bāhiya, a respected ascetic who urgently seeks the Buddha's guidance, receiving what may be the most condensed teaching in all Buddhist literature: "In the seen will be merely what is seen, in the heard will be merely what is heard..."

Bhante Bodhidhamma unpacks this enigmatic instruction, showing how it directly relates to our vipassanā practice and the six sense bases. He explains how this teaching points beyond conceptual understanding and the illusion of an experiencing 'I' to the pure awareness that recognizes phenomena without identification. The talk explores the three taints (āsava) that Bāhiya was freed from - sensual craving, craving for existence, and ignorance - and concludes with the Buddha's inspired utterance describing the transcendent state of final nibbāna.

This teaching offers profound insights into the nature of liberation and the distinction between annihilation and the transcendent state beyond the five khandhas, making it essential listening for serious practitioners seeking to understand the deepest levels of Awakening.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So, last week we tackled this very cryptic saying from the Buddha, this very cryptic teaching. He couldn't have reduced his teaching any further, I don't think. It was about Bāhiya of the Bark Cloth. So, I said that this week we would actually read the discourse and revise what we said, because it's quite difficult, really.

The collection that this belongs to, by the way, is called the *Udāna*, U-D-A-N-A. I'll try to remember to put it in the chat box for you, which you can buy as a little booklet. It's translated by John Ireland. So that's where this translation comes from.

The Bāhiya Sutta. This is about Bāhiya. Thus have I heard. At one time the Lord was staying near Sāvattthī in the Jeta Wood at Anāthapiṇḍika's monastery, and at that time Bāhiya the Bark Cloth was living by the seashore at Suppāraka. He was respected, revered, honoured, venerated and given homage, and was one who obtained the requisites of robes, alms food, lodging and medicines.

We said last week that he was probably a follower of a particular Brahmin sect, depending on the Upaniṣads, and that their signature was wearing bark cloth. But here it's really talking about the myth that arose from him whereby he gets shipwrecked and he must have had a Damascene moment out at sea because when he lands he doesn't want to be a merchant anymore. He wants to be a *samaṇa*, an ascetic, and he gains the respect of everybody.

And these four requisites, robes, alms food, lodging, and medicines, that's the requisites of the Buddhist order. It's really basic, isn't it? That's all you need to live. There's something to wear, something to eat, a roof over your head, and medicine when you're sick.

So now, while he was in seclusion, this reflection arose in the mind of Bāhiya of the Bark Cloth: Am I one of those in the world who are *Arahats* and who have entered the path of *Arahatship*? And the word *Arahat* is an honorific, really. It's the blessed one or the holy one or something like that. But of course, it's given to somebody who's completed the path.

Then a *devatā*, who was a former blood relation of Bāhiya of the Bark Cloth, understood this reflection in his mind. Being compassionate and wishing to benefit him, she approached Bāhiya and said, "You, Bāhiya, are neither an *Arahat*, nor have you entered the path to *Arahatship*. You do not follow that practice whereby you could be an *Arahat* or enter the path of *Arahatship*."

That's a bit crushing, isn't it? I mean, a poor man's living, doing the best he can and this *devatā*'s told him he's wasting his time.

Then he asks, "In the world including the devas, all the gods, who are the *Arahats* and who have entered the path of *Arahatship*?"

"This there is, Bāhiya, in a far country, a town called Sāvattthī, there the Lord now lives who is an *Arahat* and fully enlightened one. That Lord, Bāhiya, is indeed an *Arahat* and he teaches the *Dhamma* for the realization of *Arahatship*."

Then Bāhiya the Bark Cloth, profoundly stirred by the words of that *devatā*, then and there departed from Suppāraka. Stopping only one night everywhere along the way, he went to Sāvathī where the Lord was staying at the Jeta Wood at Anāthapiṇḍika's monastery.

At that time, a number of *bhikkhus* were walking up and down, doing walking meditation in the open air. Then Bāhiya the Bark Cloth approached those *bhikkhus* and said, "Where, revered sirs, is the Lord now living, the *Arahat*, the fully enlightened one? We wish to see the Lord who is an *Arahat*, the fully enlightened one."

"The Lord, Bāhiya, has gone on alms round among the houses."

Then Bāhiya hurriedly left the Jeta Grove. Entering Sāvathī, he saw the Lord walking for alms food in Sāvathī. Pleasing, lovely to see, with calm senses and tranquil mind, attained to perfect poise and calm, controlled, a perfected one, watchful with restrained senses. So that's a classic trope describing the Buddha.

On seeing the Lord, he approached, fell down with his head at the Lord's feet and said, "Teach me *Dhamma*, Lord, teach me *Dhamma*, *Sugata*, so that it will be for my good and the happiness for a long time."

This *Sugata* translates literally as well gone. It obviously means somebody who's transcended, gone to *Nibbāna*.

Upon being spoken to thus, the Lord said to Bāhiya of the Bark Cloth, "It is an unsuitable time, Bāhiya. We have entered among the houses for alms-food."

A second time Bāhiya said to the Lord, "It is difficult to know, for certain, revered sir, how long the Lord will live. And how long I will live? Teach me, *Dhamma* Lord, teach me, *Dhamma Sugata*, so that it will be for my good and happiness for a long time."

A second time the Lord said to Bāhiya, "It is an unsuitable time, Bāhiya. We have entered among the houses for alms food."

But Bāhiya wouldn't give up, you see. A third time Bāhiya said to the Lord, "It is difficult to know for certain, revered sir, how long the Lord will live and how long I will live. Teach me *Dhamma*, Lord. Teach me *Dhamma*, *Sugata*, so that it will be for my good and happiness for a long time."

Now, this is one of these things that perhaps was part of the age. You could ask three times, and if the answer was still no, there was no point in asking again. So this time the Buddha took pity on poor Bāhiya, and he said this:

"Here, Bāhiya, you should train yourself thus: in the seen will be merely what is seen, in the heard will be merely what is heard, in the sensed will be merely what is sensed, in the cognized will be merely what is cognized. In this way you should train yourself, Bāhiya."

So now this is referring directly to our *vipassanā* practice. So the Buddha categorizes consciousnesses according to the sense base. So you have eye consciousness, ear consciousness, nose, taste, and body consciousness, and the mind consciousness. So what the mind is aware of, of course, is the internal life, the interior life of emotions and thoughts. So these are your six bases, and it's upon these bases that consciousness arises.

So he says, "So when, Bāhiya, when you are in the seen, when for you in the seen is merely what is seen, in the heard is merely what is heard, in the sensed," which means smelling and tasting, "in the sensed will be merely what is sensed, in the cognized is merely what is cognized, then, Bāhiya, you will not be with that. When, Bāhiya, you are not with that, you will not be in that. When Bāhiya you are not in that, then Bāhiya you will be neither here nor beyond nor in between the two. Just this is the end of suffering."

Now he's pointing, he's saying to Bāhiya, you will not be in that. Now remember if we go back to this Upaniṣad, it's talking about the unknown knower is always pointing to somebody, the one who understands, the censor, and so on. So now what Bāhiya seems to have been doing is looking for this knower, and of course he's not finding it. So the Buddha tries to avert him from that and draw him down to the level where he's just experiencing things without the sense of I.

So at that very base level there's always a sense base and a sense base has some object that it's sensing. Obviously you know if you've got eyes and you're looking then you'll see something like for instance now you see me. Now those two then have to have some way of relating that information onto something that can be seen, can be known. And that's what consciousness is. That's the *viññāna* consciousness, the consciousness of the aggregates. All these consciousness are dependent on a sense base.

Now, in our meditation, you see, what we're trying to do is to get down to that level where there isn't an I. What happens normally is we see something. We don't see it as it is. We see it within a category, which is our conceptual understanding. So when I see, for instance, an apple, I don't see that apple as something distinct and spare. I see it within my concepts of what apples are. And depending on that concept I'll be able to say to myself well this is a sweet apple or it's not so sweet and then of course there's I

like sweet apples I don't like unsweet apples and then once you've said that you have a relationship with it I want a sweet apple or simply want a sweet apple and then you get the I want a sweet apple.

Now what he's asking Bāhiya to do is to cut through that whole mentation dependent on a delusion of an I and get down to basics. And once he does that, of course, he recognizes that there is something which is aware of what's on that screen of consciousness. And that separation allows him to make the insight of what he really is before he becomes an I.

I hope that hasn't confused you completely. It's quite, the teaching is quite difficult. So when he says you are not with that, in other words you don't identify with the object by way of conceptual understanding. The apple, you don't. You're not in that, you're not identifying with the sense base, the taste, the sense of taste.

And when you don't identify with that, what comes up on the screen is pure, without the manipulation, the distortion of liking, not liking, wanting, not wanting. And that's when we're able to see that there is something which is distinct from everything that we're experiencing. And that's the process of awakening. That's what it is.

So then he says, "Now through this brief *Dhamma* teaching of the Lord, the mind of Bāhiya the Bark Cloth was immediately free from the taints without grasping. Then the Lord, having instructed Bāhiya with this brief instruction, went away."

So now this is the point, this is what happens when we become fully liberated. We are free from the taints. Now the word is *āsava*, and there is in that word the meaning of the word *sru*, which means to flow. So it's like the corruptions are flowing out of us. Sometimes they're called inflows, sometimes outflows. And they are the basic delusions that are affecting our lives for the worse of course.

So the first one is the taint craving for sensual pleasure, craving for sensual pleasure. The second one is the craving for existence, in other words always becoming. That's why you know anytime death approaches us we panic. So we want to continue from moment after moment. And we want to be somebody. We're always redefining ourselves. And finally, of course, the taint of ignorance, which, of course, is not understanding the way things really are. So he's freed of all that. And because he's freed of all that, he's come to the end of suffering.

So then, of course, not long after the Lord's departure, a cow with a young calf attacked Bāhiya of the Bark Cloth and killed him. When the Lord, having walked for alms food in Sāvathī, was returning from alms-round with a number of *bhikkhus*, on depart-

ing from the town, he saw that *bhikkhu*, that Bāhiya of the bark cloth, had died. Seeing this, he said to the *bhikkhus*, "*Bhikkhus*, take Bāhiya's body, put it on a litter, carry it away and burn it, and make a stupa for it. Your companion in the holy life has died."

So a *stūpa* would be a mound in those days, that's all. "Very well, revered sir," the *bhikkhus* replied to the Lord. Taking Bāhiya's body, they put it on a litter, carried it away and burnt it, and made a *stūpa* for it. Then they went to the Lord, prostrated themselves, and sat down to one side.

Sitting there, those *bhikkhus* said to the Lord, "Bāhiya's body has been burnt, revered sir, and a *stūpa* has been made for it. What is his destiny? What is his future birth?"

"*Bhikkhus*, Bāhiya of the Bark Cloth was a wise man. He practiced according to the *Dhamma* and did not trouble me by disputing about *Dhamma*. *Bhikkhus*, Bāhiya of the Bark Cloth has attained final *Nibbāna*."

Now, I love the way this little phrase has been put in there. So, did not trouble me by disputing about *Dhamma*. So he was constantly hassled by people, you know, questioning what he understood, what he taught. I find that a lovely little phrase to tell you something about the Buddha's life.

Then on realizing this significance, the Lord uttered on that occasion this inspired utterance. So this is where he's stating what *Nirvāṇa* is:

"Where neither water, nor yet earth, nor fire, nor air, find a foothold, gain a foothold. There gleam no stars, no sun sheds light, there shines no moon, yet there no darkness reigns."

So the first of course is our physicality which of course includes the whole psycho-physical organism. Where neither water, these are the four great elements, water, earth, fire, and air, and then the outer world, the material world that we live in. Gleam no stars, no sun sheds lights, there shines no moon, yet no darkness reigns.

Now, I was listening to a talk by Bhikkhu Bodhi, in which he was asked, what is the understanding of this *Nirvāṇa*, you see? And he said that in the Theravada Buddhism, there were two understandings. The first one was that when you've finally purified your heart and it's time to become liberated, the five *khandhas*, the psycho-physical organism, comes to an end, and that's it.

Now, I know people who believe that, that that's what the Buddha's teaching, and I cannot, I just cannot know the difference between that and annihilation. And the Buddha, often in the discourses, says he is not teaching annihilation. He says the only things that are annihilated are greed, hatred and delusion.

And then Bhikkhu Bodhi says the second reason, the second understanding, which is the traditional understanding, is that when the psychophysical organism, the five *khandhas*, come to an end, there is a transcendent experience, and that's what this, "yet there no darkness reigns," is pointing to.

And if you actually get that book, the *Udāna*, the inspired verses of the Buddha, you'll see that there's a whole section on *Nibbāna*, and they're all basically pointing to the same thing.

Dōgen Zenji, actually, the great Zen master, talked about his moment of liberation by saying the body and mind fell away, the body and mind fell away. That's another way of stating it.

So then he goes on, "When a sage, a Brahmin, has come to know this for himself through his own wise experience, insight experience, then he is freed from form and formless, freed from pleasure and from pain."

In other words, he's gone beyond. He's gone beyond all the amazing stuff you can get from absorption techniques, and he's gone beyond all that we can experience pleasure or pain from our physicality. So he's always pointing to something which is beyond.

Now he doesn't want to call it, he doesn't want to give it a name, he doesn't want to substantiate it, because then you end up like Bāhiya completely confused looking for your soul, looking for your eternal self. And that's why he's constantly pointing to it but not giving it a name.

Of course in later Buddhism, in Mahāyāna Buddhism, they began talking about it as the *Dharmakāya*, the body of the truth, sometimes Buddha nature.

"This inspired utterance was spoken by the Lord also. So did I hear."

Well, as usual, I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused confusion, and that by your careful investigation you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Joy

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 17 min

In this heartwarming talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the important but often overlooked practice of cultivating joy in Buddhist spiritual life. Drawing from his monastic experience and the Dhammapada, he addresses why many practitioners fear indulgence and consequently suppress natural joy, creating unnecessary suffering.

Bhante explores muditā (appreciative joy), one of the four brahmavihāras, explaining how rejoicing in others' happiness undermines envy and jealousy while expanding our own capacity for joy. He shares practical wisdom about distinguishing between healthy enjoyment and attachment, using examples from daily life and monastic experience to illustrate the middle way approach to pleasure.

The talk includes guided reflections on remembering daily joys rather than dwelling on difficulties, and concludes with a joy-based meditation practice similar to mettā bhāvanā. Bhante emphasizes that ethical conduct naturally leads to happiness, as taught in the Dhammapada, and that developing joy is both restorative for the heart and supportive of spiritual progress toward the ultimate peace of nibbāna.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

I've got my little microphone as usual. Being spring, or April anyway, I thought we would have a go at joy. The first thing I did was to look up all the synonyms we have: pleasure, enjoyment, happiness, gladness, delight, thrill, exaltation, elation, bliss, ecstasy, rapture, and absorption. That's not bad, is it? And it's all good. It's not as though the Buddha asked us to be miserable all the time, even though most of the teaching is about getting rid of suffering.

You know, he was asked how he feels when he teaches and somebody doesn't accept the teaching. He said he feels all right with it—calmer. But when somebody does accept his teaching, he feels happy, feels joyful.

Now, it's an interesting thing that all my teachers never introduced us to the practice of joy. It's very strange—*mettā* all the time, compassion a little bit, but joy never. I'm thinking they did this because of the problem of indulgence. And I think that's what goes wrong, of course. All these beautiful mental states to which we are heir corrupt as

soon as we try to hold on to them or want more of them. So it's a case of recognising that nothing is repeatable and that when it's gone, it's gone, and there's no point in hankering after it. For instance, if you take a morsel of food which you delight in, once you've swallowed it and the aftertaste is gone, that's it—let go.

Now this fear, this fear of indulgence, actually destroys joy. And I noticed it in the monastic life more than in lay people. For instance, at the monastery Kandamoda, there would obviously be occasions when people would come with special foods to celebrate a birthday, a marriage, and so on. One of the things that is quite lovely is buffalo curd, *miikiri*. It was handed out, and you put loads of sugar with it, or *kittel* juice—a bit like maple syrup—and it's wonderful.

We're all eating it, and there was a monk sat next to me who was the picture of the ascetic—very gaunt, with his cheeks drawn in. I knew him. While we were eating, he was glaring at this curd. As we came to the finish, he leant forward quite slowly, lifted it up slowly, and then basically shovelled it down his throat. I've always presumed he was just so afraid of indulgence. That's no good, is it?

There was another case too. There was my teacher, Sayadaw U Janaka. About ten years ago, he taught at a place called Beatenberg, which is near Interlaken—right in those beautiful lakes in Switzerland. From there, on a beautiful day, you can see these three great mountains: the Eiger, the Mönch, and the Jungfrau.

During the retreat, the weather was miserable—rainy, cloudy. One day it all opened up, and it's a glorious sight: the white peaks against this deep blue sky. Everybody on the retreat went out onto the balcony and outside to have a look. Well, he gave them hell, didn't he? He upset a lot of people. He told them they were useless meditators, were just indulging, and he was wasting his time and all sorts. I don't think he was invited again. I remember whenever I would say something like, "Isn't that a beautiful flower?" he would say, "Ah yes, but it fades. It fades, it dies." A bit of a killjoy really, but his intention of course was to awaken me to the problem of indulgence.

That seed of indulgence is always there, right to the bitter end. Mara is always right there, just waiting for the moment to creep up on us.

It's a case of just recognising these two things: if we begin to see what the consequences of indulgence are, then we'll make ourselves afraid to enjoy something. But actually, if for instance you have a biscuit, right, and you finish the biscuit—the last bit goes down, flavour's gone—and then you get this "I think I'll have another one." As soon

as that comes, well, that's greed, right? So you have to sit there and wait for that to exhaust itself. Once you've done that, you've exhausted the karmic consequence of the greed that arose while you were eating that biscuit. I think it's as simple as that.

I know somebody who got into the habit of eating biscuits just before they went to bed. He was getting rather afraid of it. So instead, he turned to music. Now that's a skilful thing. If you find that an indulgence feels a little bit overwhelming, then put your attention on some other joyful thing that you like to do.

So there we are. There's the fear—the fear of indulgence undermines, destroys enjoyment of joy. And to become indulgent with our joys, wanting more of this, more of the same—it's just the old suffering.

Now the question is, why is it we remember mostly at the end of the day the painful parts and hardly any of the joys? Well, I suppose the reason is because painful things hurt. But unfortunately, it does shadow out the joys of the day. So we have to make a special effort to remember the joys of the day. Instead of obsessing about our failures and our upsets, we can contemplate the successes and joys of the day.

The interesting thing is, the more you make yourself aware of the joys of the day, the more you bend that way and the more you see what is actually undermining your joy. And this, of course, creates even greater joy. So we try to rid ourselves of behaviours which undermine our joy, and over time our joy grows. Of course, this is done with a certain affectionate awareness. This is towards ourselves—being kind to ourselves, gentle to ourselves, and seeking what lifts the heart: music, nature, friendship and so on.

Now, this word *muditā*, which is one of the four *brahma-vihāras*—remember, love, compassion, joy, and peacefulness, equanimity, are the four great mental states. These we can develop indefinitely. It's often translated as appreciative joy, reciprocal joy. What this does, of course, is it undermines envy and jealousy. I define those two as saying that envy is wanting what the other person has, and jealousy is wanting what the other person has and hating them for having it in the first place.

It's interesting in the East—if you make a donation to a cause, if you make a donation to, say, a monastery, all the names are posted up with exactly how much you gave. It starts off with, I don't know, maybe a thousand pounds and goes all the way down to a couple of shillings. That's an old word, isn't it? It's done because in the East it's understood that people will rejoice in the good *kamma* that you have gained by your offering.

When it came to Bill Gates giving his millions away, I wonder what our response was. "Well, he got all that money, he should be able to give something away. The one percenters—he's got enough blessings." Did we say, "Oh, good on Bill, may he receive many blessings"?

So here we have that sort of reciprocal joy of actually being joyful in somebody else's successes and joys. I think it comes as a revelation that we can actually be more joyful for others than for ourselves. This is not strange, of course, to parents who rejoice in the successes of their offspring.

I remember once—I must have been about maybe twelve years old because my sister's eleven years younger than me—I got back from school and sat opposite my mother. She held Maria and encouraged her to walk towards me. When she did, I mean it was joy. It was wonderful to see this little toddler trying to make her way.

So this development of being joyful for other people in the joys of other people and the successes of other people is really heart-lifting.

Joy is also a restorative. Somebody's called it restorative joy. So there you are, down in the dumps, and you think to yourself, "Well, how can I lift my heart? How can I bring joy into my heart?" Whatever level—it doesn't always have to be amazing ecstatic joy. It's just feeling happy, generally happy. That's when you meet up with a friend or you watch a good film and so on.

In the monastic life, of course, the daily routine tends to be the same. Even when there's a feast day, the only difference is you turn up for a better meal and then you go back and it's just the same. So it can move you towards a sense of apathy, a sense of laziness and all that. It was then that I realised the amazing power of a long, mindful cup of tea. No doubt about it.

I mean, if we just list all those things—this is not an exhaustive list—just the sensual joys that we get that lift the heart, relations of happiness, just the religious joys of feast days. Now the ethical joys are really what the Buddha points to. As far as he's concerned, virtue, goodness equals happiness. In chapter twenty of the *Dhammapada*, a lot of the verses are devoted to being happy. This is what he says:

"Oh, how happily we live without hate among those with hate. Among people who hate, we live without hate. Oh, how happily we live without misery among those in misery. Among people in misery, we live without misery. Oh, how happily we live without ambition among those with ambition. Among people with ambition, we live without ambition."

Just a note on that ambition—there's nothing wrong with us offering our talents for the benefit of the company, people, et cetera. But of course it becomes corrupt when we start thinking about money and power.

So the whole idea really, if we want to develop joy, is to bend that way.

So what have we talked about? We've talked about the enemies of joy. We realise how corruptive indulgence is, how it becomes an obsession—what they call feeding the dragon. Because of that, we can't allow ourselves to enjoy something. And then of course, there's the indulgence itself, which becomes a trap in itself. That's feeding the dragon. The way we do it is by becoming more aware of our daily joys and just bending life towards that way, just as we do with *mettā*. Then we have this reciprocal joy, undermining envy and jealousy and really being happy for other people's happiness. And finally, to use joy to lift the heart when we feel a bit down in the dumps.

So here are some exercises. You have to make a resolution. If at the end of today, you sit and you think, "How happy was I today?" and all you can remember is the miseries, then you have to make a determination that tomorrow, you'll actually acknowledge when you're happy—any level of happiness, any level of joy. It could just be contentment. Just to acknowledge it. Doing that, of course, you remember it by the end of the day.

The other thing you might try to do is to contemplate every evening for about a week, maybe five, ten minutes, and just go back in your life and think of all the joys you've had. All the joys you've had. By the end of the week, you'll have a big smile on your face.

The other thing is the practice of joy, which is like *mettā*. So you go through all the categories, but the blessings are: "May you be joyful, may you be ever more joyful." Now those are the ones that are regularly used. I like to add, "May you attain the sublime peace of *Nibbāna*."

The problem with *Nibbāna* is that there's no emotions in *Nibbāna*. So it's not that sort of happiness. In fact, that's what Sāriputta said. He says it's the very absence of emotions which is the bliss of *Nibbāna*. That's a bit difficult for us, but at least we can make that intention because, according to the Buddha, this is the highest of all happinesses.

So, "May you be joyful, may you be ever more joyful, may you attain the sublime peace of *Nibbāna*." I think peace rather than bliss. I've sometimes used bliss, but peace gives you, I think, a slightly better feel for it. As I say, at the end of this hour, that's what I'll be doing. I'll be doing joyful meditation instead of *mettā*.

Very good. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I have not caused confusion, and that by your development of joy, you will be joyful sooner rather than later.

Is the Buddha an Atheist?

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 26 min

In this thought-provoking talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma addresses the frequently asked question of whether the Buddha was an atheist or believed in God. He begins by distinguishing the Abrahamic conception of an omnipotent creator God from the diverse theistic traditions of ancient India, explaining that the Buddha's position cannot be understood through Western atheist-theist debates.

The discussion centers on the Kevaddha Sutta (DN 11), where a monk searches through various celestial realms seeking answers about where the four primary elements (earth, water, fire, air) completely cease. Even the great Brahmā, despite his claims of omniscience and creative power, admits ignorance and directs the monk back to the Buddha. The Buddha reframes the question entirely, pointing to a transcendent consciousness that is "non-manifestive, limitless and all luminous" - beyond the material elements and ordinary mind-body consciousness.

Bhante explains how the Buddha can be understood as a "non-theist" rather than an atheist, as the question of God simply doesn't arise in his teaching framework. The talk concludes by examining whether Buddhism constitutes a religion, distinguishing between belief in a personal deity versus recognition of transcendent, unconditioned reality accessible through direct experience and the Noble Eightfold Path.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

The question this evening is: did the Buddha believe in God? Did Buddha believe in a God? Or was he an atheist, a non-theist, a non-creator theist, or an agnostic? From this another question arises: is Buddhism, the teaching of the Buddha, a religion or is it not?

First of all, to understand the Buddhist position, we have to put aside the Abrahamic God of the Jews, Christians and Muslims. This Abrahamic God created the world and also created the moral order, so he can punish and reward depending on our behaviour. This Abrahamic God is the one who created the world and established the rules and therefore can punish or reward.

In the West we have this atheism which is quite aggressive against this omnipotent, omniscient and omnipresent God. These atheists base their understanding on scientific materialism.

We can safely say that the Buddha never talked about this sort of God. In fact, I don't think it arises in the Indian tradition at all. The Buddha never talked about this type of God, and no other Indian traditions do either.

In the Brahminical system there was Brahma the creator, Vishnu the preserver, and Shiva the destroyer. The Law of Karma was included in this vision. So it wasn't that God either punished or rewarded you - there was the Lord of Karma.

There are many other types of theisms: pantheism, panentheism, polytheism. Even though in the scriptures they talk about the *devas*, the gods, these can be seen more like angels. They're more like angels. None of these has power over the world, the power of creation.

The Buddha definitely was not an agnostic. He doesn't say anywhere that he cannot decide whether there's a god or not because he hasn't got enough information. In fact, the idea of God simply doesn't arise in his teachings. In this sense he can be called a non-theist. There simply isn't the mention of a God in that sense. We also have a similar situation with Taoism. The Tao is seen as maybe the ground of being, but there's no personal God or anything like that.

There were other questions that the Buddha didn't answer. He would not go beyond what can be personally experienced. For instance: Is the cosmos eternal or not eternal? Is it finite or infinite? He doesn't answer that. He says it's not determined.

Another question was: Is the body the same as the everlasting soul or is the body one thing and the everlasting soul something else? The objection here would be the definition of a soul, and he didn't answer that.

Then there are the four questions to do with the Buddha himself. Does the Tathāgata, the Buddha, exist after death or does he not exist? Does he both exist and not exist? Or does he neither exist nor not exist? This was known as the quadrilemma - we have a dilemma; this is the quadrilemma - and he didn't answer.

In those days, on full moon nights, the teachers would come to these shrines, which were like beautiful parks, and they would argue their different doctrines against each other. The Buddha wouldn't go to them. He said it was a thicket of views, a wilderness of

views, a contortion of views, a writhing of views, a fetter of views. It is accompanied by suffering, distress, despair and fever, and it does not lead to disenchantment, dispassion, cessation, to calm, direct knowledge, full awakening, *Nibbāna*.

Does this mean that there is no teaching about transcendence in the Buddhadhamma? Many times he talks about *Nibbāna* as a transcendental experience, something beyond the body and mind.

Now we are going to read this discourse which is where the Buddha really makes fun of the idea of a creator god but goes on to tell us that there is a transcendent state. This discourse is known as the Kevaddha discourse. He's a monk.

This is his question: Where do the four primary elements cease completely - namely the element of the earth, water, fire and air? In other words, where is the material world annihilated?

He approaches the various realms of the gods. Firstly the Four Kings, but they don't know. They send him to the gods of the Thirty-Three, and they in turn to the gods of Yāma, and so on to the Suyāma gods, the Joyful gods, the gods of Santussita, the gods who delight in creation, all the way up to the gods of Brahma's host. Even they say they don't know, but Great Brahma will.

It was not long before the Great Brahma became manifest, and that monk drew near to him and said, "Where, friend, do the four great elements - earth, water, fire, and wind - cease without remainder?"

When he had thus spoken, the Great Brahma said to him, "Monk, I am the Great Brahma, the Supreme, the Mighty, the All-seeing, the Ruler, the Lord of all, the Controller, the Creator, the Chief of all, appointing each to his place, the Ancient of Days, the Father of all that is and is to be."

Then that monk said to Brahma, "I did not ask you, friend, as to whether you were the Great Brahma the Supreme and Mighty, the All-seeing, the Ruler, the Lord. I wanted to know where do the four great elements - earth, water, fire and wind - cease without remainder?"

And the Great Brahma said to him the same thing again. And then again, the third time, Kevaddha said, "I didn't ask you, friend, as to whether you were the Great Brahma the Supreme, the Mighty and so on. I wanted to know where do the great elements - earth, water, fire and wind - cease without remainder?"

Now the Great Brahma took that monk by the arm and led him aside and said, "These gods, these *devas* of the retinue of Brahma, believe there is nothing I cannot see, nothing I have not understood, nothing I have not realized. Therefore I gave no answer in their presence. I do not know, monk, where these four elements - earth, water, fire and wind - cease without remainder. Therefore, monk, you have done wrong, have acted unwisely in that ignoring the Exalted One, the Buddha, you have undertaken this long search among others for an answer to this question. Go now, return to the Exalted One and ask him the question and accept the answer he gives you."

So Kevaddha finds the Buddha and asks him the same question, and the Buddha corrects him, saying the question should be asked like this: "Where do earth, water, fire and air find no footing? Where are long and short, small and great, fair and foul? Where are the body and mind brought to an end?"

The Buddha's answer now refers to the body, the mind and consciousness: "There is a consciousness that is non-manifestive, limitless and all luminous. Here water, earth, fire and wind find no footing. Here long and short, small and large, pleasant and unpleasant - here matter and mind are all brought to an end. With the cessation of consciousness, this is all brought to an end."

Here we have a very clear statement. The first consciousness is the transcendent, having no boundary and no objects. It is unconditioned, not depending on anything outside itself.

The second consciousness cannot be the same because that comes to an end. This is the consciousness of the five *khandhas*, the five aggregates, the body and mind. This is the consciousness that operates within the mind, constantly arising and passing away, dependent on the sense-bases. Hence the Buddha talks of eye-consciousness, ear-consciousness and so on.

Returning to our other question: can you have a religion without a god? Is the Buddhadhamma a religion? The answer depends upon whether you believe in a god or not, and whether that means that it's a religion.

If you define religion as teaching that there is a transcendent, non-changing reality beyond the material and mental worlds, then it is a religion.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused confusion, and that your devotion to the practice and the Eightfold Path will mean that you will be liberated from suffering sooner rather than later.

Fear and Courage

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 23 min

In this insightful talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines fear as the most fundamental emotional state dependent on the delusion of self. Drawing from the Dhammapada (verse 39), he explains how the Buddha promised that all fear disappears for one who has awakened, whose mind isn't agitated, and who has abandoned both merit and demerit.

The talk explores six areas where we need courage: physical, social, moral, emotional, intellectual, and spiritual. Bhante emphasizes that fear is actually trying to protect us, so we must "give it a hug" rather than run from it. He shares the Buddha's own experience with fear and terror in the jungle, demonstrating how to turn towards fear and remain present with it until it subsides.

From the courage needed for physical challenges and social activism to the moral courage required in complex ethical situations, Bhante shows how each encounter with fear becomes an opportunity to undermine the delusion of self. The talk culminates with spiritual courage - the willingness to walk the path of renunciation toward nibbāna, despite not knowing what awaits. Through vipassanā practice, we learn to sit with difficult mental states as physical sensations, allowing them to be released naturally rather than creating stories that perpetuate suffering.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So well, I've chosen this topic of courage, but really what we're talking about is fear, isn't it? Overcoming fear.

Now fear is, I would argue, the most fundamental of our emotional states, dependent on delusion. So this delusion of a self has created a self which feels uncertain because, you know, sickness, ageing and death and all that. Therefore it has this fear about itself and it reacts to this fear by making itself safe, and that's when we start accumulating stuff. So money makes us feel safe, a big bank account, lots of friends and power of course, and lots of pleasurable things to do so we keep our mind off these horrible things.

So this fear of death or fear of sickness, ageing and all that has this effect of making us try to escape it. And of course, this is one of the great awakeners. This was the awakener, the awakeners that drove the Buddha to seek liberation: sickness, ageing and death. So it obviously plays a big part in our lives and it shapes our behaviour. When we're in any situation which is dangerous or stressful or in any way a challenge, it's something we need to deal with. I'm sure all of you have to some extent or other, and it won't go until the very last moment when the self is destroyed. So it's going to be with us for a while.

And we have to see it as a friend. I mean, after all, it is trying to protect us, right? And so we have to give it a hug and then we have to open up to it, get the feel of it and not run away from it. So, of course, that running away from it is panic, isn't it?

So if we consider the amount of fear that we have as a measure of the delusion of self, every time we undermine this fear, we're undermining the delusion of self. So there is a plus to it. And in fact, the Buddha in the Dhammapada, verse 39, tells us that in the end, all fear would disappear. This is what he says: "For one who has awakened, whose mind isn't agitated, whose heart isn't tormented, and who has abandoned both merit and demerit, fear does not exist." So once the mind has been silenced and the heart calmed, and there's no attempt to create *kamma* based on a self, me creating stuff, fear is completely gone. So the prognosis is good. This is what we have to keep remembering.

Now psychologists have delineated six areas of experience where we experience fear, and I'm indebted to Gwen for this, who runs the monthly meeting on climate change, climate crisis. So it's the physical, the social, moral, emotional, intellectual and spiritual. This is where we need to find a certain level of courage.

So the physical, I think, is pretty straightforward, just straightforward: the fear of pain, fear of debilitating illness, etc. So whenever that touches us, we come across this fear and it's being able to sit with the fear, allow it to arise, pass away. That's the courage, the internal courage. Of course, some people have to find that physical courage in daily life. I'm thinking of sports. A lot of sports demand physical courage, especially boxing. I don't know if any of you have done a bit of boxing, but you definitely got to have a bit of physical courage there. And then there are occupations: soldiering. If we think of what's happening now in Ukraine, both sides demands physical courage. Even the police sometimes need that.

So this identity with the body is profound. I mean, you can't be here without one, so it's the physical representation of our existence. So it's important that whenever this comes to us, that we really turn towards it, see it as a friend, see that it's actually trying to protect us and almost get comfortable with the feelings of fear. That's the big thing, not to push it away.

So we may use that as a question of ourselves: has there been a time in our lives when we've been physically timid when we should have done something, and how do we feel about that? Is there some guilt and shame that we haven't worked through? And then to make these silent inward resolutions that if it's demanded of us, we'll do our best to manifest courage.

So that's the physical part. The social part usually is to do with feeling embarrassed in a meeting. So you don't want to ask a question in case people think it's silly and stuff like that. So we're afraid of criticism, saying something which other people will jump down our throats for, things like that. Even expressing ourselves to neighbours, to a neighbour who you know has a different opinion or a different understanding. So that social courage is sometimes something that really we have to try to express.

I mean, obviously we have great examples of that: Martin Luther King, Nelson Mandela. All these people who are out on demonstrations, which are getting to be more and more policed and more danger of being fined and sent to prison. And of course, when you think of countries and the amount of courage you need, like for instance that terrible time in Iran where the Morality police murdered that young woman, and the tremendous repressive measures that the government took, even capturing people and then hanging them.

We've got of course Russia. So you've got a man called Kara-Murza, who is a political activist, journalist, author, filmmaker, political prisoner. So he spoke against the present war and he's ended up in jail for 25 years. And unless Putin is somehow got rid of, he's going to be there for 25 years. And then, of course, there's that Russian opposition leader, Navalny, who's tremendously courageous. It's unbelievable, really, whom Putin actually tried to poison.

Even if you look back into Russian history, the misery of the Russians is unbelievable. I don't think it's quite remarkable. And yet they find this courage through, if you remember Stalin's time, when the *samizdat*, when they were writing poems and all sorts of stuff and passing it on bits of paper to friends, trying to keep the resistance alive. And of course there's the investigative journalists: 67 have been murdered last year. The most prominent of course was when the Israeli forces shot, murdered Shireen Abu Akleh in the occupied West Bank. Awful, awful, awful.

So again, it's social courage. It's again an opportunity for us to contemplate where we haven't made our views known out of fear, out of fear of criticism or whatever, being mocked, attacked. And again there might be some shame or guilt around that. So you have to work through it, allow it to come up and then to make that resolution: should I find myself in such a situation, I'll make my understandings known.

Shading into that is moral courage. It's more to do with right and wrong. And I'm reminded now of the 60s, which of course is prehistoric now. But we had a person in the UK called Mary Whitehouse who really led the charge against the loss of moral compass. In those days it was called permissiveness and people were getting very upset about it. And of course we did lose the moral ground. We found out about the behaviour of that famous DJ, Jimmy Savile, and then the Catholic priests and all that and paedophiles. So there was something that happened in the 60s which took away a grounding that we used to have as a society in morality.

But of course, these situations are never absolutely white and black. It's quite difficult to decide. Then we have things like abortion, which in Europe is now a dead subject, really. But we can see the tremendous war that's going on in the United States over it. And the usual battle between the mother's rights and the right of the foetus.

And I think more upfront these days for us is immigration and the impact it's having on society. And no one has a clue. I mean, I haven't a clue as to what the answer is to the growing level of immigration. And when climate change really begins to bite, presumably it's going to get much worse. These people are coming out of areas of abject poverty and almost unliveable. And on top of that, there's the political refugees.

So, of course, the danger here is that it pushes society, the indigenous society, we can say, to defend itself and move over towards fascist regimes, which is happening. We've got Orbán in Poland. We've got Meloni in Italy. And this comes out of fear, but it's something that if we want to maintain a liberal society, something we really have to tackle.

So again, there's this whole area of morality which demands courage. And has there been a time in the past we could have been more morally courageous? And again, to make that resolution.

The next one is the emotional courage. Well, that points to opening up to these very difficult mental states that we have within ourselves. And that's, of course, very much part of our practice of *vipassanā*, just to allow very difficult mental states to arise and to be able to see the aversion that we have to it, the fear that we have to it, and just to allow that to pass away and then just to sit quietly with it, to sink into the fire, tie ourselves to the bonfire and just allow it to rage. And we do that because that's the heal-

ing. Once these emotions have a chance to liberate themselves they... of course what we mistake is that when we begin to create these stories in the mind, it feels like a relief. If you're angry and you go off onto a fantasy of beating somebody up, then it feels like a relief. But actually it's just exercising the anger. It's when you feel it as a physical sensation that it's actually being released. So this of course we know through our *vipassanā*.

And there's a little passage here that I've copied from the Buddha who has had to tackle fear when he first went out into the jungles. "And while I was staying there, a wild animal would come, or a peacock would make a twig fall, the wind would rustle the falling leaves, and the thought would occur to me, is this that fear and terror coming? And then the thought occurred to me, why do I just keep waiting for fear and terror?" So instead of that, this is what he determines. "What if I, in whatever state I'm in, when fear and terror come to me, were to subdue that fear and terror in that very state? So when fear and terror came to me while I was walking backwards and forwards, I would not sit down or stand or lie down. I would keep walking backwards and forwards until I had pacified the fear and terror. When fear and terror came to me while I was standing, I would not walk or sit or lie down. I would keep standing until I had subdued the fear and terror. And when fear and terror came to me while sitting, I would not lie down or stand up or walk. I would keep sitting until I had subdued that fear and terror. When terror and fear came to me while I was lying down, I would not sit up or stand or walk. I'd keep lying down until I had subdued the fear and terror."

So in other words, he turned towards it. The word subdue just suggests some suppression, but that's not what he means. So again, if we have a specific mental state that arises that we find very difficult, if it comes up at a convenient time when it's just you by yourself, whatever, just to be able to move into it and stay with it.

And then there's the intellectual. So recently here in the UK, we had a Professor Kathleen Stock, who's a philosopher and a gender critical academic. And she's been hounded out of the university that she worked in. And there was a whole rumpus at Oxford University asking her to be cancelled. And she basically stated in her book that trans women are not, it's difficult to say, are not the same as born women. Let's put it that way. So that's created quite a rumpus. And of course, she lost the job and everything from it.

So this whole area is one where people have to have the courage to speak their truth, you might say. It's a dodgy area because it depends which way you're looking at it. One of the paradoxes of this particular argument is nobody complains about a woman who becomes a man, changes her gender to a male. And I presume that's because there's not

much problem with that. So if a trans man walks into a male toilet, it's not a problem for the men. And if they happen to be in the same sport, boxing or something like that, it wouldn't be a big problem for men. But on the other side, it's obviously some women feel threatened by it in hospitals, in toilets and in sport.

So it's a difficult area. And we need to think about it because there may come a time that we have to express our views, our opinions, and feel free to do so. I mean, here in the West, we have that freedom.

Interestingly enough, in Hindu or Buddhist countries, and I think also true in the Far East, there isn't this obsession with sex at all. And the funny thing is that in the East, Buddhist especially, there's a myth that you're much better off to become enlightened if you happen to be born a man. So many women make the determination to be born a man in the next lifetime. And there was a case in Sri Lanka, which is the opposite, where a Catholic bishop became a Buddhist. And towards the end of his life, this is, I think, going back to the 60s, 50s, 60s, towards the end of his life, he determined that he wanted to be reborn as a woman. So he began dressing as a woman and trying to change his gender before he died.

Anyway, it really is just a case, intellectually, of really being able to hold our views and opinions just a bit more lightly, to see them more as perspective. If you hold onto your views and opinions too strongly, I'm right and everybody else is wrong, then there's always conflict. But to be able to be open to critique, to have your views challenged, even nuanced, I mean, that really takes courage.

And then finally, we have the spiritual courage. And there's one little example here, which I think really affected me when I found this out. When the Inquisition started and they attacked the Cathars, the Albigensians, down in the south of France, what's today is the south of France, there was an occasion where some escaped from the first town that was attacked in Béziers, and they ended up in a place called Minerve, which was a heavily well-fortified small town with a river running through it, etc. And there was a certain Simon de Montfort who was really quite a cruel soldier. Anyway, they were eventually conquered and he just kept lobbing stones at them with a catapult.

Anyway, when they finally collapsed and they entered into the town, they built a big bonfire and 140 Cathars threw themselves onto the flames. That's courageous. And ironically, there is a monument to that right in front of the Catholic Church. That's a bit cheeky.

So in our actual spiritual practice, there is, remember, this whole process of renunciation, of letting go, letting go, letting go. And really, this idea of *nibbāna*, it's a shady idea. The Buddha tells us it's the highest happiness. It's absolutely you want it when you've got it. But we don't know what it is. And in the Christian tradition, they talk of the *mysterium tremendum* and *fascinans*. So it's the mystery which is both frightening, makes you tremble, and yet it fascinates you. Yet you want to find out what it is.

So it's going to take some courage because it's like you're walking backwards towards a cliff. You know there's a drop coming somewhere. You know you've got to let go of everything at some point, but you don't know when it's coming and you haven't a clue what's going to happen when you actually fall off the cliff. So there's a bit of anxiety, fear, existential anxiety around the whole process of spiritual practice. So again, whenever that sort of fear comes up, we just turn to it, the usual thing, give it a hug. It's only trying to protect us and make a determination to continue with our practice.

So these six areas just give us a way of examining the whole idea of timidity when fear comes and courage. There is another side to this which I'll tackle in another talk and that of course is the courage of forbearance, the courage of patience, and the Buddha has a lot to say about that.

Very good. So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I have not caused confusion, and that by your ability to stay with fear, to overcome fear, you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Patience

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 19 min

In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the perfection of patient forbearance (khanti), which the Buddha called "the supreme austerity." Drawing from classical texts including the Theragāthā and various suttas, he examines how patience serves as both passive courage and inner strength that builds resilience when everything falls apart.

The talk covers five key areas for developing patience: dealing with insults, criticism and slander without retaliation; enduring life's hardships and adversities with acceptance; cultivating patience toward difficult people; bearing with our inner reactivity driven by desire and aversion; and maintaining patience with our spiritual progress without attachment to outcomes. Bhante shares the powerful story of Bharadvāja the Rude, who abused the Buddha only to be transformed by the Buddha's patient response, illustrating how non-reactivity can heal both oneself and others.

Using practical examples from monastery life and personal experience, including the extreme teaching of the Parable of the Saw, Bhante demonstrates how patient acceptance—"this is the way it is"—allows difficult emotions to burn themselves out naturally. He emphasizes that spiritual progress unfolds like a tree growing from seed to fruit, requiring gentle persistence rather than forcing or measuring against expectations. This teaching offers profound guidance for developing the inner strength and equanimity essential for both meditation practice and daily life challenges.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsbuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsbuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsbuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed and noble, self-enlightened one.

Last month we did courage, which doesn't actually come up as a separate item in the ten perfections, the ten virtues to be perfected, but I suppose you could fit it into *adhiṭṭhāna*, which means resolute resolution. We'll do that another time. What we talked about was courage as doing something, achieving something, even though it's very difficult one way or the other.

But there's a passive side to courage, which is, of course, patient forbearance. Now, the Buddha is very big on that. He encourages us to develop it. So this is what he says: "Patient endurance is the supreme austerity. Whoever endures abuse, assault and imprisonment without animosity, and who has forbearance as one's strength, as one's mighty army, I call a brahmin."

So a *brāhmaṇa*, in the Buddha's understanding, is someone who's achieved something. He was always poking fun at the brahmins who were pretending to be the spiritual leaders of society. Many of them were a bit corrupt, I think. I'm sure there were some good ones.

"He who holds back rising anger like a rolling chariot, him I call a real driver. Other people are but holding the reins." And there's a verse here from the *Theragāthā*, which is the collective verses of the elders. This is the senior monks, not the nuns. "Forbearance is the highest virtue. Forbearance is the highest self-control. Forbearance is the highest happiness."

So there's a lot going on for this virtue of forbearance. We look at one or two areas: all those areas where we feel insulted, slandered and all that sort of stuff. Then there's the hardships and adversities that come to us through life. And we're, of course, cultivating patience with others. Then there's this inner bearing with reactivity, letting go of our inner reactions to things. And finally, patience with the spiritual path. In so doing, we build up this inner strength and resilience. You know, when everything falls apart, there's that ability to bounce back.

The first one: dealing with insults, criticism, slander. It's important for us to face these things when they come up, instead of retaliating, becoming upset. You have to develop this patience and maintain equanimity, which is difficult, of course. Often the best thing is to approach the person who's done this to you and have a little discussion with them. That's before you hit them.

Now, there's an occasion here where the Buddha is actually abused by somebody. So I shall read out this little bit. At one time, the Buddha was staying near Rājagaha in the bamboo grove, the squirrel's feeding ground, and the Brahmin Bhāradvāja the Rude heard a rumour that a Brahmin of the Bhāradvāja clan had gone forth from the lay life to homelessness in the presence of the ascetic Gautama. So remember that's his family name, Gautama. Angry and displeased, he went to the Buddha and abused and insulted him with rude and harsh words.

When he'd spoken, the Buddha said to him, "What do you think, Brahmin? Do friends and colleagues, relatives and family members and guests still come to visit you?" "Sometimes they do, Master Gautama." "And do you then serve them fresh and cooked foods and savouries?" "Sometimes I do." "And if they don't accept it, Brahmin, who does it belong to?" "Well, in that case, it still belongs to me."

"In the same way, Brahmin, when you abuse, harass and attack us, who do not abuse, harass and attack, we don't accept it. It belongs to you, Brahmin, it still belongs to you. Someone who when abused, harassed and attacked abuses, harasses and attacks in return is said to eat the food and have a reaction to it. But we neither eat your food nor do we have a reaction to it. It still belongs to you, Brahmin, it still belongs to you."

Now the Brahmin mistakes the Buddha's assertive forthrightness for aggressive bluntness, and he says, "The king and the retinue believe that Master Gautama is a perfected one, and yet he still gets angry." So one of the signs of somebody who's perfected, of course, is that they don't get angry, or at least when they do show anger they're only putting it on.

The Buddha replies, "For one free of anger, tamed, living in balance, freed by right understanding, one who is composed and at peace, where would anger come from? When you get angry at an angry person, you just make things worse for yourself. When you don't get angry at an angry person, you win a battle hard to win. When you know that the other is angry, you act for the good of both yourself and the other if you're mindful and stay calm. People unfamiliar with this teaching consider one who heals both oneself and the other to be a fool."

Anyway, this seems to have convinced Bhāradvāja. He's practically bowled over because he then says, "Oh, excellent Master Gautama." And before you know it, he's taken refuge in the Buddha, his teaching and the order, and he wants to become a monk. Then he receives the going forth, the ordination in the Buddha's presence. And not long after the ordination, the Venerable Bhāradvāja the Rude, living alone, withdrawn, diligent, keen and resolute, soon realized the supreme end of the spiritual path in this very life. He lived having achieved it with his own insight the goal for which people rightly go forth from lay life into homelessness, and he understood: "Rebirth has ended. The spiritual journey has been completed. What had to be done has been done. There is no return to any state of becoming." And the Venerable Bhāradvāja became one of the perfected ones.

I don't know how you handle when you feel angry about what somebody's done or said about you. But if somebody has been angry with me, I've learned to just listen to what they say. Even though there's a reaction here, I put my whole attention on actually

what they're saying. In so doing, I then reply to what they're saying and maintain at least an outward sign of non-anger, non-reactivity. That normally allows them to cool down a bit. Then hopefully there's some discussion before anything gets worse.

That leads us, of course, to having patience with others. We meet people who just get up our noses, and somehow we have to cultivate this acceptance, this patience with them. Responding with a certain understanding and compassion.

There was a case at Kanduboda, which was where I stayed for quite some time. A schizophrenic came—at least he told us he'd been diagnosed as schizophrenic—and he'd obviously stopped taking the pills. He was doing some very funny things, like meditating in the nude, which in the East is a bit off. Sometimes showering, public showering, you know, where you go to the open well and pour water over yourself. He was doing some other silly things that were disturbing people.

The people there—I didn't know this was going on because the place was a little bit far away from my own hut—went to the abbot and complained about him, but the abbot did nothing. Eventually, in a bit of desperation, they came to see me. I said, "Well, I'll go up and see the Venerable Upāli and see what he'll do." So I went up and expressed their annoyance, the fact that they felt their practice was being heavily disturbed. And he didn't do anything.

I never knew whether it's because he didn't want to confront this man or whether it was a teaching of just bearing up with what is unpleasant. Usually it's the unpleasant which disappears. Usually it's the opposite. Somebody disturbs you and we tend to move away. But actually, if you just hang on in there, they usually give up and disappear. So this was a big teaching for me.

The second one, of course, is endurance in adversity: when things fall apart, when you have an illness or something like that, or you lose a close friend or a family member, or somebody at work leaves whom you had a good relationship with. All those things, just the ordinary adversities of life that come our way. Just being able to accept them. This is the way it is. That's the big phrase, isn't it? Just to accept it.

Sometimes I've found it helpful to write out the situation so that I'm clear as to what's actually happening. That allows whatever has arisen—anger, disappointment, grief, despair, all that sort of stuff—to eventually burn itself out.

As you know, recently I had some really bad trouble with a slipped disc, which stopped me from walking actually, the sciatica. Funnily enough, having accepted the situation this year, this is the first time I've actually walked around the meadows twice a day and really enjoyed the way that nature's come alive over the spring. So it's not been that heavy.

It all comes down to this basic acceptance: this is the way it is. If you keep saying that to yourself, just banging it into your head, "This is the way it is," and then just letting the heart relax around that. This is the way it is. Then the possibilities usually turn up. We went through that very strange period of lockdown, which was really weird. For many people, it was just an opportunity to do stuff they always wanted to do. Now they can't do what they usually do. So take up new hobbies and writing and music and stuff like that. So it is very much a case of bearing with it. It begins with this acceptance. Then, of course, we find that it's not so bad.

However, there can be situations which are very painful. There's a discourse here called the Parable of the Saw. I'm sure many of you have heard it. The Buddha says, "Monks, even if bandits were to sever you savagely, limb by limb with a two-handed saw, he who gave rise to a mind of hate towards them would not be carrying out my teachings. Monks, even in such a situation you should train yourselves thus: Neither shall our minds be affected by this, nor for this matter shall we give vent to evil words, but we shall remain in full concern and pity with a mind of love, and we shall not give in to hatred. On the contrary, we shall live projecting thoughts of universal love to those very persons, making them, as well as the whole world, the object of our thoughts of universal love—thoughts that have grown great, exalted, and measureless. We shall dwell radiating these thoughts, which are void of hostility and ill-will. In this way you should train yourselves."

That's a bit of a demand, isn't it? In fact, when I once said this in a talk, somebody said, "Well, the Buddha had a great sense of humour." So bearing up with things just gives us that sense of resilience.

When it comes to our inner practice, this is also to do with how we react to what's happening to us on the outside. But of course, it also affects how we react to ourselves within ourselves. All this comes under that quality of reactivity. Here again, there's an importance to be able to bear with ourselves, to bear with our own thoughts and emotions, sensations and stuff like that, just so that we can develop a clarity of mind.

I was reminded of Brian Keenan. Some of you remember this. He was captured by Shiite militiamen in 1990, when he wrote the book. He had another person, John McCarthy, who shared the cell with him, and for four years they lived in this really

horrible imprisonment. If you read the book *An Evil Cradling*, it really is a shocker. He came out of it, from all intents and purposes, really strengthened. I remember when I read the book, there's a point where he has an insight into thought which I thought was a spiritual insight actually. But unfortunately there was another man there, an American, who really was broken by it. It's a sad story. Some people just... I mean, now we've got this business in Ukraine and Russia, so there are people having to go through this sort of stuff.

The final thing is, of course, patience with our spiritual progress. You have to be careful here because lots of people say to me, "Well, I don't feel I'm progressing." That means normally that we've got some idea as to where we ought to be, what we ought to have achieved by now, some idea of what the insight practices are, some idea about *nibbāna*.

This can be very debilitating, and I always think it's best just to put that to the side, because the spiritual practice, so long as you're making that effort—that gentle effort to just keep mindful, keep working with it—it's bound to move. The Buddha talks of it like the growth of a tree, from a seed and how long it takes for that tree to finally fruit. So it is a case of really having patience with that, but also not getting into it at all, really. It just happens naturally.

I think it's much more wise in a way just to work with our negative mental states, because as they begin to lose their power over us, there's a greater clarity anyway. It's just part of the practice. In fact, somebody complains to him about how hard the practice is, and the Buddha says, "Well, in the end, you achieve *Nibbāna*." And the questioner said, "Yeah, *Nibbāna*, so what?" He says, "Well, when you get there, you are happy and contented." *Tathī sukha-vihārī*.

So we have to be careful about that, not wanting to have some idea as to what spiritual insights or what *nibbāna* is, and just have that confidence that we're moving that way.

So we've been looking at this patient forbearance, which the Buddha really highlights as an important practice: how to work with people who slander us or abuse us or say nasty things to us; how to work with hardships and adversity when it comes our way; cultivating patience towards others; and then reactivity either towards others, but spiritually in the practice, this reactivity that we have within ourselves, driven by desire, wanting something, not wanting something, always trying to make the world comfortable. And then finally, just having patience with the spiritual path. The Buddha says it's a gradual path.

Very good. So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance and that by your development of patient forbearance you will achieve the final liberation from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Equanimity — The Most Important of All Virtues

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 25 min

In this profound teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores upekkhā (equanimity), which Ñāṇapoṇika Thera called "the most important of all virtues." Drawing from the wisdom of the Mahāsi tradition, Bhante explains how equanimity serves as the foundation that prevents all other virtues from falling into their subtle errors — stopping loving-kindness from becoming attachment, compassion from becoming pity, and sympathetic joy from becoming excitement.

The talk covers equanimity's crucial role in the seven factors of Awakening (bojjhaṅga), where it balances investigation of dhamma and supports Right Awareness. Bhante demonstrates how upekkhā is essential for vipassanā practice, maintaining the cool objectivity needed to observe the three characteristics of existence — impermanence, unsatisfactoriness (dukkha), and not-self (anattā).

Using vivid examples including the four worldly conditions (gain/loss, fame/disrepute, praise/blame, pleasure/pain), Bhante shows how equanimity keeps us steady through life's inevitable changes. The session concludes with a guided equanimity meditation using the phrases: "May I be calm, peace-loving, open and composed," extending these qualities to benefactors, neutral persons, difficult people, and all beings everywhere.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahatto sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahatto sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahatto sammā-sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

So we're covering equanimity this evening, and I think that completes the four illimitables. Maybe I'm not sure I've done compassion. Well, I'll get around to it if I haven't.

According to Ñāṇapoṇika Thera, who was the German founding monk of the Buddhist Publication Society to which Bhikkhu Bodhi then became the editor—he's got a massive collection of books on Buddhism—he wrote what is still a classic, *The Heart of Buddhist Meditation*, well worth a read. He was a follower of the Mahāsi like myself, and he wrote another book called *The Vision of Dhamma*. In it he states that equanimity is the most important of all virtues, and I agree.

Now first of all we have to understand what equanimity is, and I might extend the meaning of it just a little bit. So synonyms are things like composure, calmness. It's got this word "animus" in the middle of it, and that's a Latin word which covers both the heart and the mind. So in Buddhism, remember, when feeling arises, perception arises; when perception arises, feeling arises. So the intellect and the emotional life are always working together. This is the point.

What equanimity would ask us to do is not to hold on to opinions—see them more as perspectives—so it's open to other people's and undermines a sense of "I'm right and everybody's wrong," that sort of position. From the heart's point of view, you're overcoming things like acquisitiveness, aversion, fear, preference.

Now if we think of a judge, we definitely don't want him to fall to the victim of bribery and all sorts of personal gain. We don't want her to be swayed by the clever arguments of the lawyers. We don't want her to be afraid of threats. We don't want him or her to be biased towards the accused because they just don't like them, and they've no preference as to what the verdict of the jury comes up with. So they must maintain a sense of composure, unruffled poise. So this is equanimity.

If we look at something like climate crisis, equanimity would stop us from becoming panicking preppers, imagining terrible scenarios. I mean, frankly, what's happening now doesn't need much to the imagination. We don't get angry with deniers, and we help to maintain an attitude of whatever the outcome is so that we keep to our principles.

So Nāgārjuna has done a set of writings on the maxims, which relate to situations which are desperate. In such a situation, we remain calm, tranquil, stiff upper lip, that sort of thing. Not so stiff, Mike.

When we look at where it's important, it stops all the social virtues from falling into the error of their near enemy. So love has its obvious enemy—it has hatred. But its near enemy, of course, is attachment. And what equanimity is supposed to do is to stop you doing that. So equanimity, as it were, is subsisting all our virtues. If it's not there, we slip into these subtle errors.

Compassion—the obvious enemy is cruelty, but the subtle enemy is having pity for, giving preference to somebody whom you have more pity for than for somebody else. So if you were a nurse or a doctor or a teacher even, then of course you'd upset other people by giving other people preferential treatment.

When it comes to joy, one of the obvious enemies is jealousy, of course, because we're supposed to rejoice in the joy, in the success of others. But the subtle enemy would be to over egg it, to get all excited. And again, equanimity calms us down, keeps us on the steady path, keeps the joy true to its object.

And finally, there's equanimity itself. And of course, that also has an enemy, a subtle enemy. The obvious enemy, of course, is to become completely unruffled, to lose your composure, and that would be it. The subtle enemy is indifference. So we think we're being equanimous, but actually we're being indifferent. We're being apathetic. We're not really caring. So what we do for that is, depending on the situation, we raise the social virtue. So if it needs friendship, you raise love; if it needs compassion or caring nature, you raise compassion, etc.

So the equanimity is something that subsists all the other virtues, stops, for instance, courage falling into foolhardiness, humility dipping into this false self-effacement, a humble humbleness, and keeps us cool. It keeps us cool, it keeps us poised, but it also keeps us warm, it keeps us engaged.

There was an occasion when I was at two monasteries—they'd happened one after the other, actually—where I was with one monk and there was a cat in the room, had obviously been playing around with a mouse and killed it. So I just said, "Did you try and stop that?" And he said, "No, it's cat *kamma* and mouse *kamma*." And I went to another monastery later on, and this cat just jumped out and jumped on this bird. And this monk got up and gave the cat a great wallop. Unfortunately, he didn't save the little bird. The bird died. And he very beautifully held it up by the wings and chanted, "All compounded things arise and pass away." So which one had equanimity, you see?

Now, another place we find equanimity is in the factors of enlightenment. So all these factors of enlightenment are supporting *sati*, the main one, supporting right awareness. And we have these qualities which balance each other. So we have a sense of focus, sense of steadiness of attention, and that needs right effort. So too much effort, you get restless; too little effort, the mind begins to wander.

And then you have this pair of—well, the word *pīti* is translated as joy, but it's the joy of interest. Just like when you're exploring anything, when you're interested in anything, that's a joyous mental state. And that needs calmness. Again, it stops the interest becoming excited. So too much calmness, you fall asleep; too little calmness, you get all excited and restless.

And then the final two are the investigation of the Dhamma, which, when you're sitting, are the three characteristics of existence, which is impermanence, how we create suffering for ourselves, the *dukkha*, and not-self, insubstantiality. And that's balanced with equanimity. So it stops us trying to see something, it stops us over-efforting, and it keeps us cool, it keeps us objective in our investigation.

So that's the seven factors. So when it comes to *vipassanā*, whenever we practice *vipassanā*, as we'll do tonight a little bit, there has to be this quality of equanimity. And you'll notice that in those seven factors of enlightenment, there isn't any love, there isn't any compassion. We can presume that that's there as an underlying purpose because we want to escape suffering, so that's an act of compassion towards ourselves. But it's not directly involved in the process of insight.

But in *vipassanā* we have this *upekkhā*, this equanimity. Now again, if we get up from a practice and we go straight into daily life, then the danger of *upekkhā* falling towards its near enemy is there—so it becomes a sort of aloofness, a lack of, an inability to fully engage. And the way we overcome that is by doing *mettā*.

So in ordinary daily life, after you've done your hour or two hour meditation in the morning, you then bring to mind the people whom you're going to visit, you're going to meet during the day, and you offer them this loving kindness. And especially to those whom you're having some problems with. And of course you do it again in the night after your two to three hour meditation session.

Finally, there's the four worldly conditions, sometimes referred to as the four worldly winds: gain and loss, disrepute and fame, blame and praise, pleasure and pain. So when it comes to gain and loss, sometimes you win and sometimes you lose. I mean, playing games at school really helps us to become acquainted with those two mental states. And the thing is, what equanimity does, it stops us getting excited about gaining too much and we don't get depressed when we lose. It's a way of being unruffled. It stops us overreacting, that's all.

So when the Buddha, for instance, was asked how did he feel when somebody rejected his teaching or at least didn't respond to his teaching, he said it's fine. According to him, it was the person's *kamma*. But when somebody actually did follow, he said he felt joy. So that's that sympathetic joy, the joy of knowing that somebody was on the path to liberation.

When it comes to having a fame or infamy, a good reputation, we all want a good reputation. We all want people to have a feeling that we're good people, that they respect us, etc. And when we find somebody's slipped us a little slander, said things that,

even if it's only a small thing, we find it humiliating. We get angry about it and we do the same to them. But equanimity stops you doing that, you see. You just accept it. That's the way it is. And we try not to fall into that error ourselves, of course.

At that time, they used to have these meetings on the full moon night, which were sort of debates between the various teachers and philosophers, the Brahmins. And seemingly that was the big night out. I mean, this is before reading and writing, radio, TV, internet. I mean, what did people do before all that? Well, they used to, in the East anyway, they'd gather on a full moon night and listen to these talks.

So the Buddha warned his monastics not to get involved in these events. And this is some of the verses that he tells them: "Desiring debate, they plunge into an assembly where each takes the other as a fool. Relying on others, they state their contention, desiring praise while claiming to be experts. Addicted to debating in the midst of an assembly, their need for praise makes them nervous. But when they're repudiated, they get embarrassed. Upset at criticism, they find fault in others. In their doctrine, if their doctrine is said to be weak, the judges declare it repudiated, the loser weeps and wails moaning, 'They beat me.' When these arguments come up amongst ascetics, they get excited or dejected, seeing this refrain from contention. The only purpose is fame and profit."

There's a Buddha telling us not to get involved in these argumentations.

The next one would be blame and praise. Now, whenever you get blamed, even if it is your fault, it's not very nice. It hurts, you see what I mean. Actually speaking, when something goes wrong, we shouldn't be blaming people. We should be asking, how did it happen? What we're looking for is a solution so that that particular incident doesn't happen again.

For instance, we had an occasion—we've had, I think, two of our rice cookers ruined because the bowl wasn't inside and the assistant just put the food straight into the cooker. So it went everywhere, right into the machinery, into the electrics. We tried to save both of them. It was impossible. So now, recognizing that that mistake is done, it's easy to do, we now leave an empty bowl next to the cooker so that when the other bowl is taken out to be washed and the person comes in, they recognize that there's no bowl in the cooker, and so far so good. We're going to keep our fingers crossed on that.

There's no good blaming people. You have to find out how the mistake was made, how it came about, and then you just correct it. Simple as that.

Anyway, on this business of praise and blame, there's a story of a Zen monk. So he entered a village—he was a local monk, he lived in his own little hut somewhere—and he came into the village for alms. Suddenly this young woman accused him of making her pregnant. He was silent. When the baby was born, they took it to his dwelling and he received it without saying anything, and he nurtured it well. Of course, over time, especially the young woman wanting her baby back, the truth came out. So all the villagers went back and apologized and took the baby back, and he gave it to them, and he never said a word. So that's how we can deal with praise and blame.

The final one, of course, is pleasure and pain. So we're always seeking pleasures and we're always trying to get away from pain. And these days with our consumerism and all that and our adverts always wanting to make us excited, basically, we just want more. It doesn't matter what it is. We just want more of it. And so we tend to get lost in that greediness. But that doesn't mean to say that we shouldn't appreciate a joy when it arises or a pleasure when it arises, but the trick of course is to remind ourselves that it's over, it's gone, it's finished. It cannot be repeated. This is the big thing. You can't repeat a joy. I get something like it, but you can't repeat it. So you just let go of it. That's it. It's fine.

And what equanimity does of course is it stops these unnecessary reactions and rides on acceptance. This is the way it is. Things arise and pass away. You can't repeat anything. A joy will come and a joy passes. If I remember Blake's little phrase, "To kiss a joy as it flies is to live in eternity's sunrise." Well, that's the trick.

So we have a little verse here from the Buddha telling us about the four worldly conditions or winds: "Gain does not obsess their minds and loss does not obsess their minds. Fame does not obsess their minds and disrepute does not obsess their minds. Blame does not obsess their minds and praise does not obsess their minds. Pleasure does not obsess their minds and pain does not obsess their minds. They're not attracted to gain or repelled by loss. They're not attracted to fame or repelled by disrepute. They're not attracted to praise or repelled by blame. Not attracted to pleasure or repelled by pain. Having thus discarded attraction and repulsion, they are freed from birth, from old age and death, from sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection and anguish. They are freed from suffering, I say."

So, having gone through these qualities—the quality of equanimity, how it's part of the seven factors of enlightenment, how we use it in our *vipassanā* practice, and these four worldly winds—how do we actually develop it as an exercise?

Very much the same as *mettā*, in fact exactly the same as *mettā*. You have certain well-wishings and you offer it to a benefactor and so on and so forth, and that's what I thought we would do now. And we'll just slip into the meditation. You can carry on doing this until we get to the refuges and precepts or just decide to do the vipassana whenever you think so.

So what I've got here are four adjectives, and you can formulate your own. You can add, you can take away. So the first one I put is "May I be calm." So this refers to physical relaxation, loosening body tensions, calming the heart with the out breath. Just relax. So that's the underpinning of equanimity.

"Peace-loving." Well, this refers to an attitude of always wanting to engender an underlying sense of safety and peacefulness.

"Open." This refers to an attitude of being able to receive other people's opinions and not see them as trying to indoctrinate us. It's just being open to other people's opinions. Our own opinions may be nuanced, may change, who knows? But it's not about clinging to our little "I'm right and everybody else is wrong." And to engage with people. I mean, these days when you look at the political situation, it's just A against B. There's no meeting place, and it's a matter of really just people relaxing around that.

And finally, "composed." This is a basic posture, a serene, unruffled poise.

So that's it. So "May I be calm, peace-loving, open and composed. May I be calm, peace-loving, open and composed."

So I'll guide us through the various qualities and then we'll go straight into the meditation.

So may I be calm, peace-loving, open and composed.

Calm, peace-loving, open and composed.

So we can bring to mind some of our benefactors. Those who are near and dear to us. Friends, people at work, whomever we're with. There's that character, there's that neutral person, someone we see but don't know, that category.

Turning towards ourselves. Come on, we may have some difficulties. Offering our goodwill to each other. Our equanimity. May we.

To all our neighbours and neighbourhood. To all the people in our country. All the peoples of Europe. All people on earth and finally to all beings in all directions.

Compassion and Its Subtle Enemies

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 28 min

In this deeply personal exploration of karuṇā (compassion), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the fourth brahmavihāra through vivid memories from his youth on the hippie trail in Calcutta. Drawing on the Buddha's own word anukampā—meaning 'trembling with' another's suffering—he distinguishes between sympathy and empathy while revealing compassion's subtle enemies: do-gooding, pity, empathy bias, codependency, and compassion fatigue.

The talk illuminates how genuine compassion arises not from a superior position but from authentic connection with suffering. Bhante discusses both passive and active modes of compassionate response, emphasizing the courage needed to simply be present with others' pain. He addresses practical challenges like maintaining emotional boundaries, avoiding burnout, and recognizing when helping becomes enabling.

The session concludes with guided compassion practice using traditional Pali blessings, extending loving concern through the six directions to all beings who suffer—from those facing illness and death to victims of oppression and even those who cause harm. This practice transforms our understanding of karuṇā from mere sentiment to profound spiritual cultivation.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So I've chosen to look at compassion. This is the last of our four *Brahmavihāra*, the dwelling places of the gods, of the highest gods, by which we mean these are the most beautiful mental states that we can achieve. We've done loving-kindness, done joy, done equanimity. So compassion is the last one.

I'd like to start with my own little story here. I went along the hippie trail around about the seventies and I ended up in Calcutta during the Indo-Pakistan war when Bangladesh got its liberation from West Pakistan. Every day for three weeks, when we were expecting bombers to come over, I used to go to this Sikh restaurant and on the opposite side of the road, there was a woman with a huge goitre under her chin. I passed that woman every day. I never gave her a penny.

One day I came back and just as I turned around the corner, there was a little girl there who must have been well over seven, undernourished, looked very young. She was squatted down chewing a dried out black banana skin. She had this self-possession to cover her sex, because all she had was this little dress. And I walked straight past her.

So I've got these two images from this callow youth, and they're very difficult for me to remember without a certain sense of pain. Of course, the reason the pain is there is not simply because of seeing this suffering, which I just had never seen before. I mean, there were sick people everywhere, lepers, people with elephantiasis. They were there on the pavement. What pains is that I didn't respond. I didn't put a penny in that woman's hand. She sat there all day, completely emotionless with her hand out like that. And I didn't go out and buy a banana for this little girl.

Here we have what happens to us: you feel that you haven't responded. You haven't responded from a compassionate heart for whatever reason. So it all begins with that connection, which we call empathy and sometimes sympathy.

I just want to make a little distinction there. This is an arbitrary distinction because these words are used in different ways. Sympathy these days has some suggestion of pity, but sympathy for me is when you have to imagine what the person is suffering. I've never been starving. I've been hungry, but then I've always had food. I've never been in a state where I'm actually starving, so all I can do is imagine what it must be like because I felt hungry. There's a connection there.

But when it comes to, say, refugees, I've never been a refugee. I haven't a clue what it means to suddenly up and out your home, to find yourself on the road without much money, having to buy your way, sometimes being attacked. So there's a point where there's sympathy where you have to imagine what the person is going through, and there's empathy where you've actually had an experience which connects you.

That's just a little distinction I want to make so that we're clear when we're sympathizing and when we're actually empathizing. Sometimes we think we're empathizing when actually we're imagining, which isn't a problem if it all leads to the same place, which is a compassionate act, a compassionate word. But I thought I'd hang on to that little definition just for clarity's sake.

The Buddha himself uses a word *anukampā*. The prefix *anu* suggests movement towards, and *kampā* actually means trembling. He says: whatever a teacher can do for his students out of *anukampā*, out of this connection with his students, I have done for you.

So this *anukampā* is that point where you have that sense in your own heart of the suffering of the other. It's that connection, whether it's imaginative sympathy or whether it's empathic connection. The other word we use is *karuṇā*, which actually has its root in doing. The word in Sanskrit means doing, but it was also used for holy, it was part of the rituals of the Vedas. So you get this word *karuṇā*, which is actually the action. You might call it the sacrifice or the sacrament.

When we have responded to somebody's suffering, no matter what it is, from the smallest to the most awful, there are two modes: one is passive and one is active. In the passive mode, it's often good enough just to be with the person, not even to say anything. An obvious case would be when the person is either extremely ill and is just there in bed and all you can do is actually accompany them. And of course, when somebody is dying.

What we come across when we have that situation is our sense of powerlessness. That's very difficult for us because we want to do something. But if we are sensitive enough to the situation and to the person, often it's good enough just to be with them, just to accompany them.

When it comes to compassionate action, when you're actually going to do something, our tendency is to try and overdo, to slip into the error of the do-gooder. We've all got it in us, which is when we want to do the good we want to do for your benefit, whether you want it or not. Of course, this really gets up people's noses.

It's a good idea to ask them what they want to do. Even if your suggestion is rejected and even if you know that your suggestion would actually be the better thing to do, we've got to pull back a bit and let the person who's suffering have the last say. When we do over-help like that, perhaps it's coming from some inner feeling of wanting to be esteemed, to be loved, all the usual rubbish that we suffer from.

It's often easier to say what a virtue is by saying what it isn't. So we know it's not do-gooding. These are reactions that we have when we come across suffering.

The first one would be in an extreme case where the person is really suffering. There you've got to have that sense of courage to be with them. It's very difficult if the person is really in a lot of pain, especially when they're dying. I read a book about this poor woman who was screaming every time towards the end of her life, and eventually the doctor decided to sedate her with the permission of the family. It often takes a bit of courage to be with somebody who's in real pain or suffering.

There are certain situations which might be a work situation, but it can be somebody you're looking after where you have reactions of disgust, where they're sick, where they're suffering from diarrhea, all the impurities of the body manifest. Somehow you have to recognize the disgust and yet still come from the heart of compassion.

We can often be caught unawares when somebody has asked us to do something and we feel messed about. I had my day carefully planned and now they want me to do this and that, especially within a family, and you can feel yourself being angry about that. Again it's being aware of these negative emotions that come up, these negative mental states, and still focusing on what you can do for the person.

Sometimes a person hurts themselves, an accident for instance, and you might be wanting to blame them. So stupid, how could you do that? I remember I once had an assistant here who put the ladder up against the gutter on the decking. The ladder slipped and he just fell flat onto his face almost. Luckily, there was nothing but a bit of a bruise. But I could hear myself saying, well, that was stupid, wasn't it? I didn't say it, no. I then went up and made sure that he was okay. But you've got to be careful.

Of course, if it's somebody close to you, you can feel quite overcome by grief and that can have an immobilizing effect. Again it's just resting with that and trying to come above it and to connect with the person. That way I think we can keep these emotional states at bay. You might have to deal with them afterwards, but not while you're in some situation with them.

You can understand things like panic when, say, a child hurts itself and the parents just panic. Obviously that doesn't help, doesn't help the child, but it's again hopefully bringing that mindfulness, that connection with our own hearts and that reaction and then to rise above it and respond.

There's pity. That's another one which isn't particularly nice. That's coming from a superior position, often because we're trying to guard ourselves against actually connecting with what's happening. It's all "poor thing. I feel so sorry for you. I know how you feel." Often we find that that's because we're a bit afraid of facing our own possible sickness and eventual death.

There can be a sense of relief, like when somebody has a serious illness, as we have in our family, and you can first of all feel the fear. Well, if it's in the family, I might get it. And then a sense of relief: well, it's not me, is it? We have to understand that as just basically coming from this false view of self. Not to get all guilty about that. It's just a reaction. But again, it's this ability to rise above it.

These I've picked up from various things that I've read. There's what's known as empathy bias. So if a nurse, for instance, is in a ward, but has a rather particular connection with one of the patients, then you might find the nurse visiting them slightly more often and not really heeding what somebody is calling from the other side of the ward because they don't particularly like them. So there's always that going on.

Codependency. That's a bit of a problem because if a person is getting a lot of self-esteem from helping, it's very difficult for them to stop. Often they're feeding the person who's actually suffering so that they don't have to stop doing good. I knew a mother whose son was a drug addict and she was always helping him, paying for his rent when he didn't have it and buying food for him. I said to her, "Well, what you're doing is just feeding his habit financially." She says, "Yes, but I'm his mother." She couldn't get over that feeling of guilt if she stopped helping her son, but it would have been the best thing to do.

I think you have to be careful when you are dealing with a long situation of somebody whom you're looking after, perhaps. That's your emotional boundary: to know when you're being taken advantage of, even perhaps abused. So that's something else to be careful about.

Sometimes we find ourselves becoming very involved in a compassionate charity. I'm thinking of people who get very much involved with refugees, on the side completely of the refugees, and they can have a lack of recognizing what it's doing to them. You get that burnout and then a resentment from it, what they call compassion fatigue. I think that's easy to fall into because there's so much bad news. Everywhere you go, there's just bad news, and you can feel your heart going out to various situations and various people. But in the end, you've got to recognize that enough's enough. Stop feeding all the bad news and try and find some good news.

Sometimes overemphasizing that helping people and becoming too attached to somebody might blind us to the fact that we might be, in a sense, not allowing them to reflect upon their own situation and take moral stance about themselves. I'm thinking of ADHD, that hyperactive impulsive behavior. Somebody might, for instance, just get into gambling because of it, and we're being over-compassionate. We're not actually... the problem with medicalizing something is that the person then drops their moral responsibility towards themselves. "Oh well, I'm ADHD" or "I'm on the whatever it is." So it's a case of also recognizing that we might be making excuses for them. We might be therefore avoiding difficult conversations.

All these things are things to be wary of. It's not as though we have to go around with a great big list. Every time we help somebody, you've got to have your list out just in case you're doing something wrong. It's more in the sense of recognizing that when we are being compassionate, there's probably some undertone that's going on there, coming from this wrong sense of ego, this wrong sense of self.

But there are of course great virtues to be had from compassion, and one of them is patience, which we've dealt with.

One of the telltales, I think, of compassion is that you're actually deeply happy about it. This is not the happiness of joy or the happiness of buying an ice cream. This is that sense of an inner worthiness, an inner sense that you're doing the right thing. It's a deeper sense of joy, which I think you've all experienced at some point when we've helped people.

So that's the sign of compassion. We're not supposed to be suffering when you're being compassionate. That would be ridiculous. In fact, this confusion came up when I was in a particular meditation center where they had eventually – it was lay people discussing – they eventually came to the conclusion that the Buddha could not have been compassionate because he had been suffering. How ridiculous that is. So we have to be careful there.

There's the Tibetan practice of *tonglen*, which is all about making that connection with others. Pema Chödrön has a very good meditation up on YouTube, an introduction shall we say. I just want to mention this because it will appear eventually as a tip. It'll be the next one actually, the one for October. And there you'll be able to pick up these connections.

But I do want to mention this one point where the Buddha came across a monk who was actually suffering from dysentery. So he was completely in his excrement. When he saw the sick monk and asked him, "Well, who's attending to you?" He said, "Nobody." And then he said, "Why?" He says, "Well, I don't attend to monks, so the monks don't attend to me."

So he and Ānanda looked after this monk and then he gathered the monks together and he said to them: "Look, you have no mother, you have no father who might tend to you. If you don't tend to one another, then who will tend to you? So whoever would tend to me should tend to the sick."

So that is making them make a connection to the Buddha himself. Whoever is attending to somebody who's sick, you are attending to a Buddha. Now you might not take that literally as the Buddha himself, but to the Buddha within, to that within us which is transcendent.

And then he goes on and gives a whole list of people who should be looking after them. So he was involved in that.

So now I'm going on a bit, I'm afraid. What I want to do now is just do a bit of compassion practice. And I'm going to actually share this with you.

Okay, so these are the blessings that we do here in the morning *puja*. The idea is that as we go through this list, we can bring up a phrase which expresses our compassion. The one that's normally used is "may your sufferings lessen, may all your sufferings come to an end." That would come out of the *Visuddhimagga*, this compendium of Buddhism written by Buddhaghosa in the Middle Ages. Or you can make up some other phrase that makes sense to you, but just for this it might be good just to stay with this one here. And then as I go through the list, just keep repeating that, and then we'll do the six directions. After that we'll just slip into the meditation. You can continue doing it or return to *vipassanā*.

So if we just settle for a moment.

We can bring to mind anyone we know who's having a hard time. At this moment there are people who are suffering from severe physical or mental disease. There are people in the process of dying and those who have died and left grieving family, relatives and friends. There are people going hungry, homeless and destitute. There are those struggling with personal and interpersonal difficulties.

There are all the victims of prejudices, all those caught up in wars and repressive regimes, and those being tortured. There are all the criminals, oppressors and all who willingly do harm. All those suffering from natural disasters and climate crisis. All sentient beings have been cruelly treated and unnecessarily slaughtered. And all who find life meaningless.

Now we can continue with the ten directions. To all beings in front of us who are suffering. All beings behind us. All beings to our left. All beings to our right. All beings below us. All beings above us. And to all beings in all directions.

So feel free to continue this practice or just sit in *vipassanā*.

Good Friendship, Good Companionship, Good Comradeship is the Whole of the Spiritual Life

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 18 min

In this illuminating dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines one of the Buddha's most striking declarations: that good friendship, good companionship, and good comradeship constitute the entirety of the spiritual life. Drawing from the exchange between the Buddha and his attendant Ānanda, Bhante explores the profound nature of kalyāṇamittatā (spiritual friendship) and its central role in developing the Noble Eightfold Path.

The teaching gains deeper resonance through connection with Ubuntu, the South African philosophy encapsulated in "I am what I am because of who we all are." Bhante demonstrates how this interconnected understanding illuminates the Buddha's words in the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), particularly the practice of observing phenomena "internally, externally, and both internally and externally."

Through practical examples spanning our physical bodies, mental states, and conceptual frameworks, Bhante reveals how we exist in constant communication and mutual influence with those around us. This understanding transforms our appreciation of spiritual friendship from mere companionship to recognition of our fundamental interdependence. The talk offers both newcomers and experienced practitioners fresh insight into how our relationships shape our spiritual development and why cultivating wholesome spiritual friendships is essential for progress on the path to Awakening.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsaṃbuddhassa

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsaṃbuddhassa

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsaṃbuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

This evening I thought we'd tackle this advice that the Buddha gives us. As you know, Ānanda was the Buddha's attendant for the last twenty years of his life. He was his cousin and he would listen to all the Buddha's talks, and he had a contract with the Buddha when he took on this work that the Buddha would always relate to him anything he'd said when he wasn't there. He had this phenomenal audio memory.

He would say things, give his opinion, and the Buddha would gently correct him. So one was that he had now really come to understand dependent origination. And the Buddha said, "Oh no, Ānanda, dependent origination is deep, profound," et cetera, et cetera. Well, he made the same mistake when it came to the spiritual life. Ānanda said that he thought good friendship, good companionship, and good comradeship were half the spiritual life.

And the Buddha said, "Oh no, Ānanda, it is the entire spiritual life, Ānanda, that is good friendship, good companionship, good comradeship. When a person has a good friend, a good companion and a good comrade, it is to be expected that they will develop and cultivate the Noble Eightfold Path." In other words, your *kalyāṇamitra*, your spiritual friend.

So if we just look at those three things with arbitrary definitions of these different words: If we take good companionship, a companion is usually somebody who travels with you. So really, it's those who are closest to you - your spouse, your partner, your very close friend. And you can understand that, let's take partners for instance. If both of them are actually on the same path, that's a tremendous refuge, isn't it? Even if one is a Tibetan and the other one is a Theravāda, I'm sure they can find some support for each other. So there's that intimacy, an intimate relationship. If that intimate relationship exists and both people are actually on the same path, that's obviously a great support.

On a wider level, we talk about good friendship - they're all the people whom you know, apart from those who are close to you. And I think some of you will have found, like I did, that as I moved into the Dhamma, I became more and more involved. I found that I was losing my interest in the theatre, the local semi-professional theatre that we had in Birmingham at the time. And eventually I stopped going. I didn't actually say goodbye to anybody. When I look back, I didn't say goodbye to anybody and tell them what I was doing. I just faded out, you might say. And interestingly enough, I can't remember meeting any of them again. And that's part of that movement towards a spiritual life for me, and you might have found that also to be true of yourselves.

When it comes to comradeship, for me the word comrade is associated with the communist party - "Comrade Boris" - I'm not talking about big Boris, of course. So that gives us a feel that we're in something that is much bigger than just our personal relationships and it's something that's very grand. So Buddhism is of course a world religion and it's not only got so many million people who are following the Buddhist path, it also has a massive history, two and a half thousand years. And I think what that does when

you reflect on it, it gives you tremendous confidence. You would have thought by now, after 2,500 years, that people would have sussed out whether the Buddha was telling the truth or not, whether it was just a big tale.

So when I used to contemplate this about friendship being the entire spiritual life, it never matched up for me. I couldn't quite work out why it should be the entire spiritual life. But then, of course, I came across Ubuntu. Now, some of you will know it as the open source operating system on Linux. But that's not what I'm actually referring to. Ubuntu is a South African philosophy from, say, Zimbabwe downwards. So the Zulus and the Xhosa people, all those people have this philosophy of Ubuntu and you can encapsulate it in one small sentence: "I am what I am because of who we all are." I am what I am because of who we all are. In other words, I am my relationships. And I remember Krishnamurti saying that actually.

So in the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse, the Buddha actually, in the four sections - one on the body, one on feeling, one on mental states, and one on the teachings of the Dhamma - there is this recurrent phrase that goes through it. They meditate observing an aspect of the body or feelings or mental states or teaching of the Dhamma internally, externally, both internally and externally. And it's this last one that I want to centre on. In other words, the Buddha is asking us to be aware of ourselves, aware of others, but also this interaction that is constantly happening between us.

If we just take one or two examples: this body, for instance. This body that we've got isn't something we chose. I definitely would have chosen something better, I think. I just happened to end up with this body because of all the genetic history that came before it. And this body expresses that genetic history. It's part and parcel of that specific genetic history.

When it comes to the body, the food I eat, not only is it grown by others and sold by others and often cooked by others, but the actual recipes that we use are usually made up by other people. So there's this constant flow of information about what's nice to eat, what makes a good meal. It's the same with clothes and fashions - the fashions change. Who changes them? Some bright spark has an idea and then after that we're all wearing different clothes. I mean, in my own life, my pseudo-hippie stage, I went around with flowery pants.

When we look at our dwellings, these are all designed by other people, all the furniture we have in it. And of course, this becomes obvious when you look at different cultures and then you see different food, different clothes, different ideas of how houses should look. And finally, medicines and care. All these medicines are produced by other people. They're coming into my body. They affect me.

So we get this idea that this body isn't static in any way, not physically. The water that we're drinking, here we've got this chlorine in it. The air that we're breathing is full of CO₂ because of people using fossil fuels and all that. So you can see that the body itself is in a process of communication with the world around it.

And in terms of other areas, we're actually just expressions of our culture. The problem is that this sense of self seems so static, it seems so real. You don't seem to think you change except when it's obvious that you change. You get this sense of substantiality. But then when you contemplate it, you realize it's just a concept. And the concept holds us in present time, as it were, but unfortunately creates a wrong relationship.

We've got this word proprioception. Proprio means self, perception of self, perception of the body. So you've only got to watch how your body changes, for instance, with whatever you're sitting on - a chair, a metal bench, an armchair, lying on the bed, doing yoga on the floor. We're constantly having to negotiate with the environment around us.

And when you're walking with somebody, you have to be in step. If they're walking too fast, you tell them to slow down. If you're walking too slow, they tell you to hurry up. So there's this constant negotiation going on.

If you catch yourself, for instance, with somebody who has authority over you - it could be a policeman - suddenly you feel guilty anyway, even if you've not done anything wrong. But you'll notice that when you're with somebody who has authority over you or whom you respect, who is an authority, whether you like it or not, you'll shrink your body. That's how we express that respect or deference. And in the same way, when we feel ourselves to be in authority or in authority over others, you'll lift the body up, you'll pull your shoulders back. And all that's to do with communication.

I don't want to spend too much time on this because there was a video I came across about this poor young kid whose parents thought had an evil spirit, so as a toddler they put him in with the chickens and basically he became a chicken. When he got too big for the chicken coop they put him in an old people's home and tied him to a bed. A woman called Elizabeth Clayton - you can see it, it's on YouTube, there are two videos. One, you see him as a young man and later on as much more socially interactive. But he's actually standing there like a bird. He's got his shoulders like this as though they're flopping wings. It's awful. And he will never be able to speak, never be able to communicate. And what that does for me is it puts in sharp relief how much we owe to our relationships.

Our mental states are constantly - we'll notice that our mental states are often affected by the people we're with. So if you're with people who are depressed, who feel down, it pulls you down. I mean, you might try to lift yourself up but in the end, you might give in. Whereas with people who are in a happy state, who are bubbly, it just lifts you up. So there's this constant communication at the heart level.

And there's also a communication at perceptual level, at a conceptual level. Take something like big concepts like free speech or democracy or something like that. You can see that what we read in the newspapers, what we hear people say on the television and things like that, what we discuss amongst ourselves, constantly our concepts are beginning to change, they move. And what's understood there, there's an actual word for it, it's called apperception. So for instance, we all have a concept of an apple. But every time you see an apple, that concept is slightly changed. And so it is with these rather more abstract concepts that we have. And you can see these change over time.

I was just thinking about kings and queens since we have one here and other countries too. But there was a time when you could insult a king or somebody like that. It was lèse-majesté and you'd find yourself being whipped or chucked in a jail or worse. And if you think about Putin and Xi Jinping and Kim Jong-un, you can see that depending on the country you're in or where you're at, your concept of how a country ought to be ruled changes. There are people who will support Putin and Xi Jinping and all that. And all these concepts we're absorbing and we are doing our own little interpretation of them, but we're in constant communication.

So I think that sums up this statement by the Buddha. And I just want to return to it. So this is what the Buddha says: the entire spiritual life is good friendship, good companionship and good comradeship. And when a person has a good friend, a good companion, a good comrade, it is to be expected they will develop and cultivate the Noble Eightfold Path.

And in his life, you remember, he had these six companions who probably followed him from those times when he was practicing those absorption states to when he was practicing the ascetic practices of almost starvation really. And remember when he left them, they didn't want to know him. As far as they were concerned, he'd gone soft. And then when he came back, it took them a while to realize that maybe he had changed. And there was a conversation there which comes out when he talks about his new understanding and he asks them, "Have you ever heard me speak like this before?" So right there within the Buddha's life, he had these six companions.

And if we then understand that within the concept of Ubuntu, I am what I am because of who we all are - I am my relationships - so the Buddha is trying to urge us, or at least trying to make us understand that the people around us are our inspiration, they're our support. But they're also supposed to be checks. A good friend tells you when you're not doing things as you ought to be doing them.

So that's what I was centring on. And I just felt that I had a better concept of what the Buddha was talking about when I came across this teaching or this philosophy of Ubuntu.

So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused confusion, and that by your development of good friendship, you will complete the Noble Eightfold Path and be fully liberated sooner rather than later.

The Five Constant Contemplations

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 24 min

In this profound teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the five themes for regular contemplation outlined by the Buddha in the Aṅguttara Nikāya (AN 5.57). These contemplations address our universal human condition: aging, illness, death, separation from all we hold dear, and our ownership of karma. Rather than morbid reflections, these practices serve to undermine our intoxications with health, youth, and life that lead to unwholesome conduct.

Bhante explains how proper contemplation works—not as mere intellectual thinking, but as a heart-practice that allows us to deeply digest difficult truths until resistance dissolves into acceptance. He provides practical phrases and methods for each contemplation, emphasizing how this universal human condition offers strange comfort rather than despair. The teaching includes the Buddha's own verse on how these reflections led to his renunciation and awakening.

These contemplations directly support the path to liberation by abandoning the fetters and uprooting underlying unwholesome tendencies. The session concludes with guided contemplative phrases for each of the five themes, offering practitioners concrete tools for this transformative practice.

Namo tassa bhagavato hara-hatto samma-sambuddhassa Namō tassa bhagavato hara-hatto samma-sambuddhassa Namō tassa bhagavato hara-hatto samma-sambuddhassa
—Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So this is our November moon, a little earlier than November but even so it's a November moon. There are 13 this year. I've pre-recorded this because I'm on retreat this year and I'm very grateful to Mark that he's going to run it through for us.

If you remember last November, this lugubrious month, I devoted it to our favourite party topic: death. And we saw how powerful that contemplation was, according to the Buddha, leading directly to liberation. I'm going to say something about how that works in terms of contemplation. But this is only one of a set of five. And we find a discourse in the Numerical Sayings in section five, number 57, which talks about the Five Constant or Regular Contemplations.

So the first thing he enumerates, the five contemplations: "There are these five themes that should often be reflected upon by a woman or a man, by a householder or one gone forth." One gone forth is a monastic. What five? "I am subject to aging, not exempt from aging. I'm subject to illness, not exempt from illness. I'm subject to death, not exempt from death. I must be parted and separated from everyone and everything dear and agreeable to me. I am the owner of my *kamma*, my actions of body, speech and mind." That's the *kamma* here, not the consequence. "The heir to my *kamma*, I have *kamma* as my origin, *kamma* as my relative, *kamma* as my resort. I will be heir to whatever *kamma* actions I do, good or bad."

Now we're going to leave *kamma* till next November because there's too much here. But even so, you can still contemplate that.

Then he tells us how we should reflect upon this. They should often reflect, "I'm subject to illness. I'm not exempt from illness." In a state of health, beings are intoxicated with their health. And when they're intoxicated with their health, they engage in misconduct of body, speech, and mind. So in other words, when we feel okay, we tend to push the body. Just think about our eating habits and the difference between living to eat and eating to live.

"I'm subject to aging. I'm not exempt from aging." In their youth, beings are intoxicated with their youth. And when they are intoxicated with their youth, they engage in misconduct of body, speech and mind. Now, of course, it's not only the youth who are intoxicated with youth. This is a very youth culture. So everybody is intoxicated with youth — you know, Botox. Old people are useless, a weight on society. And of course, 60 is the new 40. So it's really getting beyond that and accepting our age as it comes towards us.

"I'm subject to death. I'm not exempt from death." During their lives, beings are intoxicated with life. And when they're intoxicated with life, they engage in misconduct by body, speech and mind. So of course what we try to do is live to create as many great experiences we can. We want to suck as much joy out of life as we can, squeeze the stone for more excitement. So, of course, this leads to unfortunate behaviour. And we only got to think about now a societal denial of death.

"I must be parted from everyone and everything dear and agreeable to me." Beings have desire and craving in regard to these people and things that are dear and agreeable. And excited by this craving, they engage in misconduct of body, speech and mind.

So one little exercise that I suggest you might do is to create two lists: one list of all the things you would not want to lose, want to be robbed of, and the other list of all the people that you wouldn't want to lose or who you wouldn't want them to go away or disappear. And then just go through and just catch your relationship to those things.

Remember that when it comes to things, we can't actually own them. I mean, that's a legal fiction. What we can do is use them. So if somebody steals my mobile phone, I go around moping and moaning about this dreadful thief who has taken my phone. It's no longer my phone, is it? It belongs to the thief. So I instead have to wish that he uses that phone to good purpose and that if he sells it on, that money be used for the benefit of himself and other people. So that's the way we ought to look at it. People are different, of course, and that's a different area we don't want to go into this evening.

And then of course there's the reflection on *kamma*: "I am the owner of my actions, heir to my *kamma*. I have *kamma* as my origin, *kamma* as my relative, *kamma* as my resort. I will be heir to whatever *kamma*, good or bad, that I do." People engage in misconduct by body, speech and mind because we're not always conscious of the effects of what we might be doing. But as I say, we shall leave that for more detail next November.

And this is how he wants us to reflect. "I am not the only one who is subject to illness, not exempt from illness. All beings that come and go, that pass away and undergo rebirth, are subject to illness, not exempt from illness." Now that sort of contemplation I find personally rather comforting. You know, it's just to know that you're not on your own, that this is the big picture. Everybody falls ill sometime or other.

And it's the same with aging. "I'm not the only one subject to aging, not exempt from aging. All beings that come and go, that pass away and undergo rebirth, are subject to aging. None are exempt from aging." And that's all beings. That's even our little pet rats who run over our property. And again, it's a strange comfort.

It's the same with death. "I'm not the only one who's subject to death, not exempt from death. All beings that come and go, that pass away, undergo rebirth, are subject to death. None are exempt from death." So I don't know, there's a comfort in looking back and seeing your mother and father, if they have died, of the generations before — your grandfathers and grandmothers, your uncles and aunts and all that. And if they can go, then of course I can go. That's not a problem. So it's a case of, I don't know, feeling somewhat comfort that you're just part of that process.

I mean, I remember I saw a cartoon once where there's an elderly lady on her deathbed, surrounded by her friends. And she's asking, "Why me? Why not one of you?" And of course, just consider if we were the only ones to die. You know, everybody else is alive. Everybody else is mucking about and having a great time. And just me, I've got to die. Well, it wouldn't be fair, would it?

"I am not the only one who has to be parted and separated from everyone and everything dear and pleasing to me. All beings that come and go, pass away and undergo rebirth, must be parted and separated from everyone and everything dear and pleasing." So this of course is renunciation. This is of course being able to let go and to bring ourselves back to the reality of our relationships with things and, of course, more touchingly with people. It's really about accepting the way it is.

And then finally, "I'm not the only one who is owner of one's *kamma*, heir to one's *kamma*, who has *kamma* as one's origin, *kamma* as one's relative, *kamma* as one's resort, who will be heir to whatever *kamma*, good or bad, that one does. All beings that come and go, that pass away and undergo rebirth, are owners of their *kamma*, heirs of their *kamma*, have *kamma* as their origin and also their resort."

Now, what he says is this: as they often reflect on this theme, the path is generated. They pursue the path, develop it and cultivate it. And as they do so, the fetters are entirely abandoned and the underlying tendencies are uprooted.

So what he's saying is that by practising these sorts of practices, we are undermining all our delusion. And when it comes to the fetters, these are wrong view of self, sceptical doubt, clinging to mere rules and rituals as if they're enough to become liberated. And that's what you gain when you enter the stream, the first level of attainment. But sensual craving and ill will don't go until the third attainment. And then finally in the fourth attainment, the *arahat*, the fully liberated — craving or really wanting these beautiful *jhānic* states, both the lower four and the upper four; conceit, this business of "I am better, I am worse, I'm equal to"; restlessness, which really includes all the defilements that we've had before, but now are just so fine that they are experienced as restless; and finally, the whole of ignorance, delusion disappears, upon which all our suffering was grounded.

The *anusaya*, these underlying tendencies, they are these subconscious, unwholesome habits. So we know this from our Freudian psychology, that there is underneath us all this unresolved stuff. And given the right impetus, given the right circumstance, it'll pop up. And hence we have embarrassing Freudian slips.

Let me just, first of all, read his verse. Now, I've written this out in just straight sentences, because then it's much more directly understandable than when I read a verse, which is somebody else's translation, trying to keep the verse of the Buddha.

So this is what he said, or this is what he said to himself at some point in his training: "It terrifies ordinary people to contemplate sickness, aging and death, and that they are inescapable. If I find myself detesting such people, it would not be proper for me, for I have the same flaws. Contemplating this, while knowing that there's no acquisitiveness in *Nibbāna* — you can't take anything with you to *Nibbāna* — I overcame these obsessions with health, youth and even life. I saw safety in renunciation, so I put effort into the practice and realised *Nibbāna*. It is no longer possible for me to indulge in sensual pleasures. Now I have fulfilled the spiritual path. I shall not come back again."

So now contemplation, how does it work? So first of all, it's not thinking. We use thought, but it's really to get in touch with our feelings. And when you get in touch with your feelings, let's say about death, which is an easy one — an easy one to start with because it's so heavy — you find a phrase which touches you. And what I mean by touch is that it frightens you a bit or you feel you don't want to go there. The more you don't want to repeat that phrase, the more you have to repeat it. And you just keep repeating it into the heart until you feel there's a becoming, a sort of acceptance of it.

And when it's fully digested, when the reality of what you're saying is fully digested and there's no more aversion, and there's no more fear of whatever you're saying, then you'll find that there comes this sense of relief. This is the way it is. And with it, you might find yourself even smiling. And that's what we have to do. We have to find phrases which move us, phrases which push us a little to accept things.

Now, it might be memories. It might be something we've remembered. Perhaps we remember seeing a friend's corpse or a parent's corpse, anything which would bring up for us our fear of death. And the same is true for falling sick. Everybody has a particular illness, I think, that they're afraid of. Everybody is, to some extent, hypochondriac — either some terrible paralysing disease, or you pick up a tick or something when you're walking out in the fields and you're afraid of the illnesses and parasites you can get from those things. And there's, of course, dementia. That's a background fear, I think, to anybody who approaches my age anyway. Anyone over 70, you know, you begin to forget things. You think, "Oh, that must be the first sign."

So you have to allow these things to come up into your mind and you're using the word, you're using the memory, but really what you're doing is you're getting in contact with your heart's feeling about it. And so you just keep repeating it gently, staying with the heart's reaction, wait for that resistance to disappear and then it's digested. Now

that's not the end of it. You'll find another sentence which brings up much the same thing, but over time we're getting used to the idea that we may fall sick, we will definitely be growing old — even if you're very young, you're still growing old — and we will die.

And we will be separated from everything that is dear and agreeable to us. And we are owners of our *kamma*. Whatever we've done in the past will manifest.

So what I've done here is I've put up some phrases, some stuff on the screen. So I'm going to share screen with you now. And what we're going to do is go through them and then I'm going to leave the main page up there for maybe two, maybe three minutes. And if you carry on with that contemplation into our normal meditation time and then if you wish you can always go back to the breath, that's not a problem. But at least here we can start.

So here we see some of the five regular ones. I've just been talking about this — how to repeat it and get it into our hearts.

So sickness is a mini death, the preparation for death. The body manifests its vulnerability. There is discomfort, pain, and there's also some disability. And this undermines our obsession with health and beauty.

So you might find a phrase that repeats something like: "Sickness is unpreventable. I will probably fall sick. This body is of a nature to fall ill. This body has not gone beyond sickness."

Then there's aging, which is, you might say, a progressive dying. And this contemplation undermines our intoxication with youth, trying to stay young forever. Abandon that. "Aging is inevitable. This body is subject to aging. This body has not gone beyond aging. This body is now in a process of aging."

So one of these sentences, or find your own sentence, find your own way of touching your fear and aversion about aging.

Death, of course, is certain. Life is uncertain. That's straight from the Buddha. Sometimes saying the obvious gets through the thick shell of not wanting to know. "Life is uncertain. Death is certain. Death is inescapable. Everyone must die. The remainder of our lifespan is decreasing continually." So this is what I say — you know, every time we have breakfast, to remind ourselves: this is one less breakfast in this lifetime. When we've had a superb lunch somewhere, this is one less superb lunch in this lifetime. When we've had an amazing meal with friends out in the restaurants and all that, this is one less amazing meal with friends I shall have in a restaurant.

"Death will come regardless of whether or not I've made time for practice." Now that's a killer. You've got to really meditate on that — that, you know, it's no good as you're dying saying, "Oh, if only, if only I had." We don't know when we're going to die. Human life expectancy is uncertain. There are many causes of death. The human body is very fragile. Only the practice of Dharma can help us at the time of death. Our wealth cannot help us. Our loved ones cannot help us. Our own body cannot help us. Death is inescapable. This body is subject to death. This body has not gone beyond death. This body will die.

And then there's the second one: "I must be parted and separated from everyone and everything dear and agreeable to me." Well that's something again we can make these two lists in our own time. But you can't take anything with you. That's the problem.

And then contemplation of *kamma*: "I own my actions. I inherit the results of my actions. I'm born of my actions. I form relations through my actions. I live dependent on my actions. And whatever I do, for good or for ill, I will inherit the results." Actions here is actions of body, speech mainly, but of course it all begins in the mind.

So I'm just going to put these on the screen.

There they are. Let me make it a bit bigger. One second. There we go. I can just roll that up a bit. Can you all see that? Come on, that's it. Right, so there are your contemplations.

What I'm going to do is leave this for two minutes, and I will now hope that this little homily will have been of some use to you, that I've not caused confusion, and that you will, by your severe practice of these five contemplations, arrive at the goal we're all striving for sooner rather than later.

Retreat Start: Standing and Walking Meditation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 55 min

In this foundational retreat session, Bhante Bodhidhamma guides practitioners through a complete meditation sequence beginning with standing meditation and transitioning into sitting practice. The session starts with establishing proper posture and body awareness, systematically scanning from the soles of the feet to the top of the head, cultivating what he describes as the 'bubble of consciousness' - our immediate field of experience.

The teaching emphasizes five of the seven factors of awakening (bojjhaṅga): Right Awareness (sammā sati), concentration as 'steadiness of attention,' effort, tranquility, and equanimity. Bhante introduces the Mahasi Sayadaw method of noting practice, using words like 'rising, falling' for breath awareness and mental noting for mind-wandering states.

The session progressively guides practitioners to investigate the three characteristics of existence: impermanence (anicca) - observing how everything arises and passes away; unsatisfactoriness (dukkha) - examining how our desires create suffering; and not-self (anattā) - recognizing the distinction between observer and observed. Practical instructions include maintaining proper posture, working with sleepiness and restlessness, and developing the objective stance of the vipassanā practitioner. The session concludes with guidance on reflecting upon one's meditation experience and making commitments for future practice.

We can start the standing meditation. It takes about 10 to 15 minutes, and if that's too long for you we'll just sit down.

Standing, make sure you feel grounded, balanced, lifting up through the spine to the top of the head. Standing tall, spend a moment now relaxing the brow, eyes looking downward unfocused. The jaw—is there any tension there? If so, just waggle it about a bit or clench the jaw and relax. Shoulders. Any tension there? If so, give them a good squeeze. Hands joined in front or by the side, whatever's comfortable.

So just acknowledge the posture. Energy running up the spine to the top of the head. Everything else just hanging off. Relax.

Draw your attention now to the soles of your feet. What can you feel down there? Can you isolate the sensations of pressure? Can you isolate the sensations of warmth or coolness? What about the more subtle sensations that tell you what you're standing on?

The sponginess of carpets, the hardness of wood? Can you isolate areas of the soles where the sensations are neutral? Can you get in contact with those around the instep maybe?

Becoming aware of how the sensations are continuously changing as the body rebalances itself. And just acknowledge that these sensations arise whether we want them to or not. They're not under our direct control.

So let's take our time. Let's come up the body, see what we can feel both on the surface and the inside of the body, and be aware of areas that seem to be devoid of feeling, just empty.

When you get to the abdomen, can you feel the sensations caused by the breath there? The rise and fall? Is there any tension?

Coming up into the stomach area, can you feel the breath there? Is it more prominent? Is there any tension there?

Moving up into the chest. Can you feel the breath there? Is that more prominent? Do you have a shallow breath? Any tensions? Feel the heartbeat?

Shoulders still relaxed. The jaw. The brow.

When you get to the scalp, scan it like you did the soles of your feet. What can you feel up there?

Now without moving your eyes, just become aware of the colours and shapes ahead of you. Any sounds? If you're in a quiet room, it might just be the sound of the electrical equipment or your body humming in your ears. What's the atmosphere of the room you're in like? Can you sense the presence of those around you or near you?

So your attention is completely out there. Now at the same time, bring in the in here—the feet, the breath, sensations in the body both inside and outside. This is the bubble of our consciousness. This is the world we are actually experiencing moment after moment, being created by this complex organism. We can't get outside it, underneath it, above it. This is it. This is the world as we experience it. This is our universe. And we're always at the centre of it.

So we may as well relax. Relax into this present moment, wide awake. And just allow the attention to move to whatever draws it. Something you see, now something you hear, now something you feel. Just hang loose within that globe.

Relaxing, abiding in the present moment, wide awake. In this mode, just being, we can let go of ideas of achieving something—that's doing, doing something now for some future result. But here in this mode, just being, this is the result. There's no reason for being. It just is.

Relaxing, dwelling in the present moment, wide awake. In this mode, just being, there's only this ever-presenting moment. There's no past, there's no future, just this moment here and now. So there's no reason to plan, even looking forward to anything. Doesn't matter. We're not going anywhere in this mode. We're always arriving.

Relaxing, inhabiting the present moment, wide awake. In this mode we're sitting back within ourselves. We're not reacting, not responding, just watching, feeling, experiencing. And the world is just arising and passing away because we're not engaged. We don't have to present somebody, be a person, a personality. We can be anonymous.

Relaxing, abiding in the present moment, wide awake, achieving nothing, going nowhere, being nobody.

In this mode we're developing five of the seven factors that lead to liberation. There's the awareness, of course, and there is that steadiness of attention—a phrase I prefer. Concentration, which I think makes us feel tight. It's just the effort needed to maintain steadiness of attention. A sense of calmness in that steadiness, even if the body feels restless and the heart agitated. The watcher, the observer, is calm.

And then there's the quality of equanimity. The dictionary says this is a balanced mind, but it should be a balanced mind and heart. Just letting go of holding on to views and opinions, be completely open-minded. And the heart, to let go of its prejudices, its fears, its aversions, its preferences. Open-hearted. Open-hearted and open-minded.

When these are established, we can bring in that curiosity specifically around the three characteristics of existence: impermanence, how we create suffering, and not self.

So this is the base. You can always return to it in sitting and in daily life. And in daily life, to maintain this poise stops us from being carried away by emotions. You've had a phone call, you've finished a piece of work, you've been out and about and you feel anxious, irritated, overexcited. But if you can just stop after every action, after every piece of work, after every conversation and let the heart empty itself, then in the clarity and calmness you can see the next intention. We can decide whether it's wholesome or skilful or otherwise.

If it is unwholesome and unskillful, we just stay still with that energy until it dies away, or at least begins to die away, and so it doesn't have such a hold on us. If it's skillful, of course, we empower it. Just in this very simple way we can better our habits and improve our personalities. But it takes this degree of attention.

Our next intention is to sit. So let us now begin to practise in the way the Mahāsi Sayadaw would have us: by slowing everything down and becoming aware of the tiniest movements. We can begin to use noting words to keep the attention tethered to the object and stop it wandering off into fantasies. Moving, stretching, lifting, placing, lowering. Taking our time, aware of all the movements it takes to get this body into a sitting posture. Intending to sit.

Make sure the posture is the expression of the awakened one, like a good statue. Lift up from the lower abdomen, the muscles in the lower back. When you do this you will feel the breath in the abdomen much more clearly, and then lift up the spine to the top of the head. Spend the initial moments relaxing the brow, eyes gently closed, the jaw, shoulders, and hands on your lap, whatever feels comfortable.

Acknowledging the posture: energised up the spine, everything else relaxed. If in our sitting the body begins to slump, just make the intention: intending to lift, lifting, lifting. If the body becomes tense: intending to relax, relaxing, relaxing.

Draw the attention now to the breath at the abdomen, or whatever you feel it most, using a noting word: rising, rising, falling, falling. If you're established at the nostrils and don't want to move to the abdomen: in, in, out, out. Get in touch with the breath, the feel of it. Just relax the attention onto those feelings.

If the mind is wandering, when you wake up out of it, really recognise and acknowledge what it's doing. Worrying, worrying. Planning, planning. And draw the attention away and bring it back to the breath and determine to stay there.

Feeling sleepy or tired, just lift the spine, open the eyes just a little. And if the sleepiness is still there you can open them wide, but keep the attention inward. Just relaxing the attention on the sensations caused by the breath, allowing those neutral sensations to bring silence to the mind, calmness to the heart, stillness to the body.

If the mind is wandering, when you wake up out of it, really recognise and acknowledge what it is doing. We're interested in the mood, emotion, mental state or attitude that is driving the fantasies. Let go of the story. We're only interested in what is actually motivating it. Irritation, irritation. Excitement, excitement. Then draw the attention back to the breath and determine to stay there.

Feeling sleepy or tired, keep making that effort: lifting up, opening the eyes. And don't forget, if the dullness and lethargy become overwhelming, you can stand up.

Allowing the attention to settle on the breath. As we feel more settled, draw yourself closer to see if you can catch the very beginning of the in-breath, stay with it to the very end, and the very beginning of the out-breath, and stay with it to the very end. If when you do this you find yourself getting tense, then sit back within yourself and have the impression of receiving the breath. Rising, rising. Falling, falling.

From now on, when the mind wanders and you recognise and acknowledge what's driving it, instead of coming back to the breath, come back into the body. See if you can feel it. If it is excitement, come into the body and see if you can feel the agitation, feel the restlessness and perhaps heat. If it's worry, feel the warmth and happiness. Stay there till it all evaporates.

And again, feeling dull-minded or lethargic in the body. You can also get into the feel of these states, the sensations, the feelings. Keep energising the spine and you can still open the eyes to let the light in.

When we get lost, we can always begin with the breath. The breath is our anchor and reference point. When we're confused, for instance, best to go back to the breath. Let's begin again with the breath. Rising, rising. Falling, falling. And find the noting you need just to help keep the attention steady.

Becoming aware of how we are reacting to what we're experiencing. How when something is pleasant, we're drawn towards it. We want to maintain it, to develop it. Can you feel the force of that desire?

When something is unpleasant, we first ignore it, but then we just want to get rid of it. If the posture is a little uncomfortable, we want to change it. Can you feel the strength of the desire? Can you feel these desires and not do anything? Just allow them to express themselves and exhaust themselves.

This is the desire the Buddha points to as the psychological cause for our suffering and unsatisfactoriness. Is that true for you?

Becoming aware of how everything we are experiencing is arising and passing away. Everything is in a process. Nothing repeats itself. Even though each breath is similar, they're never the same. Everything is vanishing, disappearing. Nothing remains. Is there anything reliable?

Becoming more aware of how everything we're experiencing is an object. If we have discomfort in the knee, we're looking down from the position in the forehead as the observer. It's a sort of observation post. Can we make that separation, that distance between the observer, the feeler, the experiencer and the object more obvious to us?

At times we can use a word like 'there'. So there's aching, there, over there is an itch. If it's an emotion or mood in the body: there's irritation, there's excitement. When it is an image in the mind, right in front of you, you can point to it: there's an image. You might even be able to do this with a thought.

Are the observer and the observed, the feeler and the felt, the experiencer and the experienced, the same or distinct? Can the perceiver be the perceived?

Becoming more aware of how everything is happening of its own accord. In *vipassanā*, we've taken the objective position of the observer, the feeler, the experiencer. We've separated out from the psycho-physical organism and allowed it to manifest as it wants. We find that the body offers us sensations and feelings, pleasant and unpleasant, whether we want it to or not. The heart, its moods and emotions, pleasant and unpleasant, whether we want it to or not. And the mind, its thoughts and images, wholesome and unwholesome, whether we want it to or not. We don't have direct control. If control is being exercised by the body, the heart and the mind, how can they be me?

Putting aside all instruction, have absolute confidence that this intuitive awareness is able to understand the way things really are, that it can have profound insight into the nature of things. We don't need to keep thinking about it, prompting it. No need to do anything. Don't try and change anything. Just absolute acceptance of this is the way it is. All we need to do is just observe, just feel, just experience whatever draws the attention within the field of awareness.

When we come to the end of a sitting, it's good to spend a little time reflecting on our experience. You can ask questions of yourself. How diligent was I in bringing myself back to the present moment? If I thought I was diligent, then I should congratulate myself. If I thought I could have been a little more committed, I should encourage myself. There's no need for self-criticism.

Was there some mental state or physical state that you had to work with? Some form of discomfort or agitation perhaps? Some sleepiness? How did you deal with it? Just choose one of them. If you thought you were skilful, you can congratulate yourself. If you thought you could have been a little more committed, you could encourage yourself. Don't get into self-criticism.

In this sitting, what was most prominent for you? The role of desire in creating unsatisfactoriness? Or was it the impermanence of things? Or was it that everything you were experiencing was an object, not under your direct control?

And it's good to make a resolution. It can be quite specific: Next time I feel dozy, I'll immediately open my eyes. Or it can be a general commitment to affectionate mindfulness.

When we come out of a sitting, don't jump out of it. Open the eyes gently and let the light in.

The Discourse on Developing Loving-Kindness

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 28 min

In this comprehensive exploration of the Karaṇīyamettā Sutta, Bhante Bodhidhamma guides us through the Buddha's systematic approach to developing mettā (loving-kindness). Drawing from one of the earliest strata of Buddhist teachings, this discourse reveals how cultivating boundless loving-kindness serves not merely as a feel-good practice, but as a genuine path toward Nibbāna.

Bhante examines the sutta's opening foundation—the moral and spiritual prerequisites including contentment (santuṭṭhi), being easily maintained (subhara), and having few duties (appakiccho). He explains how mettā functions as one of the brahmavihāras (divine abodes) and pāramīs (perfections), with its unique characteristic of eliminating ill-will completely. The talk includes Buddhaghosa's classical definition and practical guidance on developing mettā systematically—from beloved beings to neutral ones, extending boundlessly in all directions.

The discussion addresses common misconceptions about loving-kindness practice, emphasizing that genuine mettā involves no self-interest or attachment. Bhante offers practical techniques for cultivating this quality in daily life, including mindful engagement with routine tasks and maintaining what he calls 'affectionate awareness' throughout all activities. The episode concludes with guidance on using the Karaṇīyamettā Sutta as a meditation practice, making this ancient teaching accessible for both newcomers and experienced practitioners seeking to deepen their understanding of the Buddha's approach to unconditional goodwill.

I was rooting around the websites and I came across a course that was written by a man called Andrew Olendzki. He was the director of the Barre Center for Buddhist Studies, which is an offshoot from IMS, which is the big meditation centre in Barre, Massachusetts. That was begun by Joseph Goldstein, Sharon Salzberg, Jack Kornfield — some of you know them — and lots of others too. He did a lot of good work while he was there and they produce a very good magazine. Anyway, he's done a course based on the Karaniya Mettā Sutta, which is what we normally go through at the end of this sitting. So I thought I'd just go through it to give you an idea of how the Buddha puts it all together. And then if you want, I'll put the link for that course if you want to take it a bit further.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

Just in case I forget at the end, I hope you have a joyful Christmas and a great new year. I usually forget to say those sorts of things.

The Karaniya *Mettā* Sutta is the discourse on what we ought to do in order to develop *mettā*. That's what Karaniya means. And it comes from a very early strata of the Buddha's teachings, which was a collection of verses. So remember that in those days they couldn't read and write. It's a bit odd to think of the Buddha as an illiterate, but he was. Therefore, because it was written as a verse, it's pretty close to what he himself would have developed.

That word *mettā* comes from the word *mitta*, which means friends. To translate *mettā*, we can use the words loving-kindness. So loving is the attitude that you have within yourself and kindness is the way you express it. There's another one called goodwill. That stresses the role of intention and the will itself. And of course it's in the Christmas greeting, isn't it? Peace on earth and goodwill to all men — or as we would say, all sentient beings. Bhikkhu Bodhi's definition is a heartfelt concern for the well-being and happiness of others.

I think that touches a bit on compassion, really. And it doesn't really mention that there's no self-interest and there's no attachment. So we've got lots of types of love: erotic, romantic, family relationships, friends, people at work. Those aren't evil. You would still have those relationships even if you were fully liberated. But unfortunately, because we're not liberated, there'll be some attachment to them. There'll be some expectations of them, which leads to disappointment and sometimes to control. So that's all to do with the type of unwholesome love.

Buddhaghosa, who was this writer of the Path of Purification — some of you might know it, it's a great big tome which is probably one of the great spiritual manuals of the world — in the fifth century. This was his definition. This is how he defined all virtues. *Mettā* has the mode of friendliness as its characteristic. Its natural function is to promote friendliness. It is manifested as the disappearance of ill-will. That's a bit odd, isn't it? To manifest something that disappears. But basically, when there's no ill-will, you know that it's got to be *mettā*. And its footing, its basis, is seeing with kindness.

Here's a line which I like: When it succeeds, it eliminates ill-will, because you can't have those two mental states together. If you've got goodwill, there can't be ill-will there. When it fails, it degenerates into selfish affectionate desire. Those are a couple of strong lines there.

Mettā, of course, appears quite often in the Buddha's lists, these interminable lists. It's one of the perfections. It's one of the divine abodes, which is the most beautiful mental state that you can develop. It's one of the four illimitables, with compassion, joy and equanimity — means that you can just develop it indefinitely. And it's also a suitable subject to develop these absorptions, these blissed-out states.

So the first stanza: This is what has to be done. One has to be skilled in what is good in order to reach the peaceful state — *Santam Padam*, the path of peacefulness. This is about achieving *Nibbāna*. But you'll find if you do that course that he stretches it into peace in society, peace within yourself and all that. But it's actually — this discourse is actually about achieving *Nibbāna*. But it is worthwhile to notice when you're peaceful because that quality of peacefulness is a quality of the seven factors of enlightenment. It's one of those things that we ought to develop just generally.

These are the things that we have — in a sense he's presuming that we've developed a little bit. The first one is *sakko*, which means a confidence, a capability in doing this sort of work. And we'll end up by suggesting one way that we can do that.

The next one is *ujū*, which means to be upright really — upright. So this is to do with our moral rectitude and to get away from the stuff that comes out of delusion, of acquisitiveness, aversion and fear.

The next one is *suvaco*, which means skillful speech when spoken. So the speech has to be kindly, it has to be truthful, beneficial and rather importantly, timely. It might be kind, truthful and beneficial, but you shouldn't have said it then.

Mudu is a softness, a tenderness, and it's normally put with the word for heart. So it's a gentle heart, a tender heart, a gentle person.

And *atimāni* is to be without pride, arrogance, conceit, to be unpretentious.

So those are virtues that we need to develop. And then he carries on.

In the next verse he says to be content, to be contented. Now this isn't the contentment that you get when you've done a good job and you feel contented, or you've found someone whom you like to be with and you feel contented. This contentment is a basic

line. It's a basic attitude of contentment. To enter each moment with that sense of "this will do." This contentment doesn't mean you can't change something, but it underlies everything that we do — a sense of contentment.

The next one is *subharo*, which means easily maintained. This probably refers to the monastics. But it's a case of making a distinction between what you need, what you want, and what is actually sufficient. And that will determine whatever you have to do in your daily life. But basically, it's really needing only little. And these days, of course, with climate change, it has a bit more meaning.

The next one is *appakiccho*, which means to be less busy. Well, I think that rings a bell, doesn't it? We're always trying to do too much, trying to achieve too much — burnouts and all that sort of stuff. So it's good to reflect upon our lifestyle, just find out where we're actually stressing and to just let go of a few things. I think it's to do with priority.

And there's also, I think what also helps in life is to make the small tasks that we do meaningful. Just washing pots, vacuuming and all that sort of stuff. Normally we want to get them out of the way and get on with life. But if you see them as an occasion where you can just stop for a minute and do them very mindfully in a very relaxed way, abandoning all ill-will, they become little islands. And then from there you launch into your next project. So remember the old Zen saying: when you wash the pots, just wash the pots.

Engaging lightly — *sallahukavutti*, *sallahukavutti*. This is not to take things too seriously, to keep mindfulness. Not to be able to relax and to have that wholesome heart attitude. It's actually just to keep a smile on the face. The background smile really helps so you don't get too serious about things.

Santindriyo — this is quietening the faculties. We're a very visual culture — all this YouTube and TV and Netflix and social media. And we're always looking for some sort of sensual delight — food, the countryside. It's always — we're always looking for that sort of excitement. And in a sense that misses the mark because it's not quite happiness. And that's why often excitement doesn't work for us. Whatever used to make us really excited loses its flavour. So it is a case of being more content. It comes back to being content and to just every so often to spend some time just looking at a blank wall and just allowing that sense to calm down a bit.

Nipako just means prudent, wise, discreet, thoughtful. So that's a lovely quality, isn't it? To be considerate, basically, to be considerate, to be aware of what other people need. We're always centring upon ourselves.

Apagabbha means to be modest, to be courteous and not impudent. So again, it's about not pushing yourself. I mean, the word humility doesn't go down too well these days because we all believe in the suffering self. But humility actually just means to be natural and to be in communication with people, to see yourself in relationship.

This is again a reinforcement not to hanker after worldly things. So when you walk down the shopping mall or something like that, and your eyes constantly gazing at things — the clothes, the jewellery, the computer, the laptops, the phones — it's always looking for something. But if you're there to get something specific, just go for it. And then have a cup of tea.

So all this is about calming the senses, just calming down, trying to be much more contented.

The third stanza — he sums it all up here. He says not to commit even the slightest deeds that a wise person could find fault with. So that basically sums it up. Now this wise person is the spiritual friend, your *kalyānamitra*. That could be a teacher, it could be a very close friend, somebody whom you can talk to about things which have a spiritual meaning. And if there isn't one, there's always the Buddha within. When I have a moral question, or in a sense any question, if I just sit very still and just ask this Buddha within, just plunk the question into the heart, I normally get a fairly good answer. So we have a wisdom inside us, but often sometimes we're overcome with doubt and to discuss it with somebody can be very helpful.

And then we get the first well-wishing: So may all beings live in safety and in gladness. The word *sukhita* just means happy. And if you put a 'd' instead, *dukkhita* means you're not happy. And then it says so may all beings develop, may become more happy. So that's giving us a hint as to what we ought to say.

And it's not about you feeling happy. When you're doing the *mettā*, it's not about making yourself feel happy. Your intention is about others. I mean, there is a point where you turn into yourself and say "may I be happy" — there's no problem with that. But you're not practising *mettā* in order to be happy. Then it just becomes a self-centred practice. You're doing it in order to establish a relationship with the world, which is one of giving, of offering.

And then he gives us ways in which we can do this, gives us a technique. So he says: whatever beings there are, weak or strong, without exception, long or short, big, medium-sized, small, subtle or gross. Now the word here is *pāna*, which means breath-

ing beings. So I presume this includes insects, but I'm not so sure about bacteria, if they're beings. And what he's suggesting is no matter how a being looks, it's always that attitude of offering goodwill. Doesn't matter what their physical shape is.

In the second verse, he opens it out. He says to those who are visible or invisible, can't even see them. Residing near or far, those who have — those who've already been born and those who've yet to be born. This is almost transcending space and time. So you're really just expanding it outwards.

In the sixth verse, let no one deceive — now he's come back to — once you've developed this *mettā* you can't do this sort of thing. You can't deceive somebody. So to deceive somebody really is to take advantage of them. And then the next one is not to despise anybody. So you have to be careful about that. Not to be excessively, not to be angrily critical. You've got to watch out for jealousy and bad-mouthing. And of course, this also refers to ourselves — what they call the inner critic. When you hear yourself lambasting yourself, just turn towards it and say "calm down." You have to turn it into a little devil and give it a hug. So again it's not wishing harm to anyone. He sums it up with that — not wishing harm to anyone.

In the seventh verse, he points out: just as a mother would protect her only child at the risk of her own life, even so we should cultivate boundless thoughts of loving-kindness towards all beings. That's a very strong image, a mother protecting a child who's being threatened.

I saw a video of a lion and a lioness who were beginning to mate and they were walking at opposite sides of a fence that was obviously a containment in a reservation for them. And as the lion moved down one side of the fence, he was giving sounds of yawning — if you can imagine that, like a lion yawning. And she, the lioness, was coming the other way with a companion, yawning as well. So I thought when they get together, they'd be a bit hanky-panky and smoochy. But in fact, as soon as he got close to her, he attacked her viciously. And both of these lionesses attacked him. And then he pulled away.

I thought, well, that is so strange because there was no comment about it. But in the — what happens is if a lioness has cubs by a particular lion, then the lion goes off — he's done his bit. If a stray lion comes past, he'll try to kill all those cubs and mate with her so that she has his cubs. And she has to defend them. Sometimes she's actually killed, but most times she just comes away with bites and bruises. So what he was doing was testing her fierceness. And then in the video the commentator says "and now he's showing respect." I couldn't work that out, but seemingly he was showing her respect.

And of course we have the story of the Buddha quietening the elephant that had been set upon him by the dastardly Devadatta, who was a cousin and wanted to lead the order. He had lots of criticism. And that was the picture I had up before just in case you didn't see it. Now I'll just share the screen quickly. So that's the *mudrā* that's what we associate with loving-kindness — that hand offering it from love. It's nicely moved. Normally it's just a flat hand which isn't so appealing. And in his lap — I'm taking that to be the Dhamma, the jewel of the Dhamma. It's a Thai statue.

So now we have a third way in which we can develop that *mettā*, and it goes even further: let him cultivate a boundless thoughts of loving-kindness towards the whole world. And what he means there is, of course, all the worlds, all the cosmos, above, below and all around. So that's that practice of doing it in the six directions. Normally it's a compass thing — north, south and all that.

But in the East, normally it's a compass thing—north, south and all that—and as we do it, all beings in front, behind, left, right, below and above, unobstructed, free from hatred and enmity.

Now the next verse—he says that this should be developed all the time. It should be just a natural state of mind. So whether you're standing, walking, seated or lying down, so as long as you're awake, you should develop this mindfulness. Now whenever I read a translation, I always slip in "affectionate" there. It's not just mindfulness—it's an affectionate mindfulness.

Now just now, you see, as we're all looking at each other, just put a little kindling of kindness in your heart towards everybody. See, you can do it, can't you? See, that can be there all the time, even when we're not so aware of it. And that's what he's asking us to do, and he calls it a divine abiding. So this is like being a god.

And in the final verse, he sums it up. He says you don't want to have erroneous views. So these are the views about how we create suffering for ourselves through that wrong desire, understanding impermanence, and the fact that we have to get used to the idea that we're going to grow old, sick and die. This relationship we have with the body—heart and mind of it being me. So that's the identity of having this human form. And our practice of *vipassanā* is trying to make that clear. And in fact, what we are looking for is what's looking.

There's also erroneous views about *kamma*—that you can't get away with anything. It comes back in one way or the other. There's a very interesting quote from Jung that I came across. He says, "Whatever has been repressed will manifest as fate." And if you

look at your life and you find yourself doing something over and over again, falling into the same sort of mistake, then underneath that there will be some sort of suppressed or repressed mental state. I think that's really quite an insight.

So then, endowed with these virtues and wise with insight... Now the next line is a bit heavy because you have to abandon all sensual desire. But remember, it doesn't mean you stop eating. It just means to abandon the wrong desire—which is that greed, which is trying to get happiness from the sensual world as a permanent thing. That's the problem. Happiness arises and passes away like anything else. And then he says you don't have to be reborn again. The actual translation is "not to be conceived in a womb"—basically, you don't have to be reborn.

So that's just a quick run through this particular discourse.

So okay, so how do we practice it? Well, remember that it's good to have a touchstone. It's good to have something you can go back to which raises that sense of warmth, that kindling in the heart. So for instance, I know one teacher talks about holding a baby, you see. You use a pet—we always love pets. Or some... we normally start with the benefactor, so that's somebody who warms the heart, you see.

Now if you've got that and you've developed it a bit, you can always go back to it. Whenever we move into a category and you feel that the warmth in the heart has gone, you just go back and remind yourself of that kindling by bringing that person or the pet or whatever it is to mind. And remember that you're developing it in order to develop right attitude towards all beings.

And the other thing is not to worry if it doesn't come, see, because the heart has its own logic, doesn't it? You want to feel loving; you're just not feeling it. So if you obsess about that, then it becomes a misery. But just by doing the practice, I think you'll find...

Now I have a poet, Gerard Manley Hopkins, who some of you might know. He's known as the father of modern English poetry. And some of his sonnets are really about his own spiritual development. And there's one that starts: "My own heart let me more have pity on. Let me live to my sad self hereafter kind, charitable. Not live this tormented mind with this tormented mind tormenting yet. I cast for comfort I can no more get by groping round my comfortless than blind eyes in their dark can day, or thirst can find thirst's all-in-all in all a world of wet."

So those first two lines I've often used: "My own heart let me more have pity on..." And if you can kindle—if you can get that kindling within yourself—then you offer it out from there. I find it extremely strong: "Let me live to my sad self hereafter kind and charitable"—to my anxious self, my angry self, to my guilty self, you see. It doesn't do

much for the poem, but you can use it that way, so that you can generate a warmth towards yourself. And of course, it's easier to move from that heart. But as I say, if it's not there, not to worry at all. You can use your pet or something to generate it.

Okay, very good. So I thought what we would do is, instead of usually ending with the refuge and precepts, we would start with those, and then I would do that guidance through the *Mettā* Sutta, and then we would continue until the end when I would read the discourse—a translation of the discourse—and end off with our usual chant of *sabbe sattā sukhī hontū*.

Okay, so I can only hope my words have been of some assistance and that by your practice of *mettā* you will generate a beautiful heart that will lead you to everlasting peace and happiness.

The Importance of Tranquillity

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 16 min

In this comprehensive teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores passaddhi (tranquillity) as one of the seven bojjhaṅgas (factors of awakening). He examines how calmness affects both body and mind, discussing the physiological benefits including the activation of the parasympathetic nervous system, release of beneficial neurotransmitters like serotonin and endorphins, and reduction of cortisol.

The talk covers the relationship between physical relaxation and mental states in Buddhist understanding, explaining how tranquillity supports samatha (calming) practices and leads naturally into right concentration (sammā samādhi). Bhante discusses how calmness underlies the four brahmavihāras (divine abidings) - particularly upekkhā (equanimity) - and connects to the deeper states of jhāna.

Practical guidance is offered for cultivating tranquillity in daily life: taking pauses between tasks, mindful breathing before sleep, and making decisions only from calm states. The teaching emphasizes that passaddhi is not merely relaxation but a crucial spiritual quality that enables wisdom, improves relationships, and supports both vipassanā insight and the ultimate peace of nibbāna as described in the Metta Sutta.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So I thought this evening we'd tackle this factor of enlightenment. The word is *passaddhi* and it translates as calmness, tranquillity, serenity. And you can see that this is really important because the Buddha's included it in one of the seven factors of enlightenment.

So just to remind you, the seven factors are awareness, and you've got effort and concentration. You've got this calmness and curiosity, and then you have equanimity and the investigation of the Dhamma. So the first six are just general virtues that everybody can develop. What turns them into factors of enlightenment is the investigation of the characteristics of existence: impermanence, how we create suffering for ourselves through wrong attachments, wrong desires, wanting, not wanting, and of course, identity, not self.

So I think people who've done Yoga Nidra will find that's a really deep way of relaxing. And we have to, in war zones, you have to keep calm and carry on. So I don't know whether I want to post that up in present war zones. Terrible what's happening.

The Buddha always splits everything into body and mind. So if we look at what happens in the body, I did a bit of research. Most of you know this better than I do, actually. Remember, we have autonomic systems. So one is the sympathetic, one is the parasympathetic. So the sympathetic one is the fight and flight. So you're walking across the road and a car suddenly makes for you. Before you know it, you've got to the other side. So that's the sympathetic nervous system. The parasympathetic is the opposite. So it's about calmness, rest and digest. It affects your heart rate and so on.

The big thing about being calm, about relaxing into the present moment, is physically it releases all these wonderful neurotransmitters: serotonin, which makes you feel happy and well-being and feel good factors, the endorphins. Now I remember that in Buddhist understanding, these hormones within the body affect the mind.

So there are two different systems within us. There's this more gross energy that we call subatomic particles or subatomic energy. And there's a mental energy which is separate from that. This you can actually experience in your meditation. So it's not as though these hormones directly make you happy. They just have the effect on the heart of making it happy, your emotional life. And of course, it works the other way. When you're angry, the body gets hot.

Similarly, it reduces cortisol. So that's what we have when we've got all this stress related stuff, which isn't very good for us. Because you're relaxed, because the body is feeling okay, obviously it's much better for you, for our immune system. So we're able to fight diseases. As you know, there's a syndrome where people who are stressed at work go on holiday and then fall ill. So it's as though they have to have a real rest.

So it lowers muscle tension. I mean, that's the whole point of relaxing, isn't it? To relax the muscles as such. And this, of course, can alleviate even chronic pain. Just going back to my first episode with my back, the first time the disc prolapsed, I went along to an acupuncturist and I was surprised that as the needles went in, this anxiety came up. And as the anxiety dissipated, the pain wasn't anywhere near as bad as when I had this anxiety holding the body as it were for me. It was trying to protect me. I mean, these systems are trying to protect us.

And similarly, of course, it helps digestion. It actually says that stress can lead to digestive issues such as indigestion, irritable bowel syndrome. So especially to feel relaxed around eating. I mean, if you're at work and you're being pressured and you're

just chucking the sandwich down your throat, can't be doing you good, can it? And in Eastern understanding, I was thinking of the Chinese. Eleven o'clock to one o'clock is eating time. So your body is primed to eat at that time. And from one o'clock to three o'clock is liver time. So if you're rushing around while your liver's trying to handle all these nutrients, you can see it's not going to do you very good. So between eleven and three o'clock, make an effort to be a bit more relaxed. That's if you're stressed.

As a change in brain activity, you get these lovely alpha brain waves. So these are the ones that you have when you're feeling relaxed. It's also a very creative place to be. And we're there when we meditate. So when you're actually in that state of just *vipassanā*, normally the mind will go down to these alpha waves.

And obviously it improves your sleep because if you're not calm when you're trying to sleep, it's difficult. I mean, that's why really, to close everything down about half an hour before we intend to sleep, get off the social media, turn off Netflix, the BBC, and do something which is going to calm us. I personally sometimes listen to the chanting from Throble Hole Abbey, which was my first Buddhist encounter, and I just love their chanting. But there's other types of music, read poetry, there's many things you can do that are just relaxing in order to be prepared to go into sleep.

What we want to do is get that substrate under sleep to be calm and peaceful. And of course, when we're in bed, to put the breath, to put the attention on the breath and just feel it, just feel the body breathing. See, it wafts you into sleep, very calm. I can do *mettā*, of course. But the big thing is this sense of being relaxed, of being at ease.

I'm actually reading a book on this. It was a Sunday Times bestseller called *Breath* by James Nestor. It's entertaining. It's very good. When we relax, when we feel calm, even in situations that are stressful, we can get into a calmer place. It's obviously having these effects on the body and that's got to be good for us.

When it comes to *cittapassaddhi*, the calmness, tranquillity of the heart, obviously the stress is happening the other way. It's coming as a reaction we have to a given situation or person. That stress coming in the heart is moving back into the body. So as soon as we can just relax around something which is upsetting us, making us anxious, all the better. And of course, if we have a habit of being calm in situation, it should extend itself into situations which are stressful, which means that we're slightly more emotionally resilient. We can move our emotions a bit. We're not stuck on one groove of being angry or being anxious or getting depressed about something.

And of course, when you are calm, it just improves your decision making. I make a rule for myself, which whenever I break it, it's always disastrous. I try never to make any decision when I'm miffed or angry, when I'm anxious or when I'm in doubt. If I make a decision in those states of mind, something bad turns up. So you have to wait sometimes. You have to wait until there's calmness and then there's greater clarity.

It's obviously better for our relationships too, isn't it? I mean, if you're with somebody who's neurotic, it affects you, doesn't it? And if you're neurotic, it affects them. So if we can get into the habit of just being calm, not rushing in conversation, not trying to get the answer ready before the person stopped talking, but to actually get into that mode of listening. And to listen, you've got to be calm. You've got to be open.

It's obviously a good place for creativity. We're not talking about winners of the Booker Prize or ecstatic artists. It's just daily being creative about what we do. So even washing the pots can be actually a creative action. You can find different ways of doing it. This creativity, I mean, every moment, every day is different. So without us knowing it, we've got to be creative. Even if you're driving a car, you've got to be creative. You've got to see where you're going. You've got to drive in a safe and easy way and feel relaxed. So you know what happens when you drive and you're tense and you're anxious to get to a place or you're late to get to a place. So that's how accidents happen.

So obviously being calm just has an effect on our mental health. And developing that as a base within our lives from which we move. Out of that base, you move into an action. I mean, it's going to make us happy, isn't it? Remember, these things are just habits. They're just habits that we can develop.

So it obviously has an effect on the body and it affects on the heart. And so it now becomes a *bojjhaṅga*, which is a factor of enlightenment. And it looms quite large in the Buddha's teachings. It's normally connected to concentration, calm concentration. *Samatha* is the word for calming exercises. So *mettā* practice would be a *samatha* practice. And it leads into an easy concentration. If you want to be concentrated, the worst thing you can do is to try to be concentrated. The whole thing about concentration comes when you're relaxed and at ease and just placing the attention on the object and allowing the concentration to manifest. As soon as you try and push the process, you're getting in the way and what you get is restlessness.

So you find it in the Eightfold Path. The last three are to do with mindfulness. It's right effort, right mindfulness, right concentration. And we can include in that concentration that sense of calmness.

It's one of the four divine abidings. So we've got love, compassion. They're called divine abidings, also illimitables. But there are social virtues: the love, compassion, joy, and there the word is *upekkhā*. And this is where you get that touching of calmness and equanimity. So equanimity has to rest upon calmness. You can't be equanimous if you're all agitated. Equanimous, in my understanding, refers to a certain attitude, a certain way of looking at things. Calmness is your mental state and it's supporting it.

Yes, it's in meditation. The concentration of the *samatha* practice, of course, leads to an even deeper sense of relaxation through the practice of *jhāna*, through the practice of absorptions. So it's right there within the practice. It's not something that we add on. It's a necessary part of our practice. And when we are calm and we're not restless, whenever something arises which is obstructing our meditation, messing us about in ordinary daily life, even from minor silly things to heavy mental states, that calmness, if we've got that substrate of calmness, we can deal with it. That's the point.

And then finally, of course, there is the great calmness itself. In the Metta Sutta, remember, it talks about what must be done for those people who wish to reach the state of peace. Now, they use a different word there, *santa*. But of course, it is this calmness, this state of sublime serenity. That's one of the adjectives the Buddha uses for *Nibbāna*.

So there we are. So I'm hoping that you're all convinced and that to develop our calmness is absolutely necessary. And just remind yourself, it could become part of your New Year resolutions. It's a bit late, but why not? We can always add them on, can't we?

And to get in the habit, something I've been working on all my life since I became a Buddhist, is to, when you finish something, when you've done a task, it can be just the washing of the pots, but it could be a piece of work. It could be a bit of gardening you've done, not this time of course. And when it's finished, just to relax for a moment and just reflect on what you've done and see how you feel about it. And then just to stop for a moment, just to relax into the present moment. And then quite naturally, the next thing to be done will arise. So you're moving into the next thing to be done from that base of calmness. And that allows us to be more wise, more loving.

So I'm hoping that I've convinced you to really practice this quality of calmness and that by your devotion to it, you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

The Crucial Importance of Desire and Intention

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 20 min

In this essential teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma clarifies three crucial Pali terms that are often confused: taṇhā (unwholesome craving), chanda (wholesome desire), and cetanā (intention). He explains how taṇhā operates within paṭiccasamuppāda (dependent origination), creating the cycle of suffering through our reactions to sense contact.

Using practical examples—from seeing an apple to monastic rules about stealing—Bhante demonstrates how cetanā (intention/purpose) is what determines whether our actions create wholesome or unwholesome kamma. He emphasizes the Buddha's teaching that "it is cetanā that creates kamma," showing how our purposes condition our habits and ultimately shape our character and destiny.

The talk explores the difference between negative desires that create duality and separation, versus positive cravings that lead to indulgence and addiction. Bhante explains how chanda can develop from simple wholesome desire into the spiritual zeal that becomes one of the four bases of success (iddhipāda). Drawing from the Visuddhimagga, he illustrates the level of awareness possible when we continuously note our intentions, essential for ethical decision-making and liberation from suffering.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa —
Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

I thought this evening we'd tackle this crucial role of desire and intention. There are three words that we have to be clear about: *taṇhā*, *chanda* and *cetanā*.

This word *taṇhā* originally means a drought. From that you get the idea of thirst and it's used only for unwholesome desires. It always is included in dependent origination, in the five middle factors, which are the ones that are a process. First of all, you have a contact with one of your sense bases. Remember the mind, heart is a sense base. Something has to come up into that base of consciousness: moods, emotions, thoughts, images. Then there's a relationship to what we are experiencing.

We give it first of all a name, a concept, and then we have a feeling arises with it. Dependent on those we have that reaction that we call a desire. That desire, remember, is coming from a conditioning of wanting and not wanting. In this case it's always unwholesome in dependent origination because it describes how we create suffering for ourselves. After that you have an identity: I want. Then there's the empowerment.

That's where we make a distinction between the desire and an intention. If I take an example, you see an apple. The first is just a seeing an object. It's round, etc. Then it's given a name: apple. With the word apple comes a nice feeling usually and then you might feel hungry so there's a desire for the apple which may come from just ordinary appetite but in this case with *tanhā* it becomes because we're greedy.

Then you identify with that. I want that apple. You can see there how the language confuses us. It creates a delusion, gives you the idea that the I comes first. I want the apple, but actually it comes towards the end of that process. Once you have that identity, then you empower that desire. That's when you become an apple eater. So that's the first word, *tanhā*.

The second word is *chanda*. Actually, in the discourses, *chanda* can either be wholesome or unwholesome. But in later Buddhism, the more Abhidhamma commentarial side, the *chanda* tended to be used only for what was a wholesome desire. We do need desire, but we need those desires that lead to liberation, that lead to happiness in this very life. So that's *chanda*. We can translate it as a desire. You've got to be careful. These words are so confusing. A resolution is the energy of wanting something. I'll tell you where the confusion comes in a minute.

The third word is *cetanā*. *Cetanā* is connected to the word *citta*, which means mind. Here we're talking about intention or purpose. There are these two things. There's a desire, which can be wholesome and unwholesome, and there's the purpose.

The importance of that is that the desire itself, the actual energy, the wanting, is neutral. What makes it wholesome and unwholesome is the *cetanā*, your purpose for doing something. To get a feel for what that desire is as opposed to purpose you might say one thing you can do is if you're very hungry, just sit with the food in front of you and just feel the desire. The purpose is obvious you want to eat the food but by sitting there just looking at the food and smelling the aromas and all that and you can get that feel for what desire is as an energy.

If you want to really experience it, this is what I used to say, but it's been ruined now. I used to say, turn on the TV when it's your favorite program. Sorry, sit in front of the TV when it's your favorite program and don't turn it on. But unfortunately, iPlayer has ruined all that. You can always catch up with it. Never mind.

If we take an example from physics of throwing a stone, the energy within the arm is transferred into the stone and you cannot separate the force from the stone. You can't stop it in mid-air and say, well, look, this is the force and this is the stone. They're all one. But the purpose of throwing the stone can be various. When I'm walking around the property here, some of the stones from the car park have come onto the path where they shouldn't be. So I might just pick one up and flick it back onto the car park. I might find a flat stone, we have a little pond, and I might throw it on the pond to see it skim just for the joy of it.

But then we also have rabbits. Most of you or some of you will remember my experience with moles and how we had to get rid of the lawns and create a garden. So now we have rabbits who come in and dig little holes. So I might be tempted to pick up a stone not to harm the rabbit you understand but to give it the impression that it shouldn't actually be digging a hole in the garden and they've got a whole meadow to go and do it in. These are my intentions but the actual energy or the desire to throw the stone is neutral. There's a distinction there.

The Buddha makes it quite clear. He says, I say to you that it is the *cetanā* that creates a *kamma*. *Kamma* here is not the same as karma, which has come into our language as comeuppance and what you deserve. *Kamma* here just means an action. Remember that when you repeat an action, you create a habit. As we know, a collection of habits is your personality, your character. Once you've got that, then your destiny is assured. Something is driving us to our destiny and it's these habits that we've collected throughout life. Our purpose, of course, is to discern those habits that lead us to perdition and those habits that lead to liberation.

I'll give you another example, which comes from the Vinaya, the rule of the monks. If, for instance, I see somebody's mobile and I'm very attracted to it, and I think to myself, I'd like that mobile, because they've left it unguarded on a piece of furniture or something. If I just allow the thoughts to process, in a sense, I'm building up a wrong intention. It might be that this intention becomes so strong that I actually move towards the mobile with the intention at the back of my mind to slip it in my pocket. And then I stop myself. I stop myself in that process. What the heck's going on? This is called a *dukkata*. This is already a small offense. It's not serious.

However, the desire for this mobile overtakes me and I again approach the mobile and I just put my hand on it and then, in a sort of horror, I take it back. Now, this is what's called a *thullaccaya*. It's a serious offense. I've actually gone and touched the object that I'm wanting.

But again the desire for this mobile completely overtakes me. I go to it, I touch it and I move it a nanometer. That's all. Just a nanometer. I suddenly realize what I've done. I drop it and I walk away. It's too late as far as the Vinaya is concerned. I've committed an act of stealing even if I don't get it. It's an act of stealing and in the Vinaya this is a very serious offense. It's called a *pārājika*.

Pārājika translates as end of life, which means that you have to leave the order and you can't join it again in this lifetime. This is an example to show the process of how we can unwittingly be developing a desire which then suddenly grabs us and we do something that we ought not to have done. The moral there is don't become a monastic.

Just as a reflection: When we have a negative desire, so this is to do with a sense of self. When we have a negative desire, when we're doing something or saying something, there's always a separation. You create a duality between the person who doesn't want to do something and what you're actually doing.

A simple example might be washing pots. You're fed up with washing pots, especially if you've got a family and all these pots and pans everywhere and you're fed up with it and you're washing the pots. Your sense of self is: I don't, I shouldn't be doing this. Somebody else should be doing this and I'm fed up with doing this. And you're washing the pots at the same time. There's a split there between the sense of self and what you're actually doing and that's why sometimes you lose your attention and you drop a pot and break it and then you're really mad.

If you have a positive craving, if you have something that you really want an indulging thing, then here you can immerse completely into that experience. So it might be that you're very fond of horror movies or something like that and you're knowing yourself that perhaps you shouldn't be watching these. I'm not saying you shouldn't, you're saying it to yourself. And then you absorb into the film. You lose yourself into the film.

The problem with going into something from a position of indulgence is that you go in with prejudice and it's selective. For instance, supposing now you go to a restaurant and there's a pizza. You've had all these pizzas. So you've got this idea of what a proper pizza ought to be. You walk into the restaurant, you ask for a pizza and it just doesn't

live up to what you expect a pizza to be. So you're very disappointed and you eat it, of course, grumbling. And you won't go back, of course. But if this was the first pizza you'd ever eaten, you'd be delighted by it.

Another thing is when you are eating something like sticky toffee pudding. If you eat sticky toffee pudding and what you really want is the sweetness of it, you're prejudiced towards, you're biased towards tasting the sweetness of the sticky toffee pudding. It might have all sorts of different subtle flavors but you're unaware of those. You've brushed them out as it were because all you're interested in is sweetness and that's what indulgence does. It just looks for what will gratify it.

For instance, another distinction would be wine tasters or tea tasters better. They have to put the tea or the wine on the tongue and roll it round and really be aware of all the tastes that come out from that whereas when we drink tea normally we just have this one taste in mind and if there isn't enough milk we don't like it, there's not enough sugar, if it's not strong enough and so on and so forth. It's a case of recognizing that whenever we're doing something from a position of indulgence, it's always going to crimp our experience. It's going to limit it. Apart from, of course, creating a further, greater dependency on it. They become addictions at various levels or other. Because you're always trying to satisfy this indulgence.

The fact of the matter is, it can't be satisfied. Because that's not where the suffering is coming from. The suffering is coming from some sense of lack within us, some sense of neediness within us. The object that we're using to fulfill it can never cure that sense of neediness. It just gratifies it for a little while. The only way we can cure the neediness is by staying with it until it evaporates. And the energy of that habit is slowly undermined and disappears. Looking to indulge ourselves, hoping to get rid of the sense, hoping to get rid of that craving is a non-starter. It just gets worse.

Going back to *cetanā*, remember that that's your conditioning factor. The purpose for which we are doing something is actually reinforcing a habit that we already have. So it's really important to catch that purpose. Sometimes in the discourses, remember that the word *chanda*, desire, will be used in a sense of wholesome and unwholesome. But don't be confused by that if you come across it, because it's always the purpose for which we're doing something which is conditioning us.

Just one little example, which comes from the Visuddhimagga, the path of purification, which was written by a monk called Buddhaghosa in the fifth century. It's got to be one of the great spiritual manuals of the world. In that book, which is a big tome, and

it's as dry as you could imagine. It has a whole section on the Dhamma, a whole section on how to develop beautiful mental states, such as the use of love and *mettā* and things like that, and a whole section on how to develop insight. It's a really beautiful book.

In it, he gives this example of a teacher who's with his students. While he's talking, his hand lifts up and he stops and very slowly puts his hand down. All the students want to know what happened there. They said, what happened? He said, I didn't note my intention. In other words, his mindfulness is so acute, is so in the present moment that even the smallest intention would normally be acknowledged. In this case, he hadn't. But he recognized that his hand shouldn't be there. And he very slowly put it back. He intended to put his hand back where it ought to be. That's how awake we can become in daily life. It's especially important to be awake whenever we're making decisions that are of an ethical nature.

Finally, this *chanda* is a desire which grows with the habit of doing something until it becomes a zeal and it becomes part of the four bases of power or success. I've covered that in an earlier presentation and that's your zeal and with it there comes the energy to support that aspiration. Then there's the commitment, the devotion of the heart to what you're doing. Finally, in terms of anything that needs an investigation, the path of insight, there comes that discrimination, that investigation of what we're experiencing. This *chanda* moves from being the slightest little desire, good desire in this case, to a real zeal, a real desire to achieve something. That's your *chanda*.

Just to sum up very quickly, we got these three words. This *tanhā* which is any desire which we can perceive or realize is unwholesome. *Chanda* which is a desire which is wholesome. What we have to be careful of is this *cetanā*, the purpose for which we're doing something. That sometimes takes a little reflection, because it can get a bit dodgy.

On the surface of things, we might be doing something for good purpose. I'm helping somebody just out of the goodness of my heart. But when they don't thank me, I'm very upset. That shows that underneath there I'm expecting some sort of praise. Trying to get all that stuff into consciousness really demands an ability to just stop every so often and recognize what's going on inside us.

I hope my words have not caused any confusion and that by your careful observation of desire, you will drive yourself relentlessly to your liberation from all suffering.

Satipaṭṭhāna Opening Ceremony 30th June 2007

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 56 min

This historic recording captures the opening ceremony of Satipaṭṭhāna Buddhist Retreat on June 30th, 2007, marking the establishment of Wales' premier Theravāda meditation center. The ceremony begins with traditional Pāli chanting of the Three Refuges (tisarāṇa) and Five Precepts (pañca-sīla), followed by vandanā honoring the Buddha, Dhamma, and Saṅgha. Bhante Bodhidhamma leads the blessing of the shrine and ceremonial laying of the stupa foundation stone.

The event features inspiring talks from distinguished Theravāda monastics including Venerable Premasiri from Sri Lanka, who explains the development of sati (Right Awareness) and paññā (wisdom) in meditation practice, drawing from the Mahasi method. Representatives from London Buddhist Vihāra and other meditation centers offer blessings and support for this new center dedicated to Vipassanā meditation.

This ceremony represents a significant milestone in bringing authentic Theravāda Buddhist meditation practice to the Welsh-English border region, establishing a place where practitioners can develop the satipaṭṭhāna foundations of Right Awareness as taught by the Buddha.

Hello and welcome. Welcome to Satipanya Buddhist Meditation Centre. This is our opening day and what we hope the film will catch is the blessing of the shrine, the blessing of the stupa and we're going to put something into the ground and then finally the talks given by some of the monks. It's a lovely rainy Welsh day and I'm sure you'll enjoy it.

Welcome everybody. What we're going to do is some chanting, taking refuges and precepts. And then we're going to do the Vandana, just praising the Buddha, Dhamma, Sangha. And then some special chanting to bless this water. And then we're going to make our way up to the top field, which is where the small stupa will be. And on the way, it'd be good if you could chant *Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammasambuddhassa*. Don't worry if you can't remember it, just mumble. And then when we get up there, there'll be some more chanting and I'm going to put this special pot here beneath the ground which is, as it were, the foundation for the stupa. And then after that we make our way back to this marquee.

The ground's fairly firm. It'll take a good shoe. You won't sink. But if you've got an umbrella, I'll bring that with you.

[Extended Pali chanting including taking refuges, precepts, and traditional Buddhist ceremonies]

Thank you. He has brought his business knowledge to the trust. Lastly, but not least, our ever cheerful and efficient Secretary, Sharon Hammond, whose aid is supported by Keith, who brings a wealth of experience as he is the treasurer at Amaravati. He has guided us through various difficult phases to the point where we are today.

I would like to mention one or two persons who were past office bearers and I thank them for the help given. They are Ramani Samarasinha, Anne Ashton and Sarah Quinn. My sincere thanks to all of them.

On behalf of the entire Satipanya Trust, I would like to thank the following people. I must tell you, Bhante has made a nice list but as usual he has lost the list. If I have left out any person, please forgive me.

I would like to end this by reminding all of you what happened at Buddha's last moment before Parinibbāna. All his disciples went to pay homage. They all came excepting one monk whose absence was conspicuous. When the Buddha asked where Dhamma Rama was, they sent a monk to fetch him. And when he came, Buddha said to Dhamma Rama, these monks said that you had not come. Dhamma Rama replied, O Bhante, it is true. I did not come. I thought that if I sit down in my kuti and meditate and achieve some mental attainment, it would be the best way to pay homage to my teacher. So that is why I did not come. The Buddha said, Sādhū, Sādhū, Sādhū, all follow Dhamma Rama. From this we can see the place he gave to meditation. It really is the heart of Buddhist practice.

May all of you make use of this beautiful Satipanya meditation retreat and attain liberation. As I mentioned earlier, we would be very grateful for your help and support towards the payment of the loan. We took the retreat managers all the necessary forms. And if you are a taxpayer, please feel free to give the info.

Venerable Premasiri is the abbot of one of the meditation centres in Sri Lanka and he has a special relationship with me because he was the one who ordained me into this particular chapter of the order. Next to him is Venerable Ñānamala who lives in London and is an ardent Mahāsi follower like myself. This is an old friend of mine, Venerable Piyadassi. And that's it. An equal old friend is Venerable Subodha.

When he was a layperson and I was in London, I consider to be my training college. It was there that I really learned how to teach the Dhamma. And I don't think there'd be anywhere else in the world where I could have got such a wide experience and the opportunity to teach the courses that I personally wanted to. So it's with a great sense of gratitude that I find that she's come along for this meeting.

Neva is an Anāgārikā who lives, and I'm very happy that she's come along as the Buddhist token nun. Hopefully one day there will be many of them. Father Sylvan is an Orthodox monk and to my joy just lives over there on the Glyph Stones. So I've got a brother. Sister Karen, who is a student of Father Sylvan and is also living as a hermit close by. And Sister Ruth, who is a Church of England hermit and lives at the moment down in Wales. And he's also an old friend. We've attended each other's courses.

So these are the people you look at, and there's me of course. So now I'm going to pass over to Brian, who will invite two or three people to give a little talk. Before I do this, I have a new umbrella here, so if anyone would like to claim this.

Well, first of all, I have great pleasure in inviting on behalf of the Satipanya Trust.

I would like to talk a little about *Satipaṭṭhāna*. The first beginning of meditation centre is the development of attention. In the morning we have two ideas in our mind. At the same time, we think of something else. By that time, the toothbrush has... That is one reason why we should train.

When we are training our attention, it's like teaching a little child to walk and take a few tentative steps. Gradually, he learns to walk more and more steadily. After a little while, he can walk on his own without any. When that happens, the mind starts.

At this stage, in *samatha*, we do not get attached or develop aversion to whatever objects that come to the mind. This is one of the most important things that has to arise in your mind, that is not having attachment or aversion to whatever objects that arise in the mind.

To develop mindfulness, there are five factors. First thing is that you have to stop either getting attached to or having aversion or pushing away whatever arises in your mind. We let go of the past and the future. We do not start thinking or we do not have expectations. We don't try to be too fast or too slow.

We go through the five again. We do not get attached to or develop aversion to any object. We do not think of the future or the past. We have no thinking and we have no expectations. As mindfulness develops, gradually your wisdom starts to develop. At this stage, it is not really wisdom, it is just... wisdom or knowledge develops, you develop *sampajañña* or clear comprehension.

There are five factors that help in the development of clear comprehension. *Vitakka*, applied thought, *vicāra* or sustained thought, *manasikāra* or attention, *ekaggatā* or one-pointedness of mind. *Viriya* or energy. These are the five factors that help us to develop our wisdom.

One thing is that you reduce the amount you talk. And therefore, I think it is time for me to stop. I would like to ask Venerable to answer.

We are very happy that we have been able to come and participate at a ceremony for the establishment of a centre for the propagation of the Buddha Dhamma in the Welsh-English border. We had always thought of the West as a place where it was mainly materialistic prosperity. People in the developing world are beginning to understand that whatever material wealth we have, that it does not give us ultimate satisfaction. People living in these developed countries are getting gradually attracted towards Buddhism.

The developed world has made vast strides in technology and also in military. In Asia or in the Asian culture, we do not regard arms as something good. Therefore, one of the best things that we can give to the West is the message of the Lord Buddha.

Who is a citizen of this country is a monk who has been in a number of countries around this area. He has been doing this noble task for the last twenty years or so. He had the idea to further propagate the message of the Buddha. It is the fruition of his endeavours that has resulted in what we are doing today, the establishment of this centre and also the laying of a foundation stone for a stupa.

We Sri Lankan people always bless him. As monks from Burma and other countries, we all give our blessing to him and wish his work all success. Because of this function organized by Bhikkhu Bodhidhamma, myself, as well as Venerable Premasiri and Venerable Dhammarakkhita, we all were able to come to this country.

The very name of this center reminds us of one of the most important messages that the Buddha gave us. The Venerable Premasiri placed before you a very clear and short description of what *sati* and *paññā* mean. We hope and we invite everybody, both who have come from Sri Lanka to live here, as well as all of you, to make maximum use of this center and develop your mind.

May the blessings of the Triple Gem and may our greetings to Venerable Bodhidhamma and to the Satipanya Center.

Venerable Mahāsaṅgha, dear friends in the Dhamma, it is indeed a great pleasure to be here participating in this inaugural ceremony of Satipanya Center. The founder, Venerable Bodhidhamma, he is a very good friend of the monks and devotees of the London Buddhist Vihara. I am standing to represent the London Buddhist Vihara.

London Buddhist Vihara is the oldest Theravāda monastery in this country. It was founded in 1926 by Anāgārika Dharmapāla, a Sri Lankan philanthropist. Now, eighty-first anniversary we celebrate this year. At the very beginning of this wonderful career, the founder Venerable Bodhidhamma is a very good friend of the monks of the dayakas of the LBV. At the very beginning of his wonderful career in this country, as a meditation teacher, he used to live at the London Buddhist Vihara. After that, temporarily, he started a centre in North London. And then he moved to Gaia House as a meditation teacher. Finally, he has been able to establish his own center here.

Venerable Bodhidhamma is a very experienced teacher. He has been trained at Kanduboda in Sri Lanka and Mahāsi meditation center in Myanmar. His skill in meditation especially in Mahāsi technique. According to my understanding he is one of the most experienced teachers of this technique in this country.

Here it seems to me all the factors for a meditation center are completed. A teacher or *kammaṭṭhāna* ācārya we need. So Venerable Bodhidhamma is here, a very qualified monk, in a quiet place, or what we call *suññāgāra*. It's a very quiet place. In the morning, I had to walk for one and a half hours. Nobody met me in my work, so it's a very quiet area. So his environmental factor is okay. And the supporters are dāyakas, so he is very fortunate. He has so many supporters, it seems to me.

Certainly this center, under his guidance, will be able to cater to many people, those who need support and guide for spiritual development and inner peace. On this occasion, I, on behalf of the Sangha of the London Buddhist Vihara, would like to convey our heartiest congratulations and blessings to Venerable Bodhidhamma, and to the center.

Somebody said the reason I'm here is because until I met Bodhidhamma I had received many many teachings and they all made some sense but they were all pieced here and there from different traditions and different teachers. He said, when I met Bodhidhamma, I really got it. I really understood the heart of the Dhamma, of where all those pieces came together, and that really allowed me to go deeper in my practice. So the quality of the teacher as well.

Many, many other things probably people could come up with. A sense of humor, a great sense of humor that he brings that quality of lightness, incredible lightness with the dedication and the seriousness of his commitment. It's a really lovely combination.

As we were walking over to the ceremony, as he was encouraging us to chant behind him, he turned around to us and with this twinkle in his eye, started the chanting which has both a freedom in the way he can be with his form and an incredible dedication to holding his precepts and his lineage in those five years that he was with us at Gaia House. It's a tremendous commendation.

And we're very familiar with being impersonal and pointing in that direction, but really just to honour the fruits of his practice. The great warmth and always coming through the Gaia House corridors that he would be, with great clarity, with a great heart, peace and joy he'd say, every time, peace and joy Catherine, peace and joy, wherever it was he was passing by.

So, with these great qualities that we come to celebrate, and in this wonderful centre on behalf of Gaia House. I'll read you just a little bit that was put in the Gaia House newsletter. The teachers, trustees, managers and staff of Gaia House extend our congratulations to Bhante Bodhidhamma, who was a Gaia House resident teacher from 2001 to 2005, and the Satipanya Buddhist Trust on the opening of their new centre. We wish them all the best in their new home at the Satipanya, flow deep and clear at White Grit for the welfare and liberation of all beings.

I just want to take this last opportunity because I missed out on introducing somebody who was meant to sit here but she's hiding in the back. And she is my spiritual mother.

She is the one who told me to sit facing the wall and watch whatever arises and passes away. And I don't think I've missed a day. That's the effect it had on me.

So finally, many thanks for coming.

Ceremony to Bless the Stupa — June 26th 2011 — Pt 1

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 15 min

This recording captures the opening of a traditional Buddhist blessing ceremony for the stupa at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat. Bhante Bodhidhamma leads the community in sacred Pali chanting, beginning with the traditional homage 'Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa' (Homage to the Blessed One, the Worthy One, the Perfectly Awakened One).

The ceremony includes recitation of protective chants from the Pali Canon, including portions of the Ratana Sutta (Jewel Discourse) and the Maṅgala Sutta (Discourse on Blessings). These traditional chants invoke the Triple Gem — Buddha, Dhamma, and Saṅgha — and offer blessings for protection and spiritual welfare. The ceremony follows traditional Theravāda format, moving from the stupa to a reading of the Buddha's first discourse, then to the Mettā Sutta chanting near the Kuan Yin statue.

This first part captures the devotional and communal aspects of Buddhist practice, demonstrating how ritual and ceremony support the cultivation of faith (saddhā) and create conducive conditions for spiritual development. Such ceremonies strengthen the practitioner's connection to the Buddha's teaching lineage and the supportive community of fellow practitioners.

We'll be chanting *Namo Tassa, Bhagavato, Arahato, Samma Sambuddhassa*. You all with me? Thank you.

When we get to the stupa, the monks at the top will lead us in the three refuges and precepts. Then a reading will be made of the first discourse of the Buddha, and then we'll make our way down to the statue of Kuan Yin where we'll have a reading of the Metta Sutta and a chanting of it. Then we'll make our way back to the marquee where we'll listen to some talks. At the end we'll have a cup of tea.

You'll find all you need for chanting on the back page of this handout. So we'll begin the little ceremony with our chanting.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa
Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa
Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa

[The transcript then contains extensive Pali chanting which appears to include traditional blessing chants and portions of various suttas. The chanting continues with various traditional verses including what appears to be parts of the Mangala Sutta and other protective chants, concluding with more refuge and blessing formulas.]

So make sure that you can pick up one of the joss sticks there at the corner and just follow the procession.

Ceremony to Bless the Stupa - June 26th 2011 - Part 2

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 26 min

This recording captures part two of a sacred stupa blessing ceremony at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat. The ceremony includes the traditional recitation of the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta (SN 56.11), the Buddha's first teaching on the Four Noble Truths and the Noble Eightfold Path, delivered to the five ascetics at Isipatana deer park. Participants engage in the time-honored practice of taking the Three Refuges (tisaraṇa) - Buddha, Dhamma, and Saṅgha - followed by the communal chanting of loving-kindness wishes: "sabbe sattā sukhitā hontu" (may all beings be happy). The ceremony concludes with the chanting and reading of the Metta Sutta, the Buddha's profound teaching on cultivating boundless loving-kindness toward all beings. This traditional blessing ceremony demonstrates the living tradition of Theravāda Buddhism, where ancient Pali texts are chanted to consecrate sacred spaces and generate merit for the benefit of all sentient beings.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa

These are the refuges and precepts, so we repeat after Bhante.

Sādhū, sādhū, sādhū.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa

Dutiyampi buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi

Dutiyampi dhammaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi

Dutiyampi saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi

Tatiyampi buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi

Tatiyampi dhammaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi

Tatiyampi saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi

Thus have I heard. On one occasion the Blessed One was dwelling at Baranasi in the deer park at Isipatana. There the Blessed One addressed the monks of the group of five thus: "Monks, these two extremes should not be followed by one who has gone forth into homelessness. What two? The pursuit of sensual happiness in sensual pleasures, which is low, vulgar, the way of worldlings, ignoble, unbeneficial, and the pursuit of self-mortification, which is painful, ignoble, unbeneficial. Without veering toward either of these extremes, the Tathagata has awakened to the middle way, which gives rise to vision, which gives rise to knowledge, and leads to peace, to direct knowledge, to enlightenment, to *Nibbāna*."

"And what, monks, is that middle way awakened to by the Tathagata? It is this noble eightfold path: that is, right view, right intention, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness, right concentration. This, monks, is that middle way awakened to by the Tathagata, which gives rise to vision, which gives rise to knowledge, and leads to peace, to direct knowledge, to enlightenment, to *Nibbāna*."

"Now this, monks, is the noble truth of suffering: Birth is suffering, aging is suffering, illness is suffering, death is suffering, union with what is displeasing is suffering, separation from what is pleasing is suffering, not to get what one wants is suffering. In brief, the five aggregates subject to clinging are suffering."

"Now this, monks, is the noble truth of the origin of suffering: It is this craving that leads to renewed existence, accompanied by delight and lust, seeking delight here and there. That is, craving for sensual pleasures, craving for existence, craving for extermination."

"Now this, monks, is the noble truth of the cessation of suffering: It is the remainderless fading away and cessation of that same craving, the giving up and relinquishing of it, freedom from it, non-attachment."

"Now this, monks, is the noble truth of the way leading to the cessation of suffering: It is this noble eightfold path: that is, right view, right intention, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness, right concentration."

Sādhū, sādhū, sādhū.

Sabbe sattā sukhitā hontu

Sabbe sattā sukhitā hontu

Sabbe sattā sukhitā hontu

So now we'll chant the *Metta Sutta* and then there'll be a reading of it.

This is the *Metta Sutta*: If you are wise and want to reach the state of peace, you should behave like this. You should be upright, responsible, gentle and humble. You should be easily contented and need only a few things. You should not always be busy. You should have the right sort of work. Your senses should be controlled and you should be modest. You should not be exclusively attached to only a few people. You should not do the slightest thing that a wise person could blame you for.

You should always be thinking, "May all beings be happy." Whatever living beings there are, be they weak or strong, big or small, large or slender, living nearby or far away, those who have already been born and those who have yet to be born - may all beings without exception be happy.

You should not tell lies to each other. Do not think that anyone anywhere is of no value. Do not wish harm to anyone, not even when you are angry. Just as a mother would protect her only child at the risk of her own life, so you should let the warmth of your heart go out to all beings. Let your thoughts of love go through the whole world with no ill will and no hate. Whether you are standing, walking, sitting or lying down, so long as you are awake, you should develop this mindfulness. This, they say, is the noblest way to live.

And if you do not fall into bad ways, but live well and develop insight, and are no longer attached to all the desires of the senses, then truly you will never need to be reborn in this world again.

So we can make our way to the marquee. Thank you.

Ceremony to Bless the Stupa — June 26th 2011 — Pt 3

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 36 min

This recording captures the concluding portion of Satipānya Buddhist Retreat's fourth anniversary celebration and stupa blessing ceremony. The event brings together Buddhist monastics from various traditions alongside Christian contemplatives, reflecting the interfaith dialogue that characterizes modern Buddhist practice in Wales.

Venerable Premasiri offers practical guidance on meditation as a natural daily practice, emphasizing present-moment awareness and the gradual release from past and future concerns as a path toward nibbāna. Venerable Piyananda explains the symbolic significance of the stupa structure, describing how Bhante Bodhidhamma's unique design represents the journey from ignorance (dark circle) through refuge in the Triple Gem to the Noble Eightfold Path leading to liberation.

Sister Candassiri shares profound reflections on devotional practice (bhakti), explaining how communal acts like stupa circumambulation and sutta chanting can transcend Western individualism and self-centeredness. She emphasizes how devotion supports the challenging work of spiritual training, offering encouragement and connection to the Buddha's promise of liberation from all dukkha. The ceremony concludes with the formal placement of relics and Buddhist scriptures within the completed stupa, marking a significant milestone for this Welsh retreat center dedicated to integrating vipassanā meditation into daily life.

Now, welcome to everyone. A wonderful day and a wonderful occasion. This being the fourth anniversary of the founding of the Satipanya Buddhist Retreat Centre. We're privileged today to have three speakers to give us the benefits of their Dharma wisdom. Perhaps we could express our appreciation after each talk in the usual Buddhist way with *sādhū*.

First of all, I'd like to ask the venerable Bodhidhamma to introduce our guests.

It was all very formal, wasn't it? Can you hear me through that or can you hear me like this?

I'd like to—some of you were here for the opening, so you'll remember Venerable Premasiri, who is one of our chief monks from Sri Lanka, and he has a lovely monastery called Sumati Pāla. It's right next to Khandavoda Meditation Centre, where Venerable Piyananda Thera is the chief monk. So these two venerables came over last time for the opening. So it's great that they've come again. That's my connection. This is the order that I personally belong to.

Then there's Venerable C.E. Dhammaloka. He is the chief monk at the Chiswick Buddhist Vihāra. So if you're ever in London, do feel free to drop in and do some meditation.

This is Roshi Saito. He's the abbot of the temple. He's an incumbent of the Telford Buddhist Priory. He's part of the establishment of Throssel Hole Abbey, which is up in Northumberland. That's his connection with me, because that's where I started with my Buddhist practice.

This is Venerable Kassapa. He's been a very long time monk, lived mainly in Sri Lanka. He's now beginning to live in the West, and hopefully he'll find himself a permanent place to stay.

Then there's Venerable Berault, who's a senior monk from Shasta Abbey. Shasta Abbey is the mother house of all the other houses to do with the Zen Buddhist tradition that was begun by Roshi Kennett, who some of you might know. Roshi Kennett wrote probably a spiritual classic on "How to Grow a Lotus Blossom"—highly recommended.

Then there's Venerable Nāgasena. Nāgasena is a resident monk in Birmingham Buddhist Vihāra. The connection I have with that is, of course, my teacher was there, Venerable Dr. Rewatadhamma, who died a few years ago.

And the Sister Candrasiri, I'm sure many of you know Sister. She's a chief nun, one of the chief nuns from Amaravati. I'm very pleased that she's come. Could have a long association with Sister, even though she might not know it. Because way back when they were doing Chithurst, which was then a wreck, I used to go along and wash pots and do things like that. I remember generally getting on her nerves because I was doing them too quick. I remember that.

Then there's Sister Tissara. She's also living at Amaravati and is a nun of the same order. We have a little connection there because she began her Buddhist practice at Gaia House, where I was the resident teacher at the time.

Then there's Sister Puññanandī, who has ordained in the Burmese tradition of temporary ordination. I think she'll escape the order in about a day or two. But hopefully she'll get back in in the fullness of time. Some of you know, well, in her past life, she was called Noreen. She teaches occasionally at Satipānya.

Then we have Sister Ruth. Sister Ruth is also—she's an Anglican nun ordained with the Archbishop of Canterbury and is the spiritual director of a particular trust under his name. She also holds a lineage through Gary Roshi, Roshi John Gary, and therefore carries with her these two traditions, both the Buddhist tradition of Chan, Chinese Chan, and the Christian tradition. So she's right at the interface where these two monoliths appear. She lives as a hermit up on the Brecon Beacons, and she was stuck for two months in the last snow down here, but with a tractor to feed her. Wasn't it two months? Five weeks. About two months.

Then there's Father Silouan. Father Silouan just lives across here on the Stiperstones. Those of you who come from around here will know that. He's an Orthodox monk and he's been up there for many years and obviously a great companion for me. He's up there also working and I'm trying to get escape work down here so it's an opportunity to get together.

Sister Karen is also an Anglican nun and is a student of Father Silouan. She used to live very close here, that you might know, down in Bishop's Castle, but has now moved to a glorious place over towards the coast.

And then there's Caroline. Caroline Jones is a teacher at Gaia House, and for three months of the year, she occupies the position that I had there for four years. So it's really heartwarming to find somebody here who represents Gaia House and the whole lay tradition of teachers.

So those are our guests. Well, I delivered it very well, don't you think? You didn't pay heed to my request.

Now we'd like to invite Bhante Premasiri to give us a talk, a Dharma talk.

Reverend Bhikkhu Bodhidhamma. Is it? Yes. Mahāsaṅgha. Dignitaries of the various denominations and distinguished guests. I was asked to speak a few words about the meditation by Reverend Bhikkhu Bodhidhamma.

Meditation is a very easy thing to perform. People think that it's a very difficult thing to perform. It has become difficult because they think it is difficult. You have certain aims in your life. So you tend to drop all the main aims in your life at certain times. So

always try to live with not the main aim but the aims that are not important. The main aims are that you have to eat, drink, you have to go to toilet, washrooms, you have to sleep, and etcetera. These are the main goals of your aims of your life.

You can look at these things with wisdom. So you look at these activities with wisdom. So you can perform the other balance after that. So therefore, meditation is not a difficult activity to perform. A person who lives eight years starts within about ten minutes. So if you start ten minutes a day, so how long you have been meditating during your time of eighty years? Almost then, eighty years. So if you multiply your eight years into ten minutes, how long you have been meditating then? So you have to practise this.

So Bhikkhu Bodhidhamma, Reverend Bhikkhu Bodhidhamma may teach you a better way. The ten minutes that you are going to stay with meditation or meditate, you have to just forget the past. Give up your past. You give up your future. You give up your clinging or the attachment. You don't keep on thinking or contemplating. You don't have any hopes or wishes. You should not perform slowly. You should not start fast.

So if you can get rid of yourself with these eight points, so you can reach *nibbāna* soon. What reverend says is to just forget your past, drop your future and try to be in the present. So time to come, then you can just drop your present also. There is no present in the world. That's all.

Yes? Any question? No, no. Brian knows it all. Oh, absolutely.

And now we'd like Bhante Piyananda to give us a Dharma talk. Thank you, Bhante.

Sādhu, sādhu, sādhu. The incumbent of London Buddhist Vihāra. The sisters. Members of the various denominations. Distinguished guests who participate in this ceremony.

I'm very happy to state here for the invitation that you extended to participate at this occasion by the Bhikkhu Bodhidhamma and the supporters of this place. I can remember the day that the foundation stone was laid at this place. It is obvious that Bhikkhu Bodhidhamma had taken a lot of pains to improve this place during the last four years. He has performed a difficult task in a place where the Buddhism do not exist to that extent.

Today we unveil a pagoda, which is a very important monument Buddhism is concerned. Especially countries like Burma, Sri Lanka, the pagoda is revered and given much importance. The constructing of *stūpas* had taken place with the first visit of Buddha to Sri Lanka. Later, this became one of the most important sites in pagodas,

sites in the Buddhist vihāras. That is because it symbolises Buddha, Lord Buddha. At the latter stage, this was the—this has become a symbol of what you follow up to *Nibbāna* and ultimate goal, the *Nibbāna*.

There are various types of pagodas in these countries. I will now tell you very concisely. It is a pagoda in the shape of a heap of grain, in the shape of a bubble, in the shape of a bell, and in the shape of a bell. Like this, I think Sri Lanka has more importance than any other country in the world. In particular, Bodhidhamma Mahāthera, who was our teacher, has explained the pagoda of Anurādhapura in a new way. I think he has explained Anurādhapura in a way that is unique to this country.

The pagoda that Bhikkhu Bodhidhamma has constructed gives a new version to these pagodas. Because both of them have endeavoured to display by the dark circle the beings who are suffering with *avidyā* or the ignorance. The white circle, you would have seen the white circle out of the dark circle. The Bhikkhu Bodhidhamma had endeavoured to explain, saying, people who have gone forth with the Triple Gem, and who are with the *sammādiṭṭhi* here, or the correct view.

After that, you get at the foot of the pagoda, there are three circles that denotes the Buddha, Dhamma, Saṅgha. Then you can see—or rather I should call a bell-shaped, am I correct? A bell-shaped pagoda, which you may find difficult to tread on, and it displays the Five—Eight Noble Paths. If you can tread on this Eightfold Noble Path, the way that Bhikkhu Bodhidhamma has displayed, then I have no doubt you can reach *Nibbāna*. So that is what we unveil today.

So he has established this place. By that, he—stability. Stability. Yes, stability. We presume that because of Bodhidhamma, these endeavours will establish the permanency to this Satipānya retreat centre.

So we all, the Saṅgha, Mahāsaṅgha, wish that you all live peace, prosperity and happiness and that you will ultimately reach the goal that you hope to. So may all of you all be blessed.

And now we'd like to ask Sister Candrasiri to give us a few words, thank you.

It's a very great privilege to be here today and I'm really enjoying the fact that there are so many of you and from so many different cultures and backgrounds. This is one of the most exciting things I think about Buddhism at this time, that it's drawing people who've grown up in a Buddhist culture and also many people who've been drawn by the teachings about suffering and about the ending of suffering. That's certainly what drew me.

I have to confess that I wasn't really very interested in devotional practices when I first became a nun. I loved the teachings, I loved the meditation, and I loved the possibility of liberation from suffering. That certainly kept me going for a long time.

However, Venerable Bodhidhamma asked if I would say a few words about devotion this afternoon. Over the years, I've come to have a very strong sense of devotion myself and also to see the great value of this.

The devotion has arisen out of a sense of having contemplated the life of the Buddha. I found actually, strangely enough, the biggest thing for me was actually learning about the Buddha's experience with the monks and nuns, and how the discipline was established. There are some very remarkable stories about the things that the monks and nuns got up to, and there's a real sense of appreciation of the Buddha's brilliance in the way he established the order of the monastic community and the relationship between the lay community and the monastic community. He created a situation where many, many people could benefit. That brought great joy to my heart when I contemplated that. I thought there's no way I could think up such a wonderful social system.

Thinking about the benefits of devotion and why it's a wonderful occasion for us here together to be together, one of the things I realised as having grown up in a Western culture is that I have a very critical mind. Also I have quite a strong tendency to be an individual. I tend to think of myself as being rather special and rather important. I can suffer enormously because of maybe not being quite good enough, not being quite special enough. There are all kinds of ways that I can cause myself suffering.

These occasions for devotion invite us to go beyond that self-centredness, self-preoccupation. They invite us to contemplate the possibility of liberation, the possibility of liberation from selfishness, from foolishness, to be lifted, to be carried by each other. When we perform the circumambulation of the *stūpa*, when we chant the *suttas*, we join together in recollecting the teachings, in celebrating the fact of the Buddha and his enlightenment. Something happens in the heart. It's not a rational thing, but there's a sense of being nourished, a sense of joy can arise, a sense of letting go and just entering into something altogether.

Spiritual training is not easy. Those of you who've come here for retreats, I'm sure have found it wonderful in the end, but I imagine that maybe the beginning, and certainly the middle, may have been quite difficult. It's at times like that that these practices of devotion can really help us to go beyond, to recollect our possibility, our capacity for liberation, can keep us going, can keep us treading the path.

So I encourage you to—and I'd really just like to celebrate the fact that we have this place here in Britain, a place that we can come to, that we can come and pay homage to the Buddha, the Dhamma, the Saṅgha, and contemplate the teachings, contemplate this possibility that each one of us has to free the heart from all suffering. It takes a bit of effort, it takes a lot of encouragement, but I would like to just encourage everybody to, having come here, maybe for the first time, maybe you've been coming for many, many years, just to keep coming, to keep treading the path, and may you all experience perfect liberation, may we all experience perfect liberation from all *dukkha*, which is what the Buddha has promised us that we are capable of. So let's not forget that.

Can we have one or two volunteers just to hand these little presents out to the monks? One or two volunteers?

Finally, I'd like to ask Dr Sita Sriwadana, who has been our chairman of the Trust since it was founded, to say a few words.

You're going to turn it up. If you can't hear, please tell me. I'm going to try without the mic. Okay?

Venerable sirs and friends in the Dhamma, it is with great pleasure and a sense of pride that I welcome you all here today on behalf of Bhante Bodhidhamma and all the trustees of the Satipānya Trust. I'd like to thank you all for joining us in this ceremony.

We are especially happy that our two senior monks, Venerable Premasiri and Venerable Piyananda were able to come from Sri Lanka to officiate. And to Venerable Dhammaloka, head of the London Buddhist Vihāra and to representatives and the nuns from Amaravati and representatives of all other religious denominations here. Thank you all. A warm welcome.

Even though this is a small spiritual enterprise, you would be surprised at the number of people who have been involved in the past ten years since the Trust was founded. The list is so long, and for fear of favour, I shall only mention the three persons who were crucial to this day. Firstly, Roy Griffiths, who did all the groundwork and set up the base of the *stūpa*. I wonder if I can ask you to raise your hand, Roy? Well, he's disappeared. Then there's Gary Higgins, a master stonemason who built the *stūpa*. Can you raise your hand, Gary? And Archie Kennedy, who fashioned the reliquary but was unable to be here today.

In our custom, we say thank you by joining our hands together and saying *sādhū* three times. Can we say *sādhū*? *Sādhū*. *Sādhū*. *Sādhū*.

We have progressed a great deal from our small beginnings in April 2007, when this property was purchased. It has been extensively repaired and upgraded. On 30 June 2007, the formal opening ceremony of this retreat took place, which was attended by senior Buddhist monks from Sri Lanka and London, by well-wishers, by supporters and members of the local community.

Retreats have been conducted here from that time. The retreat programme is open to all, including the general public. Its aim is to integrate *vipassanā* meditation practice into ordinary daily life. Don't worry, it's only another page. There are also opportunities to study Buddhism and to benefit from periods of calm, reflection and contemplation. Further opportunities are available to test the monastic life for both men and women.

We have already had three men who have experienced this and I believe two women are next to do so.

Today marks the culmination of the construction of the *stupa* by placing the reliquary on it. The stupa varies slightly in shape in different countries of the world. I think the Rev. Piyananda is trying to explain to you about that. But the basic form is based on an inverted bowl. This stupa is built of Welsh slate in keeping with the surroundings.

Stupas house Buddhist relics and that is why we are here today to place a reliquary which has the Buddhist relics and a DVD of all the Buddhist scriptures on the stupa and thus complete it. We are pleased to have done all this work in four years, and I invite all of you to make more use of this center in such peaceful surroundings.

Our future plans are to make the center accessible to wheelchair users, and at the same time, extend the area for walking meditation, and also provide space for formal retreatants. We appeal to you to help us with this project.

Finally, I hope you have all had a peaceful and uplifting day. On behalf of Bhante and the trustees, I wish you all a long and healthy life and a safe journey home. Thank you.

It's now 3.45 and it's time for tea. Thank you all for coming. Thank you.

The Discourse on Not-self — Anattalakkhana Sutta (SN 22.59)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 23 min

In this profound teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma guides us through the Anattalakkhana Sutta (SN 22.59), traditionally considered the Buddha's second discourse given to his five mendicant companions in the deer park at Benares. This pivotal sutta reveals how each of the five khandhas — rūpa (form/body), vedanā (feeling), saññā (perception), saṅkhāra (volitional formations), and viññāṇa (consciousness) — demonstrates our fundamental lack of control and ownership.

Bhante carefully explains how the Buddha used systematic questioning to show that none of these aggregates can be considered 'mine,' 'I am this,' or 'this is myself.' Through examining our limited control over bodily functions, emotions, perceptions, habits, and consciousness itself, we discover that the center of control lies elsewhere. The teaching progresses through the three characteristics: impermanence (anicca), unsatisfactoriness (dukkha), and not-self (anattā).

This talk is particularly valuable for practitioners struggling with the concept of anattā, offering clear explanations of why identity and the grasping for control create suffering. Bhante emphasizes that this isn't a denial of conventional selfhood, but rather a teaching tool for liberation from delusive identification. The discourse concludes with the beautiful description of liberation: 'What had to be done has been done' — the ending of false becoming and the realization of nibbāna through non-grasping.

Good evening. I hope you've had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa.

Homage to the blessed one. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So I am going to labour the point. It's just to carry on with this not-self, because I remember my own personal confusion when I came across this teaching for the first time. It seemed to be saying that there was a not-self, which seemed very confusing,

and a denial of a self. So the Buddha doesn't deny that there's a self. He just says it's unreal. And the not-self is a teaching tool. It's a way of saying, well, this is not me, it's not mine, and it's not myself.

So the discourse I want to look at tonight is traditionally the second one he gave to his disciples — sorry, to his five friends, or who had been his five friends during that time when he was self-mortifying mainly through not eating. If you remember, he approaches them and of course they don't respect him anymore — he's gone soft. But as he does approach, they see that something's changed. And when he begins to speak he keeps asking them, have you ever heard me speak like this before? And just very slowly they open up to his teaching, and one of them actually becomes what we call a stream-enterer, just the first step of four steps that take us to liberation.

So now, during the day, of course, they go off. Well, I would have thought it was some time, days maybe, because he does say that three of them went for alms round and came back, and they all shared. Sometimes it was two of them went on alms round. But it's been formalized into what's known as the *Anattalakkhaṇa Sutta*, the discourse on not-self. So this, in a sense, encapsulates this whole teaching. So we'll just go through it and you'll see how it works.

So again, he's at Benares in that deer park where he's met his five mendicants and he's talking to them and he says, is form — now this word *rūpa* is often translated as form, but obviously for us as human beings it's basically the body. Everything has form, everything has some sort of spatial reality — a cupboard, a table — but as far as we're concerned as human beings, the *rūpa* refers to this body. So he asks, is this body — this body is not self, he says to them.

So the identity to the body is an illusion, is a delusion. And he says, well, if this body were you, you'd be able to have control over it. You'd be able to say, do not fall sick. Do not suffer from any affliction. You'd be able to tell it to grow a bit more, or I would anyway, and to have more hair on the head. It doesn't matter to me at this present time, but there was a time when I could have done with more hair on my head. But unfortunately, the centre of control is elsewhere.

So this is the important point. Where is the centre of control? Where is the power? Who controls the body to stop it ageing, to stop it dying, falling ill? Of course, we can move our arms around and shake our heads and all that, but it's very superficial. It's a bit like driving a car, isn't it? I mean, when you're in a car driving, you feel you're in control, but actually the car's propelling itself. It's got all sorts of stuff going on and

anything can go wrong any time. And then when, of course, it breaks down or a tyre bursts, then you realise you're not in control of the car. The control is quite superficial. So it's the same with the body.

And when you realise that, you begin to realise that, how does he put it now? This body is not mine. You use it, but you don't actually own it. That's the distinction. Like with all objects, the ownership of an object is a legal fiction. I mean, we all agree to it. For instance, this is my laptop. But that's just an agreement that we have between us as human beings. The fact is, I don't actually own it. Of course this ownership gets very big because then people own their houses, states own their country, and that causes all sorts of problems, this idea of possessing something. And the body is not me — see, there's a disjunction, there's some sort of separation between me and the body because the body won't do what I tell it to. And I am not the body.

So this sense of self that I have is not the body. So again, we're going always back to identity. This was the big breakthrough of the Buddha, this problem of identity. If identity manifested as delusive action, it caused *dukkha*. So that's why the Four Noble Truths are phrased in what we can actually experience — unsatisfactoriness, suffering. But the root cause is this problem of identity.

So then he goes on to talk about feeling. Now, feelings are both physical and emotional, heart feelings. So again, if you hurt your body, you bump your knee or something, or you bite your tongue, then at that moment, you're not in charge of the body. The body actually goes into a spasm of pain. And you can't say, well, I don't want this pain. The pain remains. If you've got a headache, you have a headache. And you realise that when it comes to actually feelings in the body, again, very little control. You can take tablets these days, of course, but that's just covering over the pain.

When it comes to emotions, if you feel sad, you feel sad. You can distract yourself, you can listen to some music or something or jump up and down and dance or whatever, but you can't get rid of the sadness that way. It's just buried underneath this attempt to escape it. So you realise that we have very little power over our emotions. They arise and pass away. And this of course becomes obvious when you're sitting. You might sit with every intention to get deeply concentrated, have these wonderful insights, and all you have is these emotions coming up. One minute there's all sorts of anxiety, there's excitement, and then you're depressed and then you're angry. Oh, it's just a waterfall of uncontrolled emotions, uncontrollable emotions.

Then we have perception. Now perception belongs to the mind, that part which thinks — it thinks not only in an abstract sense of thoughts, words, but also in imagery, in imagination. So if I said the word cat, you not only understand what that means in-

tellectually — you know what it's got four legs and a little tail and all that — but also you have an image in your mind of what a cat is. So you know it's not a dog. We can normally tell clearly that this is a cat, it is not a dog.

And these perceptions are not controlled by us. They arise because we see things, we hear things, we touch things, we smell things, we taste things, and then we make a photocopy of it. And the more we experience something that we see every day — a car for instance — it builds up a concept about it, an image which runs with the concept, concrete concept. So you know that this is a car, it's not a truck, it's not a train, it's not a plane. And then of course it gets very subtle because then it gets very big — like freedom, democracy. But all these things are given to us. And they develop through our experience, through our cultures and so on. And you can't get rid of it. You can't get rid of your sense of what your personal freedom means to you. You can change it, but you can't get rid of it. It's just there within you.

It's the next part, the *saṅkhāra*, where we have some sort of choice, where we do have some sort of power. And all the time he's saying, well, these feelings, these perceptions, this body — you see, it's not right to say this is mine. You don't possess it. It changes of its own power. I was going to say free will, but there's no free will. It changes because of its own power. The eyes have a power to see. There's a process of vision which comes when the retina receives an object and you have this mentation going on, the whole process that's happening within the mind, within the brain mind. The brain would be the sensitive base for the mind.

Now, when it comes to *saṅkhāra*, which are the volitional conditionings — our habits, I much prefer just the word habits — you can't get rid of a habit. You can change it. You can draw it down so that it doesn't have any effect on you, but even in an *arahat*, old habits will arise, even those that belong to delusiveness. They'll arise but they have no power. They're called *vāsanā*, they're called leftovers, traces, traces of past habits. The Buddha is said to have got rid of all of those, but that again is just hagiography, turning the Buddha into some magical being, some hyper-human being, a beyond-human being. But as a human being you would have had habits. That's what a human being is — is the body and a process of habituation.

And again, when you see these habits come, when you find yourself in or acting out of a habit, you can become an observer of it. You can be aware of it and realise, well, I don't have to possess this. If I have an attitude of possessing it, I'm going to be — it's going to be difficult for me to change it. If I identify with it — I remember an old aunt saying, if she behaved like that it wouldn't be me. So a very stuck idea of who I am, and

that just produces staleness, it produces stagnancy. Whereas we want to be able to flow, to flow with events and to change with events. And that's how our lives grow, hopefully towards what is beneficial.

By the way, I did see a little cartoon about going with the flow. It just said, only dead fish go with the flow. I don't think that's the meaning here.

Then finally we have this consciousness. Now consciousness is the fifth of the *khandhas*. So remember the *khandha*, we've just been through them — the body, feelings, perceptions, habits and consciousness. Consciousness only arises when it is impinged upon, when something touches it. So it's like a screen, just like this screen that I'm looking at, like a monitor. There has to be an object. There has to be an object that impinges upon a sense base. So a light must impinge upon the eye, a sound must impinge upon the ear, something must come out of, for want of a better word, the subconscious — some sort of image, some sort of emotion which arises and then touches upon this screen, upon this screen of consciousness.

Now that screen of consciousness is not always there because it's being touched constantly by different impulses, by different stimuli. And you can't stop being conscious. I mean, you can put yourself asleep. Obviously when we go to sleep, we lose consciousness. You can hit yourself on the head and lose consciousness. But while we're awake, you cannot be not conscious. Your consciousness just arises because it's constantly being awoken by stimulus. So we don't have that control over consciousness. Whenever I put my eye on something, I become aware of it. It becomes part of my consciousness. So again, this idea of control.

Now, if the centre of control is elsewhere, then it can't be me. That's one of the definitions of I, I, me. I know I'm not you because I can't control you. I know I'm not something outside me because I have limited control. I can move objects, I can control them, but they're still objects, they're still outside me, so I know it's not me.

Now when you're meditating, you're taking a position within yourself of identifying with the observer, the feeler. Once you're in that position, everything's an object, and it's not under your control. The body offers feelings, sensations, the heart offers its moods and emotions, and the mind its thoughts and images, whether you want it to or not. It isn't under your direct control when you're in the position of the observer, the feeler, the experiencer, the one who knows in *vipassanā*.

Somebody's actually translated *saṅkhāra* as choices. There's a very good website called Sutta Central — that's just one word, sutta central — and there's another one, Ancient Buddhist Texts, by Ānandajoti, who's an English monk who lives in Thailand. I've known him for a very long time. He also has a little website I just pointed out, Dharma Documentaries. They're really quite good. I'll post this up at some point.

So now, having explored the idea of control, the Buddha then goes on to impermanence. "Ever-changing! What do you think, mendicants?" — that's another word for *bhikkhu* — "is form permanent or impermanent?" So is the body permanent or impermanent? So the answer is impermanent, venerable sir.

"And if it's impermanent, is that suffering or happiness?" Now, those two words, *dukkha*, *sukha*, you can translate as suffering or happiness, but I think it makes more sense to say, is that satisfying? Is it unsatisfying? Because one of the translations of *dukkha* is unsatisfactoriness. And of course they say, "No sir, it is unsatisfactory." "And if it's impermanent, unsatisfactory and perishable, is it fit to be regarded as 'this is mine, I am this, this is myself'?" Well the answer of course is, "No, venerable sir." So there's your basic questions — the basic question is: is it permanent or impermanent?

Now all these things are permanent or impermanent. If it's impermanent, is that satisfying for you? I mean, if you arrive at a beautiful state of mind and then it disappears, that's not very satisfactory. You want to try and maintain it, you want to try and develop it maybe. And then he goes through the rest of it. Feelings — so feelings, are they permanent, impermanent? Now this permanent/impermanent is not — it's not just changing all the time, they are completely new moments. Every consciousness is arising and passing away. So it's at that fundamental level the impermanence is immediate. Even now consciousnesses are arising and passing away in me and in you at a speed such that we're not aware of it. So it gives some idea of continuity, but in Buddhist psychology these consciousnesses are flashing, they're flashing moment after moment.

So then of course with perception. So perceptions arise and pass away just as quickly. And is that desirable? Is that undesirable? Sometimes it is, sometimes it isn't.

Then we have what he calls choices in this particular translation, Sujato Bhikkhu. But habits, I much prefer the word habits. Are they permanent, impermanent? They're constantly changing. They're either getting worse or getting better. And so on.

Consciousness is the very seat of impermanence because that's, as I say, flashing and arising and passing away. So none of this can be satisfactory to a sense of self because the sense of self wants to be in control. The identity, me — I want to be in control and I find myself not so.

So then he goes on to say, "So you should truly see any kind of form" — so it's any kind of form, but here especially the body — "past, future, present, internal, external, coarse or fine, inferior or superior, far or near, all form" — the whole material world is empty. Now that's the word *śūnya*, and I do believe he actually uses the word *śūnya* here. And the other word he uses in other scriptures is *suñña*, which means empty — it doesn't have any substance. And this of course was taken into a more metaphysical understanding by the Mahāyāna, that everything is empty. But in the Theravāda's discourses, the Buddha is very much centred on the person, on me, me and you, trying to really imprint upon us this idea that nothing is permanent and nothing has any substance.

So this is what happens. When you begin to investigate this, then this word *nibbidā* — and it's translated variously, but the one I particularly like is disillusioned — disillusion grows. And then because of that disillusion your desire fades away — *virāga santīti*. It's interesting.

I'm getting a lot of funny live chat.

And then finally, with that desire fades away, when all desire, the wrong desire fades away, then of course you are left with the experience of *nibbāna*, not-self, which is that experience of something that is beyond the five aggregates, and we'll come to that at another time.

And then finally, when a person is fully liberated, there's this lovely way of talking about it. That rebirth is ended. This constant production of a self, of a false self is ended. The spiritual journey has been completed. What had to be done has been done. That's a lovely feeling about that. What has to be done has been done. And there's no return to this constant becoming of a false self, of a false being, becoming.

And so, satisfied, the group of five mendicants were happy. And while the discourse was being spoken, the minds of the group of the five mendicants were freed from defilements by non-grasping, by losing that sense of desire. And in other words, they all became fully liberated. So let's hope that bit is true.

So I think that virtually concludes my effort to try and get across this teaching about not-self, which some of you may have found quite confusing. So remember, it's all about identity. It's about me. Who am I? I mean, that's a question you can always ask. Who am I or what am I? That would be Korean Zen. What am I?

And tomorrow, I'll talk more about the actual process of meditation. And then I have some questions that have come in and I'll tackle that in a couple of days time after tomorrow.

Upāli is Converted by the Buddha (MN 56)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

In this engaging discourse on the Upāli Sutta (MN 56), Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the Buddha's encounter with a wealthy Jain householder named Upāli in Nālandā. The talk centers on a crucial debate about which creates the most unwholesome kamma: bodily actions, verbal actions, or mental actions. While the Jain leader Nātaputta taught that bodily actions (the 'bodily rod') were most blameworthy, the Buddha maintained that mental actions hold primary importance in creating kamma.

The episode beautifully illustrates how Upāli, initially confident he could defeat the Buddha in debate, becomes convinced through skillful questioning and examples. The Buddha demonstrates that all actions begin in the mind with intention (cetanā), making mental cultivation paramount. The discourse culminates with Upāli's conversion and attainment of stream-entry, showing the transformative power of right understanding.

Bhante connects this teaching to the opening verses of the Dhammapada, emphasizing that 'all experience is preceded by mind, led by mind, made by mind.' This fundamental principle underlies all Buddhist practice, showing why mindful awareness of mental states is essential for preventing unwholesome actions and cultivating liberation. The talk offers both doctrinal insight and practical guidance for meditators.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambhodassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and fully self-awakened one.

This little talk is around a discourse called On Upāli. The Buddha meets this Jain who's called Upāli. It links in with the last moon teaching, although it's not necessary to have listened to that one, about *cetanā*, about will, and what comes first — the body, the mind or speech — in terms of creating *kamma*.

I'd like to start with the verses that open the Dhammapada, which is this collection of verses by the Buddha. All experience, all actions are preceded by the mind, led by the mind, made by the mind. Speak or act with a corrupted mind and suffering follows as the wagon wheel follows the hoof of an ox. And the opposite: all experience is preceded by mind, led by mind, made by mind. Speak or act with a peaceful mind or a wholesome mind and happiness follows like a never departing shadow.

Here we have this discourse. For those of you who want to know, it's in the *Majjhima Nikāya* number 56, the middle length sayings number 56. The Buddha is at Nālandā, which was a big town and became a very important university town, a big study town. At the same time the Jain leader had turned up with his group of monks and nuns.

You'll know the Jains — you know the big Kumbh Mela that they have every 24 years in India where according to this figure 100 million devotees gathered on the Ganges? And you've seen those naked ascetics, the Digambaras — they're the sky-clad or the space-clad. They are Jain monks. But they've also got a section of *Śvetāmbaras*, which means they are dressed in white. So this Jain turns up. He doesn't say whether he's a Digambara or not. By the way, they're grey because they rub ash into their body, which is an antiseptic.

This fellow called Dīgha Tapassī turns up and goes to have a chat with the Buddha, just out of interest. The Buddha asks him, "How many actions does the Jain leader Nātaputta describe for the making of evil *kamma*, the production of evil *kamma*?"

Tapassī replies, "Friend Gotama, the Jain, our leader, isn't used to using the word action. He uses the word rod." Now, a rod was obviously used as an instrument of punishment, apart from anything else. What the Jain leader was saying was that every time you did something which was unwholesome, you were basically beating yourself.

So he asks, "Well, how many rods does the Jain leader describe?" He says, "Well there are three rods: the bodily rod, the verbal rod and the mental rod." "And is the bodily rod one thing, the verbal rod another and the mental rod another thing?" "More," he says, "yes, they are all three different things, all these three rods."

Says the Buddha, "Thus analysed, thus differentiated, which rod does the Nigaṇṭha-Nātaputta" — that's his correct name as the Jain leader — "describe as the most greatly blameworthy for the making of evil *kamma*, the production of evil *kamma*: the bodily rod, the verbal rod or the mental rod?"

The Nigaṇṭha replies that the bodily rod is the most greatly blameworthy for the making of evil *kamma*, the production of evil *kamma*, not so much the verbal rod, not so much the mental rod.

Now you get this little bit of repartee, which it seems in those days, you got the person to repeat what they said three times so they couldn't say, "I didn't say that." So: "Did you say the bodily rod?" "I say the bodily rod, friend Gotama." "Do you say the bodily rod, Dīgha Tapassī?" "I say bodily rod, friend Gotama." "Do you say bodily rod, Dīgha

Tapassī?" "I say bodily rod, friend Gotama." Now I should think it was just a little bit more repartee like: "Are you sure it's the bodily rod?" "I'm absolutely sure." "Is this what your teacher told you?" and so forth.

Now having stated his position, Tapassī asks the Buddha, he says, "Well, what about you, Gotama?" — calls him friend Gotama. "How many rods do you describe?" And the Buddha replies that the Tathāgata doesn't use the word rod, he uses the word action. So he says, "Well, okay. Which of these actions does friend Gotama describe as making evil *kamma*, the production of *kamma*?" "Well, there are three actions: the body, the speech and the mind." "And is bodily action one thing, verbal action another, mental action still another?" The Buddha says, "Yes, this is so."

"And of these three actions, thus analysed, thus differentiated, friend Gotama, which action do you describe as the most greatly blameworthy for the making of evil *kamma*, the production of evil *kamma*? Is it bodily action, verbal action or mental?" And the Buddha replies, "Of all these three, it is the mental action which is the most greatly blameworthy for the making of evil *kamma*."

"Did you say mental action, friend Gotama?" "I said mental action." "Did you say mental action, friend Gotama?" "I said mental action, Dīgha Tapassī." "Are you sure you said mental action, friend Gotama?" "I did say mental action."

At this point, the Jain leaves. He's had enough. He can't take any more. He goes back to the leader, the Jain leader, and he explains what happened. The Jain leader praises him. He says, "You've rightly understood the message of the teacher." And then he makes fun of the Buddha. He says, "What does the trivial mental rod count in comparison to the gross bodily rod?"

Anyway, there's a certain Upāli who's listening to this. He's a householder. I couldn't quite find out what he did, but he obviously lived in Nālandā and he had some sort of huge mansion because he has servants. So I'm presuming he's either a landlord or a merchant, because merchants were becoming quite rich at that time.

He says to the Nigaṇṭha, "Look, I'm going to go to the Buddha and I'm going to overthrow Gotama the contemplative's teachings on the ground of his position." And then he gives these wonderful similes on how he's going to treat the Buddha. He says, "Just as a strong man seizing a long-haired ram by the hair would drag him to and drag him fro and drag him all around, in the same way, I, statement by statement, will drag Gotama the contemplative to and drag him fro and drag him all around." And then he gives more and more similes of how he's going to treat this poor Gotama the Contemplative.

So now the Jain leader says, "Yes, you go and refute his argument." Now Dīgha Tapassī says, "Oh, I'm not so sure this is right that a householder Upāli should try that," he says, "because Gotama the Contemplative is a magician and he knows a converting magic by which he converts disciples of other sects." So the Buddha has this magic whereby he can convince you that he's right.

By the way, Moggallāna, who was one of the two chief disciples — if you remember, Moggallāna and Sāriputta — he was actually murdered, seemingly, by a sect for converting them, for converting their members to the Buddha Dhamma. He died in Rājagaha. I think it's Rajgir today, yes. He died just shortly before the Buddha. He was killed before the Buddha.

Anyway, off he goes and he goes off to see the Buddha. When he meets the Buddha, the Buddha says to him, "If, householder, you will confer taking a stand on the truth, we might have a discussion here." "Lord, I will confer to stand on the truth. Let us have some discussion here."

"So what do you think, householder? There might be a case where a Nigaṇṭha, a Jain, is diseased, pained, severely ill, refusing cold water and taking warm water. He not getting cold water would die. Where would the leader describe his reappearance?" Now exactly why he should die because he doesn't get cold water, there's no explanation for that.

So Upāli replies, "He would be born amongst the gods attached in mind. He reappears there." "Why is that?" "He is bound by mind when he dies." So the mental state determines where he will be reborn. So the Buddha says, "Oh householder, pay attention. Answer only after having paid attention. What you said after isn't consistent with what you said before, nor is what you said before consistent with what you said after." So there's a little bit of argy-bargy there.

Then he gives him a second example. "There might be a case where a Nigaṇṭha is constrained by the fourfold constraints" — so this is the four precepts of not harming, not stealing, not being unchaste and lying — "and then he says constrained by all the constraints" — so this is all the rules and regulations of the order of Jains — "and as he walks to and fro he brings many small beings to destruction. What karmic result would the Jain leader describe for him?" "What is unintended, Lord, the Nigaṇṭha-Nātaputta does not describe as greatly blameworthy." "But if he intends it?" asks the Buddha. "Greatly blameworthy, Lord." "And under what does the Nigaṇṭha-Nātaputta classify intention?" "Under the mental rod, Lord." "Householder, pay attention. Answer after having paid attention. What you said after isn't consistent with what you said before, nor what is what you said before consistent with what you said after."

Then he gives a couple of examples which are a bit difficult for us. So he asks Upāli, for instance, if a man with a sword were to go into Nālandā, would he be able to kill everybody in that city? And Upāli says, "No, it's not possible." He said, "But supposing he had through the power of mind, through the mastery of mind, superhuman power, could he do it then?" So Upāli said, "Yes, he could." So then he said, "Ah, see what comes first in terms of importance, the mind or the body?" So he gives another example about wildernesses which we don't need to go into.

Anyway, with the last example Upāli gives in and he confesses. "Lord, I was gratified and won over by the Blessed One's first simile. But, wanting to hear these very artful ways of handling questions from the Blessed One, I thought I should treat him as an opponent. Magnificent, Lord, magnificent, just as if he were to place upright what was overturned, to reveal what was hidden, to show the way to one who was lost, or to carry a lamp into the dark so that those with eyes could see forms — in this way the Blessed One through many lines of reasoning made the Dhamma clear. I go to the Blessed One for refuge, to the Dhamma, to the Saṅgha. May the Blessed One remember me as a lay follower who has gone forth to him for refuge from this day forward for life."

Well, the next thing the Buddha said really impresses Upāli because he says, "Look, make a careful scrutiny, householder. It is good for well-known people like yourself to make careful scrutiny." In other words, don't make up your mind until you've delved a little more into the teachings. Now this impresses him. But the next one is even more impressive, seemingly for that time. "Householder, your family compound has long been like a waterhole for the Jains, and you should consider that alms food should be given to them when they come for it."

Now there's an occasion in the scriptures where the Buddhist monks and nuns are in the shrine, these big parks where they had these shrines. There's lots of food left over after the lay people have offered. So Ānanda says to the Buddha, "What should we do with all this food?" He says, "Well, offer it to these other sects." But when the lay people heard this, they were very angry. "We don't feed people who are Jains. We don't do that. We fed you. We don't want you to feed them with our food." So there's a rule. I can't offer food or a cup of tea to a priest or to a Muslim mullah or anybody who belongs to another sect. So that's how it was in those days. So this obviously impresses Upāli that the Buddha should say, "Look, you should continue to feed the Jains."

Then the Buddha gives him what's known as the graduated talk. He talks about generosity. He talks about virtue. He talks about what happens when you die with a virtuous, generous heart — you're born into a heavenly place. He then talks about the draw-

backs of being devoted to sensuality and the rewards of renunciation. And then, when the householder was of ready mind, malleable mind, unhindered mind, exultant mind, confident mind, he proclaimed to him the distinctive teaching of the awakened ones: suffering, the cause of suffering, the cessation of suffering, and the path leading to the cessation of suffering.

Right there, there arose in Upāli the householder, in that very seat, the dustless, stainless dharma eye: "Whatever is subject to arising is subject to disappearing." In other words, he saw impermanence deep enough for him to become a stream enterer, which is the first rung of awakening.

Now he's very happy. He goes home and of course the news gets back to the Nigaṇṭha, to the Jain leader, that Upāli has now become a disciple of the Buddha. Well he can't believe it. He said it's not possible. So off he goes to see Upāli.

He gets to the household and Upāli has told his gatekeeper not to let them in. So the Nigaṇṭha says to the gatekeeper, "Look, you go and tell Upāli that I'm here and I want to talk to him." So eventually he gives in and he arranges the middle gate hall. So I presume that there was a wall around the mansion or whatever he had — this large place — and you came in and there was some sort of sheltered place where I would presume mendicants were invited in and fed, and in it there would be a seat, a proper high seat for the leader. Well he takes the high seat — Upāli takes the high seat — and the Nigaṇṭhas come in, the Jains come in.

This is what he says to Upāli, the householder. "You've gone mad, householder. You're an arrogant fool. Having gone saying, 'Lord, I am going, I will overthrow Gotama the contemplative's teachings,' you've come back tied up in a web of his doctrine. It's just as if a man, having gone to remove someone else's testicles, comes back with his own removed." That's good, isn't it? "Or as if a man, having gone to gouge somebody else's eyes out, comes back with his own gouged out. In the same way, having gone saying, 'Lord, I am going to overthrow Gotama the contemplative's teachings,' you've come back tied up in the web of his doctrine. You've been converted, householder, by Gotama the contemplative's converting magic."

And Upāli replies, "Oh auspicious, venerable sir, is the converting magic. Admirable, venerable sir, is the converting magic." And seemingly then the Jain leader gets so upset he spews blood or something like that. So they leave and there's an occasion here where Upāli goes on to create this lovely poem to the Buddha, these lovely verses in which he praises the Buddha.

This whole story is really coming back to this position that the Buddha says that nothing happens unless it's first of all happened in the mind. It's within the mind that we have this will, this *cetanā*, and it's these decisions that we make that produce our actions — in this case unwholesome actions. It all begins in the mind. So as soon as we're aware of something in the mind which is unwholesome and we allow it to arise and pass away, then it cannot express itself through our words, through our speech and through our actions.

I would just like to finish by repeating again those opening verses from the Dhammapada. All experience or actions is preceded by mind, led by mind, made by mind. Speak or act with a corrupted mind and suffering follows as the wagon wheel follows the hoof of the ox. All experience is preceded by mind, led by mind, made by mind. Speak or act with a peaceful mind, wholesome mind, and happiness follows like a never departing shadow.

I can only hope my little discourse has been of some assistance, that it does not cause confusion, and that by your practice of the Dharma, you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Contemplating the Unpleasantness of the Body: Why and How

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

In this teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma guides practitioners through the asubha contemplations, a meditation practice focused on examining the unpleasant or repulsive aspects of the body. Drawing from the Giramananda Sutta, he explains how these contemplations help undermine our wrong relationship with the body - both the sense of ownership ('I have a body') and identification ('I am this body') that lead to suffering.

The talk begins by acknowledging the preciousness of human life and the body's essential role in our spiritual development. Bhante then leads through the traditional contemplation, examining the body from hair to urine, encouraging practitioners to notice their reactions without judgment. He shares the cautionary tale from the Pāli Canon where monks took this practice to dangerous extremes, leading to the Buddha establishing new guidelines.

The session concludes with a gratitude practice, offering thanks to each part of the body for its service. This balanced approach helps develop healthy detachment while maintaining proper care and respect for the body as our vehicle for liberation. The teaching emphasizes that the goal is not disgust but understanding the body's true nature - subject to decay and not to be mistaken for our true identity.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhassa

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So I thought this evening we'd have a look at the contemplation of the body. Now the Buddha actually offers us quite a few ways of doing it, but I'm going to go for the *asubha* contemplations, which translates as the repulsive or the unpleasant parts of the body. It's going to be really wonderful.

First of all, the purpose of the exercise is to undermine our wrong relationship to the body whereby we own it. It's something that we have or we are. So we'll say things like "I have a headache" or "I've got weak knees," but then of course you will say "I am ill." So there's this dual relationship we have, both of which happen to be wrong and lead us to suffering. So that's the purpose of the exercise. There are other purposes but I'll mention them towards the end.

Now it's good to begin such an exercise by reminding ourselves how precious this life is. So here we experience this joy and woe, just like animals do, but we have this developed intelligence, this intuitive intelligence, which has come, according to Buddhism, through countless births. And because of that, we're in this place and we're able to make our way out of suffering.

There are other realms which you can also think of as mental states: the hell realm, so people who are, for instance, deeply depressed or in one of the more severe mental illnesses. There's the animal realm where people get drunk. There's the insatiable hungry ghost realm, people chasing money all the time. There's the human, of course. And then there's these angry gods. Unfortunately, we've got lots of experience of that at the moment with Ukraine and Gaza and Sudan. And finally there are the happy gods, all those wonderful multi-billionaires who are sitting on their yachts. So those areas, there's not much hope of finding liberation because nothing's pushing them. It's this lovely place of being happy and unhappy and it's an inability to maintain that happiness that leads us to seek the end of it all.

So, obviously, we can't be here without a body. That's number one. It's through the senses that we experience the world. Everything we come to know has come through the senses. Well, not everything, but virtually everything has come through the senses. It's through the body we relate, we communicate, we express ourselves. Through the body we work, we do things, we help others. In other words, creating good *kamma*. And in virtually every meditation technique, the body is always central to the process.

So before we go into these *asubha* contemplations, these disgusting contemplations, it's always good to apologise to the body for any harm we've done it. And I've got this little verse which you can repeat after me and that gives you a starting point for this contemplation. So just closing your eyes for a moment:

"Whatever harm I have done to you in thought, word and deed, by way of greed, hatred and delusion, intentionally or unintentionally, I'm heartily sorry for it, and I determine from this day on to treat you with due care and respect."

Now this puts us into a good relationship with the body.

Now, this is what the Buddha tells us in the Dhammapada: "Having understood that this body is like foam, having realised its mirage-like nature, having cut off Māra's flower-tipped arrows, one should make himself invisible to the king of death." So these flower-tipped arrows are these little pushes we get for just that extra bit of cake and do this and do that, led by greed. And then he says, "Knowing that this body is like foam,

fully awake to the mirage-like nature, cutting off Māra's flowers, one goes unseen by the king of death." In other words, once we've cut out our wrong relationship with the world, we can presume that dying will no longer be something to be feared.

So I'm taking this exercise from a discourse, the Giramananda Sutta. He's sick and Ānanda's gone to the Buddha and says, "What can we do for him?" So he says, "Well, give him these 10 contemplations." So I won't go through the 10 contemplations, but two of them are the unpleasantness of the body and then its drawbacks.

So now the idea is, as I read through these different parts of the body and you're sitting in meditation, as you contact them through your imagination and through your memory, through your nose, through your eyes, just catch your relationship. Most of them I think you'll find fairly neutral, but some you'll have some relationship of disgust at some level or other. So it's really getting in touch with that and recognising that it's not necessary. We don't have to feel disgusted with the body because the body is just what it is.

And then after that, we'll just run through all these wonderful things, these horrible things that can happen to the body as a reminder that we must continue our meditation with vigour.

So if you just find yourself in a quiet place for a moment, I shall give you the instructions from the Buddha. So examining our body from the soles of the feet and down from the tips of the hair. We'll just go down. We won't come up again. So just starting at the top there, just the hair that's on the body.

And then there's nails, teeth, the skin, the muscles, the sinews, the bones, the bone marrow, the kidneys, the heart, the liver, the spleen, the lungs, the intestines, the bowels, the undigested food, the bile, the pus, the fat, the tears, the blood, saliva, snot, faeces, stools, and urine.

So now if you go back to the one where there was some sense of disgust, just bring it back to mind and just get in touch with that relationship. What does disgust really feel like? And then ask yourself, is it necessary? Can we change our relationship to it by seeing it differently? Function? Product? Biologically, scientifically.

In this way we come to accept the body just as it is.

But then the Buddha reminds us of all the things that can go wrong. And this is meant to give us that *samvega*, that sense of urgency to continue our practice.

"This body has much suffering and many drawbacks. This body is beset with many kinds of affliction, such as the following. Diseases of the eye, the inner ear, the nose, the tongue, the body, the head, the outer ear, the mouth, the teeth and lips. There's the cough and asthma, catarrh, inflammation, fever, stomachache, fainting, dysentery, gastric pain, cholera, leprosy, boils, eczema, tuberculosis, epilepsy, herpes, itch, scabs, smallpox, scabies, haemorrhages, diabetes, piles, pimples, ulcers and cancer. Afflictions stemming from disorders of the bile, phlegm, wind or their conjunction. Afflictions caused by changing weather, by not taking care of ourselves, by over-exertion or as a result of past deeds. Cold, heat, hunger, thirst, defecation and urination."

And so he asks us to meditate, observing the drawbacks of this body. So again, it's just recognising that the body is subject to disease. It's not gone beyond disease. It is of a nature to fall ill. This is meant to help us to begin to see the body in a different way, to take care of it, but not to be enthralled by it.

Now, by the way, on that list I added cancer. I don't know whether they had cancer or not in those days. It's not listed.

Anyway, what happened was that the Buddha did give this teaching about the unattractiveness of the body in praise of perceiving the unattractiveness of the body and in praise of development of the perception of the unattractiveness of the body. And he went off then for seclusion for half a month. And when he came out, he said to Ānanda, "Why does the Sangha of monks seem so depleted?"

"Because Lord, the Blessed One, with many lines of reasoning, gave monks the talk of unattractiveness. Spoke in praise of the development of the perception of unattractiveness. The monks thinking, the Blessed One, with many lines of reasoning, has given a talk on unattractiveness. They remained committed to the development of the perception of unattractiveness in many modes and manners. And they, ashamed, repelled or disgusted with the body, sought for an assassin. In one day ten monks took the knife, in one day twenty monks took the knife, in one day thirty monks took the knife. It would be good, Lord, if the Blessed One would explain another method so that this sangha of monks might be established in understanding."

Now, I can't imagine what the Buddha must have felt when he found out that this contemplation he'd given to his monks had driven them to suicide, and seemingly to monks helping people to commit suicide. In fact, it was on this occasion that he declared the first *pārājika*, which is a rule for the monks, which if you break it, you lose your ordination. So anything to do with killing another person is not allowed. So he gave them the contemplation of *jhāna* to produce beautiful mental states. Well, of course, you need time to do that sort of practice.

So another way of doing it is by offering gratitude to the body. But before we do that, let me just remind you of the purpose of this exercise. It's to encourage detachment from the body and to especially undermine that relationship of identity. It can sometimes be used, especially in the monastic orders, to cool sexual impulses. So the idea is that when some erotic idea comes to mind, you then remind yourself that this body is also not particularly erotic. And this should allow the sexual energy to die away. If, of course, a person were simply to continue developing that disgust of the body, then they would lose their sexual impulse completely. And it's to undermine society's emphasis on physical beauty and attractiveness.

So what I'm going to do is ask you to then go through the body in the same way from the top of the head all the way down to the toes and as you go down and you visualise that part of the body, just say thank you. Thank you for, for instance, give it a purpose if you want. So the skin, thank you for the protection you give this body. So just take your time going down and then when you finish that, just go into the meditation.

So it's offering gratitude to the body. And I think you'll find that all the cells jump up and down with great joy. Finally their work is being appreciated. So if we sit in silence and then just begin going down saying thank you to all the different parts of the body.

The Buddha's Alter Ego

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 24 min

In this engaging talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the prophecy made at the Buddha's birth: that he would become either a fully self-awakened Buddha or a cakkavatti (wheel-turning monarch). Drawing from the Cakkavatti-Sīhanāda Sutta (DN 26), he explores what the Buddha's life might have looked like had he chosen the path of righteous kingship.

Bhante discusses the seven treasures of the ideal monarch and the ten royal virtues (rājadhamma) that define righteous leadership: generosity (dāna), ethical conduct (sīla), self-sacrifice, honesty, gentleness, self-discipline, non-violence (ahiṃsā), patience, and harmony. He traces how these qualities mirror the Buddha's own characteristics, showing the connection between spiritual and temporal leadership.

The talk also examines the Buddha's involvement in contemporary politics, particularly his advice regarding the Vajji confederation's strength through seven factors of unity and governance. Bhante concludes by encouraging practitioners to follow the Buddha's example of engaged wisdom, becoming involved in the social and political issues of our time while maintaining the moral integrity that characterizes true leadership.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

This evening we're looking at the Buddha's alter ego, what he would have been if he hadn't become a Buddha. If you remember, eight wise men came to his birth and predicted that he would become a Buddha or a wheel-turning monarch. Seven of them said that, but there was one wise person who said that he would definitely become a self-awakened Buddha.

Now, his tribe, the Sakyan clan, was still governed in the old way. The warrior caste chose one of themselves to become the head person. It was an aristocracy. I'm sure that the Brahmins had some effect and maybe the merchants, but the essence was that somebody else could always be voted to be the head person.

As one tribe became more and more powerful, they began to conquer the different tribes. So the Buddha's own tribe, the Sakyas, were already vassals to the king of Kosala. We know from the way he organized the *Saṅgha*, the monks and nuns, that he didn't

really like the monarchical, the autocratic way of ruling. He didn't leave a leader when he died. He said he left the *Dhamma* and the *Vinaya*, the rule of the order. In Buddhism there's no Pope.

So he offers us this myth about the wheel-turning monarch. What happens is the *Dhamma* wheel appears to this particular king. This wheel appears and the king asks his advisers what the meaning of this appearance was. The counsellor says he has to follow it, and as he follows it the kingdoms will just become vassals to him.

He then follows this *Dhammacakka*, this *Dhamma* wheel, and he flies off into the air with it, taking with him his quadruple army, which is formed by his infantry, archers, chariots and elephants. He has what's known as his seven treasures. So the Buddha has seven factors of enlightenment, and this emperor has seven treasures.

The first thing, of course, is this miracle wheel which will guide him all over the world. He has a miracle horse that can fly through the air. He has a miracle elephant. I don't know what that does. And he has a gem that can cast light over a huge area, like the sun. He has a queen who is, of course, a beautiful woman. It is said that her limbs are cool in the hot season and warm in the cool season. He has a wise counsellor and a successful commander.

What actually gives him his power? It's his moral code, his integrity. Wherever he goes, he establishes peace. So the Buddha then gives us his ten qualities. This is what the Buddha is saying: that somebody who rules a country, our prime ministers and people like that, should have these ten qualities.

The first one is generosity. He's very giving with his wealth, and it makes people feel loyal to him. He sets a good example to the citizens by his ethical conduct. He will personally make sacrifices for the benefit of the people. He is very honest and straightforward. He promotes justice and trust. He's also gentle in approach, and so he can reduce conflicts and enhance peaceful relations.

He has self-control, self-discipline. He doesn't indulge himself. He doesn't give in to anger. He remains calm, and this makes him wise in his decisions. He promotes harmlessness, *ahimsa*, ensuring safety and security without violence, and in this way he spreads safety everywhere. He has patience. He can tolerate when things don't go right. And he advocates non-conflicts and harmony. He resolves disputes amicably, and in this way he maintains the unity of his kingdoms.

It does sound that this emperor has the same qualities as the Buddha. So what goes wrong? After seven of these great wheel-turning monarchs, at a certain point something goes wrong. One of these *Dhammacakka* rulers doesn't follow the rules of morality and becomes greedy. So people became poor, and for the first time in a very, very long time, somebody stole something.

He was brought to this king and the king asked him, "Why did you steal?" He said, "Well, I don't have enough money to keep my family." So the king gives him money. But then the rumour spread around that if you stole, the king would give you money. So people began to steal. After a while, the king realized he'd made a big mistake. Greed had entered into his kingdoms.

So the next thief he had executed. But this only made people more angry and the whole kingdom began to become very lawless. The Buddha said that this would continue until the next self-awakened Buddha appeared, and that Buddha would be called the Maitreya Buddha. This word comes from the word for mother, so it's a Buddha who has a mother's loving disposition.

When it comes to his involvement in local politics, he's very much ready to offer advice. There was the king of Magadha, Ajātasattu. He sent an ambassador to the Buddha to ask him if this was the right time to attack the Vajji Federation. The Vajji Federation was a combination of tribes who elected their own leaders.

The Buddha doesn't say yes or no, but he gives seven reasons as to why a country will remain strong. The first is that the Vajjis meet in harmony and leave in harmony. They don't abolish existing decrees, and I think this refers to their constitution. They respect, esteem and venerate the elders. This is a funny one: they do not forcibly abduct women or girls from their different clans. They respect and esteem their shrines. And finally, they give shelter and security to the *arahats*.

When the ambassador reports this back to the king, Ajātasattu, he uses bribery and deceit to achieve his goals. A lot of fake news. He gives false news that puts these tribes against each other, and they eventually begin to quarrel. He just walks in and takes over the country.

Here we have an occasion where the Buddha is intimately involved in what is happening in the society around him. There are many other incidents. Since we ourselves are trying to behave like a Buddha, it means that we ought to also become involved in the politics and economics of the day. In this way the Buddha is our exemplar.

So this is the Buddha's alter ego. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I have not caused confusion, and that you will by following the example of the Buddha become fully liberated from all suffering. Sooner rather than later.

We can sit for a little while and then we will do the refuges and precepts.

The Unattractive Nature of the Body

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 29 min

In this profound teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the Buddha's traditional meditation on the thirty-two parts of the body, a practice designed to cultivate non-attachment and understand our true relationship with physical form. Drawing from classical Buddhist teachings, he guides practitioners through contemplating the less attractive aspects of the body - from hair and nails to internal organs and bodily fluids - not to create aversion, but to develop equanimity and reduce identification with the physical form.

The talk includes the famous story from the Pāli Canon where monks took this practice to an extreme, leading the Buddha to provide balance through other methods. Bhante emphasizes that this contemplation serves multiple purposes: reducing attachment to physical beauty, cooling erotic impulses (particularly relevant for monastics), and helping medical professionals maintain necessary detachment.

The session concludes with a beautiful gratitude practice, systematically thanking each part of the body for its service - from the protective skin to the life-sustaining organs. This balanced approach honors both the Buddha's teaching on the body's ultimate insubstantiality (comparing it to foam in the Dhammapada verse) while cultivating appreciation for this precious human birth that enables our spiritual practice.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambodasa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambodasa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambodasa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and self-awakened one.

I thought we'd do another little exercise this evening. We've done a few in the past couple of years, and this one is basically based on the body. The body in the Buddha's teaching is just part and parcel of it, and he wants us really to undermine our identification with it, our possession of it. We'll say things like "I have a headache." See, I have a headache. So somebody has a headache. But of course, I am ill. So there's a bit of confusion there as to how we relate to this body of ours.

One thing he puts to us is to really come to terms with our relationship to the body, especially, specifically those parts that we find unattractive, repulsive even, disgusting almost. There are three parts to this. First of all, we begin by recognizing the precious-

ness of the human life. Then we do this business of relating better to the body as a mammal – I mean, we are animals at the physical level. And then to find a way to balance that through the process of gratitude.

If we think about the preciousness of this birth, the Buddha gives us a metaphor. He says suppose there's a turtle in the ocean and it only comes up to breathe once every hundred years, and in the whole ocean there's only one log. How fortunate to come to the surface and bump his head against that log. So that's how fortunate we are to become human beings. And of course, the great fortune is to have come across the *Dhamma*.

Obviously we can't be here without the body. That's simple enough. It's through the senses, through the senses of the body, the outer senses that we experience the world and everything that we learn comes through them – what we hear, what we see and so on. It's through the body that we relate, we communicate, we establish relationships, we express ourselves, art, things like that. It's through the body we work for the benefit of ourselves and others, so there's a moral element there which is of course our *kamma*. And finally, in virtually all techniques the body is included. It has to be because it's there – you have to acknowledge that the body is here. So in our practice of course it's the breath.

Having acknowledged that, having acknowledged the preciousness of the human birth, we can now just spend a moment apologizing to the body for what we may have done to it, what harm we may have done to it. We might have put it in dangerous situations, we might have put substances in it which has not done it very good and so on and so forth. If you wish, you can repeat after me this little verse: "Whatever harm I have done to you" – that's the body – "in thought, word and deed, by way of greed, aversion, fear and delusion, intentionally or unintentionally, I am heartily sorry for it. And I determined from this day on to treat you with due care and respect."

Now we can get on to the 32 parts that the Buddha goes through, which is the unpleasantness, the unattractiveness, the repulsiveness – call it what you want – of the body. Here's a verse from the *Dhammapada*: "Knowing this body is like foam, fully awake to its mirage-like nature, cutting off Mara's flowers, one goes unseen by the king of death."

So the body is foam. There's no reality to it. It's a mirage-like nature. It's something that is also an extension of our minds. Cutting off Mara's flowers – so Mara is not this sort of torturing devil of Christianity. He's more the tempter that you find in Islam,

tempting you to devote your life to sensual pleasure. And that's why he offers flowers. They're attractive, you see. Now, if we can get rid of all that as an attachment, then of course the king of death, meaning spiritual death, doesn't see us. That's what it means.

The purpose of this meditation is, first of all, to encourage that detachment from the body, or non-attachment, should I say, non-attachment. You can understand that people who are in the medical profession, I mean, they have to have a certain detachment to what the body is capable of manufacturing. It's also a way of cooling erotic impulses. This is important if you're in a monastic. Basically, when something erotic arises in the mind, when you see the impurities of that body, it tends to scupper it. It tends to take the imagination. The imagination disappears on the wonder of it. As you know, beauty is skin deep. And that's part of it too, that we don't worry about our physical beauty anymore. The body is the body. It's just the way it is. You have to be, as they say, happy in our skin.

I'm going to now read through these 32 parts. The idea is that as I mention a word, the image, the relationship will come to mind and you want to get in touch with that reaction, because that reaction is telling us how we relate to that part of the body. So it could be equanimous, it could be no reaction. On the other hand, there could be some level of repulsiveness, disgust. You're going to accept that, you'll let that come up and just acknowledge it. This is the part of the exercise of getting in touch with our relationship to the body.

So if we just settle for a moment. Here's the first one.

Hair on the head, the scalp, dandruff. Body hair. Nails, teeth, skin, muscles, flesh, tendons, bones, bone marrow, kidneys, heart, liver, diaphragm, spleen, lungs, intestines, bowels, undigested foods, faeces, bile, phlegm, pus, blood, sweat, fat, tears, saliva, nasal mucus, synovial fluid – that's around the joints – lymph.

Now just go back to the one that gave you the most sense of disgust or dislike, call it what you wish. Just go back to it and just get in touch with that feeling, with that reaction. And just see if you can change your view of it, maybe from a chemical point of view, a functional point of view.

Then he reminds us of the drawbacks of the body. He also asks us to contemplate the fact that there are diseases. And he holds a whole list here, which is not at all comprehensive, of course. Diseases of the eye, the inner ear, the nose, the tongue, the body, the head, the outer ear, the mouth, the teeth and the lips, cough, asthma, catarrh, inflammation, fever, stomachache, fainting, dysentery, gastric pain, cholera, leprosy, boils, eczema, tuberculosis, epilepsy, herpes, itch, scabs, smallpox, scabies, haemorrhage, dia-

betes, piles, pimples and ulcers, affliction stemming from disorders of bile, phlegm, wind or their conjunction, afflictions caused by change in the weather, by not taking care of yourself, by overexertion or as a result of past deeds, cold, heat, hunger, thirst, defecation and urination.

So there's a nice little list to contemplate what the body is capable of giving us. There are these two parts, but the main part is to bring parts of the body to mind that we find in some way difficult to be with equanimously and just keep working on it until that sense of disgust disappears. Disgust, of course, is a natural reaction, but I think it should be when you put something horrible in the mouth.

Now, he gave this teaching to a group of monks, you see, or to the *sangha* that was at the monastery in Vesāli. And then he went off. The Buddha went off to do two weeks by himself. He often went off for a quiet abiding. You can imagine that there comes a time when he's got lots of visitors, lots of monks, and he just needs to get away for a bit of a rest. What he would do is go off into the forest by himself, just for a couple of weeks.

Anyway, having given this talk to the monks, he comes back and he says, "Ananda, why does the *Sangha* of monks look so depleted?" In other words, where have all the monks gone? And he says, "Well, because Lord, with many lines of reasoning, gave monks a talk on the unattractiveness of the body, spoke in praise of the perception of unattractiveness, spoke in praise of the development of the perception of unattractiveness. And the monks, thinking, oh, the Blessed One, with many lines of reasoning, has given a talk on the unattractiveness of the body. They remained committed to the development of it in many modes and manners. They, ashamed, repelled and disgusted with the body, sought for an assassin. In one day, 10 monks took the knife. In one day, 20 monks took the knife. And in one day, 30 monks took the knife. It would be good, Lord, if you could explain another method so that this *Sangha* of monks might be established in understanding."

I can't imagine how he felt when he came back from his rest to find that all these monks had committed suicide because of his teachings. So what he does is he gives them the exercise of practising these absorptions.

But there's another way that we can relate to the body, which, shall we say, balances this whole business. And that is by offering gratitude. This little exercise, what we're going to do is go through the body in a different way. And we're going to recognize what the body does for us. So for instance, the skin is our outer protection. It does other things too, but whatever comes to mind, whatever comes to mind that a particular part of the body does, you say, "Thank you." And that's all you do. All you got to do is say, "Thank you." And you just keep saying, "Thank you" to all the parts of the body.

If we just settle for a moment and then I'll suggest another way that you can go through the body and do this. Just starting at the top of the head and just come down the body and just say thank you to our protecting skin all the way down to the toes. It's like you're showering yourself with gratitude.

Coming back to the top of the head there and just sink into the skull, the bones, and just saturate it with your gratitude. Thank you. Thank you. Thank you. All the way down the body. Just following the skeleton. It holds the marrow, of course, where all the blood cells are created. All the way down to the toes.

If we come back to the top of the head and this time we sink into the brain and we just keep saying thank you and then follow the nervous system all down the body. All the way down to the toes.

And coming back to the top of the head. And this time we go into the muscles of the face. Just massaging them with this gratitude. And then follow the musculature all the way down to the toes, just massaging your muscle with gratitude.

And then coming back to the heart in the body, filling the heart with gratitude. And then just follow the blood every which way, just saying thank you, feeding the body.

And coming back to the head, offering gratitude to our eyes and to the ears and to the nose. To the tongue and teeth, these are all our senses. And to the larynx, the voice. Sinking into the chest, say thank you to all the organs there. Coming down into the midriff, the stomach, liver area, all the various organs. Down into the abdomen, the various systems. Thank you to our hands. And thank you to our feet. And finally thank you to the whole body, the whole physical organism.

This organism made up of billions of cells, some guest cells, billions of guest cells – they can't be, but jumping for joy, finally their work has been acknowledged.

So this exercise then balances the unattractiveness of the body. We feel grateful that we have a body. Now, you can spend as much as you want on this exercise. I'll put a PDF up on the website. But actually, once you know what you're doing, it's just a two-minute job in the morning, just to acknowledge that there are parts of the body that we don't particularly like, just to spend a moment thanking it, and that can't be doing us harm, can it? All those negative feelings, all that negative relationship we have with the body can't be doing it any good. It's a way of suppressing what the body does.

So this brings us to the end of this lovely little exercise. I can only hope that it will further you on your path to complete and total liberation. *Sādhu, sādhu, sādhu.*

The Four Great Elements

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

In this foundational teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the four great elements (mahābhūta) as described in the Mahāhatthipadopama Sutta (MN 28) by Venerable Sāriputta. Originally conceived as divine beings governing the universe, these elements - earth (solidity/structure), water (cohesion/fluidity), fire (warmth/metabolic processes), and air (movement/energy) - became in the Buddha's teaching direct objects of experience that form the foundation of all physical phenomena.

The talk demonstrates how these elements serve as powerful meditation objects for developing both samādhi and vipassanā. By investigating our direct experience of hardness, liquidity, warmth, and movement - both within the body and in the external world - we can deconstruct our conventional perceptions and see the constructed nature of our experience. This process naturally leads to the insight of anattā (not-self) through the contemplation: 'This is not mine, I am not this, this is not myself.'

Bhante offers practical guidance for working with these elements in both formal meditation and daily life, showing how experiences like pain can be deconstructed into their elemental components. This approach helps practitioners develop equanimity and understand how the mind constructs meaning from basic sensory data. The teaching includes a guided meditation exploring each element directly through bodily sensations, making this ancient wisdom immediately accessible for modern practitioners seeking to understand the true nature of physical experience.

Namo tassa bhagavato arhato samma sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

This evening I thought we'd tackle what's known as the four great elements. Actually, that's translating *mahābhūta*, and *bhūta* means being, so it should be properly translated as the four great beings. This goes back to an earlier time when it would have been believed by people during the Buddha's time, maybe even today who knows, that gods governed the universe. For instance, Agni the fire god—he was the sun, but he actually governed the sun, governed the heat coming from the sun. So to appease him if he got too hot, you'd have to do some rituals and chant a few hymns. He was only second under Indra, who was in charge of all the gods, a bit like the Greek Zeus.

But by the time the Buddha came along, they had just become ordinary elements, just ordinary things that we can directly experience. Now, the great thing about these four elements is that they are self-produced. They cannot be reduced to anything else. They're not derived from everything. So when we're experiencing these four great elements—earth, fire, water and air—we're right at the base of our experience of life, our sensual experience of life, both outwardly and inwardly. And one of our aims in meditation is to get down to this level of insight.

So what are these? What do they refer to? There's a discourse in the Middle Length Sayings, number 28, given by Sāriputta, not by the Buddha. Sāriputta, remember, was called the general of the Dhamma by the Buddha, because he was second only to the Buddha in understanding the Dhamma itself. So he's understood to have really grasped the truth of things.

And this is what it says. Earth element represents solidity, structure. It's interesting because I read a physicist who was saying that there was no such thing as space, but that matter or subatomic energy created it. Space came because matter itself had arrived. So there wasn't a case of matter going into an empty place that we call space—the space was being created by matter itself. And there's a hint of that in the Buddha's teachings, but it is only a hint.

So it includes hardness, but also softness, and it's associated with form, occupies space. In the body, it includes head hair, body hair, nails, teeth, skin, flesh, sinews, bones, bone marrow, kidneys, heart, liver, and there's a whole load of stuff. But the important thing is that this is internal, pertaining to an individual.

And then Sāriputta makes this statement: "This is called the interior earth element. The interior earth element and the exterior earth element are just the earth element." So in other words, you can't get beyond that. It's a bit like in physics—once we're down to subatomic energy and particles, that's it. You can't get beneath that. That's what everything is made of, we could say.

The same happens with water element. The water element is what is cohesive—fluidity, elasticity. And it's liquid in the body, of course. So he says the water elements may be interior or exterior. "And what is the interior water element? Anything that is water, watery and appropriated, that's internal, pertaining to an individual." It includes bile, phlegm, pus, blood, sweat, fat, tears and all the rest of it. So it's not as though we're short of the water element in the body. In fact, I think we're mostly water. So then again, it finishes with that phrase: "This is called the interior water element. The interior water element and the exterior water element are just the water element."

So then he talks about fire. This is, of course, warmth, the metabolic processes, and it also means the process of aging—that's interesting. "So the fire element may be interior or exterior. And what is the interior fire element? Anything that's fire or fiery and appropriated, that's internal, pertaining to an individual." This includes that which warms, that which ages, that which heats you up when feverish, that which properly digests food and drink, and anything else that is fire, fiery and appropriated that's internal, pertaining to an individual. "This is called the interior fire element. The interior fire element and the exterior fire element are just the fire element."

And the final one is, of course, air, sometimes translated as wind. It's to do with movement and it's the opposite of being still. "And what is the air element? The air element may be interior or exterior. And what is the interior air element? Anything that is air or wind and appropriated, that's internal, pertaining to an individual." This includes winds that go up and down, winds in the belly or the bowels, winds that flow through the limbs, in-breath and out-breath. Now that "winds that flow through the limbs"—I think that's referring to *prāṇa*, the energy that's within the body. And so the winds include both literal gas and movements of energy. "This is called the interior air element. The interior air element and the exterior air element are just the air element."

Now, at the end of all those four elements, there's a refrain, and I've left it out because it's an important little bit to understand, because this is why we are investigating the four elements. "This should be truly seen with right understanding like this: this is not mine, I am not this, and this is not myself." When you truly see this with right understanding, you reject the air element, detaching awareness from the air element. So in other words, when we're actually experiencing this, there's a moment of reflection where we can say to ourselves, "Well look, that is not me, it's not mine, and it's not myself." And in so doing, we're sort of separating what it is that's actually thinking that, that's actually saying that. And that's, of course, your intuitive awareness. And although Sāriputta doesn't mention it here, it's at that level that you can see impermanence. You can see the changing nature of things much more easily.

So we can see now why they're used as meditation objects. In order to get down to that level of experience, you've got to focus in on it. So it's very good for getting the mind to be very still and focused. And of course, what's driving it is your interest. Remember that the whole process of investigation is the process of liberation. We're not taking anything on faith. We don't have to believe anything. And that, in fact, will be a hindrance because everything that the Buddha is putting to us is to be investigated. So it helps with the concentration. What we're trying to understand, apart from that, is how we construct the world. And in that way we're developing this insight—the insight of *vipassanā*. So it's a process of seeing things as they are.

If we take an example, an easy one—say of pain or discomfort. So as soon as that feeling of pain arises and we become aware of it, the first port of call, remember, is to see how we're reacting to it. So we want to move, we want to get rid of it. So that's the first thing. And we wait—we have to wait until that reaction begins to fade away. Then we can feel the pain more equanimously, patiently. So we can just be with the pain. And our noting word, our reflection on it, is that this is pain, and we can still do the same thing. We can say, "This is not me, not mine, not myself." You can actually say things like that to yourself.

And then once that's very clear to you and it's distanced from the awareness, like it's a real object, that's when you can plunge into the object. This is a phrase that my teacher Sayadaw U Pandita would often say. And it actually is trying to express what the Buddha says in the discourse on how to establish right awareness. He uses a form which translates as "to feel feelings in feelings"—that's what he says. "To feel the body in the body." It's as though he was having problems getting across to people, to his students, that you have to get into things. You have to sink into the object.

So here you are—you see the pain, so you then sink into that pain with the intention of seeing what it's made of. In other words, you're deconstructing that experience. And what we discover, of course, is things like heat, pressure and so on. Little different words will come to mind. And when that's clear and distanced and it's quite clearly an object, you can always say to yourself, "Look, that's not me, not mine, and not myself."

And then you recognize that when you come to the next level of perception, which gives these sensations meaning, the word "pain" arises. Ah! So now we know that pain is a mental construct. It doesn't actually exist. What actually exists are these sensations. And now it doesn't mean to say that you can forget what pain is. You need to know when to go to the doctor. But now we know that pain is a mental construct. And then the third level is to see our relationship to pain. And that's when we have that growth of patience and forbearance with what is unpleasant. So there's a whole process there, which is just part of that *vipassanā* insight process.

And just finally, in daily life, you can always bring it to mind. It's very simple. You're sitting at a table, you pick up your knife and fork or a spoon, and just for the moment there, just recognize that there's a feeling of the steel—that sense of maybe coldness. The cutlery might be cold, or you might sense the hardness of it. When you're drinking tea or coffee or just a juice or something, just for a moment feel that liquidity, the way that the liquid is moving around in the mouth. When you're outside, occasionally this summer, you might feel the warmth of the sun—at least in the UK you'll be very lucky these days. And you can feel the warmth of the sun on your skin. When walking, you

get that feeling of movement, the body moving through space, you might say. So these things we can actually experience. You can also see it second hand, like the trees moving with the wind and so on. And it's just this constant recognition that everything that we're experiencing at a physical level is based on these four elements.

Now, I must say that when it comes to the more subtle elements of smelling and tasting, there's no real understanding as to what creates the various subjective tastes within the mouth—sweetness, sour, salty, all those sorts of things. It's like the photons that hit the eye. That would be seen as a fire element. But what the eye actually sees are all these very different shapes and colors. But it's still at the base of the eye, just a fire element. And the same with the ear—all we're getting is pressure waves. And that's all that's actually being picked up by the sense base. And you can actually experience that—that there's no sound. It's just a sensation of touch. And then that enters into the mind, and it's the mind which turns it into a recognizable sound.

Well, so I'm going to—we're going to do a little exercise, and then we'll sit for a while. So if we sit comfortably and just close our eyes a little, and I'll just mention some part of the body that you can contact according to these four elements.

So we're just sitting there quietly, and we want to find something which is hard. So it could be that your one thumb is feeling the hardness of a nail, or you could be having your hand on your knee, just the kneecap there, and just get a feel of the hardness of it. Now at this point we can just say to ourselves, "Well, you see, that's not me, it's not mine, and it's not myself." Now the hardness you're feeling—I suppose it's better in the knee really—is to feel it on the bone or in the bone, not in the finger itself. That's a bit difficult. You can, of course, feel it on the finger. That's not a problem either.

And then if we try to find something which is warm or cool—the heat of the body—perhaps you can feel a part of the body that's warm. Or it could be if you put one hand on the back of the other hand, you might find that the fingers are cooler and you can feel that there's a change of temperature there, and the palm of the hand being warmer. And just get into that feeling of warmth or coolness. So at the moment I can feel the coolness of my fingers and the warmth of my palm. And I can also feel how the energy is moving. The palm feels cooler and the fingers are beginning to feel warmer. I'm right there at the base of my experience.

And then the next one would be liquidity. So you can fill your mouth with a little saliva. There's also—you can squeeze a muscle of your thigh or your biceps or whatever, or a muscle in the hand, the muscle at the thumb. And just as you press it, you can feel it sort of squeezing.

And then finally there's movement. So we can make that very simple by just lifting your hand and placing it back onto your knee, or observing the falling and rising of the breath in the body—the chest, the stomach, or the abdomen. And all you're trying to be aware of, to get down to, is that feeling of just movement. That's more easily done when it's neutral. And again, you can say to yourself, "This is not me, not mine, and not myself."

So that's a quick introduction. The last thing is that, of course, you can also do this with your emotional life. An obvious one would be anger. If you feel a bit angry about something, irritated about something. So when you come off the fantasy and you come into the body, then you feel, first of all, that there is anger. But as you go into the anger, there is just this energy, just heat that's going on and movement—heat and movement mainly. So it's just deconstructing what we're actually experiencing, always taking away that sense of something being substantial, being real. And that's how we use these four great elements.

Very good. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I have not caused confusion, and that by your careful investigation of the four elements, you will liberate yourself from all suffering sooner rather than later.

The Specific Law of Conditionality

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 22 min

In this profound dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines idappaccayatā, the 'law of this and that' or specific conditionality - one of Buddhism's most fundamental principles. He explores the famous formula: 'When this is, that is. From the arising of this comes the arising of that. When this isn't, that isn't. From the cessation of this comes the cessation of that.'

The talk distinguishes between past causation (how previous conditions create present effects) and present synchronicity (how multiple conditions converge in each moment), contrasting Buddhist understanding with the deterministic fatalism of Makkhali Gosāla and the amorality of Pūraṇa Kassapa. Through contemporary examples - from Zoom meetings to climate activism - Bhante illustrates how this law reveals the radical interdependence of all phenomena.

This teaching connects directly to the three characteristics of existence: impermanence (anicca), the absence of fixed selfhood (anattā), and how understanding conditionality can lead to acceptance rather than conflict with conditions. The talk concludes by linking this principle to paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination) and the possibility of liberation through understanding the constructed nature of self-identity.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambodassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

This evening it's slightly different. I've written an actual essay, so I'm going to keep referring to my notes. I'm wondering how many of you have come across the law of this and that, or as it's better translated, the law of specific conditionality.

This is the law of this and that, or the law of specific conditionality, *idappaccayatā*. It says: when this is, that is. From the arising of this comes the arising of that. When this isn't, that isn't. And from the cessation of this comes the cessation of that.

If we put them in a slightly different order, it makes a bit more sense. From the arising of this comes the arising of that. From the cessation of this comes the cessation of that. When this is, that is. When this isn't, that isn't.

So if we take the first proposition, from the arising of this comes the arising of that, and from the stopping of this comes the stopping of that. This is basically what we would recognize as our usual way of thinking about causality. The thief stole from the shop and he's now in jail. Someone disturbed the thief. He failed to steal anything and the police didn't bother to investigate.

If this were the only way things happen because of things in the past, it would suggest a repetitive cosmos. It would be difficult to see where creativity would come from since everything now is a product of the past. In moral terms, that leads to determinism or fatalism, and there would be no room for any form of free will.

Indeed, at the Buddha's time, there was a person who taught this very understanding. He was called Makkhali Gosāla. He taught that no matter what you did, you could not change your fate. Everything was determined. It was a very harsh position, and the consequences of this meant that you were not responsible for your moral actions, good or bad. You can't blame somebody if they had to do it by fate.

The second couplet presents how present conditions, causes, lead to present conditions. When this is now, that is, and when this isn't, that isn't. It's all in the now. This we can call synchronicity, how many events come together to present a particular situation.

If events arose from these sorts of conditions without past influence, there would be chaos because there doesn't seem to be any regulating factor. From a moral point of view, that expresses itself as amorality. What's the point of morality when there's no guarantee it will have any effect?

There was such a person who taught this: Pūraṇa Kassapa. He had the theory of the way of non-doing. What he meant by that was that actions considered good and evil carried no inherent morality and thus there exist no future consequences from committing either good or evil deeds.

Quoting him: "Even if one were to go along the right bank of the Ganges killing and getting others to kill, mutilating and getting others to mutilate, torturing and getting others to torture, there would be no evil for that course, no coming of evil. Even if one were to go along the left bank of the Ganges giving and getting others to give, making sacrifices and getting others to make sacrifices, there would be no merit from that cause, no coming of merit. Through generosity, self-control, restraint and truthful speech, there is no merit from that cause, no coming of merit." It's a pretty stark situation.

So how do these two forces operate, one coming from the past and all these different causes coming into the present? An obvious example is this Zoom meeting. We've all come from different causes. You've probably had to do various things before you set up the Zoom. I myself, I've got to make sure I'm plugged into the internet. I've got to make sure the Zoom is updated. I check the talk on my tablet and then I press the necessary icons and here I am. Everybody will go through that similar process.

But this doesn't include the way in which we had to factor this event during our day, how future events affect present conditions. Lots of personal causes went into this particular event and on top of that there's all that's going on behind the scenes in the technology which is supporting this. You can also include, of course, the conditions of nature.

If we take a snapshot of any moment, the event will be a meeting of all past causes and present actions and situations. This then becomes one of the causes for the next moment, where more results from different causes meet. There's constant change, constant process. Every event has to be singular and unique. It's not conceivable that the same thing could happen twice. Never mind Groundhog Day.

Even though we're here seemingly in a static place, the Zoom meeting is constantly changing as I'm talking and you're listening. The technology behind it all, we don't know what's going on there at all, and nature, of course, is changing. You can see that we're in a process of quite radical change.

What Buddhism tends to call this is interdependency, interconnectedness. I think it was Thích Nhất Hạnh who came up with the word interbeing when it came to the biosphere. This comes out in the Mahāyāna's metaphor of Indra's web. Indra was the king of the gods and at each vertex of his web is a jewel wherein every jewel is mirrored and so unique in itself. The cosmos is holographic and in constant change.

Blake writes it beautifully: "To see a world in a grain of sand and a heaven in a wild flower, hold infinity in the palm of your hand and eternity in an hour." We can see that it might even be more apt to call it the law of specific contingency, meaning everything coming to touch.

Now there might be a bit of a roar in the background. I don't know whether you can hear it or not. It's the tractor coming to take these bales of hay away.

Which means that we can't completely with certainty say what's going to happen the next moment. That's how so-called unexpected events happen, things that we don't expect. Earthquakes, tsunamis used to be called acts of God, but now, of course, they're acts of nature. If we had an omniscient mind, we might be able to see that what is coincidence or luck is actually conditioned.

On a personal level, this brings us always to our little special subject of death. We don't know the moment of our death. We live on a knife edge and therefore the Buddha's admonition to practice or develop continual mindfulness.

When it comes to social, economic, political situations, it does make us feel a little bit powerless when you see this law. We have such little ability to influence what's going on in the world. Of course, there are certain powers, certain people in power and corporations that will be capable of doing much more, but the overwhelming majority of us have very small influence indeed.

The strength comes, of course, when we all act together. That would be a case of contingency. If we accept our personal condition as little underlings pushing up against this heavy weight, accepting our boundaries, that should undermine all this anger and outrage, grief, fear, all the negative states that come up when we're going beyond the limits of our power and influence. Of course, that should make us more effective. It's better if the heart is not so embroiled, but calm, the mind not so agitated, but quiet.

It comes really from having confidence that if we want to support something and we see others are going to support it, this interdependency, this interconnection will actually create a force. We see that, of course, in various movements around the world.

This also brings us to the law of *kamma*. What this tells us is that the working of *kamma* and what the consequence of an action will be is basically imponderable. There's no way you can really say what's going to happen. I mean, there's a general law that if we do something wholesome, then something wholesome will come of it. If we do something unwholesome, there'll be an unwholesome result. But every action of speech and body just enters into the matrix of all relationships. We can't know the effect of what will follow.

Inwardly, it has an effect on our inner matrix of the mind. We don't know what the effect of that will be, except, again, that general understanding.

Here are some examples. There was a charity that I knew of which sent clothes to an African country only to upset the tailor trade and the local economy. The charity, of course, wouldn't have known such consequences. But you do ask whether they actually went and interviewed the people, got some understanding before they did it.

There was also a charity that would ask you to support an individual child. You had a relationship with that child. You got pictures, you got little essays. Unfortunately, it produced jealousy in the other children in the village who didn't get that sort of treatment. There was disharmony in the community. It was successful at attracting donors, but when that Western individualism meets the more communitarian African society, well, it didn't work. They had to pull the plug on it.

There's another one: tragedy leads often to charity or to a new law. The abortion law came in and it wasn't just women's rights. Of course, it was there, but it was fuelled by the injuries and death caused by backstreet abortions. In that negative sense, if this doesn't happen, this doesn't happen, because if the law hadn't passed, we'd still be continuing with the unnecessary suffering and deaths of women.

One thing that this reminds us of is the theory of chaos. In the simplest way—I have no understanding of systems theory at all—but in the simplest way, the example is that a butterfly, it's called the butterfly effect, so the flap of a butterfly with supporting conditions can end up as a hurricane. Even a small catalyst can bring about unpredictable outcomes. This is referred to as systems theory. An obvious system is, of course, the weather, which we come to know very intimately.

There was a case of a Bosnian nationalist who shot Archduke Franz Ferdinand, the heir to the Austrian throne, and his wife. It's understood to be the immediate cause of World War I, which started a month later. He was visiting Bosnia and Herzegovina in an open carriage where there were groups of revolutionaries who wanted the country to be free from Austrian rule. Even if he'd been just a little cautious, sat in a bulletproof vest or something, we might not have had the First World War.

On a more positive note, we have, of course, Greta Thunberg. She skipped school at the age of 15 to demonstrate outside the Swedish parliament, calling for greater action on climate change, which eventually led to the movement of school strike for climate. There might not have been such a movement had it not been for that plucky little teenager.

When it comes to our internal psychology, whatever we think, say and act actually affects the internal matrix of our body, heart and mind. We don't know, except again in those broadest terms, that if we do something wholesome, then we'll have wholesome results and, of course, unwholesome results.

Here are some examples that I've just plucked. I haven't been specific in names, but there was a man I was told of, a friend of a friend, who had been temperate ever since he knew he was an alcoholic as a young man. At his retirement party, he took a sip and

subsequently died of alcoholic poisoning. Needless to say, if he'd not had that false confidence at that moment, then he probably would have lived a long and healthy retirement.

There was a politician in Germany. I couldn't find the facts, but I'd seen the article. A leading member of the far-right racist party heard a child in distress and went to help. When she saw the child was black, it so connected her with humanity, with all humanity, she dropped all her far-right beliefs. If that little "chance" event had not happened, of course, she'd now be propagating far-right views.

Even in this law of unpredictability, of contingency, the Buddha clearly delineates a way in which we can bring our own suffering to an end. Can't do it for others, but we can do it for ourselves. He describes that, of course, in dependent origination, which is another talk.

When it comes to this specific law of conditionality, you can see how it supports the whole idea of impermanence. It's real radical change. There's no other way it could be. It's not that everything is impermanent, it's also that everything is therefore unsubstantial. There's nothing at the core. There's nothing there which you can point to and say, "Well, this is always here."

This, of course, refers also to ourselves as a self, which we feel is a sort of steady state within ourselves. But what it's saying is that that also changes. What we're doing constantly is selfing. This is what dependent origination actually points out to us. That's why the Buddha is constantly telling us that this sense of self that we have, the way that we experience ourselves, is delusive.

So where does this lead us? Well, it ought to stop us being in conflict with conditions, like an open radical acceptance. This is the way it is. This is the condition of this present moment. That doesn't lead to hopeless resignation. What it should do is lead to a realistic appraisal of the way things are, and it should be a basis for action. Otherwise, if we don't do that, we just live in a morass of delusive aims, constantly going against what is actually happening and just making things worse.

It's a wonder, isn't it? Like 2,500 years ago, Siddhattha Gotama, son of the Sakya tribe in North India, left home life, went to be a *samaṇa*, a wandering ascetic, wondering whether there was an end to rebirth, constant round of birth, ageing and death, all the suffering that it entails. He not only discovered this root cause of the notion of self as false and delusive, he realised that there could not be an eternal soul or self which is integral to the psychophysical organism. It's not possible for it to contain something eternal. One of the reasons for that is because of this specific law of conditionality.

Having said that, of course, you have to remember that there is *Nibbāna*. Our spiritual aim is to find out exactly what that is.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that this law of conditionality will allow you to modify and develop your actions to work with present conditions so that you become liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

The Dangers of Indulgence

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 20 min

Drawing from the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta (SN 56.11), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's teaching on the middle path that transcends both indulgence in sensual pleasures and self-mortification. Through vivid examples including Greek mythology and personal anecdotes, he explores how indulgence differs from healthy enjoyment and leads to five key forms of suffering: compulsive behavior, frustration, grief, anxiety, and boredom.

The talk emphasizes three crucial distinctions practitioners must understand: differentiating enjoyment from indulgence, recognizing the separation between body and mind in sensory experience, and distinguishing between desire and action. Bhante explains how our consumer culture confuses happiness with excitement, leading to endless seeking for stimulation rather than genuine contentment.

Practical guidance is offered on working with intention - eating to live rather than living to eat - and using renunciation as a tool to contact and transform unwholesome desires. The teaching concludes with the Buddha's comparison of nibbāna's taste to freedom, specifically freedom from compulsive craving that underlies so much of our suffering.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa — Homage to the Buddha, the blessed noble and fully self-awakened one.

I thought tonight I'd tackle this problem of indulgence. If I were to quote the Buddha, in the first discourse, which is really just a formalised teaching he had — I can't imagine that this is exactly what he said — he says that indulgence in sensual pleasures, which is base, vulgar, worldly, ignoble and not beneficial. And then he says the practice of self-mortification, which is simply painful, ignoble and not beneficial. And then he talks about the middle path.

This middle path isn't a little bit of indulgence and a little bit of mortification. It's something which transcends them. That's the middle, as it were. It's a way of saying that there is a path which does not include either the indulgence or the practice of self-mortification. That self-mortification is blaming the body for our problems. If your eye sees something which brings up lust, you start blaming the eye. That wouldn't be correct, would it? In those days, especially the Jains, they thought that the body itself was the product of our *kamma*, and you had to let go of the body — so to die, to stop eating,

was considered to be the way to go. And I believe elderly people do that even these days. Anyway, we're talking about indulgence, and this is an essay I've written really around eating, but hopefully I'll try and spread it out to include everything.

I always like the Greek myths. So, how bad can greed get? Erysichthon, the Greek king of Thessaly, had the temerity to build a banqueting hall over the shrine of Demeter, goddess of Earth's fertility and protector of the harvest. She cursed him with insatiable hunger. First, he ate everything that was in his kingdom that was able to eat. And then he started on his people and even ate his own family. Finally, still famished, he ate himself. So that's how bad it can get.

Actually, when I was staying at Kanduboda in Sri Lanka, there was an American who turned up and he was telling me that when he got lost in the wilds once, he went through a period of few days where he just didn't have any food. And when he eventually caught a pigeon, he said he just ripped it open and ate it raw. So I don't think we ever get as close to that sort of hunger usually. Normally, when we feel a bit peckish, we'll put an end to it as quick as we can. Those are the extreme conditions.

But what we have to do — there are three things that we have to become clear about. Remember, this is the other side of suffering. Everybody knows the depressions and the anxiety, and we know how to deal with that. But this indulgence is rather difficult because it's so close to enjoyment.

The first thing is to be able to distinguish when we're enjoying something as opposed to indulging it. And the second one is to begin to see the distinction between the body and the mind and what the body is actually giving us, which is pure. All that's coming in, for instance, through the ears is the vibrations in the air. And then from there, it's taken into the mind and it's the mind which gives it meaning. So you get a bell, alarm bell, and so on and so forth. And then finally, to know the distinction between a desire and an action. This is the Buddha making as clear as to what the role of the will is.

The first thing is to really begin to understand what the downside of indulgence is. Now the problem is that when we're indulging something — a food or we're out in nature and we're loving it and we're bathing in it — while we're doing that there's not a problem. It's heaven, isn't it? We think it's *Nibbāna*. It's the aftermath that we have to become aware of.

So the first thing that arises from that indulgence is, of course, that compulsive behaviour. Here, the psychology is the same as any addict. I mean, they've got it bad, but for most of us, it becomes an obsessive thing that we need. Just to take a very simple example, everybody has a special time for a tea or coffee and biscuits, coffee and a piece

of cake. And when you get to that time, if you just sit in front of it, you'll feel the process of that wanting and the compulsive nature of having to have it. You can get quite depressed if you don't get it. That's the other side too. So it's a case of recognising that as soon as we have one of these unwholesome habits, there's a certain compulsion around that behaviour.

I've got an example here of somebody who gave up smoking and thought that they were completely over it. And then at a party, they just have that just one cigarette. And before they're knowing it, of course, they're buying a packet. Now, I know that has a physical dependency to it, but it's the same sort of psychology even for biscuits.

The second problem is the frustration that arises when we don't get what we want. So if you've forgotten to buy the tea, that's terrible. Or to buy the coffee, that's even worse sometimes. And Amazon of course has spent millions on getting their products to the customer as quickly as possible. Just knowing that if they can gratify a person's desire more quickly than anybody else, then they get their loyalty. And of course, it's worked. We get angry over silly things — the bus doesn't arrive at the time and the train's late as usual and things like that. And that's the frustration of not getting what we want. And that comes from an attachment to something.

The third one is grief. Especially with things, it's especially if you lose something which is treasured by you — an engagement ring, a marriage ring, or some token of friendship, some heirloom, if that's stolen from you. I remember at college, my girlfriend at the time, she was living in this place with other girls and the landlord turned out to be some sort of thief. And just one day they found that all their little treasures were completely stolen. All the jewels that they had. It's absolutely awful. And of course, when we lose something like a mobile, I mean, we get more angry than anything, but there's a sense of grief there.

And when it comes to objects, it's good to remind ourselves that the idea of possessing an object is a legal fiction. It's something that we presume on the object, that the object is mine. But actually, when you think about it, you can only use objects. You can only use your phone. And when the thief takes it, it's his. It's not mine anymore.

The fourth one is anxiety. Under anything we possess, I'm sure you will find some level of anxiety about loss. And the more we have, the more the anxiety is there. And you can see that from people who are very rich. Once they reach a billion, it's hardly enough. They've got to insure that billion by having another billion. And it's the same with other things that we have, like friendships. We feel more safe when we have lots of friendships, people whom we can call our friends, family, like that. And there's also to do with power. The more power you have, the more safe you feel.

So when those things begin to dissipate, when they begin to lose them, that's when you touch this underground anxiety we have. And of course, that anxiety goes right to the basis of the real problem that sits under everything. And that's the idea of a self. And the self is telling us to enjoy ourselves, to try and make this life really enjoyable. And so when that joy begins to disappear that we become attached to, then you get that anxiety. Now, that isn't to say that there isn't enjoyment and the joys of life. And we'll come to that in a bit.

Finally, and I don't think this is an exhaustive list, there's boredom. If you remember after the Buddha became fully liberated, Māra, the evil one, sent his three daughters and they were sensual pleasure, sexual pleasure and boredom. So this boredom is an aversive state. What used to give you happiness doesn't give you that happiness anymore. And if we look at it, it's actually not so much the happiness that we're after, it's that little sliver on top, which is the excitement. And that's the big delusion of our consumerist societies, to confuse happiness with excitement.

If you think of a Christmas cake — this is a British and Irish Christmas cake. You get the solid bit, the fruit cake underneath it all. And then you get this sliver at the top of marzipan and the icing. And children will peel that off and just eat that, of course. And that, of course, gives the cake that little special zing. So it's just an ordinary fruitcake unless you have that little bit of marzipan and icing on top. And of course, that's what gives you diabetes, isn't it? The sugar. But we're not worried about that. We'd rather just enjoy it.

It's the same with this happiness and excitement and often when we make the right intention to just enjoy something and not to indulge, there's always that sense that we've lost a little bit of that little pleasure that we used to have through indulgence. And that's your renunciation. When the Buddha talks about renunciation, and that renunciation is the path to liberation, it's getting rid of that excitement.

I mean, the Buddha was happy. He actually says, when you get to Nibbāna, you are contented and with it happy. So we're not going to lose contentment and happiness, but it's giving up that little sliver of excitement. Well, even though I say it's a little sliver for most, for a lot of people, that's what it is. And that's where you get this clickbait that they talk about, when people are scrolling through all these fashions and computers and anything else that they want to feed off.

And what it's doing is at a physical level, we know it's drenching the brain with dopamine. But at that mental level, it's that what we call the attachment. That's the dependency. And that's what we mean when we talk about attachment. We mean that we are dependent on something to give us happiness. But when we look at that happiness,

it's actually a little level of excited energy. And that's what we've got to give up because if we don't, it creates all these problems afterwards that we've been through — compulsive behaviour and frustration and grief and anxiety and finally this boredom.

If your whole life is about being excited and it begins to lose that excitement, it could be through illness, for instance, the boredom arises. And what boredom is saying is, what's the purpose of life if I can't be excited? I've got to search something. So you can see that this boredom is the underlying engine of the whole consumerist society. It's the boredom that makes you seek the next thing that's going to make you excited. And we have this phrase, don't we? Variety is the spice of life. Well, that attitude is the path to perdition, the path to hell. But that's not necessary. We can just be happy.

The big thing that we have to do is to make sure that whenever we're going to do something which is going to bring happiness is to be very clear about our intention. Just taking food as an example, which is pretty straightforward. What's the purpose of eating? The real purpose of eating is to nourish the body. That's the real purpose so that we can continue living and practising and doing our practice. The fact that it tastes nice is part and parcel of that process. It might not be the taste that we expected, but at least that's just there, but we're not eating it for that reason.

So we go back to that little phrase, are we eating to live or living to eat? And it's just making those intentions very clear to ourselves and moving from that intention. That's what undermines this desire for excitement.

It's very difficult to separate excitement from indulgence. Aversion is clear. Aversion pushes you away from the object you don't want to know. To be aware of aversion is much easier because it separates out from what it's averse to. Same with fear. But when it comes to indulgence, it melds. The connection is melding. So it's very difficult to pull it apart and to see what the indulgence actually is.

And of course, one way to do that is if we find ourselves having a habit which is compulsive, is of course to stop it. And when the desire comes you sit with the agony of letting go of that. One example I used to use — it doesn't work anymore as you'll see — was to have a favourite TV programme, a serial or something like that, and you turn it on and just look at the blank screen and that would send you absolutely berserk. These days, of course, you can't do that because everybody's got iPlayer or something else.

But the whole point of renunciation or an act of renunciation is to contact that desire. It's an unwholesome desire, the unwholesome desire. And as you work with that over time, of course, that habit begins to dissolve. It's not being fed and therefore it just

begins to die away. And then once it's got low again, once you've got it down to a decent basis of control, then of course you simply have to watch that it doesn't get the better of you again. That's all.

But eventually we've got to give all that up, and we don't give it up unless we see the juice that comes from it, the fruit of that renunciation. And so if you take something which you can see is compulsive, it might be just a cup of tea at a certain time of day, and you just sit there with the empty cup. And you get that feeling of wanting to want it. And if you just sit with it, it's quite remarkable. If you just sit with it and wait for that desire to go away, that bad energy — remember — is transformed and what you find is that suddenly you're contented and you don't want a cup of tea. And that's the joy of renunciation.

So remember, we're not trying to confuse enjoyment with indulgence and it all comes down really to our intentions. So the more we're aware of our intentions and we correct our intentions towards just enjoying something, then you'll find yourself being a bit more contented with the way things are and with it happiness.

Just to end off with the Buddha's own quote, he talks about the taste of Nibbāna is freedom. The taste of the sea, the taste of the ocean is salt. And just as that has a taste, the taste of Nibbāna is freedom. Freedom from what? Freedom from this compulsive desire. Remember, this is the desiring side for pleasure. Remember, there's the other side too, which is all about suffering. It's all about anxiety, depression, etc.

So just to recap there, when we get into this indulgence business, we can expect there'll be an aftermath. There will be a compulsive behaviour, there'll be frustration, there'll be grief, there'll be anxiety, and there'll be boredom. And if we can get into that, then hopefully we'll liberate ourselves from it. I mean, that's the whole point of our practice, really.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I have not caused confusion, and that by your devotion to separating indulgence from enjoyment you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Reflections and Contemplative Practice of Kamma

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 25 min

In this contemplative talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the profound Buddhist understanding of kamma as intentional action, distinguishing it from the popular misconception of karma as mere consequence. Drawing from traditional Buddhist teachings, he presents five essential reflections: owning our actions, inheriting their results, being born from our actions, forming relationships through them, and living dependent upon them.

Bhante emphasizes that kamma is fundamentally about moral responsibility and the role of intention (cetanā) in shaping our destiny. He clarifies common misunderstandings, explaining that physical conditions like genetic disabilities are not direct karmic consequences, but rather how we relate to our circumstances determines our kamma. The talk includes practical guidance for transforming these reflections into heart-centered contemplation.

The session concludes with a guided meditation where practitioners repeat each reflection into the heart, allowing the truth of personal responsibility to penetrate beyond intellectual understanding into emotional digestion. This practice aims to transform our attitudes toward moral action and develop wisdom about the interconnected nature of our choices and their consequences in both this life and beyond.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa — homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So this is November and it's time for our lugubrious contemplations. We've done death, ageing, sickness and all that, so now it comes to the contemplations of *kamma*.

First of all, in the Pali, kamma, K-A-M-M-A, just means action. Consequences are called *vipāka*. Now, of course, our language uses the Sanskrit term karma with an R to mean consequence. So during this particular talk, when I talk about karma, I'm talking about the action.

The first little quote here is: beings are owners of their actions, heirs of their actions. They originate from their actions, are bound to their actions, have their actions as their refuge. It is action that distinguishes beings from inferior and superior. This is not the distinguishment according to artistic or intellectual or physical talent — this is to do

with morals, it's to do with whether we are moral or immoral, virtuous. The equation is that the more deluded you are, the more unethical you will be, and the more wise you are, the more ethical you will be.

We'll be using this normal way of contemplating kamma: I own my actions. I inherit the results of my actions. I am born of my actions. I form relations through my actions. I live dependent on my actions. And then a final catch-all phrase: whatever I do, for good or for ill, I shall inherit the results.

Now, the first one — I own my actions. We are totally responsible for what we say, for what we think, and for what we do. It's coming out of us. That's the first thing to really grasp. And the consequences that come from that are dependent upon the intention. So remember, the role of intention in the Buddha's teachings is crucial, and to be separated from desire. So there may be a desire to say something angry, but you see it and you let it go. But if you speak angrily, then that will have consequences.

Remember, it goes into a matrix — the inner matrix of our psychology, making us more angry, and the outer matrix which is all these people coming together to listen to what you said. And you don't know what the response will be. You can't tell what the consequence of an action will be because it is either enlarged or diminished by the milieu that it finds itself in, the environment that you speak into or do something into. That's the reason that the Buddha constantly asks us to make wise reflections and why we need a guide at this point.

I always think to myself how fortunate I am that I have such a wise person, the Buddha, to guide me. I doubt if there's anybody more wise than the Buddha — there may be somebody equal, but I doubt more wise, such is the profundity of his wisdom. That's the important thing to understand.

So something is a desire — nothing's happened. As soon as you empower that desire, if you remember the word *cetanā*, the will, then something comes of it. And the general rule is that if something is good, some good will come of it. If something is not good, something not good will come of it.

Now the second reflection is: I am heir to my kamma, or I inherit the results of my kamma. Here we have to again remind ourselves of the specific law of conditionality. We don't know what will happen once we say something or do something. In fact, we don't know inwardly what will happen when we allow thoughts to develop within ourselves.

The important thing for me here is to accept what comes back to us, even though it's not directly related to my personal karma. Now what that does away with, which I found a real freedom, a real liberation, is the need for punishment. Punishment comes on top of that. So when we're self-criticising, when we're full of aversive self-blaming, when we're beating ourselves up, it's all completely unnecessary. You do something unwholesome, it comes back to you, you bear the consequences, you learn from it, you make an intention not to do that again, and that's the end of it. If you do it again, the same process — habits are hard to overcome.

If you do something that's really beautiful, something that's wonderful, and the response of praise comes towards you, you accept it, but there's no need to go into how wonderful I am, how what an amazing person I really am. All that's not necessary.

There's a little note here which concerns Hoddle. Now Hoddle was the England manager between '96 and '99, and he somehow had this understanding, or at least this is what people thought was his understanding — that people who suffered some genetic disablement, that that was the consequence of a past life. And it created such a furor he had to resign. According to the Buddhist teachings, that's not right. Because, of course, the body you receive is coming from all your past generations. What is your karma, no matter how unhappy you are with the body you've received? And it might not be that it's disabled — it might be that it's just ugly, you don't like it. Whatever the body you end up with is not the direct consequence of your past actions, but the way you relate to it is.

And then we have: I am born of my actions. This is the understanding about habits. Remember that once you create a set of actions, you then develop a habit. And when we collect all our habits, that's our personality, that's our character, and it will drive us to our destiny. Our job is to see what is driving us to an unfortunate destiny, to perdition, and what is driving us towards a heavenly destiny.

This happens of course not only in terms of future lives — that's the normal understanding in Buddhism, that it does affect future life. In fact, your last consciousness as you die has a great effect on what's going to happen in the next life. It will drive you to do something about it. So if you die, for instance, with a lot of guilt on your mind — you did something which has just come up as you die and you die with that on your heart — in the next life you want to do something about that. If your last thoughts are what a wonderful life you've had, what a wonderful relationship you had, then you'll be seeking the same thing in the next life.

Remember that this also is happening in this present moment and it's happening from day to day, from year to year. We're being reborn all the time. The only thing that happens at death is that the body falls off.

Going back to the idea of genetic disease, while I was at Amaravati Buddhist Monastery — so this is going back thirty-odd years now — a young man was brought to the monastery who was severely disabled from a genetic illness. Seemingly he was going to move into a flat and be quite fairly independent, and we were asked to go and have a chat with him and all that, and we would have to carry him to the toilet, things like that. And he was perfectly happy as far as we could see. He was accustomed to his situation and he'd adapted to it.

It seems that his parents had been told that such a thing could never happen again, or it'd be a million-to-one chance of such a disease coming again. They had a daughter and the daughter suffered exactly the same. And seemingly she was extremely embittered. So here we have a similar situation and two different ways of coping with it — and that's the karma, the way they've coped with it.

The next one is: I form relations through my karma. It can be sobering, really, to think about one's past relations, relationships that one has had, and just to see what we did, what we said, which either made them flower into something beautiful or disappear and crumble into something horrible. I personally have lots of regrets of being unkind and things like that, and it's reflecting on that that makes you want to be different in the future.

Now here we have this interconnectedness. Here we're going back to this law, this specific law of conditionality. It's the understanding that we are all interconnected, interdependent, that even these words, even these thoughts that I'm giving to you, they're not mine. They don't belong to me. I've read them all. In fact, I also use GPT to give me some ideas, and then I normally just fill out around those ideas and maybe add something that I picked up from somewhere else.

It's not as though anybody is completely original. I mean, that's very rare indeed. You'd have to be a Newton, an Einstein. You'd have to be an original musician, a composer for instance. But all these people rest — as I think it was Jung who said — on the shoulders of giants. So nothing is original. Everything has been either said before or done before. We are this interconnectedness.

It's very difficult for us Westerners to get away from the idea that we're little isolated modules, whole, entire, and that we somehow have this enormous wall around us to say well, this is me and I'm not you. And of course it does affect the way we relate to

people. The philosophy that I always point to here is the South African philosophy of ubuntu, which in short just says: I am because we are. It's just catching that relationship that we have and to realise that the relationships that we create with others affect the way they relate to us.

And then there's: I live dependent on my actions. This refers both to the inner and to the outer life. Here we have, let's talk about a certain paradox, which is not understood in popular Buddhism. And that is that you can purposefully suffer and yet be inwardly perfectly happy.

I once asked somebody in Sri Lanka, a born Buddhist, brought up as a Buddhist, why he thought Jesus Christ suffered such a terrible death. And he said, "Well, he must have done something terrible in his past life." And that's the way regular Buddhists, born Buddhists would think of that. Anything that happens to them, there must be some problem, something they did in the past life. And so there's very little understanding that you can put yourself out for a cause. You can become a martyr to a cause.

If we look at some of our modern-day saints and martyrs, the obvious ones that come up are Nelson Mandela. And for me, the very tragic figure of Alexei Navalny. To lose someone with that clarity of vision and courage is really heart-rending. And especially when you hear that he would have been one of those released with the other people just recently.

I live dependent on my actions. And then we have this summary which captures all: whatever I do, for good or for ill, I shall inherit the results.

Now with these little reflections, we have to turn them into contemplations. The way we do that is by repeating these phrases into the heart. And when you do that, you've got to be aware of any aversion — you don't want to know that, you don't want to feel what comes up when you say to yourself, "I am heir to all my actions." You have to keep repeating it and feeling that negativity if the negativity is there. And you have to wait until, as the truth of that statement begins to penetrate, that aversion begins to disappear. And finally, there's a feeling of digestion. And when a contemplative subject is being digested, that's when it's going to change us. That's when it's changing our attitudes.

So that's what we're going to do. We're going to spend a moment with each statement — a minute actually. I'm going to spend a minute with each statement. During that time, if you just keep repeating it into the heart — so this is not an intellectual exercise, this is

an emotional exercise, this is a heart exercise — and just keep repeating it gently to yourself. And then after the five minutes, we'll go into the sitting. And if you want to keep it up, that's fine.

So what I'm going to now share with you is the page itself. I've highlighted those particular words because they'll give you a clue as to what we're actually, what you have to remember. But I'll leave that on the screen for you, and if you want to just jot down those main words to remind yourself, and some of you will be able to take a screenshot. Owner, inherit, born, relations, dependent — whatever I do for good or for ill, I shall inherit the results.

So if we go into a meditation, I will repeat those phrases and time them to about a minute.

The first one, again, remember repeating it into the heart: I am the owner of my actions of mind, speech, and body.

I inherit the results of my actions.

I am born each moment, each day, each lifetime of my actions.

I form relations through my actions.

I live dependent on my actions.

Whatever I do, for good or for ill, I shall inherit the results.

So now we can either continue that contemplation or return to *vipassanā*.

Forgiveness

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 15 min

In this practical teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma presents forgiveness as one of two fundamental attitudes that inform all virtues (alongside gratitude), essential for dealing with guilt, shame, and unforgiveness. He emphasizes that all emotions around forgiveness are self-made responses, not caused by others, and that forgiveness practice is primarily for our own benefit.

The talk explores the nature of saṅkhāras (volitional formations) as conditioned habits that create reactive patterns, likened to balloons of particular emotional responses that can burst when triggered. Bhante guides through the three aspects of forgiveness practice: learning to ask for forgiveness, forgiving others, and forgiving ourselves—often the most challenging.

Two key contemplations support self-forgiveness: paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination), showing how ignorance leads to delusion and unwholesome actions without culpable intent, and karma, understanding that natural consequences arise without need for additional self-punishment. The teaching emphasizes that the heart remains fundamentally pure despite deluded actions, and through practice, returns to its original purity. This practical dharma talk includes guided meditation and addresses maintaining boundaries while releasing resentment.

So I shall start.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

Excuse me, I'm out of voice. I've not been talking for a while. It's all gone husky.

So tonight we're going to have a look at forgiveness. Most of you I'm sure have done exercises on this, so I'll just go through the basics and then we'll practice it.

I think there are two fundamental attitudes which really inform all our virtues, and the first one is gratitude. Once we realize we cannot pay back what we've actually received—our life from our mother and father and so on—then it moves you. You want to

give something back. So it moves to all those qualities of love, compassion, generosity and so on. And forgiveness is the other one. That's dealing with all the dark side, all the guilt, the shame, the unforgivingness, all that stuff.

So with these two fundamental or basic attitudes, I think we can have a happy life.

The first thing to remember is that all the emotions we suffer around forgiving—trying to forgive somebody, being forgiven, asking for forgiveness and forgiving ourselves—all the emotional stuff is all self-made. When somebody says something that is a bit nasty, our response is our response. They didn't cause that. So that's the first thing to remind ourselves. All the stuff we're going to work with has been made by me.

The idea is to undermine them and then they will transform naturally. That's the other thing we have to remember. All negative states will eventually transform themselves to the opposite. Nothing is lost. Where there's hatred there'll be love and so on.

The final note on this is it's for us. So forgiveness is for us, it's not for them, which might sound a bit selfish. But they've also got the same problem with us. So whatever we're doing here now—asking for forgiveness, forgiving—they also have their own problems, and when they're doing forgiveness practice they're doing it just for themselves.

So it's basically a practice for our own benefit. If the other person is affected by it, all well and good. For instance, if we apologize to somebody and they feel the heart to respond, that's good. We've been a catalyst for their movement, their heart movement. But they don't have to forgive us. That's sometimes difficult to accept.

The next thing is about attitudes. So these are *saṅkhāras*. Most of you know that word—*saṅkhāra*. It's normally translated as volitional conditions, which doesn't mean very much, but it's basically the choices we make, the habits we have which are conditioned and conditioning. That's the important thing. So these are energetic conditionings, and the way I think of them is like they're balloons of particular types of reactivity.

I might, for instance, be very annoyed when people are late. So every time somebody's late I get irritated, and I don't look at it, I don't think about it. So this balloon of irritation around people being late grows and grows and grows. And then one day somebody's too late, and it's like a pin touches this balloon and all this irritation and anger just bursts out. That's where you get this rage, this road rage and all the stuff we hear about.

So what we're doing is we're letting the steam out, we're letting the bad air out of that balloon.

There are three subjects obviously. We have to make the ability to ask for forgiveness easy for ourselves. It's against our pride, but we have to make it easy. And then we have to ask for forgiveness. That's also something we don't like doing. And then finally we've got to forgive ourselves, which is often the most difficult.

Now, the process is we remember something, and we have an event. And that event carries with it all the loadings that we put on it—the hurt, the anger and so on. So the event comes to mind.

Now we have to be careful, really careful, it doesn't shoot off into a fantasy. Once we're up there in the clouds fantasizing, whether we like it or not we're making things worse. Whatever emotion is being exercised and made worse by storytelling. So as soon as we see that happening we just come back and we try to hold that frame fairly still. And while we're doing that the attention is drawn to what's coming from the heart.

So what might come up is hurt. Say somebody said something, so hurt. And the next protocol is how we're relating to this hurt. Now we don't like to accept that because it's against our pride. So we have to allow that aversion, that not wanting to disappear, until we can allow the heart to express its hurt completely. That's the healing process.

So we're using this little image that we've got, this event, to get in touch with the hurt. And that hurt is connected to all the hurts that we have, just like the anger in that balloon is connected to all the other angers. And as we let out one little bit of anger, everything else is affected. So it's systemic. Everything we do has a systemic effect on our own hearts and minds.

Now, when we're doing this, by the way, if as you come to forgive somebody, you can't do it—fine. You don't worry about that at all. You just keep working on the hurt. And then eventually the heart softens and you can do it.

And we always start with a bit of *mettā* just to warm the heart up a bit. And then we ask for forgiveness. We forgive others and then we forgive ourselves.

When we're asking for forgiveness, the first thing that might come up is the reason why the person did it. So you've got to be aware of that relationship you have to the person, but basically you're looking at the hurt. And when that passes, perhaps the desire of revenge, and you have to let that go too.

When it comes to forgiving, again, there's that hardness that's in the heart. It doesn't want to forgive. And there's a story here. When the Islamist blew himself up in London—this is going back a bit—there was an Anglican priest that left the order saying she couldn't carry out the ministry because she couldn't forgive the bomber who'd killed her daughter. But it's actually never a case of can't, it's a case of won't.

Let's just hope that distraught mother has found a way eventually to open up her heart. And if we look around the world at this moment there must be a lot of mothers who are utterly distraught at what happened to their children, young and old. But then you get a story like the mother who went to see her son's murderer and finally took him home when he was let out of prison and treated him like a son.

So we have to remember that to forgive somebody is not to try and forget something. That's suppressive. We're just trying to release the emotional charge. Sometimes when we do that we feel we're condoning what they do, but that's not so. That's just wrong feeling. We're letting them off.

But obviously where amends and compensation is needed, definitely we should ask for it. And especially where there's justice—where we need justice for grievous bodily harm, rape, all that dreadful stuff which I hope none of you suffered from—but then you have to seek justice but not with that anger, not with that desire for vengeance.

And sometimes you have to stay away from people who harmed us. You have to protect yourself. That's not a problem.

And then finally, forgiving ourselves. So forgiving ourselves. There are two contemplations that are really helpful.

First one is dependent origination. So remember, in dependent origination, we start off with *avijjā*, this ignorance, which produces a delusive idea about the world. And it's really based along the idea of a self. And we're trying to seek happiness in the world. And we do it in this way that creates suffering. And as we practice, we can see the cause, the psychological cause of that, which is the desire, the wrong desire, and the fact that we're holding on to things which are impermanent. It doesn't make sense. And eventually to undermine that whole concept of a self—we have it's a feeling concept, it's not just a head concept—and what this does is it takes us towards wisdom.

So one movement is from ignorance, delusion, and then the process of insight which takes us to wisdom. From the heart's point of view, just as the delusion, we cannot be blamed for the delusion. The ignorance isn't culpable. So from the heart's point of view,

we're never meant to do any harm. The heart has always been pure in its intentions. But because of this delusion, it leads itself to being acquisitive, to being aversive, to being fearful, and so on.

So all these have produced unwholesome actions. And then there's the consequence of that, which we're dealing with now, or forgiving, this business. And when all that's purified, we end up with the pure heart. So that's the process from a pure heart through all this negativity. We work with it and it's basically—most of it's the sweat when it comes to the spiritual practice. The other bits are easy. The insight's not a problem, it's just all the gunk in the heart that we're trying to get rid of.

And that leads us to purity, immaculacy, back to purity and immaculacy. So the Buddha talks about it like dirt that gets on a cloth, and when you wash it the cloth goes back to its original loveliness. So that's the projection that we're on, that's what we're doing.

And the other one is about *kamma*. So that's pretty—I mean, at its simplest equation, you do something which is harmful, some harm will come of it. You never know what. And remember that the harm, if it's outwardly, for what we speak and what we do, you don't know what the effect will be. It goes into a matrix of relationships. And the same happens to us when we do something. Every time we say something or do anything, whether it's good or bad, it affects the whole—it's a systemic effect inside us. It affects the whole psychology in some way.

Now the bit that I found really relieving was that when we do something wrong there is a karmic response to it. There'll be something comes back to it, and that's all we have to suffer. All the business about punishment and the way we talk to ourselves and the recrimination, the self-recrimination, the anguish and all that—all that's not necessary. All that's necessary is to receive the consequence of unwholesome action. Just to receive it with patience and bear with it until it also will dry up, pass away.

So that's an interesting reflection, I think, on *kamma*. So don't feed the critic. That's the big thing.

So we'll do the practice. We'll do the practice together. And then I'm going to put what is actually a written piece here as a PDF on the website with this video. So that if you want you can download it and just look at it and use it.

So we can begin our practice by just sitting quietly.

The Basics of Insight Meditation 02

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 34 min

In this foundational talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma traces the Buddha's path from his departure from family life through his awakening under the Bodhi tree, emphasizing how this journey illuminates the core principles of insight meditation. He explores how the Buddha's childhood memory of concentrated awareness during a ploughing ceremony became the key to his liberation—a shift from trying to eliminate suffering to investigating its causes with curious, direct observation.

The talk examines the Buddha's teaching methodology through the Anattalakkhaṇa Sutta, his second discourse on not-self (anattā), showing how investigation of the three characteristics—impermanence (anicca), suffering (dukkha), and not-self—leads to freedom from the illusion of a permanent, controlling self. Bhante explains the three types of suffering: dukkha-dukkha (reactive suffering), vipariṇāma-dukkha (suffering from attachment to the pleasant), and saṅkhāra-dukkha (suffering from not seeing the compounded nature of existence).

Practical guidance centers on cultivating 'Right Awareness'—that childlike quality of direct seeing before conceptual overlay. The five hindrances (nīvaraṇa) are reframed not as obstacles but as teaching tools for understanding the three characteristics. The talk concludes with reference to the Kevaddha Sutta's description of nibbāna as boundaryless, non-manifestive consciousness 'full of light,' emphasizing that the observer position itself approaches this awakened awareness where suffering cannot take root.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambhodassa — Homage to the Buddha, the blessed noble and fully self-awakened one.

So if you can imagine what it was like for the Buddha to leave his family. He's twenty-nine, he's married and he's just had a child born. It's not as though he made a sudden decision, he's off. It must have been hanging around for quite some time, and I often wonder whether his marriage was in good faith or bad faith according to the philosopher Sartre — just to follow customs and not to follow what your heart's really telling you. I'm wondering whether the birth of his child was like a crisis point where he realised he wasn't ready to be a father or whatever. Obviously during that late youth, around about twenty-five onwards, there is usually an awakening to the fact that youth is passing, and for some people it can be like an early midlife crisis. So he leaves anyway.

I can't imagine he was happy about leaving, but determined to do so, perhaps just to taste the life of the *samana*, the recluse, the wandering recluse. And then what drives him is, of course, this urge to try and get beyond suffering. So that was the big theme of the age. Everybody was concerned about bringing suffering to an end. Some thought well, if you practise the *jhānas*, these absorptions, that's where you ended up forever in these heavens. Others were materialists, and when you're materialist, they just said well, when you die you die.

So he goes in search of teachers and he probably already knows them because one of the entertainments of the age was to go out into the park at full moon — and the full moon in the east is really almost like the sun coming out — and to listen to these debates where these religious leaders would try to better each other. So he was well into it, and we know that because after he becomes liberated he's able to hold his own with his arguments and understandings. So he's well into the whole spiritual religious turmoil that was part of that time. It was the same time that the Jain leader was there and all the Upanishads, the Hindu scriptures, began to appear. So it's an age of awakening — I was going to say a bit like ours, but I'm not sure about that.

He tries, of course, these various teachers, and the first two tell him how to get into these blissful states. In both cases he's good enough to become a teacher in that tradition, and in both cases he leaves because when he comes out of those states he's back to being anxious, depressed, etcetera. So they've not answered his fundamental urge within him to find if there's an end to suffering, which I think for him would have been the end of rebirths. It's there in the scriptures — he often talks about "this is the end of becoming," and right now you have to underline that as the end of becoming as a self.

So then he tries this other form, this very hard ascetic practice, with the understanding which I think was a Jain understanding. There's some hint that he was following that practice, that the soul, the eternal soul, was trapped in the body and that the body was a manifestation of your bad *kamma*. So if you didn't have eyes, you wouldn't have lust. If you didn't have a tongue, you wouldn't have greed. So the idea was to draw the body down, and that was done mainly through fasting. He got so thin, he said he could hold his spine through his stomach. If you try that, you'll see he was very thin.

At some point, if you can imagine it, he's there with six companions who probably have been with him all that time, so they're close mates, spiritual companions, all urging each other to be more and more ascetic. At some point he realises he's not getting anywhere — he's just more suffering, he says — and he leaves. I'm sure that in all our

lives we've taken up something and then realise it's not working for us and we're going to start again. We've got to go somewhere else, got to find another way of spending life. So I can only imagine that he's pretty depressed in our terms.

We have one biographical — well no, it's not the only one. There are two fairly acceptable biographical points in his life that we know about. There's something in his early life which I'll come to, and there's this point where he's sitting on a road and a woman with offerings for the local god offers him a mince pie. It revives him and it makes him consider what he's doing, and that's when some determination takes him to have one more go. It comes from this memory which is understood to be a real true biographical moment where he remembers watching his father doing a ploughing ceremony. He remembers himself being concentrated and full of enquiry, full of a sense of curiosity.

I think that means that his whole approach completely turned around on itself. Instead of trying to get rid of suffering, he now turns towards it to find out what the cause of it is. He finds himself a nice place near modern day Bodh Gaya and there's a village close by where he can get some food. He sits and he becomes liberated from suffering in his own terms. Such is his demeanour that when he turns up again to see his friends — because he thinks well, who can I teach? At first he has that doubt about whether it's worth doing it — but then when he approaches his people, they first of all turn off. They think he's gone soft, they don't want to know him. But as he approaches them, they begin to see that there's something about him which has changed.

In the conversation that follows, which is in the Vinaya rather than in the scriptures, he's constantly asking them, "Have you ever heard me speak like this before?" So he's made a real profound breakthrough and he's trying to get it across to them. That breakthrough goes back to that childhood way of looking at things.

So when we're born, we've already got it. It's there at birth, this ability to just receive. It is said that during the first four months it's just a catastrophe of information. We're seeing things, we're hearing things, and it's just coming at us. There's no objectivity where we're absorbed in the process, and that little baby knows very clearly what's pleasant and unpleasant. So you're born directly into that duality.

Then it would seem after four months you begin to push the world outwards, and the first object tends to be your carer, your mother. So eventually what was right here, happening here, becomes out there. Pushing it out there becomes an object outside, and we forget that everything we're observing and seeing is actually being put out onto the world out there. What we're seeing is what the mind is creating at this present time.

That sense of awareness that he found, that intuitive awareness that he discovered by just relaxing within himself and observing, he picked up from that experience he had watching his father doing a ploughing ceremony. That's probably, I would have thought, around about the age of seven and eight, because that's when we become a bit more self-aware in that way. For instance, guilt comes into play around about the age of seven, and around about the age of seven we drop the idea that what we can see or what we can imagine has to be real. So Father Christmas can't come down the chimney anymore.

This awareness that he then isolates from everything else that's in the body — all the senses, the consciousnesses that arise dependent on the senses — is that whole process. That whole process of investigation is the process of liberation. That's what he discovered. That's what he's trying to tell us to do.

This word *vipassanā*, which just means to see clearly, to really look and see — he's very clear on what it is that we're trying to investigate. It's not amorphous, it's not some fuzzy idea. He says, "Have a look at desire, this process of desire." He gives us three models of a human being — actually there's another one too, but the three main ones are the five *khandhas*, whereby he deconstructs the human being as a cross-section. So there's your physicality, and then your mentality is made up of your feelings, your perceptions, all your habits which are made by us through acts of will — that's the important thing, they're conditioned and conditioning — and consciousness, which here means a screen upon which all the information lands.

Then he points out that the consciousness is dependent on the six sense bases. There's the five obvious ones, which are your five physical bases — your eye, ear, nose, etcetera — and the mind itself, which is sensing your emotions and your thoughts. Then the final one, which again is more like a cross-section, and then he gives us a process which is dependent origination.

He starts off with that sense of ignorance, and this ignorance isn't culpable. It's not as though that four-month-old baby should have known better. It's just that's what happens to us. We come in not knowing — that's the word, not knowing. Then we manufacture some idea of ourselves, a sense of me, which concretises around about the age of three, so that you have a very little individual boy and an individual girl.

That's necessary. We have to start off with a self. It has to be a stable sense of self, a good sense of self. Often in the scriptures, and especially in the Dhammapada, there's a whole section on being a good self. But once you've established it, once it's stabilised, then we've got to get — it's not that you get rid of it completely, it's just that you recognise that it's also creating a wrong relationship of identity.

Every time we come into the *vipassanā* we've moved our identity. So we have a physical identity sometimes, like when you bite your tongue when you're eating. Just for that one moment, you and that excruciating pain are one. Then you get angry with yourself and then you become an emotion. Then you might reflect upon why it happened and then you become your thought processes, and so on and so forth.

Here in the *vipassanā* we've accessed some place within us, this observer, this feeler, which also has a sense of self. That's the one that has to be cracked. That's the last sense of self that has to be undone, you might say.

In the discourse on not-self, which is the second discourse that he gives according to the tradition — so the first one is just laying out the teaching which eventually formalises into the four noble truths, and one person listening to that, one of his six companions, becomes what we call a stream-enterer. He makes a breakthrough through that delusive idea of self. Then they all go off, seemingly they all go off to get some food and they come back and have a bit of a lunch, have a rest, cup of tea, and then he gives his second talk centring on this *anattā*, not-self.

It begins by saying, "If I were the body, I could make it different. If the hair on my head was mine, I'd make it grow, but it disappeared completely — what to do? If this body and if these emotions were mine, I'd have total control over them, but obviously we don't have that sort of control." If the sensations in my body were under my control, I'd be able to do something. Now it's not as though we don't have some control, but it's very surface. Even if you think about your body, have we any idea at this moment what the spleen is doing? I'm not so sure I even know what a spleen is. All I know is you don't want to get rid of it, or try not to get rid of it.

Then he talks about impermanence and he says, "If it's impermanent, how can it be me?" So he's struggling with this word *atta*. This was the word which was being used for an eternal self — it's the same word *ātman* in Sanskrit. So it's used by the Hindus, or the Brahmins — it's not Hinduism as such yet, it's Brahmanism we call it. It's used by other teachers such as the Jain teacher to point to something which is not part of this psychophysical world, psychophysical material world.

The discourse is not saying we don't have a self — remember, it does get confusing here. What the discourse is, is a pointer which is saying, "Look, if there is this self, where is it? What is it?" The next point he comes to is impermanent. He says, "Well, if this self is meant to be an eternal soul, an eternal spirit in our language, if it's so, it can't arise and pass away."

So even by investigating everything that we're experiencing as momentary experiences, we're beginning to understand that anything I experience can't be me. It can't be this soul. It can't be this permanent sense of self. Even the sense of self disappears when we sleep, so I can't be that either.

So it was really trying to point people to really investigate whether there was this eternal soul, and it was this process of investigation which is the liberating factor. So this is the path, you might say. The specific path of the Buddha was the process of investigation.

Then of course he says if something arises and passes away and you're clinging on to it, then it's going to cause suffering. That's the *dukkha*. Later, in a later way of explaining that, he talks about the three types of suffering. So there's the suffering of reactivity, *dukkha-dukkha*. Life has suffering whether we like it or not, but how we relate to that, the unpleasantness of life, that also causes suffering.

Everything is suffering if we're attached to something, and we get attached to what is pleasant, to what is beautiful. The impermanence of that — catching the impermanence, that we can let go, we accept beauty. So the thing is, it's accepting and enjoying beauty, enjoying that aesthetic mental state. When it goes, to remind ourselves it's gone — that will never repeat itself. I'll get something like it, but I'm chasing the dragon. It's the same psychology as any drug addict.

Then finally the *saṅkhāra-dukkha*, the *dukkha*, the suffering or the dissatisfaction that comes by not seeing that everything's compounded. There's nothing that has any solidity, that has any substance. We know that on a physical level from our science. Somebody once said to me if we took all the space out of the body, we'd end up with something like a centimetre cube of matter. So that's what we're made of, these subatomic energies, whatever. It's magic when you think about it.

So it's investigating these three characteristics that lead us to discover within ourselves something which is not part of that process. He doesn't like to name it. He doesn't like to call it something. He prefers to talk about the experience — *Nibbāna*. What he says about *Nibbāna* is that there's nothing in it which you've ever experienced or can experience. It is beyond the body and mind and heart. It's beyond all, whatever we call being a human being — it's not that.

Then in another scripture where he's in a sense pushed, we might say, by the question to answer in a very direct way — it's called the Kevaddha — it's very famous amongst monastics, amongst certain monastics, because...

it goes against the idea that Nibbāna is nothing, like it's a sort of clever way of talking about annihilation. And there's this monk Kevada and he wants to know where the world comes to an end. Now the world in this sense, and the Buddha often uses it in this sense, is the world you're experiencing. It's your world, right? It's not the world as an objective thing.

And he goes and asks somebody and they don't know, and he asks these devas, these gods, and they keep saying, well, we don't really know the answer to that. You need to go up higher to the next load of gods. And he goes up and up through all these scales of godly realms, deva realms, that he gets to the great Brahma who is the creator. And he says to Brahma, where does the world come to an end? And Brahma answers, I am Brahma, I am the creator of the world, I am the all-powerful, the all-knowing, and so on and so forth. And he says, I didn't ask you that. I wanted to know where the world comes to an end. And this happens three times. It's quite a funny discourse.

And then Brahma pulls him aside behind a curtain. And he says, listen, I don't want them to know that I don't know the answer to that question. But I do know who knows, and that's the Buddha. And you made a mistake coming up here. You should have gone to him. So he nips down back to see the Buddha.

And he asks the Buddha, where does the world come to an end? And he says, that's not the right question. The question is, where does the world not find a footing? So Nibbāna exists at the same time as the world, as it was for him, the Buddha. And then he comes out with a statement. He says, there is a consciousness. So now, you see, it's like whenever somebody has an insight into human nature or into the world as it is, there's always a struggle for a word because the words that we have are always based on history, are always based on what we know. So for instance Freud, he has a real deep insight into the human psyche and there's no words that he can use, so he makes them up: the id, the ego, the superego.

So the Buddha doesn't particularly make up a new word. He is using consciousness in a particular way. And what he says is that there is this consciousness which is non-manifestive, and what he means by that is you won't find anything that the six senses offer us. So that's one way of looking at a human being: that the consciousness is based upon one of the six senses. You're either seeing or hearing, feeling, thinking. And he says there's nothing. It's just not manifest. There's no manifestation within that consciousness. And then he says that there's no boundary. There's no boundary. In other words, there's nothing there which is, which there is a relationship to. It's complete, whole and entire unto itself. And then he says it's full of light.

And that's one experience, an experience of Nibbāna. So that's our aim. Nibbāna can be experienced in different ways. That is a specific experience of the Buddha within, in itself. But every time we sit in the position of the observer, we're right with that. We're actually almost on the point of a Nibbanic experience because when you're in that position, ask yourself, am I suffering? It might be that there is some very negative mental state there. You might be feeling very sad about somebody who's died, for instance, a friend. And as soon as you become aware of it, as soon as it's there, you're allowing the heart to express its sadness and therefore its healing.

But whatever is aware of it, ask yourself, is that actually suffering? So this is a magical position to find within ourselves. It doesn't heal the heart, it allows the heart to heal itself. That's all the heart wants to do. The heart just wants to express its problems and it expresses it in feelings.

And that's where we start dealing with these so-called hindrances. All those things that are agitating, are depressing. The five. All the ones to do with desires that we want. All the aversions that we have which include the fears and anxieties. All that dullness and lethargy which has been a way of indulgence and a way of suppressing stuff. Often when we're in a miserable state, we'll just throw ourselves on the sofa and fall asleep, and so it's a nice way of just pushing things away. And of course it's very pleasant, isn't it? When you wake up in the morning on a Sunday and you might just have been tempted just to keep sleeping in that subliminal state where you just keep turning over. And then you might get up and have a cup of tea and get back in bed.

So there's all these sort of, that laziness. Well of course it's building up a mental state, and that's what we often feel when we're sitting as a hindrance. A hindrance meaning it's the danger of us being pulled into it, of giving into it. That's why it's a hindrance, is that they're actually teaching us something, these hindrances. And then there's all that area of shame and guilt, remorse, sort of secondary stuff that comes when we've not behaved in a way that's moral or ethical. And there's also, including that, the sense of just that restlessness. Restlessness. It can be physical, it can be emotional, it can be mental. It can be the three of them. And you just can't stop fidgeting. You can't stop doing something.

And the final one is doubt. But this is a type of doubt. I mean, the Buddha definitely wants us to doubt in the sense of ask ourselves, is what the Buddha is teaching true for us? Remember, this is a process of investigation. So belief becomes a real hindrance. He doesn't want us to believe anything, but he does want us to have confidence. And that's

what sceptical doubt takes away from us, because if you don't have confidence, then that doubt takes you over. In anything, in any walk of life, and you can't move. You're paralysed.

I once had a student, I don't know what happened to him, but he got into this terrible psychological place of extreme doubt. He couldn't decide whether to get out of bed or not. I mean, it's just amazing when you think about it. And I'm not so sure I could help. I'm not sure I helped him, except to say, make a decision at some point to get out of bed and get out of bed. But he couldn't motivate himself. It was very, very strange. Unfortunately, I lost contact, but I presume he's found a way out of that.

So these mental states, these hindrances that come up, are actually to be used in order to keep reinforcing in ourselves, to re-establish a different relationship with the world. Not me, not mine. And of course the danger is then that you're opting out. You're finding a place where you're becoming non-engaged. And that's why whenever we practice *vipassanā*, it's always good to do a bit of *mettā* because that re-engages us.

And basically that's what the Buddha did. If you remember, having attained this full liberation, no, just before that, you get the great doubt where Māra attacks him. So he's sitting there and all those old desires are coming up to go back to the family, back to the life that he once loved, et cetera, et cetera. And he tries to steady that doubt by touching the earth, and the earth goddess rises and says, you've got every right to seek this liberation. Because Māra is telling him that he's not good enough, he's no good. It's a waste of time. Why are you doing this? And having perfected the virtue of generosity, it means that his purpose wasn't just for himself. It was actually to try and recognise that if he found it, he could help everybody else. And that was his engagement. That was what gave him that courage to just break through.

And then afterwards, having overcome the doubt that anyone would actually understand him, sends him into forty-five years of teaching. And that's what he devotes his life to.

So just to sum up: right awareness. Bring to mind that childlike way of looking at things before conceptual thinking, before words, just to be able to see. And we can practise that just a very simple way. We can stare at something, just stare at it, and let the information come to us. And what it is we're actually investigating: these three characteristics. And to use the five hindrances as ways of seeing these three characteristics. And slowly but surely, I'm sure you've all experienced life getting a little bit better because of our practice, just a little.

So abandon progress. That's a poison, honestly. It's a poison. I always get students saying, I'm not progressing, or where am I going? You're not going anywhere. You're standing right here and you're observing process. And in observing process, that is the process of liberation. To see and understand how things have come to arise. That's the Buddhist sentence.

So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, and that by your devotion to practice you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Dukkha — Basic Premise of the Buddhadhamma

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 15 min

In this foundational talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines dukkha as the cornerstone of Buddhist teaching, beginning with its etymology from ancient Aryan cart-wheels to its central role in the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta (SN 56.11). Unlike theistic religions grounding themselves in supernatural premises, the Buddha established his teaching on the undeniable reality of dukkha — a term encompassing suffering, unsatisfactoriness, and stress.

Bhante explores the Buddha's first discourse to his five companions, detailing the Four Noble Truths and the Middle Way between sensual indulgence and self-mortification. He then examines three distinct types of dukkha: ordinary suffering (dukkha-dukkha), suffering due to impermanence (vipariṇāma-dukkha), and suffering due to conditioned existence (saṅkhāra-dukkha). The talk concludes with the Buddha's comprehensive definition encompassing birth, aging, illness, death, and ultimately the five clinging aggregates (khandhas).

This essential teaching provides practitioners with clear understanding of why dukkha forms the starting point for all Buddhist practice, offering practical insight into how recognizing these patterns becomes the very process of liberation through vipassanā meditation.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa (repeated three times) — Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and fully Self-Awakened One.

This evening I thought we'd get back to basics a little bit and just look at this word *dukkha*. The first thing is to catch a little bit of the etymology of it. Supposedly according to Winthrop Sargeant:

"The ancient Aryans who brought the Sanskrit language to India were a nomadic horse- and cattle-breeding people who travelled in horse- and ox-drawn vehicles. Su- and du- are prefixes indicating good and bad. The word ka- in later Sanskrit comes to mean sky, ether or space, but was originally just a hole, particularly of an axle."

And so *sukha* meant having a good axle hole and *dukkha* meant having a poor one. So that gives you some indication as to its roots.

Before we go into *dukkha* and its crucial place in the Buddhist teachings, just as a general understanding about isms, about religions: all the Abrahamic religions have a god, a supernatural being who punishes you if you do something wrong and gives you lots of ice cream if you do something right. This god, as you know, has created enormous problems for the Western civilisation depending on which side god was on.

The east is different. There's no such personal god in Hinduism, and all that around good and bad moral behaviour is taken care of by the law of *kamma*, as it is in Buddhism and Jainism. But Hinduism came to teach more of Brahman, who was an impersonal god. But in terms of the other main religions, Taoism, Jainism and Buddhism, they are simply no God. They are non-theistic.

So the Buddha then, like these other two religions, Jainism and Taoism, it all depends on the individual human being. We create our own worlds. We have to get out of the mess. And once we're out of the mess, we are in a state of purity and happiness.

Now, that word *dukkha* has such a wide meaning that no one English word can do it. It was originally translated as suffering, but that's far too heavy, you might say. Unsatisfactoriness and then even stress, for those of you who know the work of Ajahn Thanissaro.

Now, just as these religions have a grounding in supernatural being, which cannot be proven, although they say it can be, you'll also find that in the humanistic religions or the secular religions of liberalism, communism, national socialism in its worst form, Nazism, and now a tweaked form of liberalism as neoliberalism, all of these have a premise. We know for instance in neoliberalism everything is to be controlled and guided by the market. The governments and unions all have to get out of the way — the market knows best, and we all know where that's taken us.

So once a premise is proven to be untrue or leading to disaster, then the whole fabric, the whole architecture of that belief disappears. Now the Buddha grounds himself on something which simply cannot be denied: *dukkha*.

The first discourse is around this word *dukkha*. And this is what he says at the beginning of it: "There are two extremes should not be followed by one who has gone forth into homelessness." We can take homelessness to mean anybody on the spiritual path. "What two? The pursuit of sensual happiness in sensual pleasures, which is low, vulgar, the way of worldlings, ignoble, unbeneficial. And the pursuit of self-mortification, which is painful, ignoble, unbeneficial. Without veering towards either of these two extremes, the *Tathāgata*" — that's what he called himself, it translates badly as "such

gone," it's basically the transcendent one — "has awakened to the middle way, which gives rise to vision, gives rise to knowledge, which leads to peace, to direct knowledge, to enlightenment, to *Nibbāna*."

So the first one is about indulgence, which is that desire and attachment. And the second one is really blaming the body for all the desires we have. So if I didn't have a tongue, if I didn't have the sense of taste, I'd have no problem with food. That's a mistake that perhaps was made by the Jains, who felt that the body itself, the material of the body, was the karmic result of bad actions.

Now in that discourse he delineates the truth. He first of all states clearly that there is the truth of *dukkha*, and we'll come to exactly how he defines that later. Then he points to the second, which is the cause of *dukkha*, which of course lies in that craving. And the third is the cessation of *dukkha* — *dukkha* is completely overcome by letting go of that craving and attachment. And then there's a path, of course, leading to the cessation of suffering, a cessation of *dukkha* — the eightfold path.

And then he goes on to say what we should do about this *dukkha*. So this is the noble truth of *dukkha*: the noble truth of *dukkha* is to be fully understood. The noble truth of *dukkha* has been fully understood — so he's talking about himself now. Then he talks about the origin of *dukkha*: the noble truth of the origin of *dukkha* is to be abandoned. That cause of *dukkha* is eventually to be abandoned. And then he states of himself, the origin of *dukkha* has been abandoned.

In the third one he says there is a noble truth of the cessation, the complete eradication of *dukkha*. The noble truth of the cessation of *dukkha* is to be realised — so this is something that is to be personally experienced, that's the liberation from suffering — and the noble truth of *dukkha* has been realised by himself.

This discourse was given to his five companions. Remember, he'd left them. He had then gone on his own and finally found the enlightenment, or became, should we say, awakened. And when he came back, this is the talk that he gave to them. And this is of course a formalised talk, but it gives us some idea of what that original conversation was about.

"This is what the Blessed One said, and being pleased, the group of five delighted in the Blessed One's statement. And while this discourse is being spoken, there arose in the Venerable Kondañña the dust-free, stainless vision of the Dhamma: 'Whatever is subject to arising is all subject to ceasing.'" Then the Buddha expressed this heartfelt

sentiment: "Kondañña has really understood! Kondañña has really understood!" And that's how Venerable Kondañña became known as Kondañña who understands, or *Añña-Kondañña*.

So that's the first definition of *dukkha*. *Dukkha* later on becomes slightly more refined in the sense of being one of the three characteristics of existence, and these are what we're investigating in our *vipassanā*. So it's *anicca*, the quality of impermanence. Knowing impermanence, seeing impermanence, begins to understand why holding on to anything pleasant leads to suffering, because everything, of course, disappears. Impermanence also leads us to understand *anattā*, not-self, because the self is supposed to be eternal, immortal.

So now we come to the core aspects of *dukkha*, and this is the most general explanation that he gives. First of all, there's ordinary suffering — so the *dukkha-dukkha*. So that first *dukkha* refers to all the natural suffering and displeasure that we get in life. And the *dukkha* that he's referring to, which we get rid of, is of course the relationship we have of wanting and not wanting, reactivity. So all our reactions based upon the idea of a self seeking to make this world a pleasant place for itself, always manipulating the world to make a pleasant place for itself, wanting, not wanting — that's the first form of *dukkha*.

The next form is caused by, as we just mentioned, *vipariṇāma-dukkha*, change. So even pleasant experiences are to be looked upon as impermanent, and very foolish to hang on to them. So when we have a party, we always want another one just like it. And of course, it never turns out the way we want it.

And finally, there's the suffering due to conditionality, *saṅkhāra-dukkha*. So *saṅkhāra* is conditionality, but it's also to do with compoundedness. Everything is made up of bits and pieces that constitute an object, or rather that the human being sees as an object. So we ourselves, we experience ourselves as whole, complete, entire, and yet when we actually investigate ourselves, you know, we're just a mass of cells, or a mass — bodily speaking — a mass of cells, or just chemicals, or just subatomic energy. And the mind is just this constant flow of thinking, imagining, emotionals.

So that means that this body, this self doesn't have a permanent essence. That's the important thing. And not seeing that leads us into this delusion, which is the fundamental cause of our suffering.

Finally, he sums it all up in a sense. So this is his definition of *dukkha*: "Birth is *dukkha*, aging is *dukkha*, illness is *dukkha*, and death is *dukkha*. Sorrow, lamentation, pain, grief and despair are *dukkha*. Association with the unloved is *dukkha*. Separation from the loved is *dukkha*. Not getting what one wants is *dukkha*. In conclusion, the five clinging aggregates, the *khandhas*, are *dukkha*."

So that final sentence — the clinging aggregates. Remember that those are the body itself, all our feelings, physical and emotional, in the body, all our perceptions, and then these *saṅkhāras*. So this is where we come in, because through an act of will we've created these volitional conditionings, habits, which are conditioned and conditioning. And our job as meditators is to perceive this whole process of how we create suffering, and it is perceiving the process that is the process of liberation. The final *khandha* was consciousness, by the way.

So I can only hope that this little talk on *dukkha* will be of some benefit, and that you will by your personal and complete devotion to the practice liberate yourself from all suffering, sooner rather than later.

Non-Violence is not Pacifism

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 15 min

In this timely talk delivered during the Ukraine crisis, Bhante Bodhidhamma clarifies the important distinction between Buddhist non-violence and philosophical pacifism. He explains that the Buddha's teachings were grounded in practical wisdom rather than abstract philosophical systems, as Buddhist society was pre-literate and focused on experiential understanding of suffering and its cessation.

Drawing from the Dhammapada and monastic rules (Vinaya), Bhante explores how the Buddha addressed violence in his time, noting that he never advised kings to disband their armies but invited them to cultivate non-violence in their hearts. He examines the crucial difference between force and violence—force being necessary action without hatred, while violence includes anger, revenge, or malice. The talk includes fascinating examples from the Cakkavatti (wheel-turning monarch) teachings and the origin of the pārājika rule against killing in monastic communities.

This nuanced exploration offers practical wisdom for navigating ethical dilemmas in our complex world, showing how Buddhist principles can guide us toward compassionate action without falling into rigid ideological positions.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

Well, a few things have happened since we last met, my goodness. I think it was Harold Wilson said, a week is a long time in politics. So although it was on the horizon, something was going to happen in Ukraine, I don't think anybody imagined what actually has eventuated.

Anyway, I just thought I'd clarify or at least to give you my opinion on this business of non-violence as opposed to pacifism. Pacifism really is an ideal. It's coming from some great concept about violence, making it a global total position. At its most radical, an absolute pacifist would never take part in any war. It's normally centred on war but of course it does spread out to just killing as well, and the basic position is that the value of human life is such that killing a person deliberately is simply not on.

Unfortunately with isms, they do tend not to be in touch with reality as it is, so you do get types of pacifisms which are a bit more close to reality, you might say. So you get militant pacifists who will oppose all violence and war, but then you get conditional pacifism, circumstances where war might actually lead to less suffering. So I think perhaps the Second World War would be one example of that, to overcome Nazism. Then there are selective pacifisms that really only to do with weapons of mass destruction. But normally speaking, when people talk about pacifism, it tends to be in that absolute category.

Now, non-violence is of a different nature. One of the things that I think we find hard to understand is that the Buddha was pre-literate, the society was pre-literate. So there was no writing. So if you don't have any writing, you really can't think about things in that systematic philosophical way. So there are no isms during the Buddha's time. So the Buddha is always grounding himself on actual experience, his personal experience as to what actually causes suffering and how to get rid of it.

There is nothing in the literature like philosophy as we would recognise it, sociology, systems thinking. There just isn't that thing. Not that there weren't views and opinions, but there weren't these solid isms that we have these days. So what he's actually teaching is how to be in a world which is largely driven at the moment anyway by greed, aversion, fear, and delusion. So it's a very practical approach to the world. And this practical approach is coming from a wisdom base, a practical wisdom base. It's coming from his own personal experience and of course the good heart.

So what we're getting to is an ethical stand, a way of relating to people and in fact all sentient beings. These days you can also add nature. So when there's no violence in the mind—the mind is never empty in the sense that there's nothing there apart from maybe sleep—when there's no violence in the mind, when it's in a state of non-violence, then of course empathy and compassion arise quite naturally. Those two can't exist together. That's the point.

Now, interestingly enough, in the discourses, when the kings are talking to him and one or two of them go to war, he never advises the kings to get rid of their armies. He never tells them to stop executing people. And also, certain punishments were delicious. There was one I remember which was rubbing the convict's head with a conch shell until the bone glistened. So, I mean, it's amazing how we can think up of these things. But there's a point that he never actually advises kings to get rid of their armies. So there's some basic understanding that this is the way it is. But he does, of course, invite them to develop this sense of non-violence.

So basically, he's about principle rather than going into the details of how you ought to do something. So he always leaves that to us. It's up to us to decide what we feel to be ethically good or bad.

Now, this translated in later Buddhism, in later Buddhist cultures, for instance, the samurai. The samurai was taught or developed himself to kill without any hatred. And there was one story where a samurai has beaten his opponent, and the sword is high, about to crash down on his head, and he walks away. And when they asked him why did he walk away, he said he was angry. And you'll also know the martial art of Aikido, which is really based upon the idea that you use the other person's energy to deflect their violence towards you.

Now, there's another interesting thing about the scriptures. Remember that when the Buddha was born, the Brahmins, one in particular, a sage, came to see him and decided or saw that he was either going to be a world-conquering monarch or a fully self-awakened being. And this alter ego of the world conquering monarch is in the scriptures. It's the *Cakkavatti*, and he has this wheel which appears and begins to roll and he follows it with his fourfold army—his foot soldiers, his cavalry, his chariots and his elephants—and whenever it goes, of course, he defeats the enemy and at times he's actually invited.

Now, as soon as he takes over, what does he do? He establishes the five precepts. And in so doing, everywhere he goes is just a very peaceful and loving place. And that's a motif that occasionally comes up in the discourses. And then it gets to a point where one of these Cakkavattins doesn't follow the five precepts. And immediately the society begins to corrupt and all things happen.

There was one rather interesting occasion where stealing began. So the minister told him, well, the person's stealing because they're poor. So he decided to give this person some wealth, some land, etc., so that he had no reason to steal. And then others thought, if I want more wealth and land, what I've got to do is steal. So stealing became common. And that's when he had to start chopping heads off. So that's the way it goes.

Now, there's also an occasion which brings about a rule for the *bhikkhus* for the monastic life, *bhikkhus* and the *bhikkhunīs*. The Buddha's obviously given a very enthusiastic talk about the repulsiveness of the body, and of course the purpose of seeing the repulsiveness of the body is to become non-attached to it. However, the *bhikkhus*, the monks, seem to have misunderstood this and they went off in the forests and they began to do this contemplation on the disgusting nature of the body. And they became so disgusted that they started killing themselves and asked other monks to kill them.

And so there's this wonderful story of a monk who's actually just stabbed a monk to death to release him from this disgusting body, and he's wiping the blood off the knife. But when the Buddha hears about this, of course, he must have been in a bit of a shock really, because his words had been completely misunderstood. So anyway, he makes up this rule.

"Should any bhikkhu intentionally deprive a human being of life, or search an assassin for him, or praise the advantages of death, or incite to die in this way: 'Dear friend, what use is this wretched miserable life to you? Death would be better for you than life.' And with such an idea in mind, such a purpose in mind, should in various ways praise the advantages of death and incite them to die, he is also defeated and no longer in communion."

So this is what we know is known as a *pārājika*. So in other words, he's defeated in the sense that he can no longer be a monk in this lifetime. And he leaves the order. The people who actually... this rule, of course, doesn't apply to the people who've just been murdering the other bhikkhus, because it's not backdated. It starts from that point onwards.

Now, the other interesting thing about this rule is that the person has to actually be killed or die for it to be a proper *pārājika*, a proper defeat. So if the person whom he's trying to attempt to die or intentionally trying to kill him but fails to do so, then it's a serious offence, of course, but he's not actually asked to leave the order.

So it's not a philosophy as such. It's really just practical moral reasoning. And these two verses come from the Dhammapada: "All tremble at violence, all fear death. Seeing others as being like yourself, do not kill and cause or cause others to kill." "All tremble at violence, life is dear to all. Seeing others as being like yourself, do not kill or cause others to kill."

So a distinction here has to be made really between force and violence, and I think this is the crucial bit. So for instance, if you drop your mobile, you might just go and pick it up and see if you've broken the screen and then just put it in your pocket. But on the other hand, you might be quite angry with yourself and fed up with yourself. And so you go down and there's that extra pressure in the hand of grabbing this mobile phone and stuffing it in your pocket. So one is non-violent and the other one is... one is the use of just simple force to put what was wrong or what has happened that is wrong, to put it right. Whereas violence is the same with some form of anger, hatred, revenge, etc.

So there are arguments to justify armed intervention and which would prevent further worse bloodshed. And in this terrible thing that's happening in Ukraine, if the soldiers are following their duty—this is the Buddha saying—well, you've been given a command, this is what you've determined to do with your life. If they try to kill or in fact if they kill soldiers of and people of the other side but there isn't any violent hatred in their hearts doing it, then obviously that would come under non-violence. But it still isn't something that they should be doing.

Now the Abhidhamma, this later teaching, says that you cannot kill anything, you can't kill any sentient being without some negativity in the heart. But as you can see, to actually try to... if somebody would try to kill somebody with that sense of hatred, revenge, anger, etc., that's a far worse place to come from than somebody who is killing in order to defend themselves.

So anyway, these are just some thoughts that I might put to you. On the news bite that comes out in a couple of weeks, I shall put a couple of links. Some of you might already have started seeing it, but it's a very good set of programs on the BBC about this Ukraine disaster. And it gives you a bit of back history. And you can begin to see that it's a product really of all reasons that have come to manifest in this terrible war.

Very good. So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, and that by your devotion to non-violence you will eventually liberate yourself from all suffering sooner rather than later.

The Eight Worldly Conditions

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 20 min

In this profound exploration of the aṭṭha loka dhamma (eight worldly conditions), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines how gain and loss, fame and disrepute, praise and blame, pleasure and pain create mental turbulence when we become obsessed with them. Drawing from the Buddha's teachings, he explains how these conditions arise from our sense of self and how personalizing these experiences — 'it's me that's blamed, it's me that's praised' — creates unnecessary suffering.

Through practical reflection questions, Bhante guides us to investigate our own relationships with these worldly vicissitudes. He distinguishes between wholesome desires (needing money, friends) and obsessive craving, and between appropriate congratulations and ego-driven attachment to success. The talk emphasizes developing equanimity — that balanced state where we can receive life's experiences without the welcoming and rebelling that keeps us trapped in dukkha.

Bhante references the Buddha's description of the arahat who remains 'unshaken by worldly vicissitudes' as one of the greatest blessings. This teaching offers a practical framework for understanding how the less we personalize life's inevitable changes, the more peace and freedom we can experience. Essential listening for anyone seeking to apply Buddhist wisdom to daily life's challenges.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So this month, I've chosen these *Aṭṭhaloka Dhamma*, these eight worldly conditions, concerns, winds, fortunes, vicissitudes. It's the ups and downs of life. I mean, that's basically what it is.

So this is what the Buddha says. Gain obsesses the mind and loss obsesses the mind. Fame obsesses the mind and disrepute obsesses the mind. Blame obsesses the mind and praise obsesses the mind. Pleasure obsesses the mind and pain obsesses the mind. They are attracted to gain and repelled by loss. They are attracted to fame and repelled by disrepute. They are attracted to praise and repelled by blame. They are attracted to pleasure and repelled by pain. Thus involved with attraction and repulsion they are not freed from birth, from old age and death, from sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection and anguish. They are not freed from suffering, I say.

So that's the eight worldly conditions. Now when we look at those conditions, you can see that they all arise out of a notion of a self. It's me that's blamed, it's me that's praised, et cetera, et cetera. And when we do that, of course, it just creates mental turbulence.

When this happens at a societal level, then you can see communities being split, as we see these days. And of course, when it gets to an international level, well, there's always war.

So what's it like to be freed of these worldly concerns? In the discourse on the greatest blessings, the Buddha has stated how an awakened *arahant*, how somebody who's fully liberated, is unmoved by one of the eight worldly conditions. And he describes this as one of the great blessings. And it says that a mind unshaken by worldly vicissitudes, sorrowless, stainless and secure, this is the greatest blessing. And again we can extend that to families and countries and we might just get to a peaceful world.

So what I've done is I've just made up questions around these eight factors just to give some idea of how we can use them just to reflect on the way we are with these fortunes and misfortunes.

So if we take gain for instance, is to ask ourselves what am I obsessing about? What sort of accumulation am I gathering? What collections do I have? Wealth, power, even though we might not have much wealth at all or indeed hardly any power. The point is this obsession about it, control. How much energy do we give to it? And how much time do we waste brooding and planning over these sorts of things?

And then once we can bring a past event to mind as a practice, we can get in touch with that feeling, that craving, that holding on, the cramped grip. What does that feel like? And to try and separate that from what you might call just an ordinary wholesome desire. I mean, we need money, we need friends, et cetera, et cetera. But there's a way of having that without that obsessiveness.

And then, of course, there's loss and everybody feels that. You might lose your job. What does that feel like? If you have lost your job in the past, how did that feel? The despair, the confusion, the anxiety, panic. So much depends upon our work and the wage that we have. And then there's the self-worth that we have from our work, the sense of status, but we'll come to that a bit later.

So we have to just ask ourselves, what if I let go of that? What if I just let go of the obsessiveness and just be more content with what I have? And by going to a past occasion and investigating it and reflecting on it, it just helps us to be prepared for the next time. So we're not so shocked when we lose things, lose our work, lose money on the horses and stuff like that.

So the next one is praise. So again, we look back and we think well what have I done or said or am doing or saying which has an underlying demand for praise, for admiration, for compliments, for appreciation? I mean, how does that feel? Is it necessary? And how does that reflect on ourselves and how we're judging ourselves and how we feel embarrassed when we suddenly realize that we've said something or done something just to be praised, just to be admired. And what would have happened if you hadn't had that intention in that particular case? And what should the attitude have been?

When it comes to blame, well, nobody likes that. Nobody likes to be blamed for anything. And again, to bring up an occasion in the past where we've been blamed and we've been judged and we've been criticised, and just to get to the hurt of that and how we reacted. And sometimes, of course, we react silently within ourselves. We spend hours getting our own back in these fantasies, throwing people on fires and chucking them off bridges and things like that.

So it's getting in touch with those feelings and naming them for what they are. What is it like to be humiliated? Instead of hiding that from ourselves, suppressing it because of our pride, is to let it up to let up and just feel it and to know that if I can just allow these things to manifest they're actually dying out, they're actually curing.

And some of these things are very difficult. The hurt, the humiliation, it really hurts the ego. I mean it really punches the self. And if we're afraid of criticism, does that make us timid? Does that make us timid?

And then when we have been blamed and it has been our fault, have we been humble enough to accept that and try and do something about it and not let that rumble on afterwards about self-criticism? I'm such a fool, I'm an idiot. How could I have done that? It's just being able to let go, to let go of something.

And then we have the area of success and failure. So again, it's much the same thing. You bring to mind a past occasion when you feel you've been successful, a job well done. And there's nothing wrong with appropriate congratulations. But again, it's this business of hanging on to that success.

I've got here just what the Buddha says about somebody who becomes an *Arahant*. He says that someone who's an *arahant* with their taints - taints are the roots of all our defilements: craving, craving for pleasure, craving to become, and ignorance, the basic ignorance of self. And these are the roots from which all these defilements arise. So he says when those are destroyed and has lived the holy life, done what has to be done or had to be done, laid down the burden, reached the goal, destroyed the fetters of becoming and is completely liberated through final desire.

So you can see I mean it's that sense of completion, what had to be done has been done. And if you look at your life where you've really completed something, it's done, it's finished, it's gone. There's a sense of joy about that. And lay down the burden. The sense of relief of laying down the burden, laying down the burden of being a human being, basically. And of course, the taste of *Nibbāna* is the joy of freedom. So that's where we're heading. It's good to remind ourselves about that.

And then, of course, when we are praised, we tend to personalise things. So immediately, it's not the job that's being praised, it's me. I'm amazing. You get very big headed. And sometimes if you catch yourself like that, if you catch yourself being big headed and full of self praise and all that, then again becomes a sort of and you notice that other people are seeing it as big headedness. Of course, that again produces a sense of shame within us.

So all these things, recognise all the ego stuff as unnecessary evaluation tags. Just let them fade away. And eventually, as the Buddha said, they just fall off.

Failure, oh that's the next one, failure. So a job didn't turn out well, a relationship sadly ended. How's it feel not to achieve something, even if you've put a lot of work into it and it just hasn't happened? So again you get this personalisation. The job failed therefore I'm a failure. The relationship failed so I'm unlovable.

And it's reflecting on that and recognising that those personalisations of things are just not necessary. They just add suffering to it. And if it was a genuine mistake or whatever we can be realistic about it and to make sure that we don't repeat that same mistake. But then again of course circumstances change. We don't have that total control.

And finally, there's pleasure and pain. So pleasure, of course, both mental and physical pleasure. We're always seeking that. We're always trying to be in that pleasurable state. But it's a case of, again, not attaching to it, not making it something that is repeatable. So when we have something joyful, something pleasant, to accept that it's come to an end and there's no need to go any further with it.

And to find out how we experience desire. So sometimes for instance when it comes to food you don't feel hungry so you're not attracted so much to the cake. But sometimes when you are hungry you can't stop yourself from eating the whole cake. So there's something about desire which is separate from seeing something that is pleasant.

There's that movement towards it of wanting, wanting, wanting. And then to make that distinction between the desire and the action. So remember in Buddhist psychology this is really crucial because when something is a desire nothing's actually happened, it's just potential. But as soon as you decide to let that energy go and produce something - a thought, speech, something that you do - then becomes an action. And that action goes out into a matrix of relationships on the outside but it also moves into the inner matrix of our psyche. And that's what we call *kamma*, action.

And so we're trying to make a distinction here between indulgence and enjoyment. And we do that, and the Buddha's always on about this, by restraining ourselves. That's very difficult in our society. We're not expected to restrain. In fact, everybody wants us to indulge. But the act of restraint gets us in touch with the unacceptable level, you might say from a *Dhamma* point of view, of desire. So in other words, nothing's wrong with appetite. Everything's wrong with greed.

Then finally pain. So pain can be very difficult. And I think one of the things we have to be careful of here is that we don't take what pain comes to us as some sort of karmic resolve. I deserve the pain. We're not in charge of the body. And the body has its own weaknesses and sometimes when the pain comes it's to do with genetics, it's not to do with the person themselves.

So it's up to us to decide whether this pain is something that I want to work with. So you're working with it in terms of getting that right relationship with pain, of patience, understanding what pain is at different levels. At one level, at the basic level of contact, pain is just sensation. It's when it becomes a feeling, when it's acknowledged as a feeling that you get the sense of pain and then you get that reaction of not wanting it. But if you can't do that investigation and you haven't got the patience for it then take an aspirin, do something.

I was just thinking then of the Act of Parliament that we've had, well, it's not completely passed, about assisted dying. And it's an area which Buddhists have to really think about and where they are personally with that. And when pain gets to a point which cannot be assuaged by any of the morphines and all that sort of stuff, then one has to decide for oneself whether it's a time to put an end to one's life and whatnot. And there are various degrees of understanding as to what is right and what is wrong. But ultimately, it's the individual. It's for them to feel okay with it. So that's a big topic, that.

So again, going back to the Buddha and just giving him a bit of time to quote there. Here we go.

So when gain arises for an uninstructed, run-of-the-mill person, they do not reflect gain has arisen for me, it is inconstant, stressful and subject to change. They do not discern it as it has come to be. So that's what's missing. We presume that once I've got something it's just going to grow, that it's not going to leave me. But it's a good thing to be able to remind oneself that whatever I have received which is bringing me joy, pleasure et cetera. This too will pass.

So one of the things I try to remind people to do is that after lunch to say to yourself, well, this is one less lunch in this lifetime. We can measure our lives by how many lunches we have, how many breakfasts we have.

And then those people who are not instructed, they welcome, they grab hold of an arisen gain and rebel against an arisen loss. And so it's the same with status and disgrace, with praise and blame, and with pleasure and pain. As they are thus engaged in welcoming and rebelling, they are not released from birth, aging and death, from sorrows, lamentations, pain, distresses and despairs. They are not released, I tell you, from suffering and unhappiness.

And of course those who are awakened, those who have developed to some degree, then of course they don't welcome it in that sense of wanting to indulge it. They just receive it. And this is the difference, he says, the distinction, this is the distinguishing factor between a well-instructed disciple of the noble ones and an uninstructed run-of-the-mill person.

So what's this underlying attitude that we're trying to develop to all these worldly conditions? It's equanimity. It's equanimity. And this comes about more and more as identity about a self becomes less and less. The less we personalise things, the more we find ourselves at ease with the way things are. And it's this sense of self which is producing all the problems. And we undermine that by reminding ourselves what the correct or should we say the more wholesome, skillful attitude ought to be.

And it's, what do they say, it's a working process. I wouldn't talk about progress. Don't get involved with progress, just get involved with process. How do I get rid of these wrong attitudes that I have to these eight worldly winds, which are going to happen anyway in my life? We're not going to stop it.

So it's one of the attractions of the Buddha's teachings that he really is also buried his teachings as well into daily life. So it's not just meditation and beautiful mental states and developing *mettā* from the heart. It's actually driving us into right action, right Eightfold Path, right speech, right action and right livelihood. And one of the things we have to do is just be able to handle these eight worldly winds.

Very good. I hope that these words have been of some assistance, they have not caused confusion, and that by your careful investigation of these eight worldly winds you will soon be liberated from all suffering, sooner rather than later.

The Paradox of Fear

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 15 min

Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the complex nature of fear and anxiety from a Buddhist perspective, examining how these emotions arise from our sense of self and attachment to things we might lose. Drawing from the Bhayabherava Sutta (MN 4), he shares how the Buddha himself faced fear and dread during his forest meditations, demonstrating practical methods for working with these difficult emotions.

The talk distinguishes between unwholesome fears rooted in attachment and delusion, and wholesome fears that serve as guardians - such as dread of consequences and shame - which protect us from harmful actions. Bhante emphasizes using mettā (loving-kindness) not to suppress fear, but to embrace it with care, creating space for the energy to naturally dissipate through vipassanā practice.

Practical guidance is offered for sitting with fear and anxiety when they arise, learning to stay present with these sensations rather than reacting or allowing anxious thoughts to multiply. This approach helps purify the heart and develop the fearlessness that comes with deeper insight into the nature of self and attachment.

So I thought this month we'd have a look at fear and anxiety since there's so much of it around. No need to mention names about what's causing all the problems.

In terms of terminology, there are words in Pali which separate fear and anxiety, but for our purposes we can put them all into one category using the word fear. The way we experience fear is as a sudden jolt of bad energy in the body, and it tends to go away quickly. If you step out on the road and a car just misses you, you get that fright. Fear tends to be paralyzing and cold, whereas anxiety is something long-term. It's always about the future, always what's going to happen next, and we tend to feel that as an agitation that warms us up and heats us up. So there's quite a difference between them, but for our purposes, fear will do.

Whenever we talk about things like this, we always go back to the root problem, and there of course we find the dear old self. This is the delusion of somebody, some person which has a reality to it. Remember that even the Buddha has a personality. It's not as though you lose your personality when you become liberated, but you lose that sense of self being isolated from others, a sense of disconnect. This manifests mainly when we come across death. That's our old friend death, and anything that suggests endings al-

ways reminds us of that ultimate state, which brings fear. It's the unknowability of when it'll happen. We don't know what will happen after death. We might have a certain faith, a certain belief that we carry on. On the other hand, we might think we just disappear. But whatever it is, nobody actually wants to die.

From that sense of self we try to buffer ourselves against the world, to protect ourselves from the world and from that fear of losing. So we attach to things. We gather wealth, friends, power. We like to absorb into sensual pleasures and become attached to that sort of thing - going on holidays, sex, drugs, rock and roll. Of course, the more things we have, the more people and friends we have, the more we can lose, and therefore with that attachment there also comes fear. The Buddha in the *Dhammapada* states it quite clearly: from attachment comes grief, from attachment comes fear. One who is free from attachment has no grief, so how can there be fear?

So how do we overcome it? Well, first of all, there's just the reflection. We've done a past moon celebration where we wandered into the idea of death, sickness, aging and all that. It's bringing that up as often as we want just to get accustomed to the idea of sickness, aging and death. It's through getting used to that, that sense of being okay with the feelings that come up, that is part of purifying the heart of its fear. As it says, "One who is wise and full of insight does not tremble in the face of death."

And then there's *mettā*. You have to be careful - *mettā* isn't there to bury it, to push it away or suppress it. *Mettā* is there as a way of approaching it. I'm sure you've heard me speak about holding things with that sense of care. So if we find ourselves being anxious, being afraid of things - especially with the news and all that, which can bring up a certain sense of fear and anxiety about what's happening in the world - just stay with the feeling and embrace it with a sense of care. Remember, you can always talk to the heart: "Dear heart, I can feel you. I know you're in a dreadful state, but we'll just stay here for a little while, and I'm sure that you'll release that energy."

By creating that distance between what you're feeling and what is doing the feeling, you're allowing that energy to dissipate. So it's a way of coming to terms with fear and of allowing that sensation to die away.

What we're heading for is fearlessness, and part of the practice of *vipassanā* is to do with that. But remember, you can do it at any time if there's the occasion, if you're on your own for instance, as you'll see from a reading that I'll be giving from the discourses. You can just sit with it for a while. Sometimes it can be quite heavy - even feelings of nausea - so you just sit with it. That lack of reaction allows the heart to heal itself. Remember, every time we're reacting, pushing it away, the energy of pushing it away is actually becoming part of that fear. And if we allow the anxiety to run away

with those thoughts, then it's going to grow. So with those two ways of dealing with it, as soon as we realize we're doing that, stop and just open up to what the heart wants to say.

So I've just chosen a passage to show us how the Buddha himself dealt with it, and it's much the same as we've been talking. So it's nice to know that he went through the same problems. It's called the Discourse on Fear and Dread. A Brahmin, Janussoni, goes to see him, and there's the usual exchange of greetings and little niceties. Then he says to the Buddha, "Remote jungle thicket places in the forest are hard to endure. Seclusion is hard to practice and it is hard to enjoy solitude. One would think the jungles would rob a meditator of their minds if they have no concentration."

The Buddha agrees with that and then lists a whole load of things that if we suffer from these things, it's going to be hard to sit in solitude. So if we are unpurified of bodily conduct, verbal conduct, full of covetousness and lust, ill will and intentions of hate, sloth and torpor, restlessness and unpeacefulness in mind, uncertain and doubtful, given to self-praise and disparaging others, subject to alarm and terror, desirous of gain, honor and renown, lazy and wanting in energy, unmindful and not fully aware, unconcentrated with straying minds, devoid of wisdom - such people will find it very difficult to find solitude in the forests in the jungle thicket resting places.

Now he says of himself that he felt that he wasn't suffering from all that very much, and so he decides: "There are especially auspicious nights of the 14th, 15th and the 8th of the fortnight" - this is the moon calendar - "now what if on such nights as these I were to dwell in such awe-inspiring, hair-raising abodes as orchard shrines, woodland shrines and tree shrines?" These shrines were where the gods were, and some of them weren't particularly nice. Interestingly enough, he doesn't suggest that he went to sit in the charnel grounds to overcome the fear of death. Here he is talking about these shrines, and of course he's there during the night.

"I dwelt in such awe-inspiring, horrifying abodes as orchard shrines, woodland shrines and tree shrines. And while I dwelt there, a wild animal would come up to me, or a peacock would knock off a branch, or a wind would rustle the leaves. And I thought, 'What now if this is the fear and dread coming?'" So he's gone to experience this fear and dread.

"And then I thought, 'Why do I always dwell expecting fear and dread? What if I subdue that fear and dread while keeping the same posture that I'm in when it comes upon me?'" So he stops expecting this fear and dread. However, it does come, and he says: "While I walked, the fear and dread came upon me. I neither stood nor sat nor lay down till I had subdued that fear and dread. While I stood, the fear and dread came

upon me. I neither walked nor sat nor lay down till I had subdued the fear and dread. And while I sat, the fear and dread came upon me. I neither walked nor stood nor lay down till I had subdued the fear and dread. And while I lay down, the fear and dread came upon me. I neither walked nor stood nor sat down till I had subdued that fear of dread."

So there he is - he went through the same sort of difficulties that we have to go through.

Now, that's to do with fear as something unwholesome. But interestingly enough, fear can be wholesome. One writer calls it the paradox of fear.

Take a very simple instance: why don't we just step out on the road and cross to the other side? Because within us there's a fear of being knocked over, and it's reminding ourselves of that. Even if it's only in the background, even if it's only subconscious, we know that if we don't take care and we walk out into the road, we may very well have a serious accident.

So there are two qualities that he points to which are wholesome fear: dread of consequences and shame. He gives a whole list of things that we should be afraid of in terms of consequences - some of them pretty straightforward things like misconduct of body, speech and mind. But he also talks about famine, catastrophes, schisms. These things - being afraid of famine and catastrophes and things like that - we prepare for them. As you know, we've had floods in this country and we finally have done a little bit about them. So knowing that there are going to be catastrophes, there are going to be famines, you build up situations where you can undermine them.

So this fear of things going wrong and the fear of doing things which are unwholesome and will have consequences - that sort of fear is a wholesome fear. It stops us doing things or it makes us do things for our own personal benefit.

The other one is shame. Shame is when we feel that we've lost esteem in people's eyes if we do something that they see or hear, and that of course is something that we don't like at all. But it's also at times when we have thought something or we do something where nobody's around, but we just feel that it's not something that I expect of myself. I had an old aunt who used to say, "If I did that, it wouldn't be me." So it's that sort of understanding about how we feel when we do something that humiliates us, that we feel that our worthiness in people's eyes and in our own eyes has been undermined.

So fear and dread of consequences, in the Buddha's understanding, are actually our guardians. They stop us doing unwholesome things, and it's interesting that the academics who study this are confounded by it. I mean, to me it seems pretty straightforward, but one of them conjured up this phrase "the paradox of fear."

So there we have it. In short, we've looked at the roots of fear and anxiety based on this self and attachment to things, how we deal with it through loving kindness and insight *vipassanā* and allowing that energy to dissipate, and how some fears that we have and some fear of the loss of face are actually our protectors.

So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance and that by your careful investigation of fear you will be liberated from all fear sooner rather than later.

Renunciation: The Path to Liberation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 15 min

In this profound teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines renunciation (nekkhamma) as the first of the three Right Intentions in the Noble Eightfold Path. He distinguishes between harmful self-mortification, which the Buddha rejected after his own extreme ascetic practices, and skillful renunciation—the wise restraint of our relationship to sensual experiences.

Drawing from the Dhammapada and core Buddhist teachings, Bhante explains how the delusion of self manifests through taṇhā—the specific craving that leads to attachment and suffering. He shows how renunciation applies not only to physical pleasures like food and sexuality, but to all sensual experiences: art, nature, intellectual pursuits, opinions, news consumption, and even our meditation attainments.

With practical guidance, he offers a gradual approach: starting with small daily practices of letting go, learning to bear discomfort mindfully, and recognizing the difference between boredom and true disinterest. He addresses renunciation in relationships (releasing control and manipulation), simplifying lifestyle in our consumer culture, and finding the balance between engagement and overwhelm.

Bhante emphasizes that renunciation isn't deprivation but liberation—freeing clean energy to focus on compassionate service to others, while remaining vigilant that even our good deeds don't become sources of ego-satisfaction. This teaching offers both newcomers and experienced practitioners a clear understanding of how letting go leads to genuine peace and awakening.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa — Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So this evening I've chosen this topic of renunciation. Now it's not a word we particularly love. We don't fall for it. But you won't find a wisdom tradition that doesn't have some level of sensual restraint in its teachings. Consider Lent for Christians and Ramadan for Muslims, and the Hindu tradition and the Jains of course all have some form of fasting as part of their practice.

Now in the Buddha Dharma we have made this distinction between self-mortification and renunciation. By self-mortification, we understand that the body is to blame. So if we lost our tongues, we wouldn't have any greed. And of course, the Buddha him-

self went under such practices, nearly starving himself to death. And he ended up by saying that that sort of practice was just adding more suffering to the already discontent of life.

But renunciation is the restraint of the senses, understanding that it's nothing to do with the body but our relationship to it. So the path of renunciation is a direct path through renunciation. And of course you get monks and nuns who live way out in the jungle, completely renouncing any contact with the sensual life, only going into the village to get some alms.

To understand the importance of renunciation we have to really go back to the roots of the Buddha's teaching, and that always lies in this delusion of a self. So what do we mean by that? Well, whatever you finish this sentence with — I am — whenever you finish that with, that's what you're not. And that's what we of course presume ourselves to be. In fact the 'I' in the 'I am' is also part of that delusion.

So it's the problem of this 'me' always wanting to be happy. Now that's not so bad — the Buddha actually has a whole chapter in the Dhammapada devoted to being happy, a happy self. But it's just what we are seeking for our happiness which is going to cause disappointment and eventually a bit of sorrow. So that's easy to overcome when we keep reminding ourselves that everything, absolutely everything, arises and passes away and does not repeat. So you can't repeat the party that you had. It just doesn't happen. It's only going to cause suffering trying to do that. And so when we become dependent on something — the mobile or a person that we become dependent on — then when we lose it, that's where the pain is.

So what we have to find out is where does this self manifest, and that's the point of desire. That's the direct psychological indicator that the self is active. But it's a certain type of desire — there's a special word in Pali for it: *taṇhā*. There are other words for desire but this specific desire is the one that leads to indulgence. It's the one that leads us to attachment.

So it obviously includes all the physical senses such as food and sex, but it's the sensual pleasures too — art, nature, human association. All that comes under the name of sensual. Some people only think of sexual, but it's not. It's the total sense organ of the psychophysical organism, which includes the intellect — all the stuff we learn, the history, science, all the stuff we talk about, the politics, and the culture. It's all the imagination, the fantasy — all that's part of the sensual life. And of course the pleasures and joys we get from work.

So everything we're doing, everything we experience, we always have to be careful that there is this little bit of *taṇhā* when it's making us happy. And even in the practice when we enter into beautiful states of mind, a bit of peacefulness, a bit of joy, and the concentration exercises that some of you might practice, the absorptions — you become attached to them.

So all this would be perfectly lovely except for the clinging. So that's why we're practicing renunciation. It's a way of letting go of our cravings no matter how small they are. So the importance of the renunciation is found in the Eightfold Noble Path. So the first of course is Right Understanding, which is exactly what we're trying to do here.

And the second one is to do with Right Intentions. Sometimes it's translated as Right Thoughts, but intentions, I think, captures it better because it's the intentions that create the attitudes that then manifest in speech, in action and in our livelihoods. So what are these Right Intentions? The first one is renunciation. The second one is non-ill will. And the third one is harmlessness.

So how do we put this teaching into practice? Well, we can start little. It's getting used to letting go of things. I mean, those of you who've been on retreats, you know all about this really, but it's good just to remind ourselves that we ought to do it as a little daily practice also.

So for instance, if you find yourself snacking and grazing throughout the day at a particular time — say TV in the evening — and you recognize it as unhealthy, so you make a decision: stop it. I'm going to stop it. But then you have to remind yourself — you have to bear the discomfort. So every time the word 'toast' comes to mind, or 'biscuit' — whatever comes to mind — the alarm bell should go off. Then we repeat the reasons to ourselves why we're not going to fall for it, we're going to renounce it, and then reaffirm that determination.

Now surprisingly these desires begin to really loosen up after two or three days and they go, and we regain our agency. We gain back our control over our appetites. I mean, that's what we're heading for because generally speaking we're enslaved to these things. As soon as they come up, they come up as demands and they become needs. Well, they're not needs, are they?

But even so, even when we've got through that discomfort and now we feel we've got our agency back, you always have to be careful that little demon of the self — the demon of desire — it's only lying low. If we're not careful we will soon become an obedient servant again. So we have to remind ourselves that not until the delusive self has been completely extinguished will such unskillful desires cease.

So now here we might make a little distinction between boredom and disinterest. Remember that desires are excited by stimuli and they lose their intensity over time. So that's when we get bored with something. And taking food for instance as our little object here — it's the same. You can't keep eating the same biscuit, you've got to look for something else, we need variety. But given enough time however we go back to our favourite biscuit. That's how boredom works — we get fed up with something, we seek something else, and then we remember: oh wait a minute, what about my favourite biscuit? And then you're back to that.

Disinterest is something different. It's a spiritual quality. It is exactly that we lose interest in something so we no longer care about biscuits or what biscuits we have or even if there are any. Yet there's still the enjoyment of biscuit if it comes our way. So to quote an ancient Zen master, when asked to explain Buddha Dharma, his reply was: no preference. No preference. That's where we're aiming. We're aiming to a point where we're not sticking onto anything.

At a mental level, it's views and opinions. It's the same sort of attitude that we apply, renouncing this: I'm right and everybody else is wrong, or almost wrong, or not as right as I am. So there's always a conceit that underlies these positions. It doesn't matter what it is — religious, political, cultural and so on. Now, it doesn't mean to say that we have to change our understanding. It may be fine. But being open to others, allowing us to nuance our understanding. And occasionally we might even change our opinion, especially today with all this polarisation.

And then there's the members of the human community, aware of climate crisis, of mindless consumption. So we have a duty here to simplify our lifestyle. How many pairs of shoes do we actually need? When you're buying some clothing, do you actually need it? And then we have to see that the culture is caught up — we are caught up in this selfishness that's been generated by neoliberalism and consumerism. And then we get the idea of giving something away. In the very act of generosity, we're actually exercising renunciation. And of course, it makes living a little lighter.

When it comes to personal relationships, you see, we possess other people. So it manifests as control. We manipulate. We use anger, threats of abandonment, spiteful action. We hold grudges and nurse them. We offer presents and promises to entice them. And becoming aware of those little behaviours — developing the skills of forgiveness, training ourselves to see the situation from the other person's point of view — all that is the exercise of renunciation.

Then there's the news. Oh my goodness. You know, trailing through the news every morning, every evening, during the day, always onto it, finding out what's happened next with this constant daily messaging of war, Trumpian shocks, injustice and so on. So it's no wonder that we can build up a sense of hopelessness, disempowerment. Now we can undermine this by method, of course, but sometimes the best policy is just to stop listening, to limit the input.

During my first twelve years as a monastic, I took very little interest in world affairs. For long times I was quite secluded. And it took a while when I got back into ordinary daily life here to find out what was happening. But I never felt I'd lost anything.

The Buddha in the discourse on developing *mettā*, which we read at the end again, advises us not to be too busy. So again it's about decluttering our lives. How are we spending our time? What are we spending it on? Social media, doing things, always having to do something, trying to get back to just being every so often — being and doing.

Do we find ourselves in a sense of rush, of anxiety, even a sense of occasional overwhelm? Then you have to prioritise. You have to let go of some engagements. And of course when we do that we find ourselves being more relaxed and we meditate better and become more aware about this underlying turbulence in our hearts which is often fuelling the overactivity.

So it's allowing that to exhaust itself and bring a sort of greater sense of calmness. And it really is a wise thing to constantly remind ourselves that tranquillity, calmness, tranquillity is a factor of enlightenment, a factor of awakening.

Now, renunciation isn't the fullness of the spiritual life. Such practice brings a sense of ease into our lives, but it brings with it clean energy. Letting go of the demands of egoistic self is a relief. It's not a deprivation. The energy, the freedom we feel, seeks a different focus, and the focus is the other.

So we're social animals. Everybody knows that. We love people. We love animals. We love to help others. Some of our greatest joys is supporting others in their griefs, in their joys. But you have to always remember this little devil of self may sneak in and we find ourselves doing good in order to feel happy. That's no good. Danger lurks in the most heartfelt generosity.

Luckily, it's enough just to acknowledge the unskillful motivations and then to reaffirm the good intentions. So we don't have to be hard on ourselves. A dash of humility is needed here. Just acknowledge that the work on ourselves is yet to be done. That's a comfort. The Buddha warns us that the path is gradual, very gradual in my experience anyway.

So, renunciation. Well, it's important. We need to reflect on our lives, see where we're sticking onto something, someone, some behaviour, and just allow ourselves to let go for a while. Suffer gladly the pain of releasing the numbed cramp and enjoy a bit of peace.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I have not caused confusion, and that by your practice of renunciation you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

The Buddha as a Teacher: The Discourse on Māluṅkyāputta

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 23 min

In this illuminating talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the extraordinary teaching abilities of the Buddha through the lens of the Cūḷamāluṅkyāputta Sutta (MN 63). This discourse demonstrates the Buddha's masterful pedagogical approach: listening fully, clarifying understanding, using Socratic questioning, and employing vivid metaphors to drive home essential points.

The sutta tells of Māluṅkyāputta, a monk who threatened to disrobe unless the Buddha answered metaphysical questions about the eternality of the world, the nature of the soul, and what happens to a Tathāgata after death. The Buddha's response reveals his skill in re-directing intellectuals away from abstract speculation toward practical wisdom. Using his famous poisoned arrow analogy, he shows how such questions are like demanding irrelevant information while dying from a wound.

Bhante Bodhidhamma highlights how the Buddha refused to engage with hypothetical discussions that don't lead to disenchantment, dispassion, cessation, peace, direct knowledge, awakening, and nibbāna. Instead, he declared what truly matters: the Four Noble Truths of dukkha, its origin, cessation, and the path. This teaching method exemplifies how authentic Dhamma instruction focuses on liberation from suffering rather than satisfying intellectual curiosity about metaphysical abstractions.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhasa — Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

I'm going to talk about the extraordinary ability of the Buddha to teach. I have no doubt that he was an extraordinarily charismatic person, but this in itself would not have made him a particularly skilled teacher. He had the ability to teach large groups — monastics, nuns and lay people — and adapt his teaching to them. And he was particularly skillful when he spoke to individuals. He was able to capture their moods, their opinions, and thanks to different techniques, he was able to correct their opinions, their points of view and also their practice.

Now, it didn't always happen. A certain character called Dandapāṇi went away clicking his tongue, expressing his disapproval.

The way he usually dealt with subjects was to first listen fully to what the other was saying, then he would repeat back to them what they had just said to make sure they both understood. After that, he corrected the person with a process of questions and answers of the Socratic type. Once he'd expressed his position, he would then restate it again clearly and usually he would add a metaphor or an analogy, as he would say, because some people understand better that way.

Over the next few Buddha celebration days, I hope to take one technique after another and use a discourse to illustrate it. This is the shorter discourse with Mālun̄kyāputta. This speech is an example of the way he guided intellectuals away from conceptual, speculative thinking, by distancing them from too abstract and metaphysical ideas and instead by bringing them to a practical type of wisdom. And he had no fear of calling them fools when necessary.

Mālun̄kyāputta was the son of Mālun̄kyā, who was married to an official of the king of Kosala. He became a *samaṇa*, a wandering ascetic, and when he heard the Buddha speak, he took ordination under him, but he didn't attain liberation until he was very old.

One day, while Mālun̄kyāputta was alone meditating near Sāvatti in Jeta's Grove, Anāthapiṇḍika's monastery, he was thinking about the topics to which the Buddha had not answered, the questions to which the Buddha had never given an answer. These were metaphysical questions of the time, and Mālun̄kyāputta came to the decision that if Buddha had not given him satisfactory answers to these questions, he would have lost all faith in him and would have left the Sangha.

In the late afternoon, Mālun̄kyāputta left the retreat and went to the Buddha. He bowed, sat down on one side, and expressed his thoughts to the Buddha:

"Venerable Lord, while I was meditating alone, the following thought came to my mind. These questions, these speculative questions, have been left unanswered by the Blessed One. They have been abandoned and rejected by him. And they are as follows: the world is eternal or the world is not eternal; the world is finite or the world is infinite; the soul is the same thing as the body, or the soul is one thing and the body is another. And then again, after death, does the Tathāgata continue to exist, or after death does a Tathāgata not exist? Or again, after death does a Tathāgata both exist and not exist, or after death does a Tathāgata neither exist nor not exist?

"If the Blessed One knows, then let the Blessed One declare that to me openly, and I will lead the holy life under your guidance. If the Blessed One does not know, then it is proper for one who does not know and does not see to say clearly, 'I do not know, I do not see.' In this case I will abandon the training and return to the lay life."

Now the Buddha makes sure they both agree as to what has been said: "Well then, Mālun̄kyāputta, have I ever told you, 'Come, Mālun̄kyāputta, lead the holy life under my guidance and I will declare to you whether or not I have the answers to these questions'?"

"No, Venerable Sir."

"And have you ever told me, 'Venerable Sir, I will lead the spiritual life under the guidance of the Buddha only if the Buddha will declare these things to me'?"

"No, Venerable Sir."

"So it seems that I did not tell you, 'Come, Mālun̄kyāputta, lead the spiritual life under my guidance and I will declare these things to you.' And you never told me, 'Lord, I will lead the spiritual life under the guidance of the Buddha only if the Buddha will declare these things to me.' In this case, foolish man, who are you and what are you rejecting?"

"If anyone should say, 'I will not lead the holy life under the Blessed One until the Blessed One declares answers to these questions,' these would remain undeclared by the Tathāgata and in the meantime that person would die."

Now the Buddha uses his usual technique to support what he was saying with a metaphor or allegory:

"Suppose, Mālun̄kyāputta, a man were wounded by an arrow thickly smeared with poison and his friends and companions, relatives and kinsmen, brought a surgeon to treat him. And the man would say, 'I will not allow the surgeon to extract this arrow until I know whether the man who wounded me was a noble, a brahmin, a merchant or a worker; whether he was tall, short or of medium height; whether the bow was a long bow or a crossbow; what kind of feathers were fitted to the arrow that wounded me — whether those of a vulture, a heron, a hawk, a peacock, or a stork; and what kind of arrowhead it was that wounded me — whether it was spiked, or razor-tipped, or curved, or barbed, or calf-toothed, or lancet-shaped.'"

"All this would still not be known to that man and meanwhile he would die. In the same way, Mālun̄kyāputta, if anyone should say, 'I will not lead the holy life under the Blessed One until the Blessed One declares answers to these questions,' these would remain undeclared by the Tathāgata and meanwhile that person would die."

The Buddha continues by saying that it is not true that spiritual life cannot be conducted without such speculative questions finding an answer, and reaffirms his position:

"Whether such questions find an answer or not, there is still birth, there is still ageing, there is still death. There is still sorrow, lamentation, pain, grief and despair. And it is the destruction of these things, right here and now, that I prescribe.

"Therefore, Mālun̄kyāputta, remember what I have left undeclared as undeclared, and remember what I have declared as declared. And why have I left them undeclared? Because they are not beneficial. They do not belong to the foundations of the holy life. They do not lead to disenchantment, to dispassion, to cessation, to peace, to direct knowledge, to awakening, to *nibbāna*. That is why I have left them undeclared.

"And what have I declared? There is suffering and unsatisfactoriness. There is the origin of suffering and unsatisfactoriness. There is the cessation of suffering and unsatisfactoriness, and there is the way that leads to the cessation of suffering and unsatisfactoriness."

That is what the Blessed One said, and the Venerable Mālun̄kyāputta was satisfied and delighted by the words of the Blessed One.

This discourse shows how in general the Buddha taught — first by listening, then by probing, and then finally by stating his teaching and his use of metaphor. He would not be drawn into hypothetical, metaphysical or speculative discussions. They were simply not conducive to the spiritual aim of liberating oneself from *dukkha*, suffering and unsatisfactoriness.

The Buddha tells us there is a limit beyond which reason and logic simply cannot go, and which can only be transcended and realised by direct experience. And finally, the reason why he refused to answer these questions about himself, the Tathāgata — that is, what would happen after his death — was that this type of question arose invariably from some idea of a self that would have existed or not existed, or have existed and not existed, or neither existed nor not existed.

I hope this little talk has been of some assistance and that it has not caused any confusion. May you, through your careful practice and reading of the discourses, be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

What was the Great Discovery by the Buddha

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 15 min

In this profound exploration, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's greatest discovery - the transcendent nature of Awakening that goes beyond conventional understanding of not-self (anattā). Drawing from the Buddha's victory verse where he declares finding 'the house builder' and attaining the unconditioned citta (mind-heart), Bhante explains how this points to something beyond our conditioned psychology and physicality.

The talk delves into passages from the Udāna where the Buddha describes Nibbāna as a dimension beyond the four elements, the formless absorptions (arūpa jhāna), and all conditioned existence - 'that which is never born, never lived, was never created or bound by conditions.' Bhante clarifies that what is extinguished in Nibbāna is the delusive sense of self that creates our world of experience.

Using contemporary examples like waking up in unfamiliar places, Bhante makes the teaching accessible while maintaining its depth. He addresses how even scientific materialists can benefit from Buddhist practice while pointing to the transcendent reality the Buddha discovered. The talk emphasizes turning attention to the three characteristics (tilakkhana) in meditation practice as the path to discovering this unconditioned dimension ourselves.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa — Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

So the question was, what was the Buddha's greatest discovery?

There are lots of people who follow Buddhhadhamma, they get a lot from the practice and the teachings, who themselves are some form of materialists, atheists, scientific materialists and so on. You can understand how they get the benefit from it, because you don't have to believe anything. That's the great thing about the Buddhhadhamma — you have to explore it yourself.

But it does baffle me that some people deny the transcendence of *Nibbāna* or of the Buddha's achievement. He himself referred to himself as the *Tathāgata*, which translates rather badly as "thus gone." But the best translation I've seen is "the transcendent one," one who has transcended. What's he transcended? Well, he's transcended suffering, he's transcended *samsāra*, but I think it goes much deeper than that.

Involved in that is also perhaps a wrong understanding about the teaching of not-self. In the discourse on the teaching of not-self, he simply asks — if you look at your body, what can you control? We think we are the body, we think with our emotions, but we find ourselves ruled by everything and there's very little I can do about the lack of hair on my head. It's a bit late anyway, never mind. And then there's all that business about impermanence, and if something is impermanent then obviously it can't be substantial and so on and so forth. I'm sure you all know that.

So what I want to do is take his victory verse. That's the first thing we'll look at, and this is what he says: "Through many births I wandered in *saṃsāra*, the world of suffering, seeking but not finding the builder of this house. Painful is repeated birth."

So this house, of course, he's referring to himself — the heart, the psychophysical organism. "Oh, house builder, you are seen. You will not build this house for me again. All your rafters are broken. The ridge pole is shattered. My mind has attained the unconditioned" — *citta*, he used the word *citta*, we'll come back to that — "and I have reached the end of craving."

So here he's using a metaphor for the self — the house builder — and through the house builder we build this world that we're living in. This is our house. When you think about it, everything is happening within your body, within the mind, and then we project everything onto the world. I mean, it's magical really. So we're in this bubble of consciousness, our own little bubble of consciousness, and it's up to us to make it a fairly nice place to live in. And we've made mistakes in the past, led by delusion, and made a hash of it to some extent or another.

So what he's saying is that once he's found the cause of this house that's built — which is the self, this delusive idea of a self — then he was able to escape all the suffering that that delusion made for him.

Now this word *citta* — you see, the problem for the Buddha was that he had discovered something for which the language couldn't express, and I'm not so sure any language can. But he's stuck with words that have other meanings. So he'll talk about the *citta*. *Citta* means the mind, the heart-mind — it's the emotional and thought life, what we might understand by the Greek word *psyche*. But here it's obviously not that, because the *psyche* as we know it, the body-heart-mind complex, is conditioned. But he says he's attained the unconditioned *citta*. So he's pointing to something which is beyond our psychology and beyond our physicality, and he reinforces what produced that, which was of course the destruction of all the defilements.

"My mind has attained the unconditioned." Unconditioned means that — or rather, conditioned means that whatever that is relies on something else for its being there. A tree relies on oxygen, and so do we. We rely on food, being gross. So that's what conditioned actually means, and our minds are conditioned by the society, the things we put into ourselves. So we're in constant interplay with our environment, which includes other people. But he says this is unconditioned. So it's something that doesn't need anything else.

And he calls it the *citta*, which in a sense gives it a certain substance. Now he doesn't like doing that, so it must have been a bit of a pain for him to say that, because that's one reason he doesn't like the self — so this self is the *ātman* of the Hindu system, well the Brahminical system, which referred to an eternal soul. And there was huge confusion at that time as to exactly what it was, and there were materialists that people said when you die that's the end of it. So he stuck for words, but he clearly states that whatever he's experienced, once the house builder had been completely destroyed, was unconditioned.

By the way, Freud, with his insights, had a similar problem. He had to make up words, didn't he? Id, ego, superego.

Now, there's a very famous teacher, some of you will know him, I think — Ajahn Mahāboowa. He died not so long ago. And he was understood to be an *Arahant*. He definitely said of himself that he no longer suffered.

Now in one meditation — and I think this might have been the point of his release from suffering — he's in meditation and he's in that place of just observing, and he says this dhamma, this teaching, arose in him spontaneously, and this is it: "If there is a point or a centre of a knower anywhere, that is the agent of birth, the essence of continual becoming." And that's exactly what the Buddha discovered himself. So it's something that we also will discover in time — that whenever the self arises, the world arises, and we go into that world, which, unless we are completely purified of defilements, is a cause of suffering for us, unsatisfactoriness.

Now this isn't something that is ethereal. Every time we wake up in the morning, that process happens. You wake up and you immediately recognise yourself. And many of you, I'm sure, have experienced waking up in a strange room, in a hotel or somewhere, and you don't know where you are. Just for that one moment, there's this little frisson, this little burst of fright. You don't know who you are. And then suddenly it's you and you feel safe again and happy. So that moment is telling us that there is a point as we wake up in the morning where we take on this sense of self.

I just want to point out another way that he describes *Nibbāna*, and this comes from the inspired sayings — there's a collection of his inspired sayings, the *Udāna Sutta*.

So it opens, it just says that at one time the Buddha was staying near Sāvattthī in Jeta's Grove, Anāthapiṇḍika's monastery. And he was educating, encouraging, firing up and inspiring the mendicants with the dhamma talk about — now this is the word you see — extinguishment. But what we have to be clear about is what is actually extinguished.

And these mendicants were paying attention, applying the mind, concentrating wholeheartedly and actively listening. Then understanding this matter, on that occasion the Buddha expressed this heartfelt sentiment: "There is that dimension where there is no earth, no water, no fire, no wind" — so there's none of the four basic elements, that means there's nothing physical — "no dimension of infinite space, no dimension of infinite consciousness, no dimension of nothingness, no dimension of neither perception nor non-perception." Those are the four — what we call *arūpa jhāna* — the four absorptions, the non-material absorptions, which is the most refined state that the mind can get into where there's nothing in the mind of the body at all, not even images of the body. So there's not even that. So there's nothing from the physicality, and there's nothing all the way through the mind.

"There is no this world, no other world, no moon, no sun." So there's nothing there at all. "There, mendicants, I say there is no coming, no going or remaining or passing away or reappearing" — so there's no time and there's no space — "just this is the end of suffering."

And he uses the word dimension. So this is another way that he describes consciousness — *āyatana*. It comes up in the dependent origination and it's normally translated as the consciousnesses are based on the sense bases. So you have eye consciousness, ear consciousness, nose consciousness and you have heart-mind consciousness. And in the five *khandhas*, this consciousness is just a screen upon which information arises, and that screen is dependent upon those six sense spaces. He's saying that there is a dimension that is beyond all that, and he often refers to it as *Nibbāna*.

I'll leave you with a final one. We've just got a bit of time here. So again the mendicants are paying attention, they're applying the mind, concentrating wholeheartedly and actively listening, and this is probably the most famous statement, or the most well-known shall we say: "There is that which is never born, never lived, was never created or bound by conditions. If there was not that which was never born, never lived, was never created or bound by conditions, there would be no escape from that which is

ever born, ever lived, ever created and bound by conditions. But since there is that which is never born, never lived, never created or bound by conditions, there is an escape from that which is born, ever lived, ever created and bound by conditions."

And that's really his chosen way of expressing the transcendent — by telling you what it's not. And of course it's up to us now in our meditation practice to turn our attention towards those three characteristics, because that's where we will ourselves discover this dimension — to see impermanence, to really see it, and to see that there is a mechanism in us, this desire which is born out of the self, is an expression of the self, causing all these problems, and that sense of not me, not mine.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, they have not caused confusion, and that by your diligent practice you will indeed break through the delusion and attain *Nibbāna* sooner rather than later.

Where Do the Elements Cease Without Remainder?

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 16 min

In this illuminating talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines a discourse addressed to the monk Kevatta, exploring one of the most profound questions in Buddhism: where do the four great elements cease without remainder? The talk follows a monk's extraordinary journey through multiple heavenly realms—from the Four Great Kings to the gods of the Thirty-three, ascending through various deva realms until reaching Brahmā himself, only to discover that none of these beings can answer his question.

The Buddha's response reveals a crucial distinction between two forms of consciousness: the ordinary consciousness bound to the five khandhas and sense bases, and a transcendent consciousness that is "signless, non-manifestive, limitless, without boundary, and all-illuminating." Bhante Bodhidhamma carefully explains how this discourse points to the experience of nibbāna—not as annihilation, but as a state where the four elements "find no footing" and where nāma-rūpa (name and form) cease to manifest.

This teaching offers profound insights into the nature of not-self (anattā) and the unconditioned reality that transcends both mundane experience and even the highest jhānic states. The talk serves as preparation for deeper understanding of nibbāna, with Bhante noting that this mysterious subject requires continued exploration through dedicated Vipassanā practice.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsaṃbuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsaṃbuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsaṃbuddhassa Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

I'm continuing what we did last time, which is talk about *nibbāna*. That's the short and straight of it. Here I'm going to go through a discourse which is addressed by the Buddha to a certain monk called Kevaddha, and as we go through it you'll see what it's all about.

He says to Kevaddha: there was a monk in this community of monks, the sangha, where a thought arose in his awareness: where do these four great elements—the earth property, the liquid property, that's cohesive elasticity, the fire property, that's heat and cold, and the wind property, that's movement or stillness or stiffness, the earth property

being heavy or light—where do they cease without remainder? In other words, where are they annihilated? Then he attained such a state of concentration that the way leading to the gods appeared in his focused mind.

And so he approached the gods, and these seem to be the lowest of them, the retinue of the four great kings. He said, "Friends, where do these four great elements—the earth element, liquid, fire, and wind element—cease without remainder?" When he had said this, they said to him, "Well, we also don't know where these four great elements cease without remainder, but there are the four great kings themselves who are higher and more sublime."

So off he goes to try and find these four great kings, and when he does they also say, "We also don't know where these four great elements come to an end, cease without remainder." So they suggest that he go a little higher to the gods of the thirty-three. And when they arrive there, they also say, "Well, we don't know, but Sakka, the ruler of the gods, who is higher and more sublime than we, will know."

And in this way, they go up and up through the Yāma gods and the Tusita gods and the Nimmānaratī gods and the Paranimmitavasavattī gods. So they're going higher and higher and they're all saying the same thing: "I don't know what it is, but somebody upstairs knows better." So you can see this is getting to be a bit of a satire.

And then finally the Paranimmitavasavattī, who was the chief of the Paranimmitavasavattī gods, said, "Why don't you go and approach the retinue of Brahmā?" So when he approaches them, they said, "Of course, well, we don't know, but Brahmā himself will know."

So Brahmā was the Vedic creator god, and you can see here that it's beginning to be a bit of a satire on the way the Brahmins would believe or teach about these various gods, but especially the role of Brahmā, who was the creator, the starter of all things.

So this particular monk approaches Brahmā, and he also asks where do these four great elements cease without remainder. Just going back a little bit, he says that light shines forth and a radiance appears—Brahmā will appear, for these are the portents of Brahmā's appearance: light shines forth and a radiance appears. So Brahmā appears, and the monk approaches the great Brahmā and says, "Friend, where do these four great elements cease without remainder?"

And the great Brahmā replies, "I, monk, am Brahmā, the great Brahmā, the conqueror, the unconquered, the all-seeing, the all-powerful, the sovereign Lord, maker, creator, chief, appointer, ruler, father of all that has been and shall be."

And the monk says to him, "Friend, I didn't ask you if you were Brahmā, the great Brahmā, the conqueror, the unconquered, and so on and so forth. I asked you, where do the four great elements cease without remainder?"

Well, poor old Brahmā, he goes off again with his string of attributes: "I am Brahmā, the maker, creator, chief, appointer, ruler," and so on. So again he asks him, only this time, the great Brahmā, taking the monk by the arm and leading him off to the side, said to him, "These gods of the retinue of Brahmā believe: 'There is nothing that the great Brahmā does not know. There is nothing the great Brahmā does not see. There is nothing the great Brahmā is unaware of. There is nothing that the great Brahmā has not realized.' That is why I did not say in their presence that I too don't know where the four great elements cease without remainder. So you've acted wrongly, you've acted incorrectly in bypassing the Blessed One in search of an answer to this question elsewhere. Go right back to the Blessed One, and on arrival ask him this question. However he answers it, you should take it to heart."

And then, because of his powers, as a man might flex his arm, he appears from the Brahmā world before the Buddha.

So we've been all the way up through all these higher heavens, these sublime places, and he just doesn't have an answer. Now when he comes back down, interestingly enough, the Buddha says this to him: "Once, monk, some seafaring merchants took a shore-sighting bird and set sail in their ship. When they could not see the shore, they released the shore-sighting bird. It flew to the east, south, west, north, straight up, and to all the intermediate points of the compass. If it saw the shore in any direction, it flew there. If it did not see the shore in any direction, it returned back to the ship. In the same way, monk, having gone as far as the Brahmā world in search of an answer to your question, you have come right back to my presence."

So it suggests that perhaps there were monks in the order, monks and nuns, monastics who were still going for advice to the Brahmins, especially if they were Brahmins themselves. I don't know what it actually means, but it's an odd thing to admonish this poor monk.

So anyway, what he says to this monk: "Your question should not be phrased in this way: 'Where do these four great elements—the earth element, liquid element, fire element and wind element—cease without remainder?' Instead, it should be phrased like this: 'Where do earth, water, fire and air find no footing? Where do long and short, small and great, fair and foul, where do name-and-form, body and mind, come to an end?'"

And the answer is this: "Consciousness that is signless, non-manifestive, limitless, without boundary, and all-illuminating, in all directions full of light. There water, earth, fire and wind find no footing. There long and short, small and large, pleasant and unpleasant, there name-and-form, body and mind, have all been brought to an end. With the cessation of consciousness, all is brought to an end."

Now we have a problem. So the Buddha is a little bit like really any person who suddenly sees something which is beyond the culture, which is something which is new to the culture, and they're always scrabbling for new words. An obvious example would be Freud, who had to come up with id, ego and superego to get across his model of the human mind.

So here he's using consciousness in two different ways. So the first consciousness is the one that is going to cease, is going to come to an end. So this is the consciousness that the Buddha describes by sense bases: there's eye consciousness, there's ear consciousness, nose consciousness, tongue consciousness, body consciousness, mind consciousness. This consciousness belongs to the five aggregates, which are the body or our physicality, all our feelings driven by both the body and emotions, all our perceptions, and the *saṅkhāras*—these habits of thought, habits of actions which we create through an act of will—and this consciousness. So here this consciousness is like a screen upon which this information arises. That's the consciousness which disappears. That's the consciousness which can experience these four great elements. And he goes as far as to say that even the mind and the body also are brought to an end. But this is not a final end. It's where they find no footing.

And then he describes this experience, which has to be the experience of *nibbāna*. He says there's a consciousness—so there's a knowing which is non-manifested. The word that is *nidassana*—cannot be seen. So what cannot be seen, what cannot be felt—it stands for all the sense bases—and it is limitless, it doesn't have a boundary, it's not dependent on anything, and interestingly, it is all-illuminating or, in another translation, in all directions full of light. And it is here that the earth, the fire, the wind and water elements find no footing.

So what we have here is again a restatement that there is a mundane experience that we have through this form of body and mind, and there is something which sits within it but beyond it. And when we experience what is beyond in its purity, then what is mundane—the body and mind—do not appear. And that really is one of the most profound experiences of not-self, because everything that we experience we tend to associate with either by way of identity or possession. But here everything's gone, and yet there remains this luminous consciousness.

And just as a reminder, going back to the early quotes of last time: here he says there's a dimension where there's no earth, no water, no fire, no wind. So he's saying the same thing here, but he's not telling us what it is—he's telling us what's not there. He says no dimension of infinite space, infinite consciousness, nothingness, neither perception nor non-perception. So there's none of those higher states of mind that we refer to as the *jhānas*, the absorptions. There's not this world or another world. There's no moon, no sun. I say there's no coming or going, remaining or passing away or reappearing. There's absolutely nothing there which is either phenomenal or physical.

And then we have this other quote which again tells us what's not there: there is that which is unborn—this is how it's translated, unborn, it's almost a direct translation—unborn, undying, uncreated, uncompounded, which means it's unconditioned. So there is something which was never born, it never died, it was never created, doesn't develop, and is not bound by any conditions.

So we've had these statements now, both of the negative—what is not in *nibbāna*—but also this very positive statement about an experience that is *nibbānic*. And this is only quoted twice within the whole of the scriptures, and it doesn't appear in the Udāna collection, which are a collection of his inspired verses. So there's some filtering going on.

And just as an aside: in the Mahāyāna, when Buddhism developed into the Mahāyāna, there was a school, the Yogācāra school, that actually has a transcendent—that's what they call it—a transcendent consciousness, and it's based upon this particular phrase, this particular verse that we've just been reading.

So this does not complete the mystery of *Nibbāna*, unfortunately, and there's more to be said, and I'll find some time in order to talk about it. I can only hope these words have been of assistance, that they have not caused confusion, and that by your careful investigation through your practice of *vipassanā*, you will attain this particular experience.

Sādhū, sādhū, sādhū.

Extinguishing the Housebuilder

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 16 min

In this profound teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma continues his exploration of the Buddha's victory verse and the nature of the deluded self—the 'housebuilder' identified as Māra. Drawing upon his previous talks about consciousness 'in which nothing is manifest' as a description of Nibbāna, he presents powerful metaphors to understand the liberation process.

Using the analogy of infant development and the myth of Narcissus, Bhante illustrates how we create distance between awareness and its objects, just as a baby learns to distinguish self from world. He explains how sati (intuitive awareness) catches its own reflection in the 'pool of consciousness' and how Vipassanā practice rescues us by drawing awareness out of identification with body and mind.

The talk includes specific meditation techniques for investigating the nature of self-awareness itself, recognizing it too as an object that arises and passes away. Bhante concludes with the inspiring testimony of Mechi Kyo, an ordinary village woman who achieved complete liberation, describing her direct experience of knowing all phenomena while remaining utterly unaffected by them. This teaching offers both theoretical understanding and practical guidance for serious practitioners seeking to uproot the very foundation of suffering through insight into anattā (not-self).

Namo tassa bhagavato hara-hatto samma-sambhodassa — Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

This evening, the presentation is a little difficult because I've actually written something. So it's not going to be particularly verbatim, which is my normal way of presenting.

In the last two talks, we looked at, first of all, the Buddha's victory verse and his naming of the house builder, which is to say that deluded self, which is *Mara*. When we talk about Mara, the evil tempter, that's the self, the deluded self. And then we went on — the next presentation was about a monk who wanted to know where all the world ended. And he tells him that this is badly phrased, that it should be where the world does not find a footing. And then he gives a very clear description, for want of a better word, of a place, of that place where the world does not find a footing. And this is it: There is a consciousness in which nothing is manifest. It has no boundary and is full of light in all directions. So we can understand this to be a description of *Nibbāna*.

Now our task is to find a way to practice in such a way that this might become manifest to us. But before we do that, I'd like to offer these metaphors, these ways of thinking about what we're doing, so we can understand the process of liberating ourselves from self-deception, which is generated by this deluded self, this house builder. Now, some of you who've been to Satipanya to work with me have heard all this before, but I'm hoping that you've forgotten it. And if you haven't forgotten it, you'll excuse my presentation because I just wanted it to be in this medium.

The first metaphor is to recognise what happens to us when we're babies. It has a similarity to the process of insight meditation. For the first four months of our lives, it seems, we're bombarded by sensual information, can make no head or tail of it. But we do know when we're experiencing what is pleasant or unpleasant — that is the dual world that we enter into. Then around four months we start to delineate our first object out of this bewildering mass and in so doing we create the third dimension of depth. And it's usually out of this that we find our first object, our mother, our carer.

So the process continues, it seems, until around the age of three, we're pretty clear that I'm not anything outside my body. My body and my sense of me are separate from everyone and everything. And I know my toys belong to me. They're mine. A very strong sense of possession. There's still a great connection to Mother, but what we've done is we've distanced the outer world from the inner world.

Our practice is to distance this inner world from the intuitive awareness. Every time we experience a feeling or sensation, an emotion or mood, a thought or an image as an object, we're telling ourselves that this cannot be the awareness that knows it. The knower, the feeler, the experiencer experiences itself as quite other to everything it knows, feels and experiences. Now that's what happens when we turn everything into an object, just as the baby creates a third dimension by reaching out and so creating distance. So we're pushing away what we are overwhelmed with, our sensations, feelings, and thoughts. And that distance between the object and the awareness is the inner third dimension.

The second metaphor that I like to use is one of Narcissus. As you remember, Narcissus was a handsome, beautiful young man. And he looked into the pool, caught the image of his own face, fell in love with it, and then went to embrace it and fell in and drowned. This is understood as a myth about self-absorption, pride, vanity, conceit. And water in mythology often represents a lot of things, but life and creation, as well as chaos and purification.

However, we can read this myth spiritually. It is that *sati*, the intuitive awareness — I mean notice, not AI — that catches its image on the screen of consciousness. Consciousness itself is that screen upon which the six senses manifest. That is why consciousness is defined by the sense base: eye consciousness, ear consciousness, mind consciousness, and so on.

So every morning we wake up, the first thing we are aware of is ourselves, our self-awareness. I'm sure you'll have had the experience of waking up in an unfamiliar room at a hotel or friends. And for those first few seconds you can't recognize where you are and so who you are. There's a momentary panic till we situate ourselves. So it is that *sati* sees itself, senses itself in the pool of the mind, the pool of the world that the mind is creating, and then we drown in it.

However, the Buddha has come to the rescue and offered us a methodology to resuscitate us, ourselves. We must drag Narcissus out of the water, sitting back on the bank of the pool. And so it is that in *Vipassanā*, we draw our awareness out of the body and mind with its feelings, perceptions and habits, and we experience ourselves as the one who knows.

In this, our basic identity begins to change, where we base our identity. As children, our identity is very body-centered, and we have that experience when we bite our tongues when we're eating. Just for that singular moment of the stabbing pain, we're absorbed into it and become a physical self. We then very quickly bounce out of it and are annoyed with ourselves and so become an emotional self. We then might reflect upon it and counsel ourselves to eat more slowly and mindfully. And so we become a thinking self. But this position of the observer, the feeler, transcends them all. It can be aware of all the experiences the body and heart-mind have.

Then we might acknowledge more and more clearly the distinction between the object and the subject. So this takes us back to the distancing, the disidentifying process of the baby and young child. And this takes us a step further to investigate the nature of this identity of the self as the observer and the feeler. For having accessed within ourselves this inner position, called by Nyanaponika Thera in his classic work, still worthy of a read, "The Heart of Buddhist Meditation," an observation post. And from this observation post, we can see clearly that the body and heart, heart-mind, the emotions and thought life, continue of themselves without the engagement of this self-awareness that we now experience ourselves to be.

Now we have a situation where the self-awareness sees the body as other and that the body keeps on being the body with its sensations and feelings. The emotions and moods still continue to arise and the thoughts and images continue to flit across the mind. None of it needing the direct control of *sati*, this intuitive awareness. So we're left with the question as to the nature of this self-awareness.

Our investigation now turns towards the self-awareness, that sense of presence. Since we're aware of it, that makes it an object. So we can't be it. Worse, we realize that this identity is the very portal into the world manufactured by the six senses — the five physical senses and the heart mind. This is the face in the pool.

Indeed, this primary self is Mara, the evil tempter, inviting us into the pleasures and joys of the world, only to find ourselves entangled, ensnared and imprisoned. This is the house builder the Buddha discovered to be the agent of rebirth, the root of all our discontent and suffering.

So now there's a practice which is pretty specific to this investigation. And I'm indebted, well, we are indebted to the Mahayana school for this. When the body is very still and the heart calm and the mind is silent — now admittedly that's pretty rare in our daily lives, though it does arise on retreat — we can raise our attention into that feeling of presence located in the forehead. We can stay there to the exclusion of everything else and again just gaze. We now know because we are aware of that sense of self, it is an object and therefore belongs to the mind. So it must be arising and passing away, even though it seems to be coexistent with the awareness that knows it. Remember, consciousnesses are flashing at enormous speeds so that they give us a sense of continuity. We need to hold that position as best we can without straining, just gazing with wonder. Is that sense of self arising and passing away? That is all. Just to gaze with wonder. Presume that the awareness knows what it's looking for. So that's one particular technique.

The other one is the one that we usually use when we're practicing *Vipassanā*. And that involves directly investigating the process of impermanence. So whenever we see an object, whether it's a sensation or a feeling, mood or emotion, thought or image appearing and disappearing, the same applies. The *sati*, this observer, this feeler, that experiences the object arising and passing away, cannot itself be arising and passing away. That gap, minute as it is, between the passing of an object and the arising of another, would also constitute a glimpse into our true nature, which is unborn, undying, uncreated and unconditioned.

So we can sum up the techniques by first of all pulling away from the objects we're aware of so it becomes something to observe and feel, remembering that the perceiver cannot be the perceived. This is the first step of not me, not mine, not self. Then the direct experience of the appearance and disappearance of the object allows *sati* to experience itself as other, whole, entire and permanent. Slowly but surely, this intuitive awareness, *satipaṇṇā*, becomes an island unto itself, impervious to the physical and mental worlds. This is where the very world cannot find a footing.

Now fortunately we have an example of someone who describes what it's like to be fully liberated from the delusion of self and this actually warrants a talk but for our present purpose it's enough to quote her. I'm presuming for the time being that you know the categories that the Buddha teaches, the four great elements, the six sense bases and the five aggregates. Meichi Kyo was an ordinary, barely educated village girl who died in 1991 at the age of 90. And this is her statement:

"Body, mind and essence are all distinct and separate realities. Absolutely everything is known. Earth, water, fire and wind. Body, feeling, memory, thought and consciousness. Sounds, sights, smells, tastes and touches and emotions. Anger, greed and delusion, all are known, I know them all as they exist in their own natural states. But no matter how much I'm exposed to them, I am unable to detect even an instant when they have any power over my heart. They arise and cease, they're forever changing, but the presence that knows them never changes for an instant. It is forever unborn and undying. This is the end of all suffering."

I can only hope my little homily has been of interest, and that by your dedication to the practice you will be liberated from all suffering, like Mei-Chi Kiao, sooner rather than later.

Hope, Aspiration, and Expectation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 19 min

In this illuminating talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the nuanced distinctions between hope, aspiration, and expectation in Buddhist practice. He explores how the Pali term 'āsā' (hope) is viewed negatively in the early discourses as a subtle form of craving, while 'chanda' (aspiration) represents one of the four bases of spiritual power. Drawing on examples like the monk Soṇa's over-efforting and Puṇṇa's liberation through simple devotion, Bhante explains how saddhā (faith/confidence) provides the foundation for practice without corrupting into mere belief.

The talk addresses the common trap of practicing with hidden expectations about attaining Nibbāna, which inevitably leads to disappointment. Instead, Bhante emphasizes focusing purely on observing the three characteristics of existence (tilakkhana) - impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and not-self - as our immediate objective. He discusses how samvega (spiritual urgency) arises from contemplating birth, aging, sickness, death, and the rounds of saṃsāra, providing proper motivation without falling into expectation.

This teaching offers essential guidance for practitioners who struggle with disappointment in their meditation, showing how to maintain inspiration while staying grounded in present-moment investigation. Bhante concludes with the practical advice to 'abandon progress and put full attention on process,' revealing how genuine hope emerges naturally from clearly seeing the Dhamma at work in our direct experience.

Namo asambuddhasa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed noble and fully self-awakened one.

So we're looking at this idea of hope. At the top of my page, I've got faith, hope, aspiration, expectation, disappointment. The idea is to define all this and to see what the texts are actually saying.

Faith, of course, often translated as confidence or trust, is a foundational virtue. It's one of the five spiritual faculties: faith, effort, mindfulness, concentration, and wisdom. For our purposes, there are two pretty obvious enemies. One is to turn it into a belief system, which would then stop you from investigating. It's the process of investigation which is the process of liberation. The subtle one is skeptical doubt – we'll come to that a little later. So we've got to make clear what we mean by faith, and then we can understand a bit more the other stuff.

Remember that all our problems root back into this idea of a self which likes to know what's going to happen, forever planning and organising the future. Once we come across the Buddha-Dharma, we hear about this goal – *Nibbāna*. For some of us anyway, we don't have an idea of what *Nibbāna* is, and yet there's some hazy concept. We're told it's the end of suffering, the end of compulsive desiring. That doesn't tell us what the actual experience is.

Even when the Buddha is explicit – so-called explicit anyway – and talks about a consciousness without boundary, without an object, full of light, we still have to exercise our imagination to come up with something. Then we have an idea that this is what *Nibbāna* is. So we strive. The yogi sits full throttle, noting diligently the three characteristics of existence, how we create suffering through wrong desire – impermanence, not-self – but subconsciously somewhere trying to achieve the escape from suffering, which is another way of expressing *Nibbāna*.

Of course it ends with disappointment, which it has to, because the subtle aim is not true. We're chasing a false idea, a fake idea, and of course it's exhausting. You're making this great effort and getting nowhere.

What we have to understand is that when we're practising, the purpose is just to see these three characteristics. The subtlety of the Buddha's teaching is to distinguish between an aim which is a bit fuzzy for us and the immediate objective which gets us there, which is to observe and examine exactly what's before us, what we're actually experiencing at this moment – and those are the three characteristics.

We've got an example of wrong effort from a monk called Sona. He was desperately trying to get fully liberated and over-efforting, and he was about to leave the order when news came to the Buddha. The Buddha goes to see him and talks about tuning a vina – that's an instrument like a lute. Too tight doesn't work, too loose and you don't get the note. Ultimately you've got to get it just right.

Getting it right is to do with intention. Once the intention is right – which is just to discover and experience the three characteristics – that's enough. We don't have to worry about the future. You can understand from our life experience that having expectations often leads to disappointment.

Now in the actual discourses, the word for hope, *āsa*, doesn't get good press at all. It seems to be understood as a subtle form of craving and it's linked to failure and suffering in itself because it's never fulfilled. Somehow it's got to be transcended. The Buddha talks about *nirāsa*, which we translate as hopelessness. Well, that gets us towards despair, so there must be some misunderstanding here somewhere.

I'll give you a flavour of what it says in the discourses: "One living in hope and one who has abandoned hope, one who is cut off, lost, and one who's at peace." So one who lives in hope is going to be cut off and lost – that doesn't sound so good for us. Then it goes on: "Hope is suffering in the world. The person who lives with hope is called one who is defeated. When one's hope fails, disappointment arises, and it is suffering."

We've got a verse from a nun, Muttā Therī – one of the enlightened nuns of the period, translated by Norman, who's an expert in this. She says that "hope which some have here for children and wives and for the love of a woman, such hope does not apply to me." I don't quite know how that fits her as a woman, but anyway, again she's abandoned all worldly hopes at least.

You can see that in the scriptures, in the discourses, hope has a shade of yearning for some outcome and slips into expectation.

Now in the Mahāyāna it's redeemed, at least in our understanding of hope, but they do use a different word, *praṇidhāna*, which in Pāli – the language of our discourses – is *paṇidhāna*, which means aspiration, a longing. It fits into the Mahāyāna because of their *bodhicitta* ideal, which is a heart devoted to awakening through compassion. The bodhisattva vow, as I think most of you know, is a vow to redeem everyone before yourself. It's a universal awakening rather than a personal attainment.

But again that word there is a word in Sanskrit, *āśā*, which means hope. It's not used. It's all a bit semantic – we have to work out what this actually means. But of course, in our terms, if there's no hope then the practice feels as though it's going to run into a cul-de-sac.

If we look at the word aspiration, that I think gets us better on the path. Here we have a word like *chanda*. *Chanda* is one of the four bases of spiritual power, which I covered in January 2023. I'm sure you all remember it. The other three of the four bases are effort, consciousness, and investigation.

We said at the time that these four bases of power can be used in ordinary daily life. You need obviously a desire to attain, to achieve something, and then you need the effort to get there. You need consciousness, of course, and then you need the ability to figure out what to do – the investigation. Here we have this word *chanda*, which means a very strong desire.

Then we have the word *saṃvega*. The Buddha goes on about *saṃvega*. This is a religious fervour, a heartfelt desire to attain something. Now in the *Visuddhimagga*, which is the medieval spiritual manual, it points to eight objects which induce this devotion, gives us a sense of urgency about our practice. I don't think any of them will come as a

surprise: birth, ageing, sickness and death – of course, contemplating those. Contemplating the idea that if we don't do the practice and we fall into error, we'll end up in one of the *apāya* realms, which is either purgatory – sometimes that's translated as hell, but it's not permanent, remember, thank heavens – and then there's rebirth as an animal, or as a hungry ghost always feeling empty, and in the realm of conflict, the *asura* realm. And of course, finally, as number eight, there is just being here in this world of *saṃsāra*, the world of onward-going led by delusion.

But you can see that these realms are also quite obvious to us right here and now in the world. This desire, this eagerness to become liberated – you have to be careful that it doesn't corrupt into expectation, and this is where faith comes in really.

We've got faith, which you remember is not a belief, it's a sense of trust, of confidence. Without that, of course, you don't do anything. The obvious enemy here is skeptical doubt, which is obviously based on, or usually based on, some fear – fear of failure, fear of being fooled and so on. If we don't have that faith then you don't make a decision, you can't make a decision, you can't act. This is true in daily life. It can become a bit destructive if a person can't make up their mind about someone they're attracted to, a job they've applied for – well, the opportunity just slips away. I had a student actually for a while who couldn't decide whether to get out of bed or not. It can become a bit of a mental illness, I think.

Even if we have this great confidence in the Buddha, the Dharma and the Sangha and the Eightfold Path, it doesn't mean it's unshakeable until we reach first path and fruit. That's when we have such a clear insight into one of those three characteristics of existence that our faith becomes unshakeable – we just know it's right. But until then there's always a danger of losing it. One of them is the bad behaviour of monks – everybody goes around saying it's hypocritical. But the other, of course, is that we have this unrealistic aim – that's the expectation – and then we drop out when we try something else.

Now for some people who achieve liberation, faith is their dominant quality. It doesn't mean to say they don't have to understand or experience the three characteristics of existence – it just means that it doesn't have to be so penetrative. They're driven on by a sense of devotion. The Buddha qualifies that he says there are two people: those who are driven by faith and those who are driven by curiosity and usually have a better intelligence in order to achieve a deeper insight.

We have somebody called Puṇṇa. He comes up in the *Dhammapada*. Puṇṇa, he was a monk. He said of himself, whenever he learned a verse – a new verse from the Buddha – it kicked the one he just learned out of his head. So he didn't have a very good memory. His brother told him, "Well, you're just not going to understand the Dharma and you may as well leave and do something useful in lay life."

When the Buddha heard about this, he went to see him. He knew of the devotion that this Puṇṇa had towards himself and towards the practice – that he trusted him implicitly. So he gave him a cloth to rub, and while he's rubbing the cloth he's supposed to be saying "impermanence, impermanence," just watching impermanence. Well, he became fully liberated. I don't think it works for everybody, but you can have a go.

That means that we don't have to have any big intellect to become liberated. It's really to do with opening up the intuitive intelligence, which is the active side of awareness. Remember that *sati* is *satipaṇṇā* – it's a passive awareness observing, feeling, letting the information come. And then that moment of grasping – that's the intelligence working, the intuitive grasping intelligence.

What of hope as such? Where does this aspiration come from? We have to understand that there's always going to be a subtle desire of trying to attain something for me, and that's of course this *taṇhā*, which translates as thirst. It's a different type of *taṇhā*. Secondly, we see the impermanence while we're meditating, while we're actually practising. We can see the role of this *taṇhā*, this desire, and how that's a direct agent of creating suffering for ourselves.

While we're practising, we see impermanence. We can see things that are insubstantial – they're just arising and passing away. There's nothing that remains. And so, every so often, by being in that position, we come across a hint as to what *Nibbāna* is. Here's where our real hope is grounded. It's not in some future attainment – it's grounded in the fact that we can see these three characteristics more and more clearly. And then there comes that patience to await the great day of awakening.

Just as two asides: because we're embedded in society and the way we live, the way we interact, the way we work, it affects others. So even on a day when we feel depressed, when things aren't going our way, there's the ability to rest somewhere within ourselves in the assurance of the Dharma that gives us an air of this acceptance – this is the way it is – and calmness. This too will pass. So as we're heading along the path, there comes more and more acceptance, more and more contentment. That's how it works.

It's also of great value when we come to die. To believe on our deathbed that we're dying into some annihilation is not a particularly comforting thought – a poor return for a life that's generally done the best it can for the better of ourselves and others. Some say they are accepting this as humanist, but that's of course before the dying process. I struggled myself with this contemplation in my twenties, but of course at that time you never believe you're going to die – that's the presumption of youth. Even so, it did lead me to an understanding, or to an experience, that proved to me personally that death wasn't an end and that it was in fact another beginning.

Similarly, when somebody's dying, it makes it easy for us to know that there is a purpose to life and that we don't have to rely on an outer power or a miracle to stop the process, but more accepting of it.

We have the example of the Buddha, of course, in his death – that we call the *parinibbāna*, total *Nibbāna* – which gives us an example of someone who reaches the goal just ready to let go of life. Even as he's dying, he's asking people around him if they've got any last questions, and then he says don't be shy in asking and then regret that you didn't take this opportunity to do so.

In the actual discourses, when you read it and you come across the word hope and it says it's an absolute waste of time, it's a terrible thing to have, I think it's better to translate it as expectation. And that there is an aspiration, a real grounded hope through the practice – that's where the hope is grounded – that we can see clearly that this desire is the direct cause of attachment which creates suffering, and that we can actually get rid of it. We just don't empower it, and it just disappears.

It's doing that until we finally get down to the core desire which arises out of that sense of self – the core desire of wanting to become, wanting to become a person. That's the core desire that we're really working with. It energises our practice if we do it that way. You have to be careful it doesn't corrupt into expectation. It's really putting our attention on process and abandoning any – I don't say hope – just not thinking about progress.

So abandon progress and put your full attention upon process.

That's it. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance that by your practice you will find that path to liberation sooner, of course, rather than later.

Topics of Discussion

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 19 min

In this thoughtful exploration of Buddhist communication principles, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines a discourse from the Aṅguttara Nikāya that addresses how we discuss matters with each other. The Buddha identifies three fundamental topics of conversation—past, present, and future—and provides practical guidelines for determining whether someone is worth engaging in meaningful dialogue.

The talk covers essential skills for productive conversation: asking appropriate questions (categorical, analytical, counter-questions, and those to be set aside), maintaining consistency in discussion, and responding skillfully when challenged or confronted. Bhante explores the Buddha's approach to the avyākata (undeclared questions)—ten metaphysical inquiries the Buddha declined to answer, including questions about the world's eternality and the post-death existence of a Tathāgata.

Drawing parallels to contemporary political discourse and social media debates, this teaching offers invaluable guidance for navigating discussions with wisdom and compassion. The Buddha's emphasis on listening actively, speaking from genuine knowledge rather than opinion, and consulting "for the sake of knowledge and clarity" provides a refreshing alternative to adversarial debate culture. This practical dhamma talk demonstrates how ancient Buddhist principles can transform our daily interactions and contribute to societal healing.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa — homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

I just picked up on a discourse and it's concerned with how we discuss things with each other, how we talk to each other. So in this age of great polarization, I thought, well, let's see what the Buddha has to say.

It comes from the *Aṅguttara-nikāya*, which is a collection of the small discourses, and it starts off like this: "There are, mendicants, these three topics of discussion. What three? You might discuss the past — this is how it was in the past. You might discuss the future — this is how it will be in the future. And you might discuss the present — this is how it is at present."

Now at first that seems a bit obvious, but of course there are three very different conversations. The first one is all about memory and about opinions about memory and what we thought had happened. The second one is all driven to some future idea, some

idealism, and there could be arguments about that. And the present, of course, is an attempt to see things as they are, but everybody sees things differently, so there's all sorts of argumentation.

So what the discourse does is it takes the process of discussion. The first one is the skill in questions, so you can see whether it's worth talking to somebody. Here they would say a person is — the discourse says — a person is competent to hold a discussion, but what it means is whether it's worth you talking to them. Remember that at that time when you read the discourses, they didn't have recording machines. So the way that you got people to be clear was to ask the question three times and to make sure that "is that what you mean?" And it was done either as two individuals or in a group so that the position taken was clear, what was said was clear, and that would undermine silly arguments.

At that time they had a form of imagination which is called reproductive imagination, not like ours. If you see a car crash, you'll see it one way and then you won't be sure that you've seen it because you didn't record it fully, and there'll be questions asked. In those times they had what was called reproductive memory imagination, and they were very good at remembering things. Even today at the 1956 Sixth Great Council held in Burma, there were six monks who knew all the scriptures, all the *Abhidhamma* and all the *Vinaya* — the rule of the monks. I mean, that's a massive amount of literature. They knew it off by heart, and when the questions came about certain passages in the scriptures which were maybe not quite right, these people, these monks who became the experts, would quote directly from the scriptures.

Just as an aside, by the way, it seems that the Brahmins teach their children the scriptures and learn them by heart, and they're concerned with pronunciation only. When they can learn that, do they actually add the meaning of the words. And only when they've got the words and the pronunciation together are they allowed to discuss what the scriptures say.

So here are the sorts of questions that somebody can ask. When a person is asked a question, if it needs to be answered categorically and they don't answer it categorically, then that shows they're not worth talking to. So one of the things that you might say in Buddhism is, "Is the Buddha impermanent?" And if they prevaricate — yes, no, maybe and all that — then what we want is a clear statement: "Yes, it is."

Another one is, "Is the UK a European country?" Now I should say yes. Lots of UK people don't think they are, but that's what should be said, at least geographically.

The next form of question might need analysis. So one regular question is, "Is Buddhism a religion?" So then you have to ask, "Well, what do you mean by religion?"

Another one is when the Buddha is describing this whole idea of not-self, he starts off with control. "How much of the body can you control? Is it under your control? Can you make it grow taller?" and so on. So then you'd have to say, "Well, when he means control, he obviously means the body as an organism. But obviously I can move it around. I do have some ability to control it." And of course what he's really pointing to is sickness, aging and death.

Now sometimes you ask a question, it needs a counter-question. So one Dharma question would be, "Are the ear and nose the same?" So you say, "Well, in what way?" You say, "Well, in their function." "Well yes, they are. They're the same. They both perceive."

These days, of course, we have this whole thing about immigration. So a question might be, "Should immigrants be allowed to stay?" Well, then you say, "Well, what are the types of immigrants that are coming to the country? And can we make distinctions?"

As a teacher, you see, a *vipassanā* teacher, so I might say to you, "How's your practice going?" And you say, "Oh yeah, that's good." Now, if I'm a bad teacher, I'll say, "Oh, very good," and take your word for it. But if I'm a good teacher, then I'll say, "Well, in what way?" And you say, "Well, my mind is more quiet. I'm able to see process more clearly." I say, "Sādhū, sādhū." If you say to me, "Well, I'm feeling a lot happier," I say, "No, it's not about happiness. That's the end product."

Then there are questions that should be set aside. So in a conversation, somebody might ask you a personal question, so you don't have to answer that, even if it seems to be relevant.

Now in the Buddhist teachings, there were ten questions that he wouldn't answer. They are known as the *avyākata* — they are the undeclared ten statements or questions. First of all, they run like this: "Is the world eternal? Is the world not eternal? Is the world finite or is the world infinite?" So that he wouldn't answer. I mean, I don't think he'd know, frankly, although I have to say in the commentary on the *Visuddhimagga* it does unfortunately say that the Buddha knew the world was flat. But he didn't say anything about the world as something objective out there. His main interest was the world that we are creating moment after moment.

The next one is: "Is the soul the same as the body? Is the soul one thing and the body another?" Now he doesn't answer that, and it's something that I think is worth investigating in another little talk, so I won't go into that particular one.

And then finally there were four questions around *Tathāgata* — remember that's how he referred to himself, the one who had arrived, who had gone, who had completed the path, and it refers to any *arahat*, really. So: "Does a *Tathāgata* exist after death? Does he not exist after death?" This is known as the quadrilemma. "Does a *Tathāgata* both exist and not exist after death?" And here's a head-banger: "Does a *Tathāgata* neither exist nor not exist after death?" Well, not surprisingly, he didn't make an answer to that.

The real reason, of course, was that people were thinking of the *Tathāgata* or a liberated one as a person, as a self, so he didn't like those forms of questions. He didn't like any questions that were speculative, basically.

So now we move on to a different section, which is the skill in the conventions of conversation. When a person is asked a question, if they're not consistent about their position, or what their position is and what it isn't, about what they propose, and then they change the subject, about speaking from what they know and not from some fake position, and that it's appropriate to the procedure — so this is really when you're having a discussion with somebody, you're not speaking over each other.

Politicians are very good at that. I was watching a BBC interview with Varoufakis — I think that's his name — the Greek economist, some of you may know. And there was an economic lecturer there. She was from some Oxford or somewhere. And of course the interviewer. And at first there was — he was asking the questions, they were answering it all, looked very civilised. And then right at the end, the three of them spoke all together, trying to crush the other. It's just weird, and of course I didn't get a word of it.

So when a person is asked the question, if they're consistent about their position, what their position is and what it isn't, about what they propose, about speaking from what they know, and about the appropriate procedure, then that person is competent to hold a discussion.

How people engage — the next session: how people engage when being attacked. So you can know whether or not a person is competent to hold a discussion by seeing how they take part in a discussion. When a person is asked a question, if they dodge the issue, distract the discussion with irrelevant points, display annoyance, hate and bitter-

ness, then that person is not competent to hold a discussion. So that's politicians, isn't it? Dodging the issue, distracting it, saying something irrelevant, and occasionally getting a little bit uppity about things.

So when a person is asked the question, if they don't dodge the issue, distract the discussion with irrelevant points, or display annoyance, hate and bitterness, then that person — we can talk to them.

The next question is how people engage with confrontation — so, afraid of being bettered. You can know whether a person is competent to hold a discussion by seeing how they take part in a discussion. When a person is asked a question, if they intimidate, crush, mock and seize at trivial mistakes, then they're not competent to hold a discussion. In other words, don't talk to them. But when a person is asked a question, if they don't intimidate you, crush you, mock you, seize upon trivial mistakes, then it's worth talking to them.

It's all often in conversation — it's about winning, not about finding some truth, not about finding some way of compromise, not even coming to a position of agreeing to differ. It's about who wins.

I saw really quite a horrible discussion on YouTube between a university professor and Jordan Peterson and somebody whom you'll know — I just can't bring his name to mind — but it was vicious. It was about woke. And the professor especially was very insulting. But yeah, what can you do? I think the other two — Jordan Peterson and the other fellow, I mean, Jordan Peterson is a right-wing guru, and the other fellow was on the left — if I was any of those, I'd have just walked out. You're just insulting.

So now we have a general disposition. You can know whether or not a person has what's required by seeing how they take part in a discussion. If they actively listen, they have what's required, and if they know what they're talking about.

Well, actually, this — the next section is about the Four Noble Truths, but there the Buddha is actually stressing the ability to listen, not to be afraid of actually what the person might say, be open to the fact that your own position may be changed, may be nuanced. Often when we enter into a discussion about something, there's an underlying fear of being changed, of losing.

So the next one is much more to do with the scriptures. It says for someone who has what's required, directly knows one thing, completely understands one thing, gives up one thing and realises one thing. That one thing, of course, is *Nibbāna* and the path to

Nibbāna. And here the Buddha points out that the purpose of all discussion, as far as he's concerned, and consultation, sitting close and listening well, is the liberation of the mind by not clinging, by not grasping.

So finally there's a coda: "Those who converse with hostility — too sure of themselves, arrogant, ignoble, attacking virtues — they look for flaws in each other. They rejoice together when their opponent speaks poorly, makes a mistake, becomes confused and is defeated. But the noble ones don't discuss like this."

"If an astute person wants to hold a discussion connected with the teaching and its meaning, the kind of discussion that the noble ones hold, then that wise one should start the discussion. Knowing when the time is right, neither hostile nor arrogant, not over-excited, contemptuous or aggressive, or with a mind full of jealousy, they speak from what they rightly know. They agree with what is well spoken" — you see, actually praising the person who has a contradictory idea, praising them or at least accepting when they've made a decent argument — "without criticising what has been poorly said. They don't persist in finding faults, nor seizing on trivial mistakes, nor intimidating, nor crushing the other, nor would they speak suggestively, snidely. Good people consult for the sake of knowledge and clarity."

That's a really good statement: "Good people consult for the sake of knowledge and clarity. That's how the noble ones consult. This is noble consultation. Knowing this, a wise person should consult without arrogance."

So that's the final section of the discourse. And remember, we shouldn't take these discourses as final statements about these things. Even subjects like dependent origination crop up in various discourses from various angles. So it's not as though we take a discourse and say, "Well, that's everything to be said about discussion." Far from it. They're just pointers, and our task is to translate what we have understood back into our own lives and of course into society, especially these days when there's so much polarization.

The Buddha himself — when somebody reported to him what one of his monks or nuns had said, he would say, "Well, if you'd have asked me that question, I would have said the same thing."

So now just before we finish off, I just want to point to two or three books, and I'll put them on the website. The first one is "Nonviolent Communication" by Rosenberg, and that is really a very famous book and definitely worth reading about how to talk to people. The other one I've not read entirely, but I read little sections of it. It's called "Difficult Conversations."

Finally, I don't think you'll be able to get this book, but you might do. It's called "Bad Arguments," and it tells you all the ways that people don't answer your question, don't converse with you in a proper manner, and just cause confusion and anger usually. So very good.

I hope this little discourse is of some use to you in your life and in society, and is just part and parcel of your path to complete and full liberation from suffering, sooner rather than later.

Practising the Five Remembrances

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 40 min

In this practical teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma leads participants through the Buddha's five remembrances (pañca anupassanā) - contemplations on aging, sickness, death, separation from loved ones, and karma ownership. These daily reflections, recommended by the Buddha to awaken our motivation for practice, help us move beyond our death-phobic culture's denial of life's fundamental realities.

Bhante demonstrates two approaches: simply repeating each contemplation to feel its truth, and actively bringing specific fears to mind to work with our resistance. He emphasizes meeting arising fear, grief, or aversion with care and acceptance, allowing these natural reactions to be received and released. The practice is balanced with gratitude reflections on the preciousness of human birth, family, teachers, and the Dhamma itself.

Drawing on the Visuddhimagga's guidance, this teaching shows how intellectual understanding of impermanence transforms into heart acceptance, cultivating the equanimity and safety that paradoxically makes life more precious. As the Buddha taught, even death contemplation alone can lead to nibbāna. Essential practice for developing Right Awareness of our conditioned existence.

Okay, so these are the five remembrances that the Buddha says will really awaken our desire to practice. The idea is that we don't think about it so much. It's more getting into the feel of these things. Remember, in our death-phobic culture, we don't like to think about these things. For instance, every morning I'm sure we all wake up presuming without any shadow of a doubt that we will actually live throughout the day. There's no logical reason for believing that, because as you know, accidents happen, things happen, we can die just on a whim. But we don't remind ourselves. So what this is trying to do is say, look, every morning when you wake up, the first contemplation is to rejoice that you've actually woken up and then to remind yourself that this could be the last day.

One way or the other, or at least you could fall seriously ill and so on. Definitely you'll be getting older. There's no way you can get around that. So the sickness there, you see, that's a preparation for terminal sickness if we have one. And it's also just basically recognizing that the body can fall ill.

There's your aging business. And lots of things that the Buddha says about death. We just read one of them: death is inescapable. Everybody must die. Remember, the remainder of your lifespan is decreasing continuously. So that's a nice little reflection. And death will come regardless of whether or not we have made time to practice the *dharma*. So wealth cannot help. All this is little ways in which he encourages us.

And then number four is recognizing that in the end we part and are separated from everyone and everything dear and agreeable to us. And then finally, there's the contemplations of *kamma*.

There's two ways of doing it. One way is just to repeat the sentence into your heart, getting the feel of what your reaction is. And you might say, "This body is subject to disease. This body is subject to disease. This body is subject to disease." You play with the words to try and get some recognition of its truth value. And what you're interested in is, of course, how you're reacting to it. Either with a sense of anxiety, there's anxiety there, there's fear, et cetera.

Now you can up the ante by actually bringing to mind those things that you're particularly afraid of. So this body is subject to disease, and it could be Alzheimer's or it could be a paralyzing neurological disease, or it could be cancer. We've always got something that really worries us. And if you bring that to mind, again you're looking at your fear. So you remember this is the self not wanting to die, not wanting to fall ill, not wanting to age.

And in getting in contact with that, as soon as those feelings come, to be open to them, to receive them, to accept that this is the way our relationship is to this, and then just to allow it to evaporate a little bit.

And also the other thing is that when the fear, the grief, the aversion comes, it's easier to accept it if you receive it with a sense of care. So there's a part of the heart that is not particularly happy and it's not feeling well. And you would hug it, shall we say, as you would a child who's suffering one of these mental states.

So there's two ways there. Just repeating the phrase—this is what it says in the *Visuddhimagga*, the Path of Purification by Buddhaghosa—just to repeat it. But I think you can also use your imagination to get in touch with how we feel about these things. And so we just repeat these things to ourselves: aging, and then death, and then there's that one about parting, separated from everyone. And here again you can say it in different ways. And of course you can bring to mind what it is you are most attached to and what it will be a pain to leave. And of course you can also extend that to be parted from everyone, because they're leaving you. People die, people leave.

And again you can use your imagination to what does that mean to you. And then finally *kamma*, which has a certain brightness to it. We are the owners, we do possess our own actions. We are responsible for them: body, speech, and mind. But here of course we've got the ones that are unwholesome, but the ones that are also wholesome. And we get either the consequences of something we've done which is unskillful, and we get the reward of doing something which is skillful. So we inherit the results. We're born out of our *kamma*. It's always with us. Our relationships are formed through our *kamma*. And in fact, you could say that relatively speaking, that's what we are. We are our relationships, and they depend on your *kamma*.

And what I'll do is time a minute for each sentence, and then I'll remind you to do the reflections on gratitude. So you always have to balance these negative reflections with something positive. You know, gratitude for being born, your mother, for your family, your father, friends, your upbringing and education. We bring that to mind, all the medical practitioners who've helped you, all the gifts of our society, of our culture, the world, of nature.

And then finally, just to remind ourselves that this life is precious. Here the Buddha says we have this combination of joy and woe, and the intuitive intelligence sharp enough to find our way out of *saṃsāra*, the world of constantly going round and round. And finally just the preciousness of the *dharma*.

So now we can find the first one there. I'll just keep a timer going. So: "This body is subject to disease. This body is of a nature to fall ill. This body has not gone beyond sickness. This body is subject to aging. This body has not gone beyond aging. This body is now in a process of aging. This body is subject to death. This body has not gone beyond death. This body will die.

"I will be parted and separated from everyone and everything that is dear and pleasing to me.

"I am the owner of my actions of mind, speech, and body. I will inherit the results of my actions." Don't forget there's a dark and a bright side to these statements, and you can bring both wholesome and unwholesome actions to mind. And in that way you can balance the act, you might say. And I dare say that in the end you're on the positive side. "I am born each moment, each day, each lifetime of my actions. I form relations through my actions. I live dependent on my actions. Whatever I do, for good or for ill, I shall inherit the results."

To balance these reflections, we can either really consider the wonderful things we've done in our lives, and there will be them, they will be there if you care to look, or we can do this reflection on gratitude and the joys of life. So to make sure that it's actually worth living.

So just bringing to mind our mother, father, family, friends, all our upbringing and education, all the people, all the teachers that have helped us. And if we had a religious upbringing, the teachers that have helped us spiritually. And there's all the medical practitioners. And there's the gifts of our society, our culture, of the world, of nature. And then there's the miracle of waking up in the morning, consciousness, the preciousness of human life. Remember, we were given it. We weren't in control of that. There's very little we're actually in control of. Then finally, just the preciousness of the *dharma*.

So at this point, you can either continue this contemplation and what you can do is go back to the one or two that seemed to really touch you, that had an effect on you, and work with it gently, just accepting its truth value. Or then you can just return to *vipassanā*.

So just a final word. As we practice this, what we're doing is we're moving from an intellectual understanding of these statements into a heart acceptance. So a sense of them being digested. And when we accept the truth value of these things, the gift, of course, is a feeling of safety, a feeling of equanimity. And that allows us to feel inwardly more serene, just this acceptance of the way things are and the fact that we have very little control over sickness, aging, and death. And it's just allowing that thought to be accepted within the heart. That's the thing, you see.

And if you do this exercise, you don't have to do it for so long. In the morning, you know, almost one of the first things you do before you even sit. Then after a while, just reading them through is enough. It's enough to put you into that right mindset of not being surprised if something goes wrong during the day.

So I hope you found this useful. And according to the Buddha, remember, just the contemplation of death—never mind all the *vipassanā* and all the other stuff—just contemplating death is a path to *nibbāna*. That's how incisive, how wonderful it can be just to do that. And the paradox is, of course, that everything becomes precious. Life becomes absolutely more wonderful because of it.

There's a book by a man called Becker called *The Denial of Death*, and he goes into what happens when we deny it, when we're in a state of aversion to it. And it's really interesting how money is somehow connected to the aversion to death, you know, getting as much as we can to preserve ourselves. And the other one, which of course we do

know from COVID, is our going to our toiletry is part of death, because of course all our shit, if you'll excuse the word, is dead. And that's why during COVID, everybody went out and bought loads of toilet paper. So that's what happens if we don't contemplate death. We spend a lot of money on toilet paper.

So I hope my words or this little practice has been of some assistance and that it will help you in your journey towards full liberation from all suffering.

Revising the Basics

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 27 min

Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the Buddha's revolutionary discovery within the spiritual ferment of ancient India's Axial Age. Drawing from the Buddha's childhood memory of absorbed observation during his father's plowing ceremony, he illuminates how genuine practice involves moving beyond conceptual overlays to experience reality directly.

The talk emphasizes vipassanā as 'seeing things as they really are' - a radical investigation that reveals the three characteristics of existence: impermanence (anicca), unsatisfactoriness (dukkha), and not-self (anattā). Bhante explores how our deepest fear of death underlies all attempts at control, and how bringing awareness to mortality paradoxically enhances life's beauty and meaning.

Referencing the Buddha's second discourse on not-self and drawing parallels with Korean Zen's 'what is this?' inquiry, the talk demonstrates how sustained attention to present-moment experience undermines the illusion of a controlling self. Practical guidance connects formal meditation with daily life awareness, showing how the practice naturally leads toward the contentment and happiness (tutti, sukhī va hoti) that characterizes the path's fruition in nibbāna.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa — homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

I just thought I'd start with the basics in case there are some questions about the actual practice. Are there any questions? No? Everybody's perfectly clear and proper? I can't see everybody when I'm on this. No questions? Fantastic. Well, that's pretty easy then.

Just the usual reminders. We have to ask ourselves: what was the Buddha's discovery? When we go back through his life we can see that he tried all the various techniques that were present at the time — very concentrated states that we call absorption, fasting, controlling your food intake on the understanding that the body was the problem and if you could just draw the body down then all the temptations that come with the body would disappear. So he just got very thin and presumably almost died. I don't know, but he definitely got very thin.

He was a man of his time. Even though we see him as extraordinary, there was a time of great ferment. It's known as the Axial Age. The Brahminical tradition was producing all these new scriptures, and there was the Jain leader too, who was a contemporary of the Buddha. There were six other teachers at the time whom the Buddha had to contend with, one of them being what we would recognise these days as a materialist. So it was in that melee that the Buddha was working.

Just as these days — Trump isn't extraordinary. He's just an expression of our neoliberal situation. Without that situation, Trump would never have appeared. It's the same with the Buddha. He's the flower of this enormous investigation that was going on at that time into consciousness, into afterlife, all the things that were obsessing people.

What he discovered was that by turning inward — but up until then seemingly he's trying to escape. He's trying to escape the suffering of life, he's trying to escape rebirth, this problem of constant reincarnation. When all that fails and he's sitting under a tree, he does have this memory. As far as I know, this is the only true autobiographical memory piece in the whole of the scriptures. Everything else we can presume was made up — all that business about him being the son of a king and having these three gardens that he would go to and all that stuff. But the one point that seems to be true is this memory.

It's a kernel memory of him watching his father doing a plowing ceremony which opened up the planting season. His father was the head man, basically, of a tribe which is situated in North India, now into the border of Nepal. What he remembers is sitting there, watching his father with that sense of curiosity. He's absorbed — he's absorbed into that process. He's not thinking about it, he's not reflecting on it, he's just watching. At the end of that watching he comes to understand what his father's doing. I position him somewhere around about the age of seven or eight, something like that. Somehow that opened up to him a way of looking which was not conceptual.

That's our real problem. Everything we look at, everything we taste, everything we smell, everything we touch comes with a concept. That concept can be very simple like "hot" or it can be huge like "democracy." But it's conceptual. It's an idea which we then plunk onto the experience. So we never — I won't say never, but usually, more often than not — we experience things through a concept.

It's not as though we want to get rid of concepts. You need to know when something is hot and when it's cold. But it's drawing that attention back down out of the conceiving mind, out of conceptualising things. It's extraordinarily difficult, and the only way to do it is to drive the attention towards what we're actually experiencing in this present moment.

Conceiving, what the mind does is it gives us a reality that we can live with. Take time. We have a memory of things past and an idea of things future, and somehow time is a funnel that we're passing through — we're in time. But actually that's not what's happening. What's happening is things are arising and passing away in this present moment. There is no — whatever there was even a nanosecond ago has completely disappeared, and what's coming in the future, we haven't a clue. Generally speaking, because we're in a situation like ours in the West which is fairly peaceful, we don't get that sense of insecurity. But if you were living now in one of the war zones in Ukraine, you never know when one of these bombs are just going to blow you to pieces. You're living right on the edge, which brings you right into the present moment when you're like that.

It's this effort to begin to experience things before we have an idea of what it is that allows us to see things like impermanence, because we're right there. The mind is always constructing. It's always constructing.

That's the purpose of *vipassanā*. *Vipassanā*, remember, means to see things as they really are. The *passanā* means to see — *passati*. The *vi* is just a strengthener, to really see it. Just that effort to keep the attention on exactly what we're feeling, exactly what we're experiencing — the breath, take the breath for instance — to stay with it and to drive the attention right into it with that sense of curiosity, which is asking: am I actually seeing this as it really is? Or is there some conceiving going on?

In the Zen tradition of Korea they have this thing called the *hwadu* which just means "what is it?" "What is this?" It's just a way of centring that attention, constantly asking ourselves: am I seeing this the way it is? When I say constantly asking ourselves, I'm not saying that we should be there asking ourselves constantly "what is this?" — that is drive you potty. It's an attitude. It's an attitude that we're trying to develop of a radical doubt about ourselves as to our ability to see what's actually happening.

It's an honest doubt. It's asking ourselves: am I seeing this as it really is? On a grander scale: am I understanding the world as it really is? Do I understand where we are historically, where we are economically? It's like a general interest. But in terms of the practice: am I actually seeing myself as I really am? That's the question.

This effort to draw ourselves into the present moment opens up the possibility of really experiencing the fact that we are totally momentary. Totally momentary. The whole thing — the whole body-mind, everything — it's arising and passing away moment by moment.

This has a systemic effect because it makes us realise that the whole thing about holding on to something, keeping it, trying to stop things moving, trying to stop things changing, is a fool's game. It just creates frustration. It creates sorrow. Even in relationships — to try and hold a relationship as it is: "You're not the person I began to live with, you're not the person I married" and all that. Those sorts of statements don't make any sense within a situation which is in a state of continuous change.

That trying to hold ourselves as we are where we feel comfortable, trying to hold the other person where they are — that sense of trying to control. Underneath that, what do you find? You find fear. Fear, right at the fundamental base of our existence. But fear of what? Fear of death.

It's always underneath everything we're doing, this fear of death. Death in all its aspects of loss. Every moment is a momentary death. Every time you lose something, you've lost something that was part of you. Even if you only owned it, you didn't describe yourself by it, you didn't identify by it, but it was part of you. It's a little death, a mini death.

That fear, if it's not brought into our lives, begins to affect us in all these peculiar ways. During the pandemic, you'll notice — I'm sure some of you noticed or some of you read about it — everybody went out and bought loads of toilet paper. What an amazing thing! I met somebody and they'd actually — I think it was a bit cheeky — there was this elderly woman and she walked out with a whole trolley full of toilet paper and he made a big comment on it. There were all sorts of people around and he made a comment on it.

If you read about what the suppression, the repression of death does to us, you'll notice that we make these connections with — if you excuse the word — with money. That's why money is dirty somehow. We construe money as being part of death, part of loss. This not bringing that death into our lives is really undermining us. It's not opening us up, it's making us clamp down with fear.

If in the morning you were to say to yourself: "I might not live the whole of this day. I might actually die, or I might see the first signs of a terminal illness." At first you might think: "Well, if I do that, I'm just gonna get depressed." But actually the opposite happens. By bringing death as a possibility in our lives at all times — we don't know the hour or the day, Jesus said — as soon as we bring that into our life, the effect is to make us realise how amazing life is, how we have this consciousness in the first place, how is it there is something anyway.

The fact that there is this — I'm looking out onto a scene where there's the sun shining and the snow is full of this whiteness and it's a rare occasion these days — and there's beauty out there. One connects, one can feel it. That beauty and the joys of life become more accented when you recognise that everything's transient and that ultimately it'll all disappear and I'll disappear.

All these things, when you're looking into your practice, when you're actually diving in to your feelings, to your sensations, to your breath, and getting down there to see that it's just made up of little bits and pieces, little sensations arising and passing away — all this is part of seeing impermanence. As we go deeper into this impermanence and see what the suffering arises by not accepting impermanence, we're getting down to that deep level of fear. That fear is pointing to something. It's pointing to a concept about who I am. The deepest fundamental problem of our existence is identity.

I've noticed that now — some of you will know Sutta Central on the website, it's a great site — Ajahn Sujato has done all the scriptures now, which he seems to have translated. Some of his translations are a little bit, as you would say, inventive. But they're good. I've noticed that he's now translating delusion as identity. Finally, actually pointing to it. That's the root of it.

That discourse that the Buddha gives — his second discourse, which allows the five companions of his to become fully liberated — now that's not magic. Remember, they'd been practising like him for years with these absorption states and with the self-mortification things about not eating and all that stuff. They all become liberated after this talk. What's the talk on? The talk is about not-self. What that talk is simply saying is: is the idea of me as a person real? Can I substantiate it?

The first thing he points to is control. As you're doing your meditation, inside yourself you can see that things are just happening. You're not telling the breath to breathe. You're not telling your heart to express its sadnesses or its happinesses. You're not saying to your mind: "Now think about this, think about that." It's just all happening. That sense of not-control begins to take away this idea that I must be this psychophysical organism. That's what you're undermining.

When you look at impermanence, you can see that whenever you hold on to something, it's going to cause suffering because it's not going to be there. It's going to change. Something's going to happen.

It's this process of *vipassanā* which — the more we can really devote ourselves to doing it properly — often in our practice we get lazy, and I'm just as guilty of that as anybody else, where you sit and you start off with a good intention but then the mind wanders and before you know it you're worrying about this and you're thinking about that.

That opening gambit where we sit and we really talk to ourselves and say: "Come on, settle down, calm, be peaceful, draw your attention into the breath" — and be aware of what mental state you're beginning with. If it's a very agitated state, perhaps a scan through the body might be very helpful — going down if you are agitated, coming up if you're slothful, as it raises energy. If we acknowledge the mental state that we start with and work with it, and then we have that steadiness of attention to actually turn it into something we're investigating.

That's what we're actually practising. The practice and ordinary daily life — they shave into each other, they move into each other. For instance, at the end of a piece of work or you've done a bit of gardening or you've done this or you've made a cup of tea, just to stop for a moment and just recognise: that's gone, that's finished, that's the end, it's not there anymore. Then just to relax into this present moment, just to stop, and then the next intention comes and you empower that intention. That way there's a sense of at least guiding your life — I don't want to use the word "controlled" — you're guiding your life in a way that is going to lead to greater happiness, greater contentment.

There's a section in the *Dhammapada*, which is a collection of all these verses that the Buddha made up, totally devoted to making the self happy. This self that we feel — it can actually make itself happy. That's why we practise *mettā*, we practise joy, we practise compassion. The practice is to make ourselves happy, but not excited. There's another confusion we get into. Excitement is that level of agitation that comes when we're feeding into a desire, and the unfortunate consequence of that is that you can't feed it enough and it keeps coming back, keeps coming back. One of the things about happiness and joy which is coming from the goodness of the heart is that once it goes, there's no hankering after it and it always comes with a sense of calmness.

There are all these indications in the Buddha's teachings that our practice is supposed to actually make us more contented and happy in our daily life. That's taken over time. You can't measure it week by week, because some weeks are awful and some weeks are pretty good. But over a measure of time, you can see that your life is becoming more settled, more calm, more peaceful, more joyful. The practice is what is, shall we say, pushing you a little. It's just pushing you a little to look a bit more deeply.

If we can bring that sense of just being, just stopping every so often, and then noting that intention, making sure the intention is, as the Buddha would say, to our own benefit, for the benefit of ourselves, for the benefit of someone else, or for both our benefits.

and that's what makes work so meaningful - when you can see it as a benefit, when you can see it as a service. I've just watched a wonderful film. It's by the German director Wim Wenders. It's called Perfect Days.

It's basically about this man - we find out more about him as it goes on - but he basically cleans toilets. And he fills his day, he fills his part-time day with a bit of photography, a bit of music, looking after trees. And you can get the feeling that here is someone who has dropped out of a type of life which was stressful and has now found a way of just being. And he's taken a very simple job to maintain that sort of connectedness with society.

By the way, the toilets in Japan are amazing. I mean, they are architectural beauties. It tells you a lot about the Japanese. Their toilets are something else. So you have to look that up on AI to find out what the Japanese toilets are like.

So just to recap, we're practicing to see the three characteristics of existence. That's what they're called. The first one is to see the process of desire - and it's a wrong type of desire. It's the desire that wants to cling, that wants to have it all, that wants more. In our society, that word "more" - before it used to be more of something. I want more chocolate, I want more ice cream. But now it's just more. There's more of everything I've got and more of what I haven't got.

And then there's this process of seeing impermanence, and to bring that into our daily lives all the time - to see that everything comes to an end, everything comes to an end.

And then finally this idea of self, not-self - of constantly questioning who this person is. Who am I? What am I? Just constantly questioning that.

Now in that process, unwittingly - well, or in fact quite self-consciously - we're drawing something away from its confusion with this psychophysical organism. And it's this awareness. Every time you're aware of something, you're pushing it away from your awareness. You're becoming more aware of what the awareness is.

And it might be that at some point in your practice, either on retreat or even in daily life, if the attention is quite clear, you might just become aware of being that awareness. So you're up here, as it were, and you're being aware of being aware. And you can glance back in, glance back into that awareness. And when you come out, you can ask

yourself: What's it made of? What do I see there? What did I feel? What did I know? And you might surprise yourself to find out what that is. That's just a little exercise that I've culled from the Mahāyāna tradition.

So our practice is onward leading. That's the important thing. And even though we have dips in it, even though sometimes you look back and you think, "Well, I haven't changed that much," that's only because of expectation - of expecting the practice to be a magical thing. But the Buddha said, he didn't disguise it. He didn't say it was easy.

And I always like to quote this person who asked him, he said, "This training you're giving us is very hard." And the Buddha said, "Well yeah, but in the end you achieve Nibbāna," which is variously described, but one description would be without that unwholesome desire. And the person says, "Oh yeah, but so what? What's this Nibbāna business?" The Buddha says, "When you get there, you are contented and with it happy." And the words for that are *tuttihi, sukhi va hoti*. So I always say tutti frutti and sukhi va hoti.

So our practice is leading us towards a contentment with life, a general happiness, and eventually this understanding of a transcendental state, this experience of a transcendental state that we call *Nibbāna*.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I have not caused even greater confusion, and that by your practice you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

The Necessity of Joy

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

In this teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma addresses the often-overlooked practice of sympathetic joy (muditā), one of the four brahmavihāras or 'divine abodes.' Drawing from his experience with Burmese meditation masters, he explains why joy requires deliberate cultivation alongside mettā (loving-kindness), compassion, and equanimity.

Bhante distinguishes between wholesome joy and mere excitement, emphasizing that true joy is calm, appropriate to circumstances, and free from attachment. He explores how developing sympathetic joy naturally undermines envy and jealousy, as mentioned in the Buddhist discourses: 'envy is abandoned by one who develops sympathetic joy.' The talk includes insights into the body-mind relationship in Buddhist psychology and how our physical receptors can be trained to receive more positive mental states.

The session concludes with a guided meditation practice for cultivating muditā, using traditional phrases while extending joy progressively from beloved individuals to all beings. This teaching offers both theoretical understanding and practical tools for developing one of Buddhism's most healing heart qualities, particularly relevant for maintaining emotional balance in challenging times.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble, and fully Self-Awakened One.

Some of you who read my tip—I don't know if many people read the stuff, but some of you did read it—will know the basic content. But I thought I would speak to that particular tip that I did on joy, sympathetic joy.

I just don't remember any instructions by my teachers to develop joy, or compassion for that matter, or even equanimity. None of the Burmese Sayadaws taught me that at all. It was always about *mettā*.

Now, of course, there is a certain reason for that. Maybe it's because once we've established *mettā*, it's obviously easier for us to respond to other people's suffering and their joy, and to be equanimous within ourselves even though we are surrounded by suffering. The joy doesn't move out into excitement or indulgence. So the *mettā* really is the base. Once that's established, we can presume the other illimitables will arise.

So what we mean by illimitable is, of course, that these qualities can be developed indefinitely. It's just up to us. You can go up to the highest absorption if you wish with them. And it's also known as the *brahmavihāra*. Just to remind you, Brahmā was the chief god of the Vedic system, and so what he's saying is that this is the most beautiful heart state that we can experience. It's one of the most beautiful. Actually, you can develop any virtue illimitably—it's just that these are the four what we can call social virtues.

It's important for us to balance the compassion, especially now when we can see that the world is beginning to crash. We can have terrible forebodings of what's going to happen economically, politically, and so on. So somehow you have to be careful if you are listening to the news. I know some people just don't listen to the news anymore—it's just too depressing, too upsetting. But if you are, you have to balance it a bit with joy.

Sometimes on retreat, which I'm going to lead a retreat soon, I'll often say at the end of the day we do a meditation on joy, and I say, "Bring to mind moments of the day when you felt joyful." One or two people tell me afterwards that they can't remember any. So the reason for that, of course, is that we're not paying attention to it. That's understandable because unless you're feeling ecstatic joy or big joy, you don't notice the little moments when you feel content, fairly content, when you feel fairly happy—nothing particularly exciting.

In fact, we don't want excitement. And so not paying attention to it means that we're not clicking on it. When we do start paying attention to these moments of joy, then they grow because of that attention. Remember, an act of attention is an act of intention—it's an empowering act. Your awareness notices, your attention notices what's happening, and when it's a full attention, it becomes a full—it fills up your whole consciousness. And in that way, it grows.

So we have to train ourselves in periods where we're feeling downcast to pay attention when any bit of joy comes up. "Ah, there's a bit of joy. Fancy that."

And of course, we have to make the distinction between joy and excitement. So excitement is that bit of indulgence where we become attached to a certain joy, which is understandable, but it unfortunately causes consequences. An obvious one is grief at loss, the fear of loss, the anxiety of loss.

But joy is very cool. It doesn't have that. It's the difference on your Christmas cake between marzipan and icing. The icing's too much—you should always take it off, it's very bad for you—but the marzipan's fantastic, even though it's got a bit of sugar. Well, compared to icing. That's your distinction.

So joy is quiet. It's a pleasant, at times very pleasant, mental state, even to the point of absorption. It's always accompanied with calmness—this is the point—always calm. There's always a sense of equanimity there. It doesn't demand that you keep it going. When it goes, it just goes, and that's fine. And it's always appropriate to the joyful situation you're in.

We can feel joy for ourselves when we've succeeded at something. That's fine—there's nothing wrong with that. And when we're with somebody who is joyful, we respond with that joy, and it's appropriate to the situation. You've only got to think of parents when they rejoice in their children's successes—it's very natural to do so.

And one of the reasons that we're not really aware of the little joys that pass through us during the day—the little happinesses, the little contentments—is that, of course, we're much more aware of the horrible things that might happen, perceived dangers. I suppose it's all got to do with evolution—that's what they say anyway. But the fact is that unless we pay attention to these little joys, they won't grow. Simple as that—they won't grow.

I like to quote the mystical romantic poet William Blake on this. He always has a lovely verse: "He who binds himself to a joy does the winged life destroy, but he who kisses a joy as it flies lives in eternity's sunrise." So eternity here can be understood as the ever-present moment. It's not a matter of time as such.

It also has the positive effect of undermining envy and jealousy. I personally always thought of envy as something that—when you want what somebody else has—and sometimes it can even be a compliment if you actually don't want it. So if you say, "Well, I envy your new car," and there's no desire for that car in you, that's fine. That's one way we use it.

But envy normally is wanting what the other person has. And jealousy is wanting what they have and also hating them for having what they have. So there's a bit of hatred in there. But it's also—I think it involves a loss, a fear of losing what you have to a rival. I mean, in a relationship, that can happen, so jealousy comes up.

As it says in the actual discourses, there's a lovely line: "Envy is abandoned by one who develops sympathetic joy." So that has—that's something to really work on if we find ourselves being envious and jealous. And it has the effect, then, therefore, of lessening any resentment or selfishness. It undermines that rivalry, especially at work, where you have colleagues or work people whom you see are doing better than you. It can get pretty nasty.

I had an occasion with that myself, actually. I was offered a promotion, and the funny thing was that it wasn't really a promotion to do with my department that I was in. So I was in the General Education Department in an FE college. And what had happened was after the great and honourable Mrs Thatcher brought in her new rules, there was a huge amount of unemployment in Birmingham. It rose from—I remember this—it rose from six to sixteen percent in six months. And I had the idea that as an FE college with all our trainings, we could get some of them in.

So I started this program for them. Now, of course, the people who wanted the promotion were the engineers, were the electricians. They didn't expect me teaching sociology or something. At the time, I was teaching English to immigrants. So there was this real rivalry there. It was quite horrible. And one man took great exception to me. Anyway, I left and became a monk, so they were all right in the end.

For those of you—oh yeah, there's an important point here which is about the body and mind. So in Buddhism, the body and mind are two different energies—they're not the same. And when you die, it's the mental body that rises out of the physical body. And what the body does is it's like a sounding board. It resonates the heart—it resonates against the body.

And you may actually have the experience when you are absorbed into an emotion and you're feeling it and you're seeing what its characteristics are—you may just have the experience where they actually separate and you can see that the body makes everything worse. And actually, whatever you're suffering from—say the depression—it's the body that feels the heaviness. It's the body that makes it really quite difficult to bear. So there is that combination.

So that means, and according to what I've read—I don't understand the chemistry or anything at all—but basically our cells have receptors for various types of hormones. And if you've got depressive hormones constantly coming into the body, those receptors grow at the expense of those receptors that receive the chemicals that make you happy. So dopamine, endorphins, all those things that make you happy—the receptors are less.

Now the thing is, I'm not so sure you'd be particularly aware of that, because when you feel depressed, you'd feel heavily depressed. But when you feel joy, you wouldn't know that actually you could feel more joyful if you hadn't developed depression so much. I know this is a very contorted way of talking about this, but I'm trying to get across that there's actually a physical reason for practising joy, and for raising it in whatever way you can—walking in nature, in a park, or whatever, meeting friends,

anything that lifts the heart has a direct effect upon the body. I mean, we know that because bad mental states can actually make you physically ill. So it's good to remind ourselves of that.

Okay, so there's lots of reasons there for developing joy. And we may as well end this talk with the actual practice. So if we just sit quietly for a moment, and then we'll just repeat these phrases and go through the process that we do when we practise it with *mettā*.

So make sure that you're sitting comfortably. It doesn't have to be as if you're sitting in *vipassanā*—just make sure you're comfortable. That's the important thing. And then just drawing ourselves inwardly and just recognising the mental state we're in and just resting with that for a moment.

And then in the same way that we do with *mettā*, bring somebody to mind who raises joy when you see them. It can even be a comedian—somebody who brings a sense of joy into the heart. And it's good to have a smile on the face. It's good to have a smile. It doesn't have to be a great big Richter smile, but a smile does release all the endorphins or whatever. And just to feel that on your face, a gentle smile.

And you're bringing somebody to mind who makes you joyful when you see them. And the blessings are: may you be joyful. May you be ever more joyful. And if you wish, may you enjoy the sublime happiness of *Nibbāna*.

So may you be joyful. May you be ever more joyful. May you experience the sublime happiness of *Nibbāna*.

So we can bring somebody who's helped us in our lives—offer them the blessings of joy.

And to all those who are near and dear to us. Friends, people at work, whomever we wish.

Choosing a neutral person, someone we see but don't know.

Turning that joy towards ourselves.

We can even bring someone to mind that we're having difficulties with. Not big difficulties, but difficult.

Radiating outwardly to each other. May we, our present spiritual companions...

And to our neighbours and neighbourhood, to all the people in our country, to all the peoples of Europe, to all people on earth.

And finally, to all beings in all directions.

Polarisation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 16 min

In this insightful talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddhist understanding of social polarisation, tracing its roots to identity and the three conceits (māna) - believing oneself better, worse, or equal to others. Drawing on the Buddha's teaching of anattā (not-self), he explains how group identity creates comparison and moral superiority, leading to the personalisation of policy disagreements into existential threats.

The talk explores how the proliferation process (papañca) described in the Madhupiṇḍika Sutta (MN 18) operates between people, creating echo chambers reinforced by social media algorithms. Bhante discusses practical examples from immigration debates to local village disputes, showing how emotional rewards from like-minded groups intensify positions and erode empathy.

Offering Buddhist solutions, he emphasises the Buddha's teaching that 'the whole of the spiritual life is good companionship' while warning of its inverse - how groups can reinforce false narratives. The talk concludes with practical advice for practitioners: acknowledging our biases, engaging with opposing views through mettā (loving-kindness), and using meditation to transform aversion into its opposite. This dharma teaching provides valuable guidance for maintaining equanimity and compassion in increasingly polarised times.

I'm going to have some reflections on polarization. I've been on ChatGPT and a couple of YouTube videos, but I'm trying to get it within the Dharma of the Buddha.

Polarization often happens in times of change when people take positions. This would be fine except for identity. Identity seems to be the primary cause for this polarization, or the foundation of it you might say. Of course, that's at the root of suffering according to the not-self doctrine of the Buddha.

Each party thinks of itself as morally superior, hence more virtuous, more intelligent and, of course, more patriotic. This is the working of the self that thrives on comparison, not on the various definitions of what virtue might be, but personalising and criticising the person. Hence the three conceits: I'm better, I'm worse than you, and the more subtle conceit, I'm equal. The last one is what supports group identity. You find your companions and that group now compares itself with other groups. That's how it works.

When it comes to immigration, for instance, we have those who accept it and even say we need more of it. And the opposite, of course, who say it's a conspiracy to replace the white race. So these people see each other as existential threats because they've personalised it. Disagreements are no longer about policy, but about who you are.

Now we as Dhammikas - a *Dhammika* was the original way that the followers of the Buddha referred to themselves, followers of the true law - we need to be aware when we're identifying with a group and not lose the objective perspective, which enables us to criticise our stance on any particular topic. For instance, if there's a general agreement in the group that immigration has gone too far, especially since Covid, then we also need to know that there are changes happening in the European Convention of Human Rights, which also protect our own freedoms.

This leads to hardening of positions, moralising of areas such as public health, climate crisis and wealth. They become moral absolutes such that any compromise is experienced as betrayal. Because of the distortion of conceit, such positions fail to see that interconnectedness, interrelatedness, interdependence that we talk about.

For instance, withdrawing international aid - in other words, not sharing our wealth - leads to greater poverty. So it should not be a surprise that the numbers grow of people wanting to escape that very poverty and destitution. This fact that richer countries are reducing aid also tells us that this neoliberal order and its economic system has allowed the market to rule without any social responsibility and follows the dictum, "greed is good."

The system has produced such uncertainty that more and more people are feeling their jobs are insecure, causing anxiety about loss of status and wealth. Such unhealthy and unwholesome mental states drive people to believe anyone who says they've got the answer. All these fears around such areas as loss of work, rising cost of living, immigration, climate are all coupled with the growing despair that normal institutions are incapable of bettering the situation.

This leads to a loss of confidence in political parties, unions, religious organisations, other civic institutions that once were able to mediate and bring needed change. But it's no wonder that people start to join mass movements emotionally manipulated by demagogues and led by populists to deceive them into believing that they are working for the common good.

What has made everything exponentially worse, of course, is social media. From the heady days when it was believed the internet would bring a harmonious world community, we're descending into a worldwide verbal brawl. At the moment it's words, but it soon could become violent action. Witness the storming of the Capitol by MAGA devotees.

The algorithms feed on our natural bent for threat and opposition, rather than having algorithms that help us to welcome and cooperate. They herd people in what's called epistemic silos - isolated groups of like-minded people that go on to intensify the situation, even to the point of conspiracies. This, of course, has actually happened many times in history, leading to civil wars. Europe's been full of civil wars.

Such an occasion happened in our little tiny village of Llanigon. A neighbour working for the Shropshire Council in England to bring more wealth to the area won a grant - I think it was a million pounds actually - from the Lottery Fund. A local eco-warrior saw this as a danger to turning the area into a holiday resort. There were meetings and finally a confrontation with the Lottery Fund grant receiver. Young men used foul language, happily stamped out by a retired magistrate, and eventually everything calmed down. In the meantime, an email was sent full of expletives calling on resistance.

Frankly, the whole fracas was beyond pathetic. To this day I haven't seen any change and still wonder what happened to the money. But all the markers were there: moral outrage - "How dare the Shropshire Council do this to us? We're in Powys, Wales!" Simplified narrative - "It's going to ruin the area." Conspiracy theories - "What else are the Council going to do?" And group validation - I was told the meeting at the pub went very well. It's a wonder they didn't turn up to the meeting armed with picks, shovels and trowels, the local population being farmers and retired well-to-do.

But what stays with me is the amount of anger that it generated. Quite weird.

The consequences of these silos is that they are groups that create realities that cannot coexist with other realities. That's the problem with conspiracies. This is also a consequence of the postmodernism that questioned objective truth, declaring we all have our own realities, hence all is relative. So we move to post-truth and, of course, outright lying.

Now, the Buddha taught the whole of the spiritual life was good companionship. We're interdependent beings. And of course, the obverse is also true. A den of thieves - "good companionship" is also necessary to invoke false narratives and conspiracies. The

disturbing fact is that feedback loops intensify since thoughts feed on thoughts, emotions on emotions, and ready with backing from social media and the rewards of finding such friends - the feeling of safety, emotional support and ideological fantasizing.

The Buddha tells us about this inner process very clearly and how it produces proliferation. The Pali word is *papañca*, which I particularly like a lot. Sense consciousness arises from the base of the eye, ear, nose, tongue, body and the mind, and it's dependent on those senses. So when you have an object and a sense base and consciousness, that's what he calls contact. Contact is a requirement for feeling. What we feel, we perceive. What we perceive, we think about. What we think about, we proliferate. What we proliferate is the source of which judgments driven by proliferating perceptions beset a person, and this occurs on all the senses. For those of you interested, that's from the Honeyball Discourse in the Middle Length Sayings, number 18.

The same process is magnified between people, so that moral outrage rewarded by groups leads to certainty, and the group reinforces itself by denigrating the opposite groups, leading to a loss of empathy and to a loss of communication. This distrust simply leads to a hardening of positions, especially where the others are seen as potential threats. And again, there's the emotional rewards of like-minded friends.

So how can we do something to reverse the process, or at least undermine it? The basic cause lies in identity - how people define themselves. And this identity narrows to a particular cause, creating a barrier that expels anyone who disagrees and then places verbal and other weapons on the barrier to destroy those it describes as enemies.

For such alienated groups, one is to point to a higher identity that embraces to some extent those of other parties. This is the work of politics, of course. When it comes to immigration, for instance, both sides of the argument need to be lifted to a greater overall view of the situation. And this can be done through the very media that supports polarisation by bringing opposing groups to dispute in the open. No matter how distasteful we may find some of the people, they need to be engaged in open debate.

There's also the benefit of citizen assemblies that have been used to great effect in Ireland. I don't know why we don't have them in the UK. Perhaps the government finds them threatening.

When we identify with a cause, everything becomes saturated with me. And me is always right. We might refer to this as ego, but I prefer the old word pride. It finds it hard to compromise and any giving in to the opposition is seen as a shaming betrayal. But once we soften the grip and admit that no one has total exclusive truth and open up to

another's views, compromise allows a wise solution. These are perspectives that can accommodate different views. Enemies can become people we can discuss and argue with.

And there's our Dharma practice. As ordinary citizens, we need to make our views known to politicians, to our local MP, whenever possible, encourage the government to control media content. We also need to be sensitive to journalists to make sure we know who are non-partisan and independent. We need to be able to tell facts from comment. And when it comes to media, to limit the amount and type we allow into our hearts.

We also have to admit to our biases. Biases can be explicit - we're aware of them - or implicit - we're not aware of them. Prejudices, meanwhile, are those biases that we're actively developing. Acknowledging biases allows us to counteract their effect. It's virtually impossible not to have religious, racial, gender and class bias. It's in the DNA of our culture. We may find that difficult to accept, but unless we're aware of them, they'll affect our behaviour. And we may be embarrassed by Freudian slips and suddenly becoming self-defensive or aggressive when accused.

Practising *mettā* is not just a contemplative practice, but approaching people or media we are strongly against with a heart that is open to understanding where they come from. And it would really help to find a discussion group - online, better in person - where we can bring up, which are set to bring people of differing views into dialogue with each other.

This leads us to realizing that it is destructive to shame other people - like, for instance, saying they're ignorant. This happened after the Brexit referendum. And there's no point in showering people with facts if they don't trust us. The wisest thing is to follow the Buddha's own approach, which was to understand the other's position and question it before launching into our own views and opinions.

Polarization isn't something new. It can lead to civil wars. It's done so in many countries in the past. And it's our task to be sure that we're not fuelling this malignancy that has the danger of metastasizing into a general conflict that's of no benefit to anybody.

So what do we do when a racist, sexist, religious, gender or any other bias thought comes into the mind? We might find ourselves feeling guilty and push the thought away without really accepting it. So that conditioning has not been allowed to manifest and continues to fester. If we allow the bias to manifest in our minds and hearts, then we can begin to undermine it.

First, there's the acceptance: this is a bias in my heart. And once I accept it, we can recognise it as unwholesome. Now, usually it arises because we've seen or heard someone whom the bias hates. So we can bring that person to mind, see the situation from their point of view. We can apologise to them as an active Dharma practice within ourselves. Then we can hold the person in a caring embrace. You can't hate and care at the same time.

Sometimes you have to be creative with this process of undermining biases. If we're sitting in meditation and we get one of these biases coming up, you might find it just as useful to just sit with the aversion, just the feeling of the aversion. And what we're doing, we're just allowing that bad energy to exhaust itself. And then if we stay to the very end, when that feeling of aversion comes to an end, we stay to the point where it disappears, you might experience it transforming into the opposite. So you might suddenly find your heart full of love or peacefulness or some other positive state.

Nothing's lost in allowing these negative states to come up and pass away. They're always changing towards their opposites. This we find in the Right Attitude of the Eight-fold Path, which is stated as going from greed to generosity, hatred to love, and cruelty to compassion. It happens naturally in the meditation, as long as we allow the heart to have full freedom to express itself.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused confusion. Write to me if they do. And that by your practice, you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later. If you've got any comments, do email me. I'd like to hear.

Dullness and Lethargy

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 15 min

In this practical talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines thīnamiddha—dullness and lethargy—one of the five hindrances to meditation and spiritual progress. He distinguishes between the phenomenological experience of mental dullness (thīna) and physical heaviness (middha), moving beyond traditional moral judgments to understand these states as they actually manifest in practice.

Drawing on the Buddha's advice to Venerable Moggallāna, Bhante explores practical remedies: changing focus, physical stimulation, opening the eyes, walking meditation, and when necessary, mindful rest. He distinguishes between temporary dullness as a passing state versus depression as a persistent trait, emphasizing the importance of recognizing the difference.

The talk includes insights from the Burmese master Sun Lun Sayadaw, who achieved liberation in record time and attributed others' slower progress to laziness. Bhante shares personal experiences from intensive retreats, including a humorous incident that illustrates how profound dullness can become. He explores the interconnection between restlessness and lethargy as manifestations of the same dysregulated energy, offering specific techniques for lifting energy through body awareness.

This teaching provides essential guidance for recognizing and skillfully working with one of meditation's most pervasive but often underestimated obstacles.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa — homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

This moon I thought I'd cover this dullness and lethargy. It used to be called sloth and torpor, which are, of course, moral views of them. And it's also listed in the seven deadly sins of the Christian tradition. You'll know them all: pride, avarice, lust, envy, gluttony, anger and sloth.

These days we tend to use gentler phenomenological titles and call them how we feel them. So we feel them as dullness in the head and lethargy in the body. And of course cognitive science always comes up with its own little definitions — arousal dysregulation. So when you feel very dull and lethargic and lazy and all that, you can say, "Oh, this is just arousal dysregulation."

Thīna-middha — that's the word. So *thīna* refers to this dullness in the head, and *middha* refers to this heaviness or physical torpor.

Now I don't think we put enough accent on this. The other hindrances everybody knows about — sensual desires and ill will, anger and all that — and we know about restlessness and we know about remorse and guilt and shame, and doubt often comes up for us. But I don't think we realise how pernicious dullness and lethargy is.

So how does it come about, this dullness and lethargy? Consider certain situations. Sunday morning — you wake up and you're nice and warm in bed and it's absolutely wonderful, and you think, "I'll just roll over and roast the other side for a moment." So you don't need it, but it's just a lovely thing to disappear into this sweet oblivion. And especially when it's subliminal — you're not quite asleep, but you're not quite awake. And it just feels very lovely.

Well, of course, that's really bad energy. I mean, everything we do creates physical or mental energy. So this energy now is one that pulls us down.

And then there are occasions when we feel a bit bored, or we're a bit upset or feel a bit depressed. We'll come to depression in a minute. Or we feel a bit depressed and we think, "Oh," and we get on the sofa and disappear, or you throw yourself under the duvet. One way or another, you just get rid of yourself. It's a sort of soft suicide. But it takes an effort — you have to do it. So there has to be this intention to disappear, and there's an energy that makes you do that. And of course when it comes up in meditation or in ordinary daily life, you just get this dullness in your head and this heaviness in the body. So it's just a bad habit, that's all.

There was an Arahant in Burma called Sunlun, and he attained full liberation at record Olympic speed. It seems he was a clerk in an office and he met someone who taught him how to do breathing meditation. But what they taught him was this very heavy, fast breathing. You can get it on YouTube — S-U-N-L-U-N. And it was something like six months — he just did this practice and within six months he'd made it, and then began to teach the system. So again, you can check it out on YouTube. And he was asked, "Why is it that people... I mean, you did it in this express speed — how is it people don't?" And he said, "It's because they're lazy."

So there we are. That's coming from an Arahant. So the problem with that dullness and lethargy is that it then expresses itself as a sort of apathy, an unwillingness to do something. "I can't be bothered." Boredom sinks in. So it really has a long effect on us in terms of our attitude in daily life.

You have to be careful not to confuse it with depression. I've got some stuff here which points out the difference. In meditation, the dullness, or in ordinary daily life when you feel dull or you feel this heaviness in the body, it's normally just a state. But if it's depression, it becomes a trait — it's with you a lot of the time. And in the posture it improves with lifting the energy.

So if you feel drowsy in the posture, there are a few things you can do. You can open your eyes, let the light in. You can lift your body up, put more energy in it, and it normally will dissipate. The other thing, of course, is to sink into the feeling and just be with it and investigate its qualities — the softness of it, the tingliness of it. You'd be surprised how it feels when you drop into the body. And sometimes if you're dull in the head and you just wake up, as it were, and investigate this sort of porridge in the head, you'd be surprised. You wake up like a light bulb. It's quite remarkable.

But if it's depression, it's a mood. It just doesn't move. So you have to be careful not to confuse those two. And if you do think that you are depressed, then obviously you might need some help.

Just zooming forward to the Buddha. So he had his early two disciples, Moggallāna and Sāriputta. They were Brahmins. And they became, of course, his two chief disciples. And Moggallāna went to him for some advice about dullness and lethargy. And he gave these sorts of advice.

He says, "Change the focus, put your attention on something which is going to raise your energy." In his terms, it could be reflecting on the Dhamma. You can even do some chanting — just something to lift the energy. He also suggests that you pull your earlobes. So you can always try that if you really press your fingers in — it really hurts. In the old days that's what your parents used to get hold of just to wake you up. And then there's light, of course — I've mentioned opening the eyes and letting the light in. And then he says, "And walking meditation, of course — you can always do that."

And also, just in ordinary daily life, remember: after you've eaten, even if it's the right amount, if it's carbohydrates, the body does produce a chemical that makes you feel drowsy, wanting you to spend some time resting in order to digest and go through that whole process. But you have to be careful that you don't give into the sleepiness of it, that's all. And if, in fact, you are overcome by sleepiness after you've eaten, then you might be eating too much.

And then he says when all that fails, he talks about mindful rest — to actually rest and just try a yoga thing of neurone or yoga *nidra*, something like that, just to relax and not to actually lose consciousness.

So just to run over those causes again, I've got it listed here. There's overeating, sometimes oversleeping. That's when you're indulging in blissful oblivion. Be careful of boredom — that also makes you want to go to sleep. So you have to lift up a bit of interest and physical exercise. Don't forget physical exercise. It doesn't have to be much, but you've got to take care of the body in terms of its energy systems. So doing things like Tai Chi, yoga, but also some aerobic stuff like walking or cycling or something. All these add to a sort of general feeling of energy.

Now, one thing you can do if you do feel sleepy is to again remind ourselves of the urgency of the situation. Every morning we wake up and I'm sure that we are absolutely sure that we will live the whole day. But there's nothing certain about that at all. And we can drop dead any time, or we could be caught up in an accident or fall off a cliff. Who knows? It's getting that feel that we're living on this knife edge, and that brings a sense of urgency of wanting to really bring the practice into daily life. Sometimes you can bring inspiring teachers' teachings to mind.

So basically it's a hindrance. It's one of the hindrances. It's a mental state that I think we have to take quite seriously. In my own practice I've spent hours dealing with dullness and lethargy, and at one point it used to last for ten days. I used to just walk around in this fog.

And there was a lovely occasion in a meditation room that I was staying in Malaysia at the time — I was working with Upandita. And everybody, of course, was getting up at half past three. And the diligent ones, if they were falling asleep in the meditation, they were doing walking meditation at the back of the hall. And the lights were quite low. And we're all sitting there, and there's this hell-raising of a crash — glass broken. It sounded terrible. And this poor meditator, he might have been a monk, walks straight into a glass picture. So that's how dull you can get. He wasn't hurt, but it was just a funny occasion.

I'd like to leave you with something I haven't said for a very long time, which is to recognise that we were most probably conceived on a bed and we probably were born on a bed, and we spend a third of our lives in bed, and when we're sick we go to bed, and we'll probably die in a bed. So it's good to remember that the bed is probably the most dangerous place on earth. And just stay with it — every time you look at the bed, just think of it as the pit, so that you actually regulate how much you're falling asleep. Because any oversleep creates this bad energy, this downer.

On a final note, there is a connection between restlessness and dullness and lethargy. Often in your meditation you'll be quite restless and then suddenly find yourself dozing. And sometimes you're feeling very dull and unenergetic and suddenly you become

restless. And as I experience it, it's the same energy — one of it's coming up and the other one's going down. So one trick when you are feeling dull is to start from the feet and just bring your attention up the body, feeling things. It's an exploration. But don't go down — start again at the feet and just keep coming up. And that also, for me anyway, has an effect of lifting that energy.

Very good. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, and that by your diligent practice, never falling into the error of dullness and lethargy, you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Adhiṭṭhāna — Determination

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 20 min

Bhante Bodhidhamma examines adhiṭṭhāna — determination or resolution — as one of the ten pāramī (perfections) essential for awakening. He explores the Pali etymology of adhiṭṭhāna, breaking it down as 'higher establishment' and connecting it to the familiar term satipaṭṭhāna (establishment of awareness).

Drawing from the Visuddhimagga, Bhante explains adhiṭṭhāna as 'an unshakable resolve directed towards a wholesome goal, grounded in wisdom.' He demonstrates how determination serves as a binding force that brings together all ten pāramī — from dāna (generosity) and sīla (virtue) to paññā (wisdom) and upekkhā (equanimity) — in service of liberation.

The talk addresses the Buddha's own journey from extreme ascetic practices to the middle way, illustrating the difference between harmful willpower and skillful perseverance. Bhante emphasizes developing determination through small, consistent resolutions rather than overwhelming commitments, noting how keeping simple daily practices builds the 'muscle of perseverance.' He concludes with the arahant's declaration: 'What had to be done has been done' — the profound satisfaction of completing the spiritual task through unwavering resolve.

I shall begin.

So we're just looking at this virtue, *pāramī*, this perfection. We'll come to that in a minute. This word, the resolution, determination, *adhiṭṭhāna*.

So we've got lots of words. Persistence, tenacity, perseverance, doggedness, resolve, resolution, steadfast, willpower, purpose, purposeful, grit. And all these are life's little nuances to our understanding of determination.

So the word itself, *adhi*, it'd be split into *adhi* and *ṭṭhāna*. *Adhi* just means higher, above, superior, etc. So you get it in words like *adhicitta*, superior mind, or *adhipati*, who's a ruler. *Ṭṭhāna* is used both in a realistic sense of place or location, but metaphorically, it's a state, a condition, a reason, occasion. And most of you will know the *Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta*. So the *ṭṭhāna* at the end is the establishment, the foundation. The *paṭi* is just reinforcing that—a deep and profound establishment of *sati*, awareness. And that's the discourse on how to establish awareness.

I like the word perseverance for some reason. Just dogged perseverance.

In the Visuddhimagga, it talks about the resolution to undertake and carry out the requisites of awakening without wavering. It's an unwavering commitment, unshakable resolve. It also talks about an unshakable resolve directed towards a wholesome goal, grounded in wisdom and supported by the other perfections.

So what we'll do is go through these perfections and show how *adhiṭṭhāna* is a binding force that brings them all together in order for us to attain a particular goal. Of course, here we're centred on liberation, but these things also work for even making a relationship work, some task at work itself, anything that you undertake, which is going to take effort and continued effort. All these factors come into play.

So if we just go through the *pāramī*. So generosity, *dāna*. So when you set yourself a goal on something, it's being generous to yourself, isn't it? You're giving yourself something. You're giving yourself an aim. And because we are always interconnected, as you know, involving other people, it's also a gift for them. So that generosity comes in there somewhere, the feeling of giving.

Now, when it comes to virtue, *sīla*, ethical conduct, you can then see how if you don't have that, things can go a bit wrong. So somebody I think who has clear determination is Putin. I mean, he's prepared—when I say that, he's prepared to put so many millions, so many thousands of young men at the front to be killed and wounded. So it's not actually affecting him. He's probably enjoying caviar. So but at least he's got that determination to sacrifice everybody to that final aim of expanding the Russian Federation. And of course you'll see that in all of these authoritarians, these tyrants. Yeah, and we can point to other people too, but we shan't go into that.

So it has to be, in terms of our practice of becoming fully liberated, then obviously we need to—it needs to be virtuous.

Now *nekkhamma*, renunciation. Consider—we've just had a little baby in the family, and when you think about—and I'm many of you will have had children—so when you think about having a child, that's a huge commitment. And you have to have perseverance.

I think it was Kabat-Zinn, who some of you will know—all that stuff about mindfulness training—he said bringing up children was like 18 years on retreat. So that sort of complete devotion. I mean, a baby is 24 hours, 24/7, you know, conditioning. And you have to give up something. Yeah. You have to give up what you would normally have done—go to the pictures or whatever, however you amuse yourselves. So it involves some level of renunciation.

Paññā. So it's wisdom, of course. It's got to be a certain devotion to righteousness. I'm thinking here of people who really spend an enormous amount of energy trying to get injustices corrected. The one that comes to mind recently was—for those of you in the UK—this huge miscarriage of justice about the post office, where the powers that be trusted this accounting software and it eventually ended up with 900 postmasters being dismissed. And there were suicides and some went to jail—completely miscarried justice. And it was the actions of one man in particular, Alan Bates, who spent 20 years getting justice. Can you imagine that? 20 years perseverance. And that's the sort of wisdom—that the idea of justice.

Now obviously that's going to take energy, effort. Right? Don't confuse effort with perseverance. Perseverance is a mental state, it's a mental attitude, whereas effort is the energy—you need both the physical and mental energy. Not having any of these can undermine the whole project.

And then of course there's patience. Like this man—20 years, for heaven's sake—and to actually have the patience and the willingness to endure. That's important too.

And then we have *sacca*, which is truthfulness. It's really being honest about oneself, about one's capabilities. Obviously, if you have an aim which is beyond your capability, you just get burnout and disappointment. I mean, if I started thinking about becoming a professional footballer, and I got the kit and I went training, turned up at clubs—it might be that a good friend of mine might come to tell me that maybe I was being a bit misguided, not enough humility. So there has to be that sense of real, being real about oneself.

There's *mettā*, of course. Doing anything which is wholesome—and here we're talking specifically about liberation—it's obviously an act of loving kindness, an act of care towards ourselves. And because it always involves other people, it therefore is an act of care towards others.

And then finally, this quality of *upekkhā*, which is equanimity. So that's being able to bear with things, not to get caught up in disappointment, not to go berserk when something wonderful has happened, to keep that even keel, which of course reserves energy and helps us to be more narrowed in our focus when we want something.

So that's—you can see how once you've brought a certain sense of persistence, a certain sense of commitment to something, all these virtues come to support you. Gratitude—once you think about the things that have been given us, then the natural thing is to want to give back.

So virtues always support each other in some way or other, whereas vices—anger, greed—they cancel each other out. You can't be angry and greedy at the same time, even though it might feel like that. There are two mental states that cancel each other out.

So how much should we—what should our determination be when it comes to this process of liberation? So this is taken from a particular discourse where the Buddha describes the sort of ascetic practices that he did. And he says—he starts off with this clear determination: "Let only my skin, sinews and bones remain. And let my flesh and blood dry up. I will not give up my effort so long as I have not attained what can be attained by human strength."

Now, this took him into those ascetic practices, like holding his breath for as long as he could, not eating, of course, almost starving himself to death. And at some point he realized that this was over-efforting. It was a wrong sort of perseverance.

And with that he leaves his companions, if you remember, and then he finds this lovely place. Sorry, and then he remembers this occasion in his life which, according to the academics, is the only bit of biography you can actually believe, where he remembers watching his father doing an opening plowing ceremony and he's a young kid. And you know how young kids get involved. And he's totally involved in what his father's doing, drawn by curiosity, by interest.

And this not only changes his practice from trying to attain something—liberation, trying to attain it—to investigating his condition. And he realizes that when he was in that state, he was actually very happy.

And now we call these things—when I say now, it's been only fairly recent in the past five, maybe seven, ten years—that the whole thing about sutta jhānas has come to the fore. So the old jhāna was normally—they call them the Visuddhimagga jhāna, where you become completely absorbed and lose all touch with the surroundings. I mean, they're beautiful, they're very enjoyable, but there's no insight in it. Whereas with these sutta jhānas, they're much lighter. You can still be aware of things, but it has that quality of curiosity and so is a path to liberation. And this is what he begins to practice, and this is what he refers to when he talks about people doing jhāna practice. It's a supportive thing to your inquiry.

So it was a case of him realizing this when all the other stuff that the ascetics were practicing had failed him.

There's a distinction to be made between that and willpower. So willpower in that sense of total commitment, but it's a sort of narrow vision. And you're not aware of the mountains and the chasms that are in your way. And you keep collapsing and push and push and push. And of course, it upsets everybody around you. It's willpower business, right?

So you know from the reaction of people around you that you might be doing something which is ego-based, pride-based, rather than coming from that sense of humility and of reality—being real about oneself and real about the situation. It's a—that often happens when we're practicing and we move into over-efforting.

So that's the point where the determination, the perseverance has actually gone a bit wonky, right? Normally in meditation, if you're sitting and you do that, the meditation just collapses. You just can't do it for a while.

So when *adhiṭṭhāna*, this perseverance, this resolution is developed, there's always that clear understanding about what the goal is. There's a moral integrity about it. There's a consistency about your practice and about what you're devoted to. And there's the ability to endure, the ability to endure.

So and the Buddha reinforces this: "When a bhikkhu"—that means anybody who's listening—"has resolution, has developed it and has made it his basis"—now that's the ground of his practice, you might say—"then he obtains the destruction of the taints."

These taints, the *āśava*, they are deep-seated mental defilements. They include—well, there's four of them—just the craving, craving for existence, wanting to live, which is understandable, but it's that sort of attachment to life. Ignorance, ignorance about one's true identity. That's the basic problem. And sometimes wrong view is attached to those *āśavas*, those taints. They're also called cankers. It's a bit odd—a canker is some sort of white thing on your tongue, isn't it, that hurts? I don't know. So somebody's called them fermentations. Translators do have a good time, I think.

So finally, how do we actually develop this? So it's the small resolutions that you make that you keep that builds up the muscle of perseverance. So all of us have experienced perhaps being on retreat or on a Zoom or something and you've made a resolution that you're going to sit every morning for half an hour, 40 minutes, one hour, whatever it is. And it works for two or three days, and then it all shrinks. It becomes 25 minutes and then 20 minutes and then it just all disappears, and you wonder what's happening.

So this is a lack of that resolution, a lack of that persistence, right? That perseverance. So one reestablishes it, right? And to establish a habit, you've got to put some energy into it, some commitment, and you must do it religiously for three months. And then it becomes ingrained, right? Not to say that we don't get lazy again and we lose it and we have to start all over again.

But that's the purpose of resolutions throughout the day. Sometimes—and I've made this mistake myself—you make a resolution to help somebody, and you've done it without real reflection. So I remember once a friend of mine said he was moving into a new flat and he was gonna decorate on the weekend, and I just blurted out, "Oh, I'll come and help you." See? Well, come Saturday morning, the last thing I wanted to do was decorate his apartment. But I was good—I was very good. I determined to go and I went and helped him out for the morning anyway.

So sometimes we have to be careful what we resolve. It's a bit like being careful what you wish for.

And to praise ourselves when we've actually completed something which has taken a little bit of endurance. Often, I don't think we congratulate ourselves enough. We don't have that sort of self-love, that self-praise. There's nothing wrong with that, as long as it doesn't get into an ego and how wonderful I am. But when we complete a task, we should stop and just say, "Oh, that was good. I did good."

And in that vein, it's good to remember past times when we persevered with something and achieved something. And that builds up confidence we can do, you see.

And so to end this off, there's always these little phrases that arahats seem to say when somebody seems to say when they become fully liberated, and one of them is a lovely little thing. It just says: "What had to be done has been done." And you can imagine the relief of being able to say that, right?

So we set ourselves a task, we commit ourselves to it, we resolve to complete the task—save, you always have to have a little small print, yeah?—save in emergency or extraordinary circumstance. And you complete it and then you can say to yourself, "What had to be done has been done." And you get that sense of deep satisfaction. Yeah. Very good.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance and that by your unshakable resolve, you will attain full liberation from suffering sooner rather than later.

The Four Clingings (Upādāna)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 15 min

In this illuminating talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines upādāna, the eighth link in paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination), literally meaning the fuel that keeps active processes alive. He explores the four types of clinging that perpetuate suffering: clinging to sensual pleasures (kāmapādāna), clinging to rites and rituals (sīlabbatupādāna), clinging to views and opinions (diṭṭhupādāna), and clinging to self-view (attavādupādāna).

Bhante explains how clinging to sensual pleasure involves all six senses, including mental phenomena, and leads to constant manipulation of our environment. He discusses the supportive versus liberating aspects of ritual practices, examines how attachment to views creates polarization in politics and relationships, and reveals the root clinging to self-view from which all other clingings arise.

Drawing on core Buddhist psychology, he shares the Buddha's crucial insight that identity follows wanting, not the reverse—a understanding that creates space for choice and wisdom. Practical antidotes include vipassanā meditation to see these processes clearly, restraint and fasting from compulsive behaviors, cultivating humility regarding our views, and practicing virtues that undermine selfishness. This teaching offers both theoretical understanding and practical guidance for loosening the grip of clinging in meditation and daily life.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

So we're tackling this word *upādāna*. It's translated as clinging, sometimes grasping. It's important because it's the eighth link on dependent origination. Its literal meaning, according to the Pali dictionary, is that material substratum by means of which an active process is kept alive and going: fuel, supply, provision. In other words, its role in the psyche is the same as something like petrol or electricity in the car - it sustains the process.

So there are four of these clingings. The dharma is very good at lists, so we've got four of these. The first one won't surprise you: clinging to sensual pleasure; clinging to rites and rituals as if they were liberating; clinging to views and opinions; and finally, of course, clinging to the view of self.

If we look at the first one, most of you will know this - it's the desire for sensual pleasure. But remember that there are six senses in the Buddhist teaching, and the sixth, of course, is the mind itself. So it means all our emotions, all our thoughts, etc., which is dependent usually on some physical base.

The problem is that, of course, when we're driven by this desire, it's never fulfilling. As soon as we are fulfilled, we rest for a little while and then we want some more. And it leads us to manipulating the world we're living in to make it fit into me. So we're constantly having this little strife or struggle, sometimes quite minor - little irritations and things like that - and sometimes pretty major. But anything that arises out of that desire to seek happiness in pleasures, in the six sensual pleasures, is obviously going to lead to some level of unsatisfactoriness.

So how do we tackle that? Well, we know it's through *vipassanā*, to see it clearly, to see that process clearly is the first understanding. And then, of course, there's the practice of not indulging it. So if we can make a distinction here: when we eat toast, it makes us happy. But if we eat toast in order to make us happy, there's going to be a problem. That's the one we don't want.

And the other thing that the Buddha uses is restraint. He's big on restraint. So in other words, whenever we feel that compulsive nature over something, doesn't matter what it is - toast, cup of tea - to just hold back and let go of it. Wait for that energy to give way. And if possible, do without it. It's like when you walk on the street and you come across a cafe and the coffee hooks your nose and reels you in - it's resisting that and just walking steadfastly past that cafe, at least until the next one! But it's really restraining everything which is becoming obsessional.

And don't forget fasting. So fasting isn't only not eating if it's become obsessional. It's all the social media, the news, the videos, the shopping, etc. Anything that becomes compulsive, we stop for a while just to let go of it. When we come on retreat, the first three days are always difficult, and one of the things that makes the first three days really difficult is the change of habits - drinking, getting up at a different hour, not eating at the same time. All these things are irritating. We don't like to change our habits. So that's the first clinging: clinging to sensual pleasure.

The next one is clinging to rites and rituals as a religious practice. Now, some of it is very supportive, for instance, bowing. So bowing can be an expression of surrender, of gratitude, of a sense of offering, like you're offering your day for the benefit of others. And it can be a sense of awe - when you bring the profundity of the Buddha's teachings to mind and say, "How did he do it?"

Lighting a candle - that can remind us of the three paths within the Eightfold Path. So the light is the path of insight, the warmth the path of love, and the action of the flame the path of wholesome works. And it's important to recite the refuges and precepts every morning, because that just reminds you what your life is about. Ultimately, it gives it that deeper meaning.

Chanting, beading, it's all good to keep the mind steady, to stop it wandering all over the place. And of course, taking refuges and precepts as a public declaration is where you're committing yourself to the path and has a real strengthening effect. It doesn't mean to say that you might not become a Muslim later on. It's just that at this present moment, you're devoted to this particular teaching.

So all these practices - actually, it's like sealing a particular relationship with the public rite of marriage. There's the christening or the naming ceremony. And there's burials. These are all rituals and very meaningful. But in themselves, unfortunately, they don't lead to liberation.

Number three. Well, this is a big one: clinging to views and opinions. I mean, our whole politics has now become polarising because of people clinging to their views and opinions. And what happens is that you forget about the issue and you start to attack the person. These arguments are called *ad hominem*: *argumentum ad hominem*. There's a bit of Latin there, which means that the argument, the speaker attacks the character, the motive, some other attribute of the person who's making the argument, forgetting the issue. As long as they can humiliate the other, they've won the argument.

And interestingly enough, the Buddha actually in very early strata of the discourses tells his monks and nuns not to get involved in these open debates. So you just come away either with a big ego or you just come away humiliated.

Just on my own reflection, right up until I think Thatcher came in, politics tended to still be gentlemanly. It's still patriarchal, so gentlemanly. But then the names came out - they started calling conservatives who didn't follow her way "the wets," if you remember. People who were unemployed became "scroungers." And so the whole thing began to get quite ugly, really.

There was Cameron making fun of Farage's name, his poncy foreign-sounding pronunciation. And recently Polanski was made fun of because of his teeth. Of course, Trump is a master of it. I mean, once he said "Sleepy Joe," really that was the end of it, I think. So it's drawing politics down to this really ugly level of just trying to destroy the person. And of course it's all over - I've just mentioned things like that in the UK, but everywhere you go this is what's happening.

So the antidote, of course, is a little bit of humility, really - to realise that whatever view I have, I can't grasp the whole situation, the whole matrix that the problem is in, and that I need other people's perspective. And the wider my perspective is, the more I can say, "Well, I'm getting close to understanding the situation."

And sometimes people think that this teaching tells you not to have a view. Well, remember, the Buddha had a view. He had right view. So we can have views - it's just the way we relate to them in terms of identity: I am right, everybody else is wrong; I'm a lefty; I'm a right-winger, and so on and so forth. And there's no need for it. If we come down to just looking at the issues and asking, "Well, what can we do here?" - it's as simple as that - "What can be done?" So this is a big problem, this polarisation. And it's all this clinging to my view.

The final one, of course, is clinging to the view of self. And this is the root clinging. From this clinging, all clinging clings. And the problem with the self is it only sees the sensual world, and it only sees the sensual world as a place where it can make itself happy.

So you can't blame yourself for wanting to be happy in the sensual world. And what it does - it obviously collects a lot of stuff to feel safer: more money in the bank, etc. But then that acquisitiveness has to be guarded, and therefore you're always on the lookout for danger: governments, people like that to take all your money away. And then of course, if they're bigger than you like governments, you tend to hide.

So you've got this basic triangle - this three-pronged movement into daily life of assertiveness, aversion, and fear. And from that, all the problems arise.

So how do we undermine that? Well, obviously again it's *vipassanā*. And I want to point you to this place that we get to sometimes when everything is calm, the mind is still, everything's calm, and you become very much aware of being the observer, the feeler, the experiencer, the knower, the witness - it doesn't matter what you call it. But it's beginning to understand that whatever is perceiving cannot be what is perceived.

So when I look at the shed that's in my garden here, I can't be the shed. So when I go inwards and I perceive a pain, I can't be it. It's an object of my perceiving. And it's making that more and more clear to ourselves that begins to undermine that sense of self.

And we can also undermine it by just practising virtues. Anything that undermines that sense of ego, a sense of selfishness - generosity, love, compassion, sympathetic joy and so on. All these - when we are practising virtues, we must be undermining the sense of self. Simple as that.

And finally, just this core insight that the Buddha gives us about the self. He saw clearly that the identity comes after the wanting. And it's language that fools us. I say, "I want a coffee." So the "I" comes first and then the want and then the coffee. But psychologically, it's coffee, want, I. And this allows us to just distance from the want. We can actually see the wanting as an object, some feeling within us. And it gives us just one moment of choice. It's the only moment we have of choice.

Now, this isn't some airy-fairy free will. This choice is conditioned. It's conditioned by wisdom or lack of it. And what we want to know is, well, how does wisdom grow? Well, it's the very suffering that's being caused that makes us seek the end of suffering, which guides us towards wisdom. And that's how it works. Now this is a really amazing insight that the Buddha had into our psychology.

So there we have it: these four clingings. Clinging to sensual pleasure; clinging to rites and rituals as if they were enough to make us liberated; clinging to views and opinions, the conceit of "I am," "I am right"; and finally, this clinging to the sense of self. And that one, of course, is the most difficult and the final clinging to be unclung. I'm getting very good with the word "cling."

So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance and that by your unclinging, you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

The Buddha's Use of Similes

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 20 min

In this illuminating talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's masterful use of similes throughout the Pāli Canon, demonstrating how these vivid metaphors make complex teachings accessible and experientially meaningful. Drawing on insights from neuroscience about left and right brain functions, Bhante explains why the Buddha intuited that imagery and metaphor often communicate what straightforward logical explanation cannot.

The talk explores several famous similes from the suttas: the Simile of the Saw (Kakacūpama Sutta), teaching boundless patience even under extreme provocation; the Simile of the Raft, illustrating that the Dhamma itself is a means to liberation rather than something to cling to; and the Fire Simile used with Vacchagotta to point toward Nibbāna as beyond all conceptualization. Bhante offers important context about ancient Indian understanding of elements, clarifying that the fire simile does not suggest annihilation but rather points to something beyond description.

Particularly poignant are the Buddha's Victory Verses (Dhammapada 153-154) about the 'house builder' representing the delusion of self, and the Simile of the Blind Turtle, conveying the extraordinary rarity and preciousness of human birth. Bhante emphasizes that human existence uniquely combines sufficient joy and woe with the awareness needed for investigation into the three characteristics—the very process of liberation. These teachings remind practitioners of the urgent opportunity present in this life to pursue Awakening with diligence.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Awakened.

I thought we'd spend at least an occasional meeting on the scriptures themselves, and to start with, I'd like to look at the way the Buddha constantly uses similes. The discourses are just full of them, cleverly used to make us understand things from a slightly more experiential point of view.

By the way, I only learned today what a blue moon was. I knew the phrase "once in a blue moon," meaning it's virtually impossible, but I didn't realise it actually meant when you get a second full moon in a solar month. It seems to have arisen from white American folklore. Anyway, that aside.

Those of you who've read this masterwork by Iain McGilchrist, *The Master and His Emissary*, about left brain and right brain, will know that the left brain is associated with logical, analytical, linear, verbal, factual and sequential thinking, and that the right brain is linked with creative, intuitive, artistic, non-verbal, emotional and imaginative abilities. Actually, according to McGilchrist, these two sides work very well together. The one needs the other, but really the right brain should be in charge — that's what he's saying. In our culture, it's all left brain stuff, very linear, and so forth.

The Buddha intuited that. I'm sure he didn't know the psychology in the same way that Iain McGilchrist knew, but he definitely intuited that people understand by way of simile, imagery, and metaphor what might be difficult to understand as just a straightforward logical explanation. We call these similes *upāya*, skilful means. I've just chosen some, and most of them I think you will know. They're very famous.

First of all, how much patience, how much forbearance should we have? This is talking about right speech. There are five aspects of speech by which others may address you: timely or untimely, true or false, affectionate or harsh, beneficial or unbeneficial, with a mind of goodwill or with a mind of hate. In any event, you should train yourselves: our minds will not be affected, and we will say no evil words. We will remain sympathetic to that person's welfare, with a mind of goodwill and with no inner hate. We will keep pervading them with an awareness imbued with goodwill, and beginning with them, we will keep pervading the all-encompassing world with an awareness imbued with goodwill, equal to a cat-skin bag — abundant, expansive, immeasurable, free from hostility, free from ill will. That's how you should train yourself.

A cat-skin bag, I presume, is made from cat skins. He's saying that we should develop this affectionate awareness no matter what, even when somebody says very rude, very harsh things, silly things to us.

But now he reinforces it. How patient should we be? How forbearing should we be? This is a very famous simile. "Monks, even if bandits were to carve you up savagely, limb by limb, with a two-handled saw, he among you who let his heart get angered even at that would not be doing my bidding, would not be following my teachings. Monks, if you attend constantly to this admonition on the simile of the saw, do you see any aspects of speech, slight or gross, that you could not endure?" "No, Lord." "Then attend constantly to this admonition on the simile of the saw. That will be for your long-term welfare and happiness." This is what the Blessed One said, and gratified, the monks delighted in the Blessed One's words.

So there we have it. I once read this out in a talk and somebody said, "Well, the Buddha had a great sense of humour." But I think he's actually telling us that there's no end to patience. That's it. And that anger has no place anywhere.

Then there's a famous one about the end of training, or what's the training for? Here we have the simile of the raft. He puts this training in perspective to the goal, which is of course liberation. "Supposing there was a person travelling along the road. They'd see a large deluge whose near shore was dubious and perilous, while the far shore was a sanctuary, free of peril. But there was no ferryboat or bridge for crossing over. They'd think, 'Why don't I gather grass, sticks, branches and leaves and make a raft? Riding on the raft and paddling with my hands and feet, I will safely reach the far shore.' And so they would do exactly that. When they'd crossed over to the far shore, they'd think, 'This raft has been very helpful to me. Riding on the raft and paddling with my hands and feet, I have safely crossed over to the other shore. Why don't I hoist it on my head or pick it up on my shoulder and go wherever I want?' What do you think, mendicants? Would that person be doing what should be done with that raft?" "No, sir." "And what, mendicants, should that person do with a raft? When they've crossed over, they should think, 'This raft has been very helpful to me. Why don't I beach it on the dry land or set it adrift in the water and go wherever I want?' That's what a person should do with a raft. In the same way, I have taught how the teaching is similar to a raft: it's for crossing over, not for holding on to. By understanding the simile of the raft, you will even give up the teachings, let alone what is against the teachings."

I think we have to be slightly careful here. What he's saying is that once we are completely liberated, we don't actually need to remind ourselves about the training, because it has become imbued in ourselves. In another discourse, he's asked whether he actually thinks about what he's going to say when he's teaching the *Dhamma*, or whether it comes to him spontaneously. His reply is again another simile. He says, "What about a very highly skilled chariot maker? Do they think about what they're doing, or do they just make the chariot? Because they just have that know-how, that physical know-how." And he says, "Well, it's like that with me. Whenever I talk about the Dhamma, it comes out spontaneously."

Then we have: what is *Nibbāna*? It is simply beyond words, concepts, images — getting across something that is inexplicable. Here the Buddha uses this famous, very well-known metaphor of the fire. There are, I think, three discourses where he's talking to a person called Vacchagotta. Vacchagotta is, shall we say, very sceptical, and he doesn't really get it often. There was once when he asked the Buddha, "Look, is there a self or is there not a self?" And the Buddha wouldn't answer. He was very quiet, you see. Vac-

chagotta leaves with a click of his tongue, fed up. Ānanda asked the Buddha why he didn't answer, and one of the reasons is that if he had said that there was a self or that there wasn't a self, it would just make Vacchagotta's confusion even greater.

Here he's again talking to Vacchagotta, trying to explain what Nibbāna is. He says, "What do you think, Vaccha? Suppose a fire was burning in front of you. Would you know this fire is burning in front of me?" "Yes, I would, worthy Gotama." "But Vaccha, supposing they were to ask you, 'This fire burning in front of you, what does it depend on to burn?' How would you answer?" "I would answer like this: this fire burning in front of me burns in dependence on grass and logs as fuel." "Suppose that fire burning in front of you was extinguished. Would you know it was extinguished, that it was quenched?" "Yes, I would, worthy Gotama." "But Vaccha, supposing they were to ask you, 'This fire in front of you that is quenched, in what direction did it go? East, south, west, north?' How would you answer?" "It doesn't apply, worthy Gotama. The fire, dependent on grass and logs as fuel, when that runs out and no more fuel is added, the fire is reckoned to have been quenched for lack of fuel." "In the same way, Vaccha, any form by which a realised one might be described has been given up, cut off at the root, made like a palm stump, obliterated and unable to rise in the future."

Now unfortunately, this has often been used as a way of saying that the Buddha is just talking about annihilation, complete extinction. But in fact, that doesn't take into consideration — which has only come out fairly recently, within the last twenty or so years — the science of the time. The fire element, like the earth element and the water element and the wind element, are all around us. They're there as latent possibilities. Given the right occasion, the element of fire will come down and grasp the object. That's why it's a simile for grasping. It's not as though, the way we think of the log catching fire, there's something in the log that happens. You might say that the oxygen in the air grasps the log, something like that. We have this element of fire everywhere, the element of heat. Given certain circumstances, it will congregate around a particular object, a log, and in so doing it will consume it. Once it's consumed, it's not as though the fire is extinguished and gone completely — it goes back into its latent form, and then it can't be described. You don't know where it is; it's just around you, you might say. This is the way the Buddha tries to explain that Nibbāna is simply beyond any conceiving, any imagination, anything like that. It's just beyond it.

Now we come to another great simile, the simile of the house builder. This of course is his victory verses. They come from the *Dhammapada*, numbers 153 and 154. "Oh, how many a birth in *saṃsāra* have I wandered in vain, seeking the builder of this house. Repeated birth is indeed suffering. Oh house builder, you are seen! You will not build this house again. Your rafters are broken, your ridge pole is shattered. My mind

has reached the unconditioned; I have attained the destruction of craving." This house builder, of course, is the self — this delusion of the self — and he's actually found the core of it.

Then there's another discourse where he uses the same imagery. This comes from a whole group of discourses known as the *Opamma Sutta*, the suttas on similes, devoted to discourses given with similes. It's in the *Samyutta Nikāya*, the Connected Discourses. Number one reads like this: "So have I heard. At one time the Buddha was staying at Sāvattthī in Jeta's Grove, Anāthapiṇḍika's monastery. There the Buddha said, 'Mendicants, the rafters of a bungalow all lean to the peak and meet at the peak. When the peak is demolished, they're all demolished too. In the same way, all unskilful qualities are rooted in ignorance and meet in ignorance. When ignorance is demolished, they're all demolished too. So you should train yourself like this: we will stay diligent. That's how you should train yourself.'"

Here again we have a very obvious little simile about the houses they built. Most of them were just single stories, of course. There was a presumption that you'd be very rich if you had a two-storey house, so they were all bungalows. The ridge pole is the one right at the top of the roof. If the roof collapses, that's real bad news for the house, because especially in the rainy season, you're going to be washed out. Here again he uses this peak, this ridge pole, to point to this essential delusion of ignorance, which is the self. When that goes, everything that has been created by the self is also demolished. You can't do anything unwholesome again, because the root cause of the unwholesome is this delusion of being a self.

What do we mean by being a self? Reminding ourselves: we mean that we think, we believe, we experience ourselves to be this human being as such, and this human being is seeking happiness. But it does so through the sensual pleasures that the body offers and the mind offers and the heart offers, and that's the problem. When the self goes, all the unwholesome stuff that's dependent on that also disappears, but you still keep living. The Buddha said the only thing that goes is this essential delusion, greed, acquisitiveness, and aversion — aversion meaning both aversion and fear.

As a final one, the preciousness of human birth. This again is number two within this collection of similes. "Then the Buddha, picking up a little dirt in his fingernail, addressed the mendicants. 'What do you think, mendicants? Which is more: this little bit of dirt on my fingernail, or this great earth?' 'Sir, the great earth is far more. A little bit of dirt on your fingernail is tiny compared to the great earth. It doesn't count. There's

no comparison. It's not worth a fraction.' 'In the same way, the sentient beings reborn as humans are few, while those not reborn as humans are many. So you should train yourself thus: we will remain diligent. That's how you should train yourself.'"

This is supported by another very famous one about the turtle, the blind turtle. This also comes from the Connected Sayings. "Monks, suppose this great earth were totally covered with water, and a man were to toss a yoke with a single hole there. A wind from the east would push it to the west. A wind from the west would push it to the east. A wind from the north would push it to the south. A wind from the south would push it to the north. And suppose a blind turtle were there. It would come to the surface once every hundred years. What do you think? Would that blind turtle, coming to the surface once every hundred years, stick his neck into the yoke with a single hole?" "It would be sheer coincidence, Lord, that the blind sea turtle, coming to the surface once every hundred years, would stick his neck into the yoke with a single hole." "It's likewise a sheer coincidence that one obtains the human state. It's likewise sheer coincidence that a *Tathāgata*, worthy and rightly self-awakened, arises in the world. It is likewise sheer coincidence that the *Dhamma* and the *Vinaya* expounded by the Tathāgata appears in the world. Now this human state has been attained. A Tathāgata, worthy and rightly self-awakened, has arisen in the world. A Dhamma and a Vinaya expounded by the Tathāgata appears in the world. Therefore, your duty is to contemplate: this is suffering, this is the origin of suffering, this is the cessation of suffering, this is the path of practice leading to the cessation of suffering."

Here we have this idea of coincidence. We can begin to understand that when we realise that every moment is this meeting of all of our past causes with present conditions. These past causes are coming, they hit the present conditions, so we never know exactly what's going to happen moment after moment. When we live like this, in a country which is fairly peaceful, we can normally predict that we're going to wake up tomorrow. But not if you're in Ukraine, or if you're in Lebanon, or even Gaza. There's a sense of unknowability, of sheer coincidence. This is how he gets across to us the sheer fortunate birth of being born as a human being.

Why is it that as human beings, this is the best place to be to become liberated? Because there is this joy and woe, and there is this awakenedness, this intuitive awareness developed enough to investigate. It's that process of investigation into the three characteristics of existence which is the process of liberation.

There we are. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, and that by — in the words of the Buddha — our diligence, we will become fully liberated sooner rather than later.

Restraint (Saṃvara)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 19 min

In this practical teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines saṃvara (restraint) as an essential Buddhist practice for regaining control over habits and desires that diminish our well-being. He begins by tracing the root of our difficulties to the constructed self and its relationship with the six sense bases, explaining how attachment to pleasures—from scrolling social media to intimate relationships—inevitably leads to dukkha (unsatisfactoriness).

Bhante discusses how lost agency manifests in our lives: knowing a habit is harmful yet finding ourselves caught in it despite our best intentions. He presents the Buddha's teaching on Right Effort from the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta, which provides the framework for understanding restraint—generating enthusiasm to prevent unskillful qualities from arising, abandoning those that have arisen, cultivating skillful qualities, and maintaining them.

Three approaches to restraint are explored: ethical restraint based on recognizing harm to ourselves and others; mindful restraint where awareness of guilt or discomfort becomes a guardian warning us of unskillful behaviour; and wisdom-based restraint arising from direct experience of the unwholesome qualities of indulgence. Bhante emphasizes that restraint is not suppression—holding back with annoyance or self-hatred—but a patient waiting for desires to pass, like waiting for cars before crossing a road.

The talk concludes with a guided practice using Saint Augustine's four-step method: Can, Ought, Want, Will. This technique helps practitioners move from recognizing capability through accepting responsibility to genuine desire and finally firm resolution. Bhante notes this practice applies equally to abandoning unwholesome habits and cultivating virtues, offering a practical tool for daily life and formal meditation.

The topic for this month is restraint. I've written something, so I'll talk to what I've written. It's a bit more organised.

The Buddha is very big on restraint, *saṃvara*, and we need to know why. We need to see how it affects our sense of agency and our self-worth. A sense of agency means control — your control over your life. Now, whenever I reflect on the Dharma and practice, I always go back to the starting point, where all the miseries have their root. And that, of course, is the self.

This self is a relationship. It's a relationship with the world we find ourselves in, and that world is the world of the six senses. Remember, the Buddha describes consciousness by the sense base: eye consciousness, ear consciousness. And don't forget, the mind is also understood as a sense base. That's the world we seek happiness in. Not that there isn't any happiness there — it's just that we can't maintain it. We can't trap it, simply because everything arises and passes away.

Now, we know all this. We know it through our readings and listenings, and we know it through the practice of *vipassanā*, where we try not to get caught up in the fantasies and the stories we tell ourselves. We know that attachments and indulgence to anything we enjoy — from lollipops to intimate relations — will cause some degree of suffering or unsatisfactoriness. Yet we persist. We persist because the desires have a hold on us, and there's often also the fear that we will lose some level of happiness if we let go of what gives us happiness.

So let us first contemplate the loss of agency. This means we've lost control over some part of our lives. The desire takes over. Even when we make strong acts of will — "I will not scroll" — in a moment of inattention, there we are scrolling. And even when we're doom-scrolling and we know it's cultivating despair, yet we scroll. This used to be called a lack of self-discipline, but these days nobody wants to hear about discipline. It seems to have gone out of our education system. When was the last time you ever heard the words "have some self-discipline"? There is a connotation in the word of punishment, of course, but the original meaning comes from the word learning — a disciple. And to learn, we need to put our minds to it. We need to have self-discipline.

So here we have a situation where the ardent meditator knows they need to give up late nights to rise early and practice before setting off to work. Yet for all the determination, they still get caught up in social media and Netflix. What they're actually doing may be wholesome, but it means they miss out on this morning practice, which they give a lot of importance to. Something has to give, and that is the role of restraint.

How does it feel when, after all your effort, you don't seem to be able to get rid of a habit that you know is harmful to you — and may be harmful to another? Anger is often a good candidate. It comes out as sarcasm, spite, outright rage, clever digs that spike and wound. Turned inward, it beats you up, despises you, and hammers home how worthless you are. Here we need that alert awareness, mindfulness, that senses when the triggers come — and not indulge in the rising anger, but actually mentally park it. We're not suppressing it, but putting it to one side, and then raising goodwill, laying it over. When we turn inwards afterwards, at some later time, we can embrace it with a sense of care and just allow it to manifest. Some part of the heart is diseased.

Now, here's the Buddha's description of right effort. It's when a mendicant generates enthusiasm, tries, makes an effort, exerts the mind, and strives so that immoral, unskillful qualities don't arise. They generate enthusiasm, try, make an effort, exert the mind, and strive so that immoral, unskillful qualities that have arisen are given up. That's the bad side. The good side is obviously balancing it. They generate enthusiasm, try, make an effort, exert the mind, and strive so that skillful qualities that have not arisen do so. And they generate enthusiasm, try, make an effort, exert the mind, and strive so that skillful qualities that have arisen are not lost, but increase, mature, and are fulfilled by development. This is called right effort. You'll also see that in the discourse on how to establish mindfulness.

So here we have four ways through which the Buddha asks us to exercise restraint, and from which we get the purpose for our restraint. The first is the way of morality and ethics. If what we're doing is harmful — harmful to ourselves or others, or both — then obviously we should restrain ourselves. It may be that someone has decided to become a vegetarian or vegan on moral rather than health grounds. Now they have a connection with the suffering of farm animals. Because of past habit, they may find themselves buying fish and chips — that iconic British meal. Fish often don't quite make it into the definition of sentient beings. As a monk in Sri Lanka once quipped, fish are considered "self-propelling animated vegetables." I've heard people say they can't feel pain because they're cold-blooded — such as when our fingers freeze, we don't feel anything.

Accepting that fish are sentient beings, that person may feel guilty while they're eating, and they avoid the feeling by eating more quickly, stuffing themselves.

The second restraint is by way of mindfulness. While eating the fish, such a person who's practised vipassanā will become more acutely aware of any feelings of guilt or remorse — so much so that it almost spoils the pleasure. This is where guilt has become a guardian, a warner of such behaviour. Where there's unskillful action, there will also follow unwholesome consequences. Allied to this is the awareness of the six sense bases. In hot weather, the shapely bodies of women and men come into view, and upon seeing, erotic feelings may arise. This is natural in the sense that it has a biological conditioning. But then, do we turn away and refuse to indulge, or do we linger and develop lust? Lust can become obsessive, but even at a low level, left ungratified, lust leaves a feeling of discomfort and discomposure. That feeling, recognising it, encourages us to restrain ourselves.

Such practice is a direct way of understanding the second noble truth, the cause of suffering: "The noble truth of the cause of suffering, O monks, is this. It is the craving which produces rebecoming, rebirth, accompanied by passionate greed and finding fresh delight now here, now there — namely, craving for sense pleasures, craving for becoming, craving for non-becoming, not wanting stuff." And it fulfils one of the right intentions — I prefer "right attitudes" — of the second step of the Noble Eightfold Path, namely renunciation, which is gently pulling ourselves away from indulgence and attachments. You could argue that renunciation is the whole of the spiritual path.

Finally, it is the understanding of the direct experience in our sitting and ordinary daily life of the unwholesome qualities of indulgence and attachment that develops the wisdom to practise restraint. *Samvara* is the spiritual exercise of refraining from fulfilling desires that we perceive to be harmful. There's a holding back of that energy. But as always, if done with annoyance or self-hatred, self-accusation, that would be just suppressing it, not transforming it. Moreover, any annoyance and self-hatred will simply reinforce those attitudes. Instead, we wait for it to pass — as when we wait to cross the road, waiting for cars to pass. This allows the fuel of the desire to be expended, the habit to be weakened. And the more we do this, just like any exercise, it becomes easier.

The more we resist temptations, the better we feel about ourselves, simply because we've taken back control. The more we feel in charge of our lives, the more we follow the ways of skillful actions, the more we feel happy about ourselves. The more we feel satisfied and contented with ourselves, the more our self-worth grows. And self-worth is that deep inner feeling and knowing of one's own goodness.

One way to develop strong resolution is to fast. You'll find some kind of fasting in most religions, such as Lent for Christians and Ramadan for Muslims. In the Buddhist teaching, it's included when a lay person takes the eight precepts and undertakes not to eat after midday. Now, this is not to be confused with dieting for health's sake, or fasting as a practice of self-mortification, beating oneself up. Rather, it is to become aware of any attachment we have to eating and drinking. Feelings of hunger are one thing, but the inability to stop ourselves from immediately reacting — hence constant snacking — is another. In my own case, giving up a cup of tea in the morning requires total commitment.

There's also a practice that was developed by Saint Augustine. In his autobiography, he tells us that as a young man, he had difficulty restraining his lust and prayed, "Give me chastity and continence, O Lord, but not yet." That's an honest confession.

Now, there are four parts to this, and some of you who have been on retreat with me will know them: can, ought, want, and will. We might sometimes fool ourselves and say that we cannot give up tea and coffee, but when we look a bit closer, there's usually a "won't." The first step is to speak gently into our hearts, directly into ourselves: "I can." I can refrain from drinking too much tea, for my own benefit and the benefit of others. And you've got to wait. You've got to keep repeating that — "I can, I can, I can do it" — especially if there's a "won't" in the way. You keep saying that until you feel it's digested. There is definitely a knowing that one can give up tea.

Then we have to accept full responsibility. That's the next step: "I ought to." For my own benefit and the benefit of others. Once that's taken on — again, you have to feel a bit of digestion there, a bit of acceptance — once that's done, it's normally not so difficult to get that want. "Yes, I want to do it. This is what I really want to do. It's for my own benefit, the benefit of others." And then finally, of course, that strong, determined act of will: "I will. I will do it." When the occasion arises, will. And of course, you can practise this with virtue as well. Can, ought, want, will.

I personally find this best done right in the morning. And if I want to get up when the bell goes, I do it before I go to sleep: "I can get up when the alarm goes." I think you'll find it really effective in everyday practice.

So what I'd like to do now is to actually do this practice and then just slide into the meditation. Find yourself in a nice meditative posture. We can either say "I can refrain from" or "I resist the temptation to" — whatever works for you. What you've got to choose is some habit that you have which you'd like to be rid of, or at least let it have less hold on you. Something like that. Once you've chosen it, very gently repeat into your heart: "I can. I can refrain from this, for my own benefit and the benefit of others."

When you're doing this by yourself, you can obviously take a bit more time if this isn't enough. But once you can get that feeling that you can, you can resist the temptation, then we go on to the next one: "I ought to. I ought to do it, for my own benefit and the benefit of others." Once that's been developed within us to a point where we really take on that responsibility, then we can move into cajoling the heart: "Yes, I want to. I want to refrain." And then, as you feel that this has now really built up, we make that act of will: "I will refrain." You can add "when the situation comes" — it doesn't really matter — but just getting that commitment.

Although this talk has been about refraining from something which is unwholesome, we can, just to finish off, use these steps in order to develop a virtue. In the same way, we develop a virtue that we'd like to develop more: "I can develop this virtue, for my own benefit and the benefit of others. I ought to. I want to." And finally, "I will."

And so we can begin our period of meditation.

The Kālāma Discourse

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 15 min

In this illuminating talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Kālāma Sutta (AN 3.65), often misunderstood as a blanket endorsement of 'believe what you want.' He clarifies that the Buddha's teaching actually offers a method for careful investigation rather than unlimited freedom of belief.

The discourse arose when the Buddha visited Kesaputta, where the Kālāmas were bewildered by competing teachers each claiming exclusive truth. Rather than adding another dogmatic voice, the Buddha gave them criteria for discernment: don't rely merely on repeated hearing, tradition, rumour, scripture, speculation, seeming logic, pondered notions, another's apparent ability, or even the authority of a respected teacher. Instead, investigate for yourselves whether actions lead to harm or benefit.

Bhante contextualizes this within the Kālāmas' genuine concern about kamma and rebirth, explaining how the Buddha addressed their existential anxiety through four consolations covering every possibility—whether or not there is an afterlife, whether or not evil deeds bring consequences. He then guided them in the practice of mettā, karuṇā, muditā, and upekkhā (the brahmavihāras) as a means to cultivate a good heart.

The talk highlights the Buddha's remarkable skill as a teacher—meeting people where they are, building confidence through dialogue before introducing deeper teachings like the Four Noble Truths and the Eightfold Path. Bhante emphasizes that inner happiness through moral integrity surpasses momentary pleasures gained through delusion, hatred, and greed.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble, and Fully Self-Awakened One.

So this evening we were going to look at the Kālāma Discourse, the one that concerns the Buddha's visit to Kesaputta. It looks like this was his first visit because when he gets there, the Kālāmas are all confused and bewildered because teachers have been saying that they've got the answer and everybody else is wrong. It's the usual thing of "I'm right and everybody else is wrong." "There are some monks and brahmins, Venerable Sir, who visit Kesaputta. They expound and explain their own doctrine. The doctrines of others they despise, revile, and pull to pieces. Venerable Sir, there is doubt, there is uncertainty in us concerning them. Which of these venerable monks and brahmins spoke the truth, and which falsehood?"

Now, we don't really realise what the problem is until we get towards the end of the discourse. To make this more plain to us, what they're concerned with is the fact that they are worried about *kamma* and rebirth. Remember, in those days that was a given for the vast majority. There were materialists who thought you disappeared when you died, but most believed that there was a rebirth, and there was confusion as to what actually caused you to get a rebirth in one of the realms. So you could be born in the violent realm of the angry gods, or the hungry ghost realm, always longing but never satisfied. You could be born as a dull-minded animal, a chattel on somebody's farm. You could, of course, end up being a denizen of hell, which is constant pain and suffering.

Just as an aside, this sort of existential fear was expressed by the Greeks as fate, by which they meant that these gods they believed in were just doing whatever they wanted to do, no matter what happened to human beings. So they would lose their personal agency in this chaotic world of earthquakes and big storms and so on. In the medieval period, the horror was of course to go to hell, and the Catholic Church softened it by creating a purgatory, so that only those who were really, really naughty ended up in eternal hell, and the rest could go to purgatory for a while, be cleansed, and then shoot off to heaven. And of course today, because if you are an annihilist, if you're a scientific materialist, you're looking into nothingness. This is explored especially by the philosopher Nietzsche and then Heidegger, and what Nietzsche talked about was the abyss. He obviously came close to what it means to become nothing at all, to die, finish, which is the death of self. There's another very famous philosopher called Nishitani, who had studied with people like Heidegger, and then went through his Zen practice and realised that this abyss was actually the loss of the self. And that once you leaped over that, you found what we would call *anattā*.

Okay, so back to the Kālāmas. Now, he doesn't fall—the Buddha doesn't fall into the trap of trying to convince them. This is the point. He rather tries to give them ways and means by which they can find out for themselves whether something is true or not. He gives them a method by which they can find a way out of their doubt, out of their confusion. First of all, he tells them what they should not do, then what they should do, and finally how to develop further qualities that would lead to a happy realm and a happy life here and now.

So this is where he makes this very famous statement, which is often understood to be a declaration of "believe what you want," freedom of belief, but it's not. It's a freedom to investigate, a freedom to question. "It is proper for you, Kālāmas, to doubt, to be uncertain. Uncertainty has arisen in you about what is doubtful. Come, Kālāmas, do not go upon what has been acquired by repeated hearing." I mean, consider how Trump lies and lies and lies and then somebody actually believes him. "Nor upon tradition, nor

upon rumour"—rumour would be, social media, stuff coming through social media. "Nor upon a scripture, nor upon surmise"—just an opinion, a guess, but you don't have the proper evidence. And that means that sometimes you don't have to come to a conclusion. "Nor upon an axiom"—just because something is universally accepted doesn't mean it's true. "Nor upon specious reasoning"—clever, clever, clever reasoning that confuses you. "Nor upon a bias towards a notion that has been pondered on"—this is what we get with information silos. "Nor upon another's seeming ability, nor upon a consideration, 'This monk is our teacher,' Kālāmas." In other words, even somebody whom you really, really trust, whatever they say, you still have to question. "And then you would know for yourselves," he said. "These things are immoral, these things are blameable, these things are censured by the wise, undertaken and observed these things lead to harm and to ill—so abandon them."

So in other words, completely against anything like blind faith. Again, he's not asking them to dismiss all teaching. He's asking them to be pragmatic, to have a hands-on investigation. Obviously he'd be very much against the postmodern idea that every opinion is equally true, that you create your own reality, and all that—being selective about what you can and what you can't believe. And that's as though the spiritual path is some sort of smorgasbord and you can take what you want. And of course, Western Buddhists often tend to do that. They'll accept some of what's in the scriptures, but not all of it, such as rebirth.

So now the test for rebirth. And this was generally accepted at the time. Remember, there were the Jains and other sects who understood that there was some connection between your ethical behaviour and where you took rebirth. So he asks them: "Come, when you yourselves know these things are bad, these things are blameable, these things are censured by the wise, undertaken and observed these things lead to harm and ill—abandon them." And of course, he says the opposite for what is good.

And then he continues this sort of Socratic dialogue. "What do you think, Kālāmas? Does greed manifest in someone for their benefit or harm?" "For their harm, Venerable Sir." "Kālāmas, being given to greed, being overwhelmed and vanquished mentally by greed, such a person takes life, steals, commits adultery, and tells lies, and they prompt others to do so likewise. Will that not eventually be harmful and damaging for them?" "Yes, Venerable Sir." And of course he says the same for hatred and delusion.

And then he asks: "What do you think? Are these things good or bad?" "Bad, Venerable Sir." "Blameable or not blameable?" "Blameable, Venerable Sir." "Censured or praised by the wise?" "Censured, Venerable Sir." "Undertaken and observed, do these

things lead to harm and ill, or not? How does it strike you?" "Undertaken and observed, these things lead to harm and ill. That's clear to us." And of course the same is true for what is beneficial, the opposite.

And he simply uses the negative to point to what is positive. "What do you think, Kālāmas? Does absence of greed manifest in someone for their benefit or harm?" "For their benefit, Venerable Sir." And so he goes on through hatred and delusion.

So then, having got them to that stage, he opens up to a practice of *mettā*. "The disciples of the Noble Ones, Kālāmas, who in this way is devoid of coveting, devoid of ill will, undeluded, clearly comprehending and mindful, dwells pervading one quarter with the thought of love, likewise the second, likewise the third, likewise the fourth. So above and below and across, he dwells encompassing all sentient beings everywhere in the entire cosmos with the abundant, exalted, boundless thought of love that is free of hatred and malice." And then of course he says the same for compassion, joy, and equanimity or peacefulness.

So here he's now given them a way in which they can develop a good heart, so that upon death they can presume to be born into a happy realm. Their fundamental problem, of course, is kamma and rebirth. And here he gives them, rather cleverly I think, four consolations or assurances, and he covers every angle.

"Suppose there is a hereafter and there is a fruit, result of deeds done well or ill. Then it is possible that at the dissolution of the body after death, I shall arise in a heavenly world which is possessed of the state of bliss." So if kamma is correct and there is fruit, then upon death I'll end up in a heavenly realm. This, he says, is your first consolation, your first assurance.

"Supposing there is no hereafter and there's no fruit, no result of deeds done well or ill, yet in this world here and now, free from hatred, free from malice, safe and sound and happy, I keep myself." You will find this to be your second consolation and assurance. So even if there isn't any rebirth, it's good to do it anyway.

"Now suppose evil results befall an evil doer. I, however, don't think of doing harm to anyone. Then how can ill affect me who has done no harm, any harmful deed?" You will find this to be your third consolation and assurance. So even if there isn't a consequence to evil doing, at least in your own heart you're in a good state, you're in a beautiful mental state.

And finally, "Supposing evil results do not befall an evil doer, then I see myself purified in any case." You will find this to be your fourth consolation and assurance.

So what's the teaching? Well, the basic line is the inner happiness of moral integrity surpasses those momentary, superficial pleasures gained through delusion, hatred, and ill will.

So his approach, you can see, really shows us what a skilful teacher the Buddha was. These people are not ready for the Eightfold Path and the Four Noble Truths. They've come to him, they've told him about their confusion, and the last thing they want is for somebody to come along and say, "No, no, that's all rubbish. Listen to me, I know the truth." So he gives them this way of investigating themselves, and this inspires them so much that they take refuge in the Buddha. So one can presume that either later in the day, after he's taken a meal—because that's when he would normally arrive, on alms round in the morning, after the meal, and he'd been refreshed and had a rest—he would then talk about the Four Noble Truths and the Eightfold Path, now that he's got their confidence.

So you can see the structure of this discourse: from confusion through investigation, ethical discernment, inner transformation. This brings about confidence, and ultimately, when the Buddha tells them about the Four Noble Truths and the path, and of course *vipassanā*, they will reach—they will have realised the truth.

So I hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused any confusion, and that by your commitment to your practice and careful questioning of anything you hear, you will be liberated from all suffering, sooner rather than later.

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